

# Facial Expression

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  - Micro-expression Keywords (B07CM5DW9F)
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  - Handshake Styles Best Reflect a Person's Personality
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## Part One: Basics

### 2.3.1 What Is Subjective Expectation?

The subjective expectation we discuss refers to the judgment the nervous system forms about impending events, based on all past and current information it can receive. Reading this sentence alone may suggest a clear, logical mental process, making subjective expectation seem highly rational. It must be emphasized that the term "expectation" here does not refer to a logically derived forecast such as the answer to "If it rains, what tool should one carry when going out?" On the contrary, most people describe this cognitive activity with the word "feeling," and it typically occurs without deliberate "thinking."

“Feeling” is in fact a rapid cognitive assessment and judgment formed by the neural centers when multiple strands of logical inference intermingle and influence one another. Its chief characteristic is that the individual does not know how the judgment was reached; the actor cannot clearly articulate the cognitive process.

For example, upon arriving at the office one morning, you notice more than one colleague glancing at you with flickering eyes; the moment they realize you are looking back, they all avert their gaze. Normally your assistant brings your favorite tea to your desk within three minutes, yet today the assistant seems to skirt around you—still busy with tasks, but noticeably odd. Someone is seated in the boss’s office with their back to you, identity unclear; when the boss sees you, they deliberately walk over and close the blinds. Even the ever-diplomatic Old Liu merely offers an awkward smile, bends slightly, then turns and retreats while walking backward.

Anyone placed in this situation would form a judgment of danger. Yet in the process of “sensing that something is wrong,” no “because... therefore...” reasoning occurs. Instead, like an animal, one applies the most primitive criterion—“how things ought to be at their best or most normal”—to perceive the surroundings. These are the expectations we refer to. More often than not, subjective expectation runs counter to rational thought, yet it is not easily noticed or brought into awareness.

Humans are an evolved animal species whose primary needs, like those of other animals, are survival and reproduction. To survive and reproduce, humans instinctively generate numerous expectations based on prior conditions. The following examples illustrate this seemingly abstruse concept.

### 1. Subjective expectation in a dark environment

Entering a pitch-dark space where one cannot see one’s own hand immediately slows and cautions every movement; this is an evolved instinctive reaction. The subjective expectation at that moment is that objects (people, animals, or otherwise) capable of causing harm may be present; even in their absence, collision with any object could cause injury. No one regards a dark environment as safe and warm, so the body naturally contracts while the limbs cautiously explore the surroundings. No one strides briskly or swings the limbs freely. In short, everything must be done with care.

Some attribute this to fear of the unknown, because nothing can be seen. This explanation equates the root of fear with the unknown (invisibility). Yet why should the unknown necessarily produce fear, and why does this inevitable link exist? Continuing along this line of thought yields the answer: because the unknown (invisibility) implies possible danger. That is subjective expectation.

Does the unknown therefore preclude any expectation of beneficial objects? Sometimes it can, but only when prior information has prepared the ground—for instance, secretive behavior by others on one’s birthday may suggest a surprise celebration. Such a situation is not truly unknown. Absent preparatory information and without any relevant signs, entry into an unknown situation triggers the survival instinct to generate a negative expectation at once; thoughts turn to self-preservation rather than to good fortune. For a living organism, seeking survival is the norm; expecting good fortune is not.

A blind person remains unable to see yet does not remain perpetually fearful, because familiarity with dark environments and a distinctive mode of acquiring information render their subjective expectation of such settings safer than that of sighted individuals; darkness is ordinary for them. Certain psychiatric patients facing unknown dangers—for example, threatening gestures of anger from others—may likewise feel no fear, because they cannot cognize the stimulus and therefore form no subjective expectation. Thus the unknown is not the root of fear; the expectation that harm may occur is the root of fear.



## 2. Subjective expectation in a bright environment

Conversely, if no prior information suggests otherwise, pushing open a door and entering a brightly lit room where every corner is clearly visible usually produces no vigilance; one feels relaxed and at ease. In such an environment everything lies in plain sight, so the subjective expectation is that no negative stimuli will appear.

## 3. Subjective expectation in a tense event

The boss enters the open-plan office and loudly announces that year-end financial difficulties require laying off two-fifths of the staff. Tension instantly fills the room. Colleagues exchange glances; everyone fears for their own position. At this moment the subjective expectation of the great majority is that they themselves face dismissal. Even when rational analysis concludes that one does not belong to the group to be cut, few can fully trust that rational conclusion and remain entirely untroubled.

Only when the final outcome is confirmed—including confirmation for those actually dismissed—can everyone truly exhale. Subsequent reactions differ: those retained feel relief; those dismissed feel dejected or argue their case; yet the preceding worry has certainly vanished. Estimating one's score after the college entrance examination, however high, still leaves one unable to relax completely until the admission result arrives. The two situations are identical. Until a confirmed result is known, the inner expectation remains that an unfavorable outcome is possible.

## 4. Subjective expectation in a relaxed event

The most typical relaxed event is the collective, slightly foolish countdown of ten seconds at New Year's to welcome the new year. The expectation discussed here is not the new hopes for the coming year—that is aspirational. We refer only to people's subjective expectation of what will occur after those ten seconds. What is it? Cheering and leaping; every face around one beaming with joy; perhaps some tears as well, yet the atmosphere is certainly one of excitement and positivity enveloping everyone.

This expectation requires no clear analysis or judgment, no deliberate thought—correct?

Dark environments and tense events share the same nature: both generate negative subjective expectations. Although the complexity of the triggers differs, the result is highly similar—fear of harm. Bright environments and relaxed events likewise share a nature: because one perceives a relatively strong sense of control and safety (for example, the setting or event is simple, or one's command of the situation is strong), they produce a calm or positive subjective expectation. A positive subjective expectation, however, requires more auxiliary information to arise spontaneously. More often, when people feel strong control they generate only a calm subjective expectation.

Consequently, the human mental state tends more frequently toward the negative; yet this is not a misfortune, for the existence of these negative subjective expectations enables safer survival while simultaneously fostering a longing for happiness and hope. Once a happy fact arrives, the feeling of happiness becomes all the more precious, so that everyone pursues joy as a lifelong goal.

If happiness were the norm, normal human psychology could not sustain it. Deprived of the pressures of survival and reproduction, people would chase illusory spiritual pleasures such as drug use.

Those possessing genuine insight strive to maintain a balance—not quantitative, but qualitative—between pressure (negative subjective expectation) and joy.

A common saying holds that nine out of ten things in life fail to go as one wishes. The "wishes" in this phrase are not the expectations we discuss; they are the "intentions" formed after rational deliberation and may be

rendered as “purposes” or “hopes.” Such considered aspirations are usually far more complex and ambitious than expectations generated by the survival instinct. Precisely for that reason, nine out of ten of them remain unfulfilled.

### Summary:

If the “subjective expectation” described above must be rendered in plain language, the closest equivalent is “a vague sense that ... is possible,” yet it differs from a “premonition,” because a premonition is still something thought out and usually passes through conscious reasoning. With expectation, by contrast, one is often entirely unaware that such a judgment has already been formed.

## Emotion ABC Theory: Irrational Beliefs Deceived You

Activating event A is merely the indirect cause of emotional and behavioral consequence C; the direct cause of C is the belief B produced by the individual’s cognition and evaluation of activating event A.

Emotion ABC theory was originally proposed by the American psychologist Ellis. He maintained that activating event A is merely the indirect cause of emotional and behavioral consequence C, while the direct cause of C is the belief B generated by the individual’s cognition and evaluation of activating event A. In other words, a person’s negative emotions and behavioral disturbances (C) are not directly triggered by an activating event; they are directly caused by the erroneous beliefs (B) that arise when the person who experiences the event forms an incorrect cognition and evaluation of it<|eos|>

## 2.2 The Role of Emotions

According to the second explanation, the generation of emotions requires “situationality,” “objects that can satisfy a certain human need,” and “the opposite” (objects that cannot satisfy a certain human need) can trigger emotions of different natures. However, the dictionary’s standard definitions alone do not make clear exactly how emotions are stimulated.

People often say that reason is above emotion.

If we look at what people do in social life, it is true that rational thinking makes more decisions. Yet an important precondition is often overlooked at such times: everyone’s social activities follow the same or similar norms, and those norms themselves were defined by countless people using reason.

In the micro-reaction (微反应) research system, we hold that emotion is above reason.

Whether in social life or purely physiological activities (such as outdoor pursuits, sports, or eating), the first neural response to a stimulus is usually emotion; only afterward does thinking replace emotion as the dominant force. If the stimulus is too strong, thinking yields its dominant position and emotion takes over the body’s operations. Laughing at the wrong moment during an important performance, or impulsively harming someone despite knowing the serious legal consequences, are both decisions made by emotion.

Do not conclude that reason ranks above emotion simply because the quantity of decisions made by reason far exceeds those made by emotion. The human mind is actually quite fragile and easily drawn into emotional impulses; most major mistakes are driven by emotion, so the quality of emotion-driven decisions is closer to humanity’s animal nature. Moreover, most memorable events are the product of rational thought (because memory and thinking belong to the same type of cerebral-cortex function), whereas emotional impulses are not primarily based in the cerebral cortex and are therefore difficult to remember.

Emotions can be clearly perceived by others and exert an influence on the body. Some manifestations are obvious and may even produce serious consequences; others are harder to observe, such as changes in breathing or heartbeat. One thing is certain, however: wherever there is emotion, the body undergoes change. Even minute internal changes are still changes and can be captured by appropriate methods. This is the principle behind the development of the polygraph (formally called a "multichannel psychological recorder").

Both emotion and reason are functions the nervous system uses to process external information. Reason is suited to relatively rational situations, while emotion is closer to animal instinct and better suited to handling intense stimuli.

Emotion is an evolved survival mechanism. From a Darwinian perspective, emotion better ensures survival (safety) and reproduction (love). All emotions operate on a single-layer logic: if something benefits me, respond positively; if it harms me, first compare and judge, then choose among rejection, confrontation, avoidance, or abandonment. These evaluative criteria are free of social standards and rest solely on the organism's subjective feelings; therefore emotion can directly reflect the subject's cognition and experience. This is also why analyzing emotion can reveal a person's true thoughts.

In coping with complex environments, emotion can mobilize bodily energy and direct certain movements to maintain internal balance, especially the balance and stability of the nervous and circulatory systems. These tasks are too difficult for rational thought. No matter how intelligent a person may be, he or she is still an animal.

## 2. The Diversity of Expectation Mismatches

### (1) A normal American driver in the United States

A normal American driver operating a vehicle in the environment described above forms expectations based on traffic laws and common sense, proceeding through intersections according to the rules. If another vehicle violates those rules, other drivers generally do not take excessive offense, though contempt is certainly present; a driver with a short temper may even become angry.

### (2) A normal American driver newly arrived in China

A normal American driver who has just begun driving in China, besides learning the traffic regulations, does not know that China lacks the "unwritten rule" of taking turns at intersections. He therefore waits for vehicles from other directions to proceed in order. When he realizes that others are not waiting and that this does not violate any traffic rule, his long-standing habitual expectation is contradicted by the unfamiliar driving reality. Surprise, contempt, anger, and helplessness appear in succession, and he may eventually conform.

### (3) An experienced Chinese driver in China

Chinese road conditions and driving habits constitute a self-contained system in the minds of most experienced Chinese drivers. In addition to obeying traffic regulations, actual road behavior includes many "flexible arrangements" that everyone tacitly understands. Consequently, ordinary Chinese drivers rarely encounter the kind of expectation mismatch an American driver experiences upon first driving in China. Although negative emotions may still arise when encountering particularly unreasonable vehicles, the subjective expectations of ordinary Chinese drivers generally align with actual road conditions, so normal Chinese traffic does not provoke excessive emotional fluctuations in experienced drivers.

### (4) A "mature" Chinese driver in the United States

A driver familiar with Chinese road conditions and habits—for example, myself—encounters many expectation mismatches when first driving in the United States; in plain terms, he receives many stimuli.

The first time I queued at an intersection without traffic lights, I felt surprise mixed with confusion! Why had everyone stopped? There was no red light!

When my turn came to be first in line, I had not yet noticed the “unwritten rule” of alternating passage. I drove straight across the stop line and simultaneously saw the car on the left also beginning to move—fear! Wasn’t there going to be a collision?

My speed was faster; I did not see the reaction of the vehicle on the left, but I did see the driver opposite staring with wide eyes, then frowning in puzzlement, upper lip slightly raised and nostrils flared, expressing mild disgust. My confusion deepened! What was going on? There was still no red light!

Only after a companion later explained American driving habits did I understand the source of the disgust I had witnessed.

This example, presented solely to examine the origins of emotion, illustrates how different environments and different people produce different expectation mismatches and ultimately different emotions and reactions. Because of this diversity, special attention must be paid to the individual characteristics of the test subject and the testing situation when designing micro-expression testing protocols and analyzing results.

## 2.1 The Concept of Emotions

The Xinhua Dictionary gives two definitions for the word “emotion” (情绪):

1. Mood; state of mind; in low spirits; waking up in a bad mood.
2. The experience arising from a person’s attitude toward something. Often used interchangeably with “feeling” (情感), yet distinct. Emotion is linked to natural human needs and is situational, transient, and has obvious external manifestations; feeling is linked to social human needs and is stable, enduring, and not necessarily accompanied by obvious external manifestations. The emergence of feeling is accompanied by emotional reactions, while changes in emotion are also controlled by feeling. Ordinarily, an object that satisfies a certain human need elicits a positive emotional experience such as satisfaction, joy, or pleasure; the opposite elicits a negative emotional experience such as dissatisfaction, sorrow, or fear.

From an ordinary person’s perspective, the two definitions show no obvious distinction. If you wish to understand this book, however, you must read and reflect carefully on them, especially the second.

In the first definition, “mood” and “state of mind” commonly appear in phrases such as “in low spirits” or “in high spirits,” describing an overall bodily affective state. This kind of “emotion” lasts relatively long—hours or days, but also possibly only minutes. It corresponds closely to the English word mood.

The second definition contains two excellent points that require special attention: first, it is “situational, transient, and has obvious external manifestations”; second, what satisfies a need produces positive emotion, while the opposite produces negative emotion. The typical feature of this sense of “emotion” is that it requires a concrete situation to be triggered; different situations trigger different emotions, and the resulting emotions are short-lived. This sense corresponds to the English word emotion.

In the study of micro-reactions, the “emotion” we focus on and employ is limited to the second definition.

Because this type of emotion more accurately reflects the true inner state of the person involved. The first type of emotion can serve as a reference for overall judgment but cannot be used to determine truth.

The emotions examined and discussed in this book are generally very brief. The shortest lasts no more than one second (surprise); other emotions are measured in seconds and are extremely fleeting. Only one emotion—sadness—can last as long as several days, and the reason for this exception is explained in Chapter 8. It is precisely because emotion is both brief and authentic that the expressions it produces are genuine and reliable.

#### 4. How to Manage Your Own Emotions

Emotion can constrain a person, can fulfill a person, and can also harm a person. Therefore we must manage our emotions well. To manage one's emotions, one must understand a single point: emotion management is the adjustment of emotion, not the suppression of emotion. Emotion itself is neither good nor bad; what matters is the manner of its expression. What, then, is the healthy way to manage emotion? It is to express the appropriate emotion, in the appropriate manner, in the appropriate situation.

How, then, do we manage our own emotions?

First, we must observe our own emotions. Learning to observe one's emotions is the first step in emotion management. We can frequently remind ourselves to pay attention to our emotions and ask inwardly, "How am I feeling right now?" For example, when a friend arrives late to a meeting, you can ask yourself, "What am I feeling? Am I angry?" Once you recognize that you are angry, you can adjust your emotion in time and remain its master.

Second, express your emotions appropriately. What constitutes an appropriate expression of emotion, and what constitutes an inappropriate one? Returning to the example of a late friend, consider the distinction. You might say tactfully, "The agreed time has passed and you still haven't arrived; I was really worried something had happened to you on the way—you scared me!" By conveying the feeling "I was very worried about you," your friend understands the effect his lateness has had on you. This is an appropriate way to express emotion. Conversely, if you accuse your friend, he will naturally focus on defending himself against the attack rather than considering the matter from your standpoint. That is an inappropriate way to express emotion.

Finally, release emotion in an appropriate manner. Releasing emotion means giving yourself an opportunity to clarify your thoughts and organize your feelings. What, then, counts as an appropriate method of release? We can measure it by asking several questions: How can I act so as not to repeat the mistake? Will this action cause greater harm? How can I reduce the unpleasant feeling? After asking these questions, you will understand that confiding in a friend, listening to music, traveling, or having a good cry are appropriate ways to release emotion, while drinking, speeding, or committing suicide are inappropriate ways.

#### 4. Expectation Mismatches in Relaxed Events

At New Year's, a large crowd foolishly counts down the final ten seconds to welcome the new year. Our expectation is that everyone will cheer and leap together at the last moment, surrounded by an excited, positive atmosphere.

- **Stimulus one:** At the instant the New Year bell rings, everyone around remains eerily silent instead of cheering and leaping as imagined. You feel extremely strange and may even sense that something bad has happened (promptly revising your expectation).

- **Stimulus two:** At the instant the New Year bell rings, in addition to the expected cheering and leaping, candy rains from the sky. You feel delighted—surprised and even happier!

If, having read this far, you still do not understand what we mean by subjective expectation, we must resort to our trump-card example.

The claim “I had no expectation” actually means you did not realize you held a certain expectation. Such subjective expectations usually concern matters one does not consider worth conscious attention. A simple illustration: you are using a computer to surf the internet, enthusiastically playing an online game or busily sending and receiving work emails. In this ordinary situation, do you have an expectation? What might it be?

Suddenly the network disconnects; web pages will not load; the game freezes. You can only stare helplessly. What is your reaction? You curse! If you determine that the disconnection was caused by human factors (the network administrator’s negligent inaction or malicious sabotage), you may feel contempt (for incompetence) or anger (for malice). If the other party then behaves arrogantly and self-righteously, your anger may trigger a fighting response. This occurs because your subjective expectation at that moment is “the network will remain connected and I will be able to continue what I am doing.”

Subjective expectation is therefore a trend judgment—“how things ought to be at their best or most normal.” Not only humans but animals possess it as well. If this important neural-response mechanism were lost and everything depended on rational thought to maintain external responses, animals lacking complex cognition could not survive, nor could humans.

It is upon encountering expectation mismatches that emotion is first directly produced.

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It is upon encountering expectation mismatches that emotion is first directly produced.

### 3.1 Must Inner Emotions Always Have External Expressions?

Inner emotions always have external expressions, because these internal states of the nervous system and their external manifestations both carry important physiological significance; unlike thought, they cannot be retained purely in the brain without leaving any trace.

Every movement of the body’s muscles serves a physiological purpose, and the muscles of the face are no exception. Frowning, for example, besides signaling anger, doubt, or pain, can also indirectly close the upper and lower eyelids, thereby affecting the way the visual system receives information. Pressing the lips together, besides indicating displeasure, can prevent the instinctive urge to spit out bitter medicine. In other words, the facial expressions we take for granted not only convey meaning but also possess direct or indirect physiological functions.

Some of these physiological functions remain effective today; others have become evolutionary instincts that were once adaptive in ancient times.

Consider a threatening expression. Raising the upper lip to expose the canine teeth is not unique to humans; many wild animals open their mouths and bare sharp teeth before a fight. Such facial actions are essentially what we call expressions.

Human expressions, of course, can convey richer meanings. Before a friendly discussion, people smile at each other; when arguing a point, furrowed brows are common; upon hearing that a model couple has suddenly divorced, eyes widen in disbelief (“How is that possible?”); when someone self-importantly holds forth, a slight one-sided smirk (technically, unilateral upward pull of the corner of the mouth) may appear as a sign of contempt; in conflict, people glare or even curse; while watching a horror film, one gasps and the eyes widen as a chill runs down the spine; when bidding farewell to the deceased, the bereaved may have dull, lusterless eyes, yet the brows involuntarily lift in an effort to remain composed.

We must therefore clarify two points here:

### Psychology Mini-Class

Cognitive therapy emerged in the United States in the 1960s and 1970s. Its principle is to influence a person’s emotions and behavior according to their cognitive processes, thereby changing maladaptive cognitions.

Because people differ in cultural level, knowledge hierarchy, and environment, different individuals often hold different cognitions of the same issue. For example: in the same hospital, a child, based on their own cognition and experience, may regard it as a frightening place; an adult, based on their cognition and experience, may regard it as a place that saves lives and relieves suffering. Thus the key lies not in what the hospital objectively

is, but in the different emotions different people develop toward the hospital because of differing cognitions, which then affect their behavioral responses.

For instance, a person with low self-esteem constantly feels they have not performed well enough, that those around them dislike them, and even their parents dislike them; consequently they remain gloomy and unwilling to interact with others. The strategy of cognitive therapy is to help them dismantle old erroneous cognitions, reconstruct their cognitive structure, form a correct self-evaluation, and thereby regain confidence.

Cognitive therapy master Ellis held that an individual's interpretation and evaluation of an event they experience, together with their cognition and beliefs about it, are the root of the emotions and behaviors that follow. Therefore, when irrational cognitions and beliefs produce maladaptive emotional and behavioral responses, only by guiding and debating to change and rebuild those irrational cognitions and beliefs can the therapeutic goal be reached.

Cognitive therapy is mainly used to treat various illnesses and psychological disorders and has shown notable efficacy in treating emotional depression. It is especially effective as a short-term treatment for adult patients with unipolar depression. Researchers at the University of Pennsylvania found that three months of cognitive therapy produced significant improvement in 80 percent of patients with unipolar depression.

### Pendulum Effect: Emotions Also Have Cycles

Emotions function like a barometer and follow fixed cycles. In addition, male and female emotional cycles differ markedly. Only by accurately grasping the cycle of emotions can one reasonably control them.

Have you ever experienced this: after a promotion or raise your mood is ecstatic and euphoric, yet a few days later you suddenly feel there is nothing to be happy about and begin to feel irritated by interpersonal relationships or other matters.

Just as the sea has tides and the moon waxes and wanes, human emotions also have cycles. Like a pendulum swinging between high and low, emotions alternate between elation and dejection. In the course of psychological activity under specific conditions, the higher the intensity of feeling, the steeper the psychological slope, making it easy to shift toward the opposite emotional state. In other words, if you feel extremely happy at one moment, the next moment is very likely to bring sadness.

Scientific research indicates that, under normal circumstances, the human emotional cycle lasts 28 days, cycling repeatedly from peak through critical point to trough. When a person's emotions are at the peak of the cycle, they typically feel refreshed and cheerful, display strong vitality, show rich feelings, and are amiable toward others; when emotions are at the trough, the person often feels lonely and isolated, becomes irritable, easily develops rebellious feelings, and may even display unpredictable mood swings.

The emotional cycle acts as a barometer of our feelings; we can use it to arrange work and life rationally. When emotions are high, schedule more difficult or tedious tasks and do things one would rather avoid; when emotions are low, go out for a walk, arrange recreational activities, chat with family and friends, and seek psychological support from others so as to pass safely through the low period.

Then what are the differences between male and female emotional cycles? Let us examine them below.

## Chapter 3 The Natural Combination of Emotion and Expression



There are six universal emotions in the world: surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and happiness. Each emotion possesses specific micro-expression morphological features; from these micro-expressions the corresponding emotion can be accurately inferred.

Is there truly a necessary connection between emotion and expression?

The first step is to clarify the meaning of the term "expression" as used in this book.

According to the Xinhua Dictionary, "expression" refers to the external manifestation of emotion and is divided into facial expression, verbal expression, and postural expression. Facial expression is the manifestation of emotion on the face and is the primary form of emotional expression; verbal expression is the manifestation of emotion through tone, rhythm, and speed of speech; postural expression is the manifestation of emotion through body posture and movement.

Under this definition, expression is an integral part of emotion, just as vocalization is an integral part of language; the two are inseparable. Neuropsychological research also supports this view, holding that after the nervous system analyzes and judges information from a stimulus source, it produces a state of excitation or inhibition that directs the body to act; this complete "internal + external" process is called emotion.

However, the dictionary definition of expression encompasses facial, postural, and verbal aspects, corresponding fully to all meanings of the English word "expression," for which "expression" is the more appropriate translation. Native Chinese speakers share an implicit habit: when they say "expression," they naturally mean facial expression in particular, so the standard definition does not fully align with common usage. For reasons of convenience, rigor, and respect for habit, we limit the "expression" or "micro-expression" discussed in this book to facial expression only. This limitation will not be repeated hereafter.

## Diversity of Expectation Mismatch

- **Normal American driver in the United States:** A normal American driver operating a vehicle in the above environment follows laws and common sense as expectations and proceeds according to rules at intersections. If another vehicle violates these rules, other drivers generally do not take it too seriously, though contempt is certainly present; if the driver has a bad temper, anger may also arise.
- **Normal American driver newly arrived in China:** A normal American driver who has just begun driving in China, besides learning the traffic regulations, does not know the Chinese "unwritten rule" of sequential passage at intersections, so they wait for vehicles from other directions to proceed in order. After waiting, they discover that others do not wait, yet this does not violate traffic rules. Long-standing habitual expectations are contradicted by unfamiliar road conditions, producing surprise, contempt, anger, and helplessness in turn; ultimately the driver may become assimilated.
- **Experienced Chinese driver in China**

Chinese road conditions and driving habits, however, form a self-contained system in the minds of most experienced Chinese drivers. In addition to obeying traffic regulations, actual road driving involves many "flexible adaptations" that everyone tacitly understands. Therefore, when ordinary Chinese drivers encounter complex situations on the road, they are less likely to experience the kind of expectation mismatch an American driver newly arrived in China would feel. Although negative emotions may still arise when encountering particularly unreasonable vehicles, on the whole the subjective expectations of ordinary Chinese drivers largely match actual road conditions, so normal Chinese traffic does not provoke excessive emotional fluctuations in experienced drivers.

### 2.3.3 Differences in Expectation—Using Driving as an Example

Expectation is subjective and therefore varies greatly across different situations.

Anyone who has driven or ridden in a car knows that the driver's seat easily generates various negative emotions. Except when traffic suddenly clears after severe congestion—producing positive emotion—contempt, helplessness, impatience, fear, and anger almost always appear. We call these "driving's bad emotions."

The reason is that driving has clear rules. These rules include not only officially issued laws and regulations but also the driver's subjective expectations—other vehicles driving reasonably, safely, and smoothly.

When you are rear-ended for no reason, your mental expectations of reasonable and safe driving by others are contradicted by the accident; your first instinctive reaction is anger. When someone drives unreasonably—making an abrupt U-turn, changing lanes, cutting in, or driving slowly for no reason when nothing is ahead, or braking repeatedly without cause—these situations violate your expectations of reasonable driving and smooth flow; your first instinctive reaction is contempt and anger. When roads are congested and vehicles crawl forward, the slow speed contradicts your expectation of smooth flow; your first reaction is anger, which turns to helplessness once you acknowledge you cannot change the situation.

Subjective expectation is complex, however; different people in different situations form different expectations and therefore experience diverse emotions.

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Subjective expectation is complex, however; different people in different situations form different expectations and therefore experience diverse emotions.

## 3. Expectation Mismatch in Stressful Events

The boss enters the open-plan office and announces loudly that year-end financial difficulties require laying off one-fifth of the employees. Tension instantly fills the room; everyone looks at one another, each fearing for their own position. At this moment your subjective expectation is: I might be the unlucky one.

**Stimulus 1:** Your name is not on the layoff list. You will? Breathe a sigh of relief and even feel a bit of happiness.

**Stimulus 2:** Your name is on the layoff list, but the name of someone worse than you is not. You will? Feel dejected and angry. Dejection comes from being eliminated; anger comes from the unfairness of the elimination.

**Stimulus 3:** A few days later another notice arrives: no layoffs after all, and because new financing has come through everyone will receive a raise. You will? Of course feel happy.

Hence the joke: Leader A enters the office: "This year's performance is poor; each person gets a 100-yuan year-end bonus." Everyone is indignant. Leader B enters the office: "This year's performance is poor; the boss says we have to lay people off." Everyone falls silent and looks at one another. Leader B continues: "However, after I argued forcefully, our department will not have layoffs, and each person will still receive a 100-yuan year-end bonus." Everyone cheers.

The joke illustrates how to be a leader—essentially, how to set subjective expectations. The greater the gap one can create between subjective expectation and reality, the stronger the stimulus to the person.

## 2.4 The Core Value Like a Treasure Trove—Studying the Role of Expectation Mismatch

If you have patiently read this far, congratulations: you have obtained a very important treasure!

Why devote an entire chapter to explaining the "expectation mismatch" principle of emotion generation? Because this principle plays a decisive role in psychological testing.

Only by designing effective stimuli can one elicit genuine emotions from the person being tested; only then is it possible to capture the subtle changes that appear on the face and ultimately determine lies and truth.

To deliver effective stimuli—especially directional effective stimuli—one must first analyze the subjective expectations of the person being tested. Once those expectations can be hypothesized, expectation mismatch can be manufactured to stimulate the other party. The direction of the mismatch (that is, the emotional direction) remains under the tester's control: information above expectation (evaluation) guides positive emotion; information below expectation produces negative emotion, and the specific type of negative emotion varies with the nature of the evaluation.

Usually we employ role substitution and decision-simulation restoration methods to analyze the subjective expectations of the person being tested.

This method is discussed in a separate paper. Stimulus sources also take many forms; besides the most common verbal questions, they can include visual stimuli, actions and performances, and situational shaping. (See the discussion of stimulus sources in Micro-reaction (微反应).)

## Conclusion

From the moment you opened this book until you finished reading it, you have already learned a great deal. It is time to test your learning outcomes in the various scenarios of real life. Your daily actions are like a laboratory, and your current interpersonal relationships, together with the new relationships you ultimately form through your efforts, become the experiments.

You now possess enough knowledge to deepen your research further. You will find that the more often you use the techniques you have learned to observe and interpret others' behavior, the faster your "people-reading" ability improves.

It is a good idea to share the "people-reading" insights you have just gained with close friends and your opponents. Yet remember that mastery of body language can be applied in many ways; we hope you use what you have learned to respond better to those around you, leverage your strengths, collaborate with others, and solve problems efficiently.

You now understand clearly that to know a person it is far from enough merely to listen to what they say; one must also attend to their facial expressions. This prompts you to observe everyone around you more carefully. In turn, others will sense that you are considerate and understanding. Consequently you will find that you can communicate more effectively and positively with everyone in daily life.

#### (4) A "Mature" Chinese Driver in the United States

A driver familiar with Chinese road conditions and driving habits—for example, myself—encounters many expectation-mismatch situations when driving in the United States for the first time; in plain terms, they receive many stimuli.

The first time stopping in line at an intersection without traffic lights produces surprise plus confusion! Why has everyone stopped? There is no red light.

When I reach the front of the line, I still have not noticed the "unwritten rule" of alternating passage and drive straight across the stop line; at the same time I see the car on the left also starting to move—fear! Isn't there going to be a collision?

My speed is faster; I do not see the reaction of the vehicle on the left, but I do see the driver in the oncoming car staring with wide eyes in surprise, then frowning in puzzlement, upper lip raised and nostrils slightly flared sideways, expressing mild disgust. Confusion deepens! What's going on? There is still no red light!

Only after a colleague later explained American driving habits did I finally understand the source of the disgust I had witnessed<|eos|>

### 1. Male Emotional Cycles

Some people think men have few emotions, but this is a misunderstanding of men. In fact, it is because male emotions are relatively hidden. If you observe the men around you carefully, you will certainly find that they also have times when they feel irritable and periods of emotional lows. For example, he may be cheerful every day, greet acquaintances proactively, and be the "life of the party" in the office, yet one day he suddenly stops wanting to talk and sits alone. That is likely when his emotions are in a low period.

Some women do not understand this characteristic of men. They notice their husband suddenly distancing himself, acting cold, and hiding away playing games or watching television. When they try to approach him, his reaction is hard to accept. Women who do not know the truth often misunderstand and think it is because their husband no longer loves them, but that is not the case. Everyone has a certain emotional cycle; it is just that some people show it clearly while others do not. Most people experience an emotional low about once a month, so feeling irritable or getting angry for no reason during this period is completely normal. At such times, a wife should not complain or doubt but should understand her husband and help him with psychological guidance.

## 1. American Highway Rules

During my time in the United States, I drove in the three cities of Washington, Denver, and Los Angeles. I do not know whether the entire country follows the same traffic laws, but at least in the places I visited, saw, and drove, not every intersection has traffic lights. Most intersections, however, have a "STOP" sign. In the absence of traffic-light constraints, traffic-police direction, or camera surveillance, every American driver I observed followed a shared consensus rule: vehicles stop at the intersection in the order they arrive, and one car from each direction proceeds in turn. See Figure 2-1.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2-1]*

By regulation, a driver who sees a "STOP" sign must bring the vehicle to a complete halt (speed zero), regardless of actual road conditions. This is a strict standard for obtaining a U.S. driver's license. The consensus rule of queuing and taking turns (whether or not it is explicitly written into U.S. traffic statutes) has also become an ordinary subjective expectation among American drivers. Everyone considers this the proper way to proceed; they know it, and they know others know it.

## Chapter 2 Emotional Triggers

Emotion is the first neural response when a person encounters an effective stimulus; it cannot be deliberately "faked." Therefore, purposefully designing stimuli to elicit genuine emotions in others is the key step in tearing away their false front and striking directly at inner truth.

This chapter examines, in order, the following questions: what we mean by emotion, the important role of emotion, the process by which emotion arises, and the important role of emotion in micro-expression analysis. The opening text is relatively rigorous; readers should be mentally prepared.

If you are already convinced that micro-expressions can reveal a person's psychological state and wish to proceed directly to the various micro-expression features of the face, you may skip this chapter for now and begin reading at Chapter 4. However, if you still have doubts, question the reliability and scientific basis of micro-expressions, or are very interested in micro-expressions and need foundational knowledge to strengthen your analytical ability, please read this chapter through patiently.

After finishing it, you will discover a small treasure at the end of the chapter—one that can raise your micro-expression analysis skills to a professional level.

So let us begin with the dry textual analysis.

### Psychology Mini-Lesson

One day the famous German chemist Ostwald was suffering from a severe toothache and was in a terrible mood. He took out a manuscript sent by an unknown young man, glanced at it hastily, found it full of strange statements, and tossed it into the wastebasket. A few days later his toothache eased and his mood improved. Remembering those strange statements, he decided he should read the manuscript again. He quickly retrieved it from the wastebasket and examined it carefully. The paper turned out to have great scientific value.

He recommended the paper to a scientific journal. After publication it quickly caused a sensation in academic circles, and its author later received the Nobel Prize.

Imagine what would have happened if Ostwald's mood had not improved.

When people are in a positive emotional state, they easily perform at their best; judgment and analytical abilities function normally. Conversely, when people are in a negative emotional state, reason is affected, self-control declines, judgment and analytical abilities drop, and they may even act in ways they themselves find unbelievable.

### 3. Cognitive Appraisal Theory

In addition to evolutionary theory and bodily-perception theory, there is another view called cognitive-appraisal theory. This view holds that an emotional response arises only after a prior condition—the appraisal of the event. In fact, as early as ancient Greece, the philosopher Aristotle proposed a similar idea: that human emotions come from our view of the world and our relationships with those around us. Anger, for example, arises because we feel others are slighting us.

Following Aristotle, researchers represented by Arnold argued that emotion stems from the evaluation of an event's meaning and importance. In other words, the importance we assign to an encountered event directly determines the type of emotion we experience. Lazarus held the same view, stating that "emotion is the physiological and psychological organization of responses to good and bad information in the ongoing environment; it depends on short-term or continuous appraisal."

This position regards cognitive appraisal as the core of emotional response and better explains the differences among various emotions. For instance, in the same environment and under identical stimuli, different people may experience different emotions.

### 2. Bodily-Perception Theory

Another line of research holds that emotion arises from the perception of bodily changes. The older view was that we first experience the feeling of emotion and only afterward experience a series of bodily changes. For example, we first feel fear and only then experience a racing heart or sweaty palms.

Early on, however, William James, the father of American psychology, proposed the opposite view: "Emotion is the bodily change that arises directly with the perception of the stimulus, together with our feeling of that bodily change. We usually think we feel sad because we have failed and then weep; we feel afraid because we meet a bear, tremble, and then run. Yet the actual sequence is the reverse: we feel sad because we weep; we feel afraid because we run."

Following James, the Danish psychologist Lange put forward a similar view, arguing that emotion is the result of visceral activity and emphasizing the relationship between emotion and vascular change. Thus James and Lange agreed on the origin of emotion: the sequence is that an emotional stimulus first produces a physiological change in the body, and that physiological change then gives rise to the emotional experience.

### 3. The Influence of Emotion on Life

Many people strive and struggle in career, wealth, health, marriage, and interpersonal relationships yet ultimately achieve nothing and even become depressed or develop various psychological disorders. They do not realize that the root of the problem lies in living inside a program written by their own past experiences.

The emotions generated by our life experiences affect our present life at every moment. Although time, place, and events differ, the same emotions keep arising, the same outcomes keep repeating, and similar troubles and sufferings keep recurring. The psychologist Freud discovered and confirmed that human behavior is

constantly governed by the unconscious—that is, by the influence of the mind—and that the mind is largely formed by the emotions stored from past life experiences.

Human emotions continuously evolve and develop with life. Past emotions are stored in the mind like seeds, becoming life programs that influence a person's present and future. If they are not resolved in time, these emotional seeds will continue to act on our lives as time passes and will shape our destiny.

## Context

Context is a general term that mainly includes three factors.

1. **Test background information** (English: WHAT): What happened before the lie-detection questioning? What results will follow once the lie-detection conclusion is reached (whether correct or incorrect)? Who ultimately stands to gain? Who ultimately stands to lose?
2. **Who is being tested** (English: WHO): The specific circumstances of the person undergoing the lie-detection test, including personality, behavioral habits, upbringing and educational background, representative past actions, position within the overall matter (location within the relationship network), and so on. Later chapters will convince you that different people lie in different ways.
3. **Testing environment**: The layout, lighting, objects, personnel, and other factors inside the testing space that may affect the person being tested.

The same stimulus source may elicit different reactions in different contexts. The same stress micro-expression may also carry different meanings in different contexts.

## American Highway Rules

During my time in the United States, I drove in the three cities of Washington, Denver, and Los Angeles. I do not know whether the entire country follows the same traffic laws, but at least in the places I visited, saw, and drove, not every intersection has traffic lights. Most intersections, however, have a "STOP" sign. In the absence of traffic-light constraints, traffic-police direction, or camera surveillance, every American driver I observed followed a shared consensus rule: vehicles stop at the intersection in the order they arrive, and one car from each direction proceeds in turn.

By regulation, a driver who sees a "STOP" sign must bring the vehicle to a complete halt (speed zero), regardless of actual road conditions. This is a strict standard for obtaining a U.S. driver's license. The consensus rule of queuing and taking turns (whether or not it is explicitly written into U.S. traffic statutes) has also become an ordinary subjective expectation among American drivers. Everyone considers this the proper way to proceed; they know it, and they know others know it.

## 1. Evolutionary Theory

In the study of emotion, one line of research holds that emotion is the product of evolution. This view regards emotion as an adaptation to the environment, gradually formed by human ancestors in the process of adapting to the natural world; it mobilizes multiple different components simultaneously to cope with and solve various problems encountered. Tomkins, for example, stated: "Emotion is the basic motive of the organism, a set of organized responses that, once activated, can simultaneously cause many bodily organs to produce corresponding response patterns."

Following Tomkins, Izard also held the same view, emphasizing the adaptive nature of emotion. He pointed out that emotion is a motive closely linked with perception, cognition, and motor responses. From a

functionalist standpoint he stressed the importance of emotion's external behavior—expression—linking emotion's innateness and social learnedness, its adaptability and communicative function through expression. He also maintained that emotion comprises three aspects: physiological arousal, subjective experience, and external expression.

## 1. Expectancy Discrepancy in a Dark Environment

If the light is turned on and a group of friends stands in the room holding flowers, what is your reaction? Not only does the tension immediately relax, but a strong feeling of pleasure also arises. Because the contrast is so great, the stimulus produces an enormous surprise!

If you slowly move toward the light switch, encounter familiar furniture such as sofas and tables along the way, then successfully turn on the light and find nothing unusual in the room, what is your reaction? Besides bodily relaxation, there should be no other reaction, because in this process neither a negative stimulus nor a positive stimulus occurred.

If you suddenly hear a sinister laugh and feel a breeze brush past your ear, what is your reaction? Fear instantly intensifies—greater than the fear caused by darkness alone and greater than the fear caused by the sinister laugh and breeze alone.

In this situation, the expectancy discrepancy that triggers fear is the sum of the absolute value of the negative expectation and the absolute value of the stimulus from the fear source.

## 1. Definition of Emotion

When discussing emotion, one must give it a definition, yet this seems an impossible task. Like the concepts of "time" and "consciousness," we encounter and use them constantly in daily life, yet it is difficult to give them an accurate definition. In fact, psychologists and philosophers have debated the definition of emotion for more than a hundred years without reaching a consensus. One statistical survey showed that the psychological community has produced at least ninety definitions of emotion.

In emotion research, different investigators focus on different points and attempt to define emotion from their own research perspectives, resulting in the lack of uniformity mentioned above. Here, from the standpoint of ordinary public understanding, we offer the following definition: emotion is a collective term for a series of subjective cognitive experiences; it is a mental and physiological state produced by the integration of multiple sensations, thoughts, and behaviors.

## Psychology Mini-Lesson

Ellis studied human nature and identified several patterns, summarized as follows:

1. People can be rational and reasonable or irrational and unreasonable. If one thinks and acts rationally, one will be very happy, competitive, and effective.
2. Emotion arises from people's thinking, so psychological distress often stems from irrational, illogical thinking.
3. People possess both sociological and biological tendencies—toward rational, reasonable thinking and toward irrational, unreasonable thinking. In other words, every individual inevitably harbors varying degrees of irrational thoughts and beliefs.
4. Humans are language-using animals; thinking proceeds through language. Continuously repeating an irrational belief in internalized language inevitably leads to irresolvable emotional distress.



## 2. Expectancy Discrepancy in a Bright Environment

Conversely, when entering a brightly lit room where every corner is clearly visible, a person can walk and move about with relative ease. In such an environment everything is in plain sight, so the subjective expectation is that no negative stimulus will occur.

**Stimulus 1:** If nothing happens, how do you react? No particular reaction.

**Stimulus 2:** If friends are already standing in the brightly lit room holding flowers, how do you react? There is surprise, but the degree of surprise is certainly not as intense as in the identical situation in a dark environment.

**Stimulus 3:** You turn around and suddenly find someone pressing a sharp pair of scissors against your abdomen while covering your mouth. How do you react? Intense fear. The prior expectation of safety clashes with the fact of fear, again producing an absolute-value summation.

## 2. Does the Presence of an Expression Necessarily Indicate the Presence of Emotion?

The answer to this question is: not necessarily.

From birth onward, years of accumulation enable people to produce various common expressions at will; this is even easier for actors. A good actor can even precisely control a single eye to shed a tear within two seconds.

Therefore, merely observing an expression does not confirm that the person has genuinely experienced the corresponding emotion.

In psychological testing, to maximize the chance of confirming inner states by observing subtle changes in expression, one necessary step must be added—effective stimulation. Effective stimulation means designing a stimulus source according to the specific circumstances of the person being tested so as to elicit genuine emotion. Once genuine emotion arises, it will be expressed through facial expressions; what we must do is filter out the false and capture the true.

### 2.3.2 What Is Meant by Expectancy Discrepancy

Simply put, it means that the way events unfold next does not match your subjective expectation. Expectancy discrepancy can be qualitative or quantitative. When expectancy discrepancy appears, emotion arises spontaneously. When events exceed (surpass, improve upon) expectation, people experience pleasant, positive feelings and thus positive emotion; when events fall short of expectation, people experience dissatisfaction and negative feelings and thus negative emotion.

#### 1. Expectancy Discrepancy in a Dark Environment

If you enter a pitch-dark environment where you cannot see your hand in front of your face, your nervous system naturally assumes that objects capable of harming you may be present. Consequently you instinctively contract your body and send your limbs slowly exploring in all directions. You instinctively tell yourself: be careful.

## Micro-Emotion Facts

How is emotion defined? What are its classifications? What influence does emotion have on life? How does one manage one's own emotions? How much do you know about micro-emotions?

Everyone possesses rich emotions, and each emotion exerts a different influence on us. So how much do we understand about emotion? Next let us gain a deeper understanding of what emotion is from the perspectives of its definition, classification, influence on life, and management.

## The Importance of Staying Calm

When you argue with someone or hear remarks that anger you, first stay calm. Silently count to ten in your mind and restore your composure. Remember that if you become agitated or fly into a rage, nothing good will come of it; on the contrary, your mood will only worsen. Once you understand these points, you will no longer experience such large emotional fluctuations and will be able to remain unaffected by others.

## Where Exactly Does Emotion Come From

Emotion is an inseparable part of our lives. So where exactly does our emotion come from, and how is it produced?

Everyone has emotions—worry, tension, irritability, doubt, fear, jealousy. It can be said that emotion is an inseparable part of our lives; having emotions shows that our life is in flow. So where exactly does our emotion come from, and how is it produced?

## 3.7 Some Terms Used in This Book

The content of this book primarily studies analyzing people's true psychological states by capturing micro-expressions. The book employs some relatively specialized terms, which are introduced uniformly here in advance to prevent words uncommon in daily life from disrupting your reading flow.

## Chapter 1 Opening the Password Box of Emotions

Where do emotions come from? What is the ABC theory of emotions? Do emotions also have cycles? Why are our emotions always influenced by others? Our emotions are like a password box containing many secrets, and only by opening the password box of emotions can we discover what lies inside.

### Actor/Party

When introducing micro-expression knowledge, to describe actions that are not stress responses—for instance, in the context of performed facial expressions—the term “test subject” cannot be used; instead, “actor” or “party” refers to the individual.

### Test Subject

This book draws on numerous testing experiments and real test cases to illustrate the principles and applications of micro-expressions. Therefore, it frequently employs “test subject” to denote the person who produces a stress response during testing.

## 2.3 Causes of Emotional Arousal — Expectation Mismatch

The root source of emotions lies in the mismatch between stimuli encountered and a person's “subjective expectations,” abbreviated as “expectation mismatch.”

## Preface

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## Preface (merged)

## Preface (merged)

## Preface (9786267173633)

In a well-known chain café in Tokyo's Ginza district, surrounded by the aroma of coffee, I pondered what to say and how to express it during the upcoming meeting. My thoughts were interrupted by the classic song "White Christmas" playing in the background. When I looked up, I saw the person I was scheduled to meet.

"Excuse me, are you Mr. Kojima?" I asked.

"Yes, I am Kojima. Are you Mr. Shimizu?" the man replied.

"Hello, I am Kenji Shimizu from the Institute of Facial Expression Science. Pleased to meet you!" I answered.

"Likewise, pleased to meet you."

The man—Mr. Kojima—was a company president in his forties. His firm regularly organized lectures that applied psychology to improve business performance.

Information I had seen online sparked my interest in his business, and I hoped he would incorporate “micro-expressions” into the company’s lecture curriculum, so I arranged this meeting. That day, I explained to Mr. Kojima, whom I was meeting for the first time, that micro-expressions are useful not only in business but in all face-to-face communication. Mr. Kojima appeared engaged; his posture leaned slightly forward, palms facing me, as he listened attentively. However, when we began discussing a concrete business collaboration proposal, his smile lasted only an instant. In the next moment, one corner of his mouth lifted, and he began to speak.

Kojima: “Mr. Shimizu, you really do love micro-expressions! (At that moment, an asymmetric smile appeared on one side of his face.)”

I: “.....Yes. I certainly do love micro-expressions.”

Kojima: “Sorry to interrupt. Please continue.”

I: “My apologies. I’ve been the only one speaking so far. May I ask for your opinion? Or shall we end the discussion here for today?”

Kojima: “Well..... Let’s leave it at that for now. I have a proposal regarding this matter. I suggest you return to university for further research and become Japan’s leading authority on micro-expressions before proceeding. I believe commercializing micro-expressions at this stage would be quite difficult. Perhaps we can revisit the idea once the timing is right. What do you think?”

After Mr. Kojima finished speaking, the atmosphere made it clear that no further progress would occur. He then stood up and left the café.

One month after the meeting, the expanding “Micro-expression Training Website” contacted me directly, at which point I learned that Mr. Kojima had appropriated my commercialization model. At the time, he had said, “Commercializing micro-expressions is very difficult,” yet his true intention had been to steal the model and develop it himself.

Do you know how I detected his inner thoughts? That’s right—it was from the micro-expression that flashed across his face for an instant.

In that moment during our conversation, an expression of “contempt” appeared!

“Contempt” is an attitude of superiority shown when comparing oneself with others. On the face, it appears as one corner of the mouth lifting. When I mentioned the business proposal, he displayed a dismissive attitude while simultaneously wanting to seize the business model. Fortunately, I noticed the micro-expression and, when discussing the core details of my model, hesitated and held back, so he did not obtain the critical information.

What I want to convey here is that, from both scientific and experiential perspectives, it is possible to discern another person’s true intentions. Therefore, I have studied various human thoughts and methods and compiled the discipline of “micro-expressions,” which allows one not only to see through others’ real intentions but also to avoid being disadvantaged in conversation.

“Micro-expressions” refer to unconscious facial expressions that last only 0.2 seconds. This aspect will be explained in detail later. Expressions are innate communication signals shared by all humans, regardless of culture, ethnicity, gender, age, or era; even people who are blind from birth display facial expressions.

If one can read these unconsciously displayed signs, it becomes possible to instantly interpret another person's thoughts and emotions. Mastering the skill of reading micro-expressions, as mentioned earlier, further protects one from falling into traps. In recent years, communication methods that utilize facial expressions have gained increasing attention. In fact, many well-known companies with operations in Europe and the United States now provide micro-expression training.

In our daily lives, the ability to read expressions can be the key to gaining conversational initiative and control. The technique of reading micro-expressions is a science-based, entirely new communication technology.

Since becoming a business consultant specializing in micro-expression reading, I have met many people who are successful in their careers and fulfilled in their personal lives. In this book, I will introduce the "subtleties" of micro-expressions in a clear, practical manner that anyone can apply.

The skill of reading micro-expressions not only guides one toward professional success but also deepens understanding of human psychology and fosters better interpersonal relationships. I sincerely hope that every day you are surrounded by kind and positive emotions!

**Editor's Note:** The events described at the beginning of this book have been altered to a certain degree, without substantially changing the facts, so as not to point to specific individuals involved.

## **Preface (9787510438820)**

Life is a masquerade; everyone hides their true expressions behind a mask. The person standing before you—is their speech sincere, or are they saying one thing while thinking another? Let an FBI special agent show you how to detect whether someone's facial expressions are genuine or false, revealing their inner thoughts so clearly that pretense becomes impossible and concealment fails.

The FBI once arrested a spy. Although the spy was willing to discuss his own involvement in the case, he refused to name his accomplices. An experienced and seasoned FBI agent named Davidson used the following method. First, Davidson listed the names of everyone who had worked with the spy. He wrote each name on a small card and showed the cards to the spy one by one, asking him to describe each person briefly.

In reality, Davidson was not interested in the answers; he was watching the spy's facial expressions. Although the spy maintained steady eye contact and gave negative answers, Davidson noticed that when the spy saw one particular name, his eyes suddenly widened, his pupils contracted rapidly, and he narrowed his eyes slightly.

Davidson, an expert in body language, knew that upon seeing his accomplice's name the spy's eyes had widened involuntarily from tension, yet he had quickly contracted his pupils to conceal his unease, resulting in a narrowed gaze. This was the information Davidson sought. He put the cards away and left.

The next day, Davidson showed the spy a photograph of the person whose name had triggered the reaction and said, "Tell me about this person." The spy's eyes widened like saucers. "How did you know?" he asked in surprise. Davidson replied, "You didn't really think you were the only one cooperating with us, did you?" The spy cursed, "That bastard!" and then began to confess everything in detail. In the end, both spies were convicted.

So stop assuming that only a "second party," "third party," or "Nth party" can betray you. When your "little schemes" are guessed or your "hidden calculations" are seen through, it is often your micro-expressions that are to blame—in other words, your micro-expressions have given you away.



In fact, not only a glance or a frown, but every word and every movement conveys information and constitutes a bodily language. A person performs an action only when their body intends to do so.

I once attended a research meeting to discuss a new product of significant scientific value. The topics included patent rights, equity, royalties, research and development costs, and how to persuade the commissioning company to manufacture and sell the product.

At the start of the discussion, one member of the opposing team adopted an eager posture: sitting forward on the edge of the chair, body leaning in, toes touching the floor, like a sprinter waiting for the starting signal.

### **Eager posture**

Because he was a technical specialist on their team, his reaction directly affected the outcome of my pitch. His “poised to act” posture told me he was interested in what we were discussing. I therefore guided him to raise technical questions, which our researchers answered one by one.

I had deliberately chosen to sit beside this key person from the outset so I could observe his every movement. Once we had fully addressed his technical concerns and removed his doubts, his attitude became highly cooperative.

The negotiation proceeded smoothly precisely because I immediately noticed the technical specialist’s posture indicating willingness to cooperate and made good use of that observation, allowing us to sign a mutually beneficial agreement quickly.

Gerard I. Nierenberg, known as the “father of negotiation training,” has shown through real negotiation experience that when communicating, simply paying a little attention to the other person’s micro-movements reveals their thoughts completely. No matter how casual a small movement may seem, it is triggered by psychological activity and fully exposes deeply buried mental states.

You may not know that micro-expressions are also called “facial micro-reactions,” and micro-movements are also called “bodily micro-reactions.” Together they form the broader term “micro-reactions” (微反应).

Whatever inner activity or emotional expression lies beneath a familiar or unfamiliar face can be seen at a glance through micro-reactions. Because micro-reactions are instantaneous, involuntary responses that occur the moment a person receives an effective stimulus—responses not controlled by conscious thought—they are instinctive reactions inherited through long-term biological evolution and cannot be deliberately “faked.” Therefore, they are the most accurate clues to a person’s true inner thoughts.

Micro-reactions act as an “amplifier” for reading inner emotions. Once this “amplifier” captures hidden “subtext” such as a twitching eyebrow, a nose rub, or crossed arms—like a scent-sensitive bloodhound—you will find that reading people is no longer difficult.

### **Preface (B07B3SW8DX)**

You are enjoying a pleasant conversation with a friend when they suddenly fly into a rage. You are baffled, unsure why their mood changed so abruptly.

You visit a client, who sits with arms crossed. You feel puzzled, uncertain whether your presence is welcome.

You work diligently, yet your supervisor gives you no friendly looks and often criticizes you. Unable to read your supervisor’s emotional shifts, you can only endure again and again.

You quietly devote yourself at home, yet your family finds fault with you. You are at a loss, unsure how to please them.

.....

In daily life, many people are skilled at disguising themselves and keeping their emotions from showing on their faces, which undoubtedly increases the difficulty of interacting with them. Therefore, it is necessary to learn some knowledge of micro-emotion psychology so that we can detect emotional fluctuations through others' expressions, body movements, and words, thereby seeing through their psychology and piercing their disguises. Because emotions are neural responses to stimuli, they arise before rational thought, are uncontrollable physiological reactions, and cannot be deliberately faked. In other words, even the most skilled pretender cannot completely hide their emotions.

Your mind is often shrouded in the gloom of depression, feeling sorrow without reason.

Your temper is short; you are frequently provoked by others' casual remarks and do not know how to extinguish the anger inside.

You often feel anxious and restless yet lack the strength to break free from this state.

You are constantly troubled by fear and long to overcome it but cannot find a way.

You cannot help suspecting others, doubting that people around you are plotting against you, even though you know you should not, yet you cannot control it.

.....

Many people become trapped in negative emotions such as depression, anger, anxiety, fear, suspicion, and frustration, falling into the abyss of these feelings. In contrast, others consistently hold on to hope, embrace enthusiasm, remain confident, work actively, and maintain inner peace, as if living in a land of happiness. Why is this so? Faced with the same circumstances, why do people's emotions differ so greatly? How do emotions arise? Is there a way to overcome them? These are major questions confronting every modern person.

As John Milton said, "He who can control his own emotions surpasses a king." If we can control our emotions, release and resolve negative ones, and tap into latent positive ones, we hold the key to the door of happiness.

Identifying others' emotions helps us interact with them better; decoding our own emotions helps us enjoy a happy life. This is the purpose of publishing this book and the value it offers. To achieve this goal, we adhere to the following basic principles:

1. Accessible language and strong readability

Most readers find specialized psychology works somewhat obscure, while overly superficial ones lack readability; both types discourage readers. This book presents micro-emotion psychology knowledge in accessible language while maintaining strong readability.

2. Comprehensive content with emphasis on practicality

Many books on micro-emotion psychology cover narrow topics and focus only on theory, offering little practical value. This book incorporates numerous research findings in micro-emotion psychology, spans a wide range of fields, and emphasizes solving real-world problems.

### 3. Simple methods with strong operability

This book introduces many straightforward techniques for controlling, expressing, and releasing emotions, drawing on professional therapies such as ACT, exposure therapy, dredging methods, color therapy, and art therapy. These methods are highly operable, and non-professionals can master them quickly.

## **Preface (9787510438820)**

### **preface**

A raised eyebrow or a lifted corner of the mouth reveals a person's true thoughts! People's faces write their inner secrets. Mastering certain decoding methods for facial expressions makes others' pretense increasingly obvious and their concealment increasingly exposed.

Jack is a purchasing agent at a large manufacturing company. Because of his work, he frequently attends various business negotiations. Once, while discussing the purchase of components with a newly developed factory in another city, the other party quoted a price nearly 30 percent lower than competing bidders, with only one condition: Jack's company must pay half the deposit in advance.

"I negotiated with their sales representative for over an hour. Throughout, he seemed very uneasy; his left hand kept making small movements—either pushing his glasses or rubbing his nose. While speaking, his eyes occasionally glanced upward to the right, and he frequently licked his lips. I suddenly recalled what Dr. Lightman said in *Lie to Me*: 'Eyes looking left indicate recall; looking right indicates fabricating a lie.' So I did not sign the contract immediately. Instead, I had an investigation agency check the other party's credentials and discovered it was a shell company, saving my company nearly 500,000 yuan in losses." Whenever Jack recounts this incident, he still becomes very emotional.

Eye movements and raised eyebrows—do not underestimate these micro-expressions; they may be the crucial signals that allow you to see through the other person and turn the situation around. As the French writer Diderot said, "Every movement of a person's mind is displayed on their face, clearly and distinctly drawn."

You have an interview for a new job and are eager to try, yet the competition is strong. You feel very nervous and hope to make a good impression on the interviewer. What can you do?

From the moment you meet the interviewer, you must pay attention to your own body language: smile and look directly at the person. If they smile back, you have made a good start. If their face remains expressionless, do not let your anxiety show. Maintain eye contact and respond positively to the interviewer's body language to break through their defenses: if they keep a tense face, you smile; if their posture is stiff, you relax—as if mirroring them.

Remember not to cross your arms or cross your legs; keep your feet roughly parallel and sit facing the interviewer. Let your hands rest loosely at your sides or on your knees, and keep your eyes level—do not glance around. Leaning slightly forward can convey a positive impression, but do not lean too close, as that may feel oppressive. If you notice the interviewer unconsciously leaning back, try relaxing your posture and leaning back slightly.

Life is a game, and living is a contest. If you can accurately read others' micro-expressions and also make good use of your own—avoiding or minimizing negative expressions and movements—you will navigate social and business interactions with ease and ultimately achieve happiness and success in life.

## Preface (9787538583373)

Whenever we see an unfamiliar face, we unconsciously make basic judgments: Is the face round or long? Are the eyes large or small? Are the lips thick or thin? Is the makeup neat? Is the smile friendly? The purpose is to judge the person's basic character from their expression and decide whether we like them. Unfortunately, the expressions we see are not always genuine, which directly affects our initial judgment. Therefore, judging micro-expressions becomes extremely important.

The shortest duration of a micro-expression is 1/25 of a second, and the longest does not exceed 1/4 of a second. Because the time is so brief, it is extremely easy to overlook. Yet these fleeting expressions betray many deliberately concealed true emotions.

Through the study of micro-expressions, we learn that a smile does not always indicate happiness—it can also signify sarcasm, helplessness, or contempt. Crying does not always indicate sadness—it can also signify fear or joy. A furrowed brow is not always anger—it can also indicate thinking or worry. A pout is not always disdain—it can also indicate sadness or suppressed laughter.

Learning and studying micro-expressions helps us make more accurate judgments and reduces unnecessary difficulties and obstacles in interpersonal relationships. It must be noted, however, that micro-expression research cannot be completed through a single book; it requires long-term training and observation. Moreover, micro-expressions are not meant for pranks, showing off, or harming others. Therefore, before learning about micro-expressions, please prepare a kind intention.

## The "Tricks" of Success

In many people's eyes, I was once a successful actor and am now a successful professional analyst; perhaps in the future I will pursue yet another field. At every stage of life I ask myself: Have you truly recognized yourself? Have you truly recognized this job? Have you truly recognized the people around you? These three questions are as simple as can be, yet few people ever truly think them through. Let us now discuss these three questions.

Socrates said: "Know thyself."

Money, material goods, or power are not necessary conditions here. The first step toward success is to recognize yourself and your work. I have what I have today because I have always known what I want to do, what I am suited to do, and how to put it into practice. A person who does not even know their own character or abilities is like a headless fly, bumping into walls until it is battered and bleeding.

King Solomon said: "With all you possess, obtain understanding."

Once I have a clear understanding of myself and my work, I draw on all my experience and reason to "understand" the attitudes of those around me, including family members, the personalities of colleagues, the psychology of clients, and how to build good interactions with them. Whether a person succeeds depends largely on their ability to get along harmoniously with the people around them.

If you have studied the great or successful figures of history, you will find that they each possess at least one of the following two traits:

- First, they identified a life goal aligned with their interests and talents and pursued it with determination.

- Second, they possessed a keen eye for people and excelled at evaluating others.

These are the “tricks” of success I mentioned at the outset. This book will teach you the basic principles and operating methods of these “tricks.”

Of course, mastering the “tricks” of recognizing yourself and recognizing others is no easy matter, because humans are highly skilled at deception and disguise. We say things we do not mean and do things we do not want to do; when happy we can pretend to be sad, and when in pain we deliberately appear calm. Sometimes we cannot even figure out what we ourselves are thinking, let alone what others are thinking!

Fortunately, when God created humanity, a unique “clue” was left on each person’s body. Master these “clues,” follow them, and you can see into a person’s inner world, perceive the real them, and everything else will follow naturally.

Many years ago, a craftsman brought his fourteen-year-old son to my office. “Mr. Balken,” he said, “I would like you to analyze whether this boy is suited to carpentry. His hands are very dexterous; sometimes he spends the whole day whittling and is completely absorbed. I am wondering whether he should quit school and begin learning woodworking with me now. I believe he will become an excellent carpenter earning eight dollars a day.”

I looked at the boy seriously, exchanged a few words with him, then told the father: “Yes, this child is very caring—not only toward wood but toward the whole world. If I am not mistaken, he must enjoy helping others. For such a compassionate and dexterous child to quit school and become a carpenter earning eight dollars a day would be a waste of talent. My suggestion is to send him to medical school to specialize in surgery, so he can help others while fully realizing his own value. Trust me, he will be happy—and he will earn far more than eight dollars a day.”

The kindhearted carpenter father followed my advice. The boy did not disappoint; he graduated with honors from medical school and is now a distinguished surgeon.

My recommendation that the boy study surgery was based on the key knowledge in this book—grasping the “clues” God left on his body. Through these subtle “clues,” I saw in him something far more precious than mere mechanical talent.

For many readers this may still seem abstract. To be specific, a person’s appearance, voice, and manner are intricately linked to their inner world.

During my acting career I met all kinds of people every day (and even more so now). One of my interests has been to infer character traits, occupation, family situation, current mood, and whether someone is lying simply by observing their outward expressions. I have found that the more educated, accomplished, or high-status the person, the more interesting the exchange, because they, like me, are constantly reading subtle expressions. If I do not take the initiative, I risk being found out—you know, even with all my experience reading people, I cannot completely control my own micro-expressions.

Expressions—static expressions (such as body type, skin color, bone structure) and dynamic expressions (facial expressions, voice, movements of the hands and feet)—together form a complete system. The amount of information it contains is vast and complex, yet the system is simple to operate and highly effective. In the chapters that follow, I will concretize this seemingly complex system so that you can master this “technique” in the shortest possible time and take the shortcut to success and happiness.

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## **Preface: "Listening" with Your Eyes**

By observing details such as a person's fingernails, shirt collar and cuffs, shoes, the knee areas of trousers, calluses on the index finger and thumb, and manner of speech and behavior, one can clearly determine a person's occupation.

—Arthur Conan Doyle

The observation of surrounding things has proven to be an extremely attractive pastime. In public places such as shopping centers, grocery stores, conference rooms, social gatherings, or sporting events, we all occasionally observe others. If you are like us, you will find yourself guessing others' psychology: Why did they behave this way or make that decision?

For example, when someone sticks out their tongue, makes a face, or tilts their head, it indicates a specific thought or emotion. Whether or not they speak, the information conveyed by their body movements fully reflects their thoughts and feelings. Even when they do speak, in most cases we should simultaneously pay attention to the information conveyed by their body language to confirm whether what they said is true.

Being aware of the emotions and intentions behind people's behavior is very helpful in life. By practicing the methods provided in this book repeatedly, you can clearly grasp what triggers these behaviors. With this deeper understanding, you will be able to handle all kinds of interpersonal relationships in a highly professional, relaxed, and efficient manner.

By reading this book you will learn how to train yourself to observe the nonverbal information around you more carefully. You will begin to learn to "listen" with your eyes and carefully consider the meanings conveyed by people's gestures or expressions<|eos|>

## **Talking and Laughing, But No Deal in the End—Why?**

May I ask, in work or daily-life communication situations, have you ever experienced the following—

- In a business setting, the discussion was lively, yet no deal was closed?
- Responding as usual to a client's casual inquiry, only for it to turn into a complaint incident!
- Your supervisor listened to your presentation with a smile, yet did not adopt your proposal?
- The contract was signed, but did you concede too much?
- Fooled! The investment pitch that "guarantees profits" was all lies!
- A subordinate who was "in excellent shape" suddenly developed emotional issues...
- A couple who reconciled after an argument suddenly says they want to break up?

How do you feel about the situations listed above? Do they resonate strongly? The common thread hidden in all of them is "failing to read the other person's true intention."

Eh? Is this an obvious matter? Of course, if you could understand the other person's true intention, the communication scenes mentioned earlier would not produce misunderstandings. To prevent misunderstandings, how can you correctly grasp the other person's true intention and achieve good communication?

This is the key point this book explains; the secret is to read the other person's "micro-expressions (微表情)."

Let me give an example and think backward. Imagine the kind of person who can easily solve the problems above, or skillfully avert crises before they occur, and communicate smoothly with all kinds of people. Do you have such a person around you—

- The top-performing salesperson, the insurance broker with a high closing rate;
- The service staff requested by many clients;
- The colleague who gives excellent presentations;
- The interviewer who accurately judges candidates;
- The supervisor followed by many subordinates;
- The first-rate manager who revives multiple companies;
- The businessperson whose life runs smoothly.

Why does the person who comes to mind not seem ordinary?

What timing, what circumstances, and how do these people who are good at communication choose what to say and what attitude to adopt with the other party? How do they do it? Similar questions inevitably arise, don't they? These people understand "reading the room" and "seeing into people's hearts." Yet even when we know that "reading the room" and "seeing into people's hearts" are important, most people still do not know what to do.

In fact, even if you ask "Why are you so good at reading the room?" "How can you correctly know what others really mean?" or "How are you so good at communicating?", the usual answers are "I don't know" or "It's just a natural reaction."

Even if you accept that "one day I will naturally possess communication ability," reality is urgent; because insight is usually reflected directly in work results, to survive in the workplace you must acquire this ability as early as possible.

## **Reading the Room Is a Powerful Communication Tool**

The "reading the room" and "seeing into people's hearts" mentioned in the previous section play a very important role in communication. How exactly should one observe, and how should one perceive? Most



people do not understand, and therefore many may not even know whether their own communication methods are correct or incorrect; they keep repeating the same mistakes, thinking they can learn from erroneous experiences, yet they cannot come up with better solutions.

You may want to ask others how to achieve “reading the room” and “seeing into people’s hearts,” but most people who possess this ability may not clearly know why they can sense the atmosphere of an interaction and can only explain it as a rule of thumb gained through long-term observation and correction.

The rules of thumb developed through experience are sometimes correct and sometimes incorrect. Moreover, such rules of thumb are useful only for certain people and offer limited help to most.

The current situation is that those who learn rules of thumb from communication experts do not know how to learn them correctly, and the teachers themselves do not know how to teach them correctly. The main reason is that the abilities of “reading the room” and “seeing into people’s hearts” have not yet been technologized—that is, they have not been systematically organized. Even if one is a communication expert, everyone’s situations and environments differ, so it is not easy to convey the skill universally.

In conclusion, possessing the ability to read “micro-expressions” is equivalent to having a powerful communication tool that can be easily applied in daily life or work.

In other words, by understanding the other person’s expressions, you perceive their true intention and communicate smoothly.

In fact, various studies show a direct connection between the ability to read micro-expressions and communication skills. For example, top-performing salespeople, interviewers who accurately judge whether candidates are lying, and management consultants who revive multiple companies cannot clearly explain to others how strong their communication ability is, but they share the common trait of possessing excellent micro-expression reading ability.

There is no doubt that people who are good at “reading the room” and “seeing into people’s hearts” are actually the ones who instantly see through the other person’s micro-expressions and immediately perceive and interpret their meaning.

Because micro-expressions are scientific, both the generation of expressions and how to train the ability to read micro-expressions can be explained systematically. The science of micro-expressions turns these communication experts’ rules of thumb into something “visualizable,” converting rules of thumb into a technology. Once technologized, it becomes easier to learn communication skills and correctly perceive and interpret micro-expressions.

### **Micro-Expression Emotional Psychology (Bestselling New Edition)**

Cracking the human mask of “saying one thing and meaning another,” discerning the other person’s true intention in 0.2 seconds

#### **微表情を見抜く技術**

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## Translator's Afterword

Scientific research shows that in daily communication, 7% of information is conveyed through words, 38% through voice, and 55% through facial expressions and body posture.

Words can lie, but the body cannot. Even if you are silver-tongued, your body will betray you and clearly reveal your true inner thoughts to others. Likewise, you can observe and interpret others' micro-expressions to see into their hearts. In other words, personality analysis is a two-way process.

Psychology master William James once said: "The main cause of all emotions originates from the physical."

The human mind and body are closely connected; even the slightest physical influence moves the mind. Scientific personality analysis is built on this connection between physiology and psychology. Any emotional expression—joy, happiness, sorrow, anger, melancholy, fear, and so on—reaches the muscles, blood, and other bodily components, triggering a series of external manifestations. The more often you repeat the same emotion, the deeper the "imprint" left on the body; over time, these seemingly insignificant "imprints" become the "display" of inner emotions.

## **Reader's Guide**

One book to understand a thousand faces, one book to master the workplace and relationships.

This is a psychology book you will not be able to put down; every chapter, every section, even every sentence tells you how to achieve success. Do not tell me you do not need success, or do not need more success—that only exposes your lack of confidence.

Modern society is turbulent; beneath order lies war without gunpowder. Why, in every negotiation, do you tread carefully yet still get seen through without realizing it? Why, on every date, can you never enter the other person's mind, never figure out what they are thinking, and end up parting unhappily? Why do you work hard yet fail to receive the recognition and rewards you deserve, while someone "lazier" than you keeps rising? Why do you always not know why you are this way or that way?

What this book tells you is the truth behind these "whys," and how to use that truth to make your career more successful and your life happier.

## **Finding the Right Path for Yourself**

No matter how wise or humble a person is, no matter how unattainable they seem to others, there are always moments when they appear self-righteous. The most obvious example is that we always, consciously or unconsciously, measure another person's thoughts or behavior by our own thinking and standpoint. This gives rise to doubts such as: Why did he do that? What is he really thinking? Or complaints such as: He is simply bizarre! I really cannot stand him!

My job is to help people resolve these doubts and soothe these complaints.

Half a year ago, a gentleman came to see me. He owns a department store. He hoped his son Tom would take over, so he sent him to study business management. But Tom was only interested in clothing design; he loved all kinds of fabrics and drew many design sketches. When Tom expressed his desire to attend night school to study fashion design, the gentleman flew into a rage.

## **Introduction: Who Says There Is No Shortcut to Success**

This book is written for the attentive, the inattentive, and everyone who longs for career success and a happy life.

I firmly believe that everyone is either educating or being educated—you must succeed. Yet reality tells us that success always belongs to only a portion of people. Years of practical consulting experience have taught me that many people do not succeed not because they lack goals, but because they lack skills. Before entering the main topic, I would like to talk about the “skills” of success.

## Facial Expressions Are a Universal Language: You Can Tell by the Face

### Facial Expressions Are a Universal Language: You Can Tell by the Face

Readers who have reached this point may wonder, “Are micro-expressions truly universal across countries?” or “I always feel that Americans and Japanese differ in how they display expressions on their faces?”

In conclusion, micro-expressions are a phenomenon common to all countries. In addition, the reason Japanese and American expressions differ lies in the presentation of those expressions and in the varying strength with which the facial muscles are engaged; the underlying nature, however, remains the same.

## Chapter 2 Facial Expressions Are the Primary Pathway for Expressing Emotions

Experts believe that human expressions are extremely rich and that the face is the most expressive part of the body. It can convey many complex emotions in every direction, such as indifference, fear, anger, surprise, sadness, contempt, and disgust. By carefully observing a person’s expressions, we can decipher the code of their emotions.

### History of Research on the Universality of Expressions

#### Ventilating Comfort Behaviors

Many people, especially men, sometimes place their fingers between their collar and neck and then pull the clothing away from their skin. This ventilating action is usually also a response to stress, signaling that a person feels dissatisfied or unhappy with what they are thinking about or with their current environment. Most women employ ventilating comfort behaviors in more subtle ways, perhaps only shaking their shirt a few times or brushing their hair back.

Once we understand these comfort behaviors, we can use them to interpret others more effectively, truly understand what is in their minds, and obtain more information:

1. Identify comfort behaviors promptly when they occur. The more you pay attention to these body signals, the easier it becomes to spot them.
2. Establish a baseline of comfort behaviors for each person. This allows you to notice changes in the frequency and intensity of comfort behaviors and respond accordingly.
3. When you see someone perform a comfort action, pause and ask yourself: “Why did they do that?” Recognize that the person must have encountered something unsettling. Your role is to act as a collector of nonverbal intelligence and uncover the reason.
4. Comfort behaviors generally occur after a person encounters something stressful. Therefore, as a basic rule, the appearance of a comfort behavior allows you to conclude that something stressful has taken place.

5. The ability to link comfort behaviors to their corresponding stressors helps you better understand the thoughts and actions of the people you interact with.
6. In certain environments, you can observe whether a person feels stressed (as reflected by an increase in comfort behaviors) by saying or doing something, thereby gaining a clearer understanding of their thoughts and intentions.
7. Pay attention to the body parts a person comforts. This matters because greater stress produces more frequent facial or neck-stroking movements.
8. The stronger the stress or discomfort, the higher the frequency of comfort behaviors.

Comfort behaviors are one of the primary ways to distinguish comfort from discomfort. More often than not, they substantially reveal a person's emotional state and true feelings. Therefore, we can come to know someone through their comfort behaviors.

### **The Comfort-Behavior Effect: Small Movements Surface When a Person Feels Uneasy**

**Micro-expression keywords** When people feel stressed, they unconsciously touch their neck, face, or other areas; we call this comfort behavior. When someone performs such an action, it indicates they are experiencing distress, pressure, discomfort, threat... inner unease. This is a very important clue that can reveal whether a person is lying or deliberately concealing something.

Everyone self-soothes, especially during a painful or threatening experience, and at such times people often produce comfort behaviors. The same occurs in animals; for example, cats and dogs lick themselves or others as a form of comfort.

Humans, however, have many more ways to comfort themselves. Infants habitually suck their thumbs; some people chew gum or bite pencils—these are also comfort behaviors, though the individuals themselves may not realize it. Most of the time, people overlook these subtle comfort behaviors and fail to appreciate their significance in revealing thoughts and feelings.

Comfort behaviors leak many secrets; they tell others you feel uneasy or have a negative reaction to something someone has done or said. Therefore, to read a person's mind, you must notice these subtle comfort behaviors so we can know what the other person is thinking and see their true nature.

There are many types of comfort behaviors. For instance, when we feel stressed we typically massage our neck lightly, touch our face, or play with our hair. These movements are entirely spontaneous comfort behaviors. In general, comfort behaviors take the following forms:

#### **Neck Comfort Behaviors**

Touching or stroking the neck is the most common and most meaningful comfort behavior in daily life and one of the most effective and frequently used. Men and women differ in how they massage the neck. Generally, men's massaging actions are more forceful; they grab or cover the area below the chin, stimulating the nerves there to lower heart rate and achieve a calming effect. Sometimes men also press the sides or back of the neck with their fingers or adjust the knot of a tie or the collar of a shirt.

Women's soothing behavior usually involves covering or touching the suprasternal notch. The suprasternal notch is the shallow depression between the Adam's apple and the sternum; some call it the "neck hollow." When a woman touches or places her hand on this spot, it indicates she feels distressed, threatened, uncomfortable, insecure, or afraid.

In many cases, under stress a woman covers her suprasternal notch with her right hand while supporting her elbow with her left hand. After the stress passes or when an unpleasant discussion pauses, her right hand lowers and gradually relaxes to grasp her left arm. If the situation becomes tense again, her right hand rises once more to the suprasternal notch.

Neck-massaging behavior is a very important clue that can reveal whether a person is lying or has concealed important information.

### **Turning the Feet**

In most situations, people like to orient their bodies toward someone or something they like. We can also use this information to judge whether others are willing to see us or would prefer to leave. Suppose you approach two people who are talking; you know them and want to join the discussion, so you walk over and greet them. You are unsure whether they welcome your joining, so observe their feet and torso movements. If they move their feet and torso to welcome you, their welcome is wholehearted. If they do not move their feet but merely turn and say "hello," they do not want you to join.

Likewise, we turn away from people or things we dislike. Moving one's feet away is a signal of seeking relief, indicating a desire to leave one's current position. When you are conversing with someone and notice that the other person gradually or suddenly moves their feet away from your side, you should make some adjustment. The person may have an appointment they are late for, or they may no longer wish to listen or stay. In short, turning the feet is a signal that a person wants to leave.

Therefore, we must recognize that although some people may appear enthusiastic on the surface, their feet are the most honest.

### **History of Research on the Universality of Expressions**

Expressions are a universally shared research finding. The first person to publish on universal expressions was the renowned British biologist Charles Darwin. In 1872, Darwin conducted a detailed investigation of emotions and the related facial-muscle movements and published the view that human and animal expressions share commonalities, arguing that humans are consistent in how they display expressions.

Darwin's claim, however, met fierce criticism and doubt from cultural anthropologists. Cultural anthropologists maintained that expressions, like language, are learned and vary across cultures. This view was not overturned, and the theory of universal expressions remained at a disadvantage for a long time.

In the early 1960s, psychologist Silvan Tomkins published research on the connection between emotion and expression, demonstrating that emotions and facial-muscle movements are inseparable.

Following Silvan Tomkins, American psychologist Paul Ekman and Carroll E. Izard, author of *The Psychology of Emotions*, began research on the universality of expressions across countries.

### **Directional Feet: Foot Movements Reveal the Other Person's Emotional Fluctuations**

Micro-expression keywords Want to know the emotional fluctuations of the person sitting across from you? Do not look at their eyes or listen to what they say—look at their feet. We usually notice people's expressions and gestures, yet psychologists have found that feet also "speak." Observing how a person moves their feet offers a glimpse into their inner world.

When interpreting human body language, most people are accustomed to starting from the upper body—for example, the face. Yet although we always look at a person's face first, facial expressions are often used to bluff or conceal true emotions. Therefore, it is better to reverse the angle and start from the bottom up, focusing first on the feet and reading the other person's mood through foot behavior.

The feet can be said to be the most honest part of our body. All our emotions—confidence, humility, fear, anxiety, anger, annoyance, flattery, caution, happiness, hurt, shyness, bashfulness, tension, depression, excitement, and so on—can be expressed through foot behavior. From an angry stance to a joyful jump, and from the tension of a job promotion to other states, the feet send us emotional signals one by one.

In general, foot behavior can be divided into the following types:

### **Anticipation**

Perhaps each of us has silently expressed anticipation for something. For example, before participating in an activity, people rub their hands together (see Figure 4.42) as if washing them. Unless their hands are cold from the weather and they are warming them by friction, this is a nonverbal way of conveying strong interest in the activity. Before rolling dice, gamblers like to rub the dice between their hands and then throw—this may be for the same reason.

When children see the tour bus carrying their mother stop, they happily rub their hands together in eager anticipation of seeing what “delicious” treats their mother's travel bag contains. A company executive over sixty will make the same gesture upon learning the company has just landed a major deal.

Another gesture of anticipation is rubbing the thumb and forefinger back and forth (commonly used when people expect money or a gift). It is undeniable that we sometimes convey this feeling of anticipation without realizing it.

### **Omitting One's Own Name and the Names of People Involved**

University of Hertfordshire psychologist Wiseman says: “When people lie, they feel uncomfortable, so they instinctively remove themselves from the lie they are telling. For example, if you ask someone why they did not come to a scheduled dinner the night before, they will complain that their car broke down and they had to wait to have it repaired. Liars usually say ‘the car broke down’ instead of ‘my car broke down.’”

Therefore, if someone repeatedly omits “I” when answering your questions, there is reason to suspect them. Conversely, liars also rarely use the names of the people involved in their lies. A famous example is when former U.S. President Bill Clinton, addressing the nation, refused to use “Lewinsky” and instead said, “I did not have sexual relations with that woman.”

### **Securing Prompt Service**

In many large cities, doormen, waiters, and other service-industry workers generally adopt various anticipatory postures to signal their desire for a tip. For example, they jingle the coins in their pockets or assume the “ancient Egyptian statue” pose with palms held behind the back and facing upward.

Verbal remarks and pauses are also extremely important parts of anticipatory postures. A waiter might say, “Have a pleasant day and I hope you are satisfied with our service,” then pause and wait for the customer to respond. If the customer does not understand the hint for a tip, the waiter may continue: “Sir, let me check

whether a better table has been reserved for you.” If the customer repeatedly ignores the hint, the service they receive will be greatly reduced.

### **Anti-Gravity Foot Behaviors**

For example, when a person feels happy or content, they experience a floating sensation—such as after completing a work task or winning a lottery jackpot. To an excited person, gravity seems to lose its effect. These behaviors are quite obvious; if we observe carefully, we can catch them in daily life<|eos|>

### **Cross-Cultural Experiments and Results**

Ekman and Izard’s initial experiments involved showing photographs of American facial expressions to people from various cultures around the world and asking them to judge what emotions the expressions conveyed. The results indicated that the six emotions—“happiness,” “disgust,” “anger,” “sadness,” “fear,” and “surprise”—and their associated expressions could be correctly identified across different cultures. This led to gradual acceptance of the idea that facial expressions are a universal phenomenon.

Yet this conclusion triggered another controversy. Critics argued that participants in the expression-recognition experiments had become familiar with American expressions through films, magazines, and other media, allowing them to accurately link emotions to expressions. Therefore, the results could not serve as evidence of universality.

In response, Ekman’s research team located subjects who had never seen Americans and had never encountered related information through any media. They traveled to a jungle tribe in Papua New Guinea to conduct the experiments. The results showed that the Papua New Guineans, like earlier participants, could correctly identify the various expressions.

Ekman photographed the expressions of these participants and brought the images back to the United States, where Americans were asked to identify the emotions shown. Although the American participants had never seen Papua New Guineans, they correctly identified the emotions conveyed. This demonstrated that the expression of basic emotions was similar in both cultures and confirmed the existence of an ability to recognize expressions.

In addition, many other studies of various designs aimed at verifying the universality of expressions reached the same conclusions as Ekman and his colleagues. Research involving infants and blind individuals showed that the expressions of infants, adults, and blind people share common features, further supporting universality.

As of 2016, seven universal human expressions have been recognized. The emotions expressed identically regardless of race are:

- Happiness
- Contempt
- Disgust
- Anger
- Sadness
- Fear
- Surprise



## Micro-expression Fundamentals

### Micro-expression Keywords

Most people believe that individuals tend not to value things that come too easily. Therefore, when someone asks a favor, they often decline by claiming to be busy. In reality, they are not truly occupied; they are simply inflating their own worth. If you extend the invitation a few more times, you will likely succeed.

People rarely cherish what they obtain “too easily.” Conversely, what requires great effort to acquire is more likely to be prized. The same holds true in social interactions: those who are readily available receive less regard, while someone who must be invited repeatedly and repeatedly cites busyness becomes increasingly valued.

The story of the Three Visits to the Thatched Cottage is the classic illustration. Upon learning that Zhuge Liang was a rare talent, Liu Bei resolved to recruit him to help conquer the realm. Accompanied by Guan Yu and Zhang Fei, Liu Bei traveled to Longzhong to invite Zhuge Liang to leave his seclusion. On the first visit, Zhuge Liang happened to be away, so Liu Bei left his name and returned disappointed.

A few days later, hearing that Zhuge Liang had returned, Liu Bei set out again with Guan Yu and Zhang Fei through wind and snow. Once more, Zhuge Liang was out; Zhang Fei stamped in anger and Guan Yu seethed with resentment.

Only on the third visit did Liu Bei finally meet the “busy” Zhuge Liang. The scholar, just back from a journey and exhausted, was fast asleep. Liu Bei waited respectfully outside the door.

When they finally spoke, Zhuge Liang’s incisive analysis of the strategic situation impressed Liu Bei deeply. Liu Bei’s sincerity in turn moved Zhuge Liang, who agreed to assist.

We usually remember the tale as proof of Liu Bei’s thirst for talent and respect for ability, which earned him lasting fame. Yet we often overlook Zhuge Liang’s own maneuver. After Liu Bei had already left his name on the first visit, could Zhuge Liang have been unaware? When Liu Bei stood waiting at the door, could the meticulous Zhuge Liang have failed to notice? Probably not. He was merely testing Liu Bei or raising the stakes of his own value.

In modern times, busyness has become an even stronger symbol of status. High-ranking officials schedule October appointments as early as January. Such people will not accept an invitation at once. Only those without money or position remain idle enough to respond immediately.

Sometimes the claim of busyness is genuine, but often it is a deliberate façade meant to emphasize one’s importance.

Take the entertainment industry. A minor actor who has just gained a little recognition receives a call from a director offering a major role. He will never blurt out, “Yes, yes, I’ll be there on time.” Instead he steadies himself, takes a deep breath, perhaps straightens his clothes, and replies slowly, “I’ll have to check my schedule first.” He then flips through a small notebook or whispers to his assistant before finally saying, “All right, I’ve arranged the time.”

He desperately wants the part, yet he cannot show it. He fears appearing cheap. By striking a slightly haughty pose and projecting an image of frantic activity, he makes others feel he is in demand and that securing him was an achievement.

If someone immediately agrees to your request, it is hard for them to project status; you may even look down on them. The same principle appears in bargaining: when you name a price and the seller accepts at once, you instinctively wonder whether you have overpaid.

In business circles the tactic is common. You ask an important client, "Mr. Zhang, would next Tuesday suit you? If so, I'll bring the revised proposal." The client rarely answers right away. After a pause he says, "I'll see how things stand. Contact my secretary in advance." Even if his calendar is clear, he chooses to signal that he cannot commit immediately, thereby displaying his importance.

No matter who the person is, he may not truly lack twenty minutes, yet he must appear to have no five minutes free. By doing so he lets you know that meeting you requires him to cancel other matters, creating the impression that you must not waste the opportunity.

Once you understand this psychology, you possess an effective remedy when important contacts decline. When they say they are busy, the best response is repeated, sincere invitations that acknowledge their heavy schedule. You might say, "Mr. Chen, I know you are extremely busy these days; I'm sorry to disturb you. Do you have any time at the end of this month?" If the first attempt fails, try again and again. When the other party feels the display of busyness has served its purpose, they will usually accept—provided your request genuinely interests them. They will not forgo a real opportunity merely to posture. Of course, if the invitation holds no appeal or they truly have no time, they may still refuse.

### **The task they ask you to handle "by the way" may be what they truly care about**

#### **Micro-expression Keywords**

People tend to mention what matters most first and relegate less important matters to the end. Yet sometimes the favor they ask you to perform "by the way" is actually their real concern. Because the true matter may not be entirely aboveboard, they invent another pretext and ask you to handle the important item incidentally. Recognizing their actual purpose prevents wasted effort.

We assume incidental tasks are unimportant, but people sometimes use this device when they feel awkward stating their real objective. For example, a department manager hands a subordinate a document and adds casually, "While you're there, could you check whether Section Chief Zhang is in his office?" Delivering the document is secondary; learning whether Section Chief Zhang is present is the manager's true intent.

When people are reluctant to reveal their real purpose, they often resort to this strategy.

Recently, department head Li Li noticed that an experienced employee's work quality and efficiency had declined. Direct criticism would have been awkward given the employee's seniority. Instead of reporting the matter or discussing it with colleagues, Li Li approached the employee for a candid conversation.

She began, "Master Wang, you are an outstanding technician. You have worked on this production line for years and your repairs have always satisfied customers. Many people praise your skill."

After a brief pause she continued, "This month the company plans to reward employees whose efficiency and quality rank highest. I thought I would drop by to see how your work is going and whether you need any help."

Wang understood the subtext: Li Li wanted to learn why his recent performance had slipped. He frankly explained that family issues had affected his mood and promised to improve.

Li Li's opening praise was not her goal; her goal was to assess his situation and offer support. By wrapping the implied criticism in compliments, she preserved his dignity and earned his gratitude.

Sales professionals employ the same method. Two cinemas competed by cutting prices. Cinema A offered 20 percent off; Cinema B countered with 50 percent off. In a fit of anger, A's owner slashed prices to 20 percent of face value. B's owner responded with 10 percent tickets plus a free bag of sunflower seeds.

A's owner assumed B would soon go bankrupt. Yet months later B's owner had replaced an old Santana with a new Audi A6 and purchased two apartments.

An inquiry revealed the secret: the 10 percent tickets and free seeds lost money, but the seeds were salted, making customers thirsty. B then sold sweet drinks, which increased thirst and drink sales. Packed houses plus beverage revenue more than offset the losses on tickets and seeds.

What appears to be a generous giveaway can conceal the real objective. Supermarkets, websites, and restaurants issue coupons not out of generosity but to drive repeat visits, often requiring a minimum spend. The coupon's true purpose is your next purchase.

The tactic echoes the idea of "the wine is not the point, the company is," or "making a feint to the east while attacking the west." When you hear phrases such as "if it's convenient..." or "by the way..." recognize that the speaker wants something. "You've made good progress, but pay more attention to details" is not praise; it signals that details are lacking. A neighbor who says, "You pick up your child every day—what a responsible father. If it's convenient, could you bring my son home this weekend? I have a client meeting..." is really asking for childcare help.

Discerning true intentions requires extra thought. Merchants' promotions promising "spend 300 yuan, get 50 yuan back" are not pure customer appreciation. Considering the motive helps avoid unnecessary spending. In interpersonal dealings, reflecting on "by the way" remarks lets you grasp the other party's real intent. When a superior assigns one task and then adds another "by the way," the incidental task may be the one that truly matters; failing to recognize this can cause disappointment.

## Facial Expressions

There is a saying that goes, when looking at a person, look at the face first. Generally speaking, a person's face is the essence of the entire body, and every face is unique. A small face can reveal the other person's age, gender, race, and so on, while the subtle expressions on the face directly reflect their inner thoughts at that moment. Therefore, in daily interpersonal interactions, the workplace, or business negotiations, observing the minute changes in the other person's expression to discern shifts in their inner state allows one to remain in a position of complete initiative, gaining every advantage and making things proceed more smoothly.

In general, there are many ways to see through a person's heart, and learning to read faces and observe expressions is one of the most important. Research by human psychologists has shown that in human psychological activity, facial expressions most clearly reflect emotional changes and serve as a channel for viewing a person's inner world, because even emotions deliberately buried deep inside will be reflected on the face inadvertently. From the perspective of traditional Chinese physiognomy, one can also predict a person's character and fate from facial shape and appearance. Although many modern people regard these folk fortune-telling theories as unscientific or even absurd, there is nevertheless a certain scientific basis and accuracy in inferring and judging character from facial expressions.

The American psychologist Bayer once conducted an experiment on whether expressions can reveal inner emotions. He had people make seven different expressions—anger, fear, seduction, helplessness, happiness, sadness, and indifference—recorded each one, and then showed the recordings to the public, asking viewers to guess what emotion each expression represented. After a period of study, the results showed that viewers correctly identified an average of only two emotions from the expressions. This demonstrated that even when performers deliberately produced an expression conveying a specific emotion, it was not easy for others to guess correctly. In ordinary social interactions, facial expressions appear in an instant; even expressions of melancholy can easily be mistaken for sadness. To see through a person's psychology from these minute movements requires mastering certain methods and techniques.

Hong Shen once wrote in *The Art of Film and Drama Performance*: "To complete an expression, the raising of an eyebrow is as necessary as the raising of an arm." Sha Ting's *The Acting County Magistrate* also states: "His movements were lively, and his face was highly expressive—truly 'crying when he wanted to cry, laughing when he wanted to laugh.'" This shows that rich facial expressions play an irreplaceable role in helping people interpret others' inner emotions.

The face is considered the most effective expressive organ, manifested primarily through changes in the eyes, eyebrows, mouth, nose, and facial muscles. The rich expressions of the face arise from the abundance of mimetic muscles, mostly located around the oral and palpebral fissures and belonging to the class of cranial muscles. Examples include the orbicularis oculi and orbicularis oris, which originate from the skull and insert into the skin. When these muscles contract, they alter the shape of the palpebral and oral fissures, producing expressions of joy, anger, sorrow, or pleasure. Facial wrinkles vary with changes in expression and also participate in speech.

Among all living beings, human expressions are the richest and most complex. Facial expressions are a product of evolution and are closely linked to humanity's unique skill—language. Before language emerged, people communicated with the outside world through simple body language or other means, expressing only the simplest and most primitive needs, such as joy, anger, sorrow, pleasure, surprise, and fear. Facial expression was one of these methods. The phrase "voice and expression both full" describes the emotion produced when language and expression work together. Even today, when the human language system is highly developed, people still add facial expressions and other body language when giving speeches or trying to persuade others more effectively. At the same time, every human face is different and possesses its own unique characteristics; even twins who look almost identical will show differences when their faces are examined closely.

Human interaction requires expression, and expressions become richer in emotion because of interaction. Every country and ethnicity in the world shares the same rich and complex facial expressions of happiness, sadness, calmness, and anger; these expressions reflect a person's true inner feelings. "Every movement of a person's mind is shown on the face, clearly and distinctly drawn." This is how Diderot evaluated human expression in his *Essay on Painting*. In other words, the expression on every person's face can reveal their inner physiological and mental state, so even a tiny expression can betray one's true emotions.

Expressions such as joy, anger, sorrow, and pleasure are conveyed through facial movements, and the specific actions of the face vary according to fluctuations in inner emotion. After in-depth research on facial expressions, American scholar Wolff found that changes in the left and right sides of the face are not symmetrical; expressions generally begin on the left side first. Wolff pointed out in his paper that when a person expresses inner emotion, changes on the left side of the face occur faster and more intensely than on the right. This is because the human brain is divided into two hemispheres. Normally, the right hemisphere

controls and sends signals of genuine inner emotion, and the physiological response is reflected on the left side of the face. The left hemisphere can be called the rational-emotion area; it generally sends signals related to emotion, which are then reflected on the right side of the face. In simple terms, the left side of the face mostly reflects a person's true inner emotions, while the right side may display false emotion. Therefore, if you want to understand the other person's true thoughts, pay attention to changes in the left side of their face during conversation. This allows you to discern their psychological state, obtain a favorable position, and make things proceed as you wish.

As early as the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods, there was the story of Chunyu Kun reading faces. By observing people's facial expressions to discern their psychological motives, he was regarded by many as having prophetic abilities.

At that time, King Hui of Liang was ambitiously recruiting talented scholars from across the realm. Someone repeatedly recommended Chunyu Kun to the king, saying that his talent was comparable to that of Guan Zhong and Yan Ying and that he was worthy of an important court position. Eager for talent, King Hui summoned Chunyu Kun twice. Both times, Chunyu Kun remained silent, leaving the lofty king embarrassed. After the two meetings, King Hui began to reproach the recommender for suggesting someone so taciturn and ungrateful. The puzzled recommender asked Chunyu Kun for an explanation. Chunyu Kun smiled indifferently and replied, "Actually, I very much wanted to have a heart-to-heart talk with the king. The first time I saw him, his face showed the look of someone eager to gallop about—clearly preoccupied with entertainment such as chariot driving—so I stayed silent. The second time, I saw on his face an expression of pleasure-seeking and guessed he was thinking of sensual entertainments and had no desire to chat, so again I said nothing." The recommender relayed these words to King Hui, who could not help but admire Chunyu Kun's powers of observation. From then on, Chunyu Kun was given important responsibilities at court. It is clear that knowing how to observe a person's micro-expressions not only allows one to discern others' thoughts but also creates more opportunities for advancement.

## Emotional Behavior

In academic terms, emotion is defined as a sudden reaction to an important internal or external event; a subject always reacts to the same event in the same way. Emotions are short-lived and consist of a coordinated set of responses involving language, physiology, behavior, and neural mechanisms.[3]

From another perspective, emotion is also a survival mechanism that animals evolved and that was continuously accumulated and strengthened through evolution, because emotion can provide simple solutions to problems frequently faced by ancient humans, such as generating fear and deciding to flee[4][5] or generating anger and deciding to fight.

Simply put, the emotion mechanism is the behavioral drive produced after an animal cognitively appraises an external stimulus. It follows the simplest logic, like the most straightforward brute: whatever it thinks, it does, without any scruples.

When something unexpected yet desired occurs, the surprise emotion drives behavior and enhances information gathering.

Faced with a negative stimulus, first assess relative strength. If weaker than oneself, respond with disgust and move away or drive it off; if roughly equal, respond with anger and attack to protect one's interests; if stronger, respond with fear and flee or hide; if damage has already occurred and cannot be undone, abandon effort.

If the stimulus is positive, respond with joyful excitement.

This simple mechanism evolved by animals ensures they adapt to the environment, survive, and reproduce.

For example, while lying on a dentist's chair undergoing tooth extraction, the anesthetic has taken effect and there is no pain. The doctor is using a drill and chisel to remove the diseased tooth. Rationally, one trusts the doctor completely; the professionally trained technique is causing little pain and will certainly produce a good outcome. The entire event is entirely positive and beneficial. Therefore, one cooperates, does not move or refuse, shows no displeasure or fear, and may even smile and say it does not hurt while praising the doctor's skill.

Yet observe your own body. Are the fingers tense? Are the arms inadvertently exerting force? Is the torso unable to relax completely?

This is the emotional behavior triggered by fear. Your cortex tells you there is nothing to fear; this is a good thing. But other regions of the brain and most of the nervous system do not reason; they generate a fear-type emotion in response to the stimulus and prepare the body for fight or flight. This reaction is especially obvious in children, whose limited social knowledge keeps them closer to the natural responses of small animals.

Imagine extracting a tooth from a conscious lion—what would be the result?

With the evolution of social civilization, few people can act wantonly using only simple single-layer logic; most autonomous behavior follows social rules. Nevertheless, human emotion still exerts great influence on behavioral decisions.

Unlike animal emotion, the vast majority of human emotions are triggered by social affairs. People experience many events every day. The brain must first treat the complex array of social behaviors as stimuli, then, on the premise of understanding social rules, perform cognition and feeling, which in turn triggers internal appraisal and emotional drive. Emotion, however, remains a survival mechanism closer to animal nature and follows a single-layer logical chain of judgment and decision-making, so it produces numerous physiological and behavioral changes. Although the cortex intervenes in the generation and execution of decisions during cognition and decision-making, many physiological reactions and behaviors still cannot be constrained by reason.

For example, after anger arises, gaze focuses on the stimulus source, heart rate increases, blood pressure rises, breathing quickens, pores open, sweat secretion increases, and muscles contract in preparation. Particularly intense anger can cause hair to stand on end, while digestive activity decreases, saliva secretion diminishes, and gastrointestinal peristalsis slows. This state is better suited for running, fighting, or confronting and helps the individual gain an advantage in combat, or at least avoids adding physiological burden.

Even when modern civilized individuals encounter extremely anger-provoking events, they must consider the constraints of social rules. One cannot casually fight, because fighting may bring police intervention under public-security procedures, wasting more time or even incurring social punishment. When treated unfairly by a boss, one may feel aggrieved and angry yet will not charge forward and bite like a lion; at most one will stare with resentful eyes, clench fists, or raise volume and speech rate, while language and overall demeanor still conform to social norms, even including ingratiating or submissive content.

Those minute changes in gaze, muscle tension, and energy display nevertheless match the most primitive features of anger expression. By capturing these traces, one can understand the person's true feelings.

Now to answer the question:

**The word “micro” is extremely important.**

We do not look at the person’s social performance; those are prepared “performances,” possibly even specially trained. We look only at the tiny reactions that social behavior has not masked. Although minute in form and brief in duration, they express the person’s true feelings and cognition—that is, physiological and emotional state. Finally, one especially important precondition is—

**“One-way expression, no analysis.”**

### **3.6.1 Upper Facial Expression Muscles**

#### **1. Frontalis**

The frontalis lies in the forehead above the eyebrows and is bilaterally symmetrical. Its fibers blend with adjacent muscles, including the procerus, corrugator supercilii, and orbicularis oculi, thereby moving and influencing the entire eyebrow and eye region.

When the frontalis is relaxed, the forehead skin is flat, with no expressive change from the eyebrows upward to the hairline. When it contracts, it raises the eyebrows and the corresponding skin, forming wrinkles in the forehead skin. In adults (not infants or the elderly), two to three wrinkles appear. At the same time, the elevation of the eyebrows naturally lifts the root of the upper eyelid. If the eyes are open, this action increases the degree to which the eyes are open—more technically, it enlarges the palpebral fissure.

#### **2. Corrugator supercilii**

The corrugator supercilii is a small, cone-shaped muscle located at the medial end of the eyebrow and is bilaterally symmetrical. It lies hidden beneath the frontalis and orbicularis oculi (which is why it is drawn separately on the opposite side of the face in diagrams) and partially fuses with them.

Working together with the orbicularis oculi, the corrugator supercilii pulls the eyebrows downward and inward, causing the eyebrows to bulge above the eyes to shield them from strong light. The frowning action produces vertical skin lines on the nasal forehead.

#### **3. Procerus**

The procerus lies between the glabella and the nasal root and is bilaterally symmetrical.

It pulls the glabella downward, producing transverse skin lines between the medial canthi and at the nasal tip. It participates in frowning and brow-concentration movements and likewise helps shield the eyes from excessive light.

#### **4. Levator palpebrae superioris**

Although small, the levator palpebrae superioris has a relatively complex anatomical structure and lies mainly inside the upper eyelid; it is bilaterally symmetrical.

Its function is to elevate the upper eyelid. Contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris raises the upper eyelid—the action of opening the eyes. Contraction of the orbicularis oculi and relaxation of the levator palpebrae superioris closes the eyes. In addition, the levator palpebrae superioris is connected via check ligaments to the superior rectus muscle that controls eye movement; when the eyeball performs an upward gaze, the upper eyelid automatically rises while the eyebrows are lifted by the frontalis.

Eyelid position depends on the coordinated action of the orbicularis oculi and levator palpebrae superioris as well as the degree of eyeball protrusion. When the eyes are opened in a relaxed state, the lower eyelid margin normally passes at the level of the inferior limbus, and the upper eyelid covers half the vertical diameter of the iris (one-quarter of the vertical diameter).

The levator palpebrae superioris contains smooth-muscle components (Müller's muscle), which are controlled solely by the autonomic nervous system and therefore not subject to voluntary conscious control. When a person is in a state of fear or excitement, sympathetic activation causes the smooth muscle in the tarsal plates to contract, widening the eyes (enlarging the palpebral fissure). When sympathetic activity is inhibited (for example, during intoxication), the upper eyelid droops. Sympathetic contraction can also produce conditions such as Horner syndrome.

## 5. Orbicularis oculi

The orbicularis oculi is a broad, flat, elliptical muscle, bilaterally symmetrical, surrounding the orbit and extending inward into the eyelids.

Its location is of great strategic importance. Originating near the medial side of the nose, its fibers form a complete ellipse that connects most of the muscles of the upper face:

- ① Superiorly, some fibers blend with the frontalis and corrugator supercilii.
- ② Medially, some fibers reach the superolateral portion of the procerus.
- ③ Inferiorly, some fibers variously cover or blend with neighboring muscles, including the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, levator labii superioris, and zygomaticus minor.

Thus the orbicularis oculi becomes the central connection point for the muscles of the upper face: above it moves the eyebrows via the frontalis and corrugator supercilii; medially it connects to the procerus at the nasal root; below it moves and influences the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, levator labii superioris, and zygomaticus minor. Whenever the orbicularis oculi contracts, it necessarily draws these muscles into coordinated movement; conversely, contraction of the surrounding muscles stretches the orbicularis oculi, altering the morphology of the eye region.

Because of this strategically important position, the orbicularis oculi plays a significant role in important facial expressions and various ocular reflexes.

The palpebral portion of the orbicularis oculi can freely pull to close the eyelids easily, as in sleep or protective blinking in response to light. Its most important function is to close the eyes tightly or produce eyelid-closure movements while simultaneously depressing and tightening the eyebrows, cooperatively reducing the amount of light entering the eyes. During traction of the entire orbicularis oculi, radial skin folds form at the lateral canthus; after middle age these folds often become permanent—the so-called crow's feet.

In addition, contraction of the orbicularis oculi indirectly affects the muscles of the lower face, producing slight elevation of the upper lip and cheek prominence. These effects are indirect because the primary muscles responsible for upper-lip elevation and cheek prominence are not the orbicularis oculi; they will be described in detail later.

Consequently, morphological changes of the eyes and surrounding area possess very powerful expressive power, all determined by the strategic position of the orbicularis oculi. Observing changes in the eyes and their surroundings is key to capturing expression changes.

## 1. Physiological Expressions

Physiological expressions fall into four major categories: comfort and pain, attention and absent-mindedness. These four categories of expressions are triggered entirely by physiological stimuli, with distinct forms and shared characteristics. Of course, they subsequently give rise to related emotions.

### (1) Comfort



When a stimulus triggers physiological comfort, humans close their eyes, with the eyeballs rolling upward during closure (this movement is visible while the eyes are closing). At the same time, the closing action occurs without forceful contraction of the orbital part of the orbicularis oculi muscle.

During this process, the eyebrows may remain still or lift slightly, incidentally raising the upper eyelids (though the eyelids stay closed). The amplitude of the eyebrow movement is proportional to the degree of comfort (enjoyment).

If the stimulus is intense—for example, loud, fast-paced music, strongly flavored food, or powerful smells or tactile sensations—it produces an eyebrow raise combined with both upper and lower lips being drawn inward and bitten by the teeth. This form of comfort expression is essentially a resistance to sadness, an enjoyment and satisfaction derived indirectly from physiological discomfort. The greater the distortion of the eyebrows and the stronger the lip-biting force, the more intense the enjoyment.

It is usually accompanied by a deep inhalation.

## (2) Pain

When a stimulus exceeds a certain threshold and the brain receives signals from sensory organs that it registers as harmful, a pain expression appears. Physically, the person draws a deep breath while muscles tense in resistance and defense. On the face, the orbital and palpebral parts of the orbicularis oculi contract simultaneously, closing the eyes and forming pronounced compression wrinkles. The intensity of pain is proportional to the degree of closure. Unless the pain is unbearable, most pain expressions keep the eyes from closing completely; this may be a remnant morphological feature from when prey in nature, even while being bitten, still retained the intention to resist and escape.

While the muscles contract vigorously to close the eyes, the pain expression also shows three additional features: teeth clenching, horizontal lip stretching, upper-lip raising, and lower-lip pulling. The upper and lower teeth are forced together by contraction of the masseter muscles, which become prominent; the levator labii superioris group raises the upper lip while the depressor labii inferioris pulls the lower lip downward, exposing both sets of teeth—the more severe the pain, the greater the exposed area. Contraction of the platysma keeps the corners of the mouth horizontal, balancing the actions of the levator labii superioris group and depressor labii inferioris so that the mouth corners stretch horizontally outward. The buccinator contracts together with the orbicularis oculi and levator labii superioris group, bunching the cheek skin and partially covering the lower half of the iris with the lower eyelid.

It is usually accompanied by a deep inhalation.

The expressions triggered by these two physiological states are always extremely full in amplitude—intensely pleasurable enjoyment, intensely unpleasant pain, or highly conflicted composite forms. Examples include the enjoyment expression when tasting delicious food or hearing beautiful music, the pain expression when pulling hard in a tug-of-war or suffering an injury, and the unburdened, unfeigned contorted expression of sexual climax.

These two categories of expressions also appear in many other contexts:

- **Comfort:** enjoyment during a moderate massage, the pleasure of slight intoxication from a small drink, the warmth and relaxation of a hot bath after fatigue, and so on;
- **Pain:** the expression triggered by biting cold, the expression elicited by scalding water, the breathless expression after an all-out 800-meter sprint, the restrained expression when inner pain has no outlet,

and so on;

- **Composite:** the expression during a deep-tissue massage, the expression while getting a tattoo, the expression while singing heavy-metal rock, and so on.

More remarkably, these three types of expressions are morphologically very similar—eyelid closure, orbicularis oculi contraction, platysma contraction that stretches the mouth corners horizontally outward, depressor anguli oris contraction that pulls the mouth corners downward, and depressor labii inferioris contraction that lowers the lower lip. Such expressions can be observed simply by participating in or watching people's faces in the situations listed above. Each expression quite directly maps the actor's true feelings and cognitive appraisal, because it is elicited by changes in their physiological state.

### (3) Attention

The two hallmarks of the attention expression are: furrowed brows plus passive eyelid movement, and gaze directed at the stimulus source. Gaze direction is an easily observed indicator, yet furrowed brows plus passive eyelid movement are easily confused with the brow-and-eye combinations seen in disgust or anger expressions.

In disgust, when the brows furrow, the amplitude of eyelid closure exceeds the passive-movement value (the person's baseline is below three-quarters), especially with upward movement of the lower eyelid, exposing the middle segment of the iris, and often accompanied by upper-lip raising.

In anger, when the brows furrow, the eyelids do not merely descend under pressure but expand vertically on the outer sides. This is also often accompanied by upper-lip raising.

### (4) Absent-mindedness

The two hallmarks of the absent-minded expression are: the upper eyelids naturally droop to the upper edge of the pupils, and the gaze is unfocused. An unfocused gaze differs from attention in two ways: there is no focal point, and any movement that occurs follows the rotation of the head (face) rather than leading it. If an eyebrow raise occurs while the upper-eyelid margin remains at the upper pupil edge, absent-mindedness is even more certain. Absent-mindedness typically appears during dejection or intoxication. (See Chapter 10 of this book for details.)

### Question 1: What Is a Micro-reaction ()?

The full name of micro-reaction (微反应) is psychological stress micro-reaction.

A psychological stress micro-reaction is an "inadvertent" action a person makes after receiving an effective stimulus.

In interactions with others—especially adversarial ones—no one wants others to see obvious signs of losing composure. Losing composure is one form of micro-reaction; it lays bare one's true state of mind and makes one appear "weak" in front of an opponent. Therefore, once people notice they are losing composure, they immediately try to suppress, conceal, or even disguise their true state.

However, losing composure counts only as a low-level "micro" reaction because it is too obvious. Reactions that truly qualify as "micro" are not easily detected by an opponent and sometimes are invisible even to one's own side. Like losing composure, a micro-reaction is also a momentary loss of control over internal emotions

and external behavior, except that the loss of control is very brief, the morphological change is small, and the person usually covers it with a fluid, seamless masking action.

After professional study and training, both humans and machines can learn specific methods to observe these inconspicuous movements and thereby decode the person's true feelings and cognition.

### **Restatement: What is a micro-reaction?**

A psychological stress micro-reaction is an inadvertent action a person makes after receiving an effective stimulus.

Because the person will attempt to mask it, any obvious reaction you can easily see is very likely one the person deliberately performs for you to see. What truly merits attention are the "inadvertent" (not made by choice) small reactions—those the person did not notice or could not fully conceal. Behind these small reactions are usually powerful habits, emotions, or even physiological needs issuing commands. Once these patterned reaction forms are observed, one can begin to infer the person's true feelings and cognition.

### **Example:**

A person wearing light clothing shivers in the cold wind, face etched with suffering.

You ask, "Cold?"

The person immediately straightens the chest and replies loudly, "Not cold." While answering, the person slightly tightens the arms and shoulders yet still cannot suppress the shivering; the shivering merely becomes less obvious because of the effort.

Which are the micro-reactions? Is the person cold or not?

The shivering and the tightening of the arms and shoulders are micro-reactions—behavioral commands issued by physiological need. The person is cold.

### **Another example:**

A subordinate official picks up the leader's bedpan with a smile, saying solicitously, "Don't move, don't move. You're ill and need proper rest; I'll take care of it."

After leaving the room, the smile remains on the face, but the arms are held as straight as possible to keep the bedpan as far from the nostrils as possible, and the person walks while holding the breath.

Which are the deliberate displays and which are the uncontrollable micro-reactions? Which reveal the person's true feelings?

The smile and the words are deliberately performed for the observer. The distancing and avoidance of the foul object reflect the person's true cognition—disgust.

Yet humans are complex: even while physiologically disgusted and repelled, they can express respect and closeness through contradictory behavior.

Even more astonishing is that many people actually believe this performance!

### **Final example:**

The leader calls Xiao Zhang into the office, pats his shoulder, personally pulls out a chair, and invites him to sit. Leaning slightly forward with a kindly expression, the leader says with a smile, "The leadership team has reviewed your performance and found you outstanding in every respect—virtue, ability, diligence, achievement, and integrity. We are therefore considering a promotion and giving you more responsibility."

At this point the leader pauses and studies Xiao Zhang.

Seeing Xiao Zhang respond with modesty and caution, the leader continues, "However, there is currently no suitable position at group headquarters. There is a deputy-general-manager post in one of the regional divisions, one level above your current rank. Although conditions there are more difficult, it offers valuable experience and accumulation of credentials. What do you think? Whether you stay here a while longer or go to the region first for training, the final choice is yours; the leadership team will essentially respect your decision."

Xiao Zhang cannot make an immediate choice between the two options. After a brief hesitation, the leader no longer leans forward but reclines against the chair back, lights a cigarette, and watches him with an air of nonchalance.

Readers are invited to guess: among all these actions by the leader, which are deliberate and which are micro-reactions?

What is the leader's true intention—genuine trust and promotion, or an apparent promotion that is actually a demotion?

### 3.1 Must Inner Emotions Have Outer Expressions?

Inner emotions must have outer expressions, because both the internal neural states and the external manifestations serve important physiological functions; unlike thoughts, they cannot be retained purely in the brain without leaving traces.

Every movement of the human musculature has a physiological purpose, and facial-muscle movements are no exception. For example, frowning, besides signaling anger, doubt, or pain, can also indirectly close the upper and lower eyelids partially, altering the way the visual system receives information (see Figure 3-1); pressing the lips together, besides indicating displeasure, can prevent the instinctive urge to spit out bitter medicine (see Figure 3-2). In other words, the facial expressions we take for granted not only convey meaning but also possess direct or indirect physiological functions.

Some of these physiological functions remain effective today; others have become evolutionary instincts that were once adaptive in ancient times.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3-1]*

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3-2]*

Consider the threat expression: the action of raising the upper lip to expose the canine teeth is not unique to humans. Many wild animals open their mouths and bare sharp teeth before fighting. This facial (animals do have faces) movement is essentially what we call an expression (see Figure 3-3).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3-3]*

Human expressions, of course, can convey richer meanings. For instance, people smile at each other before a friendly discussion; furrowed brows are common when arguing a point; eyes widen in disbelief upon hearing that a model couple has suddenly divorced; a person may inadvertently curl one corner of the mouth upward (academically termed unilateral mouth-corner raise) upon hearing a self-important individual hold forth, signaling contempt; during conflict one may glare or even curse; while watching a horror film one may gasp while the eyes widen and a chill runs down the spine; at the farewell of a deceased loved one, the grieving person's eyes grow dull, yet the brows are involuntarily lifted in an effort to stay composed.

We must therefore clarify two questions here:

1. Does the presence of emotion necessarily produce an expression?

To answer this, the key premise is that genuine emotion is present. When no suppression or disguise is required, emotion will elicit a relatively full expression that adequately conveys both the quality and intensity of the feeling. In modern society, interactions follow many social norms, so situations allowing unrestrained expression are rare; emotional display is often constrained. Under such conditions, expressions become more subtle or even take the form of "face-heart discord" disguise expressions, as if everyone were wearing a "social mask." Yet, unlike an actual mask, the human face cannot remain completely motionless. Whenever emotion arises, every subtle facial movement is commanded by the nervous system (a corpse does not move) and carries specific meaning—or, in the occupational parlance of this field, analytical value. Even when the face appears as still as water, slight eye movements can reveal the person's inner state (see Chapter 10).

Therefore, the answer is: whenever emotion appears, it triggers facial expressions. These expressions may be simple or complex, but they will certainly include genuine emotional reactions and may also include processed or controlled disguise expressions.

2. Does the presence of an expression necessarily indicate the presence of emotion?

The answer is: not necessarily. Over years of accumulation since birth, people can produce common expressions at will; this is even easier for actors, who can precisely control a single eye to shed a tear within two seconds. Therefore, merely observing an expression does not confirm that the corresponding emotion has arisen internally. In psychological testing, to maximize the chance of confirming inner states through observation of subtle expressive changes, an essential step must be added—effective stimulation. Effective stimulation means designing a stimulus source tailored to the tested individual's specific circumstances so as to elicit genuine emotion. Once genuine emotion is aroused, it is expressed through facial behavior, and our task is to filter out the false and capture the true.

## **Your Observation Platform: The Airport**

The airport is the best place to observe the full panorama of people's behavioral dynamics. It is like a wonderful experimental building that allows you to observe countless nonverbal cues, which can reveal people's thoughts, feelings, and attitudes.

By observing the body language of every passenger arriving or preparing to depart, you can infer their mental state. In addition, you can judge whether they are worried about missing a flight, whether they are about to visit friends or relatives, or whether they are expecting someone to meet them...

As shown in the figure below: a businesswoman sits in an airport terminal seat, waiting for her flight's boarding announcement. You will notice that she sits upright, her body stiff, her back constrained, her ankles motionless, and her hands tightly clasped.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.1 紧张的女商人]*

From these nonverbal cues, we can infer that the businesswoman is currently tense and anxious, and further deduce that she fears flying or is worried about flight delays, perhaps because she might miss an important appointment.

In front of this businesswoman, three male businessmen are making phone calls. You will observe that the first man sits there anxiously, his eyes fixed on the laptop resting on his lap. His shoulders are stiff, his jacket buttoned neatly, as if he is about to attend a meeting. In addition, his facial expression is very serious.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.2 全身心投入业务的男商人]*

From this we can determine that the businessman is talking to someone, perhaps his boss. He is extremely eager to impress the other party, to convince them, or to influence them to some degree.

The second man on the phone appears quite relaxed. He casually crosses his legs, one hand supporting the back of his head, his body leaning slightly backward, smiling and approachable. It is not difficult to infer that he is speaking with someone familiar, possibly his wife or an old friend.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.3 轻松悠闲的男商人]*

The third man leans his body forward, speaking in a low voice, attempting to create a private space amid the crowded airport flow. You will notice that he raises one hand to cover the left side of his face, his eyes cast downward, as if unwilling to let others see his expression. By observing his body language, we conclude that he is acting secretly, possibly planning a transaction or meeting that cannot be seen by others.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.4 秘密行事的男商人]*

At the baggage claim, you will see a family group—easily identified by their similar walking gaits. Observe closely: are they anticipating a pleasant holiday together? Or is there some tension in their relationships? Does this tension indicate that something unpleasant occurred during their journey? Use your intuition to judge.

If today is a weekend, many travelers' family members or friends will be there to meet them, so you will witness many touching scenes of hugs and kisses. These physical actions are all nonverbal expressions of love and joy.

Alternatively, you may see some travelers collect their luggage and head straight to the parking lot or the curb where taxis are waiting. At this point, note whether they walk quickly or stroll leisurely. A person's walking speed can give you deeper insight into how important their trip is.

You will also find some people waiting anxiously, constantly checking their watches or looking toward the direction from which vehicles are arriving; others grip their phones tightly, as if waiting for a call.

As you can see, the airport offers many different people and scenes for you to observe. So the next time you fly, arrive at the airport early, put down your book or magazine, and spend some time observing the people around you. You will see many different postures that provide sufficient hints and clues to infer their current

mental state and thereby deduce their thoughts and feelings. If the subjects are with others, observing how they interact allows you to infer the nature of their relationships.

In short, the longer you observe and interpret others' behavior, the more skilled your "people-reading" technique becomes.

#### 4. Flawed Research Examples

Researchers from the Department of Psychology at Princeton University, including Hillel Aviezer, published their findings in the journal *Science* on November 30, 2012. The paper argues that without corresponding body language, people cannot accurately judge others' emotions solely through "reading faces and observing expressions."

The article caused a sensation upon release because it appeared in a top-tier scientific journal and was regarded by many as "self-evidently" correct. Some research institutions even began using it to promote themselves and suppress competitors. A single "personal view" intended for peer review became an authority and a weapon, generating considerable excitement.

The study used Google to select photographs of professional tennis players at moments of high emotion on the court as experimental material, exploring the accuracy with which subjects could identify genuine and intense human expressions, since in top-level professional tennis tournaments, players' expressions at critical points are often distorted by strong emotions.

At this point in the introduction, we can see that this paper, like the one mentioned in Case One, is essentially a study of expression recognition rather than an analysis or derivation of micro-expressions. Both contain the word "expression," yet their research cores and methods differ greatly.

The paper's experiments found that when subjects viewed complete photographs of athletes holding racquets on the court, they could easily identify the athletes' emotions. However, when the athletes' bodies were removed and only their contorted faces remained, the subjects could no longer determine whether the emotions were elation or dejection. When only the faces were removed and the bodies retained, people could still accurately judge whether the athletes had scored or lost a point. More interestingly, the researchers swapped heads and bodies among photographs of winners, losers, and people in sexual climax, finding that whether the same facial expression was identified as "positive" or "negative" depended entirely on which body it was attached to.

The article therefore concludes that people mistakenly believe emotional information comes from the face, when in fact bodily expression allows more accurate grasp of a person's emotional state.

This study has nothing to do with micro-expressions; even its expression recognition component targets only the most intense expressions. Because its "destructive power" is considerable, we will explicitly point out the following errors in this article that denies the effectiveness of judging emotions from expressions:

1. One-sided expressions should not serve as research material. How can one guarantee that the "intense expressions" produced by athletes on the court contain no performative elements? The more commercialized the event, the more athletes need to perform, because commercial interests are involved. Whether they appear arrogant or humble, struggling or effortless, there is theoretically always the possibility that they are "performing for the audience and sponsors," so such material should not be used to identify and analyze genuine emotions. Of course, using footage from sports competitions is more reliable than using public speeches, because during intense matches people do reduce control

over social behavior, but this does not mean all expressions are genuine emotional displays, since there is no way to prove the correspondence between such expressions and emotions. If we assume the athletes' expressions are entirely unadulterated, then they belong to the category of physiological expressions; the three types of physiological expressions inherently overlap substantially, so failure to distinguish them is normal. This is an erroneous conclusion stemming from unclear definition of the research object.

2. What mindset do people have when they allow themselves to be filmed or photographed during sexual climax? Are they completely naturally immersed and enjoying themselves, or might they be exaggerating or suppressing? How can such material be used as a replacement comparison object? Identification data from such comparisons carry no persuasive power.

Thus, the samples the authors compared, which appear very different, are in fact physiological expressions sharing the same morphological features; it is unsurprising that subjects showed low recognition rates. Using this to claim that expressions cannot effectively convey emotion is merely the performance of the ignorant claiming there is "nothing to discuss."

Institutions that genuinely study emotions and micro-expressions should criticize this *Science* paper for drawing conclusions without even clarifying the most basic classification of expressions. Unfortunately, many institutions and individual scholars still primarily cite and venerate it—a strange phenomenon that merits reflection.

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#### 4. Scenario Construction

Sometimes, to achieve more complex objectives, auditory, visual, behavioral, and performative factors are combined to design a scenario in which the target is placed without their knowledge, eliciting various reactions.

A film once depicted this method in detail; its English title is *The Truman Show*. The protagonist has been placed since childhood inside a scene constructed for a television program. Every street, house, object, neighbor, and person around him was arranged by the program; even the sky and ocean are virtual. Over the decades of his growth, every event and even every line of dialogue was scripted, yet he himself remained unaware. At the end of the film, the male lead walks out of this virtual world at all costs.

In criminal investigation and criminal psychology research, scenario-construction stimuli are also frequently employed. For example, investigators and relevant witnesses are positioned in the original crime scene; based on physical evidence, logical inference, witness statements, and other information, the suspect is required to reenact the crime process in order to help the suspect recall more details or verify whether prior statements hold. When the suspect is unknown, investigators may reenact the scenario in the suspect's role to help identify more psychological and behavioral characteristics of the perpetrator and narrow the scope of the investigation.

Many real-world scams employ the same technique. In 2014, fraudsters rented space in an industrial park, disguised themselves as stationed military personnel, and posted "soldiers" in camouflage at the entrance to prevent outsiders from entering. They also spent heavily to install slogans such as "Listen to the Party's commands, build the maritime frontier" on the roof of the rented office building. Even police attempting to enter for investigation were refused by the "soldiers" on guard, who cited the area as a military restricted zone closed to unauthorized persons.

The fraudsters created a highly realistic environment and claimed externally that a large infrastructure project was open for bidding, tricking bidding companies into paying various fees. After the case was cracked, prosecutors verified that the amount involved exceeded tens of millions of yuan.

Regardless of the stimulus method used, once the stimulus source takes effect, the target produces a large number of related reactions. The next task is to screen these reactions. The target's responses may include social behaviors, emotional behaviors, and physiological behaviors appearing in combination. Based on the characteristics of the different behaviors, once emotional and physiological behaviors are identified, psychological analysis of the target can proceed.

This final step of psychological analysis is essentially an attempt to establish a causal link between the stress response and the stimulus source.

For example, if the suspect across from you is suspected of serial murder, then the following set of stimulus sources and responses may hold major investigative value.

Investigators show the suspect crime-scene and autopsy photographs from several recent murder cases and say: "The killing methods in these recent cases, although still using knives, seem much cruder than in the earlier ones!"

The suspect at this moment interlaces his ten fingers, stretches his body, leans his torso against the chair back, crosses and slightly extends his legs, and displays a trace of contempt on his face—short of disgust.

Although the suspect does not speak, analysis of his micro-reactions (微反应 (micro-reaction)) reveals the following responses:

- Interlaced fingers indicate a high level of self-control posture;
- Stretching the body and leaning the torso back are external signs of a relaxed mindset;
- Crossed and swinging legs are external signs of a dominant psychological state;
- The contempt expression maps an inner sense of superiority and negative evaluation;
- Not speaking is a social response that clearly expresses the suspect's decision not to respond.

This entire series of responses stems from the crime-scene photographs and the investigator's comment.

What kind of person, after such a stimulus source, would exhibit relaxed, superior, and negative subjective cognition? One logical explanation fits: these cases do not increase his culpability, hence the relaxation; the methods and results fall short of the level he believes himself capable of, hence the contempt. If this causal link holds, the suspect's degree of suspicion rises substantially. Although he did not respond verbally and engaged in self-suppression, the emotional reactions that leaked out still provided major investigative clues. These two emotional reactions would not simultaneously emanate from an innocent person.

## Greeting Your Own Expressions

Try doing this: stand in front of a mirror that shows your entire face, smile, frown, and pout. You will notice that as these facial expressions appear one after another, no corresponding emotions arise. In other words, smiling does not mean you are happy, frowning does not mean you are angry or worried, and pouting does not bring feelings of rejection or disdain. You can fully control the movement of your facial muscles.

Yet if you conclude from this that emotions and expressions have no necessary connection, you would be gravely mistaken.

You can certainly say that the presence of an expression does not necessarily indicate the corresponding emotion. However, when a genuine emotion exists, you must acknowledge that an expression will appear. But why do some people display one thing on their face while feeling something else inside, without others noticing? It is because most people cannot distinguish genuine expressions from fake ones.

Under the pressure of a series of social norms, everyone lives wearing a mask. For example, when meeting someone you dislike but cannot afford to offend due to various pressures, you will still smile despite inner disgust. Or when extremely angry yet unable to vent in public, you pretend to remain calm. Beyond social norms, some wear masks to conceal lies. Regardless of the reason, facial expressions convey only two messages: what one wants others to know and what one does not want others to know.

So what are genuine expressions? What are fake expressions?

Simply put, genuine expressions are unconscious reactions—for instance, the joy that lights up the face upon hearing good news—uncontrolled and without deliberate thought. Fake expressions are deliberately disguised ones, conscious reactions, such as a child showing a smile to parents while craving a toy.

Whether genuine or fake, the basic emotions remain the same: happiness, anger, sadness, disgust, surprise, fear, contempt, and so on. Frequently these emotions do not appear in isolation; anger and disgust may occur together, or surprise and fear together. This produces diversity and complexity in facial expressions. In addition, the escalation or de-escalation of emotional intensity produces different expressions, such as shifting from happiness to sadness or from impatience to rage.

The greatest difference between fake and genuine expressions lies in the mismatch between emotion and expression. For example, when you are happy but hear a friend's complaint, you must adopt an expression of regret that matches your friend's mood. The ability to consciously control one's expressions is not learned only in adulthood. As young children, we often hear parental instructions such as "When someone greets you, smile back—that is polite," "When someone gives you something, show happiness," and "Don't keep a straight face all the time; it makes people uncomfortable." Over time, learning to control expressions and conceal true emotions becomes a habit and a principle of conduct, known as display rules (表现准则).

Setting aside the complexity that display rules introduce, expressions themselves number in the thousands, some lacking any corresponding descriptive word. Differences in intensity, simultaneous occurrences, timing,

and duration further complicate the task of distinguishing genuine from fake expressions.

This does not mean we are helpless. Through extensive experimental research and practical experience, psychologist Paul Ekman summarized a set of “most seductive facial cues,” namely micro-expressions (微表情). Through micro-expressions, people can read the authenticity of expressions with greater subtlety. This analysis technique was adopted by the FBI in the early 1990s and remains in use today.

## **Observing a Series of Body Movements**

Every posture a person adopts is like a word in language. To understand a language, we must combine words into sentences or paragraphs; only then can complete thoughts be expressed. Therefore, determining whether a group of gestures aligns with spoken language requires time. Likewise, identifying inconsistent movements to negate everything you hear demands repeated practice.

When observing someone, first consider all their words and gestures, then extract the main information, form complete sentences and paragraphs, and finally reach a conclusion. Do not focus solely on one sentence or one visible action. To ensure accuracy, observe the full sequence of behaviors. This is analogous to listening to someone speak: you must hear the entire statement, not merely a word or sentence, to grasp the intended meaning.

For example, while conversing with someone who appears highly capable, confident, and knowledgeable, you suddenly notice an extremely incongruent laugh. This single action largely overturns your initial impression. Moreover, tension appears in the arms and legs, and the body keeps shifting as if avoiding an unpleasant situation. You conclude that the person is not the capable, confident, and knowledgeable individual you first perceived. Yet you must also consider whether something you just said or did made the person uncomfortable or nervous. Therefore, when observing others, remain aware of how your own words or actions are being perceived so you can interpret the other person’s overall behavior more completely.

When observing a specific posture, note any other simultaneous behaviors that convey a similar meaning and use them for mutual confirmation. For instance, a salesperson’s coordinated set of movements (posture cluster) might look like this: while enthusiastically pitching a product, the person sits on the edge of the chair, feet apart with toes pointing forward, hands on the table, and torso leaning forward. In this book you will learn the meanings of these various postures, but the key is to consider them together to form a complete impression.

Understanding postural consistency functions like a monitoring device through which you can discern the meaning of a person’s attitudes and behaviors. This awareness prompts further observation and prevents premature conclusions based on superficial glances. In other words, it exerts a degree of control over your own conduct.

At first, interpreting body language may seem interesting and easy. Soon, however, you will discover that one posture can quickly be countered, reinforced, or confused by another. People untrained in “nonverbal behavior” often overlook postural consistency and reach one-sided conclusions. Our experience shows this has caused them considerable harm; many failures have arisen in exactly this way.

We have also found that the number of meanings a single behavior can carry depends on how many people interpret it. Therefore, remember that one posture represents only a single nonverbal cue; the information conveyed by the entire body is what matters. Shifting focus from individual postures to posture clusters

reveals that they are inseparable, and body movements and postures become far easier to understand. This greatly aids recognition of the full meaning of human posture.

### What Can Micro-reactions Be Used For?

Uncovering the “real thoughts” that a person intentionally or unintentionally conceals.

This description easily evokes thoughts of lie detection. Indeed, in popular culture and television dramas, the technique is often marketed as a mind-reading skill for exposing lies.

In reality, lie detection is one of the cutting-edge applications of micro-reactions (微反应), but relatively complete conditions are required to reach a true/false judgment. If the stimulus is inadequate, the subject maintains good control, and no obvious external reaction appears, micro-reactions cannot yield a judgment; the task must be handed to a polygraph. The polygraph measures indicators that are purely controlled by the autonomic nervous system—physiological signals entirely beyond the subject’s conscious will. Thus, even with no movement or expression and with heartbeat and breathing deliberately steadied, the polygraph’s sensitivity cannot be evaded.

Micro-reactions are not limited to lie detection. They apply to all interpersonal scenarios.

Whenever people interact, the technique can be used:

- Does the stranger you just met harbor malice or schemes?
- The blind date looks promising—should you invest real effort?
- What lies behind your boyfriend’s hesitation?
- Can the outwardly loyal subordinate be trusted?
- What is the true attitude of the deeply reserved boss?
- Why does the colleague’s polite and proper manner feel slightly off?
- Who in the team is secretly disloyal?
- Is the important client, whose face reveals nothing, satisfied or not?
- What does the other party’s silent smile mean at the critical moment of negotiation?
- Where is the fluent suspect lying...

The more complex social rules become, the more people must think and the more intricate their displayed behavior grows. Many harbor no malice and do not intend to do wrong or lie; they simply must act in accordance with social rules, sometimes without even realizing it. Many misunderstandings arise from this.

People’s genuine feelings and desires remain deeply hidden inside these “shells”; this is what we call “civilization.”

Obedying only the law of the jungle—communicating solely through body, teeth, and strength—belongs to a state millions of years in the past. If humans could always act like machines, making the most rational decisions and displays according to input rules, they would be “gods.” Unfortunately, no matter how complex social rules become and no matter how advanced the education of the person you are dealing with, that person remains human—a protein-based organism governed by the nervous system—whose every behavior is firmly constrained by the two fundamental drives of survival and reproduction. Precisely for this reason, feelings and desires closer to the animal core frequently leak through the “shell” in small traces that are difficult to suppress; most people are not even aware they should suppress them. These traces are micro-reactions and can be used to analyze and judge the person’s real thoughts.

Because behaviors triggered by physiological needs and emotional impulses are closer to humanity's animal instinctual logic—a simple logic of “take the good, reject the bad”—these drives are powerful enough to have preserved humans on Earth through millions of years of evolution. A mere ten thousand years of civilization history cannot erase their influence.

Therefore, micro-reactions study and analyze human physiological and emotional behavior, not the readily observable words and actions.

## 1. Micro-expressions

Micro-expressions (微表情) are a term that has attracted increasing attention. The so-called micro-expression is a psychological term referring to a complete emotional expression whose normal duration has been greatly compressed. Between different expressions, facial micro-expressions inadvertently reveal a person's true inner state. In the United States, micro-expression research has been applied in national security, the judicial system, clinical medicine, and political elections.

Although micro-expressions appear fully on the face, they last only briefly before being masked by other or false expressions. Hence the defining feature of micro-expressions is their “micro” quality. Jiang Zhenyu notes: “The key point of ‘micro’ is the transition from emergence to disappearance; a micro-expression flashes by in less than 1/4 of a second.” Consequently, micro-expressions are generally difficult to capture, few people notice them, and research indicates that only 10 percent of people can detect micro-expression changes.

Precisely because micro-expressions are small and rapid, they reflect inner feelings and motives more truthfully than the other, consciously produced expressions people normally display.

Changes in facial expressions such as smiling, frowning, or showing anger quickly provide useful information about psychological and emotional shifts. By observing these changes, one can infer a person's current intentions and motives.

People are often reluctant to voice their inner concerns, yet a sullen mood is written plainly on the face. Therefore, in daily communication we should obtain as much verbal and nonverbal information as possible through facial expressions. At the same time, understanding micro-expressions allows us to manage our own emotions so others do not read our thoughts.

A simple handshake, a glance, or a faint smile can convey significant diplomatic information. Accurately grasping the emotional meaning of these micro-expressions in everyday interactions, the workplace, or business negotiations can help capture opportunities for success.

In social interactions we deal with all kinds of people—some of good character, some not; some broad-minded, some petty; some reserved, some outgoing and warm. Misjudging people is one of the easiest mistakes to make, so reading people through micro-expressions is a profound art. How, then, can we accurately use micro-expressions to see into others' hearts? This requires cultivating a discerning eye for observing micro-expressions.

Current micro-expression research remains at an early stage, focused on constructing effective measurement tools and equipment. Significant progress occurred in 2002 when Paul Ekman successfully developed the Micro-expression Training Tool (METT), which includes five parts: pretest, training, practice, review, and posttest. According to Ekman, training with this equipment enables people to quickly detect the presence of micro-expressions and improve their recognition ability.

## 1. The Nature of Emotion

The nature of emotion is a survival mechanism that animals evolved and that has been continuously reinforced through evolution. Emotion supplies simple solutions to problems ancient humans frequently faced, such as generating fear and deciding to flee or generating anger and deciding to fight. The emotion mechanism is the behavioral drive produced after an animal cognitively appraises an external stimulus. It follows the simplest logic, like the most straightforward blunt person: whatever it thinks, it does, without hesitation.

Thus each emotion has a specific function—note, a specific function for the “primitive state” of humans. For people living under complex social rules, the function often lacks positive value, because the essence of social rules is constraint. By understanding the mechanism of emotion, we can work backward to infer the cognitive appraisal and feelings of the actor.

- Surprise is unexpected concern and prompts increased information gathering.
- When facing negative stimuli, first assess relative strength.
- If the stimulus is weaker, respond with disgust and move away or drive it off.
- If the stimulus is roughly equal in strength, respond with anger and attack to protect one’s interests.
- If the stimulus is stronger, respond with fear and flee or hide.
- If the stimulus has already caused irrecoverable loss, abandon effort.
- If facing a positive stimulus, feel pleasure or even excitement.

This simple mechanism evolved by animals ensures they adapt to the environment and survive and reproduce. Humans retain a powerful emotion mechanism; once an emotion arises, it can generate strong behavioral drive, including interference with social behavior. Therefore, when you see a certain emotion (micro-)expression on a person’s face, it indicates that the corresponding emotion has been generated. In a lie model, the cognitive appraisal and feeling represented by the emotion constitute the “reason for lying.”

A common dialogue illustrates this:

“Why have you been avoiding me lately?”

“I haven’t! You’re the boss’s right-hand person now, busy every day until you’re exhausted—I wouldn’t dare disturb you.”

To aid understanding, the dialogue above has been made more direct, yet even from the words one can already form a rough judgment. In real life such exchanges are often more veiled, and the text alone does not reveal truth or falsehood. At this point, if the other person displays a disgust-type expression, it indicates unwillingness to meet you because of “looking down on you.” If an anger-type expression appears, the reason is “interests threatened” and hostility. If a fear-type expression appears, the reason is “power disparity” and reluctance to provoke you. If a sadness-type expression appears—helplessness or dejection—it indicates the person has already lost heart about the current situation. If a pleasure-type expression appears, the person is considering your welfare, does not want to add trouble for you, and hopes you will fare even better.

The same words, paired with different emotional drives, can mean entirely different things.

Therefore, we must identify the cause by recognizing the actor’s expression rather than listening only to the words spoken.

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The essence of emotion is a survival mechanism that animals evolved, continuously accumulated and reinforced through the process of evolution. Emotions provide simple solutions to problems that ancient humans frequently faced, such as generating fear and deciding to flee, or generating anger and deciding to fight. The emotion mechanism is the behavioral drive produced after an animal cognitively processes and evaluates external stimuli. It follows the simplest logic, like the most straightforward brute: it does whatever it thinks, without any reservations.

Therefore, each emotion has a specific function—note, a specific function for a person's "primitive state." For decision-making by people living under complex social rules, emotions often lack positive significance, because the essence of social rules is constraint. By understanding the mechanisms of emotion, we can reverse-engineer a person's cognitive evaluations and feelings.

- Surprise is unexpected concern and prompts heightened information gathering.
- When facing negative stimuli, first assess the relative strength.
- If the stimulus source is weaker, respond with disgust by distancing or driving it away.
- If the stimulus source is roughly equal in strength, respond with anger by attacking to protect one's interests.
- If the stimulus source is stronger, respond with fear by fleeing or hiding.
- If the stimulus source has already caused irrecoverable loss, abandon effort.
- When facing positive stimuli, feel pleasure or even excitement.

This simple mechanism evolved by animals ensures they adapt to their environment, survive, and reproduce. Humans retain a powerful emotion mechanism; once an emotion arises, it can generate strong behavioral drives, including interference with social behavior. Therefore, on the level of facial expression, if you observe a certain emotional (micro) expression on a person's face, it indicates that the corresponding emotion has been triggered. In the lie-detection model, the cognitive evaluation and feeling represented by the emotion constitute the "reason for lying."

For example, here is a common exchange:

"Why have you been avoiding me lately?"

"No way! You're the boss's right-hand person now, busy every day until you're exhausted. I just don't dare disturb you."

To help readers understand, the dialogue has been made more direct, yet even the language already reveals the general picture. In real life such exchanges are often more veiled, making it impossible to judge truthfulness from the words alone. At that point, if the other person shows a disgust-type expression, it means he does not want to see you because he "looks down on" you; if an anger-type expression appears, it means he feels his interests are threatened and is therefore hostile; if a fear-type expression appears, it means he dares not provoke you because of the power gap; if a sadness-type expression appears—helplessness or dejection—it means he has already given up on the situation; if a pleasure-type expression appears, it means he is considering your welfare, does not want to cause you trouble, and hopes you will do better and better.

The same words, powered by different emotional drives, can mean entirely different things.

Therefore, we must identify the cause by reading the person's expressions rather than by listening only to what is said.

## The Meaning of Micro-expressions



To understand a person's true thoughts and read another's inner state, we must grasp the meanings of "micro-expressions":

- **Raising the right eyebrow:** When a person's right eyebrow rises, it indicates a question—either about what someone else has said or about something the person has done in the past.
- **Eyebrows pulled upward and tensed:** When a person's eyebrows are pulled upward and tensed, the person feels intense fear. We produce this expression unconsciously while watching a horror film.
- **Staring into the other person's eyes:** Sometimes a person maintains eye contact while speaking; this often indicates lying. The speaker is checking whether the deception is succeeding or has been detected. When someone speaks while staring into your eyes, pay attention.
- **Breaking eye contact:** When two people are engaged in eye contact and one suddenly breaks it, this does not necessarily mean lying; the person may simply be recalling something.
- **Eyes glancing left or right:** During conversation, eyes may drift left or right unconsciously, revealing inner processes. Glancing left usually signals recall; glancing right more often signals the construction of a lie.
- **Sudden pupil dilation:** This common expression conveys several states—fear, anger, or sexual arousal. Context and setting distinguish among them.
- **Flared nostrils and tightly pressed lips:** This expression indicates that the person is angry.
- **Left corner of the mouth raised:** When a person smiles with the left corner of the mouth raised, the smile is likely false. Roughly 74 percent of genuine facial feeling is expressed on the right side of the face.
- **Lip compression:** A classic ambiguous gesture frequently made by women. The person performing it is internally choosing or struggling.
- **Chin raised:** A sudden chin raise signals that the current topic is embarrassing; change the subject. If the corners of the mouth turn downward at the same time, the person is feeling self-reproach.
- **Prolonged surprise:** If a surprised expression lasts longer than one minute, it is feigned.

Many additional micro-expressions exist. Recognizing them helps us discern others' true intentions in daily life. Once you understand micro-expressions, fleeting facial signals become sources of valuable information.

## Question 2: Does Foreign Research Exist on Micro-reactions?

If we seek a foreign lexical counterpart for “微反应,” the original English term is “Micro-expressions.”

Many people know the striking term “micro-expression,” which corresponds to “Micro-expressions.” The term is not an invention of television drama; in its original literature, context shows it refers to facial micro-expressions—expressions of very brief duration or incomplete movement. Professor Paul Ekman is the leading figure in this research. He and his team have worked to apply micro-expressions to the judgment of genuine emotion in test subjects and have specifically examined their validity for lie detection, although the data have not been especially strong.

However, the Chinese meaning of “expression” is broader than facial display; it encompasses expression, manifestation, phrasing, and more. The standard translation is “mode of expression.” Facial displays, gestures, speech, and writing can all be “expression.” For instance, after a boyfriend says “I love you to death,” no woman takes the word “death” literally, because it is merely an “expression.”

The proper English term for “facial expression” is “facial-expressions.” Analyzing a person's true psychological state should not be limited to facial expressions; one must observe and interpret the subject's full range of

expressions, body movements, and verbal content. In applied settings, judging intent solely from micro-expressions yields low success rates and efficiency.

Consequently, the literal translation of “micro-expressions” should not be confined to facial micro-expressions; “micro-display” would be more appropriate. Yet in everyday Chinese usage, “表现” usually implies deliberate display. If the object of analysis is deliberate behavior, one cannot reliably infer genuine psychological states, let alone use the data for lie detection.

When a stimulus is effective, a subject’s initial instantaneous reactions are overwhelmingly beyond conscious control and are therefore authentic. These reactions are quickly suppressed and masked, and their amplitude is small. For this reason we focus on “Micro-expressions,” where “Micro” means “minute.”

Because research on effective stimuli is as important as research on minute displays, we ultimately chose the word “reaction” to cover the complete stimulus–display process and distilled the entire subject into the single Chinese term “微反应” to correspond to the English “Micro-expressions.”

### Note

The most prominent scholar is the American psychologist Professor Paul Ekman. The term first appears in his works, such as *Emotions Revealed* and *Telling Lies*.

## 3.4 Do Different People Show the Same Micro-expressions?

This is the final foundational question that must be addressed. When different people experience happiness, anger, or other emotions, are their facial expressions identical? Do identical expressions on different faces represent identical psychological states?

Humans can produce an enormous number of expressions. If one merely counts the combinatorial possibilities of the facial muscles involved, the theoretical number of distinct facial configurations far exceeds imagination—even before accounting for variations in contraction intensity.

Not every configuration qualifies as an expression, yet the richness of possible expressions is evident. People living in different societies may possess certain unique facial expressions for communication; many of these are learned. Nevertheless, from Darwin to Professor Paul Ekman, earlier scholars have scientifically demonstrated several basic expressions shared by all humans. Darwin clarified the evolutionary basis for such universal expressions; Professor Ekman traveled to primitive tribes in New Guinea to observe indigenous facial behavior among people who had never encountered so-called civilized society and therefore had no opportunity to imitate learned expressions. These respected studies confirm that the following emotions produce universally shared facial features in humans:

- Pleasure
- Sadness
- Surprise
- Disgust
- Anger
- Fear

Only these six basic emotions with universal expressions are noted here; further variations are discussed in later chapters.

In addition, expressions triggered by bodily stimuli—pain, drowsiness, and exertion—also exhibit cross-regional and cross-cultural universality and will be examined in the book.

Which emotions fall outside the scope of study?

Everyday language contains many additional terms for describing mood and state: awe, greed, suspicion, paranoia, jealousy, stupidity, pity, disappointment, expectation, regret, complacency, frivolity, and so on. Strictly speaking, these words do not denote human emotions; they describe external manifestations and often carry subjective evaluations.

We conducted a small experiment: the word “disappointment” was given to twenty different people, who were asked to imagine and describe the outward appearance of a disappointed person. The returned descriptions varied widely. Some described silence and departure; others described stamping and loud scolding; still others described a forced smile or a sigh.

Consequently, terms that carry evaluative connotations and do not directly name emotions (they should be neutral nouns) lie outside the scope of this book.

### Footnote

[1] Of the facial muscles that construct expressions, twenty-two groups can be independently controlled. The combinatorial calculation of twenty-two yields approximately forty million possibilities. This calculation is merely a numerical exercise and has little relation to actual expressions.

### Is This Too Dark?

In some situations an adversary wishes to conceal true intent; applying micro-reactions to adversaries can improve countermeasure efficiency. More often, friends cannot clearly express themselves through etiquette and language; applying micro-reactions to friends can improve communication efficiency. Just as knowing only Chinese limits one to a dubbed or subtitled version that may contain alterations or distortions, while learning English permits direct access to the original meaning, micro-reaction is a tool for understanding others.

What ordinary people observe is social behavior—performances staged for them.

“Ordinary people” here includes various professionals: police officers, soldiers, physicians, psychological counselors, leaders at every level, matchmakers, professional ideological workers, and so on. Most behavioral analysis rests on observed “performances” and draws inferences accordingly. When fortunate, the subject offers no concealment, and all words, actions, and micro-reactions are candid. Once the subject deliberately masks behavior, however, every word and action becomes potentially deceptive and cannot serve as a reliable basis for judgment.

Example:

A psychologist friend of mine, emphasizing his professional identity, discussed academic points with me. He argued that, based on the cases he had seen, clients seeking psychological counseling display extremely complex behavior that cannot be interpreted within a micro-reaction framework.

I showed him a recording. In the recording a suspect described his secret crush on a schoolgirl and his frequent fantasies of intimacy with her. Whenever such scenes arose in his mind, he felt intense shame, could not concentrate on his studies, and watched his grades plummet, becoming increasingly self-destructive.

After pausing the recording, I asked what he had observed.

My friend replied that he had seen the suspect's tear-streaked face and anguished expression and had read pain, panic, helplessness, sadness, self-disgust, anger, and a young man's self-reproach.

I told him I saw excitement. Clenched fists, a slightly hunched torso, gaze fixed on the words, rising volume, accelerating speech, and heavier breathing—all these signs of excitement occurred while the suspect described the girl and his infatuation. The nonverbal behavior contradicted the verbal content of guilt and remorse; it was not the behavior of contrition.

The recording was from an early interrogation in a rape-and-murder case. Several hours later, confronted with evidence, the suspect confessed.

I acknowledged frankly: "Yes, micro-reaction cannot interpret the 'performances' you observed. Social behavior is influenced by too many factors; its meanings cannot be exhaustively listed; theoretically it cannot be analyzed for truthfulness. In short, everything the person does and says is deliberately crafted for you to see. If you simply accept it and begin analysis, you are essentially jumping into the hole the other person has dug and helping to bury yourself. We look only at the minute reactions that could not be masked."

### **Question 9: Can Micro-reactions Be Controlled?**

You may think that, after rigorous training, you can control your own micro-reactions—immediately suppressing any outward sign once a stimulus is felt.

Controlling one's body has two meanings:

- One is muscular control: the ability to execute movements precisely, skillfully, and with fluid start and stop. From this perspective, dancers—especially classical dancers—and athletes in disciplines that demand refined movement, such as martial arts or gymnastics, possess good bodily control.
- This ability, however, is entirely different from the control required for micro-reactions. It is control for performance.

The second meaning of bodily control is the capacity to manage responses so that the nervous system remains unperturbed by stimuli. Three types of people can truly remain "unmoved":

1. The highest type transcends gain and loss. They feel no joy in gain and no regret in loss—even of life itself. This approaches a divine state.
2. The intermediate type possesses rich experience, deep reserves, and strong self-confidence. Anyone who reaches this level is no longer ordinary.
3. The lowest type practices self-hypnosis, forcing belief in something that is not true. This may be even harder; only certain individuals with mental disorders can fully achieve it.

These three types are also the most difficult to read when one is observing another's inner state. Formidable politicians belong to the second type, accomplished actors to the third; the first type remains rare.

Yet none of these individuals can completely control their micro-reactions. Leaving aside physiological indicators governed by the autonomic nervous system—pupil size, heart rate, circulation, sweat secretion—which cannot be voluntarily controlled, even emotional motor actions executed by skeletal muscles are almost impossible to suppress.

Suppressing genuine reactions is a complex and demanding process:

1. First, one must not be surprised. One must anticipate the stimulus and decide in advance to control oneself.
2. Next, one must not care. Regardless of the stimulus, one must accept it and rapidly analyze its nature (benefit or harm) and intensity.
3. Then, one must not react. Through perception and thought, every possible bodily response must be identified and halted—perhaps with some missed.
4. Finally, one must double-check for any overlooked leakage and correct it.

Once everything is supposedly under control, are you satisfied? Listen: your rigid posture and wooden expression already indicate that something is abnormal and that you are hiding information you prefer others not know. That you show no reaction to such a gratifying (or horrifying) event is itself a tell. The inevitable existence of such tells is the very foundation on which the observation of micro-reactions rests.

### **What Are “Micro-expressions”**

“Micro-expressions” are an involuntary revelation and concealment of inner feelings, a term from psychology. Sometimes people convey their inner feelings through facial expressions. Between or during these expressions, the face may briefly display a micro-expression that unconsciously “leaks” additional information. A micro-expression is an instantaneous expression, typically lasting 1/4 second and as short as 1/25 second. Through micro-expressions, we can determine whether we truly like someone.

Although this subconscious expression lasts only a moment, the trait readily reveals our underlying emotions. For example, during an interview a natural action can expose inner states: fiddling with one’s tie or jewelry indicates restlessness; tightly pursing the lips signals embarrassment; biting fingernails reveals a lack of security. Therefore, when others point out a small secret you harbor, do not be surprised—scratching the head, touching the nose, biting a finger, or blinking are all micro-expressions that can reveal psychological conditions. Sometimes a micro-expression conveys an emotion opposite to the one consciously felt.

Compared with deliberately produced expressions, micro-expressions more accurately reflect genuine feelings and motives. For instance, a fleeting contempt may appear within someone’s smile, or a stern face in a parking lot may suddenly flash fear.

Although we sometimes overlook micro-expressions, the brain is still affected by them and revises its interpretation of others’ expressions. Thus, when someone displays a natural “happy” expression containing no micro-expression, we can conclude the happiness is genuine. If, however, the “happy” face is accompanied by fleeting micro-expressions of “mockery” or “contempt,” we tend to perceive the face as “sly” or “untrustworthy” even without consciously noticing the micro-expressions.

In the popular American drama *Lie to Me*, the protagonist Cal Lightman is a micro-expression master who solves numerous major cases by reading these fleeting expressions lasting less than 1/5 second. When a person inadvertently shrugs, rubs the hands, or raises the lower lip, Lightman knows they are lying. By analyzing facial expressions he can read emotions—from hidden hatred to sexual impulse to jealousy. In short, micro-expressions betray a person’s true inner state.

### **3.3 The Concept of Micro-expressions**

In modern social life, controlled and disguised expressions far outnumber those that genuinely convey emotion. Although some authentic expressions flash by and are then suppressed or replaced by performance, careful observation can still reveal the inner state behind these brief, subtle changes. Such expressions may

last only an instant and involve only slight muscle movement, yet even minute changes such as a slight eye movement carry meaning (provided an emotion is present).

We call expressions that are not under conscious control, may be triggered by emotion or by habit, last only briefly, or involve incomplete muscle contraction “micro-expressions.”

Each emotion possesses specific morphological features in its micro-expressions.

The word “or” connects “last only briefly” and “involve incomplete muscle contraction” because not every micro-expression is short-lived. A micro-expression may satisfy both conditions simultaneously (brief duration usually implies incomplete contraction), yet some expressions meet only the “incomplete contraction” condition while lasting longer. For example, a face that retains most features of a smile may also show a slight raising of the eyebrows that persists for a long time. The slight brow raise results from incomplete contraction of the medial frontalis. A full brow raise is a typical feature of sadness. Therefore the slight sadness marker mixed into the smile also falls within the scope of “micro-expressions” we study.

### Notes:

1. Strictly speaking, habitual expressions are not genuine emotion-driven expressions and do not represent true inner states. Because habits, like emotions, are not under conscious control and produce unfeigned reactions, they serve as important benchmarks for judging changes in psychological state. Habitual expressions are usually treated as the subject’s baseline; they are important for analyzing the real psychological state behind expression changes and are therefore included in the concept of micro-expressions. For instance, a person who habitually blinks rapidly will continue to do so when not tense, so blinking cannot be taken as evidence of inner tension.
2. In *Telling Lies*, Ekman notes that as a clue to deception, micro-expressions “can fully display the concealed emotion yet flash by so quickly they are often overlooked. From appearance to disappearance, a micro-expression lasts less than 1/4 second.” Ekman further subdivides subtle expressions into micro-expressions, micro-momentary expressions, and other categories.

### Faces Come and Go in a Flash

Under normal circumstances, the various reactions people display when expressing inner emotions occur naturally and instantaneously; any attempt to fake them appears stiff and deliberate. In most cases, if we do not pay attention to facial observation, we will not notice changes in the other person’s expression, because psychological states are reflected on the face in an instant—expressions come and go so quickly that missing them naturally prevents us from perceiving the other person’s emotional shifts.

The earliest research on micro-expressions took place in the United States. During the war on terror, the U.S. government sought greater advantage and therefore organized a large team of experienced psychologists to study lie-detection techniques in hopes of obtaining more information about terrorist organizations. Most current methods of detecting lies rely on instruments such as polygraphs. A polygraph works by registering physiological changes—elevated blood pressure, altered respiration, or changes in skin conductance—when the subject lies. In reality, a polygraph alone cannot conclusively determine that someone is lying, because it detects anxiety and other physiological reactions caused by lying, not the lie itself. Paul Ekman, professor at the University of California, San Francisco and one of the most distinguished psychologists of the twentieth century, evaluated the polygraph as follows: “It may miss the most dangerous liars—those who do not care whether they lie, those who do not know they are lying, or those who have been trained to lie.” Clearly, polygraphs are not reliable for exposing lies.

In his book *Telling Lies*, Paul Ekman introduces the Facial Action Coding System (FACS), the key to his research on identifying deceivers. During his studies Ekman discovered that the human face contains 43 action units, each formed by the movement of one or more muscles. These units can combine freely, producing the rich variety of facial expressions. Of the expressions formed, 3,000 carry emotional significance.

In China, research on micro-expressions and related topics remains in its early stages. The first scholar to explore the field is Professor Jiang Zhenyu, who studies psychological-stress micro-reaction testing. He states: "Many lies are accompanied by incongruent facial expressions that allow others to detect the deception. Even well-trained liars cannot always control the outlets of their true emotions; those fleeting facial expressions reveal the mismatch between words and emotion."

### **Reactions to Nonverbal Information**

Austrian psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud once said: "One person's unconscious can unconsciously influence another person's unconscious." This means you may evaluate others on the basis of your own judgments and intuitions rather than facts—in other words, on the basis of a person's body language.

A study by Harvard experimental psychology professor Robert Rosenthal and Nalini Ambady confirmed the power of nonverbal information. The researchers showed a group of undergraduates 32 video clips of different teachers lecturing and asked the students to evaluate the teachers. Because the audio had been scrambled or removed, the students could judge only by body language. The evaluations matched those given by students who had attended the full lectures and completed end-of-semester assessments. Although the latter attributed their ratings to friendliness or clarity of presentation, the study showed that most evaluations were formed on the basis of nonverbal communication.

By applying logical reasoning and deliberate assessment, you can avoid reacting solely to body movements. Without considering possible causes of those movements, you may be misled by body language. For example, a judge we know suffered a stroke during a trial; facial muscles twitched and the corner of the mouth drooped, making the defense attorney visibly uneasy. Had the attorney known the movements were involuntary, the unease would not have occurred.

To avoid misunderstanding, you must remember how your own expressions and gestures are perceived by others. At all times, be aware of the nonverbal messages you are sending. Are your arms crossed? Is your body leaning? If you adopt an open posture, others may be more receptive to your views.

You should also observe the other person's body language. If you sense defensiveness, you can adjust your conversational style to make the person more receptive. Speakers call this "audience awareness"; they detect it readily. When they observe negative nonverbal cues from an audience member, they quickly change topic, tell a joke, or offer a humorous remark to elicit laughter and relaxation.

### **Experimental Case: Can Acting Counter Micro-reactions**

We conducted an experiment in which subjects, while remaining naturally relaxed and in full control, were asked to repeat a performance three times to see whether rational control could produce identical repetitions. Cameras recorded each performance for later comparison.

During the experiment, three photographs were shown one at a time. After seeing the first photograph, subjects were instructed to devise a performance plan expressing the simple message "This girl is beautiful!"

No restriction was placed on performance style; subjects were encouraged to use whatever style they controlled best—exaggerated or restrained—as long as all three performances were identical.

If subjects succeeded, the theory that micro-reactions can be suppressed by acting would be supported. If subjects could not succeed despite thorough mental preparation and a performance plan, the hypothesis—that acting cannot override psychological-stress micro-reactions (微反应 (micro-reaction))—would be confirmed.

The first two photographs were nearly identical images of a beautiful young woman; the third photograph differed markedly—an ugly animal, a disgusting face, a painful scene, etc.

The results were telling: none of the 87 subjects produced three identical performances, even though they had only one sentence to deliver. Even subjects with excellent control showed obvious reaction delays, prolonged gaze, stiffened and less mobile facial muscles, and increased respiratory control after the third photograph appeared.

The experiment demonstrates that changes in the stimulus source strongly affect response patterns; the greater the difference in the stimulus, the more it disrupts any performance plan the subject attempts to maintain.

In summary, when facing a highly skilled performer we hold two sharp swords. The first is control of the stimulus source: by presenting stimuli from multiple angles and at varying rhythms we can disrupt performance plans and leave the person little room or time to react. The second sword is baseline characteristics. Through successive layers of stimuli we obtain the person's behavioral baseline—their genuine emotional and social behavioral features. Under these conditions, even if the person's mind is highly developed and controls every coping behavior, they cannot restore the baseline features governed by real emotion. In simple terms, the performance no longer matches reality. This is why even excellent actors cannot use acting skill to counter micro-reactions.

## Facial Asymmetry

Facial asymmetry refers to the situation in which one side of the face moves more than the other, indicating that the displayed emotion may not be genuine. As noted earlier, an asymmetrical smile is one clue that a person is lying.

Take smiling as an example. Smiling is one of the most common expressions in daily life. American psychiatrist Dr. William Fry emphasizes that life cannot do without laughter; without laughter people become prone to illness, including serious illness. Although laughter brings many benefits, in conversation we must recognize that not every smile is genuine; many people fake smiles every day. How can we distinguish them? It is not difficult.

When a person smiles genuinely, both corners of the mouth rise simultaneously and the eyes narrow. The zygomaticus major and the orbicularis oculi contract together. Because a genuine smile arises spontaneously and is not under conscious control, the emotional centers of the brain automatically tighten the orbicularis oculi in addition to reflexively lifting the corners of the mouth, causing the eyes to narrow, crow's feet to appear, and the brows to tilt slightly.

In contrast, a fake smile involves only the corners of the mouth rising. A posed smile is produced by consciously contracting facial muscles, stretching the mouth, and lifting the corners. Unlike a genuine smile, the orbicularis oculi does not contract because the eye muscles are not under voluntary control and change



only when emotion is truly felt. Sometimes fake smiles appear exaggerated, with strong muscle contraction that seems to bunch the entire face, creating the illusion of narrowed eyes. On closer inspection, however, the crow's feet and tilted brows of the fake smiler cannot be faked. In other words, if we cover all but the brows and eyes of both genuine and fake smilers, the genuine smile is still recognizable, whereas the fake smile shows only lifeless eyes.

Therefore, to determine whether a smile is genuine or false, observe the eyes and brows—the most important clues. Even an expert in expression will show subtle differences between genuine and posed expressions. By paying attention we can detect those subtle differences.

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### **Language Exchange from “One Glance”**

In a vacuum, verbal communication is impossible. More precisely, people, speech, and body movements form a composite process. When communicating, we must combine these factors to follow and develop.

We are born with the ability to infer what someone is thinking from an expression. For example, we often notice that a person’s words do not match their body language. Intuition tells us something is wrong, but we often choose to ignore it or disbelieve its existence. Now is the time to trust intuition.

When verbal and nonverbal information conflict, nonverbal information proves more authentic. Therefore, in communication, it is crucial for posture and speech to remain consistent. The key to a politician’s electoral success lies in maintaining this consistency.

Of course, most candidates have received professional training to ensure their verbal information aligns with nonverbal behavior. Unfortunately, we can still see many senior politicians using body movements inconsistent with their words during speeches.

For example, when saying “I am very happy to have sincere exchanges with teenagers,” their fingers wave around, pointing and scolding them in public; or, trying to convince the audience they are enthusiastic, friendly, and concerned about people’s hardships, they repeatedly chop the podium with empty hands to emphasize their points. These are inappropriate body movements.

In the writing process, maintaining consistency between verbal and nonverbal information is also very important. This has been recognized by many famous writers. Especially in detective novels, key scenes often involve someone trying to cover up the truth, only for their behavior to betray them. World-renowned detectives like Sherlock Holmes and Miss Marple often use the subject’s body language to solve cases.

When studying an individual’s posture, we must make a series of related observations from various aspects, not relying on a single posture. This is what we call a “posture cluster”—a group of “nonverbal behaviors”

combined from various forms. Posture clusters may involve many actions occurring simultaneously or one after another, such as arms crossed, ankles overlapped, and fists clenched, and so on.

## Social Behavior

The most typical feature of social behavior is that the action is accountable to others; although ultimately for oneself, the direct connection is always something done for others. For example:

- Morning greetings must be heard or seen by others;
- Work presentations must be understood or approved by others;
- Polite gestures must convey goodwill to others;
- Party conversations must win others' approval or even liking;
- Shopping requires handing money to others to receive goods;
- Job interviews, oath-taking, heartfelt talks, angry outbursts, chasing buses, queuing, seeking medical care, studying for exams, training for competitions, music and films, love and marriage, negotiations and competition, investigations and litigation—all are actions performed for others.

These matters follow different social rules; the specific steps and expressions may be simple or complex, and people must learn to master their performance in the process. The other side of the same matter is that mastery also means, in theory, complete control over how to perform.

Take language, a classic social behavior, as an example.

Language is an indispensable communication tool in modern civilized society, including both spoken words and written text. Language must be learned before it can be used; its function is to tell others one's thoughts, which may be true or false. With practice, language can be mastered fluently; in face-to-face speech, one can achieve logical completeness and self-consistency, with steady and fluent pronunciation, whether the speaker is sincere or insincere. In fact, many true statements appear hurried, anxious, agitated, or indifferent precisely because the control is less refined.

From the perspective of cognitive psychology, the brain center controlling language is located in the cortex. Damage to specific cortical areas can severely impair or destroy language function. The human cortex is responsible for "thinking," the highest cognitive center capable of logical and abstract thought and controlled behavior. For this reason, the proportion of the cortex in the human brain is far higher than in any other species on Earth.

In other words, every word you read and every utterance you hear is, in theory, 100 percent a deliberate product intended for you to read or hear. Given that, can what you hear or see be taken as "truth"?

The same logic applies to other social behaviors and will not be repeated.

## Question 10: Can Performance Suppress Micro-reactions?

After repeatedly reading this book and memorizing *Microexpressions*, if one performs according to the rules for analyzing people, does that make lying invincible? Impossible.

Even the finest actors perform according to a script; even the most cunning swindlers execute fraud according to their own plan, yet they are more alert than actors because their opponents are living people, not scripted characters; even the most calculating corrupt officials rely on lines polished through countless prior corrupt acts, and once confronted with evidence they can no longer maintain consistency.

As noted earlier, without stimulus interference even a primary-school student can recite an essay vividly. To counter behavioral analysis with performance, one must know every possible stimulus that may arise during the performance, the most reasonable response to each stimulus, and then master every breath, every eye movement, every muscle relaxation, every postural shift, every expression, and every word through powerful memory and countless rehearsals.

You will find that an actor's script essentially tells the actor which stimuli (plot points) will be encountered and how best to respond. Outstanding, emotionally invested actors therefore deliver lifelike performances. Their infectious realism stems from the fact that most professional actors adopt and practice the Stanislavski system—immersing themselves in the role, cultivating the required emotions, and performing from the inside out rather than mechanically. The performance feels authentic because genuine emotion is present; all expressions, movements, and vocal tones flow naturally under the appropriate emotion, which the actor has pre-generated in the mind through empathy or imagined situations. Thus they are not rationally controlling their actions and expressions; in fact, no one can.

In real life, even the finest actors, once deprived of a script and burdened with personal stakes, see every rehearsed plan collapse. Of course, actors who merely "show face" may engage in rational performance daily and feel they succeed, surrounded by fans; such cases fall outside our discussion.

### **First-Rate Operators Are Especially Sensitive to "Microexpressions"**

As mentioned earlier, top-performing salespeople, interviewers who accurately judge whether candidates are lying, and management-consulting firms that revive multiple enterprises share the ability to perceive and interpret microexpressions at a high level.

Several individuals with superior judgment excel at distinguishing various forms of microexpressions; their abilities, both in experimental results and real situations, merit study. We therefore arranged interviews to learn from them.

One operator displayed remarkable sincerity; I wish to share an especially memorable segment of that interview.

The gentleman is referred to below as Mr. S. He has served as head of several enterprises, repeatedly turning near-bankrupt companies around. A management expert and first-rate operator, he remains a director of several well-known firms and chairman of his own company, a widely recognized figure.

Mr. S meets many people daily and communicates under varied circumstances. Especially during meetings, he can always identify "who does not fully agree with the content," "who wants to raise a question but remains silent," "who is interested," "who supports his view," and "who is skeptical" ... When asked how, he simply replies, "No particular reason; I just sense it."

I once attended a meeting with him and witnessed him correctly naming participants who wished to speak before they raised their hands, allowing the meeting to proceed smoothly.

Subordinates also recounted an impressive exchange. After a subordinate delivered an important briefing, Mr. S remarked only, "The briefing itself was fine, but your mood is off." The subordinate had indeed been "in a poor mood"; he had quarreled with his wife that morning before entering the office.

These anecdotes illustrate how Mr. S routinely notices subtle changes or emotional fluctuations in his subordinates.

## An Efficient Method of “Reprimand”

Consider the situation from the perspective of a team leader or supervisor. When a subordinate makes a work error, how should one reprimand? How can the same mistake be prevented?

Imagine this: a subordinate loses a major client’s lease renewal. When asked why the contract was not renewed, the subordinate accepts full responsibility, suggesting the explanation was insufficient and the client was displeased.

At that moment, what is the subordinate’s expression? Some show obvious remorse. Others merely feign remorse or even justify themselves righteously. Even if the surface expression appears remorseful or earnest, closer observation may reveal microexpressions that betray the true thought.

What microexpressions might appear? Try to picture them.

Expressions of “regret,” “shame,” “embarrassment,” or “guilt” indicate the subordinate is genuinely reflecting on the mistake and will accept advice or encouragement. After an error, such feelings activate a mechanism to avoid repeating it.

Conversely, if “contempt,” “disgust,” “anger,” or “fear” microexpressions appear while you are speaking or offering suggestions, attention is required.

A “contempt” microexpression suggests the subordinate likely dismisses your words. An “disgust” microexpression suggests the content will probably not be accepted. An “anger” microexpression suggests the subordinate feels your remarks are unfair. A “fear” microexpression suggests the error may have destroyed the subordinate’s willingness to try again.

Therefore, when reprimanding a subordinate or offering improvement suggestions, inferring emotional shifts from microexpressions enables appropriate responses and further guidance. The above examples illustrate how microexpressions can reveal emotions, guide success, and serve as a powerful support for team building and management.

## Section 2: Are Microexpressions the Same as Expressions?

The German philosopher Nietzsche once said, “The mouth may lie, but the face reveals.” This indirectly shows that many lies are accompanied by facial expressions carrying special meaning, and these tiny facial movements can expose the shadow of a lie.

In real life, no matter how skilled a liar, someone can always expose the deception, because during the act the liar’s true feelings, though not expressed verbally, are fully revealed through tiny facial expressions, unnatural body movements, and hesitant or tense speech. Anyone familiar with microexpressions can quickly identify the liar. The renowned psychologist Freud noted that when conversing with a stranger, concentrated attention easily reveals whether the other is preparing to deceive. He added that during the act, a liar’s lips may tighten from tension and guilt, fingertips may “speak,” and every pore may betray the person—consistent with Nietzsche’s observation that the face reveals the truth.

Although people can identify liars through expressions and movements, most lack the ability to observe strangers’ microexpressions; they overlook important microexpression cues, allowing deceivers to succeed repeatedly. Jiang Zhenyu, director of the China Legal Information Center at China University of Political Science and Law, has stated: “In fact, most people cannot identify liars well; only a very small number are born

with precise detection ability. The majority, even trained judges and customs officers, perform no better than a coin toss.” Thus, identifying liars through facial expressions is not easy. It requires both the awareness to read others’ psychology during conversation with strangers and mastery of certain microexpression-reading techniques.

To recognize microexpressions and thereby gain insight into an interlocutor’s mental state and obtain more advantages, let us now examine these remarkable microexpressions together.

### **Microexpressions: The Most Revealing Facial Clues**

A microexpression (micro-expression) lasts only 1/25 of a second. It disrupts the integrity of an emotion and briefly replaces it with another expression. Because the duration is so short, it is difficult to capture with the naked eye, yet it is the facial clue most likely to betray emotion. Tracing the discovery of microexpressions inevitably leads to Paul Ekman’s experiments.

In the late 1980s, Paul followed a female psychiatric patient. Shortly after admission she applied for discharge, claiming she had emerged from her emotional gloom and longed to return to family life. Paul interviewed her and recorded the session on video.

Afterward, reviewing the tape in the observation room, Paul noticed, besides a few slight body movements, a fleeting expression. Slowing the footage, he clearly saw an extremely brief expression of melancholy quickly covered by a smile. The expression lasted roughly 1/25 of a second. Freezing the frame and comparing it with the subsequent smile, Paul realized the patient was lying; she had deliberately produced a radiant smile to convince the doctor she had recovered. In reality her depressive symptoms remained obvious. The patient later admitted she had indeed intended to deceive the medical staff so she could leave and attempt suicide.

Thereafter, Paul Ekman added a pause button to every playback of interview recordings so he could capture fleeting microexpressions at any moment.

Anyone can become skilled at detecting microexpressions through continuous practice. The practice is not merely memorizing expression features—although that is a basic exercise—but repeatedly viewing expression photographs. Research shows that after viewing several hundred faces, practitioners can usually capture microexpressions and distinguish genuine from false expressions.

### **Question 4: Why “One-Way Expression Is Not Analyzed”? (9787554606841)**

If a person is autonomously outputting information from beginning to end (one-way output), none of the information expressed—including language, body movements, expressions, and even minute actions such as fist clenching, breathing changes, or torso leaning—can serve as a basis for micro-reaction analysis.

Large movements cannot be analyzed, nor can small movements. Why?

Because even the tiniest details are not reactions; they may be pre-prepared “expression schemes.” History contains countless real cases of this kind. Attempting to derive conclusions close to the truth from them is simply foolishly helping to bury the evidence.

A single extreme counter-example suffices.

A film contains a long, uncut take performed by a leading actor or actress. Every tiny eye flicker, inadvertent finger tremor, barely visible smile or pout—every detail on screen is moving. What does it prove? That the

actor's performed plot and emotions are his or her own real experiences and feelings? Of course not.

Whenever expression is one-way—whether by actor, politician, or schoolchild, whether recorded or live—full preparation is possible, employing every means to achieve the goal. Certain professions even require professional training before speaking to perfect the delivery.

Therefore, one-way expression is not analyzed, because it may in theory be 100 percent “performance”!

We analyze only “reactions,” which presupposes that we first apply a stimulus and then observe the subject's instantaneous response to the stimulus information.

The more a stimulus breaches the subject's psychological preparation, the more effectively it elicits a reaction; we call such stimuli “effective stimuli.”

Because these stimuli do not exist in the subject's performance plan, the subject must temporarily engage the cognitive system for assessment and decision-making, thereby generating physiological, emotional, and social behaviors and, consequently, “micro-reactions.”

#### **Question 4: Why “One-Way Expression Is Not Analyzed”? (9787554606841)**

Actually, one-way expression can be analyzed

#### **Stimulus Source**

Genuine expressions must be triggered by authentic emotions. Therefore, to observe micro-expressions, appropriate stimuli are required to elicit the subject's real emotions.

The most common method is to ask questions. Other frequent approaches include displaying images or videos, playing sounds, or delivering a message. In extreme cases, a person can appear suddenly after applying makeup. All methods capable of inducing emotional change in the subject are collectively termed stimulus sources in this book.

When analyzing authentic psychology through micro-expressions, it is especially important to note the logical relationship between the stimulus source and the subject's micro-expressions.

For example, when a negative stimulus (such as a derogatory stimulus source) is applied, the subject is almost never expected to display positive emotions such as satisfaction or happiness. This logical relationship can both predict the direction of the subject's micro-expression response to some extent and, when the nature of the micro-expression violates the logical relationship, support a judgment of deception in context. This serves as a key logical criterion for verifying truth or falsehood in psychological testing.

After enduring rigorous theoretical research, we finally begin examining the subtleties of each micro-expression.

Micro-expressions and standard expressions share the same lineage, originating from their common physiological mechanism—emotion. To master the morphological features of micro-expressions for each emotion, one must start with the fullest expressions, then progressively reduce certain local morphological features on the face and the amplitude of muscle movements until only the micro-expression features remain. Beginning with surprise, the morphological features of micro-expressions for disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and smiling are all studied according to this logic.

We start with the simplest: surprise!

Note: The phrase “almost never” is used first to maintain rigor; second, in extremely rare cases, being belittled may elicit pleasure in the subject. For instance, if the subject intends to “play the pig to eat the tiger” (concealing strength while deliberately allowing the other party to underestimate them), they may briefly display a deceptive sense of satisfaction when belittled (as expected).

### 3. Social Expressions

Social expressions are deliberately produced under the control of will, with the purpose of assisting verbal content so that the other party understands or trusts the speaker’s intent. Therefore, social expressions can convey only social intent and cannot be used to judge authentic cognition or feelings.

Through observation and imitation in various social situations from childhood, combined with many expressions that evolved from emotional prototypes into conventional forms, people employ numerous social expressions to aid communication.

Social expressions have two major characteristics:

- They lack a stimulus source as a prerequisite; the actor produces them voluntarily, and their meaning matches the semantics.
- They typically involve movement of a single organ or combinations of multiple organs, yet the movements are asynchronous and mismatched in amplitude.

In simple terms, social expressions are deliberately produced nonstandard emotional expressions. Because they are intentional imitations without underlying emotion, they cannot achieve the precision of genuine emotional expressions.

Examples include deliberately raised eyebrows, winking with one eye, smiling with lips pressed together or pursed while the eyes remain still, or a single lip-curl movement.

Social expressions vary widely and are always intentional; they cannot serve as evidence for analyzing authentic emotions. The most exaggerated social expressions can be described as “making faces.” Imagine someone conveying “sincerity” while making faces—would you apply serious attention and meticulous technique to analyze that expression?

Unfortunately, not all researchers worldwide can distinguish social expressions from the other two types. Much research focuses precisely on the recognition and analysis of social expressions, and interview expression-recognition software can identify only deliberately performed expressions. It struggles to detect single subtle expressions and is even less capable with composite subtle-expression combinations. This situation fails basic logical self-consistency and is regrettable.

## 2. The Limbic System: The Emotional Center

The brain structure closest to the cortex is the limbic lobe, also known as the limbic system. The limbic system governs emotion; controls behaviors related to species survival, such as fight, flight, and sex; participates in regulating certain autonomic functions, such as hunger, sweat secretion, and heartbeat; and is involved in motivation, learning, and memory.



The limbic system is a collective term for several brain structures defined by their similar primary functions. These functions share the characteristic that they cannot, or can only minimally, be controlled by subjective will. Rational decisions from the cortex can at most intervene but cannot exert decisive control.

All human brain activity operates as an integrated whole rather than through independent parts, so information transfer and mutual influence necessarily occur between regions. Nevertheless, a region with clearly defined characteristics such as the limbic system can explain why a large portion of human behavior is not governed by will. Even highly capable individuals can at most indirectly interfere through “thoughts” and cannot exercise direct behavioral control—for example, over emotional behavior. This is an objective law determined by physiological structure and constitutes the scientific theoretical basis for using emotional behavior to interpret a person’s authentic feelings with high accuracy.

Positioned between the “rational brain” (cortex) and the “biological brain” (cerebellum and brainstem), the limbic system parallels how emotional behavior lies between social behavior and physiological behavior: it is close to biological instinct yet requires cortical cognition and reasoning for judgment.

Behavior controlled by the emotional center may be masked by social behavior, so methods are needed to filter it.

What method can filter it? The use of appropriate stimulus sources to force subjects back into an animal-like primitive self-preservation state, which reflects authentic psychological reactions. Such behavior receives the highest priority in observational credibility.

### 3. Social Expressions

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expression-recognition software can identify only deliberately performed expressions. It struggles to detect single subtle expressions and is even less capable with composite subtle-expression combinations. This situation fails basic logical self-consistency and is regrettable.

### **Actually, One-Way Expression Can Also Be Analyzed**

Actually, one-way expression can also be analyzed. This is not a contradiction but an emphasis on a basic principle.

If the goal is to obtain the other party's authentic cognition (for example, whether they are lying) by analyzing their behavior, one must first establish a strict analytical rule—do not analyze one-way expression. The principle, already detailed earlier, is that one-way expression is easily faked and can become a tool of deception.

However, the vast majority of people in the world cannot control their behavior with such precision. It is extremely difficult to rehearse and control every movement, word, glance, and eyebrow. Consequently, even in undisturbed one-way expression, most individuals can control only the primary intended meaning, while the majority of subtle physiological and emotional behaviors remain.

The strict research principle of "do not analyze one-way expression" is adopted to ensure that scientific conclusions minimize interference from possible deception, so that the meaning of each micro-reaction (微反应) points cleanly and clearly to the actor's authentic cognition and feelings. In practical application, it suffices to remember that social behavior carries the possibility of performative deception; one need not cynically assume every social behavior is a disguise.

Moreover, even the analysis of intentionally produced behavior alone can yield highly valuable information. This set of information is called "the actor's intent." Hairstyle, clothing, accessories, scripts, slides, fluent speech, etiquette, consumer goods, and so on, all plainly indicate what information the actor wishes to convey. Such information does not equate to objective fact, yet it accurately reflects the actor's intent. Often this information is also very important: it forms the basis for building good social relationships and can be used to design partial response strategies toward the actor.

### **Muscles You Cannot Control**

Once micro-expressions appear, another issue must be confronted: some expressions are simply beyond voluntary control. In other words, certain facial muscles possess strong autonomy and are difficult to govern by conscious will.

A 1982 report on the meeting between the Pope and Polish leader Jaruzelski described the Pope maintaining a smile and shaking hands with Jaruzelski with a "determined expression." This conveyed an important message: the Pope had acknowledged Jaruzelski's rule in Poland.

The event traces back to the strike at the Gdańsk Shipyard in Poland. Workers launched a major strike to secure a more relaxed political and living environment. The Soviet Union conducted months of military exercises along the Polish border to intimidate Poland. Many feared that if strike leader Wałęsa proved too radical, the Soviets would become dissatisfied and send troops to suppress the strike. After multiple rounds of confrontation, Wałęsa ultimately compromised. With Soviet support, the Polish army took charge, and military leader Jaruzelski became the nation's top leader. A year and a half later, Pope John Paul II visited Poland. His arrival rendered the situation delicate; people speculated whether the Pope had come to support the strike or

to support Jaruzelski. When the two men met, without a word spoken, everyone read the answer from the Pope's expression—the Pope supported Jaruzelski.

Everyone knows the Pope was a master at controlling expressions. He could use his expressions to convey clear political signals, even if not always sincerely. Yet few people in the world could control their expressions as freely as John Paul II.

Some facial muscles can be controlled at will; others are difficult to control. We now clarify the most critical expressive muscles of the human face.

## Related Notes

- **Logical-thinking will:** refers to purposeful behavioral decisions and commands. For example, "Because I am hot, I will remove my coat."
- When blood carbon dioxide levels rise, peripheral chemoreceptors in the carotid and aortic arteries and central chemoreceptors in the medulla detect the increase and raise respiratory rate. Exercise also increases respiratory rate through muscle proprioception, elevated body temperature, adrenaline release, and motor impulses from the brain.
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## 3.2 Whether Expressions Are Honest

As illustrated by the images listed in Chapter 1, full and common expressions are quickly recognized by most people, who then judge the expresser's state of mind. Historical records exist of individuals with brain-function damage who could not recognize expressions; infants under three years of age also cannot recognize all basic expressions. However, mentally normal adolescents and older individuals have no difficulty recognizing common expressions encountered in daily life.

Nevertheless, many obstacles arise in the process of interpreting expression meaning. These difficulties fall into two categories:

- The first concerns determining the meaning of complex expressions. As shown in the final set of images in Chapter 1, such expressions look familiar, yet ordinary people cannot accurately judge the expresser's state of mind; they have a feeling but lack clarity and certainty.
- The second concerns expressions displayed by psychological experts with strong self-control. Whether a blank face or a convincing performance, these expressions are highly deceptive and difficult to interpret.

Overcoming the first category requires the ability to deconstruct complex expression features. Overcoming the second requires, in addition to deconstructing and knowing the subtle facial changes that belong to each expression feature, one further step: distinguishing genuine from false. In a single sentence, expressions triggered by emotion are genuine; expressions controlled by thought are false.

Expressions dominated by emotion are genuine expressions. The fuller the emotion, the more pronounced the resulting changes usually are, and the easier the meaning is to confirm. To determine whether an expression reflects authentic inner feelings, special attention must be paid to these genuine expressions triggered by emotion.

**Summary:** Where there is emotion, there is always an expression; yet an expression does not necessarily have a corresponding emotion as its support. Therefore, the generation of emotion is the foundation of the entire research system, and distinguishing genuine from false expressions is the core value of the entire research system.

## Physiological Behavior

The most typical feature of physiological behavior is that it is directed solely at oneself. While objective outcomes may involve others, the direct associations are actions performed for oneself. Examples include:

- Eating, which resolves hunger and supplies the body with energy and nutrients;
- Drinking, which resolves thirst and supplies the body with water;
- Defecating, the final stage of food metabolism that expels unnecessary waste residue;
- Urinating, the final stage of water metabolism that expels excess water from the body to keep bodily fluids renewed;
- Sleeping, the rest process for the nervous system and body that relieves tension, enhances anabolism (production of cellular structures), and reduces catabolism (breakdown of cellular structures), among other functions.

These self-directed actions are necessary for individual survival. Except in extreme circumstances, no one can exercise complete control over them. On the contrary, these physiological internal needs exert powerful driving force on behavior and can even cause loss of reason and dignity.

In fact, among the eight major human physiological systems—including the respiratory, circulatory, digestive, nervous, endocrine, urinary, reproductive, and motor systems—only the motor system and the diaphragm plus related accessory muscles responsible for breathing can be regulated by cortical logical-thinking will[1]. Even the diaphragm's routine movement does not require will; it is managed entirely by the autonomic nervous system under the joint control of the brainstem, medulla oblongata, and pons[2].

Thus, physiological reactions can map changes in the actor's nervous system with high accuracy. The polygraph operates on this principle: it measures the subject's skin conductance, heartbeat, respiration, blood volume, and other physiological indicators, then judges abnormal psychological activity (lying) according to the correspondence between anomalous indicator changes and the questions posed.

## Keywords of This Book: Micro-expressions (Micro-expression)

You are probably already familiar with this term. Literally, "micro" means subtle, and "expression" refers to changes in facial or postural features that convey inner thoughts and feelings. It must be emphasized that expressions are not limited to facial expressions alone; that would be far too narrow.

Micro-expressions are inherited through long-term human evolution and are not subject to conscious control, so they most accurately reflect a person's true inner world. In other words, micro-expressions are determined by the subconscious and represent an unmaskable truth of thought. They are often hidden beneath other

expressions and vanish in an instant; only 10 percent of people can capture them. They can last as briefly as 0.04 seconds, yet that fleeting 0.04 seconds may betray you.

In the United States, research findings on micro-expressions are widely applied in national security, the judicial system, clinical medicine, and political elections. Many well-trained terrorists can easily pass polygraph tests, but micro-expressions shatter their false masks.

There is no doubt that micro-expressions constitute an advanced and discreet branch of psychology. Grounded in rigorous professional psychology, the authors of this book reveal without reservation how to simplify this difficult “professional technique” and apply it skillfully to everyday life and work.

If you are a manager, read this book carefully; it will show you how to lead a team more effectively. If you are an ordinary employee, be sure to master the “techniques” in this book; they will become your secret weapon for success. If you are a negotiator, do not overlook any detail; you will certainly need them. You do not have to predict the future with precision, but you must grasp the correct principles of analysis and maintain a broad perspective and vision.

Pick up this book. Until you see results, it will be your reliable assistant.

Common Facial Expressions

French physiologist Duchenne de Boulogne wrote in his book *The Mechanism of Human Facial Expression*:

We encounter many unfamiliar faces; these faces reflect people’s inner states. As age advances, the reflection becomes clearer. The face is a display screen that reveals all our inner activities—emotions, desires, expectations, and more.

The “face” we speak of includes not only static physical appearance but also dynamic facial expressions. A person’s forehead, eyebrows, eyes, nose, mouth, and other physical features, together with the movements of these parts, constitute what we call “facial expressions.” A normal person has 44 facial muscles that interact with blood vessels, nerves, and smooth, taut skin wrapped around cartilage and bone, enabling more than 5,000 distinct expressions. Each expression corresponds to a different psychological state. The ability to perceive these states has profound implications for success and happiness.

Psychologists have identified six basic emotions—happiness, sadness, surprise, fear, anger, and disgust—that are expressed relatively directly through facial musculature. The correspondences are summarized in the following table:

| Emotion   | Forehead | Eyebrows/Eyes                                                                           | Cheeks                                     | Mouth                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Happiness | Smooth   | Lower eyelids slightly raised; crow’s feet appear at the outer corners                  | Cheeks bulge, sometimes narrowing the eyes | Corners of the mouth lift and the mouth lengthens; lips may part to reveal teeth; laugh lines appear outside the corners of the mouth |
| Sadness   | Wrinkled | Eyebrows shortened and raised; a triangle forms between the brows, nasal root, and eyes | Muscles slack and dull                     |                                                                                                                                       |

## **Leading People Requires Leading Their Hearts—Start by Observing Subordinates' Expressions**

Many well-known companies with operations in Europe and the United States provide micro-expression training for their management teams. They understand that the ability to detect and interpret micro-expressions is highly useful for team building and management.

The essential elements of team building and management are “people, materials, and money.” Numerous solutions and countermeasures exist for issues arising from materials and money. But what about the human element? An organization is an aggregation of people, each with distinct emotions and values. The organization maintains the delicate bonds and distances among individuals. Yet if any one person's emotions become entangled or collapse, the entire group suffers adverse effects.

In other words, when even one member of a team experiences poor emotional states, the impact is not confined to that individual or a few others; the overall team atmosphere deteriorates and everyone's work efficiency declines rapidly. If early signs of deteriorating relationships or emotional friction among colleagues can be detected, timely repair becomes possible.

Team leaders who supervise many subordinates must monitor their team members' emotional states to raise overall productivity. They must pay special attention to how subordinates are faring at work and whether their psychological condition is affecting performance.

Communication style with subordinates also cannot be ignored. Are you issuing instructions by email when a direct conversation would be possible? Do you assign tasks without making eye contact? Do you criticize subordinates' mistakes solely from your own viewpoint?

Executives at well-known Western companies generally agree on the need to understand how to handle subordinates' emotions. One method that has attracted attention is micro-expression analysis.

### **Observing Words and Expressions**

People who study body language sometimes complain that their minds go blank and they fail to register information conveyed through others' nonverbal behavior. You may encounter the same difficulty while learning, but take courage: fully mastering the techniques of nonverbal communication is a learning process, as difficult as acquiring fluency in a foreign language.

Most foreign-language teachers strongly recommend that students spend more time listening and watching fluent speakers' pronunciation—that is, “immersive learning.” The same principle applies here: once you grasp the meaning of the body movements you observe, repeated practice will suffice.

As mentioned earlier, any gathering of people is an excellent observation site—airports, parks, shopping centers, and so on. Social gatherings and business meetings that permit free expression of emotion and attitude are especially suitable for thorough study, because participants are highly engaged and openly voice their views.

Another effective way to hone people-reading skills is to watch documentary reports, panel discussions, debates, or even fictional crime dramas on television. In simulated performances, actors display a wide range of emotions and intentions. Interview programs are also worth watching; during interviews you will unconsciously observe how the subject responds to questions through body movements.

While watching these programs, first try to follow the narrative from the visuals alone and note each person's facial expressions, gestures, and postures. Then, every five minutes, turn on the sound and compare the verbal content with the conclusions you drew from the expressions and postures. Pay attention to the harmony and consistency of the expressions and postures.

### Chapter 3 The Natural Combination of Emotion and Expression

Six universal emotions exist in the world: surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and happiness. Each emotion possesses specific micro-expression morphological features that allow accurate inference of the corresponding emotion.

Is there truly a necessary connection between emotion and expression?

The first step is to clarify the meaning of the term "expression" as used in this book.

According to the *Xinhua Dictionary*, "expression" refers to the external manifestation of emotion and is divided into facial expression, verbal expression, and postural expression. Facial expression is the manifestation of emotion on the face and is the primary form of emotional expression; verbal expression is the manifestation of emotion through tone, rhythm, and speed of speech; postural expression is the manifestation of emotion through body posture and movement.

Under this definition, expression is an integral part of emotion, just as vocalization is an integral part of language; the two are inseparable. Neuropsychological research supports this view, holding that after the nervous system analyzes and evaluates stimulus information, it produces excitation or inhibition that directs the body to act. This complete "internal + external" process is called emotion.

However, the dictionary definition encompasses facial, postural, and verbal aspects, corresponding fully to all meanings of the English word "expression," which is better rendered as "expression" in the broad sense. Native Chinese speakers habitually understand "表情" to mean facial expression specifically, so the standard definition and common usage do not perfectly align. For convenience, rigor, and respect for usage, the "expressions" or "micro-expressions" discussed in this book are limited to facial expressions. This limitation will not be restated hereafter.

## 2. Emotional Behavior

The central control of emotional behavior lies in the limbic lobe, positioned and functioning between the physiological and rational centers. Consequently, emotional behavior is guided by cortical judgment while simultaneously triggering physiological changes and muscle movements that are not easily constrained by the cortex. Once an emotion arises, basic physiological activities such as heartbeat, blood pressure, respiration, pupil dilation, perspiration, and gastrointestinal motility are affected, as are behaviors such as eye movement, muscle tension or relaxation, facial expression, and trunk posture. These behaviors may later be controlled by the cortex to achieve self-inhibition or concealment, yet they cannot be entirely prevented.

This is the origin of micro-reactions (微反应).

Behind every emotional behavior lies the simplest decision logic of the human organism as a biological individual, carrying the most direct physiological significance for safeguarding individual survival—identical to the emotional responses of animals.

For example:

- When surprised, one looks, listens, and senses more in order to judge whether the stimulus source is beneficial or harmful.
- When disgusted, one withdraws or rejects in order to reduce or block the continuing impact of a negative stimulus, without deeming it worth fighting.
- When angry, one mobilizes physical and mental resources to struggle, eliminating or reducing the threat the stimulus poses to one's interests.
- When afraid, one hides or flees to ensure survival when victory is judged impossible.
- When sad, one accepts the outcome, ceases wasting physical energy on futile recovery, and relinquishes the attempt to reverse the result.
- When happy, one expends considerable energy laughing and becoming excited in order to quickly moderate the high neural excitation produced by a positive stimulus.

It is precisely for this reason that we can interpret emotional reactions to deduce a person's true feelings and cognitions.

### **Training "Emotional Perception," Starting with Reading the Other Person's Expressions**

Mr. S wanted to solve the mystery of "being able to tell what the other person is thinking or feeling." It is undeniable that before acquiring mind-reading ability, Mr. S had conversed with all kinds of people and thereby gained intuitive and spiritual experience. Through countless social interactions and frontline management experience accumulated over many years, these encounters became spiritual gains.

Yet Mr. S's wish was to "technologize experience." Within the realm of experience, these abilities belong to rules of thumb that are difficult to convey clearly to others. Mr. S possessed the management skills required of an operator, most of which depended on his own level of competence.

When Mr. S learned of the existence of micro-expressions, he thought: "Perhaps it is because I can perceive micro-expressions. Micro-expressions are scientific; they can turn rules of thumb into techniques. Once techniques are created, they can be taught to others."

For Mr. S, the phrase "balance of reason and emotion" was important.

Regarding this phrase, Mr. S said: "Acting reasonably earns others' recognition while also understanding their emotions. Mastering the balance between 'reason' and 'emotion' sets an example for the new generation of leaders."

In the terminology of emotional psychology, a rational mind riding the track of emotion constitutes the judgment, leadership, insight, and affinity that operators, supervisors, and managers must possess. The key to further strengthening "emotional perception" lies in the ability to detect and interpret micro-expressions.

### **Chapter 1 Without Micro-expressions, You Are "Out"**

Is "micro-expression mind reading" truly so magical that a single, almost imperceptible micro-expression can reveal a person's innermost thoughts? Although micro-expressions are remarkable, once you learn to observe and understand what they signify, they cease to be unfathomable.

After the American television series *Lie to Me* aired, it became hugely popular across the United States, especially among younger viewers, who began paying attention to micro-expressions and micro-reactions in daily life and social interactions. When the series, centered on micro-expression lie detection, was introduced



to China, it rapidly captured Chinese audiences and sparked a wave of interest in lie detection. Subsequently, in 2010, Hong Kong's Television Broadcasts Limited produced *The Mind Reader*, a drama strikingly similar to *Lie to Me*; its subject matter likewise involved solving criminal cases through expression observation. Although the actors' expressions were somewhat exaggerated and stiff, this did not diminish public enthusiasm for "lie-detection techniques" and "mind-reading techniques."

In *Lie to Me*, the male lead, Cal Lightman, states: "An ordinary person tells an average of three lies every ten minutes during conversation." Have people really become so untrustworthy? Is "micro-expression mind reading" truly so magical that a single, almost imperceptible micro-expression can reveal a person's innermost thoughts? Although micro-expressions are remarkable, once you learn to observe and understand what they signify, they cease to be unfathomable. This chapter will guide you into the world of human "micro-expressions" and explore their mysterious origins.

## 1. Basic Physiological Activities

Basic physiological activities controlled by the autonomic nervous system proceed automatically without any cortical thought or command and continue even in the absence of any stimulus; examples include breathing, heartbeat, blood circulation, sweat secretion, food digestion, endocrine function, and pupil constriction or dilation.

In simple terms, these activities do not require "thought" to direct them. Their normal maintenance usually does not involve the first three processes—that is, they are managed directly by the autonomic nervous system without engaging the brain's thinking and judgment.

However, cortical cognition, evaluation, and judgment can influence the state of these basic physiological activities.

When an abnormal situation arises—for instance, fright or joy—the brain receives stimulus information from the sensory organs, performs evaluation and judgment, and may also generate volitional behavioral decisions and overt actions. Yet the judgment produced by cortical rational cognition and evaluation also affects the autonomic nervous system and thereby influences basic physiological indicators.

For students, examination results are a highly significant stimulus, often carrying major implications for gain or loss. When a student sees his or her report card, the cortex applies highly complex rules of judgment that may include numerical scores, ranking percentages, scholarship or advancement prospects, parental reactions, peer evaluations, rewards or punishments, and so on. These purely social-rule judgments can cause pupils to dilate and blood pressure to rise in happy students, sudden cold sweats in fearful students, and listlessness in sad students.

Thus, the daily maintenance of basic physiological activities does not require volitional participation, yet the results of rational evaluation and judgment can significantly affect changes in their indicators.

### Step Two: Sternly Tell Them—Don't Think You Are So Impressive; in Fact You Understand Nothing!

When a hopeful person is completely rejected, his or her emotions fluctuate markedly and the mouth changes accordingly. You can first eliminate two types of people:

- People whose mouth corners turn downward: rigid, stubborn, strong self-esteem; they tend to withdraw when struck.

- People who purse their lips tightly: solid workers, but suspicious and prone to closing themselves off.

Therefore, focus next on the following types:

1. **People whose lips form a straight line:** strong character; they do not withdraw immediately when frustrated and can complete ordinary tasks well.
2. **People whose mouth corners turn slightly upward:** flexible minds, relatively open-minded; they do not become pessimistic when criticized harshly and maintain good interpersonal relationships.
3. **People whose lower lip protrudes forward:** strong self-esteem, adventurous spirit; even if you are the interviewer, they will show disagreement or even refute you if they believe you are wrong.
4. **People whose upper and lower lips both protrude forward:** calm and rational; they mentally raise defenses when they sense a situation unfavorable to themselves.
5. **People who bite their lips:** strong analytical ability; they may be listening attentively or analyzing your words against their own experience. Regardless of whether you are right or wrong, they will form their own judgment internally and, once decided, will carry it through to the end.

Believe me, once you combine these observations with the specific content and characteristics of the project, you will certainly be able to select the most suitable candidate from the five types above!

## 1. Cortex: Rational Center

The first center is the perception and thinking center, served by the cortex. The cortex includes the frontal lobe, parietal lobe, occipital lobe, and temporal lobe, among others. Specifically:

- The frontal lobe is responsible for controlling somatic movement, integrating sensory information, and higher-order thinking and decision-making;
- The parietal lobe handles somatic sensation and constructs cognition of the world, such as spatial awareness and sense of direction;
- The occipital lobe primarily processes visual information;
- The temporal lobe manages auditory information, semantic and episodic memory, and the processing and control of auditory-related language.

The language functions unique to humans are all managed by centers located in the cortex. The auditory language center resides in the temporal lobe, the visual language center (for reading) is in the parietal lobe, with its visual input coming from the occipital lobe. The motor language centers for speaking and writing are located in the frontal lobe. Referring again to the earlier figure and annotations, one primary function of the frontal lobe is “higher-order thinking and decision-making,” which explains why, in the micro-reaction (micro-reaction) framework, verbal expression is classified as classic social display—the form most subject to voluntary control. In addition, the frontal lobe serves as the motor center, governing all deliberate somatic movements.

In the simplest terms, the cortex’s role is: “Figure it out, carry it out, say it out.”

Behaviors controlled by the cortex are the easiest to falsify and the least reliable when observing for deception.

Every skeletal muscle movement throughout the body can be precisely controlled by the cortex; the content one thinks before speaking and the vibration of the vocal cords during speech can also be cortex-controlled. This is why the micro-reaction framework follows the principle “do not analyze unidirectional expression.”

## 2. Emotional Expressions

Each emotional expression possesses a unique combination of organ morphology features. Micro-expressions conform to these same features, differing only in that their amplitude and duration are smaller and thus easily overlooked.

Humans possess six basic emotions. Extensive scientific evidence shows that emotional expressions are consistent across geography, race, society, education, age, and gender. They are: **surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and happiness.**

These six basic emotions have many milder variants, listed below:

- Surprise has few variants;
- Variants of disgust may include revulsion, aversion, dislike, contempt, distaste, scorn, and dismissiveness;
- Variants of anger may include irritation, irritability, irascibility, temper outbursts, displeasure, seriousness, and sternness;
- Variants of fear may include apprehension, worry, anxiety, unease, dread, embarrassment, concern, and taboo avoidance;
- Variants of sadness may include sorrow, dejection, low mood, loss, guilt, regret, helplessness, grievance, and gloom;
- Variants of happiness may include satisfaction, smugness, joy, delight, and excitement.

The specific morphologies of these emotional expressions constitute the core of this book and will be examined in detail in the corresponding later chapters. Once the morphological features are mastered, the emotional category can be accurately inferred.

Emotional category is crucial for determining lies and the subject's true cognition and feelings.

## 3. Actions and Performances

Examiners can achieve strong stimulative effects by performing certain actions or staging performances.

For example, while serving tea or water, one may control interpersonal distance and torso posture, the placement and force with which a cup is set down; while conversing, one may regulate speech rate and gaze; upon meeting, one may control handshake style and duration or the intensity of an embrace; while walking together, one may adjust position, speed, and whether physical contact occurs. These subtle everyday behaviors exert a cumulative, subliminal stimulative effect.

If a stronger stimulus is deliberately required, "improper" behavior readily produces it. Examples include straightening a stranger's collar, tie, or shirt buttons on first meeting; touching or stroking the other person's body (arm, back, waist, or hip); or insisting on lighting a cigarette for a nonsmoker and placing it in their mouth.

Beyond interactive contact, performances can also be designed to generate intense stimulation. Examples include repeatedly digging one's nose in front of a fastidious person; behaving with abandon—eating, drinking, and speaking without restraint—in the presence of a dignified individual; displaying murderous intent before someone already panicked; stammering before a person in deep grief; or feigning shock before someone who is self-satisfied. Such stylistic behaviors elicit strong reactions from different subjects and trigger numerous valid responses.

## Summary

In summary, when humans face threats to survival or reproduction, their response mechanisms revert to an animal level.

At such times, animalistic reactions override rational “posturing” and assume control, revealing inner emotions and thoughts through myriad subtle responses.

## Other Limbic System Structures

The following structures are also regarded in some literature as part of the limbic system:

- **Mammillary body:** Important for memory formation.
- **Pituitary gland:** Secretes hormones and regulates homeostasis.
- **Dentate gyrus:** Considered a factor in constructing new memories and modulating pleasure.
- **Entorhinal and piriform cortices:** Receive olfactory input within the olfactory system.
- **Fornicate gyrus:** The region surrounding the cingulate gyrus, hippocampus, and parahippocampal gyrus.
- **Olfactory bulb:** Handles olfactory sensory input.
- **Nucleus accumbens:** Mediates reward, pleasure, and addiction.
- **Ventral prefrontal area:** Essential for decision-making.

[2]

## Cranial Nerves

These ten pairs include the oculomotor, trochlear, trigeminal, abducens, facial, vestibulocochlear, glossopharyngeal, vagus, accessory, and hypoglossal nerves.

## True and False Expressions: Human Expressions Are Best at Concealment and Disguise

Micro-expression keyword: Can expressions also be false? Indeed, apart from fleeting micro-expressions, the brain can direct the production of various expressions that accompany lies. Deliberately produced expressions either fail to synchronize with bodily movements or appear overly intentional, inevitably revealing small flaws. Careful observation can always expose aspects of a person’s inner state and remove their mask of pretense.

In daily life, when someone says “I love you,” do you privately wonder whether they are lying—whether the sentiment is genuine or feigned? When a new acquaintance treats you with elaborate courtesy, you may think, “Actually, he is not pleased to see me.” We routinely attempt to read others’ inner states through their expressions, yet how many can confidently claim to “see through” another person?

Our surroundings are not short of individuals whose outward appearance contradicts their inner nature and who excel at disguise, using a glittering exterior to conceal inner malice. When dealing with such people, one cannot rely solely on surface impressions; one must penetrate the appearance to discern their true thoughts, especially their ever-changing expressions. Distinguishing genuine from false expressions enables us to identify their inner reality.

Research has identified three cues that reveal an expression as false: facial asymmetry during conversation, temporal factors, and relative sequencing.

## 3. Emotion–Expression Causal Logic

A complete logical link exists between the generation of emotion and the stimulus source; that link is the subject's cognitive appraisal of the stimulus.

First, we observe muscle movements and changes in facial organ morphology. These movements and morphological changes follow universal patterns, allowing inference of the emotion category and intensity. The judgment that stress-induced emotional expressions are accurate rests on the fact that each muscle movement and morphology possesses an original physiological meaning shaped by evolutionary survival needs.

Next, each emotion corresponds to a category of cognitive appraisal and feeling—that is, the subject's internal subjective judgment of the stimulus source.

Therefore, regardless of what the subject expresses verbally or through other social behaviors, the stress response contains critical information. The micro-expressions map the subject's true cognition and feelings, enabling the most accurate assessment. Combined with the causal link to the stimulus source, this information can unlock many "secrets the subject cannot or will not state."

### Figure 2-3 Psychological Analysis via Expression

#### Context

Context is a collective term encompassing three factors:

- **Test background information:** In English, WHAT. More precisely, what has occurred before the polygraph questions are asked? What outcomes (correct or incorrect) will follow the polygraph conclusion? Who ultimately stands to gain or lose?
- **Who is tested:** In English, WHO. Here WHO does not refer to narrowing the suspect pool but to the specific profile of the person undergoing the lie test—personality, behavioral habits, upbringing and education, representative past actions, and position within the overall event (location in the relational network). Later chapters will confirm that different individuals lie in different ways.
- **Test environment:** This cannot be rendered simply as WHERE in English. The environment here primarily denotes the spatial layout, lighting, objects, and personnel that may influence the subject during testing.

The same stimulus source may elicit different responses in different contexts. The same stress micro-expression may likewise carry different meanings in different contexts.

#### Temporal Factors

Temporal factors also permit differentiation of genuine from false expressions. These include the duration of a facial expression and the speed of its onset and offset, supplying additional cues about the speaker's expression.

Generally, expressions that persist for a long time are almost always false; genuine, heartfelt expressions are brief unless the emotion reaches an extreme, as with Fan Jin's expression in "Fan Jin Passes the Exam"—ecstatic or furious. Even in such extremes, facial expressions rarely last long.

No rigid rule governs onset and offset speed as a deception cue, except for surprise. When a person displays a surprised expression, its onset, duration, and offset are extremely brief—less than one second. If the expression lasts longer, it is usually either playful or declarative and can be judged as feigned. Once an

unexpected event is clarified, a person quickly recovers composure. Although anyone can produce a surprised expression, few truly understand that genuine surprise appears and disappears rapidly.

## 6. Orbicularis Oris Muscle

Among the fifteen groups of facial muscles, the orbicularis oris is the only one that does not appear in symmetrical pairs, although its internal structure is symmetrical.

Its name closely resembles that of the orbicularis oculi, differing by only one character. The nomenclature originated from the mistaken assumption that the mouth, like the eye, is encircled by a ring of striated muscle functioning as a sphincter. In reality, the orbicularis oris comprises four parts—marginal and peripheral portions—whose junction corresponds externally to the vermilion border. The peripheral portion connects in all directions to other major facial muscles of the lower face: levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, levator labii superioris, zygomaticus major, platysma, depressor anguli oris, depressor labii inferioris, and mentalis.

Contraction of the orbicularis oris purses or protrudes the lips, while surrounding muscles may exert opposing forces, pulling portions of the orbicularis oris in different directions to produce actions such as raising the upper lip, elevating the mouth corners, stretching the lips, lowering the mouth corners, or parting the lower lip.

Consequently, the mouth is the second critical site, after the eyes, for capturing and analyzing expression changes.

### 3.5.2 Decoding “Why Lie” via Micro-Expressions

In summary, dynamic facial expressions fall into three categories, as shown in Figure 2-2.

Whenever physiological, emotional, and social expressions contradict one another, or when physiological and emotional expressions contradict the subject’s verbal statements, the subject is likely concealing their true thoughts.

Knowing whether someone is lying, however, is not the most important goal. Knowing why they are lying is the far more significant analytical objective.

The final chapter of *Micro-Reactions* explores in detail why psychological stress micro-reactions can detect deception. The first question to resolve is: What constitutes a lie?

A lie is defined as “cognition differing from expression.” To establish that an utterance is a lie, one must identify and demonstrate that the subject’s subjective cognition differs from the expressed content; this is the internal logic of lie detection. Both “cognition” and “expression” are indispensable, and a contradiction between them must exist for a lie to be present.

Identifying a contradiction between cognition and expression identifies the lie.

## Your Observation Record Sheet

While learning to read people as one reads a book, you must attend to many details. Only then can you accurately describe a person’s thoughts or feelings. Pay attention to the following:

- Facial expressions, including forehead, eyebrows, eyes, nose, mouth, and chin.
- Head position.

- Back and shoulder position.
- Shoulder and hand movements.
- Leg and foot movements, including gait.
- Pitch and other vocal changes, such as throat clearing.
- The interactions among all the above changes.

When these nonverbal cues are linked, they form highly instructive information. During interactions, this information helps determine the next step. Whether the encounter is casual and private or formal and professional, the information can, in certain situations, assist you—at minimum by maintaining harmony and reaching consensus.

### **Consider “Other Possibilities”**

Observing others’ postures is simple; accurately interpreting their meaning is exceptionally difficult. For instance, when someone suddenly covers their mouth while speaking, this usually indicates uncertainty about the truth of their statement. If you encounter this gesture, do you conclude the person is lying? Human nature being what it is, we rarely consider alternative explanations instinctively. Most people automatically interpret the gesture as lying, uncertainty, or an attempt to hide something.

The facts may indeed be so, yet before concluding, recall whether the person has performed this gesture previously and under what circumstances. If not, consider whether they may have undergone recent dental work or been told they have bad breath and have just become aware of it during the conversation. In short, always entertain other possibilities.

### **3. Cerebellum and Brainstem: Animal Center (or Physiological Center)**

The brain structures that maintain basic physiological functions are the cerebellum and brainstem; the brainstem comprises the midbrain, pons, and medulla oblongata.

The cerebellum governs movement and balance. Complex limb movements—gymnastics, martial arts, square dancing—can be executed without consciously directing each muscle. Although cortical oversight remains available during competition or conflict, most everyday actions occur without “thinking” involvement.

The brainstem regulates complex reflex activities, including respiration, heartbeat, and blood pressure, all essential for sustaining life. Of the twelve pairs of cranial nerves, ten (excluding the olfactory and optic nerves) have their nuclei in the brainstem. Medicine therefore often uses “brainstem death” as the criterion for loss of human life. All basic physiological activities that require no conscious attention are managed continuously here.

### **Step ③ | Design Dialogue That Supports Emotion**

After interpreting micro-expressions, one can identify the suppressed emotion and its underlying cause, then craft questions that resonate with that emotion, allowing the conversation to proceed more smoothly. This is not merely a psychological insight; it is an essential skill whenever one must initiate interaction with colleagues or clients in professional settings. Greater experience facilitates smoother integration with Steps ① and ②.

At this point, although concrete application methods have not yet been addressed, you may still find the three steps unclear. Rest assured—more explicit guidance follows. Once a micro-expression is detected, one can

infer that the other person harbors an additional story beneath their surface words. In other words, the instant a micro-expression appears is the moment to pose a question and the focal point for uncovering the relevant topic.

### **Relative Sequencing**

Relative sequencing refers to the precise temporal alignment of an expression with speech, voice, and bodily behavior. For example, if a person is angry, the facial expression of anger should appear simultaneously with the words "I'm furious." If the expression appears only after the words are spoken, it can be judged as feigned. If the expression precedes speech, its authenticity cannot be determined without additional methods.

Any facial expression that fails to synchronize with bodily movements is likely feigned. Mastery of the techniques for distinguishing genuine from false expressions makes one a mind-reading expert; anyone in your presence will have their mask removed.

### **Corporate Executive Suppressed by the Board of Directors**

We tested a corporate executive. She was a highly successful woman in every respect, with outstanding psychological resilience and personal cultivation. Yet when asked about differences in investment strategy with the board, she displayed several small signs of irritation, including changes in facial expression and shifts in body and leg posture. The most noticeable was that, while describing her own views and the current situation, she lit and smoked two cigarettes in succession. Although all outward manner and speech remained perfectly composed, we concluded that the matter was extremely difficult for her and that her mood was correspondingly poor.

After the test she confirmed our inference: she had indeed been suppressed by the board on investment strategy and felt quite depressed.

## **2. Visual Stimuli**

In scientific experiments, visual stimulation is a very common method. Different images or videos are displayed on a screen and subjects are asked to respond to the visual information. Eye-trackers are typical devices of this kind; some micro-expression experiments also employ them. Abroad, researchers have used the speed at which subjects like photographs of Black and White people to gauge the degree of racial bias. Tests for homosexual tendencies, advertising effectiveness, and product popularity are further examples too numerous to list.

In criminal investigation, photographs, slides, documentary evidence, and witness statements are likewise used to present visual stimuli that elicit relevant reactions from suspects.

## **12. Platysma**

The platysma originates from the upper chest and inserts, after passing over the mandible, into the orbicularis oris at the corner of the mouth; it is paired. In this book the term refers only to the facial portion of the platysma, because these fibers can pull the corners of the mouth and thereby form important facial expressions. Near the mouth angle the fibers lie between the depressor anguli oris and the depressor labii inferioris, on the same plane as the latter; at their margins the three muscles fuse and all attach to the lower lip.



The action of the platysma is similar to that of the zygomaticus major—stretching the corners of the mouth laterally—yet the direction is entirely different. The zygomaticus major pulls the corners toward the ears; the platysma pulls them laterally and downward (in concert with the depressor anguli oris). It typically appears in expressions of crying with an open mouth or of pouting and conveys negative emotion.

### 3.6 Muscles That Produce Facial Expressions and Micro-expressions

Fifteen groups of muscles initiate and form facial expressions; additional craniofacial muscles also participate. For ease of study and memorization we divide the dominant muscles into upper and lower groups and illustrate them schematically. Muscles 1–5, centered on the orbicularis oculi (No. 5), constitute the upper-face expression group (abbreviated “upper face” from Chapter 4 onward). Muscles 6–15, centered on the orbicularis oris (No. 11), constitute the lower-face expression group (abbreviated “lower face” from Chapter 4 onward). Note that many other muscles exist on the face—temporalis, masticatory muscles, etc.—and actual anatomical diagrams are far more complex. The muscles shown are the principal bundles that dominate expression formation.

#### Reference Note

The levator palpebrae superioris is a thin triangular muscle arising from the lesser wing of the sphenoid bone immediately above the optic canal, separated from the attachment of the superior rectus. At its posterior attachment it is a slender narrow tendon that gradually broadens; as it passes forward above the eyeball it widens markedly and ends anteriorly as a broad aponeurosis. Some tendinous fibers run straight forward into the upper eyelid and attach to the anterior surface of the tarsal plate. The remaining fibers radiate through the orbicularis oculi to insert into the skin of the upper lid.

(Gray’s Anatomy, 39th ed., Susan Standring, trans. Xu Qunyuan, p. 776. Peking University Medical Press, 1st ed., January 2008.)

### Micro-expressions Are Unconscious and Difficult Even for the Person to Control

The face contains thirty to sixty muscles known as “muscles of expression.” By controlling these muscles, a variety of expressions are formed on the face. Some of these muscles are difficult to move by conscious will; a person cannot arbitrarily control every expression. These hard-to-control muscles readily reveal micro-expressions in an instant.

We now turn to the psychology behind the appearance of micro-expressions in order to understand further what causes them to surface unconsciously.

A micro-expression is a suppressed emotion that appears unconsciously on the face for an instant and then vanishes immediately. It is not a deliberately feigned expression. Two situations may be considered:

### 3.5 The Principle of Micro-expression Lie Detection

Once a genuine emotion arises it must be expressed, though not necessarily only through facial changes. It can also be judged and analyzed through body movements, posture (see the book *Micro-reactions* (微反应)), and language, ultimately approaching the truth.

First, do not attempt to analyze everything. The expressions you see on another person’s face may well be deliberately disguised or well-trained “shells.” Analyzing such expressions only causes you to “throw yourself

headlong into a pit someone else has dug.”

What we must analyze are only the physiological and emotional expressions triggered after an effective stimulus. Social expressions must never be analyzed.

### **Question 3: What Does the “Micro” in Micro-reaction Mean and Where Does It Come From?**

Human behavior can be divided into three categories: physiological behavior, emotional behavior, and social behavior.

After receiving an effective stimulus, humans produce physiological and emotional behaviors that reflect their true cognition and feelings. Yet they are unwilling to be seen through, so they attempt to suppress and disguise these behaviors with socially controlled behavior. As a result, the physiological and emotional behaviors shrink in amplitude or disappear, shorten in duration or cease, and become hard to detect—hence the word “micro.” Nevertheless these behaviors still exist and can still break through the inhibition and disguise of social behavior. Even when small in amplitude and brief in duration, they continue to convey large amounts of valuable and valid information.

### **Learning How to Read People**

Learning comes from gaining insight through reading books, yet among all the knowledge in the world the most necessary is learning how to perceive others and studying all kinds of people with care.

—Lord Chesterfield

To learn to read people as one reads books, the first requirement is that you must become a keen observer. You can begin now by going to crowded places and observing everyone’s postures, expressions, movements, and interactions. This chapter provides a platform for cultivating sharp observational skills—the airport, an ideal setting for honing your powers of observation.

### **1. Questioning**

The most common form of stimulus is to ask a question and require the person to answer. Questions may be posed verbally or in writing; the latter is less common. In daily life and in criminal investigation, the great majority of exchanges consist of verbal question-and-answer sequences. The questioner can further modify the emphasis of the stimulus by varying volume, rhythm, stress, repetition, tone, and other paralinguistic features.

Besides questioning, many other forms can also serve as excellent stimuli.

### **Conclusion**

This chapter prepares you for the careful observation that follows. Yet you cannot know whether your people-reading efforts will succeed until you act on your own intuition. It is the same principle as with a new car: it must pass tests before it reaches the showroom, but only real-world use can truly evaluate it.

Before you begin actual testing, however, you still need to learn a great deal. In the chapters ahead we will discuss in detail the meanings of people’s various expressions, gestures, and postures.

### **Micro-expression Keywords**

When we observe others, the first thing we see is the head. It moves almost constantly. Through head movements we can analyze another person's inner thoughts: approval or disapproval, friendliness or hostility, interest or boredom, and so on.

When using movement to read people, we begin with the head. This is not only because the head is at the top of the body and most conspicuous, but also because head movements convey a great deal of information. Below we list several examples at random.

## 15. Mentalis

The mentalis originates from the inferior border of the orbicularis oris (below the lower lip) and inserts into the skin of the chin; it is paired.

When the mentalis contracts it produces two effects: it bulges on the chin, creating an uneven skin surface, and simultaneously pushes the central part of the lower lip upward. This important morphological feature appears chiefly in expressions of sadness. The action can also be performed voluntarily to express deliberate sorrow, contempt, or other negative meanings.

### Step ① | Understanding the Relationship Between Muscles of Expression and Emotion

First, understand the relationship between muscles of expression and emotion. For example, movements such as "both eyebrows drawing toward the center" or "lower lip rising" are related to emotion. "Both eyebrows drawing toward the center" is associated with "anger," while "lower lip rising" is associated with "sadness."

Next, understand the causes of these emotions. For instance, "anger" arises when a desired goal is obstructed. Understanding the functions of expressions and emotions is very important.

## 16. Buccinator

After the cheeks are puffed out, the buccinator can expel air between the lips—an important action when playing wind instruments, which is also the origin of the muscle's name (Latin buccinator = trumpeter). Its main contribution to expression is "puffing the cheeks," yet this artificial expression has no close relationship with emotion and at most signals relief from pressure. It is therefore marked "A" and is not explained in detail in this book, nor included among the principal muscle groups.

### Head Tilted Backward

This movement indicates pride or confidence. Usually, however, it leaves a negative impression. In television dramas, for example, snobbish characters often tilt their heads back with nostrils pointing upward when facing someone they consider inferior. In life, when a person tilts the head backward, the emotional progression is roughly from smugness to self-importance to a sense of superiority. Basically, the movement makes others feel you are being provocative, so it should be used sparingly.

### Question 6: What Forms Can Stimuli Take?

Psychological-stress micro-reaction analysis does not examine a person's unidirectional expression, because it is impossible to determine which parts are controlled social behavior and which are inadvertent genuine disclosures; theoretically, unidirectional expression can be 100 % controlled.

Psychological-stress micro-reaction analysis examines only stress responses—reactions that occur after a stimulus. Therefore a stimulus source must first be present before analysis can begin.

1. Questioning
2. Visual stimuli
3. Actions and performances
4. Situation shaping

### **How to Discern the Other Person's "True Intention"—The Three Steps Are Key!**

Detecting and interpreting micro-expressions allows us to capture another person's unconscious emotions. How, then, do we capture these unconscious emotions?

The following outline introduces the steps; detailed content and practical methods will be explained in this and the next chapter. Applying the ability to read micro-expressions in communication involves three steps, categorized as "understanding," "interpretation," and "support":

### **Chapter 2 Eyebrow and Eye Corners Conceal Intentions; Voice, Expression, and Smile Reveal Mysteries**

Micro-expressions are revelations of inner truth. When people express a thought or feeling, a fleeting expression may cross their face—this is a micro-expression on display and in communication. The information these micro-expressions convey constitutes the most accurate clues to another person's inner intentions. People can be judged by their appearance; through careful observation and analysis of micro-expressions we can discern a person's spiritual life and inner mysteries.

#### **7. Levator Labii Superioris Alaeque Nasi**

The middle portion of the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi attaches to the major alar cartilage and the overlying skin; the lateral portion extends into the lateral upper lip (toward the mouth corner) and there fuses with the levator labii superioris and the orbicularis oris; it is paired.

Contraction produces two effects: the middle portion dilates the nostril; the lateral portion elevates and everts the upper lip, raising, deepening, and increasing the curvature of the top of the nasolabial fold.

### **Chapter 1 Observing People in the Subtle, Discerning People in the Invisible**

Reading words and expressions is the fundamental skill for handling all human relations with ease. Without it, one is like someone turning a rudder without knowing the wind direction. In real life we must deal with all kinds of people and face extremely complex crowds; we must therefore train a pair of discerning eyes capable of accurately reading others' inner thoughts. Once we possess this ability, many people's little schemes will no longer escape our notice.

#### **Question 5: What Can Micro-reactions Be Used For?**

Interpersonal behavior is highly complex; the performance presented onstage and the motives backstage are usually processed multiple times before finally appearing before you. Do not readily believe the performance you can directly observe; instead, look through the performance for the "uncontrolled" micro-reactions of the parties involved. Only those tiny reactions can be used to analyze and judge the parties' true cognition and feelings.

## Head Lowered

This head movement signifies negation. For example, if your superior lowers the head halfway through your work report, it almost certainly means dissatisfaction with the work and unwillingness to continue listening. At that point you should tactfully stop and offer to improve the work. People also lower the head unconsciously when receiving criticism, thereby expressing remorse.

### 14. Depressor Labii Inferioris

The depressor labii inferioris lies below the orbicularis oris, fuses with its inferior circumference, and is paired.

As the name indicates, this muscle pulls the lower lip downward and slightly laterally and can also help evert the lower lip. It participates in angry shouting, biting, fear, and sadness. To expose the lower teeth, the depressor labii inferioris must be engaged.

### 13. Depressor Anguli Oris

The depressor anguli oris arises by a long attachment from the mental tubercle of the mandible and the continuous oblique line below the origin of the depressor labii inferioris; it is paired.

**Action:** When the mouth opens or when sorrow or distress is expressed, the depressor anguli oris pulls the mouth corner downward and laterally. When the mouth opens, the mentolabial sulcus becomes more horizontal, its middle portion level.

## Head Suddenly Dropped

This can hide the face and indicates that the person is being humble or shy. In a competitive setting, however, lowering the head signals that the person can no longer bear the pressure and hopes the argument will end soon.

The head is the body's "command center" and is the first to convey another person's inner language; it truly cannot be ignored.

## Head Held Straight

In ancient Chinese philosophy the phrase "neither 偏 nor 倚 is called the mean" appears. It means that if the head posture remains in a normal position, the person neither approves nor disapproves of your viewpoint and maintains a neutral stance. Such individuals may be deeply calculating and extremely reserved; to persuade them you must present terms advantageous to them.

### 11. Risorius

The fibers of the risorius interweave at the mouth corner with the zygomaticus major, depressor anguli oris, and orbicularis oris; some superficial fibers attach beneath the dermis of the nasolabial fold; it is paired.

The risorius assists the zygomaticus major in elevating the mouth corner during smiling and indirectly alters the shape and depth of the nasolabial fold.

## Head Tilted to One Side

Generally, when we are interested in something or someone, or when we agree with a viewpoint, we perform this movement, often accompanied by repeated nodding. Therefore, when someone is speaking to you, simply tilting your head, nodding, and smiling will make the other person feel warmth and encourage continued conversation.

## **Micro-expressions: Only the Fleeting Expressions Are Authentic and Credible**

### **Micro-expression Keywords**

People display inner feelings through expressions. Some expressions are not controlled by the brain; they are subconscious and often flash by in an instant. We call them "micro-expressions." Only these very brief expressions reveal people's true inner state.

### **Head Suddenly Raised**

With an unfamiliar person, raising the head indicates surprise. In a familiar setting it indicates sudden realization or sudden understanding. In business interactions such movements generally leave an impression of instability and unreliability. This body language is also highly unwelcome.

## **10. Zygomaticus Major**

The zygomaticus major originates from the zygomatic bone and, at the mouth corner, fuses with the risorius, orbicularis oris, and depressor anguli oris to form a deeper muscle bundle; it is paired.

Although the zygomaticus major and zygomaticus minor have similar names, their actions are completely different. For expression, the zygomaticus major has only one function: pulling the mouth corner upward and laterally to produce a smile.

## **Chapter 1 Becoming a Faithful Reader of Body Language**

- Your observation platform: the airport
- Language exchange generated by "one glance"
- Observing a sequence of body movements
- Considering "other possibilities"
- Reading "words" and observing "color"
- Reactions to non-verbal information
- Your observation record sheet
- Conclusion

### **Repeated Nodding**

Nodding indicates agreement, understanding, and encouragement. Most often it signals agreement; simply nodding and smiling while listening to someone speak can leave a favorable impression. If the movement is performed too frequently, however, it can appear perfunctory.

## **3.7 Some Terms Used in This Book**

This book primarily studies the analysis of people's true psychological states by capturing micro-expressions. Certain relatively specialized terms appear; they are introduced here uniformly so that readers will not be distracted later by uncommon vocabulary.

## Chapter 1 Ten Professional Questions to Enter the “Micro” Gate

Social performance is always a prepared “performance”; micro-reactions are instinctive biological responses and are therefore the most accurate clues to a person’s true inner thoughts. They are a tool for understanding others and can also be used to design strategies for dealing with them.

### Section 1 The Secret Weapon for Seeing Through People's Hearts: Expressions

A person's expressions refer to the ways in which people express emotions and sentiments through postures, attitudes, and similar means. They can generally be divided into facial expressions, verbal and tonal expressions, and body posture expressions. Subtle changes in these expressions can reflect the subtle emotional fluctuations or changes in a person's inner world.

#### 8. Levator Labii Superioris

The levator labii superioris originates from the inferior orbital margin. Its muscle fibers, together with the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi and the zygomaticus minor, converge on the lateral side of the upper lip (near the corner of the mouth), symmetrically on both sides.

Contraction of the levator labii superioris raises and everts the upper lip, and together with other muscles, alters the shape of the nasolabial fold.

#### 9. Zygomaticus Minor

The zygomaticus minor originates from the lateral surface of the zygomatic bone and inserts on the lateral side of the upper lip (near the corner of the mouth), symmetrically on both sides.

Contraction of the zygomaticus minor raises the upper lip, exposes the upper maxillary teeth, helps deepen and lift the nasolabial fold, and primarily participates in expressing emotions of disgust and sadness.

### Step ② | Correctly Interpreting Micro-expressions

After understanding what the actions of the facial muscles mean in terms of emotions, the next step is to actually interpret them. After reading about the seven expressions introduced in this book, by paying attention to and carefully observing the other person's expressions, one will naturally acquire the skill of interpreting micro-expressions.

#### Actor/Party Involved

When introducing knowledge about micro-expressions, if it is to describe actions that are not stress responses—for example, in the context of performing facial expressions—one should not use “test subject,” but instead use terms like “actor” or “party involved” to refer to them.

## Chapter 2 The Four Meridians and Eight Vessels Important to Micro-reactions ()

The full name of micro-reaction is psychological stress micro-reaction, referring to the inadvertent reaction actions a person makes after receiving an effective stimulus; its applicable fields are all interpersonal interaction scenarios. Micro-reactions—everyone can't escape them!

## Question 7: Why Can't Humans Fully Control Their Own Behavior?

"One-way expression without analysis" illustrates the importance of the stimulus source. Why, under the premise of an effective stimulus, can humans not control their behavior 100%? This needs to be explained starting from our brain.

1. Cortex: Rational center
2. Limbic system: Emotional center
3. Cerebellum and brainstem: Animal center (or physiological center)
  1. Basic physiological activities
  2. Emotional behavior

## Chapter 2 The Face That Speaks

"The face reflects the heart," a person's temperament can be seen from the face. Appearance is naturally also a focus of observation. The face directly reflects a person's inner world; everything the other person wants to say or doesn't want to say can be found in the face.

## Question 8: What Is a Baseline?

1. Various indicator values from a physical examination.
2. Calm-state baseline: behavioral characteristics in a calm state.
3. Emotional-state baseline: behavioral characteristics dominated by real emotions.
4. Stable social behavioral characteristics.

## Test Subject

This book will use many testing experiments and actual test cases to illustrate the principles and applications of micro-expressions. Therefore, the book will frequently use "test subject" to refer to the person who makes stress responses during the testing process.

## Hands Clasped Behind the Head

This type of posture is often considered the exclusive domain of successful people. In social settings, people like accountants, lawyers, and business managers—some confident individuals with a sense of superiority—often adopt this posture.

## The Human Behavioral Process

The human behavioral process, described from the perspective of the nervous system, can be divided into four processes: cognition, evaluation, decision-making, and implementation.

## Complete Diagram of Brain Functions

Based on current human research on the brain, we roughly divide the entire human brain into three centers.

### 3.5.1 Physiological Expressions, Emotional Expressions, and Social Expressions



Human expressions can be divided into three categories: physiological expressions, emotional expressions, and social expressions.

See Hands (c-hands).

## **What Is the 0.2-Second "Micro-Expression" Message**

### **Seeing Through the Other Party's "Hidden Emotions" While Adjusting the Direction of Conversation**

Understanding how to interpret the micro-expressions that appear on the other person's face can provide the following practical benefits:

1. In business negotiations, receptions, and similar situations, understanding the emotions the other party wants to hide allows you to adjust the focus and direction of the conversation

When negotiating business, you can find points of interest from the client's "surprise" micro-expression, or in negotiations, understand the limits of acceptable conditions from the "disgust" micro-expression. If you can see "anger" and a polite smile from the client's micro-expressions, you can understand their true intentions and propose appropriate responses in a timely manner. Even during a presentation, you can clearly see if the listener is smiling but actually feels "contempt" toward the content.

2. Building good interpersonal relationships outside of managing organizations or teams

A subordinate's smile may briefly reveal a "sadness" micro-expression, which could be a sign of a change in psychological state. When a supervisor offers advice to a subordinate, the "disgust" micro-expression can show that the advice is not genuinely accepted. Even in meetings, it is possible to anticipate who understands the content and who wants to raise questions.

3. Identifying suitable talent during recruitment interviews

In recruitment interviews, the "fear" micro-expression can be used to determine whether the candidate is lying. By focusing on the points revealed through micro-expressions, timely questions can be posed to uncover aspects of the candidate not shown on the résumé.

4. Detecting "danger signals" hidden in emotions during arguments with a partner

Micro-expressions of "contempt" or "disgust" during an argument are warning signs of an impending breakup. Early detection of signs that the other person's feelings have faded still leaves an opportunity to repair the relationship through effort.

Different situations produce different micro-expressions. Correctly perceiving and interpreting them allows the direction of communication to be adjusted appropriately.

Up to this point, how have you viewed micro-expressions? Does the world of micro-expressions and the extent of their usefulness seem interesting? Next, the profound world of micro-expressions will be presented step by step on each page. Follow along and enter the world of micro-expressions!

### **Identifying Moments When Emotions Fluctuate**

From the above, seven micro-expressions are universal across countries, and eleven are generally common. In addition, other distinct expressions and facial movements appear on the face in an instant, especially around

the eyebrows or corners of the mouth. Most of these expressions arise as reactions when emotions are suppressed.

For example, a typical "anger" expression is generally formed by four parts: the eyebrows, eyes, lower eyelids, and lips. However, when a micro-expression of "anger" appears, usually only one or two parts are visible, and occasionally all four appear simultaneously. This indicates that combinations of "anger" micro-expressions are far more numerous than ordinary "anger" expressions. No one knows exactly how many micro-expressions exist, but it is certain that micro-expressions are richer than ordinary expressions.

As mentioned earlier, micro-expressions reveal suppressed emotions. When emotions are suppressed, feelings and psychology manifest at the moment of oscillation.

Consider whether you have ever encountered such a situation. At what moments do micro-expressions appear instantly?

- When winning against an opponent in teasing or a game—"happiness"
- When finding someone else's presentation or opinion childish—"contempt"
- When unable to accept the other party's suggestion—"disgust"
- When treated unreasonably or when one's own ideas are not understood—"anger"
- When actually feeling sad but pretending to be energetic—"sadness"
- When worrying that a lie has been discovered and breaking into a cold sweat—"fear"
- When unexpectedly learning a fact but not wanting the other party to know—"surprise"

From these examples, it is clear that everyone at times deliberately suppresses emotions to prevent them from showing on the face. Therefore, possessing the skill to perceive and interpret micro-expressions should be very helpful in both work and life!

### **What Is the 0.2-Second "Micro-Expression" Message?**

What exactly is a "micro-expression"? In simple terms, it is "a suppressed emotion that suddenly flashes across the face like lightning in an instant and then disappears immediately—a subtle change in facial expression."

How long does a micro-expression appear on the face? Research shows it lasts less than 0.2 seconds. Sometimes it is only about 0.1 seconds, or even just 0.05 seconds. Because it is so rapid, such subtle movements are mostly overlooked and go unnoticed in ordinary communication unless one has learned methods to perceive and interpret them.

There is no strict data on exactly how many micro-expressions exist. First, consider the broad category of "expressions." The expressions mentioned here refer to ordinary expressions that are normally visible. In terms of duration, they typically appear on the face for about 0.5 to 4 seconds.

Scientific research has found that people have at least more than ten thousand different expressions. In particular, the seven expressions "happiness," "contempt," "disgust," "anger," "sadness," "fear," and "surprise" are universal across cultures, ethnicities, genders, ages, eras, and even among people who are blind from birth.

These seven expressions are communication signals that people possess from birth, mechanisms already encoded in DNA. In recent years, eleven additional expressions—"shame," "humiliation," "guilt," "apprehension," "boasting," "joy," "pleasure," "excitement," "happiness," "reassurance," and "satisfaction"—have also been found to be common, and scientists continue to study them.

See Microexpression foundations (c-micro-foundations).

See Microexpression foundations (c-micro-foundations).

## Two Scenarios of Micro-expressions

### Conditions for Micro-expression Presentation and Cultural Differences

An expression of “disgust” should appear, yet a smile shows instead—why? Have you also accepted the argument that expressions are universal?

Now we return to the question raised at the beginning of the previous section: are micro-expressions truly universal? As noted earlier, the seven universal micro-expressions flash across the face in an instant of 0.2 seconds.

Micro-expressions usually occur when a person tries to suppress an emotion. Therefore, the degree of emotional suppression ability and the necessity of suppressing emotion both affect how micro-expressions manifest. In other words, depending on the individual’s level of expression control, a suppressed emotion may appear on the face as a micro-expression or may surface as a normal expression.

Yet “Americans and Japanese clearly express emotions differently!” The following experiment clarifies this point. One group of Americans and one group of Japanese participants were asked to watch a film that elicits disgust while alone in a laboratory; their expressions were recorded with a hidden camera. Analysis showed that both groups displayed an expression of “disgust” toward the footage.

Next, participants from the first group were joined by an observer in the laboratory, while a second group underwent the same experiment. An interesting result emerged. Compared with the first experiment, the Americans in the second group again displayed “disgust” directly, but the Japanese participants smiled instead.

This smile is understandable. Japanese people generally maintain harmony within a group and therefore rarely display personal negative emotions openly—an outcome closely tied to cultural norms. Consequently, the Japanese participants, who should have shown “disgust,” smiled instead, indicating that the emotion of “disgust” had been suppressed. In contrast, Americans do not mind displaying negative emotions openly in front of others and therefore express their feelings directly through facial expressions.

The difference in emotional expression between Americans and Japanese arises because individuals regulate their expressions according to the immediate context. At such moments the emotion may surface as a micro-expression or as an ordinary expression. Without the skill to detect and interpret micro-expressions, their presence remains unnoticed.

The conditions under which micro-expressions appear are influenced by culture or personal circumstances. Various studies show that whenever emotion is suppressed, micro-expressions appear on anyone’s face regardless of setting; interpretation must therefore take these conditions into account.

### No Expression Does Not Mean No Emotion

When one person harbors feelings of disgust or unease toward another yet does not wish the other to know, the face becomes expressionless.

In daily life we sometimes encounter people who remain expressionless no matter what others say or do. Many find such individuals difficult to deal with. In reality, the absence of expression does not equal the absence of emotion. If inner activity fails to register on the facial muscles, the result appears unnatural; the more expressionless the face, the more intense the underlying emotion is likely to be.

For example, an employee who resents a supervisor's words or actions but dares not voice the anger may deliberately adopt a blank expression. No matter how thoroughly the anger is suppressed, the inner dissatisfaction remains strong; close observation of the face will reveal that something is amiss.

People often describe such a wooden face as a "dead person's" face—expressionless and indifferent. The "dead person's" face itself constitutes an unnatural display.

Moreover, although such individuals strive to keep joy or anger from showing, when inner emotional intensity rises their eyes may suddenly widen, wrinkles may appear around the nostrils, or twitching may occur on the face. Thus, a sudden facial twitch indicates that the person is experiencing intense emotional conflict at a deep level of awareness.

When dealing with such a person, it is best not to reprimand directly or cause embarrassment on the spot. Upon noticing a subordinate's pale complexion or facial twitching, a supervisor might say, "Have you been feeling unwell lately? If something is bothering you, feel free to talk about it," thereby soothing the suppressed emotion.

A rigid or twitching expression at least signals that the relationship between superior and subordinate has reached a low point; both parties should then exchange views openly to clear up misunderstandings and improve relations.

A completely expressionless face can sometimes also signal goodwill or affection. Women in particular may feel that openly displaying affection violates social expectations and therefore show the opposite expression, appearing indifferent when they are in fact deeply concerned.

### **① Unconsciously Suppressing Emotion**

A person whose face displays a micro-expression is unaware that the emotion has affected the visible expression; neither the micro-expression on the face nor the suppressed emotion itself registers consciously. When micro-expressions were first discussed in the 1960s, American psychologists E. A. Haggard and K. S. Isaacs conducted a series of studies on their origins. They recorded therapy sessions, catalogued facial expressions and body-language features segment by segment, and discovered brief intervals in which patients displayed expressions of distress lasting only seconds. The patients themselves reported neither noticing the distressed expressions nor feeling the corresponding emotion.

### **② Deliberately Suppressing Emotion**

The opposite situation occurs when emotion is suppressed consciously. In such cases the individual is aware of suppressing the emotion at the moment the micro-expression flashes across the face, yet the facial muscles still produce the micro-expression involuntarily. For people who must wear a mask every day, the deliberate control of emotion probably feels more familiar than unconscious suppression.

See Microexpression foundations (c-micro-foundations).

## Ekman and Friesen's Research Cases

### 2.1.2 Researching Videos or Images in the Media

Searching television stations or the internet for non-dramatic documentary material such as public speeches and live performances is another mainstream research method.

#### Case One:

In 2009, scholars from the University of Arkansas and the University of Portsmouth jointly published an article in the journal *Motivation and Emotion* examining the impact of President George W. Bush's subtle facial expressions during speeches [1]. The subject was a roughly twelve-minute televised public address by Bush concerning the U.S. military response to Iraq's invasion of Kuwait. Researchers analyzed the expressions throughout the speech, removing seven primary expressions each shorter than one second. According to FACS standards, all of these expressions included the lip-corner puller (AU12) required for a smile. The researchers then recruited 206 undergraduate students as participants; one group viewed the complete recording while the other viewed the edited version.

Participants who saw the full recording gave more favorable evaluations, reporting lower levels of perceived threat and anger, whereas those who viewed the version with smiles removed reported noticeably higher threat and anger. The researchers concluded that micro-expressions exert a clear influence on the persuasive power of a presidential speech.

The study appears rigorous, yet it is not.

When a president appears before national or even global attention on public media, can every word and gesture be taken as representing his genuine cognition and feelings? Can analysis of these micro-expressions reveal the president's true inner thoughts?

With such research material we must assume that every detail may have been trained and adjusted to convey specific emotions and intentions, thereby achieving more reliable communicative effects. Consequently, this study of "micro-expressions" actually illustrates the misleading nature of "potential performance."

The study violates the principle of "one-way expression, no analysis" that we emphasize.

The research material consists of a U.S. president's public address in the media. Under no circumstances would the president have been pulled in to speak without preparation. Before the address, his staff likely invited numerous expert advisers to refine arguments and wording, had the president rehearse repeatedly, and brought in behavioral specialists to train posture, expressions, and gestures so as to avoid unnecessary slips that might weaken the speech's impact while strengthening its intended meaning. The twelve minutes represent only the final product; outsiders cannot know how much targeted training preceded it.

#### Case Two:

On 30 November 2012, Hillel Aviezer and colleagues in the Department of Psychology at Princeton University published their findings in the journal *Science*. The paper argues that, without corresponding body language, people cannot accurately judge another's emotional state by "reading faces" alone [2].

The article caused a sensation upon publication in a top-tier scientific journal and was widely accepted as self-evidently correct. Some research institutions even used it to promote themselves and disparage rivals. A single

scholarly opinion piece intended for peer review became an authority and a weapon, generating considerable commotion.

The study selected photographs of professional tennis players captured at moments of high emotion on the court via Google as experimental material, investigating how accurately participants could identify genuine and intense human expressions. In top-level professional tennis tournaments, players' expressions at critical points are often distorted by strong emotion.

At this point we can see that, like the paper in Case One, this is essentially a study of expression recognition rather than an analysis or derivation of micro-reactions (微反应). Both papers contain the word "expression," yet their research cores and methods differ substantially.

The study found that participants could easily identify players' emotions when shown complete photographs of athletes holding racquets on the court. When the body was cropped out and only the contorted face remained, however, participants could not determine whether the emotion was elation or dejection. When only the body was shown and the face was removed, participants could still accurately judge whether the player had just won or lost a point. More interestingly, when researchers swapped faces between winners and losers or between winners and individuals experiencing orgasm, recognition of the same facial expression as "positive" or "negative" depended entirely on the body to which it was attached.

The authors concluded that people mistakenly believe emotional information originates in the face, whereas bodily expression actually allows more accurate apprehension of a person's emotional state.

This study has no connection to micro-expressions; even its expression-recognition component concerns only the most intense expressions. Because its "destructive power" is considerable, we must explicitly note the following errors in this article that denies the efficacy of facial judgment of emotion:

1. One-way expression should not serve as research material. How can we be certain that the "intense expressions" displayed by athletes on the court contain no performative component? The more commercialized the event, the more athletes must perform, because commercial interests are involved. Whether appearing arrogant or humble, struggling or effortless, a theoretical possibility always exists that the display is "performed for spectators and sponsors" and should not be used as material for identifying and analyzing genuine emotion. Of course, using footage from sports competitions is more reliable than using public speeches, because during intense play people do reduce control over social behavior; yet this does not mean the expressions are unfiltered revelations of genuine feeling, since no evidence can establish a direct correspondence between such expressions and emotion.
2. What mindset characterizes individuals who allow themselves to be filmed or photographed during orgasm? Are they completely natural and immersed, or do they exaggerate or suppress? How can such material serve as a comparative research object? Recognition data derived from such comparisons carry no persuasive force.
3. The authors claim that the categories of expression they compared—excitement, pain, orgasm, and so on—made accurate identification and differentiation difficult for participants, and therefore conclude that if even such full expressions are hard to identify, ordinary expressions must be still harder. Yet the authors merely followed a methodologically sound research paradigm while lacking basic understanding of the objects they studied.

Human expressions fall into three categories: social expressions, emotional expressions, and physiological expressions.

- Social expressions vary widely and are deliberately produced; they cannot serve as evidence for analyzing genuine emotion.
- Each emotional expression possesses a unique combination of organ morphologies; micro-expressions conform to these same features, differing only in amplitude and duration.
- Physiological expressions comprise only three types: enjoyment, pain, and orgasm, with orgasm representing an integrated display of the first two. Expressions triggered by physiological conditions necessarily exhibit extremely full amplitude. Intense enjoyment, intense exertion pain, intense pain, and intense conflicted orgasm share the same morphological features: eyelid closure, orbicularis oculi contraction, platysma contraction that horizontally stretches the mouth corners, depressor anguli oris contraction that pulls the mouth corners downward, and depressor labii inferioris contraction that lowers the lower lip.

The samples the authors compared, though seemingly quite different, are in fact all physiological expressions sharing identical morphological features; low recognition rates among participants are therefore unsurprising. Using this result to argue that expressions cannot effectively convey emotion constitutes an "ignorance is bliss" stance.

Institutions genuinely engaged in emotion-and-expression research should have criticized this *Science* paper for reaching conclusions without even distinguishing the most basic expression categories. Unfortunately, many institutions and individual scholars continue to cite and venerate it; this peculiar phenomenon merits reflection.

Both cases above are typical examples of research conducted with media material, yet their findings do not withstand scrutiny. The main reasons are twofold:

1. Media material is better suited to "recognition" studies and cannot address the logical paradigm of "deriving genuine cognition and feeling." Recognition data are easy to obtain, but recognition quality is difficult to control, because reliable evidence proving the correctness of the recognition result is essentially unavailable.
2. The production process of media material is unknowable and contains numerous confounding factors; even live broadcasts, the most "authentic" form of presentation, employ many techniques that allow subjects to fabricate. If the material under study is fabricated, all subsequent research loses its meaning.

#### **2.1.4 Criminal Investigation Research**

A comprehensive review of the advantages and disadvantages of the three research methods described above shows that micro-reaction research must solve one fundamental problem: both emotional behavior and social behavior must be present in the research subject, and social behavior must exert an inhibitory or masking effect on emotional behavior.

Who, then, would exhibit such a state and still be available for study?

In everyday life almost everyone displays the above "self-contradictory" state under certain circumstances. Unfortunately, these vivid, visible states cannot become research material. First, they cannot be recorded; second, they cannot be verified.

Inability to record means that although the complex behavior can be observed, conditions for photographing or videotaping do not exist; once recording equipment is set up, most subjects adjust their behavior in

response to the camera. As the saying goes, "in front of the lens, everyone acts a little." Only one situation can preserve behavior in its original form: surreptitious recording.

Inability to verify is a common shortcoming of all naturalistic material, including surreptitious recordings. We may idealistically assume that the recording did not affect the subject's responses, that physiological, emotional, and social behaviors were all captured ideally, and that we can derive the subject's "genuine" cognition and feelings from every subtle facial and postural cue in a logically complete and self-consistent manner. Yet how can we prove that the derived conclusions truly correspond to the subject's subjective cognition and feelings? The conclusions may be 100 percent accurate, but what evidence can demonstrate this? We cannot rely on the subject's self-report or the experimenter's interpretation.

To study micro-reaction patterns of applied significance, the researched individual must generate genuine emotion, must attempt to inhibit and mask it, must fail to control it completely, and there must be evidence proving that conclusions derived from micro-reaction analysis match the individual's subjective cognition and feelings.

Who possesses all these characteristics?

The answer is criminal suspects under investigation.

A suspect undergoing interrogation will inevitably experience genuine emotion. Whether factually innocent or guilty, suspects will feel surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, or enjoyment during the process.

Suspects will also engage in self-suppressing and masking social behavior to control their emotional displays. An innocent person fears being wrongly accused yet must appear upright; must suppress impatience to cooperate; must remain polite despite affronts to dignity, and so on. A guilty person must work even harder to disguise true emotion under investigative pressure: appearing unconcerned when afraid, courteous when angry, indifferent when surprised, and deeply concealing pleasure, and so on. If these genuine emotions were easily detected and interpreted by investigators, the psychological balance between the two sides would shift instantly.

Yet can suspects fully control their behavior? No, because they face not an ordinary street argument but a professionally specialized and closely coordinated team. This team possesses scientific forensics, legal authority, legitimate power, and dedicated time and space; they hold partial evidence and employ rigorous, comprehensive logical chains to investigate the suspect from multiple angles. The diversity and persistence of stimuli therefore guarantee that no suspect can completely control their behavior.

Most crucially, whether judging whether the suspect is lying or extracting case-related details, the investigative team ultimately relies on a complete chain of physical evidence. The final court verdict likewise rests on the completeness of the evidence chain—the foundational rule of a modern society governed by law. Although the judicial system is not perfect, it remains the fairest and most persuasive evaluative framework available.

These very evaluative criteria can be used for our research. When studying suspects' anomalous reactions we form various judgments—about truthfulness, case-related information, motives, and subjective attitudes—and these derived conclusions can be verified as correct or incorrect by evidence.

Only under such stringent conditions can valid micro-reaction research material be collected, and it is precisely for this reason that research findings on micro-reactions possess strong vitality and ecological validity.



In the following sections we introduce readers to common reactions of the torso, posture, and limbs that occur after a person receives an effective stimulus. These reactions carry clear directional meaning and can be used to interpret the individual's subjective cognition and feelings.

It should be noted that all reactions discussed below refer to stress responses rather than stable postures maintained by the individual. Although stable postures can sometimes be informative, we focus exclusively on stress responses; this point will not be repeated later.

### **2.1.1 Laboratory Experiments**

The basic experimental procedure recruits participants and has them view images or videos displayed on a computer. A camera, or even a high-definition video camera, is positioned unobtrusively to record changes in the participant's facial expression while viewing the stimulus material.

The material shown on the computer is content likely to elicit an emotional response—for example, the cruel killing or helpless death of a young life.

Before the experiment, researchers inform participants that they should try not to display any expression regardless of what they see. Once participants indicate understanding and consent, the experiment begins. Participants view the stimulus material while the camera records their facial changes. After the session, researchers analyze the recordings or rely directly on data captured during the experiment by facial-recognition or expression-recognition software—recording the timing, frequency, duration, and emotional category of any micro-expressions—then perform statistical processing and prepare a manuscript for publication.

This type of experiment has an obvious limitation: how can participants experience genuine emotion, and thereby produce overt emotional expressions, inside a laboratory?

Among the six basic human emotions, sadness can be elicited through empathic response to experimental material; surprise may appear if the material is sudden and unexpected; particularly disgusting or contemptible stimuli may evoke disgust. The other three emotions—anger, fear, and enjoyment—are difficult to elicit genuinely.

Most participants recruited by universities and research institutions are volunteers (for example, undergraduates) who receive modest compensation or other benefits. How, then, can researchers genuinely anger participants without violating research ethics? How can they induce genuine fear—would showing a horror film suffice? Even setting aside these two negative emotions, the sense of gain or superiority required to produce genuine enjoyment is also hard to achieve in a laboratory. The limitation of this method is that it cannot supply appropriate stimuli inside the laboratory to generate genuine emotion in participants, let alone overt emotional expressions.

Furthermore, even if the recruited participants are especially emotionally reactive and do produce various emotions through the methods described, a second question arises: how can participants be induced to suppress the emotions and their associated responses, thereby generating micro-reactions? For example, if a participant has been successfully angered and is genuinely furious, how can that student be made to voluntarily suppress the anger in order to continue cooperating with the experiment?

Micro-expressions arise when a person has already generated an emotion and its overt expression but, constrained by various rules, performs self-suppression or disguise. Only under these conditions can micro-

reactions serve as reliable traces for distinguishing genuine from feigned emotion and fulfill the research purpose.

The highly reactive participants who have been angered, frightened, or pleased—what motive would they have for masking their responses? Merely to comply with the experimenters' instructions? If that were the case, they would not have generated genuine emotion in the preceding step.

Without sufficient motivation to mask, there will be no effective suppression or disguise, and the small reactions that leak out will not be genuine "traces" of emotion but are more likely "performances" produced to cooperate with the study. In that event, the ecological validity of the research findings would be extremely questionable.

### 2.1.3 Experimental Research Using Real-Life Cases

Scholars represented by American researcher Paul Ekman invited participants from various groups—such as students, police officers, housewives, and salespeople—to take part in experiments during their early micro-expression studies. In these experiments, participants were asked to judge, based on a subject's facial expressions and movements, whether that subject was lying.

This experimental approach represented a substantial improvement in design over the methods described earlier. At minimum, evidence existed to verify whether the subject was in fact lying. Participants, unaware of the truth, applied their own judgment methods, and the results could be checked against reality to determine accuracy.

Nevertheless, this type of research contains a fundamental flaw.

It seeks to derive formulaic "lie-detection" micro-expressions, much like the many so-called "micro-expression" rules circulating online. Everyone hopes to find patterns such as "when the corners of the mouth turn slightly downward, the person is lying, because downturned lips indicate embarrassment and lack of confidence." Yet applying such simple, equation-like rules yields very low accuracy.

Numerous published studies show that people's accuracy in detecting deception through behavioral observation falls mainly between 45 % and 60 %, with an average of 56.6 %. Observers achieve 67 % accuracy when identifying truthful statements but only 44 % when identifying lies—worse than a random 50 % guess [3].

Where, then, does the problem lie with this research method?

The difficulty is that researchers attempt to find universally applicable formulas.

Rigid formulas lack logic, whereas lie detection requires discovering an internal logic. Deception is shorthand for "cognition differing from expression." To establish that an expression is a lie, one must locate and demonstrate that the subject's subjective cognition differs from the expressed content. This is the intrinsic logic of lie detection: the two elements "cognition" and "expression" are both indispensable and must stand in contradiction.

Formulaic identification dispenses with logic. It applies a single standard to everyone, ignoring the diversity and variability of individuals across large samples, which produces the poor results cited above. Even today, many people newly introduced to micro-expressions raise the fundamental question: Are everyone's behavioral characteristics identical? Can the same set of criteria be used to analyze different people?

## Ekman and Friesen's Research Case

Psychologists Paul Ekman and W. V. Friesen once conducted facial-expression analysis on patients concealing suicidal tendencies. At the time, a patient with suicidal intent had been involuntarily hospitalized. After a period of inpatient care, the patient informed the physician that he had fully recovered and wished to be discharged.

The attending physician noticed subtle anomalies in the patient's speech that differed from his usual manner, yet could not pinpoint the cause—an indefinable sense of incongruity. The discharge request was therefore denied. The conversation had been videotaped. Later, when Ekman and Friesen analyzed the patient's expressions, they discovered a surprising fact. Played at normal speed, the recording showed the patient maintaining a smile throughout, cheerfully describing plans for after discharge. After repeated viewings, the two researchers still found no visible anomaly in the patient's expression, so they decided to examine the footage frame by frame at reduced speed. Only then did they notice that, in the brief intervals between smiles, the patient fleetingly displayed a distressed expression before quickly resuming the smile—an expression too rapid to be readily perceived. In a subsequent interview, the patient, whose discharge had been refused, candidly admitted: "If I had been allowed to leave, I intended to commit suicide."

Such changes in the facial muscles that are difficult to control voluntarily arise from unconscious or suppressed emotions and produce micro-expressions. "Facial muscles are sometimes beyond voluntary control." Do you agree with this statement? If one could control the facial muscles at will, what would the situation be?

Charles Darwin's book *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals* discusses the "inhibition hypothesis," which holds that when an emotion arises, the facial muscles cannot be controlled by the will; deliberate suppression is futile, and the emotion is still reflected naturally. Conversely, a person can deliberately produce an expression and enact an emotional response even in the absence of emotion; when attempting to suppress emotion, one can also restrain the expression and prevent the inner feeling from showing. In practice, however, when an emotion occurs without the person's own awareness, and given that facial muscles cannot be fully controlled by the will, it is difficult to completely conceal a micro-expression once a strong emotion is aroused.

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## 2.1 Comparison of Common Research Methods

At present, numerous research institutions worldwide are studying micro-expressions or behavioral analysis, and the term "micro-expression" is becoming fashionable. Their research methods generally fall into four categories.

## Part Two Facial Regions

### Chapter Two Everything Is Presented on the Face

- Studying Facial Expressions
- Eyes
- Eyebrows
- Nose
- Mouth
- Chin
- Micro-expressions
- Conclusion

A person's eyes speak as much as their tongue. The advantage is that no dictionary is needed to understand the whole world through the language of the eyes.

— Ralph Waldo Emerson

Among all sites of nonverbal communication, facial expressions are the least controversial. Typically, we fix our eyes on the other person's face more often than on any other part of the body, and every expression we see is considered meaningful. In fact, each of us has encountered expressions such as "a look that could kill," "dead-fish eyes," or "a flirtatious demeanor."

Facial expressions can convey many thoughts or emotions through nonverbal means, whether intentionally or unintentionally. In this chapter we will examine the various expressions of the face. Remember, however, that although we focus on observing individual expressions, we cannot draw conclusions from any single expression alone. Instead, we must connect all expressions together (including gestures, postures, and speech), integrate preceding and following movements, and grasp the full meaning of the posture cluster.

#### Studying Facial Expressions

People generally believe that facial expressions play a very important role in communicating thoughts, feelings, and emotions. Yet almost no one knows how to break facial expressions down into components.

The figure below shows two groups seated facing each other across a conference table. Most observers notice only the difference in appearance between the two groups, but that is merely a broad observation. On closer inspection, many more details become apparent: furrowed brows, raised eyebrows, widened eyes, flared nostrils, pursed lips, and so on.

What do you notice in Figure 2.1? Quickly note your observations; you will likely record many. In the pages that follow, we will see how changes in each part of the face correspond to shifts in a person's mental state.

**Unhappy meeting participants**

**Happy meeting participants**

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.1 会议桌前对立的双方]

#### Facial Expressions and Sign Language

Through this chapter you have learned that facial expressions can support, modify, or contradict information conveyed by words. Did you know that facial expressions are equally important in sign language, where they

help determine whether the message conveyed by the hands is genuine?

For example, a person signs "Grandfather is ill," and the meaning is clear, yet the face shows no expression. If someone then signs the question "Is Grandfather really ill?" the hand gestures remain the same, but the facial expression changes to one of urgent inquiry.

In other words, if the questioner doubts that Grandfather is truly ill, the same hand gestures will be accompanied by a questioning facial expression.

Therefore, whether others communicate with you through speech or sign language, you should attend to the posture clusters they display; only then can you truly understand what they mean.

## Conclusion

You now understand the meanings of various facial expressions, yet you must still combine them with body movements.

When people communicate, many use their hands, arms, and even shoulders (treating the shoulders as an extension of the arms). But how do the legs and feet participate in expressing body language—for instance, in the way a person stands or walks? In the next chapter we will examine how other parts of the body convey information.

## Facial Micro-reactions — A Face Reveals a Hundred Phases, Observing the Face Identifies the Person

Raise an eyebrow, lift a corner of the mouth, and the true thoughts inside become known. In the view of FBI agents, a person's face writes their inner secrets. Mastering the decoding of facial micro-reactions (微反应) makes any attempt at concealment increasingly obvious and any attempt at hiding increasingly exposed.

## Eyebrows

### **Eyebrows: The Barometer of Joy, Anger, Sorrow, and Happiness**

Eyebrows have always been one of the most emotionally expressive parts of the face, capable of conveying many different moods. The raising, drawing together, lifting, or drooping of the brows can reflect complex inner states such as joy, anger, sorrow, or happiness. When a person's mood changes, the shape of the eyebrows changes accordingly. In short, the eyebrows function as a barometer of mood.

A single eyebrow raised indicates doubt toward the other person.

Gerard Nierenberg, known as a "face-reading expert," conducted extensive experiments with his assistants on the relationship between psychological activity and facial expressions. He found that the eyebrows most readily reveal a person's psychological secrets.

Nierenberg noted that when a person raises only the left or right eyebrow, it usually signals incomprehension or doubt about what the other person has said or done, as if asking, "Really? Are you sure that's what you mean?" (see Figure 1.6)

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.6 挑起一侧的眉毛]

When both eyebrows are raised, the person is expressing strong appreciation, liking, or extreme surprise; the gesture can also signal that a question is about to be asked (see Figure 1.7).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.7 挑起的双眉]

George arrived at the director's office as arranged. Ordinary agents like George rarely had the chance to discuss work face-to-face with the director; only the extreme urgency of the situation had prompted him to request a direct meeting with a plan in hand.

The matter had begun when one of George's informants told him that two terrorists might be arriving the next day at a New York airport carrying important documents on a highly unusual flight. Upon investigation, George discovered that the flight was the very one carrying a senior U.S. official returning home. The intelligence struck George as bizarre, yet the informant had always been reliable, and George did not want to miss an opportunity to eliminate terrorists. When he reported his idea to his supervisor, the supervisor rejected the plan for lack of sufficient evidence. Frustrated, George decided to present the plan's feasibility directly to the director.

The moment George entered the office, the director, seated behind a large desk, looked him over several times from head to toe, clearly displeased by his arrival.

Sure enough, after only a few exchanges the director began to pick apart George's plan, raising a long list of objections to both the overall concept and its specific execution, and finally attempting to dismiss the operation outright as completely unworkable. George had to keep emphasizing the plan's importance, but the director merely grunted and unconsciously raised his left eyebrow while twitching the corner of his mouth, displaying an expression of complete disbelief.

Sensing the director's rejection, George borrowed a sheet of paper, took out a pen, and wrote out every step and timing detail of the plan. He also listed, point by point, the losses that would result if the plan were abandoned. Only then did the director lower his raised eyebrow, smile, and nod repeatedly, clearly accepting the plan.

Through the director's raised and lowered eyebrow, George had keenly detected an opening within the signal of rejection. Later George explained: "One eyebrow raised while the other remains lowered is a sign of 'doubt.' When a person is both surprised and doubtful, one eyebrow rises. When both eyebrows rise, the person is very surprised. At the time, only one of the director's eyebrows was raised, so I judged that he was both surprised and doubtful about my plan. I therefore explained the plan in greater detail and, during the explanation, drew out the reason for his surprise. Once the director's surprise and doubt were resolved, he would certainly agree to the plan."

When someone says "Really? So that's how it is!" while raising one eyebrow or repeatedly touching the eyebrow or eyelid, it shows that the person does not fully believe you. At such moments we must probe further for the reason behind the disbelief or produce stronger evidence. Only by eliminating the other person's doubts can we gain greater trust.

If, when you say "Let's have a drink sometime," the other person's eyebrows rise, it indicates that the invitation is being taken as mere diplomatic language. If you then confirm the time and place of the gathering, the other person will feel genuinely appreciated and trust in you will rise sharply.

Under normal circumstances people rarely raise a single eyebrow, so whenever the gesture appears it should never be dismissed as accidental; it must be taken seriously and its cause identified. In any interaction,

lingering doubt on either side severs the thread of communication. When we see an eyebrow rise, we must reason and appeal emotionally, supplying enough evidence to prove our point and dispel any negative notions, rather than continuing along the originally planned line of conversation; otherwise the exchange will end fruitlessly.

### **Reading the Face Begins with the Forehead**

If you want to know whether someone you have just met thinks quickly and acts promptly, many methods of assessment and verification are available.

When I was a child, my grandmother would often remark upon seeing a child, "Look at that high forehead—this child is bound to achieve something," or "That child's forehead is flat; clearly no creativity, won't amount to much."

Perhaps influenced by my grandmother, in my years of consulting work, the first thing I notice when a new client enters my office—apart from obvious traits such as skin color, build, and hair—is the forehead. Although my grandmother's statements lacked theoretical grounding, whether a person's forehead is convex or concave does, to some extent, reflect certain character and psychological traits.

It is necessary here to define the forehead: the area from the eyebrows upward to the hairline. If the person is bald or has a shaved head, the wrinkled portion that appears when the eyebrows and eyes are raised is the forehead. Generally, the width of the forehead is roughly twice its height.

When a person's forehead slopes sharply backward from the eyebrows and eyes, making the forehead region appear prominent, the individual typically possesses sharp insight and rapid responsiveness. Such people are naturally inquisitive, fond of asking "why," and able to spot problems and locate their causes in the shortest time. They are mentally agile yet easily impulsive, yet they are always purposeful and idealistic.

Whether you are a salesperson or a negotiator, the best way to persuade such people is not to "tell" but to demonstrate, because they resist accepting anything external without engaging their minds. Only through demonstration, allowing them to feel and experience for themselves, can they become interested in your product or proposal.

When the upper part of a person's forehead is especially prominent while the eyebrow-and-eye area is relatively flat, the individual tends to think carefully, enjoys reasoning and analysis, pursues matters to their roots, and possesses a rich imagination. When not thinking, such people often appear absent-minded. They are, in short, dreamers.

A young man once believed that behind lightning and thunder must lie some extraordinary latent force. He tied metal to a kite and began chasing lightning; eventually he found electricity. That dreamer was Franklin. Indeed, he had a high, protruding forehead. Countless dreamers with protruding foreheads have appeared throughout history—Copernicus, Shakespeare, Einstein, Shaw, to name a few familiar examples. They dreamed and explored for the sake of social civilization and human happiness, creating the abundance we enjoy today.

A young man came to see me. He had worked in a grocery store for more than half a year, found the job tedious, and felt unable to communicate with his colleagues, leaving him deeply frustrated. He had brown skin (indicating endurance and practicality) that was also relatively fine (indicating inner gentleness), and a rather prominent forehead (indicating active thinking and rich imagination). I could hardly imagine him lasting so long in a grocery store. During our conversation I learned of his interest in painting and suggested he work in

a gallery. Later he told me that there he not only acquired knowledge but also found like-minded friends<|eos|>

### 3. Anger State (9787554606841)

The angry eyebrows take on a clear “10:10 shape,” meaning the inner brows are drawn together and pressed downward toward the midline of the face while the outer brows are raised diagonally upward toward the sides of the face. The common saying “sword-like brows stand on end, tiger eyes glare round” describes exactly this appearance.

The angry eyebrow configuration is a composite of two nervous-system states: attention and preparation to attack.

Attention here is extremely intense because the matter concerns success or failure, even life or death. The brows are tightly knitted, matching the severe-concentration pattern explained earlier; this prepares the person to gather information for an impending fight. Because the attention is so strong, angry brows are always knitted, producing vertical frown lines.

During attack, the body’s entire energy radiates outward; limb movements become large in both amplitude and force. Even the facial features, supported by abundant energy, expand: the brows lift high, the eyes widen (“eyes splitting at the corners”), the mouth opens to roar (or to assist forceful breathing), and the nostrils flare with rapid respiration. True anger is an impulse to attack—to charge forward, knock the opponent to the ground, and, unable to restrain the urge, continue the assault even after the opponent has lost the ability to resist. Consequently, the body’s energy produces an uncontrollable explosive impulse.

Thus, intense attention combined with intense attack produces the classic angry brow shape: inner brows knitted, outer brows raised. The two opposing muscle actions—corrugator supercilii versus frontalis—compete. Most people find it difficult to produce this shape deliberately. When the shape appears, it indicates that the subject’s anger is already strong and may soon trigger attack behavior. If the outer brows gradually level off, inner anger is subsiding and the desire to attack is diminishing; if the vertical frown lines vanish instantly, the charging impulse, physical combat, and angry shouting disappear simultaneously.

Another posture deserves attention: during attack the head lowers slightly, the eyeballs roll upward a little, and the chin tucks back. This is part of the standard preparatory posture in combat and is commonly seen on trained fighters, especially during competition. The movement stems from the evolutionary instinct to protect the throat and abdomen. Therefore, even if the posture is not habitual, its appearance allows one to infer that hostility is rising and an attack tendency is present.

### **Eyebrows Leak Secrets**

Eyebrows function like a “sensitive display” of emotion, revealing the constantly shifting inner feelings. The information they convey is as important as that provided by the eyes, nose, and mouth.

Lines such as “Sitting in gloom, brows lowered long; walking lazily, steps slow,” “A thousand sorrows, ten thousand hates, both brows bear,” and “No sooner leave the brows than they rise again in the heart” all use eyebrow descriptions to express emotion. Eyebrows have long been linked with melancholy, yet they also signal surprise, hope, doubt, amazement, arrogance, anger, and other states.



Many people are accustomed to reading emotional fluctuations from changes in the eyes, nose, and mouth, but pay insufficient attention to the eyebrows. The reason may be that eyebrows themselves are not as eye-catching as the other features. Nevertheless, the information they convey is equally important.

If we attend only to the eyes, nose, and mouth while ignoring the eyebrows, the information obtained from the face will be incomplete and may easily lead us in the wrong direction. This is especially true with skilled deceivers: the eyes, nose, and mouth may reveal nothing unusual, yet the eyebrows can betray the truth. When a person's emotion changes, the shape of the eyebrows changes accordingly. Anyone who tries to mask real thoughts by altering eyebrow shape will ultimately fail, because the effort required is too great.

American social psychologist Lynn Clasen, known as a "face-reading expert," conducted extensive experiments on the relationship between personality and facial expression. She found that hiding or altering subtle facial movements is extremely difficult. Eyebrow changes are among the subtlest of these movements. Research shows that eyebrows can produce more than twenty distinct dynamics, each corresponding to different emotions and mental states. For example, when a person is worried, the brows are usually knitted; when worry dissipates and the mind is at ease, the brows relax; when a person cannot suppress inner joy, the brows rise and the eyes smile.

Humans experience joy, anger, sorrow, and happiness, generating a wide range of emotions, and the eyebrows serve as a "sensitive display" of those emotions. What, then, does this display reveal?

### **Eyebrows When Confident**

Both surprise and confidence raise the eyebrows. Unlike the surprise configuration—brows lifted high and eyes wide—the confident lift raises the brows only slightly, producing a modest widening of the eyes that is nevertheless noticeable. In conversation, an instantaneous brow raise indicates that the speaker is highly skilled in the topic and feels confident about it.

You may have encountered this situation: while chatting with a friend, the friend asks a difficult question. As the question is posed, the friend's brows shoot up and then quickly return to normal. When you say you do not know, the friend immediately supplies the answer. The brow raise conveys: "I guessed you wouldn't know, but I do." The next time this happens, you need not waste effort searching for the answer; the other person only wants to hear "I don't know."

Of course, not every eyebrow movement is genuine. Some actors excel at controlling their brows and use them to convey a character's current emotion. This is deliberate acting. A more powerful technique is the Stanislavski system, which trains performers to relive past emotions in order to calibrate emotional intensity accurately. The facial expressions produced this way are not feigned; they arise from re-experiencing earlier feelings and are therefore, to some extent, authentic. When portraying sadness, for instance, the actor recalls past sorrows to trigger an emotional release. Many actors report that after an intense crying scene they lose control and continue weeping until the emotion is fully discharged. This indicates they have convinced themselves that the emotion is real rather than performed. Such liars are extremely difficult to detect: they deceive themselves until they believe the lie, rendering all subsequent emotions and expressions genuine. The only practical response is to wait patiently until they themselves realize they are lying.

### **Eyebrows When Angry**

Angry eyebrows are relatively easy to recognize: the inner brows converge toward the glabella and press downward, forming a bulging muscle between the brows, while the outer brows rise. This shape transmits two

messages: “What are you going to do?” and “How am I going to deal with you?”

“What are you going to do?” usually arises when the other party has severely provoked the subject and negative emotion has reached a peak. To protect personal interests, the subject remains vigilant, adopting a preparatory attack posture that corresponds to “How am I going to deal with you?”

While preparing to confront the other person, the subject mobilizes great energy for self-protection and to gain advantage in the struggle; movements therefore become larger and more forceful. As this energy is about to be released, the face assumes a correspondingly explosive expression: eyes widen, outer brows lift, nostrils flare, and breathing quickens. When anger can no longer be contained and must erupt, the body launches the attack. Consequently, when you see someone’s eyebrows assume this shape, it is advisable to withdraw or adopt a conciliatory tone; otherwise, once the anger is fully vented, a violent and powerful assault may follow.

Forming the angry brow shape requires simultaneous action of the frontalis and corrugator supercilii muscles and is not easy to fake.

In addition, several facial cues accompany the transition from anger to attack: the eyeballs roll slightly upward, the chin tucks back, and the head lowers a little. This configuration can be observed in combat sports such as sanda; athletes instinctively lower the head before striking—an ancient protective reflex for the throat and other vital areas. Therefore, when someone displays this posture in daily life, it signals readiness for physical confrontation.

It should be noted that the knitted-brow appearance produced by lowered brows and partially closed eyelids does not represent anger alone; it can also indicate worry, confusion, dissatisfaction, disgust, or thought. Accurate interpretation requires contextual information.

## **Chapter 10 Eyebrow and Eye Expressions**

Analysis of the micro-expression features of basic emotions is complete. In addition to using emotion as a guide, simply observing the movements of the eyebrows and eyes can reveal a great deal of hidden information about the subject’s inner state. The five distinct eyebrow configurations, the rotation of the eyeballs, and the opening and closing of the eyelids all map to certain psychological conditions.

The ancient saying “The eyes are the windows of the soul” must open this chapter. Even from the professional perspective of micro-expression research, the saying qualifies as a poetic truth. What we must explore further is how the eyes and eyebrows function as windows of the soul.

A true master of micro-expression analysis can determine a subject’s psychological state and its changes—at minimum the general nature and direction of those changes—simply by observing subtle movements of the eyebrows and eyes. Important meaning lies hidden in eyebrow shifts and gaze-direction changes that ordinarily seem meaningless. Once you recognize the question—“Why would a person’s nervous system, at this moment, command the brows to rise or command the eyeballs to move, shifting gaze away from its previous fixation point?”—you can understand the significance of these minute movements.

Moreover, all six basic emotions and their expressions involve the eyebrows and eyes, and the morphological features of the brows and eyes remain crucial criteria for identifying micro-expressions. For this reason we devote a separate chapter to them.

## 10.1 Micro-expressions of the Eyebrows

### 10.1.1 The Role of the Eyebrows

### 10.1.2 The Five Micro-expressions of the Eyebrows

#### (4) By Shape

- **Straight brows:** People with thick straight brows tend to be bold, strong-willed, and speak loudly and sternly; those with thin straight brows are stubborn, lack patience, yet are intelligent.
- **Triangular brows:** Resolute and decisive, unafraid of setbacks, yet self-centered and cold.
- **Broom-shaped brows:** When the inner brows spread outward, the person usually becomes fully engaged only when a matter is nearing its end; when the outer brows spread outward, the person frequently starts strongly but finishes weakly. Consequently, achieving great success in a career is comparatively difficult.
- **Knife-shaped brows:** Intelligent and decisive, yet lacking tact, indifferent to personal feelings, and unskilled at managing interpersonal relationships.
- **Crescent brows:** Generous, decisive, popular, and likely to succeed; however, excessive trust in others may lead to deception.
- **Willow-leaf brows:** Honest, able to get along with others, yet not very family-oriented.
- **Upward-slanting brows:** Competitive and domineering, with strong self-esteem; difficult for others to agree with or understand.
- **Messy brows:** Physically developed but mentally simple, unable to concentrate, reckless, and inclined to solve problems with force or quarrels.

In addition, Professor Mark found that people with narrow glabellar regions tend to be calculating, while those with wide glabellar regions are generous; people whose outer brows are scattered are easily unsettled by financial conditions; and people with soft, smooth brows tend to be refined.

#### Joy, Anger, Sorrow, and Happiness in the Eyebrows

Besides protecting the eyes, the eyebrows are among the most expressive features of the face. Their subtle changes also reflect a person's inner activity. For example, when the other person knits the brows, it indicates either doubt or anxiety and distress; when the brows relax, the person is cheerful and open-hearted—any thoughts you have may be voiced at once. If both brows rise together, the person feels extreme delight or extreme surprise and emotional fluctuations are large; it is best to wait until the person calms down before speaking. If only one brow rises, the person is thinking and should not be disturbed.

From a medical perspective, eyebrow shape reflects the condition of the endocrine and hepatorenal systems, the two physiological factors that most strongly influence temperament. Therefore, judging character from the eyebrows is not mere speculation. Facing someone with thick, heavy brows, you sense intimidation because you know the person's temper is likely volatile; facing someone with slender, elongated brows, you feel an unconscious affinity and often discover that the person is talented.

Professor Mark of Columbia University collected 3,000 photographs of adult eyebrows, classified them by length, thickness, density, and shape, and, after interviewing the owners, reached the following conclusions:

### 10.1.1 The Role of the Eyebrows

Every human organ exists for a reason. Organs without function were eliminated long ago through evolution. Eyebrows also serve a purpose. The most widely cited function is to prevent sweat, rain, and other irritants from flowing directly into the eyes under the force of gravity when humans walk upright. Close observation reveals that each eyebrow hair grows upward or horizontally outward; this direction effectively channels small droplets of liquid away from the eyes below, guiding them down the sides of the face.

Try to furrow your brows and look upward; you will see the eyebrows in front of you. Although in the normal position the eyebrows sit above the eyes and cannot be seen, muscular contraction can raise them to form an awning-like structure that protects the eyes. This protective movement is accomplished by the coordinated action of the orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii muscles; while providing physical shielding, it also maximizes visual attention to the stimulus, raising the level of mental alertness.

Beyond their evolutionary protective function, eyebrows serve another important purpose for humans: the expression of inner states. Overall, eyebrow movements and configurations fall into five categories.

## 5. Eyebrows Raised High

Chapter 4 examined the features of the surprise expression. In an unprepared, uncontrolled surprise expression the brows are usually lifted together with the upper eyelids, rising above their normal position; the higher the brows rise, the greater the degree of surprise.

In daily life another situation also raises the eyebrows: when speakers feel confident about what they are saying (though this is not itself a feature of confidence) and even believe the listener should accept it as shared tacit understanding. Thus a rapid bilateral brow raise often occurs when someone asks a question to which they already know the answer. Even without speaking, a quick brow raise can convey this tacit understanding to the recipient, which may be translated as “You know what I mean.” See Figure 10-6.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-6]*

However, this bilateral raise differs from the surprise raise in a key respect: the degree of upper-eyelid involvement. In surprise the brows and upper eyelids rise in matching amplitude; in the confident raise the brows lift high while the eyelids show only a slight passive elevation.

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## Eyebrows

Eyebrows have always been among the most expressive features of the face and can convey many different emotions. Some people can raise one eyebrow independently. When a person raises only the left or right brow, the movement is usually deliberate and signals doubt, as if to say, “Really? Are you sure that’s what you mean?”

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.7 挑起一侧的眉毛]*

Some people’s eyebrow movements are less varied, yet they still use the brows to convey a range of emotions. Raising both brows, for example, signals surprise and is sometimes used to indicate that a question is about to be asked. When both brows are knitted tightly together (forming vertical lines), the expression may indicate anxiety, anger, or dejection.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.8 挑起的双眉]*

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.9 紧皱的双眉]*

### Eyebrows That Are Soft and Well-Groomed

Eyebrows that are soft and extend slowly outward on both sides with a slight curve belong to people who are highly cultivated and clear-headed. In contrast, eyebrows that are not soft, stand upright, and grow sparsely indicate a lack of cultivation; such people act carelessly, reach for what is beyond their grasp, and fail to stay grounded. If the eyebrows are also short, the person tends to shortchange friends because they overprotect themselves and weigh everything by self-interest, giving an impression of selfishness.

In addition, people whose eyebrows droop or hang low to cover the eyes possess strong comprehension and deep observation. Those with straight eyebrows value practicality. Those with curved eyebrows are sensitive and love beauty. Those whose eyebrow tails point upward have a bold and strong character. Those whose eyebrow tails point downward have a weak and pessimistic character. People with spiral or coiled eyebrows are intelligent yet suspicious, highly vain, and prone to setbacks midway. People with “eight-character” eyebrows (八字眉) tend toward pessimism and lack fidelity in love...

Of course, a reminder to every reader: although there is a saying “read the eyebrows and see through the person,” truly understanding someone still requires comprehensive analysis and observation. Because people are the hardest to know, there is also the saying “you may know a person’s face but not their heart.”

### Eyebrows in Sadness

Eyebrows in sadness are not as easy to judge as those in anger. In most cases, sad eyebrows show the outer ends pressing down and the inner ends lifting, but the change is very slight and hard to observe, and not every sad expression produces it. One form of sadness shows no lift in the brows and no bulging muscle between them; the shape remains close to normal. This sadness can be described as “being utterly dispirited,” indicating that the person has lost any positive emotion that could be mobilized; strength drains away, muscles cannot exert force, and the eyebrows therefore show no change.

In such cases we must rely on another clue—the eyelids. Eyelids, simply understood as the lids themselves, change more noticeably than the eyebrows in a sad expression.

Generally, a sad expression engages the orbicularis oculi, corrugator supercilii, and frontalis muscles. The orbicularis oculi draws the inner eyelids toward the center, stimulating the tear glands beneath the lids to prepare for and release tears.

### **Eyebrow Density Reflects Emotional Depth**

People with thick eyebrows also have deep emotions; people with thin eyebrows have shallow emotions. Beyond density, examine whether the brows are thick yet soft and orderly, with clear upper and lower layers. If so, the person is especially good to friends, sincere and lasting in affection, and willing to go through fire and water for them.

Physiognomy generally holds that people with sparse, light eyebrows basically do not value ties with brothers, friends, or spouses and tend to “set morality aside and put profit first.” In real life, most people who abandon wives or sell out friends and show no loyalty or righteousness have sparse or light eyebrows.

Each eyebrow hair is said to represent care and feeling toward others. Especially under today’s market economy, such sparse-browed people will “step on friends’ heads” to pursue wealth for their own benefit and survival; once they succeed, they keep friends at a distance, preferring to enjoy their gains alone rather than share them.

### **Deep Frowning**

Frowning generally falls into two types: protective frowning and aggressive frowning.

Protective frowning aims to shield the eyes from external harm; the cheeks below the eyes are also lifted while the eyes remain open. This withdrawal response usually appears when a person faces external attack, sudden strong light, or intense emotional stimulation.

Aggressive frowning is still rooted in defense; it reflects worry that one’s own aggressive emotion may provoke a counterattack and is therefore linked to self-protection.

The most common deep frown appears in situations of annoyance, anxiety, depression, fear, or indecision (see Figure 1.8).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.8 紧皱的双眉]*

### **Eyebrow Changes Also Reveal the Heart**

As the saying goes, “the eyes are the windows of the soul,” so the feature closest to the eyes and most intimately related should be the “window frame of the soul”—the eyebrows!

Eyebrows sit above the eyes and their primary function is to protect them. Imagine doing heavy physical labor or studying and working in the heat of summer: when sweat runs down from the forehead, without eyebrows to block it the sweat would flow into the eyes and cause various eye ailments. Similarly, if dust falls from above, eyebrows can block it and protect the eyes.

Besides protection, eyebrows are also a highly expressive facial feature that can convey many different emotions. When a person’s mood changes, the shape of the eyebrows changes accordingly. Below we analyze this in detail.

## 2. Expressive Eyebrows

Like other facial features, every movement of the eyebrows carries meaning. Joy, anger, sorrow, and pleasure—the seven emotions and six desires—can all be read from the eyebrows. American social psychologist Lynne Klassen has pointed out that eyebrows most clearly reveal a person's inner voice.

Eyebrow movements mainly include raising caused by contraction of the frontalis, frowning caused by contraction of the corrugator supercilii, and lowering caused by combined contraction of the orbicularis oculi and depressor supercilii. From ancient times to the present, Chinese has many expressions describing eyebrow movement, such as "joy rising to the brows," "brows relaxing and eyes smiling," and "kind brows and gentle eyes." These phrases were distilled from accumulated observation of people's facial movements.

Eyebrows convey many emotional meanings. Common actions include frowning, relaxing the brows, raising them horizontally, lifting them vertically, and knitting them.

### What Eyebrows Tell You

When strong external light stimulates the eyes, the eyebrows immediately knit, forming a raised muscle above the eyes like a small sunshade to protect them. Beyond this basic function, eyebrows can also reflect a person's psychological state.

Under normal conditions with no external stimulus, the eyebrows form an arc with the peak at the top. However, age, ethnicity, grooming habits, gender, and other factors produce variations in the resting shape. Some people habitually keep their eyebrows slightly knitted during ordinary conversation, appearing worried or angry when in fact it is merely a habitual frown.

Yet once emotion surges, the eyebrows abandon their usual calm and become animated.

### Eyebrow Flash

An eyebrow flash occurs when the brows first rise and then instantly drop again, like a meteor streaking across the sky—quick and agile. This is a universal human signal of welcome upon seeing an acquaintance and is a friendly gesture.

When an eyebrow flash appears, it indicates the other person is in a pleasant mood, inwardly approving, or showing warmth toward you. The flash is usually accompanied by a head lift and a smile, though it can occur by itself. Eyebrow flashes often appear in conversation to add emphasis. Whenever a speaker wants to stress a particular word, the eyebrows flash, as if to say, "What I'm saying is really striking!"

In short, the subtle movements of the eyebrows can reveal a person's psychological changes very well; next time you interact with someone, do not forget to watch their eyebrows!

### 1. Normal Shape

The normal shape refers to the eyebrow position when a person is awake, has received no negative stimulus, and has nothing requiring attention, with the eyelids open in their usual way. For most people the normal shape is two arcs whose peaks point downward. Given the enormous individual variation in samples—age, ethnicity, gender, whether the brows have been groomed, personal habits, and baseline muscle tone—a baseline test on the subject is required to determine the normal shape.

For example, many elderly people, even when awake and conversing normally, keep their eyebrows raised as high as possible; this baseline shape generally carries no special meaning.

## The Forehead Also Reflects the Other Person's Emotions

**Micro-expression keywords** People often say that a broad forehead indicates intelligence. This is because the forehead occupies nearly one-third of the head and is easiest to observe. Likewise, if you want to know a person's mood, simply observing the forehead can give you some idea.

We often say one cannot judge a person by appearance. Yet in real life almost everyone engages in "judging by appearance." People prefer to befriend those with dignified features and feel aversion toward those with unattractive features. In fact this psychological tendency is not entirely wrong; a person's character is indeed reflected in their appearance. Below we discuss several different forehead types and the personalities they reveal.

### Corrugator Supercilii

The corrugator supercilii lies on the inner side of the eyebrows. When relaxed, the brows are smooth and the skin between them is flat; when tense, a cone-shaped muscle rises above the eyes and vertical creases form between the brows. The corrugator cannot move independently and usually works with the orbicularis oculi. It activates under strong light, worry, or anger.

Between the eyebrows and eyes there is a muscle similar to the corrugator—the depressor supercilii, located between the inner eyebrows and the nasal root. Tension in the depressor supercilii causes the inner brows to droop and produces horizontal wrinkles in the frontalis above the nasal root. It also participates in the overall frowning process.

### Eyebrows Can Also "Convey Feeling"

Micro-expression keywords: Eyes and eyebrows are like twins—mutually generated. Eyes can "convey feeling," and eyebrows can likewise express a person's inner voice. As mood changes, eyebrows may tighten or relax and change shape accordingly.

The idiom "conveying affection through brows and eyes" originally referred to romantic signals between men and women, yet it also shows that eyebrows can transmit psychological states. As mood changes, eyebrow shape changes with it.

### Heart-Shaped Forehead

People with this forehead type are gentle and considerate. Whether toward friends, family, or partners, they never raise their voices, are good at thinking of others, and take excellent care of their family's daily needs. Women with this forehead are praised for being "full of feminine charm"; men may lack a certain masculine vigor. Their shortcoming is insufficient judgment and execution; they handle matters inefficiently and tend to procrastinate. Their will is also somewhat weak, and they can be willful at times.

## 10.1 Micro-expressions of the Eyebrows

Eyebrows are divided into the head (the end nearer the midline of the face), the body, and the tail (the end nearer the same-side ear); the highest point is called the peak. See Figure 10-1. **The eyebrow head is an**



## **important indicator for judging eyebrow movement and shape.**

### **Broad Forehead**

Such people are intelligent and highly intelligent. They possess talent yet can be frivolous, lack self-control, and are prone to emotional excess. In other respects they are calm, make accurate judgments, and have strong self-esteem. Once they achieve something they easily become arrogant. They are soft-hearted and lack ruthlessness; they generally excel in academic fields and are unsuited to competitive environments.

### **Angular Forehead**

Such people usually have a long, thin face with a somewhat pointed forehead. They have a strong character; men appear very masculine, while women seem less gentle. They have strong individuality and opinions and are not easily persuaded. They also possess a strong sense of justice and dare to fight against injustice. They are cool-headed and decisive, act without impulsiveness, and therefore rarely make major mistakes.

## **Section 2 The “Mysteries” of the Eyebrows**

If the eyes are the windows of the soul, then the eyebrows are the curtains on those windows. Eyebrows protect the eyes, yet the information they convey is rich and varied. A line in the novel *Dream of the Red Chamber* states: “A natural charm resides entirely in the brows; a lifetime of countless emotions gathers at the corners of the eyes.” This shows how great a role the eyes and brows play in facial expression.

### **Reading the “72” Variations of the Eyebrows**

FBI experts who specialize in human facial expressions have found through experiments that eyebrows exhibit many changes besides raising. Often, simply by observing an opponent’s eyebrow movements during an investigation, FBI agents can deduce that person’s psychological activity with considerable accuracy. Many agents obtain clues from the following details.

### **Scattered Eyebrow Tails Symbolize Scattering Wealth**

Sparse or fragmented eyebrow tails, also called “broom eyebrows,” symbolize the scattering of wealth. Such people often act without thorough consideration, lack planning, and are impulsive, so they frequently suffer unnecessary financial losses and scatter the money they have worked hard to earn. This is the eyebrow shape least associated with accumulating wealth. In addition, people with these brows are restless and worry about everything, making them even more likely to lose money.

### **Eyebrow Raise**

Raising the eyebrows, holding them briefly, then lowering them is called an eyebrow raise. It is often accompanied by a quick, brief downward twitch of the mouth corners. The eyebrow raise signals an unpleasant state of mind and sometimes helplessness. In addition, during heated discussion, when a person reaches an important point they may repeatedly raise their eyebrows to emphasize their words.

### **Knitted Eyebrows**

Knitted eyebrows means the brows rise and move toward each other simultaneously. When people encounter trouble or extreme melancholy they usually display this expression, producing a mournful face full of worry and heavy thoughts. Some patients with chronic pain frequently show it, whereas acute sharp pain produces lowered brows and a contorted face.

### (3) By Density

- **Thick eyebrows:** Arrogant and stubborn, strong self-awareness, not very modest, yet straightforward and popular.
- **Light eyebrows:** Simple-minded and down-to-earth.
- **Sparse eyebrows:** Quiet and introverted, relatively rational, yet emotionally changeable, lacking drive, and in less than ideal health.

### Narrow Forehead

Such people are not mentally sharp but are diligent, steady, and honest. They treat others kindly and are easy to get along with. Their shortcomings are lack of perseverance—they easily give up at the slightest setback—and a somewhat childish personality; they are emotionally impulsive, even unreasonable, and very willful.

### Narrow Space Between the Eyebrows Indicates Pettiness

People with a narrow space between the eyebrows are also narrow-minded, like to haggle over trifles, are small-minded, and find it hard to get along or cooperate with others. Why? Because when some people encounter something disagreeable they knit their brows; over time the muscles between the brows atrophy and the space naturally narrows. Correspondingly, people with a wide space between the eyebrows also have broad minds.

## 3. "Marriage" in the Eyebrows

The *Book of Rites* states: "Food, drink, and the relations between men and women—these are the great desires of humankind." Throughout history, marriage has been one of life's most important matters and therefore one of the most closely watched and troubling themes. How to find one's ideal partner amid the vast sea of people—let us glimpse some of the secrets hidden in the eyebrows.

### (1) By Length

- **Long eyebrows** (extending beyond the eyes): Mild temperament, values emotion, easy to negotiate with on any matter, yet prone to melancholy and sentimentality.
- **Short eyebrows** (not extending beyond the eyes): Selfish and irritable, unwilling to compromise easily, yet also prone to melancholy and sentimentality, and liable to fall out with family.

### Frontalis

The frontalis is paired and symmetrical, located above the eyebrows and forming the forehead. It influences all changes and movements of the eyebrows and eyes.

Under normal conditions, when an adult's frontalis tenses, the eyebrows rise, wrinkles appear on the forehead, and the open eyes appear larger.

## **Messy Hairline**

Regardless of forehead shape, a messy hairline easily creates the impression that the person is unreliable and arouses dislike. In fact, such people have excellent eloquence and are skilled at social interaction. However, because of their cold and selfish side, others are often unwilling to form close relationships with them.

## **Rounded Forehead**

Such people can be described as the cute type, always carrying a strong childlike quality and treating others with courtesy and respect. Yet they often lack decisiveness and have no opinions of their own. Men with this forehead may be described as "effeminate"; women usually have many friends and are well liked.

## **Scattered Eyebrow Tails Indicate Restlessness**

The phrase "when wealth scatters, people find no peace" aptly describes such individuals. Because scattered brows also represent scattered wealth, many financial problems arise, leading to restlessness. If the eyelids are also puffy and press on the eyes, the person is even more likely to be a hot-tempered, selfish individual.

## **Which Eyebrow Shape Shows the Least Sign of Accumulating Wealth**

A Chinese folk saying goes: "Whether a person has money or not can be seen from the tip of the nose; whether they can save money can be seen from the sides of the nose; but to see whether a person knows how to spend and earn money, or to share benefits with friends—so that when there is money, everyone earns—one must look at the eyebrows."

## **Slanted Eyebrows**

Slanted eyebrows refer to a configuration in which one brow lowers while the other rises. The raised brow resembles a question mark and reflects the questioning, puzzled psychology of the person. On adult male faces this silent language is frequently seen.

## **Protruding Forehead**

This type is mostly seen in men; women rarely have it. Such people are earnest and stubborn, hold firmly to their own views, and possess the conviction to carry things through. They are somewhat lacking in flexibility; in interpersonal relations, losses outweigh gains.

## **Psychological Mini-Lesson**

Eyebrow changes are rich and varied. Psychologists point out that human eyebrows can display more than twenty different movements, and each movement corresponds to a different emotion. So what emotions do the various eyebrow movements reflect?

## **Eyebrows Drawing Inward and Lifting Outward**

If a person's two eyebrows draw together toward the center, you know they are thinking; as the saying goes, "brows knit and a plan comes to mind." If both brows lift outward, the person is clearly delighted—this is called "brows flying and color dancing."

## M-Shaped Forehead

This is also a male forehead type. Such people are rational and capable, and they like to do things cleanly and neatly; otherwise they feel dissatisfied. They enjoy lecturing others and can be stubborn. They are better suited to focused research or creative work.

## 10.2 Micro-expressions of the Eyes

Since the purpose of this book is not to treat eye diseases through surgery, it will not list every component of the eyes and their appendages in exhaustive detail, but will cover only those parts related to the micro-expressions under study.

### 10.1.2 5 Micro-expressions of the Eyebrows

Eyebrow movement is produced mainly by contraction of the frontalis muscle, which raises the brows; by contraction of the corrugator supercilii muscle, which draws them together in a frown; and by contraction of the orbicularis oculi and depressor supercilii muscles, which lower them. Different combinations of these actions produce five primary forms.

#### (2) By Thickness

- **Thick eyebrows:** Strong liver qi, proactive in action, yet prone to impulsiveness.
- **Thin eyebrows:** Relatively delicate and indecisive.

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Chin (c-chin).

See Sadness (s-sadness).

## Eyebrow Muscles

### 1. Frontalis Muscle

The frontalis muscle is located in the forehead region above the eyebrows, symmetrically on both sides. The fibers of the frontalis muscle blend with adjacent muscles, including the procerus muscle, the corrugator supercilii muscle, and the orbicularis oculi muscle, thereby pulling and influencing the entire eyebrow and eye area.

When the frontalis muscle is in a relaxed state, the forehead skin remains flat, showing no expression changes from the eyebrows upward to the hairline. When the frontalis muscle contracts, it pulls the eyebrows and the corresponding skin upward, raising both eyebrows as a whole and forming wrinkles in the forehead skin. In adults (not infants or the elderly), the forehead skin develops 2~3 wrinkles due to creasing. At the same time, the raising of the eyebrows naturally lifts the root of the upper eyelid. If the eyes are open, this action increases the degree to which the eyes open; more formally, this is termed an increase in the palpebral fissure.

### 2. Corrugator Supercilii Muscle

The corrugator supercilii muscle is a small cone-shaped muscle located at the inner end of the eyebrows, symmetrically on both sides. It is hidden beneath the frontalis muscle and the orbicularis oculi muscle (which is also why it is drawn separately on the other side of the face in the diagram) and partially fuses with them.

Working in coordination with the orbicularis oculi muscle, the corrugator supercilii muscle pulls the eyebrows downward and inward, causing the eyebrows to form a bulge above the eyes to shield them from strong light. The frowning action produces vertical skin lines on the upper nasal forehead area.

### 3. Procerus Muscle

The procerus muscle is located between the eyebrows and the nasal root, symmetrically on both sides.

The procerus muscle pulls the eyebrows downward, incidentally producing horizontal skin lines between the inner corners of the eyes and at the top of the nose. It participates in frowning and the action of drawing the eyebrows together, and likewise helps to avoid excessive light.

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

## Eyebrow Main Movements

### Eyebrow Raising

If a person raises only the left or right eyebrow, it usually indicates a lack of understanding or doubt about what the other person has said or done, as if asking: "Really? Are you sure that's what you mean?"

If both eyebrows are raised, it signals great delight or extreme surprise and is sometimes used to indicate that a question is about to be asked.

George arrived at the director's office as scheduled. Ordinary agents like George rarely had the chance to discuss work face-to-face with the director; only the extreme urgency of the situation had prompted him to bring his plan directly to the director.

The matter began when one of George's informants told him that two terrorists might be arriving the next day at a New York airport carrying important documents on a very special flight. After investigating the flight, George discovered that it was the same one carrying a high-ranking U.S. official returning home. The intelligence struck George as bizarre, yet the informant had always been reliable, and George did not want to miss an opportunity to eliminate the terrorists. When George reported his idea to his supervisor, the supervisor rejected the plan for lack of sufficient evidence. Frustrated, George decided to take the plan straight to the director.

The moment George entered the office, the director, seated behind a large desk, looked him over from head to toe several times and showed little friendliness toward his arrival.

Sure enough, after only a few exchanges the director began to pick apart George's plan, raising a long list of objections to both the overall scheme and its specific execution, and finally attempting to dismiss the operation outright as completely unfeasible. George had to keep stressing the plan's importance, but the director merely grunted and, without realizing it, raised his left eyebrow while twitching the corner of his mouth, displaying an expression of complete disbelief.

Sensing the director's rejection, George borrowed a sheet of paper, took out a pen, and wrote out every step and timing detail of the plan. He also listed, one by one, the losses that abandoning the operation would entail. Only then did the director lower his raised eyebrow, smile, and nod repeatedly, clearly accepting the plan.

Through the director's alternating eyebrow movements, George had keenly detected an opening within the signals of rejection. Later George explained: "One eyebrow raised while the other remains lowered is a sign of 'doubt'; when a person is both surprised and doubtful, one eyebrow rises; when both eyebrows rise, it indicates great surprise. At the time only one of the director's eyebrows was raised, so I judged that he was both surprised and doubtful about my plan. I therefore explained the plan in greater detail and, during the explanation, drew out the reason for his surprise. Once the director's surprise and doubt were resolved, he was certain to approve the plan."

When someone says "Really? So that's how it is!" while raising one eyebrow or repeatedly touching the eyebrow or eyelid, it shows that the person does not fully believe you. At such moments we must probe further for the reason behind the disbelief or produce stronger evidence. Only by eliminating the other person's doubts can we earn greater trust.

If, after you say "Let's have a drink sometime," the other person's eyebrows rise, it means the invitation is being taken as mere diplomatic language. If you then confirm the time and place of the gathering, the other person will surely feel grateful and trust you far more.

Under normal circumstances people rarely raise a single eyebrow, so whenever the movement appears it should never be dismissed as accidental; it must be taken seriously and its cause identified. In any interaction, lingering doubts on either side will sever the thread of communication. When we see an eyebrow rise, we must reason patiently, appeal emotionally, and supply enough evidence to prove our point, thereby removing any negative notions. We must not simply continue along the originally planned line of conversation, or the exchange will end fruitlessly.

## **7. Eyebrow Shrug**

Raising the eyebrows, holding them briefly, then lowering them is called an eyebrow shrug. It is often accompanied by a quick, brief downward twitch of the corners of the mouth and is most common during conversation. When people are engaged in heated discussion they tend to repeat small movements to emphasize their words, especially at key points; habitual complainers do the same. The gesture expresses an unpleasant surprise or a sense of helplessness.

Eyebrow movements are highly varied, each dynamic reflecting a different psychological shift. In general, displeasure or confusion can be shown by knitting the brows; jealousy or distrust by raising the brows; one brow raised and the other lowered by the classic signal of suspicion; both brows raised together by surprise; both brows lowered by dejection or sorrow; thick brows drawn sharply upward by anger; brows drawn together in a cold stare by contempt; winking and nudging by joking; lowered brows and downcast eyes by submission; raised brows by a sense of relief and satisfaction; and dancing brows by excitement.

### **1. Knitting the Brows**

Knitting the brows means contracting the eyebrows toward the bridge of the nose and narrowing the eye sockets. There are two types: protective and aggressive. The former protects the eyes from external harm; during the movement the cheeks beneath the eyes are also lifted while the eyes remain open. This occurs

when facing an attack, sudden strong light, or intense emotional reaction. The latter is a defensive reaction and is essentially self-protective.

Knitting the brows can convey many moods: hope, astonishment, arrogance, ignorance, thoughtfulness, worry, displeasure, or difficulty. Common expressions such as “brows knit in deep concern” or “brows knit and a plan forms” are directly related to this movement.

#### **4. Raising or Lowering the Brows**

A sudden raising of the eyebrows signals surprise; a full raising indicates that something or some news is hard to believe. Observing people around you, you will often see this movement when they first encounter something incredible. A sudden lowering of the eyebrows shows disapproval of what you have said. A half-lowering indicates incomprehension and lingering doubt. A complete lowering signals that the other person is angry and on the verge of explosion; at that point it is best to drop the sensitive topic or find an excuse to withdraw.

#### **Deep Knitting of the Brows**

Knitting the brows falls into two categories: protective and aggressive.

The purpose of protective knitting is to shield the eyes from external harm; the cheeks beneath the eyes are also lifted while the eyes remain open. This withdrawal reaction typically appears when a person faces an attack, sudden strong light, or intense emotional stimulus.

Aggressive knitting is still rooted in defense; it reflects concern that one’s own aggressive emotions might provoke a counter-reaction and is therefore linked to self-protection.

The most common deep knitting of the brows occurs in situations of annoyance, anxiety, dejection, or indecision.

#### **Brows Relaxed**

The opposite of knitted brows, this expression appears when a person feels cheerful and at ease, usually after encountering something pleasant or solving a difficult problem. It is an especially good moment to make a request; once the brows have relaxed, the person is more likely than usual to agree.

Although the eyebrows are merely accessories to the eyes and in some people their changes are not very obvious, they play as important a role as the eyes themselves. Their every stillness and movement subtly reveals the speaker’s state of mind. When observed together with the eyes, they allow a more accurate reading of another person’s mood.

#### **6. Lowering the Brows**

Lowering the brows is a reaction to aggression. Protective lowering shields the eyes from external harm; when danger appears, the cheeks beneath the eyes are also lifted while the eyes remain open and attentive to the surroundings. This up-and-down compression is a typical withdrawal response to external stimuli—for example, the same reaction occurs when the eyes are suddenly exposed to strong light. It can also appear when emotions surge dramatically, such as during loud crying or laughing or extreme nausea.

## **Raising the Brows**

The idiom “raising the brows and exhaling” describes the release of long-suppressed feelings and the joy of victory. In general, raised brows indicate emotions such as satisfaction or happiness.

However, if a person frequently raises a single brow, it suggests an arrogant character and indifference toward others. In states of extreme surprise or delight, both brows may also rise high along with widened eyes.

## **Eyebrow Shrug**

This expression consists of raising the brows, holding them briefly, then lowering them, often accompanied by a downward twitch of the mouth corners. It conveys displeasure mixed with helplessness. For instance, when someone keeps bothering you and refuses to listen to any explanation, you may produce this movement to express dissatisfaction and resignation.

In addition, the movement often appears when the other person is emphasizing a point and wants you to agree.

## **Eyebrow Flash**

An eyebrow flash occurs when the brows are raised and then instantly lowered, like a meteor streaking across the sky—quick and agile. It is a universal human signal of welcome and a friendly gesture.

The flash is usually accompanied by a head lift and a smile, though it can occur on its own. It generally appears in conversation to add emphasis. Whenever a speaker wishes to stress a particular word, the brows flash, as if to say, “What I’m saying is really astonishing!”

## **Knitted Brows**

Ancient poems often used “knitted moth brows” to describe a woman’s sorrow. In real life, when a person is deeply distressed and cannot find an outlet, a worried expression with tightly knitted brows commonly appears. The same movement occurs when someone is extremely anxious or indecisive. At such times the person greatly needs comfort; offering concern can be like sending charcoal in snowy weather and may win lasting friendship.

## **2. Eyebrow Shrug**

When the other person feels unhappy or helpless, an eyebrow shrug often appears: the brows are raised, held briefly, then lowered, accompanied by a quick downward twitch of the mouth corners while the rest of the face shows little change. The movement also tends to occur when the person is emphasizing a viewpoint, usually to gain your agreement.

## **5. Eyebrow Flash**

At the moment of meeting, if the other person’s brows suddenly rise and then instantly return to their original position—like a meteor streaking across the sky—we call it an eyebrow flash. It is a universal signal of warm welcome and a friendly gesture. When the brows flash repeatedly, it indicates particular delight at the visitor’s arrival. This expression is common between old friends who have not seen each other for a long time and is usually accompanied by a head tilt and a smile.



## **Knitting the Brows**

People generally knit their brows in two situations. First, when suddenly exposed to strong light or facing an external attack, they instinctively knit the brows to protect the eyes and resist the assault. Second, when confronted with a problem and unable to find an immediate solution, they may knit their brows involuntarily.

Usually, knitting the brows expresses emotions such as annoyance, dislike, disagreement, or defensiveness.

## **5. Winking**

Winking means suddenly closing the eyelids; the movement resembles a blink but carries a different meaning. Winking is often paired with nudging and is mainly used to signal the other person to act according to one's intention, to convey affection, or to stop the other person. This expression most often occurs between couples or people who know each other well and usually requires mutual understanding and tacit cooperation.

## **Single Brow Raised**

A single brow raised while the other is lowered resembles a large question mark. It is the characteristic expression of doubt, indicating disbelief in what the other person has said. If the doubt is not promptly addressed and dispelled, continued mistrust may damage the relationship or cause a plan to fail.

## **Eyebrow Shrug**

Raising the brows, holding them briefly, then lowering them constitutes an eyebrow shrug. It is frequently accompanied by a quick, brief downward twitch of the mouth corners. The gesture expresses displeasure or helplessness. During heated discussion, a person may also shrug the brows repeatedly to emphasize important points.

## **3. Raising the Brows**

The idiom "raising the brows and exhaling" is often used to describe the satisfied expression that appears once long-suppressed emotions have been released. When a person's brows rise, it indicates great delight or surprise. At such moments the other person's emotions are highly agitated; if you have something to say, it is best to wait until the mood has calmed.

## **1. Knitting the Brows**

When facing difficulty, danger, or something unpleasant, people instinctively knit their brows, drawing them slightly inward and shortening the distance between them. Knitting the brows is an extremely common expression that can represent many emotions, such as happiness, doubt, astonishment, arrogance, confusion, fear, or denial.

## **Single Brow Raised**

A single brow raised while the other is lowered resembles a question mark and reflects the raised-brow person's doubt and incomprehension. This silent language is frequently seen on the faces of adult men.

## **Brows Knotted**

Brows knotted means both brows are raised and drawn toward each other. When people encounter trouble or feel extremely depressed, they usually display this expression, resulting in a mournful face and “unfurrowed brows laden with worry.” Some patients with chronic pain also show it.

### **Brows Drawn Inward or Outward**

If a person’s brows move toward the center, you know the person is thinking, as the saying goes: “brows knit and a plan forms.” If both brows flare outward, the person is clearly in high spirits—an expression called “dancing brows and radiant face.”

### **4. Vertical Brows**

Vertical brows—brows standing upright—can indicate fright, excitement, or agitation. In daily life, when a person receives an unexpected stimulus such as a scare, involuntary trembling and vertical brows may occur, even causing the hair to stand on end.

### **Brows Bristling**

Bristling the brows usually shows that anger has reached its peak and an explosive outburst may follow. People who are already angry also often raise their brows.

### **7. Eyebrow Arrangement: Neat or Disordered**

People whose eyebrows are neatly arranged and lustrous tend to be honest in character and fortunate; those whose eyebrows are disordered and grow in inconsistent directions are often inconsistent in word and deed and are mostly hypocrites.

### **2. Brows Spread**

Brows spread means the eyebrows expand outward. The main meaning is relief and a pleasant, relaxed mood. The common saying “brows spread and eyes smiling” captures this sense.

### **3. Horizontal Brows**

Horizontal brows means the eyebrows form a straight line. Meeting someone with horizontal brows signifies hatred or anger toward that person.

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

## **Eyebrows Among the Seven Emotions**

### **1. Knowing Temperament from Eyebrows**

Eyebrows form an important part of the face beyond the five sensory organs. From the perspective of traditional Chinese medicine, a person's eyebrows reflect the condition of the endocrine system as well as the liver and kidneys. Because the liver and endocrine functions strongly influence temperament, eyebrow shape can reveal character. Ancient texts describe them this way: "Eyebrows are the graceful cover of the eyes and the standard of the face; they embody the essence of the eyes and distinguish the wise from the foolish. Sparse, fine, level, broad, elegant, and long eyebrows indicate an intelligent nature, while coarse, thick, unruly, chaotic, short, and furrowed eyebrows indicate a fierce and stubborn nature."

### 1. Eyebrows Have Thickness and Thinness

Just as eyes vary in size, eyebrows vary in thickness, and this variation correlates with temperament. Thick eyebrows generally belong to more masculine, active, and impulsive individuals who often receive protection from their parents. Thin eyebrows belong to more feminine, passive, and indecisive individuals. The same eyebrow shape can produce very different effects on different people. For example, crescent-shaped eyebrows look attractive, yet a man with such eyebrows tends to have a weak character.

### 2. People Whose Eyebrow Tails Point Upward or Downward

Eyebrow tails that point upward usually belong to people with strong self-esteem and personality. They rarely compromise, lack coordination, and make decisions decisively; as a result, they often earn others' respect. Eyebrow tails that point downward are commonly called "eight-twenty" eyebrows. People with downward-pointing tails are compassionate and typical "nice guys." They enjoy helping others and often respond to teasing with a smile rather than retaliation.

### 3. Eyebrow Tails Extending Beyond the Outer Eye Corner

Such individuals possess generosity and excel at perspective-taking, allowing them to empathize with others; they also tend to enjoy financial comfort. From an emotional standpoint, people with short eyebrows have shallow marital affinity. Those with long, thick eyebrow tails enjoy good fortune and remain active in any situation. Excessive thickness, however, can incline toward arrogance and cunning, potentially fostering self-centeredness. People whose eyebrow tails are long yet sparse tend to be steady in temperament; they possess rich knowledge but lack initiative and leadership. Note that sparse eyebrows caused by alopecia areata can improve with attention.

### 4. Willow-Leaf Eyebrows and Straight Eyebrows

Willow-leaf eyebrows belong to gentle, intelligent, and meticulous individuals who value human relationships and therefore honor their parents and maintain harmony with siblings. Straight eyebrows belong to persevering, action-oriented individuals. Wide straight eyebrows indicate boldness, while narrow straight eyebrows indicate stubbornness and lack of endurance; such people can also be devious and may become high-intelligence offenders.

### 5. Close-Set and Wide-Set Eyebrows

The ideal distance between eyebrow and eye equals the width of one finger laid horizontally. People whose eyebrows press low over the eyes find it difficult to remain calm; they tend to be devious, suffer poor luck, and experience frequent family turmoil. They often lack vision, focus on immediate gains, and neglect the future. People whose eyebrows sit farther from the eyes usually have mild temperaments and an imposing presence, a sign of longevity.

### 6. Wide and Narrow Eyebrow Spacing

People with wide spacing between the eyebrows mature early, act steadily, and enjoy longevity. They possess broad-mindedness, wide perspectives, and an easygoing nature that avoids excessive concern over trifles. People with narrow spacing between the eyebrows are the opposite: narrow-minded and prone to serious illness in middle age.

### **Women Observing Men**

- Men whose eyebrows are thick, close to the eyes, and whose gaze flickers should be approached with caution. Such men are naturally deceitful and may resort to any means for personal gain, including covert attacks. Having committed many unethical acts, they find it hard to trust anyone, including their girlfriends.
- Men with level, straight eyebrows are fair-minded and principled. They give an impression of safety and reliability, making them popular with women. They resist temptation and make ideal marriage partners, though they also hold their partners to high standards.
- Men whose eyebrows are fine, clearly defined, and grow smoothly along the brow bone often receive help from benefactors and enjoy good career luck.
- Men whose eyebrows extend straight and long past the eyes possess ambition and can advance rapidly in their careers.
- Men with high eyebrows and narrow noses tend to be knowledgeable, attuned to trends, refined in taste, and handsome; their standout qualities naturally draw attention.
- Men with messy eyebrows are usually highly opportunistic and lack a practical approach, so most achieve little.
- Men whose eyebrows press low over the eyes (the distance between brow and eye ideally accommodating one finger) are narrow-minded, timid, impatient, and profit-driven; most ultimately fail.
- Men whose eyebrows carry an "arrow" shape at the inner end love to stir trouble, criticize others while excusing themselves, and find harmonious relationships difficult.

### **Men Identifying Women**

- Women with longer eyebrows are generally cautious and far-sighted. They approach marriage with great seriousness, love deeply once committed, and remain devoted.
- Women with shorter eyebrows are highly dependent, lack independence, and hold romantic fantasies while possessing rich and delicate emotions.
- Women with thick eyebrows are often careless and willful. They act decisively, refuse to accept defeat, and dislike a mundane housewife's life. When given scope in the workplace they can become capable assistants to their husbands. In love they take the initiative, love and hate openly, and embrace new experiences.
- Women with fine eyebrows tend to be vain, status-conscious, and emotionally detached. They are emotional, intuitive, and inconsistent, making them unreliable.
- Women with narrow spacing between the eyebrows enjoy good interpersonal relationships and popularity; conversely, women with wide spacing are self-important, outgoing, and leadership-oriented.
- Women born with eyebrows set close together act impulsively and possess narrow minds.
- Women born with eyebrows set farther apart readily trust others, are easily deceived, and often waver in decisions.

### **Eyebrows That Are Soft and Well-Groomed**

Eyebrows that are soft, extend gradually outward on both sides, and curve slightly indicate a cultivated person with a clear mind. Conversely, eyebrows that are stiff, upright, and sparse belong to people who lack cultivation, act carelessly, aim too high, and fail to stay grounded. If the eyebrows are also short, the person may shortchange friends because excessive self-protection and constant focus on personal gain create an impression of selfishness.

In addition, eyebrows that droop or hang low over the eyes indicate strong comprehension and keen observation. Level eyebrows indicate practicality. Curved eyebrows indicate sensitivity and love of beauty. Eyebrows whose tails point upward indicate a bold and strong character. Eyebrows whose tails point downward indicate a weak and pessimistic character. Spiral or whorled eyebrows indicate intelligence mixed with suspicion, strong vanity, and a tendency to encounter setbacks midway. "Eight-character" eyebrows indicate a tendency toward pessimism and inconstancy in love.

Of course, friends should remember that although "reading eyebrows reveals character" exists as a saying, truly understanding a person still requires comprehensive analysis and observation. Because people are the hardest to know, the saying "one may know a face but not the heart" remains true.

### **The Density of Eyebrows Reflects the Depth of Emotion**

Thick eyebrows accompany deep emotions, while sparse eyebrows accompany shallow emotions. Beyond density, examine whether the eyebrows are thick yet soft and orderly, with clear upper and lower layers. If so, the person treats friends especially well, maintains sincere and lasting affection, and would go to any length for a friend.

Physiognomy generally holds that people with sparse, light eyebrows fundamentally disregard emotion, brotherhood, friendship, and marital bonds; they tend to "set morality aside and place profit in the center." In daily life, those who abandon wives or sell out friends are mostly people with sparse, light eyebrows.

Each individual eyebrow hair represents care and feeling toward others. Especially under today's market economy, such sparse-eyebrowed people will "step on friends' heads" to pursue wealth for their own benefit and survival; once successful, they keep friends at a distance and prefer to enjoy their gains alone.

### **Which Eyebrow Shape Indicates Wealth Luck**

The preceding discussion concerns eyebrows in motion. Even when eyebrows are still, their surface shape alone can reveal character traits.

Chinese folk wisdom also states: "Whether a person has money can be seen from the nose tip; whether a person can save money can be seen from the nostrils; but whether a person knows how to spend and earn money, or shares benefits with friends so that everyone profits together, must be judged from the eyebrows."

### **Scattered and Fragmented Eyebrow Tails Symbolize Dispersal of Wealth**

Eyebrow tails that are sparse, scattered, and broken—also called "broom eyebrows"—symbolize the dispersal of wealth. Such people often act without thorough consideration, lack planning, and easily act on impulse, so they frequently suffer unnecessary financial losses and scatter the money they have worked hard to earn. This shape shows the least sign of accumulating wealth. In addition, people with these eyebrows feel restless and worry excessively, making them even more prone to losing money.

### People with Narrow Eyebrow Spacing Are Penny-Pinching

People with narrow spacing between the eyebrows are small-minded, fond of haggling over trifles, and petty; they find it hard to get along or cooperate with others. The reason is simple: whenever such a person encounters something disagreeable, they furrow their brows, and over time the muscles at the center of the brow atrophy, narrowing the space. Correspondingly, people with wide spacing between the eyebrows also have wide hearts.

### People with Scattered Eyebrow Tails Feel Restless

The saying “when wealth disperses, people find no joy” fits these individuals perfectly. Because scattered eyebrows also represent scattered wealth, many financial problems arise and produce restlessness. If the eyelids are also puffy and press on the eyes, the person is even more likely to be a hot-tempered, selfish individual.

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

## Eyes

### (1) Complete Closure

Eyelid closure is a voluntary movement that any normal person can perform at will. The content we examine focuses solely on instinctive reactions triggered by stimuli, excluding habitual eye closure (common among the elderly) and habitual blinking. These two behaviors lack a necessary stimulus source and therefore hold no value for psychological analysis. They can, however, serve as the subject’s **baseline reaction** for comparison. Deliberate closures or blinks are likewise excluded from consideration.

Stimuli capable of producing visual blocking fall into two broad categories: positive ones, such as music worth savoring, delicious food, or problems requiring concentrated thought; and negative ones, such as terrifying images or threatening questions. Both categories elicit the same cerebral response—“I don’t want to see it.”

#### ① Positive Stimulus Sources

Positive stimuli prompt the brain to close the eyes in order to concentrate and prevent visual processing from diverting limited neural resources. Closing the eyes while listening to music heightens auditory perception; closing them while tasting food heightens gustatory perception; closing them while sniffing appears to sharpen the detection of subtle odors; and closing them while thinking allows mental energy to focus on finding a solution. More often than not, people do not close their eyes intentionally for these benefits; the action is an instinctive response to the stimulus itself, because visual processing consumes substantial neural capacity and closure conserves effort. As shown in Figure 10-11.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-11]*

Although precise data are unavailable, everyday observation and personal experience suggest—albeit “unscientifically”—that vision accounts for a very large share of human information intake. Reducing the

neural load devoted to vision logically frees resources for other activities.

## ② Negative Stimulus Sources

Negative stimuli signal potential harm and generate unpleasant emotions such as sadness, worry (fear accompanied by thought), disgust, or fear (without thought). To reduce or avoid these stimuli, the nervous system orders the eyelids to close, cutting off visual input and thereby limiting damage.

A simple experiment illustrates the point: pick up a small object and make a sudden throwing motion toward a trusted companion (without actually releasing it). Even without prior warning, the person will almost invariably close the eyes reflexively. Long-term evolution has instilled an automatic self-protection mechanism that activates whenever harm is perceived, regardless of conscious trust.

Closure remains under voluntary control, yet sudden stimuli override conscious intention and are governed by evolved instinct.

Additional examples confirm that negative stimuli produce complete eyelid closure: after seeing a horrifying image, when feeling disgusted yet powerless, or when saddened and unwilling to look. As shown in Figure 10-12.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-12]*

High-frequency blinking in the absence of physical irritants (wind, particles) also constitutes visual blocking. The difference is that high-frequency blinking usually mixes instinctive closure with rational decision-making: the person both wants to block the image and strives to keep the eyes open to maintain rational engagement with the situation.

The clearest illustration occurs when people confront difficult decisions; blink rate rises noticeably.

“Difficult” here refers not to logical or computational problems—which typically produce frowning and a fixed stare—but to dilemmas involving choice: what to say, how to say it, or how to balance self-interest against risk. In actual testing, many effective stimuli have produced precisely this pattern: subjects unwilling to disclose the truth yet striving to appear forthcoming, resulting in rapid blinking.

## Test Case

### What situations increase blink rate

We tested a computer programmer whose résumé claimed years of experience and proficiency in multiple languages. When asked for algorithmic details of one language listed, his blink rate increased sharply for three to four seconds; he then admitted limited familiarity with that language.

### Principle:

When facts must be concealed or details fabricated, intense cognitive effort is required. Prolonged closure or staring would be too obvious a tell, so the subject avoids them. The negative stimulus of the question, combined with the added load of concealment, produces elevated blink frequency even when the questioner is not visually aversive.

Note that this section addresses high-frequency blinking alone; in practice, increased blinking usually occurs together with gaze aversion, a topic examined separately below.

## Interpreting Emotions Through Eye Expressions

The Indian poet Tagore observed: “Once anyone masters the language of the eyes, the variations of expression become endless.” Beyond their role as visual organs, the eyes convey a person’s genuine emotions.

Whenever circumstances permit, look directly into the other person’s eyes; doing so signals respect, sincerity, and a willingness to connect. Pay attention, however, to the duration of eye contact.

In *The Psychology of Interpersonal Behaviour*, Michael Argyle notes that mutual gaze typically occupies 30–60 percent of interaction time. When the proportion exceeds 60 percent, the parties are likely either mutually attracted or preparing to fight; further observation of accompanying behaviors is needed to distinguish the two.

What matters is not eye shape or size but the expression within the eyes. As Mencius wrote in “Li Lou I”: “Nothing about a person is better than the pupils. The pupils cannot conceal evil. When the heart is upright, the pupils are clear; when the heart is not upright, the pupils are clouded.” A person’s moral character is plainly visible in the eyes.

Thoughts and intentions frequently appear in the eyes; reading them reveals inner states. The following observations, drawn from classical and practical sources, illustrate how to discern intent from gaze during conversation:

- Steady, calm eyes indicate that the person already has a well-formed plan for the matter troubling you. If unwilling to state it openly, the reason is likely confidentiality; wait quietly for instructions.
- Scattered, unfocused eyes indicate helplessness. Anxiety or further questions are pointless; compose yourself and devise your own response.
- Eyes that dart sideways with a sharp quality signal marked coldness. Postpone any request and withdraw promptly; later analyze the cause and seek to restore rapport.
- Dark, sullen eyes are a warning of malice. Proceed with caution; the person may be preparing to strike from behind. Unless you intend confrontation, disengage.
- Restless, unusually mobile eyes suggest hidden schemes. Advance carefully; traps may lie on every side. Discount flattering words—they are bait.
- Dull, lifeless eyes accompanied by pale lips reveal extreme anxiety despite verbal reassurances. The person is still searching for a solution but has found none. Withdraw and formulate your own plan; if you have one, present it with an estimate of its chances.
- Eyes that seem to blaze indicate rising anger. Offer conciliation if you wish to avoid rupture; otherwise, further pressure will provoke open conflict.
- Serene eyes and a slight smile show genuine satisfaction. Compliments or requests are likely to be well received.
- Wandering, inattentive eyes indicate boredom; end the topic or change it.
- Steady, fixed eyes indicate that your remarks are considered worth hearing; continue as planned.
- Downcast eyes and lowered head signal heavy distress. Avoid cheerful or sympathetic topics; offer brief comfort and withdraw.
- Upward-rolling eyes indicate disdain; stop and seek another approach.

In short, eyes may be scattered or concentrated, mobile or still, flowing or fixed, sullen or dull, lowered or raised. Careful attention to these variations reveals character and intention with clarity.

## Remember to Look at the Other Person One More Time



When two people meet each other's gaze, both immediately sense a contradiction: they want eye contact yet also want to avoid it. This oscillation produces the complex patterns of human eye movement.

—Desmond Morris

We consciously regulate our actions to appear proper, yet our eyes often betray inner secrets. Others, like attentive hounds, watch those eyes for advantage. FBI experts, for example, detected panic in Saddam Hussein's eyes—an observation that contributed to the decision to invade Iraq. Interrogators routinely mine fleeting glances for leverage.

Trust in conversation rests largely on eye contact. If a speaker's eyes continually drift away, or if blink rate rises markedly above baseline, credibility suffers.

FBI agent Joe, acting on a tip, went to a suspect's girlfriend's apartment. She denied the suspect was present. During repeated questioning her blink rate rose noticeably while she remained outwardly calm. Joe concluded the suspect was inside and, after obtaining consent to search, found him in a wardrobe.

Joe's detection of elevated blinking revealed the girlfriend's concealed anxiety despite her composed demeanor.

Leonardo da Vinci remarked that "the eyes are the mirror of the soul." Joe Navarro adds that sustained eye contact helps build rapport during interviews; when shaking hands or speaking, allow the gaze to linger before slowly shifting it to either side.

In daily interaction, eyes signal interest or aversion, maintain conversational control, and convey emotions words cannot express. They can foster warmth and openness or, conversely, tension.

During greetings, dominant individuals tend to maintain longer eye contact; more deferential individuals maintain shorter contact. Between men, prolonged same-sex eye contact can be misinterpreted; brevity is advisable.

To keep an interaction comfortable, break eye contact roughly every five seconds rather than staring continuously. Avoid looking down, which signals a desire to end the exchange. Instead, glance upward or sideways as if thinking; the other person will interpret the movement as cognitive effort and remain engaged. While listening, cycle attention between one eye, the other eye, and the mouth; the speaker will sense genuine interest.

In argument, steady, resolute eye contact can exert pressure without words. Maintain the gaze while the other speaks, observing tone and expression. Silence combined with unwavering attention is often sufficient to prevail.

## **Why Do the Eyeballs Keep Moving**

In everyday conversation and communication, we can easily notice that a speaker's eyeballs are not fixed on a single point. They sometimes move left, sometimes right, sometimes up, sometimes down. Most people overlook this, yet in micro-expression research, eyeball movement occupies a crucial position.

The first to discover that eyeball movement relates to a person's thoughts were Richard Bandler and John Grinder, who together created NLP (Neuro-Linguistic Programming), which includes EAC (Eye Accessing Cues). They proposed that eyeball activity falls into the following categories:

- Eyes looking up and to the left indicate people are recalling images; eyes looking up and to the right indicate people are constructing images. These belong to visual memory and visual construction.
- Eyes looking horizontally to the left indicate people are recalling sounds; eyes looking horizontally to the right indicate people are constructing sounds. These belong to auditory memory and auditory construction.
- Eyes looking down and to the left indicate people are thinking to themselves, known as “internal dialogue”; eyes looking down and to the right indicate people are feeling, including emotional sensations and physical touch sensations, which belong to kinesthetic memory. Research shows that habitually looking down and to the right over long periods can make a person prone to depression.

Suppose you ask a friend whether they went to the beach on vacation. If their eyes first look up and to the left, then down and to the right, it shows they began by recalling the beach scene and then recalled the associated feelings, confirming the certainty of the trip. This proves they really went. If, upon hearing the question, they quickly glance up and to the right, it indicates they are searching their mind for previously seen beach photos or footage and using those memories to fabricate a beach experience. This is enough to prove they did not go but are trying to describe a beach convincingly.

Now let's conduct an interesting experiment to demonstrate the relationship between eyeball movement and sensory memory.

Look up and to the left and picture the appearance of a friend you have not seen for several years. Although many details may be unclear, their overall look will still appear in your mind. Give yourself half a minute to recall, without rushing, and try to retrieve some details. After half a minute, look straight ahead and clear the image from your mind. Then look down and to the right and try to recall the friend's appearance again. You will find that the earlier recall was smooth, but now it comes in fragments and your attention is hard to sustain. This shows that looking down and to the right does not aid visual recall.

However, this eye-accessing-cue pattern does not apply to everyone. Some people's sensory memory and eyeball movement are reversed, although such individuals are rare. In those cases we cannot rely entirely on the pattern and must first determine the relationship between the person's sensory memory and their eyeball movement. There is a very simple test.

You can ask them some straightforward questions:

- What color are the walls in your room? If their eyes look up and to the left before answering, it shows their visual memory follows the eye-accessing-cue pattern. If you are still unsure, continue with more questions, such as asking them to describe their mother's appearance, until you are certain their visual memory matches the pattern.
- Next is visual construction. Try asking: Imagine what a person of the opposite sex would look like wearing your clothes. How would the wallpaper at home look if changed to a floral pattern? If their eyes look up and to the right, you can then judge the truthfulness of their statements using the eye-accessing-cue pattern.
- Then come auditory memory and auditory construction. For auditory memory you can ask: How does the chorus of your favorite song go? What does your favorite person of the opposite sex sound like? For auditory construction you can ask: What would music sound like if it could play underwater? Imagine the sound of ice cracking. If their eyes move left during recall and right during construction, they fit the eye-accessing-cue pattern.
- Finally, kinesthetic memory. You can ask them what moldy bread tastes like, or to imagine hugging their favorite person, or biting into a sour orange. If their eyes look down and to the right, it proves they fit

the eye-accessing-cue pattern. If you wish to continue, you can ask what encouraging words they would say to themselves if they failed. If their eyes look down and to the left, it shows they are engaged in "internal dialogue."

## **(2) The Erroneous Application of Cross-Control of Left and Right Brain Movement**

If an improper summary of brain-function lateralization is still excusable, then deriving from that mistaken summary a link between eye-movement direction and left-right brain division is an even more ignorant display.

The basis for this derivation is presumably the principle of crossed control between the two hemispheres. Crossed control means the left hemisphere controls movement of the right-side limbs and the right hemisphere controls movement of the left-side limbs. This is a scientific conclusion.

What is hard to understand is that, if the crossed-control rule is followed, the left hemisphere should control the right eye and the right hemisphere the left eye. If recall or fabrication engaged only one hemisphere according to its specialized functions (which in fact does not occur), the result should be movement in one eye rather than both eyes moving together. Moreover, according to crossed control, if the right hemisphere governs left-hand movement, does that mean the left hand can only move leftward? If leftward movement is managed by the right hemisphere, then when both hands move leftward together, which hemisphere should control them?

Therefore, the direction of eye movement has no relation whatsoever to functional differences between the left and right hemispheres.

The original source of this fallacy may lie in NLP's six-direction eye-movement theory.

In this well-known speculative model, the "NLP school" claims that when a person's eyes turn up and to the left, they are recalling visual information, such as "What color are your curtains?" When the eyes turn up and to the right, they are constructing visual information, such as "What color is a purple zebra's tail?" When the eyes turn horizontally to the left, they are recalling auditory information, such as the melody of a famous piece of music; when the eyes turn horizontally to the right, they are constructing auditory information, such as composing an original melody. When the eyes turn down and to the left, the person is talking to themselves; when the eyes turn down and to the right, they are perceiving kinesthetic and sensory information.

To prevent their speculation from being falsified, NLP also added a left-handed reversal supplement: if the person is left-handed, all directions are reversed. This still relies on the theory of crossed hemispheric control of the limbs.

In reality, to provide coherent visual information, eye movements must occur simultaneously and in the same direction; otherwise visual confusion results. Every nerve that controls the extraocular muscles receives input from corticobulbar fibers of both hemispheres.

In other words, each eye is simultaneously controlled by both sides of the brain.

Thus normal eye movements are conjugate; they do not allow the independent, asynchronous movements possible with the limbs.

Of course, with training some people can deliberately perform disconjugate movements, because during convergence both medial rectus muscles contract simultaneously, the lens thickens, and the pupils constrict,

enabling near fine work. By contrast, the lateral rectus muscles responsible for divergence are not controlled by the oculomotor nucleus but by the abducens nucleus; therefore the two eyes cannot diverge without passing through the oculomotor nucleus, whereas the medial rectus muscles are directly controlled by the oculomotor nucleus, allowing crossed eyes.

The neurophysiological principles are presented to demonstrate that eye-movement direction is entirely different from the crossed-control mechanism of the limbs and cannot be arbitrarily applied by imagination.

This set of conjectures, published in 1979, has no data support and cannot withstand verification.

We conducted a small experiment: 200 participants each answered six questions while their eye movements were recorded on video and later analyzed.

The statistical results showed that some criteria had a mismatch rate above 70 percent, others close to 50 percent; the average falsification rate for the six rules was 63 percent. In other words, using six-direction eye movement to analyze another person's thoughts carries nearly a two-thirds chance of being wrong—less reliable than a 50-50 guess. The probability that any one person fully conforms to the six-direction pattern is 37 percent, roughly three per thousand (2.6‰), an appallingly low figure.

Therefore this judgment criterion can produce erroneous conclusions and wrongfully implicate others.

At this point we can safely discard this "pseudoscience." If interested, you may also carefully examine the similar rumor that "right-handed people are more rational (rigorous, conservative, etc.) while left-handed people are more artistic (innovative, emotional, etc.)" and identify where it goes wrong.

### **Those Who Look Away First Lack Confidence**

The popularity of the American drama *Lie to Me* sparked a wave of "micro-expression research" in society. As one parent whose son is still in elementary school described: "My son is in elementary school. Because I didn't want him watching television too late and affecting his studies, I told him the television might have a problem." The son immediately replied with great certainty: "Don't lie to me. You touched your forehead while speaking, which shows you weren't confident when you said that, so you were lying. I know exactly what you're thinking..."

In truth, the flamboyant Dr. Lightman on the show is no match for real FBI agents who must judge expressions daily.

The FBI possesses a videotape recording the entire exchange between agents and a person of interest in one case. The interviewee, Carter—a murder suspect—had every detail of his responses captured. After the agents posed a highly provocative question, Carter leaned forward slightly and gave a very mild reply. In those few seconds, most people would miss anything unusual and might even believe Carter's gentle answer proved his innocence. Yet the experienced agents' eyes did not miss it.

After the first interview, the agents reviewed the tape and noticed a subtle detail. They rewound and played it at one-quarter speed. In a segment lasting less than one second, Carter's expression completely distorted: his nose wrinkled, facial muscles contorted, teeth bared, and eyebrows lowered—an unmistakable expression of anger and disgust. After finishing his answer he also stole two glances at the agents. Clearly Carter had very little confidence in his own reply.

Some human micro-expressions last only 1/25 of a second and are hard for ordinary people to detect, yet they accurately reflect the person's true emotional changes. If, after we ask a question and receive a very affirmative answer, the speaker raises their head or shifts their gaze upward to observe our expression just as they finish, we can be certain they lack confidence in their answer. Because they lack confidence, they care greatly about others' opinions and therefore secretly observe us. Such signals usually last only about 0.5 seconds. Spotting this expression near the end of a conversation allows us to grasp the other person's inner world; we must not let the moment pass but should press for more time to uncover the truth.

In Carter's case, after reviewing the tape the agents used the tactic of denying his answers and obtained the truth. Thus, during information-gathering conversations, accurately judging whether the other party's expression conveys confidence is extremely important.

We also often hear statements such as "That price is already the lowest; I can't go any lower" or "I've told you I don't know, because I wasn't even at the scene." If the speaker delivers these firm words yet steals a glance at us at the critical final moment, we can conclude the firmness is feigned.

If we continue to maintain eye contact, the other person will often look away and lower their head, fearing their true thoughts will be exposed. To conceal this, they must lower their head. This further confirms their answer is not confident or that room for negotiation remains. We therefore have no need to compromise and can adopt an equally firm stance to counterattack. Faced with false firmness, greater firmness on our part will only increase their tension, forcing them to retract their earlier statements and ultimately reveal their bottom line.

Conversely, if we wish to feign firmness ourselves, we must not voluntarily look away during the exchange, as doing so would give the opponent an opening to probe our own bottom line.

## **The Eyes Are the Windows to the Soul**

Every part of the human brain, like other parts of the body, develops with greater use and atrophies or loses function with disuse. Consequently, the language centers of talkative people are highly developed. This theory was first discovered in 1861 by the famous French surgeon and neuropathologist Paul Broca. At the time Broca was director of a Paris insane asylum. After some patients with aphasia died, he dissected their brains and found that a specific region in each case either contained a tumor or had been destroyed. This gray area lies just behind and above the eyeball; the medical community named it "Broca's area" and the resulting aphasia "Broca's aphasia," or "motor aphasia."

Under normal conditions, blood flow to this region increases when a person speaks compared with when they are silent. Therefore the more one talks, the more developed the area becomes, causing the eyeballs to protrude slightly downward and outward. In other words, of two otherwise similar people standing before you, the one whose eyeballs protrude slightly is usually the more talkative. Once they start speaking they become voluble, sometimes even gesticulating. You can take advantage of this by extracting useful information from their torrent of words.

Of course your counterpart may be taciturn, in which case you cannot obtain much useful information from their mouth, yet you can still capture through their eyes certain "truths" of which they themselves may be unaware.

For example, while you are earnestly presenting your proposal, if the other person's gaze drifts elsewhere, they are probably uninterested in what you are saying or are thinking about something else. At such moments

you need to change the topic or strategy promptly, or cooperation will be difficult. Likewise, when a person's emotions change, their pupils change accordingly—an alteration they cannot see but you can observe clearly. Many expert card players win repeatedly because they are skilled at reading opponents' pupil changes to infer whether their hands are strong or weak. When a person is excited, their pupils can dilate four- or fivefold; when calm, they constrict sharply. Similarly, salespeople can gauge whether a customer is interested in their product, and negotiators can sense whether the other side is satisfied with the terms.

The eyes easily betray a person's inner state. If someone's eyelids are half-closed, their eyeballs darting left and right, and they avoid direct eye contact, it is basically safe to conclude they have something to hide. By contrast, an honest person will look at you calmly and steadily—an expression that cannot be faked. Some cunning individuals deliberately feign honesty, appearing calm and composed, yet to mask the lack of confidence in their gaze they often overdo it by staring fixedly.

In addition, blink rate can reveal clues. Blinking is a subconscious behavior that is difficult to control without special training. Psychological research has found that when psychological pressure suddenly increases, blink rate rises. For instance, when a non-professional liar tells a lie, their psychological pressure surges and their blink rate can more than double compared with normal.

Some people also unconsciously glance sideways at you, sometimes briefly, sometimes for longer. Generally, a sideways glance carries three possible meanings:

- Interest in you, though the glance is usually furtive and not meant to be noticed;
- Inner hesitation;
- Dismissiveness toward what you are saying—this being the most common meaning of a sideways glance.

Of course we cannot stare at an opponent indefinitely; doing so makes people uncomfortable. Psychologists suggest that during conversation it is appropriate for one's gaze to rest on the other person's face 30–60 percent of the time; when managed well, this can effectively produce positive outcomes. Therefore correct gazing is very important in communication.

In daily life, three gazing styles are most commonly used.

### **Visual, Auditory, or Kinesthetic**

Have you ever watched a skilled locksmith at work? It is almost like watching magic.

He handles a lock and hears sounds you cannot hear, sees things you cannot see, and senses conditions you cannot feel. In moments he understands the entire structure of the lock and repairs it.

An excellent communicator works the same way. He can discern anyone's inner combination (also called strategy)—thinking and reflecting like a locksmith to map out another person's internal structure.

The key to understanding someone's strategy is to notice their words and actions. People transmit every signal you need about their strategy, sometimes through language, sometimes through behavior, and sometimes even through their eyes.

You can learn to read a person as skillfully as you read a book or a map. Remember, a strategy is simply an imagined combination that produces a specific result. Your task is to prompt people to experience their strategies while you observe their distinctive reactions.

People generally fall into three types: visual, auditory, and kinesthetic.

- **Visual:** People who primarily use the visual system tend to view the world in images. They obtain their greatest sensory power through the visual portion of the brain. Because their language tries to keep pace with the changing images in their minds, they often speak quickly. Because they simply want to describe the images in their heads, they pay less attention to phrasing and prefer visual language, describing how things look, what shapes they take, and whether they are bright or dark.
- **Auditory:** People with strong auditory senses speak more slowly, with fuller voices and measured rhythm. Because words carry great weight for them, they choose what to say with care. They often express themselves with auditory language, such as "That sounds right to me," "I can hear what you're saying," or "Everything sounds fine."
- **Kinesthetic:** People with strong kinesthetic senses speak even more slowly. They respond mainly to touch, their voices are deep, and each sentence seems squeezed out one word at a time. They frequently use kinesthetic language, always trying to "grasp" the "concrete form" of something—whether it feels "heavy" or needs to be "touched." They commonly say, "I've found the answer, but I haven't quite gotten hold of it yet."

Everyone possesses all three systems, yet most people are dominated by only one. When you are learning someone's strategy and decision-making process, first identify which sensory system is primary so you can tailor your message accordingly.

By watching and listening while paying close attention to a person's eyes, you can immediately recognize which system they are using.

Consider this question: What color were the candles on your twelfth birthday cake? When answering, 90 percent of people raise their heads and look to the left; this is how right-handed people, and even some left-handers, recall visual images.

Now answer the next question: What would Mickey Mouse look like with a mustache? Take a few minutes to describe it. This time the eyes may rise and move to the right—the place where the eyes construct images.

Thus, simply by watching people's eyes you can understand their strategies.

A person's voice also carries meaning. Visual people speak quickly and sharply, often with a nasal tone and wide pitch variation. Kinesthetic people speak slowly and in a deep register. Auditory people maintain an even tone and articulate clearly.

Therefore, even limited interaction can reveal a person's mental processes clearly and accurately. The best way to learn strategies, however, is not observation but practice. Apply these exercises to as many people as possible.

## Understanding People's Feelings Through Eye Expressions

Psychologists tell us that a person's hidden thoughts and conflicts always surface unconsciously through changes in the eyes. FBI agents have long noted this and focus on suspects' eyes during interviews.

How, then, can we read someone's true thoughts from their eyes during conversation? The following points are offered for reference.

- When the eyes are calm and steady, the person already has a clear plan and is confident of success regarding the matter that concerns you. If you ask for advice and the person does not state it plainly, it is usually because the matter is confidential. Do not press; simply wait for their decision.
- When the eyes appear scattered and unfocused, the person also has no solution. Becoming anxious is useless, and asking for guidance is equally pointless. Stay calm, think of your own approach, and stop asking; further questions will only increase their confusion. This is your moment to show ability—devise a plan yourself.
- When the eyes shoot sideways with a sharp look, the person is unusually cold. If you have a request, do not present it; find an excuse to leave at once. Even staying a moment longer is inappropriate. Afterward, examine why they are distant and seek ways to restore rapport.
- When the eyes look dark and gloomy, recognize it as a signal of ruthlessness. Negotiate with caution. A dangerous hand may be poised behind you. Unless you are prepared for confrontation, withdraw quickly.
- When the eyes move in ways unlike their usual pattern, the person harbors a scheme and intends to make things difficult. Proceed carefully; do not approach lightly. Traps may lie on every side. Do not trust sweet words; they are bait on a hook or sugar coating on poison.
- When the eyes look dull and the lips pale, the person is extremely anxious about the current problem. Although they say it is nothing and are still trying to find a way, they cannot. Stop asking; withdraw and consider your own response. If you already have a plan, present it and state your level of confidence.
- When the eyes seem to blaze, the person is burning with anger. If you do not intend to break with them, signal compromise and seek a way out. Otherwise, further pressure will trigger open conflict.
- When the eyes are tranquil and a smile appears, the person is very pleased about something. To win favor, offer a few compliments. If you have a request, this is a good moment; they are more likely than usual to agree.
- When the eyes dart about and the person seems distracted, they have grown tired of what you are saying and further talk will be pointless. End the conversation, take your leave, or introduce a new topic they prefer.
- When the eyes fix steadily on you, the person believes your words are worth hearing. Present your case as planned. If your reasoning is sound and your proposal feasible, they will accept it.
- When the eyes lower and the head tilts downward, the person carries a heavy burden of worry or pain. Do not speak of happy matters, which would only deepen their distress, nor of painful ones, which would intensify shared suffering. Offer a few words of comfort and leave promptly; further talk is pointless.
- When the eyes turn upward, the person is unwilling to listen. No matter how strong your arguments or how skillful your delivery, the outcome will not be pleasant. Stop at once and seek another approach later.

In short, eyes may scatter or focus, move or stay still, flow or fix, appear dark or dull, lower or rise. Careful observation will reveal people's feelings completely.

## Eye Contact

When you listen intently to someone, have you noticed their eyes drifting to other objects? When you are halfway through a story, have you noticed the listener watching you closely the whole time? People generally seek stronger eye contact while listening than while speaking.



When we listen carefully, we usually look at the speaker, especially the eyes. This helps us understand what is said and provides clear feedback. When we speak, however, we tend to look around or fix on other objects to organize our thoughts.

If someone avoids your eyes during conversation, they are either not listening or hiding something.

In *The Psychology of Interpersonal Behaviour*, Michael Argyle notes that mutual gaze typically occupies 30–60 percent of interaction time. When gaze exceeds 60 percent, the individuals are likely either attracted to each other or preparing to fight; further behavioral cues are needed to determine which.

Cultural background and location determine whether eye contact is appropriate. In North America, people generally favor eye contact; elsewhere it may be viewed as an attempt to dominate and considered rude.

In some places, eye contact between a woman and an unrelated man is regarded as improper. In others, a woman's use of eye contact signals that she is a prostitute.

Before interpreting someone's eye contact negatively, consider their cultural background and the reasons they may avoid it.

Another factor is personality. Extroverts usually have no difficulty with eye contact, while shy people may engage in less. When a normally shy person suddenly makes more eye contact than usual, it may indicate they are pretending or lying. Do not overlook this basic point.

When asked a question that makes them uncomfortable or unsure how to answer, people often try to change the subject and adopt a defensive posture, producing more eye contact than usual.

In a state of staring or gazing, the eyes remain fixed on a particular object. Upon entering a room we instinctively scan it quickly and register our surroundings—an automatic action of which we are barely aware. If our eyes linger longer than usual on an object or person, it signals interest.

When observing someone who is staring or gazing, note whether the eyes are focused or vacant. Focused eyes indicate active thinking or analysis. Vacant eyes suggest daydreaming and lack of awareness of the object in view.

### **Reading Inner States from Eye Expressions**

Micro-expression keywords: Many liars avoid eye contact; people expressing affection gaze deeply into each other's eyes. A person's inner secrets are written in the eyes. To read others, one must interpret their gaze.

The ancients spoke of observing a person's "spirit," which refers to the eyes. Successful social interaction depends on reading expressions; at every moment one must adjust approach according to facial changes. The most characteristic facial change is in the eyes. Therefore, recognizing others' thoughts requires skill in reading their eyes.

When a person's eyes are calm and steady, they already have a clear plan and are confident of success. For some reason they cannot state it plainly. Do not press; simply wait for their action.

When the eyes appear scattered, the person has no solution. Asking for advice is useless; stay calm and devise your own approach.

When the eyes shoot sideways with a sharp look, the attitude is unusually cold. If you have a request, set it aside for now, examine the reason for the coldness, repair the relationship, and then seek help.

When the eyes look dark and gloomy, the person is ruthless. Deal with such an individual with extreme caution. Unless necessary, keep your distance for safety.

When the eyes move frequently in unusual ways, the person harbors schemes and is deeply calculating. Do not trust their words, especially pleasant ones; they may be bait on a hook. Proceed with great care.

When the eyes look dull, the person is slow-witted, timid, and slow-thinking. Do not consult them about problems. A timely hint may earn their lasting gratitude.

When the eyes appear exceptionally sharp, the person is angry and emotions are running high. The slightest spark may trigger an outburst. Do not confront; compromise appropriately and seek an exit.

When the eyes are tranquil and a smile appears, the person is especially pleased with something or someone. To win favor, offer compliments. If you have a request, this is a good opening.

When the eyes wander restlessly, the person has grown impatient. Further talk will only increase annoyance. Stop at once, take your leave, or introduce a topic they enjoy.

When the eyes fix steadily on you, the person is keenly interested and eager to hear more. Whatever you say will be well received.

When the eyes lower, a painful memory has been touched. Stop immediately.

When the eyes turn upward, the person is unwilling to listen. No amount of reasoning or skill will persuade them; they have already seen through your intent and will only become more dismissive. Stop at once and seek another opportunity later.

In short, eyes may be dull or lively, dark or clear, sharp or gentle. Careful observation will reveal a person's true inner state.

## 1. Eyelids

For practical purposes, the eyelids may be understood as the common term "eye skin," yet they are more than a simple layer of skin. Inside the eyelids lie glands and muscles. The glands secrete fluid that lubricates the eyeball, while closure of the eyelids is controlled by the orbicularis oculi muscle. When this muscle contracts, the upper and lower eyelids close, protecting the eyeball. In addition, inside the upper eyelid is the levator palpebrae superioris muscle, which raises the upper eyelid—commonly called opening the eyes. Both muscles are largely under voluntary motor control and can be moved at will; in academic terms this is called "voluntary movement." The upper eyelid also contains smooth-muscle components controlled solely by the autonomic nervous system and cannot be moved at will.

From this we may draw an important conclusion: all eyelid-closure movements are executed under neural command. Sometimes closure occurs because one "wants" to close the eyes; a normal person can perform this action voluntarily at any time. At other times closure occurs without conscious intent, driven instead by emotion, instinct, or habit and without passing through deliberate thought. Two simple examples illustrate this:

1. Stand face-to-face with a good friend. Tell them “Don’t be afraid,” but do not instruct them “Don’t blink.” Suddenly make a threatening motion toward their eyes without actually striking them. Observe the reaction. They know you are a friend and will not harm them, yet the eyelids still close involuntarily to protect the eyes—an evolved instinctive response. Only if you specifically instruct them beforehand “Do not blink” might they be able to suppress it.
2. Place something foul-smelling (such as stinky tofu) or visually repulsive in a cup. Ask your best friend to smell or look at it, warning them that it is unpleasant but urging them to try. Despite the trusted instruction and mental preparation, they will still involuntarily furrow the brow and narrow the eyes (eyelid closure).

**Summary:** When confronted with disliked, difficult, or distressing negative stimuli, the eyelids close involuntarily in an attempt to reduce the impact of the stimulus. Although the action is involuntary in the sense that it is not directed by conscious thought, it remains under neural control. The anatomical structure of the upper eyelid is shown in Figure 10-7.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-7]*

Inside the eyelid there is also a muscle called Müller’s muscle (Müller肌), which differs in that it is smooth muscle. Smooth muscle is governed by the autonomic nervous system and cannot be controlled by “wanting” to move it; its action is an involuntary neural response, academically termed “involuntary movement.” When the sympathetic nervous system is excited by negative stimuli such as fright, anger, or pain, contraction of these muscles increases the degree to which the eyes open. Consequently, effective stimulation produces involuntary reactions, and these “involuntary movements” are highly valuable for analyzing a person’s true psychological state.

## 1. Eyelids

Loosely speaking, the eyelid can be understood as the commonly referred to eyelid skin, but unlike its colloquial name suggests, it is not merely a layer of skin. Inside the eyelid there are also glands and muscles. The fluid secreted by the glands lubricates the eyeball, while closure of the eyelid is controlled by the orbicularis oculi muscle. When the orbicularis oculi contracts, the upper and lower eyelids close, protecting the eyeball. In addition, inside the upper eyelid there is a “levator palpebrae superioris” muscle whose sole function is to lift the upper eyelid upward, commonly known as opening the eyes. Most of these two muscles are under somatic-nerve control and can be consciously directed—an action academically termed “voluntary movement.” The upper eyelid also contains a smooth-muscle component governed solely by the autonomic nervous system; it cannot be controlled by “thinking.”

From this we can derive an important conclusion: every eyelid-closure movement is executed under neural-system command. Sometimes the person “wants” to close the eyes and a normal individual can do so at will; at other times the closure occurs without conscious intent, driven instead by emotion, instinct, or habit and bypassing deliberate thought. The two simplest examples are:

1. Stand face-to-face with a good friend, tell him or her “don’t be afraid,” but do not add “don’t blink,” then suddenly make a threatening gesture toward the friend’s eyes—without actually striking. Observe the reaction. The friend knows you are a good friend and will not cause harm, yet the eyelids still close involuntarily to protect the eyes; this is an evolved instinctive response. Of course, if you had specifically instructed the friend beforehand “don’t blink,” he or she might have been able to suppress it.

2. Fill a cup with something foul-smelling (for example, stinky tofu) or visually repulsive, then ask your best friend to smell or look at it, stressing that the contents are unpleasant but urging the friend to try anyway. Despite the trusted request and mental preparation, the friend will still involuntarily furrow the brows and squint (eyelid closure).

**Summary:** When confronted with disliked, difficult, or distressing negative stimuli, the eyelids close involuntarily in an attempt to reduce the impact of the stimulus. Although the movement is involuntary in the sense that it is not directed by conscious thought, it is still executed under neural-system command. The anatomical structure of the upper eyelid is shown in Figure 10-7.

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Inside the eyelid there is also a set of muscles called Müller's muscle (Müller muscle); these are smooth muscle and therefore governed by the autonomic nervous system. Their movement cannot be controlled by "thinking"; it is an automatic neural behavior, academically termed "involuntary movement." When the sympathetic nerves are excited by negative stimuli such as fright, anger, or pain, contraction of these muscles increases the degree to which the eyes are open. Consequently, when a person receives an effective stimulus, involuntary reactions appear, and these "involuntary movements" are highly valuable for analyzing a person's true psychological state.

#### **Clue Four: Blinking and Eye Closure**

The eye closure and blinking discussed here refer to reactions that occur after the eyes receive external stimuli. Because both types of facial change can be consciously controlled, deliberate or habitual blinking and closure fall outside the present discussion.

We can begin with a pleasant visualization:

Walking barefoot on a warm evening beach, sunlight spreading across the sea, a scene of molten-gold sunset. Beautiful music and the sound of waves reach the ears, prompting spontaneous dancing. From not far away your dream lover approaches; hand in hand you dance together.

Do you find yourself unconsciously closing your eyes while mentally picturing this romantic scene, even the appearance of the dream lover? This eye closure is triggered by positive stimuli; you are entranced and enjoying the moment, mentally filling in details. Clearly, the primary function of such closure is to heighten a particular sensory experience. Standing among flowers and closing the eyes to inhale deeply intensifies smell; tasting fine wine or food with eyes closed intensifies taste; listening to music with eyes closed intensifies hearing. In short, eye closure under positive stimulation serves to concentrate attention. Just as you mentally reconstruct the scene above, a high degree of focused attention is required.

From the standpoint of expression, eye closure under positive stimulation conveys relaxation and pleasure. The corners of the mouth lift slightly, the brows remain relatively level, and changes are minimal.

In addition to positive stimuli, many negative stimuli also cause us to close our eyes—for example, witnessing a bloody surgical procedure, a frightening scene in a horror film, coercion, grief-driven avoidance, something repulsive, or the helplessness of disappointment.

Under negative stimulation, eye closure serves to block unpleasant visual information and is often an unconscious reaction. When sudden negative stimuli arrive, the eyes close instinctively to protect the self before conscious thought can intervene.

From the standpoint of expression, eye closure under negative stimulation conveys discomfort and aversion. The chin shows uneven folds, the mouth corners turn downward, the brows furrow, and transverse wrinkles appear across the bridge of the nose. Multiple muscles—the frontalis, corrugator supercilii, orbicularis oculi, depressor labii inferioris, and orbicularis oris—are involved, making the movement difficult to fake.

Like eye closure, blinking can also be voluntarily controlled, yet rapid blinking belongs to instinctive closure. This commonly occurs when people encounter a thorny problem. We have all experienced situations in which an interviewer asks about a subject we are not good at. You may not notice it, but if recorded, you would see that within four seconds of facing the difficult question you blink several times. This results from simultaneously trying, by instinct, to close the eyes and escape the problem while striving to keep them open and solve it.

The “problem” here is not a mathematical or logical calculation; it refers to the need to decide what to do next, how to resolve the issue quickly, or what to say. When facing the former type of problem we usually furrow our brows; when facing the latter we blink rapidly. At the same time the direction of gaze also shifts.

### **People Whose Eyes Habitually Turn Rightward Are Impatient and Irritable**

During conversation the eyes often move in different directions. Therefore, simply noticing which way a person’s eyes turn while thinking can reveal aspects of that person’s character without either party realizing it.

The “prisoner-abuse scandal” prompted outside scrutiny of U.S. prison management. The authorities assigned the FBI to investigate; the warden named Bert received the most accusations from inmates, so agents decided to interview him. The interview took place in Bert’s office.

The office was simply yet elegantly furnished, indicating that its occupant was a highly cultivated person. When the agents met Bert they found it hard to connect him with the inmates’ description of a “prison demon.” Bert’s attire, background, speech, and manner toward the agents all conveyed courtesy. Once everyone was seated the interview began.

Throughout the agents’ pointed questioning Bert maintained a mild demeanor and gave reasoned answers, reinforcing the agents’ belief that he bore no resemblance to the “irascible and brutal” figure described by the inmates. During the entire interview the only notable behavior was that Bert’s eyes repeatedly turned rightward when he answered questions; otherwise everything appeared smooth. Precisely because of this eye-turning habit, one astute senior agent began to doubt Bert’s true character.

Earlier, professors at Stanford University had conducted specialized research on the relationship between eye movement and personality. They invited several men and, for thirty seconds, continuously asked them various questions while recording the direction of eye movement. The subjects were then divided into two groups: Group A consisted of those whose eyes turned left while answering; Group B consisted of those whose eyes turned right while answering.

Analysis of the two groups’ personalities revealed that members of Group B were more impatient and aggressive; they found it difficult to suppress feelings of restlessness for long or to conceal them completely and would eventually seek an outlet. Members of Group A displayed the opposite traits; they tended to internalize displeasure and did not exhibit aggression.

From the eye-movement evidence the agents concluded that Warden Bert was in fact an irascible person whose mild façade was a disguise. In a second interview they deliberately provoked him with rude language,

exploiting his character weakness to elicit the truth. Bert fell into the trap and revealed his irritable, violent nature.

People who are easily angered are usually poor at managing interpersonal relationships. Because such a temperament is not formed overnight, changing it is no easy task. Consequently, when interacting with others, if you notice that a person habitually turns the eyes rightward, you can infer that the individual is highly aggressive and difficult to handle. Only by making full use of this trait during conversation can you better accomplish your objective.

### **People Whose Eyes Habitually Turn Rightward Are Aggressive**

During conversation the eyes often move in different directions. Therefore, simply noticing which way a person's eyes turn while thinking can reveal aspects of that person's character without either party realizing it.

The "prisoner-abuse scandal" prompted outside scrutiny of U.S. prison management. The authorities assigned the FBI to investigate; the warden named Bert received the most accusations from inmates, so agents decided to interview him. The interview took place in Bert's office.

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## Reading Emotion from the Eyes

Modern cosmetic techniques can alter the eye socket, canthi, eye corners, eyelids, and even eyelashes, yet they cannot change a person's gaze. No matter how advanced the techniques, makeup or surgery cannot mask the eyes. Therefore, rather than listening to eloquent speech, observe the eyes carefully.

On television we often see gamblers wear sunglasses while placing bets to shield their gaze and prevent opponents from reading their emotions. This demonstrates the close relationship between changes in the eyes and psychological activity.

In today's society we inevitably encounter all kinds of people. To interact more effectively, one must be able to read emotion through another person's eyes. Most people believe that only the eyes do not lie; if you wish to glimpse someone's inner world, begin with the eyes.

What emotional changes, then, can be discerned from a person's eyes?

### 1. Eyes bright, slightly sinister

If the other person's eyes are bright and slightly sinister, it indicates distrust. During an argument, if one party displays this look, hostility is present. When a friend or colleague misunderstands you and you attempt to explain, the other person will often show this expression.

### 2. Lifeless eyes

Some believe that lifeless eyes appear only when a person harbors no dissatisfaction. This view is mistaken. For example, when you run into a former girlfriend and say, "I happened to be passing by and didn't expect to see you—would you like to have coffee?" if she merely smiles briefly on her face and quickly returns to a lifeless gaze, it usually signals inner unease and dissatisfaction with the present situation.

### 3. Focused gaze

If the other person's eyes remain focused while you speak, it means he or she is listening attentively. This can be interpreted in two ways: either the topic genuinely interests the listener, who is happy to hear you talk; or the listener finds your words of little use yet maintains politeness and respect by not interrupting rudely.

### 4. Shifting gaze

A shifting gaze is often a sign of inner unease. A special group merits attention here: individuals medically termed "gaze-phobia patients." After their eyes meet another person's, they immediately look away and then glance about involuntarily, feeling extremely uncomfortable.

### 5. Upward or downward gaze

An upward gaze signals respect and admiration; conversely, a downward gaze indicates an intention to preserve one's dignity or a slight sense of emptiness.

### 6. Sharp, stern gaze

A sharp, stern gaze usually constitutes a warning not to cross the person's 底线.

## (1) Absence of [I want to tell you]

The true psychological state is [I do not want to tell you]. Because the speaker does not wish to continue yet is compelled by the situation to say something, gaze aversion occurs and eye contact is broken.

Several behaviors may accompany the gaze shift:

- The speaker tells the truth but treats the act of speaking as a mere task, unconcerned whether the listener actually hears it.
- The underlying reluctance produces hesitant speech (pauses, stuttering, repetition, etc.) together with reduced volume and tone.
- Certain information is deliberately withheld.
- Fabricated information is supplied merely to manage the immediate conversational context.

### Specific Cases

**Case One:** As a doctor, when a patient is gravely ill you are reluctant to deliver the bad news to the family for fear of causing distress, yet you must do so. At that moment you actively avoid eye contact, unable to bear watching the family's reaction. Your inner wish at that instant is essentially "I hope you didn't hear it, I hope you don't know." This subjective desire carries a strong emotional component; sentimentally you do not want the other party to suffer negative impact. Nevertheless, rational consideration leads you to deliver the message.

Imagine, by contrast, that examination confirms the patient has recovered. When you report the good news to the family, you will look the listener in the eye, eager to witness the relieved, positive reaction.

**Case Two:** As a subordinate, after mishandling a project you dread reporting the failure to your boss for fear of an outburst and subsequent repercussions, yet you cannot conceal or avoid the truth. Again you will actively avoid eye contact, afraid to see the boss's reaction. Your inner wish at that instant is likewise "I don't want to say it; I hope you don't hear it, I hope you don't know."

Conversely, after extraordinary effort the project succeeds. When you report to the boss you will look him or her in the eye with enthusiasm, anticipating affirmation and encouragement in return.

**Case Three:** When a girl feels shy she often cannot look the other person in the eye and her voice becomes soft, almost inaudible. Rationally she wants the other person to hear her sincere confession, yet shyness creates an additional subconscious wish: "As a girl, how can I take the initiative to say something like 'I like you'?" Social etiquette has taught her true inner awareness: she does not want to say it, she does not want to say it.

However, if the girl truly cares about the other person and faces a potential emotional threat from a third party, she will look the young man sincerely in the eye (anger, too, is sincere) and express her affection.

### Section 1 The Eyes of the Mind

Confucius once said: Observe a person's pupils, and nothing can be hidden! The meaning is that to understand someone, begin by looking into their eyes. As the saying goes, the eyes are the windows to the soul. Even a fleeting glance can reveal a surprising amount of information, express rich emotions, and even betray the deepest "secrets" of the heart. People are accustomed to using the eyes to explore and understand others. Upon first meeting, they typically look at the other person's eyes before anything else.

In general, the first impression of a person comes largely from the information conveyed by the eyes. Eye contact can be said to be the primary element shaping that impression. Throughout history, countless descriptions of the eyes have allowed observers to gather extensive information. To a certain extent, a person's eyes reflect their inner world. Depicting the eyes is therefore equivalent to describing someone's



inner landscape. This is evident in traditional Chinese opera face painting: positive characters are shown with thick eyebrows and large eyes or refined features, while villains appear with shifty or triangular eyes that look repulsive. Ancient people already knew how to read expressions and judge character by observing the eyes. Some individuals wear sunglasses even indoors or in shade and refuse to remove them, because they do not want others to discover their secrets through their eyes.

When we say the eyes can speak, we usually mean that eye movements convey a great deal of information. Level gaze, direct gaze, side glance, upward glance... each can reflect the relationship between people. When encountering someone they like, the eyes light up with special brilliance. An arrogant person's eyes often dart about unconsciously. Someone with something to hide dares not meet another's gaze. An upright and innocent person's eyes are calm and convey sincere strength. Lovers' glances carry a sweet quality... The rotation of the eyeballs, the opening and closing of the eyelids, the speed and direction of gaze shifts, and the coordination between eyes and head movements produce a complex and subtle language of the eyes that continuously transmits and exchanges information. Within these small eyes lies a vast world. So what specific information can human eyes convey, and how can we understand others? The most direct and effective method is to learn the meanings most people's eye movements typically express, so that "your eyes betray you."

## Winking

Winking means using one eye to signal the other person. It indicates a tacit understanding between the two: "This matter stays between us." If a third party is present, the wink can make that person feel excluded or isolated. When such an exchange occurs between two strangers, it shows they share the same view on something and signals strong mutual recognition.

People generally believe eye details reflect inner states:

1. Eyes sparkling indicate abundant energy and strong interest in the conversation.
2. Dull, lifeless eyes suggest a person lacking drive or confidence who finds everything uninteresting.
3. Shifting, unsteady gaze indicates indecision, distraction, or a state of tension and unease.
4. Eyes that brighten and dim suggest a calculating mind; during conversation, they show the person has grown impatient and wants the talk to end soon.
5. Bright, piercing eyes indicate integrity, courage, decisiveness, and trustworthiness.
6. Initiating eye contact shows an open heart and a straightforward character.
7. Avoiding or evading another's gaze indicates inner tension, insincerity, or something being concealed.
8. Calm, steady eyes reflect inner composure and clear judgment.
9. Sharp, penetrating eyes indicate ambition, competitiveness, hidden aggression, and outward boldness—a person of courage and insight.
10. Restless, wandering eyes usually belong to deceitful individuals who should be avoided.
11. Clear, limpid eyes indicate simplicity, openness, and broad-mindedness—a person worth knowing.
12. Muddy, dim eyes suggest a crude, foolish, petty, or vulgar character.
13. Half-closed eyes, as if half-asleep, represent a calculating expression that reveals deep scheming, a preference for clever maneuvers, and fear of others seeing the true inner self.

In interpersonal interactions, therefore, we must understand not only spoken words but also the "language" of the eyes if we wish to maintain an active and advantageous position.

## Chapter Summary

Different eyebrow shapes can express different mental states. Slight movements of the eyeballs produce subtle changes in gaze. These changes occur under explicit instructions from the nervous system, whether the action is deliberate or involuntary, and can therefore map to certain psychological states.

This chapter attempts to summarize the meanings behind subtle changes in eyebrows and eyes, but it is offered only as a reference direction for analysis rather than a set of rigid rules.

The main conclusions are as follows:

- Five micro-expression forms of the eyebrows and their meanings: neutral; lowered to show attention; raised to show confidence or rapport; “8:20” shape to show sadness; “10:10” shape to show anger.
- Mutual gaze expresses three elements: speak properly, listen properly, and show that one is listening properly. Interruption of mutual gaze therefore signals the absence of one of these factors.
- Pupil changes cannot be consciously controlled and directly map subjective likes and dislikes. Pupils dilate under positive emotions and constrict under negative emotions.
- Eyelid closure and widening can be voluntarily controlled. When stimulation is effective, however, many such movements are instinctive reactions beyond conscious control and can map inner changes. In general, widening indicates a desire to receive more information and commonly appears in surprise, anger, or fear; closure indicates refusal to receive more information and commonly appears in sadness or disgust.
- Two exceptions should be noted: first, during laughter the eyes close for physiological reasons; second, when concentration is required (whether handling negative stimuli or enjoying positive ones), the eyes may close to conserve neural energy and improve information-processing efficiency.
- Eyeball rotation can be controlled; different directions correspond to different inner states. Upward rotation often signals complacency, avoidance, or innocence; downward rotation indicates bearing pressure; leftward or rightward rotation requires comparison against an individual’s baseline and cannot be interpreted uniformly.

### **Test Case: The Elegant Woman Who Lied**

We have tested many individuals whose gaze-shift baselines differ. Currently, the most common indicator of deception is movement that violates the personal baseline.

One test subject was a very elegant woman who answered questions calmly throughout the session. Later analysis confirmed that most of her statements were truthful. When faced with stressful questions (those requiring choice or recall), her habitual baseline was to shift her gaze to the right. Whether the task involved complex calculations (left-brain), visual-spatial puzzles (right-brain), or recounting how she had accumulated wealth through shrewd investments, her gaze moved right whenever she needed to formulate an appropriate response.

Only one question elicited a lie.

When asked whether she strongly disliked a particular female friend, her eyes rapidly shifted left by approximately three-quarters of an iris diameter, after which she calmly denied any dislike. No other obvious indicators appeared.

Because this gaze shift deviated from her baseline, we added two follow-up tests.

- Image test: We prepared ten images, including neutral landscapes (cell towers, normal traffic aerial views, regional maps), a positive stimulus (a photograph of a male singer she liked), graphic autopsy

images of real corpses, and a photograph of the female friend. Her pupils dilated when she saw the singer's photo. After neutral images, the sudden appearance of the friend's photo caused her pupils to constrict.

- We then asked her to describe and evaluate a specific incident involving the friend. During the description and evaluation, a micro-expression of contempt (a derivative of disgust) appeared on her face.

These two results indicated that she harbored feelings of disgust toward the person. Consequently, the cognitive pressure of denying that disgust produced the anomalous gaze shift. It could be confirmed that she had lied on this question.

## How to Tell Who Likes You

Once you read the following, you will know how to determine whether someone likes you.

- **Cannot meet your eyes:** Their gaze avoids yours. When your eyes happen to meet, they become flustered and blush, looking embarrassed. When you look at them, they look away or lower their head. While together they keep watching you, but the moment you turn to look at them they shift their gaze; when you look elsewhere again they resume watching. If you turn back, they smile and look away once more.
- **Nervously explains to you:** When you speak with someone of the opposite sex, they stare at that person. If they are seen speaking with someone of the opposite sex, they become nervous and offer explanations to you.
- **Creates opportunities to meet:** They find excuses to give you something or borrow something from you simply to arrange a meeting.
- **You are the constant topic:** When chatting with others, they repeatedly bring you up and always want to see your reaction to any event.
- **Concerned about everything about you:** They feel sad when you cry and care deeply about all aspects of your life. They think of many ways to show concern yet hesitate to act; if you face difficulties, they become more anxious than you are.
- **Shows off in front of you:** They seize chances to display humor, talent, capability, or depth in your presence, listen to music you like, and wear clothes in colors you prefer.
- **Appears awkward in your presence:** They never initiate conversation and sometimes blush. When they see you, their speech becomes disjointed. Passing you, they pretend not to notice. When alone together they feel embarrassed and unconsciously fidget with objects or jewelry.

## Pupils Reveal Your Most Authentic Feelings

Scientists have found that pupils do not "lie." They are sensitive indicators of vital functions, extensions of the brain, and markers of central-nervous-system activity; they most truthfully reflect a person's inner feelings.

Pupils respond to interest with astonishing sensitivity. At a national conference of the American Society of Medical Hypnosis, Dr. Edward Hess presented clinical findings: "When the eyes encounter something sufficiently pleasurable or stimulating, the pupils dilate rapidly and unconsciously." (See Figure 1.1)

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.1 瞳孔扩大的眼睛]

People have long known how to read inner states through changes in pupil size. Ancient Persian jewel merchants, for example, reportedly set prices according to how much a customer's pupils dilated when

viewing jewelry. If a diamond's brilliance caused dilation, the merchant would quote a higher price.

During courtship the eyes are the most effective organ for transmitting emotion. When a man encounters a woman he admires, his pupils involuntarily dilate under the strong stimulus of desire; the woman intuitively reads the signal. Especially in dim light, the pupils dilate quickly, increasing mutual attraction and fostering romantic connection.

Pupils also dilate under terror, tension, excitement, anger, or pain, while they constrict to a pinpoint—"laser-like gaze"—under disgust, fatigue, or annoyance (see Figure 1.2). If the pupils show no change, the person feels indifferent or bored.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1.2 瞳孔缩小的眼睛]*

## 1. Pupil Contact in Nonverbal Communication

When two people look into each other's pupils, they instinctively feel they should say something or listen to the other; this situation is discussed in detail in the next section.

Summarizing participants' subjective reports from the latter part of the experiments, we found that during prolonged mutual gaze without speech, both parties attempt to use eye contact to discern the other's inner meaning. If the gaze continues even longer, they can no longer extract useful information; although their eyes remain fixed on the other's pupils, their minds have already wandered.

When a stranger on the street stares directly into your eyes (and you simultaneously notice you are looking into theirs—this is pupil contact), one of the two usually breaks the gaze to avoid further interaction. If no conversation or directions are needed, continued pupil contact makes both parties feel awkward: "Why is this person looking at me?" If the other person is irritable, in a bad mood, or a street tough who feels challenged, the mutual scrutiny may be interpreted as provocation and lead to unnecessary physical conflict. The most common line in such situations is "What are you looking at?!"

Without anything to express, a few seconds of pupil contact cause loss of thinking ability and entry into a state of forced mental numbness. Staring at a single static object without receiving new information produces the same blankness as gazing at anything for too long; the mind has already drifted elsewhere.

Long-term evolution has tuned the human visual system and brain to prioritize dynamic information, because movement in the environment affects survival (predators) and reproduction (where one's partner is). After a period, the brain therefore ignores static, unchanging sources of information.

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conversation or directions are needed, continued pupil contact makes both parties feel awkward: “Why is this person looking at me?” If the other person is irritable, in a bad mood, or a street tough who feels challenged, the mutual scrutiny may be interpreted as provocation and lead to unnecessary physical conflict. The most common line in such situations is “What are you looking at?!”

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This occurs because long-term evolution has tuned the human visual system and brain to prioritize dynamic information, because movement in the environment affects survival (predators) and reproduction (where one’s partner is). After a period, the brain therefore ignores static, unchanging sources of information.

### **Eyes That Can “Speak”**

Although the eyes are a small organ, they are the most acute of the five senses, accounting for nearly 70 percent of sensory input and playing a major role. They not only display emotion but also reveal the code of a person’s mood.

Mencius said: “Nothing is better for observing a person than the pupils. The pupils cannot conceal inner ugliness. If the heart is upright, the pupils are clear; if the heart is not upright, the pupils are clouded. Listen to a person’s words and observe the pupils—how can that person’s true nature be hidden?” In other words, nothing surpasses the eyes for judging character. The eyes cannot mask inner flaws. An upright heart produces clear, bright pupils; a crooked heart produces dull, clouded pupils. By listening to speech and watching the eyes, one can determine whether a person is good or bad.

The eyes are the windows of the soul; they convey our emotions. It is no exaggeration to say that eye expressions are the most complex, subtle, and expressive component of facial expression. Almost never looking at the other person’s eyes while listening is an attempt to conceal the truth.

Customs officers, for example, often ask an extra question while examining a completed declaration form: “Is there anything else to declare?” At that moment their eyes are fixed not on the form but on the traveler’s eyes. If the traveler cannot meet the officer’s gaze steadily, it usually indicates something to hide.

Physiologically, the eyes are the brain’s extension into the eye sockets. The speed and direction of eyeball movement, changes in pupil size, and the opening and closing of the eyelids—all directly governed by cranial nerves—together with the coordination of eyes and head movements, allow the eyes to reflect a person’s emotions naturally.

What emotions, then, do the various changes in the eyes express?

### **The Key to Interpersonal Interaction Lies in Eye Contact**

From childhood, teachers have taught us to look at others when speaking; this is the most basic social courtesy. If someone does not look at us during a conversation, it indicates either that they are not listening or that they are hiding something. Therefore, whenever and wherever we interact with anyone, we must look into the other person’s eyes. Mutual eye contact conveys respect, appreciation, and a deeper spiritual connection, yet the duration of that contact must be carefully managed.

In the book *The Psychology of Interpersonal Behaviour*, author Michael Argyle notes that people typically spend 30–60 percent of their total interaction time gazing at each other. When mutual gaze exceeds 60 percent, the individuals are likely either mutually attracted or preparing to fight. Determining which outcome will occur requires close observation of their subsequent behaviors.

An extroverted person generally has no difficulty with eye contact, whereas a shy person may engage in far less. Conversely, when a normally shy individual suddenly maintains unusually prolonged eye contact, it often signals that they are either acting or lying. One should never overlook this basic principle.

When observing someone who is staring or gazing, pay attention to whether their eyes are focused or appear vacant. Focused eyes indicate active thinking or analysis of the object in view. Vacant eyes, by contrast, suggest the person is daydreaming and unaware of the object before them.

## **(2) Incomplete Closure**

The orbicularis oculi muscle contracts, moving the upper and lower eyelids toward closure without completing it; the eyes remain slightly more open than in a fully closed state. The internal state represented by incomplete eyelid closure is somewhat more complex.

### **① “Passive” Closure**

One form is “passive” partial closure, triggered by the demands of other facial expressions. Examples include the eye narrowing that accompanies hearty laughter or sorrowful crying; in both cases the emphasis lies on emotional release rather than on the exchange of visual information. During genuine laughter the pleasurable stimulus has already been fully received, so further visual input is unnecessary. During genuine crying the painful stimulus has already registered, and the priority is emotional catharsis rather than visual exchange. In these expressions the eyelids close primarily for physiological reasons.

Consider laughter. Laughing and sneezing both involve rapid, forceful exhalation. This breathing pattern raises capillary pressure in the eyes and increases intraorbital pressure; eyelid closure forms a protective barrier that prevents the sudden pressure surge from injuring the eyeball.

Crying adds the factor of tears. The lacrimal glands produce abundant tears that well up between the eyelids. To channel the tears and fulfill the eyelids’ role of moistening the cornea during blinking, the eyelids automatically perform a closing motion.

## **(3) Controlling Gaze**

In formal or serious settings, controlling gaze is common—for instance, between superiors and subordinates, teachers and students, or competing opponents. The focus rests on the triangular area at the center of the other person’s forehead, accompanied by a tense, serious atmosphere. The primary effect of this gaze is to exert psychological intimidation. Research shows that winners in sumo, boxing, and similar contests often prevail not solely through superior technique but because their gaze secures a psychological advantage. The same principle applies in negotiation: fixing one’s gaze on this region allows one to seize the initiative.

Eye contact, as a form of silent “language,” can backfire if misused. Out of responsibility to the reader, several cautions are necessary:

1. Align your line of sight with the other person. If your eyes wander across their body or fix on something else, they will sense deliberate avoidance or rudeness, and the conversation may end unpleasantly.

2. Keep the focal point on the other person's face. As noted earlier, directing gaze between the eyes and chin helps create a relaxed atmosphere.
3. Avoid prolonged staring at any single feature. Studies confirm that gaze exceeding ten seconds raises the likelihood of discomfort, especially during opposite-sex encounters.
4. Do not abruptly avert your eyes. In formal settings, quickly shifting your gaze when someone looks at you suggests evasion or concealment. Even if uninterested, withdraw your gaze calmly rather than fleeing.

## **The Psychological Mystery of Pupil-to-Pupil Eye Contact**

To explore the psychological effects of sustained pupil-to-pupil contact, we conducted a small experiment with fifty university students randomly paired into twenty-five dyads. Participants were instructed to gaze directly into each other's eyes for twenty seconds without speaking. Observers recorded reactions, and participants later described their experiences.

### **Experimental results:**

- At the instant of eye contact, both parties simultaneously sensed that the other might speak or that they themselves should say something.
- After two seconds, constrained by the no-talking rule, most felt awkward (many wanted to laugh) and began using their eyes to seek additional information in order to complete the twenty-second interval.
- After five seconds, participants felt an urge to look away; a few dyads continued exchanging nonverbal information through their eyes, accompanied by occasional laughter.
- Upon completion of the twenty seconds, every participant reported relief and expressed a strong desire both to speak and to break eye contact; suppressing both impulses proved uncomfortable.

### **Experimental conclusions:**

The experiment revealed two functions of pupil-to-pupil contact: first, to signal readiness for verbal exchange ("I have something to say + you may speak, I'm listening"); second, to gather nonverbal information when speech is unavailable.

Note that the situation discussed here is pure mutual gaze without interruption or redirection, distinct from covert signaling that uses eye movements to indicate direction.

## **Test Case: The Psychological Mystery of Pupil-to-Pupil Eye Contact**

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### **Clue Six: Half-Closed Eyes**

Half-closed eyes involve a reduced degree of eyelid opening, usually serving as an adjunct to emotion and appearing alongside other expressions such as sadness or joy, disgust or contempt. At such moments the eyes themselves are not the primary vehicle of expression; when a person is intensely happy or deeply distressed, attention focuses on the emotional stimulus rather than on visual intake or output. The partial closure is therefore a purely physiological action.

During hearty laughter, rapid air exchange increases capillary pressure in the eyes. Partial closure relieves this pressure and protects the eyes, much as the eyelids automatically close during a sneeze.

Similarly, during intense sorrow or pain, rapid breathing occurs and the eyes again rely on partial closure for self-protection. Tears provide an additional reason for closure: to channel them and maintain corneal moisture, the eyelids cooperate physiologically by narrowing.

Another context for half-closed eyes is the "come-hither" look. Extensive research shows that when people feel comfortable and pleased in another's company, their eyes narrow slightly—an evolutionary pattern in which eyes close during states of intoxication or enjoyment, so that half-closure signals comfort and pleasure.

Nearsighted individuals may also squint when viewing distant objects, but this action uses the ciliary muscle to flatten the lens for sharper focus. The ciliary muscle operates outside conscious control and activates only when the autonomic nervous system deems it necessary. Such squinting carries no expressive meaning; it is purely physiological.

### **Business Negotiation—Timing Determines Success or Failure**

In the course of our work we frequently discuss cooperation with large enterprises. A unique domestic distillery group spends hundreds of millions of yuan annually on anti-counterfeiting efforts. Our team was invited to design an online platform integrating anti-counterfeiting, evidence collection, and litigation support. When the distillery's chairman came to Beijing for an annual forum, we brought our proposal and sought a meeting. Our side's leader enjoyed a strong prior relationship with the chairman, and we hoped to finalize the project.

Throughout the conversation, however, once the discussion turned to the proposal, the chairman's gaze drifted slightly; he merely nodded and repeated "Good, good." This visual withdrawal did not stem from contempt or disrespect but from the absence of the factor "I want to listen carefully." We therefore concluded



that the timing was inappropriate: the chairman was preoccupied with forum preparations and guest reception and would not absorb the proposal's details. The meeting would not yield the desired outcome, so we ended the discussion and left materials with the responsible staff member.

We also observed that his seated posture remained tense, torso leaning forward, hands braced on his knees—the classic “escape reaction” indicating readiness to stand and leave (see the book *Micro-reaction* (微反应)). As predicted, once we finished presenting the project, the chairman restored direct eye contact, expressed polite apologies, observed all necessary courtesies, then quickly rose and began greeting other guests.

### **Application Case: Business Negotiation—Timing Determines Success or Failure**

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## **6. Rolling the Eyes**

Rolling the eyes is a common ocular expression that involves both complex eyeball movement and a complex gaze-shift sequence.

The classic eye-roll typically signals contempt. Slow-motion analysis reveals several variants:

1. When the roll begins from direct eye contact, the sequence is: eyelid closure; reopening with upward gaze (partial sclera visible); gaze then shifting laterally away from the stimulus while the head turns; continued downward lateral shift; final eyelid closure, with gaze settling sideways, level or downward, or the head returning to face the stimulus.
2. When the roll begins from a side-facing orientation, the sequence is: brief glance toward the other person (without full eye contact); upward gaze accompanied by eyelid closure; reopening while gaze returns to the original or opposite direction.
3. When a girl rolls her eyes flirtatiously at her boyfriend (not in genuine anger) while saying something like “You're annoying,” an additional step occurs: at the end the gaze returns to the boyfriend's pupils, conveying sincerity (sometimes accompanied by a coy or mock-stern smile) and checking whether the playful message has been received.

## Clue Three: Tears

Tears are an autonomic response triggered by emotional stimuli such as sadness, fear, worry, relief, or joy. Determining whether tears are genuinely prompted by the immediate emotion can be difficult. As noted earlier, the Stanislavski acting method trains performers to relive authentic emotions in order to produce the required display. One certainty remains: whether performed or spontaneous, the underlying emotion behind tears is always real.

Consider the case of an American mother who appeared daily before the media, weeping over the loss of her daughter. FBI investigators suspected she had murdered the child, yet her display of inconsolable grief seemed so convincing that few believed the accusation. In one recorded segment, however, investigators detected a fleeting expression of guilt while she cried. They concluded that her tears might stem not from grief but from remorse over the killing. Perpetrators commonly experience guilt, fear, disgust, or contempt afterward; skilled deceivers can suppress these emotions, yet genuine feelings still flash across the face—this is the power of micro-expressions. Although the case remains controversial, the investigators remained convinced of the mother's guilt.

## (2) Absence of "Please Listen Carefully"

The underlying thought is "You need not listen carefully." Whether the listener pays close attention is unimportant; feedback is irrelevant, and the speaker simply finishes speaking. In such moments the speaker's gaze also tends to drift. Linguistic features include: unemphasized volume and tone, possibly at normal levels or reduced energy; smooth, continuous, sometimes rapid delivery. In short: "This matter has nothing to do with you."

## Specific Cases

**Example 1:** This pattern frequently appears in meetings when participants know their views will be opposed yet feel compelled to state them anyway. Eye contact is avoided while the opinion is delivered; the internal stance is "I'll say my piece; your disagreement is irrelevant and I don't care about your opinion."

Conversely, when a dominant party wishes to issue a warning or compel acknowledgment, sustained direct eye contact is used to convey: "Listen carefully—this is my position. Your opinion? It doesn't matter; I won't hear it anyway. Just agree."

## Squinting

If a person squints but not because of strong light stimulation, it indicates they may be preparing to say something or expressing uncertainty. If a person squints while smiling broadly, it shows they feel extremely happy.

In addition, the eyelids are considered the area that most reflects a person's sexual desire; the shape of the eyelids can reveal a person's psychological attitude toward love.

- People with single eyelids on both eyes: Their personality is mostly introverted, solitary, sensitive, strong self-esteem, determined, hardworking and practical. Their expression of emotions is reserved and restrained; even when standing in front of someone they usually admire or like, they will try their best to remain calm and show no trace. In the company they can advance rapidly through solid professional

knowledge; in family matters they are relatively conservative, and once they have an affair, their tracks will immediately be exposed.

- People with double eyelids on both eyes: Outgoing and enthusiastic, emotionally rich; they are easily moved by others' caring gestures or inquiries about their well-being, especially from the opposite sex, and therefore often cannot resist the temptation of the opposite sex. Whether in work settings or other social gatherings, they are always the most popular. They belong to the honest and reliable type, with a happy and fulfilling family life.
- People with one single eyelid and one double eyelid: Such individuals usually do not easily reveal their true intentions; they often complain and grumble during work or interpersonal interactions. People with this eyelid type have low loyalty in love, like to pursue change or stimulation, possess a flirtatious nature, are relatively open in sexual matters, and frequently accept advances without refusal.

## Blinking Frequency

Blinking is both a spontaneous behavior and a subconscious behavior. Regardless of whether a person's eyes appear dry or moist, paying attention to their blinking frequency is very important. Always observe the blinking frequency of the person you are talking to, noting whether it is normal, too fast, or too slow. Note that what you say and do will also affect the other person's blinking frequency. When judging a person's intentions, observe their blinking frequency and consider it together with other postures.

It is well known that if a person is lying, their blinking frequency will be much higher than usual. For example, U.S. customs inspectors usually inform travelers that if they have undeclared prohibited items, they will be sent back to their country. You may think this is a very redundant procedure because travelers have already filled out declaration forms. In fact, it is not; when the inspector makes this request, they carefully observe the traveler's eyes to see whether the blinking frequency is normal. If the traveler's blinking frequency is too high, the inspector will check the traveler's luggage.

In addition, law enforcement personnel usually record a suspect's blinking frequency to help them determine whether the person is guilty. A higher blinking frequency can reflect a person's sense of guilt, while a lower blinking frequency indicates that the person is preparing to confess something. It is precisely for this reason that the suspect has no energy left to pay attention to their own eyes. This is why it is necessary to note all of a person's expressions and gestures.

## Clue Two: Pupil Dilation

The FBI once handled a murder case involving sexual harassment. After the suspect was arrested, he consistently denied having any sexual intentions toward the female victim and denied killing her because she resisted. At the time, no bodily fluids from the suspect were found in the victim's body, making it difficult to establish evidence. Later, while reviewing the suspect's interrogation video, investigators noticed a detail: whenever the suspect mentioned the female victim, his pupils would dilate. This crucial detail revealed the suspect's true thoughts. People's pupils dilate only when they see or think of something they like; the most typical example is sexual desire. Investigators seized on this detail and continued questioning until the suspect finally confessed.

The pupil is not an independent organ but a small opening in the middle of the iris. Light can only form an image on the retina by passing through the pupil. When light is too strong, the pupil constricts to protect the optic nerve from damage. When light weakens, the pupil dilates to absorb more light and see a clearer image.

The pupil is controlled by smooth muscle, which obeys only the autonomic nervous system and not conscious will. In other words, pupil dilation or constriction is entirely a genuine reaction and cannot be faked.

When people see something they like, their pupils naturally dilate to capture a clearer image. When they see something they dislike, their pupils naturally constrict to reduce the discomfort caused by negative stimuli.

### **(1) Erroneous Summary of Left-Right Brain Division of Labor**

Earlier research conclusions in cognitive psychology stated that the left brain is primarily responsible for functions such as speech, reading, writing, mathematical calculation, rote memory, logical reasoning, and symbolic thinking; the right brain is primarily responsible for image-thinking functions such as recognizing object size and shape, spatial cognition, map reading, face recognition, painting composition, music, structural assembly, and perceiving others' emotions.

More importantly, the vast majority of human work is completed through coordinated effort of both hemispheres rather than through separate responsibility. For example, memory is often said to belong to the left brain, so to whom does image memory belong? If image information is processed by the right brain, then drawing a picture from the mind must involve the addition of logical and temporal order, which is the responsibility of the left brain! Similarly, musical notes are mainly processed by the right brain, but composing and singing songs must be completed by both hemispheres simultaneously. According to the latest brain cognition research, previous conclusions about left-right brain division of labor have gradually been corrected by more experimental findings and are not as absolute as in older textbooks.

Those seeking theoretical support for fallacies made their first mistake—superficially summarizing brain cognition as “left brain responsible for memory, right brain responsible for fabrication.” Setting aside whether creation, construction, and fabrication have the same meaning, even this derivation process is absurd. Further questioning: What relationship exists between eye movement direction and the distinction of left-right brain division of labor?

## **2. Eye Contact in Verbal Communication**

If speech is possible, mutual pupil gaze becomes the start of effective communication; this is the consensus of both parties. It is called a consensus because both parties in mutual gaze can feel the meaning of the gaze and what it will trigger; it is called a beginning because mutual gaze is the initiation process for both parties to engage in “full-duplex” communication.

### **What is “full-duplex” communication?**

Here a technical term from the communications field is borrowed, meaning that at the same time, both parties in the communication can send and receive information; a simpler explanation is shown in the figure below.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-10]*

When both parties in a dialogue discuss important information that concerns them both, at least at the beginning they must be looking directly into each other's eyes. In normal verbal communication, mutual gaze expresses three meanings:

1. [Speaker] I want to speak to you;
2. [Speaker] Please listen carefully;
3. [Listener] I am listening carefully.

Because communication is bidirectional, both parties are simultaneously speaker and listener and therefore hold all three expectations at once. If any one of these expectations is missing during the dialogue, it will cause an interruption of mutual pupil gaze.

## 5. Not Looking at Someone Directly

Not looking at someone directly means looking at them sideways, except the face does not turn sideways with the eyeballs and remains facing the person being looked at. There are two reasons for discussing this deformed gaze here: first, in this gaze state the pupil is on one side rather than in the middle, resembling the appearance of left-right eye movement; second, this gaze state reflects an unwillingness to look, equally lacking “sincerity” as eye movement.

Whether hoping for sincere communication or looking up in search due to an unexpected stimulus (for example, someone calling you from the side), a head-turning movement will occur so that one's face faces the viewed object as directly as possible. Turning only the eyes without turning the head directly reflects a relatively negative mindset (equivalent to unwillingness to look). It should be specially noted that the “unwillingness” mentioned here includes not only the conventional meanings of aversion and negation but also other negative intentions such as fear (stealing a glance, afraid of being discovered) and disdain, collectively termed unwillingness.

Emotions and mindsets that may cause sideways glances mainly include:

- Smiling with pride (I am better/stronger/correcter/..... than you)
- Contempt (I am better/stronger/correcter/..... than you)
- Worry (cannot clearly express concern and anxiety toward the other)
- Disgust (directly negating the other)

## 2. The Eyeball

The eyeball is the organ through which humans obtain visual information.

Luminous light sources such as television sets and computer screens can use their own energy to project light into the eyeball, while most objects in daily life cannot emit light themselves and instead reflect other light into the eyeball; this is also the most common source of visual information we see. Regardless of the light source, the eyeball is the organ that receives light and requires light to enter in order to “see” anything. As humans possessing this organ, what we do is choose the direction we wish to pay attention to and locate the source of incoming light.

Therefore, gaze—the term we are very familiar with—is not a line emitted by our eyes but the direction we choose so that external light can accurately enter the eyeball. We actively “look,” but “seeing” is the passive entry of light; if we do not wish to see, we can either change direction or cut off light entry into the eyeball.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-8]*

The anatomical structure of the eyeball is far more complex than that of the eyelids, with many more individual components; this book will not introduce them one by one, as shown in Figure 10-8. Most of these are optical organs.

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## Summary

The various cases above confirm two points:

- First, if both parties need to conduct effective communication, they will spontaneously engage in mutual pupil gaze. We believe mutual pupil gaze is a necessary constituent condition and startup procedure for effective communication—that is, the full expression of both parties being ready with [I want to speak to you], [Please listen carefully], and [I am listening carefully].
- Second, during dialogue, when both parties subjectively harbor more complex psychological states (such as fear, guilt, shyness, displeasure, contempt, disgust, embarrassment, and other negative emotions), they actively cancel mutual gaze and shift their line of sight away from the other’s pupils. Although the content of the communication may still be serious and both parties at the rational level still hope the other can effectively express and receive information, emotion may override reason in decision-making, presupposing, defaulting to, or even hoping that the communication between the two at that instant will not be so effective, stopping mutual pupil gaze.

Therefore, working backward from this logical relationship, we arrive at a somewhat startling conjectural conclusion: stopping mutual pupil gaze (including gaze-blocking reactions and gaze-shifting reactions) must correspond to the absence of certain elements among the three. Research on gaze-blocking reactions and gaze-shifting reactions will be elaborated in 10.2.3 and 10.2.4 respectively.

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## Eyelids

In discussions of eye contact, the importance of the eyelids is usually overlooked. In reality, even a very small matter, such as how much sclera a person shows, can convey a great deal of information.

It is well known that drooping eyelids represent many meanings, so please judge accurately according to the specific scene whether a person feels tired, bored, depressed, listless, or is flirting.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.4 眼皮低垂]*

Straining to keep the eyes wide open usually indicates that a person is very interested in something. If the eyes are opened too wide, it means they may be very surprised or frightened.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.5 努力睁大双眼]*

If a person squints but not because of strong light stimulation, it indicates they may be preparing to say something or expressing uncertainty. If a person squints while smiling broadly, it shows they feel extremely happy.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.6 斜视]*

## Blinking Frequency Reveals Lies

Blinking is both a spontaneous behavior and a subconscious behavior. Regardless of whether a person's eyes appear dry or moist, paying attention to their blinking frequency is very important. Always observe the blinking frequency of the person you are talking to, noting whether it is normal, too fast, or too slow. Note that what you say and do will also affect the other person's blinking frequency. When judging a person's intentions, observe their blinking frequency and consider it together with other postures.

It is well known that if a person is lying, their blinking frequency will be much higher than usual. For example, U.S. customs inspectors usually inform travelers that if they have undeclared prohibited items, they will be sent back to their country. You may think this is a very foolish procedure because travelers have already filled out declaration forms. In fact, it is not; when the inspector makes this request, they carefully observe the traveler's eyes to see whether the blinking frequency is normal. If the traveler's blinking frequency is too high, the inspector will check the traveler's luggage.

FBI agents usually also record a suspect's blinking frequency to help them determine whether the person is guilty. A higher blinking frequency can reflect a person's sense of guilt, while a lower blinking frequency indicates that the person is preparing to confess something.

## ② Iris

The iris controls the amount of light admitted. People generally believe the pupil controls the amount of light admitted; both statements are correct, because the iris and the pupil are essentially the same thing.

The iris is ring-shaped, and its central part is the pupil; that is, the pupil really is a hole! The iris is composed of multi-unit smooth muscle. The portion near the center (that is, the edge of the pupil) is the circular muscle layer, innervated by parasympathetic fibers of the oculomotor nerve (the parasympathetic nerves are not controlled by thought); when it contracts, the pupil constricts, hence it is also called the sphincter pupillae. The peripheral portion of the iris consists of radiating muscle fibers, innervated by sympathetic fibers ascending from the neck (the sympathetic nerves are also not controlled by thought); when it contracts, the pupil dilates, hence it is also called the dilator pupillae.

Special attention should be paid to the fact that the sympathetic and parasympathetic nerves together are called the autonomic nervous system and cannot be controlled by "thinking." Smooth muscle also exists in internal organs such as the stomach, intestines, and bladder; humans likewise cannot control the movement of these internal organs by "thinking." These are "involuntary movements." Therefore, if you find the preceding knowledge too complex, simply remember one sentence: iris movement cannot be commanded by "thinking" and can genuinely reflect the psychological state of the person involved.

## ② Iris

The iris controls the amount of light that enters. It is commonly believed that the pupil controls the amount of light entering, which is correct; both statements are true because the iris and the pupil are essentially the same thing.

The iris is ring-shaped, with the pupil at its center, meaning the pupil is truly a hole! The iris is composed of multiple units of smooth muscle. The part near the center (the edge of the pupil) is the circular muscle layer, innervated by parasympathetic nerve fibers in the oculomotor nerve (parasympathetic nerves are not under voluntary control). When it contracts, it constricts the pupil, hence also called the sphincter pupillae. The peripheral part of the iris consists of radiating muscle fibers, innervated by sympathetic nerve fibers ascending from the neck (sympathetic nerves are also not under voluntary control). When they contract, they dilate the pupil, hence also called the dilator pupillae.

Special attention: The sympathetic and parasympathetic nerves together are called the autonomic nervous system and cannot be controlled by "thinking." Smooth muscle also exists in internal organs like the stomach, intestines, and bladder, which humans similarly cannot control through "thinking." These are "involuntary movements." So, if the previous knowledge seems too complex, just remember this: The movement of the iris cannot be commanded by "thinking" and can truly reflect the psychological state of the person involved.

## 3. Rotation of the Eyeball

Rotation of the eyeball maximizes the visual field while also controlling the direction of gaze. Unlike control of pupil dilation and constriction, eyeball movement is governed by six muscles known as the extraocular muscles. These muscles attach to the exterior of the eyeball; each eye has six: the medial rectus, lateral rectus,



superior rectus, inferior rectus, superior oblique, and inferior oblique. All six extraocular muscles are skeletal muscles and can be controlled by conscious intent. Therefore, under conditions of clear consciousness, the direction of eye movement is always "intentional." This point is important!

Each movement of the eyeball results from coordinated action among the muscles, and the movements of both eyes are normally coordinated. Abnormal insertion points of the extraocular muscles, underdevelopment of a muscle, or paralysis of the nerve supplying a muscle can produce strabismus and other disorders.

This establishes a very important fact, one of great significance for micro-expression research: why the eyes look straight at another person or why they shift away can both be confirmed as results of conscious control—though not solely of cognitive consciousness. So why do you shift your gaze direction during a conversation?

What we seek to explore is precisely this "why."

### 3. Rotation of the Eyeball

Rotation of the eyeball maximizes the visual field while also controlling the direction of gaze. Unlike control of pupil dilation and constriction, eyeball movement is governed by six muscles known as the extraocular muscles. These muscles attach to the exterior of the eyeball; each eye has six: the medial rectus, lateral rectus, superior rectus, inferior rectus, superior oblique, and inferior oblique. All six extraocular muscles are skeletal muscles and can be controlled by conscious intent. Therefore, under conditions of clear consciousness, the direction of eye movement is always "intentional." This point is important!

Each movement of the eyeball results from coordinated action among the muscles, and the movements of both eyes are normally coordinated. Abnormal insertion points of the extraocular muscles, underdevelopment of a muscle, or paralysis of the nerve supplying a muscle can produce strabismus and other disorders.

This establishes a very important fact, one of great significance for micro-expression research: why the eyes look straight at another person or why they shift away can both be confirmed as results of conscious control—though not solely of cognitive consciousness. So why do you shift your gaze direction during a conversation?

What we seek to explore is precisely this "why."

### 2. Changes in the Pupil

As previously noted, the pupil is an opening in the center of the iris rather than an independent organ. The pupil permits light to enter the eyeball and form an image on the retina. When light intensifies, the pupil constricts to prevent excessive stimulation of the optic nerve; when light dims, the pupil dilates to admit as much light as possible for a clearer image. All these actions are performed by the smooth muscle that controls the iris. Smooth muscle is governed solely by the autonomic nervous system; no amount of effort allows direct control through cognitive commands. See Figure 10-15.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-15]*

Interestingly, as evolution progressed, human pupillary responses became more complex and sophisticated. Experiments show that when people see something they like, their pupils dilate (for example, when a man sees an attractive woman or a gambler sees a strong hand), ensuring they take in more of the pleasing sight; when they see something they dislike, the pupils constrict (for example, during a graphic surgical dissection), minimizing exposure to negative stimuli. This is the pattern of the pupil's stress response.

## How to Use Eye Contact to Elicit the Truth

So how, in different settings and circumstances, should one employ eye contact to put the other person at ease and thereby gather more truthful information?

During a two-person exchange, sustained eye contact is generally positive, yet staring fixedly can make the other person uncomfortable and eager to end the conversation. To avoid this awkwardness, one may interrupt eye contact every five seconds. Remember not to look downward, as that signals the end of the talk. Instead, try looking upward or to the side, as though thinking.

In an argument, the power of eye contact should not be underestimated if one wishes to maintain an advantageous position. Used well, it can compel the other person to yield even without words; used poorly, one has already lost half the battle. Maintain steady eye contact with a firm gaze. Continue watching while the other speaks, observing tone and expression through that contact. Silence combined with steady gaze is the most effective way to prevail without speaking.

## Remember to Glance at the Other Person One More Time

When two people look at each other, they immediately sense an internal conflict: they want eye contact yet also want to avoid it. This back-and-forth has evolved into a complex set of human gaze-shift patterns.

—Desmond Morris

We use reason to govern every bodily movement, striving to keep them proper, yet our eyes can betray inner secrets. Others watch our eyes like keen hounds, treating us as quarry. For example, the sole reason President Bush decided to attack Iraq was that FBI experts detected panic in Saddam's eyes. For FBI agents, every interview can yield a breakthrough by reading an inadvertent glance.

In human interaction, the foundation of mutual trust is largely built through eye contact. If someone looks away while speaking with you, will you still believe what they say? If their blink rate rises noticeably above normal during conversation, will you still believe they are innocent?

### a. Positive Expressive Half-Closure—Eyes Like Silk

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-13]*

Eyes like silk is a woman's way of conveying charm. See Figure 10-13. The word "silk" itself indicates that eyelid closure is nearly complete. Still, professional rigor requires us to dissect this appealing state and examine the underlying psychological reality.

The origin of eyes like silk is actually a variation of the "focused enjoyment" discussed earlier. The evolutionary process runs roughly as follows: focused enjoyment requires closing the eyes (already examined); over time this natural physiological response became a shared understanding that a closed-eye expression signals enjoyment; therefore people consciously half-close their eyes to display a pleasing expression that communicates "I am enjoying this (being with you) right now."

Thus, when applying makeup to appear alluring, draw the eyeliner finer and longer. To project a spirited look, avoid this style entirely; instead increase the distance between brow and eye so the eyelids appear more open.

## Special Note

This conclusion applies only within rigorous psychological testing, where it may assist in judging the mental state of a subject while speaking, and must be combined with other factors for comprehensive analysis before any conclusion is drawn. The most critical step in every analysis is to determine the cause—that is, what stimulus prompted the eyeball movement or gaze shift.

If, after reading this section, you feel greatly inspired and proceed to apply this logic in isolation: the moment you observe the cessation of pupil-to-pupil contact, you immediately conclude the other person lacks sincerity in communicating and declare, "So your eyes moved away—you dare not tell me the truth (or you dare not listen properly)!" Such an approach is overly harsh and may produce erroneous conclusions and unnecessary trouble.

Therefore, if your purpose is simply normal daily life, never memorize these research conclusions by rote. Life should be enjoyed lightly; there is no need to haggle over every detail. Moreover, our research has already reached the level of "nitpicking." Such minute observations are useful only for uncovering the truth behind complex puzzles. Do not misuse them. Remember this well.

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### **3. The Eyes Light Up**

Usually, when a person is happy—especially pleasantly surprised—the phenomenon of "eyes lighting up" occurs. The cause is not an illusion; the eyes genuinely become "brighter."

In moments of pleasant surprise the eyes widen, exposing a larger area of both the iris and the sclera (the white of the eye). On one hand, the overall reflective surface increases; on the other, the pupil dilation caused by positive stimuli, together with the pigmented iris, heightens the contrast between the dark region and the light sclera, making the eyes appear brighter. In addition, the increased blood circulation from excitement supplies the eyes with more energy, further contributing to the brightening effect.

Conversely, most sorrowful eyes (assuming no acute grief or indignation) appear dull simply because the above process is reversed: the exposed area of the eyeball decreases due to eyelid closure, contrast between light and dark regions weakens, and the absence of excitement-induced microcirculatory changes naturally produces a vacant look.

## 10.2.2 Pupil-to-Pupil Contact

"Pupil-to-pupil contact" is an unusual phrase; ordinary people would not use it, yet micro-expressions must be examined at this level of detail to be valuable.

Pupil-to-pupil contact means two people are looking into each other's eyes—not merely gazing in the general direction, but precisely fixating on each other's pupils.

Gaze direction is extremely precise, and human detection of gaze information is likewise highly accurate. Experiments show that if your gaze shifts even slightly away from the other person's pupil, they will perceive that you have looked away. Sometimes, even within a 180-degree arc in front of you, you can sense whether someone is watching you or has shifted their gaze. See Figure 10-9.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-9]*

Of course,

certain works of art describe people sensing a gaze from behind; such perceptions are usually based on multiple auxiliary cues rather than any genuine physiological reception of attention.

## 2. Downward Gaze Shift

In contrast to an upward gaze shift, a downward shift generally indicates that the person had already anticipated several possibilities in mind, one of which has now materialized in the situation at hand. We may broadly summarize a downward gaze shift as conveying a mindset of "endurance." Such shifts usually reflect relatively negative states, such as guilt (feeling one is not good enough, has made a mistake, or bears responsibility), disagreement (yet feeling powerless to change the situation), anger (yet suppressing it for the moment), or anxious thinking (searching for a way to respond to doubt). Unlike the escape impulse signaled by an upward shift, a downward shift typically shows that the person knows they cannot flee and must simply endure until the moment passes or they are defeated.

Even the downward gaze that appears in shyness carries the same psychological meaning. Shyness is actually fear of seeing the other person's reaction and learning of their disapproval (dislike), yet a strong desire for a positive outcome remains, so the person endures the pressure and persists.

## 10.2.4 Gaze Shifts

After eye contact, a shift in gaze may indicate subtle psychological changes; the underlying reasons have already been analyzed. We now examine, one by one, the possible meanings of gaze shifts in different directions.

Before proceeding with this line of analysis, however, it is necessary to pour cold water on any would-be mind readers: determining the meaning of any individual's gaze shift requires first firmly recognizing that gaze shifts are highly individualized. Different people, through long-term environmental adaptation and learning, may develop distinct gaze-shift habits. Establishing a subject's baseline gaze-shift habits (called the baseline in psychological testing) is therefore the correct first step. Never mechanically apply the interpretations below.

Starting from pupil-to-pupil contact, gaze shifts occur in four basic directions: up, down, left, right, with combined variations then arising: upper-left, lower-left, upper-right, lower-right. Left and right, up and down, are all defined from the actor's perspective.

## Pupil Dilation or Constriction

Pupil dilation or constriction is a physiological response beyond personal control. When one is in close proximity to another person, the process of dilation or constriction can be observed very clearly—especially in individuals with green, blue, or hazel eyes.

Of course, this physiological response normally occurs in reaction to light. The dimmer the light, the more the pupil dilates, and vice versa. Yet emotional changes can also cause pupil dilation or constriction. When a person is attracted to someone or something, the pupils dilate. When a person is very angry or indecisive, a "laser-like" gaze appears.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.2 瞳孔放大的眼睛]*

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.3 瞳孔收缩的眼睛]*

## Psychology Mini-Lesson

Humans possess an innate talent for reading eyes, evident from infancy. A newborn can, within two to five days, judge whether another's gaze is directed at them. By four months they can distinguish between shifting and steady gaze. By nine to eighteen months they can interpret the deeper meanings conveyed by the eyes.

It is said that experienced police officers, amid a crowd, can identify a pickpocket who has not yet acted simply by reading the eyes. A pickpocket's gaze differs markedly from that of ordinary people. Regardless of circumstances, pickpockets continually watch pockets and handbags. Inside a store they neither shop nor examine merchandise; instead they watch where customers place their wallets while paying. Before acting they often look around to see whether anyone—especially police—is watching them. While committing the act they tend to hold their breath, appear tense, and stare blankly. Experienced officers can detect them through observation of the eyes.

## Eye Contact in Daily Life

In daily life, people's contact and communication always involve each other's eyes. For example, eyes always let us see those we are close to or fond of, while we ignore or refuse a second glance at those we dislike; when we see the key point of something, we usually stare at it for a long time; in addition, we can use our gaze to convey a sense of strength and thereby control the entire conversation; when our emotions are affected, the eyes can express feelings that words struggle to convey. Therefore, what the eyes convey is not only secrets but also an atmosphere of pleasure and friendliness that exerts a more favorable influence on the conversation.

As mentioned above, during handshakes or greetings, people with stronger dominance tend to maintain eye contact longer, while those with milder personalities maintain it for a shorter time. For men, when greeting someone of the same sex, it is best to keep eye contact brief; otherwise, it can easily send the wrong signal and cause unnecessary trouble.

### 10.2.3 Visual Blocking

When subjected to negative stimuli, the nervous system mobilizes every available bodily resource to prevent the increase of those stimuli. Retreating to control distance, contracting the limbs, or using hands or feet to create a barrier are all possible reactions. Visual blocking is one such reaction.

Visual blocking refers to the use of an obstacle to block one's own line of sight. In more academic terms, it means using an obstacle to attempt to stop or partially stop light from entering the eyes, thereby refusing or reducing the reception of visual information. The obstacles mentioned here are generally other organs of one's own body; the most common is the eyelid, followed by the arm or an object held in the hand.

Common actions such as closing the eyes and blinking (blinking being a high-frequency eye-closing action) achieve visual blocking through eyelid closure. In addition to eye closure, visual blocking also includes pupil constriction. Since micro-expressions focus on facial expressions, actions that use the hand or other objects for visual blocking are not discussed in this book; see the book *Micro-reaction* (微反应) for details.

### ① “Black Eyeball”

A small piece of knowledge must be shared: the “black eyeball” is not an independent black sphere. As shown in Figure 10-8, the seemingly clearly demarcated “black eyeball” has the cornea on the outermost layer (readily associated with donation), accounting for about one-sixth of the eyeball's area and completely transparent; this is the entry point for light. The colored part beneath the cornea, commonly called the “black eyeball” by Chinese people, is anatomically known as the **iris**.

Depending on the pigment contained in the iris, it displays different colors. Caucasians have less iris pigment and appear gray-blue; East Asians have more pigment and appear brownish-yellow; people of African descent have the most pigment and appear black.

The remaining outer shell of the eyeball is called the sclera. The sclera is hard, white, and opaque (the visible white of the eye is part of the sclera) and, together with the cornea, encloses the entire eyeball and protects its internal structures.

Among the numerous components of the eyeball, those directly relevant to micro-expression research are the iris and the pupil.

## Psychology Mini-Class

Psychologists have found that the eyes convey spirit largely through the expansion and contraction of the pupil, the movement of the eyeball, and the degree of eyelid opening and closing.

A person's emotions are closely related to changes in the pupil. Pleasurable stimuli cause the pupil to dilate, while aversive stimuli cause it to constrict. In addition, when a person is panicked or excited, the pupil can expand to four times its normal size; thus, some describe pupil changes as a marker of central nervous system activity.

Eyeball movement can also reveal emotion. For example, if the other person's eyeballs are relatively stable and move little, it indicates sincerity; conversely, if the gaze wanders and flickers, it suggests a more calculating mind and insufficient sincerity.

The degree of eyelid opening and closing can likewise indicate emotion. If the other person's eyelids droop, it signals dejection or annoyance; if the eyes are half-closed, it indicates arrogance and disregard for others.

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Among the numerous components of the eyeball, those directly relevant to micro-expression research are the iris and the pupil.

### **Eye Baseline**

The eye baseline refers to the position of the eyelids in a neutral static state; its indirect indicator is the size of the exposed iris region, which can be measured by vertical diameter.

Under normal conditions, what we commonly call large eyes means a greater vertical separation of the eyelids in the natural static state—that is, a larger exposed iris region; conversely, small eyes mean a smaller exposed iris region. For the expression models used in this book, the upper eyelid covers 19 % of the iris's vertical diameter, the lower eyelid covers 9.5 %, and the exposed iris region accounts for 71.5 % of the entire iris's vertical diameter.

With this set of baseline data, one will not misjudge whether a person is widening the eyes or closing the eyelids. From another angle, any slight increase or decrease in iris exposure can be immediately and sensitively detected against the baseline state, allowing inference as to whether the person is widening or narrowing the eyes.

### **3. Scleral Show Indicating Depth of Character and Irritability**

Scleral show refers to eyes in which the dark iris is displaced upward or downward so that the white of the eye is visible above or below the iris. People with scleral show are talented, mentally agile, deep in character, well-versed in strategy, and relatively likely to attain a certain status. Scleral show is further divided into upper scleral show and lower scleral show. Upper scleral show means white is visible above the iris. Such individuals are typically self-centered, highly neurotic, irritable and quick to anger, and prone to attacking others. They also harbor deep feelings of inferiority, are sensitive to criticism, tend to think the worst of situations, and exhibit a stronger criminal tendency. Lower scleral show means white is visible below the iris—that is, the eyes show white beneath a raised iris. These individuals are comparatively self-confident, strong-willed, bold, highly materialistic, and persevering once they have decided on something; however, they can also be willful and cold, inconsistent in word and deed, and occasionally disregard others' feelings.

### **Orbicularis Oculi Muscle**

The action of the levator palpebrae superioris is always closely linked to the orbicularis oculi; contraction and relaxation of the orbicularis oculi directly affect the tension and relaxation of the levator palpebrae superioris. The orbicularis oculi is distributed around the eyes and constitutes a crucial facial muscle region; it interacts with the frontalis, corrugator supercilii, depressor supercilii, levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, levator labii superioris, and zygomaticus minor, among others.

In our facial expressions, eye opening, eye closing, frowning, and eyeball movement all require the cooperation of the orbicularis oculi. Moreover, it indirectly influences the upward turn of the lips and the contraction of the cheek muscles—that is, smiling.

When observing expressions to judge inner thoughts, the eyes and their surrounding area are an important focal point. Every change in the eyes reflects, to varying degrees, the timely inner changes of the person involved. The orbicularis oculi is the key muscle that drives all of this.

### **c. Myopic Squint**

Of course, there is an even more special case—myopia.

Myopia occurs because prolonged viewing of near objects keeps the lens in a tense, deformed state under the action of the ciliary muscle, making recovery difficult; as a result, distant objects cannot be focused on the retina, producing myopia.

Squinting the eyes uses the compression of the orbicularis oculi to slightly alter the anteroposterior circumference of the eyeball, thereby modestly improving image quality. Therefore, myopic students who are not wearing glasses will squint when they need to see something clearly, which can help to some extent. However, once the structure of the eyeball and the principles of image formation are understood, it becomes clear that only by using the ciliary muscle to flatten the lens can image quality truly be changed. Because the ciliary muscle is controlled by the autonomic nervous system and cannot be moved at will, squinting to compensate for myopia is of limited help.

## **5. Protruding Eyes Indicating Optimism and Kindness**

Physiologically, protruding eyeballs result from well-developed nerves behind the eyeball; consequently, people with protruding eyes are generally kind-hearted, optimistic, and cheerful. They are good at socializing, appear talkative in communication, work energetically and conscientiously, yet have a tendency to be forgetful; their thoughts can seem flighty and capricious. Their temperament leans toward impatience and a degree of neuroticism; they often torment themselves by creating unnecessary problems. Women with protruding eyes, especially young girls in love, tend to display a mixture of excited anticipation and anxious agitation. Boys may not understand why she rushes to a date, seems distracted and answers irrelevantly during the date, and then flees as if escaping at the end. In fact, not only boys fail to understand; the girl herself may not fully grasp her own emotions.

### **(3) Correct Analytical Approach to Lateral Gaze Shifts**

The only certainty is that a lateral gaze shift indicates a nervous-system command, which may be intentional, habitual, or an instinctive unconscious command, but it necessarily interrupts the ongoing interaction; analysis can be performed by comparing each subject's baseline.

Gaze shifting has no necessary connection to lying. Although it interrupts the current interaction, the reason may be to prepare for better communication, such as recalling facts, logical reasoning, or numerical calculation; it may also involve fabricating false information or concealing true information. In addition, lateral gaze shifts may simply be emotion-driven—for example, displeasure or disgust—with no complex thought involved, merely an unwillingness to continue the exchange.

## **Negative Emotions in the Gaze**



Under normal circumstances, people turn their heads to face the other person's eyes directly. If only the eyes turn without the head, a sidelong glance results, conveying negative emotions of disdain, contempt, disgust, or rejection.

This point is very important when establishing rapport with others. If your interlocutor begins by looking at you sideways, it shows he does not yet trust you and is unwilling to engage in the conversation. You need to establish rapport with him first; this will be discussed later. Observing whether he opens up to you, changes in gaze are a clear indicator. When he gradually faces you and begins to look at you directly, it proves your method is working and the other party is now willing to communicate further.

### **1. Upward Gaze Shift**

Based on our actual tests, we believe an upward gaze shift can map to three psychological characteristics: one is the implication of placing oneself in a higher status, often used to express disdain and frequently combined with the interjection "tch" to form a contemptuous expression; another is the implication of "this has nothing to do with me" or "I am staying out of it," often appearing during feigned innocence; the third is the most common situation among subjects: the person had not anticipated being asked the question and begins to think on the spot, involuntarily rolling the eyes upward. Both recall and fabrication have been observed across different subjects; even during baseline-test medium-difficulty arithmetic questions, subjects have shown upward gaze shifts while performing mental calculations.

### **(II) Intimate Gaze**

This gaze pattern is widely used between strangers meeting for the first time, friends of the opposite sex, family members, and close friends. Generally, it begins with both parties' eyes, then moves to the chin and subsequently to various parts of the body.

For example, when someone approaches from a distance, you typically scan quickly from the face to the waist to determine gender. You then examine the person again to gauge their level of interest in you, focusing the gaze on the eyes, chin, and areas above the abdomen. If two people are relatively close, they focus the gaze on the region between the eyes and the chest. Young men and women often use this intimate gaze to convey affection.

### **3. Lateral Gaze Shift (Debunking a Widely Circulated Fallacy)**

A gaze shift to the left or right disrupts the most sincere pupil-to-pupil contact, yet no definitive mapping rules can be established for left versus right shifts because individual habits differ.

A so-called psychological claim states, "If recalling something, most people's gaze shifts left; if fabricating, the gaze shifts right." Those propagating this rule solemnly offer an explanation linking it to the crossed control of the brain's hemispheres and the differing functional specializations of the left and right hemispheres: the left hemisphere handles memory, the right handles creation. Many treat this rule as a valuable lie-detection criterion; below we expose the fallacy.

### **③ Pupil**

Once the iris has been introduced, the pupil is essentially fully covered as well. The pupil is not an independent organ or component; it is simply the opening in the center of the iris through which all visual

light enters. Therefore, regardless of ethnicity, the pupil always appears black—not because of pigment, but because of the darkness inside the body.

Thus, when light is too strong, the sphincter pupillae within the iris contracts automatically and the pupil constricts; when light weakens, the dilator pupillae contracts automatically and the pupil dilates. These adjustments are performed autonomously by smooth muscle under autonomic nervous system control and do not require separate instructions from the cerebral cortex (responsible for thought).

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### (3) Absence of [I Am Listening Attentively]

When the true inner state is unwillingness to “listen attentively” to the other person, or when other factors such as embarrassment or awkwardness prevent attentive listening, the listener may also exhibit gaze shifting.

Imagine: if the other person is saying something you want to hear—for instance, information concerning your personal interests, the outcome of a punishment or appointment, or entertaining gossip that excites the nervous system—you will certainly look the speaker in the eye and listen carefully to every word.

However, when the content is uninteresting or unwelcome, the listener will choose to shift gaze while listening.

### Gaze Direction as a Prelude to Communication

During conversation, the eyeballs often turn in different directions. Through these directions, one can glimpse a person’s inner activity.

When a person looks upward, it indicates they are likely thinking or trying to recall something. Perhaps they are a visual thinker attempting to form an image in the mind. If the eyes look downward, it may indicate submission or guilt about something. If a person’s eyes look to the side, note that they may be about to become angry. Of course, this can also be understood as an attempt to escape the conversation or a sign of distraction.

### I. Eye Shape, the Color of the Mind

Eye size is not limited to length and width; it also includes the vertical opening when the eyes are open and the size of the pupils. Since ancient times, large eyes have been regarded as an important element of beauty and a synonym for purity and gentleness. People with large eyes have good expressive ability but also tend to be overly sensitive; their clear likes and dislikes may lead to communication difficulties with others. Women

whose large eyes reveal spirit are especially prone to impulsive relationships, later regretting their rash actions. Therefore, when facing anyone or anything, avoid overly subjective assumptions and strive to remain prudent and objective.

## **Gaze Direction**

During conversation, the eyeballs often turn in different directions. These directions can help you judge what a person is truly thinking.

When a person looks upward, she is likely thinking or trying to recall something. Perhaps she is a visual thinker attempting to form an image in the mind. If the eyes look downward, it may indicate submission or guilt about something. If a person's eyes look to the side, note that she may be about to become angry. Of course, this can also be interpreted as an attempt to escape the conversation or a sign of distraction.

### **1. Small Eyes Indicating Simplicity and Intelligence**

People with small eyes are mostly honest, simple, and introverted; to outsiders they appear as mystics. They are all intelligent and strong-willed, yet sometimes overly fixated on minor matters and may lose the greater for the lesser. Such individuals are usually careful, patient, and good at persevering. Although many lack outstanding external features, their inner potential and strength often prove astonishing. Women with small eyes lead ordinary lives, dislike risk, and can be somewhat petty-minded; after marriage they become typical virtuous wives and mothers. In addition, people with small eyes whose gaze flickers constantly have great potential to become outstanding figures.

## **Micro-Expression Keywords**

The eyes are the windows to the soul. A person's psychological state and inner world can be conveyed through the eyes. Psychologists believe that to enter another person's inner world, the first thing to look at is their eyes.

As the saying goes, the eyes are the windows to the soul and the most accurate expression of a person's emotions and inner activities. A person's moral character, behavior, and loyalty or treachery can all be reflected through the eyes. Therefore, psychologists believe that to enter another person's inner world, the first thing to look at is their eyes.

### **Dilated Pupils Betray His "Love"**

Indian poet Tagore put it well: "Once anyone learns the language of the eyes, the variations of expression become endless." Beyond serving as the body's visual organs, the eyes can also truthfully convey a person's various emotions. As the saying goes, "The eyes are the windows to the soul."

So how can one read a person's inner secrets or hidden matters from the eyes? FBI agents tell us that the answers lie in changes in pupil size, gaze direction, eye contact, and blink rate.

## **Clue One: Gaze Direction**

### **Emotional Changes and Gaze Direction**

Changes in emotion lead to changes in gaze direction: when depressed or sad, the gaze drops downward; when shy or guilty, the gaze moves downward or to the side; when rejecting or disgusted, the gaze turns away. Yet gaze is very easy to control and does not even require special training. Some people skilled at lying can keep their gaze fixed on you without you noticing a thing. Therefore, do not use the other person's seemingly sincere gaze as an excuse to convince yourself to believe them.

### **Clue Five: Rolling the Eyes Upward**

Rolling the eyes upward is commonly understood to indicate contempt. Beyond that, it can also signal a desire for greater closeness, typically seen in the female partner within a romantic couple. This type of eye roll differs from contempt; the gaze usually returns to the male partner's pupils afterward, accompanied by a smile. The smile serves both to appear cute and sincere and to seek an affirming signal from the male partner. The male partner must distinguish this from eye rolls expressing contempt or disgust, or unnecessary misunderstandings and trouble may arise.

### **b. Half-Closed Eyes Indicating Negativity**

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图10-14]*

Half-closed eyelids frequently appear in expressions of emotions such as disgust-related states (contempt, disdain) and sadness-related states (displeasure, crying), as shown in Figure 10-14. Note, however, that true anger and anger-related threats do not involve half-closed eyelids; the eyes widen instead. For detailed distinctions, see Chapter 6.

## **Eyes**

People often say the eyes are the windows to the soul. If that is so, then the eyelids are the projections, and the eyebrows and forehead represent the window's decorations. These factors can help you build a complete picture of a person's psychological state.

In this section we will closely observe how the eyes "speak," including eye contact, pupil dilation or constriction, and blink rate. Later we will also learn how the eyebrows play a key role during eye communication.

### **Clue Seven: Looking at Someone Sideways**

First, try a small experiment. Have a friend walk ahead of you at a distance of 15–20 meters, making sure your loud call can be heard. Do not tell the friend beforehand that you will call their name. When they are unprepared, suddenly call their name from behind. You will find that they will try to turn their head and even rotate their body to face you directly. Similarly, if you suddenly call a friend from beside them, they will turn to respond face-on as much as possible.

## **4. The Eyes of Fear**

When facing a fear stimulus, people often display a particular gaze shift—rapid multidirectional eye movement.

This action is difficult to fake; it is not impossible, but hard to do. Only the vigilance that accompanies fear causes high-frequency eye rotation to quickly notice every change nearby—an evolved instinct.

The value of this stress micro-expression lies in the fact that the frequency of changes in gaze direction is directly proportional to the degree of inner fear.

#### **4. Deep-Set Eyes Indicating Talent and Alertness**

People with deep eye sockets and recessed eyeballs tend to be talented, possess strong comprehension, high alertness, and thorough thinking. They are rational individuals skilled at studying the essence beneath surface appearances. Such people are often calm and honest, finish what they start, tend to be silent and reserved, patient and responsible in their work, and are down-to-earth doers. However, they are not good at expressing themselves, act slowly, have somewhat short tempers, and focus more on their own and immediate interests.

#### **2. Narrow Eyes Indicating Kindness and Introversion**

People with narrow eyes have meticulous minds, keen observation, orderly work habits, and highly detailed plans. Such individuals are usually kind and friendly, possess a spirit of dedication, yet are relatively introverted, lack decisiveness when facing issues, and often echo others. They can hold extreme views when assessing situations and frequently hesitate as a result, missing opportunities. In many cases, people with narrow eyes have fragile emotions, are somewhat neurotic, and tend to be suspicious.

#### **Eyes: Windows for Peering into the Heart**

"The human eye speaks as many words as the tongue and, without a dictionary, can reveal the entire world through the language of the eyes." This remark by American writer Ralph Waldo Emerson tells us that a person's eyes can reveal their inner thoughts, which is of great significance in deciding whether to advance or retreat, draw close or keep distance, in interactions with them.

#### **1. Eye Closure and Blinking**

Full closure of the eyelids completely blocks light with imaging significance from entering the eyes (while still allowing light detection), meaning nothing is seen. Even high-frequency eyelid closures such as blinking severely affect visual imaging. At this point in the reading, try it yourself: fix your gaze on an object and deliberately blink rapidly three to four times. How does it feel?

#### **(I) Social Gaze**

When your gaze falls below the other person's eye level, it creates a typical social atmosphere. The focus of the gaze is between the other person's eyes and mouth, avoiding pressure and allowing the conversation to proceed in a warm, relaxed environment. Therefore, mastering social gaze is invaluable for business negotiations and commercial cooperation.

#### **Eyes Wide Open**

This indicates strong interest in what you are saying and attentive listening, with active thinking occurring. If the eyes are wide and the mouth is open, it shows that something you said surprised them and they can hardly believe it. At this point, you need to provide a clearer statement or further detailed explanation for the other person to accept it.

#### **Sideways Glance**

People who like to glance at others sideways are generally introverted and shy. If this behavior is accompanied by a smile, it tells the other person, "I am interested in you!" But if accompanied by a pout or lowered eyebrows, it signals doubt, contempt, hostility, or criticism.

### **Levator Palpebrae Superioris**

The levator palpebrae superioris muscle lies within the upper eyelid, small in form yet crucial. When tense, it lifts the upper eyelid upward and opens the eyes. Every morning when we open our eyes, this muscle is at work. When the levator palpebrae superioris relaxes, the upper eyelid contracts, producing eye closure.

## **6. Round Eyes Indicating Frankness and Affability**

People with round eyes are naturally easygoing, cheerful, frank, consistent in word and deed, highly popular, quick to understand, and have wide interests and strong thinking ability. Such individuals work conscientiously and actively, are sensitive, and therefore easily influenced by external factors. They have strong self-esteem accompanied by a tendency toward self-righteousness.

### **Continuous Blinking**

Blinking continuously while speaking indicates that the person is thinking about something else while talking. Blinking continuously while listening shows that they have no interest in what you are saying but find it hard to refuse, so they pretend to listen while their mind has already wandered far away.

## **10.2 Micro-Expressions of the Eyes**

Since the purpose of this book is not to treat eye diseases through surgery, it will not list every component of the eyes and their adnexa in exhaustive detail, covering only the parts related to the micro-expressions under study.

### **② "Active" Closure**

The case of "active" closure differs from the previously discussed maximum distinction in that the eyes are the primary initiator and executor of emotional and cognitive expression. Active half-closure, like full closure, also carries different shades of meaning.

### **Reading Desire from the Eyelids**

In discussions about the eyes, the importance of the eyelids is often overlooked. In fact, the degree of eyelid opening and closing can likewise reflect a person's mental state. Let us now examine the FBI agents' analysis.

### **Drooping Eyelids**

Drooping eyelids carry many meanings, so judge accurately according to the specific context whether a person with lowered eyelids feels fatigue, boredom, dejection, laziness, or is flirting.

### **Struggling to Lift the Eyelids to Widen the Eyes**

This usually indicates strong interest in something. If the eyes open too wide, it may mean the person is very surprised or afraid.

## Chapter Three: The "Great Learning" Between Eyebrows and Eyes

The eyes are the windows to the soul, and the eyebrows are the window frames. No matter what people have experienced, words can lie but the eyes cannot!

### Revealing Eyes

Beyond eyeball movement, the eyes also provide many other clues for micro-expressions.

See Brows (c-brows).

See Brows (c-brows).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

### Eyelids and Micro-movements

#### (1) Complete Closure

Eyelid closure is a movement that can be voluntarily controlled; a normal person can perform this action at any time. The content we will explore focuses solely on instinctive reactions triggered by stimuli, excluding habitual eye closure (common in older adults) and habitual blinking, as these lack a necessary stimulus source and hold no value for analyzing psychological states. However, these habitual actions can serve as the subject's **baseline reactions** for comparison. Of course, the research content does not include deliberately performed eye closures or blinks.

Stimuli that cause visual blockage generally fall into two categories: positive ones, such as music worth savoring, delicious food, or problems requiring focused thought; and negative ones, such as terrifying images or threatening questions. Both types elicit the same brain response—I do not want to see it.

#### ① Positive Stimuli

Positive stimuli prompt the brain to order the eyes closed in order to concentrate and avoid letting visual processing divert limited neural resources. Closing the eyes while listening to music can intensify auditory sensation; closing the eyes while tasting food can intensify gustatory sensation; closing the eyes while carefully sniffing with the nose can seemingly detect subtler odors and intensify olfactory sensation; and closing the eyes while pondering a problem can concentrate mental energy to arrive at an answer. Note, however, that people more often close their eyes as an instinctive reaction to a stimulus rather than for any specific purpose, because processing visual information consumes excessive neural capacity and closing the eyes conserves considerable effort. See Figure 10-11.

Although we lack precise data on the percentage of external information humans obtain through vision, both inquiry and personal sensory experience allow an "unscientific" conclusion: the proportion is large. The logic holds that conserving neural resources otherwise spent on visual processing enhances the efficiency of other neural activities.

#### ② Negative Stimuli

Negative stimuli make the nervous system perceive possible harm, generating various negative emotions such as sadness, worry (fear involving thought), disgust, and fear (fear without thought). To reduce or avoid

negative stimuli, the nervous system commands the eyelids to close, cutting off visual input and thereby limiting harm.

A simple experiment illustrates this: pick up a small object and make a quick throwing motion toward someone you know well (without actually releasing it). Even if the person trusts you completely and has not been specifically instructed not to close their eyes, they will still involuntarily shut their eyes to avoid possible injury. Evolution has equipped the nervous system with an instinctive tendency to seek benefit and avoid harm; when harm is sensed, self-protection mechanisms activate automatically. Although the person knows you are reliable and would never harm them even at personal cost, such a prank still triggers a natural reaction.

Eye closure or non-closure can be consciously controlled. Yet under sudden stimulation, conscious thought exerts no control; the action is governed by instincts accumulated through evolution.

Additional examples confirm that negative stimuli produce eyelid closure. After seeing a terrifying image (note: afterward, not at the instant), when feeling disgusted yet helpless, or when saddened and unwilling to face something, a pronounced reaction—complete eyelid closure—occurs. See Figure 10-12.

In the absence of physical stimuli such as wind or airborne particles, high-frequency blinking is also essentially visual blockage. The difference is that high-frequency blinking usually mixes a large measure of rational decision-making into the instinctive impulse to close the eyes, resulting in simultaneous instinctive blockage of vision and determined attempts to keep the eyes open in order to maintain rational attention to the situation.

The clearest illustration occurs when facing a difficult decision: many people's blink rate increases. A difficult decision here does not refer to logical deduction or computational problems; such pressure-free difficulties typically produce frowning and a fixed gaze—in other words, staring blankly—while visual input is effectively ignored. The decisions that raise blink rate involve choices about what to say, how to say it, or how to weigh options according to the principle of seeking benefit and avoiding harm. In actual tests we have conducted, many reactions to effective stimuli consisted of the subject desperately blinking because they did not wish to reveal the truth.

## 5. Orbicularis Oculi Muscle

The orbicularis oculi is a broad, flat, elliptical muscle, symmetrical on both sides, encircling the orbit and extending inward to the eyelids.

The location of the orbicularis oculi carries significant strategic importance. Originating from the medial side near the nose, its fibers form a complete ellipse that links most of the muscles in the upper half of the face:

- Superiorly, some fibers merge with the frontalis and corrugator supercilii.
- Medially, some fibers reach the superolateral portion of the depressor supercilii.
- Inferiorly, some fibers variously cover or merge with adjacent muscles, including the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, levator labii superioris, and zygomaticus minor.

Consequently, the orbicularis oculi becomes the central connection point for the muscles of the upper face: above it influences the frontalis and corrugator supercilii that move the eyebrows; medially it connects to the depressor supercilii at the nasal root; below it influences and is influenced by the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, levator labii superioris, and zygomaticus minor. Any contraction of the orbicularis oculi



necessarily draws these muscles into coordinated movement, while contraction of the surrounding muscles in turn stretches the orbicularis oculi, altering the morphology of the eye region.

Given this strategically vital position, the orbicularis oculi plays an important role in major facial expressions and various ocular reflexes.

The palpebral portion of the orbicularis oculi can readily draw the eyelids closed, as during sleep or in protective blinking triggered by light. Its most important function is to seal the eyes tightly or produce eyelid closure while simultaneously depressing and tightening the eyebrows, cooperatively reducing the amount of light entering the eyes. During full contraction of the orbicularis oculi, radial skin folds form at the lateral canthus; after middle age these folds often become permanent—the so-called crow's feet.

In addition, contraction of the orbicularis oculi indirectly affects muscle bundles of the lower face, producing slight elevation of the upper lip and cheek prominence. These effects are indirect because the primary muscles responsible for upper-lip elevation and cheek prominence are not the orbicularis oculi; they will be described in detail later.

Thus the morphological changes of the eyes and their surroundings possess powerful expressive capacity precisely because of the strategic position of the orbicularis oculi.

Observing changes in the eyes and surrounding area is key to capturing shifts in expression.

### Interpreting Your Love Life from Eyelid Shape

In discussions of the eyes, the importance of the eyelids is often overlooked. In fact, the degree of eyelid opening and closing can likewise reflect a person's mental state.

- **Drooping eyelids:** Drooping eyelids carry many possible meanings, so judge according to context whether a person with lowered lids feels fatigue, boredom, dejection, laziness, or is flirting.
- **Effortfully raising the eyelids to widen the eyes:** Usually indicates strong interest in something. If the eyes open excessively wide, the person may be surprised or frightened.
- **Squinting:** If a person squints without being stimulated by bright light, they may be preparing to speak or expressing uncertainty. If the squint is accompanied by a broad smile, the person feels very happy.

Moreover, the eyelids are considered the part of the face most reflective of sexual desire; their shape can reveal a person's psychological attitude toward love.

- **Both eyes single-fold:** Personality tends to be introverted, solitary, sensitive, strong-willed, determined, and diligent. Emotional expression is reserved and restrained; even when standing before someone admired or liked, the person strives to remain composed and show nothing. Professional expertise allows steady career advancement; in family life the person is conservative, yet any extramarital affair quickly becomes evident.
- **Both eyes double-fold:** Outgoing and warm, emotionally rich; small caring gestures or solicitous inquiries, especially from the opposite sex, easily move them, making resistance to opposite-sex attraction difficult. Whether at work or social gatherings they are invariably popular. They belong to the loyal and honest type whose family life is happy and fulfilling.
- **One single-fold, one double-fold:** Such individuals rarely reveal their true intentions and often complain or grumble in work and interpersonal settings. People with this eyelid configuration show low

loyalty in love, enjoy change and stimulation, possess a tendency to philander, and are sexually open, seldom refusing advances.

#### ① “Passive” Closure

One form is “passive” partial closure caused by the requirements of other expressions. Examples include the eye closure that accompanies hearty laughter or sorrowful weeping; in both cases the emphasis lies elsewhere than on the transmission or reception of visual information.

During genuine hearty laughter the mind is in a state of great pleasure; the pleasurable information has already been received (the stimulus is complete—otherwise why laugh?), so there is no need to see anything or to signal that one is looking. Likewise, during genuine sorrowful weeping the mind is in acute pain; the saddening, aggrieved, or oppressive information has already exerted its stimulus, so there is no need—and no capacity—to see anything or convey anything with the eyes, because the priority is to release the emotion or else “internal injury” will result. In such expressions the eyes close more from physiological necessity.

- **Laughter:** Laughter operates on a principle similar to sneezing. Both involve rapid, voluminous exhalation; this respiratory pattern raises capillary pressure inside the eyeball and increases intraorbital pressure. Eyelid closure creates a barrier that protects the eyeball from sudden high internal pressure.
- **Crying:** In addition to the respiratory factor already mentioned (crying also involves spasmodic exhalation), there is the influence of tears. The lacrimal glands secrete abundant tears that well up within the eyelid structure; to direct the tears and fulfill their primary duty (one function of the eyelids is to moisten the cornea during blinking), the eyelids automatically close.

#### 4. Levator Palpebrae Superioris

Although small, the levator palpebrae superioris has a relatively complex anatomical structure[1] and lies mainly inside the upper eyelid, symmetrically on both sides.

Its function is to elevate the upper lid. Contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris raises the upper eyelid—the action of opening the eyes—while contraction of the orbicularis oculi and relaxation of the levator palpebrae superioris produces eye closure. The levator palpebrae superioris is also connected via check ligaments to the superior rectus, which moves the eyeball; when the eyeball performs an upward gaze, the upper lid automatically rises and the eyebrows are lifted by the frontalis.

Eyelid position depends on the coordinated action of the orbicularis oculi and levator palpebrae superioris together with the degree of eyeball protrusion. When the eyes are relaxed and open, the lower-lid margin normally passes at the level of the inferior limbus, while the upper lid covers the upper half of the iris width (one-quarter of its vertical diameter).

The levator palpebrae superioris contains smooth-muscle fibers (Müller’s muscle), which are controlled solely by the autonomic nervous system and therefore not subject to conscious volition. When a person is frightened or excited, sympathetic activation causes the smooth muscle within the tarsal plates to contract, widening the palpebral fissure. When sympathetic tone is inhibited (for example, during intoxication), the upper lid droops. Sympathetic overactivity can also produce conditions such as Horner syndrome.

##### a. Positive Expressive Partial Closure—Eyes Like Silk

Eyes like silk constitute a flirtatious expression in women. The word “silk” itself indicates that eyelid closure is nearly complete. Nevertheless, professional analysis requires us to dissect this appealing situation and examine the underlying psychological state.

The origin of eyes like silk is actually a variant of the “concentrated enjoyment” discussed earlier. The evolutionary process is roughly as follows: concentrated enjoyment requires eye closure (already examined); over time this natural physiological phenomenon became a shared understanding that a blissful expression with closed eyes signifies enjoyment; consequently people consciously half-close their eyes to display a pleasing expression that conveys “I am enjoying this (being with you) very much.”

Therefore, when applying makeup to appear seductive, the eyeliner should be drawn slender and elongated. To project a spirited, heroic air, such a line must never be used; instead the distance between brow and eye should be increased so the eyelids appear more widely open.

### 10.2.3 Visual Blockage

When confronted with negative stimuli, the nervous system mobilizes every available bodily resource to prevent further increase in the stimulus. Retreating to control distance, contracting the limbs, or raising a hand or foot as a barrier are all possible reactions. Visual blockage is one such reaction.

Visual blockage refers to the use of an obstacle to obstruct one’s own line of sight. In more technical terms, it is the deployment of an obstacle intended to block or partially block light from entering the eyes, thereby refusing or reducing the reception of visual information. The obstacles in question are generally other parts of one’s own body—most commonly the eyelids, followed by the arms or objects held in the hands.

Ordinary eye closure and blinking (blinking being rapid, repeated closure) accomplish visual blockage through the eyelids. Besides closure, visual blockage also includes pupillary constriction. Because micro-expressions focus on facial expression, actions that use the hands or other objects for visual blockage are not discussed in this book; see the book *Micro-reaction* (微反应) for details.

## 2. Blinking

If a person blinks several times within a single second, it indicates emotional arousal and strong interest in something; it can also be interpreted as timidity or shyness, an unwillingness to meet another’s gaze directly. Under normal conditions a person blinks five to eight times per minute, each blink lasting less than one second. A blink exceeding one second signals boredom, lack of interest, or even contempt and disdain. Continuous blinking indicates that the person is striving to suppress their feelings. Vigorous blinking often reveals tension.

### Circumstances That Increase Blink Rate

We once tested a computer programmer whose résumé claimed years of experience and proficiency in multiple programming languages. When asked for algorithmic details of one language listed on the résumé, his blink rate rose sharply for three to four seconds, after which he admitted unfamiliarity with that language.

## 4. Prolonged Eye Closure

Prolonged eye closure accompanied by exhalation indicates anxiety and high stress. It can also occur when a person is unwilling to face a situation or individual and wishes to escape. For example, while walking down the

street and suddenly encountering someone one does not wish to meet, the person may close the eyes for an extended period out of fear of being noticed.

### 1. Eye Closure and Blinking

Full eyelid closure completely prevents light capable of forming images from entering the eyes (though light detection remains), rendering objects invisible. Even the high-frequency closures of blinking severely disrupt visual imaging. At this point you may test the effect yourself: fixate on an object and deliberately blink rapidly three or four times; note the sensation.

### 3. Squinting

During conversation, if the other person squints, frowns, and repeatedly scans you, it signals that they are filled with doubt and are searching you for clues to verify their judgment. This expression primarily conveys non-acceptance or uncertainty and frequently appears when someone feels unsure about a decision.

### 11. Insecure and Low-Self-Esteem Blinking

Some people blink incessantly; such individuals often lack confidence and a sense of security. They may have received little affection in childhood and never stood out, resulting in low self-confidence. Because frequent blinking creates a poor impression, these people usually have few close friends and find it difficult to sustain relationships.

#### b. Negative Expressive Partial Closure

Partial eyelid closure frequently appears in expressions of disgust-related emotions (scorn, disdain) and sadness-related emotions (displeasure, weeping). Note, however, that genuine anger and anger-related threat never produce partial closure; the eyes widen instead. For detailed distinctions see Chapter 6.

### (2) Incomplete Closure

Contraction of the orbicularis oculi produces eyelid closure that is not complete; the eyes remain slightly more open than in full closure yet less open than the normal resting state. The inner state represented by incomplete eyelid closure is somewhat more complex.

#### ② "Active" Closure

The chief distinction of "active" closure from the cases discussed earlier is that the eyes themselves are the primary initiators and executors of emotional and cognitive expression. Active partial closure, like complete closure, can carry different expressive meanings.

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

## **Pupil Dilation or Constriction**

### **II. Your Pupils Betray You**

The eyes are most critical at the pupils. To understand a person, try focusing on the other party's pupils to help uncover the truth and judge whether their words are genuine, because pupil dilation and constriction are extremely difficult to control. Someone who has lied can spread their hands to show sincerity or wear an innocent expression to proclaim innocence, yet they cannot control the dilation of their pupils caused by excitement.

Long ago, people already knew how to use pupils to read others' inner thoughts. When communicating or negotiating with others, watch their eyes carefully. We often see such scenes in novels or TV dramas: when the male lead is caught hiding something from the female lead, she presses for the reason and usually adds, "Look me in the eyes when you speak." This is precisely about watching the other person's pupils, because pupils expand and contract with the speaker's emotional fluctuations. For example, at a critical moment in negotiations, the other party may claim the price has reached its lowest and cannot be discussed further, yet their pupils dilate—this indicates they are excited about an impending victory. The price they offered is definitely not the lowest; they are lying.

In addition, compared with dark-colored pupils, light-colored pupils are often more attractive because the dilation of light-colored pupils is more noticeable.

Pupil changes carry different meanings, and variations in size can also reflect certain psychological activities.

For instance, pupil dilation. When a person feels pleasure or excitement, or receives a certain stimulus, their pupils can dilate to four to five times their normal size. Pupils also expand rapidly when someone develops a strong interest in or motivation toward another person or thing. It is said that ancient Persian jewelers priced jewelry according to the size of the customer's pupils. If a sparkling diamond ring caused the buyer's pupils to dilate, the merchant would raise the price accordingly.

We often say or hear the phrase "You're so happy your eyes are shining." This expression is not without basis; people's pupils may dilate from joy, appearing as if they are glowing. When people are in an excited state, their pupils likewise dilate. For example, when a girl watches a horror movie, she curls up while her pupils also dilate. This occurs because the terrifying stimulus excites her. Usually, a person appears more energetic when excited, precisely because pupil dilation during excitement makes them look more spirited.

Another example is pupil constriction. When a person is in a negative state such as anger, disgust, hatred, depression, or suspicion, their pupils contract to a very small size. For instance, after a couple quarrels, if the woman returns home angry, even if she tries hard to hide her emotions and appear nonchalant, someone nearby may still notice something is wrong and ask, “What happened?” This is not surprising. Once a person becomes angry or emotionally low, their pupils shrink, making the eyes look dull and lifeless. The same phenomenon occurs in business settings. If your client suddenly squints, it indicates they have doubts about something and are internally conflicted.

Yet another example is when pupils show no change. Sometimes, while discussing a topic with someone, you may find yourself speaking animatedly and growing hoarse, while the other person appears to be listening attentively with their head tilted, yet their pupils show little change. In such cases, it is advisable to stop the topic, because the other person is not interested or does not care. The absence of significant pupil change is a natural sign of inattention or indifference. Upon noticing such pupils, the initiating party should realize that the matter under discussion does not interest the other person.

### 3.1.1 The Remarkable Pupil

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3-1 瞳孔]*

In lie-detection (experiments), the pupil test can powerfully demonstrate this point. The pupil is an opening (literally a “hole”!) in the center of the iris (commonly called the black eyeball, though iris color varies across ethnic groups) that allows light to reach the retina. Its physiological function is that when light intensifies, the pupil constricts to prevent excessive light from stimulating the optic nerve; when light dims, the pupil dilates to admit as much light as possible onto the retina for clear imaging. These two changes occur constantly, yet humans cannot perceive them, because all dilation and constriction are performed by the smooth muscles controlling the iris, which are governed solely by the autonomic nervous system. No matter how hard you try, you cannot consciously control them. See Figure 3-1.

Interestingly, as evolution progressed, human pupil responses became more complex and advanced. Experiments show that when people see something they like, their pupils dilate—for example, when a lecherous man sees a seductive beauty or a gambler sees a strong hand—so they can take in more of the pleasing sight. When they see something they dislike, their pupils constrict—for example, when watching a bloody surgical dissection or filthy swirl—to minimize exposure to negative stimuli.

A master of maintaining composure may exhibit only pupil changes while remaining otherwise impassive. Ordinary people, however, experience not only pupil changes but also more obvious accompanying behaviors; for instance, upon seeing a beautiful woman they are certain to widen their eyes and drool, while upon seeing a billowing white bedsheet they will have long since shut their eyes tightly and screamed.

This is one of the laws of visual stress responses.

## 2. Changes in the Pupil

As previously introduced, the pupil is an opening in the center of the iris rather than an independent organ. The pupil permits light to enter the eyeball and form an image on the retina. When light intensifies, the pupil constricts to prevent excessive light from stimulating the optic nerve; when light dims, the pupil dilates to admit as much light as possible for the clearest possible imaging. All these actions are performed by the smooth muscles controlling the iris. Smooth muscles are governed solely by the autonomic nervous system; no matter how hard you try, you cannot directly control them through conscious commands.

Interestingly, as evolution progressed, human pupil responses became more complex and advanced. Experiments show that when people see something they like, their pupils dilate (for example, when a lecherous man sees a seductive beauty or a gambler sees a strong hand) so they can take in more of the pleasing sight; when they see something they dislike, their pupils constrict (for example, when watching a bloody surgical dissection) to minimize exposure to negative stimuli. This is the law of pupil stress responses.

### 15. Small Pupils

Selfishness, strong self-awareness, and a lack of emotional sensitivity are characteristics displayed by people with smaller pupils. Such individuals are competitive and unwilling to admit defeat; they are better suited to acting independently. If people of this type are mature and socially adept, able to navigate relationships smoothly, they can achieve even greater success in their careers.

### 14. Large Pupils

People with large pupils give the impression of bright, spirited eyes and are relatively attractive. They tend to have gentle temperaments, treat others with approachability, and lead simple lives. They are caring and considerate, perform well at work, enjoy excellent interpersonal relationships, and adapt readily, enabling them to seize opportunities effectively.

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

## Gaze Types

### III. Decoding "Eye Language"

In a dimly lit room, a woman sits at a table, head slightly lowered, eyes looking upward—this scene has captivated countless people. Raising the eyes upward while lowering the head conveys both submission and deference along with an ineffable charm. This posture, which makes a woman appear childlike, holds fatal attraction for men. A scene in the novel *Love in a Fallen City* depicts Bai Liusu doing exactly this upon meeting Fan Liuyuan: "That lowered head, so tender," the coyness of words half-spoken inevitably stirs the heart. One wise woman in the world also won universal affection with this posture: the late Princess Diana of Britain. When her marriage was on the brink of collapse, she tucked her chin slightly inward, lifted her eyes upward, and revealed her slender, fair neck—an elegance unmatched, like a work of art. This childlike purity triggered affection in thousands, especially when people believed the royal family was attacking her.

Clearly, the eyes store and transmit vast amounts of information. Through the eyes one can glimpse a person's innermost thoughts. Yet every eye movement carries rich inner meaning, and the same movement can convey very different meanings depending on the person using it. Consider the sidelong glance. The action carries different significance for men and women: if a woman uses it on a man during their first meeting, it indicates she rather likes him but feels too nervous to look directly, so she steals glances; the same action performed by a man carries a hint of contempt. A sidelong glance implies looking down on the other person. One must also integrate the accompanying eye expression for a full analysis.

Another common eye movement is the upward roll of the eyes. It produces an innocent expression used to signal that one has done nothing wrong or has been wronged. Whether the conveyed message is genuine still requires other factors for judgment, because this single expression can, like language, deceive the observer.

Then there is the wink. When people wish to signal mutual understanding, they often wink at each other; the expression says "only you and I know." Outsiders see it as through a fog. Some people wink while making faces to heighten the realism of their performance; anyone who does so must hold a favorable impression and genuine liking. This occurs more frequently among children.

Additional movements include lowered eyes and shifting pupils. The former is an unfriendly gesture carrying contempt and also signals indifference or lack of concern. Its user is typically rational and calm, rarely impulsive, yet fundamentally self-centered and extremely willful, with views that are hard to change. As for the latter, rapid pupil movement usually indicates a sharp sixth sense, quick reactions, and the ability to read people swiftly; such individuals are also more emotional. When interacting with them, watch one's words and actions, because they are easily influenced and may overreact. Conversely, people whose pupils move slowly tend to be less sensitive, experience smaller emotional swings, and are less easily swayed. Between romantic partners, a woman can glean information from the direction of her partner's pupil movement: movement toward the upper left indicates recalling the past; toward the upper right indicates imagining something never seen before; toward the lower left indicates calculating something; toward the lower right indicates sensing one's own body; and horizontal movement left or right indicates attentive listening and an effort to understand what is being said.

Different angles and directions of gaze convey different quantities of information. If someone looks up at you, the gaze expresses respect and admiration; conversely, looking down at you signals an intent to maintain personal dignity. If the other person pays no attention and continues working without shifting gaze, the behavior indicates indifference, neglect, and emotional distance. A serious, piercing gaze constitutes a warning that you may have unwittingly offended the person. A steady smile accompanied by a gentle, warm gaze shows respect and genuine interest in the topic.

"Eye language" is so important for an individual—especially for women—that skillful use becomes a powerful, invisible weapon that captivates. A charming smile and expressive eyes, every frown and smile filled with tender affection, eyes like autumn waters sparkling with light, convey infinite allure. Bai Juyi praised Yang Yuhuan in "Song of Everlasting Sorrow" with the lines: "One glance back, a hundred charms born; the six palaces' powdered beauties lose all color." Eye language thus serves not only as a tool for gathering information about others but also as a means of expressing one's own emotions. Much can be mined from a person's eyes; therefore, in social interaction the eyes must never be overlooked as a vital entry point.

## **(2) Erroneous Application of Cross-Control Movement Between the Left and Right Brain**

If an improper summary of brain-function lateralization is still excusable, then deriving from that error a link between eye-movement direction and left-right brain division is an even more ignorant display.

The supposed basis is the principle of crossed control: the left hemisphere controls movement of the right-side limbs, and the right hemisphere controls the left-side limbs. This is a scientific conclusion.

Yet it is incomprehensible that, if crossed control is followed, the left brain should control the right eye and the right brain the left eye. If recollection or fabrication truly engaged only one hemisphere according to its specialization (which in fact never occurs), the result should be movement of a single eye, not both eyes moving together. Moreover, under crossed control, if the right brain governs left-hand movement, does that mean the left hand can move only leftward? If leftward movement is assigned to the right brain, then when both hands move leftward together, which hemisphere is in charge?



Therefore, eye-movement direction has no relation whatsoever to functional differences between the left and right brain.

The original source of this fallacy may lie in NLP's six-direction eye-movement theory. Note that the following cited content is incorrect.

In this well-known speculative model, the "NLP school" claims that when a person's eyes turn upper left, the individual is recalling visual imagery, as in "What color are your curtains?" When the eyes turn upper right, the person is constructing visual imagery, as in "What color is a purple zebra's tail?" When the eyes turn horizontally left, the person is recalling auditory information, such as the melody of a famous piece; when turning horizontally right, the person is constructing auditory information, such as composing an original melody. When the eyes turn lower left, the person is talking to themselves; when turning lower right, the person is sensing kinesthetic or perceptual information.

To prevent falsification, NLP added a left-handed supplement: if the subject is left-handed, all directions are reversed. This still relies on the theory of crossed hemispheric control of limbs.

In reality, to provide coherent visual information, eye movements must remain simultaneous and in the same direction; otherwise visual confusion results. Every nerve controlling the extraocular muscles receives input from bilateral corticobulbar fibers. In other words, each eye is simultaneously governed by both hemispheres.

Normal eye movements are therefore conjugate; unlike the limbs, the eyes cannot move in opposite directions or at different times.

Of course, with training some people can deliberately cross their eyes, because during convergence both medial rectus muscles contract, the lens thickens, and the pupils constrict, enabling near work. In contrast, the lateral rectus muscles responsible for divergence are not controlled by the oculomotor nucleus but by the abducens nucleus; therefore the eyes cannot diverge independently. Because the medial rectus is directly controlled by the oculomotor nucleus, crossed eyes are possible.

The neuroanatomical principles are presented to demonstrate that eye-movement direction operates under an entirely different mechanism from limb crossed control and cannot be arbitrarily mapped by imagination.

This set of conjectures, published in 1979, lacks any supporting data and cannot withstand verification. We conducted a small experiment: 200 participants each answered six questions; their eye movements were videotaped and later statistically analyzed.

The results showed that some criteria failed to match more than 70 percent of the time, others approached 50 percent; the average falsification rate across the six rules was 63 percent. In other words, using six-direction eye movement to analyze another person's thoughts yields an error probability approaching two-thirds—less reliable than a coin toss at 50 percent. The probability that any individual fully conforms to the six-direction pattern is 37 percent, roughly three per thousand (2.6‰), an abysmal figure.

Consequently, this criterion produces erroneous judgments and unjust accusations. We can therefore discard this "pseudoscience" with confidence. Interested readers may similarly examine the parallel rumor that "right-handed people are more rational (rigorous, conservative, etc.) while left-handed people are more artistic (innovative, emotional, etc.)."

### **Frequent Blinking as a Sign of Lying**

Scientists have found that the pupil does not “lie”; it is a sensitive display of vital functions, an extension of the brain, and a marker of central-nervous-system activity that most faithfully reflects a person’s true inner feelings. When we interact closely with someone, we can clearly read minds and detect lies through pupillary recognition (a method of observing blink rate and pupil dilation or constriction).

Blinking is both a spontaneous and a subconscious behavior. Regardless of whether a person’s eyes appear dry or moist, monitoring blink frequency is crucial. One must continually note whether the interlocutor’s blink rate is normal, excessively high, or excessively low.

It is well known that when a person lies, the blink rate rises markedly above baseline. U.S. customs inspectors, for example, routinely inform travelers that failure to declare prohibited items will result in repatriation. One might consider this foolish, since travelers have already completed declaration forms. Yet when inspectors issue the reminder, they closely observe the traveler’s eyes for abnormal blink frequency. If the traveler blinks excessively, inspectors search the luggage.

Investigators likewise record a suspect’s blink rate to help determine guilt. Elevated blink rate can reflect guilt, while a lowered rate may indicate that the person is preparing to confess something. Precisely because of this, suspects lack the attention to monitor their own eyes. That is why every facial expression and gesture must be recorded.

Japanese management consultant Takeda Tetsuo has noted that blinking not only reveals the other person’s current state but often also displays personality. Generally, people who blink frequently are narrow-minded and less trustworthy. When negotiating or entrusting matters to such individuals, it is best to speak directly.

The pupil’s response to interest is astonishingly sensitive. Dr. Edward H. Hais presented clinical findings at the annual meeting of the American Society of Medical Hypnosis: “When the eyes encounter something sufficiently pleasurable or stimulating, the pupils dilate rapidly and unconsciously.”

People have long known how to interpret inner states through pupillary change. Ancient Persian jewel merchants reportedly priced gems according to the size of a customer’s pupils upon seeing the jewelry. If a diamond’s brilliance caused pupil dilation, the merchant would quote a higher price.

During courtship the eyes are the most eloquent organs of emotion. When a man encounters a woman he admires, his pupils dilate involuntarily under the strong stimulus of desire; the woman intuitively reads the signal. Especially in dim light, accelerated dilation heightens mutual attraction and fosters romantic love.

In states of terror, tension, excitement, anger, or pain the pupils dilate; in states of disgust, fatigue, or annoyance they constrict tightly, producing a “laser-like gaze.” Absence of change indicates indifference or boredom toward the person or object viewed<|eos|>

## 6. Rolling the Eyes

Rolling the eyes is a fairly common eye expression. It involves complex eyeball movement and is in fact also a complex gaze-shift process.

The classic eye roll is often used to express contempt. If we slow-motion replay the action, several variations become visible:

1. When the eye roll begins from direct eye contact with the other person, the sequence is: eyelids close; then open while the gaze moves upward (partial sclera visible); the gaze then shifts from upward to the

side away from the stimulus, accompanied by a head turn; next the gaze moves downward on that same side; eyelids close again; finally the gaze settles to the side, either level or downward, or the head may turn back to re-establish contact with the stimulus.

2. When the eye roll begins with the face already turned sideways toward the other person, the sequence is: first shift the gaze toward the other person's side for a quick glance (without full eye contact); then move the gaze upward while closing the eyelids; then, as the eyelids reopen, shift the gaze again to the direction the face is already oriented toward, or even farther in the opposite direction.
3. When a girl rolls her eyes at her boyfriend in a coquettish rather than genuinely angry way, accompanied by lines such as "I hate you," an extra step appears: at the end the gaze returns to the other person's pupils, partly to convey sincerity (sometimes paired with a coy or domineering smile) and partly to check whether the playful message has been received.

For further reading, see [http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neuro-linguistic\\_programming](http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Neuro-linguistic_programming).

## **(2) Missing [Please Listen Carefully]**

The underlying thought is actually [You don't need to listen carefully]. Whether the other person is "listening carefully" feels unimportant. The speaker does not care whether the listener hears or responds and simply finishes speaking. At such moments the speaker also shows gaze aversion. Typical speech features include: volume and tone lack emphasis and may stay at a normal level or drop in energy; delivery is smooth and may be rapid. In short: this has nothing to do with you.

### **Specific examples:**

#### **Example 1:**

This pattern is common in meetings when issues are discussed. Democratic decision-making invites differing opinions; it is normal for people to disagree on the same question, and everyone tries to seek common ground while reserving differences. When a speaker knows the listener will not accept the idea yet still insists on stating it, gaze aversion often occurs: the speaker finishes the point without looking directly at the listener. The real inner state is: I'll say what I want; your disagreement is useless and I don't care about your view.

However, in the same meeting, if the stronger party is making a show of force or pressuring the dissenting side to understand and respond, the speaker will stare directly into the listener's eyes, conveying: Listen carefully—this is what I mean. What do you think? The subtext is: Don't have an opinion; even if you do, I won't listen; agreement is required immediately.

## **(1) Erroneous Summary of Left-Right Brain Division**

Earlier cognitive-psychology research concluded that the left hemisphere mainly handles speech, reading, writing, mathematical calculation, rote memory, logical reasoning, and symbolic thinking, while the right hemisphere mainly handles recognition of object size and shape, spatial cognition, map reading, face recognition, drawing composition, music, structural assembly, and perception of others' emotions.

More importantly, most human tasks are performed through coordinated activity of both hemispheres rather than exclusive control by one side. For instance, if memory is said to belong to the left hemisphere, to which side does visual memory belong? If visual information is processed by the right hemisphere, then drawing that mental image still requires logical and temporal sequencing—functions attributed to the left hemisphere. Likewise, musical notes are said to be processed mainly by the right hemisphere, yet composing and singing

songs require simultaneous participation of both sides. Recent brain-imaging studies have also revised the earlier, overly absolute claims about hemispheric specialization found in older textbooks.

Those seeking theoretical support for a fallacy make a first mistake: they glibly reduce brain findings to “left brain handles memory, right brain handles fabrication.” Setting aside whether creation, construction, and fabrication are synonymous, the reasoning itself is flawed. Further questions follow: What does the direction of eye movement have to do with hemispheric specialization?

## **5. Not Looking Directly at Someone**

Not looking directly means glancing sideways while keeping the face oriented toward the person being observed. This distorted gaze is discussed here for two reasons: first, the pupil is positioned to one side rather than centered, resembling lateral gaze shifts; second, it signals an unwillingness to look, just as gaze aversion signals a lack of sincerity.

Whenever genuine communication is intended or an unexpected stimulus prompts a search (for example, someone calling from the side), the head turns so the face can face the target as squarely as possible. Moving only the eyes without turning the head directly maps a relatively negative attitude (equivalent to unwillingness to look). The “unwillingness” here includes not only the usual connotations of aversion and rejection but also fear (stealing a glance while afraid of being noticed), disdain, and other negative intentions—all grouped under unwillingness.

Emotions and attitudes that commonly produce sidelong glances include: smug laughter (I am better/stronger/correcter than you), contempt (same), anxiety (concern or worry cannot be expressed openly), and disgust (direct rejection of the other person).

## **2. Eye Contact in Verbal Communication**

When speech is possible, mutual pupil contact marks the start of effective exchange—an implicit agreement between both parties. It is an agreement because both participants sense the significance of the mutual gaze and what it will trigger; it is a beginning because mutual gaze initiates the “full-duplex” communication process.

### **What is “full-duplex” communication?**

The term is borrowed from communications engineering. It means both parties can send and receive information simultaneously. A simpler explanation appears in Figure 10-10 below.

When two people discuss important information that matters to both, they begin with direct eye contact. In normal verbal exchange, mutual gaze conveys three messages:

1. [Speaker] I want to speak to you;
2. [Speaker] Please listen carefully;
3. [Listener] I am listening carefully.

Because communication is bidirectional, each person is simultaneously speaker and listener and therefore holds all three expectations. Interruption of mutual gaze occurs whenever any one of these expectations is missing.

## **2. Downward Gaze Shift**

In contrast to an upward gaze shift, a downward shift generally indicates that the person had already anticipated several possibilities and one of them has materialized. We can summarize the downward gaze shift as a mindset of endurance. It usually maps to relatively negative states such as guilt (feeling one is not good enough, has made a mistake, or bears responsibility), disagreement (combined with helplessness and inability to change the situation), anger (suppressed for the moment), or anxious thinking (searching for a way to answer a challenge).

Unlike the escape impulse signaled by an upward gaze, a downward gaze usually shows that the person knows escape is impossible and must simply endure until the moment passes or defeat occurs.

Even the downward glance that appears in shyness carries the same psychological mapping. Shyness is actually fear of seeing the other person's reaction—fear of learning that one is disliked—yet a strong desire for a positive outcome remains, so the pressure is endured.

#### **10.2.4 Gaze Aversion**

After mutual gaze, a shift in direction may signal subtle psychological change; the reasons have already been analyzed. We now examine the possible meanings of gaze shifts in each direction.

Before proceeding, however, a caution is necessary for those who would like to play God: any analysis of an individual's gaze aversion must first establish that person's habitual pattern (called the baseline in psychological testing). Different people, through long-term environmental adaptation and learning, develop different gaze-aversion habits. Therefore, determining the tested person's baseline is the correct first step. The following observations should never be applied mechanically.

Starting from mutual pupil contact, gaze can shift in four basic directions—up, down, left, right—and then combine into diagonals: upper-left, lower-left, upper-right, lower-right. Left and right, up and down are defined from the actor's perspective.

#### **(3) Correct Analytical Approach to Lateral Gaze Shifts**

The only certainty is that a lateral gaze shift indicates a neural command—whether deliberate, habitual, or instinctive—that interrupts the ongoing exchange. Analysis must compare the shift against each tested person's baseline.

Gaze aversion has no necessary connection to lying. Although it interrupts the current exchange, the reason may be preparation for better communication—recalling facts, logical reasoning, or calculation—or it may be fabrication or concealment. Lateral shifts can also be purely emotional, such as displeasure or disgust, with no complex thought involved, simply an unwillingness to continue the exchange.

#### **1. Upward Gaze Shift**

Based on actual testing, we find that an upward gaze shift can map to three psychological features:

- One is the signaling of elevated self-status, often used to express disdain and frequently paired with a "tsk" sound to form a contemptuous expression;
- Another is the signaling of "this has nothing to do with me" or "I am staying out of it," commonly seen when feigning innocence;

- The third, and most frequent, occurs when the tested person did not anticipate the question and begins to think on the spot, involuntarily rolling the eyes upward.

Both recall and fabrication have been observed to accompany upward shifts; even moderately difficult arithmetic problems in baseline testing can elicit upward eye movement during mental calculation.

### 3. Lateral Gaze Shift (Debunking a Widespread Myth)

A gaze shift to the left or right breaks the sincerity of direct pupil contact, yet no fixed mapping can be assigned to left versus right because individual habits differ.

A popular psychological claim states: "If someone is recalling an event, most people's eyes move left; if fabricating, the eyes move right." Proponents of this rule further explain it by reference to crossed hemispheric control and supposed functional specialization—left hemisphere for memory, right for creation. Many treat the rule as a valuable lie-detection tool. We now dismantle the myth.

#### (3) Missing [I Am Listening Carefully]

When the listener's true state is unwillingness to "listen carefully" or inability to do so because of embarrassment or other reasons, gaze aversion also appears.

Imagine the opposite: if the speaker's topic is something you want to hear—information affecting your personal interests, a disciplinary decision, a job appointment, or exciting gossip—you will maintain eye contact and listen to every word.

For uninteresting or unwelcome content, however, listeners choose to avert their gaze.

### 5. Looking Elsewhere

When someone looks away during conversation, it often means lack of interest or unfavorable feelings toward the other person. Looking elsewhere can also indicate inferiority or shyness. The eyes are the window to the soul; prolonged eye contact can expose inner thoughts. Therefore, if the other person cannot meet your gaze and keeps looking away, it may be because they are trying to hide a secret and fear you will see through them.

### 16. Strabismus

Strabismus has two causes: congenital or acquired. Congenital strabismus can sometimes be improved through eye-training exercises. Acquired strabismus, however, warrants extra caution in social interaction because most people who develop it are considered to have improper intentions, which also produce flickering or evasive glances. When a woman's eyes show strabismus combined with a backward glance, she is said to be changeable and unpredictable, which is considered unfavorable for marriage.

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

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See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

## **Eye Shape Interpretation**

### **22. Uneven Eyes**

People with uneven eyes are very cunning in their dealings. They are usually quite talented, have deep scheming, are good at strategizing, and handle matters with superb skill. This type of person has a volatile temperament and often experiences self-contradictory situations; their inner self is both inferior and stubborn; their emotional life or career tends to fluctuate and waver, but their financial luck is quite good. If a woman has uneven eyes, she is both talented and competitive, can make a good impression on the surface, can easily control and dominate others, and is also extremely skilled at hiding her shortcomings. However, people with uneven eyes are more likely to remarry. Generally speaking, if a man's left eye is larger, he is prone to discord with his father and wife, and has a tendency toward male chauvinism; if the right eye is larger, he will have no affinity with his mother, and may be afraid of his wife, and may also be more affectionate toward women other than his wife. If a woman has a larger left eye and smaller right eye, she is very likely to fear her husband and will work tirelessly for him. Overall, having the left eye larger than the right is relatively better, with better financial prospects, and those who fear their wives are more likely to gain a virtuous helper.

#### **c. Myopic Squinting Eyes**

The cause of nearsightedness is that when viewing near objects for long periods, the lens remains in a tense deformed state under the action of the ciliary muscle and has difficulty returning to normal. As a result, distant objects cannot form an image on the retina, creating nearsightedness.

Squinting the eyes forcefully allows the orbicularis oculi muscle to slightly alter the front-to-back circumference of the eyeball through compression, thereby mildly improving image quality. Therefore, nearsighted students who do not wear glasses will squint when they need to see something clearly, which helps to some degree. However, once the structure of the eyeball and the principles of image formation are understood, it becomes clear that only by engaging the ciliary muscle to flatten the lens can image quality truly be changed. Since the ciliary muscle is controlled by the autonomic nervous system and cannot be moved at will, squinting to compensate for nearsightedness is of limited help.

### **9. Double Eyelids: Warm and Outgoing**

People with double eyelids have an open and generous personality, and are candid and enthusiastic. Their minds are flexible and they adapt quickly. Although their eyes look attractive, they lack perseverance and patience in their work, are highly emotional, and tend to act on feelings. Double eyelids are classified by whether the eyelid is long or round. Those with long eyelids belong to the emotionally rich yet fragile type. They have poor resilience and resistance to setbacks, and lack perseverance and constancy. Those with round eyelids (where the central part of the eyelid curves upward into a rounder shape) have an open, innocent, and lively personality, but are also easily deceived and must therefore exercise extra caution. In addition, there is a rarer case of one single eyelid and one double eyelid. Such people tend to be rather contrary. For example, after deciding on something and having it approved by others, they may ultimately reject it themselves, showing a tendency toward self-contradiction and indecision.

### **24. Drooping Eye Corners**

People with drooping eye corners are strongly influenced by their childhood experiences and early education. If they receive a good education from a young age and develop noble character, they are more likely to become successful members of society. In social interactions, they usually benefit, often receiving help from others and support from benefactors, giving them a high chance of success. However, if their childhood was unhappy, they may develop a rebellious mindset. They become wary of others and do not trust people easily. If they enter business under these circumstances, they may act unscrupulously and to the detriment of others for personal gain. If a girl is born with drooping eye corners, her personality will be gentle and endearing; she will be affectionate, family-oriented, and a classic virtuous wife and mother.

### **8. Single Eyelids: Opinionated and Strong-Willed**

People with single eyelids are proactive, calm, and possess strong willpower. They have firm opinions, good judgment, and can endure hardship and setbacks. Most are introverted, highly self-respecting, somewhat suspicious, and occasionally display a timid side. In handling interpersonal matters, their excessive competitiveness and strong self-awareness can lead to disagreements and strained relationships. Girls with single eyelids tend to be shy and yearn for a steady, long-lasting relationship, so persistence is required when pursuing them.

### **10. Multiple Eyelids: Emotionally Rich**

Multiple layers of eyelids indicate that a person is emotionally rich. As their friend, one is sure to be valued by them and can form a deep, lasting bond. Even with acquaintances, they remain warm and likable. Their shortcoming is that they are sensitive and impulsive, often overthinking when they see others talking behind their backs, and may even join in to offer their own opinions. If the eyelids are of the inner double type,



emotional and rational sides are balanced, making this the best eyelid form and indicating a friend worth knowing well.

### **1. Eyes Wide Open**

If a person's eyes are wider than usual, with raised eyebrows and furrowed brow, it indicates anger. When someone stares directly at another person with tense eye muscles and tightly squinted eyelids, it shows intense anger. This action is meant to vent inner rage and to intimidate or threaten the other party. Additionally, if a person's eyes are wide open, mouth agape, and expression rigid, it generally signifies extreme fear or shock.

### **19. Peach Blossom Eyes**

This type of eye is always full of smiles, with the center of the lower eyelid curving upward in a crescent shape. The eyes appear bright and moist, conveying a captivating gaze. People with peach blossom eyes are romantic by nature, enjoy excellent opposite-sex relationships, and lead colorful emotional lives, yet they may also attract trouble. Women with peach blossom eyes tend to be easygoing and approachable, with little defensiveness. Their social skills are not strong, they find it hard to refuse others, and they are easily swayed by temptation.

### **20. Triangular Eyes**

As the name suggests, the eyes resemble triangles. Such people may appear fierce and give off a coercive impression. In fact, they are often cunning, competitive, aggressive, and unwilling to admit defeat; they may also be stubborn and hold extreme views. When a man has this eye shape, he may become a formidable figure like Cao Cao. A woman with this eye shape may dominate her husband after marriage.

### **12. Narrow Eye Spacing**

People whose eyes are close together act decisively and efficiently. They also have good eyesight and accurate vision. However, they tend to be introverted, narrow-minded, impatient, and often gloomy or overly anxious. Although their gaze is sharp, it lacks long-term vision; they focus on immediate gains. They are prone to suspicion and jealousy, are calculating, lack persistence, and are changeable.

### **13. Wide Eye Spacing**

Generally, the ideal spacing between the eyes equals the length of one eye. People with wider spacing have a broader field of vision, are open-minded and mild-mannered, and tend to encounter more opportunities than others. They are tolerant, handle relationships well, and are well-liked. It should be noted that if the spacing is excessively wide, the person may be overly timid, hesitant, and inactive.

### **7. Many Worries**

People who harbor many worries show numerous wrinkles at the outer corners of the eyes. They carry too many troubles and experience ups and downs in their emotional lives. Because they overthink, they may appear somewhat neurotic. They are also vain, self-centered, have weak self-control, weak ethical standards, and lack a sense of responsibility.

### 17. Knife-Cut Outer Eye Corners

Such people are talented in both civil and military affairs, emotionally refined, conscientious, quick-witted, insightful into human nature, and magnanimous and refined in character, handling matters comprehensively. A woman with this eye shape makes a capable and supportive partner. People whose inner eye corners are sharply hooked like a bird's beak have good memory and can handle many different types of work.

### 21. Deep-Set Heavy Eyes

Small or deeply recessed eyes are called heavy eyes. Most people with heavy eyes inherit the trait. Small eyes indicate a narrow field of vision, so the personality tends to be stubborn, selfish, conservative, and suspicious. Yet they are also tenacious, unwilling to give up or admit defeat, and possess perseverance, which can bring them certain rewards.

### 18. Watery Eyes

Eyes that appear moist and glistening are very appealing, especially in girls. Such people have richer emotional lives than their peers and may occasionally act in ways that seem inconsistent with their appearance. Because their looks are endearing, they form particularly good connections with the opposite sex.

### 23. Upward-Tilted Eye Corners

These individuals have strong persistence. Once they set a goal, they move forward resolutely, remain undisturbed by external factors, stay calm, and hold firm beliefs. In girls, this trait may lead to indecision in love; due to insecurity, they easily develop jealousy, which can cause relationships to end.

## Basic Emotions in the Eyes

### 3. Eyes Lighting Up

Usually, when a person is happy, especially surprised, the phenomenon of "eyes lighting up" appears. The cause of this phenomenon is not an illusion; the eyes truly become "brighter."

When surprised, the eyes widen, exposing a larger area of both the iris and the sclera (the white of the eye). On one hand, the overall reflective surface increases; on the other, positive stimuli cause pupil dilation, and combined with the pigmented iris, the contrast between this darker region and the lighter sclera becomes more pronounced, making the eyes appear brighter. In addition, the increased blood circulation from excitement does, to some extent, add energy to the eyes, which also contributes positively to their brightness.

Conversely, most sad eyes (assuming no grief or indignation) give the impression of a dull gaze. This is essentially the reverse of the above: the exposed area of the eyeball decreases due to eyelid closure, the contrast between light and dark regions weakens, and without the micro-circulatory changes brought by excitement, the eyes naturally appear lifeless.

### 4. The Gaze of Fear

When facing a fear stimulus, people often exhibit a distinctive eye movement—rapid, multi-directional shifts of the eyeballs.

This action is difficult to fake; it is not impossible, but hard to perform convincingly. Only the alertness triggered by fear prompts the high-frequency eye movements that allow quick attention to every change in the surroundings—an evolved instinct.

The value of this stress micro-expression lies in the fact that the frequency of changes in gaze direction is directly proportional to the degree of inner fear.

See Eyes (c-eyes).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

## Nose

### II. Psychological Signals from the Nose

People's understanding of the nose often centers on its role in breathing. Many have experienced the urge to sneeze in an environment with an unusual or strong scent, at which point the sensitive nose responds with corresponding expansion and contraction.

The nose, in its shape, relates to a person's temperament. As one of the five sensory organs, it is the least mobile part of the face. Although its expressions are fewer than those of the eyes or other organs, the nose possesses its own distinct language with very clear meanings. Therefore, people can discern another's inner thoughts from the subtle language of the nose.

In daily life, we can "observe the heart through the nose." Minor changes in the nose may reveal your true inner thoughts. If you observe those around you, you will notice that some people's noses sweat easily, perhaps indicating they are in a tense or constrained environment—this is a sign of psychological agitation. Others may suddenly see their noses turn pale, reflecting a very negative emotional state manifesting physiologically in the nose. In addition, when people are angry, their nostrils flare outward involuntarily, signaling that they are forcefully suppressing negative emotions.

Even a small nose can reveal many bodily secrets during conversation.

1. **Wrinkling the nose:** The person finds your conversation or behavior distasteful

When someone violates traffic rules, spits on the ground, encounters an irritating odor, or hears statements they disagree with, people often make a "sniffing" expression. The nose twitches slightly upward with obvious expansion and contraction. These subtle changes represent the nose owner's psychological reaction of venting inner dissatisfaction or disgust, and these inner activities are openly betrayed by the nose's movements.

2. **Flaring nostrils:** The person is angry and experiencing dissatisfaction

The Chinese idiom "seven orifices emitting smoke" describes extreme anger. When angry, a person's nostrils generally flare outward. During anger or while forcefully suppressing inner emotions, people breathe more air to relieve inner agitation, causing the nostrils to expand with small but noticeable opening and closing movements. If you misspeak during a conversation, watch whether the other person's nose shows these signs and remedy your mistake promptly.

3. **Sweating nose:** The person is in a state of tension or agitation

Generally, if someone whose nose does not normally sweat easily suddenly begins to sweat, it indicates that their environment is making them feel tense or agitated, with psychological emotions subtly

manifesting on the nose. When facing sudden changes or problems that must be solved, people become involuntarily tense, and the tip of the nose begins to sweat. Sometimes this physiological sign appears when people try to hide inner anxiety or cover up a mistake.

4. **Change in nose color:** The person's mood is negative and they are in a withdrawn state. Many ask whether the nose can change color. In normal circumstances, the nose does not change color unless a health issue arises or inner emotions fluctuate significantly. A sudden paling of the nose indicates the person has suffered a major blow, had their self-esteem wounded, or feels guilt. Reddening of the nose warrants attention to personal health, as long-term alcohol consumption, excessive spicy food, endocrine disorders, cardiovascular disease, or abnormal liver function can cause the nose to redden or darken.

5. **Touching the nose:** The person is concealing the truth and feels resistance or hesitation. Many have seen the American drama *Lie to Me*, in which Dr. Cal Lightman solves a complex criminal case by reading the micro-expression of nose-touching. Psychology holds that touching the nose is a very subtle action that reveals much about inner psychological activity. First, if you ask someone for help during a conversation and they unconsciously touch their nose, you can infer they feel resistance to your request, even if they verbally agree. Second, if the other person keeps touching their nose while you discuss a topic, it basically shows they are not interested, and you should tactfully switch to a more engaging subject. Finally, when facing temporarily unsolvable problems, people may unconsciously touch their noses to give themselves psychological comfort or to hide their true thoughts.

Note that touching the bridge of the nose indicates deep thought and inner struggle, not necessarily concealment. These subtle differences can lead to different interpretations of the information revealed.

## Never Scratch Your Nose When Lying

Have you ever felt an itch in your nose while lying and unconsciously touched it to relieve the discomfort? Remember the protagonist Pinocchio in the classic Italian fairy tale *The Adventures of Pinocchio*? Whenever he lied, his nose grew longer.

Several American scientists recently discovered that the saying "lying makes the nose grow" is not groundless. They explain that when a person lies, anxiety increases blood flow to the nose, causing slight swelling. Although this change may not be obvious and others might not notice it with the naked eye, the liar feels an itch from the nasal tissue congestion and scratches it.

The scientists even studied Bill Clinton's testimony to the grand jury regarding the Monica Lewinsky affair. They found that Clinton rarely touched his nose when telling the truth, but whenever he lied, his brow would furrow slightly before the lie, and he touched his nose once every four minutes, totaling 26 touches during the testimony.

Drawing on accumulated experience and extensive field practice, FBI agents also consider touching or lightly rubbing the nose (usually with the index finger) a typical lying expression.

Many years ago, the late renowned body-language expert Professor Ray L. Birdwhistell discussed a book he had written with a young man. When the professor asked the young man's opinion of the book, the young man rubbed his nose and said he liked it very much.

Professor Birdwhistell smiled and said, "You're lying. You don't like the book at all." The young man was stunned, but he did not understand how he had given himself away and had to admit he had only read a few

pages before finding the writing “really dull.”

It was unfortunate for the young man that he rubbed his nose in front of a body-language expert.

Nose-touching is a common gesture, but does every instance mean the speaker is lying? Jiang Zhenyu, head of the China University of Political Science and Law micro-reaction research group and lecturer of the “Psychological Stress Micro-reaction” course, answered on the program *Extraordinary Knowledge*: “When reading people through micro-expressions, one must also consider whether this is a momentary unconscious reaction and not rigidly apply micro-expression dogma. Some people habitually touch their noses; this cannot be judged as lying.” Moreover, directly interpreting nose-touching while speaking as “wanting to hide something” would be unfair to those with rhinitis!

Therefore, we should not interpret every gesture so absolutely. Determining whether someone is lying requires combining other lying indicators. Sometimes the other person touches their nose simply because of pollen allergy, a cold, or discomfort from glasses pressing on it.

However, there remains a clear difference between rubbing the nose due to discomfort and touching it due to lying. Rubbing due to discomfort is forceful, while touching due to lying is very gentle—usually a quick rub along the lower edge of the nose with the hand, sometimes just a light touch that is almost imperceptible. The latter action also appears elegant and is often accompanied by other gestures such as crossed arms, fidgeting, or rapid blinking.

“In fact, when we see the nose-touching gesture, if we can confirm the other person has no nasal discomfort, we can work backward to conclude that the person is excited (or nervous). The key is to analyze why this physiological change occurred. What caused the excitement (or tension)? Was it the question you asked, the answer they gave, something that happened earlier, or a situation that might occur later? Combining these contextual factors and ruling out purely physiological causes such as illness may reveal what the nose-toucher is nervous about,” Dr. Jiang Zhenyu further explained.

In any case, we must remind you: next time you lie, never scratch your nose!

## Section 1: The Most Temperamental Nose

A Chinese saying states that “appearance is born from the heart,” meaning a person’s temperament can be seen in their facial features. Many begin observing a person from their appearance, and people usually look at the eyes first because a pair of clear, bright eyes do not lie; one can observe character and temperament from the gaze. In truth, the nose, like the eyes, can reveal personality and temperament, yet people often overlook observing the nose.

In ancient times, many scholars and Taoists predicted people’s futures through facial reading or divination, including a so-called “nose-reading technique.” It was said that one could understand a person’s character, temperament, and fate from the length, width, tilt, and protrusion of the nose, giving rise to the saying “the nose gathers wealth.” These ancient nose-reading techniques may seem mysterious and unscientific to modern people. However, the nose, located at the center of the face and one of the five sensory organs, allows us to scientifically observe its changes and discern temperament and psychological activity from its subtle shifts.

Physiologically, the nose is one of the respiratory passages. In Roy Hess’s *Human Aesthetics*, it is noted: “Since Aristotle, people have believed that the nose is closely related to character, and it is the earliest organ to form in the human embryo, also regarded as a symbol of beauty.” Thus, the nose plays a vital role in facial features.

“Sniffing” describes disdain or contempt for certain people or matters, while “nostrils pointing to the sky” describes arrogant individuals. Therefore, the nose is indeed closely linked to inner emotions. In daily life, we can observe inner emotional fluctuations and psychological activity through breathing-induced changes in the nose’s shape and color, because inadvertent nasal changes often most fully and truthfully reflect what people are thinking.

In the animal kingdom, animals without language maintain contact and communication within their groups through various actions, including using the nose to express inner emotions. Biological research reports indicate that animals habitually bare their teeth to show anger and signal an attack. At the same time, an angry animal’s nostrils flare to allow the lungs to take in more oxygen, enabling them to enter a tense fight-or-flight state. When animals are angry, their nostrils flare; humans, when expressing anger, also exhibit this alongside language or body movements. In addition, people’s casual nose movements reveal different emotional changes. Understanding the information conveyed by the nose is increasingly important for social interaction in daily life. To gain an advantage in social situations, one must know both oneself and others by fully understanding the emotions hidden deep within.

The nose is a window into a person’s temperament. Generally, a person with a peaceful mind shows no change in the nose. If the other person’s nose slightly expands during conversation, it indicates inner feelings of pride, anger, or fear—perhaps they are restraining or suppressing their true emotions. If the other person touches their nose from time to time while talking with you, you should consider whether they are concealing the truth or disagreeing with what you said. This is a compulsive action that is generally difficult to hide. Research shows that when lying, psychological suggestion increases blood flow to the nose, causing it to swell and itch. In addition, when nervous, the nose may sweat unconsciously or change color. These subtle nasal changes can help people understand the other person’s true psychological state.

Thus, like the other sensory organs, the nose has its own unique expressive language, and these subtle expressions reveal bodily and psychological secrets.

## How the Nose Expresses Emotions

Alfred recently wrote me a letter saying: “...I applied the people-reading techniques you taught me to sales, and my performance has been excellent lately—even my boss finds it unbelievable. Thank you so much! I now find work truly enjoyable.” His performance, once average, has now risen to second in the entire company. This once again gave me and my theory.

The above is merely a brief interlude before entering the theme of this section. What I want to discuss next is the nose. Yes, this part that you may have overlooked can also convey a great deal of silent information.

Have you ever noticed the noses of Africans? Most are short and flat with wide nostrils; I call this the “concave-type nose.” People from cold regions are the opposite: Anglo-Saxon noses are usually long, allowing thin cold air to warm slightly in the nasal cavity before entering the lungs. Therefore, nasal features are closely related to lung function. Generally, people with strong lung function have larger noses. These individuals often have well-developed motor skills, lively personalities, decisive actions, and strong ambition. Being with them, you feel full of sunshine and vitality. Conversely, people with weak lung function have smaller nostrils, lack ambition, dabble in everything without depth, and most are lazy.

To help you better understand the secrets of the nose, I have specially prepared the following table for your reference.

| Name           | Physical Features                                                            | Personality and Psychological Traits                                                                                                                                                |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Small nose     | Short nasal bridge, small nostrils                                           | Cheerful personality; insufficient willpower, easily influenced; most are relatively lazy and lack the courage to change their lives                                                |
| Greek nose     | Long, straight nasal bridge forming a sloping straight line, high nose shape | High taste, good understanding of art, pursuit of beauty and nobility; very confident but prone to pride, giving an impression of being difficult to approach; some prefer solitude |
| Depressed nose | Nasal bridge not straight but concave                                        | Cheerful personality, can be close even with strangers                                                                                                                              |
| Straight nose  | Nasal bridge straight, nose shape lower than Greek nose                      | Relatively selfish, pays attention to details; rational, smoother at work; popular with the opposite sex but also easily abandoned                                                  |
| Aquiline nose  | Shaped like an eagle's beak, tip hooked downward                             | Cold and fierce personality, very greedy                                                                                                                                            |
| Broken nose    | Nasal bridge shows a break in the middle                                     | Quite stubborn, difficult to compromise; strong aggression in personality, easily offends others                                                                                    |
| Fleshy nose    | Thick flesh                                                                  | Obsessed with money, willing to endure curses, typical miser; smooth in dealings, flexible in social interactions                                                                   |

The nose undergoes certain changes in specific situations. For example, when stimulated by an odor, the nostrils expand noticeably and the entire nose may tremble slightly. From a medical perspective, when a person is excited or tense, breathing and heartbeat accelerate, causing nostril expansion. Therefore, if the other person's nose enlarges during conversation, there are usually three possibilities: pride, dissatisfaction, or suppression of emotion. Additionally, a sweating nose tip indicates inner anxiety or tension, so the side with a sweating nose tip during negotiations often loses. Wrinkling the nose indicates disgust; "humming" through the nose indicates disdain and rejection; trembling the nose indicates tension. Another interesting phenomenon is that when a person experiences negative emotions such as fear, apprehension, embarrassment, or unease, the nose turns pale.

Thus, although the nose is the least dynamic facial organ, it still hints at much information. Combining nasal characteristics with those of other parts helps you more accurately detect the other person's inner thoughts.

### Touching the Nose May Indicate Lying

When a person lies, even if they try their hardest to conceal it, some flaws will always show. For example, when someone frequently touches their nose, they are likely lying.

"My dear child, lies are easy to spot because there are only two kinds: one with short legs and one with a long nose. The lie you told has a long nose." These are words from the famous fairy tale *Pinocchio*. In the world of this tale, whenever the protagonist Pinocchio lies, his nose grows longer.

Scientists at the Smell & Taste Treatment and Research Foundation in Chicago, USA, discovered that when people lie, they release a chemical substance called catecholamine, which causes the cells inside the nasal

cavity to swell. Using special imaging equipment that displays blood flow inside the body, the scientists also revealed that during lying, a person's nose enlarges due to increased blood flow, raising the internal temperature of the nasal cavity. This causes the nose to swell and produce an itchy sensation, so people can only frequently rub their noses with their hands to relieve the itch. Therefore, touching the nose is a relatively common body movement when a person lies.

When lying, the insular cortex of the brain, which regulates body temperature, is activated; this is the main mechanism behind the rise in nose-tip temperature. The cerebral hemispheres are divided into five lobes: frontal, parietal, occipital, temporal, and insular. The insular lobe is triangular and island-shaped, located deep in the lateral sulcus and covered by the frontal, parietal, occipital, and temporal lobes. It is closely related to the brain's reward mechanism, helping convert a person's desires for other things into "actions that achieve satisfaction." The insula becomes active when a person experiences real feelings. When someone exerts every effort to psychologically suggest to themselves that they are not lying, their nose-tip temperature gradually returns to normal levels.

American psychiatrist Charles Wolf and neurologist Alan Hirsch conducted an in-depth study of Bill Clinton's testimony to the jury regarding the Monica Lewinsky scandal. They were surprised to find that Clinton generally did not touch his nose when telling the truth. However, every time he lied, before the lie was even spoken, his brow would inadvertently furrow slightly, and he touched his nose once every four minutes, reaching a total of 26 touches during the testimony. Ultimately, the scientists concluded that several signs, including nose-touching, indicated that many of Clinton's statements were lies.

Touching the nose is a very common small action. Not only lying can prompt a person to touch their nose; other reasons may also cause it. For example, some people touch their nose simply because of pollen allergies, a cold, or discomfort from pressure by eyeglasses. Another example: when a person is in a state of unease, anxiety, or anger, the blood vessels in their nasal cavity also expand, and nose-touching may occur. Therefore, this is an auxiliary means to determine whether the other person is lying, not a definitive method.

When identifying whether someone is lying, other lying indicators must also be combined for interpretation. Because the purpose of touching the nose is self-soothing to relieve anxiety, and the source of anxiety does not necessarily come from lying. A simple example: in a noisy environment, some people are inherently prone to anxiety and will subconsciously rest their chin on their hand; the purpose is similar to touching the nose while speaking. Therefore, always remember this rule: simple nasal itching usually only triggers the single gesture of repeatedly rubbing the nose, with no connection to the content, frequency, or rhythm of the conversation; if some connection exists between them, you should be alert to the content of their speech.

## **Listening to the Nose's Voice**

If there is a stranger around us, it is difficult for everyone to instantly judge them before they speak, because accent is an important basis for people to identify their compatriots. But accents can be learned and imitated; many actors are very good at speaking various dialects, yet people can still detect that this is a stranger. What is their basis? In fact, the nose plays a major role here.

When a person enters an unfamiliar environment, they can learn the local people's expressions, but they cannot fully relax their emotions as if among acquaintances. Nervous tension will still manifest in their body and expressions. In micro-expression changes, a person's discomfort with the environment can appear in the eyes, eyebrows, and corners of the mouth, but these parts are very easy to observe, so someone who deliberately wants to conceal themselves will block these signals. The nose, however, has never been noticed.



Even if people in tense, unfamiliar environments have their accents corrected, they still cannot hide their nasal tone.

Nasal tone can be considered a very special signal among nose expressions. People who are conservative in thought and unwilling to break through themselves or change their current situation generally exhibit nasal tone. This is because they try hard to control their voice and nasal cavity; overly tense muscles make the area around the nose tight, the voice begins to be pushed backward, and nasal tone ultimately forms.

In addition to assisting the oral cavity in producing nasal sounds, the nose itself has its own way of vocal expression. Its unique structure gives the nose innate conditions for sound production. When stimulated by the outside world, the nose emits sounds in its own unique language, the most common being a sneeze.

Sneezing has physiological causes. Stimulation of the nasal mucosa from external sources or from a cold makes sneezing irresistible. Different irritating odors give sneezes many different meanings. Before sneezing, the nose shows frequent trembling accompanied by muscle twitching; a loud sneeze sends a clear signal: I don't like this smell! This can be considered the most passionate of all the nose's emotional expressions.

When people are in a state of sadness and begin to shed tears and cry, tears always attract maximum attention in an exaggerated way, and the wailing mouth is also an important component of crying, but the nose will also produce its own sound at such times. In a crying person, the nose emits a "sniff sniff" sound through constant twitching. The appearance of such a sound indicates that the person has received relatively strong stimulation and a high degree of emotional suppression; it serves as a judgment standard and signal for the level of grief. Sometimes, after the performance of tears and wailing ends, people may still remain in a state of sadness; at this time the nose will continue to emit twitching sounds to express its own inescapable low mood.

Sometimes the nose can reveal a person's true inner thoughts through sound. When a person expresses a skeptical attitude, the nose will be slightly raised, and at the same time a "tsk" sound will be emitted from the nasal cavity. Although they have not spoken, this sound is the clearest expression of their stance; the person producing this breath sound is clearly taking a negative attitude toward others' opinions.

### III. Never Touch Your Nose When Lying

The nose has many forms of language. If you observe carefully, you can read from the nose's small movements many inner worlds that people deliberately try to hide. Among the many micro-expressions of the nose, the action of touching the nose must be mentioned. It is another characteristic of people when lying, in addition to facial or body language. If, when you ask someone a question, they hesitate and accompany it with a nose-touching action, you should consider whether they are concealing something about the matter you asked.

Long ago, Italian writer Carlo Collodi created *Pinocchio*. In the story, the young protagonist Pinocchio is a puppet; as soon as he lies, his nose grows longer. Although this is merely a fabricated fairy tale, it inadvertently illustrates that there is a certain connection between lying and the nose.

When people lie, many psychological reactions manifest physically. Some blush when lying, some dare not look the other person in the eye, and some involuntarily touch their nose. There are many examples in life. When football legend Pelé discussed his divorce again, out of a desire to conceal the truth, he involuntarily "stroked his nose" while answering reporters' questions to relieve his inner psychological burden. Former U.S. President Bush also made nose-touching movements when reviewing domestic affairs and answering

reporters' questions about the Iraq War, prompting outside speculation about whether Bush's words concealed the actual situation. The act of touching the nose when lying is actually a manifestation of the "Pinocchio" effect.

The "Pinocchio" effect, simply put, is that during lying a person's nose enlarges due to increased blood flow; the instantaneous rise in blood pressure causes the nose to swell, which in turn causes nerve endings in the nasal cavity to transmit an itchy sensation. The person then lightly touches the nose with their hand to relieve the itch. This effect was summarized by scientists at the Smell & Taste Treatment and Research Foundation in Chicago through repeated clinical experiments. According to research results, when a person lies, a chemical substance called catecholamine is released, causing the cells inside the nasal cavity to swell. This proves that when lying, blood pressure rises and triggers a series of tiny bodily changes, including the nose-touching action.

The nose-touching action is very small and will not be noticed if one does not observe carefully, yet although the movement is small, it reveals your true inner situation and especially easily lets others know you are lying.

**Warm Reminder:** Touching the nose is a very common action, but not every instance of nose-touching absolutely means the other person is lying. Sometimes it may be because the other person has a cold or because the surrounding environment has caused nasal allergies, both of which can produce nose-touching actions. To determine whether the other person is lying while touching their nose, one must also combine context, speaking rhythm, and other body language for auxiliary identification.

### **The Nose's Expressions Are Ever-Changing**

Observe the animals around you; many of them have flexible noses. A dog's nose is almost the most sensitive among all animals. Humans have used police dogs' noses to solve drug cases, allowing them to achieve repeated remarkable feats. Although the human nose does not possess such sensitive sensation, it is equally indispensable among micro-expressions. Whether expressing joy or conveying sadness, the nose has not fallen behind because of its structure.

When a person who has been busy all day returns home and smells the aroma of food, their joyful emotion is expressed not only through the eyes and mouth. When people are joyful, the nose performs noticeable expansion and contraction movements. Although the amplitude is not large, for a nose of this structure it already counts as a very passionate expression. This action frequently appears on people whose emotions are high; even without smelling the aroma of food, the nose's expansion and contraction will occur with similar amplitude. This manifestation of joyful emotion can also be conveyed through the slight flaring and gentle fluttering of the nostrils.

People often call arrogant individuals "looking at people through the nostrils." Although the nostrils do not possess the structure or function to look at people, during the emotional expression of arrogant people they very much like to play this role. A person who holds their head high conveys an attitude of disdain and pride; their raised-head appearance is exactly as if they are lifting their own nose high. In daily life, people who frequently hold their noses high are mostly aloof and unsociable individuals.

In addition to the various expressions it performs itself, the nose's expressions are also accompanied by coordination with other body parts: when frowning in displeasure, the nose also contracts along with the furrowed brows; when people smell an odor they dislike, they cover their nose with their hand. The action of covering the nose with the hand is a transmission of disgust emotion. Even without odor stimulation, people

may still perform this action because they have seen someone they dislike or heard something they do not want to hear; this action has long become a way of transmitting unpleasant emotions.

Just as covering the nose with the hand is a covert transmission of unpleasant emotion, many of the nose's expressions are relatively covert. When communicating with others and wanting to understand their micro-expressions through the nose, one must have more patience and more meticulous observation.

### **The Nose That Stands Out Amid Calm**

Although the nose occupies the geographically optimal central position on our face, many people have not paid attention to its expressions.

When you recall some impressive expression made by someone in your memory, you will find that the nose is always a part you cannot ignore. Even if you have not deliberately noticed it, it simply has this ability to become an important member of expression performance in the process of remaining obscure.

Among organs that transmit emotions, we often prefer to focus attention on the eyes and lips because these two parts are truly adept at expressing themselves. They are unrestrained and arrogant one by one, with exaggerated movements and the largest amplitude; their ever-changing modes of expression make it impossible for your eyes to leave them. Standing silently beside them is the nose. The human facial muscle structure gives the nose very little movement space; it does not have much exclusive expressive language. For this reason, the nervous system's distribution has also overlooked it and has not given it much "screen time."

But in reality, is the nose truly as bland and devoid of expressive desire as we think? You are wrong; it is the facial expression organ most likely to stand out amid calm.

Because the nose appears wooden in its performance, many people ignore it. Yet FBI researchers skilled in micro-expression studies have not let it slip away easily. They discovered that the human nose can almost be considered the most honest among all expression organs, because it is not good at disguising and is not easy to disguise; its reactions to external stimuli are always the most direct.

Although the nose's own structure appears insufficiently refined, the nasal cavity, as an important channel for communication between the human body and the outside world, is densely packed with many nerve endings. They can sense changes in the surrounding environment through breath and temperature, which are then manifested in the owner's facial movements. No one would think the nose also has a sensitive side; its muscle twitching and emotional expressions are most synchronized with the body's excitement and panic. At least from current scientific research results, the nose is very willing to participate in micro-expressions.

### **Pinching the Bridge of the Nose Is an Act of Deep Thought**

If a person pinches the bridge of their nose with their hand, it often indicates that this person is focusing on and deeply considering the decision they are about to make. A person experiencing intense inner struggle will lower their head very low while pinching the bridge of their nose with their hand, as if to check whether they are truly in a predicament or whether this is merely a nightmare.

If we are asked a question that is difficult to answer, in order to conceal inner confusion and reluctantly produce an answer to cope, our hand will usually unconsciously move to the nose, touching it, pinching it, rubbing it, or even pressing and squeezing it with particular force, in a posture of "it's really difficult to ask me to answer."

When a person does this, it is best for us to remain quiet and wait for them to raise objections to the matter under discussion. We must make them understand that we acknowledge their feelings, will not apply any pressure to make them quickly emerge from thinking, and will patiently wait for them to voice their doubts<|eos|>

## The Nose Also Reveals Hidden Intentions

**Micro-expression Keywords** The nose, as a respiratory organ, plays an important role in the human body. However, recently it has been discovered that different types of noses can reflect people's different personalities and hidden intentions. Some even say that if the shape of the nose changes, the personality will change accordingly.

Freud said in *The Aesthetics of the Human Body*: "A nose that is thin and pointed indicates a bad temper; a long and thin nose indicates a frivolous person; a person with a lion nose is easily deceived; a person with a hooked nose will never suffer a loss..." As soon as his remarks came out, people discussed them extensively. By the time of Aristotle, many began to believe that the nose is closely related to personality.

Modern psychologists have proven through research that different types of noses can reflect different personalities and hidden intentions. According to the clinical experience of a Japanese doctor: "Once a person undergoes rhinoplasty, those who were previously introverted often become stubborn individuals."

## One, The Nose and Temperament

Napoleon once said: "Give me a person whose nose should be large and full... Whenever I need to find someone to complete any useful mental work, if there is no other suitable candidate, I always choose someone with a long nose." From Napoleon's description, we can easily see that it is not without reason that people usually regard those with large and full noses as powerful or wealthy individuals. In addition, people believe that those with aquiline noses are very wise and intelligent, and also have a certain influence. The famous detective Sherlock Holmes is a typical representative of this.

As the saying goes, things resemble their owners. A person's facial features can all reveal their personality traits. Just from the shape of the nose, one can roughly know a person's temperament. So, what types are there approximately? The following is an analysis of different nose shapes and people's temperaments.

## Nose Wrinkling Indicates Disgust

A wrinkled nose usually indicates disgust (from mild dissatisfaction to extreme disgust), seemingly suggesting that the person has smelled a particularly bad odor.

Describing common behaviors indicating disgust as "turning up one's nose" is most appropriate. This action clearly conveys a person's dislike and opposition. Even infants instinctively turn their heads away from disliked food, as if avoiding the unpleasant smell, while adults tend to tilt their heads back.

Sometimes, a person's wrinkled nose also indicates they are deep in thought and dissatisfied with one of their ideas.

## Bag Nose

The nose is high, the bridge has a slight arc, the tip droops into a hook shape, and the wings are thick without exposed nostrils. Based on the shrewd and profitable character of Jewish merchants, this type of nose is also called a “Jewish nose.” People with this nose shape have a strong desire for money. For money, they can abandon everything—status, reputation, even human relations and morality—regardless of being reviled.

The nose sits at the center of the face, standing tall, connecting to the forehead above and the philtrum below. Its shape also clearly tells us what kind of personality its owner has.

### **Flared Nostrils Indicate Frustration or Anger**

When a person’s nostrils flare, it indicates that a confrontation is about to occur. Psychologists generally believe that when people are frustrated or angry, their breathing becomes rapid and deep, and widened nostrils are the body’s way of taking in more oxygen, signaling preparation for a fight.

Animals behave similarly. A rancher in Texas once told us that an angry bull flares its nostrils and snorts loudly through them before charging. This is a serious warning that must be taken seriously.

### **Does Your Nose Attract Wealth**

From the perspective of physiognomy, the nose is usually no less important than the eyebrows and eyes. The “wealth palace” refers to the nose, representing a person’s lifelong fortune and career. Having a “good nose” means having a “golden” future.

*The Complete Book of Divine Physiognomy* records: “The nose is the wealth star, residing in the earth mansion. If it is straight like a hanging tube or an ox gall bladder, it brings a thousand granaries and ten thousand chests. If it is upright and full, one will be wealthy throughout life. If it is centered and unbiased, one will enjoy continuous prosperity. An aquiline tip like a hawk’s beak brings financial loss and poverty.” We can observe a person’s nose to predict their wealth and temperament.

## **6. Aquiline Nose**

In many character illustrations, the figures have aquiline noses. Their noses resemble a hawk’s beak, with the tip drooping downward in a hook shape; the nostrils are barely visible from the front. Such people have quick minds, meticulous thinking, strong adaptability, and abundant energy. They can handle sudden and complex situations. The famous detective Sherlock Holmes and former British Prime Minister Tony Blair are representatives of the aquiline nose. People with aquiline noses are usually cold and cruel, and they prefer solitude. They constantly seek new sources of stimulation because they refuse to settle for the ordinary.

## **10. Rounded Nose Tip**

People with rounded nose tips are typical extroverted socialites. They are eloquent, kind to others, and possess sympathy and human warmth. They know how to maintain balance in relationships. Their optimistic and cheerful outlook helps them make many friends. If they leverage their diplomatic skills, they can achieve great success in their careers. However, such people tend to treat matters without proper priority and often start strong but finish weak. Their moods are unpredictable, with tempers that flare and fade quickly. In addition, their lack of wariness often leads them to be deceived.

## **3. Greek Nose**

Greek sculptures often feature noses with a straight, sloping bridge, so they are called "Greek noses." People with Greek noses have high taste, excellent appreciation for beauty and noble arts, strong self-confidence, and lofty ideals. They are typical idealists who handle affairs methodically and earn widespread admiration. At the same time, they tend to be reserved in speech, and their natural arrogance can make others keep their distance.

## **2. Long Nose**

People with long noses have temperaments opposite to those with short noses. They are rational, possess strong self-esteem and a sense of responsibility, and do not allow others to tarnish their reputation or pursuits. They deliberate carefully and act cautiously, showing strong obsessive tendencies. Because they insist on considering everything thoroughly, they often overlook other matters, giving an impression of arrogance, and their social skills appear weaker. There is a folk saying that women with long noses usually marry well and live long lives.

## **Short and Low Nose**

Such people have cheerful personalities, but their willpower is not very firm. They are relatively lazy and lack the courage to change their lives. If they fail at something, it is hard for them to recover. If they come from a poor background, they may muddle through life without achievement. They have few ideas of their own and are easily influenced by others, making them relatively easy to persuade. If female, they tend to lack ethical standards and are easily taken advantage of by men.

## **1. Short Nose**

People with relatively short noses are generally straightforward, simple, and honest, like children who cannot easily distinguish right from wrong. They often lack cunning and give others a relaxed, comfortable feeling. Such individuals are cheerful but lack deep consideration. When facing external temptations, they are easily swayed and may act impulsively. This trait is especially pronounced in women.

## **Straight Nose**

This nose shape forms a straight line, neither too low nor very high, and appears comfortable to the eye. Such people have clear minds and generally enjoy smooth progress in work and career. They also have good luck with the opposite sex, though they are prone to being abandoned. At the same time, they tend to be overly concerned with minor details in everything they do, and they are somewhat selfish, thinking more of themselves than of others.

## **The Nose Enlarges When Lying**

Did you know that your nose enlarges when you lie? The body's reaction to lying is that extra blood flows to the face. Some people's entire face turns red, and the nose may swell by a few millimeters. Of course, this swelling is invisible to the naked eye, but the liar feels discomfort in the nose and unconsciously touches it—this is a sign of lying.

## **4. High and Straight Nose**

Ancient texts describe an upright nose as an "isolated peak standing alone." People with this nose shape are upright and full, confident, capable, and clear-headed. They achieve considerable success in their careers and can be considered outstanding individuals. However, they have high standards, like to haggle over small matters, and can be somewhat selfish. While capable themselves, they also hold others to strict standards.

## **9. Pointed Nose**

People with pointed noses generally have strong self-esteem and a self-centered tendency. Their speech is sharp and sarcastic. They can see into people's hearts, and their cold exterior often gives an impression of being unapproachable. They resist criticism from others. Their withdrawn nature makes them dislike close interactions, yet this also gives them an advantage in being calculating.

### **People with Upturned Nostrils**

People whose nostrils point upward let wealth come and go without accumulating it. Most such individuals are poor at saving money and spend wastefully without restraint. They usually only know how to spend money, not how to earn it, and they see nothing wrong with this. Ancient physiognomy texts say: "Nostrils pointing upward mean no grain stored overnight at home." If such people become addicted to gambling, the consequences are disastrous.

### **People with a Flat Nose Bridge**

A flat nose bridge makes it seem as if there is no nose at all. Such people are suited only to living honestly and accepting their fate. Because their financial luck is poor, they can only handle small amounts of money. Once they have more, it causes physical ailments or attracts others' envy, leading to mental unrest. In addition, they trust others too easily, so money is often swindled away.

### **Long and Straight Nose**

Such people are exceptionally talented, aesthetically gifted, and highly refined. They have deep appreciation for beauty and fashion and a strong understanding of art. They are idealists with a penchant for cleanliness, very confident in themselves, and sometimes arrogant. They also enjoy solitude and lack social skills, so they are not well-liked by those around them.

## **5. Low Nose**

A low nose is relatively short. Such people have temperaments opposite to those with high, straight or Greek noses. They tend to be content with the status quo, have few demands on themselves, lack confidence, and are somewhat lazy. They make no plans for life or work. Their frequent hesitation in making decisions causes them to miss many good opportunities.

### **Low Bridge and Pointed Tip**

People with narrow noses, low bridges, pointed tips that are thin and sunken are inwardly malicious and often obtain wealth through fraud. One may refer to "Zhou Tiger's" nose as an example. Such individuals usually have poor health, weak financial luck, and face frequent obstacles in their endeavors. Their marriages are prone to failure. If female, their husbands are certain to be unattractive.

### 13. Rounded Tip with Full Wings

The nose symbolizes wealth. People whose noses have flesh are usually considered good at making money. Such individuals are upright and strict, responsible, positive, and willing to strive. They often excel in business. Their combination of investment skill and frugality means they need not worry about household finances.

#### The Nose Also Expresses Emotions

Generally, when interpreting others' inner activities through facial expressions and features, one may not regard the nose as a highly expressive part because the information it conveys is far less rich than that from the eyes and mouth. Nevertheless, it has received attention from FBI agents, who have summarized the following three points of experience:

#### Straight Bridge with Rounded Tip

A straight bridge and a rounded, fleshy tip represent the perfect nose. Fleshy tips indicate a kind heart and good financial luck, with ample clothing, food, and shelter. Such people never deliberately pursue wealth, yet wealth comes to them.

In addition, those whose bridges curve left enjoy investing and want to gain without effort, while those whose bridges curve right are rather stingy.

### 11. Small Nostrils

People with small nostrils handle matters like those with long noses: they deliberate carefully and act cautiously, living frugally. The novel's miser Grandet is an example of this nose type. They are sensitive and anxious about gains and losses, making others reluctant to associate with them. They also lack foresight for the future.

#### The Nose: Mirror of Inner Activity

Is the nose only for smelling odors? If you think so, you are greatly mistaken. The nose can also leak secrets, but only if you are not paying attention. Although the nose generally does not move much, when combined with the other facial features it forms a whole that can expose a person's inner secrets.

#### Aquiline Nose

The nose shape resembles a hawk's beak, with the tip drooping downward in a hook. Such people often have sinister personalities and are cold and cruel. They are greedy by nature, insatiable in their pursuit of money and power, and lack human warmth. Although they may live long lives, their later years are lonely and desolate.

#### People with Lines on the Nose

Generally, people with horizontal lines on the nose are prone to hidden illnesses that are hard to treat; both marriage and career are likely to fail. People with vertical lines are prone to being adopted or to adopting others. If the vertical line is exactly on the tip, it is the "five horses dismembering the body" pattern; pay attention to traffic injuries.



## **Segmented Nose**

The bridge has a segmented appearance in the middle. Such people are mostly stubborn and highly aggressive. In interpersonal relations they do not know how to compromise and never yield. They often offend others because of their personality and are not very popular.

## **7. Depressed Nose**

A depressed nose does not have a straight bridge; instead the bridge is collapsed and flat. Such people are relatively shy and lack sufficient self-confidence, yet they are cheerful and approachable, giving others a sense of inexplicable warmth.

## **8. Broken Nose**

A broken nose refers to a nose with a segmented appearance in the middle of the bridge. Such people are stubborn by nature, dislike others pointing out their faults, have quick tempers, and lack necessary coordination skills. Their unsociable behavior makes them prone to offending others.

## **Depressed Nose**

A depressed nose means the bridge is not high enough—what is commonly called a flat nose. People with this nose shape are mostly cheerful and enjoy interacting with others, especially strangers, toward whom they have an inexplicable ability to feel close.

## **12. Large Nostrils**

People with large nostrils have temperaments opposite to those with small nostrils. They like to make many friends, have strong social skills, and do not fuss over trifles in life. However, they are careless in their actions and spend money like water, belonging to the “live for today” type.

## **People with a Low-Hanging Nose Tip**

A nose whose nostrils are not exposed and whose tip hangs low indicates frugality and the ability to save money, even a tendency toward stinginess. Such people are good at calculation and financial management, making them suited to business and wealth accumulation. Those with wide, open wings can obtain unexpected or windfall gains.

## **People with an Crooked Nose Bridge**

One can judge whether a person’s heart is upright by looking at the nose; a straight nose is very important. If the bridge is crooked, having money in hand will give rise to crooked thoughts.

## **How the Nose Expresses Emotions**

### **How the Nose Expresses Emotions**

When interpreting others’ inner activities through facial expressions and facial features, you may not regard the nose as an extremely emotionally expressive part, because the information it conveys is far less rich than that of the eyes and mouth. Yet it can indeed supply several body-language cues.

- **Flared nostrils indicate frustration or anger:** When a person's nostrils flare, it signals that a confrontation is imminent. Psychologists generally hold that breathing becomes rapid and deep during frustration or anger, and the widening of the nostrils is the body's way of drawing in more oxygen, foreshadowing preparation for conflict. Animals behave the same way. A Texas rancher once told us that an angry bull flares its nostrils and snorts loudly before charging. This is a serious warning that must be taken seriously.
- **Wrinkled nose indicates disgust:** A wrinkled nose usually signals disgust (ranging from mild displeasure to extreme revulsion), as though the person has detected an especially foul odor. The common expression "to turn up one's nose" at something fits perfectly. The gesture clearly conveys dislike and opposition. Even infants instinctively turn their heads away from disliked food to avoid the unpleasant smell, while adults tend to tilt their heads backward.
- **Pinching the bridge of the nose is a sign of deep thought:** If someone pinches the bridge of the nose, it often means they are focusing on and weighing a decision. A person experiencing intense inner conflict lowers the head and pinches the bridge of the nose, as if checking whether the difficulty is real or merely a nightmare. Businesspeople frequently adopt this posture to show they are caught in a decision-making dilemma, conveying the sense that "answering is truly difficult." When someone does this, it is best to remain silent and wait for them to raise objections to the matter under discussion. Let them know their feelings are understood, that no pressure will be applied to force a quick exit from reflection, and that their questions will be heard patiently. In most cases, pinching the bridge of the nose occurs together with closed eyes, a posture that represents strong internal doubt. In his book *The Art of Reading Minds: The White House Brain Trust*, "the father of negotiation" Gerard Nierenberg writes that a lawyer attending one of the seminars reported knowing a judge who habitually used this gesture to express thoughts and feelings about a case. If the judge believed the defendant guilty, the gesture did not appear; if the judge believed the defendant innocent, the gesture appeared, sometimes with the eyes closed for several minutes while the judge wrestled with how to rule.

Although nasal expressions are relatively few, the nose's central position on the face still supplies clues to character traits, especially those a person tries to conceal.

## Disgust

The common behavior that signals disgust is aptly described as "turning up one's nose." The gesture clearly conveys dislike and opposition. Even infants instinctively turn their heads away from disliked food to avoid the unpleasant smell. Adults tend to tilt their heads backward, an action often described as "looking down one's nose" at someone.

The behavior of "turning away from someone" (or "cold-shouldering another") likewise signals disgust at what a person says or does. In the deaf community, where visual experience is vital to communication, turning one's back on someone who wishes to converse is considered the ultimate snub.

## Reading Wealth from the Nose

In physiognomy the nose is usually considered as important as the eyebrows and eyes. The "wealth palace" refers to the nose and represents a person's lifelong financial prospects and career. A "good nose" is said to indicate a "golden" future.

The *Complete Book of Spirit Physiognomy* records: "The nose is the wealth star and resides in the earth mansion. A nose shaped like a hanging gall bladder or a cut tube brings granaries and storehouses by the

thousand. An upright, straight, and full nose brings lifelong prosperity and riches. A centered, unbiased nose ensures steady, abundant fortune. A nose with an eagle-beak tip (sharp and hooked) brings financial loss and poverty.” The following observations about the nose are offered for reference.

### **7. Levator Labii Superioris Alaeque Nasi**

The middle portion of the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi attaches to the major alar cartilage and the overlying skin; the lateral portion extends into the lateral upper lip (near the corner of the mouth) and merges there with the levator labii superioris and orbicularis oris. The muscle is bilaterally symmetrical.

Contraction of the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi has two effects: the middle portion widens the nostrils, while the lateral portion lifts and everts the upper lip, raising, deepening, and increasing the curvature of the top of the nasolabial fold.

#### **People with a Low Nose Bridge and Pointed Nose Tip**

A person whose nose is narrow, whose bridge is low, and whose tip is pointed, thin-fleshed, and sunken is considered inwardly treacherous and often obtains money through fraud. “Zhou the Tiger’s” nose may be consulted as an example. Such individuals usually have poor health, limited financial luck, and encounter repeated obstacles and difficulties in their affairs; marriage is also prone to failure. If the person is a woman, her husband is said to be unattractive or to lack the capacity to bring prosperity to his wife.

#### **People with Upturned Nostrils**

A person whose nostrils point upward lets money come and go without accumulation. Most such individuals find it hard to retain wealth, spend extravagantly, lack restraint, and understand only how to use money, not how to earn it; they themselves see nothing wrong with this. Ancient physiognomy texts state: “Nostrils pointing skyward, and the household has no grain left for the next night.” If such a person takes up gambling, the consequences are said to be disastrous.

#### **People with a Flat Nose Bridge**

A person whose nose bridge is flat, as though lacking a nose altogether, is advised to remain content with an honest, modest life and accept fate calmly. Because financial prospects are poor, such individuals can handle only small sums; once larger amounts appear, health problems or the envy of others arise, disturbing the mind. They also trust others too readily and are easily defrauded of money.

#### **People with a Straight Nose Bridge and Rounded Nose Tip**

A straight nose bridge and a rounded, fleshy tip constitute the perfect nose. Fleshy tissue at the tip is said to indicate a kind heart and good financial prospects, with clothing, food, and housing all abundant. Such people never deliberately chase wealth and status, yet wealth and status come to them.

In addition, a nose bridge that bends left indicates a fondness for investment and a desire for unearned gains, while a nose bridge that bends right indicates frugality bordering on stinginess.

#### **People with Lines on the Nose**

A horizontal line on the nose is generally said to indicate susceptibility to hidden ailments that are difficult to treat, with marriage and career both prone to failure. A vertical line suggests the person may be adopted or may adopt others; if the vertical line lies exactly on the tip, it is called the "five-horse dismemberment line," and caution regarding traffic injuries is advised.

### **People with a Low-Hanging Nose Tip**

A nose whose nostrils are not visible and whose tip hangs downward belongs to someone who is thrifty and able to save money, even to the point of miserliness. Such individuals excel at calculation and financial management and are suited to commerce. Wide, flaring nostrils are said to bring windfall or unexpected gains.

### **People with an Crooked Nose Bridge**

Whether a person's heart is upright can be judged from the nose. A straight, centered nose is considered essential; if the bridge is crooked, money in hand is said to give rise to dishonest thoughts.

See Nose (c-nose).

See Nose (c-nose).

See Nose (c-nose).

See Nose (c-nose).

See Nose (c-nose).

## **Mouth**

### **The Many Meanings of Sticking Out the Tongue**

The tongue reveals a great deal through its movements. FBI agents remind us to observe changes in a person's tongue during interactions.

Although the tongue is an internal organ, it can be exposed and thus serves as a medium for body language, conveying fear, desire, rejection, and aggression. All of these trace back to an infant's instinctive feeding responses.

For example, many sensitive, fragile, and somewhat neurotic people frequently make "biting" motions. Tracing the origin, this reproduces the primitive instinct of an infant tightly gripping the mother's nipple when hungry to feel secure.

Thus, "biting" is a form of "self-soothing." It stems from habitual anxiety formed in infancy for unknown reasons. The infant's thumb-sucking, the child's nail-biting, and the adult's chewing on ballpoint pens, cigarettes, or cigars differ in object, yet the underlying anxiety remains the same.

Among tongue movements, FBI agents consider the use of the tongue to express "rejection" the most noteworthy.

For instance, when people experience great fright, in addition to staring blankly, raising both hands with palms outward, they often extend the tongue fully. These gestures were once puzzling, but are now

understood as exaggerated “rejection” actions. Raising the hands with palms outward represents an attempt to push away something frightening, while fully extending the tongue mirrors an infant pushing away unwanted food with the tongue—an expression of rejection, only more intense.

Because this gesture occurs when one is frightened, people sometimes direct it at others when aggressing: “doing unto others what one does not want done to oneself.” This is “aggressive tongue protrusion,” also called “sticking out the tongue and making a face.” Its purpose is to intimidate and rudely insult, yet its root remains “rejection,” which transforms into “contempt.”

When people encounter minor fright, tension, or embarrassment, they stick out the tongue briefly before retracting it. This form is commonly seen in kindergarten children and expresses the mildest degree of rejection. Lacking aggression and occurring mostly in young children, the gesture persists despite teachers’ corrections and has become a way to “act cute,” signaling minor tension, fright, or embarrassment.

Beyond rejection, tongue protrusion can also convey the feeling—shared by young and old, male and female alike—of having “narrowly escaped disaster.”

FBI agent Antonis wanted to buy a good car. He went to a dealership and told the salesperson, “I am willing to buy this car at this price.” After some bargaining, the salesperson used a familiar tactic: “All right, let me check with our manager.” He left to consult the manager, and Antonis stepped out of the office to browse.

A few minutes later, Antonis happened to glimpse the salesperson and the manager talking behind a glass door. Although he could not hear them, he could clearly see their movements. After speaking with the manager, the salesperson stuck out his tongue—briefly, but unmistakably.

Antonis returned to the salesperson’s office and waited. The salesperson soon came back and said, “Our manager believes the price I quoted is the best we can offer.”

Antonis replied, “You mean this is your lowest acceptable price?”

“Yes,” the salesperson answered.

“No room for further negotiation?” Antonis pressed.

“None,” the salesperson said, nodding. “This is our lowest price.”

“In that case, thank you,” Antonis said, rising and walking straight out of the office toward the exit without looking back. As he reached the door, he heard someone calling his name: “Wait! Wait!”

The salesperson brought Antonis back to the office and offered to lower the so-called lowest price by another 2,700 yuan—only 100 yuan above Antonis’s initial offer.

The key points of the story are: first, determine the true bottom-line price of the car; second, when you see the salesperson stick out his tongue, recognize that he is trying to get you to accept the supposed lowest price by luck.

Once you learn to observe this behavior, it proves highly useful in bargaining or intense competition.

### **Small Tongue, Big Secrets**

Although the tongue is an internal organ, it can be exposed and thus serves as a medium for body language, conveying fear, desire, rejection, and aggression. All of these trace back to an infant’s instinctive feeding

responses.

For example, many sensitive, fragile, and somewhat neurotic people frequently make “biting” motions. Tracing the origin, this reproduces the primitive instinct of an infant tightly gripping the mother’s nipple when hungry to feel secure. Thus, “biting” is a form of “self-soothing.” It stems from habitual anxiety formed in infancy for unknown reasons. The infant’s thumb-sucking, the child’s nail-biting, and the adult’s chewing on ballpoint pens, cigarettes, or cigars differ in object, yet the underlying anxiety remains the same.

Among tongue movements, the various ways the tongue expresses “rejection” are the most noteworthy.

For instance, when people experience great fright, in addition to staring blankly, raising both hands with palms outward, they often extend the tongue fully. These gestures were once puzzling, but are now understood as exaggerated “rejection” actions. Raising the hands with palms outward represents an attempt to push away something frightening, while fully extending the tongue mirrors an infant pushing away unwanted food with the tongue—an expression of rejection, only more intense.

Because this tongue-protrusion gesture occurs when one is frightened, people sometimes direct it at others when aggressing: “doing unto others what one does not want done to oneself.” This is “aggressive tongue protrusion,” also called “sticking out the tongue and making a face.” Its purpose is to intimidate and rudely insult, yet its root remains “rejection,” which transforms into “contempt.”

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Beyond rejection, tongue protrusion can also convey the feeling—shared by young and old, male and female alike—of having “narrowly escaped disaster.”

Once you learn to observe this behavior, it proves highly useful in bargaining or intense competition.

Many years ago, I wanted to buy a good car. I went to a dealership and told the salesperson, “I am willing to buy this car at this price.” After some bargaining, the salesperson used a familiar tactic: “All right, let me check with our manager.” He left to consult the manager, and I stepped out of the office to browse.

A few minutes later, I happened to glimpse the salesperson and the manager talking behind a glass door. Although I could not hear them, I could clearly see their movements. After speaking with the manager, the salesperson stuck out his tongue—briefly, but unmistakably.

I returned to the salesperson’s office and waited. The salesperson soon came back and said, “Our manager believes the price I quoted is the best we can offer.”

I replied, “You mean this is your lowest acceptable price?”

“Yes,” he answered.

“No room for further negotiation?” I pressed.

“None,” the salesperson said, nodding. “This is our lowest price.”

“In that case, thank you,” I said, rising and walking straight out of the office toward the exit without looking back. As I reached the door, I heard someone calling my name: “Wait! Wait!”

The salesperson brought me back to the office and offered to lower the so-called lowest price by another 2,700 yuan—only 100 yuan above my initial offer.

The key points of the story are: first, determine the true bottom-line price of the car; second, when you see the salesperson stick out his tongue, recognize that he is trying to get you to accept the supposed lowest price by luck.

## **2. Why Do People Bite Their Lips?**

You often see people biting their lips and think little of it, yet this simple action reveals much about a person's psychological state. The meaning of lip-biting varies by context.

Psychologists have suggested that lip-biting originates from the sucking reflex of infancy and serves to release tension and calm suppressed emotions.

The following outlines the psychological implications of lip-biting:

### **1. Anger or irritation**

When angry, facial muscles produce slight twitching movements due to the emotion. In addition to flaring and wrinkling of the nose, the mouth stiffens and the person unconsciously bites the lips. Judging from the conversational context, if the other person bites their lips, consider whether you have said something offensive.

### **2. Inner tension**

Many job candidates exhibit increased small movements and lightly bite their lower lip with their upper teeth while waiting for an interview. This lip-biting often stems from a lack of confidence and involuntary tension about the unknown interview situation; they hope to ease their psychological burden by biting their lips.

Research indicates that people bite their lips under tension because accelerated blood flow causes a slight swelling or itching sensation in the lips, prompting an unconscious light bite.

### **3. Self-suggestion to relieve inner anxiety**

Anxiety also triggers lip-biting as a form of psychological self-suggestion aimed at easing the anxious feeling. During exams, test-takers may lightly bite their lips while pondering a difficult question to reduce the pressure of the temporary obstacle. It is said that former U.S. President George W. Bush made this gesture upon learning of the September 11 terrorist attacks in 2001.

### **4. Manifestation of self-punishment**

Some people habitually bite their lips; this actually reflects self-compulsion and self-punishment. When facing failure, lightly biting the lips expresses both inner anxiety and self-blame for the mistake. This behavior appears more often in people with strong self-esteem and high personal standards.

### **5. Concealing true inner emotions**

When facing accusations or misunderstandings, people may unconsciously bite their lips. When wronged yet unable to clarify or refute immediately, they feel strong dissatisfaction and resistance, which manifests in the lip-biting gesture. If you, as a supervisor, observe this during criticism of an employee, consider whether additional facts exist and offer the employee a chance to explain, thereby avoiding deeper rifts that could hinder work.

From the above, although lip-biting is subtle, it provides considerable information about psychological activity. A small micro-expression can betray one's thoughts and reveal inner feelings. Generally, lip-biting conveys a lack of confidence and is not a favorable habit for job candidates or everyday social interactions, as it inadvertently signals negative emotions. Frequent lip-biting not only affects appearance and leaves a poor impression but also allows others to detect tension, anxiety, and fear. These effects hinder daily communication and business negotiations, so those with the habit should break it.

## **1. Knowing What You Are Thinking Without You Opening Your Mouth**

Inner emotions can be expressed not only through words but also through micro-expressions of the mouth; people often overlook these micro-expressions and thereby reveal subtle psychological shifts.

The mouth is closely linked to personality. Observing mouth shape allows a rough understanding of character traits. The following introduces mouth types:

### **1. Optimistic and Cheerful Crescent Mouth**

Also called the upturned crescent, this mouth shape features corners that turn upward. The person's personality matches the shape: lively, outgoing, emotionally rich, and mentally agile. They excel in adaptability and execution, often thriving in the workplace and earning leaders' attention.

### **2. Cautious and Stern Downturned Crescent**

The opposite of the upturned crescent, this shape has corners that turn downward. Such individuals are cautious in dealings, eccentric in temperament, and difficult to approach, giving an impression of aloofness; they often play the role of loners. Their sensitivity leads them to dwell on trifles and complain, yet they are considerate of others.

### **3. Strong-Willed Straight Line**

A straight-line mouth, as the name suggests, forms a straight shape when the lips are closed. These people possess unmatched willpower and strong self-awareness, making them resistant to others' opinions.

### **4. Mild and Gentle Rectangular**

The rectangular mouth resembles the Chinese character "四." Both upper and lower lips are full and plump. These individuals are mild-mannered, honest, and possess a strong sense of justice; they tend to succeed in work and life. Their distinctive personalities also help them make many friends.

### **5. Selfish Protruding Lower Lip**

In this shape the lower lip protrudes as if ready to receive the upper lip. People with this mouth enjoy quibbling, are skilled at debate, and show strong endurance, yet they rarely receive important responsibilities from superiors.

### **6. Justice-Oriented Protruding Upper Lip**

The opposite of the protruding-lower-lip shape, this mouth has the upper lip protruding to cover the lower lip. These individuals are reasonable, possess a strong sense of justice, and display a readiness to help when witnessing injustice. Their perfectionism is matched by a relatively perfect personal image.

### **7. Sociable Elongated Mouth**

People with elongated mouths are generally mild. They offer more compliments than criticism, have good character, and know how to handle relationships, so others enjoy their company. They are



meticulous, earn trust through reliability, and fully exercise their social and professional abilities in practice.

### 8. Independent and Stubborn Odd-Shaped Mouth

This mouth resembles the shape formed when blowing on a fire. People with this shape generally have independent personalities and distinctive traits, yet in interactions their stubbornness often makes others uncomfortable, creating a clear sense of compulsion.

Thus, even when the mouth remains silent, observing its movements reveals clues to a person's psychological activity.

### Mouth Micro-Movements Reveal Various Emotions

The mouth does not only display various emotions when speaking; even when silent, small mouth movements can reveal different emotions. In fact, the mouth is one of the most expressive parts of the face.

Among the organs on the human face, the mouth occupies a prominent position, is relatively large in target area, and can perform many actions. The orbicularis oris muscle around the teeth has been trained to be highly flexible through long-term speaking, so it often makes many movements subconsciously.

When observing a person's facial expressions, one absolutely cannot overlook the small movements of the mouth, because changes in the mouth and surrounding muscles make these micro-movements a breakthrough point for seeing through the other person's inner thoughts. Upward corners of the mouth indicate happiness, downward corners indicate pain, a wide-open mouth indicates surprise, tightly closed lips indicate anger... The muscles on the lips can exhibit subtle and complex changes, and even those hard-to-detect subtle emotional shifts will be expressed through the flexible orbicularis oris muscle.

The mouth holds an important position among the facial features; every action—opening and closing, moving forward or backward, upward or downward—is valuable information. It can be said that the mouth has rich forms of expression. So, how can one discern a person's emotions through small mouth movements?

#### 1. Lips pressed tightly together

When a person hides or tenses their lips, it often indicates they are facing pressure. As the pressure increases, the originally full lips gradually become flat and eventually turn into a straight line. At this point, it shows that their emotions have hit rock bottom. If a person presses their lips tightly together, it indicates they are anxious and under great pressure, because tightly pressed lips are a sign of self-suppression.

#### 2. Lips pursed

During conversation, if the other person purses their lips, it means they are dissatisfied with what you are saying and hope you will stop or change the topic promptly. Lip pursing occurs in many situations. For example, when two lawyers debate, one lawyer states their view while the other often purses their lips to show disagreement. Another example: during police interrogation, if the information about a suspect contains errors, the suspect will purse their lips to indicate that the investigator's statement is wrong.

#### 3. Corners of the mouth turned up or down

Corners of the mouth turned up mean the other person feels cheerful and is also a sign of goodwill and politeness. Corners of the mouth turned down mean the other person's mood is low, they are in sorrow or pain, and it is also an expression of helplessness.

#### 4. Pouting

When a person is unhappy, they often extend the lower lip forward and turn the corners of the mouth downward; this action is called pouting. Pouting expresses a negative emotion and frequently appears in sadness, anger, despair, or contempt. During conversation, if the other person's lower lip juts forward, it indicates they do not believe the external information received and hope for an affirmative reply.

#### 5. Licking the lips with the tongue

A person frequently licks their lips because they feel dry-mouthed and hope to moisten the lips somewhat; this shows they are under great pressure. Research indicates that when a person feels uncomfortable or nervous, they repeatedly lick their lips with the tongue to comfort themselves and attempt to calm their inner state through this action.

### Closed Lips

Although cultures around the world differ greatly, body language shows universality; people of different races and cultures maintain consistency in body language. Micro-expressions (微表情) belong to the category of nonverbal behavior. Within nonverbal behavior, the position occupied by the lips is not central; people pay more attention to information conveyed by limbs, torso, and facial expressions. Micro-expressions can transmit inner emotional changes more accurately and directly precisely because they are hard to detect, and the lips excel at this.

Besides producing smiles, people's lips generally remain in a relaxed, pleasant state, yet at times people close their lips tightly, as if trying to hide them. This action occurs because the muscles around the lips tighten inward, causing the shape to contract. According to the principle that pleasant emotions cause the body to expand while negative emotions cause the body to contract, the tightening of the lip muscles also conveys a negative emotion. People who make this movement are generally in some kind of trouble; they may have detected an unsettling signal but are unwilling to express it immediately, so they use this action to control themselves. This movement is also called lip pressing, because it is like installing a lock on one's lips to prevent them from making inappropriate sounds.

An American shipping company once reached an impasse during business negotiations, so they invited Nicholas Bartum, an FBI expert on nonverbal behavior, to assist the negotiation by observing the other party's micro-expressions and help secure the deal.

At the negotiation table, Nicholas carefully observed every negotiator's emotional changes, using their expressions, movements, and language to predict whether the negotiation would reach a mutually satisfactory result. When the shipping company's CEO presented their contract terms, Nicholas suggested explaining each clause one by one and breaking the task into individual items so the other side could understand them in greater detail. This negotiation style gave Nicholas the opportunity to observe each person up close, and it proved very wise. When the other party heard one particular clause, Nicholas suddenly noticed a change in their nonverbal behavior: although their body movements remained unchanged, they locked their lips tightly shut. He quickly wrote a note and passed it to the shipping company's CEO, informing him which clause the other side found extremely objectionable.

After receiving Nicholas's information, the shipping company's CEO immediately raised that key clause. Both sides held a highly productive discussion. Seeing the shipping company's sincerity, the other side made certain concessions. The deadlock broke quickly once the key point was identified, and a negotiation that

might have collapsed reached agreement; a contract worth tens of millions of dollars was perfectly resolved simply by detecting one instance of tightly closed lips.

## Section Two “Big Mouth”

A folk saying goes: a man with a big mouth will eat from all directions, while a woman with a big mouth will impoverish her husband. To modern eyes this saying appears to lack scientific basis and is considered an undesirable notion. In addition, ancient physiognomy states that people with thin lips are relatively unfeeling, unrighteous, and stubborn; people with thick lips value emotions and are generous; people with cherry-small mouths are cautious in dealing with others and consider matters thoroughly from every angle. In general, the mouth is closely related to a person’s temperament.

The famous American actress Audrey Hepburn, once called a fallen angel, said: “For attractive lips, speak words of kindness.” In truth, an appealing mouth can not only voice praise for beautiful things but also reveal a person’s character and inner psychological activity; it can truly be called a “big mouth.”

The mouth, like the nose, is one of the five sensory organs. It is not only an important tool for communication with the outside world and for eating; some also call the mouth the “outlet officer.” Medically, mouth expressions are determined by the orbicularis oris, depressor anguli oris, and mentalis muscles.

In daily life, people use the mouth to express inner emotions, yet when the mouth produces speech it also transmits silent language information. Through the subtle expressive movements of the mouth we can glimpse a person’s psychological state, making the mind no longer unfathomable.

It is known that facial muscles change with inner emotions, with the muscles around the eyes and mouth showing the most obvious changes. People can recognize different inner states through the various movements the mouth displays. For example, when angry, a person not only flares the nostrils but also presses the lips together; when happy, a person smiles, causing the corners of the mouth to rise; when sorrowful, the corners of the mouth droop involuntarily; when surprised, people often open the mouth wide. In addition, people kiss those around them to express love, bite their lips to relieve inner repression, and pout to signal dissatisfaction. During conversation, if the other person’s lips move slightly backward at the corners, it shows they are listening attentively; if they occasionally bite their lips, it indicates they are thinking about what you said. All these subtle mouth movements provide us with valuable information.

Every opening and closing of the mouth reflects a person’s inner world; understanding mouth micro-expressions is highly useful in daily interactions.

## “Rectangular Smile”

Decades ago, Professor Ewan Grant of the Psychology Department at the University of Birmingham proposed a professional term for expressions—the “rectangular smile.”

When people produce a “rectangular smile,” the lips pull away from the upper and lower teeth, forming a rectangle. In fact, the “rectangular smile” does not accompany a relaxed, happy mood and a genuine smile; it can even be considered an expression of pain.

When we are in low spirits, it is difficult to fake a genuine smile. A typical example: if you are unhappy, you cannot simultaneously engage both the zygomaticus major and orbicularis oculi muscles to display a radiant genuine smile, yet given the special circumstances you must politely force a smile, so a fake smile appears.

A fake smile does not come from the heart; it only engages the zygomaticus major that lifts the corners of the mouth—what Chinese call “smiling on the surface but not from the heart.”

University of Pittsburgh psychology professor Jeffrey Cohn is developing a machine to analyze facial muscle changes in suspects during interrogation. “We can state how many times each muscle moved, how long it stayed before changing, and whether the subject’s performance was genuine or feigned,” he explains.

Yet you do not need Cohn’s machine to detect a lying boyfriend or a guilty young woman, because a liar’s insincere smile can be exposed within seconds. “A genuine smile is even, symmetrical on both sides of the face; it comes quickly but fades slowly. It involves wrinkles from nose to mouth corners as well as crow’s feet around the eyes,” Cohn says. “A feigned smile comes more slowly and shows slight asymmetry; when one side is not quite real, the other side tries to respond positively. The eye muscles are not fully engaged—that is why the ‘villain’ in films has a cold, malicious smile that never reaches the eyes.”

After years of research, scientists have found that the key to a happier life lies in interpersonal relationships, and a sincere smile helps people get along better, so it is very important. For those who smile genuinely, happiness will not be far away.

### **The Mystery of Licking and Biting the Lips**

When people find themselves in an unsettling environment, they often need to find an outlet to relieve negative emotions. Tense nerves not only make people irritable but also easily lead to mistakes, so seeking comfort is almost human instinct. Comforting actions are many and performed by different body parts; among micro-expressions there is also a comfort-related action—biting the lips.

Faced with pressure, people almost all show very similar reactions: stroking the forehead or neck, fiddling with clothes or hair—these are ways people relieve pressure. Women often play with clothing hems or hair because they feel nervous and their nervous system seeks comfort; they calm themselves this way. Men, due to social status and image requirements, cannot display too many comforting actions, yet they do not miss opportunities to soothe their tension through micro-expressions; lip-licking is an action that occurs in both men and women. When people encounter negative stimuli—sometimes a difficult question, sometimes hearing or seeing something oppressive—they lick their lips. The reflection of the limbic brain’s management system on the lips, though subtle, is real.

Similar to stroking oneself, people also scratch their heads; this action likewise reflects an extremely negative emotion, indicating the person is experiencing stronger tension, embarrassment, or unease. When lip-licking turns into lip-biting, the expression can be viewed as an escalation of anxiety. When a child faces a difficult problem or is caught doing something wrong by parents, they may lick their lips to comfort themselves and reduce worry. But when they have not reviewed before an exam or their father approaches, lip-biting appears, showing they sense the trouble has grown serious.

### **Mouth Features and Personality Analysis**

The mouth reflects the condition of the stomach and digestive system. If a person has full lips, ruddy lip color, neat teeth, and healthy gums, then without doubt their stomach digestion and nutrient absorption function well; they are a vibrant person. Conversely, if a person has a small mouth, pale lips, and poor teeth and gum condition, it indicates weaker bodily resilience and the need for more rest.

Stanford University professor Jewell once conducted five brief conversations with 809 volunteers on the topics of family, career, friendships, future, and sex. Through comparative analysis he found:

- People with wide, thick lips become relatively excited when discussing sex-related topics.
- People with narrow, thin lips are relatively composed and possess stronger self-control.
- Among people whose lips appear relaxed, over 70 percent stated that their greatest career trouble is lack of resolve and difficulty persisting.
- People whose mouth corners turn downward become very dejected whenever setbacks are mentioned and feel pessimistic about the future.
- Among people whose mouth corners turn upward, over 90 percent are cheerful, full of confidence in family and career, and hopeful about the future, even though they have encountered many setbacks.

Another survey showed:

- Among people with short upper lips, over 85 percent like to hear praise; when harshly criticized they more easily lose morale and may even become decadent or self-abandoning.
- People with longer upper lips are the opposite; after being mocked or ridiculed, most of them reflect on the pain, draw lessons, and move forward courageously.

From a dynamic perspective, the mouth has four basic movement patterns: opening and closing, up and down, forward and back, loose and tight. Observing these movements together with the personality traits contained in the mouth's static features allows us to form a rough judgment of a person met for the first time.

### **People Who Smile with Lips Pressed Together**

Besides producing speech, the lips have another very important function: expressing emotion. A toothy smile can be considered its most charming moment. As one of the most common human expressions, a smile expresses inner pleasure and conveys positive, friendly information. Before people enter the world, they easily grin broadly over small gains, yet as age and experience increase, such pure, unrestrained laughter becomes rarer, while smiles achieved through mental control become more frequent. Often people part their lips to the sides to show great pleasure, yet they are not truly happy; it is merely a social requirement.

Fake smiling is one of the important features distinguishing humans from other creatures, because almost no animals except humans fake smiles. To cope with people or matters they dislike and to remain in uncomfortable, tense environments, people engage mouth muscles to produce a fake smile and handle awkwardness. This can also be counted as one of the fruits of human evolution: by issuing fake smiles, people can avoid much trouble, and it also supplies micro-expression observation with a severe yet interesting topic, attracting many experts and scholars to study the difference between genuine and fake smiles.

Distinguishing the meaning hidden in a smile is a very important lesson in micro-expressions. When a person parts their lips to reveal a charming and seemingly candid smile, how do you know whether they are truly happy or harbor ill intent? Besides rich social experience, we can also discover the truth by understanding how a fake smile is produced. Through long-term observation and analysis of smiles, the FBI found that fake smiles most easily appear when people smile with lips pressed together.

### **III. Disaster No Longer Comes from the Mouth**

In daily life people inadvertently develop certain habitual actions of which they remain unaware; for example, small movements such as pouting reveal much information, and other mouth movements also "speak" one's

true inner feelings through nonverbal forms.

The information conveyed by habitual mouth movements is useful both in daily social interaction and in the workplace. If you can interpret the other person's micro-expression information well, you can adjust the direction of conversation or action accordingly and help your life or work proceed more smoothly.

### 1. Pressing the lips together: a sign of self-suppression

When a person suffers setbacks or failure, the lip-pressing action is common. Although small, if you observe carefully you will notice that the corners of the mouth of the person making this movement turn downward—the exact opposite of a smile's upward corners. This shows that the person performing the lip press is in a state of emotional dejection and inferiority, truthfully reflecting their inner anxiety and distress.

Lip pressing means applying pressure to both upper and lower lips to close the mouth tightly, as if conveying the message that nothing should enter the body. When people encounter trouble or pressure they unconsciously press their lips; at first they merely tense the lips, and as pressure grows the mouth becomes flat or forms a straight line—these changes occur in an instant.

Generally, when people feel pressure and anxiety they try to use lip pressing to suppress their true inner emotions. Although it does not show on the face, this tiny, instantaneous mouth movement still reveals personal inner feelings without reservation.

## Psychology Mini-Class

In business negotiations, what the other party says is often unreliable, but small movements of their mouth can reveal the truth. Body language experts have observed that subtle mouth movements frequently display a person's emotional shifts, causing lies to fall apart on their own.

### 1. Pressing the lips together

During negotiations, if you see the other party press their lips together, it indicates they have made up their mind, are fully prepared, and will not yield easily. If they press their lips together while avoiding eye contact, it suggests they harbor a secret they do not wish to reveal; the lip press occurs because they fear leaking information.

### 2. Biting the lips

During negotiations, if the other party frequently bites their lips, it shows they doubt their own abilities and lack sufficient confidence in the negotiation. Observing this movement during talks means the other side has begun to compromise and is about to concede.

### 3. Mouth opening unconsciously

During negotiations, if the other party's mouth opens unconsciously and they appear listless, it indicates they feel bored with their surroundings or do not understand the topic under discussion and lack the confidence to respond.

### 4. Lips pursed upward

Lips pursed upward means the other party has objections and is very dissatisfied with the terms you have offered. From a psychological perspective, this is the party's way of keeping their dissatisfaction "outside the door." In business negotiations, when the other side makes this movement, they typically will not agree to any conditions and are waiting for you to adjust your approach.

## Smiling with Lips Pressed Together

Smiling with lips pressed together occurs when people stretch the muscles at the corners of their mouth while keeping the movement restrained, producing a controlled and polite expression on the face. This manner of expression often leaves the other person unable to read whether the attitude is positive or negative, yet whenever someone displays this expression, the meaning is usually one of refusal.

Failing to judge the other person's true thoughts through micro-expressions of the lips often leads people into misunderstandings and places them at a disadvantage in communication. Women frequently convey their emotions through micro-expressions of the lips. When they smile with lips pressed together, the corners of the mouth move slightly backward, producing a smile without warmth; this indicates that the attitude they are showing differs from their actual inner thoughts—they do not truly feel that way. When a woman praises a friend's unattractive dress or compliments a neighbor's child, she often smiles in this pressed-lip manner. In her heart, the dress does not merit praise; she offers it only for the sake of her friend's feelings. She also does not genuinely believe the neighbor's child is superior to her own; the compliment is given merely to meet social expectations.

The gap between true feelings and the demands of the situation prevents people from expressing emotions freely. When the lips cannot speak the heart directly, their micro-expressions become worth careful consideration.

## Section 3 The "Dancing" Tongue

The recent CCTV documentary *A Bite of China* has sparked widespread interest. The tip of the tongue can taste the full range of flavors—sweet, sour, bitter, spicy, and salty—adding richness and color to daily life. Beyond taste, the usually hidden tongue also conveys psychological information; a simple tongue movement can reveal what someone is thinking.

Human emotions are subtle. Compared with foreigners, Chinese people tend to be more reserved when expressing genuine feelings, yet small tongue movements can still betray personal emotions. American basketball star Michael Jordan occasionally licks his lips while shooting on the court. Why? In general, people lick their lips with the tongue when they are under significant pressure; high pressure causes dry mouth, and licking the lips moistens them while also easing inner tension.

In addition, children often stick out their tongues when they misbehave or act mischievously. When adults make the same movement, it can signal shyness or an attempt to ease embarrassment. On the sports field, if a doubles partner misses a ball due to momentary carelessness, some players habitually stick out their tongue toward their teammate as an apology; the playful gesture also diffuses the awkwardness.

Clearly, the information revealed by the tongue tip should not be overlooked.

## Pouting and Pursing Lips

Pouting is a deliberate forward thrust of the lower lip (see Figure 2.17) that can express various emotions such as sadness, disappointment, or dejection. People may pout when joking or when serious, but the expression generally signals a transitional reaction between dissatisfaction and anger. The look can also suggest immaturity, so it should be used with caution. Many people become irritated when they see someone pouting.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.17 Pouting]*

Pursing the lips generally indicates that a person is angry. In practice, two distinct pouting postures are recognized as "pursing the lips": one occurs when people suppress anger and press the upper and lower lips tightly together (see Figure 2.18); the other occurs when the lips are compressed from all directions, making the mouth appear small and tense. Either posture shows that the person is trying to restrain anger or avoid being judged by others.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.18 Pursing the lips]*

### **Licking or Biting the Lips**

Licking the lips is usually viewed as a sexually suggestive signal (see Figure 2.19). If you are flirting with a man and he licks his lips, whether intentionally or not, it means he wants to kiss you.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.19 Licking the lips]*

Of course, licking the lips is not only a sexual cue. In daily life, people also lick their lips when their mouth feels dry in order to moisten it.

When a person bites their own lips, it usually indicates anxiety, discomfort, frustration, or embarrassment (see Figure 2.20). In addition, lip-biting can signal confusion.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.20 Biting the lips]*

Although lip-biting is regarded as a sign of restlessness (sometimes immaturity), many people have the habit and are often unaware of it.

## **2. Pouting: An Expression of Dissatisfaction or Disagreement**

Pouting, commonly called "pursing the mouth," is frequently seen on children's faces; they pout over minor matters to show inner discontent. Adults convey the same meaning when they pout. Because adults tend to feel self-conscious, their pout is usually less decisive than a child's and consists of a quick, slight forward thrust of the lips.

If you notice the other person thrusting their lips forward during conversation, you should consider whether they disagree with what you have said. Pouting appears often in meetings or at the negotiating table. When the other party disagrees with your statement but does not voice it, they may still reveal it through this movement. The stronger their inner resistance, the longer and more frequently they pout, often accompanied by crossed arms.

Some people also pout while thinking. Therefore, whether the movement expresses inner dissatisfaction or resistance must be judged according to the context and other body language; it cannot be interpreted in isolation.

### **8.1.3 Grinding the Teeth**

Similar to clenching the fists, when a stimulus provokes anger in the subject yet the subject remains silent, the most common reaction is to grind the teeth. Easily observed grinding includes changes in the contact points of the upper and lower teeth, such as rubbing the canines together or biting with the incisors ("gnashing"); another possibility is that the teeth remain in the same position but are pressed together forcefully, causing the masseter muscles on both sides of the face to contract and become visibly tense.



In actual investigative cases, some suspects manage to speak in a mild and reasonable tone while occasionally showing a brief contraction of the masseter muscles between sentences. This contradictory display—mild words paired with muscular tension—indicates that the suspect maintains good verbal control and conceals aggressive impulses, yet the behavior still reveals a flaw.

The inadvertent appearance of teeth-grinding during an interview is a classic sign that the subject feels threatened and under pressure; subconsciously, the subject hopes the teeth will "attack" and eliminate the negative stimulus.

## **5. Covering the Mouth with the Hand: A Sign of Thinking or Shyness**

In many situations we notice people covering their mouths with a hand. This movement suggests the person is rather shy and does not want others to see their less favorable side. In addition, some people unconsciously cover their mouths when deep in thought; the gesture helps them concentrate and solve problems.

Generally, people who frequently cover their mouths tend to be quiet around strangers and maintain stronger psychological defenses than others. You may also see someone quickly cover their mouth after blurting out the wrong words; the action is a response to realizing the mistake and expresses a sense of guilt.

People's true thoughts are not always spoken aloud; in many cases they prefer to keep them hidden. Yet everyday nonverbal behaviors such as lip-pressing lay a person's character bare. Understanding the various meanings of mouth movements therefore helps us control our own mouths so they no longer become "big mouths" that broadcast our psychological secrets.

## **Licking or Biting the Lips**

Licking the lips is usually viewed as a sexually suggestive signal. If you are flirting with a man and he licks his lips, whether intentionally or not, it means he wants to kiss you. Of course, licking the lips is not only a sexual cue. If he feels his lips are dry, he may lick them to moisten them.

When a person bites their own lips, it usually indicates anxiety, discomfort, frustration, or embarrassment. In addition, lip-biting can signal confusion. Although lip-biting is regarded as a sign of restlessness (sometimes immaturity), many people have the habit and are often unaware of it.

Other common mouth movements are also easy to interpret. For example, a wide-open mouth indicates surprise, tightly closed lips indicate anger, upturned corners of the mouth indicate joy, and downturned corners indicate self-reproach. During conversation, never overlook the other person's mouth movements.

## **Teeth Reveal a Person's Emotional State**

Micro-expression keywords: Are your teeth straight? Do not underestimate the teeth we keep hidden; besides helping us chew food, they can unintentionally reveal a person's emotions and character.

The portrait of Washington on the U.S. dollar appears to show a set of straight, healthy teeth. In reality, Washington suffered from periodontal disease and wore full dentures from an early age. The denture technology of the time was poor, and whenever he opened his mouth to smile the dentures risked falling out. The photographer solved the problem by having Washington remove the dentures and stuffing cotton into his mouth, finally capturing a natural-looking smile.

True or not, the story illustrates the importance of teeth. They affect not only health and appearance but can also, from a single tooth, allow us to infer personality and mood.

### **Pouting and Pursing Lips**

Pouting is a deliberate forward thrust of the lower lip and can express various emotions such as sadness, disappointment, or dejection. People may also pout when joking or when serious, but the expression generally signals a transitional reaction between dissatisfaction and anger. The look can suggest immaturity, so it should be used with caution. Many people become irritated when they see someone pouting.

Pursing the lips generally indicates that a person is angry. In practice, two distinct pouting postures are recognized as "pursing the lips": one occurs when people suppress anger and press the upper and lower lips tightly together; the other occurs when the lips are compressed from all directions, making the mouth appear small and tense. Either posture shows that the person is trying to restrain anger or avoid being judged by others.

### **Mouth Movements Reflect Inner Activity**

Micro-expression keywords: The mouth is an important channel for emotional release. Whether people are happy, angry, or melancholy, they vent through speech. If you observe their mouths carefully at such moments, you will notice that different moods produce different small movements.

The muscles around the mouth are exceptionally well developed, and the mouth is one of the most flexible parts of the body. We use it to eat, to speak, to laugh when happy, and to pout when angry. The mouth opens or closes, tightens or relaxes, forming a rich repertoire of movements that also convey a person's inner state at that moment.

### **Laughing in Short Bursts**

People who laugh in short bursts are generally cold and indifferent by nature.

Yet laughter does not always symbolize kindness or goodwill. People often use fake smiles to hide feelings and mask expressions; without careful observation it is difficult to read them.

More than a century ago, scientists discovered that humans produce both genuine and fake smiles. When we do not feel truly close to those around us, we use fake smiles; genuine smiles are reserved for people and things we truly care about. In fact, infants only a few weeks old already know to save genuine smiles for their mothers and offer fake smiles to others.

### **Lips Also Undergo Seventy-Two Transformations**

Although verbal expression plays a major role in daily life and the oral cavity together with the entire vocal apparatus carries out this task, people still attribute the credit to the lips. In people's eyes, two thin lips seem capable of withstanding a million troops; the power released when the lips meet is immeasurable. The muscular structure of the lips is extremely agile, the result of continuous evolution after humans learned to use language. Yet long experience has also shown that the more agile the lips, the more they can deceive; therefore, observing micro-expressions of the lips has become a key focus.

### **Overlapping Teeth**

Overlapping teeth occur when two adjacent teeth cross, one in front of the other. People with this trait tend to be highly self-confident and capable; they handle work with ease and perform exceptionally well. Because of this, they can develop arrogance and strong jealousy, sometimes becoming willful and headstrong, which leaves them with few close friends. Women with overlapping teeth in particular tend to stir up trouble and are not suitable as friends.

Although teeth are small, their usefulness is great. Besides helping us chew food, they display a person's personality and emotions; we should not overlook them.

## **The Mouth**

The mouth is the only body part that can communicate both verbally and nonverbally. It is well known that the verbal information a person emits may not reflect their true thoughts or feelings. However, the nonverbal information conveyed by the mouth is quite reliable and rarely misleads. For example, we can easily distinguish between a genuine smile, a nervous smile, and a fake smile. Next, let us examine what the mouth conveys when it is not speaking.

### **Licking the Lips Is Not Only a Sexual Signal**

The mouth is the only body part that can communicate both verbally and nonverbally. We all know that the verbal information a person emits may not reflect their true thoughts or feelings. However, the nonverbal information conveyed by the mouth is quite reliable and rarely misleads.

Next, let us follow FBI agents in learning how the mouth conveys inner thoughts when it is not speaking.

### **Mouth Movements Expose Inner Feelings**

The mouth is the only body part that can communicate both verbally and nonverbally. We all know that the verbal information a person emits may not reflect their true thoughts or feelings. However, the nonverbal information conveyed by the mouth is quite reliable and rarely misleads.

Next, let us examine what the mouth conveys when it is not speaking.

### **Laughing Out Loud with "Ha ha ha"**

Hearty laughter usually appears when everyone is very happy. During such laughter the upper and lower incisors are exposed, and eye contact is usually avoided because the head is tilted backward.

People who laugh heartily are essentially lonely. They are informal, alternate between warmth and coldness, and act decisively without hesitation. When women frequently produce this kind of laugh, they are generally leadership types.

## **The Mouth: A Medium That Reflects the Mind**

Chewing food and speaking both require the mouth. These frequent daily actions make the muscles around the mouth exceptionally developed and sensitive, turning mouth movements into a key that opens the inner world. Whether opening or closing, rising or falling, moving forward or backward, tightening or relaxing, these basic mouth movements form a rich variety of psychological cues.

## **People with Spaced Teeth**

Although the teeth are spaced, overall health is good. Such people tend to be cheerful and optimistic, straightforward, and without guile. They are honest and treat others sincerely. Their shortcoming is that they cannot keep secrets; any small secret entrusted to them will not stay hidden and may be inadvertently revealed. Therefore, never tell them anything you do not want others to know.

## **Orbicularis Oris Muscle**

The orbicularis oris muscle surrounds the mouth by 2–3 centimeters, forming a flat, round shape controlled by the facial nerve. Its functions include closing the lips, chewing, and producing speech. When the orbicularis oris muscle is tense, the lips perform actions such as tightly closing, pursing, corners turning upward or downward, or the lower lip parting. Like the eyes, the mouth is a key area for observing facial expressions.

## **Slight Smile with Mouth Slightly Open, Revealing Upper Incisors**

When people smile lightly, their upper incisors become exposed, and they usually make eye contact with others. This smile often serves as a greeting among friends, family, and colleagues or business partners for whom one feels genuine regard. People who display this smile are typically imaginative, highly creative, full of vitality in their outlook on life, and possess a strong sense of humor.

## **3. Pouting: Expression of Sadness and Contempt**

Pouting appears more frequently on the faces of people who are habitually unhappy; their lower lip protrudes forward while the corners of the mouth droop. They use this movement to release inner displeasure. At the same time, a person who scoffs at something will also execute a quick pouting motion.

## **Small Teeth**

People with small teeth have gentle, calm personalities and exceptional endurance. They are emotionally rich, enjoy helping others, and maintain good relationships. Their logical thinking is strong; they proceed methodically, work meticulously, and remain attentive to detail. However, they tend to be sensitive, even somewhat neurotic, and often fixate excessively on minor points.

## **Inward-Tilting Teeth**

Both upper and lower rows of teeth tilt inward. Such individuals readily accept new things, frequently propose bold ideas and innovations, and prefer to stand out from the crowd, making them well suited for planning roles. They take pride in distinctive behavior. Their drawback is a strong tendency toward revenge.

## **Large Teeth**

People with large teeth also possess good physical stamina, abundant energy, rugged personalities, and bold actions. Yet they lack sufficient care in their work and are prone to errors. They think deeply, act honestly, and love their jobs. In personality, they tend to be selfish and driven by strong desires.

## **Protruding Teeth**

Most such people speak bluntly and without filter, often offending others. They are stubborn, self-centered, and may act outrageously to attract attention. Their obstinate nature also strains relationships with relatives and friends.

#### **4. Crooked Mouth: Extreme Inner Tension and Anxiety**

When a person's mouth appears stiff or skewed, it signals extreme inner unease so intense that the individual remains unaware the mouth has twisted. Sometimes, however, the crooked appearance simply reflects a habitual speaking manner.

#### **Smile with Corners of the Mouth Turned Down, Mouth Barely Open**

During this smile the lips remain tightly closed; it flashes briefly in familiar settings or when circumstances feel satisfactory. People who frequently display it are stubborn and ambitious, yet reluctant to reveal their inner emotions.

#### **Levator Labii Superioris Muscle**

The levator labii superioris muscle primarily raises and everts the upper lip while cooperating with other muscles to deepen and lift the nasolabial fold. It covers a broad area from the lower edge of the orbicularis oculi muscle to the outer side of the upper lip, with one muscle on each side.

#### **Neatly Aligned Teeth**

Teeth are evenly spaced and orderly. Such people are traditional, prefer routine, and resist change. They work conscientiously and steadily, shoulder responsibility, confront problems with courage and reason, and enjoy high esteem.

#### **Laughter Has Not Only Sound but Also Shape**

Laughter reflects mood, yet its forms differ widely. Drawing on research in nonverbal communication and psychology, FBI agents have concluded that observing how a person laughs reveals inner character and personality.

#### **Usually Quiet, but Laughs Exaggeratedly**

Such individuals seem reserved with strangers, yet once genuine bonds form they value friendship deeply and will go to great lengths for friends when needed.

#### **Nervous Laugh**

The laugh is hurried, stops abruptly, then resumes after checking others' reactions. This signals inferiority and lack of confidence; the person fears even laughter may be inappropriate.

#### **Zygomaticus Minor Muscle**

The zygomaticus minor muscle lies outside the cheekbone and extends to the outer side of the upper lip. Its main action is to lift the upper lip and deepen the nasolabial fold.

## Covering Mouth with Hand When Laughing

Most such people are introverted and gentle; they rarely disclose their true thoughts even to close friends.

## Laughing Along When Seeing Others Laugh

Such people are optimistic, outgoing, emotionally responsive, compassionate, and maintain a positive outlook on life.

## Depressor Labii Inferioris Muscle

The depressor labii inferioris muscle lies beneath the orbicularis oris muscle, adjacent to the depressor anguli oris and mentalis muscles; its primary function is to pull the lower lip downward.

## Laughing with Whole Body Shaking

Such people are open-minded, straightforward, and sincere.

See Sadness (s-sadness).

See Hands (c-hands).

See Hands (c-hands).

## Mouth Muscles

### 6. Orbicularis Oris

Orbicularis oris is the only muscle among the 15 groups of facial expression muscles that does not appear in symmetrical form, yet it is internally symmetrical as well.

The name of orbicularis oris closely resembles that of orbicularis oculi, differing by only a single character. This naming was in fact a misunderstanding; at the time of naming, the mouth was assumed to be encircled by a series of ring-shaped striated muscles functioning as a sphincter. In reality, orbicularis oris consists of four parts that together form the peripheral and marginal portions; the lips commonly referred to are the marginal portion. The line of junction between the peripheral and marginal portions corresponds on the external surface to the boundary between the red lip and the skin. The peripheral portion is open and connects in every direction to other important expression muscles of the lower face: levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, levator labii superioris, levator anguli oris, platysma, depressor anguli oris, depressor labii inferioris, and mentalis.

Contraction of orbicularis oris produces tightening or pursing of the mouth, while the actions of surrounding muscles may exert opposing effects, pulling the respective portions of orbicularis oris in different directions and thereby producing actions such as raising the upper lip, elevating the corners of the mouth, stretching the lips, downturning the corners of the mouth, or parting the lower lip.

Consequently, after the eyes, the mouth is the second key site for capturing and analyzing changes in expression.

## 12. Platysma

Platysma originates from the upper chest and ultimately terminates at the corner of the mouth on orbicularis oris after passing the mandible; it is bilaterally symmetrical. The platysma discussed in this book refers specifically to its facial portion, because it can form important expression configurations by pulling on the corners of the mouth. The fibers of platysma near the mouth angle lie between depressor anguli oris and depressor labii inferioris, occupying the same plane as depressor labii inferioris; at their margins the three muscles fuse and all attach to the lower lip.

The action of platysma resembles that of zygomaticus major—stretching the corners of the mouth laterally—yet the direction is entirely different. Zygomaticus major stretches the corners of the mouth toward the ears, whereas platysma stretches them laterally and downward (in coordination with depressor anguli oris). This movement typically appears in expressions of crying with the mouth open or pouting, conveying negative emotion.

#### **16. Buccinator**

After the cheeks are puffed out, buccinator can expel air between the lips—an important action when playing wind instruments, which is also the origin of the muscle's name (Latin buccinator = trumpeter). Buccinator's primary contribution to expression is "puffing the cheeks," yet this voluntary expression bears no close relationship to emotion and is used at most to indicate relief from pressure; it is therefore marked with an "A" and is neither explained in detail nor included among the principal muscle groups in this book.

#### **14. Depressor Labii Inferioris**

Depressor labii inferioris lies inferior to orbicularis oris, fuses with the inferior peripheral portion of orbicularis oris, and is bilaterally symmetrical.

As its name indicates, this muscle pulls the lower lip downward and slightly stretches it laterally; it can also assist in everting the lower lip. It participates in actions during angry shouting, biting, fear, and sadness. Exposing the lower teeth necessarily requires the action of depressor labii inferioris.

#### **13. Depressor Anguli Oris**

Depressor anguli oris arises via a long attachment band from the mental tubercle of the mandible and the continuous oblique line, situated inferior to the origin of depressor labii inferioris; it is bilaterally symmetrical.

**Action:** During mouth opening and expressions of grief or sorrow, depressor anguli oris pulls the corners of the mouth downward and laterally. When the mouth opens, the nasolabial folds become more horizontal, with their middle portions level.

#### **11. Levator Anguli Oris**

The fibers of levator anguli oris interweave at the mouth angle of orbicularis oris with zygomaticus major, depressor anguli oris, and orbicularis oris; some superficial fibers attach beneath the dermis of the nasolabial fold; the muscle is bilaterally symmetrical.

During smiling, levator anguli oris assists zygomaticus major in elevating the corners of the mouth and indirectly alters the shape and depth of the nasolabial folds.

#### **10. Zygomaticus Major**

Zygomaticus major originates from the zygomatic bone and fuses at the corners of the mouth with levator anguli oris and orbicularis oris to form a deeper muscular bundle; it is bilaterally symmetrical.

Although zygomaticus major and zygomaticus minor have similar names, their actions differ markedly. For expression, zygomaticus major has only one function: pulling the corners of the mouth upward and laterally to produce a smile.

### **8. Levator Labii Superioris**

Levator labii superioris originates from the inferior orbital margin; its fibers converge with those of levator labii superioris alaeque nasi and zygomaticus minor at the lateral portion of the upper lip (toward the corners of the mouth); it is bilaterally symmetrical.

Contraction of levator labii superioris elevates and everts the upper lip and, together with other muscles, alters the shape of the nasolabial folds.

### **9. Zygomaticus Minor**

Zygomaticus minor originates from the lateral surface of the zygomatic bone and terminates at the lateral portion of the upper lip (toward the corners of the mouth); it is bilaterally symmetrical.

Contraction of zygomaticus minor elevates the upper lip, exposes the maxillary teeth, and helps deepen and lift the nasolabial folds, participating chiefly in expressions of disgust and sadness.

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Nose expressing emotions (s-nose-emotions).

## **Basic Mouth Movements**

### **Licking or Biting the Lips**

Usually, licking the lips is seen as a flirtatious sexual signal. If you're flirting with a man and he licks his lips, whether intentional or not, it means he wants to kiss you. Of course, licking the lips isn't just a sexual hint. If someone's lips feel dry, they'll lick them to moisten them.

When a person bites their own lips, it usually indicates anxiety, discomfort, frustration, or embarrassment. Additionally, lip-biting can also show confusion. Although lip-biting is considered a sign of restlessness (sometimes childish), many people have the habit of biting their lips and are often unaware of it.

Sometimes, smiling doesn't necessarily mean happiness

Smiling reflects a person's mood, but there are many variations in how people smile. Observing the way someone smiles can reveal their inner thoughts and personality.



## **Pouting and Pursing the Lips**

Pouting is an action where the lower lip is deliberately protruded, which can express various emotions such as sadness, disappointment, or frustration. People may also pout when being playful or serious, but it generally leans toward a transitional reaction between dissatisfaction and anger. Moreover, this expression can evoke associations with childishness, so it should be used cautiously. When seeing a pouting action, many people tend to become annoyed.

Pursing the lips generally indicates that a person is angry. In fact, there are two different pouting postures considered "pursing the lips": one is when people press their upper and lower lips together while suppressing anger; the other is when the lips are squeezed from all directions, making the mouth look small and full of tension. Either posture indicates that the person is trying to suppress their anger or avoid being commented on by others.

## **Lips Pushed Forward**

More protruding forward than the action of lips pushed aside, becoming pursed forward. This suggests that the person's mind may be in some defensive state and they are trying to speak. At this point, no matter what you say, they won't believe it; it's better to give them a chance to speak, and things might take a turn.

Usually, the inner messages conveyed by the mouth are relatively easy to observe and understand. However, observing the mouth alone may not be entirely accurate, and it needs to be combined with other facial movements for a final judgment.

## **Mouth Pressed into a Straight Line**

A person making this gesture may be facing an urgent situation or needs to make a major life decision quickly. The lip-pressing action indicates they have already made a decision but feel great pressure, and they unconsciously do this to encourage themselves and build confidence. If someone frequently makes this gesture, it suggests they have a stubborn personality and won't back down when facing difficulties, so they have a high chance of success.

## **Smiling**

The corners of the mouth turn upward, forming a slight arc. Generally, this action indicates mental pleasure; it is a natural expression of true feelings, conveying sincerity, conviction, friendliness, affection, joy, shyness, and other emotions. Both others and the person themselves will feel comfortable in body and mind. Smiling more, even if it's a forced smile, is a lubricant for interpersonal relationships and can promote harmony in relationships.

## **Mouth Forming an "O" Shape**

The mouth opens into a circle, with accompanying expressions like eyes widening and eyebrows raising. This mouth movement may occur when encountering or hearing something unbelievable, feeling extremely shocked and surprised. For example, if a very unattractive person marries a beautiful bride, acquaintances hearing this would certainly open their mouths wide, as if asking, "Is this really true?"

## **Teeth Biting the Lips**

During conversation, if the other person bites their upper lip with their lower teeth or their lower lip with their upper teeth, it indicates they are listening attentively to your conversation and carefully pondering the meaning of your words. If this happens at the negotiation table, it means they are very interested in your product or approve of the terms you've proposed. Next, you can persuade the other party quite easily without much effort.

### **Laughing Out Loud**

The mouth opens wide, even without regard for appearance. Generally, this action represents extreme happiness and shows great trust in the other person, indicating a close relationship where they don't fear damaging their image. People rarely make this gesture in front of strangers. It usually occurs in front of acquaintances when emotions are extremely relaxed, leading to open-mouthed laughter.

### **Lips Twisted to One Side**

This indicates inner anxiety and unease, possibly due to encountering significant trouble or being in a difficult situation. For example, this mouth shape can be seen on the face of a driver waiting for a traffic police officer to handle an issue.

Additionally, some mouth movements are very quick and small in amplitude, and if not careful, we might miss them.

### **Lips Pushed Slightly Forward**

The lips protrude slightly forward, resembling a pout but with a small amplitude. This indicates a skeptical or uncertain attitude toward the received external information, hoping for confirmation or a more detailed explanation.

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

## **Mouth Shapes for Specific Emotions**

In Hollywood's golden age, male actors cast as despicable villains did not cover their mouths to imply the presence of a secret; instead, they lowered their voices and spoke with their mouths turned to one side.

This behavior typically leads us to associate the speaker with prisoners or people who have criminal records. In the past, prisons forbade inmates from conversing with one another. To avoid breaking the rules, prisoners spoke with their mouths turned to one side. Over time, the habit became deeply ingrained and continued even after release.

When people deliberately try to keep their conversation from being overheard, they often press a palm against their mouth while speaking. If a seated person rests both elbows on the table and clasps both hands over the mouth, the unspoken message is: "I don't want you to hear what I'm saying" (see Figure 4.33). The same posture is held while listening to others and is released only when the speaker reaches a key point or an appropriate moment.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 4.33 Concealing One's Conversation]*

Note that the gesture of covering the mouth should not be confused with the action of interrupting someone. Interrupting signals a desire to break into the conversation and offer one's own suggestion (see "Can I interrupt?").

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

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See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

See Mouth (c-mouth).

## Chin

### **Mentalis**

The mentalis lies beneath the orbicularis oris. Its primary function is to control the raising and lowering of the chin. When the chin rises and forms an irregular, wrinkled bulge on the surface, the mentalis is tense. People can usually control the mentalis voluntarily to produce expressions of sadness or contempt.

These facial muscles form a group whose changes are easy to observe. Understanding them reveals the meaning behind expressions.

Some of these muscles can be controlled consciously, such as the mentalis and the corrugator supercilii. One important muscle region, however, cannot be controlled at will: the levator palpebrae superioris. This muscle contains smooth muscle fibers, formerly called involuntary muscle. As the name implies, it cannot be controlled consciously and responds only to the autonomic nervous system. Its activation therefore signals

some form of stimulation—fear, tension, pain, or worry. That is why the levator palpebrae superioris is a key area in the study of expressions.

When liars try to conceal genuine emotion, they often attempt to control their facial muscles, yet muscles containing smooth fibers cannot be masked unless the liar suffers autonomic-nerve damage.

In addition to smooth-muscle cues, symmetry across paired facial muscles can be observed. When a person in pain is forced to smile, the muscles involved in smiling become asymmetrical—one side larger, one side smaller. This “asymmetrical expression” is an important means of detecting deception. No method other than continuous practice reliably reveals such asymmetry.

Muscle knowledge shows that certain expressions are difficult to control or conceal. A deceiver may replace one expression with another in a short time, yet may remain unaware of an uncontrollable micro-expression that has already appeared.

A Swedish chef was hired to endorse a cooking magazine. To promote natural, organic food, the photographer supplied two freshly dug potatoes still covered in soil. The chef was asked to hold them and look pleased. The muddy, slippery potatoes disgusted the fastidious chef, yet she forced a smile for the sake of the shoot. The resulting photograph looked perfect to most viewers. Psychologist Feksa, however, identified several micro-expressions—wrinkled nose, raised cheeks, slightly everted upper lip, deepened nasolabial folds—all indicating disgust.

Later sections present basic methods for reading faces. These techniques should not be treated as infallible; accurate judgment of emotion requires multiple skills and background knowledge of the individual.

## **Teeth, Chin, and Emotion**

Teeth are linked not only to physical health but also, to some degree, to personality.

- People with large teeth tend to be intuitive, thoughtful, honest, and warm-hearted, yet less attentive to detail.
- People with small teeth usually possess strong analytical and discriminative abilities, are gentle and calm, and show high endurance.
- Protruding teeth indicate frank, rapid speech that may exaggerate; such individuals often lack persistence.
- Inward-slanting teeth suggest creativity, personal principles, and strong planning ability.
- Even teeth reflect a preference for stability, composure, responsibility, and willingness to confront problems.
- Loose teeth indicate an open, straightforward nature free of guile, yet such people may unintentionally reveal secrets; conversations with them should be chosen with care.

One day at the corner of 42nd and 5th Streets in New York, a small elderly woman stood frozen at the curb, overwhelmed by the traffic and noise. Her chin trembled. A young man helped her, and once steadied she stopped trembling.

Emotion is closely tied to the anatomy and movement of the chin. Physiology teaches that cardiac nerve endings extend to the chin. When fear disrupts heart rhythm, blood flow to the periphery is reduced, causing the chin and teeth to tremble.

A large, prominent lower jaw produces a relatively recessed chin, termed a “recessed chin.” Cardiac rhythm in such individuals is typically firm, steady, and strong. Their character tends to be brave and persistent; they act only after careful deliberation and maintain control over their actions. This does not imply that a protruding chin denotes cowardice. Although heartbeat in a “protruding chin” is less even, these individuals are mentally agile and react intensely.

Imagine you are a retail salesperson. A customer approaching with a long, pointed chin requires patience; such people deliberate carefully, and an aggressive pitch will only annoy them. A customer whose chin is short and recedes needs no lengthy explanation—simply display the merchandise.

Remembering a person’s name does not mean knowing the person; only by understanding character, interests, and aspirations can one truly know another.

### **Protruding Chin: Signal of Defiance**

Traditional physiognomy holds that the chin represents late-life wealth and the capacity to accumulate assets. A square, rounded chin forecasts financial security and property in old age; an overly narrow chin suggests wealth will scatter. A recessed, small, inward chin indicates that even if money is present, the person lacks the ability to enjoy it and may suffer illness or distress because of poor financial judgment.

Although the chin appears slow to respond, it can reveal deeper thoughts and feelings. A protruding chin signals defiance. Children who reject parental advice commonly thrust the chin forward.

Hand-to-chin contact often conveys the attitude “Very well, let me think,” a gesture observed worldwide during decision-making. Henry Siddons wrote in *The Art of Gesture*: “This posture indicates that a prudent person is forming a judgment.”

On stage, especially in Shakespearean productions, actors frequently adopt the pose while delivering lines that signal careful analysis. Spectators at chess matches likewise observe players touching the chin when considering the next move. Once a decision is reached, stroking of beard or chin ceases.

A common accompanying expression is a slight sideways glance, as though weighing long-term consequences.

Touching the chin or cheek can also indicate inner unease or fear. After President Nixon became entangled in the Watergate affair, he was observed touching his chin and cheek during an interview—an action he had never displayed before the scandal. Psychologist Professor Fast concluded that Nixon could not escape involvement.

In psychology, self-touching is interpreted as self-soothing. Its basic meaning is inner unrest, heightened tension, or fear. When emotionally wounded or stressed, people unconsciously touch, scratch, or pinch themselves. Nixon’s self-contact revealed his fear once evidence mounted.

### **Character Written on the Chin**

Although “one may know the face but not the heart,” personality traits are nevertheless expressed through micro-expressions. Different personalities produce characteristic micro-expressions. Careful observation and analysis of these signals allow rapid insight into character and prediction of behavior.

Reading personality from the chin is simple yet requires skill. Continuous practice and the conversion of everyday experience into general principles are necessary.

The chin area is richly supplied with nerve endings. Stimulating the vagus nerve nearby can induce calm, yet when an already calm person repeatedly strokes the chin, the motive is not self-calming. Why?

Actors observe micro-expressions most closely; they replicate them to portray different personalities. In film and television, characters who frequently touch the chin are typically detectives, thinkers, or professionals requiring strong logical ability. Their shared traits are caution and vigilance. The chin functions almost as a valve that triggers composure and encourages objective observation. In contrast, people whose emotions are light and thinking straightforward pay little attention to the chin; it remains relaxed and moves only in concert with smiles. Such individuals are generally outgoing, receptive to suggestions, and less opinionated—sometimes to the point of appearing indecisive.

### **Chin Defying Gravity**

The chin occupies the lowest position on the face, limiting its range of motion. Its normal posture is downward, aligned with gravity. When a person wishes to project positivity or confidence, the body defies gravity—raising hands, lifting feet, and elevating the head so the chin, normally perpendicular to the ground, tilts upward.

An upward chin is a classic micro-expression indicating positive emotion. A highly raised chin signals strong self-confidence, though it may also be read as arrogance. French President Charles de Gaulle, renowned for political and military acumen, left a lasting visual impression with his habitually elevated chin.

When de Gaulle disliked a reporter's question, he would raise his chin and declare, "I will make no comment on that matter." The image, widely broadcast, became emblematic of de Gaulle and conveyed a lofty refusal that introduced the world to a distinctly French chin posture.

### **Nerve Endings of the Chin**

People are often seen rubbing or stroking the chin during extreme tension, seeking comfort. Comfort gestures are reliable nonverbal signals of emotional distress and can prompt timely changes in topic or direction. The abundance of such gestures at the chin stems from its distinctive anatomy: numerous nerve endings extend from the neck to the chin. Medical research shows that massaging this region effectively lowers blood pressure and restores normal heart rate, rapidly producing calm.

Men and women differ slightly in chin-touching. Men more often grasp or cover the chin, stimulating the vagus nerve and carotid sinus with greater pressure to achieve quick calm. Men engaged in thought frequently touch the chin unconsciously; the gesture has become a hallmark of the thinker.

### **Section 4: The Remarkable Chin**

In Mao Dun's *The Shop of the Lin Family*, the chamber of commerce president "stroked his chin and smiled again." Within context, the gesture reveals the president's deliberation and a touch of self-satisfaction, marking him as a cautious man.

The chin, though not counted among the five sensory organs, strongly influences overall facial contour. Beyond its roles in speech and mastication, the chin's shape offers clues to temperament.

Daily observation shows that male jawlines from mandible to zygoma appear more angular and firm, while female jawlines tend to be softer and rounder. Individual chins vary: an S-shaped profile (convex above, concave below) suggests quick thinking and extreme caution; a reverse-S profile (concave above, convex below) suggests optimism, flexibility, and aptitude for handicrafts. Other shapes likewise disclose temperament.

#### **4. Square Chin**

A square chin denotes ambition, practicality, adherence to personal beliefs, and perfectionism. Such individuals rarely tolerate error. The same traits foster deep self-respect and stubbornness, yet also produce resilience.

Chin-related actions can indicate inner state and are useful in business negotiations and workplace interactions. People who stroke the chin while listening are usually attentive and thoughtful, moving toward a decision. In meetings, listeners who lean forward and rest the chin on a hand are typically concentrating; the gesture externalizes their mental engagement.

#### **Chin Movements and Emotional Analysis**

Forward or retracted chin position reflects emotion and inner change. Though ordinary in appearance, the chin conveys important information.

Unlike other facial expressions, chin movements are subtle and often overlooked, yet they reliably indicate psychological shifts. Experienced observers can read emotion and interpret psychology from the chin.

A retracted chin signals forbearance; a drooping chin signals fatigue; a tightened chin signals submission. Psychologists note that habitual chin retraction often accompanies timidity, inner unrest, and worry. Such people proceed cautiously, focus on immediate gain, and lack long-term vision. They rarely trust others and keep them at a distance.

Different chin movements therefore correspond to distinct emotions.

#### **Chin**

Although the chin appears slow to respond, it can reveal deeper thoughts and feelings.

For example, contraction of the mentalis indicates "suppressed" anger; clenching the teeth shows that even while feeling rage or irritation, the person is attempting to control emotion. Although the mouth remains closed, mental activity is visible through tightening or curving of the upper mentalis.

In general, a protruding chin signals defiance, as when children reject parental advice.

#### **Psychology Mini-Lesson**

The FBI holds that many methods can analyze psychological change. Reading the chin is one effective approach.

Drawing on years of field experience, the FBI notes that chin movements are subtle and difficult to detect, yet provide a valuable window into psychological secrets. The Bureau examines the following aspects:

## Restless Chin

Anatomically lowest and seemingly functionless, the chin is often dismissed as useless. Micro-expression observers, however, regard every muscle as purposeful and emotionally expressive. Though inconspicuous and frequently ignored, the chin's emotional range is rich and authentic; beneath its plain appearance lie multiple puzzles awaiting solution.

## 2. Round Chin

A round chin conveys an approachable impression. In traditional Chinese physiognomy, such a chin often accompanies a happy marriage. A woman with a round chin is typically family-oriented and attentive to every detail of care. A man with a round chin is viewed as a symbol of prosperity, gentle and compassionate, and likely to enjoy career success.

## 1. Long Chin

A long chin lends an elegant, delicate appearance to the face, yet excessive length may seem unapproachable. A short chin produces the opposite effect, making the face appear cramped.

## Platysma

The platysma originates at the corners of the orbicularis oris and extends downward to the upper chest. Its broad coverage allows it to pull the mouth corners sideways and downward, producing downturned or pouting expressions.

## 3. Wide Chin

A wide chin suggests a firm temperament, a tendency to probe matters to their roots, caution, sensitivity to minor issues, and pronounced jealousy.

See Legs and feet (c-legs).

See Hands (c-hands).

## Mentalis

The chin, commonly referred to as the lower chin (bottom of the chin). The mentalis originates below the lower circumference of the orbicularis oris (lower part of the lower lip) and inserts into the skin of the chin, symmetrically on both sides.

When the mentalis contracts, it serves two functions: the mentalis bulges, forming a lump on the chin with an uneven skin surface; at the same time, it presses the middle portion of the lower lip upward. This important morphological feature primarily appears in sadness-related expressions. However, this action can also be voluntarily invoked to deliberately express negative meanings such as sorrow or contempt.

See Chin (c-chin).

See Chin (c-chin).

## Chin Movements and Gait



## **2. Single Finger Supporting the Chin**

Place the index finger on the cheek, support the chin with the thumb, and curl the remaining fingers between the chin and lips. People who adopt this posture are generally rigorous and hold a strong critical attitude internally, or they are preparing to persuade the other party with a completely opposing viewpoint. During conversation, if someone makes this gesture, take note—the other party may be about to refute you. In social settings, they usually do not like to speak much or voice their own opinions, because they struggle to find topics for shared conversation. As a result, such individuals often appear introverted and difficult for others to understand. However, psychologists have found through research that although these people are not skilled at expressing their views, they have relatively easygoing personalities and are approachable, though they are not very proactive in social situations.

### **1. Chin Held High**

People who hold their chin high are generally arrogant and overly confident, believing they never make mistakes; even when they do, they will argue forcefully to save face. Such individuals typically possess a strong sense of superiority and intense jealousy, refusing to acknowledge others' successes and often dismissing others' achievements. In addition, people who hold their chin high have strong self-esteem and cannot tolerate those who fail to respect them. After years of study, psychologists have found that when people raise their chin, they are often displaying fearlessness, arrogance, dominance, or even an attitude of haughtiness. Therefore, a raised chin always conveys an impression of authority.

### **2. Chin Pulled Back**

The FBI notes that people who pull their chin back and press it low generally possess strong self-awareness and cannot tolerate being slighted. If someone belittles them, they easily become enraged and will confront the offender through concrete actions. They disdain those who play mind games and often respond with indifference, yet this does not indicate stupidity. Because they are straightforward by nature and consider scheming beneath them, they conduct themselves openly and honorably.

## **6. Stroking the Chin**

Stroking the chin is actually a brief form of supporting the chin. If the action is accompanied by a raised face and a smile, it indicates the person feels triumphant. Such individuals generally possess ample confidence—sometimes bordering on arrogance—and their attitude toward others lacks sincerity. In addition, stroking the chin can signal inner unease or loneliness.

### **1. Chin Lifted**

The FBI observes that people who lift their chin display their emotions openly and do not know how to conceal them. They are straightforward and sincere, treating those they like with candor and refusing to feign warmth toward those they dislike. Because their likes and dislikes are so clearly expressed, they can appear cold and may unintentionally offend others.

## **5. Both Hands Supporting the Chin**

Resting the chin on both hands like a little girl is actually a form of self-soothing. People who frequently adopt this posture imagine their hands as a reliable support, indicating they have concerns and are paying little

attention to their surroundings, fully absorbed in their own thoughts. It may also mean they find the other person's words boring and are fantasizing about finding enjoyment elsewhere.

#### **4. Chin Following the Gaze**

When communicating, people whose chin follows their gaze tend to be steady and practical. They value reason and loyalty, distinguish clearly between love and hate, and adhere strongly to principles. They possess considerable self-control, do not indulge themselves, rarely lose their temper, and do not quibble over trifles; even when taken advantage of, they do not dwell on it.

#### **3. Chin Aligned with the Head**

People whose chin remains aligned with their head have relatively mild temperaments and are gentle toward everyone. Even when encountering individuals they dislike, they respond only with coolness rather than confrontation. Such individuals are rational and composed, refusing to let emotions dictate their actions, and they observe certain principles in their conduct.

#### **3. Single Hand Vertically Supporting the Chin**

Resting the chin on the palm with fingers curled and tapping the nose indicates the person is currently bored or uninterested in what you are saying. Although they appear to be pondering something, they are actually just playing with their fingers.

#### **4. Single Hand Horizontally Supporting the Chin**

Resting the chin on the palm while supporting the cheek with the fingers shows the person is thinking seriously. If someone makes this gesture while you are trying to persuade them, it means they have begun to waver and are evaluating and judging your words.

See Chin (c-chin).

See Chin (c-chin).

## **Part Three Basic Emotions on the Face**

### **Small Scenario**

Woman: Let's break up.

Man: What did you say? (Surprise. He did not expect her to bring it up so directly.)

Woman: Yesterday I got a call from XX (Note: name of her ex-boyfriend). He said he can't forget me.

Man: Why is he still calling you now? (Disgust. He feels repelled by the woman's ex-boyfriend.)

Woman: I think he's right. He understands me better than you do.

Man: What!! (Anger. An urge to attack arises; if that man were here, he would probably charge at him.)

Woman: Being with you is fun, but the pain is just as great. We've argued so many times, yet you still can't fully understand who I am. He may not be romantic, but I feel more secure with him. I can't let go of him. I've

thought about it for a long time. For both our sakes, let's just be friends.

Man: I can change. I can change anything for you. I can't live without you. (Fear. He knows the chance of winning her back is slim.)

Woman: You deserve a better girl, and there are already many good ones around you. What you're feeling now is just not being used to it yet. I know it's cruel, but I really don't want us to keep repeating the same arguments. Here's your phone back, and the house key. Goodbye. I'll always wish you well.

Man: ... (Sadness. He knows it is irreversible.)

This is only one of many common scenes in life. If someone feels nothing, it can only mean they no longer care. As long as they still care, an emotional reaction will occur.

Are humans rational advanced beings or slaves to emotion? Both statements are too extreme. Adding a premise makes it more accurate: when not in a hurry, humans are masters of reason; when hurried, humans are slaves to emotion. The "hurry" here refers to encountering an effective stimulus.

When we encounter an effective stimulus, the first reaction is surprise. Unexpected or uncertain sudden stimuli draw attention. If the event was already confirmed in advance, the worrying has already been done and one simply waits calmly.

At the same time as surprise, a quick judgment can be made—whether the stimulus source is beneficial or harmful. If it is good, the rest is simple: a great benefit brings hearty laughter, a smaller one brings quiet delight. If it is bad, further level assessment is required.

Stimuli that are disliked, disapproved of, or unacceptable—such as a bad smell or unpleasant words—but that carry no aggression or threat, trigger disgust. The immediate thought with disgust is to confirm that the stimulus source will not harm oneself; rejection is enough, so the impulse is simply to move farther away or ignore it. Looking down on someone is the most common form of disgust: disapproval combined with a very low evaluation.

If the negative stimulus source escalates and poses a threat—whether to life, opinions, reputation, or even minor contradictions and obstacles—anger arises. The hallmark of anger is the urge to attack, the desire to eliminate the threatening stimulus through specific action.

However, if the negative pressure of the stimulus source exceeds the limit the person can bear—for example, being unable to fight back, unable to win an argument, or facing an irreversible downturn—the person loses confidence to carry out an attack (including resistance) and loses confidence that the threat can be removed. The only options left are to flee or accept fate. At this point the harmful outcome has not yet occurred, so the emotion is fear.

Once the outcome occurs and becomes an established fact with no hope of reversal, fear ceases and is replaced by sadness. When a negative stimulus source produces a result, the outcome is invariably a loss of benefit; sadness stems from that loss. The person had been caring and striving all along precisely to prevent the adverse result, so once it happens the entire body goes slack and loses energy—the most typical outward sign of sadness.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1]*

In summary, the first reaction to an effective stimulus is surprise; afterward, two directions of emotion arise. The positive direction produces varying degrees of pleasure. The negative direction, depending on the intensity of the stimulus source, produces—from mild to severe—disgust, anger, fear, and sadness. These six basic emotions cover all possible emotional reactions humans experience when processing external information. Common emotions such as contempt, irritation, fright, embarrassment, displeasure, and guilt can all be classified as derivatives of these six basic emotions at different intensities, as shown in Figure 1.

Similarly, American micro-expression pioneer scholar Paul Ekman also holds that humans possess six universal emotions and expressions that transcend race, culture, and region: surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and pleasure. To prove this crucial conclusion, the professor traveled to primitive tribes in New Guinea to study the facial expressions of populations that had never had deep contact with the outside world. This single great study alone commands the respect of later generations.

Emotions process different stimuli, while expressions constitute another mode of human communication—more authentic and accurate than language. More importantly, these six emotions and the expressions they drive are naturally linked. If facial expressions can be dissected to analyze the emotions behind the face, one can to some extent understand others' true inner thoughts (see Chapters 2 and 3 for details).

Therefore, in this book we organize the study and discussion of micro-expressions along the trajectory of these six emotions. In addition to the six basic emotions—surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and pleasure—we incorporate as many derivative emotions as possible, striving to identify the core essence of the micro-expressions of these emotions and helping readers improve their ability and efficiency in capturing micro-expressions. Among them, surprise is a relatively pure emotion; only afterward do various judgments arise. If the judgment is negative, the following sequence appears according to stimulus intensity: disgust-type emotions (including disgust, contempt, disdain, and other derivatives of varying intensity), anger-type emotions (including anger, threat, irritation, and displeasure and other derivatives of varying intensity), fear-type emotions (including fear, fright, unease, worry, and other derivatives of varying intensity), and sadness-type emotions (including sadness, guilt, helplessness, and other derivatives of varying intensity). If the judgment is positive, pleasure arises and triggers a smile.

Each emotion has its own distinctive expression; no matter how complex, every emotion possesses necessary morphological features and typical morphological features. These minute and subtle morphological features are the so-called micro-expressions.

Whether dealing with pure “micro-expressions” or complex compound expressions, there is only one way to grasp their true meaning: capture every subtle change on the face, distinguish the genuine from the false, and finally confirm the inner thoughts they represent.

Next, please test your current level of expression-recognition ability.

## Color Method: Emotions Change with Color

Human emotions are linked to color; fluctuations in our emotions are often influenced by color. Therefore, the color method can also be used to regulate emotions.

London's Blackfriars Bridge was once black, and people frequently jumped from it to commit suicide. After the bridge was painted sky blue, the number of suicides dropped noticeably. Research found that black appears gloomy and intensifies feelings of pain and despair, pushing already depressed people one step closer to

death. Sky blue, by contrast, makes people feel cheerful and hopeful, so to some extent it rekindles the will to live in those who had given up.

Why does color exert such a strong influence on human emotion?

Psychologists believe emotions are affected by color because colors originate from nature's innate palette—the blue sky, the bright red of blood, the golden sun. Seeing colors identical to these natural hues involuntarily evokes sensory experiences associated with those natural objects. People of different regions, ethnicities, and personalities share similar sensory experiences with certain colors; this may be the reason.

What effects, then, do different colors have on emotion?

### 1. **Green**

In nature, green is the color of grasslands and forests—the color of life—conveying vitality, youth, and freshness. Green feels gentle, friendly, comfortable, steady, and cool; it calms the nerves and relieves eye strain, exerting a certain soothing effect on negative emotions. A green environment can lower skin temperature by about 2 °C, reduce heart rate by 4–8 beats per minute, and make breathing more even. Frequent exposure to green helps maintain a calm mental state; therefore, walls in operating rooms and intensive-care units, as well as medical staff uniforms, are often light green to reduce the fear of critically ill patients.

### 2. **Blue**

Blue is the color of the sea and sky—an imaginative hue that conveys stability, peace, tranquility, and loftiness. It is also a relatively serious color. Blue regulates nerves and calms the mind; for example, blue light has a significant effect in treating insomnia and lowering blood pressure. Frequent exposure to blue tends to make people straightforward, refined in taste, and less materialistic.

### 3. **Yellow**

Because yellow is the color most easily absorbed in the spectrum, it gives a bright and free feeling. It symbolizes health and stabilizes mood. Some factories paint their walls yellow to eliminate or reduce the boredom workers feel during repetitive manual labor. Frequent exposure to yellow makes people cheerful, optimistic, and humorous.

### 4. **Red**

Red is a relatively stimulating color that often evokes a burning sensation and feelings of positivity, boldness, and enthusiasm. Occasional exposure to red can make people proactive and energetic. However, frequent exposure to red can also make people irritable, restless, impatient, and anxious.

### 5. **Purple**

Purple balances the inner self and relaxes the spirit. Some people therefore choose purple clothing for pregnant women to stabilize mood and prevent prenatal depression.

### 6. **Pink**

Pink symbolizes health and is a color commonly used by Americans; it is also women's favorite color. It relaxes the mind and soothes emotions. Pink has been employed to varying degrees in places such as the naval brig in Seattle, the youth home in San Bernardino, California, the psychiatric ward of the Los Angeles Veterans Hospital, and a school for hyperactive children in the South Bronx, all with the aim of calming emotions. For example, placing a violent patient or offender alone in a room with pink walls quickly quiets the person.

## 2.2 The Role of Emotion

According to the second explanation, the generation of emotion requires “situationality”; objects that “can satisfy a certain human need” and, conversely, objects that cannot satisfy such a need can trigger emotions of different natures. Yet the dictionary definition alone does not clearly reveal how emotion is actually stimulated.

People often say reason is superior to emotion. Judging by what people do in social life, rational thinking does make more decisions. However, an important premise is often overlooked: everyone’s social activities follow the same or similar rules, and those rules themselves were defined by countless people using reason.

In the micro-reaction research system, we hold that emotion is superior to reason. Whether in social life or purely physiological activities (outdoor pursuits, sports, eating, etc.), the first neural response to a stimulus is usually emotional; only afterward does thinking replace emotion as the dominant force. If the stimulus is too strong, thinking yields its dominant position and emotion takes over the body’s operations. Laughter during an important performance or impulsively harming someone despite knowing the serious legal consequences are both driven by emotion.

One should not conclude that reason is superior to emotion simply because the quantity of decisions made by reason far exceeds those made by emotion. Human psychology is actually quite fragile and easily swept into emotional impulses; major mistakes are often caused by emotion, so the quality of emotion-driven decisions is closer to humanity’s animal nature. Moreover, most memorable events are products of rational thought (because memory and thinking belong to the same type of cerebral-cortex function), whereas emotional impulses are not primarily based in the cerebral cortex and are therefore difficult to remember.

Emotion can be clearly perceived and affects the body. Some effects are obvious and even serious; others are harder to observe, such as changes in breathing or heartbeat. Yet one point is certain: wherever emotion exists, the body undergoes change—even minute internal changes are changes and can be captured by appropriate means. This is the principle behind the development of the polygraph (technically called a “multichannel psychological recorder”).

Emotion and reason are both functions of the nervous system for processing external information. Reason suits relatively rational situations, while emotion is closer to animal instinct and better suited to handling intense stimuli.

Emotion is an evolved survival mechanism. Using Darwin’s evolutionary perspective, emotion better ensures survival (safety) and reproduction (love). All emotions follow a single-layer processing logic: if something benefits me, respond positively; if it harms me, judge further and then choose among rejection, confrontation, avoidance, or surrender. These judgment criteria are free of social standards and rest solely on the organism’s subjective feelings; therefore emotion can directly reflect the subject’s cognition and feelings. This is also why judging emotion allows analysis of a person’s true thoughts.

In coping with complex environments, emotion mobilizes energy within the body and directs certain movements to maintain internal balance, especially the balance and stability of the nervous and circulatory systems—tasks too difficult for rational thinking. No matter how intelligent, humans remain animals.

### Anger Is Difficult to Fake or Conceal

Anger is the emotion that demands the greatest amount of energy—more than crying or laughing.

Consequently, once anger is aroused, the entire body coordinates and enters an obvious fighting state. Energy storage and transport require the cooperation of respiration and blood circulation. Therefore, when anger arises, breathing depth necessarily increases in an attempt to inhale more oxygen for combat. Under the direction of anger, the circulatory system accelerates and strengthens heart contractions, raising the volume and speed of blood circulation while elevating blood pressure to supply sufficient oxygen and fuel to the muscular and nervous systems.

This leads to two conclusions: first, the fighting response is hard to fake because it requires large amounts of energy to be coordinated and consumed throughout the body, making performance difficult. Feigning an anger response is the hardest form of pretense to execute convincingly. Second, once genuine anger appears, it manifests very clearly and is easy to capture.

Even under the constraints of civilized social rules that prohibit casual fighting or arbitrary harm, the primitive fighting response has evolved into several refined forms that appear non-combative yet reflect the same underlying danger.

Verbal and written attacks, sports competitions, and displays of wealth or beauty contests are all such evolutions.

In China's Ming dynasty, the important work of the censors was to reprimand people—supervising officials below and criticizing the emperor above, even engaging in open confrontations at court. The language of these scholars was elegant and profound, filled with classical allusions, and they observed proper ritual etiquette; yet once they became emotionally engaged, they would forget their status and image on the court just as people do in street quarrels.

Sports competitions are a derivative form of combat using the body; the stronger and more skillful side wins. Even spectators who cannot participate personally have their nerves stirred by the contest, shouting and cheering in excitement. This is why sports have developed into a vast, enduring industry.

Attractive people satisfy the opposite sex's innate need and desire for high-quality reproduction, so handsome men and beautiful women also compete overtly and covertly over appearance in hopes of attracting more affection and pursuit. Wealth is a condition for a high-quality life and can to some extent prove other advantages, so displays of wealth and financial competition also occur frequently.

For any individual human being, no matter how the forms change, bodily reactions share the same characteristics as animals fighting—strength and speed.

The three stages of the fighting response are combat preparation, combat exertion, and defensive protection.

#### 4. Subjective Expectations in Relaxed Events

The most typical relaxed event is counting down the final ten seconds with a large crowd on New Year's Eve to welcome the new year. The expectations discussed here are not the new hopes for the coming year; those are aspirational. We focus solely on people's subjective expectations of what will happen after those ten seconds. What are they? Cheering and jumping for joy, with every face around lit by happiness—some may cry, yet the atmosphere remains excited and positive, enveloping everyone.

This expectation requires no clear analysis or deliberate thought, correct?

Dark environments and tense events share the same nature: both generate negative subjective expectations. Although the triggers differ in complexity, the outcome is similar—fear of harm. Bright environments and relaxed events likewise share a nature: a sense of control and safety (because the setting or event is simple, or the individual has strong command of the situation) produces either a calm or a positive subjective expectation. Positive subjective expectations require more supporting information to arise naturally. More often, when people feel in control, they form only calm subjective expectations.

Human mental states therefore lean negative more frequently, yet this is not necessarily harmful. The presence of these negative subjective expectations helps people survive more safely while fostering a longing for happiness and hope. Once genuine happiness arrives, the feeling becomes especially precious, so that everyone pursues joy as a lifelong goal.

If happiness were the constant norm, normal human psychology could not sustain it. Without the pressures of survival and reproduction, people would chase illusory spiritual pleasures such as drug use.

Those with genuine insight strive to maintain a qualitative balance between pressure (negative subjective expectations) and happiness rather than a merely quantitative one.

A common saying holds that nine out of ten things in life go against one's wishes. The "wishes" here refer not to the expectations discussed in this text but to intentions formed after rational deliberation—purposes or hopes. Such considered aspirations are far more complex and ambitious than the expectations generated by survival instincts, and precisely for that reason they are fulfilled only one time in ten.

### 2.3.1 What Is Subjective Expectation?

Subjective expectation, as used here, is the judgment the nervous system forms about imminent events on the basis of all information received from past and present experience. Reading that sentence alone may suggest a clear, logical mental process, as though subjective expectation were highly rational. It must be emphasized that the term "expectation" does not refer to the logically derived forecast produced by a question such as "If it rains, what tool should I take outside?" On the contrary, most people describe this cognitive activity with the word "feeling" and usually do not engage in deliberate "thinking."

"Feeling" is in fact a rapid cognitive assessment and judgment made by the central nervous system in which numerous logical cues intermingle and influence one another. Its chief characteristic is that the person cannot explain how the judgment was reached; the individual cannot clearly reconstruct the cognitive process.

For example, upon arriving at the office one morning you notice more than one colleague glancing at you with flickering eyes; the moment they see you looking back, they avert their gaze. Normally your assistant brings your favorite tea within three minutes; today the assistant skirts around you while still busy with tasks—an odd departure. Someone is seated in the boss's office with their back to you, identity unclear. The boss, seeing you arrive, deliberately closes the blinds. Even the ever-conciliatory Old Liu offers only an awkward smile, a slight bow, then turns and retreats.

Anyone placed in this situation forms a judgment of danger. Yet in the process of "sensing that something is wrong," no explicit "because... therefore..." reasoning occurs. Instead, like an animal, the person applies the most primitive criterion—"what things should be like at their best or most normal"—to appraise the surroundings. These are the expectations in question. More often than not, subjective expectations run counter to rational thought, though they are not easily noticed or brought to awareness.



Humans are an evolved animal species whose primary needs, like those of other animals, are survival and reproduction. To meet these needs, people instinctively generate numerous expectations based on prior conditions. The following examples clarify this seemingly obscure concept.

## Psychology Mini-Class

At many moments in daily life, music can be used to reduce stress and dispel unpleasant moods.

### 1. **Waking up in the morning**

When the busy day ahead comes to mind, many people feel glum or even irritated and lack any motivation to get up. To dispel the annoyance, play a few pieces of music and draw positive energy from them. Listen while rising, washing, and eating breakfast so the day begins pleasantly and you bring an upbeat attitude and full energy into work and life.

### 2. **Commuting to and from work**

Commutes often feel long, especially in traffic jams that breed frustration and inner agitation. Listening to some uplifting music can calm the irritability and sweep away the bad mood caused by the congestion.

### 3. **Cooking and doing housework**

Many people return home after a full workday already tired and hungry, with little energy left for cooking or chores. Relying on takeout long-term deprives one of the taste of home and harms health. Neglecting housework leaves the home cluttered, which affects both physical health and mood. When reluctance to cook or clean arises, let favorite music accompany the tasks; this removes irritability, creates a relaxed feeling, and transforms the experience.

### 4. **Before sleep**

Adequate rest is essential for physical and mental health, so good sleep matters. When lying in bed tossing and turning brings agitation, listen to music for a while; the various sleep problems that trouble you will fade. A few beautiful, soothing pieces can induce mental pleasure and bodily ease, producing calming and hypnotic effects. When using earphones, keep the volume moderate and avoid prolonged listening, or hearing damage and other health risks may result.

## 1. Subjective Expectations in Dark Environments

Entering a pitch-dark environment where one cannot see one's own hand immediately slows and cautions every movement—an instinctive reaction shaped by long evolution. The subjective expectation at that moment is that objects (people, animals, or other entities) capable of causing harm may be present; even without such threats, collision with any object could cause injury. No one regards a dark environment as safe and warm, so the body naturally contracts while the limbs reach out slowly to explore. No one strides quickly or swings the limbs freely. Caution governs every action.

Some attribute this to fear of the unknown—because nothing can be seen. This explanation equates the root of fear with the unknown (invisibility). Yet why should the unknown necessarily produce fear, and why does that necessary link exist? Continuing in that direction yields the answer: because the unknown (invisibility) implies possible danger. That is subjective expectation.

Does the unknown never allow expectation of beneficial objects? Sometimes it does, but only when prior information has prepared the ground—for instance, secretive behavior on one's birthday may suggest a surprise celebration. That situation is not truly unknown. Absent such preparation, when a person suddenly

enters an unknown setting with no preceding signs, the survival instinct generates a negative expectation at once; the mind turns to self-preservation rather than anticipating good fortune. For a living organism, seeking safety is the norm; expecting good fortune is not.

A blind person remains unable to see yet does not remain perpetually fearful. Because of familiarity with dark environments and a distinctive way of obtaining information, the blind person's subjective expectations in such settings are safer than those of a sighted person; darkness is ordinary. Certain psychiatric patients facing unknown threats—for example, another person's angry postural threat—also fail to experience fear, because they cannot cognize the stimulus and therefore form no subjective expectation.

**The unknown is not the root of fear; the expectation that harm may be present is the root of fear.**

### Half-Full, Half-Hungry Method: Handling Pressure Correctly

Excessive pressure can crush a person; insufficient pressure breeds complacency. Only appropriate pressure keeps a person alert. Therefore the correct approach is the half-full, half-hungry method.

To understand this method, consider an experiment:

A chimpanzee is placed in a cage with its favorite food positioned outside at a distance reachable only with a stick also placed inside the cage. Researchers then observe the chimpanzee's feeding behavior when fully fed, when ravenously hungry, and when half-full, half-hungry.

When fully fed, the chimpanzee ignores the food outside; the stick becomes merely a toy. When ravenously hungry, it likewise ignores the stick and frantically reaches with its forelimbs, then grows angry, pounds the cage, screams, paces, and finally sits panting. Only in the half-full, half-hungry state does the chimpanzee use the stick to obtain the food and eat contentedly.

Thus, when excessively hungry the chimpanzee loses rationality because of overwhelming desire; when fully fed it has no desire to feed. Only in the intermediate state can it think rationally and use the available tool.

The same principle applies to humans: pressure that is too great or too small readily produces problems. Too little pressure makes work feel unchallenging, lowers efficiency, and induces mental slackness. Too much pressure easily exceeds psychological limits and becomes counterproductive. Pressure must remain moderate, because only then does a person maintain peak performance.

### Psychology Mini-Class

Moderate pressure benefits physical and mental health, yet once pressure reaches an individual's personal limit it must be relieved promptly. How, then, can pressure be relieved and psychological health preserved?

#### 1. Cut off the source of pressure

No universal standard exists; the method must be tailored to the individual.

Entrepreneurship, for example, generates controllable pressure for those with high psychological resilience but overwhelming pressure for those with low resilience. The latter should avoid starting businesses and thereby eliminate the pressure at its root<|eos|>

### Psychology Mini-Classroom

If you feel tense, stressed, or fatigued, observe more blue and green. Especially after a full day of work when you feel physically and mentally exhausted, under heavy pressure, and mentally tense, appropriate exposure

to blue and green can regulate the nerves, calm the mind, and relieve fatigue. However, moderation is also important; otherwise, prolonged time in a green environment can easily make a person feel desolate. Because red excites and stimulates, it is not conducive to emotional relaxation, so red should be avoided.

If you feel pessimistic, depressed, or downcast, observe more red, yellow, orange, and pink, as these belong to warm tones and can make people feel cheerful and generate excitement. Many entertainment venues use pink and orange to make rooms appear lively and warm, helping people relieve and release inner gloom. It is generally believed that when feeling depressed, especially for those with depression, blue should be avoided, as it may worsen the condition. People with autism or mental depression should not stay long in white environments.

If you feel irritable, suspicious, prone to anger, or emotionally unstable, observe more pink, light blue, and light yellow, as these colors are relatively bright and can strongly arouse unrestrained emotions, whereas dull colors such as white and black have a calming and suppressive effect on emotions. Generally speaking, white has cooling, calming, and stabilizing effects; for those who are agitated, restless, or insomniac, black helps restore stability; both white and pink can regulate people who are easily angered; pink and light blue can reduce adrenal hormone secretion, thereby stabilizing emotions.

### Music Therapy: Recovering Calm Through Music

When you feel irritable, sad, or lonely, music can provide spiritual comfort. Today, many people compose music like Chinese herbal formulas to treat various psychological disorders.

Music therapy is a treatment method based on the theories and methods of psychotherapy, primarily using music with medical treatment as a supplement. It mainly produces therapeutic effects through the form of music, influencing human emotions via rhythm, melody, tone, harmony, tempo, and dynamics.

Some psychologists believe Beethoven's music can make the sorrowful happy, the timid brave, and the frivolous solemn. The ancient Greek philosopher Aristotle most admired the key of C, considering it most suitable for cultivating the character of young people. They all held that music can directly affect human emotions and behavior.

A survey showed that different styles of music were played in a music appreciation class, after which students who heard the music were asked to describe their experiences. Regardless of whether the students had any musical background, over 90% reported similar reactions: when hearing a melodious piece, they felt cheerful and emotionally stable; when hearing an impassioned march, they felt inspired and enthusiastic; when hearing a solemn dirge, they felt sad and distressed.

Beautiful music can enhance the excitability of the cerebral cortex, improve people's moods, stimulate emotions, and make people feel invigorated. It also helps eliminate negative psychological states such as tension, anxiety, depression, and fear caused by various factors, thereby improving stress resilience.

### 3. Mismatch with Expectations of a Stressful Event

The boss enters the open-plan office and announces loudly that the company is facing financial difficulties at year-end and must lay off one-fifth of its employees. Tension instantly fills the room; everyone looks at one another in alarm. This state of mutual alarm means each person feels varying degrees of tension, unease, and fear. At this moment, your subjective expectation is: I might be the unlucky one.

- **Stimulus 1:** Your name is not on the layoff list. You? You breathe a sigh of relief and even feel a bit happy.
- **Stimulus 2:** Your name is on the list, but the name of someone less competent than you is not. You? Dejection mixed with anger. The dejection comes from being eliminated; the anger comes from the unfairness of the elimination.
- **Stimulus 3:** A few days later, another notice arrives saying no layoffs will occur after all, and everyone will receive a raise due to new funding. You? Of course you feel happy.

Hence the joke: Leader A enters the office: "This year's performance is poor; each person gets a 100-yuan year-end bonus." Everyone is indignant. Leader B enters the office: "This year's performance is poor; the boss says we have to cut staff." Everyone falls silent and exchanges glances. Leader B continues: "However, after I argued forcefully, our department will not cut anyone, and each person will still receive a 100-yuan year-end bonus." Everyone cheers.

The joke is about how to be a leader—in other words, how to set subjective expectations. The greater the gap created between subjective expectation and reality, the stronger the stimulus on people.

## 2.1 The Concept of Emotion

According to the *Xinhua Dictionary*, the term "emotion" has two definitions:

1. Mood; state of mind; in low spirits; waking up in a bad mood.
2. The experience arising from a person's attitude toward things. Often used interchangeably with "feeling," yet distinct. Emotion is linked to a person's natural needs and is situational, temporary, and has clear external manifestations; feeling is linked to a person's social needs and is stable, enduring, and may lack obvious external manifestations. The emergence of feeling is accompanied by emotional reactions, while changes in emotion are also controlled by feeling. Usually, an object that satisfies a certain need elicits a positive emotional experience, such as satisfaction, joy, or pleasure; conversely, it elicits a negative emotional experience, such as dissatisfaction, sorrow, or fear.

From an ordinary person's perspective, the two definitions show no obvious distinction. However, if you wish to understand this book, you must read and reflect carefully, especially on the second definition.

In the first definition, "mood" and "state of mind" are commonly used in contexts such as "in low spirits" or "in high spirits," providing an overall description of one's bodily emotional state. This kind of "emotion" lasts relatively long—not only hours or days, but also minutes. This usage is closer to the English word *mood*.

### 1. Expectation Mismatch in a Dark Environment

If you enter a pitch-dark environment where you cannot see your hand in front of your face, your nervous system naturally assumes that objects capable of harming you may be present, so you instinctively contract your body and extend your limbs slowly to explore the surroundings. You instinctively tell yourself: be careful.

- **Stimulus 1:** If the light is turned on and a group of friends stands in the room holding flowers, what is your reaction? Not only does the tense nervous system immediately relax, but a strong sense of pleasure also arises. Because the contrast is so great, the stimulus produces enormous surprise!
- **Stimulus 2:** If you slowly move toward the light switch, encounter familiar furniture such as sofas and tables along the way, then successfully turn on the light and find nothing unusual in the room, what is your reaction? Besides bodily relaxation, there should be no other reaction, because no negative or positive stimulus appeared during the process.

- **Stimulus 3:** If you suddenly hear a sinister laugh and feel a breeze brush past your ear, what is your reaction? Fear instantly intensifies, exceeding the fear caused by darkness alone and also exceeding the fear that the sinister laugh and breeze alone could produce.

In this scenario, the expectation mismatch that triggers the fear emotion is the sum of the absolute value of the negative expectation and the absolute value of the stimulus from the fear source.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

Psychology offers many art therapy methods, such as painting, music, knitting, calligraphy practice, sandplay, and dance movement therapy, all of which help patients alleviate negative emotions.

In the course of psychotherapy, changing unhealthy psychological patterns is very difficult, yet changing behavior is comparatively easy. Art therapy can leverage changes in the body to help patients establish new behavioral habits and create new connections between body and emotion, ultimately relieving inner negative emotions. For example, when treating anxiety disorders, patients often do not know how to express their inner feelings appropriately and instead exhibit tension, sweaty palms, and difficulty breathing. Art forms such as painting, calligraphy, and dance can bring out emotions and conflicts suppressed in the subconscious, thereby relieving stress.

Many psychiatric hospitals employ professional occupational and recreational therapists. They can provide systematic and reasonable treatment and adjust the plan according to the patient's condition. Some hospitals even offer more specialized sandplay, allowing patients to freely choose props such as figures, houses, trees, and animals and arrange various scenes in a sand tray. The therapist then asks questions based on the scenes created and assesses the participant's psychology and emotions according to the answers, finally offering guidance.

## Chapter 8 Offense and Defense—Fight Response

Once anger is aroused, the entire body coordinates and enters a clear fighting state. Therefore, the fight response is extremely difficult to fake and easy to recognize. Although the fight response has undergone several transformations under the constraints of civilized social rules, the inner state it reflects remains equally dangerous; once it appears, it must be treated with vigilance.

### **Interpretation of meaning:**

Seeing an offensive posture in the fight response indicates that the other person's mind is engaged in confrontation and possesses a strong desire to win—belonging to a dominant mindset. Conversely, seeing a defensive posture indicates that the other person's mind is enduring an attack and attempting self-protection—belonging to a subordinate mindset.

When animals compete for resources, the outcome is often severe: fight or die. Consequently, the survivors are the strong, and over generations this fighting consciousness has become deeply embedded in the blood and every nerve. Whenever danger appears, it may awaken the fighting consciousness hidden within the body.

Human social history is likewise filled with life-and-death struggles—from street brawls to gentlemen's duels, from gang fights to large-scale wars. Motives have grown more complex and tactics more advanced, yet the bodily reactions during combat remain unchanged: blood boiling, hair standing on end, breathing quickening, reason fading. Anger, as the neural mechanism and core driving force supporting these intense offensive behaviors, has remained in the human brain through evolution.

## 1. Envy, Jealousy, and Hatred

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-33]

1. Eyebrow shape is normal; slight frowning action visible through the glabellar lines, indicating attention and response;
2. Upper eyelid shape is normal, with no obvious raising or drooping; however, the lower eyelid is tense and slightly bulging, a morphological feature of anger;
3. Gaze directed toward the upper left, in this image fixating on the stimulus source to the left; the upward direction indicates a higher self-positioning (relative to the stimulus source);
4. Upper lip raised, nasolabial fold clear, yet showing signs of restraint, indicating a disgust-type emotion judged as mild contempt according to degree;
5. Mentalis muscle clearly contracted, producing uneven ridges that push the lower lip outward while the upper lip is pressed tight;
6. Depressor anguli oris and platysma show slight contraction; corners of the mouth pulled slightly sideways and downward in a micro-bend, forming a "bitter pout," indicating restraint and helplessness.

**Summary:** Contradictory attitude toward the object of gaze—on one hand, a negative emotion of disgust, possibly at the level of contempt; on the other hand, attention and response with slight anger, yet no means to change the situation, resulting only in self-restraint and acceptance of the status quo.

## The Explanation and Function of Emotion

Two points in the second definition are particularly well explained and merit special attention. First, emotion "is situational, temporary, and has clear external manifestations." Second, objects that satisfy needs elicit positive emotions, while the opposite elicits negative emotions. The typical characteristic of this definition of "emotion" is that it requires a specific situation to be triggered; different situations produce different emotions, and the elicited emotion lasts only a short time. This usage aligns with the English word *emotion*.

In the study of micro-reactions (微反应), the "emotion" we focus on and employ is limited to the second definition. This type of emotion more accurately reflects the true inner state of the person involved. The first type of emotion can serve as a reference for overall judgment but cannot be used to determine truth.

The emotions examined and discussed in this book generally last a very short time. The shortest does not exceed one second (surprise); other emotion types last only seconds and are extremely brief. One exception is sadness, which can last up to several days, but it is the only emotion with this peculiarity; the specific reason will be explained in Chapter 8. It is precisely because emotions are brief yet genuine that the expressions they trigger are authentic and reliable.

## 1. Choosing Music That Matches the Emotion

Most people believe that when feeling low, one should listen to upbeat music to improve one's mood. Research, however, shows this view is entirely mistaken; doing so only deepens depression. The proper approach is to choose music that matches one's current mood. For example, a depressed patient should listen to melancholic pieces, such as waltzes with a sense of sorrow. Once the patient's mind receives the baptism of these pieces, the inner melancholy disappears without notice.

To verify this, experts conducted an experiment with 14 young people who were feeling low after a recent breakup. They played several pieces of light, cheerful music; all participants sank into deeper distress. The

experts then changed strategy and played several desolate pieces; 12 of the 14 experienced a miraculous reduction in negative emotions, as if they had found kindred spirits. Finally, interviews revealed that most participants felt music matching their current mood was more effective at regulating mood and venting emotion, whereas listening to upbeat music when feeling low produced the opposite effect.

## Chapter 2 The Arousal of Emotion

- 2.1 The Concept of Emotion
- 2.2 The Function of Emotion
- 2.3 The Cause of Emotional Arousal—Expectation Mismatch
  - 2.3.1 What Is Subjective Expectation?
  - 2.3.2 What Constitutes Expectation Mismatch
  - 2.3.3 Variability of Expectation—Using Driving a Car as an Example
- 2.4 The Core Value Like a Treasure—Studying the Role of Expectation Mismatch

## 6. Stubborn Disagreement

- ① Eyebrows raised, more noticeably on the right, without accompanying upper-eyelid elevation, indicating higher self-positioning and an external expression of confidence;
- ② Upper eyelids lowered almost to contact with the lower eyelids, palpebral fissure very small, ruling out enjoyment and representing a reaction of not wanting to see the stimulus source, confirming that the stimulus source is evaluated as negative;
- ③ Not looking directly at the stimulus source; gaze directed lower right, indicating prior expectation of the stimulus source's appearance, enduring the negative stimulus without agreement and without attempting to change it;
- ④ Nasolabial fold confirms upper lip raised, a disgust-type expression feature indicating denial;
- ⑤ Depressor anguli oris contracted, corners of the mouth clearly pulled downward; mentalis contracted, forcefully pushing the lower lip upward; lower lip tensed and pressed against the upper lip; muscles on the chin raised with uneven surface—this is the typical “bitter pout” morphology, indicating helplessness and self-restraint.

### Summary:

Facing a negative stimulus source, the person maintains their own viewpoint, disagrees with the information from the stimulus source, yet shows no desire to act to change it, adopting an attitude of endurance and forbearance toward the negative stimulus.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

ACT therapy has demonstrated broad practicality in real-world applications. For example, it has helped people successfully quit drug addiction. ACT therapy encourages addicts to face and accept the fact that they need drugs and informs them of the major physical and mental effects that will follow once they quit, then guides them to realize that people should not seek comfort and satisfaction solely from drugs but should have other pursuits. Research found that after 12-step treatment, addicts' dependence on drugs decreased significantly.

In 2004, 27 epilepsy patients in South Africa received nine hours of ACT therapy; the frequency of their seizures was markedly lower than that of patients who received ordinary placebo treatment.

Because ACT therapy has achieved notable results in practical application, it has been hailed as “the third form of psychotherapy after behavioral therapy and cognitive therapy.” To date, more than 12,000 psychological professionals in the United States have received ACT therapy training, and Hayes’s theory now has followers in 18 countries.

## 5. Unconvinced

- ① Eyebrows raised, shape natural, yet eyelids relaxed with no trace of orbicularis oculi or levator palpebrae superioris action, indicating not surprise but confidence or higher inner self-positioning;
- ② Gaze shifted lower left; visual blocking indicates interruption of effective communication; downward direction indicates endurance;
- ③ Overall head posture shows chin raised (see “upward gaze response” in *Micro-reactions*); together with the eyebrows, this expresses higher self-positioning;
- ④ Mentalis slightly contracted, pushing the middle of the lower lip upward, causing the corners of the mouth to turn downward; lips pressed together; raised muscles on the chin form uneven bulges, indicating self-restraint.

### Summary:

Internally maintains a firm opinion (eyebrows and head), does not wish to accept the information from the stimulus source (for example, someone’s viewpoint), interrupts effective communication, yet is constrained by the situation from leaving or refuting, therefore expresses self-restraint (mouth shape) while merely continuing to listen (gaze lowered).

## 7. Intensified Unconvinced

- ① Eyebrows have returned to normal height, no longer raised, and show slight frowning traces (glabellar lines);
- ② Upper eyelids droop lower, the result of a deliberate action, indicating visual blocking of the negative stimulus source;
- ③ Gaze shifted lower left, interrupting effective communication, merely enduring;
- ④ Fully raised upper lip and deep nasolabial folds reveal strong inner disgust;
- ⑤ Under strong contraction of the mentalis, the lower lip is pushed upward and pressed against the upper lip, indicating denial yet self-restraint.

### Summary:

Also expressing unconvinced, yet far more intense. No higher inner self-positioning—only disgust. Mouth morphology collectively expresses inner disdain, while the self-restraint features and lowered gaze within visual blocking convey endurance of the negative stimulus information. In simple terms: “Say what you want; I’m listening, but I absolutely do not agree.”

## 3. Subjective Expectations During Tense Events

The boss walks into the open-plan office and announces loudly that the company is facing financial difficulties at year-end and must lay off two-fifths of its employees. A tense atmosphere instantly forms. Everyone



glances at one another, each fearing for their own position. At this moment, the vast majority of people's subjective expectation is that they themselves face the danger of dismissal. Even when rational analysis leads one to conclude that one does not belong to the group being cut, very few can fully trust that reasoning and feel no tension whatsoever.

Only when the final outcome is confirmed—once the names of those to be dismissed are known—can everyone truly breathe a sigh of relief. What follows varies: those retained feel fortunate; those dismissed may slump in dejection or argue their case. Yet the earlier worry has certainly vanished. The same holds after the college entrance examination: even a high estimated score brings full relaxation only after the admission results arrive. Until a confirmed result is received, the inner expectation remains that an unfavorable outcome might still occur.

#### 4. Oh No! How Tragic! (An Immersive Tragic Scene)

- ① Eyebrows are lowered and tightly furrowed, showing concern; the inner third twists upward (more noticeably on the left), indicating fear or sadness.
- ② The upper eyelids are raised forcefully, meeting the lowered brows to form skin folds; combined with the brow shape, this expresses fear.
- ③ The levator labii superioris contracts, lifting the upper lip and creating shallow nasolabial folds on either side of the nose, indicating disgust.
- ④ The platysma pulls the corners of the mouth sideways, the depressor anguli oris pulls the corners downward, the depressor labii inferioris pulls the lower lip down, and the mentalis contracts, pushing the middle of the lower lip upward and creating an uneven muscular bulge on the surface. This mouth shape is the typical feature of crying with an open mouth and conveys intense sadness.

##### **Summary:**

The brow and eye configuration expresses fear; the lower face expresses sadness and mild disgust. This indicates that the individual is extremely afraid of the negative stimulus, and the tragic scene has triggered empathetic pain that gives rise to sadness.

#### 2. Choosing Music According to Temperament

The style of music chosen must also match the individual's temperament, because only suitable music produces good therapeutic results, and different temperaments call for correspondingly different music. For example, an impatient person should listen to slow-tempo pieces that invite reflection, such as the adagio sections of certain classical symphonies; this can calm the mind and overcome irritability. A person who is self-critical, pessimistic, or passive should listen to bold, uplifting music, because such pieces are filled with resolve, can invigorate the spirit, and help restore self-confidence.

In short, music therapy is not the same as ordinary music appreciation. It requires selecting music that matches the emotion and also choosing different music according to different temperaments. In a specific atmosphere and with specific melodies, people can regulate themselves and thereby achieve therapeutic goals.

#### 2. Mismatched Expectations in a Bright Environment

Conversely, when one enters a brightly lit room where every corner is clearly visible, a person can walk and move about with relative ease. In such an environment everything is in plain sight, so the subjective expectation is that no negative stimulus will occur.

- **Stimulus one:** If nothing happens, how do you react? You show no reaction.
- **Stimulus two:** If friends are already standing in the brightly lit room holding flowers, how do you react? You feel surprised, yet the degree of surprise is certainly less intense than in the same situation in a dark environment.
- **Stimulus three:** You turn around and suddenly see someone pressing a sharp pair of scissors against your abdomen while covering your mouth. How do you react? You feel intense fear. The prior expectation of safety clashes sharply with the frightening reality; the effect is still the sum of the absolute values.

## 6. Psychodrama Therapy

Psychodrama has an eighty-year history of development and has become an important method of psychotherapy. Through a special dramatic form, it lets emotionally low individuals play certain roles, mainly performing themselves in situations of psychological conflict. The psychological conflicts and emotional problems are gradually brought onto the stage, thereby releasing emotions and relieving inner pressure.

All the above art forms can be used to purify one's emotions. Which form to use depends on one's actual circumstances. By channeling surplus energy into these art forms, one has no surplus time left to dwell on troubling matters. Once one's capacity for artistic appreciation improves and the spirit is elevated, one no longer frets over trivial matters and can control or channel one's own emotions.

### 2. Insufficient Pressure

Since excessive pressure easily leads to an "overload state," does that mean the less pressure the better? Certainly not. Today, many people have lost their passion because of a lack of pressure and challenge, gradually developing an attitude of "what's the use." If this continues, it will damage their enthusiasm for life and affect a positive, optimistic outlook.

This is how "rubber people" in the workplace are created. Without pressure or challenge they become lazy and unmotivated, living by the rule "do just enough to get by." Comfortable days easily breed inertia and make people complacent. Gradually they become unable to leave that comfortable life.

### 1. Excessive Pressure

Excessive pressure easily makes people depressed, anxious, distressed, pessimistic, or despondent, causing them to lose enthusiasm for life and self-control. They may suddenly become angry, burst into tears, or laugh uncontrollably. Originally quiet people become emotionally excitable; originally easygoing people become irritable; originally active people become sluggish. In addition, excessive pressure increases interpersonal friction and makes people cold.

Excessive pressure easily leads to fatigue and even an "overload state." It can be said that excessive pressure often acts as an "invisible killer" in life, delivering devastating blows to one's career, family, relationships, and emotions and greatly harming both physical and mental health.

## 5. Art Therapy Through Painting

Art therapy through painting refers to the method by which the painter presents suppressed emotions and conflicts through drawing and obtains release and satisfaction in the process. It belongs to the methods of psychotherapy and has good therapeutic effects.

When feeling low, one might try painting a picture—letting the mind wander freely and drawing whatever comes to mind, expressing emotion through this means. There is no need to worry about what the picture depicts or whether anyone can understand it; one can even discard or tear up the finished work. Even so, the negative emotion can still be relieved.

### 3. Moderate Pressure

Psychologist Yerkes holds that pressure and motivation generally follow an inverted-U relationship: only when pressure is adjusted to its optimal point does it produce positive effects. If the pressure applied is too small, a person cannot fully realize their potential; if the pressure applied is too great, it produces negative emotions such as fear, anger, and anxiety.

How, then, should the degree of pressure be gauged? It should be such that, once the pressure is placed upon us, we feel a certain degree of tension and urgency yet are not crushed by it.

#### 2.3.2 What Is Meant by a Mismatch with Expectations

Simply put, it means that the way events unfold next does not match one's subjective expectation. A mismatch can be qualitative or quantitative. Whenever a mismatch occurs, emotion arises spontaneously. When something exceeds (or is better than or more positive than) expectation, one experiences pleasant, positive feelings and thus positive emotion. When something falls short of expectation, one experiences dissatisfaction or negative feelings and thus negative emotion.

### Summary

If one must translate the "subjective expectation" described earlier into plain language, the closest rendering is "a vague sense that ... might happen," yet it differs from a "premonition," because a premonition is still something one thinks up, usually through conscious mental effort. With expectation, by contrast, a person is often unaware that such a judgment has already formed.

### 4. Creating Works of Art

Creating works of art takes many forms—for example, sculpting figures, modeling clay figures, or making pottery. When all one's energy is poured into artistic creation, one unconsciously forgets one's troubles. Moreover, once a piece is successfully completed, one can also experience the joy of creation; as a result, negative emotions dissipate.

### 2. Subjective Expectations in a Bright Environment

Conversely, if no other information has previously suggested otherwise, when one pushes open the door and enters a brightly lit room where every corner is clearly visible, one usually feels no vigilance and moves about with relative ease. In such an environment everything is in plain sight, so the subjective expectation is that no negative stimulus will appear.

### 3. Playing a Musical Instrument

Music is an indispensable part of life; a beautiful piece can drive away a person's negative emotions. Therefore one can release emotion by playing the piano, the guzheng, the flute, or the violin. When a graceful melody floats through the air, the negative emotion in one's heart is carried away with it.

## Chapter 8 Mining the "Treasure" of Positive Emotions

Whether life is happy depends on our emotional state, because only under the guidance of positive emotions can we increase our subjective sense of well-being. It can be said that positive emotions are our inner source. Therefore we must strive to mine our own positive emotions so that we may enjoy a happy life.

### 2.3 The Trigger of Emotion—Mismatches with Expectations

The root cause of emotion lies in the fact that the stimuli one encounters do not match one's "subjective expectation," abbreviated as "mismatch with expectation."

#### Seven Basic Emotions

##### **Abandoning Improper Ways of Expression**

Expressing emotions requires the right method. Appropriate methods yield good results, while improper ones have the opposite effect. Only by knowing which methods are improper can your emotions be truly released.

Some people mistakenly believe that expressing emotions means constantly blaming others, so they adopt a method of blaming others without reason, venting their emotions by attacking others like a porcupine. This instead triggers the other party's defense mechanisms, filling them with negative emotions.

Therefore, expressing emotions appropriately is an art. Only by knowing which ways are wrong and abandoning these improper ways of expressing emotions can one truly release their own emotions.

##### 1. Do not express emotions by throwing things

Many couples, when arguing intensely, like to express their dissatisfaction by throwing things, often grabbing plates, bowls, chopsticks, or phones and throwing them around. This way of expressing emotions has significant negative effects: it incurs economic losses and leaves psychological shadows on the other party. If valuable items are accidentally broken, it will definitely lead to greater conflicts afterward, even resulting in an unmanageable situation.

##### 2. Do not use verbal violence when expressing emotions

Some people, when anger rises, disregard whether their words will hurt others and habitually use verbal violence to express dissatisfaction, such as "It's not even difficult, yet you can't do it—you're such a good-for-nothing" or "You waste air while alive and waste land when dead; I really don't know the value of your existence." "Harsh words wound in June's chill." These remarks carry discrimination, trample on the other party's dignity, and pierce their heart like a knife, inevitably provoking even more vicious retaliation.

##### 3. Do not say one thing while meaning another when expressing emotions

Some people like to say one thing while meaning another when voicing complaints, for example: "Right, you're absolutely correct—it's all my fault. Who told me to worry for no reason? What business is it of mine what time you come home?" These individuals clearly feel miserable and need comfort, yet they pretend it does not matter and hide their true feelings. Their purpose is to avoid being hurt, but does this truly prevent

harm? Not necessarily, because not everyone possesses high emotional intelligence to recognize the discrepancy; some will interpret the words literally and fail to detect the underlying emotion.

#### 4. Do not use the silent treatment when expressing emotions

The silent treatment refers to expressing dissatisfaction through prolonged silence. Its hallmark is extended non-communication: neither arguing nor interacting, merely stewing internally. It seems to say, "You are unreasonable; I cannot be bothered with you. Do whatever you like—I simply will not speak another word to you."

Compared with verbal violence, the silent treatment can be even more damaging, because ignoring someone and refusing dialogue wounds more deeply than harsh words. Moreover, those who employ it do not feel good either, as they must bottle up negative emotions without release or transformation.

#### 5. Do not complain incessantly when expressing emotions

When emotions arise, one feels blocked and wants to pour everything out as quickly as possible. This often leads to nonstop complaining to express dissatisfaction and grievance, such as repeatedly saying "Today is driving me crazy," "Oh no, what will I do tomorrow?" or "Help me think of a solution—I really can't handle it anymore."

This approach brings only momentary relief to the speaker while completely disregarding the listener's feelings and denying any chance to respond, inevitably causing resentment. No one wants to become another's emotional outlet or trash bin, so allowing the other party an opportunity to speak is the minimum respect owed.

#### 6. Do not exaggerate when expressing emotions

Some people like to exaggerate when expressing emotions, often losing their temper over trivial matters and refusing to stop until the issue escalates. For instance, some women in relationships frequently blame their boyfriends without cause; even when the boyfriend tries to explain, they dismiss the explanation and accuse him: "You only know how to argue. I can see you don't care about me at all and have never considered my feelings—you have no place for me in your heart."

Exaggeration when expressing emotions leaves a poor impression on the other party. It not only fails to transform negative feelings but also damages the relationship.

### **Choosing the Right Moment So Emotions Can "See the Sun"**

Wrong timing wastes effort. The same holds for expressing emotions: only the right timing aids problem-solving and emotional release; otherwise all efforts are in vain.

You may have encountered this situation: you pour out your grievances, yet the other person waves you off impatiently, saying, "I'm busy right now and have no time for this. If you have something to say, wait until I'm free!" How did you feel? Did you want to retort, "Why are you so difficult? Can't you just listen to me finish?"

In reality, it is not that the other person has too many matters; it is that you chose the wrong moment. The proper timing for expressing emotions is crucial to resolving issues and transforming feelings. With poor timing, how can the other person calmly listen to complaints? Therefore, we must know when expressing emotions is appropriate. Specifically, emotions can be expressed at the following moments:

### 1. Wait until both parties have calmed down before expressing emotions

When conflict or friction occurs, both sides feel angry. Expressing emotions impulsively at such times will likely produce sharp, harsh words that easily hurt the other party. The other person's tolerance is also at its lowest and will not listen calmly but will counterattack angrily. This only escalates conflict, hindering both problem resolution and emotional relief. It is better to wait until both have calmed down, providing a buffer period that helps both parties handle the matter rationally.

### 2. Express emotions behind the other person's back

How many people can hear direct criticism without flying into a rage? In most cases, expressing emotions face-to-face signals an impending "storm" and easily triggers direct conflict, so we can express emotions behind the other person's back.

For example, a salesperson rushes into the office while the sales manager is absent, slaps the manager's desk, and says, "I have a complaint for you! You're great in every way except you treat us salespeople like children and scold us without regard for our dignity. You must stop doing that, understand?" A colleague asks in confusion, "The manager isn't here—what's the point of losing your temper like this?" The salesperson grins and replies, "Exactly—because the manager isn't here I'm venting this way. If he were here, would I dare?" By then, much of his anger has already dissipated.

Expressing emotions behind someone's back, as this salesperson did, may seem comical, yet it works well.

### 3. Wait until the other person is psychologically prepared before expressing emotions

One must wait until the other person is psychologically prepared, because expressing one's own negative emotions without considering the recipient's capacity to accept them is selfish. Imagine yourself in the other person's position—would you approve of such timing? For instance, your relationship with your spouse has deteriorated badly and you have repeatedly considered divorce. This has troubled you for a long time, so you want to raise the topic soon and end the relationship. At that point you must consider whether your spouse can accept a sudden divorce request and withstand the sudden blow.

In such cases, allow the other person a buffer period so they can gradually recognize that the marriage has reached an impasse and rationally accept the situation. In short, you cannot damage the other person's interests or disregard their feelings merely to express your own emotions.

### 4. Wait until the other person has ample time before expressing emotions

We all know that when someone is busy, they have no spare attention for another person's emotions. If you choose such a moment, you will surely be rejected. Therefore, why not wait for a time when the other person has ample time?

### 5. Express emotions in an appropriate setting

We often see scenes in films and television where someone has something urgent to say, begins to speak, notices a third party present, stops, and says, "May we speak privately?" Similar situations arise at work: after an unpleasant exchange with a colleague, you feel upset and want to talk with another colleague, only to find a third person present, making it difficult to speak. Hence, choosing an appropriate setting when expressing emotions is important.

## Following Several Principles When Expressing Emotions

If one does not follow certain principles when expressing emotions, the expressed feelings will provoke dislike and rejection. Conversely, following principles makes the expressed emotions more acceptable.

Bacon once said, "However angry you may be, do nothing that cannot be undone." This indicates that expressing emotions should have principles and boundaries. Expressing emotions without principles not only fails to gain acceptance but also stirs the other party's negative emotions, ultimately worsening the situation rather than transforming one's own feelings.

We express emotions to convey our feelings and obtain the other party's recognition and understanding, not merely to vent dissatisfaction. Therefore, no matter the method, certain principles must be followed so that we can express our emotions effectively.

What principles, then, should be followed?

### 1. Principle of receptivity

Because each person's personality differs, psychological resilience also varies widely. When expressing emotions we must therefore adapt to the individual, taking each person's psychological capacity into account rather than treating everyone uniformly. For example, after making the same mistake, an introverted person tends to be sensitive and fragile; a single glance or expression may suffice for correction. An extroverted person, however, may appear "thick-skinned"; unless the issue is stated explicitly, they may not realize it.

### 2. Principle of sticking to the matter at hand

When expressing negative emotions, one must not vent indiscriminately or say whatever comes to mind; the principle of sticking to the matter at hand must be observed. If the expressed emotion matches the event that occurred, it will be understood and accepted by most people; if it does not match, it will not.

To follow this principle, keep the expressed emotion consistent with the triggering event. For instance, if someone embarrasses you publicly and angers you, you may say seriously and earnestly, "What you did was disrespectful. I am angry and hope you will not do it again." Importantly, never "rake up the past" by dragging in unrelated previous incidents, which would only complicate the issue.

### 3. Non-harm principle

The non-harm principle means neither damaging others nor damaging oneself. Expressing emotions serves three main purposes: first, to move the other party emotionally so they understand our feelings; second, to prompt the other party to reflect on their behavior and prevent recurrence; third, never to attack the other party over the issue or create new problems.

### 4. Principle of matching intensity

The intensity of expressed emotion should correspond as closely as possible to the intensity of the stimulus that aroused it. One should not fly into a prolonged rage over trivial matters, as this escalates conflict and provokes resentment. Nor should one gloss over matters of principle, which may lead others to view one as easy to bully and therefore treat one with greater contempt.

### 5. Positive-direction principle

After expressing emotions, the situation should move in a positive direction. If expression only makes

matters worse, bringing trouble to oneself and angering others, it is better not to express the emotion at all.

## 6. Principle of tact

Language should be tactful and wording reasonable when expressing emotions. You may wonder whether this is possible, since no one can speak only pleasant words when emotional. Indeed, when agitated, people tend to use strong language and may even say hurtful things. Yet remember that the purpose of expressing emotions is not to hurt the other party or to vent, but to communicate sincerely and seek a solution. Therefore, follow the principle of tact and correct the habit of speaking sharply.

## 7. Principle of moderation

Moderation should be observed in everything. In fact, the so-called bottom line for expressing emotions is precisely the principle of moderation. If you want others to accept your emotions and understand your feelings, you must not over-express them, or you will inevitably anger the other party. Once angered, the other person cannot understand your feelings while in that state.

## Do Not Deliberately Suppress Your Emotions

Long-term deliberate suppression of emotions not only lowers quality of life but also causes loss of work enthusiasm and even affects interpersonal relationships. Therefore, provided emotions do not spiral out of control, do not deliberately suppress them.

Humans experience seven emotional changes—joy, anger, worry, thought, grief, fear, and fright—all normal. Although keeping joy and anger from showing on one's face offers benefits to both self and others, reasonable expression of emotions is also necessary. Failing to express when one should, or to release when one should, only harms physical and mental health. For example, excessive grief that is not vented, or burying great grievances deep inside while closing the door on emotions and pretending nothing is wrong on the surface while weeping internally, will damage health and intensify psychological and physiological imbalance. Surveys show that many cancer patients endured long-term suppression of emotions before onset. More than 70 percent of breast-cancer patients exhibited symptoms of liver qi stagnation.

One important reason women generally live longer than men, besides physiological and psychological advantages, is that women are more inclined to cry. Tears shed in sorrow contain very high levels of protein—harmful substances produced by mental stress that accumulate in the body and harm health. Tears also contain two important chemicals, endorphin complexes and prolactin, which clear out depression-causing substances accumulated in the body and thereby reduce psychological pressure. Research indicates that after crying, emotional intensity decreases by 40 percent.

Many methods exist for relieving emotions: some people cry heartily, some confide in a few close friends, some go shopping with friends, some listen to music or engage in other activities.

What other ways can channel emotions?

### 1. Exercise

When angry, exercise can be an excellent outlet. Physical activity helps calm the mind, releases endorphins, and prompts the body to produce chemicals that stimulate feelings of pleasure and happiness. Therefore, when feeling suppressed, try running, walking, swimming, push-ups, or yoga; these will help reduce pressure and release anger.



## 2. Take a short nap

If you feel overwhelmed and can no longer control pent-up emotions, calm yourself and take a short nap. Sometimes relaxing the body and mind is necessary. A nap of only 15–20 minutes can occasionally produce a clear head and calm state, enabling a more rational approach to problems.

## 3. Deep breathing

Anger is a highly harmful negative emotion that affects both mental and physical health. Deep breathing helps calm the nerves, ease anxiety, and clear the mind. Therefore, whenever difficulties arise, practice several deep breaths. Never bottle anger inside or allow it to control your life.

## 4. Write down the problems you encounter

Writing down problems is a healthy way to vent. This method helps categorize troubles and identify appropriate solutions. For example, if you dislike your boss yet cannot resign for various reasons and cannot voice your thoughts, write the issues down to release inner dissatisfaction.

## 5. Spend time with pets

An article in the *British Medical Journal* notes that closeness to animals can help people overcome depression. Experiments have shown that a person with depression who regularly plays with dolphins experiences significant relief. Therefore, frequent contact with animals helps people relax and ease their emotions.

Whether you believe it or not, spending time with pets will calm you immediately. When angry and unwilling to see anyone, play with a pet. No matter how sad you are, these small animals can bring you joy. Especially when you gently stroke them, you will feel completely relaxed.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

Emotional people are hard to read, making it difficult for others to find ways to interact with them, so people around them gradually drift away. Because of this emotional volatility, their lives are unhappy and they also trouble others. Therefore, when expressing emotions, one must choose a rational approach rather than an emotional one.

Observe emotional people: when they vent, they often direct their anger at their closest loved ones but rarely at their bosses or colleagues. This shows that even losing one's temper involves rationality. Emotional people are not unable to control themselves; they simply do not want to.

So, once an emotion arises, what exactly should one do?

### 1. Rationally analyze the cause of the emotion

After an emotion appears, do not get angry immediately or lash out at others. First calm down and think carefully: Why am I angry? Does this matter really affect me so much? Why am I suddenly so worked up? What good does it do? Run these questions through your mind. Once answered, your emotion will likely subside considerably.

### 2. Shift your attention

Shifting attention can undoubtedly change your mood quickly and prevent you from sinking deeper into emotional reactivity. Choose activities that calm the mind according to your interests, such as listening to music, painting, practicing calligraphy, or watering plants. Once your attention moves to these tasks, you will stop dwelling on what upsets you, and negative feelings will disappear.

### 3. Hold your own opinions

People prone to emotional reactions should develop independent judgment. Once they decide something, they should not change their minds easily. With independent views, emotions are less easily swayed by external factors and emotional volatility decreases.

### 4. Strengthen psychological resilience

Avoiding emotional reactivity requires stronger psychological resilience. Resilient people do not conclude they are full of flaws just because someone points out shortcomings, nor do they become inferior or sad as a result. When facing setbacks, resilient people recover quickly and avoid feelings of defeat or loss.

### 5. Use self-suggestion

Self-suggestion relies on language and thought to stimulate oneself and thereby influence mood and will. Building confidence requires self-suggestion and self-encouragement.

For example, when facing something frightening, one can suggest: "There is nothing to fear; this is not a big deal." When encountering setbacks, one can suggest: "All setbacks pass; if I persist, I can overcome them and defeat myself." Frequent positive self-suggestion will make negative emotions fade.

## Choose the Right Listener When Venting

Venting can help eliminate negative emotions, but not everyone is a suitable listener. If the listener leaks information and creates more trouble, the effort backfires.

Venting means telling another person one's joys and sorrows without reservation. It is both an emotional release and a psychological regulation technique. Life inevitably brings frustrations and the resulting distress. Psychologists have found that appropriate venting benefits physical and mental health. However, one must choose the listener carefully; only then can one speak freely. An unsuitable listener may leak the information and cause additional problems.

Some people enjoy prying into others' private matters, then exaggerate or minimize what they hear and use others' secrets as conversation topics. If you misjudge such people and confide in them, you may face situations in which they stir up trouble or sow discord.

Choose a listener according to your own circumstances; otherwise venting may have little effect. How should one choose?

#### 1. Vent to objects

Films often show characters speaking their troubles into a hole in the wall and then sealing it, or speaking into a bottle of water and then pouring the water away. People like using objects because venting to them is completely safe; no leaks occur. If the sole goal is to vent, objects can be an effective strategy.

#### 2. Vent to familiar friends

When emotions arise, the first impulse is often to confide in familiar friends, who know one's life best and may offer concrete, useful advice. Because they are trusted, they generally will not disclose secrets.

Familiar friends may include colleagues, family members, classmates, or childhood friends. The choice depends on the issue. For life dilemmas, turn to experienced parents; for work frustrations, turn to

colleagues; for youthful confusion, turn to childhood friends.

## Neutral Expressions with Movement

Neutral expressions that involve movement require attention to the face. Facial movements and wrinkles are affected by the amount of facial fat or by botulinum toxin injections; either can erase the characteristic wrinkles that normally appear with expressions.

Round faces are generally associated with infants or young children, but the focus here is on adults—specifically, expressions of people who are overweight. Infants and young children display emotions directly on their faces; even when they try to suppress feelings, they usually cannot control their expressions, so emotions are clearly visible. Reading an infant's or child's face does not require close attention to subtle lines. Adults are better at controlling expressions and hiding true feelings; therefore, the subtle wrinkles that appear become important indicators for identifying micro-expressions (微表情).

Excess facial fat can hide wrinkles, and certain expressions may eliminate characteristic lines, making it harder to judge expressions from wrinkles alone. In such cases, observing the movement of facial muscles is more effective than watching for wrinkles. Botulinum toxin injections, a cosmetic procedure that reduces the appearance of aging, use botulinum toxin type A to eliminate wrinkles. Depending on dosage and individual variation, the face may show no wrinkles after injection, complicating expression interpretation.

Personal habits also affect micro-expression recognition—for example, the way someone smiles or blows their nose. Some people produce “wrinkles around the nose” when smiling, creating features associated with “disgust,” or raise one corner of the mouth asymmetrically, signaling “contempt.” Blowing the nose similarly creates “wrinkles around the nose.”

When observing a person's neutral expression, establishing a baseline is essential. Confirm the neutral expression first, then identify the movements that distinguish other expressions and correctly interpret what the face actually shows.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

Emotions can generally be expressed at four levels:

### 1. Expression to oneself

Expression to oneself means communicating with one's own consciousness so that it clearly recognizes the state and source of the emotion. This step sounds simple and is often overlooked, yet it is vital to health. Once one fully understands one's emotional state and its origin, the emotion is already half released.

### 2. Expression to others

Expression to others means finding someone to talk to when negative emotions appear—sharing feelings with family or friends, or consulting a therapist for a more professional outlet.

### 3. Expression to the environment

Expression to the environment means going out into nature when feeling low. One might stand atop a mountain to sense its vastness and beauty or stand by the sea and shout one's troubles to the waves. The problems then seem far less significant.

#### 4. Sublimated expression

Sublimated expression means transforming negative emotions into productive energy rather than lamenting fate. Beethoven's symphonies are one example. Many works of art contain the creator's emotional shifts; resonance arises because the audience senses those emotions.

## 2. The Sequence of Emotions

Research on basic human emotions has produced various classifications. The six categories that have gained the widest acceptance are those used in this book: surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and enjoyment.

Paul Ekman is the most frequently cited scholar in the field and a foundational figure. Through empirical work he confirmed Darwin's long-standing hypothesis that human emotions have universal expressions. Ekman's original framework included a seventh basic emotion, contempt, but he later revised the list to six. This aligns with the view here that contempt is an extreme form of disgust and shares the same essence.

The six emotions follow an internal sequence based on the cognitive appraisal a person makes after a stimulus—comparing the stimulus with one's own "strength."

Surprise is neutral because the person has not yet understood what happened. Once the stimulus is judged negative, disgust arises if it is weaker than oneself, anger if roughly equal, fear if stronger, and sadness if irreversible loss has occurred. Once judged positive, the stimulus produces satisfaction if it meets expectations, pride if it exceeds them, and joy if it greatly exceeds them.

Understanding emotions and stimuli through this sequence allows precise insight into another person's psychological state.

### Expressing Emotion ≠ Being Emotional

Emotions should not be deliberately suppressed; they need appropriate expression. Yet expressing emotion is not the same as being emotional. Being emotional vents feelings in a destructive way; expressing emotion communicates them constructively.

Emotional people experience noticeable mood swings over trivial matters and act under the sway of irrational feelings. Their behavior follows feelings rather than reason. They are easily controlled by their emotions, becoming elated when needs are met and deeply disappointed when they are not. They also tend to lack independent thinking and psychological resilience, so external events readily affect them. Even minor incidents can trigger strong reactions.

Many people, once emotions surge, vent without restraint and later regret the outburst. Although they know the behavior is harmful, they feel unable to stop it. Emotions cannot be forcibly contained, or they will eventually find an outlet. The outlet, however, can be chosen to avoid destruction, because emotion is not the same as emotional reactivity.

Emotional states fall into three categories: mood, passion, and stress.

### Psychology Mini-Classroom

Maslow's hierarchy of needs shows that once lower-level needs are satisfied, higher-level needs naturally emerge. When desires remain unfulfilled during this pursuit, dissatisfaction ferments into complaints. Everyone

complains at times. Imbalance between effort and reward, blocked self-actualization, or damaged relationships can all produce chronic grumbling.

How can one choose the right moment to complain? Several guidelines help:

1. Do not complain when agitated

When dissatisfied, never let complaints escape in the heat of the moment. Words spoken under agitation usually carry strong personal emotion and are hard for others to accept.

2. Do not complain in the office

The office is a daily workspace and a sensitive environment; it is not an appropriate place to vent dissatisfaction. Subjective complaints may be misunderstood by colleagues. Frequent complaining also creates the impression that one cannot handle the job, raising doubts about competence.

3. Complain when others are in a good mood

Choose a moment when the listener is cheerful, because a good mood increases tolerance. When someone is already unhappy, tolerance drops; the complaint may be rejected or even provoke embarrassment.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

Appropriate emotional expression includes several elements:

1. Use precise adjectives

Choose exact adjectives. Instead of "I feel terrible," which is vague, say "I am angry" or "I am somewhat disappointed."

2. State the reason for the emotion

Clearly explain why the emotion arose so the other person understands its source. For example: "I heard you told others things about me that are rumors, so I am angry." Subsequent conversation then becomes easier.

3. Do not hold the other person responsible for your emotion

Avoid phrases such as "You made me angry," which place the problem on the other person and can provoke defensiveness or conflict.

4. Avoid personal attacks phrased as judgments

Do not say "You maliciously slandered me" or "You are targeting me." Use neutral statements such as "It is not good for you to say that about me." This conveys the emotion without inflaming the other person.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

An education service center released the report "Listening to Children's Voices," based on 20,870 student cases across more than ten provinces and municipalities including Beijing and Shanghai. The survey found

that 70 percent of primary and secondary students wanted to confide in someone yet did not choose parents as their first choice, and more than 30 percent could not find a suitable listener. Only 26.73 percent said they most wanted to tell their parents their private thoughts; 49.56 percent preferred close classmates or friends; 5.61 percent preferred strangers online; and 13.84 percent chose to keep their thoughts to themselves forever.

Another survey on willingness to confide showed that 90 percent were willing to share their thoughts, but only 58.47 percent could find a listener. Another 31.75 percent wanted to confide yet had no one available, so many resorted to writing diaries or talking to themselves.

Students identified the most important qualities of a good listener: "understands all my feelings" (46.96 percent), "can offer some help" (20.05 percent), and "makes me feel safe to speak" (17.79 percent).

### **Thin Lips and Slanted Eyebrows Are Both Emotional Language**

Every face, everywhere, displays seven universal expressions: happiness, contempt, disgust, anger, sadness, fear, and surprise. The muscle characteristics and functions of each expression are described below.

Before detecting and interpreting micro-expressions, first recognize the baseline: the neutral expression. A neutral expression shows no emotion and takes two forms.

- The first occurs when a person has no opinion, feels indifferent, or pays little attention while someone else speaks, or when the person has not listened closely; it can also be called a "blank expression."
- The second appears during conversation when the speaker's facial muscles move around the mouth solely for articulation, without emotional involvement.

The former may be termed a neutral expression without movement; the latter, a neutral expression with movement.

Before interpreting others' emotional expressions, it is necessary to understand each person's neutral expression, because it serves as the baseline for all expressions. The differences between the two neutral forms are explained next.

### **The "Neutral" Expression Without Movement**

For example, a person may have facial features such as "inverted eyebrows" and "thin lips." (Later in this book it will be explained that "inverted eyebrows" are one of the expression characteristics of "sadness," while "thin lips" are one of the expression characteristics of "anger.") If one knows the person's original facial features, one will not misjudge the person as displaying "sadness" or "anger" when the person is in a "neutral" expression.

For someone with the "inverted eyebrows" feature, the eyebrows become even more slanted when "sad"; for someone with the "thin lips" feature, the lips become even thinner when "angry." In addition, as people age, wrinkles alter the way expressions are recognized. Unless one is of the same generation or is close to an older person, interpreting the expressions of older adults is relatively difficult, mainly because of the wrinkles on the face.

Special attention should be paid to "crow's feet at the outer corners of the eyes" and "wrinkles between the eyebrows." People with "crow's feet at the outer corners of the eyes" appear to be smiling; people with "wrinkles between the eyebrows" appear to be angry. When people with "crow's feet at the outer corners of

the eyes" smile, the wrinkles at the outer corners become deeper; when people with "wrinkles between the eyebrows" become angry, the wrinkles between the eyebrows also become more pronounced.

### **Section 3 The Most Primitive Human Expressions: Surprise, Disgust, Anger, Fear, Sadness, Pleasure**

In daily life, you may notice that a child's face is like the sky in June—changeable in an instant. The expressions on their faces are the most direct and authentic reactions to their inner emotions. People experience the seven emotions and six desires; when encountering all kinds of events, they produce different expressions due to changes in inner mood. The most primitive human expressions include six kinds: surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and pleasure.

In the animal kingdom, animals receive information through their own five senses. When there is any slight movement around them, they immediately take corresponding actions to avoid an unfavorable environment. When startled by something sudden, they retreat or display a surprised expression. When humans encounter unknown or sudden events, they also display surprised expressions. Upon receiving new external stimuli, they subconsciously stop what they are doing, raise their heads, and widen their eyes and mouths. These actions that express surprise are completed in an instant.

#### **Psychology Mini-Classroom**

In nature, when a reservoir's water level exceeds the warning line, the reservoir must perform regulated discharge; otherwise, the reservoir's safety will be threatened. If, at that moment, discharge does not occur and water continues to be poured into the reservoir, the reservoir will collapse.

Psychoanalytic master Freud once used reservoir theory to describe the process of handling human emotions. He believed that every person's body contains an emotional reservoir in which all negative emotions are stored. If the emotional water level reaches the so-called warning line, the individual's temper becomes irritable and emotions cannot be well controlled. If left unaddressed and allowed to worsen continuously, the emotional reservoir will collapse and produce psychological problems. Therefore, to maintain mental health, one must not allow too much water to accumulate in one's emotional reservoir; instead, one must find ways to channel the emotions in the reservoir.

#### **Disgust**

- Wrinkles present
- Lower eyelids raised, wrinkles appear below
- Upper lip raised and slightly pursed
- Upper lip pulled upward while lower lip pulled downward

We are accustomed to inferring a person's character traits and inner activities from facial expressions, but often facial expressions can be deceptive.

Some people who are clearly emotionally agitated pretend to have a blank expression; some who are clearly very sad appear very carefree; some smilingly tell you "the proposal is really good," yet the final collaboration ends in failure. Thus the face is a dual system that can both deliberately display expressions and spontaneously produce certain expressions independent of the owner's will. We must learn to discard the false and retain the true, capturing authentic facial expressions.

#### **Confiding in Strangers**

Some matters are inconvenient to let familiar people know about, for fear that they will mock us once they know. At such times, confiding in a stranger is also a good method. In front of strangers we can open our hearts and speak out all our troubles without too many concerns or pressures, saying whatever we want. Even if the stranger does not know us well enough to offer constructive advice, we will feel relieved after voicing our troubles.

The strangers mentioned here can be netizens we have never met, radio program hosts, passersby we encounter by chance, or friends we have just met.

## **Mood**

Mood can be described as a background-like subjective experience that reflects a person's calm and enduring emotional tendency. Mood has a diffuse quality, treating all matters with the same attitude rather than being an experience tied to a specific relationship. A person's worldview, ideals, and beliefs determine the basic tendency of mood, and mood plays an important regulatory role among these three. However, mood also possesses relative variability; after experiencing a major event, the experiencer may retain the emotion toward that event for a long time. For example, when a person loses a loved one, even if usually optimistic, the person may remain depressed for a long period.

## **Confiding in a Psychologist**

Some people have very serious negative emotions. Confiding only in objects, friends, or strangers will not produce good results, because their problems are severe and must be resolved by seeking professional help. At such times, one should confide in a psychologist.

In recent years, psychologists have become increasingly numerous, and choosing to confide in a psychologist and ask for a specific treatment plan is no longer something unacceptable. From a psychologist one can obtain more professional guidance, thereby untangling inner knots and gradually improving one's mood.

## **Passion**

Passion is a relatively brief emotional state characterized by intensity and explosiveness, often triggered by events of great personal significance, such as becoming ecstatic after achieving success or becoming extremely fearful when in danger. The emotional experience at such times is often intense, and a person's reason may be inhibited, resulting in "narrowed consciousness." If one's mood is in a negative state at that moment, emotionally driven behavior is very likely to be triggered, leading to reckless or agitated actions.

## **Chapter 6 Matters to Note When "Sharing Emotions"**

Everyone has emotions; this is not a big deal. However, we must keep emotions within a reasonable range. In other words, we must learn to express our emotions in appropriate ways, neither deliberately suppressing them nor allowing them to run rampant. Only then can our emotions be relieved and maintained in a reasonable state.

## **Stress**

Stress refers to the adaptive response a person makes to a certain unexpected environmental stimulus. It is often accompanied by a series of physiological reactions, such as elevated blood pressure, muscle tension,



and accelerated heartbeat. Behavioral responses under stress require that the individual's abilities match the situation; otherwise, serious physiological reactions may lead to adaptive disorders.

## Anger

- Wrinkles present
- Eyebrows lowered and drawn together, brows furrowed, vertical wrinkles between the eyebrows; distance between the eyes narrowed
- Muscles tense or bulging
- Lips may be pressed tightly into a line with corners turned down; or the mouth may be open with lips remaining tense

## Fear

- Wavy wrinkles present
- Eyebrows raised and drawn together; upper eyelids lifted, lower eyelids tensed; vertical wrinkles between the eyebrows
- Muscles tense
- Mouth slightly open, lips pulled back

## Surprise

- Wavy wrinkles present
- Eyebrows raised; eyes widened, more sclera visible
- Muscles relatively tense
- Jaw dropped, mouth slightly open

## Sadness

- Corners of the mouth turned down; if sadness is extreme, the lips may tremble

## Anger

### Lingering Anger

When people vent their anger, their body and mind achieve a certain degree of balance, but this does not mean the anger has completely disappeared. More often than not, after venting, the underlying problem still exists, so the intensity of the anger remains high. At this point, however, the facial expression of anger has changed completely: there are no longer movements in the lower half of the face, only changes around the eyes and brows—eyebrows lowered and furrowed, upper eyelids raised, lower eyelids tensed. If the eyes are covered, nothing can be discerned from the mouth alone.

From these analyses of anger types, it is clear that the most typical micro-expressions of anger are: eyebrows lowered and furrowed; upper eyelids raised, exposing part of the iris, with skin folds appearing on the upper eyelids due to the pressure from the brows; lower eyelids tensed. To determine whether someone is angry, one need only look at the eyes and eyebrows. The closer the distance between the upper eyelids and the eyebrows, the deeper the anger.

One case illustrates well how anger micro-expressions and triggers form.

A young man passionate about novel writing had been writing since graduating from university without taking any other job. Over five years he produced hundreds of thousands of words, yet no publisher accepted his work. He remained confident, believing his novels were unparalleled. His family urged him to find a job to support himself and write in his spare time, but he refused, insisting that publication had simply not yet come at the right time. His situation later became the subject of a reality television program.

On the show, a publishing expert bluntly told him that his novels had no publication value whatsoever and that he should seek other work. For the first ten minutes or so, he maintained a confident and composed demeanor, but at that moment he erupted, becoming highly aggressive. He began defending himself, accusing the expert of failing to recognize quality, and claiming that one person's opinion did not represent all publishers. During his defense, his face displayed classic anger expressions while his mouth took on an expression of disgust.

Those five years had placed enormous pressure on him, yet he had continued to evade society and persist with writing. He was unwilling to admit this and did not want others to see through him. When someone opposed him, he inwardly rejected that person and felt disgust. The expert's frank statement struck at his vulnerability, threatening what he saw as his survival interest (his belief that he could earn a living through novels) and thereby triggering anger. Disgust prompts a desire to escape, while anger prompts a desire to attack.

Sometimes anger mixes with disgust or fear, making it difficult to tell which dominates. Beyond micro-expressions, the presence or absence of an aggressive tendency reveals which emotion prevails. Another case: a mother witnessed her daughter being raped by a criminal. In desperation she attacked the criminal with a sharp object and killed him. Fear was present in her heart, yet the threat to her daughter ignited intense anger, producing an impulse to attack. Such anger micro-expressions prove useful in FBI investigations. After her arrest the mother initially denied the killing, claiming she had been panicked and helpless and that her daughter's account matched. Yet when an investigator asked her to describe the scene, an angry expression appeared on her face. Although a single micro-expression cannot serve as courtroom evidence, it can assist investigators. Fear does not produce aggression; only anger drives a person to attack regardless of consequences.

### **"He's No Good!"**

This phrase denies another person's ability in front of others. For the person being denied, it constitutes reputational damage and readily provokes anger. Reputation functions as a calling card in human society, recording much important information about an individual. People hope to use this card to build beneficial social networks that help them achieve various goals. Once erroneous information appears on the card, it directly threatens the person's survival environment. A quick online search reveals many celebrities waging courtroom battles over reputation. Reputation is, to some extent, a bargaining chip for a better life; damage to it inevitably lowers future quality of life and triggers anger.

These are common triggers of anger. In various forms they threaten people's survival and reproduction and therefore elicit anger.

It is now time to discuss the facial expressions of anger.

Every expression made after anger arises serves to attack or drive the other person away. Once the stimulus exceeds a threshold, it escalates into physical action and combat. Because the body rapidly mobilizes all available strength for attack, the force released in anger is astonishing and relatively brief.

The face likewise recruits every available muscle to produce a full anger expression. Consequently, a complete anger expression shows changes from the eyebrows down to the chin.

Let us begin with the eyebrows.

Lowered and furrowed brows constitute the typical expressive feature of anger. As noted in earlier chapters, brow lowering reduces intense light stimulation to the eyes. When people encounter difficulties or troubles, this brow shape appears in order to reduce glare and focus thought. Through evolution the action became habitual in times of trouble. When we fail to understand lecture content, our brows lower; when pondering solutions, our brows lower; when angry, our brows also lower. Regardless of the stimulus, lowered brows convey only one message: intense focus on the matter at hand.

Lowered brows alone cannot conclusively indicate anger, but when combined with raised upper eyelids and tensed lower eyelids, the expression is unmistakably one of anger. In anger the eyes widen while the brows press downward, creating a downward-closing tendency in the upper eyelids; the resulting compression produces a fold in the upper eyelid skin. What is commonly called “eyes wide with rage” describes this configuration.

In short, lowered brows combined with raised upper eyelids and tensed lower eyelids form the standard expressive signature of anger.

Next, the nose and cheeks.

Under the combined action of the levator labii superioris and the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, the upper lip rises, the nostrils flare, the nasal wings lift, the nasolabial folds deepen, and the cheek muscles bunch.

FBI investigators encounter anger expressions routinely. When suspects realize the truth has been uncovered, a fleeting anger expression often appears, indicating they feel threatened.

Finally, the mouth. In full-blown anger the mouth is generally not closed; it opens to varying degrees. When the stimulus exceeds the threshold and control is lost, the mouth opens maximally to permit roaring. This requires the joint action of the depressor labii inferioris, the platysma, and the mandible. The depressor labii inferioris pulls the lower lip downward, exposing the lower teeth; the platysma draws the corners of the mouth outward; the mandible opens the oral cavity.

### **“You’re No Good”**

This is a negative attitude that intensifies with tone. Sometimes a single contemptuous glance suffices to provoke anger. Most people become angry, even furious, when faced with negation. This reaction occurs in all animals.

An animal psychologist once handled a case involving a two-year-old dog whose owner reported that after a trip the dog had become irritable and would bare its teeth at the owner. The psychologist asked for details of the trip. It sounded ordinary: the owner had taken the dog to stay at a friend’s estate for a while. The friend also kept several dogs, and the owner had expected his dog to enjoy the company. Instead, on the second day the dog became listless, avoided the other dogs, and hid in corners. After returning home it grew quick to anger.

The psychologist examined the dog and found nothing unusual except the colorful clothing it wore. He asked whether the owner had dressed the dog the same way during the estate visit. The owner confirmed that he had; at home the dog never wore clothes, but for the visit he felt the outfit would display his distinctive taste and prevent loss of face before his friend. The psychologist then asked whether the estate dogs were allowed to grow naturally without restraint or clothing. The owner said yes; those dogs were fierce, retained their natural instincts, and possessed beautiful coats.

After this exchange the psychologist identified the problem. He explained that the dog had been slighted by the estate dogs because of its clothing. To humans an animal's coat is merely aesthetic, yet in the animal world a coat signals bloodline purity, breed quality, and social rank. Animals value natural form and freedom to run. Scent is also crucial for establishing friendly relations. A clothed dog resembles a stripped human—pitiful and alien among its kind. Deprived of the coat that symbolizes race, lineage, and status, and lacking the familiar scent of its peers, it naturally encounters contempt and exclusion.

Once slighted, an animal faces loss of authority and territory—matters that threaten its survival environment. The dog therefore became hostile, especially toward the human who had dressed it. Had the dog worn clothes from birth and lived among similarly attired peers, the outcome might have been different.

Even in developed civilization, being slighted or negated can threaten a human's survival environment. Denied ability, one may be passed over for important roles or even fail to secure decent employment. This directly creates economic pressure and the pressure to form a family. Faced with such a threat, anger naturally erupts.

## 1. Road Rage

Driving on the road readily generates anger, especially in heavy traffic. Anyone with driving experience can immediately recall situations that provoke anger. Minor cases include the car ahead failing to accelerate when it should, cutting in without queuing, refusing to yield when required, or changing lanes without signaling. More serious cases involve accidents such as being rear-ended or sideswiped without cause. In all these situations, violated expectations are obvious factors, and the indignant thought "Can't you drive?" arises both mentally and verbally.

Some conclude from this that **unreasonableness** is the trigger for anger. They argue that if everyone drove reasonably, traffic would flow smoothly and such anger would not occur. Others maintain that unreasonable driving is something anyone might do and is not the key trigger; suffering a loss (harm to one's interests) is the actual trigger.

When unreasonable driving amounts to arrogant self-importance or even malicious provocation, it does provoke anger—a natural response to a challenge to dignity, comparable to a stranger shoving you on the street. The connection to driving is incidental; the provocation simply occurs through driving. This negative stimulus to ability and dignity resembles an invasion of an animal's territory and instinctively elicits anger.

When the behavior is not malicious provocation but merely a question of whether one suffers a loss, further analysis is warranted: what advantage does cutting in or overtaking actually confer?

The psychological process that truly triggers anger is not necessarily the direct obstruction, delay, or offense; it may lie deeper than the immediately apparent cause. Whether anger arises depends directly on the purpose of the trip.

Under normal circumstances, drivers care primarily about what they must do upon reaching their destination; the journey itself is merely a necessary process. If one is simply cruising aimlessly, ordinary unreasonable driving (non-malicious) and traffic jams rarely provoke anger. Being hit might still trigger anger, yet deeper reflection reveals that the anger stems from the ensuing complications—damage assessment, insurance claims, repairs, and wasted time—that disrupt subsequent plans. The car's physical damage matters little provided no one is injured. Imagine driving an already damaged car for leisure; one more dent would hardly matter.

### 6.1 The Roots of Anger

In the animal world, simple predator-prey dynamics produce hunger in the predator (its primary motive) and fear in the prey. Because the power imbalance is stark, the weaker party cannot eliminate the threat and can only flee (fear). If fortunate enough to run fast, it survives. The weaker party therefore does not feel anger. The stronger party, if it fails to catch the prey, likewise feels no anger; it merely conserves energy for the next attempt.

When the two sides are evenly matched, anger appears more readily. Territory represents a mutually recognized rule of interaction among animals that possess ruling power. Whether the challenge originates inside the territory or from an outside stranger, the territory holder feels anger, because the challenge implies two things:

- First, the challenger knows this is my domain yet dares to trespass—an enormous violation of expectations. How dare you show such disrespect!
- Second, if the challenger wins, the original holder loses everything—mate, offspring, quality of life, even life itself. This constitutes a massive threat encompassing both survival and reproduction. Such a threat must be eliminated! Anger arises, followed by physical combat.

In the human world, the stimuli that elicit anger are likewise **threats to interests**—threats that may harm survival and reproduction. This mechanism is essentially identical to that in animals.

Human anger, however, exhibits broader and more complex derivative forms. Civilization, education, and the fine-grained division of daily life cause anger to arise more often from various derived threats.

The threatening stimuli discussed here do not refer merely to overt threats such as verbal warnings or brandished weapons; they encompass a more abstract notion—the situations a person subjectively perceives as potentially harmful.

A person evaluates whether a stimulus constitutes a threat to interests. If the threat can be eliminated through personal effort, anger may arise; if no such confidence or intention exists, fear results; if the matter is dismissed entirely, disgust (commonly contempt) appears. Thus, whether an interest threat exists resides entirely in the mind of the individual and is strongly linked to self-perception.

### Anger

Anger is a formidable negative emotion because of its destructive power. With disgust or fear one can simply walk away and ignore the source. Once anger arises, however, the person finds it difficult to discharge the emotion by leaving; instead, they tend to approach the other party, creating a sense of intimidation.

Countless events can provoke anger: failing to secure a seat, having a design stolen, a child's disobedience, theft, a taxi driver ignoring a hail in cold wind, a computer freezing at a critical moment, unfair distribution of benefits, differing opinions...

Regardless of the variety, all such events share a single root: developments fall short of subjective expectations, generating a powerful sense of threat. A sense of threat can also produce fear or disgust. When one's strength is far inferior to the opponent's, fear arises; when one deems the opponent unworthy of engagement, disgust arises; when strength is comparable and a little effort could prevail, anger arises.

This anger response evolved from primitive society and has never been eliminated. In early human times, people shared land with wild beasts. Meat was the primary food source, so hunting was the original means of survival. When traps were set or beasts pursued and the prey escaped, anger arose. Without quarry, the group faced hunger. With the emergence and evolution of civilization, failure to secure prey came to signify incompetence and the threat of ridicule.

Beyond food, the most primitive anger also arose from territorial violation. Both animals and humans maintain defended territories that symbolize identity and status. Intrusion by an enemy naturally provokes anger. Two scenarios exist: when the defender is slightly stronger, the reaction is "You are weaker than I, yet you dare challenge me—clearly you do not respect me; you must be taught a lesson." When the defender is slightly weaker, the reaction is "If I lose, my property, wife, children, and life will be endangered—how hateful! I must fight to the end and drive the intruder out."

Today the triggers of anger extend far beyond contests over food and territory, as everyday life readily demonstrates.

### **Psychology Mini-Class**

American psychologists conducted this experiment: they injected substances from the blood of angry people into mice and observed the mice's reactions. At first, the mice appeared lethargic and lost their appetite completely. They stopped eating and drinking, and within just a few days they died.

American physiologist Elmer also performed a similar experiment. He collected "qi water" (breath condensate) from people under different conditions—anger, regret, grief, and calm—and compared them. The results confirmed that anger is extremely harmful to the human body. When he placed the "qi water" exhaled during calm into test water, it remained clear and colorless with no impurities. The "qi water" from regret left a protein-colored precipitate after settling; the one from grief left a white precipitate; and the one from anger left a purple precipitate. When the "anger water" was injected into white rats, the rats lost vital signs within minutes.

From these experiments, Elmer concluded that even ten minutes of anger consumes as much energy as running a 3,000-meter race. The physiological reactions during anger are intense, and the secretions produced are more complex and toxic than those from other emotions.

Therefore, people who anger easily find it difficult to stay healthy or live long. When a person flies into a rage or sulks, a series of physiological changes occur that damage various parts of the body and can even threaten life. For example, anger accelerates the heartbeat; the heart is invaded by rage, leading to palpitations, heartache, chest tightness, and lung distension, ultimately injuring the heart and lungs. Anger also produces extreme anxiety and a sensation of gastric fullness that suppresses appetite; over time this inevitably impairs gastrointestinal digestion and harms the spleen and stomach. Furthermore, during rage the mental state can

become disordered, causing extreme emotional tension and mental confusion. Under such adverse psychological conditions and negative emotions, the “insular cortex” in the brain is stimulated and alters the brain’s control over the heart, impairing myocardial function, triggering sudden ventricular fibrillation, causing arrhythmia, and even stopping the heartbeat and resulting in death. Therefore, from the perspective of one’s own health, one should actively extinguish the anger within.

#### 4. Interest Conflicts

One of the most common forms of anger in human society occurs when others threaten one’s interests.

Two competing departments in a company ask the boss for budget. Regardless of the methods the department heads use or the final budget the boss grants, the competition is no longer benign and can already provoke anger and hostility between the two heads. Yet is the root of the anger truly the portion of the budget the boss approved or denied? One possibility is that the two are not merely concerned with the numerical amount of money but with the competitive outcome the numbers represent.

Whoever receives the larger budget approval will enjoy many derivative benefits; the approval may signify the leader’s recognition, “reputation in the arena,” and the loyalty of subordinates—all of which affect future survival and development. If the two departments receive equal budgets, or even if the side that receives more still feels threatened by the other’s aggressive competitive behavior, anger can arise.

Thus, much anger triggered by damaged interests has the interests themselves as only the surface phenomenon or trigger; the future threat represented by the damage is the core issue. If the damage to interests becomes an established trend—that is, if the competitor believes they will always lose to you—then their heart will fill with powerless fear or sorrow.

Many examples of the same nature exist: competing for people, money, or territory. Competition in romantic relationships is also a frequent context for anger. Driven by the pursuit of superior reproduction, any threat to one’s own love for another or to the loved one elicits a physiological impulse toward angry attack. But if true love has already passed, only tears of sorrow flow, not the hot blood of anger.

#### Suppressed Anger

Unlike inhibited anger, suppressed anger is sulking with no outlet. Anger must be vented to maintain mental balance and support healthy psychological development. Yet as civilization advances, people are constrained by countless external factors and cannot vent anger freely. Even as children we were told by parents not to lose our temper in public. A mere pout would draw a stern “Stop pouting—don’t be so childish.” Over time, holding anger in became associated with good upbringing.

After entering society, we experience more sulking than joy because we cannot vent anger at will and emotions cannot develop naturally. This is not only a matter of upbringing but also of survival. When negotiating with clients or communicating with a boss, any display of anger can jeopardize one’s future and livelihood. Anger must be forcibly suppressed, which in some ways is more frightening than shouting. Because one must exert effort to restrain and not shout, the muscles around the mouth tighten, forming tightly closed lips. Under the combined action of the levator labii superioris, levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, and mentalis muscles, the suppressed mouth shape curves downward overall—corners of the mouth droop, the nasolabial folds deepen, and the chin shows uneven wrinkles. The eyes display typical anger features: eyebrows lowered and furrowed, upper eyelids raised, lower eyelids tensed.

Note that without changes in the eyebrows and eyes, a pout alone cannot reliably indicate anger. Similar pouting appears in expressions of grievance or sadness. Therefore, to judge anger, one must also consider the shape of the eyes and eyebrows.

### **Restrained Behavioral Capacity**

Anyone tied up with ropes becomes angry, yet in real life many invisible ropes bind us and continually provoke anger.

Parents want their children to be versatile; the more skills, the better—not only for cultivating temperament but also for securing a brighter future. So parents begin fostering artistic sensibilities: piano, violin, painting, calligraphy, dance, singing... After school or on weekends, children must spend one or two hours on artistic training after finishing homework. For children, constant movement better matches their natural inclinations—playing tag with friends, for example. Try picking up a toddler who has just learned to walk; the child will struggle to break free, and if unable to do so will flush, cry out, and breathe rapidly—an expression of anger. For a child who craves activity, sitting still to practice art is torment. They want to resist yet must yield to parental authority, creating a sense of restraint. The longer the restraint, the greater the negative emotion, until it becomes anger that erupts as shouting. Once the shouting draws parental rebuke, the anger turns into sadness and disgust.

The same dynamic exists between lovers or spouses. You may not want your partner to befriend members of the opposite sex or to dress revealingly. Early in the relationship such “don’ts” may be interpreted as love, but over time a strong sense of restraint fills the heart. One feels one’s behavioral freedom is controlled and constrained, and freedom is lost. At that point anger arises and leads to repeated arguments.

### **3. Anxious Anger**

Every parent has the same experience—coaxing a child to sleep, a sweet and loving moment. Can anger arise? Absolutely. The classic scenario is when the parent has an important commitment afterward (a conference call, for example).

If an important arrangement looms yet the child, as usual, demands another story or keeps wriggling and refusing to settle, occasionally speaking up just when you think they have fallen asleep, these originally endearing behaviors can ignite anxious anger. The inner script runs roughly: “Child, it’s time to sleep; it’s late. Daddy/Mommy has something important to do. Fall asleep quickly so I can get to it; if you stay awake this late you might ruin my plans.”

As time presses and anxiety accumulates, anger easily surfaces; one becomes irritable and may even scold the child. Yet if one truly has no choice but to wait until the child sleeps (for instance, when one is the sole caregiver), once the deadline for the important matter passes and the child is still awake, anger dissipates and calm returns—unless that matter matters more than the child’s distress.

Incidentally, this is also why especially busy parents tend to raise rebellious children: the child concludes that they matter less to the parents than earning money or attending a meeting. “Since I don’t matter, you might as well stop minding me.”

### **Anger Expressions**



When anger has not reached its peak and one only wants to retort, the mouth closes less tightly. Because one still intends to vent anger through words—accusations or arguments—lower teeth are often visible, and sometimes upper teeth as well.

When freshly provoked and preparing to attack, the mouth closes a little more; the teeth meet. Yet the raising of the upper lip signals “Watch out, I’m angry.” At this degree of closure the upper teeth are definitely exposed, displaying a biting posture and strong aggression. The phrase “gnashing one’s teeth” accurately describes this state. Animals about to strike bare their canines to show ferocity, teeth closed and ready to tear. When humans prepare to attack, gnashing teeth both declares the resolve to bite through to the end and prepares to endure pain. Indeed, people also clench their teeth when bearing pain. Try the action: jaws tight, mouth stretched, both rows of teeth visible. In the mirror you look either ferocious or in agony.

Although the mouth shape of bearing pain resembles anger, the eyebrows and eyes differ markedly. In pain the brows rise at the inner ends and press down at the outer ends, the eyes close—signs of avoidance.

Having described the standard expression of full anger, we now turn to other types of anger expressions—namely, micro-expressions of anger.

## 2. Restricted Freedom

Restricted freedom poses the greatest threat to survival. Without freedom of movement one is surrounded like prey with no escape and will surely die. Thus, in the instinctive awareness accumulated through human evolution, restricted freedom registers as an extremely serious threat.

When adults play with children they sometimes, out of affection, hold the little one to their chest and gently pin the arms and legs. Can you guess the child’s reaction?

Instantly the child’s face changes to anger, flushes bright red, holds a breath, and struggles to break free—an unmistakable anger response. The restraining force is not strong and does not hurt, and the preceding play atmosphere was pleasant; the mere act of restraint produces such a dramatic shift.

The child’s subjective expectation is free movement. Any behavior that restrains a child’s capacity to act creates a negative expectation violation. Even during play, sudden loss of freedom triggers instinctive discomfort and anger. After a brief moment and a feeble effort that fails to change the situation, the child opens the mouth wide and wails, expressing grievance (unwilling yet powerless to alter the situation) and bewilderment—this is the emotion of sadness.

## 4. Sneer (Angry Smile)

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-27]*

1. Head slightly lowered, chin tucked (head-attack posture feature);
2. Eyebrows furrowed and lowered in a “10:10” shape, vertical glabellar lines present (anger feature);
3. Upper eyelids raised forcefully against the resistance of lowered brows, forming wrinkles on the eyelid skin (anger feature);
4. Lower eyelids tensed (anger feature);
5. Upper lip raised, exposing upper teeth; corners of the mouth pulled sideways and upward, lower lip relaxed (local smile feature);
6. Upper teeth show a tendency to bite the lower lip, indicating suppression.

**Summary:** Anger features are obvious, confirming it as the dominant emotion. Mouth features of a smile appear, yet the eyes do not participate, so the smile is not genuine and no pleasure is present. Combined with the lip-biting suppression action, the person can be judged to be suppressing anger (temporarily not attacking) while using the smile to convey a sense of control or low pressure. A smile issued under dominant anger can be called a sneer, expressing both offensive potential and inner satisfaction with the outcome of the fight.

### **Interest Competition**

Anger arising in interest competition is common.

Two department heads compete for the design and execution rights of the same product. They submit the best designs screened by their departments to the client, who chooses which to use. In benign competition the probability of anger erupting is low. If one side uses improper means to win, the other side will certainly be furious. This is not merely about whether one's own department's design is adopted; it also concerns whether one will receive the boss's favor, performance bonuses, and so on. Adoption signals recognized competence, spreads within the circle, motivates subordinates to work harder, and greatly increases promotion chances. Rejection, conversely, threatens promotion, public opinion, and finances.

Rivalry between romantic competitors follows the same pattern. As noted in the section on happiness, when choosing a mate people pursue superior reproductive genes. The appearance of a rival naturally threatens the loss of those genes, producing anger that is physiologically difficult to control and may escalate to physical fighting.

### **"Are You Up to It?"**

This inner question typically arises during provocation. It conveys "I want to see whether you're really up to it" or "Who's better—you or me?" The provocateur usually hopes for an intense response and therefore uses this mindset and tone to enrage the other party.

Still, the provocative tone "Are you really up to it?" is relatively mild. Its implication—"I'm strong; let's see how strong you are"—is gentler and more sincere. If the provoked person is steady, they will weigh whether to accept the challenge, sensing their own inferiority. Without outside instigation they may choose to retreat. But if the provocateur says "I can see you're not up to it; even if we fight, you'll lose," the provoked person's anger ignites easily. They will want to prove their strength and the other's misjudgment. Precisely at such moments the provoked must stay clear-headed and control their anger, for this may be a "goaded tactic."

### **(1) Contempt**

A common line of negation is "You're no good!" Depending on tone, it can convey rich shades of meaning. Such contempt need not involve threatening actions; it may be only a sentence or a glance (expression). No one likes to be negated, especially when belittled (which amplifies the negation) or negated without factual basis (slander), both of which readily provoke anger.

When animals are regarded as inferior by their own kind during survival, they lose authority and control; their safety faces great risk—they may be preyed upon, defeated, lose mates or offspring, even life. In today's highly civilized, specialized society, having one of one's skills negated likewise means losing competitiveness and survival opportunities. This threat is the most direct stimulus for anger.

Even cultivated scholars will step forward to defend their reputation if baselessly slandered or belittled in their area of expertise. On the internet, minor differences of opinion routinely prompt opinion leaders to launch verbal and written attacks—fresh cases appear constantly.

## **(2) Provocation**

Provocation usually precedes open struggle. The provoking party expresses a desire to fight and hopes the other will respond in kind, deliberately arousing anger by attacking whatever the other cares about most. Provocation is the behavior most likely to ignite anger. There are many forms; the key lies in the target's personality and concerns. Broadly, one type says "Let's fight and see," the other "You have no skill; I disdain fighting you—if we did, I'd finish you easily." The latter usually provokes more anger, because the former is often sincere, the speaker possesses real strength, and the target can more readily apply reason to consider the course of events and non-combat resolutions—unless bystander commentary interferes. The latter deliberately conveys a very low evaluation and uses disdain to intensify the expectation violation, making the target eager to disprove the assessment and teach the provocateur a lesson, since the evaluation is so low it seems easy to correct. Yet this is precisely a psychological trap.

## **Chapter 6 Micro-expressions of Anger**

When the intensity of a negative stimulus escalates beyond the threshold of disgust and poses a threat to the individual, it triggers anger. Anger is characterized by an aggressive impulse aimed at driving away or eliminating the source of the negative stimulus.

The essence of disgust is a "top-down rejection" attitude toward the negative stimulus, involving attempts to exclude, avoid, or simply ignore it. At every level of disgust, there is no desire to change, attack, or eliminate the stimulus source; at most, one walks away. However, if the stimulus intensifies to the point of creating threat or harm, the individual's emotion escalates to a new level—anger.

The essence of anger is the desire to attack and prevail—eliminating danger through aggression.

Events that provoke anger are richly varied in daily life. They range from a taxi driver ignoring a hail on the street to someone physically attacking you or your child. Therefore, readers should prepare for the first task: patiently sorting out the sources of anger.

### **Breach of Agreement**

#### **Situation A**

Woman: "Why are you so late? I've been waiting forever."

Situation A

Man: "I'm sorry. Something came up at the last minute. I'm really sorry, darling."

Woman: "I'm not eating."

Situation B

Buyer: "You said you'd hold it for me. Why did you sell it to someone else?"

Seller: "They bought it on the spot. I couldn't refuse. Next time—next time it arrives, I'll notify you first."

Buyer: "There won't be a next time. No credibility."

Both Situation A and Situation B produce anger from a breach of agreement. On the surface, what is lost is a date or an item; in substance, a threat has been perceived. When the man arrives late, the woman feels undervalued and threatened with possible abandonment. When the goods are sold to another buyer, two threat elements appear: a sense of disrespect and violated dignity, and the practical loss of the item, which may disrupt daily routines until a replacement is obtained.

#### **8.2.5 How to Distinguish Genuine from Feigned Anger?**

Attack gestures can also be used to feign anger. A person who is actually worried (fearful or sad) may deliberately display aggressive movements to make others believe their words or to end an uncomfortable conversation. Such displays are not driven by genuine emotion.

The key question is how to judge the authenticity of these auxiliary movements.

When an action is genuinely driven by emotion, arm movements require no conscious thought; they match the force and rhythm of speech. Language and movement spring from the same source—anger. Anger concentrates force on the target, aligning gaze, weapon, and body posture in a single direction.

Feigned anger is constructed through deliberate thought control. Without direct emotional drive, the movements fail to synchronize fully in force or timing, revealing numerous tells.

#### **Obstruction in the Process of Reaching a Goal**

Anyone who has run a race understands the anger that arises when obstacles appear on the track. A better finish is lost because a stone trips the runner. In real life, much anger stems from blocked progress toward a goal; traffic jams are the classic example.

During a traffic jam people become irritable because the expected arrival time is delayed, potentially triggering a chain of negative consequences—late arrival at work and docked pay, a missed client meeting and an unsigned contract, or lost career and financial opportunities. These thoughts quickly turn irritation into anger. Conversely, if the day is free of obligations and no destination is urgent, a traffic jam does not provoke anger, because no goal exists to be obstructed.

#### **Controlling Anger and Extinguishing Inner Rage**

When inner rage burns fiercely, one must neither vent it without restraint—harming self and others—nor suppress it indefinitely and add to physical and mental strain. The skill is to extinguish the fire at the first spark.

Psychological research shows that frequent outbursts increase the risk factors for heart disease and other illnesses. People who rarely lose their temper experience significantly lower mortality and heart-disease recurrence rates. Therefore, effectively inhibiting anger helps maintain a calm state of mind.

Achieving this is not difficult; many methods exist for dousing inner fire. The practical question is how to cool the emotion.

#### **Suppressed Anger**

The foundation of suppressed anger is denial. In mild denial the orbicularis oris muscle relaxes while the mentalis and depressor anguli oris contract, producing a pout. This expression conveys "I don't think so," "This is awkward," or "I'm a bit upset." When the orbicularis oris also contracts, the denial deepens into displeasure. At a still greater intensity it becomes suppressed anger. Because reason demands that anger be forcibly contained, greater muscular effort is required. If this expression appears during conversation, the other person is already intensely angry yet is actively restraining it; changing the topic or pausing the exchange is advisable.

### **Disgust Escalating into Anger**

Disgust can escalate into anger. The resulting expression shows anger in the brows and eyes while retaining disgust in the mouth and nose.

In the disgust expression the upper lip rises, forming the nasolabial fold. When combined with lowered and furrowed brows, raised upper eyelids, and tensed lower eyelids, the configuration indicates anger triggered by disgust. A slightly open mouth prepares for speech; lowered brows signal readiness to attack.

When one feels inner disgust toward another person, avoidance is the usual choice. When interaction is unavoidable, the disgust expression may appear unintentionally. If the other person then utters words that intensify negative emotion, disgust rapidly converts into anger.

### **Furrowed Brows and Biting Lips Both Signal Red Lights**

The key facial markers of anger are "forceful eyebrows and lips." The characteristic actions are "both eyebrows drawn toward the center," "eyes widened," "lower eyelids markedly tensed," and "lips pressed tightly together or mouth open." Anger encompasses irritation, annoyance, discord, defiance, and disagreement—feelings that arise when a personal goal is obstructed or when one rejects a current event or another's statement. When anger occurs, muscles tense and heart rate rises. In evolutionary biology the anger expression serves to intimidate others and signal an impending attack.

### **3. Jealousy Stems from the Monkey-King Mentality**

Humans possess a strong innate "I alone am supreme" consciousness, often called the monkey-king mentality. Everyone wants to be the most important, the strongest, the undisputed number one. When others treat you as most important or when you regard yourself as the strongest, you feel happy and gratified. Conversely, when someone fails to treat you as most important or when you cannot accept being inferior, you feel inferior, hurt, anxious, and irritable. Once you recognize that you are not the strongest but the weakest and most pitiable, the monkey-king mentality collapses and jealousy arises.

#### **Loss of Self-Control?**

An extremely angry or frustrated person who cannot directly express feelings often scratches the head, strokes the neck, clenches fists, or grips arms or wrists in an attempt to maintain self-control.

If standing, the person may take a threatening step forward to close distance and display a "staring" expression. If the distance closes to within touching range yet self-control is still desired, anger may be redirected onto a substitute object—pounding a fist on a table, slamming a door, or kicking an item.

### **2. Suppressing Rage and Responding Calmly**

When someone shouts at you or attacks you verbally, how should you respond—ignore it or retaliate? Adjust your mindset and make no reply. The event has already occurred; you cannot change it or control the other person's behavior. Retaliation only escalates conflict and worsens the situation. Non-response "removes the fuel from the fire," making it difficult for the other person to continue the outburst.

#### **4. Facing the Root Cause**

Virginia Williams once said, "The key is not to keep saying 'I'm furious' without taking action. You need to identify why you are angry and then move forward." A simple request or action can produce results. Therefore, if your anger stems from your wife purchasing an expensive cosmetic without consulting you, confront the root cause by obtaining her commitment to seek your opinion before future large expenditures.

#### **Signs of Anger or Resentment**

- Cold attitude, silence
- Turning the head away
- Maintaining distance
- Lips pressed tight or pouting
- Arms or legs crossed
- Slamming the door in anger

Just as a child's angry behavior should not be ignored, a partner's signs of irritation or annoyance deserve attention. Interpreting the other person's body language allows you to rebuild a good relationship in a timely and constructive manner.

#### **7. Shifting Your Attention**

An enraged person can easily lose control and commit irreversible acts, so the emotion must be cooled. One effective method is to shift attention. For example, when someone provokes you and you feel the urge to strike, listen to soothing music, walk in a park, or stand by a lake in the breeze—any technique that redirects attention and extinguishes inner fire.

#### **5. Being Denied**

Denial is a general term for a category of stimuli. As analyzed in the chapter on disgust, abhorrence, contempt, and disdain are all forms of denial. In concrete expression they subdivide into direct denial, belittlement (contempt and disdain), disgust, and, on the basis of belittlement, provocation and disrespect.

#### **3. Identifying the Cause of Your Anger**

When the urge to become angry arises, wait until the emotion has cooled slightly, then identify the cause. Is it because friends repeatedly mock your figure and clothing? Because a supervisor constantly claims you are not working hard enough and you feel wronged? Because parents criticize you without reason and disregard your feelings?

#### **5. Avoid Coarse Language**

Mutual understanding is the best way to extinguish inner fire, so practice empathy. Even when very angry, refrain from calling the other person a "fool," an "idiot," or worse; such language treats the other as an enemy and makes empathy impossible.

### Signs of Anger

- Tears and rage
- Worried or irritable expression
- Turning the head away
- Slamming the door forcefully

See The seven basic emotions (c-seven-emotions).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Part III — Basic emotions on the face (p-basic-emotions).

See Part III — Basic emotions on the face (p-basic-emotions).

See Voice and speech (c-voice).

See Legs and feet (c-legs).

### Disgust

#### Disgust

When we see those nauseating foods, we squint our eyes, wrinkle our noses, pull the corners of our mouths back, and sometimes make a retching motion. This is the classic expression of disgust, originally triggered by spoiled, nauseating food. In times when humans had no concept of food hygiene, eating spoiled food could lead to vomiting, diarrhea, fever, and other illnesses, with severe cases possibly resulting in death. Therefore, disgust toward spoiled food became a survival skill.

With the development of civilization and technology today, humans rarely accidentally consume spoiled food, but the expression of disgust has remained, evolving into a reaction to undesirable phenomena, events, and people.

Compared to anger, sadness, and fear, the reaction of disgust is not as intense, and the facial changes are not as dramatic. This is because the stimulus from the trigger does not cause significant negative impact on oneself. The triggers for disgust vary with different stages of social development. For example, in feudal society, a man and a woman meeting alone would be considered disgusting, but today, it is not a trigger for disgust. In contemporary society, there are roughly two situations that can trigger disgust: negation of the stimulus; perceiving it as poor or despicable, yet not constituting a threat.

A volunteer (pseudonym H) participating in a psychology experiment recounted an incident from which we can analyze the formation of the emotion of disgust.

H is a beautiful girl who was pursued by many during her university years, but she focused entirely on her studies and did not date any boys until graduation. On graduation day, she suddenly received a letter that roughly said: H, I know you have had a crush on me for many years. Because of my busy studies, I have always pretended not to notice you. Today we have graduated, and the burden of study has been temporarily set

aside. I hope to clarify this relationship with you and step into society together. It was signed by a boy named J. There were quite a few boys in H's class, but only a few she interacted with regularly, and she did not recall any dealings with J.

At first, H suspected J had mistaken her for someone else, so she sought him out to talk. J was a self-important boy who, though neither handsome nor academically outstanding, always considered himself a heartthrob and would not easily glance at girls, carrying an air of a prince high above others.

H found him and asked if he had made a mistake. J insisted he had not and confidently claimed H had a crush on him. H asked on what basis he said that; over four years they had exchanged only a few words and had almost no intersection, so how could there be talk of a crush? J told H that at the opening ceremony she had deliberately stepped on his foot and smiled at him, and from that moment he had decided H had feelings for him; otherwise, why would she not date for four years when plenty of boys pursued her? It was obvious she was waiting for him.

H found this both amusing and exasperating. She said she had indeed stepped on him at the opening ceremony, but it was not intentional; smiling was basic courtesy, and not accepting others' pursuits for four years was to focus more on her studies—she also planned to prepare for a master's degree. If she were to date, it would be after entering a master's program. Later J kept telling classmates that H had a crush on him, making H extremely embarrassed.

While discussing this matter, H displayed disgust once and anger once. Disgust appeared when mentioning J's insistence that H had a crush on him; anger appeared when she spoke of J spreading the rumor to classmates. The psychologist asked why she felt disgusted by J, and she replied: "I hate boys with prince syndrome, so self-important. He is not handsome, his grades are poor, so on what grounds does he think I would like him? If I were to like someone, it would be tall, handsome, and at least cultured. In short, he makes me feel very low-grade."

There is another similar case provided by a volunteer we will call M.

During his internship, M encountered a man who claimed to be a director and wanted to discover him as a talent. It is undeniable that M is tall, handsome, steady, kind, and knowledgeable, making him well-suited to be a high-quality idol. However, M still preferred the programming industry and had little interest in the entertainment industry. To persuade M to appear in his film, the director said he had collaborated with many famous directors and actors, naming several who had even won Oscars. M immediately grew suspicious: if he had worked with so many celebrities, why was he unknown? Out of politeness, M did not leave immediately but listened to what the man had to say.

While the director expounded on his artistic philosophy and current artistic trends, M found his ideas clichéd and somewhat vulgar, not what one would expect from a cultivated, knowledgeable person. The director told him that today's films do not emphasize substance or culture but star power; as long as big names appear, the film will succeed. M asked: if you believe only big names should star, why must I appear in your film? The director said many big names had already signed on, but they were supporting roles; the male lead had not been found until he happened to see M and felt his temperament fit the role. M asked some professional questions about art, and the director stammered and evaded, nothing like someone with professional training.

Watching the boastful director, M felt disgust. He believed the director's views were all incorrect; a good story is always the soul of a good film. Moreover, the director made M feel very low-grade.



From these two cases we can see that negation and low-grade quality are the triggers for disgust, making the person feel dislike, yet these do not affect them. One more point to note is the difference between disgust and anger. As in H's case, her initial emotion was disgust, but when J spread the rumor that she had a crush on him, disgust turned into anger because it threatened her reputation and could affect her future romantic prospects.

Having understood the triggers of disgust, let us next examine the features of a full disgust expression.

### **The Man with Six Titles**

A volunteer named Xiaoya who participated in our research recounted an encounter with a man of exceptional quality. During their first contact, the man first handed over his business card, which listed six different titles, from president of a certain company to advisor to a certain group, researcher at a certain research institute, and finally "class monitor of a certain university's graduate course program." After the surprise of this self-introduction, the two began exchanging views on the current state of the film industry in an attempt to find cooperation opportunities.

In this man's view, making films in the industry required the "three bigs"—big investment, big stars, big publicity. Although he had so far only made two experimental music videos, he firmly believed that as long as someone invested enough money to hire big-name directors and stars and adapt a well-known historical story, a successful work would result. Then, from the start of shooting, hype and publicity would begin, even manufacturing gimmicks to attract attention, until the film finally entered theaters and achieved both fame and fortune.

When Xiaoya pointed out that film is an art form that tells stories through images and sound, so a good story should be the core element of a good film, the man strongly refuted her and repeatedly emphasized, "Who in China watches stories? As long as there are stars on screen, people get excited; the bigger the stars, the more people will watch, and the higher the box office!" While later describing his grand plans, his impassioned manner left no room for others to interject, and he frequently mentioned which entertainment stars he had attended events with, taken photos with, and whose phone numbers he had stored, looking completely self-satisfied.

Eventually Xiaoya had to end the meeting early, politely excusing herself with another appointment. We tried to point out the sources of her emotion at the time, and Xiaoya agreed with the two features we analyzed: "First, what this man said seemed wrong to me; second, he did not realize his views were wrong and still shamelessly boasted and promoted himself—this ignorance made me feel very low-grade."

A similar real-world case involves an entertainment celebrity crossing over to act as an opinion leader. In March 2015, a well-known lawyer published on social media his critical opinions about traffic police conducting nighttime checks for drunk driving. This attention-seeking behavior drew widespread public criticism and questioning and became a laughingstock for a time.

After the entire incident, we analyzed the public's disgust toward this lawyer and concluded it stemmed mainly from the fact that, in his capacity as a "legal professional," he expressed views that showed ignorance of basic legal knowledge yet he considered them correct, criticizing the normal enforcement actions of traffic police. The public viewed his erroneous opinions as low-grade, and as a lawyer he should not have been so ignorant; this self-importance was deeply disgusting.

Of course, the public feedback also contained a large amount of abusive language. It should be noted that abuse is an aggressive act stemming from anger and has already exceeded the upper limit of disgust. A necessary feature of disgust is the absence of any desire to attack.

By discussing the two cases above, we can see that the triggers capable of arousing disgust in interpersonal communication share common patterns. For a person to feel disgust toward a stimulus, at least two necessary features must exist simultaneously: first, negation of the stimulus, specifically manifested as disagreement or non-acceptance; second, in addition to disagreement, the belief that the stimulus is low-grade, far below one's subjective expectations of it.

Contempt very easily triggers anger. If A feels contempt for B and B refuses to accept it or even provokes, A very easily escalates to anger and attempts to "subdue" B, with lines roughly like: "You little punk, I'll make you submit!" If B clearly knows A feels disgust toward him and must maintain a connection with A, B is very likely to feel anger to protect his dignity from infringement. We will explain anger in detail in the next chapter.

For example, two company executives engage in a reasonable debate, each supported by specific theoretical or factual evidence for their views. Although both may harbor negation, they will not necessarily feel disgust and may even appreciate each other. If a low-grade evaluation factor is added to this situation—for instance, the product manager believes the sales director's proposed sales growth plan for the next year has no basis whatsoever, completely脱离s the company's current objective conditions, and is all baseless talk—disgust will arise.

In some cases, the stimulus's level may not objectively be low, but because its excessively high self-positioning exceeds reality, it can also produce a relatively low-grade evaluation. An arrogant senior colleague may indeed have ability, but because he cannot accept reasonable views from juniors and is blindly conceited, he can arouse disgust. Historically many famous ministers also aroused the emperor's disgust because of such self-importance after great achievements. In *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, Wei Yan repeatedly caused Zhuge Liang's disgust and vigilance for this reason (Zhuge Liang's comment that Wei Yan had a rebellious bone at the back of his head is merely novelistic technique and will not be discussed). This subjective low-grade evaluation held by the actor is a relative effect caused by the stimulus's excessively high self-perception; objective reality is made to appear low-grade by the stimulus's arrogance.

If the objective situation is already low-grade and is paired with a blindly conceited display, the degree of disgust will be strongly increased.

#### **Fun Case: The Man with Six Titles**

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If the objective situation is already low-grade and is paired with a blindly conceited display, the degree of disgust will be strongly increased.

### 5.3.3 Features of the Disgusted Expression

When the intensity of the stimulus decreases, the degree of aversion also decreases. When our state of rejection is slightly weaker, the disgust dominated by the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi muscle is instead controlled by the levator labii superioris, resulting in an overall milder degree of facial deformation. As shown in Figure 5-11.

The disgusted expression shown in the figure can be analyzed with the following features:

- ① While the orbicularis oculi muscle contracts, it causes the eyebrows to press down slightly; the corrugator supercilii muscle also participates in contraction, forming slight frown lines;
- ② Slight contraction of the orbicularis oculi muscle causes the eyelids to tense and close slightly;
- ③ The levator labii superioris muscle dominates the contraction, lifting the upper lip upward;
- ④ The alae of the nose are indirectly lifted upward and stretched to both sides, forming shallow grooves on both sides of the alae;
- ⑤ The lower lip shows no obvious morphological change; the lips may remain closed or slightly parted.

It can be seen that when the overall movement of the facial muscles weakens, the most prominent feature is still the lifting of the upper lip and the alae of the nose, along with the resulting grooves on both sides of the alae; next, the morphological changes in the eyes and eyebrows are also quite prominent features.

Darwin, in his book *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals*, also mentioned that disgust can sometimes be expressed without visible changes to the upper lip (for example, when obscured by a thick mustache), as long as the deep lines on both sides of the alae are observed, along with the eyes and eyebrows, it can be fully conveyed.

### Test Case

#### Taking Risqué Photos to Seek Fame

Usually, when we talk about internet celebrities known for "aesthetic ugliness," this expression appears involuntarily. If the visual stimulus is added, the effect becomes even more pronounced.

We tested a young girl who very much wanted to become famous. She had taken some rather risqué, ambiguous-style photos in an attempt to attract attention and establish herself in the entertainment industry for development. To determine her behavioral motives, we prepared photos of a famous internet celebrity "Sister X" and videos of TV programs she had participated in. When the girl saw her photos and videos, the expression in Figure 5-12 immediately appeared on her face.

By analyzing this natural facial reaction, we confirmed that she felt disgust toward "Sister X"'s appearance.

However, when several video clips of TV programs were subsequently played, the girl's face showed great excitement and attention. Although "Sister X" performed and talked confidently and boldly in the programs, it did not increase the girl's disgust. Through capturing and analyzing changes in the girl's gaze direction, we noted that her increased excitement was directly related to the logos of major TV stations that kept appearing. Therefore, our analysis concluded that the girl very much hoped to achieve similar attention and fame, and participating in recordings on major TV stations was a stimulus that excited her. The feeling of disgust was limited only to aversion toward "Sister X"'s appearance; she had no objection to her method of becoming popular through "aesthetic ugliness."

### 5.3.2 Features of the Disgusted Expression

The physiological expression of disgust differs from vomiting in one obvious respect: because there is no need to create a passage for vomiting, the mouth does not open as widely as it does during the vomiting action. As shown in Figure 5-8.

This image shows the expression when tasting a very unpleasant flavor or odor. We make the same expression when we hear something disgusting or see a repulsive scene. Such an intense facial muscle configuration (which can be described as distorted) can convey an even stronger sense of disgust in real life than the vomiting expression. Because the mentalis muscle contracts and pushes the lower lip upward, pressing the lips tightly together, it visibly suppresses the vomiting action, in line with the rules of civilized society that prohibit vomiting at will. Compared with vomiting, this expression is more practical and less exaggerated. This mouth shape can be understood either as an effort to control oneself and not vomit in public (already at an extreme level of disgust) or as a primitive signal of refusing to accept any unpleasant taste.

The muscle movements and facial morphological features that constitute the disgusted expression are as follows:

- ① The corrugator supercilii muscle contracts, knitting the eyebrows tightly;
- ② The orbicularis oculi muscle contracts strongly, closing the eyes tightly and simultaneously pressing the eyebrows downward;
- ③ The levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi muscles contract, lifting the upper lip while squeezing the sides of the alae to form the nasolabial folds;
- ④ The mentalis muscle contracts, forcefully pushing the lower lip upward so that the lips are pressed tightly together; the chin simultaneously wrinkles upward, producing many folds on the surface skin; a deep groove forms between the lower lip and the raised muscle on the chin;
- ⑤ The depressor anguli oris muscle contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth downward, counterbalancing the action of the levator labii superioris and forming bracket-shaped lines on both sides of the mouth.

Other disgusted expressions similar to this morphology differ mainly in the shape of the mouth. In some cases the lower lip is relaxed and the mouth opens slightly; apart from the upper lip, no other parts participate forcefully in forming the expression. As shown in Figure 5-9.

In other cases the corners of the mouth are pulled sharply sideways under the action of the platysma, flattening the lower lip, smoothing the surface skin, exposing part of the upper teeth while the lower teeth are partially covered by the upper teeth. As shown in Figure 5-10.

## Test Case

### Bloody Visual Stimuli

Producing such an intense disgusted expression requires a stimulus of very high intensity. Simple problem stimuli or verbal stimuli rarely achieve this effect. In the experiments we conducted, only the video *Forensic Autopsy Demonstration* and some bloody post-disaster corpse photographs elicited disgusted expressions approaching this degree in the subjects<|eos|>

## 2. Disgust Expressions of Varying Intensity

If the stimulus is very strong, it produces intense disgust, that is, physiological disgust, prompting avoidance of any close contact or relationship with the stimulus source. If the stimulus intensity weakens to a moderate level, it produces revulsion; the rejection and disapproval represented by revulsion are also quite strong and can largely be triggered by psychological stimuli. As stimulus intensity decreases further, it produces contempt; contempt expresses a top-down sense of rejection on the part of the actor, yet the mindset remains light. If the stimulus intensity is very weak, it produces disdain; “not deigning to look” is the typical representative of this mindset.

Regardless of the degree of disgust, the common conclusion is this: the appearance of disgust signifies a top-down negation within the actor’s mind.

Full disgust triggers the action combination of brow furrowing + eyelid closure + upper-lip elevation. When social context imposes no restrictions, these features can be displayed without restraint. In important social situations, however, inner disgust often cannot be expressed freely, because doing so would be perceived as “very rude.” Therefore, once emotional expression is constrained, these full disgust expression forms cannot be displayed at maximum amplitude; the actor adopts the principle of reduced amplitude and reduced intensity to restrain emotional leakage, even though the actor remains unaware of the process.

Consequently, the micro-expression features of disgust concentrate on eyelid closure or upper-lip elevation. Slight eyelid closure replaces brow furrowing + eyelid closure, giving the appearance that the person is squinting at something; yet this isolated eyelid movement without accompanying brow action, when paired with steady gaze fixed on the stimulus source, can to some extent indicate the emergence of disgust. In certain social contexts the brows and eyes may remain still while the upper lip rises ever so slightly; this is the common “little contempt” expression.

## Chapter Summary

The original stimulus sources for disgust-type emotions are pungent odors and rotten, nauseating food. Therefore, when disgust expressions are at their fullest, they consist of brow furrowing + tightly closed eyes + vigorous upper-lip elevation + lower lip pressing upward so that both lips are pressed tightly together. Translated, this means “do not look, do not smell, do not eat.” If the ears could move, “do not listen” might also appear. For example, during an argument a girl may cover her ears with her hands, tightly close her eyes, and shout loudly, “I don’t want to hear it, I don’t want to hear it!” The brow-furrowing action helps increase the force of eye closure; tightly pressing the lips together rejects taste and some gaseous stimuli. Yet what is the purpose of upper-lip elevation? Aquatic animals such as seals can actively close their nasal passages through muscle movement—an evolved function. Humans lack this ability; the human nasal passages cannot be moved voluntarily. However, when the upper lip is vigorously elevated, the levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi objectively flatten the oval nasal passages, impeding free inhalation and exhalation and thereby reducing negative stimulation from pungent odors.

The essence of disgust-type emotions is negation; because these stimulus sources are not powerful enough to pose a harmful threat, the negation is usually top-down. An expression such as contempt is an extremely pronounced manifestation of this top-down negation. The emotion holder feels elevated above others (correct, rational, intelligent, excellent) while perceiving a vast gap between the stimulus source and themselves (wrong, reckless, foolish, inferior). Consequently, the contempt expression retains partial forms of the full disgust expression, typically including narrowed eyes, eyelid closure, and upper-lip elevation. In social situations where full contempt cannot be displayed, these standard expression forms often appear as unbalanced unilateral lip elevation and eyelid narrowing.

## 2. Disgust Expressions of Varying Intensity

If the stimulus is very strong, it produces intense disgust, that is, physiological disgust, prompting avoidance of any close contact or relationship with the stimulus source. If the stimulus intensity weakens to a moderate level, it produces revulsion; the rejection and disapproval represented by revulsion are also quite strong and can largely be triggered by psychological stimuli. As stimulus intensity decreases further, it produces contempt; contempt expresses a top-down sense of rejection on the part of the actor, yet the mindset remains light. If the stimulus intensity is very weak, it produces disdain; “not deigning to look” is the typical representative of this mindset.

Regardless of the degree of disgust, the common conclusion is this: the appearance of disgust signifies a top-down negation within the actor’s mind.

Full disgust triggers the action combination of brow furrowing + eyelid closure + upper-lip elevation. When social context imposes no restrictions, these features can be displayed without restraint. In important social situations, however, inner disgust often cannot be expressed freely, because doing so would be perceived as “very rude.” Therefore, once emotional expression is constrained, these full disgust expression forms cannot be displayed at maximum amplitude; the actor adopts the principle of reduced amplitude and reduced intensity to restrain emotional leakage, even though the actor remains unaware of the process.

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### The Slightly Overweight Person Sensitive About Body Shape

We once tested a slightly overweight young man. A core question during the session concerned whether he was sensitive about his body shape. Because he was studying criminal investigation, we began the conversation from the topic of “lie detection” technology.

- **Question:** How do you rate the effectiveness of traditional polygraph (lie detection) instruments?  
**Answer:** They’re all right. In terms of sensitivity and objectivity, they are fairly accurate for excluding criminal suspects. Once the test is done, if the person did it and simply claims not to remember, saying they didn’t do it will definitely be captured.  
**【Expression: No obvious change; maintains baseline smiling appearance.】**

- **Question:** How do you rate our micro-reaction (微反应) psychological testing technology for lie detection?  
**Answer:** I'm not very familiar with it. From your introduction it seems it might work.  
【Expression: Upper lip elevated, unilateral corner of the mouth raised, ipsilateral eye narrowed more tightly, forming a "disdainful smile."】
- **Question:** So you don't fully agree; you merely find the content we introduced reasonably logical, yet you do not accept the accuracy of the test—is that correct?  
**Answer:** (Slight surprise and embarrassment, fleeting) Heh, I think this testing technology could be interfered with by the subject's deliberate performance.
- **Question:** Do you feel your body shape is somewhat overweight?  
**Answer:** A bit overweight.  
【Expression: Returns to smiling appearance, appearing calm.】
- **Question:** Do you mind it yourself? Do you feel it is not attractive enough?  
**Answer:** There's nothing I can do about it; I'll just let nature take its course.  
【Expression: The unilateral corner-of-the-mouth raise and ipsilateral eye narrowing reappear, but this time the smile looks somewhat stiff.】

#### **Test Case: Taking Provocative Photos to Seek Fame**

Usually, when we discuss internet celebrities who have become known through "aesthetic ugliness," this expression tends to appear involuntarily. Adding visual stimulation makes the effect even more pronounced.

We tested a young woman who very much wanted to become famous. She had taken a series of large-scale, suggestive photos in an attempt to attract attention, establish herself in the entertainment industry, and advance her career. To determine her behavioral motivation, we prepared photos and television program video clips of a well-known internet celebrity referred to as "Sister X." When the young woman saw the photos and videos, the expression shown in Figure 5-12 immediately appeared on her face.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-12]*

By analyzing this natural facial response, we confirmed that she harbored disgust toward "Sister X"'s appearance.

However, when several subsequent television program video clips were played, the young woman's face displayed great excitement and attention. Although "Sister X" performed and spoke confidently and boldly in the programs, this did not increase the young woman's disgust. Through capture and analysis of changes in the young woman's gaze direction, we noted that her increased excitement was directly related to the successive appearance of logos from major television stations. Therefore, our analytical conclusion was that the young woman very much wanted to be noticed and become famous in the same way; being able to participate in programs on major television stations was the stimulus source that excited her. The disgusted feeling of revulsion remained limited to disgust toward "Sister X"'s appearance; she had no objection to the "aesthetic ugliness" method of achieving fame.

#### **5.2.1 Extreme Disgust: Vomiting**



The most fundamental feature of the disgust expression originates from a bodily action: vomiting, as shown in Figure 5-1.

To open the mouth to its maximum, in addition to lowering the jaw, a person instinctively elevates the upper lip (note the shape of the opened mouth in the figure, with both corners of the mouth lifted upward—this is an exaggerated expression of the upper lip being raised). Elevating the upper lip engages two muscle bundles: the levator labii superioris and the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, as shown in Figure 5-2. It should be noted that these two muscle bundles cannot be moved independently; they always contract simultaneously. The difference is that the levator labii superioris is more easily controlled voluntarily, whereas the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi located on either side of the nasal bridge is usually controlled spontaneously by strong emotion. Therefore, in particularly intense disgust expressions the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi plays the dominant role; in ordinary-intensity disgust expressions the levator labii superioris plays the dominant role.

As shown in Figure 5-2:

1. Orbicularis oris
2. Levator labii superioris
3. Levator labii superioris alaeque nasi

In addition to opening the mouth, the vomiting action also triggers an instinctive linked response—tightly closing the eyes and furrowing the brows. Tightly closing the eyes requires contraction of the orbicularis oculi, which, together with the raised cheeks, compresses the eyelids, producing a strong eye-closure movement (though usually not complete closure) and forming arc-shaped wrinkles beneath the lower eyelids. The contraction of the orbicularis oculi serves, on the one hand, to prevent increased internal pressure caused by vomiting from injuring the eyeball and, on the other hand, to reduce negative visual stimulation from the stimulus source to a certain extent. It should be noted, however, that contraction of the orbicularis oculi is not deliberate; it is a natural reaction to the vomiting action.

### 5.1 Generation of Disgust Emotion

Among all emotions triggered by negative stimuli, disgust belongs to a relatively mild reaction type; anger, fear, and sadness all produce more severe reactions than disgust.

The effectiveness of specific disgust stimulus sources is greatly influenced by different social cultures and education. For example, an outgoing personality does not become a disgust stimulus source in a social atmosphere that advocates and encourages individuality, yet it can very easily provoke disgust in others when placed in a conservative, strictly hierarchical social atmosphere.

We have done our best to summarize the universal characteristics of stimulus sources that can trigger disgust emotion in human society, offering these observations for further discussion.

An actor makes two evaluations of a disgust stimulus source: first, negation; second, inferiority—here “inferiority” refers to a level that is detestable yet not threatening enough to harm the actor’s interests.

Two examples illustrate this point.

A “self-important” person is, in almost every society and culture, the stimulus source most likely to provoke disgust in others.

Self-importance is not the same as an outgoing personality; it is unfounded outgoingness. The inner meaning of the term is that the actor is in fact "not" something, yet believes themselves to be that thing. Here "is" can be translated as correct, successful, noble, perfect, or any other affirmative evaluation. In short, the mindset "I am good, you (all) are bad" is the mentality of a person who is actually not very good yet considers themselves important. Having an excessively high self-evaluation and then using it as a basis for showing off, arguing, or rejecting others' correct opinions is the behavioral pattern most likely to provoke disgust.

## 2. Displeased Disgust

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-34]

### 2. [Expression Description]

- ① Obvious brow-furrowing action (brow wrinkles) together with twisting of the inner one-third of both brows, brows raised upward; combined with eyelid morphology this is judged not to be fear and constitutes a necessary feature of sadness emotion;
- ② Upper eyelids pressed downward under the action of the orbicularis oculi, almost covering the upper half of the iris and remaining above the pupil. Because this is not natural drooping but forced closure to this position, it is not vacant staring; combined with the downward pressure of the brows it is judged to be a typical form of disgust expression;
- ③ Orbicularis oris shows slight contraction; the lips are not completely relaxed but slightly pursed outward, to a very small degree, while the mentalis also shows a coordinating action, indicating self-restraint and refusal to express one's own viewpoint.

### Summary:

The morphology of the brows and the forced closure of the eyelids express displeased (displeasure belongs to the sadness category) disgust, primarily unhappiness (denial), using an ignoring gaze (appearing vacant) to indicate unconcerned contempt (belonging to disgust), forming a contradiction with the tightened brows; the slight restraining morphology of the mouth expresses an inner state of bearing pressure, reinforcing the expression of disgust emotion through silence. This indicates that the inner disgust is very strong, yet cannot be fully expressed through obvious facial expressions. The absence of necessary anger features also means the absence of external manifestations of offensive desire, so this is not anger.

### Interesting Case

#### Returned Overseas Subordinate Sneering at Director's Dialect Accent

If you encounter an extremely foolish person (in your own estimation), and that person still overestimates their ability to challenge you, yet you believe you possess the instantaneous capacity to handle them, and because the disparity in strength between you is excessively large, you will display this disdainful expression. If the other party is serious and earnest, your expression may remain merely disdainful; yet if the other party attempts some clumsy and foolish action (movement or speech), you will involuntarily reveal a sneering expression.

Once, during a meeting with mid-level managers of an IT company, everyone was discussing improvement plans for an internet application product. Because the design plan involved a large number of English terms, everyone was mixing Chinese and English while speaking. When the technical director of the development

department explained with a noticeable dialect accent, I noticed a very slight sneering expression flash across the face of one of his subordinates.

The director was recognized within the company as an expert in development experience and technical ability, so it could be judged that this sneer was certainly not directed at the modification plan. After the meeting I asked the director whether XXX had studied abroad; he gave an affirmative reply.

This confirmed that the previous judgment was correct: the subordinate's disdainful smile had been triggered by the director's non-standard English pronunciation. Because the subordinate was very pleased with their own English pronunciation, they involuntarily revealed their inner emotion.

#### **Interesting Case: Returned Overseas Subordinate Sneering at Director's Dialect Accent**

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#### **5.3.5 Micro-Expression Morphological Features of Disgust**

Disgust, contempt, disdain, and sneering all belong to disgust emotions of varying intensity. All facial expressions of disgust emotions share one identical characteristic morphology: elevation of the upper lip, with the alae nasi also elevated and grooves appearing on either side of the alae nasi. The differences lie in the degree of muscle movement and the degree of coordination with other facial organs.

The nose plays a less important role in other expressions, yet becomes a typical indicator when disgust emotion arises. When no other obvious changes occur on the face, simultaneous changes in nasal morphology and the appearance of grooves on either side of the alae nasi allow us to easily judge the presence of disgust through this feature, even if the upper-lip action is obscured. As shown in Figure 5-16.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-16]*

Therefore, **the micro-expression morphological feature of disgust**, that is, the necessary feature of the disgust expression, is the movement of the levator labii superioris and the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi.

Visually this appears as upper-lip elevation with nasolabial folds on either side of the alae nasi. Under effective stimulation, if such a feature appears on the tested person's face, it can be concluded that disgust emotion has arisen within them. The fundamental meaning of disgust emotion is negation.

## Chapter 5 Micro-expressions of Disgust

If the nature of the effective stimulus is negative, and after an instant of surprise the person develops ideas of rejection and withdrawal, disgust will arise. Contempt and disdain are also derivatives of disgust-type emotions.

When you see the word "disgust," the classic expression immediately forms in your mind: eyes narrowed (signaling "don't look"), nose wrinkled (signaling "don't smell"), corners of the mouth pulled back, and possibly the tongue extended (signaling "don't eat"). This is correct; the original source of disgust is rejection of spoiled food.

Because ancient ancestors who ate spoiled food suffered severe physical discomfort, vomiting, illness, or even death, they instinctively rejected such items upon seeing, smelling, or tasting them—an evolutionary survival skill.

Interestingly, although modern people have a strong understanding of food safety and rarely encounter actual spoiled food, they still produce the same expression when confronted with people or situations they find distasteful—for example, obsequious but incompetent officials or ignorant and arrogant playboys—as if those people or things carried the odor or taste of decay.

### Disgust

Disgust is a common expression. When people encounter something inconsistent with their cultural or moral environment or receive negative news, they display a disgusted expression. This is the outward manifestation of an inner resistance to something they dislike.

When disgust intensifies to the point that the emotion cannot be resolved internally, it transforms into anger, and an angry expression appears on the face. Psychologically, anger arises from dissatisfaction caused by external obstacles, delays, offenses, or self-punishment, which then develops into anger. An angry person's brows furrow, the nostrils flare, and the person may also clench the fists or display other body language.

### Test Case: Gory Visual Stimuli

Producing such an intense disgust expression requires a stimulus of very high intensity. Simple question or verbal stimuli rarely achieve this effect. In our experiments, only the video *Forensic Autopsy Demonstration* and certain gory post-disaster corpse photographs elicited disgust expressions approaching this level in participants.

This expression closely resembles the pain expression. The subtle difference is that in disgust the upper lip is raised higher and the nasolabial folds on either side of the nose are deeper. This may occur because viewing such distressing visual information triggers an instinctive self-protective aversion rather than actual pain.

#### 5.2.2 Full Disgust Expression

The muscle movements recruited by the physiological need to vomit form the primitive shape of the disgust expression, as shown in Figure 5-3.

On the basis of the primitive vomiting expression, the extreme disgust expression adds tightly closed lips while the eyes and eyebrows remain essentially unchanged. The expression appears to be a reaction to a foul odor that is steadily approaching: eyes closed to avoid seeing, nose wrinkled to avoid smelling, lips sealed to avoid tasting—strictly preventing any offensive information from entering the body.

Common expressions of disgust, contempt, and disdain each contain one or more of these facial features, differing only in number and degree.

### **Fine Lines Around the Nose and the Expression of Sniffing “Something Smelly”**

The key feature of the “disgust” expression lies in the “fine lines around the nose.” The face shows actions such as “wrinkling the nose” or “raising the upper lip,” or both features appear together. “Disgust” encompasses negative emotions such as aversion, rejection, and dislike. The pathway of the “disgust” expression can be described as the action of blocking an unpleasant smell (wrinkling the nose). However, “disgust” is not merely a physical phenomenon of shutting out an unpleasant odor; the same expression appears toward a disliked person or an unwelcome statement. In evolutionary biology, the “disgust” expression functions as a warning signal to nearby companions about the presence of spoiled food.

### **Disgust**

Disgust is a negative emotion that is difficult to reverse, yet it is necessary to determine exactly what the other person finds disgusting. If the person is disgusted by you, your efforts may be wasted. You must find ways to reverse the disgust, first establishing rapport and then continuing the conversation. If the stimulus for the other person’s disgust is something or someone else, the situation is much easier to handle. You can ask whether they have encountered something unreasonable and, if appropriate, offer to listen. While they are speaking, do not interrupt; wait until they finish before offering your own views.

### **3. Summary of the Meaning of Disgust Expressions**

Whether it is profound disgust or rejecting contempt, the core is an attempt to expel something disliked. Therefore the actions center on the nose and mouth and are usually accompanied by brow furrowing, jointly expressing the instinctive desire not to see, smell, or taste.

Disdain, however, is slightly different. It merely conveys a sense of looking down on someone and a strong feeling of superiority, without any desire to reject. Because the mindset is relatively relaxed, disdain is often accompanied by an incomplete smile with one corner of the mouth raised.

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## Analysis

Based on the baseline state (smiling appearance) and the reaction to homogeneous questions in the micro-reaction (微反应) psychological test, the expression that appeared when the subject answered whether they minded their overweight figure indicates that they do mind. The reply "There's nothing I can do about it" expresses both non-acceptance of their figure and a sense of helplessness, consistent with the expression. "Just let it be" continues the helpless message while adding a slight tendency toward "not minding much."

### 1. Morphological Features of Disgust Micro-expressions

The morphological features of disgust micro-expressions—that is, the necessary features of the disgust expression—are the actions of the levator labii superioris and the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi muscles. Visually, the upper lip is raised and the nasolabial folds appear on either side of the nose, as shown in Figure 5-17.

When an effective stimulus is present, if the subject displays these features, it can be concluded that disgust has arisen internally. The fundamental meaning of disgust is negation.

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When an effective stimulus is present, if the subject displays these features, it can be concluded that disgust has arisen internally. The fundamental meaning of disgust is negation.

### 5.3 Morphological Features of Disgust Micro-expressions

In everyday interpersonal communication, such exaggerated external displays are rare unless deliberately performed for others. Most disgust expressions triggered by genuine emotion retain only part of the structural morphology of the vomiting expression, yet are considerably milder than actual vomiting. Different degrees of disgust manifest in different expression morphologies.

#### 11.2.2 Disgust

After evaluating the stimulus source, the individual judges it to be negative, generating a feeling of annoyance and an impulse to withdraw, yet without any desire to change or eliminate the stimulus source. This emotion is expressed as a disgust expression.

The most primitive stimulus source for disgust is spoiled food.

### 5.2 Full Disgust Expression

A classic line from a Stephen Chow film states: "Vomit, keep vomiting, and you'll get used to it." When a person feels extreme aversion toward someone or something, the body produces a reaction similar to vomiting, as though invaded by the smell or taste of decay.

See The seven basic emotions (c-seven-emotions).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

## Contempt

### The Case of the Sneer

There is a particularly interesting case involving sneering. A university once conducted a survey asking whether respondents could accept having a boyfriend or girlfriend who was overweight. Some participants stated outright that they could not accept it, while others, out of politeness, said they could consider it. One student was especially typical: when asked if he would mind his girlfriend being overweight, he said he would not mind and displayed an expression resembling a smile. Many were deceived by his expression; it was not a smile at all but a sneer. His mouth showed clear left-right asymmetry, with slight fine lines on the lower eyelids. When he raised the corners of his mouth, it was accompanied by a quick exhalation, somewhat like a “humph.” This was a clear sneer, indicating that he fundamentally looked down on overweight people and would never choose an overweight girl as a girlfriend.

Here it is worth reminding those who feel insecure about certain aspects of themselves not to be deceived by others and not to belittle themselves unnecessarily. Recognizing both oneself and others is equally important. To change the status quo, one must work to improve oneself—at minimum by enriching one’s inner qualities and strengthening one’s advantages.

The micro-expressions of the seven basic emotions reach their conclusion here. The knowledge provided only teaches some basic skills and should not be relied upon completely. If you wish to become a true micro-expression researcher, much more knowledge must be acquired, many more books must be read, and—most importantly—extensive practice is required. Many experts in micro-expressions examine hundreds or thousands of photographs and video clips daily to capture more accurate expression signals. Never experiment widely after learning only the basics; the results may not be effective or accurate. Inaccurate results can lead to embarrassment and trouble. Therefore, use micro-expression knowledge with caution. Let it serve as a tool for self-protection rather than a weapon for attacking or harming others.

### Facial Features of Contempt

- **Eyebrows:** Due to contraction of the corrugator supercilii, the eyebrows furrow and are pulled downward by the orbicularis oculi, just as in disgust.
- **Eyes:** The orbicularis oculi contracts, causing the eyes to close slightly.
- **Mouth:** Contraction of the levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi raises the upper lip, forming the nasolabial fold. The lower lip shows no obvious change. The mouth in contempt may be closed or slightly open.

This expression is commonly seen when we observe comical figures, such as certain internet celebrities. We feel contempt not only for their appearance but also for their self-promotion tactics.

The expression of disdain is much milder than contempt. The eyebrows remain relaxed without furrowing or downward pull, and the eyes show little obvious change—only a clear nasolabial fold, a slightly raised upper lip, and partial exposure of the upper teeth. Because the person feels extreme disregard and a sense of superiority, a smile appears, causing the corners of the mouth to lift slightly. If the lift is more pronounced, it becomes a sneer. A clear feature of a sneer is the asymmetry of the mouth. However, the eyes do change: as

the smile widens, the orbicularis oculi contracts, though only mildly, producing slight wrinkles on the lower eyelids.

### **Contempt**

Many psychologists regard contempt as a derivative of disgust or as mild disgust. Contempt nevertheless merits separate discussion because it occurs more frequently than disgust.

Contempt is likewise triggered by negative stimuli, yet the intensity is low and poses no threat to the individual. The person considers the stimulus unworthy of expending energy to confront, because the other party is perceived as far inferior.

Mild contempt manifests as disdain. Disdain is complete disregard—a dismissal that places the other person on an entirely different, lower level, not even worth a glance. Because the other is wholly beneath notice, the mind treats them as insignificant, generating a sense of ease that produces a smile: a cold smile or a sneer.

For example, if you represent one of the world's top one hundred companies and the opposing representative comes from a firm of only thirty employees, and both of you are competing for the same client, the disparity in strength leads you to look down on the opponent and disbelieve they could possibly win the client—hence the disdain. If the opponent refuses to yield and then embarrasses themselves, you may laugh: that is a sneer.

### **Contempt**

If the other person directs contempt toward you, the best response is to withdraw, because this negative emotion is difficult to reverse. Once the person is fixed in this attitude, even the best suggestions will be futile and will not leave a deep impression. At such moments, it is advisable to avoid direct conversation and instead have someone else convey your suggestions and views; this is far more effective than speaking directly.

If the contempt concerns an unrelated matter, there is no need for concern; it will not affect the outcome of your exchange. If the person says, for instance, "That was really foolish of him," they are seeking your agreement. You may offer a few words of concurrence to satisfy their psychological need; this will facilitate further communication.

### **Be Careful with the Unilaterally Upward-Curving Corner of the Mouth**

The key feature of the "contempt" expression is the "unilateral upward lift of the mouth corner"; among the seven basic expressions, it is the only one that is not left-right symmetrical. "Contempt" encompasses negative emotions such as superiority, disdain, and a cold attitude (cold smile). It appears when one feels superior in experience or knowledge to others or observes another's immoral behavior. Individuals who display the "contempt" micro-expression tend to criticize others in daily life and generally hold negative views of others. The "contempt" expression does not appear on infants' faces; it emerges only when a person begins comparing themselves with others. "Contempt" is the expression signal that arises when one feels the need to evaluate or judge another.

### **3. Cold Smile, Sneer (Contemptuous Smile)**

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-26]*



1. One side of the upper lip is raised, exposing the upper teeth, with nasolabial folds forming on both sides of the nose (disgust feature);
2. One corner of the mouth is noticeably lifted, with one cheek raised (smile feature);
3. The eyelids are closed, yet the lower eyelids show no bulging or tightening, and no smile lines appear beneath them (denial of genuine smile feature).

**Summary:** This confirms the emotion of disgust (contempt or disdain). Because the eye features are absent, the smile is insincere; the upturned mouth corner reveals an inner sense of superiority toward the disgust-eliciting stimulus rather than genuine pleasure—it is a look of utter disregard.

See Varieties of smiles and microexpressions (s-smile-varieties).

## Surprise

### 4.2.1 Physiological Significance of the Surprise Expression

Why does the face make these specific muscle movements to express inner surprise at the very first instant of an unexpected stimulus? Breaking it down point by point makes the reason clear.

1. The frontalis muscle contracts fully, raising the eyebrows significantly;
2. The levator palpebrae superioris muscle contracts; together with the frontalis, it lifts the upper eyelid substantially, widening the eyes and exposing the sclera above the upper edge of the iris, as shown in Figure 4-3;

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-3]

The combined contraction of the frontalis and levator palpebrae superioris opens the eyes wide. “Eyes opened wide” literally refers to an increase in the gap between the eyelids (technically called the “palpebral fissure”), but it actually implies greater exposure of the eyeball. A full expression of surprise matches this implication, even revealing the sclera above the iris. When relaxed, a person’s upper eyelid normally covers about one-quarter of the upper edge of the iris.

Opening the eyes this wide is an instinctive response to admit more light. In darkness (or a low-light environment) before the eyes have adapted, a person naturally opens the eyes wide rather than squinting as they would in bright conditions.

Thus, widening the eyes serves to see more clearly and gather as much visual information as possible, helping the individual assess the nature and potential impact of the stimulus source. The raising of the eyebrows is a secondary result: the frontalis is recruited to help open the eyes maximally. Using only the levator palpebrae superioris to lift the upper lid is both strenuous and less effective. You can test this yourself: while keeping the eyebrows still, try to open your eyes as wide as possible; you will feel the urge to raise the brows. Coordinated contraction of the frontalis makes the action easier and more efficient.

3. The mouth opens involuntarily, accompanied by a quick inhalation; only the lower lip drops slightly under the pull of the jaw (mandible), without tightening the lip surface or stretching it sideways, as shown in Figure 4-4.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-4]

At the instant of an unexpected stimulus, a person cannot yet determine whether the source is benign or dangerous. Evolutionary experience dictates that the first step is to inhale and store energy. After the brief moment of surprise (the assessment phase), if the stimulus is negative, the person will flee or fight—actions that demand substantial physical energy. Even if outwardly still, the rapid mental processing belongs to the derived escape or combat response (figuring out how to cope). If the stimulus is positive, the person may calmly resume the prior state or rush forward with cheers and excitement, expressing delight (pleasant surprise).

The mouth movement exists solely to draw in more air, preparing the body for the energy required in the next action of fleeing or fighting.

Therefore, the mouth change does not involve stretching the lips or surrounding muscles; such effortful actions do not occur in surprise. Only the jaw drops downward intentionally (in the direction favored by gravity, which is economical), opening the mouth for a rapid inhalation.

Darwin explained why the mouth drops open in surprise. When we suddenly notice something, he wrote, “the other organs of the body (such as the muscles) are forgotten and neglected”; the weight of the jaw causes it to drop, opening the mouth. This also supplies air for the shock, preparing for “flight from danger.”

Although this conjecture can now be refuted—because the jaw does not automatically drop when a person is fully unconscious—the skeletal and muscular structure of the jaws shows that opening the mouth is certainly a voluntary movement. Nevertheless, Darwin’s line of reasoning remains highly illuminating, and his attention to such minute expressive details more than a century ago still commands admiration for his scientific acuity.

You can also test this yourself: inhale rapidly through the nose only. If you pay close attention, you will notice that rapid nasal inhalation without opening the mouth requires considerable contraction of muscles near the throat—an awkward action, as shown in Figure 4-5. Hence, breathing through the mouth during surprise is the least costly and most efficient way to store energy.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-5]*

#### 4. The rest of the body remains motionless;

One purpose of stillness is to avoid unnecessary energy expenditure; the second is to assess the situation before acting. Moving randomly while the facts are unclear can lead to serious errors and place oneself in danger. This too is an evolutionary adaptation paid for with blood and lives in the wild, where the strong prey on the weak.

#### 5. The interval from the onset of facial muscle contraction to maximum contraction is very brief; the true inner moment of surprise lasts only about one-quarter of a second.

The reason surprise emotion and expression are so short-lived was already discussed when explaining the cause of the surprise emotion. For an unexpected stimulus, taking too long to judge its nature and impact (usually a threat) would miss the optimal response window; at best one is mocked for “still not figuring it out,” at worst one encounters danger or loses life. The exaggerated performances seen in Stephen Chow films are merely a way to signal to the audience that the character is surprised; they may also serve a comedic purpose.

### 4.2.1 Physiological Significance of the Surprise Expression

Why does the face make these specific muscle movements to express inner surprise at the very first instant of an unexpected stimulus? Breaking it down point by point makes the reason clear.

- ① The frontalis muscle contracts fully, raising the eyebrows significantly;
- ② The levator palpebrae superioris muscle contracts; together with the frontalis, it lifts the upper eyelid substantially, widening the eyes and exposing the sclera above the upper edge of the iris, as shown in Figure 4-3;

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-3]*

The combined contraction of the frontalis and levator palpebrae superioris opens the eyes wide. "Eyes opened wide" literally refers to an increase in the gap between the eyelids (technically called the "palpebral fissure"), but it actually implies greater exposure of the eyeball. A full expression of surprise matches this implication, even revealing the sclera above the iris. When relaxed, a person's upper eyelid normally covers about one-quarter of the upper edge of the iris.

Opening the eyes this wide is an instinctive response to admit more light. In darkness (or a low-light environment) before the eyes have adapted, a person naturally opens the eyes wide rather than squinting as they would in bright conditions.

Thus, widening the eyes serves to see more clearly and gather as much visual information as possible, helping the individual assess the nature and potential impact of the stimulus source. The raising of the eyebrows is a secondary result: the frontalis is recruited to help open the eyes maximally. Using only the levator palpebrae superioris to lift the upper lid is both strenuous and less effective. You can test this yourself: while keeping the eyebrows still, try to open your eyes as wide as possible; you will feel the urge to raise the brows. Coordinated contraction of the frontalis makes the action easier and more efficient.

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At the instant of an unexpected stimulus, a person cannot yet determine whether the source is benign or dangerous. Evolutionary experience dictates that the first step is to inhale and store energy. After the brief moment of surprise (the assessment phase), if the stimulus is negative, the person will flee or fight—actions that demand substantial physical energy. Even if outwardly still, the rapid mental processing belongs to the derived escape or combat response (figuring out how to cope). If the stimulus is positive, the person may calmly resume the prior state or rush forward with cheers and excitement, expressing delight (pleasant surprise).

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④ The rest of the body remains motionless;

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#### 4.1 Generation of the Surprise Emotion (9787554606841)

For animals, when everything is normal they go about their business at leisure. But when they sense any disturbance, they immediately use their acute sensory organs to integrate sounds, sights, smells, and even air movements to assess possible dangers in the environment. They stop all activity at once, raise their heads (because most sensory organs are concentrated there), and use eyes, nose, ears, and every hair on the body to evaluate a large amount of information in an instant:

- What is happening? Is there danger?
- What is the source of the danger?
- How many are there?
- How fast are they moving?
- How far away are they?
- Can our group guarantee our safety?
- Should we flee or fight?
- Which direction offers escape?
- .....

All these questions must be answered in roughly one second; otherwise life may be lost. Why is the reaction window so brief? Because in one second a cheetah running at full speed can close 35 meters—longer than the entire length of a basketball court (28 meters). If surprise lasted longer, the outcome would be predictable.

Through generations of evolution, humans have retained this same instinctive response.

Upon sensing an unexpected stimulus, a person stops all activity, fully activates every sensory organ, and strives to gather as much information as possible to decide the next action.

Although the interval is short, it is critical. In addition to the facial expression, the entire body coordinates to maintain intense concentration and rapid mental processing. Because the task is demanding, that brief instant consumes the full resources of the nervous system. The high level of neural focus and expenditure causes other bodily movements to decrease sharply or cease. On one hand, the nervous system has no attention to spare (it issues no commands to move), and extra movement would add to its load; on the other hand, remaining still allows assessment before action—unnecessary movement could bring disaster while the situation is still unclear. (See the book *Micro-reactions* (微反应) for details.)

The stimulus that triggers surprise emotion is relatively simple: an unexpected change that matters to the individual.

“Unexpected” means the change was not anticipated, either by conscious thought or by unconscious expectations. The stimulus may suddenly appear or disappear, shift from stillness to motion, or change from noise to silence—any of these can be directly perceived.

However, stimuli that produce a clear expression are usually those the person cares about, so their impact is strong. A windfall and a sudden calamity both trigger the same initial surprise expression, which later develops into delight or terror respectively. If the unexpected event has no meaningful consequence—for example, an unrelated stranger rounding a street corner (literally an “unexpected” encounter)—it will not affect the person, who therefore will not care and will not experience surprise. Hence the key point:

A stimulus capable of eliciting surprise must be an unexpected change that matters to the person.

We now turn to the morphological features of the surprise micro-expression.

## 4.2 The Most Surprised Expression

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-1]

If you feel the image contains elements of fear, first note the eyebrows and mouth. The relaxed lip shape and natural (untwisted) eyebrows indicate she is not afraid (fear expressions are covered in Chapter 7). From here, focus solely on the features of surprise.

If the stimulus is strong enough, the fullest surprise expression appears as in Figure 4-2.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-2]

1. The frontalis muscle contracts fully, raising the eyebrows significantly; in older individuals horizontal wrinkles appear on the forehead, while younger people may show a smooth forehead without wrinkles;
2. The levator palpebrae superioris muscle contracts; together with the frontalis, it lifts the upper eyelid substantially, widening the eyes and exposing the sclera above the upper edge of the iris;
3. The mouth opens involuntarily, accompanied by a quick inhalation; only the lower lip drops slightly under the pull of the jaw (mandible), without tightening the lip surface or stretching it sideways;
4. The rest of the body remains motionless;
5. The interval from the onset of facial muscle contraction to maximum contraction is very brief; the true inner moment of surprise lasts only about one-quarter of a second. Once contraction reaches its peak and stops increasing, the genuine surprise emotion has already ended; any remaining facial expression

is consciously produced to communicate surprise to others, usually as a context-appropriate feedback signal ("I'm letting you know I'm surprised").

#### 4.1 The Generation of Surprise Emotion (9789620756689)

For animals, when everything is normal they go about their business in a leisurely manner. But the moment they sense any disturbance, they immediately use their acute sensory organs to integrate judgments based on sound, vision, smell, and even air movement, assessing possible dangers in the surrounding environment. They halt all actions at once, raise their heads (since most sensory organs are concentrated in the head), and use their eyes, noses, ears, and every hair on their bodies to instantly process vast amounts of information:

- What is happening? Is there danger?
- What is the source of the danger?
- How many are there?
- How fast are they moving?
- How far are they from me?
- Can our group ensure my safety?
- Should I flee or fight?
- Which direction offers an escape route?
- ...

All these questions must be answered in roughly one second; otherwise, life may be lost. Why is the reaction window so brief? Because in one second a cheetah running at full speed can close a gap of 35 meters, while a standard basketball court is only 28 meters long. If surprise lasts too long, the outcome is predictable.

Through generations of evolution, humans have retained this same instinctive response.

When an unexpected stimulus is perceived, all actions cease and every sensory organ is fully activated to gather as much information as possible for deciding the next move.

Although the interval is short, it is critical. In addition to facial expressions, the entire body coordinates to maintain intense concentration and rapid processing. Because the task is demanding, the nervous system expends its full capacity in that instant. This high concentration and consumption cause other bodily movements to decrease sharply or stop altogether. On one hand, the nervous system has no spare capacity to issue movement commands, and excess motion would add to its load; on the other hand, the pause allows for deliberate action—unnecessary movements could prove disastrous while the nature of the change remains unclear.

The stimulus that triggers surprise is relatively simple: an unexpected change that matters to the individual.

"Unexpected" means the person had not anticipated it, whether through conscious thought or unconscious expectation. The stimulus may appear suddenly, disappear suddenly, shift from stillness to motion, or change from noise to silence—any of these can be directly perceived.

Yet stimuli that produce clear expressions are usually those the person cares about, so their impact is strong. A windfall and a sudden calamity both elicit the same initial expression of surprise, which then develops into delight or terror respectively. A trivial, inconsequential surprise—for example, encountering an unrelated stranger at a street corner—will not affect the person and therefore will not generate surprise. Hence the principle:

Any stimulus capable of eliciting surprise in a person must be an unexpected change that matters to that person.

We now turn to the morphological features of the micro-expression of surprise.

### Chapter Summary

The essence of surprise is that something unexpected yet relevant has occurred. Surprise registers an unexpected piece of information that matters. In nature, any stimulus worthy of an animal's surprise may bear on survival or reproduction.

Surprise is nevertheless a neutral emotion. It registers only that an unanticipated yet relevant stimulus has arrived; it has not yet evaluated the stimulus's nature or intensity. Consequently, the duration of surprise is very brief—extremely brief. This is the source of the well-known line from *Lie to me*: “Surprise lasting more than one second is fake.” Note, however, that the original dialogue carries the adverbial qualifier “during interrogation.”

During this brief instant the organism's sole task is to gather as much information as possible for the central nervous system to judge, assess, and decide. In the facial expression the eyes widen to increase light intake; humans also raise the eyebrows to help lift the eyelids. In the limbs a freeze response appears, reducing unnecessary small movements so the central nervous system can concentrate. Occasionally a quick inhalation occurs, stocking the body with oxygen for subsequent action.

1. The micro-expression feature of surprise is the raising of the upper eyelid, exposing more of the superior margin of the iris than usual. Once this subtle change appears on an otherwise neutral face, surprise can be identified. Of course, surprise vanishes almost instantly and the face soon returns to baseline.
2. The typical morphology of a full surprise expression is: both eyebrows raised high, eyelids open, eyes widened and attentive, lower jaw relaxed and dropped, mouth parted for a quick, slight inhalation.

After the expression of surprise, the emotion may shift into any of the primary emotions: surprise turning to joy, surprise turning to disgust, surprise turning to anger, surprise turning to fear, or surprise turning to sadness. Surprise is the first reaction upon encountering an effective stimulus.

3. In actual testing, because of resistance and concealment, most people respond to an effective stimulus only by widening the eyes slightly; the mouth may open (a quick inhalation) but no further overt display occurs. Therefore, observing the subsequent emotional reactions after surprise is the correct way to apply the principle of surprise in testing.

**Full surprise—eyebrows and eyes**

**Moderate surprise—eyebrows and eyes**

**Slight surprise—eyebrows and eyes**

In testing, the appearance of surprise is a valuable analytical clue, because it arises from an unexpected stimulus that matters to the subject. Hence **surprise = effective stimulus**.

When using the principle of surprise emotion and expression in psychological testing, the following points should be observed:

- Design questions in advance as stimuli. Based on topics the subject is likely to care about, prepare questions or related facts the subject does not know but the examiner does, and present them at unexpected moments.
- Once a surprise expression appears, the matter has analytical value; the fuller the expression, the greater the value of the stimulus.

If the stimulus is negative, what elicits disgust? Foul odors, ugliness, and anything the person rejects can produce disgust.

covertly recorded 20 subjects under ordinary unexpected (non-threatening) stimuli using PAL video. The average duration of genuine surprise—defined as maximum muscle contraction and maximum change in facial features—was 6 frames; standard PAL video contains 25 frames per second.

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### Full surprise—eyebrows and eyes

### Moderate surprise—eyebrows and eyes



## Slight surprise—eyebrows and eyes

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-18]

In testing, the appearance of surprise is a valuable analytical clue, because it arises from an unexpected stimulus that matters to the subject. Hence surprise = effective stimulus.

When using the principle of surprise emotion and expression in psychological testing, the following points should be observed:

- Design questions in advance as stimuli. Based on topics the subject is likely to care about, prepare questions or related facts the subject does not know but the examiner does, and present them at unexpected moments.
- Once a surprise expression appears, the matter has analytical value; the fuller the expression, the greater the value of the stimulus.

If the stimulus is negative, what elicits disgust? Foul odors, ugliness, and anything the person rejects can produce disgust.

## Surprise

Consider the following exchange:

A: Someone in the department passed away.

B: What? (head snaps up, eyes widen, mouth slightly open) Wasn't he under thirty?

This is the emotion of surprise—the immediate reaction upon receiving unexpected information. It contains many rapid thoughts: Is it true? What happened? Illness or accident? What should I do? Will this affect my work? Will the company hire someone new? Surprise quickly evolves into other emotions—regret, worry, sadness.

The classic expression—head raised quickly, eyes widened, mouth slightly parted—is shared by humans and animals. Anyone who has observed a dog attentively will notice that at the slightest sound outside the door the dog lifts its head, pricks its ears, and turns them toward the source to determine whether the sound poses a threat to itself or its owner.

In nature, the first sign of danger causes animals to freeze, raise their heads, and mobilize every available sense—smell, sound, sight—to gather information. They stand and lift their heads because most sensory organs are located there, allowing them to see farther and hear more clearly. Is there danger? Where is it coming from? Are there many? How long until they reach here? Is this place safe? Where would be safer? Can we win a fight?

All this information must be processed within one second; hence surprise lasts only about one second. Any longer and escape might be impossible. To preserve life and territory, a response must be formed quickly.

Humans are no different. In primitive societies hunting was the primary means of survival; failure to react swiftly could mean becoming prey. Over time this became an instinctive response: when an abrupt stimulus arrives, all activity stops, the head lifts, attention turns to the source, and a coping strategy is rapidly formulated.

With social progress, full surprise has given rise to many variants. People can display surprise without raising the head or even while facing away from the stimulus, because the mortal threat once posed by wild beasts no longer exists. Danger has diminished and sensitivity to stimuli has correspondingly decreased.

Like animals, human surprise expressions are very brief—under one second. More precisely, a genuine surprise expression lasts only a quarter of a second. Anything longer indicates the person is deliberately allowing time for others to notice, yet even then the expression rarely exceeds one second. Because the interval is short and the information load heavy, all senses are mobilized to assist cognition. The sudden energy demand causes the nervous system to reduce other movements so that resources can be redirected to the brain. The freeze also buys a moment to assess whether the stimulus will affect the individual and what action should follow.

### **Variations in the Degree of Surprise**

Full surprise is easy to recognize, yet in contemporary society—except in moments of great joy or grief—it is rarely seen. People habitually mask their true feelings, fearing that overt display will be read at once. Consequently, surprise expressions are often attenuated. Another important factor is the abundance of modern information; few events now produce genuine astonishment.

The surprise most commonly observed in daily life is slight or moderate.

During a tender meeting, the marketing directors of three companies were competing. The director from Company A took a call. After listening for only a few seconds his eyebrows lifted, eyes widened, and mouth closed—an expression that lasted one second. He then glanced at the director from Company B before returning to normal. This was a slight surprise expression, indicating he had heard startling news; the glance at Company B's director showed the news concerned that company. Shortly after hanging up, Company A's director requested the tender committee investigate Company B, citing a report that B had illegally obtained other companies' bid prices. At that moment the tender-committee representatives and Company C's director displayed raised eyebrows, widened eyes, and slightly parted mouths—moderate surprise.

In a public setting a full surprise expression would be inappropriate. Company A's director kept his lips closed to avoid revealing emotion, yet the eyebrow lift and eye widening still occurred involuntarily, and he glanced at Company B's director. The tender-committee representatives and Company C's director showed moderate surprise because they had no need to conceal it. Their mouths, however, were only slightly open, indicating the stimulus was not especially strong; they were already somewhat inured to such matters. The degree of mouth opening is therefore proportional to the intensity of surprise. The same holds for changes in the eyebrows and eyes. In moderate surprise the raising of the brows and widening of the eyes remain noticeable. In slight surprise the brow change becomes subtle or invisible; only the upper eyelid lifts, producing a very small widening of the eyes. This expression shows the person is actively suppressing surprise or that the stimulus itself is weak.

From these observations we reach the following conclusion: the micro-expression feature of surprise is the raising of the upper eyelid. This change occurs across the entire spectrum from full to slight surprise and is the only consistent movement. During surprise the eyebrows may not rise and the mouth may not open, but the upper eyelid always lifts. At the same time inhalation occurs, though when the mouth remains closed the nose performs the quick intake. The amplitude may be small, yet an inhalation is always present.

#### **4.3.2 Morphological Features of Surprise Micro-expressions**

After the progressive reductions described in the previous section, we can see that even without participation of mouth morphology, or even without participation of eyebrow morphology, an inner state of surprise can still be expressed through elevation of the upper eyelids. We therefore specifically propose the morphological features of surprise micro-expressions; the more formal term is the “necessary morphological features” of a surprise expression (this term will be used in later passages that require rigorous discussion).

Necessary morphological features refer to the facial morphological characteristics that must not be absent from an expression.

For example, among all facial morphologies of a surprise expression, the eyebrows may not rise, the mouth may not open, yet the eyelids must lift, and at the instant the eyelids open wide there must be a simultaneous whole-body stillness; the inhalation action is performed by the nose, its amplitude may be difficult to observe, yet an inhalation tendency is certainly present. These necessary morphological features that constitute a surprise expression are the micro-expression indicators for judging that a person has experienced surprise emotion.

This section is very important for micro-expression research. We summarize the necessary morphological features of a surprise expression as follows:

1. Contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris muscle, elevation of the upper eyelids, and exposure of a larger portion of the iris than in the normal state, as shown in Figure 4-12.
2. At the same time the upper eyelids are raised, the entire body performs no other movement and exhibits an instantaneous pause. Without this instantaneous pause, the expression cannot be identified as surprise; it may instead indicate an offensive tendency of anger or an avoidant tendency of fear.
3. Although difficult to observe, during surprise there is an inhalation action, or merely an inhalation tendency. Therefore, failure to detect an inhalation action does not negate the presence of surprise, because it may simply be unobservable; however, detection of the opposite action—exhalation—confirms that the expression is not surprise and is more likely anger.

## **Calm face**

### **Necessary features of surprise (minimal features)**

Such minute changes are, on the whole, essentially impassive; if the stimulus source is not insufficient in intensity, one must admire the subject’s restraint and composure.

The last time I attended a friend’s wedding, several classmates sat around a table discussing the current situations of various prominent figures from our old class, everyone talking animatedly. During the conversation I noticed two situations that commonly elicit surprise micro-expressions: one is when an erstwhile romantic expert from those years has still not married; the other is when someone has unexpectedly divorced.

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#### 4.3.1 Common Surprise Expressions in Daily Life

In real life, more surprise expressions involve only partial facial muscle morphology.

The first type is surprise without mouth involvement, as shown in Figure 4-6:

- ① The eyebrows are not raised as high, and the eyes are not opened as wide. Yet compared with the normal state, the eyebrows are indeed raised and the eyes are indeed opened wider, as shown in Figure 4-7;

Normal-state eyebrow-eye combination

Medium-surprise eyebrow-eye combination

- ② Mouth movements may be very small (a very slight parting) or even absent. Yet if the lips do not part, they must coordinate with a nasal inhalation action; of course the inhalation force is insufficient to produce visible tension and contraction of the neck muscles, as shown in Figure 4-8.

Full-surprise mouth

Medium-surprise mouth

The second type is surprise in which even eyebrow elevation is almost invisible, leaving only upper-eyelid elevation, as shown in Figure 4-9:

Relaxed face

Slight-surprise face

① Only upper-eyelid elevation remains. Subjective control or insufficient stimulus intensity may cause the eyebrows to show no obvious elevation change, as shown in Figure 4-10;

Full-surprise eyebrows and eyes

Medium-surprise eyebrows and eyes

Slight-surprise eyebrows and eyes

② Conversely, if only the eyebrows are raised while the eyelids remain still, the expression appears vacant, as shown in Figure 4-11. Such morphology can be confirmed as not an expression of surprise emotion.

#### 4.4.2 Surprise Turning into Disgust

As shown in Figure 4-14, careful observation of the upper-eyelid morphology reveals a clear break in the upper-eyelid line under the pressure of the eyebrows. Without this straight line the eyelids would rise high and expose much of the iris. This micro-expression morphological feature proves the presence of surprise.

The most direct scenario that could produce the expression in the figure is probably: hearing for the first time that a friend's beloved dog has fallen ill and is covered in lice all over its body.

The typical features of disgust are furrowed brows plus a deepened nasolabial fold; once these morphological features are added to surprise, the expression in the figure appears. Of course, in actual life the transition from surprise to disgust is not as obvious as in Figure 4-14.

#### Test Case

Successful but family-disliked paranoid woman

In one actual test the subject was a public-interest figure who had received social attention and many awards and accolades, yet maintained deep conflicts with her own family, including spouse, children, and elders; the family felt great worry and disgust toward her. Background analysis and investigation revealed that this pattern was related to her childhood experience of parental divorce and subsequent upbringing by her paternal grandparents. Her behavioral mode was extreme paranoia: whatever she decided to do, she would not listen to others' opinions, and whoever offered an opinion became an enemy.

The subject had long been on guard or resistant toward possible negative evaluations from us. When we gradually brought the conversation to the relationship between her upbringing and her current problems, we posed the question: "Have your parents already divorced? How old were you then?"

From video playback we observed that the subject's body paused very noticeably, yet her facial surprise expression was not full and was almost imperceptible to the naked eye, showing only a slight elevation of the upper eyelids. Immediately afterward she furrowed both brows tightly, her face became as still as water, and she displayed serious concern about the question; judging from the nostrils flared to the sides and the slight

grooves beside the nasal wings, the emotion following surprise was disgust. We surmised that her inner script at that moment was “Hmm?!” (How do you know? Why ask this question?)

### **Eyes Wide Open—Does It Represent “Surprise” or “Concern”?**

After discussing the “concentrated” face, we turn to the “information-gathering” face of conversational messages. Actions such as “both eyebrows raised,” “eyes wide open,” and “mouth open wide,” whether singly or in combination, express “surprise” in emotional display and “interest/concern” in conversational messages.

Both are mechanisms of information gathering triggered by events in one’s surroundings; I call this category of actions the “information-gathering” face.

Consider the situation in which you yourself display the “information-gathering” face: on a crowded train, swaying, you suddenly hear someone speaking loudly two or three meters ahead. At that moment you turn toward the sound source out of surprise, curious about what has happened, and continue to gaze in the direction of the voice. This is the transition from “surprise” to “interest/concern.”

In this situation the eyebrows first rise and the eyes widen because of “surprise”; then, when the emotion shifts from “surprise” to “concern,” the brain begins to work and converts the emotion into conversational information, so that wide-open eyes become the only remaining facial action.

Next, consider the situation when the conversational partner displays the “information-gathering” face: imagine a negotiation scene in which the other party hides points of interest. At such moments the other party, in order to convey “I’m very interested in this topic!” or “I’m listening to you!”, readily shows raised eyebrows.

This is conversational information. In addition, when you begin to speak on a topic, if the other party shows a momentary raising of the eyebrows, this can be judged as a “surprise” micro-expression. From this “surprise” micro-expression one can detect that the other party wishes to conceal a point of interest.

To distinguish “surprise” micro-expressions from “interest/concern” within conversational messages, duration of facial expression actions, as with the “concentrated” face, is an effective criterion. A “surprise” micro-expression appears only for an instant, whereas conversational messages remain clearly visible for a period of time.

#### **4.4.3 Surprise Turning into Anger**

Looking at this figure, one can immediately recall the common line: “What did you say?!” Note her tightly furrowed brows and wide-open eyes (almost the entire iris exposed); these are the morphological features of a surprise micro-expression. Of course, the raised eyelids are blocked by the lowered brows, covering part of the iris and forming thick eyelid skin folds (the oblique line commonly called “triangular eyes”). The combination of furrowed brows and upper-eyelid elevation constitutes the morphological features of an anger micro-expression.

After a rapid surprise lasting less than one second, the stimulus source is recognized as negative and poses a great threat to the actor’s interests (the core stimulus source of anger; see the chapter on anger), instinctively generating an attack impulse—this is startled anger.

The common life situation that produces startled anger is when a person who possesses a sense of control is provoked, despised, or even threatened by someone under that control.

## Anecdotal Case

Startled-anger speaker at a high-level forum

In 2008 I attended a large high-level Sino-American forum. The main participants from both countries were expert-level figures and foreign-affairs officials with high achievements in their respective fields. The Chinese side sent a vice minister to deliver remarks. During the remarks, however, an unexpected situation occurred—the microphone produced feedback.

From start to finish the feedback lasted no more than six seconds, yet those brief six seconds allowed me to observe a clear sequence of changes on the speaker's face. At the first instant the remarks were interrupted by feedback, the speaker's face showed momentary surprise; apart from the mouth not opening noticeably, the eyebrow and eye movements were complete. Under the continued stimulus of the feedback (duration unmeasured but indeed short), the surprise then turned into furrowed-brow, glaring anger, and the originally relaxed lower face became a clenched, tense state—commonly described as an ashen face. After the feedback subsided, the speaker glanced at the person in charge of conference services, then the facial expression returned to normal and the speaker calmly completed the remarks.

## Chapter 4 Micro-expressions of Surprise

When a person receives an unexpected stimulus, the first emotion produced is surprise. Surprise is fleeting and is quickly followed by a return to normal or conversion into another emotion; the fuller the surprise expression, the greater the intensity of the stimulus source.

Humans and animals share one identical expression—surprise. Upon encountering an unexpected stimulus, a person, in the very first instant—extremely short—of receiving the stimulus information, stops all activity, raises the head, opens the eyes wide, raises the eyebrows, and slightly opens the mouth. Unfortunately, human ears cannot swivel; otherwise we would certainly also observe the ear-raising and turning toward the stimulus source seen in cats, dogs, rabbits, and other animals, listening for every slight sound.

Of course, human intelligence and level of civilization produce many derivatives of the standard surprise expression described above. For example, the classic surprise expression always involves raising the head so as to see farther and more. Humans can produce a surprise expression while maintaining various head postures—lowering the head, tilting the head, or even not turning the head toward the stimulus source (for instance, with the back to the stimulus source). All these derivatives arise because humans can finely grade the risk level of an unexpected stimulus source. Surprise expressions triggered by low-risk unexpected stimuli are almost unrecognizable, yet when the risk level of an unexpected stimulus is assessed as high, the person still reverts to the animal state and produces a complete surprise expression.

Conversely, if surprise expression features are observed on a person's face, one can conclude that the stimulus source was unanticipated, has attracted strong attention, and that the person wishes to gather more information for judgment.

Such a stimulus source is of significant meaning to the actor.

### 4.2.2 Major Surprise in Life

Almost every year we conduct recruitment of new employees. Because formal positions in public institutions are very "precious," résumé submissions have always been numerous. The résumés we receive reflect a full

spectrum of introverted, extroverted, and even boastful types. We pay special attention to applicants whose résumés contain actual cases and descriptions of relevant abilities.

Last year we encountered a fresh female master's graduate whose grades, works, and experience left a deep impression; merely reading the résumé already confirmed her excellence. During the interview, when we raised a discussion topic (not really a question) about a new animation technique used in one of her works, she immediately displayed a classic subtle surprise expression that then turned into a confident smile. This classic expression arose because she had not expected us to examine the résumé so closely (résumé screening is indeed not usually so detailed), to pose such a precise question, and to hit upon her specialty so exactly. After review by the higher department, when the employment notification call was connected, her tone alone made it clear how delighted she was, because a full second passed before she loudly confirmed and expressed thanks. Unfortunately, I was unable to see that instant of surprise expression; it must have been very full.

[1] We conducted covert filming of experimental subjects. Under ordinary unexpected stimuli (no harmful tendency), analysis of PAL-format video data showed that the true duration of surprise (maximum muscle contraction, maximum change in facial organs) for 20 subjects averaged 6 frames, while standard PAL-format video contains 25 frames per second.

### **Facial Expression Analysis**

Eyebrows raised high and upper-eyelid elevation are features of a surprise expression; one second later, upon learning that the outcome far exceeds subjective expectations, the expression turns to joy. An open mouth, upturned corners of the mouth, and deepened nasolabial folds are all signs of a smile.

Spectators watching a ball game often display this expression. When the weaker team ultimately wins, the fans experience brief surprise followed by elation—this is what we commonly call pleasant surprise.

A person who earlier said they could not return for your birthday suddenly appears on your birthday—that is pleasant surprise; someone you thought disliked you suddenly confesses—that is pleasant surprise; receiving a long-desired gift from someone else—that is pleasant surprise; winning a big prize—that is pleasant surprise. Yet sometimes pleasant surprise is not so easy to produce and may backfire.

Still using the birthday example: you meticulously plan a birthday party for a friend and, in order to create a surprise, deliberately create various troubles on that day. Moderate trouble is acceptable, but once you create trouble the friend finds quite troublesome, the plan may fall through. For instance, you pretend to lose a document; you think it unimportant, yet to the friend it represents the fruit of hard work. When the fruit is destroyed, the first emotion produced is anger. Even if you later tell the friend that the document was not lost and that it was only a well-intentioned joke, the friend will probably not appreciate it. If pleasant surprise is mishandled, it can easily become fright without delight.

Therefore, if you wish to surprise someone, you must understand that person's personality preferences, work style, and psychological needs; never make the self-righteous mistake that turns a pleasant surprise into a fright.

#### **4.4.4 Surprise Turning into Fear**

After a rapid surprise lasting less than 1 second, discovering that the stimulus source poses an overwhelming threat that could directly cause significant harm to the actor's safety results in panic, as shown in Figure 4-16.



We have known since childhood that snakes are terrifying animals—sinister, vicious, and quick-moving, with snakebites being very serious. Therefore, upon suddenly spotting a thick, long snake on the beam or under the bed, one first stares intently (surprise), then quickly retreats and flees in panic (possibly knocking over several pieces of furniture), with the facial expression stemming from deep-seated fear.

In addition to facing stimuli that may cause natural harm, people also experience panic in another type of situation.

Having previously engaged in illegal or criminal acts or violated other social norms (morals), at the moment of exposure, when the actor confirms that their actions have been discovered by others and that severe punishment will inevitably follow, panic arises. Company financial personnel who violate company regulations and relevant laws by embezzling public funds to speculate in stocks or buy lottery tickets for personal gain are frequently reported in the news. Such matters are feared to be known by others; if the money can be replenished and no one insists on pursuing the matter, one might get away with it and quietly amass a fortune. But if losses occur or someone insists on auditing the accounts, at the moment when concealment fails, the individual will experience panic.

### **Test Case**

#### **A Paranoid Woman Who Achieved Career Success but Was Not Loved by Her Family**

In one actual test, the subject was a public-interest figure who had received social attention and won many awards and accolades, yet deep conflicts existed between her and her family, including her spouse, children, and elders; her family members felt great concern and aversion toward her. Through background analysis and investigation, we found this related to her childhood experience of her parents' divorce and subsequent upbringing by her grandparents. Her behavioral pattern was one of extreme paranoia: whatever she decided to do, she would not listen to others' opinions, and anyone offering an opinion became an enemy.

The subject had long harbored defensiveness or resistance in her heart toward any negative evaluation we might make. As we gradually drew out the connection between her upbringing and her current problems, we posed the question: "Have your parents already divorced? How old were you at the time?"

From video playback, it could be observed that the subject's body froze very noticeably in her reaction, yet the surprised expression on her face was not sufficiently pronounced and was almost imperceptible to the naked eye, showing only a slight lift of the upper eyelids. This was followed by tightly furrowed brows and a somber, water-like expression indicating serious concern about the question. Judging from the nostrils pulled to the sides and the slight grooves on either side of the nasal wings, the emotion following surprise was disgust. We speculated that her inner monologue at that moment was "Huh?!" (How do you know this? Why ask this question?)

### **4.2 The Most Surprised Expression**

If you feel at this moment that this image contains elements of fear, first please note her eyebrows and mouth. Based on her relaxed lip shape and natural eyebrows (not twisted), it can be judged that she is not afraid (see Chapter 7 for the expression of fear). Therefore, next, simply focus fully on the characteristics of surprise.

If the stimulus source is sufficiently strong, the fullest surprised expression should appear as shown in Figure 4-2.

1. The frontalis muscle contracts fully, raising the eyebrows significantly; in older people, horizontal wrinkles appear on the forehead, while in younger people the forehead may remain flat without wrinkles;
  2. The levator palpebrae superioris muscle contracts; together with the contraction of the frontalis, this raises the upper eyelids substantially, widening the eyes and exposing the sclera above the iris;
- ③ The mouth opens involuntarily in coordination with a rapid inhalation; only the lower lip, driven by the chin (mandible), opens naturally and slightly downward, with the skin on the lip surface remaining untightened and not stretched to the sides; ④ Other parts of the body remain motionless; ⑤ From the onset of facial muscle contraction to the point of maximum contraction, the duration is very short; the true moment of inner surprise lasts approximately 1/4 second[1]. Once contraction reaches maximum and ceases to increase further, it indicates that the genuine surprise emotion has already disappeared; the retained facial expression afterward is the actor consciously displaying surprise to the outside world, usually as a contextually appropriate feedback method (I am telling you, I am very surprised).

#### 4.2.2 Major Surprises in Life

We conduct recruitment of new employees almost every year. Because formal positions in public institutions are very "precious," applicants have always flocked to them in large numbers. The résumés submitted represent our first contact with candidates; they come in all varieties—introverted, extroverted, and even boastful. We pay special attention to those résumés that include actual cases and descriptions of relevant abilities.

Last year we encountered a fresh female master's graduate whose grades, works, and experience left a deep impression on us; merely reading the résumé was enough to confirm her excellence. During the interview, when we raised a discussion topic (not really a question) about a new animation technique used in her work, she immediately displayed the classic subtle surprised expression, which then turned into a confident smile. This classic expression arose because she had not expected us to examine her work so closely (résumé reviews generally are not this detailed) or to pose such a precise question that aligned so perfectly with her strengths. After review by the superior department, when the hiring notification call came through, her tone alone made it clear how delighted she was, as a full second passed before she loudly confirmed and expressed gratitude. Unfortunately, I was unable to see that instant of surprised expression, but it must have been very full.

#### Fun Case

##### An Angry Speaker at a High-End Forum

In 2008 I attended a large high-end Sino-American thematic forum. The main participants from both countries were expert-level figures and diplomatic officials with high achievements in their respective national fields. The Chinese side sent a vice minister to deliver remarks. However, during the remarks an unexpected situation occurred—the microphone produced feedback due to audio issues.

The feedback lasted no more than 6 seconds from start to finish, yet in those brief 6 seconds I observed a clear sequence of changes on the speaker's face. In the first instant the remarks were interrupted by feedback, the speaker displayed an instantaneous surprised expression; although the mouth did not open noticeably, the movements of the eyebrows and eyes were fully present. Under the continued stimulus of the feedback (duration not statistically measured, but indeed very short), the surprised state then turned into anger with furrowed brows and glaring eyes, and the originally relaxed lower face became a clenched, tense state—

commonly described as a livid face. After the feedback diminished, the speaker glanced at the person in charge of conference affairs, then the expression returned to normal and the remarks were completed as if nothing had happened.

#### **4.4.1 Surprise Turning into Joy**

The raising of the upper eyelids and the full exposure of the sclera above the iris prove the presence of the surprise emotion.

After a rapid surprise lasting less than 1 second, discovering that the stimulus source is positive and of great intensity, capable of producing strong satisfaction and pleasure, results in delight.

Winning a large lottery prize or achieving victory in a thrilling competition will produce the above expression. A common technique in film and television dramas for creating surprise is to first suppress before elevating. On the protagonist's birthday, relatives and friends deliberately create depressing situations—such as not mentioning birthday wishes or manufacturing scenarios that cause the protagonist to become busy, fail, embarrassed, or frustrated—then, when the protagonist is at an emotional low point, they resolve all misunderstandings and hold a grand birthday celebration. As long as the preceding negative stimuli are not excessive, this emotional-stimulation technique can achieve a universally satisfying outcome.

#### **FBI Case**

It is worth noting that if a person's surprised expression lasts longer than 1 second, it must be fake. In an American murder case, the suspect was a young man who disappeared after committing the crime. FBI agents located the suspect's father and asked whether he knew the suspect's whereabouts. The father insisted he had long since severed the father-son relationship and had not been in contact for several years. When the agents mentioned the fact of the suspect's murder, the father produced a classic surprised expression: he stopped what he was doing, turned to face the agent, slightly opened his mouth, widened his eyes, and raised his eyebrows. He intended this expression to tell the agent that he truly had not met the suspect and knew nothing about what the suspect had done. However, his surprised expression lasted far longer than 1 second. The FBI agents determined that the surprised expression was feigned, indicating he had already met the suspect and knew what the suspect had done. As expected, by following the father the agents ultimately located the suspect's hiding place.

#### **Eyebrows Raised, Eyes Widened**

Due to contraction of the frontalis muscle, the eyebrows are raised substantially while contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris raises the upper eyelids, widening both eyes and thereby completing the surprised expression in the upper half of the face.

Widening the eyes exposes more of the eyeball, allowing more light to enter so that the situation can be seen more clearly. In low-light environments, one must work hard to widen the eyes in order to see something clearly. When animals hear any rustling, they raise their heads and widen their eyes to see the stimulus source clearly and assess its potential impact. Humans are the same: widened eyes obtain more and clearer visual information, facilitating judgment and response. The upward raising of the eyebrows assists in widening the eyes, because the levator palpebrae superioris alone cannot open the eyes to the maximum. You can try it yourself: widen your eyes as much as possible without moving your eyebrows. You will find that once the eyes reach the desired degree of widening, the eyebrows must rise.

## Surprise Turning into Disgust

The brows furrow under the action of the corrugator supercilii, and the nasolabial folds deepen—these are characteristics of the disgust expression. The upper eyelids are raised, yet because they encounter the furrowed, downward-pressing brows, slight creases appear on the upper eyelids; this nevertheless remains a characteristic of the surprise expression.

A well-regarded public figure was being interviewed. The reporter had previously asked only official questions, to which the subject responded fluently and with composure. But when the reporter asked, "Did you secretly divorce your wife last month?" the subject paused for less than 1 second; the upper eyelids lifted slightly while the eyebrows and mouth showed no change—this was mild surprise, with the subtext "How did this get out? How do you know?" Quickly the expression changed: the brows furrowed and a slight nasolabial fold appeared, typical of disgust, with the subtext at that moment being "Why ask such a question? I don't want to answer." From this it could be judged that the initial surprise had turned into disgust.

### 4.4 Combinations of Surprise with Other Emotions

Relative to the other five universal expressions, surprise is the "smallest" expression. This smallness refers not only to its shortest duration but also to the fact that surprise itself is a "neutral" emotional response. Happiness is a positive emotional response, while disgust, anger, fear, and sadness are all negative emotional responses; only surprise is an instantaneous judgment process. Therefore, surprise is usually followed by a transition into another emotion. In that brief instant, a person has already determined the nature and intensity of the stimulus source and will immediately produce a corresponding subsequent reaction based on that determination: positive stimuli trigger positive emotions and reactions, negative stimuli trigger corresponding negative emotions and reactions, and the greater the intensity of the stimulus source, the greater the degree of reaction.

Usually, the emotions that immediately follow surprise are joy, disgust, anger, and fear, forming the composite expressions delight, disgust-surprise, anger-surprise, and panic, respectively.

## Surprise

Covering the mouth with the hand while speaking is a behavior indicating surprise, doubt, tension, deception, or lack of confidence (see Figure 4.32). When a person feels sorry or regretful about what they are saying, they may also cover their mouth with a hand, as if trying to prevent their words from coming out. Law-enforcement officials typically view this gesture as an attempt to conceal the truth or fabricate a lie.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.32 以手捂嘴，表示惊讶]*

Many parents are very familiar with this action; when their child is trying to explain something and repeatedly covers their mouth with a hand, the parents intuitively know she is lying. This is because if the child were completely confident in what she was saying, her hands would not be near her mouth.

## The Nature of Surprise

Surprise is the most easily overlooked of the seven major emotions, not only because it lasts a short time but also because it rarely exists in isolation and often appears only after transitioning into another emotion. It is a transitional emotion, also called a neutral emotion. Among the seven major emotions, anger, sadness, disgust,

fear, and contempt are negative emotions, happiness is a positive emotion, and only surprise cannot be classified into any of those categories.

When good news is heard, surprise turns into delight; when bad news is heard, surprise turns into sadness or anger; when an annoying piece of news is heard, surprise turns into disgust or contempt; when threatened, surprise turns into fear.

In the space of one second the brain has already processed all the information, so the emotion then evolves into something else.

### **Surprise Turning into Anger**

When surprise is followed by the discovery that the stimulus carries a threat, surprise turns into anger. At this point, although the upper eyelids attempt to rise, they encounter the downward-pressing brows, forming obvious creases; the entire eye appears triangular. The tightly furrowed brows indicate negative emotion toward the stimulus source. The combination of downward-pressing brows and raised upper eyelids forms the typical anger expression.

Surprise turning into anger usually occurs when loss of control has placed the person under threat.

This expression is commonly seen at large public events when a host or leader is speaking onstage and sudden discordant commotion arises from the audience. The person onstage will pause briefly; after about 1 second the brows press down and furrow. Although changes in the mouth may not be great, the anger following surprise is already very obvious.

### **The Expression of Surprise**

Both eyes and mouth open wide in a startled expression.

The key features displayed by the "surprise" expression are "widened eyes and mouth"; when "both eyebrows raised upward" + "eyes widened" + "mouth opened" appear, "surprise" can be judged.

"Surprise" encompasses emotions such as astonishment, bewilderment, and being dumbfounded. "Surprise" indicates that something unexpected has occurred. The eyes widen in order to grasp the situation, and the mouth opens in order to breathe fully, thereby obtaining more information.

In evolutionary biology, the "surprise" expression signals to surrounding companions that an unanticipated event has occurred.

#### **4.4.5 Surprise Turning into Sadness**

Accidentally causing trouble or receiving bad news is surprise turning into sadness.

At one time a member of our research group became obsessed with a certain smartphone and would play its curling game frantically whenever bored. One day, because of excessive force, the phone flew out of its old protective case at the moment the finger slid and struck, landing solidly on the floor; the originally smooth touchscreen developed artistically cracked glass patterns. The instantaneous change of expression in that moment was the classic process of surprise turning into sadness.

### **Mouth Opened Wide**

The mouth opens wide in coordination with a rapid inhalation. Because it is impossible to judge whether the stimulus source will produce a positive effect, an inhalation occurs to store energy for response. Once it is determined that the effect is negative, the stored energy is used for fight or flight. If the effect is positive, the stored energy supports the person in jumping up or giving a hug.

Precisely because the mouth opens wide only for inhalation, very few muscles are involved; it is sufficient for the mandible simply to open naturally. On the other hand, air inhaled through an open mouth is far more abundant and carries far more energy than air inhaled only through the nose with the mouth closed; therefore, when suddenly stimulated, the mouth opens to allow a sufficient volume of air to enter the oral cavity.

### **Surprise Turning into Fear**

When it is realized that the threat is sufficiently powerful to cause harm to oneself, surprise turns into fear.

Try to imagine: if you are playing in a zoo and suddenly discover a wild beast has escaped, you will first be stunned, pause for about 1 second, then immediately realize your life is under threat and turn to panic, with blood rushing to both legs in preparation for flight.

We also often see such scenes on television programs: after a criminal suspect is discovered by the police, the suspect may first stand still—sometimes for less than 1 second—then, upon realizing possible arrest, display a fearful expression and prepare to flee. Some economic criminals also display this expression when exposed.

### **The Triggering and Transformation of Surprise**

The stimulus source capable of triggering surprise is an unexpected change in the matter the person cares about most. "Unexpected" means a possibility the person had not considered. "Cares about most" must be subjectively anticipated by the person. The greater the anticipation, the greater the stimulus the change produces for the person. For example, hearing long-awaited good news turns into delight; hearing the bad news of a relative's death turns into panic, which quickly turns into sadness.

As mentioned earlier, a full surprised expression features raised eyebrows, widened eyes, and an opened mouth. Here we need to analyze why these physiological reactions occur.

#### **1. Morphology of a Full Surprised Expression**

The appearance of an unexpected stimulus source for the person produces a surprised expression.

The morphological characteristics of a full surprised expression are as follows:

- The frontalis muscle contracts fully, raising the eyebrows substantially;
- The levator palpebrae superioris muscle contracts; together with the contraction of the frontalis, this raises the upper eyelids substantially, widening the eyes and exposing the sclera above the iris;
- The mouth opens involuntarily in coordination with a rapid inhalation; only the lower lip, driven by the chin (mandible), opens naturally and slightly downward, with the skin on the lip surface remaining untightened and not stretched to the sides.

#### **4.3 Morphological Features of Surprised Micro-expressions**

In real life, full surprised expressions are very rare. There are two reasons: first, people have seen a lot; even if they have not witnessed something in person, they have seen it across various public media, so stimuli capable of provoking great surprise are few; second, people have been heavily socialized not to display obvious expressions that would make them appear overly exposed. Individuals always attempt to mask and conceal their negative emotions, because an overly direct display of feeling produces the same effect as shouting one's inner thoughts aloud for everyone nearby to hear.

### 3. Morphological Features of Surprised Micro-expressions

Whether caused by subjective control and suppression or by insufficient intensity of the stimulus source, such subtle expressions may result.

The smallest surprised expression retains only the raising of the upper eyelids, while the eyebrows may show no obvious lifting.

**Summary:** The appearance of a surprised expression indicates the suddenness of the stimulus source—unexpected by the individual involved; such stimulus sources are usually effective ones.

### 2. Common Morphological Features of Surprised Expressions

When the intensity of the stimulus source is reduced, the morphological features of surprised expressions more commonly seen in daily life are as follows:

- Eyebrows raised, upper eyelids lifted, exposing more of the upper margin of the iris than usual.

See The seven basic emotions (c-seven-emotions).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

See Part V — Microexpressions (p-microexpressions).

## Sadness

### ACT Therapy: Acceptance and Commitment

When we try to drive away pain, we instead turn it into a force that torments us. Cognitive therapy prevents negative psychology but may make people more negative. What ACT does is weaken the power of negative psychology.

ACT therapy is the abbreviation for Acceptance and Commitment Therapy, pioneered by American psychologist Steven Hayes. This therapy advocates embracing pain and accepting the facts that “happiness is not the norm in life” and “people always suffer.” Additionally, it points out that when a person tries their best to control their thinking, it becomes difficult to consider the truly important matters in life. Repeatedly focusing on the wound in an attempt to heal it ultimately makes it harder to emerge from the mire of pain. Therefore, never struggle against negative emotions, nor avoid pain or harm. Instead, accept them as an indispensable part of life, and then establish and realize your own values.

ACT therapy is a new theory different from cognitive therapy. Cognitive therapy emphasizes confronting depressive thoughts head-on and ultimately changing them, while ACT therapy emphasizes being willing to accept negative emotions. To illustrate the difference between them, we can look at the following example.

Sometimes, you might have thoughts like, "Every time I go to work, I'm busy running around," "Everyone will notice my big belly," or "To have the courage to attend such a meeting, I need to drink two glasses to boost my courage." For this mindset, cognitive therapy would guide you like this: Are you always busy running around during work hours, or are you busy for a while and idle for a while like most people? Is everyone noticing your belly, or are you overthinking?

However, ACT therapy focuses on researching ways to change how people think and feel, so that patients won't be led by the nose by psychologists. For example, still regarding the "big belly issue," ACT therapy won't affirm or deny your thoughts but guides you like this: Do you think people are always looking at your big belly? Maybe so, your belly is indeed quite large, but perhaps no one cares about the size of your belly at all.

Another example: When you see the word "sunset," you might suddenly picture a beautiful sunset in your mind, but at the same time feel sad because it reminds you of a beautiful sunset at the time a loved one passed away. This vividly illustrates that human thinking is unreliable. Hayes thus concludes that human thinking has unpredictable consequences. Traditional cognitive therapy requires patients to correct negative thoughts, while ACT therapy attempts to dissolve the power of these thoughts. It won't have people say "I am very depressed," but suggests they say "I have a thought, and that thought is that I am very depressed right now."

All of the above tells everyone to accept their negative psychology, but accepting one's negative psychology is only the first step. ACT also has a second part—finding higher values to realize personal survival.

Many people's lives are monotonous and depressed, or they are unable to realize their own value because they are busy making a living. ACT therapy suggests you regain through certain methods, such as writing an epitaph. In addition, they will have you define what a good parent is, what a good employee is, and make you understand what things in life must be completed, such as how to spend the weekend, how to find your beliefs, etc. The purpose of doing this is not to fill your schedule with various activities, but to make you aware of the purpose of the things you pursue. For example, if you like fishing, it's because you can spend quality time with family while fishing, immerse yourself in nature, or enjoy the comfort of solitude.

### **Weaker Crying**

The crying discussed here is mainly closed-mouth crying, which is weaker than sobbing and commonly appears during the waning of sadness or when the sadness stimulus is mild. The greatest difference between this expression and suppressed sobbing lies in the degree of eye closure and the intensity of breathing.

Because the intensity of sadness has lessened, breathing also becomes gentler. Capillary and eyeball pressure inside the eye sockets gradually returns to normal, so the eyes no longer need to be tightly closed. Yet the emotion of sadness remains, so the brows stay lower and furrowed than usual. Interestingly, regardless of the type of sadness, the eyebrows take on a wavy shape, with a slight downward dip about one-third of the way from the inner brow, as if to say, "My heart is in turmoil."

Sad eyebrows are highly recognizable. Whether or not crying occurs, this brow shape appears whenever sadness is present. Note, however, that people may show a similar brow shape when stepping outside on an overcast day, but that shape signals discomfort rather than sadness. Overcast weather and sadness both leave a person feeling powerless, so similar expressions are unsurprising.

Returning to the eyes: although tight closure is unnecessary during sadness, the eyes attempting to open still encounter pressure from the brows, creating a fold in the upper eyelid, though it is not obvious. The lower



eyelid rises due to contraction of the orbicularis oculi, covering more of the eyeball. As a result, the eyeball appears dull under the combined enclosure of the upper and lower eyelids because less sclera is visible, contrast between black and white decreases, and reflected light diminishes.

A closed mouth is a typical feature of the sadness expression. Because the emotion of sadness persists, the mouth still stretches sideways and the corners turn slightly downward. This mouth shape also appears when we taste something bitter and is difficult to conceal. If it appears alone without accompanying brow and eye changes, judge it carefully; it most likely signals hardship, shame, reluctance, or “it wasn’t easy,” rather than sadness.

When watching major award ceremonies, some celebrities who receive important honors display this mouth shape while holding the trophy and delivering their acceptance speech before they even begin speaking. Clearly this is not sadness but the sense that it truly wasn’t easy to earn the award through hard work.

### **Helpless Sadness**

After sadness passes, one finally recognizes powerlessness over negative outcomes, leaving only deep helplessness. Helpless sadness differs from crying sadness: energy is not consumed instantly but drains away gradually.

Because the intensity of sadness has decreased, the full features of sadness gradually fade, leaving only the furrowed brows most noticeable. Pulled by the frontalis and corrugator supercilii, the brows rise slightly and furrow, though the movement is mild; it remains immediately visible as different from normal.

The eye area shows no obvious change and is usually in a normal state, sometimes slightly larger or smaller than usual. Therefore, the eyes alone cannot be used for judgment.

The mouth behaves similarly to the eyes and tends toward normal, showing no obvious change. Because intense breathing is unnecessary, the mouth remains closed, conveying “I don’t feel like talking right now; best to leave me alone for a while.” Yet the depressor anguli oris and mentalis still contract, albeit mildly, so the downward turn of the mouth corners is minimal and hard to detect.

From these analyses it is clear that, regardless of the degree of sadness, the eyebrows undergo relatively obvious changes throughout. One can say that lowered and furrowed brows, raised inner brows, and a wavy brow shape constitute the micro-expression features of sadness. However, the eyebrows also change this way during fear, though the degree of eye opening differs—eyes are wider during fear.

A well-known actress once gave a television interview in which the reporter asked how life had been since her divorce. All viewers saw her smile and say that it was fine; ending a marriage that did not suit her was perhaps not a bad thing. Yet at the moment she said “it was fine,” her brows lowered, the inner brows rose and furrowed, and her mouth quickly twisted sideways—a typical sadness expression. Although she quickly replaced it with a smile, her inner distress over the ended marriage was fully revealed.

### **Suppressed Sobbing**

We cannot sob without restraint at any time or place; we must often consider our surroundings and the impact of negative emotions, so we choose to suppress sobbing. Because vocalization is the most obvious and influential feature of sobbing, suppressing sobbing mainly requires suppressing sound. Consequently, the mouth must be held tightly closed. At this point the zygomaticus minor replaces the levator labii superioris as

the main force lifting the upper lip, while greatly reducing the lifting strength. The platysma continues to pull the mouth sideways; the depressor anguli oris pulls the mouth corners downward, but its force is far weaker than the platysma, so the downward turn of the corners is slight and grooves form on the outer sides of the mouth corners. The mentalis pushes the lower lip upward, creating uneven wrinkles on the chin; because it meets resistance from the upper lip, the lower lip does not form the W shape seen in sobbing but protrudes partially outward.

Suppressing vocalization is a subjective action, yet the emotion continues to erupt. This contradiction causes the tightly closed mouth to tremble slightly, relieving tension.

Tight closure of the mouth is the main feature of suppression, while the brows and eyes fully express the emotion of sobbing. Tension in the frontalis raises the brows; combined with the action of the corrugator supercilii, a fold forms between the brows. The orbicularis oculi presses the brows downward and closes the eyes.

Eye closure is very important; it is one of the main features of sobbing. Whether suppression occurs or not, sobbing increases capillary and eyeball pressure inside the eye sockets, so closing the eyes is a necessary protective action.

It is worth noting that although suppressed sobbing prevents the depletion of sadness energy, it prolongs the duration of the sadness emotion, affects bodily balance, and naturally influences daily life and work. Therefore, whenever sadness arises, sob if you can.

## **Mouth**

The mouth shape during sobbing is distinctive: the lips stretch sideways and open; although the lower lip is stretched, it forms an upward arc near the center. Five groups of muscles participate in the overall mouth change:

- Levator labii superioris: responsible for stretching the upper lip and bunching the cheeks, forming the nasolabial folds;
- Platysma: contracts to stretch the mouth corners horizontally, thinning the lips;
- Depressor anguli oris and depressor labii inferioris: tense to pull the lower lip downward, turning the mouth corners down, exposing the lower teeth and giving the mouth a square appearance that facilitates crying sounds;
- Mentalis: tenses and provides the main upward force on the central part of the lower lip, bringing the lower lip close to a W shape.

This mouth state makes wailing easier, rendering the sound louder and more moving. It is also the unique mouth shape of sobbing. If the upper half of the face is covered and only the mouth is viewed, locating the W-shaped lower lip allows one to conclude that the person is sobbing from sadness.

Combined with the brows, eyes, and mouth, a sobbing expression is difficult to produce deliberately unless one truly recalls some sad past event and activates the sadness emotion. If you try to imitate a sobbing expression in the mirror, either the eyes will not close enough or the mouth will not open wide enough. Therefore, if a person lacks the sadness emotion and deliberately produces a sobbing expression, it can be seen through at a glance.

Sobbing is the expression of full sadness emotion, yet in real life people rarely sob except when losing a loved one. Consequently, sadness most often takes other forms and therefore other expression features. As sobbing intensity decreases, the sadness expression becomes less obvious and the features of the brows, eyes, and mouth change accordingly.

### Psychology Mini-Class

In the 1980s, medical researchers at Stanford University in California conducted a survey of people aged 65–75. The results showed that people with strong vitality lived an average of 4.8 years longer than those with exhausted vitality.

“Strong vitality” is mainly manifested in the following aspects:

#### 1. Refusing to accept old age

People with strong vitality live to accomplish some undertaking; even when advanced in years they continue working tirelessly, always feeling vigorous and capable. This positive mindset exerts a beneficial regulatory effect on physiological quality. Because cortical excitation promotes “rejuvenation” of the body’s immune function and increases its vitality, the functions of all organs receive comprehensive reinforcement and improvement.

#### 2. Living for responsibility

People with strong vitality live to fulfill some responsibility—perhaps so their descendants can study, or so their spouse has support. They always believe they should work hard and accumulate more wealth. Consequently, they never feel tired no matter what work they do; in fact, the more tired they become, the healthier they feel. Driven by a sense of responsibility, they perceive their existence as highly valuable and are therefore able to live tenaciously<|eos|>

### 6. Mixed Joy and Sorrow (The Sad Smile)

The relationship between joy and sorrow is highly complex. Young children can sometimes shift seamlessly from laughter to tears without even pausing for breath. The facial transition from sorrow to a smile follows a similar pattern.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-29]

1. Eyebrows raised, brow shape flattening but with a twist in the inner third (sadness feature);
2. Lower eyelid, mouth, and cheek shapes follow the standard features of a smile.

Expressions of this kind can appear after a painful separation followed by reunion, or after hard-won success that comes only after prolonged hardship. We often see such bittersweet expressions on fans at football matches once their team secures a difficult victory.

### Furrowed Brows and Chin Wrinkles as Precursors to Tears

The key markers of a “sadness” expression are the “eight-character” eyebrows and the wrinkles on the chin. The facial actions consist of the inner eyebrows lifting upward, the two eyebrows drawing toward the center, the corners of the mouth turning downward, and the lower lip rising. “Sadness” encompasses negative emotions such as disappointment, loss, frustration, dashed expectations, and disillusionment. Sadness surfaces when a person loses something or someone of value. When we detect signs of “sadness” on another person’s

face, we tend to offer comfort. Sadness serves to elicit sympathy from others. In evolutionary biology, the sadness expression signals unhappiness with a situation and a desire to avoid contact with others.

## **Chapter 7: Seven Methods to "Kick Away" Negative Emotions**

Negative emotions possess remarkable destructive power and can severely affect both physical and mental health. When negative emotions arise yet remain unaddressed or untransformed, they can spread unchecked. Many techniques exist for channeling negative emotions, each offering a degree of effectiveness in helping us "kick away" such feelings.

### **Sadness**

Infants cry loudly and without restraint when sad, whereas adults rarely let tears fall freely yet still display sadness on their faces. People can release negative energy through crying. During crying, tightly closed eyes and lowered brows reveal that the person is experiencing intense sadness.

### **Analysis of a Full Crying Expression**

The expression of full, unrestrained crying (weeping) is nearly identical in infants and adults. Let us briefly analyze the features of a full crying expression.

See The seven basic emotions (c-seven-emotions).

### **Fear**

#### **Exposure Therapy: Confronting Fear Face-to-Face**

Fear is one of humanity's primitive negative emotions and also the demon in our hearts. To overcome it, one cannot simply avoid it but must confront it face-to-face.

Exposure therapy involves encouraging individuals trapped in fear to expose themselves to the stimuli that trigger fear until they become accustomed to this treatment method.

British philosopher Russell said: "Not daring to face reality, trying to think of something else when fear strikes, distracting one's attention—this is the wrong way to deal with fear and may instead intensify it." Psychologists hold the same view, believing that avoidance thinking and avoidance behaviors strengthen fear. Therefore, regardless of the form of fear, the correct approach is to face it rationally and bravely.

Research has found that the fear experience elicited by an object or situation in a person triggers avoidance behavior, and whether or not the object or situation truly poses a threat, this avoidance behavior leads to an increase in the fear experience, exerting a certain negative reinforcement effect, ultimately strengthening the avoidance behavior. Thus, experts believe that rather than avoiding, it is better to confront fear face-to-face and directly accept the fear stimulus.

Phobias are caused by sensitization, the process of becoming highly sensitive to a particular stimulus, essentially linking your fear to a specific scenario. For example, if you were startled in a restaurant, you associate the environment at that time with fear. Although there is no necessary causal relationship between the scenario and your fear, once this erroneous connection is established, encountering that environment again will trigger your fear. Since this linking process occurs automatically, it is not under conscious control.

However, exposure therapy can break the link between fear and the specific environment. After treatment begins, the person receiving treatment can be placed in the most fear-inducing situation. Usually, an imaginary approach is used, encouraging the individual to imagine the most frightening scene, with the psychologist repeatedly describing details of the most feared scenario, or using videos or slides to present the frightening situation to heighten anxiety, while not allowing escape measures like covering ears, closing eyes, or crying. After repeated exposure to fear stimuli, the person will experience reactions such as accelerated heartbeat, difficulty breathing, pale complexion, and cold limbs due to tension. However, the dreaded catastrophe the person fears most does not occur, and the fear naturally subsides.

In real life, exposure therapy is often used to treat agoraphobia, social phobia, and many other specific phobias. If a patient develops fear of a certain place, such as reluctance to enter a station or airport, drive on highways or bridges, take buses, trains, or planes, sit in high places, or stay alone in a room, this exposure therapy can be effective.

Additionally, this method of directly exposing patients to terrifying scenes can also be used to treat social phobia, such as fear of speaking in public, giving reports in front of others, or attending social gatherings. In short, exposure therapy can treat various types of phobias.

## **Fear**

Fear, like anger, arises from threat. The difference is that the threat level of anger is not as great as that of fear. Fear's threats usually involve personal safety and life, making one think of injury or death, thus lacking confidence to fight, with the primary response being flight. If the stress from the threat is too overwhelming, the individual may even abandon fleeing.

Nature is a world of survival of the fittest, where each organism is a link in the food chain, constantly facing death. Therefore, the probability of fear occurring is much higher than anger.

Because the threat is so great, obvious physiological changes occur: accelerated or stopped heartbeat, sweating, hair standing on end. If the threat can be alleviated by fleeing, the maximum response to fear is flight. But if the threat is deemed impossible to resist, and fleeing is futile, the person becomes rigid or limp, with strength instantly draining away, potentially leading to death.

However, full-fledged fear emotions are now rare because the development of human society has eliminated many safety hazards, and only in the face of natural disasters or man-made calamities does full fear appear. For example, being kidnapped by robbers while walking; being harassed by criminals while walking at night; encountering a fire, etc. More often, fear is not so intense, just fear of possible harm, such as children fearing injections or infusions; adults fearing surgery; criminals being surrounded; stocks plummeting; entering unfamiliar environments, etc.

People usually consciously suppress their fear emotions, so full fear expressions are not commonly seen.

What is a full fear expression? It is similar to a full anger expression, with furrowed brows, wide-open eyes, and open mouth. But in many details, they differ.

## **Emotion Analysis: From Worry to Fear**

Assume a warning news report states that a murderer has fled to a certain area and may still be active recently. Local residents are advised to keep doors and windows closed during the day and reduce going out

at night, especially alone. At the same time, police hope residents will cooperate: if the suspect in the photo is spotted, contact the police promptly.

Upon first hearing this news, people exhibit worry. Because they or their family members might become victims, even though the possibility is small, it does exist. They check doors and windows thoroughly before going out each day and absolutely refuse to go out at night, also forbidding family members from doing so. If a family member has not returned home late at night and cannot be reached by phone, worry turns into unease, as the likelihood of danger increases. If the family member eventually returns home, unease disappears and is replaced by joy. If the family member does not return overnight and cannot be contacted, unease turns into fear—fear that the family member has truly encountered danger, fear that the worry has become reality. This is precisely the psychological characteristic of fear: subjectively anticipating that something bad will happen and wanting to escape.

The family member returns home the next day and says they saw the criminal last night, secretly reported it to the police, and had been assisting the police. For safety, they could not call home. Unfortunately, the criminal escaped and also saw the reporter's appearance. At this point, the fear emotion not only does not subside but deepens, with a desire to leave the place quickly to ensure everyone's safety.

The criminal indeed comes to the door, and after a struggle, takes control of the person. At this moment, fear turns into terror, because subjectively it is now certain that something tragic is about to happen. Once tragedy is deemed inevitable, terror turns into grief.

Worry, unease, and fear—these three emotions each have their own facial expression characteristics that require careful distinction.

### Psychological Mini-Classroom

In real life, when using exposure therapy, pay attention to the following points:

#### 1. Consider physical and mental condition

When using exposure therapy to treat fear, one must consider one's own physical and mental condition and choose whether to undergo treatment and the intensity of treatment based on one's own tolerance. Therefore, you must have a deep understanding of your own physical and mental condition; otherwise, it will not only affect the therapeutic effect but may also lead to accidents. For example, if there are obvious heart or lung diseases, exposure therapy is strictly prohibited, because the fear response triggered during treatment may aggravate heart disease.

#### 2. Make full preparations

Before using exposure therapy, make full preparations and understand the treatment process and related knowledge. This ensures that when phenomena such as wanting to escape, accelerated heartbeat, shortness of breath, trembling, dizziness, or cold sweats occur during treatment, pre-prepared coping measures can be used promptly. For instance, one can familiarize oneself in advance with various coping plans, imagine what the worst outcome might be, or enter the fear scenario through imagination beforehand<|eos|>

See The seven basic emotions (c-seven-emotions).

See Varieties of smiles and microexpressions (s-smile-varieties).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

## Happiness

### Confidence Is Built Over Time

Confidence is not something won through struggle; it is built, not in a day or two, nor in a week, but through years of steady accumulation.

Have you ever felt unable to accept yourself, convinced you are foolish or inadequate and inferior to others? Perhaps you struggle in work, study, and relationships, remaining pessimistic, negative, and self-doubting, unable to live as optimistically and lightly as those around you. Colleagues seem more mature, optimistic, and resilient, and no matter what you do, you feel you can never catch up. In conversations you sense you are superfluous, so you withdraw and avoid interaction.

Confidence is the most basic condition for positive emotions. Confident people complete what they set out to do thoroughly, gaining a sense of accomplishment that encourages them further. For everyone, especially those prone to self-doubt, building confidence is essential.

#### 1. Practice looking others in the eye

The eyes reveal much about a person. When someone cannot meet your gaze, you instinctively wonder what they are hiding or what they fear you will see. Avoiding eye contact often signals "I feel especially inferior around you" or "Compared with you, I fall short in every way." Meeting someone's eyes, by contrast, tells them: "I am an honest person and, more than that, a confident one."

#### 2. Walk with a quicker step

Observe closely and you will notice that bodily movement reflects inner states. People who have been hurt, rejected, or stripped of confidence often drag their feet without energy, as if declaring, "I have little ability" or "I feel very inferior." Those brimming with confidence walk faster than average, projecting purpose, as if announcing, "I am heading to an important place to do something significant." Psychologists have found that simply quickening one's pace can shift a person's mental state and strengthen confidence. Therefore, walking faster is enough to cultivate it.

#### 3. Practice speaking up in public

Those who habitually remain silent in meetings often think, "My opinion probably has no value; speaking would only make me seem foolish, and others always know more than I do anyway." By avoiding public speech they erode their confidence further. Yet you need not fear appearing foolish; someone will always agree with your view. Speaking as often as possible builds confidence, making the next time easier. At any meeting, contribute early rather than waiting until silence becomes unbearable.

#### 4. Learn to smile

Smiling cultivates confidence and eases feelings of inferiority. As one poem puts it: "A smile is rest for the weary, daylight for the discouraged, sunshine for the sorrowful, and nature's finest nourishment." Smiling regularly at family, friends, colleagues, and even strangers will make you steadily more confident. If you still hesitate to smile at others, begin by smiling at your own reflection in the mirror; the effect is the same.

#### 5. Learn self-encouragement

Confidence is internal and must be generated by you. When facing an important challenge, encourage yourself: "The Creator made me and endowed me with boundless wisdom and strength." Such words

can summon inner resources. This is not a permanent solution, however; lasting confidence requires repeated self-encouragement until it becomes habitual.

## 6. **Stop procrastinating**

Some people lack confidence because long-term procrastination has compounded small failures into mounting psychological pressure. Over time this breeds a pervasive sense of defeat. The remedy is to treat every task—large or small—with care and finish what you start. Cultivating the habit of completing today's work today lightens the mind and restores confidence.

### **Bringing Passion to Work**

Repeating the same mundane tasks day after day easily drains passion. If the state persists, it breeds depression, irritability, and eventual burnout.

*Management World* magazine once surveyed two groups: high-level human-resources managers and senior executives on one side, and business-school graduates on the other. Both groups were asked which quality most contributes to success; their answers converged on a single word—passion.

If a career is gasoline, passion is the match. No matter how pure the fuel, without a match it produces neither light nor heat. Without passion, ability and advantage remain unrealized and cannot drive achievement.

Many assume passion is controlled solely by external conditions and cannot be cultivated. In fact, sustaining passion at work is not especially difficult. How, then, can we rekindle fading enthusiasm?

#### 1. **Abandon the notion that passion requires interest**

Interest certainly fuels passion, yet the belief that passion vanishes without interest does not hold. Interest can be developed. A career may begin with interest, but over time the sustaining force becomes responsibility, attachment born of familiarity, and the determination to achieve results.

#### 2. **Treat work as a vocation**

If you regard work merely as a chore or focus only on its immediate tasks, even a job you once enjoyed will lose its spark. View work instead as a vocation linked to your long-term career; it then acquires meaning, mission, and a sense of accomplishment.

#### 3. **Set fresh goals**

All work involves repetition. If repetition alone drains motivation, even an enviable position will grow stale. Only by continually setting new goals and seeking novelty can passion be maintained. Revisit old dreams, tackle long-delayed tasks, and each solved problem will generate small but accumulating achievements.

#### 4. **Reject complacency**

Complacency halts forward momentum and extinguishes passion. Treat past accomplishments as fuel for the next level rather than a reason to rest; doing so restores drive.

#### 5. **Learn to release pressure**

Every job generates pressure. Enduring it silently or exaggerating it are both unhelpful. Manage and discharge pressure scientifically, reduce fear of work, and relax; passion can then return.

#### 6. **Spend time with passionate people**

Passion is contagious. Regular contact with energetic, proactive individuals transfers their vitality to you,



prompting you to bring the same energy to your own tasks.

## 7. Keep learning

Passionate people are lifelong learners. To ignite your own passion, pursue new knowledge relentlessly and never stop moving forward.

### **Holding on to Hope**

After repeated setbacks, hope and belief become the reasons to keep living. Hope reshapes thinking and fosters a more positive attitude toward life.

Greek mythology tells of Pandora, who inadvertently opened a box and released greed, emptiness, slander, envy, and pain into the world. She closed it in time, however, leaving hope inside. Humanity has since drawn on that remaining hope to contend with evil; it has become an invisible force sustaining human will.

Hope is an emotional experience, a belief that supports us through adversity or hardship. Psychologist Averill describes hope as an emotion tied to goals: when a goal feels attainable, meaningful, and within reach, hope arises.

One year a British expedition crossed the Sahara. Sandstorms lashed the explorers' faces; thirst became unbearable, yet their water was gone. The leader produced a canteen and declared, "There is still water here, but no one may drink until we cross the desert." The canteen passed from hand to hand, its weight restoring determination to each despairing member. They eventually emerged alive. When they opened the canteen in relief, they found only sand.

Research shows that hope triggers the release of a chemical called endorphin. Normally present in low concentrations, endorphin, when elevated in marrow and brain, produces sensations of ease and well-being.

University of Pennsylvania psychologist Martin Seligman found that insurance agents who maintained hope outperformed pessimistic colleagues by 21 percent in the first year and 57 percent in the second. Pessimists told themselves after failure, "This job is too hard for me; I cannot continue." Hopeful agents told themselves, "This is nothing; there will be other opportunities, and I can learn from the experience."

Hope remains only a pleasant fantasy unless acted upon. Once a goal exists, hope becomes an active emotion that encourages fresh attempts, supplies courage to endure hardship, and prevents discouragement after setbacks.

Psychologist Martin Seligman observed that hopeful people tend to attribute good outcomes to stable aspects of their character—repeatable by effort—while viewing bad outcomes as isolated accidents that do not define their entire lives. This mindset supplies continuous motivation to persist.

### **Embracing Enthusiasm and Enjoying Life**

Many assume enthusiasm is innate and cannot be cultivated, yet it can be developed through engagement, health, focus, habit, and interest.

American naturalist and writer Dooley observed: "Nothing ages a person more than the loss of enthusiasm; when spirit declines, everything declines with it."

In both life and work, many find tasks tedious, lose enthusiasm, and feel they are merely “eating leftovers.” Under pressure they complain about cruel competition and life’s hardships. Whether work feels interesting depends largely on one’s perspective; the same tasks can be performed cheerfully or miserably.

American writer William Lyon Phelps once entered a sock shop and encountered an exceptionally enthusiastic clerk. The writer considered the choice of socks trivial, yet the clerk’s eyes shone as he declared, “You know, this is the finest sock shop in the world.” Phelps was taken aback; he had entered only by chance and wanted merely one pair. The clerk produced a box, invited him to examine the socks, and responded to Phelps’s protest—“I only need one pair!”—with “Yes, but I want you to see how beautiful they are—truly excellent!” His expression was solemn and reverent. Phelps grew intrigued and forgot the purchase. After a moment he said, “My friend, if you can sustain this enthusiasm—not because it is new or surprising, but every single day—within ten years you will be the sock king of America.”

Enthusiasm can offset a 20 percent deficit in ability; without it, a person utilizes only about 50 percent of their capacity. Whatever the job, learn to love it. Even if it is not your preferred work, exert every effort to improve it and thereby uncover hidden vitality. Once enthusiasm appears, work ceases to be drudgery and yields unexpected pleasure.

We often blame failure on lack of talent. In reality, failure usually stems from impatience: after the initial spark fades, disappointment sets in, confidence evaporates, and we abandon the effort. With sustained attention and patience, even modest results become possible. When hope seems absent, recall the original enthusiasm and draw from it the courage to continue.

### **Guiding Emotions with Benefit-Oriented Thinking**

Benefit-oriented thinking is an optimistic cognitive style that reflects a positive attitude toward life. Practicing it regularly supports both physical and mental health, helps overcome difficulties and setbacks, and sustains optimism even in adversity.

Benefit-oriented thinking means directing all considerations toward what is advantageous—looking for the good in any situation. It involves reframing unfavorable events to reveal positive elements, breaking habitual thought patterns, and cultivating constructive emotions while reducing destructive ones.

Many events admit both positive and negative interpretations. Dialectically, no occurrence is purely good or bad; good events often harbor risks, and bad events often contain opportunities. Setbacks, for example, can strengthen character or induce despair. Benefit-oriented thinking trains us to locate and amplify the positive within the negative.

To apply benefit-oriented thinking, consider the following approaches:

#### **1. Change the angle of perception**

“A mountain appears as a ridge from the side and a peak from the front; distance and height alter the view.” Different angles yield different observations.

At a concert, maestro Mehta appeared wearing a floral wreath. As he conducted, petals fell at his feet. One woman remarked, “When he finishes, he will stand among lovely petals.” A man replied wistfully, “When he finishes, only a noose will remain around his neck.” Their perspectives produced opposite images: “lovely petals” versus “a noose.” Benefit-oriented thinking requires shifting the angle so emotions move in a constructive direction.

## 2. **Break mental sets**

A mental set is a predisposition created by prior activity that inclines one toward a particular response. It is a closed form of thinking that can mislead and constrain. The saying "once bitten by a snake, ten years afraid of a rope" illustrates using past pain to interpret present circumstances. Eliminating the negative influence of mental sets is therefore essential for benefit-oriented thinking.

### **Psychology Mini-Classroom**

The following four thinking patterns are specific manifestations of benefit-oriented thinking. Forming these thinking patterns will help you move out of negative emotions and transform them into positive ones.

#### 1. **Affirmative Thinking**

Affirmative thinking means believing in a good outcome, that bad things always have a good side, and that adversity can also turn into favorable circumstances.

Asano Ichiro, the cement magnate of Japan, went to Tokyo to make a living when he was young. Upon arriving in Tokyo, he encountered many difficulties and remained in a state of hunger and cold. One day, suffering from hunger and thirst, he suddenly saw someone selling water at a street corner. Many onlookers nearby were complaining: "Tokyo is truly unfit for survival; even water costs money!" "Tokyo's prices are too high; it is not only unfit for survival but also unfit for doing business!" Upon hearing these words, Asano Ichiro felt a spark: "In a place like Tokyo, even water can be sold for money! Surviving here will absolutely not be a problem." With this mindset, Asano Ichiro soon embarked on an entrepreneurial path and eventually became Japan's renowned cement magnate.

"Water costs money to buy" and "water can be sold for money" appear to carry the same meaning, yet they reflect two completely different ways of thinking: the former is negative thinking, while the latter is affirmative thinking. This shows that affirmative thinking can steer events in a positive direction.

#### 2. **Gratitude-Oriented Thinking**

People who hold gratitude-oriented thinking face their difficulties with a grateful attitude rather than complaining or grumbling. For example, a blind person with gratitude-oriented thinking once said:

"Compared with a deaf person, I can hear sounds; compared with a mute person, I can speak; compared with someone paralyzed in the lower limbs, I can walk. So I am very fortunate."

#### 3. **Optimistic Thinking**

Optimistic thinking and benefit-oriented thinking are essentially the same: both involve changing one's own cognition when objective facts cannot be altered, ignoring matters that are unfavorable to oneself, and focusing only on matters that are favorable to oneself.

#### 4. **Possibility Thinking**

Possibility thinking refers to acknowledging one's shortcomings as much as possible while firmly believing that, through various efforts, one can certainly be no worse than others. In daily life, establish possibility thinking and do not let the "I can't do it" mindset or negative suggestions affect you; be convinced that you are the best.

### **Success**

The content encompassed by success is very broad, yet it can also be understood as a stage-specific term: during the schooling period, admission to university is success and smooth graduation is success; upon

entering society, finding a job is success, obtaining the first bucket of gold is success, and a thriving career is success.

First, consider schooling. During the schooling stage, the issue students must face is academic performance. The quality of performance depends on mastery of daily learning content. Students are always worried about whether the upcoming exam will contain material they do not know. When they receive the test paper and discover that 90 percent of the content is already mastered, they feel pleasure. Another aspect is the expectation of exam rankings. Through multiple past rankings, students have basically formed a self-positioning—for instance, always ranking fifteenth—so fifteenth place becomes the normal expectation. When the ranking is released and they find they placed thirteenth, exceeding the normal expectation, they feel happy. It is quite a pleasant surprise that classmates of comparable ability did not perform as well.

The joy brought by appearing on the list after the college entrance examination follows the same logic. No matter how good one's usual academic performance, there is always the worry of failure when facing whether one can enter an ideal university. Upon learning of admission to an ideal university, the low expectation is surpassed, signifying that the first major turning point in life has been successfully navigated; the future will be much better than if one had not entered university, which is naturally a cause for celebration.

Like schooling, job seeking and career development likewise carry the possibility of failure and rejection, so people harbor worries. When affirmation and recognition are received, the worried expectation is broken, and happy emotions naturally surface.

### **Psychology Mini-Classroom**

After working for a long time, burnout is inevitable. First, one can make a self-diagnosis: if three of the following five points are met simultaneously, one should be on guard, as burnout toward work is likely.

- Loss of enthusiasm for work, insufficient concentration, lack of interest in tasks assigned by leaders, noticeably longer working hours, and the same work taking more time to complete.
- Frequent symptoms such as headaches, stomachaches, and muscle soreness.
- Habitual suspicion, doubting one has some illness, and frequent hospital visits for checks.
- Insomnia with many dreams and loss of appetite.
- Emotional instability at work, excessive sensitivity to interpersonal relationships, and proneness to anger.

If one has already determined that burnout toward work has set in, the following methods should be used to eliminate it:

#### **1. Scientifically Plan Your Career**

Clarify your own excellent qualities so you can find work suited to you and gain a sense of achievement in it.

#### **2. Build Good Relationships with Colleagues**

In the workplace, relationships with colleagues directly determine mood, work efficiency, work enthusiasm, and other aspects, so it is essential to build good relationships with colleagues.

#### **3. Correct Your Mindset**

While working, correct your mindset: do not work merely for the monthly salary but with the mindset of realizing self-value and social value, and work with a grateful heart.

Many people mistakenly believe enthusiasm is innate and cannot be cultivated later, yet enthusiasm can indeed be cultivated. However, to cultivate enthusiasm, one must first know where it comes from.

### 1. **Enthusiasm Comes from Investment**

Enthusiasm comes from investment of time, money, and other resources; the higher the degree of investment, the greater the enthusiasm. Without investment of time and money, even if excitement can arise at any moment, it cannot be called true enthusiasm. That easily leads to feelings of fatigue and burnout.

### 2. **Enthusiasm Comes from Health**

If one is ill, personal energy declines, and declining energy leads to reduced enthusiasm, so health is also a key factor in enthusiasm. For example, a person with a high fever can hardly muster enthusiasm to devote energy to work.

### 3. **Enthusiasm Comes from Focus**

Devoting oneself wholeheartedly to one's job produces a sense of achievement, which invisibly increases enthusiasm for work. However, "enthusiasm" and "wholehearted devotion" are like the two sides of a coin, forming a causal cycle. Without enthusiasm, wholehearted devotion is impossible; without wholehearted devotion, enthusiasm cannot arise. Of course, the initial stage may bring some difficulty, but repeatedly telling oneself, "I am engaged in a remarkable job" and "It is truly fortunate to be able to do this job," will naturally transform enthusiasm for work.

### 4. **Enthusiasm Comes from Habit Formation**

In fact, changing

## **Psychology Mini-Classroom**

Sometimes beautiful fantasies also carry positive significance. For example, when you cannot handle difficulties in real life or endure the distress of certain emotions, you can temporarily leave reality and obtain inner peace by fantasizing about another world. This psychological defense mechanism can weaken external harm and stimulation, allowing the mind to live temporarily in a fantasy world.

American clinical psychologist Viktor Frankl once used fantasy to protect himself. During World War II, as a Jew, he spent four years in a German concentration camp.

After surviving, he surveyed people who had survived the camps and found that their survival had little to do with individual physical condition; the key lay in their holding beautiful visions of the future and willingly immersing themselves in fantasized beautiful prospects to endure the currently unbearable suffering. It was precisely this positive fantasy that ultimately helped them through the difficult years until the day they saw light again.

From this perspective, fantasy can exert a positive influence on the individual, helping people relieve inner pressure, soothe inner pain, and overcome difficult and bitter days with belief.

Yet every matter has two sides, including the psychological defense mechanism of fantasy. If a person becomes excessively immersed in a fantasy world while rarely taking concrete action in the real world, thinking will gradually degenerate and the person will become unable to calmly cope with various problems that arise in the real world.

## **Admiration and Expectation**

The reason we feel drawn to someone is certainly that certain conditions they possess meet or exceed our expectations. This is especially evident in women's choices of men. For example, almost every girl likes the story of Prince Charming; never insist you dislike it—this is nothing to be ashamed of. Since primitive society, men's division of labor has covered everything involving physical strength, such as hunting and farming, because fat and muscle structure makes men more suited to these tasks. Consequently, a man's robust physique and fertile fields naturally became important conditions for attracting the opposite sex. It is perfectly normal for women to hold expectations regarding these conditions. Returning to Prince Charming, the white horse represents wealth and the prince represents exalted status; this is in fact the most primitive female mate-selection expectation.

However, one issue must be considered: does he or she also like me? More specifically, does the person who meets all my conditions also like me, and can we ultimately unite and have offspring? No one can give us an accurate answer, so we always carry the normal psychological expectation that "the other person does not like me." Regardless of one's ability or status, this expectation appears during one-sided admiration. When one receives the message "I like you too," the original expectation is greatly exceeded, producing intense happiness and joy.

## **Happiness**

Humans possess seven universal emotions: happiness, anger, sadness, surprise, fear, contempt, and disgust. Regardless of race or family background, the facial expressions of these seven emotions are identical. Therefore, it is necessary to understand how these seven emotions arise and their expressive characteristics.

Happiness is discussed first because it is the only positive emotion among the seven and also a relatively complex one. So how exactly does happiness arise? From a psychological perspective, happiness stems from reality exceeding expectations. Take a common childhood activity as an example: Christmas is approaching, and we have repeatedly hinted and stated to our parents that we hope to receive a limited-edition car model, yet our parents have never clearly said whether they will buy it. On Christmas Eve we go to bed with both expectation and fear of disappointment; the next morning we open our eyes and rush to unwrap the gift. Wow, it is that car! We happily run into our parents' arms, thanking them repeatedly. This is the emotion of happiness. Because we had drawn a question mark in our minds and were prepared to accept a bad outcome, when the final fact exceeded our psychological preparation, we felt pleasure.

Below, we attempt to analyze the emotion of happiness using some ordinary life situations:

### **Watching Comedy Performances**

The happiness brought by comedy performances differs from that brought by admiration and success; it brings people more a sense of satisfaction formed by gaps and contrasts.

The most typical comedy character with a gap effect is the clown; almost every comedy performance includes a clown-like figure. They appear dull and humble, are teased everywhere, and cannot even handle ordinary matters. Such a character gives the audience a sense of superiority, greatly satisfying the achievement that people cannot obtain in daily life.

The contrast effect generally refers to comedic effects created by going against normal logic, such as nonsense comedy. Whether in characters or plot design, nonsense comedy challenges people's normal logical thinking—for instance, a graceful and beautiful woman opens her mouth and a man's voice comes out, or a dashing gentleman makes a stylish entrance only to take a big fall. This deviation from normal logic creates a

strong contrast and becomes a source of laughter. Of course, clown-like figures and the gap effect are indispensable here as well.

Both gap and contrast effects please the audience by lowering character status and increasing plot reversals; the resulting effect is likewise an exceeding of subjective expectations, thereby producing a sense of pleasure.

### **Psychology Mini-Classroom**

Persistence is an indispensable quality for gaining self-confidence. As Marie Curie said: "Life is never easy for any man or woman. We must have perseverance, and above all we must have confidence in ourselves. We must believe that we are gifted for something, and that this thing, at whatever cost, must be attained. When it is finished, you can say to yourself without fear of being mistaken, 'I have done all I could.' Once a person has self-confidence, he or she can become whatever they wish to be."

Confidence is gradually built through continuous effort and progress; giving up midway is an important reason for lack of self-confidence. Therefore, once we have decided something should be done and have begun doing it, we should not lightly give up. When you give up, you may feel very relaxed at first, but afterward setbacks and failures will continuously increase psychological pressure, producing feelings of guilt and inferiority. So never find reasons to abandon something you should do and are already doing.

### **"Blooming Mouth Corners" and "Crow's Feet" Are Marks of Happiness**

The key features of the "happiness" expression are the "blooming mouth corners" and "crow's feet"; facial movements include "cheeks raised upward" + "mouth corners lifted." The wrinkles resembling footprints that appear at the outer corners of the eyes because the cheeks are raised are called "crow's feet"; this is a feature that does not appear in deliberately produced smiles.

However, even if the micro-expression "crow's feet" does not appear, as long as the expression is not deliberate, we can still call it a genuine "happiness" expression. Because micro-expressions instantaneously reveal suppressed emotions, most of the time only partial subtle expressions appear on the face. "Happiness" includes positive emotions such as tolerance, expectation, acknowledgment, joy, contentment, and excitement. When one's hopes are fulfilled, the "happiness" expression appears. It also appears when identifying with others or showing goodwill. In evolutionary biology, showing a smile to someone conveys the message "I am your partner" or "I am very friendly."

### **Admiration**

We often face the question, "What exactly do you like about him or her?" The most literary answer is "I just like him or her; I don't know what exactly I like." Such an answer indicates that the responder has not deeply questioned the psychology of admiration but has chosen to evade it. Human admiration for the opposite sex is an instinct that long-term evolution has not eliminated, because admiration is the foundation of reproduction.

Since primitive society, the ultimate purpose of humans seeking partners has been to reproduce. On this basis, selecting a partner naturally involves certain criteria and conditions, such as good health and superior ability. As civilization has progressed, humans have added more conditions when choosing partners: figure, appearance, knowledge, wealth, status, and so on. In the final analysis, these many conditions all arise from

expectations regarding reproduction. Good figure and good appearance represent expectations of health; knowledge, family wealth, and high status represent expectations of ability.

## 5. Enthusiasm Comes from Interest

The emergence of interest is closely related to excitation in the cerebral cortex. When a person does work they find interesting, they generally do not feel fatigue; when doing uninteresting work, they more easily fall into fatigue. Therefore, if you truly dislike your current job, cannot muster any interest, and feel that time drags, there is no need to force a smile. What you need to do is find where your interest lies and then seek work suited to you. In the course of work, if you discover that part of your job does not interest you, there is no need to become overly nervous lest worry create a mental burden. In such situations, you can find ways to cultivate your own interest.

### Signs Indicating Happiness and Confidence

- Smiling or laughing
- Relaxed and casual body posture
- Standing close while talking
- Vivid and rich body movements

All parents in the world hope their children can control and balance various different emotions. Children sometimes feel fear and anger, and sometimes experience happiness and joy; the best state is to achieve balance between the two.

If your child displays more negative body movements than positive ones, do not take it lightly or ignore these signs; find ways to identify the root of the negative behavior and help the child learn to handle fear and anger emotions positively so they can enjoy more happy and contented times.

### Optimizing Emotions

Benefit-oriented thinking produces positive emotional experiences, while detriment-oriented thinking produces negative emotional experiences; this fully illustrates that thinking patterns influence a person's emotions. Conversely, emotions also influence thinking. Positive emotions promote benefit-oriented thinking, while negative emotions promote detriment-oriented thinking. For example, an inferior person cannot see their own strengths and can only see their own weaknesses. Therefore, to practice benefit-oriented thinking, one must optimize emotions so that positive emotions promote benefit-oriented thinking. In daily life, one can cultivate more positive, constructive, and healthy emotions and eliminate negative, destructive, and unhealthy emotions.

## 6. Enthusiasm Comes from Pretending

"Pretending" is no longer a new concept; many people have already used this method. In life we often hear someone say, "Pretend you can do it, and you really can." This means you can completely accomplish certain things through pretending—for instance, if you keep pretending you are happy, you will eventually become truly happy; if you keep pretending you are an enthusiastic person and display considerable enthusiasm in front of others, over time you will naturally become full of enthusiasm.

### Methods to Cultivate Enthusiasm



Changing one's attitude toward life is as simple as forming a new habit. Psychology has long established that it takes only twenty-one days to adopt or break a habit. Therefore, if you wish to form or eliminate a habit, you need only persist for twenty-one days to reach your goal; the same principle applies to cultivating enthusiasm. If you consistently act enthusiastic, after twenty-one days you may be surprised to find that you no longer need to expend much effort pretending, because your body has grown accustomed to enthusiasm.

## Joy

There is a saying that puts it well: good news brings a lift in spirits. When a person encounters something joyful, the inner emotion of joy is reflected on the face, and this joyful expression is usually manifested as a smile. People cry when sad and smile when happy; these are reflections of inner emotions and the most basic expressions. We can make a preliminary judgment about the state of a person's inner world through their facial expressions.

# Part IV — Smiles

## Smile Types

### 2. Different Smiles Can Reveal Different Information

#### 1. People Who Often Smile Quietly

People with relatively introverted and shy personalities, with calm, meticulous, and clear minds. They are good at hiding themselves and do not easily reveal their true inner thoughts. Most of the time, they observe and handle matters as bystanders. Such people can often be entrusted with important responsibilities and have leadership potential.

#### 2. People Who Like to Laugh Heartily

These individuals generally have straightforward personalities, broad-minded outlooks, and upright characters. They treat others with tolerance and generosity. They also possess a good sense of humor and often bring joy to those around them. At the same time, they are full of compassion and empathy.

#### 3. People Who Laugh Out Loud

On the surface, these people may seem dull, but once they start laughing, they cannot stop, or they frequently burst into loud laughter, sometimes even doubling over. Such individuals have sincere and straightforward personalities, value loyalty, and place great importance on relationships.

#### 4. People Who Chuckle "Hee Hee"

They usually hold themselves to strict standards. This type of person has strong creativity and rich imagination, often performing surprising feats. They also have a good sense of humor, firm convictions, and once they set a goal, they pursue it with full effort.

#### 5. People Who Smile Cautiously and Secretively

These individuals tend to be introverted and conservative. They are somewhat shy in social interactions and belong to the type who can share hardships. However, because they set high standards for others, they easily lose their temper if those standards are not met. Therefore, one must exercise extra caution when dealing with such people.

#### 6. People Who Smile When They See Others Smiling

Some people smile upon seeing others smile. This type tends to have optimistic and outgoing

personalities, with positive outlooks on life, though they are also noticeably emotional and experience greater psychological fluctuations.

#### 7. People Whose Mouth Corners Turn Downward When Smiling

Some people smile with their mouth corners turned downward, a nearly closed-eye squinting expression. Most such individuals are introverted, stubborn, and obstinate. Their temperaments are relatively melancholic and subdued; they are easily influenced by external factors and tend to be emotional, yet they appear gentle and possess strong interpersonal appeal. They all carry a romantic streak and know how to create romance at the right moments.

#### 8. People Who Cover Their Mouths When Smiling

Most are introverted and gentle, yet calculating and suspicious. Consequently, they experience greater psychological pressure than average and tend to overthink. At work, they rarely focus without distraction and often lose concentration due to various interfering factors.

#### 9. People Who Laugh Until Tears Come

Those who frequently laugh so intensely that tears appear are more compassionate and empathetic. Such people usually possess ambition and a strong desire to win. In life, they are positive and optimistic, enjoy adding color to their world, and help others to the best of their ability.

#### 10. People Whose Laughter Is Soft and Flat

They have steady personalities and remain calm in the face of events. They are reasonable, considerate in their thinking, handle interpersonal relationships appropriately, and are skilled at resolving conflicts and disputes.

#### 11. People Whose Laughter Is Sharp and Piercing

They generally have abundant energy, an adventurous spirit, and are loyal and reliable. Their emotions are rich and delicate, and they maintain positive, optimistic attitudes toward life.

#### 12. People Who Laugh Through Their Noses

They are slightly shy, modest, and considerate toward others, earning respect. This type excels at socializing, acts on principle, remains composed in situations, and rarely acts rashly.

#### 13. People Who Cannot Stop Laughing

They have relatively outgoing, lively, straightforward, and carefree personalities. Most possess a strong sense of justice, enjoy charitable acts, easily win others' favor, and maintain good interpersonal relationships.

#### 14. People Who Give a Cold "Heh Heh Heh" Laugh

Some people frequently emit a cold "heh heh heh" laugh, indicating that the person is rather sinister and cunning. If one party produces this laugh during negotiations, the talks will most likely fail.

Some people emit different kinds of laughter in different situations. Most such individuals are pragmatic; this also shows that their thinking is agile and their adaptability is strong.

In addition, laughter bears a certain relationship to the person being laughed at. When men who get along well gather, they use snorting laughs and coughs to amuse one another, because this method keeps their conversation moving in a positive direction.

Women's smiles, moreover, contain countless layers of information. Obtaining this information usually requires observing their mouths and eyes as well. For example, if her eyes are smiling but her mouth, cheeks, and other parts of her body do not move in tandem, then the smile cannot be regarded as seductive or intimate. This smile displays the gentle posture unique to women, yet it also carries an unapproachable attitude. Some women, when smiling, gently half-cover their mouths with a hand, fan, or handkerchief. This smile emphasizes their feminine charm. Its users are either shy girls experiencing first love or women of great allure using it to entice men. Another type of smile involves lightly touching the cheek beside the corner of the mouth with a hand, teeth half-visible, the smile sweet, appearing quiet and refined. Women accustomed to this smile are the most calculating and deeply reserved; they do not easily trust others and reveal even less. Such smiles are more often motivated by politeness and self-protection. If someone smiles while their eyes glance sideways and their mouth corners are slightly crooked, the smile usually carries sarcasm and a sense of contempt. The opposite of a sarcastic smile is a hearty one. A woman who laughs heartily has relatively relaxed vigilance and gives others a feeling of closeness and trust...

### **Psychology Related to "Laughing"**

Laughter is one of humanity's most important facial expressions and, like language, is a uniquely human function. Human laughter is rich and varied: joyful laughter, sorrowful laughter, smug laughter, malicious laughter, innocent laughter, sweet laughter, self-mocking laughter... Because of this, psychologists have said: "If a person could calculate how many times they have laughed in their lifetime, their IQ would be twenty times that of Einstein!"

The manner and characteristics of laughter reflect a person's personality traits. Just as I analyzed in the previous chapter, when hearing the same joke, whether a person laughs uproariously, laughs with mouth wide open, smiles faintly, squints while smiling, or does not smile at all reveals their character.

- People who frequently laugh heartily are optimistic and outgoing, upright and sincere, and do not haggle over trifles with others; if friends achieve success, they offer sincere congratulations without the slightest jealousy.
- People who like to laugh secretly are relatively conservative and traditional, more reserved and shy in front of others. They are strict with themselves but generous toward others. Once they set a goal, they strive hard to achieve it, yet if they fail, they easily fall into an emotional low and become despondent.
- People who like to cover their mouths when laughing are relatively introverted and unwilling to reveal their thoughts easily, yet they are sincere toward others and have many friends.
- Some people laugh with large amplitude, sometimes even to the point of tears; there is no doubt that most such individuals are straightforward, bold, and hate evil. If friends are in trouble, they will generously help; if friends make mistakes, they will point them out frankly. In short, they enjoy good popularity and often achieve success at work.

Laughter is like a watercolor brush that can make a person colorful and full of vitality. No one wants to stay close to someone with a gloomy expression and melancholic temperament; people always harbor inexplicable distrust toward those who speak only negatively. Yet energetic people are always surrounded by others. Being with them makes one feel cheerful; they possess an aura that inspires trust involuntarily.

"Working with this person is joyful." "Listening to this person always makes one feel optimistic and positive." Receiving such evaluations means one can be considered an excellent "deceiver." Yet you may have the following troubles—you simply lack that aura that brightens the surroundings, cannot say amusing things to

make people laugh, and cannot maintain a positive attitude at all times... No matter. To be seen as an outgoing and energetic person, simply laugh loudly and exaggeratedly.

This is not empty talk; it has a psychological basis. Dr. Nicholas from Carleton University in Canada had subjects listen to recorded short stories. Half of the stories included audience laughter in the recording. The result was that those who heard the stories with laughter easily laughed along with others, and pleasure and laughter spread. This is called the "emotional contagion effect."

Indeed, even with boring stories, if you laugh exaggeratedly and heartily, the other person will also find them funny and happiness will spread. Consequently, people will feel "being with you is enjoyable" and "you are a vibrant person."

A smile is one of the important means of maintaining good interpersonal relationships. A charming smile can make relationships more harmonious and smooth. However, a frightening fact has recently been discovered: a deliberately produced smile is immediately detected.

Dr. Mark Frank of the University of California conducted a survey and study and found that when a person genuinely feels amused and shows a heartfelt smile, the muscles on the cheekbones rise upward. When smiling ingratiatingly or flatteringly, the smile is small and expressed only through the corners of the mouth, so the cheeks never rise. Therefore, by observing the other person's cheeks, one can easily determine whether the smile is genuine or merely ingratiating.

Similarly, in situations where one must smile, if one does not want the "fake smile" to be detected, try raising the corners of the mouth, showing the teeth, and regularly exercise the facial muscles of the cheeks so they rise upward.

### **Section 3: Lies Hidden in Smiles**

Because smiles are contagious and this contagion usually relaxes people's guard, it also becomes an opportunity for those who love to lie. They artificially produce smiles when lying, so laughter divides into genuine and fake. The two are still relatively difficult to distinguish; without careful analysis, the clues cannot be detected. Precisely for this reason, smiling sometimes becomes a tool for people to conceal themselves and deceive others. When a person is hiding something, most people—especially men—display more serious expressions than usual. Psychologists have concluded after long-term research that most people associate smiling with lying, so liars subconsciously control their expressions, striving to remain serious to appear earnest. For liars, if they do smile, the frequency of such smiles is higher than that of genuine smiles, and the duration is longer; therefore, liars smile more as if wearing a smiling mask. Clearly, lies can also be hidden in smiles!

Scientific research has found that when people fake a smile, both hemispheres of the brain hope the smile will appear more authentic and credible. However, the neurons controlling facial expressions are mostly concentrated in the cerebral cortex of the right hemisphere, and the right hemisphere's cortex can only send instructions to the left half of the body. In other words, under self-conscious control, the expressions on the left and right sides of the face are not entirely the same. If the face is divided into two sides for comparison, the left side's smile will be more pronounced than the right side's. Yet if a person is smiling from the heart, there is no difference between the smiles on the left and right sides of the face.

We may rarely notice in daily life that a smile is also a window to the mind. People who frequently display smiles belong to those who like to open their hearts, are relatively confident, and feel assured; they hope to

enhance their approachability through smiling. People who rarely smile have a strong competitive awareness; they are always tense, poised to act, and full of curiosity. People who laugh through their noses tend to despise others. People who only emit laughter through nasal breaths work hard at everything, yet most of this type are rather stingy. People who smile with lips closed and teeth hidden are concealing secrets inside and unwilling to share with others. The standard form of this smile has both lips tightly closed and drawn inward and backward, making the lip line appear as a straight line. People whose one mouth corner rises display great self-confidence, yet they feel a sense of emptiness toward everything... People whose laughter sounds hearty and warm appear bold in character, yet their hearts are actually very cautious. People whose mouth corners rise when smiling often harbor great ambition. Men who laugh like women are usually serious but sometimes perform astonishing acts...

Consider another kind of smile: the cold smile. Like a sidelong glance, a cold smile is likewise a gesture of contempt and is universal worldwide. When we cold-smile, the cheek muscles on both sides of the face pull the mouth corners toward the ears, producing a mocking expression. This expression is clearly visible; even a brief appearance allows others to sense its intent. University of Washington researcher John Gottman discovered that among married couples, when one party begins cold-smiling at the other, their relationship has likely already encountered problems. In FBI investigations, when suspects believe they know more than the investigators or sense that officials do not grasp the full truth of the case, they typically perform this action.

There is also a type of smile commonly seen in film and television: after a couple breaks up, one turns and leaves while the other watches the departing figure with a tearful smile. Normally, such scenes leave audiences sighing and lamenting, precisely because they see the heartbreak behind the smile—a despairing sorrow, a strong act of letting go.

#### **Section 4: How to See Through Your Lover's Smile**

People who have fallen in love always hope to understand their partner's thoughts and personality more deeply. At such times, smiles can be used to discern their inner feelings and character. Remember, a smile reflects a person's mood, and the way people smile varies greatly according to individual habits.

##### **1. People Who Maintain a Smile as Soon as They Speak During a Romantic Date**

Such individuals have relatively kind hearts, are good at performing, relatively easygoing, and confident in handling matters; they do not easily fall into romantic predicaments. If the other person smiles reluctantly, it indicates inner dissatisfaction with the conversation and a certain gap between reality and their inner expectations.

##### **2. People Who Like to Laugh "Chi Chi Chi" Have Rich Imagination**

This type usually possesses strong creativity, views life with vitality, has a good sense of humor, and is extremely easy to get along with<|eos|>

#### **11.3.1 Complex Smiles**

Humans can express nuanced emotions through many different types of smiles. Smiles can even incorporate all negative emotions such as surprise, disgust, anger, fear, and sadness, creating expressions with multiple meanings. This is also why smiles are uniquely the most suitable social expression among all facial expressions.

In a natural smile, the eyebrows and forehead are completely relaxed. Therefore, if a particular eyebrow shape is added, the emotion represented by that eyebrow shape is blended into the smile. In addition, the strong

compatibility of smiles allows them to incorporate necessary morphological features of various basic emotions (most of which are formed by the eyebrows and eyes), creating a new meaning.

## 1. Surprise

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-24]

We encountered this image in Chapter 4 when discussing surprise. Now we can use professional analysis to break down its morphological features as follows (as shown in Figure 11-24):

- Both eyebrows raised (surprise expression feature);
- Upper eyelids significantly raised, exposing most of the upper edge of the iris (surprise and fear expression features);
- Upper lip raised, exposing upper teeth, jaw opened, lower lip opened in a U shape, corners of the mouth pulled sideways and upward (surprise and laughter features);
- Cheeks raised, with smile-specific grooves below the lower eyelids (smile feature).

**Conclusion:** Fear is ruled out (because there is no eyebrow shape feature), surprise features are confirmed, smile features are confirmed, and overall this is a surprised expression.

## 2. Expectant Smile

In Chinese habits, raised eyebrows appear not only in basic emotions such as surprise and fear but also, when appearing alone, can express another meaning—tacit understanding. Translated into current popular language, it is roughly “you know.” During verbal expression, an inadvertent eyebrow raise signals that the speaker approves of what they are saying and believes the listener should as well; this is a form of tacit understanding.

Therefore, if this raised-eyebrow shape is added to a smile without a mouth opened in surprise—only a slight teeth-clenching smile shape—the expression conveys strong trust and enthusiasm while fully revealing the person’s inner expectations. It can be called an expectant smile, as shown in Figure 11-25.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-25]

1. Both eyebrows raised (surprise expression feature);
2. Upper eyelids significantly raised, exposing most of the upper edge of the iris (surprise expression feature);
3. Upper lip raised, exposing upper teeth, lower lip elongated, upper and lower teeth clenched, corners of the mouth pulled sideways and upward (smile feature);
4. Cheeks raised, with smile-specific grooves below the lower eyelids (smile feature).

**Conclusion:** Surprise features are confirmed, but because the mouth does not cooperate, the surprise expressed is not genuine shock; instead it tends toward foreknowledge of an impending outcome—a tacit-understanding feature—while smile features are also confirmed. Overall, this is an expectant smile.

## Differences Between Social Smiles (= Feigned Smiles) and Genuine Smiles (= Real Smiles)

There are seven differences:

### 1. Asymmetry

A genuine smile is symmetrical left to right; a feigned smile is asymmetrical.

## 2. **Duration**

A genuine smile lasts between 0.5 seconds and 4 seconds; a feigned smile may last longer than 4 seconds.

## 3. **Muscles Used**

In a genuine smile the corners of the mouth rise and the orbicularis oculi muscles around the eyes contract. In a feigned smile the corners of the mouth rise but the muscles around the eyes do not contract. The genuine smile is named after the researcher Duchenne de Boulogne who discovered the action of the orbicularis oculi and is also called the "Duchenne smile."

## 4. **Onset and Offset Moments**

Compared with a genuine smile, a feigned smile appears and disappears suddenly. This "suddenness" can be observed in entertainers or idol stars. On the surface, idol stars display a fine "Duchenne smile," yet one can often see the smile vanish abruptly. A genuine smile fades gradually from the face.

## 5. **Smoothness**

Compared with a genuine smile, a feigned smile requires extra time before appearing and is accompanied by stiffness. When producing a feigned smile, a person may pause midway to adjust its intensity while thinking "What does a real smile look like?" and consciously fine-tuning the expression.

## 6. **Difference in "Duchenne Smile" Intensity**

Contraction of the orbicularis oculi is generally not under voluntary control, yet some people can achieve it. A feigned "Duchenne smile" is easily overly intense compared with a natural one—in short, "smiling too exaggeratedly."

## 7. **Synchronization**

When a genuine smile appears, the corners of the mouth reach maximum elevation at the same moment the muscles around the eyes reach maximum contraction. In contrast, when a feigned smile appears the corners of the mouth rise first, and only after a delay do the muscles around the eyes begin to move. Not only smiles but all deliberately produced expressions show asynchronous muscle actions.

When reading the above judgment points in text, one may think, "Wow, distinguishing real from fake smiles requires such careful observation—how troublesome!" In practice, once one is slightly aware of the differences between social smiles and genuine smiles, telling them apart is surprisingly easy. Most importantly, this is an essential skill that should be taken for granted. When giving a presentation, it is very important to carefully observe the subtle cues on the other person's face, prudently confirm their reactions, and then continue the conversation.

Be aware, be aware, be aware! Observe, observe, observe! Once these are done, judging social smiles is far simpler than distinguishing micro-expressions.

## **What Does It Mean When Someone Says "It Tastes Great" but Shows No Smile on Their Face?**

When purchasing goods or dining out, customers are often asked to fill out feedback forms. From a market-analysis perspective, customer satisfaction with products or services is extremely important. Satisfaction is usually assessed via paper or online questionnaires, yet how accurately do these forms reflect customers' true intentions?

It is not only I who sometimes fails to understand the questions on such forms, answers them without much care, or cannot recall the purchase experience clearly enough to answer accurately.

In addition, the motivation for buying a product sometimes changes between entering the store and leaving, and the buyer may no longer be sure what the original motivation was.

According to Harvard Business School professor Gerald Zaltman, only 5 % of one's own thoughts and emotions are conscious; the unconscious portion accounts for 95 %. This shows that people's inability to answer questionnaire-style questions correctly is understandable.

Is there no way to hear the 95 % unconscious voice? There is: interpreting customers' unconscious expressions and micro-expressions.

A research team led by Professor David Matsumoto of San Francisco State University measured emotional states by observing interviewees' facial expressions. They introduced several daily necessities—including product concepts, usage methods, and television commercials—to more than one hundred consumers, then conducted interviews and recorded the various expressions that appeared during responses.

The analysis yielded the following conclusions. Consumers' expressions during interview responses were:

- In most cases, close to their baseline expression or accompanied by smiles of varying intensity;
- Consumers' statements and expressions were inconsistent in roughly 40 % of cases;
- More than half of consumers' expressions revealed micro-expressions of "contempt," "disgust," or "anger";
- Almost no genuine smiles were observed, nor were social smiles easily detected.

Compared with paper or online questionnaires, this study shows that most true intentions surface during face-to-face interviews. In particular, consumers' words and expressions were inconsistent in about 40 % of cases, and micro-expressions of "contempt," "disgust," or "anger" accounted for more than 50 %—a striking result.

The reason is that statements such as "This product is really great!" or "I like it very much! I'll buy the same series again!" are, in nearly 40 % of cases, merely polite remarks or even outright lies. Of course, the opposite also occurs: a customer who says "This product is poor" may actually like it very much yet feel "disgust" at their own lie. Such cases usually appear in special complaint situations.

## Different Types of Smiles

- **Smile with corners of the mouth turned down and mouth barely open**

During this smile the lips remain closed. It is a fleeting smile that appears mainly in familiar settings or when one feels satisfied. People who frequently display this smile are stubborn, ambitious, and reluctant to reveal inner emotions.

- **Slight smile with corners of the mouth parted and upper front teeth visible**

When people smile lightly, the upper front teeth are exposed and eye contact with others is usually made. This smile often serves as a greeting among friends, family, or well-liked colleagues or business partners. People who produce this smile tend to be imaginative, creative, energetic in their outlook on life, and humorous.

- **"Ha-ha-ha" open-mouthed laughter**

Hearty laughter usually occurs when everyone is very happy. During such laughter both upper and lower front teeth are visible, and eye contact is generally absent because the head is tilted back.

People who laugh heartily are fundamentally solitary. They are informal, emotionally inconsistent, and



act decisively without hesitation. Women who frequently produce this laugh are generally leadership types.

- **Laughing so hard the whole body shakes**

Such people are open-minded, straightforward, and sincere.

- **Laughing in response to someone else's laughter**

Such people are optimistic, outgoing, emotionally reactive, compassionate, and positive toward life.

- **Usually quiet but laughing exaggeratedly**

Such people may seem unenthusiastic or unfriendly with strangers, yet once they form a genuine relationship they value friendship highly and, at the right moment, will go to great lengths for a friend.

- **Nervous smile**

The person smiles in a flustered manner, suddenly stops, glances at others, and resumes smiling. This indicates a sense of inferiority and lack of self-confidence; the person is even afraid of smiling incorrectly.

- **Covering the mouth while smiling**

Such people are mostly introverted and gentle; they do not readily reveal their true inner thoughts even to close friends.

- **Laughing in fits and starts**

Such people are generally cold and indifferent.

However, smiles do not always symbolize goodness or goodwill. People often use fake smiles to hide feelings and mask expressions; without careful observation it is difficult to read them.

More than a century ago, scientists discovered that humans possess not only genuine smiles but also feigned ones. When we do not truly feel close to our surroundings, we use fake smiles to face them, while genuine smiles are reserved for those or those things we truly care about. In fact, infants only a few weeks old already know to save genuine smiles for their mothers and to use fake smiles with others.

## **Chapter 4 The "Killing Intent" in Smiles**

Smiling is one of the most frequently used expressions in daily life and also one of the most complex—arguably the foremost among all expressions. It is a means of conveying emotions between humans. Life cannot do without laughter; without laughter people easily fall ill, and the illnesses are often serious.

In *Laugh Your Way to Health*, the renowned American psychiatrist Dr. Raymond Moody writes: "I have found that laughter is a human survival ability, just as a physician examines every part of the body. Laughter has become a correct and effective indicator for measuring physical health." "In general, laughter is used more to express happiness and joy, manifested through facial-muscle movements. It is mostly produced when sensory organs (especially the eyes and ears) contact external objects or language, converting them into information that reaches the cerebral cortex, after which the brain issues movement commands to the facial and even whole-body muscles. Sometimes laughter not only moves the muscles but also vibrates the vocal cords, thereby producing sound." In other words, it is a means of conveying emotions between humans. American psychiatrist Dr. William Fry also emphasizes that life cannot do without laughter; without laughter people easily fall ill, and the illnesses are often serious.

Like other expressions, smiles are divided into two major categories—"pathological smiles" and "normal smiles"—according to manner and type.

A pathological smile gives the visual impression of smiling, yet the person has no subjective intention or need to smile and feels no normal inner sensation of smiling.

Normal smiles are further divided into "active smiles" and "reactive smiles." Active smiles are mostly polite behaviors displayed by cultured individuals in many social settings or interpersonal interactions—for example, by etiquette hostesses or hotel greeters. They can also serve, under certain specific circumstances, as a way to express inner feelings or emotions. Because these specific circumstances vary, the forms of expression are also diverse, such as slight smiles, hearty laughter, sneers, bitter smiles, and cold smiles. Reactive smiles are characterized overall by being involuntary, reflexive actions triggered by external stimuli. Reactive smiles are further divided into physiological and psychological types. Physiological smiles involve the common term "funny bone"—laughter triggered by a funny bone. Psychological smiles have two situations: one is the stress-induced, sensitive laughter common among adolescents, especially girls; the other is involuntary laughter caused when the visual or auditory organs are stimulated by some externally comical image, phenomenon, text, sound, or language.

The diversity of forms and types gives smiles various connotations, making them more intriguing and harder to fathom.

### **The Underestimated Smile**

Among common expressions, the smile is undoubtedly the most likable. Yet you may not know that the smile is the most special of all expressions, because other expressions require at least three to five muscles while a smile needs only one. Even from dozens of meters away it can be spotted at a glance, with higher recognizability than other expressions. Moreover, the smile is the hardest expression to resist: if someone smiles at you, you will smile back.

Nevertheless, this simplest expression is also the most complex. You may find it hard to imagine that there are dozens of kinds of smiles, each differing in facial appearance and underlying meaning. People smile when happy, when first establishing rapport, when enjoying something, when sad, when saying one thing and meaning another, and when being insincere... In reality, these many smiles can basically be classified into genuine smiles and fake smiles.

Many people are confident they can distinguish smile categories, yet experiments prove this is difficult. Paul Ekman once conducted an experiment in which he invited more than a dozen university students to an observation room to differentiate various smiles. Some smiles came from sweet talk in romantic relationships, some from watching comedy films, and some from attempts to conceal having just watched a bloody horror film. The students' answers were essentially no better than random guesses; they could hardly match expressions to their sources. The main reason for this outcome was that the students did not know the kinds of smiles or the differences among them, let alone how to distinguish genuine from fake smiles<|eos|>

### **Various Types of Smiles**

Smiles fall into many categories. For genuine smiles, the three most common are the slight smile, the light laugh, and the big laugh.

During a slight smile, the lips remain closed. It is a fleeting expression that appears mainly in familiar settings or when a person feels satisfied (see Figure 2.13).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.13 微笑]*

When people give a light laugh, their upper front teeth become visible and they usually make eye contact (see Figure 2.14). This smile often serves as a greeting among friends, family members, and colleagues or business partners for whom one feels genuine regard.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.14 轻笑]*

A big laugh typically appears only when everyone present is very happy. Both the upper and lower front teeth show (see Figure 2.15), and eye contact is usually absent because the head tilts backward.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.15 大笑]*

Yet not every smile signals warmth or goodwill. Decades ago, Professor Ewan Grant of the Department of Psychology at the University of Birmingham coined the technical term “rectangular smile.”

The rectangular smile commonly appears when people feel obliged to force a polite expression. It therefore does not accompany genuine feelings of ease or pleasure.

When someone produces a rectangular smile, the lips pull away from both rows of teeth to form a rectangle. In reality this is not a sincere smile and can even be read as an expression of discomfort (see Figure 2.16).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.16 不真诚的长方形微笑]*

## The Secret of Laughter

Laughter is one of humanity’s oldest forms of communication; through it people consciously or unconsciously reveal aspects of their inner state. Observant individuals notice that women laugh more readily than men. A man’s low-pitched laugh registers around 43 hertz, whereas a woman’s sharp laugh can reach 2,083 hertz—high enough, in theory, to shatter glass. Women’s laughter is also more melodious, while men’s laughter often resembles mere breathing. Experiments dividing participants into all-male, all-female, and mixed groups found that men laugh more when gathered among themselves, whereas women laugh more in the presence of men. When a man and a woman who do not know each other converse, a woman’s token “ha-ha” indicates disinterest in the man or the topic; frequent audible laughter signals interest, and the more she laughs the stronger the interest becomes. When her laughter synchronizes with the man’s remarks, her interest reaches its peak.

Women are also more adept than men at using laughter to send signals that advance their own goals—an ability perhaps rooted in temperament. Men’s conversational skills, including their use of laughter, remain comparatively crude. Women view laughter not only as a sign of personal comfort or good mood but also as a means of evoking emotions in others. In certain situations laughter can indirectly convey acceptance or refusal, soften tension, and resolve awkwardness without causing loss of face.

## Reading True Intentions Behind Micro-expressions

When a customer’s true feelings are not expressed in words but surface in micro-expressions, various situations arise. Hearing the line “This is a special dish the chef prepared with full dedication, made especially for our valued guest ○○ today,” a customer may reply “It’s really delicious” even though the taste is not to

their liking; their face may nevertheless flash a micro-expression of “disgust.” Such moments occur not only in fine restaurants but also at family gatherings. At a colleague’s or friend’s home, no one will openly declare “This isn’t good!” even if the food does not suit their palate. If the micro-expression of disgust is detected, the host can avoid pressing more food and instead offer alternatives or refrain from serving the same dish on future occasions.

Consider a retail setting. When a salesperson claims, “Our products are definitely better than those of any other store,” the customer may display a micro-expression of disgust. A customer who knows more about the merchandise than the salesperson may even feel “This clerk really doesn’t know anything” and register contempt—an emotion that subtly conveys superiority.

When a customer’s sense of superiority is triggered, a useful mechanism is to invite their opinion on whether any items on display could be improved. The suppressed feeling of contempt may then prompt the customer to voice suggestions. Even if a sale is not completed immediately, the exchange can yield valuable feedback.

## 8. Vacant Smile

At first glance the image may be mistaken for a sneer of disdain. The raised upper lip and the shallow nasolabial folds beside the nostrils match the minimal features of disgust. Because disgust is a negative emotion that warrants attention, the eyes remain alert and rejecting even without a furrowed brow; they do not appear vacant.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-31]

1. The levator palpebrae superioris muscle relaxes fully, allowing the upper eyelid to droop to the upper edge of the pupil.
2. The frontalis muscle contracts and lifts the eyebrows while barely raising the upper eyelid.
3. Only the corners of the mouth and lips suggest a smile; the cheeks show slight but indistinct elevation, and the lower-eyelid smile markers are barely discernible. The mouth shape nevertheless confirms an absence of tension and a positive tendency. Combined with the vacant eyes, the smile appears intoxicated or coquettish.

People automatically close their eyes to reduce visual input under two conditions: physiological fatigue of the nervous system (drowsiness or intoxication) and moments of enjoyment or the expression of enjoyment. Partial closure of the eyelids allows other senses to register the stimulus more fully (see detailed explanation in Chapter 10). Consequently, lowered upper eyelids commonly appear during intoxication, coquetry, drunkenness, or drowsiness. The first reading of such a smile is therefore one of intoxication; the second possibility is infatuation (leering). Such scenes abound in advertising and film, where femme fatales and lechers frequently display this expression.

## A Smile Does Not Equal Satisfaction

In customer-complaint situations, micro-expressions of anger are often visible. Customers in Japan and other Asian regions tend to voice complaints while wearing a polite smile rather than first showing overt displeasure. Can you detect their true intent and read the micro-expressions hidden between the gaps of that polite smile?

The following is a real case from a chain restaurant.

A part-time staff member responded to a smiling, complaining customer according to standard procedure. At the time the matter seemed minor, yet several days later the company headquarters received a complaint call: "What on earth is going on? How could you handle it this way?" The part-timer's response had clearly failed to soothe the customer's emotions.

The staff member later explained that because the customer smiled, they had not realized the customer was already angry; consequently the complaints were not taken seriously. Although the incident occurred off-site and cannot be assessed directly, the fact that the complaint reached headquarters indicates that an anger micro-expression was likely concealed behind the customer's smile—an expression the part-timer completely overlooked.

Micro-expressions can reveal a customer's genuine feelings. Interpreting them allows service to be upgraded in real time and continuous improvement of hospitality quality.

## Explanation

Both corners of the mouth are raised and no wrinkles appear at the outer corners of the eyes, indicating a polite smile. When a polite smile appears on a respondent's face, the questioner can probe the underlying meaning with the following approaches.

Respondent: "Well... (observing the polite smile) Would you like a more detailed explanation?"

Questioner: "Understanding the overall structure is enough."

When the respondent produces a polite smile merely to leave a good impression, the questioner often replies: "Yes, please explain in more detail."

Respondent: "Well... (observing the polite smile) Is there anything missing in the explanation?"

Questioner: "It's fine."

This response conveys the unspoken message "I've already heard enough; stop talking."

Respondent: "Well... (observing the polite smile) Any other questions?"

Questioner: "Yes."

This response conveys the unspoken message "Answering one question takes so long; even though I have more to ask, time is short—please move to the next question."

A polite smile can carry many meanings. Detecting it allows the speaker to pause, refrain from continuing unchecked, and instead pose guiding questions while carefully observing the other person, thereby improving communication quality.

## 1. Laughter as a Social Tool

When alone, a person's larynx rarely trembles; giggling, soft laughter, and high-pitched laughter occur only in the presence of others. Laughing individuals frequently interrupt their speech, resume only after the laughter subsides, and seldom notice they are doing so. Professor Robert Provine of the University of Maryland, an authority on laughter and author of *Laughter: A Scientific Investigation*, writes that people laugh 50 percent more often while speaking than while listening, and they laugh thirty times more frequently in social settings

than when alone with no entertainment devices present. Provine further notes that the key trigger for laughter is not jokes but other people. Laughter is not merely a routine response to humor; it functions as a social bond that links individuals, fosters rapport, and is employed throughout social interaction. Baholovski likewise observes, "Clearly, people seek opportunities to laugh." Thus laughter during conversation acts as social lubricant: it arouses interest, eases tension, and relaxes the atmosphere. It can also reduce stress and lighten difficult moments. In the workplace, affirmative laughter can lift team morale, strengthen resolve, and facilitate smooth cooperation.

### **Explanation**

At first glance the customer appears to be smiling, yet wrinkles are visible around the nose. This is the micro-expression of disgust. Disgust is concealed behind the polite smile—an especially common pattern among Asians, particularly Japanese people.

Therefore, when a polite smile appears, extra attention is required. Negative micro-expressions may surface in the intervals between polite smiles.

The function of disgust is to "exclude what is unpleasant." How can the unpleasant element be removed for the customer? The customer has already eaten the unpalatable dish and, despite disliking it, has politely said it tastes good. Should the dish be replaced immediately? Doing so would nullify the customer's courteous compliment. A better approach is to offer improved service without causing embarrassment—perhaps by naturally asking whether any foods are disliked, inquiring whether the flavor is too distinctive, offering an alternative dish, or adjusting the bill for the day.

### **Explanation**

The superior's left corner of the mouth is rising—the micro-expression of contempt. The key point here is the mismatch between the superior's words and the micro-expression.

The superior's statement is positive, yet the micro-expression is negative. Micro-expressions signal suppressed emotion; they indicate that the superior's words are merely polite and that genuine enthusiasm is unlikely. Possible reasons for the contempt might include thoughts such as "A university student's opinion is useless," "This idea cannot produce a best-selling product," or "The plan is too naïve." Whatever the reason, the superior feels superior. In such cases, the subordinate should support that sense of superiority with questions such as "My idea may be a bit naïve—could I borrow your wisdom?" "How can we better understand ordinary consumers' needs?" or "To improve the plan, may I hear your suggestions?" Framing questions that bolster the other person's ego can turn the situation around and may even motivate an otherwise unengaged superior.

### **How to Distinguish a Polite Smile from a Genuine Smile**

The expression described below is not a micro-expression, yet it must be noted during presentations: the polite smile.

A smile deliberately displayed when nothing is amusing is artificial. People produce polite smiles in many situations—sometimes to mask negative emotions, sometimes to make a favorable impression, and sometimes to deceive or to show sympathy.

The polite smile itself is neither good nor bad. What matters is recognizing that it does not reflect genuine positive emotion. Polite smiles are obvious and easy to identify, yet during a focused presentation they are

easily overlooked. Consequently, a polite smile is often mistaken for a genuine expression of happiness.

Misreading a polite smile as a genuine smile is less serious than misreading contempt, yet correctly distinguishing the two prevents the false impression that a presentation is proceeding well when it is not. Noticing polite smiles allows timely adjustments to the presentation flow.

## 9. Smug Smile

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-32]*

1. Eyebrows are slightly raised but the upper eyelids are not, negating surprise and indicating confidence.
2. Gaze shifts to the right, avoiding direct eye contact with the stimulus source—a visual blocking behavior signaling unwillingness to receive or convey information.
3. Lower-eyelid shape matches smile characteristics.
4. Upper lip is raised, nasolabial fold is pronounced; corners of the mouth are pulled sideways, lengthening both lips. With the lower lip pushed upward by the mentalis muscle, the lip line remains horizontally straight, indicating that without the mentalis the line would curve downward—consistent with a smile.
5. The combined action of the raised mentalis and depressor anguli oris participates in suppressing the mouth shape, showing that the person does not wish the smile to appear obvious.

**Summary:** Within a confident smile (eyebrows and lower eyelids), active suppression (mouth) occurs together with visual blocking that halts effective communication—characteristic of a secret smug smile.

## 7. Sly Smile (Responsive Smile)

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-30]*

1. Both eyebrows are lowered and slightly furrowed (slight frown lines appear between the brows).
2. The orbicularis oculi contracts, narrowing the eyes; the upper eyelid is not raised (neither anger nor fear); the lower eyelid is raised, curved, and lifted, with a groove formed below by pressure from the raised cheek (smile characteristic).
3. The corners of the mouth are pulled toward the ears by the zygomaticus major, cheeks are raised (smile characteristic).
4. The lower lip is pushed upward by contraction of the mentalis, pressed against the upper lip, and the chin shows a bulge (acknowledgment characteristic).

Lowered eyebrows add a slightly mischievous quality to the smile. Contraction of the corrugator supercilii suggests active thinking, while the suppressed lips highlight a hint of malice. Even if the expression does not appear outright sly, it conveys shrewdness—as though a clever idea has occurred.

### Step One: Tell a Very Funny Joke

Laughter is one of the most typical and revealing mouth movements for observing another person's emotions. Different people's laughter in response to the same event, person, or setting can objectively reflect personality traits.

- People who laugh uproariously are usually socially adept, straightforward, and optimistic, putting others at ease.

- People who laugh loudly tend to be bold and informal yet lack patience and give up when faced with difficulty.
- People who smile gently are relatively introverted, attentive to detail, and skilled at analyzing others' words, though not eloquent.
- People who laugh with narrowed eyes are stubborn, goal-oriented, and prefer working alone, lacking a cooperative spirit.
- People who do not laugh possess strong self-control, remain rational and serious, and can make the negotiation atmosphere feel oppressive.

Therefore, employees who laugh with narrowed eyes or do not laugh at all can be sent back to continue their regular work.

### **Different Smiles Hide Different Secrets**

Micro-expression keywords: Laughing before speaking. A smile is usually considered a signal of friendliness. However, psychologists have found that there are many kinds of smiles—genuine smiles, hearty laughter, laughing with the hand covering the mouth, fake smiles, and so on. These are determined by a person's personality and different psychological states.

A smile is usually seen as a signal of joy and friendliness. Yet psychologists' research has revealed that smiling can also reflect a person's inner world and exists as a form of communication. For example, a bitter smile is not a genuine smile but a release of pent-up distress; a gentle smile can make interpersonal relationships more harmonious. People smile in many ways. What secrets, then, lie hidden behind these smiles?

### **Case**

You want to commercialize a new VCR product and are discussing the matter with your supervisor. Up to now, product development has always been based on opinions from the company's internal development team. This time you want to gather input from a youth team of two hundred university students and reflect their views in the product when developing the new model.

You therefore propose to your supervisor that the university students be assembled every Sunday for discussion, that their opinions be collected within two months, and that the new product be launched within the following year. You hope the supervisor will approve the plan and begin implementation. After hearing the proposal, the supervisor responds—

Supervisor: "Excellent! That sounds like a very interesting plan!"

### **Soft Laughter**

People whose laughter is soft are gentle and honest by nature. They dislike arguing with others and yield at every turn. They are generally reasonable, can take things in stride, and consider others' feelings, so they earn respect and affection. They are also skilled at handling interpersonal disputes, helping to calm the emotions of those involved, and achieving fairness that satisfies both sides.

In every aspect of our lives we hear others' laughter. Once you understand the personality secrets hidden behind smiles, you can identify people by their laughter and know their character and inner thoughts in advance.



## Five, Smiles in ID Photos

Smiles in ID photos. Sometimes a smile is not triggered by pleasant emotions but may stem from a desire to express friendliness. This kind of smile is most common in ID photos. In China, most people's ID photos show a closed-mouth smile. This is because, unlike a full smile that can cause noticeable facial distortion and look unnatural, a slight smile feels gentler and produces smaller facial changes, resulting in higher resemblance between the photo and the person.

### Case

You are giving a presentation at a planning meeting. After the presentation, questions are invited from the floor.

You: "Are there any questions?"

Questioner: "Where did Mr. ○○ obtain the data shown?"

You: "These are barometric-pressure data from Asia and Africa, analyzed by regression. Specifically..."

Questioner: "....."

## Section 2: The Secrets Behind Smiles

We know that smiling is an innate human survival ability and a reflection of emotion. Yet why humans smile remains a question that is still difficult to answer definitively and has no settled conclusion. Even so, we can still find some common points about smiling from clues in everyday life.

### Frequent Belly Laughs

Such people are mostly straightforward and cheerful. They do not hide their feelings; they cry when they want to cry and laugh when they want to laugh, living freely. They have a strong sense of humor, and others feel relaxed when interacting with them. They are also very caring and always eager to help those in need. They do not favor the rich over the poor, nor do they envy those stronger than themselves, so they are well worth knowing.

### Dry Laughter

Their laughter is intermittent and slightly cold. Such people are often found in business; most are realistic and practical, possess sharp observational skills, and can glimpse others' inner thoughts through details, thereby grasping others' weaknesses. They are also emotionally distant, consider only their own interests, and lose enthusiasm once the other party has no further value to them.

### Chuckling Quietly

Such people are mostly conservative in character, cautious and reserved in their dealings, and somewhat shy when interacting with others. They set high standards for others and find it hard to like anyone who fails to meet them. Once someone does meet their standards, however, they regard that person as a close friend with whom they will share both hardships and joys.

## Selection Scenario: Advertising Company Supervisor Selecting Project Collaborators

You are a supervisor at an advertising company. A row of young people sits before you. They are outstanding performers from various departments, and you need to select one to negotiate a collaborative project. By creating a scenario and observing their mouths, you can effectively eliminate some candidates and narrow the pool.

### **Case**

A regular customer comes to the restaurant for a meal. The customer says, "I'd like to try something adventurous today—let the chef decide the menu." After the regular finishes eating, you, as the owner, ask for feedback.

Customer: "It was really delicious!"

### **Laughing to Agree with Others**

Such people are easygoing, optimistic, and cheerful. They love life and generally have good interpersonal relationships. They never rush into things and prefer to let events unfold naturally. They do not demand much from life and have no great ambitions of their own. They are content to live each day plainly and happily.

### **Understanding Micro-expressions Can Improve Repeat Customer Rate**

Using the key points explained in this chapter as a conceptual framework, interpret micro-expressions to keep the communication process running smoothly.

The cases that appear in the following exercises are all drawn from real events; only the roles have been appropriately adjusted.

### **Laughing with Hand Covering Mouth**

Such people are mostly introverted and shy when interacting with others. If female, they will not take the initiative to approach others or readily confide their feelings. If male, they often display effeminate traits and seem out of place compared with others.

### **Laughing with Tears**

They frequently laugh so heartily that tears come to their eyes. Such people are emotionally rich and compassionate; they often lend a hand without expecting anything in return. They love life, maintain enthusiasm for everything, and are able to forge ahead actively.

## **11.2.6 Laughing**

A joyful laugh is a movement that converts psychological pleasure into physical pleasure (more aptly called comfort).

### **Question**

How should you respond to the questioner's reaction?

### **Question**

As the owner, how should you respond?

### **Question**

How should you respond to get the supervisor to participate in the plan?

See Contempt (s-contempt).

See Anger (s-anger).

See Fear (s-fear).

See Sadness (s-sadness).

### **Duchenne's Smile**

#### **"Duchenne's Smile"**

Researchers further discovered that the genuine smiles people display on their faces arise from the simultaneous action of the zygomaticus major near the corners of the mouth and the orbicularis oculi surrounding the eyes. In plain terms, this smile engages two muscles, causing the corners of the mouth to lift while crow's feet appear at the outer corners of the eyes.

Scientists note that because these two muscles are not under voluntary control, they cannot be faked at all; the resulting smile is a genuine, heartfelt expression that makes others feel truly happy. In honor of the Frenchman Guillaume Duchenne who discovered it, this smile is also known as the "Duchenne smile (Duchenne Smile)."

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### **Smiling Eyes**

By observing the crow's feet at the outer corners of the eyes, we can distinguish a genuine smile (invented by the French physician Guillaume Duchenne and therefore also called the "Duchenne smile") from a fake smile (what Chinese speakers often call "smiling with the mouth but not the eyes," also known as a "non-Duchenne smile").

If a person has "smiling eyes," her smile appears sincere. Whether it is a "Duchenne smile" or a "non-Duchenne smile," the corners of her mouth will lift, yet the crow's feet that appear at the outer corners of the eyes during a genuine smile are almost impossible to counterfeit.

## Social Smiles and Genuine Smiles

### An Unnatural Smile May Be a Fake Smile

A smile carries strong contagious power, yet it can also be highly deceptive. By carefully observing whether the other person's smile is natural, one can judge whether they are sincere and avoid being misled by a false smile.

The saying "a fist does not strike a smiling face" explains why "smiling tigers" appear everywhere in daily life and work. A smile is originally a beautiful expression, but many people use it as a tool to conceal their own unease or to gain more benefits.

Under the influence of a smile, people tend to lower their guard, allowing habitual liars to take advantage. Without awareness or the ability to distinguish, one can suffer major losses when dealing with such individuals. Therefore, we must learn to tell natural smiles from unnatural ones so we can stay alert and avoid being deceived.

As early as the nineteenth century, a French scientist studied the mechanism behind human smiles. Through scientific experiments he discovered that smiles are controlled by two sets of muscles. The first set consists of the zygomatic muscles, which pull the corners of the mouth back, expose the teeth, raise the cheeks, and extend the smile to the corners of the eyes. These muscles can be consciously controlled; even without any genuine reason for happiness, a person can activate them to produce a fake smile. The second set consists of the orbicularis oculi muscles around the eyes. When they contract, they narrow the eyes and create wrinkles at the outer corners. Their movement is involuntary and occurs only when a person truly feels happy; it cannot be consciously directed. Hence this type of smile is always genuine. In simple terms, a sincere smile is the natural expression of a pleasant mood; it is not subject to will or conscious control.

When someone feels genuinely happy, the signal reaches the brain's emotion-regulation area and generates a pleasurable feeling. This feeling causes the mouth muscles to contract, the lips to part slightly, the cheeks to rise, and the eyes to form fine wrinkles while the eyebrows lower slightly, producing a sincere, heartfelt smile. Therefore, to judge whether a smile is real or fake, look at the narrowing of the eyes. A genuine smile begins with the eyes narrowing; as soon as the positive emotion arises, the orbicularis oculi muscles contract strongly, causing the eyelids to bulge and shorten, the facial muscles to lift overall, and the upper and lower eyelids to press against each other.

If only the corners of the mouth move while the lips remain tightly closed, fine lines appear only around the mouth, the orbicularis oculi muscles do not contract, and the smile looks unnatural, it can be judged a fake smile—commonly called "a smile that does not reach the eyes." During a fake smile the cheek muscles stay relaxed and the eyes do not narrow. Skilled liars often bunch up the zygomatic muscles layer by layer to compensate, an action that affects the orbicularis oculi and cheeks, narrows the eyes, and makes the smile appear more natural and credible. When someone speaks insincerely, this unnatural smile often appears. For example, when a flatterer compliments a superior by saying, "You are so far-sighted; this kind of forward-thinking vision is not something ordinary people possess," the speaker, knowing the words are false, will display an unnatural smile to mask discomfort.

In addition, a fake smile often shows asymmetry between the two sides of the face. Left-handed people tend to raise the right corner of the mouth higher when faking a smile; right-handed people raise the left corner higher. A genuine smile, by contrast, lifts both corners of the mouth to the maximum extent and never appears asymmetrical.

### **Smiling When Feeling Extreme Anger, Sadness, or Hatred**

People usually describe this type of smile as “laughing on the outside while crying on the inside.” Even when filled with hostility, a person may still appear talkative and relaxed on the surface.

They behave this way because openly displaying inner desires or thoughts would violate social norms, risk alienating others, or invite public criticism and social sanctions.

A classic example is a couple’s quarrel. When husband A and wife B first married, they were deeply in love and inseparable. As daily life became routine and the novelty faded, they began arguing over trivial matters such as household supplies. At first they quarreled heatedly but reconciled within hours. Later, quarrels became frequent; they entered a phase of mutual indifference. Still, they had to face family and friends. To avoid detection, they gradually adopted a façade of affection whenever others were present. When alone, the house remained silent. Eventually they began speaking again even when no one else was around, but only about matters that had to be discussed. When their incompatibility reached an extreme, unhappy expressions gradually disappeared and both began to display smiles and courteous, affectionate attitudes.

A judge who frequently handles divorce cases once remarked that when either spouse adopts this attitude, the marital relationship has become irreconcilable.

Thus, reading facial expressions can easily lead to errors. Dark clouds do not always bring rain, and a smiling face does not always indicate happiness. Often people swallow their grievances while wearing a sweet expression. Conversely, a sullen face may conceal inner laughter.

Facial expression is a rich form of life posture and social art—an embodiment of style, identity, cultivation, temperament, and expressive ability.

Most people believe facial expressions play a vital role in conveying thoughts, sensations, and emotions, and that the content they reveal is fuller and deeper than what the mind alone conveys. The face not only conceals a person’s good and evil, reason, knowledge, intellect, and emotions but also reflects physical constitution, bodily structure, and tendencies toward physiological or psychological disorders.

Yet few people know how to categorize facial expressions in detail. Below we examine how changes in each part of the face correspond to psychological shifts.

### **“Social Smiles” as a Way to Express Negative Emotions Without Damaging Harmony**

Up to this point we have discussed expressions common across cultures. This section focuses on expressions typical of Asians, especially Japanese people. When ordinary Japanese people feel confused about what to do or when negative emotions surge, they tend to respond with a social smile to gloss over the situation. This tendency arises from a desire to maintain harmony with others.

Consider the relationship between a superior and a subordinate. If a subordinate receives an unreasonable reprimand, a Western subordinate might display an “anger” expression, directly point out the unreasonableness, and assert their own position. A Japanese or other Asian subordinate, however, even while feeling “anger,” is unlikely to confront the superior. Most will use a social smile to ease the atmosphere, preferring to exit the situation unscathed. In certain cultures or groups, avoiding conflict is regarded as a prudent rule of thumb; the habitual expression that results is called an “emotional reflex.”

Because of this emotional reflex, expressions vary across cultures. Anyone who feels “anger” will initially show an “anger” expression. Under the influence of the emotional reflex, however, the “anger” expression is weakened, replaced by a micro-expression, or substituted by another expression. Consequently, the visible reaction to the same situation can differ.

When an emotional reflex occurs, how can one tell whether a Japanese or Asian person’s “happiness” expression is genuine or feigned? When a “happiness” expression mixes with other expressions, three patterns appear:

1. The “happiness” expression used to conceal negative emotions;
2. The pattern in which negative emotions and “happiness” emotions arise simultaneously;
3. The “happiness” expression used to encourage oneself out of negative emotions.

The pattern related to the emotional reflex is the first. The following sections explain each in turn.

### **Emotional Switching: Self-Control**

The third pattern, which lies between the first and second, refers to a smile that appears when a person deliberately controls their emotions. Consider the same scenario as in the first pattern: a subordinate initially feels “contempt” toward a superior who boasts about their own ideas. Upon noticing this negative emotion and wishing to switch to a positive one, the subordinate displays a “happiness” expression. This mechanism usually operates unconsciously. Sometimes the social smile transforms into a genuine “happiness” expression; at other times the social smile remains on the face.

This mechanism of shifting from negative to positive emotion is called the “self-regulation function of emotion.” When a person cannot tolerate remaining in a negative state, they reflexively produce a positive expression and thereby convert the emotion into a positive one. Have you ever noticed someone who is clearly angry yet still smiling? Such individuals exemplify the self-regulation function. This phenomenon reveals an interesting fact: emotion does not always cause a smile; sometimes smiling itself can improve one’s mood.

Producing an expression that subsequently generates the corresponding emotion is known as the “facial-feedback hypothesis,” an important hypothesis in emotion theory.

It is generally difficult to distinguish the three patterns precisely. As noted earlier, the first and second patterns can be differentiated by comparing social smiles with genuine smiles. In the second pattern, when negative emotions and genuine “happiness” appear together, the genuine smile serves as the indicator. In the first pattern, a genuine smile does not appear. In the third pattern, the expression may look like a social smile or may become a genuine smile; it can be understood as the mode that arises when a person who should be showing a negative emotion instead displays a “smile” in front of others.

### **Explanation**

Ms. Ueno’s expression shows both eyebrows raised and drawn together, eyes wide open, lower eyelids tensed, and a tense gaze. This is a “fear” micro-expression.

Amid Ms. Ueno’s seemingly confident words, a “fear” micro-expression appears on her face. What is she afraid of? Two possibilities exist: fear related to the work content or fear related to the work format.

Content-related fear might stem from “anxiety about whether she can complete the task with her own abilities” or “anxiety about finishing on time.” Format-related fear might involve questions such as “How should I organize the materials? Should I use PowerPoint or Word?” In such cases it is helpful to offer words that support Ms. Ueno regarding both content and format.

Saying something like “Do you need anyone’s assistance? Shall we review the report-preparation process together?” can provide useful advance confirmation. Alternatively, directly asking “You look a bit uneasy—will you be all right handling this alone?” is advisable. A superior might normally say, “Let me know if anything comes up.” Yet a simple statement is often insufficient. Overly polite or overly thoughtful subordinates may feel uneasy in such situations and pretend everything is fine while handling the work. In the worst case, the deadline is missed and the report remains far from completion, creating an irreparable problem. Therefore, when a superior realizes something must be conveyed, the message should be as specific as possible.

### **Explanation**

Each expression is explained below.

1. “Contempt” + “social smile.” The left corner of the mouth is pulled upward higher than the right. This is a characteristic of the “contempt” expression.
2. “Anger” + “social smile.” The eyebrows are pressed together forcefully and the lips are tensed. This is a characteristic of the “anger” expression.
3. “Sadness” + “social smile.” The eyebrows are drawn inward and raised. This is a characteristic of the “sadness” expression.
4. “Shame.” This is a trick question. It is an expression outside the seven basic expressions introduced in this book. The characteristics of the “shame” expression are “gaze directed downward” + “head lowered” + “corners of the mouth raised” + “lips tensed.”
5. “Fear” + “social smile.” The eyebrows are raised and drawn toward the center. The eyes are wide open and the lower eyelids are tensed. This is a characteristic of the “fear” expression.
6. “Contempt” + “social smile.” The left corner of the mouth is pulled upward higher than the right. This is a characteristic of the “contempt” expression.
7. “Disgust” + “social smile.” Wrinkles appear around the nose. Only the eyebrows are lowered. This is a characteristic of the “disgust” expression.
8. “Disgust” + “social smile.” Wrinkles appear around the nose and the outer ends of the eyebrows are slightly lowered.

### **A Feigned “Happiness” Expression as Evidence of “Contempt”**

The first pattern is also called a social smile. It is a smile used to mask emotion or to deceive, produced under the influence of an emotional reflex. For example, when a subordinate listens to a superior boast about an idea, the subordinate notices flaws in the idea and feels “contempt” toward the superior who has not noticed them, generating a sense of superiority. The subordinate knows the superior dislikes disagreement, so the subordinate cannot voice a different opinion. While the superior continues to emphasize the idea’s excellence, the subordinate does not share that view and therefore displays a “contempt” micro-expression, the result of suppressing disdain. Simply suppressing the disdain, however, may not be enough to fool the superior.

To further conceal the “contempt,” the subordinate overlays a “happiness” expression on the “contempt” micro-expression, producing a combination of “contempt” micro-expression + “happiness” expression. This

"happiness" expression is not born of genuine pleasure; the subordinate feels no joy and is merely feigning the expression.

### **Psychology Mini-Class**

Researchers at the University of London recruited many volunteers to distinguish real smiles from fake ones. The volunteers proved highly accurate at identifying the two qualitatively different smiles.

The researchers noted that genuine and fake smiles activate different brain regions. Fake smiles increase activity in the medial prefrontal cortex, whereas genuine smiles activate only the auditory area in the temporal lobe. In other words, simply observing the duration of a smile can reveal whether it is real or fake. How do the durations differ?

A genuine smile lasts only 2–4 seconds. A fake smile, by contrast, can last much longer, like an overstayed guest after a meal—awkward and unwelcome. Because a fake smile is deliberately constructed, the person producing it does not know when to stop, unintentionally prolonging the expression and thereby revealing the deception. Moreover, a fake smile can be "assembled" in a very short time, whereas a genuine smile cannot; it requires more time to appear.

### **Genuine "Happiness" Concealing a Sense of Superiority**

The second pattern displays genuine "happiness." Consider the same scenario as the first pattern. When a superior boasts about an idea, the subordinate thinks, "Our boss is really childish. Is such an unoriginal idea worth such exaggerated praise? Yet there is something rather endearing about such a naïve superior." At this moment the subordinate's face shows both a "contempt" micro-expression and a "happiness" expression.

The "contempt" micro-expression arises because the subordinate finds it awkward to openly display disdain for the superior's behavior. The "happiness" expression arises from the superior's endearing conduct. Thus, unlike the first pattern, the pleasure expressed in the second pattern stems from a genuine "happiness" emotion.

### **Question**

This question does not involve case analysis but challenges the ability to read expressions in the form of "various negative expressions" + "social smile" emotional patterns. Look at the social smiles shown below and identify the hidden expressions behind each.

### **Case**

You are Ms. Ueno's superior and are about to assign her a task.

You: "Please finish the report by tomorrow."

Ms. Ueno: "No problem. Leave it to me."

### **Question**

What would be the best thing to say to Ms. Ueno?



## Micro-expression Morphological Features of Smiles

### 9.1.1 The Four Great Joys in Life

#### 1. Long Drought Meets Sweet Rain

In agrarian societies, prolonged drought creates a deep longing for rain. Note the word “prolonged,” which already reveals that people have been yearning for rain without receiving it. Each preceding day brought torment and helplessness, so this accumulated frustration has become an unconscious expectation.

Observe that this expectation differs from the logical thought of simply hoping for rain. Yet under the immense psychological pressure built up by the long drought (with no harvest in sight), sweet rain suddenly arrives! The word “meets” vividly captures the element of luck. An event far exceeding the prior helpless expectation brings a joyful smile.

In reality, whether it rains or not is merely ordinary weather and carries no inherent reason for delight. However, because the preceding expectation was so low (prolonged absence of rain would kill the crops), the sudden rainfall produces intense happiness. This extremely low expectation transforms an ordinary occurrence into something deeply pleasing.

If one assumes that a bountiful harvest should naturally bring joy, let us examine the matter more closely.

If, from the first day of sowing, crop growth could be guaranteed with the risk-free certainty of a computer executing an addition—effort without worry, confirmed free of natural or human disasters—the resulting harvest would feel no different from carrying sacks at a dock. The farmer would merely sense that a year of toil had yielded its due reward and that rest was now appropriate. Never having gone hungry, the outcome would seem ordinary, producing no smile, let alone hearty laughter.

The joy of a real-world harvest arises from the successive removal of risks. Through effort and good fortune, the entire growing season passes without drought, flood, disease, pests, or other disasters, culminating in a successful yield. The final relief from ongoing risk naturally brings delight.

Later, “long drought meets sweet rain” extended beyond agriculture. Any situation in which something urgently needed is suddenly obtained produces the same pleasurable emotion. The psychological process in these derivative contexts matches the original agricultural one and requires no separate analysis.

#### 2. Meeting an Old Friend in a Foreign Land

The happiness of meeting an old friend in a foreign land may stem from many causes. Whether it is the reunion with a good friend, the improvement of living conditions through encountering an acquaintance, or simply the relief and rekindling of homesickness, none of these are the focus here.

The contrast between the words “foreign” and “old” highlights the discrepancy between subjective expectation and actual circumstance—an instance in which reality exceeds expectation. In a “foreign” land, alienation or helplessness is the common expectation; an “old friend” offers warmth, safety, fond memories, relief from longing, and perhaps several meals of meat and wine. Delight is inevitable. With social development, people no longer confine themselves to their native places but venture outward in search of environments better suited to survival and reproduction. The notion of a “foreign land” has gradually faded, encounters with old friends have become easier, and such surprises no longer align with current social structures.

#### 3. Wedding Night

Given that the experience of a wedding night is closely tied to prevailing social morality, this item may

no longer evoke the same delight in the current environment. Nevertheless, we can discuss mutual attraction between the sexes.

When seeking a partner, the instinct for optimal reproduction leads people to prefer those with favorable attributes. Attraction to an opposite-sex physique stems from expectations of superior reproductive capacity; attraction to facial features stems from expectations of good health (proper development and distribution of bones, protein, fat, and skin, together with symmetrical and balanced facial features). Although collective psychological influences may produce varying aesthetic standards across societies, the underlying principle tends toward convergence. Preference for a male's social combativeness (now largely economic capacity and social status) parallels the animal-world requirement for male fighting strength.

Yet everyone harbors, or has harbored, a concern: will an excellent member of the opposite sex like me? The answer is not necessarily. Excellent individuals are also favored by many competitors. The other party's choice is typically a top-down "favor." The uncertainty of receiving such favor is the source of shyness.

Shyness produces delayed reactions caused by embarrassment, a complex emotion of worry. Its essence is fear that the other person will dislike or reject oneself—a relatively low subjective expectation. Young women with limited romantic experience (and young men, though later and less frequently) are prone to shyness because they lack sufficient standards for judgment and cannot gauge the probability of acceptance. As experience and emotional history accumulate, self-perception improves (knowing how others evaluate oneself), and shyness gradually diminishes; yet when encountering someone truly desired, the fear of rejection remains. The stakes have risen.

In the presence of a desired person, rejection is the normal expectation; acceptance is a surprise, a tremendous surprise. Consequently, the psychological pleasure of mutual affection becomes enormous joy, capable of triggering physiological pleasure even without the complex muscular actions of smiling. All sources of this joy lie in the perception of being favored (each believes the other is bestowing favor). Feeling favored constitutes positive information that exceeds prior expectations.

#### 4. Passing the Imperial Examination

Students fear examinations, past and present, because the examination system employs a deduction-based evaluation. Some educational authorities even require teachers to design tests that produce the notorious normal distribution curve. Students therefore habitually worry about what they have not mastered (and will lose points for) rather than reinforcing what they have mastered. They regard the presence of unfamiliar questions on every exam as normal (and teachers design accordingly); scoring full marks on every exam is, statistically, abnormal.

Likewise, occasionally performing below peers of comparable ability is considered normal. Learning after an exam that one's score is not as high as XXX's elicits no dejection or surprise, because this outcome matches routine expectation. By contrast, suddenly outperforming all peers of the same level produces surprise.

Combining these two factors, few people dare to guarantee "success" (i.e., passing the imperial examination) after a major test. This also explains why, in the interval between the exam and the release of results, few discuss their performance or future plans in a high-profile manner.

The appearance of one's name on the imperial list represents a somewhat general joy: years of hardship and anxiety receive affirmation, and the outcome often signals future improvement in living conditions. The positive gap between a low prior expectation (uncertain success) and a favorable result therefore produces a sense of relief, lightness, and hopeful happiness.

In summary, pleasurable emotions arise primarily from positive stimuli. When something better than one had imagined occurs, pleasurable emotion follows at once.

Real-life examples are more abundant than the four classical joys. A year of hard work ending with a larger-than-expected year-end bonus (an amount matching expectation is taken as deserved; a shortfall produces the opposite mood); successes analogous to passing an exam; finding a way out after many perils; defeating an evenly matched opponent or, after extreme danger, defeating a clearly superior opponent (not a game, but a matter of life and death)—all follow the same pattern.

All instances of happiness share the same psychological origin as the traditional four joys: receipt of positive information exceeding one's prior expectations.

### 1. Type One: The "Better Than Below" Type (Foolish)

Many comedic works feature a relatively "foolish" or similarly "unlucky" character. This figure misunderstands many things, commits numerous errors, or is repeatedly tricked; all such portrayals belong to the first creative technique. Several cases are listed below, though full quotation is omitted due to copyright constraints on the original works.

Excerpt from the xiangsheng piece *Learning to Dance*:

【Comic: You've never been inside the imperial palace. Right inside the gate there's a big concrete pool spouting water, like for washing hands or something. I usually walk over, wash my socks in it, hang them on the edge, and put them back on after dancing. How high-tech is that palace gate? It's made of several doors put together; you can push it like this... (physical demonstration)】

【Straight man: Hey! That's a revolving door—everywhere has them!】

【Comic: So you go in. But you can't walk too fast; if you go fast the front gets tiring, if you go slow the back clips your heels. (physical demonstration) Once you're inside, there's another world.】

【Straight man: How so?】

【Comic: There's another big concrete pool inside, also spouting water, with a pair of socks hanging on the edge—exactly like mine!】

【Straight man: Wait a minute—you went back out, didn't you?】

【Comic: (This door) is too high-tech!】

This segment is widely appreciated within *Learning to Dance*. The novel perspective on the revolving door and the recognition of "two" concrete pools are indeed amusing. Closer analysis reveals the following traits of the protagonist:

① Calling a fountain a "concrete pool" indicates that the character does not know the word "fountain" and has never seen one. The audience immediately understands that the "concrete pool that spouts water" refers to a fountain. The humor arises from the internal comparison: "This dancer doesn't even know what a fountain is."

Imagine replacing the phrase with "fountain"—would any humor remain?

② Washing socks inside the fountain produces an immediate, knowing laugh. The reason is that neither a dancer nor an ordinary person would do such a thing. Whether born of ignorance or stinginess, the act is low-grade. The audience's internal comparison is: "I know not to wash socks in a fountain; this dancer is remarkably ignorant."

③ Describing the revolving door as “several doors put together” and demonstrating the “technique” of passing through it similarly portrays the character as an unsophisticated, low-grade person.

④ The plot point of “another concrete pool with socks on it” after entering constitutes the biggest laugh. The humor lies in the dancer’s failure to realize he has exited and his mistaken belief that he has encountered yet another fountain. Some viewers may not immediately grasp this (a few might suppose another fountain truly exists inside, though this contradicts standard architectural layout), so the added detail “with a pair of socks on it” ensures universal comprehension: “Ha! He came back out again!” The strength of the joke is that the dancer himself remains unaware.

Imagine instead that the dancer had seen revolving doors before and passed through expertly, or that even on a first attempt he completed a 360-degree turn, exited, and immediately recognized, “Oh no! I came back out.” The audience would not laugh so heartily.

Many similar xiangsheng pieces exist. A comparable creative device is the construction of an unexpected plot that suddenly introduces “foolish” or “unlucky” elements the audience did not anticipate (or whose attention has been directed elsewhere). Such works allow the audience to feel superior by comparing themselves with the low status of the character, thereby achieving a satisfying or even exceeding self-perception.

Another brief example of the same style:

【Comic: Their life is very refined; every detail is handled with great care. Take the morning, for instance. Upon waking, first brush teeth, wash face, wash feet...】

【Straight man: Hold on. Wash feet? Who washes feet in the morning?】

【Comic: Forgot last night, so did it this morning. Shows refinement!】

In the video, the audience’s strongest laughter occurs precisely when “wash feet” follows “wash face.” The humor can be rendered as: “Who washes feet in the morning and then claims to be especially refined?” Performing a foolish act that violates common sense while loudly asserting one’s elegance and taste is what makes the moment laughable.

Yet my three-year-old son, who could also understand the content, immediately asked, “Why does he say he washes his feet in the morning?” The child did not find it funny; he merely noted a difference from his own habit of washing feet before bed. He therefore asked seriously why.

Two reasons explain why the child did not laugh:

① A three-year-old is still in the process of learning and has not formed independent judgment; he cannot yet distinguish normal from abnormal. He does not regard morning foot-washing as strange (a violation of convention) but simply as different from his own routine. His concern is “Why does this uncle do something different from what I usually do?” rather than “Does anyone wash feet in the morning? How odd!” Consequently he does not perceive the behavior as “foolish” (a low-grade deviation).

② The preceding setup—“life is very refined”—directs the audience toward high refinement before introducing the low-grade act of morning foot-washing to create contrast. The “refined” cue does not register with a young child; after hearing the whole segment the child registers only the single anomalous item “morning foot-washing” and experiences no contrast. Without comparison, the expected pleasure does not arise. Removing the “refined” setup and simply stating “he gets up, brushes teeth, washes face, washes feet...” would still seem odd, yet the satirical intent would remain unclear.

Thus this humorous technique first guides the audience's thinking in the opposite direction—usually upward—then establishes a low reference point that allows the audience to obtain self-satisfaction. This unexpected and substantial satisfaction naturally produces hearty laughter.

### **Unveiling the Mask of the Fake Smile**

A fake smile is a mask we often wear. Although we feel nothing of the sort inside, we force the expression onto our face; although no positive emotion has been triggered, we produce a smile so that others will think we are happy. A fake smile is not concealment. It differs completely from a bitter smile or a smile of fear. Its purpose is to mislead others into believing our emotion, and it therefore carries a certain deceptive quality.

To identify the characteristic clues of a fake smile, Paul Ekman recruited a group of students for a small experiment. He took them to a small screening room and told them in advance that he would show a heart-warming film and afterward ask each of them to share their impressions. He stressed one point: the film had been carefully selected and he hoped for their serious feedback. This was in fact a psychological pressure tactic; he wanted to plant the idea in the students' minds that "we must not disappoint Paul."

One-third of the way through the film, the students realized it was not a heart-warming film at all but a horror film. They did not voice any objection, however, and silently watched the entire movie. Afterward Paul met with each student individually and asked how the film had made them feel. Some students questioned why a horror film had been shown and whether the wrong reel had been loaded. A few students raised no questions and simply offered their own commentary on the film. Paul noticed that the students who had questioned the choice mostly displayed genuine smiles while describing their reactions. The students who had not questioned the choice, however, produced smiles without orbicularis oculi involvement when describing terrifying scenes; their noses even wrinkled and the corners of their mouths tightened. These signals indicated disgust and a sense of having been deceived; they were fake smiles. Because these students did not want to embarrass Paul, they deliberately avoided mentioning that the heart-warming film had turned into a horror film and instead moved straight into their comments, hoping to let Paul know indirectly that the wrong film had been shown. They did not realize that this very psychological impulse caused them to produce fake smiles without noticing while they described the frightening scenes.

We can now summarize the characteristics of a fake smile:

1. The facial expression of a fake smile is asymmetrical. If you photograph a fake smile, the difference between the left and right sides of the face becomes obvious.
2. A fake smile lacks orbicularis oculi participation. In the upper-face expressions, orbicularis oculi involvement is almost indispensable; it is the key to changes in the eyebrows, eyelids, and the muscles surrounding the eyes. In a genuine smile the eyebrows press downward, the upper eyelids lower, the lower eyelids bulge, and the zygomaticus major lifts the cheeks, producing crow's-feet. In a fake smile, however, no change appears in the eyes or eyebrows. Even if the person faking the smile notices the eye change, they absolutely cannot control the downward press of the eyebrows. Therefore a fake smile of ordinary intensity shows no eye change. In an exaggerated fake smile the eyes may change, yet the position of the eyebrows remains fixed. Observing the eyebrows is therefore the best way to distinguish a genuine smile from a fake smile.
3. A genuine smile usually fades slowly, its intensity gradually diminishing until it disappears, like a smooth, gentle parabolic curve. A fake smile disappears in a rigid manner: it either vanishes instantly or freezes for a moment, like a jagged line.

4. Under certain conditions a fake smile can turn into a compound expression in which the smile is mixed with an authentic emotion that cannot be concealed. As in the experiment described earlier, a fake smile may be accompanied by signals of negative emotion such as a wrinkled nose.

Learning to recognize a fake smile does not mean you should show off the skill. Never point at a friend, family member, or colleague and say, "Hey, look at that fake smile—your orbicularis oculi didn't move at all." People are often forced to wear the mask of a fake smile. Once the mask is torn away, strong negative emotions arise, and the person who exposed it will be resented. Even if no immediate reaction occurs, rejection will form in the heart. Use what you have learned to protect yourself and, when possible, to protect others skillfully. Never let this knowledge become a tool for harming others.

## 2. Testing Applications (9787554606841)

A person experiences pleasurable emotion only after receiving a positive stimulus that exceeds subjective expectation. By offering positive evaluations or establishing a relatively low comparative reference, the tester can elicit genuine pleasurable emotion in the subject. Genuine pleasurable emotion produces an authentic smile. This principle can be applied to the psychological-testing process in two ways.

First, by supplying the subject with stimulus information that the person hopes will receive approval from others—or even information that exceeds the subject's expectation—the tester can evoke pleasure, narrow the psychological distance, and remove defensive attitudes. When people are without defensiveness or guardedness, they do not exert effort to perform or conceal, and their true inner thoughts are more easily revealed. From this perspective, testing efficiency and accuracy can be improved.

An important distinction exists between the micro-reaction (微反应) psychological-testing system and the traditional polygraph-testing system in the principles used to set the testing environment. Traditional polygraph protocols require the testing environment to be as simple as possible, minimizing unnecessary stimuli that might interfere with the subject's responses. To ensure absolute accuracy, even moving objects are forbidden in the subject's field of view; the examiner usually sits to the side while questioning, no interaction occurs between the two parties, and all reactions are attributed to instrument capture and analysis. Such testing has an obvious flaw: it is extremely susceptible to interference. The subject's subjective emotions as well as other environmental factors (lighting, noise, weather, etc.) can all affect the final data accuracy.

In contrast, the micro-reaction-based testing system emphasizes authentic emotional expression, the subject's natural state, and interaction between the two parties. Every reaction the subject produces because of other environmental factors constitutes valuable baseline data for comparison with anomalous reactions. For example, if the testing environment is dim, oppressive, and noisy from machinery, the subject may exhibit irritation and related reactions even while answering low-pressure questions; these reactions can serve as baseline data. When a high-pressure question is asked, the subject may produce a freezing response out of fear and forcefully control facial expression, thereby terminating the baseline reaction. This can be analyzed as an "over-correction" anomaly, allowing capture of the subtle psychological change.

Therefore, by offering the other party effective affirmation and praise and capturing an authentic smile, the tester can narrow the psychological distance between the two parties and improve testing efficiency.

The second application is to capture fake smiles according to the morphological features of the standard smile and analyze their causes. Once the features of an authentic smile are mastered, careful observation of every smile encountered in daily life reveals a large number of fake smiles. In common situations involving disgust, anger, embarrassment (fear category), or displeasure (sadness category), insincere smiles appear;

these can be called “social smiles” and serve as effective means of maintaining or easing conversational atmosphere. Once the criteria for judging authenticity are mastered, the traces of a fake smile can be captured in context and the psychological state behind the smile can be analyzed.

## 2. Testing Applications (9789620756689)

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### 9.2.2 The Eyes of Laughter

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-3]*

As soon as intense pleasurable emotion arises, it triggers a strong contraction of the orbicularis oculi. Under this powerful contraction the most noticeable change in the eyelids during a smile is that the lower eyelid bulges, shortens, lifts upward, and covers part of the lower edge of the iris (the dark of the eye). At the same time, mutual compression of the upper and lower eyelids produces crow’s-feet at the outer corners of the eyes. Because the cheeks rise and lift (primarily through the zygomaticus major, with some participation by

the orbicularis oculi), a characteristic smile crease forms between the cheek and the lower eyelid, as shown in Figure 9-3.

A particularly subtle and distinctive feature is that eyelid closure during laughter occurs mainly from the bottom upward; the lower eyelid tightens and closes upward as the dominant movement, while the downward action of the upper eyelid is minimal. This eyelid-closure morphology appears only in smiles. In eyelid closure of other expressions the upper eyelid dominates. In normal eye closure the upper eyelid drops, forming a downward-curving arc at the eyelid line, whereas the eyelid line in a smile remains at the middle of the eyeball, as shown in Figure 9-4.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-4]*

We often say that some people have “smiling eyes.” This is because the distinctive eyelid-closure morphology on certain faces can reverse the curve of the eyelid, producing a slight upward arc. Consequently, two simple upward-arched lines are enough to depict a pair of lively smiling eyes, as shown in Figure 9-5.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-5]*

If you recall the explanation in Chapter 8 of the eye morphology that accompanies crying, you can understand why eyelid compression is so important for a smile. Laughter is also accompanied by intense spasmodic breathing, so the orbicularis oculi contracts automatically to protect the eyes from increased internal pressure. This is a reflex action sharing the same physiological mechanism as coughing, sneezing, and crying.

Therefore, if the eyes show no movement during a smile, the smile can be judged as not emotion-driven. Merely lifting the corners of the mouth can convey a sense of laughter, yet that is only a matter of etiquette. Anyone can force a smile in any emotional state, but when one is in a bad mood, the difficulty of squinting the eyes to smile exceeds even the difficulty of forcing tears.

As soon as the smile begins, the eyes start to close, and the degree of eye closure is proportional to the degree of happiness expressed by the smile.

If the degree of eye closure does not match the degree of the smile, the expression is usually judged to be a fake smile.

### 9.2.3 The Mouth and Cheeks of Laughter

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-6]*

The dominant muscle of a broad laugh is the zygomaticus major. Its powerful contraction pulls the corners of the mouth toward the ears on both sides, lifting and lengthening the upper lip. Other muscles connected to the upper lip, such as the levator anguli oris and the levator labii superioris, also contract, but these actions are considered indirect and secondary to the movement of the zygomaticus major. Under the influence of these muscles the upper lip is raised almost to its highest position, fully exposing the upper teeth and sometimes even part of the upper gums, as shown in Figure 9-6. Exposure of the teeth increases the infectiousness of the smile. Without corresponding eye morphology, however, the smile appears fake and foolish.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-7]*

In Figure 9-7 the smile on the right is a fake smile lacking equivalent eye participation. The upper eyelid appears normal; the lower eyelid is slightly pushed upward by the rising cheek, forming a very shallow smile



groove beneath the eyelid. Even so, when the degree to which the mouth is stretched is compared, the passive change in the lower eyelid does not make the overall eye change match the change in the lower face; the expression can therefore be identified as a fake smile.

Separate contractions of the orbicularis oculi and the zygomaticus major both lift the cheeks upward. Consequently, when both muscles contract together during a broad laugh, the cheeks rise and lift under double force, and the surface skin becomes smooth and taut. As soon as the smile begins, the cheeks rise and round; once the smile is full, the rise and rounding of the cheeks constitute the most obvious and largest change on the entire face, forming an apple shape. Cosmetic-surgery practitioners therefore call this area the “apple muscle.”

During a broad laugh the mandible drops, opening the mouth. Unlike surprise or fear, the chin in laughter not only drops but also moves backward toward the neck; the lower lip is greatly stretched and its surface becomes smooth; the upper lip is lifted to a full degree by the combined action of the zygomaticus major, levator anguli oris, levator labii superioris, and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, and the nasolabial folds pressed out on either side of the nose wings are especially deep and long. As shown in Figure 9-7, a feigned broad laugh usually does not alter mouth morphology to this extent.

### Analysis Case

#### Mona Lisa's Mysterious Smile

Mona Lisa's smile is the world's most famous smile. More intriguing than the mystery of the sitter's identity is the expression itself. This incomplete, almost-smiling expression gives us endless room for imagination.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-12]*

The degree of muscle contraction and the morphological features of expression across the entire face are extremely subtle:

1. The lower eyelid bulges and lifts slightly, forming a smile groove beneath it;
2. Although no crow's-feet are visible, the morphology of the upper and lower eyelids and the shadow at the outer corner of the eye allow us to judge that the orbicularis oculi is contracted (contraction of the orbicularis oculi lowers the eyebrows, creating an awning effect above the eyes);
3. The cheeks beneath the eyes are indeed raised, although they have not yet formed an apple shape;
4. On the right side of the face a faint nasolabial fold can be observed, indicating that the zygomaticus major on the right side contracted more strongly and the smile is slightly stronger there. A mild or slight smile appears asymmetrical; when contraction is incomplete, the zygomaticus major on one side contracts relatively more tightly;
5. The slight upward turn at the corners of the mouth is the clearest evidence of zygomaticus major contraction, indicating that the smile is indeed present.

Mona Lisa's smile is truly an excellent micro-expression template. Taken together, this portrait named for its smile does depict a genuine smile, because the degree of zygomaticus major contraction matches the degree of orbicularis oculi contraction—both are very slight. From a micro-expression perspective, the painting is mysterious and attractive because the smile is so faint; at the same time the sidelong gaze adds a sense of liveliness and mystery. We do not know what stimulus could elicit such a delicate, barely begun expression.

In the process of micro-expression psychological testing, any morphological feature on the face should be broken down and analyzed individually to confirm whether it constitutes a necessary condition for a particular emotion. If morphological decomposition can be performed as meticulously as in the analysis of this painting, the accuracy of the analysis will be greatly improved.

### **The Mysterious Smile of the Mona Lisa**

Mona Lisa's smile is the most famous smile in the world. More intriguing than the mystery of the subject's identity is her expression. This incomplete expression that seems to smile but not quite opens up endless space for imagination.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-12]*

The degree of muscle contraction and the morphological characteristics of the expression across the entire face of the subject are very subtle:

1. The lower eyelid bulges and lifts slightly, forming smile lines below the lower eyelid;
2. Although there are no crow's feet, the shape of the upper and lower eyelids and the shadow at the outer corner of the eye indicate that the orbicularis oculi muscle is in a contracted state (contraction of the orbicularis oculi lowers the eyebrows, creating an awning effect above the eyes);
3. The cheeks below the eyes are indeed raised, though not yet forming an apple shape;
4. In the subject's right face, a shallow nasolabial fold can be observed, proving that the zygomaticus major muscle on the right side contracts with greater force, making the smile slightly stronger. A mild or slight smile will appear asymmetrical; when contraction is insufficient, one side's zygomaticus major will contract relatively tighter;
5. The slight upward turn of the corners of the mouth is the most obvious evidence of zygomaticus major contraction, indicating that the smile indeed exists.

Mona Lisa's Smile is truly an excellent micro-expression template. Overall, this portrait named after a smile does depict a genuine smile, because the degree of contraction of the subject's zygomaticus major perfectly matches that of the orbicularis oculi—both are very slight. From the perspective of micro-expressions, the reason the painting is mysterious and attractive is that this smile is so faint, and the sideways gaze adds a sense of liveliness and mystery to the expression, as if some stimulus could trigger this delicate, restrained expression.

In the process of micro-expression psychological testing, any morphological feature in the face should be able to be dissected, analyzing each feature to confirm whether it is a necessary condition for a certain emotion. If one can perform a detailed morphological dissection like analyzing this painting, the accuracy of the analysis will be greatly improved.

### **The "Rectangular Smile"**

Decades ago, Professor Ewan Grant of the Department of Psychology at the University of Birmingham proposed a professional term for expressions—the "rectangular smile."

When people produce a "rectangular smile," the lips are pulled away from the upper and lower teeth, forming a rectangle. In fact, the "rectangular smile" is not a genuine smile accompanied by a relaxed and happy mood; it can even be considered an expression of pain.

When we are in low spirits, it is difficult to fake a real smile. A typical example: if you are unhappy, you cannot simultaneously engage both the zygomaticus major and the orbicularis oculi to produce a radiant genuine smile, yet given the special circumstances, you are forced to squeeze out a smile out of politeness, resulting in a fake smile.

A fake smile does not come from the heart; it only engages the zygomaticus major that lifts the corners of the mouth—what the Chinese call "smiling with the mouth but not the eyes."

Professor Jeffrey Cohn of the University of Pittsburgh Department of Psychology is studying machines that measure changes in facial muscles when suspects are interrogated. "We can say how many times each muscle moved, how long they stayed before changing, and whether the subject's performance was genuine or feigned," he explains.

However, you do not need Cohn's machine to detect a lying boyfriend or a guilty young girl, because a liar's insincere smile can be exposed in a few seconds. "A genuine smile is even, symmetrical on both sides of the face; it comes quickly but disappears slowly. It involves wrinkles from the nose to the corners of the mouth and laugh lines around the eyes," Cohn says. "A feigned smile comes more slowly and shows slight asymmetry; when one side is not quite real, the other side tries to respond positively. The eye muscles are not fully engaged. That is why the cold, malicious smiles of 'villains' in movies never reach their eyes."

After years of research, scientists have found that the key to greater happiness lies in interpersonal relationships, and a sincere smile helps people get along better, so it is very important.

## **2. Type Two: The Empathetic Type (Clever)**

Another stimulus source that can generate positive expectation violation is gaining benefits. From the simplest receipt of a gift to the conscious acquisition of new knowledge (learning and accepting new ideas, evaluations, etc.).

Therefore, the second way to create humorous artworks that make people laugh is to deliver positive expectation violation in the same manner as giving a gift, but what is given is not a material gift but an unexpected "clever" idea or knowledge and logic with "technical content" that the audience might not anticipate.

Zhao Benshan's skit *Selling the Limp* belongs to this category, featuring numerous "swindling" techniques unexpected by the audience, all possessing absolute "technical content," combined with the "playing dumb" performed by Fan Wei and Gao Xiumin, resulting in high comedic effect.

The Great Swindler uses psychological suggestion to make the deceived fat chef "walk two steps for nothing"—a classic swindle that, even after several viewings when the "surprise" is gone, still elicits laughter. Beyond the fat chef's "foolishness," the swindling technique itself is highly sophisticated. Even if a non-"foolish" character were placed in this situation to cooperate, using psychological suggestion to deceive would still trigger laughter, though not the hearty laughter of seeing someone fooled, but rather a knowing smile. In real life, there have also been, at least for a period, frequent cases of "masters" successfully deceiving others using such psychological suggestion techniques.

We can imagine: if it were not famous comedians but three ordinary people directly performing this scene, the effect would still make discerning viewers applaud and exclaim "brilliant!" This is the pleasure triggered by technical content. Transplanting the sophisticated psychological suggestion techniques of certain real-life

"masters" who pretend to be divine into humorous works can both satirize reality and convince the audience that such deception could indeed occur, and combined with the "better than the worst" psychology toward the fooled party, it creates a classic humorous piece.

### 9.3.1 The Full Smile

Starting from the unrestrained exuberance of loud laughter, slightly lowering the expressed enthusiasm and energy (for example, occasions where unrestrained laughter is inappropriate), Figure 9-9 shows the full smile. This exuberant toothy smile is somewhat weakened in both the eye morphology and the mouth morphology.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-9]*

It can be seen that the eyes are no longer tightly closed; the eyelids are partially open, revealing only the iris near the pupil. The lower eyelid still appears taut, straightened, and raised, with smile lines below it, though shallower. The degree of compression between the upper and lower eyelids is reduced, so the wrinkles at the inner eye corners and the crow's feet at the outer eye corners are correspondingly weakened or disappear (they disappear in younger people).

The degree to which the mouth opens is also reduced; the lower jaw tends to close, shortening the distance between the upper and lower teeth, yet the zygomaticus major still pulls the corners of the mouth to the farthest position. The upper lip remains almost unchanged; the lower lip rises, reducing or completely hiding the exposed lower teeth. Due to the strong pulling force, the skin between the corners of the mouth and the surface of the cheek muscles may press against each other, forming dimples. In this side view, we can clearly see the presence of dimples.

The degree of cheek raising is reduced, which is also the reason for the weakening of the smile lines below the lower eyelid. However, the cheeks overall remain fully raised, with smooth, lustrous skin.

The full smile is not easy to fake. You can experiment in front of a mirror and discover that the first difficulty lies in faking the eyes—deliberately contracting the eye muscles into the natural smiling posture shown is not easy; the second difficulty is matching the degree of change in mouth morphology with the degree of eye squinting. Only when both the orbicularis oculi and the zygomaticus major are fully activated by genuine pleasurable emotion can a natural and powerful linked smile pattern be formed that lifts the cheeks, closes the eyes, and coordinates the mouth—only such a smile is sincere and derived from pleasurable emotion.

### 9.4 Micro-expressions That Suppress Smiles

A smile triggered by pleasurable emotion produces two synchronous, equal-amplitude movements: eyelid closure and upward lift of the mouth corners. Synchronous means they begin moving at the same time; equal-amplitude means the range of motion is equal. The baseline state of the eyes is eyelids open, revealing the natural iris area; the baseline state of the mouth is lips closed, with no contraction around the eyes or mouth. Once smiling begins, the eyelids show a closing movement; at maximum smile the eyelids are fully closed—this range is 100%. The mouth corners begin to lift under the contraction of the zygomaticus major, the lips naturally stretch, and the lift and stretch reach maximum—this range is 100%. The equal-amplitude standard for a genuine smile means that if the eyelid closure completes 40%, the mouth-corner lift and lip stretch also complete 40%.

A feigned smile cannot achieve precise equal-amplitude movement. Eyes wide while grinning broadly or eyes narrowed while lips pressed together are classic examples of "smiling with the mouth but not the eyes."

A genuine smile originates from pleasurable emotion, and pleasurable emotion originates from self-satisfaction or expectation violation above self-satisfaction. Therefore, a truly happy smile is smug and unrestrained.

But if you receive praise in public, you will not display your happiness in an unrestrained manner. Although happy, you still maintain some reserve; you can only smile while appearing serious, expressing your reserve, cultivation, or status by suppressing part of the muscle movement while smiling.

From previous chapters we know that every expression has derivative forms produced by control. In a serious smile, to suppress the main expression of smiling, control is usually exerted over the muscles around the lips. The combined action of the orbicularis oris, depressor anguli oris, and mentalis can offset the strong stretch of the zygomaticus major, affecting mouth morphology and "pulling down" the originally full smile, but they do not affect other morphological features of the smile; the upper face maintains a natural full smile. This makes the smile complex and meaningful.

### **One. Loud Laughter**

First is loud laughter. Loud laughter is a very complex physiological movement; research shows that hearty laughter requires mobilizing 53 muscles in the face and producing more than 5,000 expressions. Therefore, during loud laughter the entire face appears to undergo obvious changes, and these changes carry distinct morphological features:

1. The eyebrows remain in their natural relaxed arch; the forehead is smooth;
2. The eyes are tightly closed, the lower eyelid bulges and lifts, and smile-specific lines appear below. Wrinkles form at the inner eye corners and crow's feet appear at the outer eye corners;
3. The mouth corners lift upward and outward, the cheeks rise to their highest position and appear roundest;
4. The upper lip lifts, exposing most of the upper teeth; the lower jaw opens, the surface is smooth, exposing a small amount of lower teeth;
5. The chin spreads, the skin is smooth, forming a smile line from the mouth corners to the chin that connects seamlessly with the nasolabial folds.

During loud laughter, facial muscle movements cause varying degrees of change around the eyes, mouth, and cheeks. Consider the eye changes: loud laughter triggered by strong pleasurable emotion makes the lower eyelid protrude, shorten, and lift upward; the upper and lower eyelids press against each other; at the same time, crow's feet appear at the outer eye corners; and because the cheeks rise and lift, a smile-specific line forms between the cheeks and the lower eyelid. It should be particularly noted that during loud laughter the eye closure occurs from bottom to top—the lower eyelid tightens and closes upward, while the upper eyelid also presses downward, but relatively speaking this action is smaller. Looking at the mouth, the most obvious feature of the lower face during loud laughter is the exposure of all upper teeth, even the upper gums, and lower teeth can also be seen. Finally, looking at the cheeks, during loud laughter the cheeks lift upward and the surface skin becomes smooth and taut. Once the smile begins, the raising and rounding of the cheeks appear accordingly; after the smile becomes full, the lifting and raising of the cheeks are the most obvious and largest morphological change on the entire face.

## **9.2 The Fullest Smile**

A happy smile is a very complex physiological movement. Without a stimulus source (a happy event or humorous segment), everyone can try to produce a happy smile and thereby understand how much muscle movement is required to complete the expression and breathing. A smile can be understood as a movement that converts psychological pleasure into physiological pleasure (more aptly called comfort).

Like the expression of crying in pain, whether an elderly person or an infant, the muscle movements and breathing patterns when smiling are exactly the same. Among the six basic expressions, smiling is the most effective means of communication across civilizations and races. A knowing smile can quickly express goodwill and is highly recognizable, requiring no learning at all.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-1]

As shown in Figure 9-1, the morphological features of hearty laughter are as follows:

1. The eyebrows remain in their natural relaxed arch; the forehead is smooth;
2. The orbicularis oculi contracts, the eyes close tightly, the lower eyelid bulges and lifts, and smile-specific lines appear below;
3. In a full smile movement, contraction of the orbicularis oculi forms wrinkles at the inner eye corners and produces crow's feet at the outer eye corners that gradually fade;
4. The zygomaticus major contracts, assisted by the levator anguli oris, lifting the mouth corners upward and outward; at the same time the cheeks rise to their highest position and appear roundest;
5. After the upper lip lifts, most of the upper teeth are exposed; the lower jaw opens, the lower lip lengthens under the combined contraction of the zygomaticus major and depressor labii inferioris, the surface becomes smooth, exposing a small amount of lower teeth (relative to the upper lip);
6. The chin spreads, the skin is smooth, forming a smile-specific line from the mouth corners to the chin that connects seamlessly with the nasolabial folds.

#### **Analysis Case: The Chamber of Commerce President Forcing a Smile**

According to a television report, in 2011, in order to destroy a city's counterfeit military uniform production and sales market, the state organized eight units including the local military region equipment department, industry and commerce, taxation, and public security to conduct a joint cleanup. Before the cleanup, reporters conducted an undercover investigation and discovered that information had been leaked by grassroots industry and commerce personnel and chamber of commerce personnel, who warned merchants everywhere that there would be a surprise operation the next day and instructed them to close and suspend business. Reporters secretly filmed the above personnel and recorded audiovisual material.

The next day, the joint cleanup indeed returned empty-handed. After learning that intelligence had previously been leaked, the parties involved were held accountable. After the parties instinctively denied the allegations, the reporters played the previously recorded undercover footage. All the parties were shocked and speechless—except for one person.

This person was the local chamber of commerce president. After being exposed for lying about notifying merchants to prepare for the inspection, he froze for a moment, then narrowed his eyes and smiled. The eyes narrowed appropriately, the mouth corners stretched wide enough, and the cheeks rose accordingly, but not fully enough; the lower eyelid showed a slight smile morphology. At first glance it appeared to be a natural smile. Upon closer observation, however, two flaws were evident: first, the lower eyelid morphology was too slight and did not match the degree of eye narrowing and mouth stretching, indicating that the actions of the orbicularis oculi and zygomaticus major were consciously and stiffly forced rather than the result of emotional

mobilization; second, the upper lip did not lift sufficiently (not as full as the degree of eye narrowing), and the lower lip rose to meet the exposed upper teeth—this mouth shape was likewise the result of forced effort.

Based on these features, combined with the flickering gaze (rapid slight movement of the iris, indicating fear; see Chapter 10 for details), it could be determined that the other party was forcing a smile to conceal inner fear.

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### **The Smirk of Satisfaction**

This kind of smile has several facial features: the eyebrows are raised as a whole while the upper eyelids remain unlifted, forming a typical expression of confidence; the gaze is directed to the right; the lower eyelids are raised; the corners of the mouth are stretched sideways, the upper lip is lifted to create nasolabial folds, and the lower lip is raised by the mentalis muscle, producing uneven wrinkles on the chin with the mouth forming a straight-line shape. The involvement of the mentalis muscle reveals the restrained quality of this smile, indicating that the individual does not wish to display amusement openly.

During an interview, one candidate maintained a proper and cautious demeanor throughout, smiling continuously. When the interviewer asked about his area of expertise, he displayed a classic smirk of satisfaction. Although he did not speak at length and answered only cautiously, the smile conveyed

confidence in his professional knowledge, with the implied message: “This question plays right into my hands.”

Each of the smiles described above carries its own distinct features, yet some share identical expression characteristics that acquire different meanings in different contexts, such as the knowing smile, the helpless smile, and the leader’s smile. All three are characterized by a slight upward curl of the mouth corners. What distinguishes them is that the leader’s smile is often accompanied by head movement, such as a slight downward tilt that creates a sense of looking down; the knowing smile frequently involves nodding, signaling recognition, agreement, empathy, or encouragement, including both encouraging smiles and listener smiles. The helpless smile lacks head movement but features a brief eyebrow furrow that lasts only an instant and is easily missed. At times it may also be paired with shoulder shrugs or sighs as bodily reactions.

### 9.3.3 The Faint Smile

The faint smile may be the most complex of the simple expressions. This is because expressions of surprise, disgust, anger, fear, and sadness each possess relatively straightforward micro-expression features that can be identified by a single organ or facial configuration, such as the raised upper eyelid of surprise, the lifted upper lip of disgust, the brow-and-eye configuration of anger, the brow-and-eye combination of fear, and the eyebrow position of sadness. Even the simplest smile, however, requires coordinated movement across the entire face; the absence of any one element in the eyes, cheeks, or mouth corners diminishes the perceived sincerity of the smile. In fact, unless deliberately feigned, the three elements naturally synchronize during a genuine smile and do not require separate conscious commands. See Figure 9-11.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-11]*

In this smiling face the orbicularis oculi muscle shows only slight contraction, producing minimal eyelid closure. Careful observation of the lower eyelid’s shape—its bulge, straightening, and slight elevation—along with the creases formed where the upper and lower eyelids press together at the outer corners, still reveals clear signs of amusement.

The mouth is closed, and the lip line curves upward at both ends. Compared with a neutral state, the slight stretching and thinning of the lips confirm the action of the zygomaticus major. More noticeable than the mouth shape is the cheek morphology. Even in so faint a smile the cheeks remain rounded and full, a distinct feature.

### Case Three: The Serious Smile

Because of age or status, older individuals or those in high positions tend to smile in a way that projects greater dignity and approachability. The upper-face features of the smile are pronounced, while the lower-face features show clear signs of restraint, especially around the mouth. The same smile appears in product-promotion advertisements that convey seriousness and reliability—for instance, daily necessities marketed for their medicinal benefits, or when a person in a white coat posing as a doctor recommends toothpaste, or when a celebrity endorses contact lenses—producing a responsible, satisfied smile. See Figure 9-17.

In such smiles the standard smile morphology remains: the lower eyelids are raised, taut, and protruding, covering more of the iris than usual, while the upper and lower eyelids trend toward closure, confirming contraction of the orbicularis oculi; the cheeks are lifted, creating smile lines beneath the lower eyelids; the mouth corners are slightly upturned, jointly confirming contraction of the zygomaticus major together with the cheek morphology.



What differs from the standard smile morphology is the participation of the mentalis muscle, which pushes the lower lip upward. Combined with contraction of the orbicularis oris, this tightens both lips so that the lip line appears horizontally straight, while the chin shows raised bumps and an uneven surface. This typical feature also occurs in sadness-class expressions and is clearly introduced to suppress the smile and the underlying joy. See Figure 9-18.

This type of smile appears more trustworthy than an unrestrained, hearty laugh.

## 8. The Dazed Smile

At first glance the image may be mistaken for a disdainful sneer. The raised upper lip and the shallow nasolabial folds beside the nostrils match the minimal features of a disgust expression. Yet disgust is a negative emotion that commands attention; therefore, even without a furrowed brow, the eyes remain alert and convey rejection rather than appearing vacant.

- The levator palpebrae superioris is fully relaxed, allowing the upper eyelids to droop to the upper margin of the pupils.
- Contraction of the frontalis raises both eyebrows while only marginally lifting the upper eyelids.
- Only the mouth corners and lip shape suggest smile characteristics; the cheeks show slight but indistinct elevation, and the lower-eyelid smile features are almost undetectable. Nevertheless, this mouth shape confirms the absence of tension and a positive tendency. Combined with the vacant eye state, the smile appears intoxicated or coquettish.

People automatically close their eyes to reduce visual interference under two conditions: first, physiological fatigue of the nervous system, such as drowsiness or intoxication; second, when enjoying or expressing enjoyment, partial eyelid closure allows other senses to fully register the pleasant stimulus (see detailed explanation in Chapter 10). Consequently, lowered upper eyelids typically appear during states of intoxication, coquetry, drunkenness, or drowsiness. The primary reading of such a smile with drooping upper eyelids is therefore one of intoxication; the second possibility is a lovestruck or lecherous expression. Such scenes are common in advertising and film, frequently associated with femme fatales and lechers.

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feature also occurs in sadness-class expressions and is clearly introduced to suppress the smile and the underlying joy. See Figure 9-18.

This type of smile appears more trustworthy than an unrestrained, hearty laugh.

### 9.1.2 Topic One: The Joy of Receiving a Gift

Whether receiving a gift brings happiness depends on two factors: the gift itself and the person giving it.

In the first category, if the giver is acceptable, the degree of joy is directly proportional to the extent to which the gift exceeds expectations (subject to relational limits—for example, a diamond ring is not acceptable from just anyone). The greater the surprise beyond expectation, the stronger the resulting psychological pleasure. Conversely, if a suitor one approves of gives only a thoughtless card on Valentine's Day, disappointment may result.

In the second category, if the giver is someone desired—for instance, a person one is romantically interested in—the surprise alone is sufficient to override other factors, surpassing expectations in both quality and quantity. Even a short note can produce prolonged happiness. The reason is that, under conditions of uncertainty about the other person's feelings, the mere act of giving already far exceeds prior expectations.

In the third category, if the giver is inappropriate, the gift's nature becomes irrelevant; the more valuable the gift, the stronger the impulse to withdraw. Would one dare accept an expensive gift from someone one dislikes who persists in offering it (excluding those who trade themselves for material gain)? This unhappiness stems from an inner rejection of the person and the psychological expectation of avoiding any involvement being contradicted by reality.

## 2. The Expectant Smile

In Chinese convention, raised eyebrows, besides appearing in basic emotions such as surprise and fear, can convey an additional meaning when occurring alone—mutual understanding. Rendered in contemporary colloquial terms, this is roughly “You know what I mean.” During speech, an inadvertent eyebrow raise signals that the speaker endorses what is being said and believes the listener should as well, implying a shared understanding.

Therefore, when a smile incorporates such raised eyebrows without the wide-open mouth of surprise—only the slight clenching of teeth typical of a smile—the expression conveys strong trust and enthusiasm while fully revealing the individual's inner anticipation; it may be called the expectant smile. See Figure 11-25.

- Both eyebrows raised (surprise-expression feature)
- Upper eyelids markedly elevated, exposing most of the upper iris margin (surprise-expression feature)
- Upper lip raised to reveal upper teeth, lower lip stretched, teeth lightly clenched, mouth corners pulled sideways and upward (smile features)
- Cheeks lifted, smile-specific lines beneath the lower eyelids (smile features)

**Conclusion:** Surprise features are confirmed, yet the absence of corresponding mouth movement indicates that the surprise is not genuine astonishment but rather an expression of anticipated outcome and mutual understanding; smile features are simultaneously confirmed, yielding an overall reading of the expectant smile.

## Section 1 The Five Major Micro-Expressions Within Smiles

In his essay "On Smiling," Mr. Zhou Ruchang wrote:

"A smile is a facial expression that reflects the inner state. Phrases such as 'welcoming with a smile,' 'face brimming with spring breeze,' and 'a face covered in smiles' demonstrate the connection between smiling and the face. 'Breaking into a smile,' 'clearing one's expression,' and 'smiling with delight' are more literary yet describe the same relationship. Expressions such as 'smiling tiger' and 'smiling on the face while suffering in the heart' indicate different situations; the notion that a smile 'reflects the inner state' requires re-examination, yet the 'facial expression' itself remains valid."

Thus, in most cases a smile is the facial manifestation of an inner emotion. In Chinese, the vocabulary used to describe smiles is vast and varied, each reflecting individual differences. For example, a beauty's smile is described as "charming," a scholar's as "a gentle smile," a refined young lady is expected to "smile without showing teeth," Yang Yuhuan's "glance-back smile," Baosi's "smile worth a thousand pieces of gold," the hearty "laughing skyward," the tacit "smiling at each other," the spirited "conversing and laughing with ease," along with bitter smiles, forced smiles, beaming smiles, hearty chuckles, wry smiles, and insincere smiles—rich, colorful, and exhaustive.

Among the many kinds of smiles, the most common and familiar micro-expressions fall into five major categories: the hearty laugh, the full smile, the faint smile, the Mona Lisa smile, and the ID-photo smile. Smiles can reveal a person's true character; through these micro-expressions we obtain considerable information.

### 9.3.2 The Full Smile

In daily life, when encountering something or someone pleasing, a full smile readily appears. Although a smile becomes even fuller when one is completely carried away by joy, such intensely positive stimuli are relatively rare, making the full smile more commonly observed. See Figure 9-10.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-10]*

The full smile still follows the common morphological features of a full smile, only with all muscle actions further reduced. The eyes remain narrowed; the upper eyelids stay largely stationary while the lower eyelids are slightly raised and bulging, forming smile lines beneath the eyes; the cheeks are lifted and full, with smooth surface skin; the mouth corners are pulled widely toward the ears, the upper lip is raised to expose the upper teeth, the lower lip is less extended so the lower teeth are not visible; the teeth are essentially in occlusion; the chin is smooth and relaxed.

Eye morphology remains important in the full smile. The lower eyelids approach a horizontal line, attempting to close the eyes from below. The tautness of the lower eyelids is an important marker of pleasure. The lower eyelids always move with the eyeballs, whether in tension or relaxation. When relaxed they lie below the eyeballs; once a smile occurs, contraction of the orbicularis oculi tightens and elevates them to the mid-eyeball level.

### Summary (9787554606841)

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-14]*

Figure 9-14 presents a comparison of smiles of varying intensity. Observation shows that the degree of eye narrowing, cheek elevation, mouth-corner stretch, mouth opening, and tooth exposure are all directly proportional to smile intensity. In a hearty laugh the eyes are narrowed most tightly, the cheeks are raised highest, the mouth is opened widest, and the teeth are most exposed. In a smile all changes are reduced; in a neutral expression no obvious changes occur.

Special attention should be paid to lower-eyelid morphology in smiles.

Whenever a genuine smile occurs, the lower eyelids shorten to varying degrees, become taut, and trend upward toward closure. The physiological reason for this upward movement of the lower eyelids is the same as the upward movement of the upper lip during a smile: increased tension at both ends of the eyelid converts the curve into a taut, upward arc, raising the lower eyelids precisely to the lower pupil margin.

In addition to the eye changes themselves, two accompanying phenomena appear: crow's-feet form at the outer eye corners, and smile-fold shadows appear beneath the eyes. Both occur during smiling and laughing.

#### **Summary (9787554606841)**

Through analysis and comparison of cases that elicit happiness, we can summarize the mechanism by which positive emotion arises.

Anything that positively exceeds a person's subjective expectations—whether by increasing the stimulus (absolute increase) or by establishing a lower reference point for comparison (relative increase)—generates self-satisfaction or even a sense of superiority, thereby producing positive emotion.

This conclusion is highly useful in psychological testing because it directly determines whether a pleasurable stimulus can be designed.

#### **Summary**

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-14]*

Figure 9-14 presents a comparison of smiles of varying intensity. Observation shows that the degree of eye narrowing, cheek elevation, mouth-corner stretch, mouth opening, and tooth exposure are all directly proportional to smile intensity. In a hearty laugh the eyes are narrowed most tightly, the cheeks are raised highest, the mouth is opened widest, and the teeth are most exposed. In a smile all changes are reduced; in a neutral expression no obvious changes occur.

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In addition to the eye changes themselves, two accompanying phenomena appear: crow's-feet form at the outer eye corners, and smile-fold shadows appear beneath the eyes. Both occur during smiling and laughing.

#### **5. The Fearful Smile**

- Eyebrow shape flattens and the angle between the brow head and brow tip changes; although no obvious brow raise occurs, the change in brow shape caused by slight elevation of the brow heads remains visible (fear and sadness morphological features).
- The upper eyelids attempt to open wide but encounter resistance from the lowered brows, forming wrinkles (accumulated bulges) on the skin; if resistance is absent, an increase in exposed iris area can be observed (fear feature).
- The lower eyelids bulge, tighten, and rise, producing smile lines beneath; combined with mouth-corner shape, lip shape, and cheek elevation, these constitute standard smile features.

**Summary:** Smile features are fully present, indicating a genuine smile, yet the eyebrow and upper-eyelid morphology constitute the minimal features of a fear expression, allowing the conclusion that a fear-class emotion is present. The smile is mixed with apprehension, commonly seen in subordinate-to-superior or weaker-to-stronger interactions; it may represent flattery, a request, or a fear-driven attempt to please.

Of course, not every instance is so pragmatic; an anxious, worried smile can appear the same way. When a boss unexpectedly praises you, the situation is both surprising and uncertain about what may follow, so one does not dare to smile openly—this is the expression that results.

### 9.2.1 Dominant Muscles of the Smile

A smile appears to produce obvious changes across the entire face, exceeding the degree of change seen in other expressions and matching the complexity of crying in pain. In fact, the core “cost” of the muscle movements in a smile is very small. Whether discussing an ordinary smile or a hearty laugh, only two groups of muscles dominate the expression.

The first group consists of the smile-specific muscles—the zygomaticus major. The zygomaticus major is highly specialized; its sole function is to stretch the corners of the mouth sideways and lift them upward, shaping the entire lower face into a smile. Movements of all other muscles serve as supporting roles.

The second group is the orbicularis oculi. The orbicularis oculi engages in many expressions, such as disgust (simultaneous squeezing and tightening of the upper and lower eyelids), anger (tightened, straightened lower eyelid), and crying in pain (eyelid closure). In a smile the orbicularis oculi is indispensable; a smile limited to mouth movements without eye participation appears insincere. As shown in Figure 9-2.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-2]

### The Charming Smile

Psychologists regard the most classic and representative charming smile as the one in Leonardo da Vinci’s painting *Mona Lisa*. Because the subject faces one direction while her eyes look in another, with the corners of her mouth slightly raised, the expression is pleasing. The greatest feature of the charming smile is the movement of the gaze. When a girl feels favorably toward a member of the opposite sex yet feels shy about expressing it, she typically smiles, holds her gaze on the other person for a moment, then quickly looks away, only to return her gaze again. This repetition signals the impulse and restraint she feels.

Charming smiles appear mostly on girls and convey “I want to approach you” or “I want to be conquered,” a point discussed later in the section on building rapport. A simple example suffices here: many films and television dramas show women of the night displaying this exact smile when soliciting customers. If you are a

man and notice a girl smiling at you in a crowd before shifting her gaze to the ground, you might consider approaching and saying hello.

### 1. Full Laugh Morphology

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-21]

The morphological features of a hearty laugh are as follows:

1. Eyebrows remain in their natural relaxed arch; the forehead is smooth;
2. The orbicularis oculi contracts, the eyes close tightly, the lower eyelids bulge and rise, and smile-specific grooves appear beneath them;
3. Contraction of the orbicularis oculi produces wrinkles at the inner corners of the eyes and crow's-feet at the outer corners that gradually fade;
4. The zygomaticus major contracts in concert with the levator anguli oris; the corners of the mouth rise upward and outward while the cheeks bulge and reach their highest, roundest position;
5. The upper lip rises, exposing most of the upper teeth; the jaw opens; the lower lip lengthens under the combined action of the zygomaticus major and depressor labii inferioris, its surface smoothing to reveal a small amount of lower teeth (relative to the upper lip);
6. The chin spreads, the skin smooths, and smile-specific grooves form from the corners of the mouth to the chin tip, connecting seamlessly with the nasolabial folds.

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- ⑥ The chin spreads, the skin smooths, and smile-specific grooves form from the corners of the mouth to the chin tip, connecting seamlessly with the nasolabial folds.

### 4. Sneer (Angry Smile)

- Head slightly lowered, chin tucked (head-attack posture feature)
- Eyebrows furrowed and lowered into a "10:10" shape with glabellar lines (anger feature)

- Upper eyelids strain upward against the downward pressure of the brows, forming folds in the eyelid skin (anger feature)
- Lower eyelids tightened (anger feature)
- Upper lip raised, exposing upper teeth; corners of the mouth stretched sideways and raised; lower lip relaxed (partial smile feature)
- Upper teeth show a tendency to bite the lower lip, indicating suppression

**Summary:** Anger features are clear and establish the dominant emotion. Mouth features of a smile appear, yet the eyes do not participate, so the smile is not genuine and carries no pleasurable emotion. Combined with the lip-biting suppression, the expression indicates that the person is restraining anger (temporarily not attacking) while using the smile to signal a sense of control or low pressure. A smile under dominant anger is termed a sneer and conveys both offensive potential and inner satisfaction with the outcome of the confrontation.

### 9.3.4 ID-Photo Smile

In daily life most smiles are not triggered by pleasurable emotion but serve to signal friendly intent. This type of smile is most common in ID photographs. Few ID photos display a full smile, because a hearty smile appears too intense and unlikely to be sustained. In addition, a full smile produces greater facial change, whereas a slight smile produces less change and therefore maintains higher resemblance between the photo and the subject. As shown in Figure 9-13.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-13]

The degree of tooth exposure during a smile varies widely among individuals. People whose lips form an upward arc usually show teeth when smiling, while others smile without showing teeth. Traditional Chinese society valued smiling without showing teeth, so many Chinese ID photos still feature closed-lip smiles.

### 1. Micro-expression Morphological Features of the Smile and Typical Morphological Features

From the eyes to the cheeks to the mouth, the standard micro-expression morphological features of a smile are formed:

- Forehead and brow area relaxed and natural;
- Orbicularis oculi contracts, causing the lower eyelids to rise, tighten, and bulge, covering more of the iris than usual; the upper and lower eyelids show a squeezing tendency toward closure and form folds at the outer corners;
- Zygomaticus major contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth sideways and upward in concert with the intensity of spasmodic breathing to produce either an open- or closed-mouth shape;
- In the natural state the upper lip rises, exposing the upper teeth; the lower lip varies in shape and exposes fewer lower teeth, and even when exposed the area is smaller than that of the upper teeth;
- Movement of the two dominant muscle groups causes the cheeks to bulge, appearing full and rounded, and produces the smile grooves beneath the lower eyelids.

Most notably, every morphological feature of a full laugh also appears in a slight smile. This is the only expression in which the necessary morphological features equal the typical morphological features; for other emotions the minimal features and typical features are never identical.

## 9.1 Why People Smile

### 9.1.1 The Four Great Joys of Life

### 9.1.2 Topic One: Joy at Receiving a Gift

### 9.1.3 Topic Two: A Performance That Makes People Laugh

## 9.2 The Fullest Smile

### 9.2.1 Dominant Muscles of the Smile

### 9.2.2 The Eyes in a Laugh

### 9.2.3 The Mouth and Cheeks in a Laugh

### 9.2.4 Comparison of Laughing and Crying

## 9.3 Micro-expression Morphological Features of the Smile

### 9.3.1 Full Laugh

### 9.3.2 Full Smile

### 9.3.3 Faint Smile

### 9.3.4 ID-Photo Smile

### 9.3.5 Micro-expression Morphological Features of the Smile

## 9.4 Micro-expressions That Suppress a Smile

## Chapter Summary

### Chapter 9 Micro-expressions in Smiles (9789620756689)

Pleasure is the only positive emotion among the six universal emotions, and the smile becomes the most complex and most socially appropriate human expression. Distinguishing genuine smiles from false ones allows analysis, in context, of the true psychological state behind the smile<|eos|>

#### 9.3.5 Micro-expression Morphological Features of Smiles

Smiles are formed by the movement of two groups of muscles. The zygomaticus major is responsible for pulling the mouth open, and the orbicularis oculi is responsible for closing the eyes. This coordinated action is a necessary system in smiling; even in the slightest shy smile, there is joint movement of both muscle groups. Therefore, the micro-expression morphological features of a smile are essentially its full morphological features, differing only in the degree of muscle contraction.

True smiles involve squinting of the eyes, tightening, lifting, and protruding of the lower eyelids, smile lines appearing below the eyes, and skin folds (crow's feet) formed by the upper and lower eyelids pressing against each other at the outer corners of the eyes; the corners of the mouth stretch and lift toward the ears; the cheeks rise and lift.



## 6. Mixed Sorrow and Joy (Sorrowful Smile)

The relationship between joy and sorrow is highly complex. Children can sometimes shift seamlessly from laughter to tears without pausing for breath. The transition from sorrow to a smiling expression is similarly fluid.

- Eyebrows lift, the brow shape flattens but shows distortion in the inner third (sorrow feature)
- Lower eyelid, mouth, and cheek morphology follow standard smile features

Expressions of this kind may appear after a painful separation followed by reunion, or after hard-won success that followed prolonged hardship. Such mixed expressions of sorrow and joy are often visible among fans at football matches when their team secures a difficult victory.

### Case Two: Suppressed Smile

This reflects an ambivalent state of mind that frequently occurs when receiving praise. According to the Chinese etiquette model instilled from childhood, one must not appear to accept praise readily or with obvious pleasure; instead, one should display modest denial and refusal. The resulting conflict between inner joy and external restraint produces this peculiar expression. See Figure 9-16.

The head is lowered, the eyes hold a smile (determined by lower eyelid morphology), the lips are pressed tightly together, yet the corners of the mouth still curve upward and the cheeks rise. These three features make the pleasure unmistakable, even though the lip posture remains suppressed and tense.

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## 9.2.4 Comparison of Loud Laughter and Loud Crying

The expressions of loud laughter and loud crying are similar: breathing is spasmodic and accompanied by vocalization, the mandible drops, the mouth stretches, the eyes close tightly, and the cheeks lift and tense. The differences between the two appear obvious yet are actually composed of many minute and precise distinctions. See Figure 9-8.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-8]*

Overall, the closure pattern around the eyes and the shape of the mouth are already sufficient for clear differentiation and judgment (see table below).

## 9.1 Why People Smile

Infants first cry loudly, but by two months of age they produce smiles; the human second expression is therefore the smile. Later, once infants master more demanding breathing actions, they emit giggles at things they find amusing—the most delightful sound in the world.

Why do people smile? From the perspective of emotional origins, a pleasant mood arises from self-satisfaction or exceeding satisfaction—that is, from receiving information that surpasses prior expectations.

We can analyze the four great joys commonly cited to examine the mechanism that generates joyful emotion.

### **Suppressed Smile**

It should first be noted that the suppressed smile originates from positive emotional stimuli and is entirely distinct from the previous two types. Because the individual cannot fully release the positive emotion for various reasons, only suppression occurs, resulting in a suppressed smile. The facial features of this smile are tightly pressed lips, tense and downturned mouth-corner muscles, a protruding lower lip, and uneven wrinkles on the chin. The smile is genuine yet attenuated. For example, during a meeting an employee may witness a superior perform a comical action but, out of respect for the superior's dignity, cannot laugh aloud and therefore produces a suppressed smile.

### **9. Proud Smile**

- Eyebrows lift slightly, but the upper eyelids do not, negating the surprise feature and indicating confidence
- Gaze shifts to the right, not facing the stimulus source directly; this is a visual blocking behavior indicating unwillingness to receive or convey information
- Lower eyelid morphology matches smile features
- Upper lip shows lifting with a pronounced nasolabial fold; the corners of the mouth are pulled sideways, lengthening both upper and lower lips; with the lower lip raised by the mentalis muscle, the lip line remains horizontally straight, indicating that without the mentalis the lip line would curve downward

## **11.3.2 Recognition of Other Complex Expressions**

### **Angry Smile**

The dominant emotion in this smile is anger, so anger features are prominent: eyebrows are furrowed and lowered; the eyes attempt to widen but form wrinkles on the upper eyelids due to the pressure from the brows; the lower eyelids are tense; the head tilts slightly downward and the chin retracts, a typical offensive posture. The corners of the mouth lift slightly and upper teeth may be exposed—this is a smile feature. If the upper teeth bite the lip, the individual is suppressing anger. If not, the person is about to erupt; the smile expresses optimistic certainty of the offensive outcome and also signals confidence.

### **3. Cold Smile, Mocking Smile (Contemptuous Smile)**

- One side of the upper lip lifts, exposing upper teeth and forming nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose (disgust feature)
- One corner of the mouth lifts noticeably with one cheek rising (smile feature)
- Eyelids are closed, yet the lower eyelids show no protrusion or tightening and no smile lines appear below (denial of smile feature)

**Summary:** The presence of disgust emotion (contempt or disdain) is confirmed; because the eye features are absent, the smile is insincere. The visible smile at the mouth corner arises from a sense of superiority toward the disgust stimulus rather than pleasure; it is disdain.

**The second function is to detect fake smiles and analyze their causes according to standard smile morphological features.**

Once the features of a genuine smile are mastered, careful observation of everyday smiles reveals a large number of fake smiles. In common situations involving disgust, anger, embarrassment (fear category), or displeasure (sorrow category), insincere smiles appear; these may be called "social smiles" and serve as effective means of maintaining or easing conversational atmosphere.

After learning the criteria for distinguishing genuine from fake smiles, one can combine them with specific contexts to detect traces of fake smiles and analyze the psychological state behind the smile.

## 2. Common Smile Morphology

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-22]

- Eyes narrow, upper eyelids remain essentially still, lower eyelids lift and protrude slightly, forming smile lines beneath the eyes;
- Cheeks lift and appear full, surface skin smooth;
- Corners of the mouth are pulled widely toward the ears, upper lip lifts to expose upper teeth, lower lip spreads less and lower teeth are not visible;
- Chin is smooth and relaxed.

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- ③ Corners of the mouth are pulled widely toward the ears, upper lip lifts to expose upper teeth, lower lip spreads less and lower teeth are not visible;
- ④ Chin is smooth and relaxed.

## 3. Micro-expression Morphology of Smiles

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-23]

Eye morphology remains important even in a full smile.

- ① The orbicularis oculi contracts slightly, lower eyelids protrude, straighten, and lift slightly toward the horizontal, attempting to close the eyes from below;
- ② The mouth is closed, the lip line curves upward at both ends;
- ③ The cheeks remain raised and full, a clear feature.

### **Contemptuous Smile**

Although called a smile, this expression does not arise from positive stimuli and therefore differs from the ordinary definition of a smile. It is not a fake smile, however, because its purpose is not to mislead others; instead, it openly displays the individual's true inner attitude. The contemptuous smile resembles a slight smile in that the corners of the mouth lift gently, yet the mouth-corner muscles tense and form raised ridges, sometimes appearing on only one side.

### **Embarrassed Smile**

This smile often appears when someone is publicly praised and indicates discomfort with the attention, uncertainty about how to respond, and a desire to escape others' gaze. Its most distinctive feature is therefore gaze avoidance or evasion; the person's eyes look downward or to the side. In addition, the mentalis contracts, producing a small wrinkle on the chin that signals difficulty; the upper teeth lightly bite the lower lip, indicating suppression.

### **Summary**

In a true smile the eyes narrow, the lower eyelids tighten, lift, and protrude, smile lines appear beneath the eyes, and skin folds (crow's feet) formed by the upper and lower eyelids pressing together appear at the outer corners; the corners of the mouth stretch and lift toward the ears; the cheeks rise and lift. Only when these features appear together can a true smile be confirmed; even if the degree of each feature does not match perfectly, the sincerity of the smile may be questioned.

### **Case One: Wanting to Smile but Unable**

As shown in Figure 9-15, if the upper half of the face is covered, the mouth posture appears so suppressed that no trace of a smile is visible; dominated by contraction of the orbicularis oris, the mouth resembles suppressed anger or crying. When the eyebrows, eyes, and cheeks of the upper face are revealed, however, a clear smile becomes evident and the overall judgment is a suppressed smile.

### **Case One: Wanting to Smile but Unable**

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### **9.1.3 Topic Two: Performances That Provoke Laughter**

Among stimuli that elicit happiness, performances designed to provoke laughter constitute a special category, such as comedy, crosstalk, humor, and slapstick. These stimuli make audiences laugh because their content produces a strong sense of satisfaction. From a creative standpoint, they fall into two obvious types:

### **Three. Faint Smile**

In a faint smile the eyelids close slightly, yet the smile remains clearly visible through the lower eyelids and the lines formed by the upper and lower eyelids pressing together at the outer corners of the eyes. The lips are

closed, the lip line stretches sideways and curves upward. The cheeks remain raised and full, still the most obvious sign of the smile on the entire face.

### 9.3 Micro-expression Morphological Features of Smiles

From hearty laughter to the slightest smile, muscle movement intensity and amplitude are gradually reduced. Summarizing the morphological features of all smiles yields the micro-expression morphological features of smiles.

#### Fearful Smile

This smile results from the risorius muscle pulling the corners of the mouth sideways, producing a slight upward lift. The eyebrows show a minor lift, and the eyes attempt to widen but form wrinkles because the brow tips press downward.

#### 11.2.6 Smile

A happy smile is a movement that converts psychological pleasure into physical pleasure (more aptly called comfort).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

## Part Five Micro-expressions

### 32 Silent Video Clips

Austrian psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud once said: "A person's unconscious can unconsciously influence another person's unconscious." This means you may evaluate others subconsciously based on your own judgments and intuitions rather than on facts. In other words, you evaluate someone based on their body language.

A study conducted by Harvard experimental psychology professor Robert Rosenthal and Nalini Ambady confirmed the power of nonverbal gestures. The researchers showed a group of undergraduates 32 video clips of different teachers in class and asked the students to evaluate those teachers. Because the sound in the clips had been scrambled or removed, the students could judge the teachers only on the basis of body language.

The results showed that the participating students' evaluations matched those of students who had attended the teachers' classes and completed teacher assessment forms at the end of the semester. Although the latter group attributed their ratings to the teachers' friendliness or clear thinking, the study indicated that most evaluations were formed on the basis of nonverbal communication.

By applying logical reasoning and deliberate assessment, you can avoid reacting solely on the basis of body movements. Without carefully considering the possible reasons behind someone's gestures, you will be misled by those gestures. For example, a judge we know suffered a stroke during a trial; his facial muscles twitched and the corner of his mouth drooped—actions that could easily make defense counsel uneasy. Had counsel known the movements were likely involuntary, they would not have appeared so unsettled.

To avoid misunderstanding, you must remember how your own expressions and gestures are perceived by others. At all times, be aware of the nonverbal signals you are sending. Are your arms crossed? Is your body leaning? If you display an open posture, others may be more receptive to your views.

You should also observe the other person's body language. If you sense defensiveness, you can adjust your approach to make the person more receptive. Speakers call this "audience awareness," and they detect it readily. When they notice negative nonverbal signals from an audience member, they quickly change the subject, tell a joke, or offer a humorous remark to make the audience laugh and relax.

## Expressions, the Canvas of the Mind

In his book *Man, the Unknown*, 1912 Nobel laureate and French physiologist Alexis Carrel wrote:

"We see many unfamiliar faces that reflect their owners' mental states, and with age these states become ever clearer. The face is like a display that reveals all our inner activities—feelings, desires, hopes."

What we call the "face" refers not only to static appearance but chiefly to dynamic facial expressions. Facial expressions play a major role in revealing emotion; they are "geometric diagrams of the inner world." Human mental activity is subtle, yet that subtlety often shows itself in expression.

When people feel joy, their facial muscles relax; when angry, their faces contort; when envious, their expressions shift unpredictably; when sorrowful, tears flow.

Some people, however, prefer to conceal these inner states. Judging solely by surface appearance can therefore lead to error. Reading another person's hidden feelings from expression seems simple but is not easy.

American psychologist August B. Hollingshead once conducted an experiment in which several people were asked to portray six emotions—anger, fear, seduction, indifference, happiness, and sadness—while being videotaped. Viewers were then asked to identify the emotions. On average, each viewer correctly identified only two. When an actor displayed anger, viewers often mistook it for sadness.

At a negotiation, the other party smiled broadly and said, "I understand; what you say makes sense. I'll certainly consider it." The negotiator felt reassured that the deal was done, yet it ultimately failed. Often people mask strong emotions with a blank face or deliberately display the opposite expression. Detecting the true emotion beneath the displayed one therefore demands heightened observational skill. Two points must be kept in mind when using expression to penetrate another's psychological defenses:

### 3.2 Auditory Comfort

Music is a remarkable phenomenon that can alter a person's mental state—exciting, pleasing, or saddening. The loud, driving rhythms in nightclubs forcibly stimulate the nervous system, after which the release of bodily energy relieves mental tension. Beautiful melodies or empathetic lyrics allow listeners to find emotional resonance and a strong sense of identification (including self-identification), producing pleasure. Identification need not arise only from happy events; identification based on sadness can trigger sorrowful resonance and intensify an already melancholy mood. Sometimes empathic resonance based on sadness exerts greater influence on decision-making than resonance based on pleasure.

Just as visual improvements can soothe a subject's nervous system and improve mood, auditory improvements can do the same.

When people feel tense or uncomfortable, they may automatically call up stored musical phrases to self-regulate—humming, singing, chanting, shouting, or whistling—to relieve nervous tension and improve mood.

This response is called auditory comfort. Singing, humming, or whistling also synchronizes breathing rhythm and force, an effective means of obtaining comfort.

### Figures 3-8 and 3-9 Auditory comfort

In a polygraph examination, extended melodic humming or instrumental playing is unlikely; the special testing context usually reduces the behavior to a brief hum, a single-note whistle, or even silent breathing movements known only to the subject. If these micro-reactions (微反应) occur after a negative stimulus, they can be provisionally interpreted as auditory-comfort responses aimed at stress relief. The corresponding stimulus can then serve as a lead for deeper inquiry.

The appearance of auditory-comfort behavior indicates that the discomfort felt by the subject is still at an early, mild stage. The self-regulatory action remains bold and unhesitating, not yet having reached the stage of anxiety or fear.

## 2.2.8 Respiratory Response

**Interpretation:** Observing the amplitude and frequency of breathing reveals whether the subject's nervous-system and bodily arousal is increasing or decreasing. Increased amplitude or frequency indicates rising arousal; the opposite indicates falling arousal. If the subject deliberately controls breathing rate and reduces volume per breath, the subject has entered a cautious, oppositional state.

Breathing supplies oxygen and expels metabolic by-products such as carbon dioxide, ensuring continuous energy delivery.

Greater physiological activity and higher arousal objectively require more oxygen. This can be achieved by deeper single inhalations, faster breathing, or both.

Because stronger exhalation rapidly removes carbon dioxide, the respiratory center senses the change and triggers increased inhalation. When inhalation also increases, breathing intensifies—typical of highly aroused emotional states, most classically anger, when rapid, forceful nasal exhalation accompanies offensive movements. When exhalation increases without a matching increase in inhalation and is performed slowly and deeply, the pattern signals relaxation or resignation.

Reduced physiological activity and lowered arousal objectively decrease oxygen demand, so the respiratory center automatically lowers both rate and depth of breathing.

In highly restrained behavior, deep, slow breathing is common. Outwardly the subject may show no change in movement or expression, and vocal volume and rate may remain steady, yet the controlled, deep breathing reveals a guarded, oppositional mindset.

Thus any form of increased breathing indicates that, although the subject appears calm, inner and bodily arousal is rising; the calm is the result of deliberate control.

## 2.2.1 Comfort Response

**Interpretation:**

The presence of a comfort response shows that the other person feels uneasy or uncomfortable and that their psychological state is weakening, yet they are attempting to recover from the disadvantage.

A comfort response has two necessary characteristics: the movement is unrelated to verbal expression and serves no illustrative function, and the movement produces a sense of comfort for the person performing it.

Many gestures that accompany speech—indicating quantity, size, sequence, location, or vivid descriptions of feeling (“my head is exploding”)—are social behaviors that assist language and carry no diagnostic value.

When a movement bears no relation to the accompanying speech, however, it merits attention. If the movement feels comfortable to the person relative to their current emotional state, it qualifies as a comfort response.

Examples include rubbing the nose (physiologically comforting and unrelated to speech or illness such as rhinitis), scratching the scalp (physiologically comforting and unrelated to speech or medical conditions such as dandruff or headache), or slapping one’s own face when emotionally distressed (providing relief through redirected sensation). Kicking a wall corner, bumping the back, kneading an arm, smelling perfume, licking the lips, chewing gum, or needing a drink or cigarette—all satisfy the two criteria and constitute comfort responses.

### **Classic manifestations:**

Covering the mouth after a verbal slip, rubbing the nose while stammering, wringing the hands while waiting anxiously.

## **2.2.2 Freeze Response**

### **Interpretation:**

A freeze response indicates that the other person’s psychological state has weakened sharply and fear is present.

The freeze response has two features: reduced frequency and reduced amplitude of movement—i.e., fewer and smaller actions. Complete freezing means all movement ceases and the body adopts a contracted posture.

Typical contracted postures include shrugging the shoulders, rounding the spine, holding the hands close to the body, pressing the knees together, and pressing the ankles together.

Reduced frequency or cessation of movement occurs because, once the subject judges that a stimulus may be harmful, minimizing or stopping movement becomes the optimal survival strategy. Predators’ sensory systems are tuned to detect motion; both prey and predator therefore remain still when the situation is uncertain and they wish to avoid detection. Only after a clear decision (fight or flight) do large-amplitude, high-frequency movements resume. In relaxed states, amplitude and frequency can vary freely.

Reduction or contraction of movement amplitude occurs because, for any given offensive force, a smaller body area presents a smaller target and protects vital organs, lowering the probability of injury. One hundred arrows shot at one square meter will strike one hundred times; the same arrows shot at one square centimeter will strike only once—a basic physical principle.

### **Classic manifestations:**

A novice job candidate sitting rigidly and speaking cautiously exhibits a typical freeze response, fearing disapproval or negative consequences. By the same logic, observing a freeze response allows one to conclude



that the person's psychological state has weakened and fear-related emotions have arisen.

## Chapter 4 Micro-expressions of Surprise

When a person receives an unexpected stimulus, the first emotion aroused is surprise. Surprise is fleeting and quickly gives way to a return to baseline or to another emotion. The fuller the expression of surprise, the greater the intensity of the stimulus.

Humans and animals share one expression—surprise. Upon an unexpected stimulus, all activity ceases for an extremely brief instant: the head lifts, the eyes widen, the eyebrows rise, and the mouth opens slightly. Unfortunately, human ears cannot swivel; otherwise we would also observe the ear-raising and orienting seen in cats, dogs, and rabbits as they listen for the slightest sound.

Human intelligence and cultural norms, however, produce many variations on the standard surprise expression. The classic form involves raising the head to see farther and more clearly, yet humans can display surprise while keeping the head in any posture—lowered, tilted, or even turned away from the stimulus. These variations arise because people assess the risk level of an unexpected stimulus in fine gradations. Low-risk surprises produce barely detectable expressions; high-risk surprises cause a return to the full animal pattern.

Conversely, when surprise features appear on a person's face, one can conclude that the stimulus was unanticipated, has captured strong attention, and prompts the person to gather more information before deciding.

Such a stimulus therefore carries significant meaning for the individual.

## Chapter 3 Don't Be Afraid, I Can Do It—Comfort Response

When people receive negative stimuli such as criticism, pressure, or rejection, they frequently display unconscious micro-reactions that seek comfort in order to reduce inner discomfort. When these subtle movements appear, the negative stimulus is important and warrants further exploration; it may hold the key to uncovering the truth.

**Interpretation:** A comfort response maps two elements: first, the person is experiencing psychological discomfort—possibly confusion, tension, or embarrassment—yet has not reached the level of fear that produces a freeze response; second, the person is actively attempting self-regulation in order to return to a calm baseline.

As an infant held tightly by its mother, the front of the body feels the warm embrace while the back is gently stroked—safe and cozy. When hungry, the mouth receives the most pleasant taste while gentle, amusing songs are sung nearby. When the eyes open, they meet the mother's loving smile.

These earliest happy sensations, though not consciously remembered, are deeply imprinted in the brain. Later, when facing discomfort or difficulty, these stored experiences guide the body to seek or recreate similar sensations for self-comfort.

What produces a sense of comfort? Appropriate temperature, humidity, pressure, frequency, and touch generate pleasurable sensation. Even in the absence of such positive stimuli, simply reducing or stopping negative stimulation itself produces comfort.

### 2.2.5 Territorial Response

## Interpretation:

A territorial response indicates a dominant, controlling mindset—high confidence, strong sense of control, and high stress tolerance.

## Expansion

Willingness to expand and stretch the limbs, especially widening the angle between the arms or between the legs, shows that the person dares to expose the chest, abdomen, and genitals—the most vulnerable parts—to incoming pressure or stimuli, even believing that no negative stimulus will enter the expanded space. This is a highly dominant mindset reflecting confidence and control.

When the person opposite spreads both arms or widens the angle of the legs while seated, the posture signals a dominant state of mind<|eos|>

## Victory Reactions

Victory reaction manifestations: People with a victory mindset become excited in both nerves and muscles, brimming with energetic support. Under conditions of some restraint, they display many active behaviors. For example:

- Frequent eyebrow movements and irrepressible smiles, which is what we commonly call beaming with joy;
- Eyes become lively and shifting, constantly observing noteworthy people in an attempt to display their achievements to them, even hoping for recognition—this is what we commonly call gloating display and demonstration;
- Head swaying, neither nodding nor shaking, but moving in all directions; in opera art, to express a young female character's smugness, performers sometimes turn their eyes sharply from side to side while smiling, combined with the head swaying toward the directions pointed by the two ears;
- Rapid shoulder shaking;
- Torso rocking, following the same principle as head swaying, like a relaxed person entering a dance hall and swaying to the music, only with much smaller amplitude;
- Frequent purposeless finger movements, such as repeatedly tapping the tabletop lightly with fingers;
- If the chair has elasticity, the person may also lean against the backrest and gently rock the torso forward and backward;
- Legs crossed, with feet swaying and rocking.

## 3.1 Visual Comfort

Everyone loves to look at beautiful things, because visual comfort and reassurance truly improve a person's mood. Everyone also loves to look at ugly things, because whether disgusting or brutal, they worsen a person's mood.

If infants frequently see their parents' smiles, they develop cheerful personalities, becoming easy to please and quick to smile—all stemming from accumulated feelings of security and self-confidence. As they grow older, what their eyes see will not always be their parents' gentle smiles; they will also encounter many negative things that upset them. Moreover, with age they will no longer be satisfied solely with their parents' smiles and will develop additional visual needs, such as beautiful people (both male and female), beautiful scenery, artworks, and things that spark pleasant fantasies (such as banknotes). However, two rules remain unbroken: first, from the perspective of the objects themselves, what is seen always contains both good and bad, and no

one, no matter how capable, can control this; second, from the perspective of the viewer, people always prefer to look at what they like and avoid what they dislike.

Therefore, if a person is willing to look, it indicates liking; if their gaze shifts away, it indicates dislike.

## 2.2 Eight Major Reaction Types

After receiving an effective stimulus, the brain generates coping strategies based on its cognition and evaluation of the stimulus source. These strategies consist of complex sets of instructions sent by the nervous system to various organs of the body.

The head and neck, torso, and limbs execute complex movements according to these instructions to respond to the stimulus source. Among them, physiological and emotional reactions are suppressed and concealed by social behavior, so they do not appear too obvious or complete. These two types of reactions are not deliberate behaviors resulting from logical thinking by the individual; even the person themselves may not be aware of them. Therefore, these stress reactions that remain loyal to the actor carry important interpretive significance.

It is particularly emphasized that the effective objects of analysis must be stress reactions.

If there is no stimulus source and the actor simply performs some stylistic action or presents a certain state—whether bold and generous or reserved and modest, whether shrugging the shoulders or standing with legs apart—these belong to "one-way expression" and we do not analyze them!

We categorize the interpretable reactions into eight types.

### Escape Reactions

The notable characteristic of escape reactions is that the face moves away from the stimulus source. The face gathers many sensory organs, including the eyes, ears, nose, mouth, and most hair, and behind the face lies the nerve center. Therefore, when faced with negative stimuli, the face actively moves away from the stimulus source. The greater the intensity of the negative stimulus source, the greater the distance moved away, in direct proportion. Because this is a response to a negative stimulus source, tension appears alongside the distancing movement, including a non-relaxed face, gaze, and breathing, as well as a non-relaxed body; the limbs are very likely to remain in a tense or blocking state.

After escaping, the gaze assumes a stable state, though the direction may vary: upward indicates a passive avoidance strategy; downward indicates a restrained avoidance strategy with potential for attack; direct eye contact indicates confrontation and resistance.

#### **Summary:**

Observing an escape reaction allows one to judge the actor's subjective cognition and evaluation as contempt, disgust, rejection, panic, fear, and so on.

### 2.2.4 Upward Gaze Reactions

#### **Interpretive significance:**

Observing an upward gaze reaction indicates that the other party's mindset has strengthened; they do not accept, are not convinced by, and do not yield to the stimulus source, showing increased confrontational

intent.

Under normal conditions, the angle between the jawline and the cervical spine can serve as a baseline for judgment. If this angle increases, one can determine that a head-raising movement has occurred. If combined with lateral angle changes, confrontational and non-compliant tendencies become even more apparent.

Larger animals tend to win fights; their strength-weakness rules are that simple.

Humans have also inherited this consciousness preserved through millions of years of evolution. When feeling confrontational and unwilling to lose, they attempt to change their height by straightening the torso and raising the head. The actual increase in height is negligible, yet this movement does alter one's line of sight, allowing a top-down visual experience. In refined confrontations, the chin-raising angle may increase only slightly, yet it still highlights the actor's non-compliance and refusal to accept.

## The Inhibitory Effect of Deep Breathing on Excitement

Although the brain accounts for only 2% of body weight, it consumes 20%-25% of the body's total oxygen. If the brain's oxygen supply is insufficient, focus, cognitive ability, and rational thinking decline, making emotional instability, irritability, and anger more likely. Such states can cause serious losses for the actor in social interactions, including social evaluation and benefit acquisition.

When blood oxygen levels are sufficient, the brain can think more clearly and efficiently and better control behaviors in various parts of the body. Therefore, when a person feels tense and slightly out-of-control excitement, they typically use deep breathing to increase oxygen intake and carbon dioxide expulsion, allowing the brain adequate oxygen for enhanced behavioral control and reduced loss of control over excitement.

## Approach Reactions

Approach reactions are the primary way of expressing positive intentions, conveying a desire to obtain more information, to express more effectively, or to engage in better physical interaction. Corresponding intentions can be scripted respectively as: "What did you say?" "I like him too!" "Don't let others know about this," along with intimate actions without scripted lines.

Approach reactions can be divided into tentative small-amplitude and low-frequency movements and acquisitive large-amplitude and high-frequency movements. When the outcome is unclear, tentative actions are used to intervene, such as listening attentively; once a definitive judgment of the outcome is made, vigorous movements express and obtain the result, such as an enthusiastic welcoming embrace.

## Chapter 3 Natural Combinations of Emotions and Expressions

- 3.1 Does Inner Emotion Always Have an Outer Expression?
- 3.2 Are Expressions Honest?
- 3.3 The Concept of Micro-expressions
- 3.4 Do Different People Have the Same Micro-expressions?
- 3.5 The Principle of Micro-expression Lie Detection
  - 3.5.1 Physiological Expressions, Emotional Expressions, and Social Expressions
  - 3.5.2 Micro-expressions Deciphering "Why Lie?"
- 3.6 Muscles That Form Expressions and Micro-expressions
  - 3.6.1 Upper-Face Expression Muscle Groups

- 3.6.2 Lower-Face Expression Muscle Groups
- 3.7 Some Terms Used in This Book

## Negative Upward Gaze Reactions

### **Interpretive significance:**

Observing a negative upward gaze reaction indicates that the other party feels guilt, sadness, or powerlessness, exhibiting a weak mindset.

In our social etiquette, apologies after wrongdoing involve bowing or even kneeling. Anyone hoping their apology will be accepted adopts the same posture—bending the spine and lowering the head. The bending of the torso and the downward movement of the head and face express a weak mindset, fully demonstrating sincerity in guilt, sadness, and the request for forgiveness. Leg and hand movements usually follow the patterns of freeze reactions, reflecting caution and worry about angering the other party.

## Failure Reactions

Failure reactions mainly manifest as a dual sense of powerlessness in mental focus and physical support. Mentally, the person appears listless and uninterested in new things and information, because the most important interests have already been lost and there is neither willingness nor capacity to care about anything else at that moment. Physically, due to dejection and lack of spirit, the body assumes a naturally scattered posture: the head, torso, and limbs all sink downward under gravity; the spine does not straighten, the head does not rise, the hands are not raised high or waved broadly, the legs do not spread widely, rise onto tiptoes, shake, or sway, and the person does not stand upright, and so on.

## Combat Power Release

The characteristic of combat power release reactions is that the suspect uses overt or covert force exertion to direct inconspicuous force toward external objects, though usually not directly at the stimulus source. Examples include finger poking, knocking on tables, slapping tables, throwing books, slamming cups, smashing phones, and slamming doors. After modification, these actions become subtle and inconspicuous in their original aggressive meaning, yet they still express the actor's confrontational mindset and desire to win. This is a way of expressing a dominant mindset.

## Chapter 1 Micro-expressions: The Finishing Touch for Reading Minds and Understanding People

In major events, people show what they wish to show; only in trivial matters do they reveal themselves. Secrets leak in the details. The moment everyone encounters an external stimulus, a reaction appears on their face. These micro-expressions are instinctive, cannot be concealed, and are beyond control. In this sense, micro-expressions are the most advantageous clue to understanding a person's true inner thoughts.

## Genuine Expressions Flash for an Extremely Short Time

A person can maintain a normal expression for several seconds, but on a "disguised face," genuine emotion lingers on the face for an extremely short time. Therefore, one must carefully observe "who shows a look of panic yet forces composure." In footage provided by the U.S. Secret Service, when Clinton mentioned Lewinsky, his forehead furrowed slightly and then quickly returned to calm.

## 2.2.6 Combat Reactions

**Interpretive significance:** Observing the offensive posture of a combat reaction indicates that the other party is internally engaged in confrontation with a strong desire to win, belonging to a dominant mindset. Conversely, observing a defensive posture indicates that the other party is internally enduring an attack and attempting self-protection, belonging to a weak mindset.

The three stages of combat reactions are combat preparation, combat power release, and defensive protection.

### Combat Preparation

The characteristic of combat preparation reactions is that the actor exerts force in an inconspicuous manner, but the target of the force is not an external object—it is "exerting force against oneself." Examples include clenching fists, gripping one's own arms, pressing two fingers forcefully against each other, gritting teeth, tugging at one's own clothing, stomping and grinding the foot, or forcefully squeezing a walnut held in the hand.

## 2.2.7 Victory-Defeat Reactions

**Interpretive significance:** Observing victory reactions indicates that the actor is excited due to a sense of gain or superiority and believes they have won the psychological confrontation; observing failure reactions indicates that the actor is dejected due to an irreversible loss.

Victory-defeat reactions can be discussed in two categories: victory reactions and failure reactions.

## 2.2.3 Love-Hate Reactions

### **Interpretive significance:**

The distance between people is very subtle: liking draws one closer, disliking pushes one away; interest draws one closer, fear sends one far away.

We divide love-hate reactions into **escape reactions** and **approach reactions** for separate discussion to facilitate understanding.

## Chapter 2 The Face Reflects the Heart—What Facial Scanning Can Tell Us

A raised eyebrow and a curled lip reveal the true thoughts in the heart! People's faces write their inner secrets. Mastering certain decoding methods for facial micro-expressions makes others' disguises increasingly obvious and their concealments increasingly exposed.

### Defensive Protection

The characteristic of defensive protection reactions is that the torso bends while the hands and feet create barriers; the torso also naturally twists to prevent the stimulus source from directly invading the chest, abdomen, or genital area.

### Self-Defense

If territory is invaded—for example, if dignity is challenged—an intense anger reaction occurs directly, producing clear combat reactions.

### 4.5.3 Facial Rigidity

## Chapter Summary

### Emotional Micro-Expressions

#### 1. Complex Smiles

The eyebrows and forehead of a genuine natural smile are completely relaxed. If a person's smile features a distinctive eyebrow shape, it indicates that special emotions have been mixed into the smile. In addition, the shapes formed by the eyebrows and eyes can incorporate morphological features of various basic emotions, blending them into a new expressive meaning.

##### 1. Surprise

The defining feature of the surprise expression is the simultaneous presence of surprise and smile characteristics.

Expression features:

- Both eyebrows raised, indicating the presence of surprise.
- Upper eyelids significantly raised, exposing most of the upper edge of the iris. This is also a surprise feature. However, judging from the undistorted eyebrow shape, there is no fear.
- Upper lip raised to expose upper teeth, lower jaw open, lower lip forming a U-shape, corners of the mouth pulled sideways and upward. These belong to surprise and laughter features.
- Cheeks raised, with smile-specific grooves below the lower eyelids.

##### 2. Expectant Smile

The eyebrows and eyes show surprise features, but without mouth coordination, it is not genuine surprise. It is a form of surprise with a known outcome. Combined with smile features, it forms an expectant smile.

- Both eyebrows raised, indicating the presence of surprise.
- Upper eyelids significantly raised, exposing most of the upper edge of the iris, a micro-expression form of surprise.
- Upper lip raised to expose upper teeth, lower lip stretched, upper and lower teeth clenched, corners of the mouth pulled sideways and upward, revealing a smile.
- Cheeks raised, with smile-specific grooves below the eyelids.

##### 3. Disdainful Smile

The smile is insincere and dismissive, stemming from a sense of superiority toward an aversive stimulus.

- One side of the upper lip raised, exposing upper teeth, with nasolabial folds forming on both sides of the nose, a typical disgust feature.
- One corner of the mouth raised noticeably, with one side of the cheek raised as a smile feature.
- Eyelids closed, but the lower eyelids show no bulging, tightening, or smile grooves below, so it is not a genuine smile.

#### 4. **Angry Smile**

Clear anger features are present, yet the mouth shows smile characteristics while the eyes lack a smile, indicating insincerity. The action of teeth biting the lip shows the person is suppressing anger. However, the smile suggests the person is not under much pressure and feels inwardly pleased about the outcome of a confrontation.

- Head slightly lowered, chin retracted, indicating preparation for attack.
- Both eyebrows furrowed and lowered, with frown lines between the brows, indicating anger.
- Upper eyelids straining upward against the resistance of the lowered brows, forming wrinkles on the upper eyelids; lower eyelids tightened, an anger feature.
- Upper lip raised, exposing upper teeth, corners of the mouth stretched sideways and upward. Lower lip relaxed, a partial smile feature.
- Upper teeth show a tendency to bite the lower lip, indicating suppression.

#### 5. **Fearful Smile**

Sufficient smile features are present, but the eyebrows and upper eyelids display fear expressions, indicating fear mixed into the smile. This smile often appears when one is worried or anxious but uncertain about what will happen next.

- Both eyebrows flattened, with a change in the angle of the line connecting the brows and brow tips; the brow shape alteration caused by raised inner brows is a fear or sadness feature.
- Upper eyelids attempt to open wide but encounter resistance from lowered brows, forming wrinkles; without resistance, the exposed iris area would increase, a fear feature.
- Lower eyelids bulging, tightened, and raised, with smile grooves below; combined with mouth, lip shape, and cheek raising, these are smile features.

#### 6. **Sad Smile**

This expression may appear after enduring hardship followed by success.

- Inner brows raised, brow shape flattened but distorted in the inner third, a sadness or fear feature; however, tightly closed eyes rule out fear.
- Lower eyelids, mouth, and cheek shapes are smile features.

#### 7. **Cunning Smile**

Smile features are evident; lowered brows add a hint of malice, contraction of the corrugator muscles implies intense thinking, and suppressed lips highlight malice within the smile.

- Both brows lowered and slightly furrowed, with frown lines between the brows.
- Eyes narrowed, upper eyelids not raised, ruling out anger and fear; lower eyelids bulging, curved, and raised, with grooves formed by compression below, a smile feature.
- Corners of the mouth pulled toward the ears and raised, cheeks lifted, a smile feature.
- Lower lip pushed upward, pressed tightly against the upper lip, with a bulge on the chin, indicating acknowledgment.

#### 8. **Distracted Smile**

People automatically close their eyes in two situations to reduce visual interference. The first is physiological fatigue of the nervous system; the second is when enjoying or expressing enjoyment, allowing other senses to fully experience the stimulus.

- Upper eyelids fully relaxed, drooping to the upper edge of the pupil.



- Both brows raised, barely lifting the upper eyelids.
- Only the corners of the mouth and lip shape faintly show smile features; cheeks show slight raising, and smile grooves on the lower eyelids are almost imperceptible. This mouth shape confirms the absence of pressure. Combined with the distracted eye state, the smile appears more absorbed.

## 9. Smug Smile

An active suppression behavior appears within a confident smile, along with visual blocking to interrupt effective communication, indicating secret smugness.

- Eyebrows slightly raised, but upper eyelids not raised, indicating confidence.
- Gaze not directed at the stimulus source but shifted to the right, a visual blocking behavior indicating unwillingness to receive or convey information.
- Lower eyelid shape matches smile features.
- Upper lip raised, nasolabial folds evident; corners of the mouth pulled sideways, upper and lower lips lengthened; with the lower lip pushed up, the lip line forms a horizontal straight line, a smile feature.
- Facial muscle raising and downward pull of the mouth corner muscles participate in suppressing the mouth shape, indicating reluctance to reveal the smile.

## 2. Blushing Does Not Necessarily Mean Shyness

Lu Xun wrote in *Quasi-Romantic Talks* · "Negotiating" *Literary Giants*: "If the author is hungry and focused on serving society, he might blush a little when speaking out." Sha Ting wrote in *Ding the Lame*: "Not blushing at all, he lets people call him the old master." Ren Daxing wrote in *Little Companion Yuehua*: "I rarely speak to girls; I blush when I see one." These mostly refer to blushing from shyness or embarrassment.

People with generally weaker psychological resilience who care deeply about others' opinions tend to display tension or excitement when interacting with unfamiliar or important individuals. This radiates to excite the sympathetic nervous system, accelerating heart rate and dilating capillaries, resulting in blushing.

Blushing is a strong physiological reaction unique to humans. Generally, blushing indicates shyness, usually a psychological response when with someone one likes. However, blushing carries other meanings. Some people blush when angry, ashamed, nervous, or when praised or criticized.

Neuroscientist V. S. Ramachandran of the University of California, San Diego, notes that women generally blush more easily than men. Interestingly, blushing may have evolved as a way for women to signal honesty to men, attracting male assistance in raising offspring. He states: "Blushing means, I won't cuckold you. If asked about chastity, I won't lie; my blush proves it."

Primatologist Frans de Waal of Emory University in Atlanta, Georgia, has also said that blushing is a way to build trust. He notes: "If you go hunting with a stone-faced companion, you'll never tell him what you want. You'll feel very uncomfortable and unable to confirm whether you should trust him." Linking blushing with embarrassment and awkwardness may disadvantage those who never blush, because it is hard to trust someone who never feels shame about anything.

When we feel embarrassed, the cerebral cortex stimulates the adrenal glands, causing our faces to redden and heat up. Yet blushing occurs not only from shyness but also from happiness and anger. Embarrassment and shyness cause blushing, as do nervousness and shame.

Blushing also occurs involuntarily when one has done something wrong or lied. Why? Scientific research shows blushing connects to advanced emotions such as guilt, shame, embarrassment, and tension.

Extreme anger can also produce blushing, often described as “face red and neck thick.” The face does not merely turn red; it may alternate between red and pale, sometimes turning ashen. This results from massive adrenal secretion causing vasoconstriction, followed by alternating congestion and anemia, or prolonged anemia of the vessels.

Extreme excitement can also cause blushing. When agitated, cells enter an excited state, accelerating blood circulation, raising qi and blood, and prompting adrenal hormone secretion that excites the person. The surface phenomenon of accelerated circulation immediately appears on the face. This mainly stems from weaker psychological resilience, excessive concern for others’ opinions, and lack of composure.

Blushing is ultimately directed by the brain. Visual and auditory nerves converge in the head. When we hear or see something embarrassing, our eyes and ears immediately relay the message sensitively to the cerebral cortex. The cortex then activates relevant areas and stimulates the adrenal glands. Once stimulated, the adrenals respond by secreting adrenaline. Small amounts of adrenaline dilate blood vessels, especially subcutaneous capillaries; large amounts cause vasoconstriction.

The best way to overcome blushing is to maintain composure when encountering exciting stimuli, make more friends, participate in more social activities, and practice conversing with strangers.

### **3. Interlaced Fingers Do Not Necessarily Indicate Confidence**

During conversation, speakers often pair verbal content with body language to enhance effect and momentum. Interlacing the fingers is a common gesture.

It is generally believed that interlacing the fingers signals strong confidence in the conversation content. Yet not all instances of interlaced fingers indicate confidence; teachers, politicians, lawyers, and those conveying information frequently use this gesture.

Interlaced fingers convey meanings beyond confidence and appear in various forms:

#### **1. Interlaced fingers, placed naturally**

Fingers interlaced and placed naturally indicate the speaker feels confident and well-prepared. Users of this gesture typically smile broadly with a calm expression. For example, Queen Elizabeth of the United Kingdom often interlaces her fingers and places them naturally and elegantly on her knees during visits or public events. This conveys both confidence and graceful demeanor.

#### **2. Interlaced fingers, hands tightly clasped**

This gesture generally signals restraint, anxiety, negativity, or denial. People may also interlace and tightly clasp fingers during major events or changes, indicating pressure or lack of confidence. This behavior is widely recognized worldwide as a self-soothing action, akin to silent prayer, though it may be subconscious. If the grip tightens progressively and finger color changes, with local areas possibly turning white, the situation is worsening and the person’s mood has become highly anxious and worried.

#### **3. Interlaced fingers, placed naturally between chest and abdomen**

This gesture generally expresses “refusal” and, to some extent, implies setback. If the counterpart uses this gesture during negotiations, further communication will be difficult. One may need to offer a cup of

tea or a cigarette to prompt the person to release the interlaced hands from between chest and abdomen. Without releasing them, the person will struggle to accept new viewpoints.

#### **4. Interlaced fingers resting on thighs, thumbs touching or circling**

If this gesture appears during conversation, the person is in a dilemma, uncertain how to proceed with the current situation or topic. Close observation may also reveal slowed speech and lip-biting.

#### **5. Interlaced fingers, one thumb extended upward**

This differs from the previous gesture: only one thumb extends upward, or even if both thumbs extend upward, their tips do not touch. The gesture conveys, "I am confident; I am very sure of what I am saying; I maintain a positive attitude toward what we are discussing."

#### **6. Interlaced fingers, eyes fixed on the other person**

This action usually indicates the person is forcefully suppressing dissatisfaction or aversion and is in a state of extreme endurance.

#### **7. Interlaced fingers, placed in front of the face**

If the elbows are propped up so that interlaced hands rest in front of the face, this is a highly hostile gesture. It proves the person is dissatisfied or hostile and wishes to end the conversation quickly.

#### **8. Interlaced fingers, one hand's fingers rubbing the other hand**

The interlaced-fingers gesture is mostly negative. People in doubt or under high pressure often use it, then rub one palm with the fingers (usually the thumb) of the other hand. This self-contact produces a soothing effect on the brain and reveals inner unease, anxiety, and complex, fluctuating emotions.

Therefore, not all interlaced fingers indicate confidence; meaning depends on context. Accompanied by different body language, the gesture expresses varied meanings and emotions.

### **4. Several "No"s in Social Interactions**

Generally, nodding signifies affirmation and approval, while shaking the head signifies negation and refusal. However, exceptions exist in social settings.

During a conversation, if the listener nods continuously more than three times toward the speaker, it indicates impatience or negation of the content. Conversely, if the listener gives a slight head shake accompanied by a smile when the speaker makes a request, it shows the listener is not entirely rejecting the idea; with further effort from the speaker, the original refusal may turn into acceptance.

In social settings, if one party speaks continuously while the other nods occasionally but out of sync with the conversation rhythm—nodding perfunctorily long after the speaker has finished—it indicates the listener is not paying attention or is thinking of something else. Conversely, if the head-shake is out of sync with the rhythm, it likely means the person is thinking of something else and shook unconsciously, not necessarily negating the content.

In daily life, nodding does not always mean affirmation, nor does shaking the head always express negation. For example:

##### **1. Slow nodding**

If the other person nods slowly every so often while you speak—two or three nods each time—it proves interest in your content and willingness to continue listening.

## 2. Rapid nodding

Generally, rapid nodding means “You are absolutely right” or “I completely agree.” Sometimes, however, it may convey other meanings, such as “I am getting impatient; stop talking,” especially when accompanied by phrases like “All right, all right” or “I know.” It may also express urgency, wanting the speaker to finish quickly so the listener can speak. Yet if the nodding is both rapid and frequent, it proves complete disinterest and a desire for the speaker to stop.

## 3. Slow head-shaking

Slow head-shaking during conversation basically signals negation, such as “I don’t quite agree,” “I don’t fully understand,” or “I won’t do as you say.”

## 4. Rapid head-shaking

In some cases, rapid head-shaking expresses strong negation but can also be used by young boys or girls to convey shyness; the amplitude is usually small. If accompanied by lowering the head, it can be judged as “shyness.”

It appears we cannot judge micro-expression meanings by ordinary thinking. Instead, we must interpret nods or head-shakes according to the specific conversational context and the other person’s reactions, rather than automatically equating a nod with “Yes” and a head-shake with “No.”

Understanding this, we should pay attention during conversations. To show interest in the other person’s words, nod several times while appearing thoughtful.

Failing to nod may give the impression that “you are not interested” or “you are difficult to talk to.”

Similarly, different head-shakes can convey your meaning to achieve the best conversational outcome.

You need not worry whether the other person understands these micro-expression meanings, as they stem from human instinct. By correctly conveying your intent, the other person should gradually grasp your meaning and adjust their own language and actions accordingly.

## Section 4: No Expression Does Not Equal No Emotion

In daily life, we often encounter people who maintain a completely expressionless face no matter what others say or do. We frequently accuse such individuals of having no emotions. In reality, a lack of expression does not mean a lack of emotion.

We all know that “no one is made of wood or grass; everyone has feelings.” Some people simply are not good at expressing emotions or choose not to reveal them easily. Every person in this world possesses emotions. Regardless of wealth, status, intellect, or experience, the emotions granted by a higher power are equal for all. Therefore, the notion of “having no emotions” can essentially be ruled out.

In fact, people who show fewer expressions may harbor richer inner emotions. When inner activity does not appear on the face, it can seem unnatural. The more deliberately expressionless someone appears, the more impulsive their emotions may actually be.

For example, in the workplace, some employees feel strong dissatisfaction with their superiors yet dare not voice it. Even when furious, they deliberately adopt an expressionless look and pretend to be indifferent, while their inner state is already in turmoil. If you observe their face closely at such moments, you may notice an odd complexion, a stiff and somewhat numb appearance—sometimes called “dead-mask syndrome.” This

expressionless “dead mask” conceals a strong inner desire: a wish for the other person to notice their dissatisfaction and resistance.

Expressionless people are usually suppressing their emotions intensely. Consequently, traces similar to those of a liar can be detected on their faces. Because facial muscles remain unchanged while psychological activity continues, certain unnatural signs appear, such as blinking, wrinkling the nose, or facial twitching. These signs reveal inner dissatisfaction and insecurity.

When dealing with such a person, do not directly accuse them or embarrass them on the spot by saying loudly, “What’s wrong with you? Your cheek is twitching—tell me your complaints!” This may cause their suppressed resentment to erupt and worsen the situation. To maintain harmonious relations, stay calm and say instead, “If you have any dissatisfaction, feel free to share it.” This approach can soothe the emotions they are struggling to contain.

At this stage, avoid excessive talk or direct confrontation. Choose another appropriate time to speak openly with them so that the expressionless phenomenon gradually disappears. This resolves the conflict with subordinates and establishes the supervisor’s positive image.

The same expressionless face can sometimes indicate extreme indifference or disregard toward others or events. Occasionally, we feel flustered when our gaze accidentally meets someone else’s. To avoid embarrassment, we both adopt an uncaring or cold expression. This only proves we care about the other person or have feelings toward them.

Consider a girl who has fallen in love with a boy. Because she is shy and reluctant to express her affection or let others know, she deliberately appears indifferent and expressionless to hide her feelings. In such cases, her behavior shows she cares about you; you should continue to express your own intentions.

For people who appear expressionless, we should watch for subtle facial changes to infer their emotional or mood shifts.

## **Identifying Emotions, Observing Psychology**

Russian literary giant Tolstoy described 97 different kinds of smiles and 85 different kinds of gazes. It is no exaggeration to say that the human face is the most expressive part of the body; it can convey a variety of complex emotions such as surprise, joy, fear, doubt, sadness, disgust, and contempt. If you observe someone’s expressions carefully, you can certainly decode their emotional signals.

Everyday examples abound: someone claims not to be nervous yet keeps tapping a foot or swinging a leg; someone says time is short yet walks slowly; someone claims no regret yet repeatedly slaps their own head. People try to conceal their true thoughts, focusing only on fabricating lies, but they cannot control their body movements. Unwittingly, they reveal inner secrets through simple gestures.

“Not lying? Then why did your voice suddenly tremble?” “Not nervous? Then why did your speech suddenly speed up?” In daily life, have you often encountered situations where language alone reveals whether someone is lying? Can language truly disclose a person’s emotions? Common sense tells us that language is the most direct communication tool and that all speech reveals inner thoughts. This book will show you that even when someone’s words are insincere, their inner emotions and psychological state leak out through tone, speed, and word choice.

Expressions, body movements, and language all carry emotions and can reveal psychological secrets. By studying the knowledge in this book, you will learn to identify emotions and detect psychological states through a person's expressions, body movements, and language.

Emotion is the first neural response to an effective stimulus; it precedes rational thought and cannot be deliberately faked. Even if the person becomes aware of the emotion and tries to control it, signs will still slip out unconsciously. These subtle emotional reactions are extremely brief—especially for those skilled at psychological camouflage, the reaction may last only 0.04 seconds. Yet if you capture this fleeting change and analyze it in context, you can strip away the disguise and recognize the true emotion and psychological state.

In addition to identifying others' emotions and detecting their psychology, studying this book will also help you recognize your own emotions and psychological state, control negative emotions, express emotions appropriately, channel negative feelings, and cultivate positive ones. You will also understand the relationship between emotion and thought. In some respects, this content is more important than recognizing others' emotions, because it directly affects your physical and mental health and determines whether your life is happy or miserable.

Finally, we sincerely wish every reader will gain knowledge and live a happy, fulfilling life.

### **Conclusion: Micro-expressions Help You See Through Life**

The purpose of *Illustrated Micro-expressions: Learn to Read People in One Minute* is to let you quickly see through others' intentions, grasp the truth, protect yourself as much as possible, understand others, and take the initiative in interactions.

Once a person enters society, they become someone's employee, colleague, boss, friend, partner, competitor, or lover. As long as you are in interpersonal relationships, you inevitably interact with others. Dealing with people is a profound art; discerning others' inner thoughts is an even deeper proposition. Many seek methods of mind-reading. Micro-expressions provide a key to quickly grasp another person's mind and serve as a powerful tool in social interactions. Micro-expressions are, in effect, "mind-reading."

People may conceal their true feelings because of upbringing, knowledge, experience, or personality. In modern society everyone is an accomplished actor. Pretending to like someone you dislike is a minor trick. More dangerous are business partners who toast you today and set a trap tomorrow, or colleagues who call you brother today and betray you tomorrow. It is hard to know a person's heart even when you know their face. Therefore, it is necessary to learn how to grasp others' true thoughts.

No matter how hypocritical a person is, they cannot control their micro-expressions. Micro-expressions are the most primitive human instinct and cannot be faked; they are natural reactions to stimuli and are not governed by conscious thought. Even the best actor's first instant micro-expression is genuine; only afterward come the fabricated expressions. By analyzing the other person's micro-reaction (微反应) and the subsequent masking reactions, the truth lies before you. At that point you achieve "knowing both face and heart." One minute is enough to see through a person. You will no longer be deceived by words or staged expressions and behaviors; you can directly penetrate the disguise, discover the real psychology, protect yourself, strike precisely, and effectively influence and guide others—ultimately remaining undefeated in work and life.

This book provides practical methods for identifying micro-expressions, including the six basic expressions—surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and joy—plus various compound micro-expressions, with real-world cases. No matter the situation, you can make sound judgments. Through the other person's language,

expressions, and body movements, you can immediately know their true thoughts and detect lies. When facing possible danger, recognizing lies triggers alertness and reduces unnecessary losses.

Master micro-expressions and you can see through people in one minute.

### 11.1.1 Expressionless Baseline

The first type is the expressionless baseline: the calm, serene appearance of a person's face when showing no expression. This baseline data is used to judge movements such as eyelid motion, eyebrow raising, or tiny changes in the cheeks and corners of the mouth. Any deviation from the baseline indicates an expression movement, as shown in Figure 11-1.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-1 面无表情基线]*

To observe a person's expressionless baseline features, you do not need to record every detail of the entire face. It is sufficient to focus on three indicators: eyebrows, eyes, and mouth.

The eyebrow baseline mainly observes the calm shape and position of the eyebrows, as shown in Figure 11-2.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-2]*

Different people may have completely opposite baseline eyebrow features when relaxed—some naturally have furrowed brows, others naturally have sword-shaped brows. Once this baseline is established, you will not mistake a raised or furrowed brow for an intentional action.

The eye baseline refers to the position of the eyelids when relaxed; an indirect indicator is the size of the exposed iris area, which can be measured by vertical diameter, as shown in Figure 11-3.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-3]*

Normally, "large eyes" means a greater vertical distance between the eyelids in the natural relaxed state—that is, a larger exposed iris area. Conversely, "small eyes" means a smaller exposed iris area. For the expression models used in this book, the upper eyelid covers 19 % of the iris's vertical diameter, the lower eyelid covers 9.5 %, and the exposed iris area accounts for 71.5 % of the entire iris.

With this baseline data, you will not misjudge whether a person is widening their eyes or closing their eyelids. From another angle, any slight increase or decrease in iris exposure can be immediately detected against the baseline, allowing you to infer whether the person is opening their eyes wider or narrowing them.

The mouth baseline mainly concerns lip shape and position, using the shape of the lip line as an indirect indicator. Also note whether the person has any relaxed-state mouth deformity, such as a protruding lower jaw or other abnormal muscle patterns. Because mouth shape has lower validity for judging micro-expression anomalies and is easily affected by speech and breathing, it is not recommended to analyze mouth-shape changes in isolation.

### 11.2.3 Anger

When the intensity of a negative stimulus exceeds the limit of disgust, anger is triggered.

#### 1. Full anger expression morphology

The morphological features of a full anger expression are as follows:

- ① The orbicularis oculi muscle contracts strongly, pulling both eyebrows downward; the corrugator supercilii muscle contracts strongly, knitting the brows;
- ② The levator palpebrae superioris muscle contracts strongly, raising the upper eyelids to the maximum in an attempt to expose the entire upper edge of the iris. However, the upward lift of the upper eyelids combined with the downward press of the brows creates a mutual compression that forms diagonal skin folds on the upper eyelid skin;
- ③ The lower eyelids tighten; the shape of the upper eyelids matches the tightened lower eyelids, known as a glare;
- ④ The levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi muscles contract together, lifting the nasal wings while raising the cheeks and forming deep grooves on both sides of the nose;
- ⑤ The jaw opens downward; the lower lip is pulled down by the depressor labii inferioris, exposing part of the lower teeth. Under the action of the platysma, the lower lip stretches sideways and thins, pressing tightly against the jawbone.

## 2. Common anger expression morphology

In modern social interactions, except when dealing with close relatives or fighting enemies, ordinary people rarely open their mouths to roar even when angry. More often they keep their lips tightly closed while holding their breath. Combined with the standard angry eyebrow-eye configuration, the face appears extremely angry.

- ① Corrugator supercilii and orbicularis oculi muscles contract, knitting and lowering the brows;
- ② Levator palpebrae superioris contracts;
- ③ Orbicularis oculi contraction also tightens the lower eyelids and pulls them slightly sideways;
- ④ Orbicularis oris contracts, pressing both lips tightly together;
- ⑤ Depressor anguli oris contracts, turning both mouth corners downward;
- ⑥ Mentalis contracts, forming a raised muscle on the chin with an uneven surface while pushing the lower lip upward to keep the lips closed.

## 3. Micro-expression morphology of anger

Under extreme restraint, the anger expression usually reduces to changes in the eyelids only.

- ① Levator palpebrae superioris contracts, attempting to raise the upper eyelids (often meeting resistance from the knitted, lowered brows);
- ② Orbicularis oculi contracts, tightening the lower eyelids closer to the skull.

### Summary:

The appearance of an anger expression indicates that the negative intensity of the stimulus source has escalated.

### 11.2.4 Fear

If the negative stimulus continues to intensify and overwhelms the individual's psychological capacity to attempt attack (resistance), anger turns into fear.

### Micro-expressions Are More Likely to Appear Here! ①

In this section we review the expressions of "happiness," "contempt," and "disgust" while tackling these questions. The expressions below are "neutral," "happiness," "contempt," and "disgust." Identify the corresponding expression from images ①—④.



Usually we judge facial expressions by overall impression, so distinguishing various emotional meanings from partial facial cues is difficult. Because micro-expressions reveal only a portion of the face, the ability to differentiate fine details among expressions becomes important.

The differences among "happiness," "contempt," and "disgust" lie in the mouth. The shapes around the mouth can be used to distinguish these micro-expressions.

**The correct answers are:**

- ❶ = "happiness"
- ❷ = "disgust"
- ❸ = "contempt"
- ❹ = "neutral"

We will explain using ❹ "neutral" as the baseline.

**❶ "Happiness."** Both corners of the mouth rise symmetrically. Compared with the neutral expression, the nasolabial folds extend horizontally and clearly curve upward.

**❷ "Disgust."** Compared with neutral, the lower lip is noticeably thicker; the entire lip is lifted from above, and the nasolabial folds extend vertically. The shape resembles nostrils being covered by a lid—the result of contraction of muscles around the nose.

**❸ "Contempt."** The right corner of the mouth is raised higher than the left. When a pure contempt expression appears, one corner of the mouth rises. When contempt is masked by happiness, the corners rise asymmetrically. However, most people's faces are naturally asymmetrical, so before judging contempt, observe how symmetrical the person's neutral expression is and confirm whether their mouth corners rise symmetrically when they smile.

A "forced smile" also tends to be asymmetrical with upward-turned corners, so pay special attention to whether the expression is a forced smile or a contempt expression masked by happiness.

### 11.2.2 Disgust

After evaluating the stimulus, the individual judges it to be negative and experiences aversion, attempting to distance themselves without any desire to change or eliminate the stimulus. This emotion manifests as a disgust expression.

The most primitive disgust-eliciting stimulus is rotten food.

#### 1. Full disgust expression morphology

The morphological features of a full disgust expression are as follows:

- ❶ The corrugator supercilii contracts, knitting the brows;
- ❷ The orbicularis oculi contracts strongly, tightly closing the eyes and simultaneously depressing the brows;
- ❸ The levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi contract, raising the upper lip while forming nasolabial folds on either side of the nose;
- ❹ The mentalis contracts, forcefully pushing the lower lip upward so that both lips press tightly together; the chin simultaneously wrinkles upward, producing numerous folds on the surface skin; a deep groove forms between the lower lip and the raised muscle on the chin;

⑤ The depressor anguli oris contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth downward and counterbalancing the action of the levator labii superioris, creating bracket-shaped lines on either side of the mouth.

## 2. **Contempt expression morphology**

When stimulus intensity decreases to moderate levels, the emotion of **contempt** arises. Contempt overall expresses a top-down rejection of the stimulus. Although it is still rejection, the mindset is far more relaxed and does not require expending much mental energy to respond.

- ① The corrugator supercilii contracts, knitting the brows;
- ② The orbicularis oculi contracts strongly, depressing the brows;
- ③ The levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi contract, raising the upper lip while forming nasolabial folds on either side of the nose;
- ④ The depressor anguli oris contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth downward and counterbalancing the action of the levator labii superioris, creating bracket-shaped lines on either side of the mouth.

## 3. **Disdain expression morphology**

When stimulus intensity is very weak, the emotion of **disdain** arises. Disdain is complete disregard; apart from looking down on the stimulus, there is no need to expend effort to reject it.

Only the final feature remains: contraction of the levator labii superioris group raises the upper lip, exposing part of the upper teeth and forming nasolabial folds on either side of the nose.

These are also the micro-expression morphological features of disgust-type emotions.

The meaning of disgust emotions is negation. If a disgust-type expression appears, one may conclude that the subject holds a negative attitude toward the information in the stimulus.

## **Micro-expressions in Marriage**

Once inside marriage, paying attention to his or her micro-expressions can prevent many issues. Of course, the most important thing between spouses is mutual tolerance and understanding; micro-expression observations serve only as a reference.

### 1. **Rubbing the nose: concealing the truth**

When a person lies, excess blood flows to the face, causing the spongy tissue inside the nose to swell by several millimeters. The liar feels discomfort in the nose and therefore touches it inadvertently.

### 2. **Gazing into the other person's eyes: while lying**

Contrary to common belief, it is not true that "if you look me in the eyes you are not lying." Beware of liars who look into your eyes to check whether their deception is succeeding. Conversely, breaking eye contact does not necessarily mean the other person is lying.

### 3. **Man's right shoulder slightly shrugs: telling a lie**

When a man is trying hard to explain something and unconsciously shrugs one shoulder, it indicates he is lying.

### 4. **Eyebrows raise when saying "I don't know" or "I'm not clear": the person actually knows the answer**

For example, when the wife mentions the mistress, the husband may quickly say "How would I know?" to distance himself. Watch his eyebrows carefully; his heart may be pounding.

### 5. **Surprise expression lasting more than one second: feigned surprise**

Over-exerting an expression produces this result. Other macro-expressions do not last longer than four seconds.

### 6. **Deliberately distancing language: lying**

Saying "that person" instead of using the name. Avoiding the other person's name clearly shows insincerity.

### 7. **Hand near the brow bone: shame**

This unconscious gesture may indicate guilt toward you; consider what might have caused it.

### 8. **Glancing at the other person then shifting gaze while the other person slightly raises the chin, indicating embarrassment: having an affair**

This occurs between a man and a woman. Sharpen your observation skills and watch for hidden dangers nearby.

### 9. **Head unconsciously shakes slightly when saying "yes": lying**

Regrettably, the body has betrayed the words.

## ③ **Easterners Focus on "Eye Changes," Less Sensitive to Mouth Changes**

Finally, let us discuss issues related to "gaze." Have you ever used emoticons? Try drawing a smiling face and a sad face. Do not rely on imagination; draw them as realistically as possible. You will discover something interesting. What kind of emoticons did you draw? Most people probably drew something like this:

- Smiling face = "<sup>^</sup>^," sad = "><" or "i\_;"
- Another type: smiling face = "😊," sad = "😞"

Do you know the difference between these two styles of smiling and sad emoticons? The correct answer is: one involves changes in the eyes, the other changes in the mouth.

The first style is typically used by Asians, while the second style is typically used by Westerners. This shows that Asians emphasize eye changes when creating emoticons, whereas Westerners emphasize mouth changes.

Experiments have found that faces in which "the eyes are smiling but the mouth is crying" are mostly judged as smiling faces by Easterners, while faces in which "the eyes are crying but the mouth is smiling" are mostly judged as smiling faces by Westerners.

Thus, Easterners are more sensitive to eye changes and less sensitive to mouth changes. From a Japanese perspective, one notable fact emerges: Japanese people tend to misinterpret "surprise" and "fear."

In one study, Americans correctly identified "fear" expressions at an 85% rate, while Japanese did so at only 66%. Other reports show that Japanese people tend to interpret "fear" expressions as "surprise" expressions.

The reason is said to be that Japanese people encounter threatening "fear" expressions less frequently than Americans, making them prone to confuse the two similar expressions.

So, in conversation, what other points should one note to distinguish hard-to-read expressions? Let us look at examples from "conversational messages."

## ② **Pay Attention to Facial Movements from Conversational Messages**

Facial movements can convey many meanings and are generally divided into two types: “emotional messages” and “conversational messages.” Conversational messages refer to the muscle movements of the face, whether conscious or unconscious, that occur while we are talking.

Emotional expressions are usually called “expressions,” but conversational messages are facial movements rather than expressions. Conversational messages appear prominently in the “eyebrows.” During conversation, the other person’s eyebrows usually move up and down; few people speak with completely still eyebrows.

We always subtly raise and lower our eyebrows while talking. For the listener, when both eyebrows rise, it indicates interest in what is being said. When both eyebrows lower, it indicates a mixture of puzzlement and careful listening. For the speaker, eyebrows moving up and down signal an intent to emphasize key points.

The difference between micro-expressions and conversational messages is that conversational messages allow clear identification of the other person’s emotions, whereas micro-expressions are harder to judge.

For example, consider the action of “both eyebrows moving toward the center.” In a micro-expression, a suppressed emotion may produce only a subtle downward movement of the eyebrows. Without careful observation, it may go unnoticed, and even close scrutiny sometimes fails to detect it. In conversation, however, simply watching the other person’s face while speaking makes these movements noticeable.

If micro-expressions are facial movements formed because one does not want the other person to detect one’s true feelings, then conversational messages are facial movements that appear because one wants to draw the other person’s attention.

### 3. Oh, How Tragic! (A Tragic Event That Does Not Concern Me)

- ① Both brows rise significantly, indicating surprise, yet the brow shape is not a natural arch; instead, it twists at the inner one-third, possibly indicating fear or sadness;
- ② Although the eyelids open to the maximum, the amount of sclera visible above the iris shows that the elevation of the upper lid is driven by strong frontal-muscle pull on the brows rather than by the levator palpebrae superioris; therefore the eyelids themselves are not tense and perform no leading action, ruling out fear (fear requires levator palpebrae superioris elevation). Combined with brow morphology, the expression is sadness;
- ③ A shallow nasolabial fold indicates trace contraction of the levator labii superioris, although the actual position of the upper lip is pulled low overall by the depressor anguli oris—an essential feature of disgust;
- ④ The platysma pulls the corners of the mouth sideways while the depressor anguli oris contracts strongly, markedly lowering the mouth corners, yet the lip line forms an upward arch;
- ⑤ The mentalis contracts strongly, pushing the middle of the lower lip upward so the lips press tightly together, creating an uneven raised surface on the chin. Combined with the effect of the depressor anguli oris, this is a typical sad mouth shape; the only difference is that the jaw has not opened and the mouth has not gaped, otherwise it would be open-mouthed crying. Thus the morphology belongs to sadness-type emotional expression.

**Summary:** Brow and eye morphology express surprise and sadness; the degree of upper-lip elevation expresses mild disgust (dislike); overall mouth morphology expresses helplessness (the psychological state represented by sadness is powerlessness to change the outcome). This expression commonly appears in the first instant after seeing a tragic scene and conveys inner helplessness toward the tragedy (powerlessness that does not concern oneself), synonymous with a shrug.

## 1. Head-Shaking Indians

It is said that Indians love to shake their heads. No matter what they express, they habitually answer with a head shake. This naturally leaves outsiders who “do not understand the situation” completely bewildered. Backpackers who have visited India therefore conclude that if you need directions you must ask at least three times and must not phrase the question in the usual way: “Is this the way to such-and-such place?” Because the answer is always a head shake, you assume it is not and take another route, yet you may have misunderstood. To avoid this, you should ask: “Which road should I take to such-and-such place?”

This Indian habit of confusing right and wrong is hard for outsiders to fathom, which is why they also call their country “incredible India.”

When meeting an Indian, they always bring both hands together in front of the chest and say “Namaste!” as a greeting. At the same time they gently shake their head with a very self-assured air. Even when they greet you with the English “HELLO,” they tilt their head to the right and then immediately straighten it. If you do not understand, you may ask, “Is there a problem?” They will swing their head from left to right in a vigorous 180-degree arc and mutter, “No problem, goodbye, thank you!” Of course the head is still shaking, but the movement is lateral rather than the usual vertical head-shake; it is a rotation of the neck in the horizontal plane, so most people can tell it does not signify negation.

Indian head-shaking is quite interesting—elegant, lively, and full of charm. Yet many times the head shake does not mean NO!

## 1. Morphology of the Crying Expression

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-18]

1. The orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii contract together, depressing both brows and producing vertical wrinkles between them. However, the middle portion of the frontalis contracts and slightly raises the brows, flattening the overall brow shape and creating an upward twist at the inner one-quarter;
2. Contraction of the orbicularis oculi produces forceful eyelid closure, creating wrinkles at the inner eye corners and crow's-feet at the outer corners;
3. Contraction of the levator labii superioris raises the upper lip while, together with the orbicularis oculi, lifting the cheeks; the raised cheeks press against the lower eyelids, forming a depressed area beneath the lower lids and nasolabial folds on either side of the nose;
4. Contraction of the platysma stretches the corners of the mouth sideways, increasing the horizontal width of the mouth beyond normal; the stretched corners press against the cheeks, forming nasolabial folds;
5. The depressor anguli oris contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth downward; the depressor labii inferioris contracts simultaneously, lowering the entire lower lip in an attempt to expose the lower teeth;
6. The mentalis contracts at the same time, pushing the middle of the lower lip upward and forming an uneven muscular bulge on the chin. The upward push of the middle lower lip covers part of the lower teeth that could otherwise be exposed, while the corners of the mouth remain lowered, allowing only the teeth at the corners to show. The lower-lip curve forms a W shape. This mouth shape is unique to the crying expression.

### 3. Capturing the Instant “Micro-expression”

In daily life we often hear many lies—some well-intentioned, some deliberately concealed—most intended to win others’ favor or praise, and some used to hide one’s true thoughts. To avoid being deceived by these lies, it suffices to catch the “micro-expression” that appears when lying.

Because the fleeting subtle expressions that cross the face often reveal one’s true emotions. The key to detecting lies lies in observing changes in the face and hands, with special attention to the muscles around the eyes and mouth

#### 1. Envy, Jealousy, and Hatred

- ① Eyebrow shape is normal; slight frowning action visible through brow furrows, indicating attention and response;
- ② Upper eyelid shape is normal, with no obvious raising or drooping; however, the lower eyelid is tense and slightly bulging, a morphological feature of anger;
- ③ Gaze directed toward the upper left, in this image fixating on a stimulus source to the left; the upward bias indicates a higher self-positioning (relative to the stimulus source);
- ④ Upper lip raised, nasolabial folds clear, yet showing traces of suppression, indicating disgust-type emotion judged as mild contempt according to intensity;
- ⑤ Mentalis muscle contraction evident, with uneven bulging that pushes the lower lip outward while the upper lip is pressed tight;
- ⑥ Depressor anguli oris and platysma show slight contraction, corners of the mouth pulled slightly sideways and downward in a mild curve, forming a “bitter pout,” indicating suppression and helplessness.

**Summary:** Contradictory attitude toward the observed subject—one side holds negative disgust emotion, possibly at the level of contempt; the other side shows attention and response with slight anger, yet no means to change the situation, resulting only in self-suppression and acceptance of the status quo.

#### 2. Capturing Unconscious Expressions

Expressionless people are often concealing or disguising themselves, so discerning their true emotions remains difficult. Yet when someone strives to appear nonchalant while forcefully masking emotion, traces can still be found.

When a person works hard to restrain effort or endure something unpleasant, their mind stays taut and facial expression appears stiff; in severe cases facial spasms may occur. This mental state resembles an inflated balloon: pinching one spot causes another to bulge.

Thus, when emotions run high, mental tension increases. If the emotion is not displayed outwardly, muscles tighten and manifest through abnormal expressions and movements, such as irregular facial twitching, continuous frowning and blinking, or wrinkles at the nose tip. These signs indicate suppressed emotion. In short, such unusual expressions allow a rough glimpse of the person’s true feelings.

#### Paying Attention to Important Facial Lines

Certain facial regions change in close relation to specific emotional shifts. To determine whether someone is sad or fearful, observing the eyebrows and forehead is important; to determine disgust or joy, the mouth best reflects the state. Therefore, by focusing on a few key lines—especially muscle movements around the eyes

and mouth—one can roughly infer the person's genuine emotional changes. How many important facial lines merit observation?

The primary line is at the corners of the mouth: note whether the corners rise or droop and whether the mouth is raised or tightly closed. Lines at the brows and eyes must not be overlooked: observe whether the eyebrows rise or fall, whether the outer eye corners rise or drop, and whether the eyes are wide or slightly narrowed.

Also attend to the forehead. When eyebrows rise, horizontal wrinkles form across the forehead; when brows are knit, vertical lines appear between them. Ignoring these details means fleeting emotional signals on the face will escape notice.

## 2. Other Complex Expressions

### 1. Envy, Jealousy, and Hatred

The observed subject elicits both negative disgust emotion, possibly contempt, and attention with a response of slight anger, yet no means exist to alter the situation, leaving only self-suppression and acceptance.

- Eyebrows retain normal shape yet display slight frowning, indicating attention and response.
- Upper eyelid shape is normal, yet the lower eyelid is tense and slightly bulging, an anger feature.
- Gaze directed upper left toward the stimulus source; the upward bias indicates higher self-positioning.
- Upper lip raised, nasolabial folds clear, yet showing suppression, judged as contempt.
- Facial muscles contract noticeably, forming a bulge beneath the lower lip that pushes it outward while the upper lip is pressed tight.
- Slight contraction of mouth-corner and platysma muscles pulls the corners slightly sideways and downward in a bitter expression, indicating suppression and helplessness.

## 3. Tragedy That Does Not Concern Me

Eyebrow and eye morphology express surprise and sadness; the degree of upper-lip elevation expresses mild disgust; overall mouth morphology expresses helplessness. The expression conveys inner resignation toward the tragic scene.

1. Eyebrows raised substantially, indicating surprise; yet the inner third of each brow shows distortion, a fear or sadness feature.
2. Although the eyes open maximally, the exposed upper iris margin indicates the levator palpebrae superioris is driven by strong brow elevation rather than its own action, ruling out fear; combined with brow morphology, the expression is sadness.
3. Shallow nasolabial folds, a necessary feature of disgust, with the actual upper-lip position pulled downward overall by muscle action.
4. Mouth corners pulled sideways and substantially lowered, yet the inter-labial line forms an upward arch.
5. Strong facial-muscle contraction pushes the middle of the lower lip upward, pressing the lips together and forming a bulge. This is a typical sadness mouth shape; because the jaw remains closed the mouth does not open, otherwise it would become open-mouthed crying.

## 1. Morphology of a Full Fear Expression

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-13]

Morphological features of an extreme fear expression are as follows (see Figure 11-13):

1. Corrugator supercilii contracts, drawing the brows together and forming vertical frown lines;
2. Medial frontalis contracts, raising the inner brows and forming inverted-U wrinkles on the forehead;
3. Levator palpebrae superioris contracts in an attempt to raise the upper eyelids, yet opposing action by orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii creates diagonal skin folds on the upper eyelids. Without opposition the upper iris margin would be fully exposed (dashed line in figure);
4. Levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi contract together, raising the upper lip and exposing the upper teeth;
5. Platysma contracts, pulling the mouth corners sideways so the mouth's horizontal width exceeds normal;
6. Depressor labii inferioris contracts, pulling the lower lip downward and exposing part of the lower teeth.

## 5. Unconvinced

- ① Eyebrows raised, shape natural, yet eyelids relaxed with no trace of orbicularis oculi or levator palpebrae superioris action, indicating not surprise but confidence or elevated inner self-positioning;
- ② Gaze shifted lower left; visual blocking signals interruption of effective communication, downward direction indicates endurance;
- ③ Overall head posture shows chin raised (see “仰视反应” in the book *微反应 (micro-reaction)*), combining with the eyebrows to express higher self-positioning;
- ④ Slight mentalis contraction pushes the middle of the lower lip upward, causing the mouth corners to turn down, lips pressed together, and an uneven muscular bulge on the chin, indicating self-suppression.

**Summary:** Inner adherence to one's own viewpoint (eyebrows and head), unwillingness to accept information from the stimulus source (for example, another person's opinion), interruption of effective exchange, yet situational constraints prevent leaving or rebutting, so the response is self-suppressed (mouth shape) while continuing to listen (gaze lowered).

### 11.1.2 True Expression Baseline

Another category is the true expression baseline—the features of a person's face when genuinely surprised, disgusted, angry, fearful, sad, or pleased. For instance, eyelid-closure travel differs completely between people with small eyes and people with large eyes, and the facial configuration formed during a genuine smile likewise varies. Added differences in muscle type, dental malocclusion, prior injury, or cosmetic procedures mean each individual possesses a distinct true expression baseline. These genuine expressive movements nevertheless conform overall to the emotional-expression movement patterns described in this book. Because individual variation is great, this book does not discuss such expressions; simply observing a subject's naturally relaxed emotional-expression features yields the baseline data set.

True expression baselines are used to judge performed false expressions.

Once the subject's expression baseline has been established, the micro-expression morphological features summarized below can be used for concrete analysis of expression changes.

## 2. The English “No” Response



In certain English contexts the use of “No” differs entirely from its Chinese counterpart, generally appearing in negative or tag questions. For example:

Didn't you see him yesterday?

昨天你没见着他吗?

No, I didn't. / Yes, I did.

是的, 我没看见他 / 不是, 我见到他了

The reason is that the following answer of “yes” or “no” is relative to the speaker’s meaning: “Yes, you are right, I did not see him” or “No, you are not right, I did see him.” The clauses “I did not see him” or “I did see him” are relative to fact, producing the apparent inconsistency. Consequently, head-shaking in this context does not signify “No”!

## 7. Intensified Unconvinced

- ① Eyebrows have returned to normal height, no longer raised, and show slight knitting (frown lines);
- ② Upper eyelids droop lower, a deliberate action indicating visual blocking of the negative stimulus source;
- ③ Gaze shifted lower left, interrupting effective communication and merely enduring;
- ④ Fully raised upper lip and deep nasolabial folds reveal strong inner disgust;
- ⑤ Under strong mentalis contraction the lower lip is pushed upward and pressed against the upper lip, indicating denial yet self-suppression.

**Summary:** The expression likewise signals unconvinced feeling, yet far more intensely. No elevated inner self-positioning is present—only disgust. Mouth morphology collectively expresses inner disdain, while the self-suppressed shape and downward gaze during visual blocking convey endurance of the negative stimulus information. In simple terms: “Say what you like; I am listening, but I will not agree.”

## 4. “Oh! How Tragic!” (Tragedy Experienced Firsthand)

- ① Eyebrows pressed down and knit, indicating attention; inner third distorted upward (more obvious on left brow), signaling fear or sadness;
- ② Upper eyelids strive to rise yet meet the lowered brows, forming skin folds; combined with brow shape this registers fear;
- ③ Levator labii superioris contracts, raising the upper lip and forming shallow nasolabial folds beside the nasal alae, indicating disgust;
- ④ Platysma pulls the mouth corners sideways, depressor anguli oris pulls the corners downward, depressor labii inferioris pulls the lower lip downward, and mentalis contracts, pushing the middle of the lower lip upward and forming an uneven muscular bulge on the chin. This mouth shape is the typical morphology of open-mouthed crying and expresses intense sadness.

**Summary:** Eyebrow-and-eye morphology expresses fear; the lower face expresses sadness and mild disgust, indicating the subject is greatly afraid of the negative stimulus source; the tragic scene evokes empathetic pain that triggers sadness.

## Micro-expressions

Paul Ekman is a renowned expert on nonverbal behavior and has authored numerous works on facial expression. In his early writings Ekman focused primarily on the following questions:

- What factors trigger emotion
- How the face conveys emotional signals to others
- How we learn to distinguish people's various reactions
- Whether we can truly learn to control our own behavior

Since those works appeared, many research teams have entered the field; one of the most interesting developments has been the study of micro-expressions (a facial expression that lasts an extremely short time).

People who control others (for example, poker players, negotiators, or con artists) are often able to consciously mask their true emotions and intentions—at least on the surface they succeed (see “poker face”).

## ① Speed of Emotional Expression

The first point concerns the speed at which emotion appears. Although micro-expressions become visible on the face, they occur in less than 0.2 seconds. Cases lasting 1–2 seconds also exist. Even a duration of only a few seconds can usually be noticed immediately when displayed on the face, yet surprisingly these expressions are often difficult to detect.

The reason is that micro-expression movements are extremely slight—only momentary, minor facial changes. A micro-expression may not appear fully across the face but only in a small portion. Therefore the modes of micro-expression appearance are summarized as follows:

- Typical micro-expressions last less than 0.2 seconds, though durations of 1–2 seconds also occur.
- Sometimes a micro-expression appears across the entire face; at other times only a partial region is involved.

## 2. Common Morphology of Sadness Expressions

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-19 闭嘴哭泣的表情形态]

- Orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii contraction is reduced yet still depresses and knits the brows; medial frontalis contracts, slightly raising the inner brows so they twist upward and the overall brow shape flattens;
- Eyelids tense and tend toward closure;
- Levator labii superioris contracts, slightly raising the upper lip and forming nasolabial folds beside the nasal alae (shallower than in weeping);
- Platysma contracts, pulling the mouth corners sideways;
- Depressor anguli oris contracts, pulling the mouth corners downward;
- Mentalis contracts, pushing the middle of the lower lip upward and forming an uneven muscular bulge on the chin; the inter-labial line is horizontal and the lips are pressed together.

## 2. Displeased Disgust

Brow morphology and forceful eyelid closure express disgust; a seemingly vacant gaze expresses contempt; slight mouth suppression indicates inner pressure being borne; the closed-mouth form reinforces the disgust

emotion. No anger morphology appears, showing that inner disgust has not yet reached the threshold for attack.

1. Clear frowning action occurs together with distortion in the inner third of each brow; the inner brows rise. Combined with eyelid assessment this is not fear but a sadness feature.
2. Upper eyelids are pressed downward, almost covering the upper half of the iris. Because the movement is deliberate closure rather than natural droop, it is not vacant staring; combined with lowered brows the expression registers disgust.
3. Lips are slightly pursed outward with accompanying facial-muscle action, indicating self-suppression and refusal to express one's viewpoint.

#### **4. Tragedy Experienced Firsthand**

Eyebrow-and-eye morphology expresses fear; the lower face expresses sadness and mild disgust, indicating great fear of the negative stimulus source, empathetic pain, and triggered sadness.

1. Eyebrows pressed down and knit, indicating strong attention; inner third distorted upward, a fear or sadness feature.
2. Upper eyelids strive to rise yet meet the lowered brows, forming skin folds; combined with brow shape this registers fear.
3. Levator labii superioris contracts, raising the upper lip and forming shallow nasolabial folds beside the nasal alae, indicating mild disgust.
4. Mouth corners pulled sideways and downward, lower lip pulled downward, mentalis contracts pushing the middle of the lower lip upward and forming an uneven muscular bulge. This mouth shape is the typical morphology of open-mouthed crying and expresses intense sadness.

#### **6. Stubborn Disagreement**

Disagreement with information from the stimulus source while adhering to one's own ideas, yet without desire to change; only endurance and patience are adopted.

1. Eyebrows raised without accompanying upper-eyelid elevation, indicating elevated self-positioning.
2. Upper eyelids closed downward until nearly touching the lower lids; palpebral fissure very small, a reaction of not wanting to see the stimulus source.
3. Gaze shifted lower right, indicating prior expectation of the stimulus source; encountering negative stimulus registers endurance without agreement or change.
4. Upper lip somewhat raised, a disgust-type feature indicating denial.
5. Mouth corners markedly lowered; lower lip forcefully pushed upward and pressed against the upper lip, forming an uneven muscular bulge on the chin, indicating helplessness and self-suppression.

#### **8. Is It Truly Expressionless?**

In Figure 11-40 the left image is the one to judge; the right image, for comparison, shows a neutral, expressionless face—neither positive nor negative.

- ① In the left image a very slight frown line appears above the right eyebrow, proving the presence of frowning;
- ② The close-up (Figure 11-41) shows that the exposed iris area in the upper image is smaller than in the lower image (compare the position of the light-reflection highlight), indicating that more of the upper iris margin is

covered by the upper eyelid and that the upper eyelid tends to droop or close. Combined with the attention signaled by frowning, a vacant state can be ruled out; the expression therefore indicates visual blocking and proves a negative inner evaluation of the stimulus source.

**Summary:** Negative signals such as dislike, disagreement, non-acceptance, or doubt.

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### **Summary:**

Negative signals such as dislike, disagreement, non-acceptance, or doubt.

## 7. Strong Discontent

Strong discontent. Without a high inner self-positioning, it is merely aversion. The mouth shape jointly expresses inner disdain, but the self-suppressed morphological features and downward gaze express endurance of negative stimulus messages.

1. The eyebrows have returned to normal height and are no longer raised, but are slightly furrowed.
2. The upper eyelids droop lower, the result of a conscious action indicating blockage of the negative stimulus source.
3. The gaze shifts to the lower left, interrupting effective communication and indicating self-endurance.
4. The fully raised upper lip and deep nasolabial folds expose strong inner disgust.
5. Under strong muscle contraction, the lower lip is pushed upward and pressed tightly against the upper lip, indicating denial yet self-suppression.

## 1. Morphology of Crying

The fullest sadness response is crying.

- (1) Both eyebrows are pressed downward, with vertical wrinkles appearing between the brows. The brows lift slightly upward, flattening the overall brow shape and producing distortion.
- (2) The eyelids close forcefully, forming wrinkles on the inner sides of the eyes and crow's feet on the outer sides.
- (3) The upper lip lifts; the raised cheeks press against the lower eyelids, forming nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose.
- (4) The corners of the mouth stretch sideways; the stretched corners press against the cheeks, forming lines.
- (5) The corners of the mouth are pulled downward, attempting to expose the teeth.

(6) The middle of the lower lip is pushed upward, partially covering the teeth that would otherwise show, while the corners remain downward, exposing the lower teeth at the corners.

## 5. Discontent

The eyebrow and head morphology indicate inner insistence on one's own view, rejection of the stimulus source's message, yet inability to leave or refute, so the expression is only self-suppressed while continuing to listen.

1. Both eyebrows are raised, the brow shape natural, the eyelids relaxed—not surprise, but an expression of confident inner positioning.
2. The gaze shifts to the lower left, indicating interruption of effective communication; the downward gaze indicates endurance.
3. The chin is visibly raised, jointly expressing a high self-positioning with the eyebrows.
4. Facial muscles contract slightly, pushing the middle of the lower lip upward, causing the corners of the mouth to droop while the lips are pressed together and the chin muscles bulge, indicating suppression.

### 1. Full Disgust Expression Morphology

The morphological features of a full disgust expression are as follows:

- The corrugator supercilii contracts, furrowing both brows;
- The orbicularis oculi contracts strongly, tightly closing the eyes and simultaneously pressing both brows downward;
- The levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi contract, raising the upper lip and simultaneously pressing to form nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose;
- The mentalis contracts, forcefully pushing the lower lip upward so both lips close tightly; the chin simultaneously wrinkles upward, producing many folds on the surface skin; a deep groove forms between the lower lip and the raised muscles on the chin;
- The depressor anguli oris contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth downward, counterbalancing the action of the levator labii superioris and forming bracket-shaped lines on both sides of the mouth.

### 2. Contempt Expression Morphology

When the stimulus intensity weakens to medium, contempt arises. Contempt overall expresses a top-down rejection of the stimulus source. Although it is also rejection, the mindset is much lighter and does not require much mental energy to cope.

Morphological features:

- The corrugator supercilii contracts, furrowing both brows;
- The orbicularis oculi contracts strongly, pressing both brows downward;
- The levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi contract, raising the upper lip and simultaneously pressing to form nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose;
- The depressor anguli oris contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth downward, counterbalancing the action of the levator labii superioris and forming bracket-shaped lines on both sides of the mouth.

### 1. Happy Smile Expression Morphology

Psychological pleasure is converted into physiological pleasure.

- (1) The brow shape relaxes into a natural arch, the forehead smooth.
- (2) The eyes close tightly, the lower eyelids bulge and lift, with smile-specific grooves appearing below; wrinkles form on the inner corners of the eyes and crow's feet on the outer corners.
- (3) The corners of the mouth lift upward and sideways; the cheeks simultaneously bulge and rise to the highest position, becoming most rounded.
- (4) The upper lip lifts, exposing most of the teeth; the jaw opens, the lower lip lengthens and its surface becomes smooth, exposing a small amount of lower teeth.
- (5) The chin is displayed, the skin smooth; from the corners of the mouth to the chin, smile-specific grooves form.

## (1) Fear Expression Morphology

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-14]

- The corrugator supercilii and the medial frontalis contract together, destroying the normal arched brow shape (dashed line); the brows raise, the overall brow shape twisting upward at the inner third (arrow);
- The upper eyelids lift upward, exposing more of the upper iris margin;
- The levator labii superioris contracts slightly, raising the upper lip and slightly exposing the upper teeth;
- The platysma contracts slightly, pulling the corners of the mouth sideways, making the horizontal width of the mouth greater than in the normal relaxed state.

[ ] ! ②

Continuing from practice ①, add expressions such as "anger," "sadness," "fear," and "surprise," and attempt the following questions.

In the expressions below, identify the expressions for "anger," "sadness," "fear," and "surprise." From figures ①–④, find the corresponding expressions.

Compared with practice ①, this is somewhat more difficult, right? At first glance they all look similar, but careful observation reveals differences.

The correct answers are:

- ① = "Fear"
- ② = "Sadness"
- ③ = "Surprise"
- ④ = "Anger"

① [ ]

The "wavy wrinkles" formed in the central part of the forehead can be observed. Through the action of "both eyebrows raising upward," the entire forehead forms "horizontal wrinkles," and ③ shows this type of "horizontal wrinkles." It can be seen that the "horizontal wrinkles" of ③ extend to both ends of the forehead.

With the added action of "both eyebrows moving toward the center," the forehead wrinkles tangle and condense into "wavy wrinkles" in the center. At this moment, the wrinkles at both ends of the forehead

disappear, forming the expression of ❶. These “wavy wrinkles” are the characteristic feature of the “fear” expression.

#### (4) Fear Micro-expression Morphology

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-17]

- The eyebrows do not rise substantially; only the raising of the inner brows and the straight, distorted brow shape can be observed;
- The eyelids are overall natural, yet the upper eyelids remain slightly higher than normal, exposing a larger iris area.

**Summary:** This morphological feature is also a necessary characteristic of fear-type expressions. The subject only feels fear when encountering a stimulus source that is about to expose their true nature.

### 3. Disdain Expression Morphology

If the stimulus intensity is very weak, disdain arises. Disdain is complete contempt; apart from looking down, there is no need to expend effort to reject.

Only the final point remains in the morphological features: contraction of the levator labii superioris group, raising the upper lip, exposing part of the upper teeth, and forming nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose.

This is also a micro-expression morphological feature of disgust-type emotions.

**Summary:** The meaning of disgust emotions is negation. If a disgust-type expression appears, the conclusion can be drawn that the subject holds a negative attitude toward the stimulus source information.

## Chapter 7: Misunderstood Micro-expressions

Different micro-expressions can also create different misunderstandings in others, due to differences in context or local customs. For example, nodding does not necessarily mean YES, and shaking the head does not necessarily mean NO. This is common in English and also prevalent in India and Sri Lanka. Therefore, to avoid unnecessary misunderstandings caused by micro-expressions and to learn to correctly identify various micro-expressions, one must understand more about the meanings of micro-expressions. This chapter will take you to decode those frequently misunderstood micro-expressions and appreciate the rich charm of micro-expressions!

#### (2) Unease Expression Morphology

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-15]

- The eyebrows overall tend to flatten while still maintaining a distorted state; the inner brows raise, but to a slightly reduced degree;
- The corrugator supercilii produces slight vertical wrinkles;
- The degree to which the eyes are open increases, but not exaggeratedly; the upper eyelid lift is not as obvious as in fear or fright expressions, yet the exposed area of the upper iris margin is larger than in a normal relaxed face.

## 2. Common Sadness Expression Morphology

Common crying in daily life often involves a tightly closed mouth, reflecting self-suppression.

- (1) Both brows are slightly pressed downward and furrowed, the inner brows lifting slightly upward, the overall brow shape flattening.
- (2) The eyelids show a tendency to close.
- (3) The upper lip lifts slightly, forming shallower nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose than in crying.
- (4) The corners of the mouth stretch sideways.
- (5) The corners of the mouth are pulled downward.
- (6) The middle of the lower lip is pushed upward, forming a muscle bulge on the chin; the lip line is horizontal, both lips pressed tightly together.

## 1. Full Anger Expression Morphology

1. Both brows press downward, the inner brows tightly furrowed.
2. The upper eyelids are raised to the maximum, attempting to expose the entire upper iris margin, yet they press against the downward-pressed brows, expressing anger and forming diagonal skin folds on the upper eyelid skin.
3. The lower eyelids tighten, matching the upper eyelids, for a glare.
4. The nose wings lift while the cheeks bulge, forming deep grooves on both sides of the nose wings.
5. The jaw opens downward, exposing part of the lower teeth, and stretches sideways, becoming thinner and adhering to the jawbone.

## 2. Common Anger Expression Morphology

In modern social interactions, ordinary people, even when angry, will not roar at will; the face appears as follows.

1. Both brows are tightly furrowed and pressed downward.
2. The levator palpebrae superioris contracts.
3. The lower eyelids tighten and pull slightly sideways.
4. Both lips are pressed tightly together.
5. Both corners of the mouth curve downward.
6. Muscle bulges form on the chin, the surface uneven, while simultaneously pushing both lips upward to keep them tightly closed.

## 2. Common Smile Morphology

Full smile expression morphology. Smiles in daily life more often appear as full smiles.

- (1) The upper eyelids remain still; the lower eyelids lift slightly and bulge. Smile grooves then form below the eyes.
- (2) The cheeks lift fully, the surface skin smooth.
- (3) The corners of the mouth still open widely; the upper lip lifts and exposes the upper teeth; the lower lip expands less, with no lower teeth visible; the chin is smooth without muscle bulges and spreads out.

### Section 1: Is Shaking the Head Really “No”?

Coming means “Come,” going means “Go,” nodding means “Yes,” shaking the head means “No”—these are daily behavioral habits known even to three-year-old children in China. This is also a convention among



people on Earth, yet in some countries it is exactly the opposite, such as beautiful India and Sri Lanka. In certain English contexts, the same phenomenon can be found: nodding does not necessarily mean "Yes," and shaking the head does not necessarily mean "No"!

## 1. Full Fear Expression Morphology

1. Both brows furrow toward the center, forming vertical brow wrinkles.
2. Both inner brows lift upward, forming inverted-U wrinkles on the forehead.
3. Attempting to raise the upper eyelids, yet due to opposing motion inhibition, diagonal folds form on the skin.
4. The upper lip lifts, exposing the upper teeth.
5. The corners of the mouth pull sideways, making the horizontal width of the mouth greater than normal.
6. The lower lip pulls downward, exposing part of the lower teeth.

## Chapter 11: Genuine and False Expressions

Facial expressions change rapidly and interweave genuine and false. To successfully decipher expression codes, one must keenly capture all subtle facial changes, disassemble and analyze the deeper meaning behind each change one by one, thereby eliminating the false and retaining the true, and grasping the inner truth of others.

After the arduous reading above, we have concluded the discussion of all micro-expressions. In this chapter we will do two things together: summarize micro-expression morphology and identify complex expressions.

### Mouth Baseline

The mouth baseline mainly refers to the shape and position of the lips, with the lip line shape serving as an indirect indicator. Attention should also be paid to whether the subject has any congenital mouth deformity features in a relaxed state, such as the mandible protruding beyond the maxilla or other abnormal muscle shapes. Because mouth morphology has lower validity for judging micro-expression abnormal reactions and is greatly interfered with by language and breathing, **separate analysis of mouth morphology changes is not recommended.**

## 4. How to Judge Genuine and False Smiles

How to judge whether the other person's smile is genuine or feigned? Genuine smiles mainly have the following features:

- (1) During a genuine smile, the eyes narrow, the lower eyelids tighten, and they lift and bulge.
- (2) Smile grooves appear below the eyes; crow's feet often form on the outer corners of the eyes from the mutual pressing of the upper and lower eyelids.
- (3) The corners of the mouth stretch toward the ears and lift; the cheeks bulge and rise.

## (3) Worry Expression Morphology

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-16]

- The raising and distortion of the inner brows indicate inner pressure, but not disgust or anger;

- The lips are pressed tightly together, the vermilion hidden; the orbicularis oris contracts, making the lips taut; the corners of the mouth also bulge due to contraction of the depressor anguli oris.

## 2. Contempt Expression Morphology

When the stimulus intensity weakens, contempt arises. The contempt expression can be analyzed for the following morphological features:

1. Slight brow wrinkles appear on the eyebrows.
2. The eyelids close slightly, simultaneously causing both brows to press downward slightly.
3. Contraction is dominated by the levator labii superioris, raising upward; the nose wings are indirectly raised and stretched sideways. The lips may remain closed or may part slightly.

## 1. Full Disgust Expression Morphology

The full disgust expression morphology is as follows:

1. Both brows are tightly furrowed.
2. Both eyes are tightly closed, while both brows press downward.
3. The upper lip lifts, while nasolabial folds form on both sides of the nose wings.
4. The lower lip is strongly piled upward, tightly closing both lips; the chin simultaneously wrinkles upward, with surface skin folds.
5. The corners of the mouth pull downward, counterbalancing the action of the levator labii superioris.

## 8. True Blank Expression

The figure on the right appears blank, yet upon careful observation, very slight expression leakage can still be seen.

1. Above the inner brow on the right, there is a very slight furrow.
2. The exposed iris area is small, indicating a tendency for the upper eyelids to droop or close; combined with the brow furrowing, this indicates visual blockage, showing an inner negative assessment of the stimulus source.

## Micro-expressions During Blind Dates

9. During a blind date, the other person's gaze always avoids the other party: such people internally pursue romantic love, act with more confidence, and possess greater mental acuity.
10. During a blind date, the other person's gaze is unfocused, looking around, absent-minded, slow to respond, or only playing with their phone: this indicates the other person is not very interested in the date internally and has other concerns on their mind.

## 2. Fear Expression Morphology

Distorted eyebrows and alert eyes are typical features of fear.

- (1) The eyebrows raise, the overall brow shape twisting upward on the inner side.
- (2) The upper eyelids lift upward, exposing more of the upper iris margin.

- (3) The upper lip lifts, slightly exposing the upper teeth.
- (4) The corners of the mouth pull sideways, making the mouth's horizontal relaxed state larger.

### 3. Unease Expression Morphology

When fear emotion weakens further, lower than fright, it becomes unease.

- (1) The eyebrows overall tend to flatten, still maintaining distortion; the inner brows raise slightly, producing slight vertical wrinkles.
- (2) The degree to which the eyes are open increases, but not exaggeratedly; the upper eyelid lift is not obvious, and the exposed area of the upper iris margin is larger than in a normal relaxed face.

## Section 1: Complex Expression Identification

So-called complex micro-expressions are those in which two or more emotions are simultaneously revealed on the micro-expression. The most common are various types of smiles. Because human smiles can express emotions with subtle differences, they can incorporate all negative emotions such as surprise, disgust, anger, fear, and sadness, thereby creating expressions with multiple layers of meaning.

### Eyebrow Baseline

The eyebrow baseline mainly observes the calm shape and position of the eyebrows.

Different people may have completely opposite baseline features in a relaxed state; some naturally have 冂-shaped brows, others naturally have sword-shaped brows. Once such baseline values are determined, one will not mistake the subject's actions of raising or furrowing the brows.

## 5. Fear Micro-expression Features

If the worry expression further disappears and only the brow and eye morphology remains, it is the minimal expression of fear.

The eyebrows do not rise substantially; only the raising of the inner brows and the straight, distorted brow shape can be observed; the eyelids are overall natural, yet the upper eyelids remain slightly higher than normal. The exposed iris area is larger.

### 1. Full Surprise Expression Morphology

The features of a full surprise expression are as follows:

1. Both brows rise substantially.
2. The upper eyelids lift, the eyes widen, exposing the white of the eye above the upper iris margin.
3. The corners of the mouth open unconsciously, coordinating with an inhalation; the lower lip opens slightly downward naturally, the lip surface skin not stretching sideways.

### Eye and Mouth Changes Most Easily Reveal Emotion

In the next chapter, examples will be given of how micro-expressions aid communication, with explanations in various scenarios. Before that, let us first discuss matters that must be noted when interpreting micro-expressions.

The notes are the following three points: "speed," "types of facial movements," and "gaze."

## ④ 「」

"Vertical wrinkles" and "diagonal wrinkles" form between the brows. Through the action of "both eyebrows moving toward the center," "vertical wrinkles" and "diagonal wrinkles" are formed between the brows. These "vertical wrinkles" and "diagonal wrinkles" are the characteristic features of the "anger" expression.

### Chapter 4: Surprise Micro-expressions

- 4.1 Generation of Surprise Emotion
- 4.2 The Most Surprised Expression
  - 4.2.1 Physiological Meaning of Surprise Expression
  - 4.2.2 Great Surprise in Life
- 4.3 Morphological Features of Surprise Micro-expressions

## ② "Sadness"

In the central part of the forehead, "mountain-shaped wrinkles" form. The actions of "the inner sides of the eyebrows raised upward" + "the two eyebrows moving closer to the center" create the "mountain-shaped wrinkles" in the central forehead. This "mountain-shaped wrinkles" is a characteristic of the "sadness" expression.

### 3. Micro-expression Features of Smiles

- (1) The lower eyelids bulge, straighten, lift slightly and approach horizontal, attempting to close the eyes from below.
- (2) The mouth is already closed, with the lip line curving upward on both sides.
- (3) The face remains raised and full, with obvious features.

## ③ "Surprise"

"Horizontal wrinkles" can be clearly seen extending across the forehead to both ends. The action of "the two eyebrows raised upward" forms "horizontal wrinkles" on the forehead. This "horizontal wrinkles" is a characteristic of the "surprise" expression.

### 4. Forms of Worried Expressions

Worry is a fear-type expression of lower intensity than anxiety.

- (1) Eyebrows raised and eyebrow shape distorted, not disgust or anger, indicating mental stress.
- (2) Lips tightly closed, hiding the red part of the lips, corners of the mouth contract producing bulges.

### 3. Micro-expression Features of Anger

Under extreme restraint, the micro-expression of anger only leaves changes in the eyelids.

1. Upper eyelids contract, attempting to lift, meeting the furrowed brows pressing down.
2. Lower eyelids tense, pressing closer to the skull.

### 3. Micro-expression Features of Disgust — Contempt

If the stimulus intensity is weak, it produces contempt emotion; contempt is complete disregard. The feature of disgust-type micro-expressions is the upper lip lifted, exposing part of the upper teeth, forming nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose wings.

#### 11.1 Expression Baseline

To judge a person's micro-expression reactions, besides preparing the stimulus source, the necessary preparatory work is to determine the subject's expression baseline.

The actor's expression baseline is divided into two categories.

### 3. Micro-expression Features of Sadness

The smallest micro-expressions look very calm; the more easily distinguishable are changes in the eyebrows.

The overall eyebrow shape is furrowed and pressed down, but the eyebrow heads are raised; this eyebrow shape is a necessary feature of sadness.

### 3. Micro-expression Features of Surprise

The smallest surprise expression only retains the lifting of the upper eyelids; the eyebrows may show no obvious lifting change. This is due to insufficient stimulus intensity or subjective control suppression.

## 2. Common Forms of Fear Expressions

In daily life, we can easily recognize expressions originating from fear-type emotions. Raised and distorted eyebrows, along with alert eyes, are typical features of fear.

## 2. Disgust

When the party believes the stimulus source they face is negative, it produces a sense of annoyance, but the party has no desire to change the stimulus source; this emotion is disgust.

## 2. Common Forms of Surprise Expressions

Eyebrows raised, upper eyelids lifted, exposing more of the upper edge of the iris than usual. Generally seen after reduced stimulus intensity, more common in surprise expressions in daily life.

## 3. Anger

When the intensity of negative stimulus escalates beyond disgust emotion, it triggers anger. The feature of anger is an aggressive tendency, attempting to eliminate the negative stimulus source.

## Chapter 9: See Through People's Hearts in One Minute

Summary of features of micro-expressions for all positive and negative emotions such as surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, joy, and summaries of other complex expressions!

## 11.3 Complex Expression Recognition

Having just learned the features of smiles, let's strike while the iron is hot and start with smiles to identify the most complex social expression of humans — smiles.

### 4. Fear

If the intensity of negative stimulus increases, overwhelming the party's psychological endurance, anger turns into fear.

#### 11.2.5 Sadness

The adverse consequence occurs, fear disappears, replaced by helpless resignation, and the emotion transforms into sadness.

### 5. Sadness

After fear comes helpless resignation, and the emotion also transforms into sadness.

### 1. Surprise

When a stimulus occurs, a person will display a surprise expression.

### Micro-expressions and Emotional Expression

The emotions expressed.

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Disgust (s-disgust).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Surprise (s-surprise).

See Disgust (s-disgust).

See Disgust (s-disgust).

See Disgust (s-disgust).

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See Disgust (s-disgust).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

## **Fearful Expressions**

### **The Psychological Defenses of a Braggart**

The subject was a staff member at a public institution who, dissatisfied with a mundane and constrained daily life, invented a so-called folk science on a socially sensitive hot-button topic. Because the theme was sensitive, several mainstream media outlets embraced it enthusiastically. Television stations from central to local levels invited him to record programs; newspapers and magazines interviewed him repeatedly; for a time even overseas media took notice. The individual proudly publicized these “achievements” on his blog. Although mainstream outlets generally criticized the folk science he promoted, their coverage only amplified his visibility—an unintended outcome.

Previously, on a program aired by a top-tier national television channel, he had stumped a well-known psychologist. In his own words, “the expert was incompetent, which made me contemptuous.” Buoyed by that experience, he arrived to challenge another program that featured a different prominent expert. Commissioned by the production team, we conducted a psychological assessment of the man.

After examining the personal history he had published, we found numerous internal contradictions; virtually the entire promotional narrative appeared fabricated. Such an extreme case was rare in our prior experience. We therefore devised an enthusiastic testing plan: begin with minor details, use pointed questioning to dismantle his façade, first psychologically overwhelm his confidence and defenses, after which the core questions would become straightforward. Once lies are exposed several times in succession, most people can no longer perform or maintain the pretense smoothly.

Knowing he claimed to have been a soldier, received special training, and piloted aircraft, I chose the highly questionable claim of “having flown a plane” as the first point of attack.

**Question:** Have you ever piloted an aircraft?

**Answer:** (He froze for a moment, then produced an awkward smile.) I can. I have flown, but I don’t fly every day.

[Analysis: The momentary freeze was a startle response; the slight surprised expression on his face likewise showed he had not expected the very first question to target this minor detail from his promotional narrative. The awkward smile already foreshadowed the direction of the test, because embarrassment is a derivative of fear, as noted earlier.]

**Question:** Have you ever taken off?

**Answer:** Never taken off. I’ve only taxied on the runway.

[Analysis: The reply pattern—retreat one step, then advance half a step—is the mark of someone unwilling to concede. Yet the overall backward movement clearly indicated psychological disadvantage. Choosing the “never taken off” answer may have stemmed from his genuine inability to fabricate the sensory and technical details that would follow a takeoff.]

**Question:** What type of aircraft?

**Answer:** (Slight hesitation) Fighter jet.

**Question:** Which specific model?

**Answer:** J-6. (His nervous system was highly tense; he adopted a combat posture, head tilted forward, eyes alert.)

[Analysis: Once the first “type of aircraft” question was asked, he understood what we were probing. The slight hesitation was spent fabricating the specific model. The combat posture and alert state fully demonstrated that he perceived the threat posed by the question.]



**Question:** As far as I know, you never served in the air force. Would the military allow someone without flight experience to pilot an aircraft?

**Answer:** Yes. It was a friend of mine, deputy commander of their flight regiment. (He maintained the combat posture, yet his gaze shifted slightly downward.)

[Analysis: The slight downward shift in gaze indicated mounting internal pressure. Continued maintenance of the combat posture showed he had not yet abandoned the attempt to lie.]

**Question:** When the aircraft taxied on the runway, how did you control acceleration and deceleration?

**Answer:** Just like a car—don't keep pressing the throttle all the way down and it will taxi without taking off. Step on the brakes and the plane slows down. (Gaze began to drift; eyebrows and eyes showed slight fear characteristics.)

[Analysis: Aircraft acceleration is achieved by advancing the throttle lever; ground deceleration normally involves main-wheel brakes, speed brakes, and reduced engine thrust. The answer revealed that the subject had never entered a cockpit to start and taxi an aircraft. Realizing he could no longer fabricate details, he also sensed the threat inherent in the meticulous detail-oriented questioning—exposure of his self-aggrandizement.]

**Question:** Does the J-6 have a throttle and brakes?

**Answer:** No throttle; you press buttons. I only controlled the stick; another pilot set all the procedures. (After finishing, his face displayed the worried expression of tightly closed lips; he avoided eye contact and his gaze dropped completely downward.)

[Analysis: Unable to fabricate a plausible answer, he began shifting the fabrication. At this point he was grasping at straws; the newly invented information was even less credible.]

**Question:** Did that pilot allow you to operate the aircraft yourself?

**Answer:** No. I sat in front, he sat behind; I operated the stick in front.

**Question:** How many seats does the J-6 have?

**Answer:** ... (Speechless, a guilty expression appeared.)

[Analysis: The J-6 cockpit has only one pilot seat. Unaware of this objective fact, the subject realized he could no longer maintain the pretense, abandoned resistance, and displayed a guilty expression. Guilt is a derivative of self-reproachful sadness and equates to an admission. Chapter 8 will explain this in detail.]

At this point, detail-oriented questioning had successfully dismantled a lie that was, for him, inconsequential. Throughout the process his emotions shifted from surprise to mild anger, then to mild worry; once he recognized he could no longer fabricate consistent details, his expression settled into the classic worried look of tightly closed lips. This classic micro-expression (微反应) revealed the fear inside him, indicating the questions had pushed him to a critical threshold and his psychological defenses would soon collapse.

After several similar questions, the subject's defensive and resistant mindset vanished; he understood that lying was no longer easy. Consequently, when later questioned about fabricated supporting data for the folk science he had invented, the interrogation required far less effort.

## Test Case

## How to Break Down a Braggart's Psychological Defenses

The subject was a staff member at a public institution who, dissatisfied with a mundane and constrained daily life, invented a so-called folk science on a socially sensitive hot-button topic. Because the theme was sensitive, several mainstream media outlets embraced it enthusiastically. Television stations from central to local levels invited him to record programs; newspapers and magazines interviewed him repeatedly; for a time even overseas media took notice. The individual proudly publicized these “achievements” on his blog. Although mainstream outlets generally criticized the folk science he promoted, their coverage only amplified his visibility—an unintended outcome.

Previously, on a program aired by a top-tier national television channel, he had stumped a well-known psychologist. In his own words, “the expert was incompetent, which made me contemptuous.” Buoyed by that experience, he arrived to challenge another program that featured a different prominent expert. Commissioned by the production team, we conducted a psychological assessment of the man.

After examining the personal history he had published, we found numerous internal contradictions; virtually the entire promotional narrative appeared fabricated. Such an extreme case was rare in our prior experience. We therefore devised an enthusiastic testing plan: begin with minor details, use pointed questioning to dismantle his façade, first psychologically overwhelm his confidence and defenses, after which the core questions would become straightforward. Once lies are exposed several times in succession, most people can no longer perform or maintain the pretense smoothly.

Knowing he claimed to have been a soldier, received special training, and piloted aircraft, I chose the highly questionable claim of “having flown a plane” as the first point of attack.

**Question:** Have you ever piloted an aircraft?

**Answer:** (He froze for a moment, then produced an awkward smile.) I can. I have flown, but I don’t fly every day.

[Analysis: The momentary freeze was a startle response; the slight surprised expression on his face likewise showed he had not expected the very first question to target this minor detail from his promotional narrative. The awkward smile already foreshadowed the direction of the test, because embarrassment is a derivative of fear, as noted earlier.]

**Question:** Have you ever taken off?

**Answer:** Never taken off. I’ve only taxied on the runway.

[Analysis: The reply pattern—retreat one step, then advance half a step—is the mark of someone unwilling to concede. Yet the overall backward movement clearly indicated psychological disadvantage. Choosing the “never taken off” answer may have stemmed from his genuine inability to fabricate the sensory and technical details that would follow a takeoff.]

**Question:** What type of aircraft?

**Answer:** (Slight hesitation) Fighter jet.

**Question:** Which specific model?

**Answer:** J-6. (His nervous system was highly tense; he adopted a combat posture, head tilted forward, eyes alert.)

[Analysis: Once the first “type of aircraft” question was asked, he understood what we were probing. The slight hesitation was spent fabricating the specific model. The combat posture and alert state fully demonstrated that he perceived the threat posed by the question.]

**Question:** As far as I know, you never served in the air force. Would the military allow someone without flight experience to pilot an aircraft?

**Answer:** Yes. It was a friend of mine, deputy commander of their flight regiment. (He maintained the combat posture, yet his gaze shifted slightly downward.)

[Analysis: The slight downward shift in gaze indicated mounting internal pressure. Continued maintenance of the combat posture showed he had not yet abandoned the attempt to lie.]

**Question:** When the aircraft taxied on the runway, how did you control acceleration and deceleration?

**Answer:** Just like a car—don't keep pressing the throttle all the way down and it will taxi without taking off. Step on the brakes and the plane slows down. (Gaze began to drift; eyebrows and eyes showed slight fear characteristics.)

[Analysis: Aircraft acceleration is achieved by advancing the throttle lever; ground deceleration normally involves main-wheel brakes, speed brakes, and reduced engine thrust. The answer revealed that the subject had never entered a cockpit to start and taxi an aircraft. Realizing he could no longer fabricate details, he also sensed the threat inherent in the meticulous detail-oriented questioning—exposure of his self-aggrandizement.]

**Question:** Does the J-6 have a throttle and brakes?

**Answer:** No throttle; you press buttons. I only controlled the stick; another pilot set all the procedures. (After finishing, his face displayed the worried expression of tightly closed lips; he avoided eye contact and his gaze dropped completely downward.)

[Analysis: Unable to fabricate a plausible answer, he began shifting the fabrication. At this point he was grasping at straws; the newly invented information was even less credible.]

**Question:** Did that pilot allow you to operate the aircraft yourself?

**Answer:** No. I sat in front, he sat behind; I operated the stick in front.

**Question:** How many seats does the J-6 have?

**Answer:** ... (Speechless, a guilty expression appeared.)

[Analysis: The J-6 cockpit has only one pilot seat. Unaware of this objective fact, the subject realized he could no longer maintain the pretense, abandoned resistance, and displayed a guilty expression. Guilt is a derivative of self-reproachful sadness and equates to an admission. Chapter 8 will explain this in detail.]

At this point, detail-oriented questioning had successfully dismantled a lie that was, for him, inconsequential. Throughout the process his emotions shifted from surprise to mild anger, then to mild worry; once he recognized he could no longer fabricate consistent details, his expression settled into the classic worried look of tightly closed lips. This classic micro-expression (微反应) revealed the fear inside him, indicating the questions had pushed him to a critical threshold and his psychological defenses would soon collapse.

After several similar questions, the subject's defensive and resistant mindset vanished; he understood that lying was no longer easy. Consequently, when later questioned about fabricated supporting data for the folk science he had invented, the interrogation required far less effort.

## 7.2 Full Fear Expressions

Only when facing a life-or-death crisis does a person rarely display a full fear expression, which comprises three basic typical features: eyebrows drawn together and raised, eyes widened, and mouth open, as shown in Figure 7-1.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-1]*

Viewing this full fear expression inevitably recalls the full anger expression discussed in the previous chapter; the two are highly similar—furrowed brows, widened eyes, open mouth. If summarized in words alone, the features appear identical. Therefore we compare them visually in Figure 7-2.

Full fear image

Full anger image

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-2]*

We trust that any normal observer can instantly distinguish the two expressions. The challenge lies in articulating the precise differences; doing so requires comparatively professional observational skill. Figure 7-3 provides the analysis.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-3]*

① At first glance both images show lowered and tightly furrowed brows. Closer inspection reveals that in the fear image the brows are raised, whereas in the anger image they are drawn inward and downward. This is the difference between the so-called “8:20” brow shape and the “10:10” brow shape. Because fear raises the brows, an inverted “U”-shaped fine wrinkle forms in the middle of the forehead, as shown in Figure 7-4; such lines are deeper and more pronounced on Western faces.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-4]*

② Both expressions raise the upper eyelids to the maximum. When confronted with a threatening negative stimulus, whether the impulse is to fight (anger) or to flee (fear), the goal is to see the stimulus as clearly as possible. Yet the differing direction of brow muscle effort produces different angles of skin folds on the upper eyelids. Sometimes, especially on younger faces, the brow raise is not obvious and the brows appear merely horizontal; the upper-eyelid skin fold can then serve as an auxiliary indicator of brow elevation, as shown in Figure 7-5.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-5]*

③ Although both expressions open the mouth—sometimes even shouting—the width and height of the opening differ subtly. The mouth shape of fear cannot produce a sharp, threatening sound. The differing mouth shapes also produce completely different nasolabial folds, as shown in Figure 7-6.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-6]*

Thus, although the overall appearances are similar, the fine differences cause the two expressions to convey entirely distinct meanings. This is one method we use to study micro-expressions. By dissecting a facial expression, identifying its typical and necessary morphological features, one can move beyond ordinary experiential recognition and directly access the person’s true inner state.

We now dissect the full fear expression in detail, examining its muscle movements and morphological features, as shown in Figure 7-7.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-7]

- ① Corrugator supercilii contracts, drawing the brows together and forming vertical wrinkles;
- ② The medial fibers of the frontalis contract, raising the inner brows and creating an inverted-U wrinkle on the forehead;
- ③ Levator palpebrae superioris contracts in an attempt to raise the upper eyelid, but because the opposing actions of the orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii are inhibited, a diagonal fold forms on the upper-eyelid skin. Without inhibition, the superior margin of the iris would be fully exposed (dashed line in Figure 7-7);
- ④ Levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi contract together, raising the upper lip and exposing the upper teeth;
- ⑤ Platysma contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth laterally so that the horizontal width of the mouth exceeds its resting state;
- ⑥ Depressor labii inferioris contracts, pulling the lower lip downward and exposing part of the lower teeth.

After studying the sadness expression in the next chapter, you will see that **the fear expression is a combination of surprise and sadness—essentially sadness that has been prepaid after surprise**. Fear arises when a stimulus exerts overwhelming intimidation; the person feels unable to resist (resistance would be anger) and believes a tragic outcome is imminent (though it has not yet occurred), so the only response is attempted flight or even surrender. Once the tragic outcome materializes, sadness follows. We therefore compare the fear expression with the surprise expression discussed earlier, given their natural connection, as shown in Figure 7-8.

Fear expression

Surprise expression

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-8]

Observing the two images, the clear distinctions between the expressions are as follows:

### 7.3.1 Different Degrees of Fear Emotions

Fear encompasses several derivative emotions of varying intensity. In ascending order of emotional fullness, they can be listed as four distinct states: **worry**, **anxiety**, **fear**, and **terror**. To clarify the distinctions among these four states, consider a threat event that harms one's own interests as the stimulus source. The four states are differentiated as follows:

The **stimulus source** is a radio broadcast: reports indicate that a prison break has occurred, and a suspect in an intentional homicide has escaped custody. The individual may have entered the XX area. Local residents are advised to secure doors and windows at night and to remain vigilant when going out during the day.

- **Worry:** As a local resident, one feels worry internally. The psychological essence of worry is that the individual subjectively anticipates a low likelihood of an undesirable outcome (personal harm), yet the possibility still exists, preventing complete inner calm.
- **Anxiety:** As a local resident and the primary informant, the suspect knows the individual reported him. The informant's inner state escalates to anxiety. The psychological essence of anxiety is that the individual subjectively anticipates an increased likelihood of an undesirable outcome. Although the outcome is recognized as probable, it remains uncertain (and undesired), leaving both facts and the mind in a borderline state.

- **Fear:** The suspect breaks in and explicitly states an intent to retaliate. The disadvantaged mindset before confronting an enemy is fear. The psychological essence of fear is that the individual subjectively anticipates a high likelihood of an undesirable outcome (injury or death) and wishes to escape or avoid it.
- **Terror:** After combat fails and a knife is held to the throat, with life or death depending on the knife-holder's whim and uncertainty about whether the blow will fall, the inner sensation is terror. The psychological essence of terror is the belief that no means exist to avert the impending negative outcome, approaching a state of grief before the outcome occurs. If harm is confirmed at this point, the emotion shifts toward grief.

Building on these four levels of fear emotions, several complex sensations commonly encountered in daily life (not classified as emotions) also arise:

- **Concern:** Derived from worry, the added character implies repeated consideration of how to avert the "worried-about" matter.
- **Dilemma:** Also derived from worry. Unlike concern, a dilemma involves multiple matters, each with advantages and disadvantages; the difficulty stems from the challenge of choosing between them.
- **Embarrassment:** Derived from anxiety and more intense than anxiety, embarrassment typically arises when one has done something wrong that may lead to an undesirable outcome. One attempts to reverse the negative trajectory but lacks an effective means of recovery. For example, accidentally mentioning a former girlfriend one liked in front of a sensitive current girlfriend produces embarrassment afterward.

Because these sensations require a specific context and coherent action sequence to be fully expressed—unlike the relatively simple facial expressions triggered by emotions—they are classified in this book merely as derivative states of fear emotions. Their specific external manifestations are not examined in detail.

After the previous section covered the full fear expression, the three derivative expressions of fear are introduced in descending order of intensity.

#### 7.3.4 The Expression of Worry

When fear arises internally but remains mild and is deliberately suppressed, the classic facial features of fear disappear almost entirely. Slightly pursed lips combined with the typical fearful brow shape can reveal the emotion of worry. The pursed lips represent restraint, while the furrowed brow indicates inner pressure and focus. At this stage, the eyes do not need to widen in alertness, because no direct stimulus source is present and visual information does not need to be captured.

During the annual Spring Festival travel rush, people anxiously waiting in line at train-station ticket windows frequently display bitten or tightly pressed lips, as shown in Figure 7-14.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-14]*

In this face, eyelid expansion is further reduced and has largely returned to normal from the fearful state, yet a slight upward lift remains with no closing tendency. The most noticeable expression features appear at two points:

- ① The raised and twisted brow shape indicates pressure without indicating disgust or anger; the brow shapes of disgust and anger do not twist.

- ② The lips are tightly closed, the vermilion is hidden, and the orbicularis oris contracts to tense the lips. Contraction of the depressor anguli oris also produces a bulge at the corners of the mouth, confirming the presence of pressure.

Capturing this combination of brow morphology and lip tension during observation allows analysis of the subject's neural state of "bearing pressure."

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-15 没有嘴部形态的担忧表情]*

If the tense lip morphology disappears, the state of worry has lightened further, as shown in Figure 7-15. In this face, only the brows and eyes reveal worry. The brows show no large elevation; only the inner brow raise and the straight, twisted brow shape are observable. The eyelids appear natural overall, yet the upper eyelids remain slightly higher than normal, exposing a larger area of the iris. If the brow elevation and twisting intensify and the upper eyelids rise further, the expression may escalate to anxiety or even fear.

This expression is easily mistaken for sadness because the brow morphology closely resembles that of sadness. However, the eyes in sadness lack the expectant force seen here and usually appear dull. The micro-expression features of sadness are discussed in the next chapter.

At an airport, I once observed a girl standing on tiptoe, silently waving at a departure point with exactly this expression. She must have felt concern for the person about to travel far, and her heart surely also held the sadness of parting. Fear and sadness share an essential similarity in their emotional nature.

### 7.1 The Generation of Fear Emotions

Fear is humanity's most ancient emotion. In prehistoric times, humans lacked advantages in physical combat and occupied a lower position in the food chain. Encounters with predatory beasts therefore produced fear far more often than anger.

Fear is the emotion generated by the possibility of harm. Because the harm is only "possible," it has not yet occurred; yet the stimulus source is so powerful that it exceeds the individual's psychological tolerance, creating a sense of inability to eliminate the impending harm.

The manifestations dominated by fear are highly varied. Intense fear can trigger physiological changes such as altered heart rate, piloerection, and surface sweating. When the stimulus source is assessed as unbeatable, flight is the common response. When the stimulus source is assessed as overwhelming (so that even flight cannot eliminate the danger), the individual may fall into uncontrollable panic and freeze in place—the so-called "scared stiff" or "scared limp" reaction. In the most extreme cases, people may lose all energy, become extremely weak, or even die of fright.

In contemporary society, however, ordinary people rarely exhibit the pure fear described above. Only when facing direct weapon attacks or life-threatening situations such as shipwrecks or fires do most people display a fully saturated fear response. At other times, pure fear is seldom observed. Most fear arises from negative events that may cause loss.

Many situations can produce fear. Lower-level stimuli that cause physical harm, such as the pain of an injection, can elicit a fearful expression even on the face of a strong man. When a thief is exposed and draws a fruit knife to threaten others, only to see three or four plainclothes officers nearby, the face typically shows the classic transition from anger to fear.

In “higher-level” contexts far removed from life-and-death stakes—such as entering an unfamiliar environment, being criticized by a boss, facing creative failure, or risking stock-market losses—most fear-related expressions are consciously controlled and suppressed, revealing only partial features.

What interests us most is capturing facial micro-expressions that reveal leaked fear or anxiety. We learn the typical features from the fullest expressions, then identify the shared characteristics between the mildest worry and the most intense terror, thereby obtaining the micro-expression morphology of fear.

Mastering the micro-expressions of fear emotions allows one to determine whether others are “afraid.”

### **Chapter Summary (9787554606841)**

The emotions of surprise, disgust, anger, and fear discussed in previous chapters share a common characteristic: they are all based on the emotion-holder’s subjective appraisal rather than on an established outcome. Sadness differs fundamentally from these four emotions because it is based on an established outcome—loss of interests—even if that outcome is only a misappraisal by the emotion-holder.

The stimulus source for sadness is “an irretrievable loss.” The emotion-holder appraises the situation and concludes that the loss has already occurred (including intangible losses such as reputation, status, social evaluation, or public perception), thereby triggering sadness. Sadness has a second characteristic: it is separated from fear by only a thin line. The two emotions are essentially identical; both involve a highly negative appraisal of the stimulus source, with the source’s force judged to far exceed one’s defensive capacity, producing either fear or sadness. The sole difference lies in whether the negative outcome has already occurred. Before occurrence it is fear; once the outcome is sealed it is sadness.

Consequently, their facial morphologies are also nearly identical. Both display the “-shaped brow formed by furrowed and raised eyebrows. In fear, however, the eyes remain open to gather information and make judgments, so the eyelids are raised. In sadness, because the outcome has already occurred, no further information gathering is required, so the eyelids close. The mouth morphologies of fear and sadness also share features: both engage the depressor anguli oris, mentalis, and platysma. Contraction of the depressor anguli oris pulls the corners of the mouth downward; contraction of the mentalis raises the chin and pushes the middle of the lower lip upward; contraction of the platysma stretches the corners of the mouth laterally and downward, forming an inverted trapezoid with the lips wider at the top and narrower at the bottom. This shape frequently appears in fear as a stunned expression and in sadness as sobbing. Because fear is unstable and transitional, its mouth shape is less classic and stable than that of sadness and is often disrupted by screaming, breath-holding, or other needs. In sadness, the negative fact has already occurred, so fewer interfering factors exist and a relatively stable mouth morphology appears.

### **Chapter Summary (9787554606841)**

Fear is an instantaneous emotion formed when the stimulus source is appraised as exceeding one’s defensive capacity.

During fear the brows furrow to indicate strong attention while the eyes widen and the eyelids rise to increase light intake. To gather information more effectively than anger allows, humans also recruit the central frontalis to lift the brows, further elevating the upper eyelids beyond the angry position. After all, humans fear death; when one feels outmatched, attention to the opponent’s every move naturally intensifies in the interest of survival.



Fear is an unstable emotion. The first instant after appraising the stimulus source as negative and more powerful than one's defenses is the moment of fullest fear. No animal waits passively for death, however, so a dynamic secondary appraisal follows. If that appraisal widens the gap between stimulus force and defensive capacity, complete powerlessness produces freezing, fainting, or even death, abandoning instinctive escape behaviors. If the dynamic appraisal reveals a possibility of flight or counterattack, the next action may be taken—sometimes fighting more fiercely. Thus the classic fear expression, like surprise, lasts only a brief instant, though longer than surprise.

### Chapter Summary (9787554606841)

The discussion of smiling is now complete. It is the most complex expression in this book. Because smiles are the most socially adaptable expressions, polite smiles can be produced even in the absence of the corresponding emotion. Capturing, filtering, and analyzing smiles is therefore the most difficult task.

Nevertheless, we still hope everyone can produce as many genuine smiles as possible, which requires remembering the micro-expression features of smiling. Although smiles are complex and variable, a pure smile is governed by only two muscles: the zygomaticus major and the orbicularis oculi. When genuine pleasure arises, these two muscle groups act in concert; the powerful emotional burst produces strong contraction that forms the full smile morphology.

### 7.3.2 The Expression of Fear

In daily life, normal fear is rarely so saturated. Brow elevation is modest, eye opening is not exaggerated—only slightly larger than usual, or even normal—yet the expression of fear can still be readily identified.

Raised and twisted brows together with alert eyes are the typical features of fear.

The wider the eyes open, the greater the internal fear. In the full fear expression the eyelids attempt to expand maximally, sometimes exposing the sclera above the iris (though often obscured by the eyelid fold). Although the fear expression does not produce such extreme eyelid movement, observing eye shape remains key to determining the degree of fear.

Figure 7-11 shows a fear expression.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-11]

- ① The twisted brow shape is produced by simultaneous contraction of the corrugator supercilii and the medial frontalis. The normal arched brow line (dashed) is disrupted; the inner brow rises and the overall brow twists upward in its medial third (arrow).
- ② The upper eyelid is raised, exposing more of the upper iris.
- ③ The levator labii superioris contracts slightly, lifting the upper lip and partially revealing the upper teeth.
- ④ The platysma contracts slightly, pulling the corners of the mouth laterally and increasing the horizontal width of the mouth beyond its usual relaxed state.

Compared with the brow and eye morphology, mouth shape is less important in the fear expression. In Figure 7-11 the woman's mouth is generally relaxed, affected only by mandibular movement and platysma contraction; the corners are pulled slightly outward, exposing part of the lower teeth.

Although muscle contraction is greatly reduced relative to the full fear expression, such an expression in real life still signals a serious situation. For example, a playful university student who has already failed one course twice and, after a final effort, is summoned to the department office and learns of another failure—confirming that graduation is now impossible—will display exactly this expression.

### 3. Differences in Mouth Shape

In the surprise expression the upper lip is not raised; the lower lip simply drops with the mandible to permit a quick, shallow inhalation. Surprise occurs before the nature of the stimulus source is determined and before any solution is chosen. Once the stimulus source is appraised as overwhelmingly harmful, the evolved instinct immediately initiates the escape response, opening the mouth to draw in the maximum volume of air for energy reserves. Consequently, in the fear expression the upper lip is raised, the corners of the mouth are pulled widely apart by the platysma, and the lower lip is not only dropped by mandibular relaxation but also lengthened and depressed by the depressor labii inferioris, exposing part of the lower teeth. This action, performed to store respiratory energy, is of the same nature as the 全身 tension—trembling, skin tightening, altered circulation—that accompanies fear.

Finally, note that a full fear expression is usually accompanied by a deep inhalation. Observing the breathing pattern that accompanies the expression is also an important cue for emotion judgment.

One expression easily mistaken for fear must also be noted. In the instant of fear, because alertness toward the stimulus source is maintained and the tragic outcome remains uncertain, the eyes never narrow. The tightly closed eyes and screaming reaction often depicted in films actually reflect an acceptance that the worst outcome has already occurred and constitute a derivative of sadness. Screaming serves both as an instinctive release of inner pressure and as an evolutionarily conserved attack behavior—using high-frequency sound to drive the opponent away. Figure 7-10 illustrates this.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-10]

#### Mini-Application: Horror-Movie Posters

*The Perfume of the Lady in Black*, Italy, 1977.

### 2. Differences in Eyelid Morphology

The eyelids in surprise open naturally to their maximum, revealing the entire upper edge of the iris and sometimes even the sclera above. In fear the upper eyelids also attempt to open wide, yet the opposing pull of the orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii on the brows creates a fold that alters the overall eyelid shape; the natural degree of iris exposure nevertheless remains visible.

#### Why Open the Eyes Wide?

The primitive motive for opening the eyes to their fullest is to gather visual information rapidly so as to determine whether one is safe.

When we are afraid, we become highly tense and acutely sensitive to our surroundings. The entire nervous system is primed for any imminent threat. This heightened vigilance is expressed by the widened eyes; when the stimulus is sufficiently terrifying, the eyes open to their limit in an instant.

The wider the eyes, the more fearful the expression appears. In this respect, **the ocular features of fear overlap with those of surprise and anger**. When fear is less intense—for example, in worry or unease—the

eyes do not open dramatically and the sclera above the iris remains hidden.

Consequently, one way to observe fear is to cover all other parts of the face and examine only the eyes. Such close-ups are common in horror films. In the figure below, although the brow shape cannot be seen, the single eye alone suffices to show that the expression is not surprise, as illustrated in Figure 7-9.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-9]*

The left image clearly shows the eye of fear; the right image shows ordinary surprise without fear. The eyelid fold in the left image results from the distinctive brow configuration.

### 7.3.3 Expression of Unease

As the intensity of an emotion decreases, so do the morphological features of its expression. Figure 7-12 shows an expression of unease. In more idiomatic Chinese the phrase “anxious unease” would match the depicted expression more precisely.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-12]*

This is the expression that typically appears upon receiving bad news. The mouth is largely relaxed, the brows are flattened yet retain their twisted shape, the inner brows are raised though to a lesser degree, and the corrugator produces slight vertical wrinkles. The eyes are opened more than in a neutral face but not dramatically; the upper lids are not lifted as high as in fear or fright, yet more of the upper iris is visible than in a fully relaxed face, as shown in Figure 7-13.

#### Uneasy Eyes

#### Relaxed Eyes

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-13]*

This expression is frequently seen while waiting. When family or friends who have not been seen for a long time are expected at the airport, and all passengers on the same flight have already emerged but the awaited person has not appeared and calls go unanswered, this anxious look surfaces involuntarily—because the mind is preoccupied with the possibility of a negative outcome.

## 2. Typical Features of Fear Expressions

When fear is fully expressed, the brows assume a distinctly twisted configuration: they flatten overall, draw together, display vertical corrugator lines, yet the inner brows are raised by contraction of the medial frontalis, producing an upward slant at the inner third. Fine inverted-U wrinkles appear on the forehead.

The upper eyelids are markedly elevated, exposing more of the upper iris than in a neutral face. The degree of eyelid opening is proportional to the intensity of fear. In milder fear expressions the eyes open only slightly wider than usual, yet even this modest increase is significant. If the brows show any twisting (regardless of degree) and the eyes are opened sufficiently wide, the expression can be identified as belonging to the fear family even in the absence of other facial changes, allowing the inference that the subject is experiencing fear.

The mouth does not participate in every type of fear expression. In terror or fright the mouth may open; when the emotion is deliberately suppressed or only mildly felt—as in unease or worry—the lips may be pressed together or remain motionless. The extent of mouth movement reflects the strength of the fear.

## 1. Differences in Brow Shape

The surprised brow is simply raised (frontalis contraction) and retains its natural arch. The fearful brow is knitted overall, with the inner ends lifted, producing a twisted shape together with visible corrugator lines and forehead wrinkles.

At the instant of surprise, no positive or negative judgment has yet been formed about the stimulus; the reaction may turn into delight, anger, or fear. Fear, by contrast, arises only when the stimulus is perceived as genuinely threatening and therefore demands concentrated attention. Consequently the raising of the brows (medial frontalis) is accompanied by involuntary corrugator activity that knits and depresses the inner brows. Remember: **knitting the brows signals intense focus.**

The fearful brow configuration is therefore more complex than the surprised one: the brows must simultaneously draw together to signal tension and pressure while being raised to help the eyes gather more visual information. As a result, the fearful brow lacks the free, sweeping lift seen in surprise.

A practice method: first raise both brows as high as possible, then knit and depress the inner brows.

## Chapter 7 Micro-expressions of Fear

Fear arises once the threatening power of a negative stimulus exceeds a person's psychological tolerance. Fright, unease, and worry are derivatives of fear, decreasing in intensity. The expression of fear is a composite of surprise and sadness—essentially the sadness that is anticipated after surprise.

Anger prompts resistance to a threat; although the stimulus is strong, the individual subjectively judges that fighting can alter or eliminate it. When the stimulus exceeds psychological tolerance, anger converts into fear. A stimulus capable of eliciting fear is one that threatens the individual's interests and is so overwhelming that, after appraisal, the person no longer believes resistance is feasible. The primary behavioral option then becomes flight; under extreme pressure, despair may lead to complete surrender.

### 1. Morphology of a Full Fear Expression

The morphological features of an extreme fear expression are as follows:

- Corrugator contraction draws the brows together, forming vertical corrugator lines;
- Medial frontalis contraction raises the inner brows, producing inverted-U wrinkles on the forehead;
- Levator palpebrae superioris contraction attempts to lift the upper lids, yet is opposed by the orbicularis oculi and corrugator, creating diagonal folds in the upper-lid skin; without opposition the entire upper iris would be exposed;
- Simultaneous contraction of levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi raises the upper lip, exposing the upper teeth;
- Platysma contraction pulls the mouth corners laterally, increasing the horizontal width of the mouth beyond its resting state;
- Depressor labii inferioris contraction lowers the lower lip, exposing part of the lower teeth.

### 3. Application of Fear Micro-expressions in Psychological Testing

A subject experiences fear only when confronted with a stimulus that threatens imminent exposure.

Because physical coercion is prohibited and the conclusions of psychological testing do not constitute physical evidence, no direct, severe threat is posed to the subject; consequently, expressions of fear or fright do not appear during testing. Moreover, because the purpose of testing is to uncover psychological inconsistencies rather than to pressure or harass, even anxious or uneasy expressions are rare; the most common micro-expression observed is worry.

#### (4) Morphology of Fear Micro-expressions

- The brows show no large-scale elevation; only a slight raising of the inner ends and a flattened, twisted configuration are observable;
- The eyelids remain largely natural, yet the upper lids are positioned slightly higher than normal, exposing a larger area of the iris.

**Summary:** These morphological features constitute the necessary characteristics of fear-family expressions. A subject experiences fear only when confronted with a stimulus that threatens imminent exposure.

#### 7.3.5 Morphological Features of Fear Micro-expressions

Summarizing the morphological features across varying intensities yields the micro-expression characteristics of fear-family emotions: **the inner brows are simultaneously knitted and raised, producing a twist at the inner third, while the upper eyelids remain elevated, exposing more of the iris.** Once this brow-eye combination appears—even at low intensity—it signals fear and is therefore the defining morphological feature of fear micro-expressions.

##### (1) Morphology of Fright

- Corrugator and medial frontalis contract together, destroying the normal arched brow shape; the inner brows rise and the brow twists upward at the inner third;
- Upper eyelids lift, exposing more of the upper iris;
- Levator labii superioris contracts slightly, raising the upper lip and partially exposing the upper teeth;
- Platysma contracts slightly, pulling the mouth corners laterally and widening the mouth beyond its relaxed resting width.

##### (2) Morphology of Unease

- The brows flatten overall yet retain their twisted shape; the inner brows are raised, though to a lesser degree;
- Corrugator produces slight vertical wrinkles;
- The eyes open more than usual but not dramatically; upper-lid elevation is less pronounced than in fear or fright, yet more of the upper iris is visible than in a fully relaxed face.

#### Expression of Fright

In evolutionary biology the expression of “fright” signals “I have no intention of attacking you” and “Please do not harm me”; it can also be used to assess whether the other party is non-aggressive or to indicate a desire to conserve energy for other purposes.

#### 1. Morphological Features of Fear Micro-expressions

The inner brows are simultaneously knitted and raised, the upper eyelids are elevated, and more of the upper iris is exposed. The fullness of the emotion is directly proportional to the degree of eyelid opening and to the degree of inner-brow elevation. This brow-eye combination is the necessary feature of fear-family expressions.

### (3) Morphology of Worry

- The raised and twisted inner brows indicate psychological pressure without indicating disgust or anger;
- The lips are pressed together, concealing the vermilion border; orbicularis oris contraction tenses the lips, and contraction of depressor anguli oris produces a bulge at the mouth corners.

## 2. Common Fear Expression Morphology

In daily life we readily recognize expressions arising from fear-family emotions. The raised and twisted brows together with the alert eyes are the typical features of fright.

### 11.2.4 Fear

If the intensity of the negative stimulus continues to increase and overwhelms the individual's psychological capacity to attack (resist), anger converts into fear.

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

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See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

## The Micro-Expressions of "Anger" Are the Timing for Apology

### Appendix: An Extra Piece on Anger Emotions

—— Paying Tribute to Professor Paul Ekman and Exploring

This is a purely academic discussion, a section paying tribute to the senior scholar along the way. If you are not interested in relatively pure academic theoretical issues, you can skip this section directly.

American scholar Professor Paul Ekman, who studies micro-expressions, believes that the emotion of anger can be divided into many different themes. In the examples mentioned by Paul Ekman, there are infants having their freedom restrained, being violated especially intentionally violated, being frustrated or feeling powerless, being insulted and slandered, being rejected by one's lover, others' anger, disappointment in others especially loved ones, behavior and beliefs being offended, and promoting behaviors and beliefs one opposes.

Paul Ekman once summarized, "We can consider frustration, others' anger, the threat of being harmed, and being rejected by others as variants of infringing on the subject. Even anger toward promoters of things we oppose can be seen as a variant."

Based on these paragraphs, we believe that Professor Paul Ekman's description of the root causes of anger emotions in the book *Emotions Revealed* is somewhat loose, failing to clearly summarize the common characteristic of anger stimuli—threat. Whether being restrained, violated, disturbed, negated, or others' anger, they all ultimately point to a threat to one's own interests. We respectfully discuss with the senior scholar and readers whether this is appropriate.

Additionally, Paul Ekman specifically used the "Maxine Kenny case" to explain and illustrate anger. The case is very simple: a man named David Lynn Scott III raped and murdered Maxine Kenny's daughter. He was arrested a year later and convicted after another 4 years.

In the book, Paul Ekman uses a statement by Maxine on the day of the criminal's execution, a photo, and an attack on the criminal to attempt to explain the generation of anger emotions. However, the analysis of the direct stimuli for anger emotions is not detailed enough, which is also the reason why in his "Anger" chapter, the analysis of the origins of anger appears somewhat scattered. At least in this case, Paul Ekman did not mention the possibility of sadness existing, but in such a case, there would certainly be sadness.

We can speculate in chronological order about the emotional changes of the party involved, Maxine Kenny. Note that the following content is merely based on hypotheses, not a scientific research process using empirical methods, and cannot be used to draw conclusions.

1. If she was at the crime scene at the time and witnessed the criminal's violation of her daughter, she would certainly produce anger emotions. Although the criminal might be tall and burly and possibly holding a sharp knife, out of protection for her offspring, the party would certainly feel anger far greater than fear, and with the support of anger's power, she would fight the criminal to protect her daughter. Because the criminal's violation directly threatened her child's safety (a threat to reproduction), harmed the years of effort invested in raising the child, and threatened her future life state, especially her emotional state. Therefore, the anger at that time would certainly be extremely intense.
2. If the criminal had finished the crime, having raped her daughter and caused death, then her subsequent emotions would depend on the criminal's follow-up behavior. If the criminal then carried out a violent violation against the party Maxine Kenny, directly threatening the party's own life safety (a threat to survival), then with the support of self-preservation and anger over the daughter's victimization, the party would still bravely fight the criminal. If the outcome of the fight remains uncertain (win or lose), anger is the dominant emotion; but once the criminal gains an overwhelming advantage in the fight (being tangled together does not count as overwhelming, since one can still tear

and twist forcefully), and the party is powerless to change the outcome (loss or even death), then fear and sadness may both become dominant emotions. Anger remains, but it no longer occupies the dominant position.

3. If the criminal finished the crime, killed the party's daughter, and then immediately left without further harming the party. Would the party pursue the criminal, or stay facing her daughter's body in inconsolable grief? An ordinary person without combat training or combat experience would certainly choose the latter. At this point, grief becomes the main emotion; the party focuses entirely on the daughter's life or death, and anger, having temporarily lost its stimulus source, recedes to secondary status or even becomes very slight. Before receiving confirmation of the daughter's death from credible personnel (such as a doctor or police), the party still has energy and believes there is still a chance for a turnaround in the situation, possibly maintaining a relatively excited neural state hoping the daughter can survive. At this time, the possibility of anger existing is extremely small, and even if present, it is far from the main emotion. But if the daughter is confirmed dead, then the party may be left with only sadness emotions, powerless to fight anything and having lost hope of salvaging anything.
4. We make some dramatic assumptions again. If we ignore the police and medical personnel at the scene and the criminal reappears, it is foreseeable that the situation of the second stage will inevitably occur—that is, the appearance of the stimulus source will trigger the party's intense anger emotions.

From 16:00 on February 5, 2011 to 16:00 on February 6, 2011, the research group initiated an online vote via Weibo, asking netizens to choose one of the following two options according to their own feelings: "When the party fights the criminal, what sentence might they mutter in their mouth or mind?"

- A. Why?! Why did you hurt her?!
- B. She's already dead! She's already dead!

The 24-hour voting results are as follows: Out of 931 votes, 72% chose option A, and 28% chose option B.

### **Explanation of option A:**

In previous internal tests, all group members without exception chose this option. Because our theoretical research hypothesis is that anger is triggered by unexpected negative stimuli, and unexpected (unreasonable) violation behavior extremely easily causes the violated person to produce anger emotions. Moreover, unexpectedness is a very important factor, because if it is within expectations—that is, the party fully confirms that the harmful behavior is about to occur (such as criminal punishment)—then anger emotions are not easily produced, and fear is more often the replacement (with exceptions). The violated person completely did not expect and does not understand why the other party would violate their rights. This huge degree of mismatch with negative expectations (violation) will cause the party, while angrily counterattacking, to produce another non-rational desire—to "eliminate" the other party's unreasonable behavioral motive, attempting through "education" or "debate" to dissolve this threat and harm factor into nothingness. "Why did you hurt my daughter? She is innocent (she didn't hurt you), she is still so young, she is still in college, she has a bright future..." Perhaps there is another possibility: repeating these reasonable (should not be harmed) factors, contrasting with the unreasonable violation behavior, can enhance one's own anger emotions, thereby mobilizing more energy for counterattack.

It is worth special note that these desires are not the result of rational thinking, but merely a combination of habit and instinct. Therefore, the party is not trying to persuade the criminal to abandon the criminal intent; it is merely a primitive expectation. Of course, if it is a quarrel-type violation and counterattack, it requires



substantial participation of rational thinking, but similar reactions will also occur: "Why did you cancel our plan? We stayed up for three days and nights for this plan; this plan is the heart and soul of the entire team. Did you read it carefully? On what basis do you negate our plan after just a cursory glance in less than a minute? This plan was drafted with reference to the XX classic case (or XX theory); it is absolutely correct!"

### **Explanation of option B:**

The language in option B can also appear in actual situations, but the party's inner state is quite different. Loss is the source of sadness. If the daughter's death has no other factors interfering, then it will certainly only leave the party with sadness, with no strength to attend to other things. "She's already dead" may appear during frenzied fighting, but more often appears in the consciousness of sadness (true sadness is rarely spoken aloud); it is a reinforcement of loss.

**The party's unexpected, criminal's deliberate harmful behavior causing death will add a considerable degree of anger to the party's sadness emotions.** But the repetition of "She's already dead" is not a direct expression of anger, but an expression of sadness. The party uses this sad result to reinforce their expectation mismatch (healthy life versus unexpected victimization and death), thereby reinforcing the triggering of anger emotions and mobilizing energy for battle.

### **Paying Tribute to Professor Paul Ekman and Exploring**

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American scholar Professor Paul Ekman, who studies micro-expressions, believes that the emotion of anger can be divided into many different themes. In the examples mentioned by Paul Ekman, there are infants having their freedom restrained, being violated especially intentionally violated, being frustrated or feeling powerless, being insulted and slandered, being rejected by one's lover, others' anger, disappointment in others especially loved ones, behavior and beliefs being offended, and promoting behaviors and beliefs one opposes.

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4. We make some dramatic assumptions again. If we ignore the police and medical personnel at the scene and the criminal reappears, it is foreseeable that the situation of the second stage will inevitably occur—that is, the appearance of the stimulus source will trigger the party's intense anger emotions.

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- A. Why?! Why did you hurt her?!
- B. She's already dead! She's already dead!

The 24-hour voting results are as follows: Out of 931 votes, 72% chose option A, and 28% chose option B.

### 6.3.2 A Variant of Anger One: Breath-Holding Lips (Breath-Holding Mouth)

Tightly closing both lips combined with the standard anger eyebrow-eye combination makes the face look exceptionally angry, as shown in Figure 6-12.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-12]*

This is a breath-holding expression. The energy provided by anger emotions infuses into the three bundles of muscles controlling the mouth, forming this special angry mouth morphology:

- Upper lip raised (action of levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi), nasal wings raised, grooves appearing on both sides of the nasal wings
- Lower lip pushed up, tightly pressed together with the upper lip, lips thinned, stretched into a straight line, lower lip protruding
- Skin at the chin position raised and uneven (action of mentalis)
- Corners of the mouth severely downturned (action of depressor anguli oris), exactly opposite to when smiling with pressed lips

This morphology can be abbreviated as "breath-holding mouth," the typical form of genuine anger. Because it requires the coordinated action of three muscles, it is difficult to fake.

This breath-holding angry expression's muscle morphology features on the face are shown in Figure 6-13:

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-13]*

- Corrugator supercilii contracted, orbicularis oculi contracted, causing both eyebrows to furrow and press downward
- Levator palpebrae superioris contracted
- Contraction of orbicularis oculi also tightens the lower eyelids and slightly pulls them sideways
- Orbicularis oris contracted, causing both lips to close tightly together
- Depressor anguli oris contracted, causing both corners of the mouth to curve downward
- Mentalis contracted, forming muscle ridges on the chin with an uneven surface, while pushing the lower lip upward to keep both lips tightly closed

However, this mouth morphology cannot be used alone as a micro-expression morphological feature of anger. Although this "breath-holding mouth" morphology is a common component of angry expressions, it can also appear in other emotions, as shown in Figure 6-14.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-14]*

If we cover the upper half of this face or replace it with another eyebrow-eye morphology, we can see that the breath-holding mouth alone is still insufficient to confirm the true presence of anger. Because the raising of the upper lip and the changes it causes around the nasal wings are not as primary or obvious as in disgust, the breath-holding mouth can also appear as part of sadness, as shown in Figure 6-15.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-15]*

**Summary:** Tightly pursed lips can to some extent express anger, but they may also appear in other expressions. To confirm an anger expression, it must be paired with the standard anger eyebrow-eye

morphology.

### 6.3.5 Morphological Characteristics of Angry Micro-expressions (9789620756689)

Through the previous comparisons and analyses, we can deduce that the morphology of the eyebrows and eyes holds important significance for expressing anger: the eyebrows are strongly pressed downward, the muscles of the upper and lower eyelids contract and tense, and the gaze focuses intensely on the stimulus source. The more intense the anger, the shorter the distance between the eyebrows and the upper eyelid margin. As shown in Figure 6-19.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-19]*

When the intensity of anger decreases, the degree of muscular movement in the eyebrows and eyes lessens accordingly, forming a weakened version of the angry eyebrow-eye morphology. As shown in Figure 6-20.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-20]*

Both eyebrows press downward and tighten, the levator palpebrae superioris contracts, and its lifting force partially counters the downward pressure of the eyebrows, causing the eyes to open wider; however, they still encounter resistance from the pressed-down eyebrows, resulting in accumulated skin folds (thickening of the upper eyelid). When these two morphologies (lowered eyebrows + widened eyes) appear together, the expression can be called a glare.

Both eyebrows press downward, the upper eyelids lift, and the lower eyelids tense; a tightly closed mouth is a classic facial feature of an angry expression. If a person habitually (or physiologically) maintains any of these features over time (eyelids cannot remain lifted indefinitely), it can give others the impression of a bad temper, coldness, or extreme seriousness. As shown in Figure 6-21.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-21]*

In the comparison of Figure 6-22, merely observing the close-up of the eyes in the image below reveals the threat of anger. Due to changes in eyelid morphology, more of the upper and lower margins of the iris become visible, and the shape of the exposed sclera also differs from the norm. This sharply angled upper eyelid morphology, with the outer two-thirds nearly straight, results from the downward pressure of both eyebrows.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-22]*

It is evident that effective ways to intensify the expression of anger are the lifting of the upper eyelids and the tensing of the lower eyelids; the wider the eyes are opened, the stronger the conveyed meaning of anger. When criticizing someone, a piercing stare can induce fear. When a glare is combined with downward-pressed eyebrows and tightly closed lips, the expression of anger becomes very pronounced.

Depending on the specific context, if a person cannot or does not wish to express anger, their facial expression may show almost no change.

On an almost unchanged face, two features can still reveal the person's inner anger:

- First, contraction of the orbicularis oculi muscle produces a highly forceful eyelid configuration, specifically manifested as lifting of the upper eyelid and tensing of the lower eyelid; at this point, even changes in the eyebrows may be difficult to observe;

- Second, intense visual focus; without gaze concentrated on the stimulus source, the angry expression is greatly diminished and becomes suppressed forbearance.

Therefore, in a restrained angry expression, although the entire face shows almost no change, the excessive effort to suppress the anger makes the tension and concentration in the eyes, along with stiffness in the rest of the face, clearly visible; it is by no means a relaxed state. During the process of maintaining a blank expression while restraining anger, the nostrils often flare and expel air forcefully.

Eye tension (lifting of the upper eyelid and tensing of the lower eyelid) combined with concentrated gaze, when the eyeballs and head remain completely still (unlike the slight backward movement in surprised wide-eyed expressions), creates a sense of powerful eye contact, forming a glare. Conversely, if the upper eyelid muscles cease contracting and return to normal, the lower eyelids relax, or the gaze shifts away from the stimulus source, then even if other angry features such as downward-pressed eyebrows and tightly closed lips remain, the original anger will completely disappear.

### 6.3.5 Morphological Characteristics of Angry Micro-expressions (9787554606841)

## Chapter Summary

## Appendix: An Additional Note on Anger

### Summary

- Option A represents an expression of anger.
- Option B received less agreement, consistent with our hypothesis, because that statement is an expression of conscious sadness rather than a direct expression of anger.

In the year that followed (before the suspect was apprehended), which emotion did the individual most likely harbor—hatred-tinged anger or grief over the loss of a loved one? I believe both emotions were present, and the dominant emotion varied from person to person. When confronted with the stimulus “my daughter is dead,” sadness dominated; when recalling the cause of her death (the criminal’s actions as the stimulus), anger dominated.

Finally, on the day of execution after the verdict, the individual said to the offender on the spot:

“You think you’re a samurai? Wake up! This isn’t feudal Japan, and even if it were, you could never be a samurai, because you’re a coward! You <|eos|>

③ Although both expressions involve an open mouth, and it is even possible that both involve shouting (the open mouth in a fear expression is more often used for deep inhalation), careful observation of the width and height of the mouth opening reveals subtle differences. The mouth shape used in fear cannot produce a sharp, threatening sound. Because the mouth shapes differ, the resulting nasolabial fold shapes are also completely different. As shown in Figure 7-6.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-6]

It is clear that although the overall appearances are similar, the various subtle differences cause the two expressions to convey entirely different meanings. This is also one of the methods we use to study micro-expressions. If we can decompose the expression on a face, identify its typical and necessary morphological

features, we can move beyond ordinary experiential recognition and directly determine the person's true inner state.

Next, let us carefully decompose a full fear expression and examine its muscular movements and morphological features. As shown in Figure 7-7.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-7]

1. Contraction of the corrugator supercilii draws both eyebrows together and tightens them, forming vertical frown lines;
2. Contraction of the medial frontalis raises the inner brows, creating inverted-U wrinkles on the forehead;
3. Contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris attempts to lift the upper eyelids, but is inhibited by the opposing actions of the orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii, producing diagonal folds on the upper eyelid skin. Without inhibition, analysis indicates that the entire upper margin of the iris would be exposed (as indicated by the dashed line in Figure 7-7);
4. Contraction of the levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi together raises the upper lip, exposing the upper teeth;
5. Contraction of the platysma pulls the corners of the mouth laterally, increasing the horizontal width of the mouth beyond its normal state;
6. Contraction of the depressor labii inferioris pulls the lower lip downward, exposing part of the lower teeth.

After learning about the sadness expression in the next chapter, you will find that **the fear expression is a combination of surprise and sadness, which can be understood as sadness anticipated after surprise**. Because fear is produced by the overwhelming threat of the stimulus, the person feels overpowered and does not dare to resist (wanting to resist would be anger) and believes a tragic outcome is imminent (though it has not yet occurred), so they only attempt to flee or even give up. Once the tragic outcome occurs, the emotion turns to sadness. Therefore, let us compare the fear expression with the surprise expression discussed earlier, as the two are naturally linked. As shown in Figure 7-8.

### **Fear Expression    Surprise Expression**

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-8]

By observing these two images, we can see the obvious differences between the two expressions as follows:

#### **Summary**

Option A represents an expression of anger. Option B received less agreement, consistent with our hypothesis, because that statement is an expression of conscious sadness rather than a direct expression of anger.

In the year that followed (before the suspect was apprehended), which emotion did the individual most likely harbor—hatred-tinged anger or grief over the loss of a loved one? I believe both emotions were present, and the dominant emotion varied from person to person. When confronted with the stimulus “my daughter is dead,” sadness dominated; when recalling the cause of her death (the criminal's actions as the stimulus), anger dominated.

Finally, on the day of execution after the verdict, the individual said to the offender on the spot: “You think you're a samurai? Wake up! This isn't feudal Japan, and even if it were, you could never be a samurai, because you're a coward! You sneak around at night wearing a black robe,

## Court Statement (Mother's Accusation Against the Offender)

carrying a weapon, searching everywhere for innocent, unarmed girls... You raped and murdered because you mistakenly believed that identity gave you such a right. You are more like a filthy, disgusting cockroach scurrying between walls in the night, contaminating everything. I have no pity for you at all! You raped my daughter Gail, abused her, and brutally killed her—not once, but seven times. Her hands were covered with defensive wounds, yet you ignored her desperate struggle to survive. You do not deserve to live!

Yet the offender showed no remorse and faced the statement with a smile. The individual struck the offender's head and was restrained by her husband and police officers.

This highly aggressive language fully illustrates the attack tendency and verbal manifestations of anger. However, using this case as explanatory support for the generation of anger is not entirely appropriate. The courtroom statement only demonstrates the individual's expression of anger and does not clearly explain the root cause of that anger. The primary emotion from losing a daughter should be sadness; that should be the dominant emotion throughout the case from incident to trial. Anger exists only within a specific context—the absolute safety of the courtroom, the individual's absolute dominance, and the offender's absolute weakness. Without this context, the individual would not have possessed the force of anger to fully express inner resentment, let alone attack the offender; fear and sadness would have predominated.

A more accurate description of this mother's feelings would be "hatred." Hatred is a compound emotion: it expresses retrospective defiance, non-acceptance, and rejection of an already incurred loss through sadness, yet the person lacks the power to change the situation and therefore seeks psychological balance by harming the interests of the hated person, rather than altering the objective result of the loss. The party harboring hatred is usually the weaker party; although an offensive impulse of anger exists internally, the overall stance toward the hated person remains one of weakness. A person holding absolute advantage does not harbor "hatred" toward an opponent.

Therefore, using this case to illustrate anger easily leads readers to confuse the stimulus sources that trigger several primary emotions, which is inappropriate. Moreover, Paul Ekman himself added, "Anger rarely lasts long by itself. Fear often precedes or follows anger—fear that those who anger us may harm us, fear of one's own anger, fear of losing control and harming others." Such descriptions inevitably leave readers puzzled.

While respectfully debating with the predecessor, I also sincerely invite readers to share their insights.

### 1. Anger While Driving

Driving on the road is a situation highly conducive to anger, especially when traffic conditions are poor. Anyone with driving experience can immediately think of potential triggers. Minor cases include the car ahead failing to accelerate when it should, cutting in line instead of queuing, failing to yield when required, or suddenly changing lanes without signaling. More serious cases involve accidents, such as being rear-ended or colliding without cause. In all these situations, a mismatch of expectations is an obvious factor, and both mind and mouth will angrily utter, "Can't you drive?!"

Some people therefore conclude that **unreasonableness** is the stimulus for anger. They believe that if everyone drove reasonably, everything would proceed in an orderly and smooth manner, and such anger would not arise. Another view holds that anyone might drive unreasonably, so that is not the key stimulus; suffering a loss or feeling aggrieved (harm to one's interests) is the true stimulus.

If unreasonable driving amounts to domineering self-importance or even malicious provocation, it can indeed trigger anger—this is a natural reaction to a challenge to one's dignity, just like a stranger arrogantly shoving you on the street. It has no direct relation to driving per se; it is simply being provoked while driving. This negative stimulus to competence and dignity is equivalent to an infringement on an animal's territory and instinctively provokes anger.

If the issue is not malicious provocation but merely whether one suffers a loss, we can probe deeper: what advantage does cutting in or overtaking by changing lanes actually confer?

In fact, the psychological process that truly triggers anger is not necessarily another person's obstruction, delay, or offense; it may lie one layer deeper than the immediately apparent cause. Whether anger arises is directly related to the purpose of the drive.

Under normal circumstances, when driving, what one truly cares about is what needs to be done after reaching the destination; the journey itself is merely a necessary process. If one is aimlessly cruising with no destination, ordinary unreasonable driving (not malicious) and traffic jams will not easily provoke anger. Being hit might still trigger anger, but upon deeper reflection, the real cause is that the accident will entail insurance claims, repairs, and other troubles plus wasted time, directly affecting normal life arrangements afterward; the extent of damage to the car itself matters little (as long as no one is injured). Imagine driving an already damaged car that has not yet been sent for repair—if it sustains a little more damage while you are leisurely cruising, what difference does it make?

### Interesting Case

#### Angry Churchill

Restrained mild anger can easily be mistaken for deep thought.

During World War II, Canadian photojournalist Yousef Karsh, attempting to capture Churchill in a state of deep contemplation while facing a major decision, risked snatching the cigar from his mouth as a provocation. The immediate reaction produced the now-famous photograph of Churchill with both eyebrows pressed down and lower lip jutting out, resembling a bulldog. The image made Karsh famous overnight.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-23]*

After so much study and research, we can use Figure 6-24 to test your ability to recognize angry expression features.

Please observe the image and determine whether it shows anger or grievance.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-24]*

**Answer:** It appears to be grievance but is actually anger.

The morphological feature most likely to be mistaken for grievance is the pouting of the mouth. Such a mouth shape does indeed appear in expressions of grievance. Because sustained lifting of the upper eyelids and maintenance of lower-eyelid tension are difficult, the glaring eye configuration does not last long. However, the morphologies of the eyebrows and mouth can persist more easily. Overall, the expression in the image looks more like grievance. Yet, for the following reasons, this image can be identified as an angry expression:



1. **Eyebrows:** The eyebrows are furrowed and pressed downward, indicating attention; judging by the force of the muscular movement, the level of attention is high;
2. **Eyes:** Superficially, the upper eyelids show no sign of lifting, and nearly half of the iris is covered by the upper eyelids. However, measuring the distance between the upper eyelid margin and the eyebrows reveals that the upper eyelids have been lifted with considerable effort. The downward pressure of the eyebrows was simply too strong, producing this morphology. In addition, the lower eyelids can be observed to be tense, positioned slightly higher and straighter than usual, with the gaze intensely focused on the photographer—precisely the morphological features of an angry micro-expression.
3. **Mouth:** The mentalis contracts and pushes the lower lip upward, creating an uneven ridge on the chin; both lips are tightly closed and thinned, protruding outward under the action of the orbicularis oris; the depressor anguli oris contracts and slightly pulls the corners of the mouth downward. This is the “breath-holding mouth” described earlier, a typical mouth morphology of anger.

### The Mechanism of Anger Generation

In the animal world, if it is simply a matter of predator and prey, the predator feels hunger (the greatest driver of action), while the prey feels fear. Because the adversarial relationship between them is unbalanced, with dominance and weakness too pronounced, the weaker party lacks the power to eliminate the threat and can only flee quickly (this is fear). If lucky enough to run fast, it escapes. Therefore, it is certain that the weaker party will not feel anger, and if the stronger party fails to catch up, it will not curse inwardly either; it can only adjust its stamina in hopes of another attempt.

When the two sides are evenly matched, anger is more likely to appear. Territory is a rule of interaction that animals with ruling power mutually recognize. Whether the challenge originates from within the territory or comes from an unfamiliar force outside, it will arouse anger in the territory's controller, because such challenging behavior implies two things:

- First, knowing full well that this is my domain yet daring to offend is a massive expectation violation; how can you show me so little respect?!
- Second, if the challenger wins, the original territory holder loses everything—mate, offspring, a good life, even life itself. This is an enormous threat, involving both survival and reproduction. Such a threat must be eliminated! Anger arises, followed by physical confrontation.

In the human world, the stimuli that trigger human anger are likewise **interest threats**—threats that may harm survival and reproduction. This is essentially identical to the mechanism that produces anger in animals.

Of course, the generation of human anger involves broader and more complex derivative variations. Civilization, education, and the detailed fragmentation of life cause anger to arise more often from various derived threats.

The threat stimuli discussed here do not refer merely to formal threats, such as verbal warnings or brandishing weapons, but to a more abstract concept: situations that the individual subjectively perceives as potentially harmful.

The individual assesses whether the stimulus constitutes an interest threat. If the threat is judged to be eliminable through one's own efforts, anger may arise; if there is no thought or confidence in eliminating the threat, the response is fear; if the matter is dismissed entirely, the response is disgust (commonly expressed as contempt). Therefore, whether an interest threat exists lies solely in the mind of the individual and has a strong causal link to that person's self-perception.

## 2. Typical Features of Anger Expressions

The typical features of an anger expression are eyebrows pressed downward, closest to the upper eyelid edges; eyes glaring forcefully, upper eyelids raised, lower eyelids tensed, gaze locked intensely on the stimulus without shifting; mouth shapes in anger vary considerably, commonly showing bared teeth, roaring, or tightly closed lips.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-26]*

### **Eyebrows:**

Lowered eyebrows indicate intense focus. Because stimuli capable of eliciting anger carry threat-level intensity, they absolutely merit attention, so the natural expression shows the typical lowered-eyebrow configuration.

### **Eyelids:**

An anger expression must include raised upper eyelids (exposing more of the upper iris than usual) and tensed lower eyelids (slightly elevated, with the eyelid line straightened). The wider the eyes open, the deeper the anger. The glaring eyes combined with lowered eyebrows give the gaze strong penetrating power. When the brow-eye configuration is paired with the mouth shape of anger, the presence of anger is clearly conveyed.

### **Mouth:**

The mouth shape is the most variable element in anger.

factors. In roaring anger, the mouth shape is influenced by the content spoken. The upper lip is often raised; the lower lip varies more. It may form a bared-teeth biting shape, be pressed together and puffed by the mentalis and orbicularis oris, or remain in its usual relaxed state. When the degree of eyelid elevation is equal, a person with an open, roaring mouth appears angrier than one with a closed mouth.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-27]*

In modern social interactions, clear, full displays of anger on the face are rare. Noticing the momentary change in the glare allows observation of the person's inner emotion.

Anger without focused gaze is a staged performance.

If the gaze wanders, lowered eyebrows and pressed lips alone cannot effectively express anger; the expression appears more like a response to pressure, commonly seen when someone is struggling to decide or thinking deeply. This is shown in Figure 6-27.

### **How to Distinguish Between "Deep Thinking" and "Anger" Expressions?**

Regarding the interpretation of eyebrow shape or mouth shape in an "anger" expression, some may wonder: "Isn't this the same as the expression when seriously thinking about something?" Exactly. When displaying an "anger" expression, the actions of "both eyebrows drawing toward the center" and "lips pressing together" coincide with the expression of serious thinking.

Facial movements fall into two categories: one expresses emotion, the other conveys conversational information about thinking. These conversational signals are facial movements produced while speaking to or listening to others and carry no emotion.

The meaning conveyed by “both eyebrows drawing toward the center” and “lips pressing together” is “concentration,” so I call this expression the “concentration” face.

The “concentration” face expresses “anger” in emotional display, yet expresses “deep thinking” in conversation. “Anger” arises when a desired goal is obstructed or an obstacle is encountered. When a goal is blocked, the aggressive emotion of “anger” appears. “Deep thinking” is the mechanism of concentrating to reorganize one’s own words or to understand another’s speech. For this reason, both the “anger” expression and the “deep thinking” expression are called the “concentration” face.

Next, let us observe whether the person before us is angry or seriously thinking, and how to tell the two apart.

Even when feeling “anger” in public, unless anger erupts irrationally and fully, the emotion is suppressed and therefore appears as the micro-expression form of “anger” (微反应 (micro-reaction)). In short, this display lasts only an instant and shows merely “both eyebrows drawing toward the center” or “lips pressing together.” That is, an expression that appears only momentarily has a high likelihood of representing the emotion “anger”; conversely, if the movement persists for a short while, it may represent “deep thinking.”

Some people around you may habitually maintain a frightening expression with lowered eyebrows and concentrated frown lines—supervisors, chairpersons, clients, and so on. They may not be irritable; they may simply be thinking seriously at that moment.

### Test Case

#### The “Inventor” Who Ignores the World

Only when the test subject perceives a threat will anger be triggered.

In other words, once anger is observed on the test subject’s face, it can be concluded that the stimulus is a highly effective core issue—the matter the subject is most worried about and least willing to have exposed.

We once encountered an “extraordinary individual,” a person who did nothing except invent.

Xiao Lu was a well-known amateur inventor, famous for building an amphibious robot from scrap materials. Yet background checks revealed that, apart from tinkering with inventions at home, he did nothing: no job (no regular income), no friends, and even when his girlfriend became pregnant he still handled all household chores himself.

During our interaction, we deliberately asked how he viewed the “inventions” he had created. He began confidently, displaying unmistakable pride in his work. We hinted that everything he had made already existed in the world in earlier, more precise, more technologically advanced, and more practical industrial forms. He grasped the implication—“what you are doing and what you have produced have no meaning or value”—and flew into a rage. In addition to the classic anger expression on his face, micro-reactions in body language appeared during his subsequent rebuttals and self-justifications.

The reason was that all of Xiao Lu’s behavior stemmed from a single motive—hobby. Because the hobby was so consuming, it brought him attention while also imposing excessive pressure, forcing him to evade all real-life problems and bury himself in persistent action. This was the point he least wanted others to see through (though perceptive people could) and least wanted pointed out. Therefore, when his core interest (evaluation of his behavior pattern) was threatened (questioned), the test subject’s anger response was inevitably triggered.

## Explanation of Option A

In previous internal tests, every team member chose this option. Our theoretical hypothesis was that anger is triggered by unexpected negative stimuli; unexpected (unreasonable) harmful acts readily produce anger in the harmed party. Unexpectedness is a crucial factor, because if the harm is anticipated—that is, the individual fully expects the injurious act to occur (such as criminal punishment)—anger is unlikely; fear is more common (with exceptions). The harmed party never anticipated or understood why the other would infringe on their rights; this massive negative expectation violation (the infringement) causes the individual, while angrily counterattacking, to generate an additional non-rational desire: to “cancel” the other’s unreasonable behavioral motive, attempting through “education” or “argument” to dissolve the threat and harm. “Why would you harm my daughter? She is innocent (she never harmed you), she is still so young, she is still in university, she has a bright future...” Perhaps repeating these reasonable (should-not-be-harmed) factors, contrasted with the unreasonable harmful act, can intensify one’s own anger and mobilize more energy for counterattack.

It is worth noting that these desires are not the result of rational thought but merely a combination of habit and instinct. Thus the individual is not trying to persuade the offender to abandon the criminal intent; it is simply a primitive expectation. Of course, when the infringement and counterattack take the form of an argument, rational thought participates heavily, yet a similar response still occurs: “Why did you cancel our plan? We stayed up three nights for this plan; it is the team’s entire effort. Did you even read it carefully? How can you reject it after a cursory glance in less than a minute? This plan was drafted with reference to the XX classic case (or XX theory) and is absolutely correct!”

## 7. Threat or Destruction?

One view holds that anger arises from the destruction of interests. This view merits further examination. Destruction is an accomplished fact; threat is a negative stimulus whose outcome is uncertain—it may cause harm, yet it may also be eliminated through effort. Therefore, if negative harm has already damaged the interest the individual cares about most, is further struggle necessary? If struggle remains possible, the outcome is still undetermined and there is an opportunity to recover through action. Whether damage has already occurred depends mainly on whether the individual subjectively believes the most important outcome has been damaged; like threat, this is a subjective assessment.

Thus the stimulus for anger is indeed threat.

In real life, some people become angry when others touch their sore spots, even when the remarks are groundless slander; others can remain detached and dismiss such slander with a smile. The difference lies in the assessment of threat: those who perceive threat become angry; those who do not perceive threat remain calm. Threat is a subjective feeling.

Fear is the weaker mindset that follows assessment of a negative stimulus. If the stimulus threatens survival or reproduction, anger arises; if the negative stimulus is overwhelming, it is no longer literally a “threat.” Here, threat is a subjective feeling.

Of course, human intelligence can influence emotion in certain respects. When serious harm occurs—whether to oneself or to a loved one—memory and reason cause the person, beyond sadness, to dwell on the malignant effects produced by the stimulus; each recollection can trigger a degree of anger.

Having clarified that the source of anger is interest threat, we arrive at a formula:

When an anger expression is observed, the individual subjectively believes their interests are threatened, hopes to defend those interests through confrontation and struggle, and believes victory is possible.

### 3. Differences in Mouth Shapes

In a surprise expression the upper lip is not raised; the lower lip opens naturally with the dropping jaw to allow quick, shallow inhalation. This occurs because, before surprise, the nature of the stimulus is still uncertain and no solution has been chosen. Once it is determined that the stimulus will cause overwhelming harm, the evolved human instinct immediately attempts to execute an escape plan, so the mouth opens to inhale the maximum volume of air for energy reserves. Therefore, in a fear expression the upper lip is raised, the corners of the mouth are pulled widely sideways by the platysma, and the lower lip not only opens with the dropping jaw but is also lengthened and lowered by the depressor labii inferioris, exposing part of the lower teeth. This action, performed to store respiratory energy, is of the same nature as the whole-body tension that occurs when we are afraid—trembling, skin tightening, altered blood circulation.

Finally, note that a full fear expression is usually accompanied by a deep inhalation. Observing the breathing movement that accompanies the expression is also an important indicator for judging emotion.

Finally, note one expression easily mistaken for fear.

At the instant of fear, because vigilance toward the stimulus is still maintained and the tragic outcome remains uncertain, the eyes never narrow. The reaction seen in films—tightly closed eyes and a scream of terror—actually occurs because the individual has already resigned to the worst outcome; it is a derivative of sadness. The scream serves both as an instinctive behavior to relieve inner pressure and as an evolutionarily accumulated attack method—driving the opponent away with high-frequency sound. This is shown in Figure 7-10.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-10]

#### Mini-application: Horror-movie posters

*The Wind of the Night*, Italy, 1977.

### 2. Differences in Eyelid Morphology

The eyelids in surprise open naturally to the maximum, exposing the entire upper edge of the iris and possibly even the sclera above. In fear the upper eyelids also attempt to open wide, but the opposing pull of the orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii on the eyebrows creates a fold that alters the overall eyelid shape, yet the natural degree of iris exposure remains visible.

#### Why open the eyes wide?

The original motive for opening the eyes to the maximum is to receive more visual information quickly in order to judge whether one is safe.

When we are afraid, we become highly tense and extremely sensitive to our surroundings. The entire nervous system is responding to a threat that may appear at any moment. High attention can be expressed through the wide-open state of the eyes; when the stimulus is sufficiently terrifying, the eyes open to their limit in an instant.

The wider the eyes open, the more fearful the expression appears. In this respect, **the eye features of fear are the same as those of surprise and anger**. When fear is milder—for example, worry or unease—the eyes do

not open especially wide and the sclera above the iris does not show.

Therefore, one special method for observing fear is to cover the rest of the face and look only at the eyes. Such close-ups are frequently used in horror films. In the figure below, although we cannot see whether the eyebrows are distorted, the single eye alone makes it easy to tell that this is not surprise. This is shown in Figure 7-9.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-9]*

It is clear that the left image shows fearful eyes while the right image shows ordinary surprise without fear. The eyelid-fold shape in the left image results from the special configuration of the eyebrow.

## **2. Glaring: Upper Eyelid Elevation, Exposure of Upper Iris Margin, Lower Eyelid Tension (9789620756689)**

Although the upper eyelid is closed downward by contraction of the orbicularis oculi while also meeting resistance from the downward pressure of the eyebrows, the levator palpebrae superioris still works in coordination to elevate the upper eyelid. Consequently, two opposing forces compress the skin of the upper eyelid, altering its shape and creating an overlapping fold.

Under normal conditions, the upper eyelid covers approximately one-quarter of the upper half of the iris. In an angry expression, however, the substantial elevation of the upper eyelid exposes a larger area of the upper iris margin. Although the upper eyelid crease is deformed by the overlapping fold, we can infer that, without the skin fold created by the downward pressure of the eyebrows, the upper eyelid line would cross the iris and leave the upper iris margin uncovered. While the upper eyelid is forcefully elevated, the lower eyelid is slightly raised, straightened, and tensed by contraction of the orbicularis oculi, making the glare appear more intense.

When the three factors—downward pressure of both eyebrows, tension in both upper and lower eyelids, and intense visual focus—occur simultaneously, the fire of anger erupts from the eyes.

Of course, the conditions discussed here represent the standard components of an anger expression; real expressions do not always conform exactly to every element. As shown in Figure 6-5, the shape of the eyebrows, the skin fold formed by the effortful elevation of the upper eyelid, the tensed lower eyelid, and the roaring mouth allow us to clearly determine that the woman is in an angry state, even though her eyes are not wide open and the iris is not greatly exposed.

Many factors can produce this phenomenon. For example, the image may capture a dynamic instant that is not the final state of anger, or the individual, though angry, may also feel slight fear and therefore lack a strong impulse to attack. What matters is not the size of the eyes or the degree of iris exposure, but attention to the combination of eyebrow and eyelid shapes.

## **2. Glaring: Upper Eyelid Elevation, Exposure of Upper Iris Margin, Lower Eyelid Tension (9787554606841)**

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Excerpted from *The Artist's Complete Guide to Facial Expression* by Gary Faigin.

#### 4. Interest Conflicts

One of the most common forms of anger in human society arises when others threaten one's interests.

Two competing departments in a company request budget allocations from their boss. Regardless of the methods used by the department heads or the final budget outcome, any non-constructive competitive behavior can already provoke mutual anger and hostility between the two heads. Yet is the root of their anger truly the portion of the budget the boss ultimately approves or withholds? One possibility is that the two individuals are not merely concerned with the numerical amount of money but with the competitive outcome the numbers represent.

Whoever receives the larger budget approval gains numerous derivative advantages; the decision may signify the leader's recognition, or it may imply enhanced "reputation within the field" and greater loyalty from subordinates, all of which affect future survival and development. Even if the two departments receive equal funding, or if the department that obtains more funding still feels threatened by the other's unreasonable competitive tactics, anger can arise.

Therefore, in many cases of anger triggered by perceived loss of interests, the interests themselves are merely superficial or serve as a trigger; the core issue is the future threat implied by that loss. If the loss of interests becomes an established trend—meaning the competitor believes they will always be defeated—then their mind will be filled with powerless fear or sorrow.

Numerous examples of the same nature exist: competing for people, money, or territory. Competition in romantic relationships is likewise a frequent context for anger. Driven by the pursuit of optimal reproduction, any threat to one's own ability to love another or to the loved one will generate a physiological impulse toward angry attack. Yet once true love has departed, only tears of sorrow flow, not the hot blood of anger.

##### (1) Mouth Shape Changes I: Angry Roaring and Biting

Angry roaring is also a common means of attacking an opponent and objectively requires the mouth to open. Biting serves to seize an opponent's limb and therefore differs from chewing. Chewing involves the posterior teeth, whereas biting primarily uses the anterior canines and incisors; this likewise requires the mouth to open and the teeth to be exposed, engaging the mandible (to open the mouth), the levator labii superioris, the

levator labii superioris alaeque nasi (to expose the upper teeth), and the depressor labii inferioris (to expose the lower teeth).

In addition to roaring, anger employs other mouth shapes to accompany the facial expression, conveying varying degrees of anger while also meeting the functional demands of different attack behaviors.

- **Left image:** The levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi contract together, forcefully elevating the upper lip. This human anger expression closely resembles the warning posture animals adopt before attacking. The upper-lip elevation is similar to the shape seen in disgust but is executed with greater force, because instinctive awareness demands that the upper canines (located at the corners of the mouth) be fully exposed to convey the desire to attack.
- **Center image:** When language serves as the weapon of attack during argument or reprimand, movement of the lower lip exposes the lower teeth. One can imagine how angry the entire face containing this mouth must be; the phrase “gnashing of teeth” comes immediately to mind.
- **Right image:** The lower lip is stretched by the combined action of the depressor labii inferioris, the platysma, and the mandible. The mandible descends, opening the oral cavity. The platysma contracts, pulling the corners of the mouth sideways. The depressor labii inferioris draws the lower lip into a U shape, exposing the lower teeth and gums. The orbicularis oris contracts, straightening and tightening the lips—an important action during loud vocalization.

### 6.3.3 Anger Variant II: Disgusted Anger

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 

In Figure 6-16, the most immediate association is the line “Get out!”

The subject’s upper lip is slightly raised, separating from the lower lip. The shape of the upper lip and the grooves on either side of the nose fully convey disgust. However, the eyebrow and eye configuration is not disgust but anger; the main distinctions lie in the degree of upper-eyelid elevation and the tension of the lower eyelid. The face clearly shows contraction of the corrugator supercilii, downward pressure of the eyebrows, elevation of the upper eyelid, and tension and straightening of the lower eyelid—the standard features of an angry glare.

Thus disgust has acquired an aggressive, threatening quality. The image captures the instant before a reprimand; the elevation of the upper lip may also prepare for vocalization.

Yet if the eyebrows and eyes in the figure are covered, the mouth shape alone cannot be identified as anger; it more closely matches the features of disgust, as shown in Figure 6-17.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 

This demonstrates that even when the nose and mouth clearly display disgust, the typicality of the eyebrow and eye configuration determines that the overall facial expression is anger.

When the characteristic features of two expressions appear simultaneously on one face, the stronger emotion occupies the primary expressive position. Because anger is an intensified form of disgust and therefore stronger, when both are present, anger is the dominant expression.

### (2) Mouth Shape Changes II: Mouth Open, Teeth Clenched



In the absence of emotion, humans clench their teeth in two situations: pain and physical exertion. Both triggers commonly occur during combat—both parties exert effort to win and experience pain when injured. To achieve victory and endure pain, clenching the teeth is necessary. Moreover, for animals, teeth are an offensive weapon, and biting is a primary combat action.

Keeping the jaws tightly closed through teeth clenching is not a natural or comfortable posture; when relaxed, the teeth exert no mutual pressure. Exposing part of the teeth at the same time increases the difficulty, requiring more muscles to perform complex movements. One can test this by first clenching the teeth firmly and then stretching the lips to expose the teeth, as when enduring a headache or pulling hard in a tug-of-war. Unlike roaring anger, teeth clenching combined with an angry glare usually appears during effortful anger.

In Figure 6-9 the lower halves of the two faces are very similar. Both mouth shapes are formed by contraction of the levator labii superioris, levator labii superioris alaeque nasi, and zygomaticus minor, elevating the upper lip while the lower lip is stretched. Yet the overall facial expressions differ. If only the lower half of the face is considered, it is impossible to distinguish clearly between anger and pain. The eye configuration, however, identifies the left image as intense anger; the right image, with eyes closed, shows pain without anger.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-9]*

### 3. Anxious Anger

Anyone who has raised children shares the experience of coaxing a young child to sleep—an affectionate, loving moment. Can anger arise at such a time? It certainly can; the classic scenario occurs when parents have important plans (such as a conference call) after the child has gone to bed.

If important arrangements await, yet the child continues to request another story or repeatedly refuses to settle, occasionally speaking just when the parent believes sleep has finally arrived, these originally endearing behaviors can provoke anxious anger. The internal monologue might run: “Child, it’s time for you to sleep; it’s getting late. Daddy/Mommy still has important things to do. Go to sleep quickly so I can get on with my work; if you stay awake much longer, you may disrupt my plans.”

As time presses and anxiety accumulates, anger readily appears, manifesting as irritability or even scolding. Yet if the parent truly must wait until the child sleeps before attending to other matters (for example, being the sole caregiver), once the deadline for the important task passes without the child asleep, anger dissipates and calm returns—unless the task outweighs the child’s distress in importance.

As an aside, this also explains why particularly busy parents are more likely to raise rebellious children: the child concludes that they matter less to the parents than earning money or attending meetings. “Since I am unimportant,” the child reasons, “you might as well stop supervising me.”

### 6. Unreasonableness

“It’s unreasonable!” represents another stimulus that provokes anger and another way of expressing it. Whether among collaborators on a shared front, rivals in competition, or strangers encountered while driving, unreasonable behavior can trigger intense anger.

Unreasonableness is, in effect, “inconsistent with the reasoning the individual accepts,” producing a mismatch with expectations. During a team discussion of solutions, after the leader has outlined a directional approach and members are anxiously refining it into an executable plan, someone who airily proposes an impractical

idea may provoke anger (or possibly contempt). What results does unreasonableness produce? The individual believes that following their own expectations and logic will yield the best outcome—or, if the focus is on enjoying the process rather than the result, that this approach maximizes enjoyment. When others act “unreasonably” in the relevant process, the individual perceives a threat to the anticipated outcome (or process). The essence of obstructed action is obstructed freedom, identical in nature to the restraint an infant experiences when prevented from moving freely; combined with possible threats to interests, this naturally elicits anger.

Similar to unreasonableness is the frustration caused by non-human or unclear factors during an activity. Apart from the absence of a clearly identifiable “unreasonable” person, all other aspects parallel unreasonableness and likewise provoke anger.

### 6.2.1 Morphological Features of the Anger Expression

As shown in Figure 6-1, the fullest anger expression includes five typical features:

1. Both eyebrows lowered and tightly knit;
2. Upper eyelid elevated, lower eyelid tensed, orbicularis oculi strongly contracted—commonly called a glare;
3. Mouth forcefully opened, upper lip stretched tight, teeth exposed as weapons of attack;
4. Chin lowered. This is important: genuine attack behavior does not involve a raised head or chin;
5. Nostrils flared, not only exposing the upper teeth in a threatening posture but also widening the nasal passages to maintain an unobstructed exhalation route.

Using the cues in Figure 6-2, the facial-muscle morphology of the anger expression can be analyzed as follows:

1. Strong contraction of the orbicularis oculi lowers both eyebrows; strong contraction of the corrugator supercilii knits the brows;
2. Strong contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris raises the upper eyelid to its maximum, attempting to expose the entire upper iris margin. However, the elevation of the upper eyelid combined with the downward pressure of the eyebrows produces a mutually compressing angry configuration, forming diagonal skin folds on the upper eyelid;
3. Lower eyelid tensed. The configuration of the upper eyelid together with the tensed lower eyelid is termed a glare;
4. Coordinated contraction of the levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi elevates the nostrils while also raising the cheeks, creating deep grooves on either side of the nose;
5. Mandible opens downward; the lower lip is pulled down by the depressor labii inferioris, exposing part of the lower teeth, and is stretched sideways and thinned by contraction of the platysma, lying tightly against the mandible.

### 6.3.4 Anger Variant III: Relaxed Lower Face

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-18]*

Examining only the lower half of the face in Figure 6-18—the area around the nose and mouth—makes it impossible to determine the subject’s expression or emotion. Because the upper lip shows no obvious elevation, the nostrils are not raised and no grooves are formed by compression between the nostrils and cheeks (the shading beside the nostrils results from crossed lighting during photography). Compared with an

ordinary open-mouth posture, the main difference in the mouth shape is that the upper lip appears narrower and the orbicularis oris is only partially contracted. The mouth does not look particularly angry; if the upper half of the face were covered, the subject would appear to be speaking.

The actual situation is readily understandable. Once roaring subsides, the mouth relaxes, yet because the stimulus for anger remains unresolved, the eyes continue to express anger intensely. Overall, the facial expression still conveys a high degree of anger, produced entirely by the configuration of the eyes and eyebrows.

Thus, during anger the mouth does not always remain tense, nor does the upper lip necessarily elevate; even when the nose and mouth are relaxed, anger can still be expressed through a specific micro-expression configuration. That micro-expression configuration is the standard angry eyebrow-and-eye morphology.

### (3) Damage to Reputation

Reputation is unique to human society; although animals may possess something analogous, this cannot be verified. Because of language and the complexity of evaluative systems, reputation functions like the scent-marking of territorial boundaries in animals, carrying a wealth of information about the individual. The communicative and consensual power of reputation far exceeds that of urine marks. Word-of-mouth transmission in human society imperceptibly creates a consensus force that shapes individual perception. Establishing and enhancing reputation strengthens and consolidates one's own survival; this is also why celebrities enjoy higher income returns. Damage to reputation, conversely, can cause substantial loss to the individual in society and may even threaten continued survival.

Consequently, once reputation has been established, the individual will strive to perfect and defend this existing "territorial" marker, using reputation to build a platform for survival and reproduction while reducing costs. When reputation is attacked or threatened, the effect is equivalent to an incursion across a scent-marked boundary, endangering the individual's survival and reproduction and readily arousing anger.

Those interested may search the internet for the number of celebrities who have responded to reputational attacks with angry lawsuits or public confrontations with their detractors. This book will not cite specific real-world cases of celebrities as supporting data.

### 3. Nose and Cheek Morphology

Anger expressions engage the levator labii superioris and the levator labii superioris alaeque nasi. Although the direct action of these two muscles is to raise the upper lip, they also indirectly affect nose shape: the alae are lifted, the nostrils flare, and deep grooves form on either side of the alae. At the same time, the cheeks are indirectly affected and rise slightly.

In the opening scene of Season 1, Episode 1 of the American series *Lie to Me*, the tall, bald suspect displays a classic anger expression (eyebrows + nose forming an X shape) after hearing Lightman name the actual hiding place of the bomb. Lightman immediately realizes the bomb is hidden exactly where he had just asked about. The script, however, labels the expression "scorn" (accurately translated as "contempt"). This is one of the more obvious errors in *Lie to Me*. The raised upper lip and grooves beside the nose alone would indicate contempt, yet the eyebrow and eye configuration of the upper face cannot be ignored.

If you are interested in the techniques depicted in this American drama, follow the WeChat public account weifanyingtm or my Sina Weibo @微反应—姜振宇 (Micro-reaction—Jiang Zhenyu) and check the *Anatomy of*

*LIE TO ME* series for detailed analyses.

### Chapter Summary

Anger is an aggressive emotion that arises when a person feels threatened or senses that their interests are about to be harmed. When angry, there is an impulse to act physically; in modern society this impulse may be channeled into debate, scolding, criticism, or other civilized forms. Regardless of the form, the essence of anger remains the same: the person believes they must interfere with or counter the stimulus through attack or retaliation. Failure to interfere risks harm; interference may change the threatened situation. The stimulus is usually assessed by the angry person as an equal opponent. Consequently, anger expressions share several consistent features: furrowed brows signal intense focus; the eyelids are raised forcefully to observe every movement of the stimulus; the opposing actions of the brows pressing down and the eyelids lifting create ridges on the upper eyelid skin. Another prominent feature is prolonged, steady gaze fixed on the stimulus—an exaggerated display of attention to an opponent—accompanied by bodily changes such as accelerated circulation, heavier breathing, muscle tension, and ample energy reserves, all preparing for imminent attack.

### 2. Restriction of Freedom

Restriction of freedom poses one of the greatest threats to survival. Without freedom of movement, a person feels surrounded like prey with no escape and certain death. In the instinctive awareness accumulated through human evolution, restriction of freedom therefore registers as an extremely serious threat.

When adults play with children, they sometimes affectionately pin a child to their chest and gently restrain the arms and legs. Can you guess the child's reaction?

The child's face suddenly changes to anger, the body flushes bright red, breath is held, and the child struggles to break free—an unmistakable anger response. The restraint is not forceful enough to hurt, and the play atmosphere was pleasant until that moment; the change occurs solely because of the restraining action.

The child's subjective expectation is free movement. Any behavior that limits a child's ability to act creates a negative expectation violation. Even during play, sudden inability to move freely triggers instinctive discomfort and anger. After a brief, futile effort to change the situation, the child opens the mouth wide and cries loudly, expressing grievance (unwillingness coupled with inability to change) and bewilderment—this is the sadness emotion.

### Chapter Summary

Anger is an aggressive emotion that arises when a person feels threatened or senses that their interests are about to be harmed. When angry, there is an impulse to act physically; in modern society this impulse may be channeled into debate, scolding, criticism, or other civilized forms. Regardless of the form, the essence of anger remains the same: the person believes they must interfere with or counter the stimulus through attack or retaliation. Failure to interfere risks harm; interference may change the threatened situation. The stimulus is usually assessed by the angry person as an equal opponent. Consequently, anger expressions share several consistent features: furrowed brows signal intense focus; the eyelids are raised forcefully to observe every movement of the stimulus; the opposing actions of the brows pressing down and the eyelids lifting create ridges on the upper eyelid skin. Another prominent feature is prolonged, steady gaze fixed on the stimulus—an exaggerated display of attention to an opponent—accompanied by bodily changes such as accelerated circulation, heavier breathing, muscle tension, and ample energy reserves, all preparing for imminent attack.

### 6.3.1 Muscles That Tense the Lips

In the anger expression with tightly closed lips, mouth shape is determined directly by three muscles: the orbicularis oris, the depressor anguli oris, and the mentalis (see Figure 6-10). All three contract to press the lips together.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-10]*

The levator labii superioris and depressor labii inferioris open the lips and do not participate in closing them.

The pout that expresses denial (reluctance, difficulty, pathos) results from contraction of the mentalis and depressor anguli oris while the orbicularis oris remains relaxed. When the orbicularis oris also contracts, lip closure becomes firmer; mild contraction signals displeasure, while stronger contraction intensifies the denial into suppressed anger, indicating that hesitation has given way to the need for greater force to restrain the impulse to attack (see Figure 6-11).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-11]*

#### 1. Lowering of Both Eyebrows

Lowering of both eyebrows is a prominent feature of anger expressions and appears in the great majority of them. Darwin observed that brow lowering signals the encounter of trouble. He speculated that in primitive times the movement reduced glare when staring at a difficulty and later became a habitual response to any difficulty. Indeed, lowered brows frequently appear in expressions of disgust, confusion (commonly seen while lecturing students, disappearing once the point is clarified), difficulty, deep thought, and even physical exertion—all forms of trouble. Because “trouble” emphasizes the object, Darwin’s conclusion is updated from the subject’s perspective:

#### **Lowered brows indicate serious attention.**

Lowered brows alone do not confirm anger; the eyes must also be engaged in forceful looking. Forceful looking includes tension and contraction of the orbicularis oculi, producing characteristic changes in both upper and lower eyelids, as well as sustained, unwavering gaze. When lowered brows combine with a fixed stare, the result is a glare—the key morphological feature of anger expressions.

#### **(1) Contempt**

A common verbal expression of negation is “You’re no good!” Depending on tone, it can convey a wide range of meanings. Such contempt need not involve any threatening action; a single sentence or glance may suffice. No one likes to be negated by others, especially when the negation takes the form of contempt (which amplifies the effect) or lacks factual basis (slander), both of which readily provoke anger.

When animals are regarded as inferior by their own kind, they lose authority and control, placing their safety at great risk of predation, defeat, loss of mates or offspring, or death. In today’s highly developed civilization and division of labor, negation of a skill likewise threatens competitiveness and survival opportunities. This is one of the most direct triggers of anger.

Even cultivated scholars will often defend their reputation when their professional expertise is arbitrarily slandered or belittled. Countless examples appear online where opinion leaders launch verbal and written attacks over minor differences of view.

## 1. Differences in Brow Shape

In surprise the brows are simply raised (frontalis contraction), preserving a natural shape. In fear the brows are knitted as a whole, the inner corners rise, the brows appear twisted, and clear vertical and horizontal furrows form.

At the instant of surprise, no positive or negative judgment has yet been formed about the stimulus; the next emotion could be delight, startled anger, or fear. Fear, however, necessarily arises because the stimulus is perceived as extremely dangerous and therefore requires concentrated attention. Consequently, the action of raising the brows (frontalis, medial fibers) is involuntarily accompanied by contraction of the corrugator supercilii, knitting and lowering the brows. Remember: **furrowed brows indicate intense attention**.

Fear therefore produces a more complex brow-eye configuration than surprise. The brows must knit inward to signal tension and pressure while also rising to help the eyes gather more visual information. As a result, the fear brow shape is less expansive than the surprise brow shape.

**Self-practice method:** First raise both brows as high as possible, then knit and lower them.

## (2) Provocation

Provocation usually precedes open conflict. The provoking party expresses a desire to fight and hopes the target will respond in kind, deliberately arousing the target's anger by attacking whatever matters most to them. Provocation is the behavior most likely to elicit anger. Its forms vary according to the target's personality and concerns, but generally fall into two types: "Let's fight and see" and "You're worthless; I can't be bothered to fight you—if we did, I'd finish you easily." The second type usually provokes stronger anger because the first is often delivered seriously by someone of genuine capability, allowing the target to respond rationally and consider non-combat solutions unless bystander opinion interferes. The second type deliberately conveys a low evaluation and uses disdain to intensify the expectation violation, making the target eager to disprove the assessment and punish the provocateur. Because the evaluation is so low, correction seems easy—yet this is precisely the psychological trap.

## Chapter 6 Micro-expressions of Anger

When the intensity of a negative stimulus exceeds the threshold of disgust and becomes threatening, anger is triggered. Anger is characterized by an attack tendency aimed at driving away or eliminating the negative stimulus.

The essence of disgust is a "top-down negation" attitude toward the negative stimulus—an attempt to reject, avoid, or simply ignore it. At no level of disgust does the person desire to alter, attack, or eliminate the stimulus; walking away is always an option. Once the stimulus intensifies to the point of threat or harm, the emotion escalates to anger.

The essence of anger is the desire to attack and prevail—eliminating danger through attack.

Events that provoke anger are richly varied in daily life, ranging from a taxi driver ignoring a hail on the street to a violent assault on oneself or one's child. Readers should therefore prepare to examine the sources of anger systematically.

### 6.3 Morphological Features of Anger Micro-expressions

Although a hysterical outburst and a cold stare appear vastly different, both can instill fear under certain conditions. This is because every anger expression shares one common feature: an attack tendency. Roaring attack, bared-teeth threat, tightly closed lips conveying severity, and piercing gaze all belong to different manifestations of anger.

Beginning with the fullest anger expression and working downward, the analysis focuses not on degree of emotion but on its morphological variations. Because anger is a dangerous, attack-oriented emotion and combat demands speed, expressions change dramatically within a short time; cold disgust can turn to fury in an instant.

Following common real-life anger expressions, the analysis proceeds from the lower face upward, examining changes in the mouth, nose, eyes, and brows to provide a comprehensive, systematic grasp of anger micro-expression and classic expression features.

### **Mouth**

Mouth shape is the most variable element in anger expressions. In roaring anger the mouth shape is influenced by the words being spoken. The upper lip is usually raised; the lower lip varies. It may form a biting, teeth-bared shape, be pressed together and protruded by the mentalis and orbicularis oris, or remain in its usual relaxed state. With equal eyelid elevation, a person with an open, roaring mouth appears angrier than one with a closed mouth (see Figure 6-27).

In modern social interaction, fully displayed, unambiguous anger expressions are rare. Noticing the momentary eye-widening change can reveal the person's inner emotion.

Anger without focused gaze is a staged performance.

Without concentrated gaze, lowered brows and pressed lips alone cannot effectively convey anger; the expression more closely resembles a response to pressure and is commonly seen when someone is reluctantly deciding or deep in thought (see Figure 6-27).

### **(4) Negation of One's Group**

Telling a capable university student "Your school is terrible!"—if the student rejects the evaluation—can provoke anger because the group to which the student belongs has been negated. The same applies to negation of a team, ethnicity, or nation. Although the negative evaluation targets an organization or group, or even other members of that group, a sense of belonging readily converts it into individual anger, sometimes of greater intensity.

Chinese people's anger provides a typical example. For more than a century since the late Qing dynasty, China suffered invasion and humiliation by foreign powers; Japan's eight-year invasion beginning in 1937 left later generations with enduring anger toward the former aggressor. People can reach a state of gnashing anger without needing further historical details.

### **Explanation of Option B**

The language in option B can also occur in real situations, but the speaker's inner state differs significantly. Loss is the source of sadness. If nothing else intervenes, a daughter's death would produce only sadness,

leaving no energy for other concerns. “She’s already dead” might appear during frantic struggle, yet more often it surfaces in a state of sadness (true sadness is rarely voiced) as a reinforcement of loss.

The unexpected, deliberate harm that caused the death adds a considerable degree of anger to the sadness. The repetition of “She’s already dead,” however, is not a direct expression of anger but of sadness. The speaker uses this sorrowful outcome to intensify the expectation violation (healthy life versus violent death) and thereby strengthen the anger that mobilizes energy for combat.

### 1. Full Anger Expression Morphology

The morphological features of a full anger expression are as follows:

- Strong contraction of the orbicularis oculi lowers both brows; strong contraction of the corrugator supercilii knits the brows tightly.
- Strong contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris raises the upper eyelids to their maximum, attempting to expose the entire superior margin of the iris. The opposing actions of upper-eyelid elevation and brow depression create the characteristic anger configuration, forming diagonal skin folds on the upper eyelid.
- The lower eyelid tenses; the shape of the upper eyelid matches the tensed lower eyelid, producing a glare.
- Simultaneous contraction of the levator labii superioris and levator labii superioris alaeque nasi lifts the nasal alae, raises the cheeks, and creates deep grooves on either side of the nose.
- The mandible opens downward; the lower lip is pulled down by the depressor labii inferioris, exposing part of the lower teeth. Contraction of the platysma stretches the lower lip sideways and thins it, pressing it tightly against the mandible.

### 2. Common Anger Expression Morphology

In everyday social interaction, ordinary people—except with close family or during actual combat—rarely open their mouths to roar even when angry. More often the lips are pressed tightly together while breath is held. Combined with the standard anger brow-eye configuration, the face appears extremely angry.

Morphological features:

- Contraction of the corrugator supercilii and orbicularis oculi knits and lowers both brows.
- Contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris.
- Contraction of the orbicularis oculi also tenses the lower eyelid and pulls it slightly sideways.
- Contraction of the orbicularis oris presses both lips tightly together.
- Contraction of the depressor anguli oris pulls both mouth corners downward.
- Contraction of the mentalis creates a muscular bulge on the chin with an uneven surface while pushing the lower lip upward to keep the lips closed.

### 6.2 Full Anger Expression

Anger is a response to a threatening stimulus, mobilizing energy to attack, drive away, injure, or eliminate the opponent. Once a negative stimulus crosses the nervous system’s red line, anger suddenly replaces disgust. Because anger directly leads to attack—whether through verbal scolding or physical action—its roots trace



back to ancient combat. These attacks require rapid expenditure of large amounts of energy, so genuine anger is difficult to sustain for long periods.

Other emotions lack such close coordination with physical action and, even at extreme intensity, do not carry an attack tendency.

### 1. Morphological Features of Angry Micro-expressions

One thing you might not easily think of is that for an externalized emotion like anger, the core determining factor of the expression is actually a very small detail—the shape of the eyelids and the gaze. The intensity of the anger emotion has an instinctive direct correlation with the degree of upper eyelid lift and the tension in the lower eyelid; the higher the upper eyelid is lifted and the tighter the lower eyelid is tensed, the angrier the expression appears.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-25]*

#### Eyelids

An angry expression must include lifting of the upper eyelids (causing more of the top of the iris to be exposed than in a normal state) and tightening of the lower eyelids (position slightly raised, eyelid line straightened). The wider the eyes are opened, the deeper the anger. Eyes glaring in coordination with lowered brows give the gaze strong penetrating power.

When the shapes of the brows and eyes are combined with the mouth shape of anger, the presence of anger can be clearly expressed.

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#### Summary

In summary, the higher the level of civilization in human society, the more complex the various consensual rules become, and the more diverse and complicated the stimuli that can trigger anger become; in the analysis of specific issues, analysis must be conducted according to the specific situation and the individuals involved.

Overall, however, the stimuli for anger can be attributed to threats to matters of concern and can be traced back to threats to survival and reproduction in primitive times.

### 3. Morphological Features of Angry Micro-expressions

In cases of extreme restraint, an angry expression usually retains only changes in the eyelids.

Morphological features:

- Contraction of the levator palpebrae superioris muscle, attempting to raise the upper eyelids (often meeting resistance from the brows being furrowed and pressed downward);
- Contraction of the orbicularis oculi muscle, tightening the lower eyelids and pressing them closer to the skull.

**Summary:** The characteristic of anger is an aggressive tendency, an attempt to drive away or eliminate the negative stimulus source.

## 5. Being Denied

Denial is a general term for a category of stimuli; as analyzed in the chapter on disgust, the essence of loathing, contempt, and disdain is all denial, so in terms of specific manifestations, it can be subdivided into direct denial, belittlement (contempt and disdain), disgust, and various manifestations based on belittlement such as provocation and disrespect.

## 2. Typical Features of Angry Expressions

The typical features of an angry expression are brows pressed downward, closest to the upper eyelid edges; eyes staring forcefully, upper eyelids lifted, lower eyelids tensed, gaze strongly focused on the stimulus source without leaving it; the mouth shape of anger is more variable, commonly including bared teeth, roaring, or tightly closed lips. As shown in Figure 6-26.

## 4. Mouth Shape

In addition to the typical angry brow and eye shapes, a full angry expression also has several variations, mainly caused by different mouth shapes. The most fearsome angry expression is anger with the mouth open and shouting, which is a sign of emotional loss of control; with a bit more rationality, it turns into clenched teeth.

## Summary

Therefore, the necessary features of an angry expression are tension in both the upper and lower eyelids plus strong concentration of gaze. If this necessary feature is missing, it can be determined that there is no anger emotion. This set of eye-shape features constitutes the morphological features of angry micro-expressions.

## Eyebrows

Lowered brows indicate strong attention. Because stimuli capable of triggering anger possess threat-level intensity and are absolutely worth attending to, the typical lowered-brow shape appears in natural expressions.

### 11.2.3 Anger

When the intensity of a negative stimulus escalates beyond the limit of the disgust emotion, it triggers the anger emotion.

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

See Workplace and professional contexts (c-workplace).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

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See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

## Morphological Features of Sad Micro-expressions

### 8.2.2 Adult Crying Expressions (9789620756689)

When adults cry due to sadness, the facial morphology is identical to that of infants. Sadness mobilizes energy that spontaneously triggers vigorous movement in the eye and mouth muscles to produce the crying expression, as shown in Figure 8-2.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-2]

The morphological features of adult crying can be broken down as follows:

1. The orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii contract together, depressing the brows and creating vertical wrinkles between them. At the same time, the central frontalis contracts, slightly elevating the brows so that the overall brow shape flattens and twists upward in the medial third. Note that this twisted brow shape also appears in fear expressions, but the contraction of the orbicularis oculi in sadness produces a more pronounced twist than in fear.
2. Contraction of the orbicularis oculi forces the eyelids tightly shut, creating wrinkles at the inner eye corners and crow's-feet at the outer corners (a single deep line is visible in the figure). The combined action of the orbicularis oculi and part of the corrugator supercilii produces tightly closed eyes. The physiological significance of this change was explained in the discussion of infant crying. The more intense the crying, the tighter the contraction around the eyeballs.
3. Contraction of the levator labii superioris raises the upper lip while, together with the orbicularis oculi, elevating the cheeks. The raised cheeks press against the lower eyelids, forming a depressed area beneath the lower lids and nasolabial folds on either side of the nose.
4. Contraction of the platysma pulls the mouth corners laterally, increasing the horizontal width of the mouth beyond its resting state; the stretched corners press against the cheeks to form marionette lines.
5. Contraction of the depressor anguli oris pulls the mouth corners downward while the depressor labii inferioris contracts, lowering the entire lower lip in an attempt to expose the lower teeth.
6. Simultaneous contraction of the mentalis pushes the middle of the lower lip upward, creating an uneven muscular bulge on the chin. This upward push conceals part of the lower teeth that would otherwise be visible, while the corners remain lowered, exposing the lower teeth only at the mouth corners. The lower lip forms a W-shaped curve. This mouth shape is unique to the crying expression, as shown in Figure 8-3.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-3]

Note that the synergistic action of these muscles creates a sharp angle of inflection roughly one-quarter of the way from each mouth corner toward the center of the lower lip, giving the mouth an overall trapezoidal appearance. This shape is optimal for producing a sharp, well-supported sound. To verify, shout "wa" without any feeling of grief and observe whether the mouth shape closely resembles the crying shape.

The crying mouth is wider (horizontally) than the relaxed mouth because of platysma stretch. The trapezoidal lip shape results from elevation of the upper lip and lateral pull on the lower lip. The lip borders become taut and thin. Elevation of the upper lip also raises the cheeks; in addition to the nasolabial folds, the action of the depressor anguli oris beneath the mouth corners produces a vertical crease running from nose to chin, as shown in Figure 8-4.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-4]*

Given the complexity of the crying action, it is difficult to fake. In genuine sobbing, the lower lip forms a W shape through the coordinated action of the platysma, depressor labii inferioris, depressor anguli oris, and mentalis. A simulated cry rarely achieves this complex muscular pattern and therefore cannot reproduce the undulating contour; nor can the degree of eye closure be accurately imitated unless genuine sadness is aroused. In reality, the emotion supplies substantial energy to execute the normal crying movements, producing both the correct amplitude and force of the facial actions and their natural coordination—an internal consistency that is hard to counterfeit.

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4. Contraction of the platysma pulls the mouth corners laterally, increasing the horizontal width of the mouth beyond its resting state; the stretched corners press against the cheeks to form marionette lines.
5. Contraction of the depressor anguli oris pulls the mouth corners downward while the depressor labii inferioris contracts, lowering the entire lower lip in an attempt to expose the lower teeth.
6. Simultaneous contraction of the mentalis pushes the middle of the lower lip upward, creating an uneven muscular bulge on the chin. This upward push conceals part of the lower teeth that would otherwise be visible, while the corners remain lowered, exposing the lower teeth only at the mouth corners. The lower lip forms a W-shaped curve. This mouth shape is unique to the crying expression, as shown in Figure 8-3.

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[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-4]

## Chapter Summary

The emotions discussed in previous chapters—surprise, disgust, anger, and fear—share the common characteristic that they are all based on the emotion holder’s subjective appraisal rather than on an established outcome. Sadness differs fundamentally from these four emotions because it is based on an established outcome—loss of benefit—even when that outcome is merely the emotion holder’s misappraisal.

The stimulus for sadness is “an irrevocable loss.” Only after the emotion holder appraises the situation and concludes that the loss has already occurred (including intangible losses such as reputation, status, or public esteem) does sadness arise. A second characteristic of sadness is that it is separated from fear by only a thin boundary; the two are essentially the same in that both involve a highly negative appraisal of the stimulus, with the stimulus perceived as exceeding one’s defensive capacity. The sole difference is whether the negative outcome has already taken place. Before it occurs, the emotion is fear; once it is confirmed, the emotion is sadness.

Consequently, their facial morphologies are nearly identical: both display the furrowed-and-raised “⏏”-shaped brows. In fear, however, the eyelids remain raised to gather information and make judgments, whereas in sadness the outcome has already occurred, so the eyelids close. The mouth shapes of fear and sadness also share features: both recruit the depressor anguli oris, mentalis, and platysma. Contraction of the depressor anguli oris pulls the mouth corners downward; contraction of the mentalis bulges the chin and pushes the middle of the lower lip upward; contraction of the platysma stretches the mouth corners laterally and downward, forming a trapezoid that is wider at the top and narrower at the bottom. In fear this shape often signals being stunned; in sadness it commonly appears during sobbing. It should be noted that fear’s emotional instability and transformability prevent the mouth shape from being as classic and stable as in sadness; screaming, breath-holding, or other needs frequently disrupt it. In sadness, by contrast, the negative fact is already established, so fewer interfering factors exist and a relatively stable mouth morphology appears.

### 1. Morphological Features of Sad Micro-expressions

The brows are raised while the overall brow remains depressed—a necessary feature of the sadness expression, as shown in Figure 8-19.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-19]

## 2. Typical Morphological Features of Sadness

During weeping the brows are depressed overall (due to orbicularis oculi contraction). Although the eyes are usually tightly closed, social context makes wide-mouthed crying rare. The typical action is mouth closure: the taut lips experience upward pressure from below (mentalis) and lateral stretch (platysma). Crying itself is a spasmodic movement.

As crying intensity decreases, the first muscles to relax are those around the eyes—the orbicularis oculi. After the orbicularis oculi relaxes, the medial frontalis contracts, raising the brows and producing forehead wrinkles; together with the corrugator supercilii this produces a slightly twisted brow shape.

Next to relax is the platysma. Platysma contraction gives the mouth the appearance of being about to cry. Once sufficiently calm, the platysma relaxes and the mouth returns to its normal state.

## 3. Derived Sad Micro-expressions

When the elicited emotion belongs to other sadness-derived categories such as guilt, displeasure, bitterness, or reluctance, the typical morphology may be the “bitter pursed lips” of the mouth. This “bitter pursed lips” shape, produced by the coordinated action of the platysma, mentalis, depressor anguli oris, and depressor labii inferioris, is a clear feature of derived sadness expressions.

### 8.2.1 Infant Crying Expressions

When very young children encounter negative stimuli (hunger, pain, fear, etc.), their instinctive response is to cry loudly, thereby attracting adult attention and protection. In infant crying, loudness is crucial; if the sound is insufficient, parents may overlook it.

Infant crying expressions are difficult to capture photographically, so a sketch is used to illustrate the morphological features, as shown in Figure 8-1.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-1]

Reproduced from *The Artist's Complete Guide to Facial Expression* by Gary Faigin.

The morphological features of infant crying are as follows:

1. Contraction of the corrugator supercilii produces a strong furrowing of the brows.
2. Strong contraction of the orbicularis oculi tightly closes the upper and lower eyelids; the lids press against each other, creating wrinkles between the eyes.
3. Contraction of the levator labii superioris tenses the upper lip and raises the cheeks, forming nasolabial folds from the wings of the nose to the mouth corners.
4. The mouth corners are pulled laterally, stretching and thinning the lips.
5. Simultaneous contraction of the depressor anguli oris and depressor labii inferioris lowers the lower lip, producing an almost vertical drop near the mouth corners that approximates a square shape and exposes part of the lower teeth. This mouth shape facilitates vocalization.
6. Contraction of the mentalis pushes the middle of the lower lip upward, covering the central teeth.

The pure crying expression in the figure is organized around the need to produce sound; each organ's shape serves a physiological purpose.

### 1. Tightly Closed Eyes

During crying the eyes are always tightly shut. The orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii contract together,

closing the eyes and depressing the brows. This innate linkage has a structural basis: the vigorous exhalation and circulatory changes during crying increase capillary pressure inside the orbit and intraocular pressure, objectively requiring orbicularis oculi contraction to tighten the periorbital skin and thereby relieve some pressure and protect the eyeball. The more intense the crying, the stronger the muscular contraction. The same muscular action occurs naturally in laughter, sneezing, and coughing, all of which also involve tightly closed eyes.

## 2. Stretched Mouth

During crying the levator labii superioris contracts, raising the upper lip and elevating the cheeks, forming nasolabial folds on either side of the nose. Platysma contraction stretches the mouth corners laterally, widening the mouth. Depressor labii inferioris contraction lowers the lower lip. Mentalis contraction arches the chin muscles and pushes the middle of the lower lip upward. These four muscles together open the lips into an approximately square contour. Orbicularis oculi contraction also elevates the cheeks to some extent, reinforcing the cheek bulge and assisting the upper-lip elevation produced by the levator labii superioris.

This mouth shape is better suited than others for producing a penetrating sound that travels farthest and reaches maximum volume.

In addition, an interesting phenomenon occurs: during crying, breathing is not steady but spasmodic. Coordinating with this respiratory pattern, the mentalis and platysma jointly control frequent changes in mouth shape, producing spasmodic movement of the jaw and lower lip. When both muscles contract, the middle of the lower lip puckers and the corners are pulled straight; when both relax, the lower lip and corners relax. This is the first time the role of the mentalis has been emphasized, because the mentalis has an important function only in sadness expressions.

### 8.3.1 Suppressing Crying with a Closed Mouth

In the crying expression, tightly closed eyes are a critical element, while the mouth may be open or closed but is always stretched. Whether the mouth is open or closed depends on the degree of distress and the degree of self-suppression. The stronger the closing action, the more intense the crying and the greater the suppression. Compared with standard crying, the most obvious difference besides the mouth is further contraction of the frontalis, which pulls the brows upward; corrugator supercilii contraction draws the brows together medially; and orbicularis oculi contraction depresses the brows and tightly closes the eyes, as shown in Figure 8-5.

No one can cry with eyes wide open; even excellent actors can only manage to shed silent tears with eyes open. Once breathing intensifies, tight eye closure inevitably accompanies the action.

The main difference between the crying shown in Figure 8-5 and full crying lies in mouth suppression. Closing the mouth during crying is intended to suppress vocalization and greatly reduce volume. An objective result is also to suppress energy expenditure, prolonging the sadness.

As shown in Figure 8-6, when the mouth is open during crying the upper lip is raised by the levator labii superioris. When the mouth is closed during crying, a subtle change occurs: the zygomaticus minor (1) takes over lip elevation with much gentler force, sharply reducing upper-lip lift; the platysma acts noticeably on the mouth corners, stretching the lips laterally (2); the groove lateral to the mouth corner is formed by the depressor anguli oris (3), but its downward pull is weaker than the lateral pull of the platysma; the mentalis raises the chin into a spherical, uneven bulge while pushing the lower lip upward into the closed position (4).

Because of resistance from the upper lip, the lower lip remains largely straight and does not arch upward (as it can when the mouth is wide open during full crying), so part of the lower lip protrudes outward.

In suppressed sadness the emotion demands an open mouth to produce crying, yet conscious will requires the lips to remain tightly closed to stay silent. The result is highly tense lips with an inward pressure opposing the upward and outward forces. This state of equilibrium in the mouth continually switches, producing slight trembling.

#### **Test Case: The False Promoter**

We tested the case of the head of a commercial training school. This person promoted on some internet forums that his training content was the most professional and authentic, because he had once made a special trip abroad to study for a year under management guru Professor XX, and therefore had the most authority to speak on this training system. With such promotion, his training school indeed gained strong commercial benefits and reputation locally.

In fact, he is a very hardworking and intelligent person. To expand his business, he made this public claim to secure a higher starting point. Unfortunately, the doubts were numerous. After we asked two key questions, he knew defense was hopeless, froze for a moment, and his face showed sadness.

**Question:** In your promotional copy, you stated that you once went abroad to study with Professor XX for a full year. In which year did this occur?

**Answer:** 2005–2006.

**Question:** Was it continuous study for one year?

**Answer:** Yes, I only returned home once, for a vacation.

**Question:** Do you know what type of visa one should apply for in country X if one wishes to stay for a year?

**Answer:** ...This...

【Expression: Eyebrows lowered and inner brows raised, eyelids widened, gaze flickering, showing an alert state—typical fear expression.】

**Question:** Did you actually apply for a visa and reside in country X for a year to study with Professor XX?

**Answer:** No. I only visited the university where he works during a trip to country X and met him once.

【Expression: Eyebrows relaxed but inner brows remained furrowed and raised, eyelids returned to normal, lips pursed—mild sadness expression.】

**Question:** Your promotional copy also mentioned that you would invite two renowned masters, A and B, from the club organized by Professor XX to lecture at your school. Do you know their appearance fees?

**Answer:** ...

In the end, when he realized he could not fabricate credible details, he bowed his head and admitted the false promotion, displaying a mild sadness expression: eyebrows slightly raised, gaze dimmed, mouth showing the “bitter pursed-lip” form.

### **3. Sad Mouth Morphology (9787554606841)**

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-10]



Whether in loud sobbing or silent, slightly restrained grief, the sad mouth appears due to the action of the mentalis muscle. In the sad mouth morphology, the upper lip changes shape under the action of the zygomaticus minor (or levator labii superioris). Many sad faces also involve the mentalis and depressor anguli oris. The corners of the mouth still tend to pull sideways and stretch, yet the amplitude of change is minimal. In crying or near-crying faces, the platysma contracts. The platysma engages during intense sadness; as sadness lessens, the action weakens and then disappears. See Figure 8-10.

This mouth morphology is a typical feature of sadness expressions and appears across many degrees of sadness. Moreover, careful observation shows that the same mouth morphology occurs when swallowing very bitter medicine, so it can also be called the “bitter pursed-lip” form.

When the bitter pursed-lip appears alone without other morphological features, it can indicate mild emotions in the sadness category such as shame, reluctance, difficulty, or hardship.

We often see this typical chin morphology at formal award ceremonies. After lengthy leadership speeches, when outstanding employees are recognized one by one and their arduous achievements recounted, the honoree’s face frequently shows the mentalis contraction forming the “bitter pursed-lip.” This morphology usually appears together with a smile, signaling the person’s inner restraint of the smile and a reminder not to become overly proud or high-profile. Yet for those who have truly invested effort and cost, the “bitter pursed-lip” also serves as a self-assessment of the past—how difficult it was! See Figure 8-11.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-11]*

### 3. Sad Mouth Morphology (9789620756689)

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In the end, when he realized he could not fabricate credible details, he bowed his head and admitted the false promotion, displaying a mild sadness expression: eyebrows slightly raised, gaze dimmed, mouth showing the “bitter pursed-lip” form.

### 8.3.5 Derived Micro-expressions of Sadness

The essence of sadness is helplessness toward an (unwanted) outcome. Many emotional derivatives fit this mindset.

- **Shame:** Self-blame or regret for a negative outcome one has caused, after the outcome has occurred.
- **Displeasure:** Non-acceptance, non-approval, or dislike of the stimulus source, yet without feelings of rejection or distancing, thus differing from disgust (whose essence is also negation).
- **Bitterness:** A subjective evaluation of past facts; the matter has ended, yet a helpless sorrow wells up.
- **Reluctant or difficult decisions:** After a hard choice (during which fear-type emotions and expressions appear; see Chapter 7), the decision means losing some benefit (no alternative), so a sadness-type emotional response also occurs. See Figure 8-16.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-16]

The classic mouth morphology can express the above sadness-category derivatives. When the brow and eye regions are viewed in isolation, no trace of sadness is visible. Further, even when the upper face is covered, the obvious “bitter pursed-lip” morphology alone allows easy judgment of the inner emotion. Of course, whether the feeling is guilt, displeasure, bitterness, or reluctance must be judged according to the specific context. See Figure 8-17.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-17]*

When the lips purse, the mentalis is the core driver. Contraction of the mentalis pushes the lower lip upward, straightening the middle of the upper lip, unnaturally lengthening the lip line, and forming an uneven raised surface beneath the lower lip. At the same time, the depressor anguli oris contracts, causing the corners of the mouth to droop. The orbicularis oris contracts, pressing the upper and lower lips together.

### 1. Sad Eyebrow Morphology

Because the eyes must open, the complexity of eyebrow morphology increases. The eyebrows are pulled in opposite directions: first pressed downward, then raised mainly at the inner brows, with a noticeably greater lift than during eyes-closed sobbing. This is the most important distinction between weeping and loud crying; even after crying subsides, the sadness emotion keeps this complex eyebrow configuration in place. See Figure 8-8.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-8]*

When the intensity of sadness diminishes, the frontalis attempts to pull against the corrugator supercilii: the frontalis lifts while the corrugator pulls down. The frontalis can only show its action once the orbicularis oculi weakens. The downward press of the eyebrows is neutralized by contraction of the medial frontalis, lifting the inner brows. Relaxed eyebrows never display this state. Vertical wrinkles reveal that the corrugator supercilii remains contracted.

On some faces the corrugator supercilii dominates and the eyebrows stay level; on others the frontalis dominates and the eyebrows form an “8:20” shape. Yet on every face the eyebrows show some entanglement; the degree of twist at the inner third of the brow indicates the degree of inner conflict.

This eyebrow shape is one of the typical morphological features of sadness. Perhaps because it arises from the entanglement of sobbing and restraint, its twisted form carries strong expressive contagion.

The basic morphology of sad eyebrows appears not only in sobbing expressions but on any sad face, and occasionally on non-sad faces. On overcast winter days, harsh weather can also produce this eyebrow morphology. In that context, the shape seems to represent hardship more than sadness, because both harsh weather and sadness stimuli confront the person with a negative situation they cannot change, so the expression is the same.

### 8.3 Micro-expression Morphological Features of Sadness (9787554606841)

Sobbing comprises two factors: muscle contraction and spasm that form the sobbing expression, and loud vocalization that accelerates energy expenditure, intensifies the person’s experience of sadness, and, if others are present, enhances expressive effectiveness.

Yet in adult society, most communicative content does not involve such intense emotion, and the communicative form is largely rational language, so adults rarely have the opportunity to sob like infants. For

most people, this fullest sobbing occurs only at the moment a loved one passes. Therefore, sadness in real life takes many forms.

In all obvious crying expressions, the eyes, due to physiological structure, tend to close tightly, and the greater the force of closure, the more intense the crying. The mouth may be open or closed, but the corners are definitely pulled sideways. Whether the mouth opens or closes depends on the degree of distress and self-restraint. Deliberate eye-closing and mouth-stretching actions are never as forceful or natural as those during actual crying. This is because emotion mobilizes substantial energy for natural physiological responses; actions fabricated from experience cannot fully replicate them—only physical pain produces comparable intensity.

The strength of the stimulus and the person's degree of restraint allow sadness to be divided into many grades: wailing, normal crying, sobbing, silent tears with mouth closed, grievance, melancholy, etc. In the fullest sobbing state the morphological features are clear and easy to recognize; in each weakened grade, even subtle morphological states of the eyebrows, eyes, and mouth can reveal sadness.

### **8.3 Micro-expression Morphological Features of Sadness (9789620756689)**

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### **8.3 Micro-expression Morphological Features of Sadness (9787554606841)**

#### **8.3**

##### **8.3.1 Suppressing Sobbing with Mouth Closed**

##### **8.3.2 Crying with Mouth Closed**

##### **8.3.3 Calm Sadness**

##### **8.3.4 Micro-expression Morphological Features of Sadness**

##### **8.3.5 Derived Micro-expressions of Sadness**

##### **8.3.6 Test Applications**

#### **Chapter Summary**

##### **8.3.5 Derived Micro-expressions of Sadness**

The essence of sadness is helplessness toward an (unwanted) outcome. Many emotional derivatives fit this mindset.

- **Shame:** Self-blame or regret for a negative outcome one has caused, after the outcome has occurred.
- **Displeasure:** Non-acceptance, non-approval, or dislike of the stimulus source, yet without feelings of rejection or distancing, thus differing from disgust (whose essence is also negation).
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- **Reluctant or difficult decisions:** After a hard choice (during which fear-type emotions and expressions appear; see Chapter 7), the decision means losing some benefit (no alternative), so a sadness-type emotional response also occurs.

The classic mouth morphology can express the above sadness-category derivatives. When the brow and eye regions are viewed in isolation, no trace of sadness is visible. Further, even when the upper face is covered, the obvious “bitter pursed-lip” morphology alone allows easy judgment of the inner emotion. Of course, whether the feeling is guilt, displeasure, bitterness, or reluctance must be judged according to the specific context.

When the lips purse, the mentalis is the core driver. Contraction of the mentalis pushes the lower lip upward, straightening the middle of the upper lip, unnaturally lengthening the lip line, and forming an uneven raised surface beneath the lower lip. At the same time, the depressor anguli oris contracts, causing the corners of the mouth to droop. The orbicularis oris contracts, pressing the upper and lower lips together.

## 8.2 The Most Intense Sadness Response — Crying

Crying is the most typical action response of sadness. Under what psychological state does a person cry?

I have specifically observed children under 3 years old. After they understand certain things, there is a period when they cry particularly often. Based on the recorded results, I found that all causes of crying stem from the children feeling that “there is no way out.” For a concrete example, a child has already eaten some snacks and agreed with the parents not to eat more, yet their actual desire is to eat a little more.

The child understands that the parents will definitely not allow further snacks. Knowing the matter is hopeless, the child begins to cry. Besides snacks, similar situations such as watching cartoons or buying toys produce the same result. A deeper look at the child’s psychology reveals that the failure to satisfy a simple need is a bad outcome, while the agreement reached with the parents and their supervision lie beyond the child’s ability to change the situation.

In simple terms, a bad outcome occurs and there is no way to alter it; the result is sadness expressed through crying.

The same principle applies to events that cause adults to feel sadness and cry.

### Small Exercise: The Expression of Grievance

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-18]*

Analysis of facial morphology features:

1. Furrowed brows and vertical frown lines indicate focused attention in response to pressure.
2. The eyelids show no obvious lift; the upper eyelid shape is entirely affected by the downward pressure of the brows, ruling out surprise, anger, or fear.

3. Gaze directed downward signals being under pressure; an energy-less gaze tends toward sadness (helplessness).
4. The levator labii superioris shows no obvious lifting action; the upper lip's upward movement is produced by the lower lip pushing upward, so disgust is ruled out.
5. The "bitter pursed-lip" shape is very typical, indicating non-acceptance yet helplessness.

**Summary:** This pressured, helpless expression, compared with pure sadness, carries an extra element of struggle and persistence; the downward gaze distinguishes it from pure sadness. The expression conveys unwillingness to accept a negative outcome together with helplessness. Grievance is a derivative of sadness that combines unwillingness to accept criticism with helplessness.

### 8.1 The Generation of Sadness

After worrying for a long time, the undesired outcome still occurs. Once a loss of interest is fixed, the instinctive drive to seek benefit and avoid harm means that failing to gain or suffering damage (loss) will trigger sadness.

Sadness originates from loss.

Examples include irreversible physical injury, the death of a close relative, the end of a cherished relationship, or the loss of important economic interests—all irreversible losses for the person involved. Facing an adverse outcome that cannot be reversed produces sadness. Sadness is the only emotion among all emotions that allows energy to dissipate; every other emotion mobilizes energy for physical expenditure.

The stimulus for sadness is "irrevocable loss."

Sadness expressions are directly linked to crying. A person's first expression after birth (more accurately, the first action) is loud crying. Of course, an infant's cry does not express sadness alone; it can also convey anger, disgust, fear, and all other negative emotions. In the absence of negative emotions, the infant's expression is quiet.

#### Close-up of the Mouth Suppressing Loud Crying

As shown in Figure 8-6, when the mouth opens to cry, the upper lip is lifted by the levator labii superioris. When crying with the mouth closed, a subtle change occurs: the levator labii superioris yields to the zygomaticus minor (1), whose force is much gentler, sharply reducing the lift of the upper lip; the platysma visibly pulls the corners of the mouth outward (2); the groove-shaped lines outside the corners are formed by the depressor anguli oris (3), yet its downward pull is weaker than the platysma's lateral pull; the mentalis raises the chin into a bumpy ball while pushing the lower lip upward into the closed position (4). Because of resistance from the upper lip, the lower lip stays largely flat and does not arch upward (as it can when the mouth is open during loud crying), so part of the lower lip protrudes outward.

In suppressed sadness, the emotion requires the mouth to open for crying, yet conscious will demands that the lips remain tightly closed and silent. The result is highly tense lips under inward pressure that counters the upward and outward forces. This state of equilibrium in the mouth continually switches, producing slight trembling.

### 2. Eye Morphology in Sadness

When sadness occurs with the eyes open, changes appear. The lift of the upper eyelid is restrained by the downward pressure of the brows, forming a fold on the skin, though less pronounced than in fear. This subtle difference is the key distinction between open-eyed sadness and fear, as shown in Figure 8-9.

### **Sad eyes**

### **Fearful eyes**

The lower eyelid covers more of the eyeball than usual.

Partial contraction of the orbicularis oculi, mainly in its lower portion, straightens the lift of the lower eyelid. This subtle change plays a major role: the area of the iris that is covered increases, with more of both the upper and lower margins obscured. Consequently, the eye's alert state disappears instantly; the gaze loses its luster and appears dim and weak. This results from reduced black-and-white contrast and a smaller reflective surface of the eyeball.

### **Small Exercise: The Expression of Grievance**

#### **Analysis of facial morphology features:**

- ① Furrowed brows and vertical frown lines indicate focused attention in response to pressure;
- ② The eyelids show no obvious lift; the upper eyelid shape is entirely affected by the downward pressure of the brows, ruling out surprise, anger, or fear;
- ③ Gaze directed downward signals being under pressure; an energy-less gaze tends toward sadness (helplessness);
- ④ The levator labii superioris shows no obvious lifting action; the upper lip's upward movement is produced by the lower lip pushing upward, so disgust is ruled out;
- ⑤ The "bitter pursed-lip" shape is very typical, indicating non-acceptance yet helplessness.

### **Summary:**

This pressured, helpless expression, compared with pure sadness, carries an extra element of struggle and persistence; the downward gaze distinguishes it from pure sadness. The expression conveys unwillingness to accept a negative outcome together with helplessness. Grievance is a derivative of sadness that combines unwillingness to accept criticism with helplessness.

### **Morphology of the Crying Expression**

Contraction of the upper lip muscles lifts the upper lip while, together with the orbicularis oculi, raises the cheeks; the raised cheeks press against the lower eyelids, forming the sunken area beneath the lower eyelids and the nasolabial folds on both sides of the nose wings;

- ④ Contraction of the platysma pulls the corners of the mouth outward, increasing the horizontal width of the mouth beyond normal; the stretched corners and cheeks create the nasolabial lines;
- ⑤ Contraction of the depressor anguli oris pulls the corners downward; simultaneous contraction of the depressor labii inferioris lowers the entire lower lip in an attempt to expose the lower teeth;

⑥ Simultaneous contraction of the mentalis pushes the middle of the lower lip upward and creates a bumpy muscular bulge on the chin. The upward push of the middle lower lip covers part of the lower teeth that could otherwise be exposed, while the corners remain lowered, allowing the lower teeth near the corners to show. The lower lip curve forms a W shape. This mouth shape is unique to the crying expression.

### 8.3.4 Micro-expression Morphological Features of Sadness

From full crying to calm melancholy, through gradual attenuation, we observe that one micro-expression feature consistently appears across varying degrees of sadness expressions. On a calm face, simply adding the necessary brow morphology effectively conveys sadness, even without changes in the eyes or mouth.

Therefore, brows that are furrowed and depressed yet raised at the inner ends, with distortion in the inner one-third of the brow shape, constitute the micro-expression morphological feature of sadness.

The same brow morphology may also appear in fear expressions, but fear expressions must be accompanied by widened eyelids, whereas sad eyes show a closing action due to contraction of the orbicularis oculi. This is the greatest distinction between the two, as shown in Figure 8-15.

**Figure 8-15** The upper image shows sad brow-eye morphology; the lower image shows fearful brow-eye morphology

### 8.3.3 Calm Sadness

Unlike crying, calm sadness can last a long time. Crying consumes large amounts of energy, whereas calm sadness merely allows the body's energy to dissipate slowly. The saddening outcome has already occurred and cannot be reversed; nothing else matters, and only helplessness remains in the body, as shown in Figure 8-12.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-12]*

As crying subsides, the muscles on the sad face gradually relax. The platysma is the first to exit, followed by the orbicularis oculi. Finally the cheeks are no longer so puffed, and the lower eyelids loosen. What remains on the face are the sad brows and a slight pout. Even after the pout disappears, the troubled brows still convey the final message of sadness.

## Chapter 8 Micro-expressions of Sadness

The most feared event has still occurred (the adverse outcome). This causes the original worry in the person's heart to vanish completely and be replaced by helpless resignation; fear therefore transforms into sadness. Sadness originates from loss and is the only emotion that permits energy to dissipate, resulting in dull, unalert eyes.

The micro-expressions of fear discussed in the previous chapter actually combine morphological features of two micro-expressions—surprise and sadness. A sudden stimulus produces surprise; after evaluation, if the threat exceeds one's coping capacity and cannot be eliminated through angry fighting, fear arises. Only a thin barrier separates fear from sadness—the question of whether the feared outcome occurs. Before the adverse outcome occurs, the emotion is fear; once it occurs, the emotion becomes sadness.

## 2. Common Morphological Features of Sad Expressions



[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-19 Morphology of closed-mouth crying expression]

- ① Contraction of the orbicularis oculi and corrugator supercilii is reduced yet still depresses and furrows the brows; contraction of the central frontalis slightly raises the inner brows, producing an upward distortion so that the overall brow shape tends toward flatness;
- ② The eyelids are tense and tend toward closure;
- ③ Contraction of the levator labii superioris slightly lifts the upper lip, forming nasolabial folds beside the nose wings (shallower than in loud crying);
- ④ Contraction of the platysma pulls the corners of the mouth outward;
- ⑤ Contraction of the depressor anguli oris pulls the corners downward;
- ⑥ Contraction of the mentalis pushes the middle of the lower lip upward and creates a bumpy muscular bulge on the chin; the lip line is horizontal and the lips are pressed tightly together.

## 2. Typical Morphological Features of Sadness

During crying the brows are depressed overall (due to contraction of the orbicularis oculi). Although the eyes are usually tightly closed, social context makes wide-open crying rare. The typical crying action is closure of the mouth; the tense lips experience upward squeezing force from below (mentalis) and lateral stretching force (platysma). Crying is in fact a spasmodic action<|eos|>

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

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See Emotion microexpressions (c-emotion-microexpressions).

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## Training and Practice

### Even If You Can Grasp Emotions in an Instant, Decisions Must Still Be Made with Caution

When meeting someone for the first time and introducing myself as an expert in expression analysis, I am often asked, "Can you tell what other people are thinking?" or "What am I thinking right now?" Such reactions usually stem from the belief that "what is on a person's mind shows on their face." After reading this book, you should understand that this is a misunderstanding.

Let us now discuss what it actually means to be able to read expressions. If you can read a person's expressions, you can "read their emotions." According to the phenomenon of micro-expressions, you can interpret the emotions the other person is trying to suppress from an instantaneous facial expression. What is the difference between reading emotions and reading thoughts? For example, if the speaker wrinkles their nose for just an instant, this is the micro-expression of "disgust," allowing you to confirm that the other person feels "disgust."

However, we do not strictly know where this feeling of “disgust” originates. It may be that the person ate something too greasy at lunch and feels unwell, or the micro-expression of “disgust” simply appeared at that moment in the conversation. It is also possible that the speaker feels “disgust” toward their own words—that is, some sense of guilt hidden behind what they are saying makes “disgust with oneself” appear on their face. Or perhaps they disagree with what the other person has said and show the micro-expression of “disgust” because they do not approve.

Therefore, even if your ability to read micro-expressions improves, you may not necessarily grasp a person’s thoughts in an instant—why does this emotion exist? To read emotions from expressions and then understand thoughts from those emotions, you must establish this sequence before you can fully comprehend the other person’s true intentions. This is why the three techniques of “observing words and expressions” (察言觀色) from the previous chapter are so important.

Using the three methods described in the previous chapter allows you to analyze and infer the other person’s thoughts precisely. Even so, you still cannot reliably read their thoughts. Too many unpredictable variables and individual differences exist, along with many aspects that science cannot explain. The phenomena and methodologies introduced in this book are all grounded in scientific knowledge. So what should you do when the methodologies or scientific points in this book do not apply? You must rely on rules of thumb.

Set aside the idea of grasping someone’s heart through scientific knowledge. Put aside everything you have learned so far and listen to what your own heart tells you. Put yourself in the other person’s position and consider matters from their perspective rather than analyzing them. Observe the whole situation with empathy. Doing so may allow you to understand the other person’s thoughts.

Even then, you may not immediately perceive the other person’s thoughts. Whether you succeed or not, move day by day toward the ideal of understanding people’s hearts. Shift your posture from the suspicion of “peeking into someone else’s mind” to “caring about someone else’s mind,” and you will gradually develop a gentler heart.

### **Micro-expressions Are Limited to Those Directed at Yourself**

Humans are interesting creatures. Sometimes, even while looking into another person’s eyes and listening to their words, they are actually lost in their own world. Their thoughts have entered a realm completely unrelated to the conversation, pondering matters unrelated to the dialogue. In such cases, even if a micro-expression appears on that person’s face, it is entirely unrelated to the day’s conversation. Therefore, when a micro-expression appears, it may seem caused by the person you are talking with, but it may actually stem from something completely unrelated. “Smiling because of a memory” is a typical example. While earnestly discussing a serious topic, a pleasant memory suddenly surfaces, producing an odd smile. The person tries to suppress the amusing emotion but cannot, so it appears as a micro-expression. Such a “smile from memory” has nothing to do with the content of the conversation or with the other person.

Moreover, even when a micro-expression arises in connection with the ongoing conversation, its cause is not necessarily the other person. For instance, during an exchange of opinions, your idea may give the other person a new thought. While that person appears to be listening, their mind is actually busy constructing a new idea. When they feel pleased with what they consider an innovative thought—“This is an idea that will impress everyone around!”—they may display the micro-expression of “contempt.”

Yet this micro-expression is not directed at you; it is an emotion shown toward a third party who is not present. Therefore, even when the person you are speaking with displays a micro-expression, it is not

necessarily directed at you.

In most situations, people believe they themselves are the most worthy of love and respect. This is called self-esteem and is an indispensable psychological function. Everyone has self-esteem and feels they are most important. Because of this belief, people can overcome criticism, slander, and setbacks and keep moving forward.

When someone hears your words or suggestions, they may say aloud, "That suggestion is wonderful! Thank you!" yet display micro-expressions of "contempt" and "disgust" on their face. Even if the micro-expression indicates they do not truly wish to accept the suggestion, graciously accept their feelings and protect their self-esteem.

### Example

Imagine two new colleagues conversing in the office on a weekend, discussing plans for tomorrow's day off.

The company requires new hires to submit the results of their most recent English proficiency test after joining and to provide the relevant certificate by a set deadline. Because the deadline is approaching, Colleague B plans to take the TOEIC (an English proficiency test) at the company tomorrow.

- **A:** "Tomorrow is Saturday. Do you have any plans?"
- **B:** "I've already arranged to take the TOEIC tomorrow."

During this exchange, a micro-expression of "disgust" appears on B's face. The function of "disgust" is to "exclude unpleasant things or matters," so we infer that the "unpleasant matter" is "having a day off taken up by an exam." Based on this inference, find words that support the idea of "excluding the unpleasant matter" and say them to B.

For example:

- "You don't have to take the test on Sunday. You can take it next Wednesday instead."
- "If you have taken the TOEIC within the past two years, that score is acceptable in the HR department!"

If B replies, "Really? Then I won't have to lose a day of vacation tomorrow! Thank you for telling me!" this reaction indicates that the earlier inference was correct and that the psychological inference proceeded smoothly.

However, if B says, "Oh, is that so?" the "unpleasant matter" is apparently not caused by "having a day off taken up by an exam" but by something else. To learn B's true thoughts, other possibilities must be inferred and the conversation continued.

### Idol Autograph Session Example

This example occurred at an idol's autograph session.

- **Fan:** "I'll support you! Keep it up!"
- **Idol:** (while shaking hands) "I'll keep it up."

Observing this scene, the analyst noticed that when the idol said the first word "I" of "I'll keep it up," a micro-expression of "disgust" appeared.

This emotion was not a reaction to the fan's shout of "Keep it up!" The key point is the micro-expression shown before the idol uttered "I'll keep it up."

Judging from the timing of the idol's utterance, he was not reacting to the fan's words but felt disgust toward his own statement. From these signs we infer that, although he was grateful for the fan's support, he felt disgust at having to say "I'll keep it up." His gaze was directed at the fan, yet the target of the emotion was himself.

This situation requires attention to the "timing" and "discrepancy" between speech and expression. Expressions shown before or after speaking reflect emotions related to the content of the speech. Expressions that appear before the speaker begins to speak usually reveal the speaker's true feelings, because the emotion arises first and then surfaces on the face.

In addition, when affirmative words appear together with negative expressions

### **Overly "Observing Words and Expressions" Can Become Annoying**

When reading micro-expressions, even if you cannot immediately understand the other person's thoughts, you can directly perceive their emotions. Be aware that this can sometimes cause distress to others.

This section offers advice, drawn from personal experience and arranged from easier to more difficult, on how to protect yourself by avoiding "overly observing words and expressions." It is intended for those who can already use micro-expressions to read others' thoughts, or as psychological preparation for those who interpret micro-expressions.

Once skill in reading micro-expressions reaches a certain level, you will automatically notice others' micro-expressions even without concentrating on their faces. Given the number of people we meet and communicate with daily, the quantity of micro-expressions observed in a single day is considerable. Reacting sensitively to interpreted micro-expressions or pondering why they appeared can create significant mental stress. Here is a suggestion:

Plan in advance which micro-expressions you intend to notice, along with their possible causes and interpretations.

"Today I will pay attention to that salesperson's micro-expressions," "When speaking with that person, I will read their micro-expressions," or "Regarding that particular topic, I will watch for micro-expressions." It is advisable to decide beforehand which occasions or individuals warrant attention to micro-expressions and to maintain an on/off mechanism for whether to interpret the psychology involved.

### **Greater Ability Brings Greater Responsibility**

One of my favorite sayings is "With great power comes great responsibility." When you possess the ability to read micro-expressions that others lack, you hold considerable power. Yet if this ability is misused, it can generate distrust toward others or cause others to distrust you. The most typical example is using micro-expressions to detect lies. Once you master the methods of judging micro-expressions and asking questions, you can accurately spot lies.

However, whose lies should you expose? Sometimes lies are told to spare the other person pain. Exposing a lie not only destroys the liar's consideration but also forces the truth into the open, leaving people unsettled.

When, under what circumstances, and toward whom to apply this powerful micro-expression judgment ability constitutes a significant responsibility for the user.

Those who possess great power bear heavy obligations and must pass rigorous tests of reality before they can achieve greatness. If you agree with this and have the confidence to strive in that direction, continue honing your micro-expression reading skills and enjoy good communication in daily life.

### How to Respond Most Appropriately According to the Other Person's Emotions

| Emotion Type | Emotional Reaction                                                                                         | How to Interact When Seeing the Other Person's Expression |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Happiness    | When one's hopes are fulfilled...                                                                          | Stimulate the other person's expectations                 |
| Contempt     | When one feels one's experience or knowledge is superior to others, or when witnessing immoral behavior... | Support the other person's sense of superiority           |
| Disgust      | Disliking people or things one finds unpleasant or unwilling to hear                                       | Understand the cause of the unpleasantness                |
| Anger        | When one disagrees or one's goals are obstructed                                                           | Remove the obstructing factor                             |
| Sadness      | Feeling unhappy about lost people or things and seeking help                                               | Extend a helping hand                                     |
| Fear         | When physical or mental safety is threatened...                                                            | Show empathy and reassure the person                      |
| Surprise     | When something unexpected occurs and one wants to grasp the situation...                                   | Provide relevant information                              |

### The Second Step: Inferring Psychology

Using the interpreted micro-expressions and other information as a basis, infer the cause and target of the other person's emotion.

Finally, we explain "taking appropriate action according to the situation and occasion."

Communication requires correctly reading the other person's verbal and nonverbal messages and then considering what action is appropriate based on that information. For example:

- When you know the other person is hiding impatience toward you, you can apologize first to ease their emotion.
- When the other person feels "sadness," extend a helping hand.
- If you notice the other person feels disgust toward you because of a lie, you can urge them to reflect, perhaps helping them speak their true feelings.

This sequence of steps is called "observing words and expressions." The most important and difficult part of the process is "correctly reading" within "inferring psychology." In "observing words and expressions,"

“inferring psychology” accounts for almost the entire weight. Therefore, “inferring psychology” can be said to be the key to “observing words and expressions.”

### ③ Consider Gaze Direction, Words, and Micro-expressions Together

Generally, the target of an emotion and the direction of gaze coincide. When the gaze is directed downward, the emotion is usually directed at oneself.

If a speaker displays a micro-expression of “contempt” while looking at everyone, the likelihood is high that the contempt is directed at everyone. If the gaze is directed downward, the speaker feels “contempt” toward themselves—that is, they feel “I am worthless” or “I have a sense of guilt.”

However, when someone wishes to hide their true intentions, they may also lower their gaze slightly, sometimes presenting a micro-expression in this manner. In such cases, even though the gaze is downward, the target of the emotion may not be themselves; caution is required during interpretation.

Conversely, even when the speaker’s gaze is directed at everyone, the emotion may still be directed at themselves; similar examples exist.

### Three Techniques for “Observing Words and Expressions” Using Micro-expressions

When expressions appear, or conversely when negative words appear together with positive expressions, the more trustworthy element is the expression. Micro-expressions in particular cannot be freely controlled by conscious will; they usually reveal true feelings. When words and expressions differ, choose to believe the expression.

The three techniques for “observing words and expressions” using micro-expressions are therefore:

- Directly ask the other person about the emotion interpreted from the micro-expression
- Say something that supports the other person’s emotion
- Consider gaze direction, words, and micro-expressions together

You may use any one method alone or combine several. Practice a little each day, trying to make abstract expressions consciously “visible,” and you will glimpse the rich and varied world of emotions that you had never noticed before.

### What Is “Observing Words and Expressions”?

What exactly is “observing words and expressions,” and how do you interpret it concretely?

To read hidden emotions from micro-expressions and find ways to touch the other person’s heart, we visualize the concrete process and define “observing words and expressions” as:

“Correctly interpreting another person’s conscious or unconscious verbal or nonverbal messages and taking appropriate action according to the situation and occasion.”

“Another person’s conscious or unconscious verbal or nonverbal messages” refers to the fact that, whether conscious or unconscious, the other person’s words or body language come from the heart.

### Verbal Example

With items scattered across a desk, a colleague says, "This desk is a bit dirty." The intended meaning is "It should be tidied up," expressed indirectly in the hope that the other person will understand. This is also called "reading between the lines."

The English term for reading between the lines is *telepathy*. Such indirect metaphors are common in Japanese communication, but to Westerners they seem like a superpower.

## Body Language

Body language consists of messages conveyed by expressions and bodily movements (nodding, shaking the head, touching the face, patting the chest, jiggling a leg, crossing arms or legs...), including posture and voice. Suppressed emotions therefore surface on the face in the form of "micro-expressions," whether consciously or unconsciously. This bodily movement also has an advanced version that appears on the body as "micro-movements."

### ❶ Directly Ask the Other Person About the Emotion Interpreted from the Micro-expression

This is the simplest method. When the other person shows a micro-expression of "fear," ask, "Is there something making you uneasy?" Directly inquire about the cause or reason for the emotion you have interpreted.

This method allows intuitive capture of micro-expressions and is easy to use. Because it directly touches the other person's privacy, it must be used with caution.

## The First Step: Reading Emotions

When reading emotions from the other person's micro-expressions, this stage allows you to determine which specific emotion the person is suppressing—whether it is "happiness," "contempt," "disgust," and so on. Even if you can infer the other person's emotion, you still cannot know "why this emotion has arisen" or "who the target of this emotion is."

### ❷ Say Something That Supports the Other Person's Own Emotion

Taking an action that supports the other person's emotion makes it easier to hear their true feelings. This method was already mentioned in the exercises in Chapter 3. Infer the cause of the emotion from the other person's facial reaction, then provide a stimulus that supports that inference or offer support for the emotion, and observe the other person's subsequent reaction.

## Correct Interpretation Is the Key

How do you "correctly interpret" these verbal and nonverbal messages? The most important thing is to base the interpretation on "observing words and expressions."

"Correctly interpreting" means "inferring psychology from the other person's emotions," which can be divided into two steps.

## Make Communication Easy! Three Tricks for "Reading People"

This section explores three techniques for "reading people" from micro-expressions and introduces methods for carrying them out. Before that, we first clearly define the matter of "reading people".

## Three Techniques for "Inferring Psychology"

Now let's introduce the core of "reading people"— "inferring psychology". Its methods are roughly divided into three types.

### Three Habits That Let You Understand Micro-expressions

#### ❶ Consciously Observe People's Expressions

Pay attention to the expressions of people around you in daily life and observe them with interest; this is the starting point for understanding micro-expressions. If you want to detect subtle emotional changes on people's faces, you must look at the other person's eyes and face while conversing. Doing so through a computer or phone screen will not work.

Observing other people's expressions with interest will reveal many facial movements that were previously overlooked, movements that actually contain a great deal of information. In addition to conversing with others, you can observe passersby's faces while walking on the street or riding the subway.

What kind of expression do pedestrians on the street wear as they walk? What problems are they pondering, or what pleasant things are they thinking about? What expressions do people talking on the phone show? Are they discussing something complicated? Is the person on the other end a lover or a boss? What about the expressions of people reading email? Have they received a happy notification, or are they viewing something that makes them uneasy? What expressions do people reading books or newspapers show? What type of book or news content are they looking at? Conscious observation of this kind sharpens your sensitivity to changes in people's expressions and teaches you how to respond.

#### ❷ Watch Programs with the Television on Mute

Turn the television volume to mute and carefully observe the micro-expressions of the people appearing on screen. News broadcasts are recommended for observation, because news anchors usually display only minimal changes in expression, which helps train the ability to read micro-expressions.

Observe the micro-expressions of news anchors to predict whether the next story will be good news or bad news. This method compensates for the shortcoming of method ❶. Although method ❶ improves your skill at observing and inferring expressions, you cannot confirm your inferences with the observed person, making it difficult to know whether your guesses are correct. Method ❷ lets you verify your inferences the moment the next news item airs, based on the anchor's change in expression.

Another approach is to leave the sound on and infer emotions from micro-expressions. This is usually used while watching talk shows: observe the speaker's micro-expressions to predict what the person will say next. Try to judge whether a participant agrees or disagrees with someone else's opinion. Can you detect the moment an opinion shifts? Has the person been persuaded? While watching the various micro-expressions of the people on screen, attempt to forecast how the discussion will turn out.

#### ❸ Use Training Tools Designed for Micro-expressions



This is the most formal and reliable of the three methods. It involves self-study with specially made animated teaching materials that improve micro-expression judgment skills. Companies in the United States, Europe, and even many in Japan sell dedicated micro-expression training materials. These materials typically require viewers to watch characters in videos and judge what emotion each person is displaying. Judgments are usually made in multiple-choice format, and the correctness of each answer is revealed immediately.

Research on the learning effects of these micro-expression training tools shows that even a single hour of video training can raise micro-expression judgment ability. One learner's pre-training accuracy rate was 40 percent; after one hour of training, the rate rose to 80 percent, and the effect lasted two to three weeks. The research indicates that using dedicated micro-expression judgment training materials for one hour every two to three weeks allows a person to retain micro-expression judgment skills indefinitely.

### **Three Habits That Let You Understand Micro-expressions**

In this section, three techniques for learning to interpret micro-expressions (微表情) will be introduced. These range from the simplest methods to professional training; I will explain them in detail, so you can try the ones you like.

## **Part Six: Deception**

### **Make an Appointment with Him in Haste to See If He Keeps It**

#### **Micro-expression Keywords**

Whether in the East or the West, stories about keeping appointments are countless. Keeping an appointment is not only the basic etiquette of interpersonal interaction but also a way to judge a person's character. Only someone who strictly honors commitments is honest and worthy of our trust and association. Therefore, it is worthwhile to make an appointment with him in haste and test his character.

Time is a non-renewable resource; once our time is exhausted, our life ceases to exist. Yet many people fail to truly recognize its importance and waste precious hours. Being late for appointments or work has become routine, always accompanied by various excuses.

Some may think, "What's the big deal if I'm ten minutes late?" But failing to arrive at the agreed time forces others to wait, which is unfair and wastes their life. Such people neither respect others' time nor keep their word. The way to identify them is to make an appointment in haste and observe whether they arrive on time.

American railroad magnate Vanderbilt regarded unpunctuality as an unforgivable sin. Once he arranged to meet a young man at his office at 10 a.m. to introduce him to a railroad superintendent for a position. The young man was delighted. Unfortunately, he arrived twenty minutes late. By then Vanderbilt had already left for another meeting.

Days later the young man finally met Vanderbilt, who asked why he had not kept the appointment. The young man replied, "Sir, I arrived at 10:20." Vanderbilt immediately reminded him, "But I asked you to come at 10!"

"Yes, I know," the young man stammered, "but twenty minutes shouldn't make much difference, right?"

"No!" Vanderbilt said sternly. "Punctuality matters a great deal. Because you were not on time, you lost the position. That very day the railroad hired someone else. And let me tell you, young man, you have no right to undervalue my twenty minutes and leave me waiting while I had two important meetings to attend."

We all prefer to deal with trustworthy people. Trustworthiness is like a person's credit rating at a bank. To assess someone's assets, check their bank records; to gauge their trustworthiness, simply set a time and see if they arrive punctually. Some lack a strong sense of time and think being a little late for a friend's gathering is harmless. Yet others detect from this small detail a lack of respect and importance, which erodes trust.

Time is the best standard for testing truth. Those who do not keep time commitments can be judged as having low credibility. Only those who honor appointments on time earn others' trust.

When PepsiCo president Carl Weilerup spoke at the University of Colorado, a merchant named Jack wanted to meet him. Carl agreed but could spare only fifteen minutes after the speech. Carl proceeded to the auditorium while Jack waited outside. As Carl spoke enthusiastically about his entrepreneurial journey and business success, he exceeded the agreed time and forgot the appointment. Suddenly a man entered from outside, walked straight to the stage, placed a business card down without a word, and left. Carl read the card: "You have an appointment with Jack at 2:30 p.m." Realizing his mistake, Carl told the students, "Thank you for listening. I would like to continue, but I have an appointment and am already late. I cannot break it, so please excuse me and good luck to you all."

Amid applause Carl hurried out, found Jack, apologized, and answered all his questions. Their fifteen-minute meeting stretched to thirty minutes.

Jack later became a successful merchant. He shared the story with friends, who grew to trust PepsiCo and decided to distribute and promote its products.

In real life, "trustworthiness" is often difficult to maintain. Some make promises to subordinates, colleagues, or friends only to forget them soon after. To know a person, first determine whether they possess "trustworthiness" and whether they are worthy of trust. When leaders assign tasks with tight deadlines, they are often testing whether subordinates can "keep their word and deliver results" and honor commitments.

Leaders can observe subordinates' trustworthiness through two methods: "open" and "closed." In the open method, a task is assigned with only a request to complete it as soon as possible, without a specific deadline. This reveals a person's sense of responsibility and efficiency. Those with strong responsibility treat every assignment as a test and finish promptly; those lacking responsibility procrastinate. In the closed method, a firm deadline is set. Failure to meet the promised deadline indicates a lack of trustworthiness. Repeated occurrences show the person cannot be entrusted with important matters.

Key points must be observed:

1. Clearly state the exact time; avoid vague expressions such as "around two" or "three or four days."
2. Confirm whether the other party can keep the appointment.
3. Ensure the matter lies within the other party's capability.

However, do not take matters out of context. If an appointment is missed, determine whether the cause is objective or subjective and whether it is excusable. In any case, "testing through tasks" yields insights into character that other assessments rarely capture.

Possess the Aura That Attracts Companions, and You Will Surely Succeed in Your Career

### **Micro-expression Keywords**

In today's society, a basic quality of successful people is the aura that attracts companions—that is, personal charisma. This refers to the moral character, personality, ability, and temperament that exert a powerful attractive force, making one popular and accepted. Such individuals are bound to succeed in their careers. When you encounter them, follow closely; you too can achieve success.

Few heroes succeed alone. Beside every successful person stand collaborators—Shi Yuzhu's "Three Musketeers," Jack Ma's "Eighteen Arhats"—yet these partners do not appear by chance. They are drawn by the aura that attracts companions, which requires sufficient personal charisma. A person endowed with charisma will surely succeed.

Personal charisma is the attraction and infectiousness a person's conduct exerts on others. In daily life we notice that some people seem luckier and achieve success more quickly. This is not because they possess greater wisdom but because they radiate an aura that draws companions. Their outstanding charisma makes more friends willing to help and more clients eager to cooperate. Personal charm is a magical resource that can elevate even an ordinary talent to enviable success.

A person may lack striking looks or substantial assets, yet if they possess the aura that attracts companions and boundless charisma, they will still become an object of admiration.

In the IT world, Jack Ma is an iconic figure. Under his leadership the "Eighteen Arhats" made Alibaba repeatedly ranked by Forbes as the world's best B2B website. While passionate about his career, the now-famous Jack Ma has maintained a rare rationality that commands respect. In a Hong Kong Sun TV interview, after the host remarked that "some say Jack Ma is very smart," he replied, "I don't think I'm smart at all. Since childhood I've been worse at studying and games than other kids. When others treat you as a hero, never regard yourself as one—that can only bring trouble. Heroes are named by others; fame is given by others..."

Frankly, Jack Ma is no handsome man; some would even call him unattractive. Forbes once described this eccentric talent: "Deeply sunken cheeks, unruly hair, a mischievous toothy grin—a five-foot, one-hundred-pound urchin." It added, "This oddly featured man has Napoleon's stature and Napoleon-like ambition!" In his own words, "A man's talent is often inversely proportional to his appearance."

Although God did not grant Jack Ma handsome features, He gave him abundant talent. Starting with an initial investment of 500,000 yuan, Alibaba grew to a scale rivaling any major portal. His stake rose from 200,000 yuan to 500 million yuan in just five years.

Known as a "maverick genius," Jack Ma is quick-witted. After being rejected three times, a single Harvard speech attracted dozens of outstanding graduates to join Alibaba. He also possesses remarkable charisma. During the early, difficult years of entrepreneurship, every friend stood as a steadfast supporter, offering the strongest backing and trust. He often received calls: "Hey, Jack Ma, how's it going? No big deal—whatever happens, we've got your back!"

Jack Ma's talent not only recruited excellent staff and accumulated friendships but also won him sincere love. He met his wife Zhang Ying in their freshman year; after graduation they quickly obtained their marriage certificate. Zhang Ying later recalled, "Jack Ma is not a handsome man. What I admired was his ability to do things handsome men could not: founding Hangzhou's first English corner, guiding foreign tourists to earn foreign currency, taking on part-time teaching jobs, and becoming one of Hangzhou's top ten outstanding young teachers..."

Personal charisma, like intelligence and education, is closely tied to one's future. Napoleon Hill said, "Success is intimately related to personal charm; those who create wealth often possess a wealth-attracting personality."

Good personal charm is a magical gift that can move even the coldest hearts.” Jack Ma’s success is inseparable from the aura that attracts companions—an aura forged by the charisma with which he conquered the Eighteen Arhats and built today’s Alibaba.

A person with charisma will be surrounded by those eager to collaborate. Even if they have nothing, others will believe in and help them. This charm is not merely handsome appearance, superior ability, or noble character; it is the integrated force of appearance, talent, personality, emotional intelligence, temperament, morality, and cultivation.

It can manifest as confidence, the internal drive that propels one forward and an essential psychological quality for success. With confidence, one maintains the certainty of victory amid hardship and faces unknown difficulties with composure that draws collaborators to follow wholeheartedly.

It can also appear as consistent integrity. In every setting they show their true selves, never altering their character to suit the occasion. Whether in intimate conversation, public speech, or job interviews, they remain consistent, free of affectation, revealing authentic personality. They communicate with their whole being; tone and posture harmonize with their words, everything natural and approachable.

In any case, those who possess the aura that attracts companions will achieve great things in their careers. Therefore, if you meet such a person, do not hesitate—follow them and you too can succeed. Just as the world remembers Bill Gates, the world’s richest man, it also remembers Paul Allen who stood behind him.

## People Who Can Convert Time into Money Are Those with Thorough Plans

**Micro-expression keywords** Many people complain that they are busy at work yet earn little money. In reality, they fail to convert time into money because they lack planning in their work, which leads to wasted time and futile efforts. A truly capable person always plans ahead and strives to exchange the shortest time for the greatest amount of money. Such individuals are ambitious, highly competent, and worthy of major responsibilities.

The *Book of Rites: Doctrine of the Mean* states: “Preparation ensures success; lack of preparation leads to failure.” This means that any undertaking succeeds with prior preparation and fails without it; here, preparation refers to planning. A person with thorough plans can convert time into money. Likewise, anyone who cherishes time and converts it into money is certainly someone with thorough plans.

People often say “time is money,” yet some endlessly waste time. They never make a plan and simply do whatever comes to mind, often squandering hours on trivial matters and delaying other tasks. They then complain about being too busy and having no time. The root cause is the absence of a thorough plan.

A certain leader frequently complained about his overwhelming workload and lack of breathing room, so he sought advice from a time-management expert. The expert asked, “What did you do this morning, and how much time did it take?” The leader replied, “Drafting a report took three hours.” The expert said, “Did you spend the entire three hours drafting the report?”

“Oh, not entirely. During that time I drank two cups of tea, smoked three cigarettes, took one break, chatted with a colleague, and answered several phone calls,” the leader said while thinking.

The expert then asked, “Can you calculate how much time all those activities consumed?”

After a moment the leader answered, “About an hour and a half.”

"Now you see: of those three hours, you actually spent only an hour and a half drafting the report. If you had used the remaining hour and a half productively, you would have felt you had far more time."

The expert advised him to record everything he did each day along with the time spent, and to continue for half a month. He would then see exactly where his time went, how much was valuable, and how much was wasted. Targeted adjustments would reveal ways to improve efficiency.

The leader followed the advice and kept daily time records. He discovered he had wasted nearly one-third of his time chatting with colleagues, answering unimportant calls, and getting angry over excessive workload. He realized the problem was not insufficient time but poor utilization.

Thereafter, during work hours he stopped idle chatter and routed calls through his secretary, who transferred only important ones. By the end of each day his work was completed smoothly, and he no longer felt short of time.

Those who constantly claim to be busy do not actually have that many tasks; they simply waste too much time on individual activities. They understand the principle "an inch of time is an inch of gold" yet lack a thorough plan, so every action wastes time.

We constantly advocate saving and cherishing time, yet people sometimes fall into the misconception that merely avoiding waste brings one close to success. This is not the case. A successful person's key lies in having a feasible plan and executing it consistently. Anyone who converts time into money necessarily maintains thorough plans, never wastes time needlessly, and follows those plans to turn time into substantial wealth.

In the spring of 1968, Dr. Robert Schuller resolved to build a crystal cathedral of glass in California. He shared his vision with renowned designer Philip Johnson: "I do not want an ordinary church; I want to create an Eden on earth."

Realizing the dream proved difficult; the final budget reached seven million dollars—an astronomical sum far beyond Schuller's means. Yet he did not consider it impossible and drew up a detailed plan:

1. Secure one donation of seven million dollars;
2. Secure seven donations of one million dollars each;
3. Secure fourteen donations of five hundred thousand dollars each;
4. Secure twenty-eight donations of two hundred fifty thousand dollars each;
5. Secure seventy donations of one hundred thousand dollars each;
6. Secure one hundred donations of seventy thousand dollars each;
7. Secure one hundred forty donations of fifty thousand dollars each;
8. Secure two hundred eighty donations of twenty-five thousand dollars each;
9. Secure seven hundred donations of ten thousand dollars each;
10. Sell ten thousand windows at seven hundred dollars each.

Sixty days later, the unique and beautiful model of the crystal cathedral persuaded wealthy merchant John Crean to donate the first one million dollars.

On the sixty-fifth day, a farming couple who had heard Schuller speak donated one thousand dollars.

On the ninetieth day, a stranger moved by Schuller's perseverance mailed him a one-million-dollar bank check.

The following year, Schuller invited Americans to purchase windows for the crystal cathedral at five hundred dollars each, payable in ten monthly installments of fifty dollars. Within six months, more than ten thousand windows were sold.

In September 1980, after twelve years, the crystal cathedral—seating over ten thousand—opened as a marvel and classic of world architecture and a must-see destination for visitors to California.

A detailed, feasible plan combined with persistent action is the best shortcut to realizing a great dream. Dr. Schuller followed his plan, converted time into money, and fulfilled his grand aspiration.

Therefore, anyone who cherishes time and converts it into money necessarily operates with thorough plans. Such a person is absolutely worthy of major responsibilities, for in their eyes time is money, and they can transform it into wealth placed before us.

## People Who Can Gain from Losses Can Build Long-Term Relationships with Them

People often say “suffering a loss is a blessing,” yet in reality no one wants to keep losing. Those willing to accept losses make better friends than those who haggle over every penny, because cooperation with them frees us from fear of being cheated and lets us focus on the work itself. Hence, when choosing a partner, first check whether the person can accept losses.

In real-life interpersonal dealings, building long-term relationships is neither simple nor straightforward. The saying “suffering a loss is a blessing” is itself an equation of interest exchange. One should not assume that accepting a loss means suffering harm for nothing; certain losses must be taken, and taken skillfully, because a well-chosen loss can bring “blessings.” People who gain from losses trade short-term setbacks for long-term gains and are therefore worth long-term relationships.

Li Ka-shing said, “What appears to be a loss often turns out to be highly advantageous.” Those willing to accept losses view them as investments. They treat others generously, yield when possible, consider others first, forgo unnecessary disputes, help when they can, and therefore easily win support. Many friends gather around them because people want to build lasting relationships with them.

A reporter once asked Li Ka-shing’s son, Li Tzar-kuoi—known as the “Little Giant”—what success secrets his father had taught him. Li Tzar-kuoi replied, “My father taught me nothing about making money; he only taught me principles of conduct.” Li Ka-shing once told his son that when cooperating with others, if seven-tenths was fair and eight-tenths possible, he would settle for six-tenths.

This means Li Ka-shing is always ready to let the other party earn an extra two-tenths, selflessly ceding benefits he could have kept. Everyone knows that partnering with Li Ka-shing yields an advantage, so more people choose to work with him. Although he takes only six-tenths, with one hundred partners he earns far more overall than if he took eight-tenths and attracted only five partners.

Since “suffering a loss is a blessing” is commonly accepted, it contains truth. People generally dislike those who always grab small advantages; such behavior inflicts a greater loss on one’s character. These individuals never accept losses and fixate on tiny immediate gains. Others refuse long-term ties with them and remain guarded, knowing no lasting benefit can be obtained.

Throughout his life Li Ka-shing entered many short- and long-term partnerships. At parting he consistently yielded, taking a smaller share. Because of this willingness to accept losses, others gladly cooperated with him

and his enterprises grew. Li Ka-shing is precisely someone who gains from losses, which is why countless people seek long-term relationships with him.

Thus only those who can and will accept losses become the first partners others seek. Such partners inspire confidence.

Song Chengrui, a Guangdong merchant, opened an electromechanical equipment company in Tongchuan, Shaanxi. Once an old client needed an electrical component, but Song searched his entire inventory without success. The client was anxious; without the part his factory faced shutdown, costing over fifty thousand yuan per day.

Seeing the client's distress, Song reassured him and promised delivery within one day. After the client left, Song took a taxi straight to the supplier in Xi'an. Finding none there either, he flew overnight to Hangzhou and then traveled on to his hometown in Guangdong.

By the time he finished, it was four or five in the morning. Ignoring hunger and fatigue, Song contacted manufacturers across Guangdong and, after reaching more than ten factories, located the component. He then rushed to the airport without even visiting his parents.

The next day, when he handed over the part, the client was speechless with gratitude. The transaction was a "loss" for Song: the component cost three hundred yuan with a thirty-yuan profit, yet he spent over four thousand yuan on travel. Song voiced no complaint, for he valued more than the immediate numbers.

On the surface Song lost several thousand yuan, yet he gained the client's trust. After receiving the part, the client's company sent a large plaque with fanfare, brought media to interview Song, and publicized his client-first conduct. Word of Song's willingness to "accept losses" spread throughout the industry; his business flourished, and the wealth he earned far exceeded the few thousand yuan sacrificed.

No loss is eaten in vain; every effort brings return. A person who yields on profit will receive compensation elsewhere. Conversely, excessive haggling over money leads to small gains and large losses. Those willing to accept losses harvest returns from them. Cooperating with such people removes any worry of being cheated, because they accept losses and gain from them. Therefore, when choosing a partner, first determine whether the other party can gain from losses. Only such a person merits a long-term relationship.

## People Who Value Knowledge and Skills Feel Proud of Their Profession

**Micro-expression keywords:** People who value knowledge and skills always find time to recharge their skills. They are ambitious and genuinely love their work. Skilled and knowledgeable, they take pride in their profession and devote all their energy to it. For any enterprise, such employees are rare and precious.

We often say "knowledge is power," because knowledge provides substance and correctly guides people forward. A successful person must be knowledgeable. Gorky once said, "Knowledge is as precious as human blood; without blood the body weakens, without knowledge the mind withers." These words underscore knowledge's importance. Hence those who value knowledge and skills feel proud of their profession.

In today's fiercely competitive society, anyone whose pockets are full but whose mind is empty will struggle to achieve anything. By contrast, those who value their own knowledge and skills become society's favored ones. With solid skills and professional expertise, they feel proud of their work at any time, because the profession gives their knowledge and skills room to flourish.

National hero Xu Zhenchao was an ordinary quayside bridge-crane operator at Qingdao Port. Despite only a junior-high education, he mastered professional knowledge and skills to become a star in his field.

To others the bridge-crane job seemed to require little technique, yet Xu thought otherwise. Through diligent study and practice he mastered “silent operation,” lowering massive containers onto iron ships or trucks without a sound. This minimized wear on containers and vessels, reduced fault rates on crane spreaders, raised efficiency, and lowered costs for the company.

Once Qingdao’s old port area handled a shipment of highly toxic chemicals destined for Xinjiang via the Alashankou border crossing. The cargo could not tolerate even slight impacts. To prevent accidents, armed police and firefighters were stationed at the dock and railway spur. Officials from the Ministry of Railways, the ship owner, and the cargo owner all came to the pier. Unexpectedly, Xu Zhenchao and his team unloaded forty containers from the ship and loaded them onto the train in just ninety minutes, without a single sound. Everyone present was astonished and burst into cheers.

Xu also mastered “one-hook accuracy.” Each container has four locking holes; although large, they are hard to distinguish from dozens of meters above on the crane, let alone align a swinging spreader precisely. Yet Xu and his teammates achieved it. One apprentice said, “It took me a year of practice.”

Xu showed no pride, remarking, “I cannot become a scientist, but I can master a set of ‘unique skills.’ These skills allow me to become a master craftsman—the kind the times and the port need.”

As the enterprise restructured, many employees were laid off, including those with secondary- or tertiary-level diplomas. Xu Zhenchao, with only junior-high schooling, kept his job through his unique skills, became a model employee in a large enterprise, a “core figure,” and a national hero.

People who value knowledge and skills feel proud of their profession no matter their post. “Tsinghua’s steamed-bun god” Zhang Liyong achieved a TOEFL score of 650 because he valued knowledge. Many stop learning after entering the workforce, busy with socializing and neglecting professional knowledge and skills; when unhappy they want to change jobs. Having lost direction in their own field, they become bewildered and are eventually eliminated by society.

Anyone who constantly complains about work and feels bored with it must have outdated knowledge and skills that no longer match the times; unable to survive in the industry, they grow weary.

Meng Fanyu, a reporter for an agricultural magazine, spent every year writing the same seasonal stories: spring plowing, summer support for agriculture, autumn technology in greenhouses, winter leaders visiting workers and farmers. Repeating the cycle year after year, he grew deeply bored.

A friend advised him to skip some dinner parties in his spare time, read more, write articles in various genres, comment on interesting news, and submit essays to different magazines. By pursuing multiple outlets he would feel his learning was limited and would be too busy “recharging” to feel bored. Meng took the advice to heart and, putting it into practice, regained his drive.

Meng felt bored at first because he did not value his own knowledge and skills, was busy socializing, and did not actively learn. When professional knowledge is solid, ability strong, and skills proficient, one does not grow bored with the profession.

Thus those who value knowledge and skills feel proud of their profession, because their knowledge and skills let them lead their field. For business owners, such employees are invaluable; once acquired, they propel the



enterprise's competitiveness forward. If you are an employer, never let such an employee go.

## Entertain Him with Fine Wine and Observe His Behavior When Drunk

### Micro-expression Keywords

Chinese wine culture has a long history. Today wine has become an indispensable part of social interaction. Before befriending someone, entertain the person with fine wine and observe his conduct once drunk; this reveals his true character.

As the saying goes, "wine loosens the tongue," yet others claim "wine disorders the senses." Therefore, in the art of judging character, "intoxicate him with wine to observe his nature" remains an effective method. China has long possessed a rich wine culture, and wine has become an essential medium of exchange between people. If we wish to get to know someone, entertaining him with fine wine and watching his behavior once drunk allows us to discern his true character.

Many believe that a person who grows irritable or argumentative after drinking must be even-tempered and agreeable when sober. In reality this view is absurd. History contains many heroic figures who enjoyed wine as well as many degenerate rulers who indulged in it, yet the rulers remained degenerate and the heroes remained heroic. Drinking is merely a form of enjoyment; wine does not invert human nature or manufacture emotions that did not already exist. It simply removes the sentry of reason, forcing us to display our various flaws.

Thus, after a few cups, a person's every trait—irascibility, sentimentality, generosity, gentleness, greed—emerges with particular clarity. A true gentleman remains magnanimous even when drunk, as in Yue Fei's "hair bristling in fury." By contrast, a petty man wearing a mask, no matter how hard he tries to conceal his inner world, often exposes his base and shameless soul once intoxicated.

Zheng Ta, the general manager of a company, invited Liu Fei, who had served as acting manager of the enterprise-management department for just over a month, to dinner. During that period Liu Fei had been extremely attentive to Zheng Ta, even overlooking several instances when Zheng Ta arrived late. Zheng Ta therefore felt he should do something for Liu Fei.

After three rounds of wine and five courses, Liu Fei's eyes were already glazed. Zheng Ta understood that the invitation itself had filled Liu Fei with pride and a sense of honor. Liu Fei raised his cup again:

"General Manager Zheng, you are the person I admire most in my life. Whatever you need, just say the word. As for the other directors, they are nothing in my eyes." Zheng Ta was astonished; such insolence was completely unlike Liu Fei's usual cautious demeanor. Normally Liu Fei was courteous to the directors and other mid-level leaders, yet Zheng Ta had sensed laxity in the enforcement of several regulations. Liu Fei's words now clarified the reason: Liu Fei was responsible for that area and therefore had a direct connection to the problem.

Zheng Ta lifted his own cup. "Thank you. Let's have another."

Liu Fei pressed Zheng Ta's hand. "General Manager Zheng, you are my superior at work and my elder brother in life. For a friend, I, Liu, will never be ambiguous..." Liu Fei was clearly drunk and began to speak from the heart. At last Zheng Ta understood why the two companies where Liu Fei had previously worked had performed so poorly.

It was evident that although Liu Fei concealed his nature well when sober, he lost control once drunk. Such a person becomes a liability in any enterprise, because his public face differs from his private one and may eventually lead the company to ruin.

Many individuals who appear upright in daily life ultimately display behavior we have never seen before; that behavior is their true character. Most of the time they are simply living behind masks, and we must not be deceived by appearances.

We can compare the following attitudes after intoxication:

- Some people like to sing when drunk. Such individuals generally lead orderly lives and are optimistic and enterprising; although their bodies may be intoxicated, their minds remain clear.
- Some people like to chat, argue, or even fight when drunk. Such individuals are emotionally unstable in daily life, possibly because of long-standing frustration or repeated setbacks; they are classic cases of unrecognized talent and may currently be at a low point in their fortunes.
- Some people fall asleep immediately when drunk. Such individuals are rational, practice self-discipline in ordinary circumstances, and rarely overstep bounds in word or deed.
- Some people boast and make reckless promises when drunk, freely issuing commitments at the table. Such individuals are representatives of the timid type: extremely vain and somewhat negative.
- Some people weep or seek someone to confide in when drunk. Such individuals have negative personalities and deep feelings of inferiority; they have usually suffered severe contempt or many grievances and frequently complain in daily life.
- Some people like to play finger-guessing games or other drinking games when drunk. These are lonely individuals who often feel emotionally isolated and use the physical activity of the games to dispel loneliness. They also tend to bury their troubles in busy work.
- Some people laugh a great deal when drunk. Such individuals are optimistic, easygoing, and informal in life; they also possess a strong sense of humor.

In his day Zhao Kuangyin staged the famous "Dismissal of the Generals over Wine" precisely because, once drunk, he could voice his true thoughts. Therefore, when we wish to understand someone, we may entertain him with fine wine; his behavior while intoxicated will lay everything bare.

## Inform Him of Confidential Matters and See Whether He Can Keep Them Secret

### Micro-expression Keywords

In television dramas, admirable Communist Party members often treat "keeping secrets" as a principle and even sacrifice their lives for it; such people deserve respect and trust. The same holds true in real life. To determine whether someone is trustworthy, tell him something confidential and see whether he remains tight-lipped; only then is he truly worthy of confidence.

The ability to keep a secret is a matter of moral character. When we need to judge whether a person can be trusted, we may deliberately reveal a secret to him and observe whether he keeps it. We can also supply false information; if it leaks, we immediately know he cannot keep his mouth shut and is therefore unworthy of cooperation or trust. It is best to avoid such people.

In today's fiercely competitive society, a single careless remark from someone who cannot keep a secret can cause irreparable damage to an enterprise. Managers must therefore pay close attention to this trait when selecting personnel.

Liu Jing worked as a receptionist at a consulting firm and therefore had access to very little confidential information. The most sensitive details she encountered were simply which colleagues had recently traveled where, which clients were visiting that day, and which hotels needed to be booked.

One day a friend invited Liu Jing to dinner and introduced her to another friend, a researcher at an institute. During the meal the researcher asked about Liu Jing's work and casually inquired about her company. Eager to demonstrate her firm's strength, Liu Jing mentioned several clients. The researcher took note, investigated the relationships, and succeeded in derailing a project Liu Jing's company was about to sign, replacing it with his own institute.

The "cooked duck" flew away, and the manager was furious. Investigation traced the leak to Liu Jing. Considering that the disclosure had been unintentional, the company did not dismiss her but canceled her year-end bonus and promotion opportunity. Thereafter colleagues avoided casual conversation with Liu Jing for fear of being implicated, and the company quickly required all staff to sign confidentiality agreements.

Although Liu Jing's incident was not catastrophic, such inadvertent leaks can still inflict major losses or even bankruptcy. Even if such people have no malicious intent, it is safer to keep certain secrets from them. As the saying goes, "Plans succeed through secrecy and fail through leakage." The success or failure of any major undertaking depends heavily on the ability to keep secrets; we must not allow loose-lipped individuals to become the decisive factor in failure.

In social interactions many people reveal their secrets without reservation. Some feel uneasy unless they have told every detail of their troubles to anyone who asks, believing that withholding information would be insincere. Yet if the listener cannot keep a secret, the information quickly becomes public. Should a conflict of interest later arise, the other party may use the secret against us. People who injure others by disclosing secrets, amuse themselves with them, or treat secrets as leverage for advancement or blackmail are common in real life.

Wang Qiang, an employee at a public institution, worked diligently and earned his superior's favor. To encourage better performance, the superior privately informed Wang Qiang of plans to promote him. Wang Qiang was delighted and decided to celebrate with his office friend Zhao Yong after work. Because the official document had not yet been issued, Wang Qiang asked Zhao Yong to keep the news confidential; Zhao Yong nodded.

Wang Qiang did not anticipate that Zhao Yong had long coveted the same position. Angered by the news, Zhao Yong went to the superior the next day and reported, "Wang Qiang has been openly boasting about his achievements, claiming the leadership has already decided he is the only candidate for promotion."

The superior was enraged and concluded that Wang Qiang had become arrogant because of minor success and required further testing. Through this episode Wang Qiang also recognized Zhao Yong's true character, but too late.

Wang Qiang was angry that Zhao Yong could not keep a secret, yet he himself had chosen to reveal it. Therefore we should not lightly entrust secrets to those who cannot keep them. We must use the method of "asking plainly to observe virtue" to test the other party; only when we know someone thoroughly should we consider entrusting him with confidential information.

People who can keep secrets earn widespread respect because their discretion makes every undertaking reliable. Conversely, those who cannot keep secrets are never worthy of trust. Recognizing their true nature protects us from harm.

## Let Him Handle Money and See Whether He Is Honest

### Micro-expression Keywords

Human desire is boundless and difficult to satisfy. Many corrupt officials fall precisely because they cannot resist the lure of gain. To determine whether someone is reliable, let him handle money; if he withstands the temptation, he is dependable.

Once money enters the picture, whether in life or work, it becomes hard to disentangle ourselves. In the presence of money, inner desires are fully exposed. Therefore, to judge a person we can use financial interests as bait to reveal his inner good or evil. For example, in the workplace a manager's greatest annoyance is an employee who deceives the company and lines his own pockets. In an era when kickbacks are common, if an employee accepts kickbacks and turns a blind eye to the quality of purchased materials, any resulting accident can cause irreparable damage—especially when the employee works in a critical department such as finance or procurement.

When selecting personnel for such positions we must therefore exercise strict scrutiny. Not everyone succumbs to money, so we can place a candidate in a profitable role, give him an opportunity to obtain funds, and let him handle money; his conduct will show whether he is honest and impartial.

Zhao Gang, general manager of a foreign-trade company, needed to hire a cashier because the previous one had been caught keeping gifts intended for clients. Zhao Gang was determined to assess the candidate's character during recruitment.

A few days later the clever and attractive Liu Fang caught Zhao Gang's eye. She was adept at reading people and her smile was genuinely pleasing, so she was selected as the company's probationary cashier and warehouse keeper.

Intelligence and appearance alone did not guarantee suitability for the role, so Zhao Gang decided to test Liu Fang. He called her into his office and pointed to a batch of red porcelain cups a friend had just delivered. "Xiao Liu, take these cups to the warehouse; they will be given to clients soon."

"All right, General Manager Zhao. How many cups are there?" Liu Fang asked.

"I didn't count them. They were a gift; just move them over."

Liu Fang said nothing more and picked up the cups. Zhao Gang added, "Xiao Liu, after you put the cups away, go to the office-supply wholesaler on West Eighth Road and buy one hundred archive folders like the one I'm holding." He held up a sample.

"No problem!" Liu Fang smiled and headed for the warehouse. Zhao Gang watched her, hoping she would pass the test. He had already checked prices on West Eighth Road: retail folders cost 0.5 yuan each, while twenty or more cost only 0.3 yuan.

Liu Fang soon returned with the folders; the invoice showed 0.6 yuan each. Zhao Gang said nothing. A few days later he had several departments collect cups for clients. Liu Fang was told to record who took how many. Zhao Gang privately noted the quantities each colleague received. When he checked the final tally, three cups were missing.

Liu Fang failed the test. Such an employee is a cancer to the enterprise; if not removed promptly, she may cause serious consequences.

An enterprise's survival and growth depend on sound financial management. If employees cannot resist the temptation of money, the enterprise cannot endure. The best way to judge an employee's integrity is to observe him in practice. Let him handle funds and watch whether he shows any tendency toward embezzlement; even if none appears, check whether he accepts bribes. Financial matters often involve multiple parties, so bribery is always possible. Once bribed, an employee may violate company rules or favor one side; such risks must be guarded against.

In general, people display three types of behavior in the presence of money:

1. The first type shows no restraint; under the guidance of self-interest they openly and brazenly demand money. Once such people gain power, serious consequences inevitably follow.
2. The second type appears to reject money at a distance yet secretly tries to obtain as much as possible, easily creating a false impression; such people require special attention.
3. The third type maintains moral boundaries, remains upright whether observed or unobserved, and adheres to principle without taking anything improper. Such people are extremely rare and best suited for positions of great responsibility.

Human nature is complex. To see through it, use money as a probe. Faced with profit, anyone will shed the cloak of hypocrisy and reveal his most naked inner thoughts.

### Assign Him a Difficult Task to Gauge His Ability

Micro-expression keywords: It is often said that a diploma is a stepping stone, but does holding a graduation certificate from a prestigious university necessarily mean superior ability? Probably not. In fact, the simplest way to test someone's ability is to assign them a difficult task and see whether they can complete it in a short time; the result is the best proof.

When we want to understand a person's ability, the best method is to give them a difficult task. For example, increase their workload or assign a task that is hard to finish, or have them handle repetitive and tedious work. This approach accurately reveals a person's overall quality, because those with special talent can always accomplish in the same amount of time what ordinary people cannot.

In today's society, more and more people are good at boasting about their abilities, yet when it comes to real work they shrink like turtles pulling in their heads. Success does not depend on whether someone graduated from a top university or on how extravagantly they praise themselves; it depends on whether they possess real skill. As the saying goes, only true gold remains after the waves wash away the sand. When dealing with others, what you hear is not always fact; to tell whether it is a mule or a horse, take it out for a walk and the truth becomes clear at once.

During the Three Kingdoms period, when Shu chancellor Zhuge Liang launched his sixth northern expedition from Mount Qi, he assigned Li Yan the task of supplying grain and fodder to the rear. Li Yan regarded this as a misuse of his talent. Unable to withstand the test of such complex and arduous work, he not only failed to deliver supplies on time—forcing Zhuge Liang's northern army to retreat—but also spread rumors before the Second Emperor Liu Shan. In the end, Zhuge Liang and the ministers had no choice but to petition the emperor to punish Li Yan severely, stripping him of office and title.

In sharp contrast to Li Yan's failure, Xiao He, during the Chu-Han contention, helped Liu Bang "stabilize the state, pacify the people, and keep the supply lines open so that grain never ran out." He ultimately secured victory in the war and was recognized by Emperor Gaozu of Han, who appointed him chancellor.

Whether a person has ability is not decided by what others say, nor by what they say about themselves; the outcome of their work is the best proof.

Ma Jiandong, from Weifang, Shandong, is 27 years old and a high-school graduate. He currently serves as sales director of an automobile company that has established more than 300 dealerships across over 200 cities nationwide, with total sales of 107,000 vehicles and net assets exceeding 100 million yuan; his annual salary is 600,000 yuan.

How did an ordinary high-school graduate reach the position of director and become a “gold-rush emperor”? After failing the college entrance exam, Ma Jiandong went to Beijing to work and found a job as a front-desk receptionist at an automobile sales company; later he was moved to clerical work in the office.

A year later, the company faced closure after media exposure of quality problems with a major brand it represented. At that time Ma Jiandong secretly applied to another automobile sales company, only to be told, “You haven’t even crossed the threshold of a university—why should we hire you?” and was turned away. That single remark spurred him to study automobile sales techniques and product knowledge with great determination. Through years of hands-on experience, Ma Jiandong accumulated rich expertise in automobile sales and set a record of selling 476 vehicles in five months, earning him promotion to supervisor. He was subsequently sent by the general manager to Peking University’s MBA program, dispatched to Germany to study automobile sales management, and eventually rose to sales director.

At any time, genuine knowledge and real ability are what convince people. Some carry an enviable diploma; others list attractive titles on their business cards. Truly wise individuals never judge ability by these things alone. Instead, they test a person’s competence through practice. A prestigious diploma may conceal an empty “straw sack,” and a title on a card may be nothing more than self-inflated vanity.

Everyone presumably remembers Zhuangzi’s essay “The Cook Carves the Ox.” The cook’s skill had reached such a sublime level that his technique appeared almost supernatural. With a touch of the hand, a lean of the shoulder, a press of the foot, and a nudge of the knee, his knife moved as if guided by a spirit; in a few swift strokes a massive carcass was cleanly separated—meat from meat, bone from bone, hide from hide. More remarkably, after nineteen years and thousands of oxen, the cook’s knife remained as sharp as if it had just been honed on a whetstone. If you wish to know whether someone truly possesses the ability they claim, or whether their ability matches the level they assert, simply assign them a task and observe the result.

## Touching the Cuffs Indicates the Other Party Is Beginning to Waver

What scheme is he plotting? What is she thinking? In an era when people’s hearts grow ever harder to read, let FBI agents tell you how to understand someone’s inner world through their words, actions, and movements.

A sexual scandal involving a well-known American figure drew intense media attention, and FBI agents played a crucial role in solving the case.

Agents obtained the perpetrator’s DNA sample from the assaulted hotel maid’s clothing. The next day, after confirming a match with the celebrity, they brought him to FBI headquarters. At first he was defiant, insisting the encounter had been consensual. As details emerged and witnesses appeared one after another, agents noticed that although he never verbally admitted to non-consensual acts, he began to waver internally. This convinced them that the maid’s account was not fabricated.

How did the agents detect this psychological shift?

World-renowned body-language expert and former FBI counterintelligence specialist Joe Navarro, with twenty-five years of experience, explains: "Approximately 60 to 80 percent of human communication occurs through nonverbal behavior. In this case, as evidence of sexual misconduct mounted, agents observed that during interviews the subject increasingly used one hand to adjust his cuff or fiddle with his watch—an unmistakable sign of internal wavering."

Psychologists have confirmed through experiments that people instinctively play with cuffs, cuff buttons, or watches as a defensive gesture when feeling flustered. Women who repeatedly adjust the position of a handbag on their arm are likewise displaying signs of psychological unease.

Seasoned agents therefore used this cue as a breakthrough: whenever the subject adjusted his cuff or played with his watch, they pressed harder, extracting numerous facts and ultimately establishing his guilt of sexual assault.

Under normal circumstances, such cuff-fiddling behavior readily reveals inner instability and reduces others' trust. Yet for eliciting information it is extremely useful, because the subject's psychological defenses are then at their weakest.

In social settings, frequent cuff-fiddlers often give opponents an opening. In the workplace, those who repeatedly fiddle with their cuffs tend to remain at the bottom of the hierarchy, assigned trivial tasks because they betray inner anxiety. The same holds true in conversation: it is a game of strategy; whoever first exposes a weakness loses earliest.

Experts therefore advise that when trying to draw someone out, you may exploit another's unease but should minimize similar gestures yourself. Especially when speaking with unfamiliar people or in public, avoid such behavior.

Control does not mean concealment. Placing your arms under the table is not foolproof; it too signals weakness. Unless absolutely necessary, keep your hands above the table. If you must adjust a cuff or watch below the table, return your hands to the tabletop immediately afterward. If you feel nervous and wish to hide it, adjust your breathing or take a sip of water instead.

Remember: never let the other person perceive you as lacking confidence or substance. Raise your own perceived value and maintain a superior posture that tells them, "I am the best."

## Inability to Recount Events in Reverse Means Lying

A certain television drama contains an amusing scene: after waiting a long time, the protagonist finally finds a parking space, only to have another car speed in and steal it just as he begins to reverse. He confronts the driver: "Didn't you see I had been waiting for this spot?" The driver nods, then shakes his head repeatedly, claiming innocently, "No, I was waiting too." The protagonist replies seriously, "You're lying—because before you shook your head you first nodded slightly..."

That single inadvertent nod betrayed the driver's secret. Clearly, lies are not impregnable; careful observation easily reveals a person's true thoughts through small, unintentional actions.

Everyone lies. A famous professor once noted that of every ten people we interact with daily, five are lying. Even the kindest person tells at least two lies per day on average. Most lies aim to conceal something or to prevent others from seeing one's true thoughts. This tendency is especially evident during interrogations.

FBI agent Jack interviewed a suspect and asked, "What did you do on the day of the incident?" The suspect answered fluently: "At eight I went to the convenience store, at ten I was on my way to work, at twelve I was eating a working lunch..." The timeline seemed to prove he had not been at the crime scene. Jack then said, "Please repeat what you just told me, but in reverse chronological order." After a long pause the suspect stammered, "At five in the afternoon I... I was..." He could not recount his activities backward. Jack therefore concluded he was lying.

People who prepare to lie can rehearse fluent answers in advance, but because they did not actually experience the events, those details never enter deep memory. Asking them to recount events in reverse exposes the fabrication. When facing a skilled liar, use this technique: pretend you did not hear clearly, pick out several time points from their account, and ask them to describe those moments again. If they cannot answer fluently, the lie becomes obvious.

The following signs during conversation also indicate lying:

- Speech is faster and smoother than usual, showing prior preparation.
- Answers are evasive and the mouth moves while the hands remain still.
- Long pauses, frequent hesitation, rigid posture, and minimal change in position.
- Eyes either avoid contact or pupils are larger than normal.
- Introverted individuals speak very haltingly when lying.

In short, no matter how sophisticated the technique, a liar always leaves traces. Even when words are seamless, body language betrays the truth. Detecting a lie grants a decisive psychological advantage; once you know the other person's real thoughts, you are no longer at their mercy. In commercial negotiations especially, mastering these techniques allows you to seize the initiative.

## People Who Tug at Their Collar May Be Lying

In films we often see the male lead, upon discovering his beloved in another man's arms, yank at his collar and undo the top button of his shirt. Even when wearing a tie he impatiently loosens it—gestures that perfectly convey agitation and unease. The actions stem from the heat of anger; he pulls the collar away from his neck to let cool air in.

More often, however, a man tugs at his collar for reasons other than mere irritation.

Jones had been troubled by questions about her new boyfriend. She wanted to know whether he had ever had a serious girlfriend before her. So she kept probing: "Was your ex-girlfriend pretty?" "Was she gentle?" Each time the topic arose, her boyfriend grew visibly agitated yet always replied cleverly, "Did I ever have a girlfriend? Of course not." While speaking he would unconsciously tug at his collar. Seeing this, Jones realized he was lying; his evasive answers only confirmed his guilt. Instead of losing her temper, she smiled and said, "I hope we can be completely open with each other. You know I'm not a petty person..."

Research shows that when people lie, the sensitive nerves in the neck produce an itchy sensation, prompting an instinctive rubbing or scratching motion to relieve the discomfort.

Objectively, men tug at collars more often than women because men typically wear suits and shirts, whereas women's clothing varies and some styles lack collars. When a woman lies, she is more likely to change the subject or turn her face away. For women who value poise, collar-tugging appears too masculine. Therefore, the gesture alone cannot confirm that someone is lying.



The accompanying facial expression is more telling. If the person is indeed lying, collar-tugging will coincide with subtle facial changes—such as averting direct eye contact. We usually determine deception by combining a shifting gaze with the instinctive collar tug.

Liars may also display an uncomfortable smile because their words do not match their feelings. A genuine smile is an unconscious facial movement beyond direct cortical control; it produces fine lines around the eyes. A false smile, directed by conscious thought, moves only the mouth muscles and looks unnatural, with fine lines appearing only around the mouth.

When uncertain whether a collar-tug stems from discomfort or from fear of exposure, follow Jones's example: respond with a sincere smile and ask, "Is something bothering you? I hope we can be open with each other," or "What did you just say? Could you repeat it?" This approach may elicit a more truthful response.

## Yu Pengnian: From Odd-Job Worker to Philanthropist

Yu Pengnian, originally named Peng Lishan, is currently chairman of Hong Kong Fude Development Co., Ltd. and president of the Hong Kong Yu's Charity Foundation. Yu Pengnian is wealthy, yet he has directed all his money toward social welfare causes. He is passionate about supporting education and social welfare and is the first philanthropist in mainland China to establish a private charitable foundation exceeding one billion U.S. dollars.

On the subject of philanthropy, Yu Pengnian has many classic sayings: "If my son is weaker than I am, why leave him money? If my son is stronger than I am, why leave him money?" "Doing good is the way to nurture health; heaven knows when one does good." It can be said that performing charitable acts has always been Yu Pengnian's dream; he believes doing good brings him great happiness.

Yu Pengnian himself came from hardship. In 1958, at the age of thirty, he left his wife and children and traveled via Macau to Hong Kong. Starting as an odd-job worker, he advanced step by step to become a boss, mainly engaged in real estate, construction, and the hotel industry. After fifty years of struggle in Hong Kong and Taiwan, he became a wealthy industrialist with assets worth several billion. He operates hotels, office buildings, and real estate with holdings in Hong Kong, Taiwan, and overseas. Rising from odd-job worker to chairman of a five-star hotel and renowned philanthropist was no easy achievement.

Since 1981 he has donated more than 25 million yuan to his native Hunan province, building more than twenty social welfare projects. In 1995 he was elected a deputy to the Shenzhen Municipal People's Congress. He invested 1.8 billion yuan to construct the fifty-seven-story five-star Pengnian Building in Shenzhen's Luohu commercial district and pledged that the hotel's net profits would be donated permanently and entirely to social welfare and education. As a member of the Standing Committee of the Shenzhen Municipal People's Congress, he has proposed legislation stipulating that after his death the building's ownership will neither be gifted nor inherited; a dedicated asset-management committee will operate it, and all profits will continue to be donated without compensation in perpetuity.

In 2003 Yu Pengnian signed a charitable-asset custody and supervision agreement with the Shenzhen branch of the Industrial and Commercial Bank of China. Under the agreement the bank would safely hold and oversee the use of his charitable assets. Yu Pengnian stated: "My money was not easily earned, but my personal wealth will not be left to my children or grandchildren."

In May 2005, through the Industrial and Commercial Bank of China, he disclosed an estimate of his assets, including the Pengnian Hotel building and his Hong Kong properties; total assets at that time did not exceed

three billion yuan.

In 2007 Yu Pengnian was named one of the world's fourteen greatest philanthropists by Time magazine. On 2 April 2008 the Hurun Philanthropy List announced in Shanghai that the eighty-six-year-old Yu Pengnian, called "the oldest philanthropist," had again won the title of "China's Most Generous Philanthropist" with donations totaling three billion yuan. This marked his third time topping the Hurun list.

Yu Pengnian was also the first person to make an actual "naked donation." At a charity dinner on 29 September 2010 he announced on the spot that he was entrusting 9.3 billion Hong Kong dollars to HSBC for management, all to be used for charity after his death. The eighty-eight-year-old Yu Pengnian attended the "Barbie" charity dinner leaning on a cane and said: "My views are the same as those of Gates and Buffett. I am therefore very happy to accept their invitation."

In daily life Yu Pengnian never lived luxuriously. He ate in the staff cafeteria; the Pengnian Hotel cafeteria reserved a seat for him, where he had three simple vegetarian meals and soup each day. On the cafeteria wall hangs his own calligraphy: "Oppose waste; better to serve one more helping."

## Clinton's Denial of an Affair with Lewinsky

Clinton's lying-analysis case (denying an affair with Lewinsky) has appeared in many books on lie detection. Some psychologists have analyzed that when he denied improper sexual relations with Lewinsky, the direction of his eyes and speech differed from the direction pointed by his index finger, proving he was lying.

This analysis quickly became mainstream and remains so, accepted by countless people. It has also led to overuse: the public treats the subtle directional difference as a discovered treasure that can prove lying. Yet to date no one has demonstrated the deeper basis for this conclusion.

Does the claim hold water?

### **Analysis begins:**

His script at the time was: "I did not have sexual relations with that woman, Miss Lewinsky. I never told anybody to lie, not a single time. Never. These allegations are false." His tone was calm and his pace and pauses normal.

His action was to jab his right index finger forward and downward rapidly and repeatedly with force, while his eyes looked toward his own left front, as if speaking to another specific person.

The finger movement expressed inner anger.

The reason Clinton's eyes and finger pointed in different directions while speaking was that, as president forced to explain the scandal to the media, his emotions were highly complex.

He must have felt intense anger—how could this matter have been exposed?—while also feeling fear about his future and negative public opinion. The clearly aggressive finger movement was meant to express that inner anger.

We have explained, however, that the offensive nature of anger causes the entire body to point uniformly at the stimulus source; an angry person's eyes must be fixed on the opponent. If Clinton had been purely angry without any fear, his glaring eyes would have moved in sync with his finger, looking at the opponent while attacking. By shifting his more sensitive and critical line of sight, his eyes not looking toward the target of the

finger attack, he revealed that his anger was mixed with another emotion—guilt that made the attack incomplete. Why would he feel guilty while denying the affair? There is only one answer.

At least the method of judging through emotional response has logic, unlike the blunt summary that “finger direction differing from eye direction equals lying.” Simply using mismatched eye and finger directions cannot be justified. Interested readers can search later Clinton videos and photos and will find numerous instances of mismatched eye and finger directions. Does that mean he was lying every time he spoke publicly?

Search other celebrities and observe how common the “eye and finger directions mismatch” phenomenon is; one will see that this formulaic conclusion is false.

## The Story of the Rural Old Lady and Bill Gates

A rural old lady left home for the first time to visit her nephew. When she pushed her large suitcase into the airport terminal, she found that the nephew who was supposed to meet her had not arrived on time. Unfamiliar with the surroundings, she had no choice but to sit and wait.

Having drunk a lot of water on the plane, she now urgently needed the restroom, yet she was carrying such a large suitcase. Although the contents were not valuable, they were gifts she had saved for relatives and friends. She could only endure, anxiously looking around in hopes that her nephew would appear soon.

A young man seated nearby noticed her anxiety and asked with a smile, “Ma’am, do you need help?”

“Oh, thank you, not for now.” The old lady glanced at the young man and inwardly blamed her nephew: “That unpunctual fellow; I’ll give him a good talking-to later.”

The young man then took a book from his pocket and began reading intently. After a while the nephew still had not come, and the old lady could no longer hold on. She pleaded with the reading young man: “I’m terribly sorry, but could you please watch my luggage while I go to the restroom? Would that be all right?”

The young man nodded readily.

The old lady returned quickly, thanked him gratefully, took a U.S. dollar from her pocket, handed it to him, and said, “Thank you, young man; this is your due reward.”

Seeing the old lady’s earnest expression, the young man accepted the money, replied “Thank you,” and put it in his pocket<|eos|>

## Yao Hai's Case

Yao Hai is the general manager of a planning company. Teachers' Day is approaching, and Yao Hai's company is preparing to organize a public welfare event involving teachers and students from several local universities. The success of this event affects the company's reputation and capabilities, so it cannot be neglected. Yao Hai therefore decides to check in briefly with Zhao Sicong, head of the public relations department and the person in charge of the event, to learn the details and see whether she has taken the matter to heart.

“Xiao Zhao, how will you ensure that the director of the education commission attends our event?” Yao Hai asks the moment Zhao Sicong enters the room.

“I’ll tell the director that Deputy Mayor Li, who oversees education, will also attend. That way the director won’t refuse!” Zhao Sicong replies confidently. Yao Hai nods and continues, “Then how can we guarantee that

Deputy Mayor Li will definitely come? After all, this is only a public welfare event."

"I'll bring a student representative with me to meet Deputy Mayor Li and have the representative express how thousands of students are looking forward to his personal guidance at the event. Then I'll add details about the event's significance and scale, especially noting that all major news media are paying close attention and that twelve provincial media outlets will send reporters on-site." Zhao Sicong has clearly done her homework; she answers without hesitation, citing every detail.

"Then how will we ensure that the participating universities approach the event with a positive attitude while our company incurs no costs?" Yao Hai asks again.

Zhao Sicong smiles and says, "We'll simply tell them the truth. We'll say the education commission leaders hope every participating university will showcase its strength, and that many journalists will be present, so they should seize the chance to promote their institutions during interviews. I believe the universities will participate very enthusiastically!" Yao Hai nods with satisfaction.

As expected, on Teachers' Day the education commission director arrives with Deputy Mayor Li, the participating universities are well organized, and each brings its own distinctive features: some students wear matching school uniforms, others carry inspiring banners, and still others wave floral wreaths together. The event is a complete success, creates a major stir locally, and Yao Hai's company benefits greatly.

Naturally, Zhao Sicong, the chief contributor, is promoted to the substantive position of public relations department manager.

When an employee can answer every question with solid reasoning even without prior notice, every company values such a person. Only by asking sudden questions can we truly see whether an employee is devoted to the company and to their own work. This approach also reveals the employee's level of knowledge.

## Introducing People of Different Status to Observe Whether Someone Is Snobbish

Micro-expression keyword: To determine whether a person is snobbish, introduce them to several people of varying status. If their attitude clearly differs toward each, the person is snobbish; they will flatter you when you succeed and abandon you when you fail. Draw a clear line with such people and keep your distance. If their attitude remains consistent, the person is upright and worth knowing.

Many people in daily life are snobbish, favoring the rich over the poor, the beautiful over the plain, or foreigners over locals. Associating with such people often leads to eventual abandonment, because once you fall on hard times they will leave. The simplest way to identify them is to introduce friends of different status and watch whether their attitude changes.

For example, when attending a banquet or party with a friend, you may introduce several of your acquaintances and exchange business cards. If your friend glances at a card with obvious disdain, you have identified a snob.

Liu Yong once brought his friend Qiang Ning to a reception. Liu Yong spotted the president of a well-known company he knew from work, went over for a drink, and introduced Qiang Ning. After seeing the president's card, Qiang Ning's reaction astonished Liu Yong: her smile could melt ice cream, and she said in a honeyed voice, "President Liu, what good fortune from a past life brought me the chance to meet someone as accomplished as you!" She then launched into an eager conversation regardless of the other party's willingness.

Recognizing a rare opportunity to connect with someone of "status," Qiang Ning searched for topics, echoed every remark, and worked to create a pleasant atmosphere.

Seeing how animated Qiang Ning was, Liu Yong assumed she enjoyed meeting people and introduced another friend. Qiang Ning glanced at the new card, replied with a flat "Hello," and turned away to find food, showing no interest in further acquaintance.

Only then did Liu Yong realize Qiang Ning was an outright snob who would not even exchange basic courtesies with people of no use to her. From that day on, he gradually distanced himself.

Snobbish people fawn only over those in power and never spare a glance for those beneath them. You can never count on such a person for help; you should consider yourself fortunate if they do not ask you for favors.

## Song Gaozong's Test for Selecting a Crown Prince

During the Southern Song dynasty, Emperor Gaozong was aging and frail. Knowing that "a state cannot be without a ruler for a single day," he decided to appoint a crown prince while still clear-minded, to prevent chaos should he die suddenly.

Yet whom to choose? After consideration, two candidates came to mind: Zhao Ju, then Prince Enping, and Zhao Shen, later Emperor Xiaozong. Their strategic abilities were comparable, their qualifications adequate, and each had distinct strengths, leaving Gaozong undecided.

Zhao Ju was clever, calculating, and reserved; Empress Xian Sheng favored him and showered him with affection.

Zhao Shen, by contrast, was bold, wise, and upright; Gaozong liked him and was inclined to name him crown prince. When both the empress and Qin Hui urged Gaozong to appoint Prince Enping, the emperor paid no heed.

Gaozong ignored all advice. Neither candidate had yet demonstrated the qualities of an enlightened ruler capable of preserving the hard-won Song realm, so he resolved to test their character personally and choose the one of better moral fiber. He devised a method of observation.

One day Gaozong summoned both men and said, "I have been occupied with state affairs and have not looked after you adequately. I recently heard your palaces lack sufficient maids, so I am granting each of you ten palace maids. This will ease your burdens and spare you the need to recruit from among the common people."

Zhao Ju and Zhao Shen thanked the emperor, each received his ten maids, and returned to his palace.

A month later Gaozong suddenly recalled them and said, "The maids I granted you last time are needed elsewhere. Return all of them; not one may be missing."

After the maids were brought back, Gaozong ordered an inspection. All ten granted to Zhao Ju had been violated; the ten granted to Zhao Shen remained untouched. Shocked by the report, Gaozong drew a sharp breath. He had not imagined Prince Enping could be so dissolute. If such a man ascended the throne, he would spend his days lost in the pleasures of the harem and never attend to affairs of state.

Often people feign uprightness to achieve their ends. Without vigilance against such hypocrisy, one can fall into danger unaware. Probing character through human nature allows reliable judgment and underscores the value of personal integrity.

## Characteristics of "Snobbish" People

- **First, snobbish people overemphasize appearances.**

They often decide whether to befriend someone based on superficial markers: whether the person's employer is a well-known company, whether their title is senior, how much their clothing costs, or whether they pay with a gold or platinum card. If your "equipment" is not high-end, you may be classified as a low-priority contact even if you are wealthy.

- **Second, snobbish people treat others differently according to status.**

In *Soldiers Sortie*, Cheng Cai, newly arrived in the unit, exemplifies this behavior: he carries two packs of cigarettes, offering the good brand to leaders and the inferior brand to fellow soldiers. To identify a snob, simply ask how junior staff feel about the person; the answer will be reliable. In the workplace it is common for employees to show one face to the boss and another to colleagues. Snobs ingratiate themselves with the boss because they believe only the boss can grant favors. Yet if junior employees hold a poor impression, word eventually reaches the boss, who will see the true character. A clear-sighted leader must therefore learn to spot snobs.

- **Third, snobbish people rank their friends.**

The word "impartial" does not exist in their vocabulary. They not only treat people differently but also assign friends to tiers: the merely wealthy, powerful, or famous occupy the ordinary tier; those who are both wealthy and powerful occupy the middle tier; those who are wealthy, powerful, and famous are their "heavyweight" contacts. They adjust their flattery according to each tier, but the underlying attitude is always sycophantic; only the degree varies.

- **Fourth, snobbish people calculate how much benefit others can bring.**

They befriend someone only if that person can deliver tangible advantages or future help; otherwise they invest no effort. They never accept a loss. If an investment yields no return, they will find a way to recover the benefit.

A snobbish friend harms one's development. Identify such people by introducing them to friends of different status and observing whether their attitude changes. Once a snob is detected, draw a clear boundary, keep a safe distance, and avoid being used.

## Minor Questions Reveal Major Flaws

During an interrogation in a criminal case, investigators asked, "How did you find and hire the victim?"

The suspect replied, "I called a number from a domestic-service flyer posted on a utility pole."

Investigators followed up: "How much did you agree to pay?"

"Two hundred yuan per hour."

"Two hundred yuan per hour is expensive. What did you want her to do?"

"My wife had been away for a long time and I am lazy. The apartment had not been cleaned for half a year, so I asked her to do a thorough cleaning. The price was already discounted eight percent; a deep clean normally

costs two hundred fifty yuan per hour. Later she agreed to the lower rate because we were from the same hometown and the job would take six hours."

The investigators exchanged glances, confirmed that local domestic-service rates matched the quoted figure, and moved on.

Seeing this, the suspect's lips curved in a faint smile. He leaned back, tapped the armrest with his right index and middle fingers, stretched his legs, and let his feet swing slightly.

This is a classic victory response, revealing the suspect's sense of triumph and accomplishment.

Interrogations often touch on basic local facts such as prices, culture, or common knowledge. When these questions have no direct link to the case, they are neutral; answering correctly should produce no smugness, and failing to answer should produce no discomfort or anxiety. The suspect's inappropriate emotional display therefore constituted a micro-reaction flaw.

Under sustained logical and detail-oriented questioning, supported by physical evidence, the suspect later confessed that he had impulsively attempted to molest the victim, causing her to fall and suffer a fatal skull fracture.

**Counter-conditioning therapy:** Replace an existing stimulus-response association with a new one. For example, if someone fears spiders, present a pleasant stimulus (such as food) whenever a spider appears, thereby converting the "spider-fear" link into a "spider-pleasure" link.

**Aversion therapy:** Also replaces an existing stimulus-response association, but substitutes an aversive stimulus for a pleasant one. In the boyfriend-and-gaming example, one would introduce unpleasant stimuli while the boyfriend plays games, gradually transforming the "gaming-pleasure" association.

## Case Analysis

Fang Ziheng is the general manager of a growing company. Overwhelmed by the expanding workload, he decides to hire an internal vice president who can handle major responsibilities independently. Because the candidate must possess genuine ability and genuine loyalty, Fang chooses to evaluate internal staff.

After reviewing eligible employees, he narrows the field to Hou Ming and Qin Kai, both of whom demonstrate strong capability. Fang decides to test their character using the "ask about right and wrong to observe their aspirations" method.

"I have a friend who is a business owner. One of his recruitment questions asks, 'What kind of person do you want to become?' One applicant's answer—'I want to become a successful boss'—greatly annoyed my friend. Isn't that ridiculous?" Fang raises the topic casually.

"Anyone who answers that way is unreliable and should never be promoted," Hou Ming says.

"I disagree," Qin Kai replies. "I think such a person is worth promoting. Only someone who aspires to be a boss or already possesses certain boss-like qualities will think from the boss's perspective and share the burden."

"Let's not argue about it," Fang says, steering the conversation elsewhere.

"Recently my friend has disappointed me. In the past he always took my calls personally; now his secretary answers, and several times she has said he is unavailable. Clearly he is avoiding me. Isn't that infuriating?"

Hou Ming responds quickly: "Anyone who becomes arrogant the moment they become a boss will soon have fewer and fewer friends." His remark is reasonable, yet Qin Kai's answer gives Fang pause: "A boss must be organized, and time management is part of that. Politely declining is more courteous than insincerely pretending to be available."

Unsurprisingly, Qin Kai is appointed vice president, while Hou Ming remains a conscientious and reliable office director.

## The Story of Chen Sheng Proclaiming Himself King

Sima Qian recorded in the *Records of the Grand Historian* the story of Chen Sheng killing his friends from his impoverished days after he proclaimed himself king.

When Chen Sheng was young, he was very poor and landless. He once worked as a hired hand for a wealthy family. One day, while resting on a field ridge, he grew indignant at the Qin dynasty's reckless conscription of labor and its relentless oppression and exploitation of the common people. Determined to escape that oppression and change his own station, he told his fellow laborers, "If any of us ever becomes rich and noble, let us not forget one another." The others replied, "You are only a hired hand—how could you ever rise to wealth and rank?"

Yet the world is unpredictable. A few years later Chen Sheng raised the banner of revolt at Dazexiang, became "King of Zhang Chu," and truly attained wealth and rank.

His old companions were delighted and naturally made their way to Chen's capital. Chen Sheng welcomed them warmly, brought them into the palace, showed them around with obvious pride, and treated them to fine meat and wine.

Gradually, however, the men grew presumptuous. They spoke to Chen as equals and repeatedly recounted his humble, inglorious past. Chen's attendants warned him that such talk damaged his dignity. Newly enthroned and eager to assert authority, Chen Sheng found a pretext and had all his former companions killed.

Those who have long been rich speak fondly of the past when they fall into poverty; those who have long been poor speak of the past with aversion once they rise. Although reminiscing about shared hardship may seem friendly, to the newly rich it is a source of shame. More often they avoid their "poor brothers" altogether.

Thus wealth and rank reveal character most clearly. As the saying goes, "When the cunning hare is dead, the hunting dog is cooked; when the rival state is destroyed, the strategist is discarded." In hardship people readily unite and become friends or partners, yet once that shared hardship ends they often betray one another to protect themselves. Therefore, whether choosing friends, partners, or talent, one must proceed with great care. Observing whom a person befriends after becoming wealthy is especially revealing.

## The Case of an Accidental Homicide

In an accidental homicide case, Party A led seven men in surrounding and beating Party B, who had taken refuge inside a car. During the melee one of Party A's men was stabbed in the neck and killed. With no surveillance footage and extreme confusion at the scene, it was impossible to determine who had wielded the knife. Each of the seven participants claimed to have been unarmed, and the weapon was never recovered. All seven were therefore subjected to polygraph examinations. Before formal testing, each underwent a forty-minute to one-hour pre-test interview.



Most striking was Party B—the man who had been attacked. Throughout the interview his hands and feet remained completely motionless, as though frozen to the chair. His tone, facial expressions, and breathing, however, appeared natural: grief, anger, fear when recalling events, and aversion toward the assailants. When speaking of the deceased he displayed a fluid mix of contempt, anger, and a trace of sympathy—humanitarian concern for the man’s family and children. Yet the polygraph data clearly implicated him. During subsequent interrogation he admitted that, while defending himself, he had unintentionally stabbed the victim. Police later recovered the discarded knife at the location he indicated.

Re-examining the pre-test interview, the frozen posture of his hands and feet was plainly unnatural. If his emotions were genuine and he was the victim, there was no reason for his limbs to remain rigidly still while his face, breathing, and speech moved freely. That freeze response pointed to a psychologically induced state of constraint. What was he afraid of? He answered every question police posed with apparent naturalness and emotion; the only fear that could account for the immobility was fear of legal consequences for the unintended killing.

## Real-World Examples

In poverty everyone is alike and can readily “share hardship,” but once wealth arrives the situation changes. It is not uncommon for people who suddenly become rich to abandon their families and cut ties with former poor friends; such people are best avoided. Conversely, those who remain unconcerned about their impoverished friends after attaining wealth are worth knowing.

Jiang Tianyang and Peng Wu were close friends who worked together in a big city. When Jiang Tianyang went several days without finding work and could barely get by, Peng Wu supported him, buying food they ate together. Jiang Tianyang said gratefully, “Peng Wu, when I make it big I will treat you well.”

Fortune turned. A few years later Jiang Tianyang’s real-estate business flourished. Many people sought his company; he was constantly hosting dinners or sending holiday gifts. His old friend Peng Wu did not intrude—whether because Jiang was too busy or because Peng felt awkward about the changed circumstances. Jiang, however, had not forgotten his promise.

Hearing that Peng Wu had been laid off during an economic downturn, Jiang immediately sought him out, offered a sum of money, and said, “You helped me when I was down; now let me help you. Please don’t refuse.” Peng Wu was deeply moved. He had not expected the now-wealthy Jiang to remember his earlier pledge. He felt fortunate to have befriended the right person.

True friends never discard you after becoming rich; only the insincere do so in order to pursue equals or those even wealthier. Such behavior reveals a petty character. Therefore, to judge someone, observe whom he associates with after becoming wealthy before deciding whether the friendship is worthwhile.

## Lincoln’s Campaign against Douglas

Abraham Lincoln once competed against the wealthy Stephen Douglas for the U.S. presidency. Douglas traveled in grand style: at every stop cannons fired thirty-two times and a band played, creating an unprecedented spectacle. Douglas declared disdainfully, “I shall let that country bumpkin Lincoln smell my aristocratic scent.”

Lincoln remained calm and unperturbed. He bought ordinary train tickets and spoke across the country. At each stop he mounted a farm wagon friends had prepared and delivered his campaign speech:

Many people have written asking how much property I own. I have only a wife and three sons, all priceless. I also rent an office containing one desk, three chairs, and a large bookcase whose books are worth reading. I am poor, thin, long-faced, and unlikely to grow stout. I have nothing to rely on except you, the people.

Douglas suffered a resounding defeat; Lincoln won. Lincoln's modesty clearly worked to his advantage. Whether facing friends or opponents, humility enhances one's image. Much of Lincoln's victory can be credited to his modesty, which Douglas's own arrogance only highlighted. The outcome was therefore unsurprising.

Confucius said, "The gentleman does not boast of his achievements nor grow arrogant in success." When dealing with people of high status, the simplest way to gauge their character is to observe how they treat ordinary people.

### Micro-expression Keywords

It is often said that "even heroes find it hard to resist a beautiful woman." Many heroes—Lü Bu, Emperor Xuanzong of Tang, among others—were undone by beauty. Those unmoved by beauty are worth befriending; those who become frivolous in its presence should be avoided.

The *Book of Songs* already contains the lines "Guan-guan cry the ospreys / On the islet in the river. / A modest, retiring, virtuous young lady / Is a good mate for our lord." The love of beauty is universal, yet when a person cannot control that impulse and sinks into the "gentle trap," the consequences can be disastrous.

In life one encounters many tests—power, wealth, and beauty among them. Passing them depends on character and conduct. People of high moral quality remain indifferent to such temptations; those of weak character and willpower rarely succeed.

Some appear upright and serious, yet beneath that façade lies a base heart. To expose such people, place a beautiful woman at their side and observe whether they remain unmoved. The hypocritical often change completely, becoming frivolous. Only those of genuine integrity stay composed, preserving dignity and principle even in the presence of beauty. Such people alone are fit for great responsibility.

### Micro-expression Keywords

The most important quality to discern in others is character. Whether someone is trustworthy or fit for great responsibility depends on character, values, and judgment on major issues. Before making friends or promoting subordinates, therefore, ask pointed questions about fundamental principles and analyze the answers.

Knowing others begins with knowing their character. Zhuge Liang, the foremost strategist of the Three Kingdoms period, excelled not only in planning but also in selecting and employing talent. In his "Seven Methods of Observing People," "aspiration" ranks first. To understand someone, first examine his ambitions, attitudes, and values. Pose questions about fundamental issues and assess his judgment.

Character governs action; action reveals worldview and values. A person's steadfastness of purpose, resistance to temptation, and conduct on matters of principle form the core of character and the basic criterion for judging others. When choosing a high military commander, for example, loyalty to the nation must come first; a commander who cannot distinguish friend from foe will bring disaster.

Thus, before entrusting someone with important responsibilities, examine his aspirations, values, and judgment. Only then can you decide whether he deserves the post.

## Suddenly Questioning Someone to Gauge His Knowledge

### Micro-expression Keywords

Examinations can test knowledge, yet if a person can answer fluently when questioned without warning, he demonstrates not only rich learning but also quick thinking and the ability to handle emergencies—true marks of talent.

To assess ability and wisdom, maintain timely communication. Use “sudden questioning” to evaluate knowledge reserves, especially when leaders wish to gauge subordinates. “Sudden questioning” need not be a surprise attack; it can also occur when an urgent situation arises and a leader needs immediate information or opinions. The capacity to respond to emergencies is an essential quality of talent.

Under sudden questioning, rapid reaction, verbal organization, and expressive ability are most clearly revealed. If subordinates are given advance notice and time to prepare reports, the information may be comprehensive, yet the test of their real-time ability and diligence is weaker than under sudden questioning.

## The Story of Marquis Wen of Wei Choosing a Chancellor

Marquis Wen of Wei needed to appoint a chancellor. Two candidates, Wei Cheng and Zhai Huang, were equally capable, leaving the marquis undecided. He consulted Li Ke, who said: “Zhai Huang recommended Wu Qi, Ximen Bao, and Yue Yang, all of whom became your officials; Wei Cheng recommended Bu Zixia, Tian Zifang, and Duan Ganmu, all of whom became your teachers. Officials are merely competent administrators; teachers must be ministers of both virtue and talent. Therefore Wei Cheng is superior.”

Many leaders today, when recommending talent, first ask whether the candidate is loyal to them personally, thereby burying many capable people—especially those who have disagreed with them or stood on a different side. Such leaders not only refuse to recommend but actively suppress these individuals. Association with them offers little chance of advancement.

A true leader never buries talent because of personal considerations. If someone is genuinely talented, the leader will recommend him regardless of whether that talent surpasses his own, because his concern is the realm, not personal position. Only with such leaders can one avoid worrying that one’s abilities will go undeveloped.

## How to Use “Sudden Questioning” in Talent Selection

Every enterprise needs personnel with strong knowledge reserves and strategic thinking. Genuine strategy differs fundamentally from petty cleverness. Useful strategy is the skillful application of management principles that safeguard and advance the enterprise’s interests, enabling calm response in emergencies.

Therefore, when selecting talent, employ “sudden questioning” to assess knowledge. The key is to pose concrete questions within the relevant domain rather than abstract ones. Questions such as “What are your views on financial management?” or “What are the duties of office staff?” elicit only abstract answers even from capable candidates.

- For financial talent, ask how to legally minimize tax or reduce expenditures to the greatest extent.

- For office staff, ask how to enforce attendance rules so that every employee feels the system's authority and complies strictly.

Sudden questioning most clearly reveals a person's actual knowledge level. Mastering this technique allows managers to select talent smoothly.

## Conclusion

*Forbes* reported that by 2007 China had sixty-six billionaires, ranking second only to the United States. That same year *Forbes* discontinued its China philanthropy list—the first time in eight years. Besides imperfections in China's charitable system that discourage public donations, the chief reason was the weak philanthropic consciousness of Chinese billionaires and their conservative attitudes toward wealth. The cancellation of the list embarrassed China's wealthy.

We often see people driving luxury cars and spending lavishly in nightclubs. Many rich individuals compete to display who spends most freely. Association with such people ultimately burdens one with money. For a wealthy person, the ability to control wealth is a sign of strength, yet how that wealth is used reveals character and taste. We should respect those who benefit the world and appreciate those who contribute to society directly or indirectly. For those who merely look after themselves, simply recognizing their true nature suffices.

A person in high office may not receive praise for competence, since the post itself demands it; yet the people he recommends clearly indicate whether he is wise or mediocre. This method reveals his true character.

## How He Spends His Money When Wealthy

Micro-expression keywords: Money is something everyone in society needs. It not only serves people's basic needs for food, clothing, housing, and transportation but also has many other uses. Each person spends money differently—some on personal enjoyment, others on charity. In fact, the way people spend money reveals their true character.

Money is not everything, yet without it almost nothing is possible. Many people agree with this statement. But how one spends money is a personal choice. If we want to understand someone, observing where they direct their money when they have it is an effective way to judge character.

Some people, once wealthy, indulge in personal pleasures—eating, drinking, and living extravagantly, caring only for their own comfort. Others, even after gaining wealth, continue to aid the poor, distribute funds widely, and recruit talent. Some invest earnings in shops and factories, seeking appreciation at every turn. Some donate surplus wealth rather than leave it as a burden to descendants. Others quietly hoard it, spending more time counting than spending. In short, each person has their own way of managing wealth, and that way reflects a core aspect of their character.

## Historical Anecdotes

During the Northern and Southern Dynasties, Gao Huan, founder of the Northern Qi, wanted to test the ambitions and courage of his sons. He gave each a tangled skein of hemp and asked who could sort it fastest and best. While the others searched for ways to untangle the mess, his second son, Gao Yang, drew a sharp knife without hesitation, cut through the skein, and declared, "What is tangled should be cut." The idiom "cut the Gordian knot" originates here. Gao Huan was impressed by the approach.

Gao Huan next assigned each son several soldiers and sent them in different directions. He then dispatched a general with troops to stage an attack. The other sons were at a loss, but Gao Yang rallied his men, surrounded the general, and—after the general removed his armor to reveal the ruse—still seized him and delivered him to Gao Huan. Gao Huan praised Gao Yang highly, saying, “Gao Yang’s insight and strategy surpass my own.” Gao Yang later inherited his father’s enterprise and became the first emperor of Northern Qi.

Clearly, those who remain calm in crisis and dare to resist can achieve great things. Therefore, before entrusting someone with responsibility, people often create an artificial setback to observe whether the person possesses the courage to overcome it.

## Lessons from Heroes Past and Present

Throughout history, countless “heroes” have fallen before beauty. Despite their literary or martial talents, they lost self-control in the presence of allure, behaved frivolously, and ruined their lives. Only those with strong willpower can shoulder heavy burdens.

Homer’s epics recount that after the Trojan War, the Greek hero Odysseus faced a deadly test of beauty on his return voyage: three bird-women sirens lived on a mysterious island. Though cannibals, their beauty and song were irresistible; almost no one could withstand them.

Odysseus knew that even his firmest resolve might fail against the sirens’ lure and that he risked becoming another set of bones on the island. He ordered his crew to plug their ears with wax and had himself lashed to the mast. Thanks to these precautions, the ship passed the danger safely.

A person’s conduct in the face of beauty reveals their truest character. Those who act frivolously will never achieve greatness. Only those who can look upon beauty without being moved earn our trust; recognizing this trait brings great benefit to our own lives.

## How He Recommends People When Holding High Office

### Micro-expression keywords

To understand someone in a position of authority, observe whom they recommend. A truly selfless leader who knows how to employ talent will promote the worthy. A hypocritical or selfish person will mostly advance personal cronies. Such a leader has a character flaw; following them risks burying our own abilities. We should choose carefully.

When someone holds high office, the talent they promote or appoint at least reflects their breadth of mind and leadership ability. If those they elevate or recommend are all personal associates or people who can deliver tangible benefits, their character is obvious.

Holding high office carries the duty to discover and employ talent. A leader must “know people and assign them appropriately.” If a leader can do neither, their leadership ability is seriously questionable. Only those who recommend capable people without regard for personal gain and who do not suppress someone more talented than themselves are truly wise leaders. The caliber of people a leader recommends represents one measure of the leader’s own capability.

## Summary

“Question them on right and wrong” means examining their judgment of right and wrong, their views on matters, and their aspirations. This shows that managers must consider the degree of aspiration when

assessing talent. Throughout history, every successful person has been single-minded in purpose and firm in belief.

Those who remain ambiguous on major questions of principle, or who bend like “grass on the wall,” are usually adept at reading the room and currying favor. They lack clear standards of right and wrong and inner moral discipline; they merely trim their sails to the wind. Such people are most likely to harm the highest interests of the nation and people at critical moments. By contrast, those with lofty aspirations, firm positions, broad minds, and shared ideals will strive for a common cause. Such talent is worth seeking out.

A person’s nobility is not decided by eloquent speech. Therefore, when judging someone’s aspirations and values, we should ask them questions of major principle and assess their judgment from the answers.

### How He Behaves When Poor—Does He Accept Ill-Gotten Gains?

Micro-expression keywords: The saying “a gentleman loves wealth but acquires it properly” means there is nothing wrong with liking money, provided the means are legitimate. Ill-gotten gains should be refused. Someone willing to accept such gains will not have good character; associating with them risks eventual deception. It is best to keep distance.

“A gentleman loves wealth but acquires it properly.” The Confucian view of finance first emphasizes “the Way”—whether wealth is obtained in accordance with ritual, morality, and behavioral norms. Confucius said: “Wealth and rank are what everyone desires, yet a gentleman will not accept them if they are not obtained through the humane way; poverty and low status are what everyone detests, yet a gentleman will not escape them if it cannot be done through the humane way.” Therefore, to judge character, observe whether a person accepts ill-gotten gains when poor.

Those who refuse unjust wealth even in poverty can be trusted and relied upon. Otherwise, any amount of money remains merely “ill-gotten.”

### Liars Often Touch Themselves

When people lie, the more they try to hide their inner state, the more their changing body movements expose it. Psychologist O’Hair and colleagues conducted an experiment:

Subjects were instructed to answer an interviewer’s questions with lies while their nonverbal behavior was recorded in each time segment. Compared with truthful behavior, liars gave shorter answers and displayed subtle actions such as fiddling with their fingers or unconsciously touching parts of their body.

When lying, people often cover their mouths but feel this is inappropriate, so they usually end up touching their noses a few times to mask the gesture. Non-liars may also touch their noses while speaking, yet the action differs noticeably. Duration and pressure reveal the difference: truthful people touch longer and with greater pressure.

### What Kind of Friends Does He Make When Wealthy?

Once someone becomes rich, what sort of friends do they cultivate? Do they remember the “poor brothers” who struggled alongside them, or do they prefer fair-weather companions? People differ in their attitudes. Many can share hardship but not prosperity; once wealthy, they may not share their good fortune. This is a human weakness and an important means of judging character. The friends a person chooses after becoming wealthy reflect their character.

When someone attains wealth and status, many similarly wealthy people naturally appear around them. At that point their attitude toward former “poor brothers” may change. Many who become rich begin to fawn on others who are wealthy and powerful and sever ties with those who once shared their struggles, because those old companions now make them lose face or lower their status.

### How He Treats Others When Holding Status—Does He Observe Proper Etiquette?

Micro-expression keywords: A person’s cultivation shows in how they treat others. Cultivated people remain courteous to everyone, neither obsequious nor arrogant. Petty individuals fawn on those above them and lord it over those below. To see someone clearly, simply observe how they interact with ordinary people once they hold status.

A change in status often alters a person’s conduct. Some are mild and approachable—even somewhat deferential—while still commoners. Once their status rises, they receive office or rank, their tone changes, they speak from on high, and arrogance appears. They display the classic look of a petty person who has gained power.

Therefore, do not assume someone is refined merely because they are gentle in ordinary times. Observe whether they still observe the same courtesies after acquiring status.

### Tell Him Disaster Is Imminent—Does He Have the Courage to Resist?

Micro-expression keywords: In daily life, people’s abilities appear roughly equal. Yet at critical moments, especially when facing calamity, some reveal themselves by fighting difficulties to the end. Such people usually possess a sense of responsibility, courage, and boldness; they can be entrusted with important tasks.

A person’s true character emerges when facing major events. Therefore, to test someone’s courage and boldness, inform them of possible disaster or difficulty and observe whether they show the will to resist. Most people feel varying degrees of fear when told of difficulties; without sufficient courage they will not willingly shoulder responsibility. So deliberately describe a difficult situation. If they appear troubled or timid, they are not suited for great undertakings. Conversely, if they accept the challenge with genuine confidence, they can be given heavy responsibility.

## Chapter 7 Observe Carefully—the Answer Reveals Itself

Generally, a person’s character is discerned through ordinary interaction, not through deliberate testing. Everyday conduct proves what kind of person someone is, because character is not something that can be put on; it is an expression of inner quality. The Analects records Confucius’s famous words: “Observe what they do, note the means they employ, and examine what brings them contentment—how can anyone hide their true nature?” The idea is to watch why they act, how they act, and their state of mind while acting—whether at ease or uneasy. After such observation, where could that person hide?

Micro-expression keywords: The kind of friends someone makes after becoming wealthy reveals their character. Those who cut ties with former poor companions to befriend other wealthy people are hypocritical and base; they will achieve nothing great in the future. We should distance ourselves promptly.

### Is He Lying to Me?

In social interactions, the frequency with which people lie or are deceived by lies is astonishing. MIT psychologist Feldman’s research indicates that the average person tells at least twenty-five lies per day. Of

course, lies vary in degree; some are well-intentioned and can be ignored. But when lies are meant to deceive or harm, how do we know whether we have been deceived?

A recent study from the University of California found that even habitual liars produce subconscious signals when their brains switch into pretense mode—signals ordinary people can detect, much like a lie detector, to catch the liar out.

Most liars fall into two categories: occasional liars and habitual liars.

## Liars Never Forget Any Detail

Try this with friends: ask what they did from leaving the office two evenings ago until bedtime. In their account they will almost certainly make a few mistakes.

Remembering every detail of a time period is difficult. People rarely recall everything that happened; they usually correct themselves repeatedly to get the sequence straight. They might say, "I went home and sat in front of the TV—oh, no, first I called my mother, then I sat in front of the TV." Liars, however, make no such slips because they have already constructed the entire scenario in their minds. They will never say, "Wait, I got that wrong." Their very reluctance to admit error during the account exposes them.

## Liars Blink or Rub Their Eyes

Some habitual liars have learned to stare directly at you to avoid detection. Because deceivers concentrate so intensely, their eyes dry out; they must blink or rub their eyes more often to relieve the discomfort, and this action leaks critical information.

Another reliable test is to watch the movement of the person's eyes. Eye movement indicates the brain is working. When most people are "constructing" a sound or image, continued eye movement also suggests they are lying. This "eye movement" is a reflex that cannot be faked unless one has received rigorous training.

## After Being Asked the Same Question Repeatedly, Liars Become Angry

Ask a question and wait for the answer. Ask it a second time; the answer remains unchanged. Leave an interval between the second and third asking. During this pause their body calms down and they think, "I've gotten away with it."

Once all physiological reactions subside and the body returns to a relaxed state, ask the question again unexpectedly. They are no longer in lying mode; they either become indignant or tend to confess. If someone says, "Haven't I already told you about this?" and then erupts in anger, they are probably lying. They may also say, "All right, I'll just tell you the truth."

## Application in Business

Leaders in business can also use this method to judge people. Within companies there are many strategic thinkers and no shortage of courageous individuals. Yet some possess deep foresight but lack the courage to face difficulties and setbacks. Employees who combine courage and strategy are ideal, but in reality such people are rare. Leaders must therefore combine talent effectively and correctly identify who truly possesses courage.

For example, when a company encounters real setbacks, managers should deliberately inform employees of the misfortune and see who volunteers to help solve the problems. Only genuine talent will step forward to



shoulder the burden at such times.

## Avoiding Eye Contact with Others

Everyone remembers their mother's childhood rebuke: "You must be lying again—you won't look me in the eye." Some occasional liars touch their eyes while lying to avoid eye contact. Women generally touch below the eye lightly, to avoid seeming rude or smudging makeup; they may also look at the ceiling to escape the other person's gaze. Men usually rub their eyes more forcefully and likewise look at the ceiling or elsewhere.

## Chapter 6 Skillful Testing—Practice Reveals True Quality

A common saying goes: "Whether it's a mule or a horse, take it out for a walk." The point is that testing shows who truly has ability; bluster and self-promotion are useless. Real skill is revealed by practice—the sole criterion of truth. "A long journey tests a horse's strength; time reveals a person's heart" is another method of testing through practice, yet more effective is the proactive design of scenarios for deliberate trials. This approach has a long history in traditional Chinese methods of judging character.

### Pulling at the Collar

The gesture of pulling at one's collar seems ordinary; people usually adjust their collars for appearance. Psychophysiological research shows that lying creates psychological imbalance, triggering subtle changes in sympathetic nervous function that produce tingling sensations in the face and neck. The person then rubs, touches, or unconsciously tugs at the collar.

### Occasional Liars

Occasional liars usually lie to avoid an unpleasant situation or to cover up a mistake. Because they are not practiced at lying, they feel uneasy, and that unease shows in appearance, body language, and voice.

### Habitual Liars

Habitual liars, through practice, can control appearance, body language, and voice so convincingly that almost no trace remains—yet their lies are not without flaws.

### Sudden Changes in Volume or Pitch

If you ask your husband who just called and he suddenly starts chattering like a magpie, be alert. A sudden rise in pitch often indicates a liar trying to mask nervousness.

[[END SOURCE]]

See Disgust (s-disgust).

See Contempt (s-contempt).

See Eyes and mouth in deception (c-deception-eyes-mouth).

### Lie Detection Basics

#### **Observe Whether He Stands Tall When His Status Is Low**

**Micro-expression keywords** Most successful people have climbed up step by step from a lowly status. When a person is in a lowly position, whether he can still conduct himself with dignity to some extent reveals his character and foreshadows his future prospects. A person of humble status who lives with dignity and conscience will not fare too poorly in later development. At the same time, associating with such a gentleman will benefit us greatly.

The phrase “lowly status” here refers to how a person behaves when in difficulty. Does he adhere to his moral bottom line and continue to conduct himself with dignity as before, or does he give up, become despondent, even live in degradation and abandon his principles? Each person’s different responses reflect different personalities and qualities.

Confucius said: “The orchid grows in the deep forest; it does not cease to be fragrant because no one is there to appreciate it. The gentleman cultivates the Way and establishes virtue; he does not alter his integrity because of poverty.”

This means that orchids and lingzhi grow in remote forests and do not stop emitting fragrance simply because no one sees them; the gentleman cultivates his moral character and does not change his aspirations because of hardship. Maintaining integrity in favorable circumstances is not difficult, but remaining upright even in lowly circumstances is truly admirable. Such a person demonstrates an extraordinary resilience of character; no matter how low his position, he will not compromise his principles. People of this kind are worth employing.

There was once a very talented young man skilled in music, chess, calligraphy, and painting, yet he remained unrecognized despite repeated examination failures. In the end he had no choice but to sell his calligraphy and paintings to make a living.

He set up a stall at his gate, writing and painting on the spot for customers in exchange for daily necessities. Because his work was beautiful, many people gathered to watch. He charged five wen for a couplet, ten wen for a plaque, and one tael of silver for a painting. When business was slow he played the qin to pass the time.

One day an official was drawn by the sound of the qin. Hearing the music, the official assumed it came from a scholarly household, but upon approaching he discovered only a poor young vendor of paintings. Still, the young man’s work was genuinely fine—elegant and free in style, unlike anything the official had seen before.

The official intended to buy several pieces to study at home and, feeling sympathy for the talent, purchased a few finished works and gave the young man five taels of silver, telling him to keep the change. To his surprise the young man refused the extra money and insisted on returning it. The official wondered how anyone could be so foolish as to reject money and suspected the young man might be putting on an act. He decided to test him, so he deliberately left his money pouch on the stall without the young man noticing and then walked away.

After only a few steps the official heard someone calling him. Turning around, he saw the poor vendor chasing after him with the pouch: “You dropped this.”

The official was immediately impressed by the young man’s integrity and talent, and resolved to help him. Back home he invited many prominent figures to view the paintings. They all praised them highly, assuming the official himself had painted them.

When the official revealed the truth, everyone was astonished. With the official’s vigorous promotion the young man met more distinguished people, his reputation grew, and he eventually became the foremost of the Four Great Talents of Jiangnan. He was Tang Bohu.

Mencius said: "Wealth and rank cannot corrupt him; poverty and low status cannot sway him; force cannot bend him—this is what is meant by a great man."

For a great man, neither high office nor poverty nor violence can alter his conduct. At all times, conducting himself with dignity remains his consistent standard. Such people earn respect no matter their circumstances or status.

Common people often say: "Conduct yourself with dignity; do your work steadily." A person should live without bowing and scraping, without meekly agreeing to everything, standing tall with backbone. Only such people are worth knowing.

I once heard a story about a migrant worker:

A young man whose parents had died young carried the burden of supporting his younger brother through school. Alone in a strange city with no skills or higher education, he could only drift from one odd job to another. His greatest pleasure was visiting a bookstore to read. Each time he opened a book he felt renewed strength and forgot the fatigue of work. One day, while reading, he was startled by a commotion outside. A traffic accident had occurred at the bookstore entrance. After the dispute ended he realized he was still holding a book and hurried to return it. Suddenly the shop owner rushed out, slapped him without a word, and shouted: "It's already bad enough that you read here—now you want to steal the book too? You ill-bred thing!"

The young man stood stunned for a moment, then quickly explained: "I'm not a thief! I want to buy this book!" The moment the words left his mouth he regretted them, because he had no money at all.

The owner seized the chance and sneered: "Fine! Pay first, then."

"This..." the young man stammered.

"Go on, pay! You said you wanted to buy it. I've seen plenty like you—when you have no money you steal books. I caught one just the other day!"

The young man stopped arguing. He left his only valuable possession, a watch, as collateral and promised to return within a week with the money. Only then, he said, could he prove his innocence. He left.

A week passed, then another, and he did not appear. Instead his younger brother came, paid for the book, and retrieved the watch. The owner, puzzled, asked: "Why didn't the young man come himself?"

"He... died. A crane collapsed at the construction site and crushed him. Inside his backpack I found this note: 'I owe the bookstore for a book. I will repay it. I am not a thief!'"

The brother handed the note to the owner and said: "My brother was not the kind of person you think."

Even in humble circumstances, dignity need not be humble. As the saying goes, "A scholar can be killed but not humiliated." You may take such a person's life, but you cannot insult him or wound his dignity. In daily life we encounter many such people. Although they hold no prominent positions and do humble work, they always act according to conscience and conduct themselves with dignity. At any time, these are the people worth knowing.

## **Making Suggestions in an Abstract Manner**

If we could always express or receive conversational content accurately, communication would produce no ambiguity or misunderstanding. Unfortunately our exchanges are not always smooth. Some remarks sound one way at first but reveal another meaning upon reflection. Moreover, people like to use non-quantitative terms to express degree—words such as “not bad,” “okay,” “a little,” “very,” or “better”—which become even more ambiguous without a reference point for comparison.

You show a plan to your superior and the superior says “It’ll do.” What does “it’ll do” mean? If the other party does not state it plainly, you must guess: does it mean “not good enough” or simply “leave it at that”? So whenever you hear such phrasing you naturally want to press: “What exactly do you mean by ‘it’ll do’? Approved or not?”

Yet in many situations this vague, abstract style of communication is actually an effective way to offer suggestions. Because the concept is fuzzy, the other person must automatically fill in the missing information. An example will illustrate.

**A:** What do you think of the evening event?

**B:** Not bad.

**A:** Thanks so much for coming to support it.

The phrase “not bad” that B used is a fuzzy concept whose real meaning could be any of the following:

1. I didn’t pay much attention; a perfunctory reply will do.
2. I watched; it wasn’t great but wasn’t the worst either.
3. I couldn’t stand it, but I don’t want to hurt your pride, so I offered mild encouragement instead of saying it was excellent.
4. Among events of similar scale, this one was quite good.

Whether A considers all these possibilities is A’s own affair. This method of offering suggestions carries the figurative explanation: “I didn’t actually say that.”

Sometimes, to deepen the impression a suggestion makes, we deliberately omit information so the other person senses it themselves; the effect is often better than stating it outright, at least because it respects the other person’s dignity. For instance:

**A:** What do you think of this plan?

A is stubborn and insecure; direct criticism would make him feel looked down upon. In such cases an abstract suggestion works best.

**B:** It’ll do.

This phrasing does not provoke resistance in A; it merely prompts him to wonder what “it’ll do” means.

**A:** Do you mean there’s still room for improvement?

**B:** Yes, I think you could do better.

Allowing the other person to realize there is room for improvement is far more effective than stating it directly.

Although abstract suggestions are sometimes necessary to preserve another person’s dignity, the approach is not always recommended. It tends to create more misunderstanding than benefit, and sincere treatment

remains the basic rule of human interaction.

Some abstract phrases cause considerable trouble. When we shop for groceries we often see food packages labeled “more delicious” or “tastes better.” At first glance there seems to be no problem; we buy the item happily, only to find upon tasting that it is ordinary or even inferior to other brands. The difficulty lies in the word “more.” “More delicious” or “tastes better” supplies no reference point. We do not know whether the product is better than the same brand’s previous version or better than a competing brand. If you confront the seller—“This isn’t better; it’s far worse than brand X”—the seller will reply: “We never said it was better than brand X; that was your own assumption.”

Abstract language allows different people to reach different understandings, and the understanding that arises in each mind is inevitably the one most convenient to that person. We believe our interpretation is correct, yet it often is not. During election campaigns, parties propose policies to win votes; some are pragmatic while others skillfully employ abstract concepts. In the area of medical welfare, one party once declared: “What kind of medical welfare system do you want? Exactly—that is what we will give you.” The statement sounds inspiring, suggesting a party deeply considerate of citizens. In reality the party has already prepared an escape hatch: if the system improves but falls short of expectations, the party can claim, “This is precisely what we promised; we did not lie.”

Therefore, whenever someone tells you “not bad” or “it’ll do,” observe the other person’s micro-expressions to determine whether the remark is affirmative or evasive.

In interrogations, however, an abstract style of questioning can be useful. For example: “We already know everything; you might as well confess.” Watch the suspect’s micro-expressions. If fear appears, it indicates the suspect did commit the crime.

The same technique works for drawing out information from others. When you say to a friend you suspect of hiding something, “I already know everything,” delivered with a confident expression, the friend will usually pause for a second. That pause signals surprise—the friend did not expect you to know. Once that expression appears, press further; the person is almost certainly concealing something. Follow up with “So you still won’t say it? How long do you plan to hide it?” This adds pressure few people can withstand unless they are exceptionally guarded.

Since the phrase “I already know everything” has been mentioned, the word “everything” itself deserves discussion. It is another fuzzy term, producing the same abstract effect as “always” or “never.” When someone says “I know everything,” does that mean all the facts or eighty percent? The distinction is hard to gauge. Likewise, after failing twice a person may claim “I always fail” or “I’ve never succeeded.” Teachers also favor such wording when evaluating students—“always late,” “never does homework,” “never studies properly”—even when the student was late only three times in a year, missed homework only a handful of times, and was merely occasionally distracted. People habitually exaggerate behaviors they dislike in order to elicit agreement and place reason on their side.

Some advertisements claim “everyone says it’s good.” How many people does “everyone” include—one hundred, two hundred, one thousand? The figure remains an ambiguous concept.

### **Opening: The Unfathomable Mind of the Big Boss**

In this world, how many people will be completely honest with you?

Newspapers, television, and the internet hide writers behind their own industrial chains, producing content they want you to “believe is true” and then performing it for you.

You may spend every day switching between roles, yet still feel the helpless fog of uncertainty.

My goddess, I have poured every ounce of my best self into an hour-long torrent of conversation, yet you still show no sign of saying more. Why is it that every time I serve you food or pour you water, you smile politely, accept both, yet never let me touch your hand? Is it refined restraint, or simply no interest in me?

Any clear-headed, rational person can perform appropriate actions and conceal true intentions. Charging straight at a goddess’s wishes this way will cost you many opportunities.

Gaze, posture, and distance are all ways a goddess reveals her intentions. Study them carefully and you will capture valuable information.

The VIP across from me has heard our best product pitch, yet says nothing. What does that mean? His crossed leg sways slightly, his body leans back on the sofa, his eyes are half-closed in a smile, and he simply watches me in silence. Should I push harder now, or wait for him to speak first? Will speaking now backfire and make me look clumsy? Was he satisfied earlier?

Big clients are naturally stronger than you, at least on the surface, because they pay the bills. Professional credibility and respectful demeanor are basic skills every salesperson masters; these clients have seen them all. Shallow answers about interest or satisfaction will never come from their mouths.

The angle of the legs, the tension in the torso, and the amplitude and frequency of any swaying all carry special meaning.

I hear that another candidate for promotion has powerful connections and that the boss favors him. Yet the boss has always praised me, even patting my shoulder yesterday and saying I have great potential. Could the boss really “prefer” him? Watching him bow and scrape at yesterday’s meeting made me nauseous. Does the boss truly like that kind of sycophant?

The boss will not casually reveal preferences, especially during sensitive periods. Should one rely on the boss’s words or on rumors?

You can cut through the fog of language and judge closeness and interest through actual bodily reactions.

Of course, if the boss is the sort who practices nepotism, there is no need to invest effort in such a person or company.

After pitching an entrepreneurial plan to an investor, the other party seems to listen throughout yet never with full attention. Are they interested or convinced? The closing line “We’ll study it and get back to you” is the most torturous of all; the wait itself is agony. Will the plan now proceed smoothly?

People in urgent need usually overlook the listener’s reactions and simply recite what they prepared.

If, during communication, you can read the “patrons’” minds through small movements, you can seize the right timing and rhythm, deliver your pitch with precision, and greatly improve funding efficiency.

In short, when interests are at stake, no one will casually tell the truth. Language is the least reliable channel of communication. All real thoughts must be judged by oneself. Accurate judgment lets you seize the best opportunities ahead of everyone else. Unable to judge? Then leave it to fate.

Human behavior reveals many secrets. In social behavior we can clearly discern the motives behind these “made-up” actions; in emotional and physiological behavior we can, through the theoretical principles of micro-reaction (微反应), reverse-engineer psychological feelings and decision motives. When someone says “like,” “very good,” “support,” “believe me,” or “we’re like family,” do they truly mean it? Countless details across the entire body can reveal the truthfulness of their words.

At the company meeting, all senior executives listen with bated breath while stealing glances at the big boss’s every move.

The big boss is the boss’s boss. I am presenting; he is listening. If he is satisfied, the project becomes everyone’s gold mine.

Yet the big boss is British, the quintessential old-school gentleman, deep and impassive.

I possess one skill no one else knows: no tiny movement escapes my eyes, not even the slightest change in breathing.

I know he is listening attentively because his gaze follows the content. This matters greatly; if his eyes drift or lose focus, hope is already gone.

After listening, the big boss remains silent, his face expressionless.

A classic social display!

Seasoned veterans of the business world routinely wear this inscrutable look because they consciously hide their feelings. The British normally observe elaborate etiquette that puts people at ease. At a moment when everything feels life-or-death, however, that same restraint and self-control become a mask.

Still expressionless, the big boss glances at my boss as if seeking his opinion, then slowly shifts his gaze to my face. While calmly watching me, he taps the table lightly with his right pinky, ring finger, middle finger, and index finger in sequence. The motion is small and unhurried.

Seeing that finger-tapping, I relax considerably and quietly exhale. Only a positive, attentive state produces that rhythm and sequential finger movement.

A few seconds later he asks, “Young man, what do you think of your project plan?”

I smile inwardly. This is probably how senior leaders test people—by applying pressure to create deterrence. Most people cannot tell whether the pressure signals anger or appreciation, so anxiety rises. Having seen the “positive and attentive” attitude behind his restraint, I recognize the question as an expression of personal interest rather than doubt about the plan itself.

My own boss gives me an almost imperceptible nod.

Now it is my turn to take control of the room.

It's show time!

## **Othello Error**

While detecting lies, people easily fall into the Brokaw trap and also commit the **Othello error**—mistaking truth for a lie. You may face this situation: someone leaks company secrets, senior leadership launches a full

investigation, and everyone who had access is questioned, including you. Called into the office and facing several leaders and investigators, you feel nervous. Although you are telling the truth, fear of being wrongly accused makes you panic. If the investigators cannot distinguish whether your fear stems from lying or from worry about being framed, you may indeed be wrongly accused.

If you happen to have done something wrong earlier, the questioning naturally stirs up the guilt you already carry, which resembles the guilt of lying. Or, in your eagerness to defend yourself, you may become excited—an excitement that can be mistaken for the excitement of lying. Thus, whether telling the truth or lying, people experience many of the same emotions under suspicion and interrogation: disgust, surprise, fear, dejection, and so on.

The clearest illustration is *Othello*, which is why Ekman named this error the Othello error.

Othello suspects Desdemona of an affair with Cassio, questions her, and threatens to kill Cassio. Desdemona asks for Cassio to be summoned to confront the matter and clear her name, but Othello says he has already killed him. Having lost her only chance to defend herself, Desdemona feels fear, dejection, pain, and despair. Knowing she will not survive, she weeps and begs Othello not to kill her. Othello wrongly assumes her grief is over Cassio's death and grows even angrier, more convinced of the affair.

Othello does not realize that an honest person facing sudden accusation can display the same fear, pain, and despair as a liar. Nor does he know that Desdemona weeps not for Cassio's death but for her own mortal danger and for Othello's distrust.

Othello mistakes truth for lies because he has already judged Desdemona guilty in his heart. Questioning with preconceptions means any reaction will be interpreted as concealment. Therefore, when detecting lies, one must discard preconceptions, avoid jumping to conclusions, and remain clear-headed and objective.

Even a person who is not naturally jealous or suspicious can commit the Othello error when confused; if others fan the flames, objectivity becomes even harder. We are told our partner had an intimate dinner with someone else. We already knew the two were close and worked well together. We then wonder why they were so in sync and conclude it must be because their relationship is improper. We answer our own question, treat it as evidence without verification, and become angry. Anger brings further emotions—disgust, sadness, despair—that block us from seeing the facts.

Another case: we already hold prejudice against someone because of past misconduct. When something bad happens, we automatically assume they did it. Such bias easily leads to the Othello error.

The best way to avoid the Othello error is to clarify the difference between the emotions of lying and the emotions of being suspected.

Distinguishing these emotions requires preparatory work: understand the person's character so you know their usual manner and reduce bias; understand their emotional patterns so you can tell how they behave when lying versus when suspected. Emotional patterns are largely built on character.

Confident or arrogant people usually feel neither fear nor guilt when suspected. Timid people feel fear when suspected—the fear of being wrongly punished—but not anger or guilt. Someone who once did wrong and has long regretted it will, when suspected of something they did not do, feel the original guilt rekindled, yet not anger, fear, excitement, or pain. All these possibilities must be ruled out during lie detection.



Another crucial point: whether the person shows emotions similar to lying also depends on the relationship between the person and the lie detector. The following example illustrates this.

A father and son have an excellent relationship; the father has never wrongly accused or casually punished the son. The son therefore trusts his father deeply and knows he will not be framed. Consequently, when suspected, the son shows no fear, tension, or disappointment in front of his father because he believes his father will not wrong him.

If the father has wrongly accused the son more than once in the past, then even an honest son will feel fear when suspected—the fear of being unjustly punished again.

Another case: the son once made a mistake, lied, and destroyed his credibility with his father. Even if he did not commit the current act, he will still feel fear when suspected, afraid his father will no longer trust him.

If these emotions cannot be excluded, the lie detector easily produces miscarriages of justice.

Distinguishing the emotions of a liar from those of an honest person requires thorough investigation to learn how the person behaves when lying versus when suspected—a lengthy process. If the lie detector and the person enjoy a good relationship with no history of wrongful accusations, mutual trust runs deep. The detector will then know the person's lying-emotion profile thoroughly, the person's suspicion-emotion profile will be relatively pure, and the final judgment will be easier.

As the old saying goes, accurate lie-detection results require first understanding the person's character, work style, and emotional patterns, eliminating bias, then combining four clues—micro-expressions, body language, slips of the tongue, and heated language—to reach a conclusion.

### **Keywords on Micro-expressions**

Leaders are busy and cannot constantly watch employees to ensure they work diligently. How, then, can one tell whether a person is worth developing? A sudden test reveals who continues to work hard when the leader is absent and who remains loyal without supervision. Such a person is an ambitious, good employee worth cultivating.

In many companies, employees think the moment the boss leaves is the perfect time to relax. When the boss is present, they feel supervised; once the boss attends a meeting, travels abroad, or negotiates a deal, they treat it as the best chance to slack off. These employees work like schoolchildren who only study seriously when the teacher stands behind them and slack off the moment the teacher steps out. To truly know someone, remove the leader and supervision and observe whether they remain loyal to themselves.

In any boss's eyes, loyalty matters even more than ability. Many bosses would rather have an employee of average talent who is highly loyal and trustworthy than a brilliant, capable person who constantly schemes for personal gain. Loyalty reflects noble character and basic professional ethics. An employee's loyalty to the company shows most clearly when the boss is away.

A sales manager once recounted this incident:

He visited a client company to discuss the sale of a new mass-market printer model. The manufacturer planned large-scale advertising and offered generous margins to distributors. He decided to secure initial orders from reputable, well-connected dealers before the media campaign began.

When he arrived at a long-standing client, the boss happened to be out. When he mentioned the upcoming new model, the employee receiving him said coldly, "The boss isn't here! We can't decide anything." He presented the promotional materials, explaining the product's strong performance and quality plus the current discount for early orders. The employee refused to listen and simply repeated, "The boss isn't here!"

He left, disappointed, and tried another company. The boss there was also absent, which discouraged him, yet he decided to try anyway. A newly hired female employee greeted him warmly. Instead of citing the boss's absence, she offered to arrange delivery the next day and said the boss could finalize details upon return.

The outcome was clear. The first company's employee lost an excellent opportunity because the boss was away; when they later requested stock, the discount had ended and profits shrank. After learning what happened, the boss fired the employee without hesitation. The second company, thanks to the female employee's continued diligence in the boss's absence, purchased the recommended product at the discounted price. Within a month they sold nearly 9,000 units and netted over 90,000 yuan. The female employee earned the boss's recognition and was promoted to supervisor immediately upon joining the company.

In workplace rules, loyalty is indispensable. Albert Hubbard wrote in *A Message to Garcia*: "Strictly speaking, a little loyalty is worth a great deal of cleverness." He even suggested that if you work for someone, do so in God's name. Whether an employee treats their work loyally reflects their character.

An employee loyal to their work will strive regardless of whether the boss is present or whether anyone is watching. Employees who require the boss's inspection and supervision always believe they work for the boss and shirk responsibility the moment the boss leaves. Such employees have low value to the company and are quickly eliminated by competition. They will never receive important assignments because they merely go through the motions rather than remain loyal to the work itself.

In *A Message to Garcia*, Lieutenant Rowan receives his superior's order and carries it out with total commitment and no complaint. No one supervises him, yet he completes the task brilliantly. More than a hundred years later, people still remember him—not only because he executed the order without excuses but, more importantly, because of his loyalty to the mission.

Employees who remain loyal to their work whether the boss is present or absent are highly valued in any company. They are loyal to the enterprise, disregard personal gain, consider the bigger picture, fulfill their duties, and safeguard the company's interests wholeheartedly. In contrast, employees who seize every chance to slack off or pursue personal gain ultimately face elimination.

If you are a boss and want to see your employees clearly, leave for a while and then return suddenly. Those who produce even better results in your absence deserve trust and promotion. Those who fail to complete their tasks deserve careful reconsideration; their presence hinders the company's progress, and removing them early benefits the enterprise sooner.

### **Leaning the Body Backward Proves One Is Lying**

Interpersonal relations researchers have observed that during face-to-face conversations, people establish different interaction distances based on their level of intimacy. With the closest individuals, the distance can shrink to 0.5 meters; between close friends, it is typically kept between 0.5 and 1.25 meters; and in public settings with strangers, people usually maintain a distance of 3 meters or more. This variation in spatial distance driven by psychological closeness is known in psychology as interpersonal distance.

If the other person wants to become better acquainted, their body will lean forward involuntarily to reduce the interpersonal distance; if they wish to keep their distance, they will lean backward to maintain a relatively greater separation. The size of the interpersonal distance reflects the closeness of the relationship.

A related phenomenon is personal space. Psychologists note that when people feel insecure, they instinctively create distance from others, carving out their own psychological territory.

FBI agent Grover observed during investigations of terrorists that the more vigilant the individual, the stronger the aversion to anyone entering their personal space. People often use objects to claim surrounding areas and build a protective barrier around themselves.

Many times you will notice that people prefer to sit alone in corners; if someone asks to sit beside you, you may feel uneasy. Leaning forward can be interpreted as opening up. The other person trusts you, so they expand their personal psychological space and shorten the distance between you. With someone they dislike, they will increase the distance and retreat as much as possible into their own "safe space."

Grover tells us that if a person likes you, they are unlikely to deceive you. Whether the body leans forward or backward reveals the place you occupy in that person's mind. Psychologists point out that when people express emotion through body language, they are often unaware of it. Body language is therefore one of the most authentic expressions of feeling and carries high credibility.

Psychologists have hypothesized that when people tell the truth, their bodies lean forward unconsciously in an attempt to draw closer, whereas when they lie, their bodies lean backward to maintain distance. Tests of this hypothesis showed that subjects adjusted their distance according to whether they were stating a lie or the truth. Those who knew they were recounting fabricated information leaned backward.

Experts have found that lying is accompanied by fear, prompting people to protect themselves unconsciously and avoid excessive closeness. Only by keeping greater distance can they remind their brains to construct a convincing falsehood.

Grover notes that people who like you are more willing to listen and lean forward to hear better. Therefore, when assessing familiarity between two people, first examine the spatial distance between them, then observe their listening posture.

We often notice that close individuals speak softly during conversation, sometimes so quietly that only the other person can hear. Someone friendly will move closer to catch your words; the simplest way to do so is to shift the body nearer. Conversely, someone who dislikes you will resist their words and may even wish to cover their ears to block the sound. Because such an exaggerated gesture is impractical, they settle for a slight backward tilt to create distance.

When a person shows liking, the underlying message is interest. People naturally draw closer to what interests them. Leaning forward signals that the individual has a certain interest in you.

Researchers studying human behavior have found that infants' bodies move toward objects that interest them. If a baby likes something, it will try every means to approach and obtain it; if it dislikes something, it will turn its head or cry in protest. From a very young age, our bodies react to what we like or dislike.

FBI agents observe that adults gradually become more polished and no longer display strong physical reactions to likes or dislikes. Instead they exercise reasonable control, leaving only subconscious movements such as leaning forward or backward or unconsciously averting the gaze.

## People Who Cover Their Mouths While Speaking May Be Lying

Covering the mouth while speaking is a gesture that signals surprise, doubt, tension, deception, or lack of confidence. When someone feels regret or remorse for what they have said, they may also cover their mouth as if trying to stop the words from emerging. FBI experts generally interpret this gesture as an attempt to conceal the truth or fabricate a lie.

Today is the day Ruoyer arrives at the FBI for an interview. Having passed the written test, he appears excited yet nervous. The interviewer notices on his résumé that he claims special-forces experience and asks what duties and training he handled. In reality Ruoyer never served in special forces, but a friend who did frequently described his experiences and training to Ruoyer and sometimes invited him to train together. Ruoyer decided the experience would help his FBI application, so he included it.

Ruoyer had prepared answers in advance, so when the question arose he recited them fluently. Nevertheless he was not hired. Although his verbal account was smooth, his body language showed anomalies that led the interviewer to suspect the special-forces claim was fabricated. Subsequent verification with the unit listed on the résumé confirmed that Ruoyer had lied.

How did the interviewer detect the discrepancy in just over ten minutes?

Normally, people naturally add gestures to emphasize their words. We may tap a finger or hand on the table to stress a point, widen our eyes or raise our eyebrows to strengthen tone, or, when excited, rise onto tiptoes if standing or repeatedly lift and lower the knees or slap them if seated.

Liars, however, focus so intently on concealing the truth that their attempts to emphasize points appear unnatural or delayed. Another characteristic is that liars tend to stress trivial details rather than the main facts.

In the case above, Ruoyer's body language matched the normal pattern at the start of the interview, but changed noticeably when he discussed the "special forces" experience.

When asked whether he had served in special forces, Ruoyer's body language directly contradicted his words: although he answered "yes," his head shook slightly, as if saying "I did not." When pressed for details, he remained unnaturally calm, showing none of the excitement or animation that usually accompanies genuine recollection. His account stayed general and omitted many important particulars. Most telling, throughout the entire discussion he repeatedly covered his mouth with his hand—an action the interviewer recognized as an attempt to hide the lie or its traces.

Of course, real life is complex, and not every hand-to-mouth gesture signals lying. A "field manual" left by an American intelligence officer lists negotiation techniques, one of which advises covering the mouth during conversation to prevent lip-reading and protect sensitive information.

Similarly, people who wish to keep their conversation private often speak with a hand cupped over the mouth. If someone sits with elbows on the table and both hands clasped over the mouth, the unspoken message is "I do not want you to hear me." The posture may persist while listening until the person decides it is safe to lower the hands.

Before drawing conclusions, therefore, consider whether the gesture has appeared before and under what circumstances. If it has not, consider other possibilities: recent dental work, a comment about bad breath, or simple self-consciousness. Always weigh alternative explanations.

## The Story of Zhang Guoqiang

Zhang Guoqiang was the director of Taihang Chemical Fiber Materials Factory, a township enterprise producing industrial fiber. Outdated equipment, capital shortages, and outstanding debts had brought the factory to the brink of bankruptcy. Zhang was deeply troubled and unsure of the way forward.

One day he received a letter from a Shanghai chemical-fiber company proposing a joint venture to produce industrial fiber. The Shanghai side would invest two million yuan to build a production line, and profits would be shared according to the factory's existing output.

Such good fortune? Zhang was delighted, yet he hesitated. With only a few old machines producing one or two hundred tons a year, he worried the profit split would be unfavorable. After much thought he decided to secure the large sum first and worry about the rest later.

The next day he wrote back, exaggerating that the factory employed more than two hundred workers and generated tens of millions in output value. He demanded the larger share of profits and operational control. A reply soon arrived agreeing in principle but stating that representatives would visit to inspect and negotiate.

Zhang devised a plan. He telephoned the municipal transport team and instructed the factory office director to borrow several old machines and dozens of workers from the municipal machinery plant. Preparations were quickly completed.

A few days later, engineer Xiao Wang from the Shanghai company arrived. Seeing that the visitor was a man in his twenties, Zhang relaxed.

The factory grounds looked clean, the workshops hummed with machinery, and trucks moved busily in and out. Zhang pointed to two trucks parked before the warehouse and said, "Those belong to out-of-town customers; some have been waiting several days."

Xiao Wang nodded appreciatively and asked, "What is your annual output?"

"Around a thousand tons, but demand still exceeds supply. The only obstacle to expansion is lack of funds." Zhang sighed and shook his head. "If your company could help, the prospects would be excellent."

Xiao Wang nodded. "Funding can be discussed; cooperation should be mutually beneficial. But the figures you provide must be accurate."

"Of course. Since we are partnering, credibility comes first."

Chatting amiably, they drove toward the administrative offices. Suddenly Xiao Wang told the driver, "Excuse me, please stop. I need to use the restroom."

Zhang saw that the nearest facility was a small toilet beside the boiler room and said dismissively, "That one is unsanitary. Let's go farther ahead."

"No need. I have a bit of stomach trouble and can't wait. It will do; I'm not an honored guest." Xiao Wang opened the door and stepped out.

Moments later he returned. As they reached the offices, Zhang handed over a report. "This is the first-half production statistic. At this rate we should exceed 1,200 tons this year."

Xiao Wang took the report, tapped numbers into a calculator, then looked up. "Director Li, this cannot be right. I estimate your maximum annual output is 200 tons."

Zhang was stunned. "Two hundred tons? On what basis?"

"On this basis." Xiao Wang pointed to the calculator. "While I was at the restroom I measured your chimney. Its diameter is 1.5 meters, meaning the heat it generates daily can support only forty workers. Even at five tons per worker, that yields only 200 tons a year."

Zhang looked embarrassed. He had not expected the young man to be so astute. Before he could respond, Xiao Wang stood and said gravely, "Supporting township enterprises is our company's responsibility, but we will not cooperate with anyone who falsifies information. Goodbye."

Xiao Wang walked out, leaving Zhang frozen in his chair, filled with regret. A person who resorts to deception will never earn others' trust. Even if such a person succeeds temporarily in business, the eventual outcome is self-inflicted harm.

When a person is frustrated and unsuccessful, conscience reviews and directs their actions; afterward it evaluates the results, producing satisfaction or self-reproach, pleasure or shame. Only by upholding principles in adversity does one demonstrate a true moral **底线**. Such people deserve our respect.

### **Scratching the Neck Signals Duplicity**

Micro-expression keywords: The distance between the neck and ears is short; scratching the ears indicates lying. Psychologists have found that scratching the neck likewise serves to relax emotions. In other words, when people unconsciously scratch their necks, they are very likely lying.

If, during bargaining, a shopkeeper says, "This is truly the lowest price; I cannot go lower," while scratching the neck, do not believe the claim. The gesture has already revealed the lie. In fact, considerable profit remains, and you can press harder.

Psychologists have discovered that when lying, people feel tension and their brains unconsciously direct the hands to touch the body, providing self-protection and emotional relief. These movements include clenching the fists, touching the nose, touching the ears, and scratching the neck.

People usually scratch the side of the neck or the area below the earlobe with the index finger; women's movements are smaller and typically involve covering the junction of neck and chest—an area anatomically called the "suprasternal notch."

Former FBI counterintelligence agent Joe Navarro once interviewed the mother of an armed fugitive. Although visibly nervous, she answered questions smoothly.

"Is your son at home?" When Navarro asked this, she placed her hand on the suprasternal notch and replied, "No." Navarro continued with other questions, then suddenly asked, "Is it possible he hid inside while you were out?" She again put her hand in the same place and said she did not know.

Recognizing the gesture, Navarro concluded she was lying. Before leaving he asked once more, "Are you certain he is not here?" She placed her hand on the notch a third time and again denied it. Navarro obtained a search warrant and found the son in a hidden room.

The mother lied three times and three times touched her neck; her body language betrayed her son's presence.

When someone says "I completely understand how you feel" while scratching the neck with the index finger five or more times, we can conclude the statement is false.

After her colleague resigned, Liang Yajie had been doing two people's work and was constantly exhausted. After two months she could bear it no longer and complained to her supervisor, requesting either a raise or a new hire. The supervisor appeared sympathetic, scratched his neck, and said, "The company sees everything you have done and acknowledges the volume of your work. I will discuss a solution with senior management." Reassured, Liang continued working double duty.

Months passed without resolution. Liang felt frustrated that the supervisor had not kept his word. Had she understood what neck-scratching meant, she would not have trusted him so readily and would have pressed for action. The supervisor's hand on his neck revealed his true position: "We understand your feelings, but the company has no current hiring plan."

In daily life, if someone repeatedly scratches the neck while speaking, do not trust their words lightly. The sensible course is to avoid befriending such duplicitous individuals, for they will never deal with you sincerely.

### **Liars Make Extra Movements Unconsciously**

Micro-expression keywords

The subconscious is not controlled by our conscious mind, yet its influence cannot be ignored. When people lie, the subconscious acts first, followed by conscious control. Consequently, even the most skilled liars produce superfluous small movements that give them away.

A highly skilled liar who manages to conceal every micro-movement might appear flawless. The answer is no.

Any individual, no matter how well trained, remains subject to subconscious impulses and will reveal themselves.

### **11.5 How to Break a Well-Designed Lie?**

Most premeditated offenders are deliberate actors. The more meticulous among them will, after committing the crime, eliminate evidence, coordinate with accomplices, and prepare every line of counter-investigation they can devise. Of course, these are only the "everything" they themselves believe they have covered.

Although objective perfection is impossible, such pre-planned countermeasures and preemptive moves do create substantial difficulties for investigators. Yet the alternating advance of law and crime remains the core driver that continually raises the level of civilization in human society.

Returning to the interrogation setting, let us examine the suspect's lies.

If a suspect has already prepared a highly detailed strategy—both in words and in demeanor—is it still possible to expose the lie?

The answer is yes, for two strongly supportive reasons.

The first reason is that judicial investigation begins with the collection of partial evidence and leads. With evidence or leads already in hand, certain facts cannot be concealed by lies. Intelligent suspects will not attempt outright denial; their most common tactic is to rationalize, in logical terms, the facts that the evidence or leads point to.

The second reason is that, even for the most meticulous mind, rationalization cannot be supported by the same thorough, detailed information that would sustain a chain of true logic. As the saying goes, one lie requires a thousand more to maintain. Every piece of information in a case is connected to every other piece from multiple angles; altering any single element triggers a cascade of logical contradictions.

A everyday example may help illustrate the point.

Suppose someone says, "I love eating beef."

We can test the statement by probing the logical chain that would normally follow:

- Question 1: "Why do you love eating beef?"
- Answer 1: "Because beef is high in protein."
- Question 2: "Is beef higher in protein than chicken?"
- Answer 2: "That is what the sources I have read say."
- Question 3: "Which sources?"
- Answer 3: "....."

Each additional layer of the logical chain increases the respondent's cognitive load exponentially. Failure to answer any single layer does not by itself prove a lie—truthful people may also respond impatiently with "Mind your own business!" Yet the more effort a person invests in appearing truthful, the more complex the reactions become; this conclusion is backed by extensive evidence.

Therefore, in criminal investigation and interrogation, even when a suspect believes every preparation has been made, the preparation can never be objectively complete. Someone who can ready three layers of explanation in advance is already exceptionally shrewd; such individuals are rare. Most people prepare only a single layer of evasion.

The more elaborate the prepared responses, the greater the mental pressure during actual questioning. The following experiment demonstrates the effect.

## **Experimental Case**

### **Basic Model of Lying**

#### **Procedure:**

Participants perform two rounds of mental arithmetic, each consisting of ten addition problems using numbers no larger than ten. Each round is recorded separately for later comparison of reactions.

#### **Rules:**

In the first round, participants must give the correct answers.

In the second round, participants must give incorrect answers, subject to two constraints:



1. The answer must remain within the integer interval  $[1, 10]$ . For example, when asked " $1 + 1$ ," the answer 2345 is invalid.
2. The answer may not reuse any number appearing in the problem itself. For example, when asked " $2 + 3$ ," neither 2 nor 3 is acceptable.

A simple set of problems may be used, such as:

$1+1=?$   $1+2=?$   $1+3=?$   $1+4=?$   $1+5=?$   
 $1+6=?$   $1+7=?$   $1+8=?$   $1+9=?$   $2+2=?$

The specific numbers and order may be randomized, provided the correct result falls within  $[1, 10]$ .

### 11.1 What Is Lying

One of the most striking applications of psychological-stress micro-reactions is lie detection.

Many young people develop a strong interest in "micro-expressions," "behavioral science," and "body language" because television dramas and programs portray these techniques as capable of exposing anyone's lies. Viewers who do not reflect carefully often forget the analytical process and remember only a list of supposed rules, such as:

1. Eyes looking left indicate recall; eyes looking right indicate fabrication.
2. A man's nose contains erectile tissue; touching the nose signals concealment.
3. Responding with contempt to a question means the question hit the mark.
4. Nodding first and then shaking the head is classic equivocation.
5. A single shoulder shrug signals insufficient confidence and therefore lying.
6. Botox-injected faces do not move, so micro-expressions cannot be analyzed.
7. Finger direction differing from eye direction indicates lying.
8. Folded arms indicate lying.
9. Two consecutive lip curls indicate lying.
10. A sudden increase in blinking indicates lying.

Unfortunately, these "standards" that so many enjoy are all incorrect.

Yes, all of them. I state this with full responsibility: they are wrong.

They are compilations made by viewers and netizens, often derived from Chinese subtitles of the American series *Lie to Me*. When Chinese dramas later adopted similar tropes, an uneven mixture of "miraculous techniques" appeared in books and online articles.

The more a book promises a single move that "defeats the enemy," the more likely it is to be an irresponsible cut-and-paste job whose author never understood the material yet managed to produce hundreds of thousands of words through copying. Such books can be browsed, smiled at, and returned to the shelf.

"Can micro-reactions detect lies?"

"Yes."

"Then why are everyone else's methods wrong and only yours right?"

"Because those standards are mindless; using them leads to mistakes, and the mistakes harm the user."

"Why are they mindless?"

"Do they have any mind? Let me ask: what is lying?"

Faced with this direct question, one-sentence formulas fall silent.

For example, why should "finger direction differing from eye direction" prove lying? Everyone knows the Clinton case—an apparently living example. Yet that single instance does not withstand scrutiny; there is also footage of Clinton himself displaying the same mismatch while telling the truth, as well as numerous other truthful speakers who exhibit the same behavior. How can one movement pattern be directly equated with lying?

Anyone willing to draw such a conclusion probably does not even know what the process of lying entails.

The most common definition of lying is "a deliberate act intended to mislead another, whose purpose has not been disclosed in advance and which the other party has not explicitly requested."

Although this definition is clear, complete, and accurate, it remains somewhat abstract and invites both oversight and quibbling. Under this wording, a magic performance could count as lying, and so could the staged awkward situations in the "Mirror House" segment of a certain satellite-television variety show. The original scholars would likely be surprised by such extensions.

We therefore identify the core feature of lying as: expression contradicts cognition.

In plainer terms: if a person is thinking A but saying B, that person is lying.

Once this feature is clearly stated, it becomes obvious that determining whether someone is lying requires at least two pieces of information: what the person "thinks" and what the person "expresses" (usually says). The two must then be compared.

### **Sincerity or Courtesy: Look at His Expression**

The American film *He's Just Not That Into You* opens with an amusing scene: girls from every background—whether African villagers or New York professionals, whether middle-aged women or slender teenagers—ask their friends the same questions: "He said he would call; why hasn't he?" "He said he would come see me; why hasn't he?" Their friends reply with reassuring excuses: "He still likes you; he's just busy right now." "He's very introverted."

These girls prefer to invent kind explanations rather than analyze objectively whether the other person's words are sincere or merely polite, and they repeatedly waste time and miss opportunities. The film's ending reminds them that a man who truly wants to pursue a relationship will find a way to contact them—by phone, MSN, or any other means. Yet a girl need not remain passive; observing and eliciting more information is also legitimate.

FBI agents are experts at this task. During interviews they must accurately gauge the interviewee's level of interest in order to control the pace of the conversation.

When an interviewee looks down, turns the face away, or presses the lips together, agents know interest has been lost and further talk will yield nothing useful. Turning the face signals a desire to leave; pressed lips signal unwillingness to speak.

A girl who sees these expressions in someone she likes should simply say goodbye, regardless of earlier enthusiastic promises to “definitely get in touch.” She should also note that if the person says “I’ll call you in a couple of days” while repeatedly rubbing the nose, the gesture clearly indicates inner rejection.

When an interviewee raises the chin, relaxes the mouth, and shows a hint of teeth, agents know the person is not entirely closed off and has accepted the topic to some degree.

A girl who observes these expressions should realize the conversation will be long; the slightly lifted chin shows the other person’s mind has opened. She should proceed gradually rather than rush, steering the talk toward the information she wants.

Eye contact also reveals acceptance. Mutual gaze lasting five seconds or longer indicates a receptive attitude. If the goal is to learn the other person’s real thoughts, this moment should not be missed.

Eye contact is not the only indicator. Additional signs include:

- Frequent incidental physical contact—light touches to the arm, back, or shoulder show the person regards you as a genuine friend.
- Head tilt—especially noticeable between romantic partners; a tender gaze naturally accompanied by a head inclined toward the other person is hard to resist.

In short, whether to take the initiative or wait depends less on words than on unconscious movements. Words can mislead; movements reliably indicate the correct response.

### **Touching the Ears Indicates Interest in the Topic**

FBI agent Laura was assigned to investigate whether an insurance company had established a front operation abroad. Company policy required every probationary employee to sell a set amount of insurance within one month to become permanent.

One day a middle-aged couple visited. Laura greeted them warmly and presented policies suitable for their age group. The couple showed little interest, leading Laura to wonder whether they had come to buy insurance or merely to gather information. When she mentioned a family policy, however, one of them casually touched an ear. Laura concluded they were interested in family coverage.

To test the inference she asked, “Are you looking for family-combined insurance?” The couple looked surprised but answered seriously, “Yes, because we have children to consider.”

Laura then focused on family policies, explained the various family-based options in detail, and quickly found a product the couple liked. She completed the sale and secured her permanent position.

American marketing consultant Mike Stark once remarked, “If the other person touches an ear, it is a signal of interest.” When someone pulls an earlobe, touches an ear, or brushes the hair near the ear or the back of the head while you are speaking, the gesture shows interest in continuing the conversation. This matches the Japanese saying “pull the ears to hear better.”

The unconscious movement of touching the ears to signal a desire to keep listening is easy to notice. People who say “I’m very interested in this topic” or “Really? I’ve never heard that before” often accompany the words with an ear touch. Even someone who rarely voices opinions will reveal growing interest through this gesture.

Therefore, during conversation it is useful to identify the other person's "sensitive words" and continue on those topics; both parties benefit. Normally, someone uninterested in the topic will not touch an ear.

Conversely, if the person folds the entire pinna forward to cover the ear canal, the gesture means "Stop talking; I've heard enough." Children sometimes cover their ears with both hands when parents argue outside the room; adults do something similar when they no longer wish to listen. If a speaker is animated while the listener inserts a finger into the ear canal as if cleaning it, the listener is signaling disdain. When appropriate, politely ask whether the listener has any comment; otherwise, change the subject.

In any conversation, observe whether the other person is touching the ears or attempting to end the topic. When both hands hover around the ears, it is time to proceed with caution.

### **Pulling at the Collar May Indicate Irritation or Lying**

In movies we often see this scene: when the male protagonist watches his beloved girl fall into another man's arms, he tugs hard at his own collar and undoes the first button of his shirt. Even if wearing a tie, he impatiently loosens it. These gestures perfectly convey the protagonist's agitation and unease. The actions arise mainly because irritation generates intense heat, prompting him to yank the collar away from his neck so cooler air can enter his clothes.

In reality, men tug at their collars for reasons beyond irritation.

Jones has been troubled by her new boyfriend. She wants to know whether he had a deeply loved girlfriend before her. So the petty-minded woman keeps trying to probe: "Was your ex pretty?" "Was she gentle?"...

Each time Jones raises these questions, her boyfriend grows visibly restless, yet he cleverly replies, "I had an ex-girlfriend? That's impossible." While saying this, he unconsciously tugs at his collar. Seeing the gesture, Jones realizes he is lying; the evasive words further reveal his guilt. Instead of losing her temper, she smiles and says, "I hope we can be open with each other. You know I'm not a petty person..."

Research shows that when people lie, the sensitive nerves in the neck produce an itchy sensation, so they unconsciously rub or scratch to relieve the discomfort.

Objectively, men tug at collars more often than women because men usually wear suits and shirts, while women's clothing varies and some styles lack collars. When a woman lies, she is more likely to change the subject or turn her face away. For women who value poise, tugging at a collar appears too masculine. Therefore, the gesture alone cannot confirm that someone is lying.

The accompanying facial expressions are more important. If the person is truly lying, subtle facial changes will appear while tugging the collar—for example, avoiding direct eye contact. We usually determine whether someone is lying by noting both the evasive glance and the unconscious collar tug.

People who lie may also display an uneasy smile because their words do not match their feelings. A genuine smile is an unconscious facial movement not directly controlled by the brain; it results from the autonomous action of facial muscles and produces fine lines around the eyes. A false smile occurs when the brain issues a command to smile and consciously moves the facial muscles, making the expression look unnatural. An insincere smile lifts only the corners of the mouth, so fine lines appear only around the lips.

Therefore, when we cannot tell whether an answer is an unconscious reaction or mere irritation, we can do as Jones did. Unable to decide whether her boyfriend's repeated collar tugs meant he feared his lie would be

exposed, she asked with a sincere smile, "Is something bothering you? I hope we can be open with each other," or "What did you just say? Could you repeat it?" to draw out his true thoughts.

### **People Who Repeatedly Adjust Their Cuffs Are Very Uneasy**

A sexual scandal involving a U.S. celebrity drew intense media attention, and FBI agents played a key role in solving the case.

Agents obtained the perpetrator's DNA from the assaulted hotel maid's clothing. The next day, after learning that the DNA matched the celebrity, they brought him to the FBI. At first the celebrity assumed the agents had no evidence of forced sexual activity and insisted the encounter had been consensual. As case details emerged and witnesses appeared one after another, agents noticed that although he never admitted to coercion, he began to waver internally. This convinced them that the maid's account was not fabricated.

How did the agents detect this psychological shift? World-renowned body-language expert Joe Navarro states, "Approximately 60 to 80 percent of human communication occurs through nonverbal behavior. Reading nonverbal cues is a core part of FBI interrogation work. In this case, as evidence of sexual assault mounted, agents observed that during interviews the celebrity adjusted his cuffs or fiddled with his watch with increasing frequency—an unmistakable sign of internal wavering."

Psychologists have confirmed through experiments that fiddling with cuffs, cuff buttons, or a watch is an instinctive defensive gesture indicating extreme nervousness. Women who repeatedly reposition a handbag on their arm display a similar sign of unease.

Experienced agents used this cue as a breakthrough, pressing the celebrity each time he adjusted his cuffs or played with his watch, extracting numerous facts and ultimately establishing his guilt on the sexual-assault charge.

Under normal circumstances, cuff-fiddling reveals inner instability and reduces others' trust. For information-gathering, however, the moment is highly advantageous because psychological defenses are most vulnerable then.

In social settings, habitual cuff-fiddlers often give opponents openings. In the workplace, such individuals remain at the bottom of the hierarchy, assigned trivial tasks because their unease leaks out. The same holds in conversation: it is a game of strategy; whoever first reveals a weakness loses earliest.

Experts therefore advise that while exploiting another person's unease to extract information, one should minimize similar gestures oneself. Especially when speaking with unfamiliar people or in public, avoid the behavior.

Control does not mean concealment. Placing the arms under the table is not foolproof; it too signals weakness. Only when absolutely necessary should arms go under the table to adjust sleeves or handle a watch, and they should return to the tabletop immediately afterward. If tension arises and one wishes to hide it, adjust breathing or take a sip of water instead.

Remember: never let others perceive you as unconfident or insignificant. Raise your own value and maintain a superior posture that tells them, "I am the best."

### **Recounting in Reverse Makes Lies Fall Apart**

An American drama contains this amusing scene: after waiting a long time, the protagonist finally finds a parking spot. Just as he begins to back in, another car speeds up and steals the space. The protagonist confronts the driver: "Didn't you see I'd been waiting for this spot?" The driver nods, then shakes his head repeatedly and says innocently, "No, I was waiting too." The protagonist replies seriously, "You're lying. You just performed a classic lying gesture—nodding slightly before shaking your head to say no."

That single inadvertent nod exposed the driver's secret. Lies are not impregnable; careful observation easily reveals a person's true thoughts through small, unconscious movements.

Everyone lies daily. One noted professor has pointed out that of every ten people we interact with each day, five are lying. Even the kindest person lies at least twice a day on average. Most lies aim to hide something or prevent others from reading one's mind, so people employ various cover-ups. This pattern is especially evident during interrogations.

FBI agent Jack questioned a suspect: "What were you doing on the day of the incident?" The suspect answered fluently: "At eight I went to the convenience store, at ten I was on my way to work, at twelve I was eating a work meal..." The timeline seemed to prove he had not been at the crime scene. Jack pressed on: "Could you repeat what you just said, but in reverse chronological order?" After a long pause the suspect stammered, "At five in the afternoon, I... I was..." Clearly the suspect could not recount his actions backward. Jack immediately recognized the lie.

People who plan to lie prepare fluent answers in advance, yet because they did not actually experience the events, those details never enter deep memory. Asking them to recount events in reverse order exposes the fabrication. The next time you face a skilled liar, pretend you did not catch part of the story, pick several time points, and ask for a fresh description. If the person cannot answer smoothly, the lie becomes obvious.

The following signs during conversation also indicate lying:

- Speech is faster and smoother than usual, showing prior preparation.
- Answers are evasive and the mouth moves while the hands remain still.
- Long pauses, frequent hesitation, rigid posture, and minimal body movement.
- Eyes either avoid contact or pupils are larger than usual.
- Introverted individuals produce markedly less fluent speech when lying.

In short, no matter how sophisticated the technique, lies leave traces. Even when words are seamless, body language betrays the truth. Once we see through a lie, we gain a decisive psychological advantage; knowing the other person's real intentions frees us from being controlled. In business negotiations especially, mastering this skill allows us to "take the initiative."

### **The Harm of Coveting Ill-Gotten Gains**

Many people cannot endure poverty and, desperate to change their circumstances, take reckless risks for "unworthy gains." They accept bribes to bend rules at work, pocket found items, or resort to theft, robbery, or fraud. Such individuals ultimately destroy themselves for the sake of ill-gotten wealth. They are unreliable; when faced with large temptations, self-interest overrides integrity and prompts further misconduct.

A website once carried this report:

A lottery-shop owner, tempted by a five-million-yuan winning ticket, lied to the ticket holder that it had not won, intending to claim the prize himself. He even enlisted a couple to help collect the jackpot.

The ticket holder, of course, remembered the numbers, and the winning information appeared in newspapers and on television. The owner's scheme backfired. By fraudulently obtaining property of enormous value, he committed the crime of fraud and received a twelve-year prison sentence—an outcome entirely of his own making.

His accomplices were also convicted of concealing criminal proceeds and received corresponding penalties.

A person's greed is terrifying. If such an individual is in our circle, we inhabit an unsafe environment. By observing how someone behaves when poor, we can gauge character and decide whether to entrust them with anything important.

The old saying warns, "Do not stretch out your hand; if you do, it will be caught." Wealth exists in many forms, but it must be earned through honest labor; no dishonorable method can make it truly ours. Although we may be poor, our spirit need not be. We must firmly reject anything that does not belong to us. Even if a dishonest act succeeds temporarily, the gain will eventually be lost, and trust in that person will be permanently destroyed.

When choosing or entrusting someone, examine how they acted in poverty. Anyone who covets ill-gotten gains will become a "landmine" buried beside us; constant vigilance will be required, and an explosion may occur at any moment over "unworthy gains."

In poverty everyone hopes for financial help and a comfortable life. Such hopes cannot be realized by grasping at ill-gotten gains; what is not ours cannot be forced. Some people, even when poor, disdain money that arrives unearned and uphold their integrity. As Tao Yuanming wrote, they "will not bend at the waist for five bushels of rice." They rely solely on their own efforts. Only such people can truly achieve great things and are worthy of friendship and trust. With them, we can entrust anything at any time.

### **People Who Scratch Their Necks Are Saying One Thing and Meaning Another**

Pete, a veteran employee at a company, had repeatedly asked his supervisor for a promotion and raise without success. One gloomy day he invited his FBI-agent friend Big to a bar. After a few drinks he recounted his frustrations.

Big laughed, clapped Pete on the shoulder, and said loudly, "Buddy, don't worry. I had the same problem with the supervisor, and he gave me the same runaround. But a stubborn guy like me doesn't let an old fox off that easily. Let me tell you what happened."

"A few months ago I went to the supervisor and clearly raised the salary issue, because my experience and ability far exceed my current pay. The supervisor just smiled, scratched his neck, and brushed me off, saying the bureau had considered my compensation, valued my work, but believed I still had room to grow. Besides, I'd been there less time than many colleagues, so my salary was already reasonable."

"As soon as I heard that, I knew he intended to reject me. So I proposed that he assign me the current 'terrorist attack' case that was troubling him. If I handled it well, I would get the raise; if not, my salary would stay the same. While I spoke, I noticed the supervisor's hand move from his neck to his chin. I immediately realized he had agreed. As you know, that was the case for which I later received commendation."

Pete could not help admiring his old friend, yet he asked, "How did you spot the supervisor's intention so quickly and adjust your strategy?"

"Experts discovered long ago that when people feel uncertain or uneasy they unconsciously scratch their necks—usually with the index finger on the side of the neck or the area below the earlobe, roughly five times," Big replied.

Big's remark reminded Pete that his own supervisor had indeed scratched his neck during their conversations. At the time Pete had dismissed it as a habit; now he understood the gesture signaled reservation—hence the repeated requests that never received a positive answer.

Big continued, "Opposition during conversation is nothing to fear. When facing 'doubtful looks' and 'duplicitous attitudes,' the key is to respond actively. Once I identify these signs, I simply change my approach so that doubt and negation turn first into thought and then into agreement."

These conversational techniques apply beyond promotions and raises. When offering suggestions to a leader, adding constructive ideas increases acceptance. When discussing an issue with colleagues, citing facts, figures, and authoritative reports strengthens one's position. The most effective way to convert doubt into agreement, however, is to demonstrate courage and resolve through action.

### **Brokaw Trap**

Tom Brokaw is a well-known anchor for NBC. He had excellent experience spotting lies on the program *Meet the Press*. He said, "Most of the clues I get are verbal rather than physical. When I look for signs of lying, I do not watch the other person's face; instead I focus on answers that make no sense or on evasive remarks that sound plausible." Paul Ekman endorsed this view, noting that Brokaw's experience has a certain validity in the process of lie detection.

Liars often talk nonstop to cover up flaws and reduce loopholes, or they may stammer and deflect because of guilt. These behaviors can serve as clues. However, Paul Ekman points out that not everyone fits this pattern. Brokaw overlooked individual differences. Some people are articulate in private but become tongue-tied when facing an audience or a camera due to nervousness; someone who is already inarticulate will appear even more awkward in public. Ekman calls this situation the **Brokaw Trap**.

To avoid the trap, individual differences must be taken into account by observing a person's usual behavioral habits. Comparing the person's baseline state with their state after suspicion arises yields more accurate results. If someone normally displays few fidgety movements but shows an increase when suspected, this indicates inner tension and unease, suggesting they have not told the whole truth. Without prior knowledge of the individual, however, judging them as a liar solely on the basis of fidgety movements observed during a first meeting is arbitrary.

Consider the classic poker example. One player coughs loudly at critical moments. The other players, except his partner, believe they have discovered the signal and feel secretly pleased. At the final hand they raise the stakes, expecting a big win. The player coughs again at the decisive moment. Believing their chance has arrived, the others lose heavily. The player had been bluffing from the start to mislead opponents; the final cough was the real signal.

During a first meeting, take enough time to distinguish a "decoy cough" from a "real signal cough." Never assume you have an opening the moment you hear a cough.

Everyone presents differently and feels differently during a first encounter. Some people become more reserved than usual in order to make a good impression, their every movement stiff and formal. Others appear nervous with strangers, stumbling over words, losing logical coherence, and fidgeting. In either case the



person's normal habits remain hidden, making comparison impossible and preventing any reliable judgment about whether they are lying.

Therefore, to detect lies it is best to arrange several meetings so the relationship becomes closer and the other person's everyday behavioral and emotional patterns can be observed.

This is where micro-expressions (微反应) become especially important. Because certain expressions cannot be fully suppressed, they may leak out even on first meeting. Yet one issue cannot be ignored: the emotional source behind the micro-expression. Without identifying that source, the expression offers little help in exposing a lie. Combining micro-expressions with three additional lie clues—body language, slips of the tongue, and heated language—makes the judgment more precise.

### 11.1.2 Determination of Lies

If the content expressed contradicts the person's cognition, the individual can be judged to be lying.

Lying falls into two categories. One is the concealment of true information—"I don't know" or "That is not the case"—or the refusal to respond at all through silence; this is academically termed "concealment lying." The other is the fabrication of false information to replace true information, calling black white or calling black "a little black and a little white"; this is academically termed "fabrication lying."

Content expressed through language, clearly meaningful gestures (such as nodding in affirmation), text, and so on is relatively easy to capture.

The difficulty in detecting lies lies in ascertaining the person's subjective cognition.

Because it is subjective cognition, it cannot be taken at face value from the person's own statements. Current scientific methods include many techniques that can obtain information from the human brain either directly or indirectly.

The most advanced is fMRI technology, which can already reconstruct scanned brain-image information into video form with considerable clarity. In one experiment, faces and movements reconstructed from fMRI closely resembled the faces and movements the subject had previously viewed.

A more traditional method is the polygraph, which measures changes in physiological indicators such as skin resistance, heart rate, respiration, and blood volume to determine which test questions have greater impact on the subject. When four of five options in a set produce no physiological change while one option consistently produces a similar change across multiple trials, that option contains the subject's subjective cognitive information.

In a theft-case test, for example, questions may concern the amount stolen. Police might ask:

"The wallet contained 2,000 yuan?"

Subject: "I don't know."

"The wallet contained 3,000 yuan?"

Subject: "I don't know."

"The wallet contained 4,000 yuan?"

Subject: "I don't know."

"The wallet contained 5,000 yuan?"

Subject: "I don't know."

"The wallet contained 6,000 yuan?"

Subject: "I don't know."

An innocent person does not know how much money was in someone else's wallet, so all five options are equally non-stimulating. The thief, having counted the money, knows the exact amount. To avoid punishment the thief will also answer "I don't know" to every question, yet when the remembered figure is mentioned the mismatch between the spoken answer and actual cognition produces an abnormal fluctuation in physiological indicators. If this fluctuation proves stable upon repeated verification, the subject is known to possess information about the stolen amount and is therefore lying.

The above method can reveal the subject's subjective cognitive information.

[1] Paul Ekman, *Telling Lies: Clues to Deceit in the Marketplace, Politics, and Marriage*. SDX Joint Publishing, December 2008:10. ISBN 978-7-108-03004-7.

### **The Movie *Indecent Proposal***

Demi Moore once starred in the film *Indecent Proposal*, which tells the story of two people who cross a moral line for money.

David and Diana are newlyweds deeply in love but financially strained. During the Great Depression they cannot find suitable work. One day in a casino they meet billionaire John Gage. In casual conversation John says, "Money can buy anything." David and Diana disagree; they believe money cannot buy everything—for example, it cannot buy love.

John then asks, "Would you let Diana spend one night with me for one million dollars?" One million dollars is an enormous temptation. The couple tosses and turns all night. In the end they cannot resist; Diana spends the night with John.

Although at the film's conclusion John, seeing that the two young people truly love each other, cannot bear to keep them apart and voluntarily gives Diana up, this is merely the director's concession to audience expectations. In reality such outcomes are rare.

In both work and career, setbacks occur; no one's life is smooth sailing. Yet people respond differently to setbacks. Some who feel unappreciated at work blame others instead of examining themselves. They give up, stop trying, ignore assignments, and even leak company information to competitors. Such employees are detestable because they have abandoned their moral底线. The底线 becomes like the emperor's new clothes—an excuse that comforts only themselves. Associating with such people risks contagion; one may become cynical and lose one's own底线. Therefore we must draw a clear line with them.

Thomas Babington Macaulay said, "A person's conduct when certain that no one will ever know reveals character." In other words, whatever circumstances you face, your actions display your moral quality. Suppose a rival company offers you a high salary and a platform to use your talents on the condition that you bring your current employer's technical data. Would you accept? This is a difficult choice. Those without a moral底线 will certainly go; morality cannot stop them and they are not worth retaining. Only those who can hold the line deserve promotion and trust.

An excellent person, even when career prospects are dim, still maintains a moral底线 and a clear conscience. Excellence is not an act but a habit. There is no such thing as an excellent act; only the habit of excellence is true excellence. A person may not excel in career, but must never lack a底线.

#### 11.4 Methods of Analyzing Lies with Micro-reactions

A simple case can illustrate the process of obtaining and judging information.

Suppose someone drops a rock on their foot and injures it.

They immediately show a pained expression and crouch to examine and relieve the pain. These are unguarded physiological reactions.

If asked, "Does it hurt?" they may, for various reasons, answer, "It's fine, it doesn't hurt."

In that case they are lying.

Cognition = pain. Through expression and movement we can clearly see that the pain they feel is intense.

Expression = "It's fine, it doesn't hurt." Because expression contradicts cognition, they are judged to be lying.

With micro-reactions the only difference from the above example is that the reactions we must observe are far less obvious. The person may exert great effort to suppress and disguise them, substantially reducing the visible physiological and emotional responses. Yet any leakage that escapes complete suppression follows regular patterns and can be used to judge the person's subjective cognition, feelings, and even assessments and judgments.

These reactions can then be compared with the content the person explicitly expresses; the result is immediately apparent.

For example, if everything the person says is modest, low-key, and compliant, yet you notice them clenching their fists slightly while speaking, you can conclude that verbal expression and emotional reaction do not match. The language conveys weak submission while the small bodily movement betrays underlying anger. Thus the person's language is a disguise.

At that point the credibility of their words drops, and more importantly their attitude is "lying." In many criminal and anti-corruption cases, determining whether a suspect lies about minor details is not the primary task; accurately grasping the suspect's attitude—i.e., subjective intent—is. Once a cunning suspect leads investigators by the nose with strategy and acting, opportunities may be lost and prior efforts wasted.

In short, a simple formula cannot determine whether someone is lying because the essence of lying is a contradiction between expression and cognition. To expose a lie one must know both the subjective cognition and the expression; neither suffices alone.

Judging a lie by formula alone is obviously naïve and fails under verification.

All the techniques presented in this book and in *Micro-expressions* aim to judge a person's subjective cognition indirectly. Physiological and emotional reactions can map the person's subjective state. When combined with information contained in the stimulus, a causal link can be established and the person's subjective cognition becomes visible.

Exposing the lie then follows naturally.

More importantly, once the person's subjective cognition is judged, appropriate strategies for dealing with them can be formulated.

In simple terms, learning to analyze micro-reactions teaches one how to interact with all kinds of people in all kinds of situations.

### **Use Negative Expressions and Words Cautiously**

To gain acceptance for one's ideas, minimize the use of negative expressions and words. As noted in the discussion of anger, a negative attitude most readily provokes anger. Whether one says "You can't do it," "Can you really do it?" or "He can't do it," the effect is to arouse anger to varying degrees. Anger triggers resistance, rejection, and even impulsive decisions. Therefore, to have one's ideas accepted, first reduce negative attitudes so that negative expressions do not arise.

Imagine discussing a proposal with colleagues. Your idea is good, yet not everyone agrees. To win over the dissenters you use the wrong approach: "You say my idea is bad—do you think yours is any better? Look at your proposal; what is this?" Even if you do not voice the thought, if you hold it you will display a contemptuous expression. Never underestimate that expression. Even a faint one, or a quiet sneer, can drive the other person to fury. Once noticed, it generates anger. If the team has already been working overtime on the proposal and tempers are frayed, your expression becomes the spark that ignites an argument.

Therefore, avoid adopting a negative attitude or displaying negative expressions. Likewise, use negative words such as "no" and "don't" sparingly.

Consider the sentence "Don't think about that plan; concentrate." You will first think about what the plan is; the moment you are told not to think about it, you already are. Parents frequently use "no" and "don't" with children: "Don't touch that, it's dangerous," "Don't eat that, it's spicy." Children then do exactly the opposite, causing frustration. Negative words can, to some extent, emphasize the prohibited action and draw more attention to it. If someone says "Don't think of the red monkey," you will inevitably wonder what the red monkey looks like, how a red monkey could exist, whether it is a baboon or an orangutan—and your mind has already wandered to "thinking of the red monkey" rather than the preceding "don't."

A divorced man remained depressed, constantly thinking he was divorced. When his psychologist advised him to think instead that he had become single, his condition improved markedly and he met other accomplished women.

Living with a negative attitude is exhausting and dispiriting. If you wish to express yourself, avoid negative phrasing; offering suggestions directly is more effective. Instead of rejecting someone else's proposal outright, describe the strengths of your own proposal. This gives everyone an objective view of your idea while preserving team harmony.

### **Building Rapport with Someone You Like**

When you meet someone you like, how do you establish rapport?

The most charming expression is the smile. Few people can remain indifferent when smiled at; usually a smile is returned. You have probably experienced this: on a train, with passengers beside and opposite you, a young person roughly your age catches your eye. The journey is long and conversation would ease the tedium. You

look at the person; they look at you. You smile; they smile back. The similar age already creates warmth, and the exchange of smiles deepens it. Soon the person initiates conversation.

The same approach works with someone of the opposite sex you find attractive. A smile is the first step in building rapport and the first step toward mutual understanding. If you see someone who moves you in a crowd, begin with a friendly smile to put them at ease.

Eye contact is another method. At a dinner you notice a stranger and feel an immediate liking. You can start with a smile, then maintain an open posture—uncross your arms, move glasses and cutlery aside—so the space between you feels clear and reduces distance. After chatting for a while, if you wish to test whether further development is possible, use eye contact. Look at the person for one or two seconds, then shift your gaze to the floor. Looking down signals invitation and conveys submission; the implied message is “You may come closer.” This cue is especially common in women.

When the other person feels noticed, they instinctively present their best self: a woman may adopt an elegant posture, touch up her makeup, or adjust her hair and clothing; a man may sit straighter and expand his chest to display strength. If the person is a woman, playing with her hair or earrings signals acceptance of the invitation. The key point is not the hair or earrings themselves but the display of the wrist. The person is usually unaware of the action; revealing the wrist or palm is an evolved signal that no weapon is held and friendly interaction is possible. The modern handshake originated from this gesture.

Next come postures that convey seduction, some of which are more common in women.

## **Imperfect Lies**

Sheriff York recently took on a strange rape case. Based on his experience, he judged that something about the case was abnormal, yet he could not identify exactly what felt off. He therefore brought the victim’s statement and the evidence to the FBI and sought out his former colleague, now FBI agent Charlie, to help analyze the case.

The victim’s statement read as follows:

Last night after work, I was walking home when I suddenly sensed someone following me from behind. I became very frightened, so I turned around to see who it was. The person stayed hidden in the shadows, however, and I could not make out his face at all. My fear grew. Just ahead was a narrow alley; I quickly slipped into it, but the person followed. We kept walking forward. It grew darker and darker, and the person drew closer. He approached me, and despite my resistance we had sexual relations. At that moment I tore this chain from his neck.

York showed Charlie the chain mentioned in the statement. After examining it, Charlie asked for York’s assessment. York replied, “If we treat this as a rape case, I see several inconsistencies. We located the chain’s owner through it. Although the owner confessed to the rape, I still feel the incident cannot be classified as rape. I simply cannot pinpoint what is wrong, which is why I came to you for help.”

Charlie nodded. “I agree with your assessment. I noticed several suspicious details in the statement. For instance, the victim repeatedly used the word ‘we’ when describing the rape. That word usually signals familiarity between two people. The victim said ‘we kept walking forward’ and ‘we had sexual relations,’ which strongly suggests the two already knew each other. In addition, the chain shows no signs of damage. It was almost certainly not yanked off in haste; it was more likely picked up or deliberately removed. I recommend further investigation.”

York accepted the advice. Back at the station he re-interviewed both parties and checked their identities and recent circumstances. The investigation revealed that the victim and the defendant had been a couple who were in the process of breaking up. The victim wanted to end the relationship; the defendant, despondent, staged the opening scene.

## Occasional Liars

People who lie only occasionally usually do so to avoid an unpleasant situation or to cover a mistake. They are not skilled at lying, so they feel uneasy while doing it. That unease shows in their appearance, body language, and voice.

- **Avoiding names of themselves and others involved**

University of Hertfordshire psychologist Wiseman notes, "Liars feel uncomfortable, so they instinctively remove themselves from the lie." They often say "the car broke down" instead of "my car broke down." Liars also rarely use the names of people they mention in the lie. A well-known example is President Bill Clinton, who, when addressing the nation, refused to say "Lewinsky" and instead declared, "I did not have sexual relations with that woman."

- **Avoiding eye contact**

Occasional liars often touch their eyes to avoid eye contact. Women typically touch just below the eye or look at the ceiling; men rub their eyes more forcefully and also look away.

- **Sudden change in volume or pitch**

A sudden rise in pitch often betrays a liar trying to mask nervousness.

- **Genuine expressions flash for only an instant**

A normal expression lasts several seconds, but on a "masked face" a genuine emotion appears for only a fraction of a second.

- **The nose enlarges slightly**

Extra blood flows to the face during lying; some people blush, and the nose can swell a few millimeters. Liars feel discomfort in the nose and unconsciously touch it.

- **Liars touch themselves frequently**

The more liars try to hide their inner state, the more small movements betray them. People often start to cover their mouths, then, realizing it looks suspicious, touch their noses instead.

- **Pulling at the collar**

Psychological discomfort triggers subtle changes in the sympathetic nervous system, producing tingling in the face and neck. Liars therefore rub or tug at their collars.

## Using Anchors to Influence Others

Anchors and micro-expressions appear unrelated, yet the correct use of anchors depends on micro-expression cues. You may recall a scene from *The Mentalist*: the inspector, wanting to confirm whether a thug had once been an undercover officer, arranged a meeting in a diner. The thug looked nervous. The inspector began asking questions he knew the man could not lie about, each time tapping the table twice.

"Are you called ×××?" Tap, tap.

"Yes."

"Are you limping on one leg?" Tap, tap.

"Yes."

The inspector kept the tapping rhythm constant while accelerating the questions. All the questions were ones the man had to answer truthfully—until the final one.

"Have you ever worked undercover?" Tap, tap.

"Yes," the man answered without thinking, then froze. Surprise flashed across his face, followed instantly by fear. He had been embedded in a gang and could not let anyone know his true identity. Years earlier he had accidentally injured someone during a gang fight and served time. After release he had tried to sever all ties with his past, including his undercover work. If the gang discovered the truth, they would kill him. When he inadvertently told the truth, his first reaction was surprise—"How did I let that slip?"—then fear, because the secret now threatened his life. His answer and micro-expressions confirmed to the inspector that he had indeed been undercover.

This is how anchors and micro-expressions work together. Each time the inspector asked a question the man could not lie about, he tapped the table twice. After several truthful answers the man had formed the association "when I hear that sound I must tell the truth." That association is the anchor.

The prototype of an anchor is classical conditioning. Pavlov rang a bell twice before feeding his dogs; eventually the bell alone made them salivate. An anchor is a conditioned-reflex technique aimed at humans; what is implanted is not saliva but an emotional state. Once mastered, the technique lets you influence others so that their emotions shift in the direction you choose.

## **Recreational Activities**

Some people relax after work by listening to music or dancing. These are recreational activities, and we can learn about a person from the music or dance they prefer.

People who enjoy symphonies tend to be self-confident, eager to express themselves, and optimistic. They quickly connect with others, yet they can be overly trusting and impractical.

People who like rock music dislike solitude and seek out like-minded companions. They are energetic, enjoy sports, and often feel dissatisfied with society. They use rock music to vent emotions. They like to stand out but rarely leave a deep impression. They frequently feel lost and need someone to help them recover a sense of self.

People who prefer pop music are ordinary and go with the flow. They pursue a relatively simple, carefree lifestyle and use music to stay relaxed.

People who favor classical music are usually rational. They practice self-reflection and self-discipline, often appearing solitary because few people truly enter their inner world.

A person's dancing style also reveals personality. Ballet lovers show great patience and perseverance. Tap dancers are energetic, attention-seeking, and punctual. Waltz enthusiasts are calm, affable, and project mature, refined charm.

## **Eating**

This cue is common among women. Women may chew olives, gum, chocolate, or ice to draw attention to their lips, sometimes licking them. If you are already sharing a meal, however, the signal loses meaning.

You may meet a woman in a bar who wears revealing clothes, circles you, glances at you, and plays with her earrings or necklace—an obvious invitation meaning “I want to be approached.” Another woman, equally provocatively dressed, may sit with legs tightly crossed and hands on her lap, signaling rejection and conservatism.

*The Mentalist* featured such a case. A female entertainer accused a wealthy young man of rape; he insisted the encounter was consensual. Police reviewed two videotapes and concluded the woman was lying. The first tape showed the man approaching her in a karaoke room. She sat alone; he initiated contact and made suggestive gestures. The inspector noticed one detail: she had crossed her legs, slipped one shoe halfway off, and was dangling it from her toes—an unmistakable flirtatious signal. When a woman is interested, she often displays an erogenous zone; the ankle is one such area.

The second tape showed the man carrying the apparently intoxicated woman into a hotel. In a mirror the police saw her wearing a satisfied, knowing smile—proof she was not drunk and was pleased her plan was succeeding.

The tapes exonerated the young man.

These techniques alone cannot guarantee that someone will like you; they are merely initial tools for understanding. Whether the other person develops affection also depends on character, background, and many other factors.

## **The Secret of Anchors**

Once something is labeled a “technique,” it can seem remote from daily life. In fact, anchors are already part of ordinary experience. Consider a simple example: you break up with a loved one on your birthday and afterward listen to the same song every day. Years later, each birthday brings sadness, and hearing that song revives the pain. The date and the song have become an anchor implanted in your mind.

We sometimes meet someone for the first time and instantly dislike them. Later we realize the person was wearing a purple fitted top—the same style once worn by someone who hurt us. The garment has become an unpleasant anchor.

Not all anchors are negative, though negative emotions tend to leave stronger impressions. Pleasant anchors also exist. University dormitory nights filled with gossip and laughter can create one. After graduation, simply sharing a room again with former roommates and chatting in the dark can instantly restore that happy feeling, even if the exact conversations are forgotten.

Music is a powerful anchor used by many therapists. Film scores become classics not only for their beauty but because they instantly evoke the emotions of a beloved scene. Horror-movie music, low and ominous, can still produce chills, rapid heartbeat, anxiety, and sweating long after the specific frightening images have faded.

By recognizing anchors we can read another person’s emotional state. If we are fortunate enough to discover a hidden anchor, we can use it to guide that person’s feelings. Most anchors, however, lie in the unconscious, unknown even to the individual. Creating new anchors therefore becomes essential.

### **11.1.1 The Standard for Truth-Telling**



If a person's cognition and expression are consistent, the person is not lying.

Even if the expressed content does not match objective reality, the person is still not lying provided the expression matches their own cognition.

Imagine one hundred small balls of different colors arranged without obvious pattern. Subjects are asked to note each ball's color, after which the sequence is hidden. They are then asked the color of a randomly chosen ball. Each subject answers according to memory. Even if the answer differs from the actual color, the subject is not considered to be lying, because the information matches the subject's internal cognition.

Truthfulness is judged solely against the speaker's subjective cognition, not against objective fact. This is why polygraph results are not admissible as evidence. No matter how accurate the instrument, it can only access subjective cognition. If that cognition itself is distorted, the technology cannot reach the earlier stage of objective reality. Although most people's subjective perceptions align with objective facts, the method cannot verify physical evidence because it cannot trace the cognitive processing that intervenes between reality and perception.

By contrast, DNA, fingerprints, footprints, ballistics, and autopsies examine physical traces that can originate only from actual events and therefore possess full traceability and strong evidentiary value<|eos|>

## **Behavior**

People dominated by visual senses are usually very quick in walking and speaking. They are also highly sensitive to color, structure, shape, and light. For them, everything visible is transient, so they must memorize rapidly; over time this becomes habit, making both walking and speaking very fast. Because their actions are swift, these individuals breathe rapidly when expressing themselves, with pronounced chest movement, and their gestures accompanying speech are frequent. When activating memory, visually dominant people look up and to the left.

People dominated by auditory senses speak and walk more slowly than the visually dominant. They are accustomed to thinking while answering, so their speech rate follows their thinking speed. Gestures that accompany speech are generally confined to the mid-body, serving as one of their ways to express and relax. Because their memory is primarily auditory, they are very sensitive to sound and are often distracted by noises. In addition, when listening to others, auditory-dominant people habitually tilt their heads; this posture enhances ear function and helps them hear more clearly. When speaking themselves, they pay close attention to tone and intonation, hoping to convey their message with a more pleasing voice.

People dominated by kinesthetic senses care deeply about anything they can touch—whether clothing feels comfortable, whether a seat is soft, whether the surroundings are elegant. When expressing themselves, their speech rate is moderate, gestures center mainly on the abdomen, and breathing is diaphragmatic. Compared with demands for sound or image, these individuals prefer to convey opinions through touch. You have certainly met people who, while talking, repeatedly touch objects, pat you, or nudge you with an elbow. They rely on kinesthetic memory; feeling matters more than anything else.

## **Timing for Anchoring**

One point must be noted: the moment for setting an anchor should be chosen when a pleasant emotion is rising, not when it is about to fade or turn negative. In other words, anchoring is more effective when the other person is already happy.

If circumstances force you to implant a positive anchor quickly, you can only try to elicit the person's happy emotion—for example, by helping them recall a past joyful event—and then set the anchor while the happiness is present. This approach yields twice the result with half the effort.

To know when the other person's emotion has become happy, you must read micro-expressions.

Try this:

"Do you remember what it felt like the first time one of your dreams came true? Do you remember the feeling when you finally obtained something after countless hardships? Yes, that feeling was wonderful. Do you remember it?"

When the other person shows a happy micro-expression, you can seize the moment to set the anchor you wish to create.

Practice several times and you will discover the benefits of anchoring. Remember two rules, however:

- First, do not overuse anchors; you cannot know what psychological shadow you might cast on the other person.
- Second, establish positive anchors, especially when you intend to influence someone.

Many parents like to frighten children. When a child enters a dark space, they say in an alarmed voice, "Come here, come here," while making a turning-and-fleeing gesture. Their intention is to make the child obedient and keep the child from playing in dark rooms. Yet after several repetitions the child learns to fear darkness and wants to escape any dark environment. Therefore a positive anchor is important: even if its effect is not as obvious as hoped, at least it does not harm others.

### **Don't Let Him See That I Lied**

Employee Xiao Wang wanted a quick look at the payroll sheet, so he slipped into the HR office when no one was around. Just as he finished and was about to leave, he ran into a colleague returning from an errand.

"What are you doing here? Need something?"

Covering his mouth, Xiao Wang gave a light cough. "Ah, nothing. I came to see Xiao Li, but he's not here."

Psychologists tell us that when people suddenly cover their mouths during conversation, it is usually because they have just lied. They try to hide the lie or conceal its traces by covering their mouths. To appear more natural, some people, like Xiao Wang in the example, pretend to cough while covering their mouths.

In short, covering the mouth with a hand can indicate that a lie has been told and the speaker is trying to mask nervousness.

For instance, during a class meeting the room is quiet. After the teacher finishes, the class monitor is asked if there is anything to add. The monitor shakes his head and says "No," yet unconsciously covers his mouth with his hand. He is probably lying, because he is hesitant about whether to raise a certain issue in front of the whole class.

Moreover, if you can see his mouth, it is likely pressed tightly shut or the upper lip is biting the lower lip. This shows inner conflict: "Should I speak or not?"

Covering the mouth is a self-warning that represents the thought “I must not put myself in danger” or “I must not offend anyone.” The implied subtext is “Don’t let him see that I’m lying” or “He must not learn this secret.”

## Finding Flaws in Speech to Expose Liars

Micro-expression keywords

Even the most skilled liars cannot be completely watertight. Either an expression or a gesture gives them away. Although people deliberately monitor their words when lying, research shows that liars still reveal slips in speech. Careful observation will always uncover traces that leave the liar nowhere to hide.

American psychologist Feldman states that humans are boastful animals and lie more than they realize—on average at least twenty-five times a day.

Most lies, of course, do little harm. Feldman classifies lies into different levels and groups the motives into three categories:

- The first: to please others and make them feel better.
- The second: to boast about oneself or put on airs.
- The third: self-protection.

Feldman notes: “We lie to others unconsciously, sometimes without thinking, and even refuse to admit we are lying. Most lies are polite responses such as ‘You don’t look fat in that at all,’ ‘Let’s have tea sometime,’ ‘I can’t come today, I’m sick,’ ‘I called you but couldn’t get through,’ or ‘I had a great time tonight; let’s get together again soon.’”

Feldman explains: “Knowing when to lie or bend the truth is a social skill.”

Some lies, however, are highly damaging—those told deliberately to achieve a specific goal. When the other person’s speech shows the following features, you should pay close attention.

## Experimental Requirements for Subjects

Subjects must control their performance as much as possible. If the two rounds of recording show consistent behavior with no obvious differences, the subject wins the trial.

In this experiment the first round requires the subject to tell the truth; the second round requires the subject to lie. Using “ $1 + 1 = ?$ ” as an example, in the second round the subject first calculates the correct answer “2,” but the rules forbid saying “2.” This creates a conflict between the true cognition (“2”) and the required response, satisfying the definition of a lie.

Such simple lie material has two advantages: every adult can easily compute the correct answer to each question, and uttering these “lies” involves neither personal gain nor loss and therefore imposes no direct psychological burden (such as fear or guilt). It can thus be regarded as the most basic model of lying.

Comparison of the recordings shows that even in this pure lie model, subjects cannot keep their second-round reactions identical to the first. Time delays lengthen, eye movements increase, and inappropriate laughter and other anomalies appear repeatedly.

The reason is that processing a lie imposes a heavy cognitive load on the brain—at least several times the load required for telling the truth. The brain must first calculate the correct answer, then verify each step against

complex rules to avoid it, and finally construct a coherent, self-consistent narrative of fabricated content. When this is compounded by emotions such as disgust, fear, guilt, or anger, plus the pressure of follow-up questions, the brain may bear a load dozens of times heavier than when telling the truth.

## **Poker Face**

A poker face generally refers to a face showing no expression. It reveals neither happiness nor unhappiness nor neutrality. Successful poker players usually master control of their body language, especially facial expressions, so that their emotions remain hidden.

You will often see them wearing sunglasses to reduce the chance that their eyes betray emotion. Sometimes they also send false signals or strike poses to mislead other players. Such behavior is not criminal. Anyone can hide true intentions by displaying an opposing expression or maintaining a poker face.

If a person does not consciously control emotions and intentions, most expressions remain on the face for at least several seconds and can be detected. The micro-expressions discussed in this chapter occur largely without conscious awareness. They commonly appear when someone tries to conceal genuine feelings.

With advances in computer technology we can rapidly start and stop video clips to record and study the micro-expressions that arise during conversation or interrogation. If your goal is merely to train yourself to notice rather than deeply analyze these micro-expressions, a computer is unnecessary.

When studying facial expressions, if we wish to understand the other person's meaning better, we must not overlook the fleeting, simplest emotional changes; they may be more important than any deliberately displayed emotion.

## **Exercise Preferences**

In their leisure time many people choose to exercise and strengthen their bodies. Some also regard fitness, weight loss, entertainment, or relaxation as forms of exercise. Regardless of the hopes or ideas people attach to exercise, long-term, careful observation reveals that when individuals choose a particular activity they are satisfying needs of both body and mind; these needs, to varying degrees, also reveal different aspects of their personality.

Therefore, if we want to explain a stranger and gain deeper insight into personality traits, asking what sport the person enjoys in leisure time can be extremely helpful.

For example, people who habitually play basketball usually have high ideals and ambitious goals. They are often confident, hope to realize their aspirations, want to outperform others, and like to stay one step ahead. To achieve their objectives they are willing to make great sacrifices and exert great effort. People who habitually play soccer are passionate, hold a very positive attitude toward life, are always ready to fight, and brim with energy. People interested in walking maintain relative composure and steadiness toward matters that do not greatly interest them; they do what they should and can do. They trust their ability to handle every task and possess good patience. Most mountaineers who call themselves "children of the mountains" are introverted individuals who are also quite demanding of themselves.

## **Body Language Case Study**

Consider body language. In an episode of the American series *Lie to Me*, a female teacher is murdered. The FBI suspects a male student who had long been infatuated with and spied on her, and immediately detains him. After analysis by Dr. Cal Lightman, however, the student is cleared: he had discovered a photograph. In the photo the murdered teacher stands at a car window, apparently talking to someone inside. Because of the angle, she blocks the driver's face. Her body leans forward, left hand resting on the window frame, right hand hanging down with the palm raised at a 90-degree angle to the wrist. It is this right-hand gesture that gives Dr. Lightman a clue.

Reproducing the teacher's movement with a raised arm yields a classic "stop" gesture. Traffic police use the same signal when directing vehicles to halt. In daily life the gesture means "Stop—don't continue," and is often seen in arguments. Dr. Lightman concludes that the teacher was arguing with the person inside the car. Following this lead, he locates the car's owner and ultimately solves the case.

Still, the familiar caveat applies: body language alone cannot support a definitive conclusion; individual differences and conversational context must be taken into account. To avoid the Brokaw trap, it is best to analyze all four lie indicators—micro-expressions, body language, slips of the tongue, and heated language—together.

## Applications of Anchoring

Before negotiating with a client, it is wise to learn the client's preferences—favorite colors, foods, music, people, and so on. People feel happy when they encounter something they like; that is why catering to tastes works. If the client likes red, you can incorporate red into your clothing to activate the client's happy anchor. If the client likes a particular piece of music, you can use it as background music for your presentation; this increases your chance of success, makes others like you more, and facilitates rapport.

Many parents frequently tell their children "You're wonderful." This too is a form of anchoring. When a child does something right, the parent immediately offers encouragement—"You're wonderful"—and the child feels pride and confidence. Over time the phrase "You're wonderful" becomes linked with pride and confidence. When the child later faces setbacks and feels low, the parent can say "Hey, you're wonderful" to awaken that confidence and pride.

Similarly, if a leader wants subordinates to work hard, an anchor can be set. While praising an employee's effort—emphasizing the word "effort"—the leader pats the employee's shoulder. The word "effort" becomes an anchor inside the employee. Later, whenever the employee works, the memory of that day's praise and the associated positive feeling surfaces, increasing diligence.

## Habitual Liars

Habitual liars, through practice, can control appearance, body language, and voice so convincingly that few traces remain. Yet their lies are never flawless.

- **Blinking or rubbing the eyes while lying**

They have learned to do the opposite to avoid detection—staring fixedly at you. Because deceivers concentrate so intensely, their eyes become dry, forcing them to blink or rub their eyes more often to relieve the discomfort.

- **After being asked the same question repeatedly, the liar erupts in anger**

Ask a question and wait for the answer. Ask a second time; the answer remains unchanged. Leave an

interval between the second and third questions. When you ask the same question again while the person is distracted, the reaction is either shame turning to rage or a tendency to confess. If someone says, "Haven't I already told you this?" and then flies into a rage, deception is likely.

- **The liar never forgets any detail**

Remembering every detail of a time period is difficult. Liars make no mistakes in their statements because they have already constructed the entire scenario in their minds. They will never say, "Wait, I got that wrong."

## **Liars Have Excellent Memory**

A police officer is interrogating a suspect.

Officer: "Do you remember what you were doing at 10 p.m. on March 18?"

Suspect: "Oh, that night I finished dinner, lay on my bed at home, and watched TV. I remember it was Channel 5—my favorite soccer program."

Officer: "What did you have for dinner?"

Suspect: "I had a cheese pizza and a glass of beer."

Officer: "That was a month ago. Since you remember so clearly, tell me what you were wearing that day. Think carefully before answering—we have surveillance footage of you entering the apartment that night!"

"Um... I really don't remember. I..." The suspect begins to sweat. The officer notices everything; after further questioning the suspect is revealed as the robber.

When asked for a specific piece of information, a liar will always attempt an answer rather than say "I don't know," because admitting ignorance risks arousing suspicion. In order to convince the police he had stayed home, the robber supplied details about the television program and the meal. Yet this person with such an excellent memory conveniently forgot what he was wearing. In reality, most people cannot recall what they did on a given day even a week earlier, let alone a month.

## **How to Respond to the Other Person's Micro-expressions**

Once you have learned to recognize micro-expressions, the next important goal is knowing how to respond. We notice the other person's micro-expression, yet we do not know whether that person wants us to be aware of the current emotional state. We must therefore determine whether the emotion is mild or intense and, if intense, whether the person is forcibly suppressing it. We can judge this from the content of the conversation. If micro-expressions appear at the very beginning of the talk, before the main topic is reached, several possibilities exist:

1. The person arrived with an emotion unrelated to the conversation.
2. The person does not want the conversation at all and is already resistant.
3. The person anticipates an unpleasant outcome and therefore begins with an emotional charge.

If micro-expressions appear during the conversation itself, they are most likely emotional responses to the discussion. In the following sections we will examine how to respond to each type of underlying emotion; doing so can noticeably improve your communication skills, or at least serve as a warning. Only sadness,

anger, disgust, fear, and contempt will be discussed, because happiness and surprise generally require no special response skills.

## **Where His Moral Bottom Line Lies When He's Down on His Luck**

**Micro-expression keywords** Everyone has times when they are down on their luck, yet people's mindsets and actions differ greatly. Some give up on themselves, abandon all restraint, or even discard their moral bottom line. Such people rarely achieve anything worthwhile, and we should keep our distance. Others reflect on themselves and hold fast to their moral bottom line; these are the people worth building relationships with.

What a person does when down on their luck reveals their moral baseline. Some actions earn genuine respect and admiration, while others provoke contempt, resentment, or ridicule. Behind these contrasting reactions lies an invisible yardstick: the moral bottom line.

When everything goes smoothly, almost everyone's principles appear clear. But when circumstances turn unfavorable, how many can still uphold that bottom line? In society we often see people in straitened circumstances violate social ethics or cross their own moral line. Some sell out friends for money; others harm others for fame or profit. People who cannot maintain their bottom line when down on their luck cannot earn others' trust.

## **How to Create a Positive Anchor**

So how do you create a positive anchor? You can learn from the salesman Jerry.

When Jerry first entered sales, his performance was poor and his manager repeatedly pressured him to improve. One day he called on an elderly woman who looked despondent. She said her daughter had just suffered a miscarriage and had no interest in buying anything. After being turned away, Jerry thought that everyone carries some worry; if he could bring customers a bit of joy along with the product samples, it would be worthwhile. From then on, whenever he mailed trial products he tucked in a small note containing a joke or an amusing incident he had encountered.

A month later, surprisingly, Jerry's sales rose sharply. Many customers were happy to buy from him because the sight of his product triggered a pleasant feeling. Without realizing it, Jerry had planted a positive anchor in his customers' minds; the note with the joke was the anchor.

Remember, an anchor does not trigger an event but an emotion. It works because we habitually link our feelings to external cues. When you want to evoke positive emotions in others, create a positive anchor.

## **Spotting the Telltale Signs: Who Is Still Lying to You**

### **Micro-expression keywords**

Lies appear everywhere in daily life. We can overlook harmless white lies, but when deception is involved, how do we know we are being misled? It is simple: watch the other person's hand gestures while speaking. These subtle movements reveal whether someone is lying and serve as a key to unlocking another person's inner thoughts.

Many have seen the American series *Lie to Me*, based on a true story. Dr. Lightman is an expert at detecting deception; he reads facial expressions, body language, and tone of voice to determine whether someone is lying and why. Lies exist everywhere. A simple shrug, hand rub, or lip press can signal deception. Even skilled

liars leak clues through minute physical movements. These subtle signals determine whether we control the interaction or are controlled by the other person.

Never ignore these faint bodily cues; they may become the key that opens another person's heart. Below are the six most common lying gestures we encounter in everyday life.

## Touching the Nose

In the fairy tale *Pinocchio*, the puppet's nose grows when he lies. In real life, people touch their noses while speaking. The gesture consists of quickly rubbing the underside of the nose a few times, sometimes so lightly it is barely noticeable. Women perform the movement with even smaller amplitude than men.

Research shows that lying increases blood flow to the nose, causing slight swelling and an itchy sensation. People therefore rub their noses to relieve the itch. Note that nose-touching is a common everyday action; to judge whether someone is lying, combine this cue with other indicators of deception.

Genuine nasal itch differs from the lying version. A real itch requires firm rubbing or even digging to relieve it, unlike the light touch of the deceptive gesture. Purely physical itching also produces only repeated nose-rubbing, unrelated to the content, frequency, or rhythm of the conversation.

## Kinesthetic Vocabulary

People whose dominant sense is kinesthetic experience the world primarily through touch or emotion. They recall events via tactile or emotional impressions and also favor taste and smell words. Common terms include: contact, touch, pain, cold, warmth, firm, soft, rough, slippery, light, heavy, sour, sweet, bitter, fragrant.

They often express themselves this way:

- You have to try it
- It smells really good
- I can feel it
- This thing is very solid
- She looks really sweet
- He is a soft, gentle person

When speaking with such individuals, emphasize how the matter will feel good to them. In real life, many conversations falter because the two parties use different dominant sensory vocabularies. A simple example:

A: You still don't get what I mean?

B: I heard you, but I don't understand.

Rephrasing to match the other person's visual vocabulary works better. If the other person is auditory, try:

A: Do you hear what I'm saying now?

B: Yes, I hear you.

Identifying someone's dominant sense requires effort. Here are several practical methods.

## 3. Complex Lies

First question: Have you ever won a professional competition championship?



An answer of “no” is not necessarily truthful. Consider a contest open only to non-professional (amateur) entrants. All participants are nominally amateurs and compete at roughly the same level; the prize is substantial. Professional athletes may conceal their status, enter under false pretenses, and win. Motive: gain.

Second question: Have you ever secretly used company funds for personal expenses?

An answer of “yes” can also be a lie.

In reality, a friend (son, wife, girlfriend, or superior) took the money. The speaker is innocent but claims responsibility to protect the friend, who can deliver greater future benefits. This is the classic scenario in which a subordinate takes the fall for the boss. By quickly resolving the matter, the subordinate may later be promoted and the family well cared for (with settlement money); refusal could bring retaliation against both the individual and relatives. Under such complex rules, lying serves both gain and avoidance of harm.

### **Covering the Mouth with the Hand**

Psychologists note that when someone suddenly covers their mouth during conversation, it usually means they have just lied and are trying to hide the falsehood. To appear natural, some accompany the gesture with a pretend cough.

In films and television, a thief or criminal passing a police officer often glances around, covers the mouth, coughs lightly, then lowers the hand and answers questions. Viewers sense the person is acting suspiciously or lying.

Covering the mouth is akin to the “shush” gesture of placing a finger to the lips: both signal a desire to withhold inner thoughts. If the other person unconsciously covers their mouth while you are talking, pay close attention to the deeper meaning. The gesture indicates concealment. You can then appear uninterested to put the person at ease; the conversation will usually proceed more smoothly afterward.

### **Volunteering Extra Information**

In police interrogations, when asked what they were doing after dinner, robbery suspects sometimes reply that they were watching television and then spontaneously name the program. This is a classic sign of lying.

Liars feel insecure and fear detection. To appear credible they embellish their story with extra detail. Unlike earlier examples, they volunteer the information unprompted because they have already rehearsed it and can deliver it without hesitation.

Truthful people feel no need for such elaboration.

Example: A girlfriend calls her boyfriend; he answers after many rings. If he has nothing to hide he will simply say, “I was in the bathroom and didn’t hear the phone.” If he adds, “The water was running loudly, and the apartment has great soundproofing...” he is probably lying.

Whenever someone lies, certain words or speech patterns become overly deliberate. Careful observation reveals the inconsistencies.

### **Recreational Games**

As times change, a person’s ability to keep pace with progress or adapt to new developments depends largely on openness to new experiences. Attitudes toward technology and games therefore reflect character and

capability.

People who enjoy computer games tend to be introverted; they like order and excel at numbers and systems. Extroverts, by contrast, treat computers merely as electronic toys for killing time and avoid them for work whenever possible. More than 90 percent of those with a strong interest in computers are introverts.

Many other leisure activities—reading, playing chess, drinking—also reveal a person's values and approach to life. Discovering how someone spends free time gives useful insight into their priorities.

## 11.2 The Purpose of Lying—Gain and Avoidance of Harm

Lying takes many forms, yet its purpose is always the same: gain and avoidance of harm. A lie either escapes a negative consequence (criticism, loss, or punishment)—truth would bring trouble, falsehood offers a chance to dodge it—or secures a benefit (reward, profit, or affection)—truth would exclude the person, falsehood offers a chance to obtain it.

Both motives involve concealment and fabrication. Experiments show that fabrication occurs more often when seeking gain, especially when the liar invents facts to elevate their own status. When avoiding harm, denial predominates; unfavorable information is hidden or rejected. Fabrication still occurs, usually by inventing contradictory details or shifting blame to someone else. See Figure 11-1.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图11-1 说谎的动机与形式]

### Standing Face-to-Face

Standing face-to-face exposes every vulnerable part of the body to the other person. When speaking with strangers or people we do not trust, we instinctively angle our bodies slightly, forming a 45-degree angle. Conversely, willingness to stand directly facing you signals that the other person does not reject greater closeness; mutual attraction and trust are present. Avoid approaching head-on at the first meeting, as it creates psychological pressure and defensiveness.

If the other person prefers to stand sideways, arms crossed, or touching the neck or collar, maintain distance. The same posture appears when the topic does not interest them; change the subject.

If the person is comfortable standing face-to-face, the position offers an excellent opportunity to build rapport and observe micro-expressions clearly. Use previously learned micro-expression techniques to gauge whether the other person wants to draw closer or feels positive toward you.

### Fear

Real-life stimuli that produce full-blown fear are rare; more common is simple apprehension. Women may fear reptiles, children may fear needles, adults may fear horror films or bad news. When you detect fear, the best response is to create a sense of safety. If you must deliver bad news to an employee, you might say: "Your efforts have been obvious to everyone. You will not lose your job over this; we simply need to solve the problem together." Remove the fear of unemployment first, then discuss the issue; results improve.

When someone close to you is afraid, a hug provides the best comfort. It evokes the security once felt inside the mother's womb and reduces fear. As children, our first impulse when frightened was to run into a parent's arms. With someone less close, ask why they are afraid while conveying that you can provide a safe environment.

## Sadness

The best response to sadness is comfort, but first consider several factors: how close your relationship is, whether someone else might be better suited to offer comfort, and the history of your interactions. Not everyone welcomes comfort. Both children and adults often prefer private space to process negative emotions, especially sadness. In the presence of people who are not especially close, most suppress sadness out of politeness and to preserve personal space.

If your relationship is very close, a simple "What happened?" or "Are you all right?" is appropriate when you notice the sadness micro-expression. If the relationship is ordinary, locate someone closer to the person; that is more effective than direct inquiry. With family members, assure them that you will stay with them no matter what and that they will not face the situation alone.

## See What He Pursues in His Leisure Time

Micro-expression keywords: In their free time, everyone chooses different ways to relax. Some prefer cultural activities, others sports, still others casual games. The chosen leisure activity reveals character and interpersonal style, offering valuable insight into the person.

A person's hobbies function as a mirror of personality. Interests vary widely. To understand someone, observe what they pursue when idle. Some enjoy sports, others outdoor pursuits such as fishing; some play chess, others collect items. Leisure interests reflect aspirations and psychological state.

Therefore, the best way to identify a person is to start with their hobbies. This approach lets you see their true nature up close and devise targeted solutions. Leisure activities generally fall into the following categories:

## Liars Often Omit "I"

Psychologist Richard Wiseman of the University of Hertfordshire observes that liars instinctively distance themselves from their falsehoods. When asked why they are late for work, someone who says "the car broke down" rather than "my car broke down" is probably lying; the real reason may be oversleeping. Repeated omission of "I" in answers therefore warrants suspicion.

Liars also rarely mention other people's names. The most famous example is President Clinton's denial during the Lewinsky scandal: he referred to "that woman" instead of naming Monica Lewinsky, stating, "I did not have sexual relations with that woman." Pay attention to such small conversational details.

## When Facial Expressions Lie

The face is a dual system that can both deliberately display expressions and spontaneously produce expressions without people realizing the information their facial expressions convey. The parts of the face that most reveal people's true feelings (not necessarily the emotions they intend to convey) are the eyes, eyebrows, and mouth.

Blinking frequency reflects a person's level of psychological comfort. The faster the blinking rate, the more it indicates that the person is lying, hesitating, or uncomfortable. Because there are differences between individuals, one should try to grasp each person's normal blinking frequency.

During a conversation, we should also pay attention to how often the other person's eyebrows raise when they say words like "how," "when," "why," and "where." This plays a key role in judging a person's sincerity.

When others are listening to you speak, pay attention to the subtle movements of their lips and mouth. If the mouth twitches, tightens, or wrinkles, it means she is implying to you that she disagrees with what you said.

### **Nodding Subconsciously Before Shaking the Head**

Boss Lin's client owed a large sum for goods that had not been paid. Several subordinates went to the company to collect the payment but were told the person in charge was not there. This time, Boss Lin went himself. He asked the receptionist, "Excuse me, is your manager, Mr. Ma, in?" The receptionist hesitated briefly, then shook her head firmly and said, "No."

Boss Lin stared at her and said, "You're lying!" Then he walked straight to Manager Ma's office and found him inside on the phone.

How did Boss Lin know the receptionist was lying? Because he noticed that after she hesitated, she made a very subtle nodding motion before shaking her head vigorously. This subconscious nod gave her away!

Researchers have found that many liars make a subconscious nod before shaking their head to deny something, indicating affirmation of the other person's question. This quick nod is hard for the brain to control; it tells us that everything said after the head shake is a lie!

### **Rubbing the Eyes**

Many of us have had the experience of rubbing our eyes when we do not want to see certain things or scenes. In fact, this happens because we are trying to stop our eyes from seeing something unpleasant, uncomfortable, or suspicious. It means: "I'm uneasy; I don't want to look!"

In daily life, if you observe carefully, you will notice that a person rubs their eyes or smiles unnaturally while preparing a lie, while telling it, and after telling it. Men often rub their eyes vigorously when making this gesture; if they are trying to cover up a huge lie, they are likely to turn their face away. Women make the eye-rubbing gesture less often; they usually just gently touch below the eye.

Of course, nothing is absolute. We cannot assume someone is lying just because they rub their eyes. We must observe first, then judge, and only then draw a conclusion.

### **The Story of Zengzi**

While living in the state of Lu, Zengzi was very poor and often tilled the fields in tattered clothes. When the ruler of Lu heard about Zengzi, he decided to grant him a small city. Unexpectedly, Zengzi firmly refused.

Someone asked in confusion, "This is a good thing. You didn't ask the ruler for it yourself; the king offered it to you. Why turn it down?"

Zengzi replied, "If a person accepts favors from others, he will fear them, and the giver often feels superior. Even if the ruler does not become arrogant toward me, how could I not feel afraid?"

As the saying goes, "Poverty does not diminish ambition." Although we may be poor, poverty should not rob us of our spirit. We should not accept rewards without merit, nor trade our dignity for wealth. Zengzi's refusal embodied self-reliance; such a person is trustworthy and worth knowing.

### **The Small Action of Swallowing Saliva**

Xiao Zhou arrived late again and was caught by the manager, who scolded him: "I hear you've gotten hooked on mahjong lately and stay up until two every night. How's your luck—pretty good, I bet."

Xiao Zhou's Adam's apple moved as he said quietly, "No, Manager. My wife hasn't been feeling well these days, so I have to take care of her in the morning."

The manager did not believe him, of course, because he heard Xiao Zhou swallow.

When a person wants to lie, inner tension creates a dry, itchy, or strange sensation in the throat, prompting them to swallow subconsciously to relieve it. So with this single action, we can tell whether the other person is telling the truth or lying.

Psychologists have found through extensive research and observation that people make many inadvertent movements when lying. The quick nod before shaking the head, eye squinting, and swallowing saliva mentioned above are all extra actions that, though brief, reveal the truth.

### **FBI Agent Case**

FBI Agent Joe received a tip that a suspect was hiding at his girlfriend's house, so he rushed over to make the arrest. When the suspect's girlfriend opened the door, she claimed her boyfriend had not been there. Unsure whether to believe her, Joe questioned her further. During repeated questioning, although she remained calm, her blinking rate was noticeably higher than at the start. From this, Joe concluded the suspect was still inside. Ultimately, after Joe insisted, a search of the room turned up the suspect in the wardrobe.

In this case, Joe detected the frequent blinking in the suspect's girlfriend's eyes and realized she was feeling uneasy and tense. Despite her outward calm, her eyes betrayed her, allowing Joe to uncover more clues through conversation.

### **Pulling at the Collar**

British zoologist and human behaviorist Desmond Morris observed that people feel an itch on the sensitive face and neck when lying, because once liars sense doubt from the listener, increased blood pressure causes the neck to sweat. They therefore subconsciously rub or scratch to relieve the discomfort. So if you see someone repeatedly pulling at their collar during a conversation, you can infer they are probably worried their lie will be exposed.

Of course, a person may also pull at their collar when angry or frustrated, so we must determine whether lying is involved. When you see someone make this gesture, you might say, "Could you repeat that, please?" or "Why don't you just say what you mean?" This will prompt a response that reveals their true intent.

### **A Slip-of-the-Tongue Case**

Here is a slip-of-the-tongue case for reference. It comes from Freud's research and concerns a doctor describing someone else's divorce proceedings. He said: "In a certain divorce case, a nurse and her husband were both listed as defendants. The case was originally brought by the wife against the husband, but she too became involved. In the end, 'he' was granted the divorce." The doctor mistakenly said "he" instead of "she." This was not a simple slip.

We must first understand the legal context of the time. Adultery was the only legal ground for divorce, and the suit was filed by the betrayed party. The outcome was usually victory for the plaintiff and a large alimony

award. From the doctor's slip, it is clear that the husband in the case was the doctor himself. Deep down, he wished he were the one filing for divorce and winning, and also receiving a substantial alimony payment.

Like micro-expressions, a slip of the tongue always carries meaning when it occurs.

### **Excessive Detail Raises Suspicion**

When we ask someone about events from several nights earlier, it is hard for them to avoid mistakes while recounting, because remembering every detail from a period of time is difficult. They inevitably correct themselves and sort out their thoughts, so their speech becomes halting: "After work I took the bus home—oh, wait, after work I caught a ride with Xiao Wang..."

A liar, however, will never make such errors. Because they are recounting something fabricated, they have already planned everything in their mind's hypothetical scenario, so their account will contain no "Wait, I said that wrong." Yet this seamless narrative is precisely what exposes them.

### **Is He Lying to Me?**

In social interactions, the frequency with which people lie or are deceived by lies is astonishing. MIT psychologist Feldman's research indicates that the average person tells at least 25 lies per day. Of course, lies vary in degree; some are well-intentioned and can be ignored. But when a lie is meant to deceive or harm, how do we know whether we have been tricked?

A recent study from the University of California found that even habitual liars produce subconscious signals when their brain switches into pretense mode—signals an ordinary person can detect, much like a lie detector.

FBI facial-expression experts, drawing on years of research, generally divide liars into two types:

### **Anger**

When you notice signs of anger in the other person's expression, do not rush to respond. First clarify several points:

1. If anger appears only in the eyebrows and eyes, determine whether the person is simply thinking or is genuinely angry. Your conversation may have troubled them, and they are trying to figure out how to escape the difficulty.
2. If it is anger, identify the source of the anger—it may not be you.
3. Never blurt out, "What's wrong? You look angry." If you are certain the micro-expression is anger, the person is trying hard to suppress it and does not want you to notice. Your remark could undo all their effort and cause the anger to erupt twofold.

### **Liars Do Not Describe Events in Detail**

A husband stayed out all night. The next day his wife asked, "Did you go gambling again last night?" The husband looked flustered and said, "No. I went drinking with friends." The wife pressed, "Really? Which friends? Where did you drink?" The husband replied, "Just a few close friends, at the usual place."

Clearly, the wife would not believe such a vague answer. When lying, a person feels guilty and fears that more information will create more holes. So when the wife asked for specific names, the husband dared not say

more, afraid of being caught. A liar cannot withstand detailed questioning; if you are suspicious, a few extra questions will reveal the truth.

## 2. Second Form of Lying

**Question:** Have you ever secretly misappropriated company funds for personal use? (Negative information)

**Lying response:** No.

Direct denial of negative information aims to avoid harm and escape possible punishment (loss of trust or material penalties such as dismissal).

If the answer is "Yes," the likelihood of lying is lower. Admitting a mistake invites punishment or loss of opportunity, so there is no motive to lie.

The two examples above, however, are only first-level logical judgments. If the rules of the situation are complex or the subject has an elaborate deception plan, each case must be analyzed individually.

### Sitting Face to Face

Standing for a while can cause fatigue, so you choose to sit and chat face to face. A table in front allows the other person to relax slightly, because vulnerable areas are shielded. If there is no table, remember not to cross your legs, as that creates a barrier; do not wear sunglasses, as they create a sense of insecurity<|eos|>

## 1. Form of Lying One

**Question:** Have you ever won a championship in a professional competition? (Positive information)

**Lying answer:** Yes.

The response to this question constitutes fabrication, with the goal of seeking gain. The title of professional competition champion can bring additional benefits (spiritual admiration and affection, or material rewards).

If the answer is: No. Then the likelihood of lying is comparatively low. Denying possession of such a positive title brings neither gain nor avoidance of harm, and carries no motive for lying.

### Micro-expression Five

Reporter: If you were to recommend a professional book to younger colleagues, which one would you recommend?

He abandons the answer, and his agent immediately indicates that time is up and the press conference is ending. At this moment, an expression of guilt appears on his face. Guilt is a derivative of sadness and represents complete abandonment of resistance, acknowledging that he has lied.

These small details may seem magical; with diligent practice, you too can discern who is telling the truth and who is lying. You will also learn how to guide a liar into admitting dishonesty.

## Conversation Style Reveals the Secret of Lying

Micro-expression keywords: When people lie, they rely mainly on language. They are unwilling to let the other party detect flaws, so they prepare a set of statements in advance, believing this will conceal the truth. In reality, this makes the conversation style appear deliberate and inadvertently reveals the secret that they are lying.

When a person lies, they pay close attention during the conversation to avoid detection. Therefore, if you listen carefully, you will notice that their speaking pattern differs from that of ordinary people.

### **Micro-expression One**

Reporter: In your book you mention using your spare time to supplement your professional knowledge. Which professional books have you read?

He pauses for about one second, indicating he did not anticipate such a detailed question. After an awkward smile, he replies: Not many, so I won't mention them and make everyone laugh. Embarrassment is one of the emotions derived from fear, representing a loss of control over the development and pace of events and a sense that one's reputation is threatened.

### **Ear Scratching**

When people do not want to listen to others, they scratch their ears, indicating they do not wish to hear at that moment. For example, during a negotiation with a client, if you are expressing an opinion and the client suddenly tilts their head and rubs their ear with a finger, it means the client holds the opposite view of what you are saying and is formulating their own point. At this point, if you do not give the other party an opportunity to speak, the exchange is likely to be ineffective.

### **Micro-expression Analysis at a Celebrity Autobiography Press Conference**

A certain celebrity published an autobiography that readers questioned as not written by the author. Because the celebrity's educational level was not high, yet the entire book displayed solid literary skill in structure, logic, and wording, suspicion arose. To clarify the facts, the celebrity held a press conference to assure everyone that the book was indeed written by them. Most people found the celebrity very sincere, but in fact many micro-expressions betrayed them.

### **Micro-expression Two**

Reporter: Which book are you reading recently?

Answer: A book by Stanislawski. While answering, a brief hesitation appears. The head tilts slightly forward, the chin retracts, and the upper eyelids lift. Although these changes are subtle, anyone who has undergone extensive micro-expression training can spot them at a glance. This is a fighting posture triggered by anger, representing the threat of the lie being exposed.

### **Micro-expression Four**

Reporter: What help have those professional books given to your career?

Answer: Those pieces of knowledge filled the gap left by not having taken professional courses and brought me great improvement. They have been of tremendous help both professionally and in terms of professional



dedication.

The answer is devoid of substantive meaning. At the same time, the gaze shifts downward, the lips press together, and an expression of unease appears.

### **Micro-expression Three**

Reporter: In your book you quote Stanislavski's most classic line, and I think it is used very well. Although everyone is already familiar with it, we still hope you can use it again to admonish younger colleagues.

Answer: I am still a newcomer myself; how can I admonish younger colleagues? At this moment the eyebrows lower, the inner brows raise, producing the typical facial features of fear. The gaze also wanders, indicating avoidance.

## **Chapter 3 Touching the Pulse of Human Nature, Detecting the Other Party's Lies**

Lies exist everywhere in life; this is not alarmism. Whether you are a manager, a civil servant, a writer, an expert, or anyone else, you face all kinds of lies. If you are deceived by one of them, your career may suffer a severe blow. What you must do is determine within five minutes whether the other party is telling the truth or lying!

## **Chapter 11 Identifying Lies Through Micro-reactions**

Lie detection is one of the most cutting-edge and impressive applications of psychological stress micro-reactions (微反应), but it is not some "formulaic" magic trick. Learning to analyze micro-reactions enables accurate judgment of whether others are lying, allowing timely formulation of response strategies to avoid losses that deception might cause. At the same time, one can also learn how to interact with various people.

### **Who Is Lying? — How the FBI Identifies Lies**

Life is a masquerade; everyone hides their true expressions behind a mask. The person standing before you—is their speech from the heart or merely lip service? Let the FBI tell you how to distinguish the genuine from the fake on others' faces, revealing their inner thoughts nakedly so nothing can be disguised or concealed!

### **What Is He Thinking? — How the FBI Reads Minds**

People whose eyes turn to the right are highly aggressive; touching the ear is a signal of interest... In the view of FBI agents, every micro-expression and micro-movement is an important signal for seeing through the other party and turning the situation around. Once these signals are deciphered, all problems become solvable and secrets cease to be secrets!

## **Part Two: The FBI's Superb People-Reading Techniques — Let You See Through Others Instantly**

What scheme is he plotting? What is she thinking? In an era when people's hearts grow ever harder to read, FBI agents distill the most practical psychological insight techniques and the most effective mind-reading principles, enabling you to see through others at a glance and instantly influence them!

### **The Most Effective Way to Offer Advice**

When we study and apply micro-expressions, one goal is to know what the other person is thinking; the other is to make the other person accept our own ideas on that basis. Getting the other person to listen to us requires not only micro-expressions but also the combination of certain psychological techniques.

## Interpreting Meaning

After studying the explanations throughout this book, we have learned to systematically observe a person's bodily stress responses and interpret the meaning of each tiny reaction. Now it is time to test the remarkable value of this system—can micro-reactions truly identify lies?

### 11.3 Forms of Lying

Lies are complex reactions that have undergone thinking and deduction; they belong to the higher-order functions of the brain and possess extremely high logical complexity. Below we examine several examples.

## Touching Body Parts

This is commonly seen in women. When a woman shows interest in the opposite sex, her body leans forward and one hand is placed on the leg or buttock, because these are among the most sensual parts of the female body.

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

## Micro-expression Leakage

### 3. Emotional State Baseline

Behavioral characteristics dominated by genuine emotions. When unrestrained and emotionally heightened, individuals break through the self-imposed constraints of social behavioral rules and act without inhibition. The facial expressions, breathing, voice, body posture, and movement features displayed at such times also constitute a baseline; these behavioral characteristics revealed during genuine emotional expression can be called the "emotional state baseline."

The emotional state baseline is harder to obtain than the calm state baseline, because the rules of civilized society in the modern world rarely permit actors to swing between great joy and great sorrow or great shock and great anger. This is unnecessary to mention when a person is alone; even when others are present, it is difficult to collect strong expressions of surprise, disgust, anger, fear, or sadness from the actor, and even hearty laughter is quite rare. However, these six basic emotions have many relatively weaker variants, listed as follows:

- Surprise is simply surprise; it has few variants and needs none.

- Variants of disgust can include nausea, aversion, dislike, contempt, distaste, scorn, and disregard, among others.
- Variants of anger can include losing one's temper, irritation, irascibility, losing one's cool, displeasure, seriousness, and sternness, among others.
- Variants of fear can include apprehension, worry, anxiety, unease, panic, embarrassment, concern, misgiving, and taboo, among others.
- Variants of sadness can include distress, dejection, low spirits, loss, guilt, regret, helplessness, grievance, and gloom, among others.
- Variants of pleasure can include satisfaction, smugness, happiness, joy, and excitement, among others.

Each of these emotional states may appear in relatively natural circumstances for any individual on any given day. Because there is no need for confrontation or disguise, these relatively "weaker" emotional states can serve as the actor's emotional state baseline. Note, however, that because these states are not pure emotional states, they are very likely to be mixed with large amounts of unconscious interference, such as habit or etiquette and cultivation. When collecting emotional state baseline data, pay special attention to these interference patterns.

For example, if a person's mouth corners are at unequal heights when genuinely smiling, that is a feature of his emotional state baseline; in future analysis it should not be identified as a smile carrying contempt.

Although collecting the emotional state baseline is relatively difficult, humans as a species have lived under highly civilized social rules for no more than 10,000 years. Millions of years of evolution have left humans, as a species, with a large number of animal habits, including common characteristics of emotional behavior. Emotion, as a single-layer logical survival strategy, drives various parts of the body to produce more primitive behaviors. These behaviors all carry physiological significance, so their patterns exhibit a high degree of stability and commonality.

Extensive scientific evidence shows that human emotional behavioral characteristics exist objectively across differences in region, race, society, education, age, and gender.

These valuable, physiologically significant characteristics are precisely the subject of this book and will be discussed chapter by chapter below.

Both the calm state baseline and the emotional state baseline can be observed and recorded from the following aspects:

- Facial features and positions of the five sense organs
- Breathing rate and amplitude
- Voice frequency and volume
- Spinal curvature morphology
- Head and chin angles
- Habitual hand positions and movements
- Standing and sitting postures
- Leg postures and angles
- Presence of prominent habitual movements, such as leg shaking or foot swinging

#### **4. Stable Social Behavioral Characteristics**

Although social behavior cannot serve as an object of micro-reaction (微反应) analysis, and although countless decisions and motives lie behind social behavior, social behavior can still function as a very important behavioral baseline for analyzing abnormal reactions in an actor.

The social behavior an actor routinely displays can also be observed in the detailed aspects listed above. What distinguishes the recording of the social behavior baseline from the calm state baseline and the emotional state baseline is that the social behavior baseline records the characteristics the actor exhibits in specific social situations.

Examples include:

- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when speaking at a meeting
- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when meeting a superior
- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when meeting a subordinate
- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when reciting lines with emotion
- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when gossiping mysteriously
- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when earnestly expressing an opinion
- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when smugly criticizing or instructing
- The actor's verbal and nonverbal features when defending under pressure

The behavioral characteristics the actor displays in these situations constitute the social behavior baseline. Data for the social behavior baseline are easy to obtain; once the actor produces an abnormal reaction that violates the baseline, it is relatively easy to detect. When an abnormality appears after a specific stimulus, we can quickly compare it with the calm state baseline and the emotional state baseline, search for matching characteristic clues, and then perform deduction and analysis.

Thus, when the young women mentioned earlier sense that their boyfriends are "acting strangely somewhere," it is mostly because the boyfriends' reactions have violated their own social behavior baselines. Those strange places are usually emotional behaviors governed by emotion; following the patterns, one can identify which emotional attribute is involved. Finally, linking the possible stimulus source may establish a clear causal connection.

Love requires honesty and a sense of harmony. Technical analysis carries risks; regardless of whether the analysis is right or wrong, merely entertaining the idea of analysis means you have already lost. However, when encountering swindlers or scoundrels, one should certainly arm oneself with science to avoid being deceived.

These two lines of program language are entirely fabricated and do not necessarily conform to any programming syntax; they are intended only to express rigid judgment criteria.

### **An Elegant Woman Who Lied**

We have tested many people whose baseline for left-right eye movement differs. Currently, the more common indicator of lying is movement that violates the personal baseline.

One test subject was a very elegant woman who answered questions calmly throughout the test; subsequent analysis confirmed that the vast majority of her statements were truthful. When faced with stressful questions (those requiring choice or recall), her habitual baseline for gaze shift was to the right. Whether the task involved complex calculations (left-brain), visual-spatial puzzles (right-brain), or recounting how she had

accumulated wealth through shrewd investments, whenever she needed to think of an appropriate way to phrase her answer, her gaze moved right.

Yet on one question alone she lied.

When we asked whether she strongly disliked a certain female friend (a specific individual), her eyes rapidly shifted left by approximately three-quarters of an iris diameter, after which she calmly denied it; no other obvious indicators appeared.

Given this anomalous gaze shift (different from baseline), we temporarily added two test questions.

1. Picture test: We prepared ten image sets, including neutral landscape images (mobile communication base stations, overhead traffic shots of normal vehicles, regional maps), positive stimulus images (a male singer she liked), actual partial anatomical photographs of corpses, and a photograph of that female friend. When she saw the male singer's photograph, her pupils dilated. After transition through neutral images, the sudden appearance of the female friend's photograph caused her pupils to constrict.
2. We asked her to describe and evaluate a certain matter concerning that female friend in detail. During the description and evaluation, a micro-expression of contempt appeared on her face (contempt is a derivative emotion of disgust).

From these two results we inferred that she harbored feelings of disgust toward that person. Therefore, when she flatly denied her disgust, the cognitive pressure produced the anomalous gaze shift. It can be confirmed that she lied on this question.

### **Facial Expressions That Lag Half a Beat**

Generally, when a person lies, they try to smile, nod, and blink in an attempt to conceal their inner activity. Psychological research shows, however, that facial features are difficult to control completely. When lying, the entire face briefly freezes; this process lasts roughly two to three seconds.

If you are observant, you will notice that many liars exhibit similar behavior.

Scene one: A comedian guest on a talk show tells a short joke on the spot. After listening, the host bursts out laughing and says, "That joke was really funny."

Scene two: A comedian guest on a talk show tells a short joke on the spot. After listening, the host says, "That joke was really funny," and then laughs.

Which scene, then, expresses the host's true thoughts? The first one, of course. In the second scene the host is merely humoring the guest.

In other words, if an expression is not heartfelt, it often appears obviously belated and mechanical or stiff. For example, when a door-to-door salesman is asked, "Can you provide a one-year warranty?" if he nods first and then says "Yes," he is telling the truth. If he first answers, "Um... yes, don't worry," and only afterward nods, you should doubt the truth of his words.

### **Question 8: What Is a Baseline?**

Whether behavioral analysis possesses powerful efficacy depends on one very important precondition—whether performance behavior can be filtered.

Suppose an intelligent program could tell with 100 percent accuracy whether a person is performing. When interacting with others, wouldn't it feel much easier if the program's prompt came through your earpiece—"He is genuine" or "He is performing"—and you could feel as though you could see through every hypocrisy as if you were a god?

In any case, I would hope everyone would stop deceiving, would be straightforward, and would be candid with one another. That way, at least one would not have to guess back and forth only to guess wrong and suffer loss.

Yet in reality, even parents dealing with young children who do not yet understand will kindly try to make the "most reasonable" expression rather than say 100 percent of what they think, let alone two people who meet by chance in society.

As long as a person's behavioral motivation contains a decision component of "this is the best way to act," performance is inevitable, but performance does not always stem from malicious motives or produce malicious results.

The task of studying micro-reactions does not include judging good or bad; it only seeks to find the differences between expression and cognition and the patterns that exist within them. To accomplish this task, one must begin with a single step—finding the baseline—and this step cannot be bypassed.

Strictly speaking, any analysis without a baseline is mere grandstanding.

### What Is a Baseline?

A simple example: suppose a person never blinks when telling the truth but always blinks rapidly ten times in succession when lying. These two fixed patterns would constitute the actor's two baselines. When you see the person not blinking, you know they are telling the truth; when you see ten consecutive blinks, they are lying. If the number of blinks falls between one and nine, neither baseline is matched, so no judgment is made.

You may think such fixed baselines cannot possibly exist.

Indeed, for humans this is merely an impossible example; do not take it seriously, although many research institutions continue to search for formulas of the type [xx behavioral feature = lying]. Such stable judgment criteria can appear only in computer program responses, because programmers set rules such as:

```
if a=not blinking then print true;  
if a=blinking 10 times then print false
```

Humans, however, do have baselines.

**Baseline** refers to the behavioral characteristics an actor possesses when not "acting," and mainly includes the following aspects:

## 2. Calm State Baseline

Behavioral characteristics in a calm state. When a person is neither flamboyant nor dejected, neither excited nor low-spirited—in other words, in a relaxed state—what their speech, manner, facial expressions, breathing, voice, and body movements look like can serve as a baseline and may be called the “calm state baseline.”

A completely relaxed state occurs in two situations: when alone or when in a safe and relaxed social environment. Behavioral characteristics when alone are difficult for outsiders to observe; unless secretly recorded, they remain unknown. In a safe and relaxed social environment, the actor will display the above baseline only when everyone present is someone the actor does not need to “worry about” and can fully trust.

Obtaining these baseline characteristics usually requires prolonged observation rather than a single session. Many young women have this feeling about their boyfriends—“I just feel something is off with him today; something must be up.” In professional terms, this “something is off” feeling is usually “capturing behavioral features that violate the baseline,” except that the young women have not studied micro-reactions and therefore cannot accurately and clearly enumerate these features.

### **Identifying the Other Party's Lies Through Facial Expressions**

Micro-expression keywords: Although liars can make their words seamless, that does not mean others will be deceived. The liar's facial expressions will betray them; language can be controlled, but facial expressions are difficult to control. To determine whether someone is lying, simply look at their facial expressions.

Is the person lying? Often this cannot be discerned from words alone. People whose speech is more eloquent than singing are unreliable, and even those universally regarded as “honest” sometimes lie. So how does one judge whether someone is lying? The first thing to do is look at their facial expressions.

Liars deliberately control both their words and their facial expressions. Generally, these are the two aspects the conversational partners pay special attention to. Yet disguising words is easy—just prepare in advance—whereas concealing facial expressions is not easy.

## **Chapter 11 True and False Expressions**

### **11.1 Expression Baseline**

#### **11.1.1 Expressionless Baseline**

#### **11.1.2 Genuine Expression Baseline**

### **11.2 Summary of Micro-expression Morphological Features**

#### **11.2.1 Surprise**

#### **11.2.2 Disgust**

#### **11.2.3 Anger**

#### **11.2.4 Fear**

#### **11.2.5 Sadness**

#### **11.2.6 Smile**

### **11.3 Complex Expression Recognition**

### 11.3.1 Complex Smiles

### 11.3.2 Other Complex Expression Recognition

#### References

#### Principle

When facts must be concealed or details fabricated, the person must think with all their might. At the same time, they cannot produce obvious reactions such as prolonged eye closure or staring blankly at one spot, because such reactions would be too conspicuous. At this moment the negative stimulus from the question is strong; even if the questioner is handsome, they become an unwelcome negative stimulus source. Combined with the brain's need to laboriously conceal and fabricate, the result is an increase in blink rate.

Note that this section examines high-frequency blinking in isolation; in practice, increased blink rate is usually accompanied by simultaneous gaze shifts. Gaze-shift issues are discussed in a later dedicated section.

#### 1. Physical Examination Indicators

These are purely physiological baselines. Values within the normal range indicate health; values outside the normal reference range indicate pathology. If a person's white blood cell count on a second physical examination is higher than on the first and exceeds the normal reference range, the person may be ill.

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part V — Microexpressions (p-microexpressions).

See Nose (c-nose).

#### Eyes and Mouth in Deception

#### Can a Smile Hide a Lie

Micro-expression keywords: When lying, people feel guilty and will deliberately try to please you to lower your guard. A smile is a very good method. However, they do not know whether the smile comes from the heart or is an attempt to cover up a lie; some people can tell at a glance.

Generally, people think smiles show friendliness and happiness. Smiles are very common in life: you see colleagues smiling at work, waiters smiling while eating, and if lucky on the bus, the conductor smiling...

Have you ever wondered how many of these smiles come from the heart? Are all smiles sincere? The answer is: Not all smiles are sincere! Beneath a smiling face, lies may also be hidden!

Xiao Qing is a new employee with a strong sense of responsibility. Not long after joining the company, she discovered various problems in management. Xiao Qing mustered the courage to knock on her supervisor's office door and offered many reasonable suggestions for improving the company's internal situation. After



she finished speaking in one breath, the supervisor smiled and told her: "Your suggestions are very good. I will discuss these issues with senior leadership."

However, after a long time, the problems Xiao Qing raised were not improved. She could not figure out why the supervisor thought her opinions made sense but delayed giving feedback.

A study by French scientist Guillaume Duchenne de Boulogne might provide the answer.

Guillaume's research found that human smiles are controlled by two sets of muscles. The first set is the muscles at the zygomatic bone, which can slightly part the mouth, pull the lips back to reveal teeth, lift the face, and then extend the smile to the corners of the eyes. We can freely control the zygomatic muscles to produce a false smile.

The second set of muscles is in the eye area, which can contract the muscles, making the eyes smaller and producing "crow's feet" at the corners. These muscles are not under our conscious voluntary control. The smile they produce is generally a genuine one.

When Xiao Qing's supervisor smiled, there were no crow's feet at the corners of his eyes, meaning he did not agree with Xiao Qing's suggestions. He said those words only to avoid discouraging her enthusiasm.

So, what kind of smile is sincere?

A few days later, employee Dong Wen also entered the supervisor's office. He had prepared an excellent promotional plan for a new product.

Let's look at the supervisor's reaction:

While Dong Wen was demonstrating the promotional renderings, the supervisor nodded while watching. The smile spread from the corners of his mouth, and as the smile grew wider, the crow's feet at the corners of his eyes accumulated more and more. Finally, after Dong Wen finished speaking, the supervisor laughed heartily, patted his shoulder, and said: "Well done, we'll go with your plan!"

Which smile is more sincere? Clearly, the one for employee Dong Wen.

Comparing them, this smile showed crow's feet. It indicates that both the mouth and eye muscles were engaged, especially the eye muscles, which are not under our conscious voluntary control. That is, only smiles with crow's feet at the eyes are genuine, heartfelt smiles.

Now we should be clear. A smile cannot hide a lie. If the smile only involves the mouth muscles, then the smile is not genuine; the facial expression will look stiff. At this point, no matter what he says next, it is best to weigh whether it is true or false.

If, when smiling, not only does the mouth open, but the crow's feet at the corners of the eyes are also squeezed out, the expression will look very natural. Such a smile must be genuine; he agrees with what you said, so he will inevitably tell you the truth.

## **Liars Often Touch Their Noses**

**Micro-expression keywords** When people lie, they feel pressure. This causes cells inside the nasal cavity to swell and blood pressure to rise, creating an itchy sensation in the nose. As a result, people frequently touch

their noses to relieve the symptom. Therefore, if you see someone touching their nose frequently while speaking, do not readily believe what they say.

In episode eleven of the American drama *Lie to Me*, a lying concealment gesture appears: rubbing a finger against the side of the nose.

After watching the show, a wife secretly observed and analyzed her husband's tone, movements, and expressions when he spoke to her, trying to determine whether he was lying.

One Friday, her husband called to say he had to work overtime, but he hesitated while speaking. She knew he was lying but wanted to find out what he was hiding. She pretended to agree, then waited downstairs at his company and secretly followed him. As it turned out, after work her husband went to a gathering with a group of "questionable friends."

When he returned home that evening, the wife pretended to know nothing. She took his hand and asked: "Was it very hard today? Did you finish your work?" Her husband touched his nose and said: "I work hard so you can have a better life; it's not hard."

People usually touch their noses when lying. Why? Scientists at the Smell & Taste Treatment and Research Foundation in Chicago may have the answer.

Their research found that when people lie, a chemical called catecholamine is released, causing cells inside the nasal cavity to swell. Using special imaging equipment that displays internal blood flow, the scientists also revealed that blood pressure rises due to lying. The technology showed that the nose enlarges during lying because of increased blood flow. The rise in blood pressure causes the nose to swell, triggering nerve endings in the nasal cavity to send out an itchy sensation. People then frequently touch their noses with their hands to soothe the itch.

This is the famous **Pinocchio Effect**.

Although people cannot see the nasal blood vessels swell, they can see the gesture of a liar touching the nose. It is easy to conclude that the person is lying.

Two well-known neurologists closely studied video footage of former U.S. President Bill Clinton testifying before a jury in the Lewinsky scandal. They found that Clinton rarely touched his nose when telling the truth, but whenever he lied, his brow would unconsciously furrow slightly before the lie left his mouth, and he touched his nose once every four minutes, reaching a total of 26 touches during the testimony! This strongly confirms the saying "liars touch their noses."

When lying, the nose-touching gesture is usually a quick rub or two with the hand along the underside of the nose, sometimes so light it is almost imperceptible. Women perform this gesture with smaller movements than men.

Of course, not every nose-touching action means the person is lying. When someone is anxious or angry, the blood vessels in the nose can also swell and produce the same gesture. Sometimes people make the movement simply because of a cold, pollen allergy, or to wipe something off the nose.

Determining whether someone is lying also requires combining other lying indicators. For example, because lying requires improvising language, speech may become hesitant; some people pause or frown; others blush. As long as you observe carefully, these small details will not escape your eyes, and knowing whether someone is lying becomes much easier.

## Frequent Blinking Indicates Lying

**Micro-expression keywords** Blinking effectively avoids direct eye contact with others. For a liar, this is the best way to conceal a lie. When you see someone blinking frequently, they are likely avoiding your gaze, meaning they are lying to you!

Before leaving work, the supervisor asked the secretary to write an important report. Because it was the secretary's birthday and she had been celebrating with friends, she completely forgot the important task. The next day, when the supervisor asked for the report, the secretary rummaged through her bag and finally pretended to be anxious, saying: "Oh no, I forgot to bring the USB drive with the file."

As soon as the supervisor heard this, he knew the secretary was lying with her eyes open. The secretary did not even own a USB drive; she had asked him a few days earlier to buy one. Moreover, he noticed that while speaking, the secretary kept blinking at a faster rate than usual.

Psychological research shows that a person's normal blink rate is 30–50 times per minute. When under heavy pressure that feels unbearable, the blink rate increases noticeably. Because lying unconsciously increases psychological pressure, the blink frequency speeds up. From this, the supervisor confidently concluded that the secretary was lying.

Besides this reason, rapid blinking also helps avoid direct eye contact with the other person. When lying, people feel guilty and dare not look the other person in the eye, fearing their inner panic will be seen through. Yet if they turn their head away, the liar worries the movement is too obvious and will be detected. Rapid blinking allows them to avoid the other person's gaze without drawing attention.

In movies or TV dramas, we often see scenes like this:

A judge sternly interrogates a prisoner: "What did you do last night?"

The prisoner lowers his head and says: "I didn't go anywhere last night; I stayed home watching TV."

This happens because when a person lies, they feel guilty and subconsciously avoid direct eye contact. This reduces pressure and allows the lie to be spoken. Conversely, if telling the truth, the person dares to look the other person straight in the eye, as if challenging: "I'm telling the truth; why should I fear you? If you don't believe me, go investigate."

In daily life, we also notice that when someone is preparing or delivering a lie, they often blink, lower their head, or make other unnatural movements. For example, when a teacher asks a student why homework is unfinished, the student may first lower their head to think, or blink a few times, then invent an excuse hoping to escape punishment.

This action signals guilt.

Often, like the secretary in the earlier example, many people will lie to your face with their eyes open. Detecting the lie is very easy because the eyes cannot deceive. A liar dares not look others in the eye, so they choose to blink rapidly or turn their head away, subconsciously hiding their gaze.

However, not all blinking means lying. If someone deliberately prolongs a blink in front of you, it simply means they are not interested in what you are saying and hope the conversation ends soon. If their eyes close for two or three seconds before reopening, it means they truly cannot tolerate the boring conversation and

wish you would disappear from their sight immediately. At that point, you need to adjust your topic or simply walk away.

Only when the blink rate is faster than usual does it indicate the person is lying. Therefore, when observing, we must distinguish clearly and avoid wrongly accusing an innocent person.

## The Glib Tongue

The tongue's role in micro-expressions is not obvious. When nervous, lips become dry, and the tongue must lick the lips to relieve dryness while also soothing inner unease. Yet nervousness does not appear only when lying; it also arises when people feel suspected. Therefore, the tongue alone cannot determine whether someone is lying.

Still, when combined with other micro-expressions, changes in the tongue are worth noting. When a lie is exposed, a person feels enormous pressure, leading to sweating, flushed face, dry lips, and other signs; licking the lips becomes a remedy for relieving tension.

A man who claimed to have been a middle manager at a Fortune 500 company applied for a position at a medium-sized firm. When the interviewer asked why he left such a good job, he said the company's philosophy did not align with his, so he decided to leave in search of a better platform. The interviewer then told him the company already knew some basic facts about him, including the real reason for his departure. At that moment he began to fidget and showed a fleeting expression of surprise. He quickly licked his lips and started defending himself. It turned out he had been fired for leaking company secrets to a competitor. The surprised expression showed he had not expected an interviewer at a medium-sized company to know these details; licking his lips indicated his inner tension and desire to quickly escape the awkward situation.

Of course, tongue changes alone do not prove lying. Consider this case:

Candidates facing a major exam are often mentally tense. When time is nearly up and some questions remain unanswered, they may sweat, feel cold hands, breathe rapidly, or even feel dizzy. At such moments the tongue tries to relieve tension in its small way by licking the lips.

Besides licking the lips, the tongue may occasionally expose its tip, which is what we commonly call sticking out the tongue. When we say the wrong thing in public, we may stick out our tongue; this not only relieves tension but also represents the brain's attempt to expel the mistaken words. People sometimes show the tip of the tongue when surprised—for example, when unexpectedly winning an award. During live award-show broadcasts, we may see this: an actress who wins Best Actress opens her eyes wide in surprise and also gives a cute little tongue protrusion. Of course, this situation is uncommon. Not every tongue protrusion signals tension or excitement; children making faces stick out their tongues, and some people do it habitually. Certain athletes, such as basketball or soccer players, stick out their tongues after missing or scoring a goal; some do it as an expression of outgoing personality that becomes their signature move, while others do it because they are so focused they pay no attention to the tongue. Jordan would give a slight tongue protrusion when dunking; that was a sign of intense concentration.

Although the tongue, unlike other micro-expressions, cannot directly help expose lies, it at least reflects the person's current mental state and provides auxiliary clues for other micro-expressions. However, interpreting what the tongue means requires considering the actual context, the individual's personality, and behavioral habits. Judging solely by one facial detail always carries the possibility of error.

## He Should Not Know This Secret

In the skit *The Policeman and the Thief* by Chen Peisi and Zhu Shimao, there is this scene:

Chen Peisi, playing the thief, is keeping watch at the alley entrance for his accomplice who is committing a crime when he happens to encounter Zhu Shimao, playing the policeman on patrol.

Zhu Shimao asks: "What are you doing here?"

Chen Peisi replies: "I'm keeping watch."

Realizing he has let it slip, he immediately covers his mouth with his hand and corrects himself: "Ah, no, I'm just hanging around."

Why did Chen Peisi instinctively cover his mouth? In his heart he was thinking: "He must not know this secret!"

When you are talking with someone, if the other person stops midway through speaking, or has only just begun, and then instinctively covers their mouth, it may mean they are unwilling to tell you this matter but have already blurted out half of it without thinking.

In such cases, do not believe what they say after covering their mouth; that is likely a lie they just made up. Only what they said before covering their mouth—the words that slipped out unintentionally—is credible.

Moreover, no matter what the other person says, and no matter how surprising the secret is, you must act uninterested. This will put the other person at ease, and the subsequent conversation will proceed more smoothly. Otherwise, they may dwell on the regret of having let the secret slip and will no longer engage seriously with you, rendering the conversation pointless.

## How to Tell If He's Lying During an Interview

The definition of micro-expression is "suppressed emotions, subtle facial movements that disappear in an instant like lightning." When it comes to using micro-expressions, the first thing that comes to mind is "seeing through lies"! Because micro-expression detection techniques are related to lie detection techniques.

Simply put, people with higher skills in detecting micro-expressions also have high accuracy in seeing through lies. However, this does not mean that micro-expressions equal evidence of lying. What is going on here? Let's explain step by step.

Research has found that liars tend to display more micro-expressions than truth-tellers. Among them, liars may experience emotions such as "guilt," "distress," "disgust," "fear," "secret delight," and "contempt," which may appear on the face as micro-expressions. Additionally, forceful movements of the upper and lower lips may also be an expression of lying. This reaction represents the message of "suppressing emotions" when about to lie and can also be thought of as a sign of feeling burdened by going against one's true intentions.

In surveys on the frequency of micro-expressions, 51% of liars show them within 0.5 seconds, and 30% within 0.25 seconds.

## Distinguishing Lies from Truth

How can we tell whether someone whose gaze appears steady is lying? We need to look further at their pupils! Psychological research has found that a person's mental activity is closely related to changes in pupil size.

Teacher Zhang is an experienced homeroom teacher for ninth-grade students. Several mischievous students in the class dare not lie to Teacher Zhang because they are always found out. Teacher Zhang's secret weapon is watching their pupils. Once, Wang Xiaomeng kicked a ball that hit another student's eye but lied and said it was not him. Although he said this while staring straight at Teacher Zhang with righteous indignation, his pupils unconsciously dilated. Teacher Zhang naturally did not believe him; after questioning several classmates, it turned out he had not wrongly accused him.

When a person lies, they feel nervous. Stimulated by this nervousness, their pupils dilate, allowing us to conclude they are lying. Of course, not every instance of pupil dilation indicates lying; it can also occur in situations of terror, anger, or affection, so each case must be analyzed according to its specific circumstances.

### **Eyes That Convey Sincerity**

When conversing with others, we need to look at them with steady eyes, but prolonged fixed staring may make the other person feel you are being overly artificial and untrustworthy. Therefore, to avoid misunderstandings, while maintaining steady eye contact, we should also coordinate with other body postures.

For example, while listening to someone speak, if you are interested in what they say, nod a few times to encourage them to continue; or offer a sincere smile; or interject some of your own thoughts. At such moments, the other person will sense your friendliness and respect.

If you are the one telling a story, to make your words more credible, begin with eye contact and then add gestures that convey confidence and affirmation. This will influence their emotions and make them firmly believe what you say.

In short, people with steady gazes may also be lying; check their pupils and other expressions to know. When communicating, avoid staring fixedly at the other person and instead coordinate with additional movements or words to express sincerity.

### **Liars Can Also Maintain Steady Eye Contact**

Researchers once conducted an experiment: they gathered a group of people, divided them into two groups, and had them sit facing each other. One group was instructed to lie to the other. All expressions of the liars were recorded. The final results were surprising.

In the experiment, only about 30 percent of the liars looked away, while the other 70 percent maintained steady eye contact. They knew that shifting their gaze would reveal the lie, so they deliberately controlled their eyes and stared at the other person to avoid detection.

In reality, during or after lying, people's gaze often drifts to the side; yet before lying, their gaze is usually very steady—partly to build their own confidence and partly to avoid arousing suspicion. Therefore, steady eye contact does not always indicate sincerity; sometimes it signals a lie.

### **What Does Scratching the Ears Mean?**

Micro-expression keyword: In daily life, when we disagree with someone's opinion, we habitually touch our ears with our hands. This is actually body language telling the other person our true inner thoughts. Therefore, adding this gesture while speaking is likely a sign that the speaker's words do not match their true feelings.

Mother: "Xiao Ming, you've thrown your socks around again. Don't you know to put them in the cabinet? Have you finished your homework? Stop watching TV—you only know how to play every day. No wonder you did so poorly on the last exam..."

Hearing his mother's nagging, Xiao Ming quickly covers his ears and puts on a pained expression: "Mom, please stop."

Scenes like this are common in daily life. Covering the ears shows he does not want to hear your voice. In the adult world, people do not cover their ears but instead scratch different parts of the ear to express varying emotions and inner thoughts.

### **Eyes That Widen Then Shrink**

Besides rapid blinking, the eyes have another movement that reveals the secret of lying.

Police showed a captured drug dealer a stack of photos and asked him to identify his accomplice. He looked through them one by one but refused to speak. Nevertheless, the observant officers had already noticed something in his eyes.

When he saw his accomplice's photo, his eyes suddenly widened, then his pupils contracted rapidly and he slightly squinted. Later, during interrogation, it was confirmed that this person was also involved in drug trafficking.

Psychological principles explain that seeing his accomplice's photo made him suddenly tense, causing his pupils to dilate involuntarily; fearing others would notice the change, he consciously squinted.

This reaction precisely revealed his inner thoughts.

### **Covering the Ear Hole with Hand or Ear**

This carries the same meaning as a child covering their ears: they are directly blocking words they do not want to hear from entering. It expresses: "I don't want to hear you continue!" At the same time, an impatient expression appears on the face.

For example, in a movie, the female lead is a chatterbox. While watching television, she often nags her husband about neighborhood gossip the moment he returns from work. The male lead has no choice but to cover his ear holes with his hands, so he sees only his wife's mouth moving but hears no nagging.

Many people have the habit of scratching their ears, unaware that this gesture leaves an impression of tension and anxiety and may even cause the other person to misunderstand that you dislike listening or lack respect. Therefore, avoid scratching your ears unless absolutely necessary.

### **Continuously Scratching the Earlobe or Behind the Ear**

This represents an anxious emotion, indicating the person is facing an unsolvable difficulty and needs help.

Xiaoyun is a very observant person who can always notice changes in people's movements and interpret their meaning. Once, she saw her colleague Lu Chong repeatedly scratching behind his ear, so she walked over and asked if he needed assistance. It turned out Lu Chong was stuck on a programming issue and could not debug the desired result. Xiaoyun promptly helped solve the problem and earned Lu Chong's deep gratitude.

When people feel anxious or worried, they release inner pressure by repeatedly scratching their ears. If you notice this sign and proactively offer help, you can greatly strengthen your connection with the other person.

### **Rubbing Behind the Ear**

This indicates disagreement with the speaker's viewpoint or a desire to express a different opinion. For instance, a salesperson keeps describing the benefits of a product. The customer glances at it once, then unconsciously touches behind the ear with a finger and soon says, "I'll think about it." This gesture means the customer dislikes the recommended item and does not want to hear more.

In everyday work and life, if you are expressing an opinion and the other person tilts their head while touching their ear, it signals that their view differs from yours and they are eager to speak. At that point, you should pause and listen to their opinion so the exchange can be productive.

### **Steady Eye Contact Does Not Necessarily Indicate Sincerity**

Micro-expression keyword: When lying, do people look away? Researchers now tell us another fact: liars may also maintain steady eye contact with you! This is because they try the opposite approach to conceal their inner panic.

We all know that when lying, people instinctively look away to avoid eye contact. Does that mean steady eye contact always indicates sincerity? Probably not. Even if the other person stares fixedly at you, they may still be lying.

### **What Signal Does Covering the Mouth with the Hand Convey?**

Micro-expression keyword: When people say something they should not have said, they instinctively cover their mouth to show regret or to stop themselves from continuing. This is a subconscious action that best expresses their true thoughts. Therefore, do not trust what they say afterward—it may well be a lie.

In ordinary conversation, we may notice that after finishing a sentence, the speaker suddenly covers their mouth. What does this reveal about their state of mind? Let us examine it together.

### **Detecting Signs of "Lying Micro-Expressions"**

In business settings, all kinds of lies fly around. Detecting them gives one an advantage over competitors, clarifies the power structure within a company, and helps avoid falling into fraud or dubious investment pitches.

This section explains the relationship between micro-expressions and lying. Among various business lies, the most critical to a company's survival is whether it can identify suitable talent during recruitment interviews and personnel evaluations.

### **Digging in the Ears with Fingertips**

A common scene occurs when one person speaks at length while the listener appears distracted and keeps digging in their ears with a fingertip.

This gesture means the listener finds everything you say contemptible and also shows disrespect toward the speaker. At this point, stop speaking on your own and ask, "What are your insightful views on this matter?" If



the other person is an elder, consider shifting to a topic that interests them.

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VIII — Applications (p-applications).

## Avoiding Eye Contact

For a long time, the question of whether liars exhibit visual avoidance has also been a topic that psychologists have competed to verify. One American scholar even chose to convey the conclusions of his research through a television drama, arguing that “when people lie, they do not exhibit visual avoidance as the legend claims; instead, they tend to look at the other person more often in order to observe the other party’s reaction (whether the lie was believed).”

In reality, this question can never yield a single, uniform conclusion.

Human diversity ensures that the answer to the question above must also be diverse. When most people improvise a lie, they fear being seen through or exposed; under effective stimulation (such as interrogation), they will shift their gaze, consistent with the pattern we have summarized. See Figure 3-6.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3-6 视线转移]*

But what if the person has come prepared? What if the lie has already been planned in advance?

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3-7 视觉关注]*

Such a person will carry out the pre-formulated plan methodically, hoping to see what effect the lie may produce and to observe the questioner’s reaction so as to make the next deceptive move. Even after believing the deception has succeeded, the individual may take pleasure in watching the opponent’s interesting expression upon being duped. Even when faced with questions, this type of person feels no surprise; whether or not the questions were anticipated, they can respond calmly, think clearly, and gradually draw the questioner into the complex trap they have set, then watch with a smile as the opponent is brought under control. See Figure 3-7.

Do you suppose such people would seek comfort through visual avoidance?

The answer is no.

The reason these skilled liars display reactions that deviate from the visual-comfort pattern is not that they are extraordinary individuals, but simply that they experience no discomfort. This only indicates that the stimulus source is insufficiently effective.

If one can analyze the subject’s personality traits and behavioral patterns, anticipate possible countermeasures against testing, and deliver effective surprise stimuli during the examination, even the most skilled individual will still exhibit visual-comfort reactions—only the degree will vary (those with strong psychological control can quickly suppress or alter their responses).

At present, investigations and interrogations in anti-corruption and bribery cases confront such suspects every day. When confronted with sharp questions and solid evidence, suspects will still shift their gaze for self-comfort, just like ordinary people.

Of course, we must acknowledge that gaze shifting cannot serve as a necessary condition for determining deception. Many factors can cause gaze shifting—thinking, fatigue, or simply a purposeless movement. Gaze shifting is not the same as gaze avoidance; one may also look away briefly to rest the eyes on something pleasant. Even when gaze avoidance can be confirmed, one must still analyze what the stimulus source is and what type of person the subject is.

Gaze avoidance while watching a surgical procedure cannot be taken as a deceptive reaction, because the stimulus source has nothing to do with lying; moreover, most people would avert their eyes in that situation, yet surgeons would not, because those images are professional rather than frightening to them. This example shows that the absence of visual avoidance likewise cannot prove that the subject is not lying.

Therefore, when gaze shifting is observed, we must take a further step to determine whether it constitutes visual comfort. If analysis establishes that the gaze avoidance arises from seeking comfort after a negative stimulus, and that the negative stimulus source is related to content about which the subject may be lying (attempting to conceal or fabricate), then the clue is valuable and warrants deeper investigation.

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

## **Lip Comfort Reactions**

### **The Outcome of Deliberately Lying to Counter the Test**

We once tested a very interesting person. This person was interesting because, before the test, we had no information about the test subject, not even basic information like their name. This kind of test without any reason, purely for testing purposes, is technically called a “no-cause test.”

Before the test started, the test questions were designed on the spot. Because it was a no-cause test, the questions were all quite conventional, such as whether they smoke, drink, their romantic experiences and feelings, and so on. Unexpectedly, the test subject showed obvious reactions to almost every question, many of which were later proven to be deliberate performances intended to test our professional level.

Among them, three consecutive questions were designed regarding whether they drink alcohol.

The first question was, “Have you ever drunk beer?”

The other party answered, “I don’t drink.”

We followed up, “Not drinking isn’t a reasonable reason; describe it specifically.”

The other party pursed their lips and then answered, “I drank it when I was very young; it was too bitter, I didn’t like it, so I don’t drink.”

It should be noted that test subjects generally position themselves as disadvantaged. If telling the truth, they feel fulfilled and confident inside, with nothing to feel guilty about; if lying, they subconsciously fear being exposed, and when thinking about the question, they are easily guided by the tester.

In the previous example, if they had insisted on saying they “don’t drink,” there wouldn’t have been any obvious flaws. But when we gave them a guide, they started running in that direction themselves, and running like that makes it easy to trip.

Hearing them start running along the direction we guided, we knew that this question could be dug deeper.

So we continued, "Please list three differences between A beer and B beer." A and B are both well-known domestic brands, common in northern regions.

The test subject thought laboriously for a few seconds and began to try saying, "I'm not very clear; the taste, price, and consumer groups are different, but they're all bitter, for sure."

Actually, how this question is answered isn't important; what's important is to put pressure on the other party and expose flaws.

Assuming you are the one taking this test, what would be your first reaction upon hearing this question?

1. If you are someone who drinks beer and knows these two brands, wouldn't you have already started thinking about the differences between them?
2. If you really haven't touched alcohol for most of your life, even if you drank a little when very young, wouldn't you directly say "I don't know"? I think so, because you really don't know and don't care about this question.
3. But if you are someone who drinks and are trying to lie to me that you don't drink. In such a situation, what would you think upon hearing this question? Would you dare to directly say "I don't know"? Especially after just changing your story?

So, seeing their response like that, the lying behavior was already quite obvious.

We waited for them to finish speaking and immediately followed up with the last question: "Explain the specific reasons for not drinking."

The comfort reaction appeared at this moment.

This is a manifestation of increased psychological discomfort. The reason is that the intensity of the stimulus source increased, making it difficult for the actor: on one hand, they have to fabricate reasons, and on the other, they worry about the lie being exposed.

The test subject began to involuntarily scratch their face, of course lightly, but for a long time (several seconds). During this period, they had to think carefully again about how to fabricate a reasonable reason for not drinking.

This is quite a long story; the "face-scratching" reaction only appeared once, seemingly not the focus. However, the interlocking, layer-by-layer questioning made the intensity of the stimulus source continuously increase. When the test subject felt enormous pressure and discomfort, they would use such actions to comfort themselves and slightly relax their tense nerves. Although initially, they hoped to interfere with our test through deliberate confrontation.

### 3.3.3 Swallowing Saliva

Swallowing food is even less likely to appear during lie detection than chewing, and if actual food is swallowed, the action has no analytical or evaluative value. However, saliva can be swallowed without food, and the act of swallowing saliva is more suspicious and carries greater analytical value. See Figures 3-15 and 3-16.

### Figures 3-15, 3-16 Swallowing Actions

You can try it yourself: under normal circumstances, deliberately swallowing saliva once—especially when there is little or no saliva—remains a relatively complex and effortful action because it involves coordinated movement of the mouth, tongue, throat, and esophagus (which you cannot feel).

When receiving negative stimuli, a test subject may unconsciously perform this complex set of movements to obtain comfort. Yet the behavior may not be consciously perceived by the actor. The swallowing action signals the central nervous system: “I am eating; I have taken something in,” thereby attempting to ease the tense nervous system.

Standard lie-detection manuals often conclude that people who swallow saliva are mostly in a state of fear, and experimental data support this view. In reality, the emotions that can trigger swallowing are not limited to fear; they may also include sexual arousal or appetite. Therefore, the stimulus source that elicits the swallow must be considered when attributing the reaction.

When analyzing swallowing, pay special attention to three timings:

1. When the subject hears a key question—that is, the critical information from the stimulus source;
2. Before the subject prepares to answer;
3. After the subject answers.

Saliva accumulation in the mouth requires three conditions: a specific duration, abnormal saliva secretion, and deviation from the usual swallowing frequency (for example, being too busy to swallow). Consequently, saliva swallowing under the following three circumstances deserves particular attention and may hold significant value:

- The interval since the previous swallow is short, or swallows occur consecutively; this violates physiological norms and can be identified as a comfort reaction indicating tension.
- Increased saliva secretion is a prerequisite for swallowing. Increased secretion results from parasympathetic excitation, a phenomenon that occurs when a person is relaxed. If the actor has been displaying excitement, tension, effort, or agitation, a subsequent swallow may instead stem from thirst caused by reduced saliva, which can be suspected as a comfort reaction mapping to tension.
- Extended speaking leaves no opportunity for normal-frequency swallowing, so a swallow after finishing speech is normal. Conversely, if speech content is brief yet a swallow follows, the action can be suspected as a comfort reaction indicating tension. If a swallow is also observed before speech, it can be classified as a comfort reaction indicating tension.

### 3.4 Skin Comfort

Among comfort reactions, visual, auditory, and lip-related comfort reactions are truly “micro” reactions (微反应). The most numerous and obvious behaviors are comfort actions directed at the skin. When these obvious macro reactions appear, the actor is unaware of them, giving them valuable interpretive significance.

Skin is the body’s largest organ, responsible for protecting the body from external invasion, receiving tactile information such as pressure, temperature, and friction, and expelling sweat. Appropriate temperature, humidity, pressure, and frequency produce sensations of comfort, warmth, and safety.

Many people do not realize that during embryonic development, neural tissue and skin tissue both originate from the ectoderm. Because of this natural “common origin,” clinical medicine has confirmed that mood affects skin health. Emotions such as tension and anxiety can trigger stress responses or endocrine

dysfunction, prompting blood-vessel walls or tissue cells to release mediators such as bradykinin and histamine; these substances can induce or aggravate existing skin conditions. For example, competitive, high-desire, or overly conscientious individuals are prone to neurodermatitis; those under prolonged suppression or unfulfilled desires are prone to chronic urticaria.

Conversely, stimuli applied to the skin exert a very important influence on the nervous system and psychological state. Comfortable stimuli improve neural perception, while painful or thermal stimuli generate negative neural assessments.

Skin, densely populated with nerve endings and fibers, can transmit large amounts of stimulation back to the central nervous system. Comfortable stimuli (such as caresses) produce pleasure; negative stimuli (such as pain) produce alertness and prompt immediate adjustments to escape them. Because the central nervous system in turn acts on the skin (as noted earlier, via endocrine and microcirculatory effects) and because of long-term conditioned reflexes, the nervous system objectively creates “skin hunger.” These two mutually reinforcing interactions lead people to learn to relieve nervous tension and discomfort by comforting the skin.

In childhood, a mother’s caresses not only make a child feel comfortable and safe but also shape good character and psychology. In adulthood, skin contact with a partner expresses genuine affection. In old age, massage or washing by children or emotionally close individuals prevents eccentricity and promotes cheerfulness.

In daily work, life, and social interactions, people also unconsciously follow this pattern. During criminal investigations, when a test subject is being interrogated and receives negative stimuli, fear of losing benefits or punishment can produce worry, fear, anxiety, embarrassment, or anger. To mask these emotions, the subject often uses skin-directed comfort actions to alleviate them.

### 3.3.2 Chewing and Its Variant Actions

Chewing and swallowing directly convey “eating” information to the central nervous system. Having something to eat is always good because it means survival without starvation. Long-term evolution has made the central nervous system consistently satisfied with—and pleased by—the act of eating. This is why overeating can improve mood to some extent when one feels down. The early film *Love on a Diet* starring Andy Lau and Sammi Cheng illustrates this “scientific” phenomenon.

During lie detection, actual eating rarely occurs. Some test protocols do arrange meals in advance to calm the subject and build a sense of security and rapport, but that belongs to test-protocol research and is outside the scope of this chapter.

In actual testing, what appears more often are variants of the “eating” action, mainly teeth grinding, chewing (usually gum), and swallowing saliva. When feasible, smoking and drinking water may also be permitted.

In tests we have conducted, subjects facing difficult questions (those requiring lies) sometimes exhibited teeth-grinding: opening the mouth and rubbing the upper and lower teeth together, usually the canines. See Figure 3-14.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 3-14 Teeth-grinding action]*

This action can make the facial expression appear threatening and can therefore also be interpreted from a micro-expression perspective. However, the friction between the canines sends the central nervous system the implicit message: “I am a predator tearing at prey (food); there is no need to worry—everything is under

control and I am in a dominant position.” Consequently, the action substantially relieves nervous tension caused by negative stimuli and provides comfort.

If the subject is chewing gum or betel nut, observe the frequency and force of chewing. Upon an unexpected stimulus, chewing may pause—this is a typical freeze response. Upon a negative stimulus, the subject may feel restless or at a loss and intensify thinking and effort; during this process, chewing frequency and force may increase in an attempt to relieve nervous tension. The key is to observe change. If the subject has been chewing rapidly or forcefully all along, that may simply be personal habit (baseline) and cannot serve as a judgment criterion. Only changes triggered by stimuli constitute potentially valuable reaction cues.

### 3.3.1 Lip Actions

When nervous, blood circulation accelerates in densely innervated areas to supply more energy, raising temperature and causing faster moisture loss from the skin surface.

Lips are such an organ.

When feeling uneasy, lips tend to become dry, prompting licking, pursing, or lightly biting the lips. Liars with weaker psychological resilience are prone to this sensation. Relieving lip discomfort and making this highly sensitive organ more comfortable correspondingly improves the overall state of the nervous system and yields substantial comfort. See Figures 3-10, 3-11, 3-12, and 3-13.

### Figures 3-10, 3-11, 3-12, 3-13 Lip Comfort Actions

Although these small lip-related actions appear common and inadvertent, when they occur after a negative stimulus or after the actor has uttered a suspicious statement, they acquire value as suspicious cues.

Generally, self-comfort actions targeting the lips can be triggered by sexual impulses, appetite impulses, or basic physiological desires.

For example, light lip-licking reactions are frequently observed in the following question-and-answer scenarios.

When asking adolescents or post-adolescents, “What kind of person of the opposite sex do you like most?” or “What part of him/her (the idol) do you like most?”, subjects still sensitive to the opposite sex often exhibit lip-licking before answering.

Why do such questions count as negative stimuli that elicit comfort reactions?

Revealing one’s preferences regarding the opposite sex to the questioner means disclosing private information under non-injurious pressure. This privacy touches the root of one’s sexual impulses and, in modern society, is largely restricted by social norms and not to be discussed openly; hence it produces mild discomfort.

Another reason is that in the pairing of liking and being liked, the person who likes another is psychologically in a weaker position, and acknowledging that liking intensifies the sense of weakness.

### 3.4.4 Derived Skin Comfort

The comfort reactions described above can also generate numerous variant forms, mostly reductions or deformations. Common examples include:

- Covering or grasping a necklace pendant
- Adjusting an earring (stud)
- Adjusting one's collar (or tie)

More covert variant actions directed at chest and abdominal skin include grasping the collar or chest clothing and shaking it back and forth a few times to “ventilate.” This objectively induces microcirculation of the air surrounding the clothed body; sensitive skin registers the gentle airflow as comfortable, reducing tension while also lowering body temperature elevated by blood pooling.

Seemingly inadvertent actions that appear after a key question possess important investigative value. On one hand, they divert the person's attention away from intense negative thoughts; on the other, they objectively soothe tense nerves.

Such reactions vary widely and are too numerous to list exhaustively. They share two uniform characteristics:

1. They are unrelated to the content being expressed and constitute “extra” actions.
2. They produce a physiological soothing effect.

Any small action possessing both characteristics is a comfort reaction. Its essence is the use of physiological comfort to regulate psychological discomfort in an attempt to reverse an unfavorable situation.

Note that not every test subject will frequently display such abrupt small actions. Professionally trained actors with performance experience produce no superfluous movements during performance; the audience sees only the role and the emotion. Performance training is a form of professional training. Ordinary people, when performing in front of an audience, frequently produce small actions involuntarily—that is, the micro-reactions (微反应) we discuss—which soothe their tense nerves and make them feel more at ease. Consequently, professionally trained individuals may exhibit very few small actions when tested.

### 3.4.3 Torso-directed Comfort

Similar to facial comfort, when feeling discomfort, actors may also perform comfort actions on the torso and limbs—chest, abdomen, arms, thighs—such as lightly patting the chest, rubbing the abdomen, or rubbing the thighs, in an attempt to self-regulate, reverse the situation, and divert the other party's attention.

Facial comfort reactions carry greater significance because, under normal circumstances, actors do not lose control to the point of touching and comforting the face; this usually indicates that the psychological stimulus is severe.

Although chest and abdominal skin is covered by clothing and less directly accessible to effective stimuli, its internal organs are vulnerable; evolutionary adaptation has rendered this skin region highly sensitive to better protect the fragile viscera. Consequently, actions applied to this skin area also produce good comfort effects<|eos|>

## Chapter Summary

Comfort responses (安慰反应) have two essential characteristics: first, the actions are unrelated to verbal expression and serve no auxiliary semantic function; second, the actions allow the actor to feel comfortable.

In many speaking situations, hand, foot, and body postures can assist in conveying the speaker's meaning, attitude, and stance—for example, indicating quantity, describing size or amount, sequencing items, pointing

to locations, or vividly illustrating feelings (such as “my head is exploding”). These movements belong to social behavior and function as linguistic aids; they carry no evidential value.

However, when language and movement are unconnected, the actions merit attention. If the movements provide the actor with comfort relative to the prevailing emotion, they qualify as comfort responses.

Examples include:

- Rubbing the nose produces a physiologically comforting effect unrelated to expression and unrelated to any medical condition (such as rhinitis or nasal congestion from a cold), and therefore qualifies as a comfort response.
- Scratching the scalp produces a physiologically comforting effect unrelated to expression and unrelated to any medical condition (dirt, itching, headache, etc.), and therefore qualifies as a comfort response.
- When a person is emotionally distressed or agitated, slapping their own face can discharge emotion and shift pain, yielding a physiologically comforting effect unrelated to expression; it therefore qualifies as a comfort response even though the action would normally cause pain.

Kicking a wall corner, bumping the back, kneading the arms, smelling perfume, licking the lips, chewing gum, needing a drink, smoking, and similar actions meet both criteria and are comfort responses.

**Classic manifestations:** covering the mouth after a slip of the tongue, rubbing the nose while stammering, wringing the hands while nervously anticipating an outcome.

### 3.4.5 Comfort Responses Targeting the Hands

The nerve endings in the hands are also highly developed. What makes analysis especially challenging is that many hand movements carry plausible everyday meanings, rendering hand-action analysis the most difficult.

Fingers are the most dexterous organs precisely because they can execute highly complex movement combinations. The skin on the backs of the hands is likewise extremely sensitive. Consequently, another typical comfort response that appears frequently under mental tension is the rubbing of one hand against the other. Common actions include:

- Wringing the hands, often seen in helplessness or anxiety
- Playing with the fingers—for instance, rubbing the thumbs together in circles while interlacing the remaining eight fingers—often seen in thoughtful anxiety or indecision
- Stroking the back of one hand with the fingers, often seen in fear or unease

In summary, if a subject exhibits any of the skin-directed comfort behaviors described above when confronted with a negative stimulus, that stimulus is especially significant and warrants further exploration and analysis; it may become a key clue to uncovering the truth.

It is important to note that the movements listed above cannot be treated as comfort responses—and therefore as signs of deception—in every situation. Do not memorize or mechanically apply the list; touching the face or wringing the hands does not automatically mean the person is lying. The individual may simply be following a personal habit or may consider straightening a tie to be a stylish gesture. To determine whether these actions constitute stress-induced micro-reactions (微反应), one must consider the entire testing context, especially whether the movements appear as changes after exposure to a negative stimulus (such as a pointed question) and whether those changes differ from the subject’s baseline behavior (habitual or non-stimulus movements). Only then can the actions be judged to have analytical value or interpretive significance.



### 3.3.4 Comfort Through Taste

In addition to oral and lip comfort responses, another category involves attempts to soothe the central nervous system through gustatory stimulation.

One reason smokers find quitting difficult is the absence of substitutes that deliver equivalent taste stimulation. In many smoking-related experiments, participants expressed a strong desire for gustatory stimulation yet did not want to eat frequently, because doing so would burden the digestive system.

Smoking supplies both taste and olfactory stimulation and directly affects nervous-system state. The trace substances produced by burning tobacco suppress neural excitability and reduce blood oxygen levels. Whether the goal is sedation, stimulation, or anxiety relief, tobacco can indeed alter nervous-system activity and lower anxiety.

During testing we allow the subject to adopt a comfortable posture from the outset and, according to individual habit, provide water and an ashtray so that drinking or smoking remains possible. Once testing begins, every reaction can reflect the subject's psychological response to the stimulus and manifest through micro-reactions. Observing the subject's normal smoking pattern (to establish baseline) and noting any changes in smoking behavior when pressure questions arise permits a more comprehensive analysis of micro-reactions.

#### Digression

At this point it is necessary to describe the ideal conditions for micro-reaction psychological testing.

For micro-reaction testing to succeed, the fundamental requirement is the delivery of effective stimuli. Effective stimulus design depends on knowledge of the subject. The more thoroughly relevant information is gathered, the more clearly the subject's personality traits, behavioral patterns, and concerns or aversions can be identified. Only then can a sound testing protocol be devised and possible stress responses anticipated, facilitating accurate judgments about truthfulness.

When nothing is known about the subject and the test has no specific purpose, the procedure is termed a "no-cause test."

Media and enthusiasts often request such tests: "Come on, see if I'm lying! Can you tell what I'm thinking?" The request is usually accompanied by a slight expression of disbelief and schadenfreude—rather like fans spotting a famous comedian on the street and immediately shouting, "Hey, give us a routine!"

Recommendation: avoid no-cause tests whenever possible.

### 3.4.2 Comfort Responses Targeting Facial Organs

A second category of skin-directed comfort responses centers on self-soothing through tactile contact with facial organs. Typical manifestations include:

- Lightly stroking the forehead or cheeks
- Rubbing the nose
- Touching the ears
- Stroking the beard
- Touching the mouth or chin

- Rubbing the neck

These actions originate in the early stages without cortical decision-making; they are controlled directly by relatively primitive limbic-system structures. Individuals without specialized training find them difficult to suppress.

The head, face, and neck lie closest to the brain's central structures and are richly supplied with blood vessels and nerves (the neck is the obligatory pathway connecting the central nervous system to peripheral nerve nodes). Tactile comfort movements directed at this region can directly modulate nervous-system tension caused by negative stimuli; when performed with slightly greater pressure they can also reduce rising blood pressure, rapidly restoring calm after an overreaction. Unlike other comfort responses, the soothing effect here is not merely suggestive but rests on objective physiological improvement and is therefore especially noticeable.

### **3.4.1 Comfort Responses for Hair and Scalp**

Scratching the scalp when embarrassed is in fact a comfort response directed at the scalp.

Hairstyle adjustment is also frequently used as a camouflage or shield. During an interview or test, rising pressure may prompt both men and women to rearrange their hair as a self-soothing measure.

Women exhibit an additional distinctive comfort response: gathering the hair at the nape, sweeping it backward, or re-braiding it to relieve tension and self-soothe.

Although these movements appear to be routine grooming, they frequently occur when the hairstyle or makeup shows no visible disarray and may remain unchanged—making them noteworthy. When the adjustments recur frequently and consecutively, they more clearly exhibit the features of a comfort response and reflect an agitated mental state.

In addition, grooming or scalp-scratching movements can redirect attention so that the actor avoids becoming helplessly embarrassed, thereby aiding psychological recovery.

### **Practical Application**

In actual use, first establish the subject's smoking-habit baseline by recording smoking frequency, characteristic movements while smoking, and the manner of extinguishing cigarettes. Then watch for anomalous changes. If an anomalous reaction appears after a negative stimulus and the frequency or intensity of smoking behavior shifts noticeably, the subject's psychological state has changed, indicating an attempt to relieve discomfort (fear, anxiety, embarrassment, or excitement) and obtain comfort through smoking.

### **3.3 Oral and Lip Comfort**

When under pressure, people employ various oral and lip behaviors for self-soothing—sucking fingers, biting nails, chewing on a pencil, eating candy, smoking, or swallowing saliva. These actions signal to the nervous system, "Don't be afraid, everything's fine, I'm eating."

Specifically, after exposure to a negative stimulus, common oral and lip comfort responses include the following:

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

## Part Seven: Body Language

### Courtship Body Movements: Instinctive Physical Signals Emitted During Courtship Between Opposite Sexes

Micro-expression keywords Courtship between men and women relies primarily on the body. It is not only instinctive but also avoids much awkwardness because of shyness or uncertainty. Therefore, when members of the opposite sex court each other, they emit certain body-language signals while awaiting an unspoken response from the other party.

Many people have experienced this: when walking down the street and encountering an attractive man or woman approaching, we instinctively straighten our posture, pull in our abdomen, and radiate vitality. Even those with a “beer belly” will unconsciously tuck in their stomach and lift their head to appear taller and more imposing, while their stride becomes lighter. The purpose of all this is to present one’s best side to the opposite sex and win favor through personal charm.

Body language can be described as the most basic communication tool people use in the process of courting the opposite sex, because nearly all thoughts and emotions can be expressed through it. In this regard, women always hold the decisive power; in 90 percent of cases, it is the woman who initiates courtship. Typically, once a woman identifies a man she likes, she continuously sends subtle courtship signals via her eyes, body, or facial expressions until she believes he has noticed both her and the signals, and has responded in some way.

The courtship process also follows certain steps. For example, if a woman spots a highly attractive man, she will first gaze at him quietly until he notices her and eye contact occurs. Next, a fleeting smile appears on her face—an acquiescent signal women often use to hint that the man should take the next step. The third step is grooming, used to highlight her charm and attract his attention. The fourth step involves speaking and moving closer, attempting to close the distance through casual conversation. The fifth step is physical contact, when a woman may seize an opportunity to “accidentally” touch the man’s arm.

Although these five steps may seem insignificant, they exert a crucial influence on the beginning of a new relationship. Body language plays a decisive role throughout. For instance, the basic grooming actions of men and women are similar and include smoothing the hair, straightening clothing, placing one or both hands on the hips, and pointing the toes and body toward the person of interest. As long as one party has not received or given a clear signal, the other will try every means to court through body language.

Basically, women employ thirteen common body movements and signals when courting, through which they convey their single status.

1. Tilting the head back and playing with the hair—the two signals women use first upon noticing someone of interest.
2. Moist lips, pouting, and slightly parted lips.
3. Self-touching, which creates in the woman the illusion of being caressed by a man.
4. Displaying the soft inner wrist to signal gentleness and submissiveness in hopes of gaining the man’s attention. Men find women with soft wrists especially delicate and appealing.
5. Enthusiastically stroking cylindrical objects—playing with cigarettes, fingers, earrings, or any item resembling the male genitalia. This action is a subconscious externalization of inner thoughts.

6. Exposing the smooth, soft skin of the inner wrist to the man of interest; as interest grows, the frequency of wrist flashing increases.
7. Shoulders raised with a sidelong glance—the raised shoulders accentuate the woman's characteristically rounded, graceful figure.
8. Swaying the hips, subtly highlighting the gender difference between men and women.
9. Twisting the pelvis—when standing, a woman's pelvic twist often signals her reproductive capacity.
10. Placing a handbag near the man so he notices or touches it indicates strong interest and willingness to accept him.
11. A common posture in which one leg is bent and tucked under the other; the knee of the bent leg usually points toward the person of greatest interest.
12. Sliding a foot partially out of a shoe and dangling it by the toes is also a signal of relaxation.
13. Women often deliberately press their legs together to draw attention to them—the seated posture men find most captivating. In addition, slowly crossing and uncrossing the legs while lightly tapping the thighs with the fingers signals an inner desire to be touched.

Women's courtship movements showcase their charm, whereas men's essentially display power, wealth, and status. Men's most common courtship body-language actions center on the crotch area.

For example, when facing a woman, the most direct way a man can highlight sexual difference is the aggressive thumbs-hooked-in-belt posture that makes the crotch more prominent. He will also gradually turn his body and toes toward the woman of interest, gazing at her with an ambiguous expression for a prolonged time to draw her attention. When seated, he may deliberately spread his legs to expose the crotch.

In public places, the most frequent courtship action men direct at women is crotch adjustment. Some women complain that men reach toward the crotch without apparent reason or warning. In reality, they simply do not understand the subtext: the area is so large that it becomes caught in the trousers, requiring constant repositioning.

It can be said that men and women often begin courting the opposite sex under the impetus of body language. Thus everyone has the opportunity to refine their appearance, enhance their attractiveness to the opposite sex, and gain more chances for contact. There are many courtship signals between the sexes; if the signals emitted are strong enough and penetrating enough, everything will fall into place naturally. Many people hesitate to confess directly because of shyness or lack of courage. If you also like the other person, respond clearly to these body signals.

### 6.2.1 Head Lowering + Spinal Curvature

Head lowering indicates a lowered self-positioning; trunk curvature indicates endurance and self-protection. These can be used to determine the emotion being expressed, its intensity, and its authenticity, as shown in Figures 6-7, 6-8, and 6-9.

When the head is lowered while the spine remains upright, the behavior usually expresses social submission.

Unless the person is a long-term member of a strictly disciplined force, the isolated head-lowering action together with verbal statements of agreement or obedience constitutes a "lie," because it contradicts the person's actual cognition.

When the head is lowered and the spine is moderately curved—yet lumbar curvature has not appeared—and no deliberate force or redundant expression is present elsewhere in the body, one can conclude that the

individual harbors no confrontational mindset and is sincerely acknowledging the situation.

As shown in Figure 6-8. In modern society, if one party lowers the head while the spine curves during a standing conversation, it indicates that the person fully accepts the disparity between them or has abandoned resistance after being overwhelmed by the received information. For example, a student who feels guilty after making a mistake will display the reaction in Figure 6-8; if inwardly defiant, the student may adopt the posture in Figure 6-7 to signal internal resistance.

When the head is lowered and the lumbar spine simultaneously curves noticeably, producing substantial trunk curvature, the stimulus is extremely strong.

In moments of extreme fear, people adopt this pronounced trunk curvature for self-protection, always accompanied by flexion and enclosure of the limbs—the “curling” tendency discussed under the “freeze response.”

This action is easily faked.

When expressing flattery or humility, people frequently adopt such a posture, yet apart from the lowered head and pronounced spinal curvature, the rest of the body remains controlled. Combined with explicit verbal statements such as “It is my honor to have you guide our work,” “It is her good fortune that you regard her favorably,” or “Please do not take offense; calm your anger, calm your anger,” these are socially motivated expressions driven by self-interest and cannot be taken at face value, as they may conceal a highly complex inner state.

It is also important to note that head lowering plus lumbar curvature constitutes a widely recognized normative apology behavior.

We often see public figures apologize by bowing in addition to speaking, as illustrated in Figures 6-10, 6-11, and 6-12. Bowing is one of modern society’s etiquette rules and is used by everyone; to some extent it is a deliberately cultivated behavior. Especially when a public appearance and apology have been prepared at length, the degree of bowing cannot serve as a reliable indicator of psychological state.

What we must observe is the inadvertent postural change that occurs after an unexpected stimulus.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-10 丰田总裁丰田章男2010年3月就丰田汽车大规模召回道歉]*

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-11 某台湾女艺人就不当言论道歉]*

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图6-12 日本女艺人酒井法子就吸毒事件向公众道歉]*

These apologies achieved relatively good public recognition and media acceptance because the posture involved lumbar curvature, fully conveying the individual’s remorse. Apologizing with an upright spine tends to invite widespread doubt and criticism.

You may ask: since the standard apology posture is a classic social behavior that can be learned or trained, how can it be cited as an example of emotional behavior?

If this question has occurred to you, congratulations! It shows that you have firmly internalized the distinction among “social behavior,” “physiological behavior,” and “emotional behavior,” and one foot is already in the professional domain.

In response to your question, I raise a deeper one: how did social etiquette become established by custom? Why, across all societies past and present, has this identical posture been adopted as a universal apology rule? Has anyone ever apologized with an upward gaze?

An apology delivered with an upward gaze, no matter how sincere and reasonable the words, will be perceived as arrogant and insincere, indicating an absence of genuine remorse. This is precisely why the upward-gaze response can be used to judge another person's state of mind. Therefore, when an individual is in a position of psychological weakness, the posture adopted is invariably one of trunk curvature and lowered head.

Imagine walking along the street and accidentally jostling an elderly person so that they stumble. Your immediate reaction is a slight bow and lowered head to express apology while reaching out to steady them, accompanied by words of remorse such as "I'm sorry."

Apology is certainly a social expression; public apologies delivered before audiences and media constitute typical "one-way expression." We cannot judge the speaker's true inner state from these displays. A carefully rehearsed apology performance may, after extensive preparation, convey remorse in an exhaustive manner, yet the goal may be to preserve public approval and related interests rather than to admit fault. At minimum, an opportunity for questions must exist, because only then can a stimulus be applied and a stress response observed.

Nevertheless, within the societal consensus on apology movements, every apology incorporates lowering the posture as a prescribed action. This is because, over time, the lowering posture has been the natural reaction of people who genuinely feel remorse; society has therefore extracted the pattern from these spontaneous phenomena, and the pattern necessarily aligns with human cognitive habits.

### 9.2.1 Body Drooping

Loss of energy produces noticeable changes in several areas: the eyes lose luster and become vacant; lacking energy, the body succumbs to gravity and exhibits an overall downward trend, ceasing all actions that resist gravity, including facial muscles, which assume a uniformly relaxed, drooping state (see the book *Micro-expressions*); the trunk can no longer remain upright and the head drops; in a standing posture, the center of gravity lowers, the legs naturally bend from loss of strength, and the person may squat or sit on the ground, the entire body contracting; breathing becomes shallow and reactions sluggish.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-11 失败的颓废]

In short, the body of a defeated person conforms to the principle of gravity and lacks the strength to resist its pull. These reactions and their variants fully reveal the psychological state of the defeated: acceptance of loss and abandonment of resistance.

Therefore, if during testing one observes that after repeated stimulation the subject exhibits signs of energy and vitality depletion, it indicates that the subject's psychological defenses are on the verge of collapse and the truth is about to be revealed.

Defeat and surrender represent psychological collapse—a state devoid of further expectation. The external manifestations of this mental state resemble those of sadness. The fundamental stimulus for sadness is the helpless loss of someone or something one cares about or loves, which to some extent also constitutes psychological surrender, such as the loss of a loved one or the failure to realize a goal after investing great

effort. All such helpless losses can produce sadness. Consequently, the above reactions can also be used to infer sadness, with analysis adjusted according to the specific context and the nature of the stimulus.

Sadness and grief, however, arise from entirely different mental states. Sadness stems from “helpless loss,” whereas grief stems from non-acceptance, disbelief, and rejection of a negative outcome (for example, loss of someone or something one cares about or loves). Grief also involves regret, indignation, and a desire to change the situation, together with the energy to express these feelings. The classic expression of grief is therefore loud weeping, while sadness more often appears as a quiet, despondent state.

## Test Case

### The Unfortunate Marriage of a High-Quality Older Single Woman

During our testing applications, a classic sequence of grief followed by sadness was observed.

The subject was a high-quality older single woman who maintained strict standards for her life: regular routines, consistent exercise, careful diet, and cultural pursuits in which she had achieved a certain level of accomplishment. Her one possible fixation was the insistence on marrying only a man who was “accomplished in both the civil and martial arts.” Here the phrase did not mean both scholarly and combative, but rather possessing both literary achievement and substantial family wealth.

Such expectations were not excessive, given her own strong qualifications. The problem arose from prolonged selectivity and screening, which fostered a habit of suspicion. She felt compelled to investigate every candidate overtly and covertly before committing, hoping to ascertain the truth. This obsessive pattern of thought had reached an unacceptable level.

Eventually she found a man she liked and married him, yet her suspicious obsessiveness produced an unhappy marriage in which both parties suffered (whether the man also contributed factors remains unconfirmed).

When asked, “Do you unreservedly wish to continue this marriage?” the woman deliberated at length before answering “Yes.” The man, present at the scene, showed a slight smile. The testing team subsequently invalidated her answer, rendering all prior effort void. The man’s expression can be imagined.

The woman’s immediate reaction was grief. Clenching her fists, she wept and loudly denied and protested, her eyes brimming with tears and filled with anger.

After the room was cleared, staff explained the basis for the judgment: first, she had concealed her financial situation, a fact supported by evidence; second, during testing she had acknowledged that under certain circumstances she would protect her own interests by choosing divorce—an admission made in the course of the test. The woman’s body rapidly lost all energy; her gaze became lusterless. She collapsed backward onto the sofa, covered her face, and sobbed silently. This helpless sorrow constituted sadness.

## Test Cases

### The “Proud” Girl Who Corrected Her Boyfriend’s Behavior

While studying the relationship between emotions and reactions, we once conducted a type of experiment. The experiment was simple: volunteers were asked to recount, within a set time, the thing they were most proud of (and, of course, the saddest thing, the most contemptible thing, the happiest thing, the angriest thing, and so on). The sessions were recorded, and afterward the recordings were analyzed for synchronous matching among content, emotion, and micro-reaction (微反应).

Emotional changes do not arise or vanish abruptly. Our research shows that, except for surprise, most emotions accumulate gradually and then fade gradually. Disgust can sometimes be triggered suddenly by smell or visual stimuli, yet more often it too builds through repeated negative input. We call this pattern “the curvilinear nature of emotional change.” Accordingly, speakers in the experiment were asked to speak for five minutes. Those who achieved genuine emotional engagement and kept content, emotion, and micro-reaction synchronized received a material reward.

Although the data set was modest, every speaker describing a genuinely proud moment displayed the same outward signs: abundant energy and large or complex movements.

One girl recounted how she had “corrected” her boyfriend’s gaming addiction. She appeared to have studied psychology; she first cited Pavlov’s conditioned-reflex theory, then described a carrot-and-stick behavior-modification model (carrot for correct behavior as positive reinforcement; stick for mistakes as punitive stimulus). She concluded with evident satisfaction. When she reached the part she was proudest of, her expression brightened, her eyes shone, her hand gestures increased, her posture straightened and leaned forward, and her chin and face lifted slightly in concert with her assertive language.

When an experimenter interjected, “Have you studied counter-conditioning and aversion therapy? You treated your boyfriend like a lab rat, didn’t you?” the classic “head-shaking” reaction appeared. The girl had not expected her boyfriend-correction story to be compared with famous psychological research; the powerful sense of validation and achievement made her head shake four times within one second.

### 3. Finger-drumming roll

In offensive reactions we have already discussed desk-directed striking movements that reflect anger. Not every instance of finger-drumming, however, signals anger. One form expresses satisfaction or pride. When a person lets the four fingers (or all five, including the thumb) of one hand fall lightly onto the tabletop in sequence—“tap, tap, tap, tap”—and each finger pauses briefly in the air before the next descends, the action is called “leisurely fingers.” It is the characteristic drumming style of a self-satisfied state.

#### Leisurely fingers

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-10]*

### 4. Straight-leg foot wag

We have already examined leg-jiggling: baseline jiggling that stops, or baseline jiggling that begins, both map to negative emotion. When, however, a person extends both legs nearly straight, crosses the ankles, and rocks the feet from the ankles, the movement signals comfort and ease. In adversarial settings it can indicate a victory response—relaxed and self-satisfied—as shown in Figure 9-10.

By the same principle, rapid shoulder shrugs, small high-frequency torso sways, or rocking against an elastic chair back all express relaxation and pleasure.

#### Female Car Model vs. Female Host

Two elegant women are conversing. The car model (hereafter “S”) maintains a professional posture throughout: smiling, hands folded on her lap, torso upright and never leaning back into the sofa, legs crossed in the classic “figure-four” position.



The host, however, asks pointed, impolite questions about private matters. A woman can remain outwardly graceful and smiling even when being rude, and both parties understand this.

S's posture undergoes three subtle shifts that reveal three successive mental states during the recording.

At first the conversation stays light—fashion, modeling, clothing, food—and S's crossed legs tilt slightly, indicating that, despite her professional bearing, she is relatively relaxed.

When the host deliberately moves to sensitive topics and grows increasingly sharp, S produces a series of reactions: several widened-eye "stares," slight nostril flaring on exhalation (classic anger), and aborted arm-crossing gestures (checked by habit). A further subtle change occurs: her crossed lower leg rises from a tilted to an almost vertical angle. Although she keeps the figure-four posture, the shift itself constitutes a preparatory escape movement.

In the final stage the host's aggression becomes so intense that S can no longer maintain a smile. After her agent quarrels with the director, S's anger mounts; the woman who had preserved decorum for nearly half an hour now leans back against the sofa. Compared with her earlier posture, this is the clearest disgust-driven escape reaction—caused not by fatigue but by strong aversion. The interview soon ends acrimoniously.

Disgust-driven escape is therefore highly significant. Whether seated or standing, it maps directly to aversion. Its appearance is valuable because, translated into words, it says "go away," "stay away from me," "how tiresome," "I no longer wish to talk."

The state is dominant: it expresses refusal and marks the point at which communication difficulty peaks.

If the negative stimulus continues or intensifies, aversion accumulates. Imagine an adolescent forced to listen to an incessant, unwelcome monologue; the feeling is unmistakable.

In commercial service, negotiation, or investigative interviewing, the appearance of this reaction is a critical juncture and must be handled in one of two ways.

First, if the topic under discussion is peripheral to core interests, the interviewee's agreement or disagreement matters little. Once aversion appears, the best response is to change the subject unobtrusively; continued accumulation of aversion risks creating personal animosity that later blocks cooperation.

Second, if the topic is central to the case, the aversion must be dispelled. Allowing the person to refuse engagement through posture or words makes any later return to the same issue far more difficult. In criminal interrogation, for example, verbal pressure and physical instructions to abandon the escape posture can be used to compel renewed engagement.

## 5.2.2 Psychological Drivers of Approach Responses

An approach response occurs when two or more people move closer, enter, or remain within personal or intimate distance without rejection or withdrawal. The causes are as follows:

### 1. Emotional closeness

The embraces, leaning, and intimacy of lovers are classic expressions of this state.

Two old comrades-in-arms who once shielded each other from bullets will, on first sight after many years, perform the most intimate gesture—an embrace. The hug is not the polite pat of formal greeting; each man pulls the other tightly and draws him inward. This maximal closeness of action and distance maps the warmth of their friendship.

An embrace is an expressive, warm form of approach etiquette.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-14 标准的拥抱]

A standard embrace has two necessary components: the fronts of the torsos (chest and abdomen) must touch, leaving no further space; and the arms must encircle the other person and pull inward, actively shortening the distance. See Figure 5-14.

Precisely because of this bodily intimacy the gesture has become a universal signal of emotional closeness.

Once the action becomes conventional etiquette, however, even people harboring reservations may use it insincerely in public settings to convey closeness to onlookers.

Such insincere embraces still betray clear discrepancies with the two necessary components—torso distance and arm tension.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-15 违心的拥抱]

The first sign is control of torso-to-torso distance. The two people smile, open their arms, and appear welcoming, yet when they meet only the shoulders and heads touch; from the chest downward there is deliberate separation, and the torso and legs angle away (Figure 5-15). These movements expose genuine reserve or distance.

The second sign is minimal arm effort. Politicians are often seen exchanging embraces in which torso alignment is correct but the arms merely brush the back without any genuine pull.

In either case an insincere embrace need not be sinister; it may simply reflect unfamiliarity and the requirements of social ritual while the underlying relationship remains amicable.

If two people consistently fail to close distance—either both maintaining it or one repeatedly withdrawing—the psychological state is one of rejection or aversion.

### 6.1.1 Arrogance

Arrogance is the attitude of regarding oneself as markedly superior (stronger, wealthier, nobler...) to another and therefore seeing no need to engage—the implicit message being “not worth my time.” The facts rarely match the self-assessment.

Beyond luxury cars, large houses, idle wealth, and ostentatious clothing, an arrogant person typically displays the following classic reactions: these external markers are insufficient; the person must also be physically higher. Instead of platform shoes, the individual lifts the chin above its normal angle, producing the sensation of greater height.

The head is the body's commander; once the commander feels elevated, confidence follows.

Although humans are civilized, this evolutionary legacy is difficult to suppress consciously. One may maintain a cultivated appearance until emotion rises, at which point the primitive pattern reappears.

Arrogance and disdain are two outward expressions of the same emotion; their motor signatures are nearly identical: head tilted back, chin raised. The raised chin naturally directs the gaze downward, so the upper eyelids often cover half the eyes in a looking-down posture. Additional synchronous signs may include head-shaking or a half-bared canine-teeth expression of contempt.

Figure 6-4 shows Takayama Kiyoshi, second-in-command of Japan's Yamaguchi-gumi syndicate, arrested at home on the morning of 18 November 2010. Although he denied the extortion charges, he offered no resistance and was described by the media as extremely arrogant.

In the photograph, neck fat obscures any obvious chin lift, yet the overall head posture is angled upward (judged by the angle between the vertical line through the ear and the horizontal). Another key feature is the open right eye (the closed left eye may be medical), half-lidded in the classic superior gaze that reveals inner arrogance.

Complete arrogance or disdain reactions are uncommon in daily life; milder versions predominate. During conversation, for example, one party may lift the chin slightly while politely stating, "Martial arts have no hierarchy; all serve health," revealing an unspoken belief that his own views are superior.

When the face is not oriented directly toward the other person yet the chin still rises, the gesture adds an element of defiance. Combined with a provocative expression, it signals a dominant confrontational mindset—stronger than disgust-driven escape and indicative of impending opposition.

A subtler seated variant occurs when a person bends the torso yet keeps the head level, thereby widening the angle between torso and head while still conveying a trace of non-submission within an otherwise compliant posture.

## 4.2 Surprise: Unexpected and Attentive

The essence of surprise is that something is both unexpected and noteworthy.

"Unexpected" means the stimulus lies outside the subject's anticipation; this is a necessary condition for the stimulus to register as effective. The immediate result is surprise, which may be followed by fear (preparation to flee), anger (preparation to fight), or joy.

Can you picture a surprised expression? That frozen look is already in your mind (Figure 4-1): eyebrows raised, eyes widened, mouth involuntarily open; in cartoons the jaw may even drop to the floor. For that instant the person is motionless.

In real life, however, few people produce such an obvious reaction. Most merely widen their eyes slightly and may part their lips (drawing a quick breath) without further display.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-1 惊讶的样子]*

Moreover, if the subject has already formed defensive or resistant expectations, any genuine surprise reaction to a related negative stimulus will be brief and minute, almost imperceptible, and will quickly convert into a self-masking furrowed brow that signals serious concern.

The standard surprise subtext is "Huh?"; the masked version is "Hmm?" (internally: "How did he know?" or "Why is he asking that?"). The subsequent brow-furrow actually expresses displeasure or aversion following the surprise (Figure 4-2).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4-2 惊讶之后的厌恶]*

The instant of surprise is the nervous system's emergency interval for processing complex information. An unexpected stimulus lies beyond conscious control; the subject cannot yet know its consequences. Long-term

survival pressures have shaped an automatic response: the subject must rapidly assess the source's nature and intensity and then select an appropriate countermeasure.

Imagine you have just accepted a "Hexi Express" delivery and are turning to open it when a knock sounds and a voice outside says, "Hexi Express!" You know you placed only one order and the voice differs from the earlier courier's. Your first reaction is to freeze and evaluate, not to ignore the knock or open the door without hesitation.

Pleasant surprises can also produce freezing: when a revered mentor calls to say the student ahead of you has withdrawn and you may now prepare for graduate study, the initial response is not immediate thanks or elation; that would imply prior certainty. Only after the sub-second surprise do joy, excitement, and gratitude surge.

## 10.4 Weakened and Inhibited Breathing

When the human nervous and motor systems enter a depressed state, physiological activity decreases and objectively requires less oxygen consumption, so breathing shifts into gentle, low, shallow respiration. Typically, this state appears only after a complete state of sorrow, such as decadence, depression, or despondency.

If stimulation produces a stress response that simultaneously weakens both inhalation and exhalation, the result is respiratory inhibition. The person exhibiting this inhibition often remains unaware of it.

The instinctive reaction to surprise is to draw a quick breath and hold it in reserve. Yet when fear follows—especially when objective conditions prevent flight or resistance, such as modern social rules or etiquette—a freezing response appears in the form of breath-holding or reduced breathing.

This weakened-breathing reaction maps the person's fear emotion and feeling.

A colleague once organized a conference and, amid the many details, forgot to send a car for an important leader. Fortunately the leader was magnanimous, raised no objection, and the meeting proceeded smoothly. Even so, the colleague's own superior was furious. At the celebratory banquet that evening the colleague received a few mild criticisms. Although the words were light, the colleague felt ashamed, reined in his earlier high spirits, and listened attentively with lowered head. During the brief silences between sentences, everyone in the room unconsciously held their breath, fearing a sudden storm. The superior stopped at that point, called for more wine, and the frozen air dissolved back into noise.

Note why the air seemed to congeal: the sensation arises from everyone's subtle breathing.

The ancient essence of this slight respiratory change is concealment—to avoid attracting a hunter's attention. When hunted, the weaker party that cannot fight must flee; if escape is also impossible, it must hide. While hiding, any noticeable airflow or breathing sound reveals one's location to the predator—an extremely dangerous outcome. Long evolutionary accumulation therefore produced the instinct that concealment involves weakening or stopping the breath. In modern society, visual concealment is rarely required except by soldiers, intelligence officers, and criminals; at most one feels the urge to "find a crack in the ground to crawl into" when embarrassed. Yet under negative pressure the psyche still seeks protection through concealment by actively weakening or suspending respiration in an attempt to reduce the other party's attention.

Consequently, under normal conditions a person encountering negative stimuli involuntarily weakens or holds the breath. The same reduction occurs when someone tries to mask their true state—for example, while lying

and remaining cautious.

From this conclusion it follows that if a subordinate's breathing becomes markedly stronger while being scolded, the anomaly deserves attention; it often signals grievance, defiance, or resistance and warrants further inquiry.

The freezing response in breathing consists of holding the breath or reducing its amplitude and frequency—the state commonly described as “not daring to breathe heavily.”

## 5.2 Proximity Responses

We begin by taking the degree of intimacy and aversion between men and women in romantic contexts as two extreme reference points. Because these distances correspond to primitive and basic needs that everyone has experienced, the relationship between psychological and physical distance is relatively easy to grasp.

Lovers in the heat of passion feel the greatest closeness; the distance they maintain therefore serves as the positive extreme.

Before reaching this positive peak, two strangers first keep a normal polite distance while conversing; eye contact then lengthens, followed by physical contact beginning with hand-holding, until they enter a very close bodily range.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-12 恋人间脚的触碰]*

For adolescents experiencing first love, the nervous excitement of the first hand-holding lingers long in memory. Leg and foot contact represents a still more advanced form of intimacy than hand contact. When lovers lightly touch or rub legs or feet, the behavior can generally be taken as an indication that sexual desire has begun to stir, as in Figure 5-12. Men and women whose relationship has not reached a certain level of intimacy will not psychologically accept such contact. The final stage is complete intimacy in which two people function as one; only when one has fully accepted the other psychologically does this distance become permissible.

Conversely, if one person feels aversion toward another, close distance is never permitted. Imagine dodging a roadside beggar who pursues you, or recalling an unwelcome suitor who, in full public view beneath a dormitory, lights a heart-shaped candle array and dances naked in the snow: which scenario makes you more eager for the other person to vanish, and which makes you want to flee as far as possible?

Between individuals of the same or opposite sex who are not lovers, once mutual trust has been psychologically established, physical contact occurs naturally and the parties pay it little special attention. When the relationship remains distant, however, physical contact makes at least one party distinctly uncomfortable.

In social settings, therefore, two noteworthy phenomena can be observed.

If you are uncertain whether a man and a woman share an intimate relationship, watch for close-range contact between them. If neither shows any obvious reaction to the reduced distance or to bodily contact, the two evidently accept each other. One should not, of course, conclude that romantic love exists between them.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-13 对触碰厌恶]*

Another situation arises once you have already determined that the relationship is not romantic. If one party then initiates contact—perhaps a light touch on a less sensitive area such as the arm or back—and the other party displays a sensitive negative reaction, most often a slight withdrawal or else freezing in place, the initiator likely harbors improper intentions toward the other. In severe cases the behavior may constitute sexual harassment, as in Figure 5-13.

## 10.2 Whether Breathing Can Be Controlled

Can breathing be controlled by conscious will?

Many people, drawing on personal experience, conclude that it can: respiration can be deliberately strengthened, weakened, or even suspended for extended periods. This conclusion is correct, because most of the muscles responsible for breathing are skeletal muscles, whose movements are subject to voluntary control.

Under normal conditions the body relies primarily on contraction of the diaphragm to draw air in. When the diaphragm contracts, the ribs expand and the abdominal organs move downward, enlarging the thoracic cavity and creating negative pressure that pulls air into the lungs. When the diaphragm relaxes, elastic recoil of the lungs together with the combined action of the pleural membranes and abdominal muscles expels the air. During forceful breathing or respiratory failure, accessory respiratory muscles also assist. When forced exhalation is required, as when blowing out a candle, the abdominal muscles and internal intercostal muscles generate pressure in the abdomen and chest to expel air from the lungs.

Accessory respiratory muscles include the sternocleidomastoid, platysma, and scalene muscles of the neck; the latissimus dorsi and pectoral muscles also function as accessory muscles. All of these are skeletal muscles.

From this perspective, breathing movements can indeed be performed under voluntary control.

Yet who consciously directs every inhalation and exhalation at every moment? If respiration required constant control, a person would die rapidly during sleep or unconsciousness. Even in ordinary social interaction, coherent speech and thought would become impossible, because one would have to issue continuous commands: "Inhale now," "Exhale now."

In fact, breathing can proceed entirely without deliberate volitional control. Automatic respiration is governed by the autonomic nervous system, specifically by centers in the brainstem, medulla oblongata, and pons. These lower and middle brainstem regions form the respiratory control center; cells there regulate breathing movements independently of thought. The respiratory centers comprise the ventral respiratory group, dorsal respiratory group, apneustic center, and pneumotaxic center, all of which can operate without interference or direction from higher cognition.

In addition, when blood carbon-dioxide levels rise, peripheral chemoreceptors in the carotid and aortic bodies and central chemoreceptors in the medulla detect the increase and raise respiratory rate. Exercise, elevated body temperature, adrenaline release, and motor impulses from the brain also increase breathing frequency. These physiological demands automatically engage the respiratory centers, which then adjust respiration without requiring cortical involvement.

This theoretical foundation allows us to infer a person's subjective cognition and feelings from changes in breathing.

[^1]: The diaphragm (English: Thoracic diaphragm) is a thin sheet of skeletal muscle extending across the base of the ribs. It separates the thoracic cavity from the abdominal cavity and performs an essential function in

respiration.

## Criminal Case: Bribery Investigation

Investigators from the anti-corruption bureau of a district under a directly administered municipality examined a bribery case.

The suspect, a technical cadre highly proficient in computer systems and programming, had received numerous national awards. A tip alleged that he had altered technical specifications in bidding documents, improperly awarded the project to the briber's company, and accepted cash in return.

Before formally filing the case, investigators conducted an initial contact interview. In a brief exchange the suspect displayed a repeated territory-freeze-territory-freeze pattern that aligned precisely with the stimuli presented. On the basis of his state, the command room immediately authorized formal interrogation, which ultimately yielded a confession and written statement.

Investigator: "Please describe your position and main work history."

Suspect: "I graduated with a doctorate from University X in year Y, specializing in internet security. After joining the agency I served successively as section chief, deputy division director, and division director, and received several national awards during that period."

While delivering this answer he exhibited a classic territorial response: torso erect, legs spread at nearly 90 degrees, hands braced on knees, forming an expansive upper-body silhouette; speech was fluent and his expression relaxed.

Investigator: "What was your role in Project Z?"

Suspect: "Our division prepared the entire project requirements document; I personally reviewed and approved the technical specifications."

He maintained the previous posture, gaze fixed on the investigator to gauge reactions.

Investigator: "Did you ever modify the final technical standards? If so, why?"

At the question the suspect immediately drew his legs together into a crossed-leg posture, arms encircling his knees in a defensive, tense configuration. His entire body contracted—the hallmark of a freezing response.

Suspect: "Reviewing and amending bidding documents falls within my duties; I did indeed modify several clauses."

Investigator: "Which clauses, and why?"

On this purely technical matter the suspect regained a sense of mastery; his legs again opened beyond 90 degrees, torso straightened and leaned forward, and he launched into a fluent, lengthy explanation of each standard's meaning and the reasons for change—an unmistakable territorial display.

When professionals discuss their specialty they can always construct tighter logic than outsiders. Pursuing such points often impedes investigative progress and risks inflating the suspect's sense of control and confidence, creating obstacles for later work.

The investigator interrupted: “Do you know Mr. A (general manager of the briber’s company)? Have you had any private financial dealings with him?”

The suspect again contracted into a freezing posture, this time with knees and ankles pressed together and torso bent forward—an expression of rapid internal shift to fear.

Subsequent confession statements and physical evidence confirmed that he had indeed accepted bribes and committed a crime.

## 6.1 Upward-Gaze Response

In human consciousness, anything perceived as larger than oneself elicits upward gaze and reverence.

In ancient times, large carnivores held an advantage in both hunting and combat; the same fangs and claws inflicted far greater injury or death when wielded by a massive opponent. Within early human groups, taller hunters more readily secured large prey to share with kin, thereby improving group survival. Towering ancient trees and sheer cliffs fashioned by nature further impressed primitive humans with overwhelming awe and a sense of mysterious, unreachable power.

Size therefore represented the unattainable and mysterious; size represented absolute superiority in struggle.

These generational memories of survival and death gradually became deeply imprinted in human consciousness. After the rise of civilization, building size corresponded to the owner’s status; imperial palaces of every era and culture were vast and imposing, and wealthy modern individuals share a common preference—ever-larger houses and longer, larger cars as visible proof of strength.

In cultural ideology, religious icons meant to be worshipped by the populace were likewise imagined and sculpted at enormous scale. The *Sutra on Contemplation of Amitayus* describes Amitayus Buddha as “having a body the color of the gold of the Jambudvipa river in the Yama heaven, measuring sixty trillion nayutas of yojanas in height, with a white tuft of hair between the eyebrows curling to the right like five Mount Sumeru, eyes pure as the clear waters of the four great oceans, and light emanating from every pore like Mount Sumeru.”

“Nayuta” denotes an Indian unit of ten billion or one trillion; “yojana” equals roughly thirty to forty Chinese li (approximately 16 km). Readers may calculate for themselves how immense the Indian imagination made the Buddha—essentially “inaccessibly tall.” The intent behind such iconography was to render the Buddha utterly unlike ordinary people through sheer height, thereby inspiring reverence.

The Leshan Giant Buddha, the colossal wooden Buddha at Beijing’s Yonghe Temple, and the Bamiyan Buddhas of Afghanistan (later destroyed by the Taliban) exemplify this tradition of gigantic statues. Standing before them, ordinary people must “look upward to see the full figure,” and a feeling of awe arises naturally.

Yet the *Diamond Sutra* records Shakyamuni’s own words: “All phenomena are illusory; to see phenomena as non-phenomena is to see the Tathagata.” In other words, one must disregard size and beauty alike. If accomplished Buddhist practitioners required height or weight to command upward gaze, something would be amiss.

Although thousands of years of civilization have witnessed countless instances of the weak prevailing over the strong and the small overcoming the large, these examples do not overturn the human tendency to look upward at height. On an individual level, however, ordinary people differ little in stature.



The subconscious principle that “taller is superior” therefore prompts people to present themselves as taller when competing.

## 4.1 The Mechanism of the Freezing Response

Carnivores must eat meat; the weak are eaten. One side must pursue and strike, the other must dodge and flee.

Both hunter and prey are acutely sensitive to moving objects—an ability honed through prolonged life-and-death struggles. Animals’ keen sensory organs integrate sound, sight, scent, and even air currents to detect motion. Only thus can predators locate escaping quarry and prey detect an approaching hunter.

Frogs represent an extreme of this evolutionary adaptation: their eyes can precisely calculate the trajectory of a flying or leaping insect and capture it, yet they ignore stationary insects; when surrounded by fresh dead flies they starve because they cannot eat motionless prey.

A gazelle grazing peacefully on a sun-baked savanna suddenly senses a subtle shift in air movement accompanied by the faint scent of a carnivore. It immediately halts all motion, raises its head (where most sensory organs are concentrated), and uses eyes, nose, ears, and every hair to assess:

- Is there danger?
- What kind of animal poses the threat?
- How many are there?
- How fast are they moving?
- How far away are they?
- Can the group ensure my safety?
- Must I flee or fight?
- Which escape route avoids ambush?

...

All these questions must be answered within roughly one second (animals rely less on conscious thought for such judgments), or the gazelle may end up in a predator’s stomach<|eos|>

## The Mouth Can Lie, But the Body Doesn't

Words are not humanity’s most basic form of expression and communication; body language is the most common and fundamental way humans express and communicate. To understand emotional displays beyond words, one must recognize non-verbal cues such as posture, movement, facial expression, clothing, and tone of voice, then interpret these non-verbal emotions to grasp others’ true intentions and communicate successfully.

When someone speaks in a cheerful tone yet shows no corresponding expression, their words contradict their real feelings. When someone struggles to articulate an idea but displays a sincere and credible look, the difficulty stems only from poor verbal skills. When someone has not yet spoken but already appears furious, they are genuinely angry. When someone speaks haltingly yet cannot hide their anger, they are enduring reluctantly.

These situations already reveal the speaker’s true state of mind, which cannot be concealed; even deliberate attempts at concealment are visible in their expression.

Experienced parents readily detect whether their children are lying; when a child labors to fabricate a story, their body and eyes have already betrayed them.

In daily life you have certainly encountered this: despite someone offering many reasons and arguments, you remain unconvinced. Someone pours out a litany of hardships to persuade you of their bitter and sorrowful circumstances—yet you do not believe them. Someone deliberately boasts in front of you about how well they are doing—yet you remain skeptical. Someone loudly declares how much they like and appreciate a gift you gave—yet you read a different message in their eyes.

Why is this? They have supplied so many reasons, yet you still do not believe them. The real cause is that their body is sending entirely different signals; through their body language you detect the lie.

In everyday interactions and information exchange, 80 percent of communication occurs through body language rather than words. Therefore, accurately reading body language is essential.

Familiarity with body language enables clearer expression of one's own intentions. In interpersonal exchanges, one must both convey meaning through body language and accurately perceive and respond to the body-language signals of others.

Reading others' body language is a key method and skill for discerning emotions. Mastery of this skill allows quick, accurate judgment of another person's emotional state and provides material for analyzing one's own past misjudgments, thereby accumulating rich life experience.

### 5.1.2 Disgust-Based Evasion

Unlike fear-based evasion, disgust-based evasion reflects the actor's non-acceptance and rejection from a position of perceived superiority. Although the person may objectively be constrained and remain in a weaker position, their inner attitude is one of disgust—an evaluation of "top-down negation."

Evasion movements prompted by disgust are typically slow and deliberate; the person dares to face the stimulus source directly with gaze, torso, and the angle of the legs. Fear-based evasion lacks this frontal courage.

The most classic fear-based evasion features are easy to spot: after an effective negative stimulus, the distance between the subject's head and the stimulus increases while the body's support points remain unchanged.

The first type is obvious: during conversation, when the exchange becomes disagreeable and further communication feels impossible, the body leans back indignantly (note: not necessarily driven by anger) against the chair back.

Many people cannot distinguish whether leaning back signals relaxation or disgust.

Leaning against the chair back in disgust differs clearly from leaning back in comfort and control: the difference lies in the degree of overall relaxation. When leaning back in disgust, even if the torso is not exerting force (unlike relaxation), other body parts (such as the legs) and especially the facial expression remain stiff and tense. This reaction indicates that the subject has received an effective negative stimulus and is experiencing reluctant anger, dissatisfaction, contempt, or disdain; the emotion drives them away from the stimulus to reduce psychological discomfort, much like moving away from an unpleasant odor.

The second type is less complete; the observable reaction may be only a slight backward lean of the torso while the head has already moved away from the stimulus, as shown in Figure 5-7.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-7 躯干后仰]

This evasion reaction is interesting because the subject often tries to mask their true feelings—negation or disgust—by adding other expressions and lines, a classic pattern. For example, two people discussing a favorite idol: one says “I like XXX,” and the other may perform this slight evasion movement, leaning back slightly, eyes either meeting or avoiding the speaker’s gaze, while maintaining a smile and saying, “Oh, really? I think he/she is pretty good too.” The verbal appearance of agreement contradicts the bodily evasion reaction; this is a typical social lie that prevents the conversation from ending unpleasantly over a trivial matter.

Genuine agreement would look like the revolutionary-film scene: stepping forward, two hands clasping and shaking vigorously while exclaiming, “Finally found my people!” Younger people might lean their heads even closer, eyes sparkling with excitement, and begin discussing details about the idol.

## 7.4 Spatial Taboos

In many situations, a dominant individual within their own territory may approach anyone inside that territory at will, and the approached person, by virtue of subordinate status, will not or dare not object; this stems from the authority the dominant person holds inside the territory. Conversely, if someone approaches or intrudes upon the territory the occupant mentally claims, the act is perceived as a strong provocation that triggers displeasure or even retaliation.

The most extreme example involves China’s ancient imperial administrative system. The rules governing the emperor’s residence were extremely strict. The emperor could roam freely inside the palace, yet clear regulations dictated who could enter or leave and where each person was required to remain. The key point is that accidental violation of these rules could result in severe punishment. Unauthorized entry into the palace was said to carry grave consequences (the author is not a professional historian; this point awaits verification).

The other side of the same coin is that the emperor could grant “permission to ride horseback inside the Forbidden City” as a reward to ministers. Allowing a minister to walk, ride, or be carried in a sedan chair inside the emperor’s domain expressed closeness and trust.

As Reginald Johnston, tutor to the last Qing emperor Puyi, described in *Twilight in the Forbidden City*: “The side gate on the west was kept open daily for those permitted to enter at stated times—princes, imperial tutors, and ministers of the Imperial Household. All who entered the Forbidden City had to walk unless they had received the special grace of ‘riding horseback inside the Forbidden City’ or ‘being carried in a sedan chair inside the Forbidden City.’ Dr. R. K. Douglas remarked that within this sacred precinct the grant of ‘riding horseback inside the Forbidden City’ was the highest honor an emperor could bestow on a minister. Yet ‘being carried in a sedan chair inside the Forbidden City’ was an even greater honor. These privileges were sometimes awarded temporarily for major court ceremonies; those who enjoyed them permanently were more highly regarded. They hung wooden plaques bearing the imperial grant above their residence gates. Most princes and a few other imperial clansmen received the sedan-chair privilege; their sons and lower-ranking clansmen received the horseback privilege. Imperial tutors, holding high status, were frequently granted the sedan-chair privilege.”

This description illustrates, through the most extreme administrative system, how important the leader’s authority inside the territory remains. Inside a superior’s office, the superior may walk up to you or stand behind you without hesitation or concern; as a subordinate you must not move about freely, nor is it

permissible to enter the office uninvited, let alone walk behind the superior's desk or stand beside the superior—an act generally regarded as incomprehensible and reckless.

Therefore, one must sometimes refrain from crossing the red line in a leader's mind; such details can determine one's continued presence or even survival.

### 9.2.3 Long-Term Suppression

After defeat, individuals develop a lowered self-perception; the nervous system enters a suppressed yet hypersensitive state. Fearing further injury, they habitually maintain a subordinate and defensive posture for an extended period. The downward-gaze response discussed in Chapter 6, which signals respect and compliance, lacks this accumulated sensitivity and habitual quality that follows defeat.

#### Test Case

A category of seemingly successful individuals that requires careful handling in daily life

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-13 长期的压抑]*

Among the subjects we tested was a seemingly successful doctoral student enrolled at a top domestic research institution in a highly regarded specialty; only a dozen or so students nationwide pursued the same doctoral track (indicating the field's elite status and future demand). The individual was also strict with himself, highly self-disciplined, passionate about various sports, and accustomed to pushing personal limits; he loved life, kept a packed schedule filled with meaningful activities, and was considered warm and reliable by friends.

The test topic was romantic psychology and behavioral patterns. Throughout the testing process this apparently high-quality subject maintained one consistent posture: chin slightly lowered, eyes slightly upturned when looking at others, as shown in Figure 9-13.

He also habitually kept a very slight forward hunch; when encountering negative stimuli he deliberately straightened his posture in an attempt to project strength. In our pre-test analysis we concluded that this was a person with deep-seated feelings of inferiority. His persistence and rigor in sports were attempts to compensate for inner insecurity by continually strengthening his physical condition—an approach bordering on obsession. If the stimulus proved effective, embarrassment, anger, or shame were highly likely to appear.

The test results fully confirmed our preliminary analysis. This doctoral student, outstanding in many respects, had experienced repeated romantic failures, each time ended by the woman. Long-term romantic setbacks had rendered him sensitive and self-deprecating; lacking proper channels to learn how to handle emotional communication barriers, he compensated through obsessive behavior in other areas.

Thus, prolonged feelings of failure can produce the following habitual posture: head slightly lowered (chin tucked), eyes slightly upturned when looking at others, body not erect, limbs tending to contract, movements rather constrained rather than natural.

Because such individuals are easily stimulated and tend to interpret neutral stimuli subjectively as negative, they should be handled with care in daily life.

### 3. Verbal Blocking

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-23 嘴唇的阻挡反应 (偷乐) ]*

Mouth-blocking reactions are mostly directed at one's own speech. A common example is "covering the mouth while stealing a laugh," as shown in Figure 8-23. Such an obvious display is a classic case of trying to hide what is already evident; everyone can see the person is laughing. What interests us more is the psychological motivation behind the reaction, which is quite intriguing.

The psychological sequence of this smile-blocking reaction is as follows:

- ① The person genuinely finds something funny at first;
- ② Then realizes they should not laugh so openly—either to spare the target embarrassment, to avoid criticism for gloating, or because long-standing upbringing and etiquette prohibit excessive display;
- ③ Finally covers the mouth with a hand to project restraint and composure.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-24 嘴唇的阻挡反应 (捂嘴) ]

Covering the mouth while crying is also a blocking reaction; its psychological motivation is relatively simple: to prevent grief from overflowing, to restrain oneself, and to reduce the spread of a sorrowful atmosphere, as shown in Figure 8-24.

Although both reactions map to very straightforward meanings and require little interpretive effort, they are typical examples of social behavior suppressing emotional behavior and help us understand the analytical method for all micro-reactions (微反应).

Another mouth-blocking behavior is more valuable for lie detection: covering the mouth with a hand while speaking, as if to stop the words from continuing.

- ① If the movement occurs before speaking begins, the person is unwilling to say it;
- ② If it occurs mid-sentence, with sudden cessation and hand over the mouth, it indicates a slip of the tongue or regret that the words "should not have been said";
- ③ If it occurs after finishing a statement and looks like wiping the mouth or accompanies a cough, it actually signals negation of one's own words—the person is denying what they just said.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-25 挡嘴]

This reaction has only two possible explanations: either the person accidentally let the truth slip out (usually accompanied by a startled breath hold, widened eyes, and a freeze response), or the person is unconsciously correcting a lie and usually pretends to remain calm, as shown in Figure 8-25.

### 3. Enhanced Exhalation as Relaxation

After experiencing intense pressure, if the person emerges unscathed or confirms that danger has passed, they relieve bodily and nervous tension through a pronounced exhalation, usually a voiced "whew" through the mouth.

We conducted an experiment with students. Ten playing cards—A, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, J, Q, K—each of a single random suit were used. Subjects drew one card at random and memorized it. Testers then asked rapid-fire questions in random order ("Is it the ace?" "Is it the king?" etc.). Micro-reactions were analyzed to determine which card had been drawn.

Although the experiment offered neither reward nor punishment, some students became highly nervous; when asked about the card they held, they displayed clear eye and mouth reactions that allowed testers to

"guess" the card correctly. The experiment's purpose was to test the sensitivity threshold of the interrogation method. Overall accuracy was admittedly not high, but this is normal for a no-pressure test.

Even this standard no-pressure test, however, produced one consistent reaction in most subjects: nearly everyone exhaled a long sigh of relief once the questioning ended, relaxing the nervous system that had been on guard. When the result was announced, those correctly identified reacted with widened eyes, open mouth, and an involuntary "Huh?!" (subtext: "No way?"). Those not identified smiled smugly.

The reason is that no one wants their reactions to betray their true thoughts inadvertently; hence the psychological pressure of being challenged during the test.

Note that, unlike other comfort behaviors, humming, whistling, or the accompanying breathing is not an avoidance tactic but a relaxation response that generally appears after the subject senses danger has passed.

When danger approaches, people inhale deeply to store energy for flight or fight; once danger recedes, they exhale fully to relax the nerves and prepare for rest. Therefore, during testing, several questions can be inserted that allow the subject to feel they have passed smoothly (for example, "We believe you had no opportunity to cheat at that time"). Observing the resulting reactions can reveal the stimuli that concern the subject and yield valuable clues.

### 6.2.2 Deformation of High-Low Positioning — Drinking Culture

In Chinese drinking culture, there is a very interesting phenomenon.

At the drinking table, especially when the people present differ in status, the person of lower status usually clinks glasses against the lower part of the higher-status person's cup. The higher-status person accepts this positioning gesture calmly and tacitly. The greater the difference between the two, the larger the vertical gap between the rims of the cups. If both parties are being especially polite, they may even compete to lower their glasses further, as though they will not clink until one has clearly gone lower than the other.

This is a deformed form of the high-low positioning described earlier and also an expression of the looking-up reaction.

## 6.3 Different Meanings of Four Handshake Methods

When the two parties are relatively equal in social attributes such as identity and status, the arrogant or submissive micro-reactions described in the previous two sections are less likely to appear. More common are reactions that express mutual respect and reciprocity.

Nodding is a common greeting gesture. Nodding is actually a reduced version of the bowing reaction that signals respect and obedience; both the duration and the amplitude of the movement are smaller. For this reason, the original meaning of nodding is to indicate recognition or respect for the other person, yet without a pronounced sense of hierarchy.

The origin of the handshake is even more interesting. The original handshake was not a gesture of courtesy but a way to prove that neither party was holding a weapon, allowing both sides to talk without fear of sudden violence.

This custom is unlikely to have originated in China's long feudal era. Feudal society had two major characteristics: first, a strict and explicit hierarchy meant that the two parties who needed to use etiquette almost always stood in a superior-inferior relationship, so the possibility of armed conflict was low; when

violence did occur, it was between rulers and resisters, an adversarial relationship that did not require polite gestures. Second, etiquette was elaborate and thoroughly instilled through formal education; it was used to express absolute obedience and reverence from subordinates to superiors. A simple action would not have sufficed to convey one's intentions. Even between peers of the same class, people would ceremoniously perform a full bow (involving head, spine, and hands together) to express harmony. Therefore, the handshake more likely appeared in ancient Western societies that lacked such complex social stratification.

In real life, a handshake is a subtle matter. Especially between strangers, the first handshake can yield additional information.

#### 4.4 Startled First, Then Afraid

Remaining still allows information to be gathered and reduces traces; contracting reduces injury.

When danger appears and the source or location of harm is still uncertain, the body's immediate reaction is not to flee but to freeze in place and adopt a contracted posture.

For example, when amateur players scramble for a rebound in basketball, if the ball suddenly threatens to hit someone, that person's instinctive reaction is not to run away—because there is no clear direction to run. Instead, the person lowers the head, hunches the back, and freezes, afraid to move. The worry is that any movement might expose a more vulnerable spot (such as the back of the head); it is safer to stay put and risk only the back or buttocks.

Many other bodily freeze reactions serve the same purpose of avoiding greater harm; this book will not list them all.

The same freeze reaction also occurs when the mind receives an unexpected stimulus, even in the absence of physical danger.

Rumors of layoffs had been intensifying, and there was even talk that an entire department would be eliminated because of a capital acquisition.

When the department head walked into the office with a grim expression, everyone held their breath and fixed their eyes on him.

He took out a list and slowly read several names.

The people whose names were called turned pale and froze in place, unable to move. Others sighed with relief or waited anxiously for more information.

The head continued: "You few, pack your things and report to the marketing department today. The rest of the colleagues, including myself, are all dismissed. Go to finance to collect  $n+4$  compensation. I'm sorry, everyone—I did my best."

The situation reversed instantly. Everyone who had just relaxed, including the employees who had been reassigned, froze in place, unsure what to do next.

From this we propose an important hypothesis: the stronger the unexpected stimulus, the greater the amplitude and duration of the freeze reaction; the two are directly proportional.

However, stimuli of this magnitude do not occur every day in real life, so reactions of this obviousness are not the focus of this book—unless a test subject receives an extremely strong stimulus during testing and also has

relatively poor psychological resilience.

The freeze reactions that truly matter during testing are almost always relatively subtle, localized freezes.

### 7.3 Flourish — My Territory, My Rules

To be a leader, one must have the ability to lead others toward happiness—whether by bringing in more prey or by accomplishing more tasks. Otherwise, why would anyone follow?

Stripping away all formalities and complex modern rules, achieving results simply requires strength (thinking power and action power).

Therefore, in a state of active control, the most common expression is flourish: issuing commands that are short and forceful. This includes language, actions, and even gaze. A person with a sense of control minimizes the time spent on command forms. On one hand, this leaves no room for questioning and demands 100 percent execution, smoothing the execution process and raising team efficiency. On the other hand, it reduces the leader's own energy expenditure, because internal friction is unnecessary when many external matters still require attention.

In language, the style is concise, favoring imperative sentences and often omitting the subject, beginning directly with the verb. Words that can be omitted are omitted; the omitted content is expected to be understood through tacit agreement.

#### **In actions**

The amplitude is usually not large—quick, medium-to-small movements that are mostly unidirectional and pointing, such as chopping, slashing, slapping, pointing, or tapping. Unlike the fighting actions described in Chapter 9, these directional movements do not deliver force; they are relatively casual.

When the identity and status gap between the two parties is large, the leader may use small gestures to reinforce the difference—for example, pointing with only the index finger or using a slight movement of the chin to convey certain intentions.

The chin also has a pointing function, but this pointing is never used in relationships that should express respect, admiration, or obedience, because chin-pointing always carries a trace of contempt and self-satisfied arrogance.

Even in today's open society, its use is limited to interactions with very close friends, nodding acquaintances with no stake involved, or initial encounters where no interests are yet at stake. Of course, the top-down directive intent remains consistent, because such small movements allow the leader to avoid raising a hand, saving effort while still feeling a strong sense of control.

If used toward a superior, an elder, or anyone else who should be respected, pointing with a slightly raised chin will ultimately harm the person doing it.

### 5.2.1 Four Types of Psychological Distance

Emotional closeness is expressed through physical proximity.

This awareness is very similar to the territorial awareness of wild animals: people allow those they accept to approach, even actively moving closer themselves, while keeping those they dislike at a safe distance, as though sensing potential harm.



According to the research of American anthropologist Dr. Hall, the physical distance between people reflects their psychological distance and can be roughly divided into four categories:

1. **Public space:** This distance applies to people who do not know each other. Dr. Hall defined it as beyond 3.7 meters. The American style relies on large amounts of statistical data to demonstrate scientific rigor. However, this definition no longer fits an overcrowded planet. Strangers on the street may brush past you, not because you consciously accept them entering your public distance, but simply because the situation does not matter to you.
2. **Social distance:** This distance is widely used in formal social activities such as office work, meetings, and business interactions. Dr. Hall defined it as 1.2–3.7 meters.
3. **Personal distance:** This distance is common between friends, acquaintances, or relatives. Dr. Hall defined it as between 46 centimeters and 1.22 meters.
4. **Intimate distance:** This distance reflects very close relationships, ranging from no distance (0 centimeters) to 46 centimeters. People allow those with whom they have close relationships—spouses, lovers, owners and pets, or very close friends—into this range. The only situation in which a stranger may enter intimate distance is for professional health care or diagnosis.

The conclusions of this classification cannot be experimentally verified or falsified, but the underlying logic is worth adopting. In real life, people do in fact manage their interpersonal distances according to these categories, even if the exact numbers vary slightly.

## (1) Circulation and Energy Reserves

Fleeing requires a large expenditure of energy.

When a person runs, the entire body participates in movement, especially the legs. The muscle groups in the legs consume a great deal of energy. This energy comes from the oxidation of stored sugars and inhaled oxygen in the body (endurance energy also comes from the oxidation of fats and proteins). Therefore, to flee, at least two biologically necessary preparations must be made: breathing (see Chapter 10: Breathing Reactions) and blood circulation (to transport energy substances).

### ① Facial color

We often hear descriptions such as "his face turned white with fright." How does fear make the face pale?

This is a typical reaction during the preparation-to-flee stage. Once the subject receives a negative stimulus and experiences a high-intensity emotion such as fear, blood circulation automatically diverts more blood away from other parts of the body and toward the legs used for running. Facial skin is exposed and directly observable. When normal circulation changes (reduced blood flow), the reduction in blood color becomes clearly visible. This is the principle behind the common expression "scared pale." At the same time, the increased blood in the legs produces muscle tension and excitement, sometimes visible as slight trembling.

### ② Body temperature and other effects

Similarly, abnormal blood circulation not only reduces blood color but also triggers a chain of sensations: accelerated heartbeat (to speed blood transport), lowered surface temperature (due to blood being withdrawn), mental blankness and slowed reactions (reduced oxygen consumption by the central nervous system), and increased speech interruptions (also an oxygen-deprivation response).

### ③ Practical application

The reactions described above mainly map to the emotion of fear. When a person encounters a frightening negative stimulus, the nervous system generates fear. The primary function of fear is to adjust the body's energy distribution—including blood and breathing—to prepare to flee the stimulus source, as far as possible.

During testing, if the subject shows any of these reaction indicators, it can be judged that their psychological state toward the stimulus source is one of fear and a decision to escape. It can therefore be inferred that the stimulus source is effective for the subject and can serve as a clue for further extraction of valuable information.

## 8.4 Exceptions for Professionals

The attack and defense reactions described in this chapter apply to ordinary people; professionals are excluded.

People who have received systematic combat training and mastered fighting techniques possess extremely high control over their limbs, rich real combat experience, and psychological stability. They are unlikely to display fear or pre-fight agitation. Even when anger arises, they immediately enter a professional-level combat-ready state.

Earlier in this chapter we discussed how a person whose territory is invaded will straighten the body in a defensive display. This reaction occurs before combat and is intended to make the opponent back down. However, a professionally trained person, before initiating action (after the display phase), does not keep the torso fully upright for protection; instead, it is slightly curved, attempting to shield the chest and abdomen.

The ready stance of professional Sanda is described in textbooks as follows:

- ① Foot position: feet separated front and back, the distance between the front heel and the rear toe is one-and-a-half foot lengths; the lateral distance between the feet is slightly wider than shoulder width; the front toes turn slightly inward, the rear toes point diagonally forward, and the rear heel is slightly lifted (for stability and quick movement);
- ② Arm angles and positions: both arms naturally bent, the angle between left and right arms approximately 90 degrees; the left fist placed in front of the body slightly below eye level, knuckles facing diagonally forward, fist eye facing diagonally upward; the angle between the right arms should be less than 90 degrees, the right fist placed in front of the right ribs slightly above the lower jaw, elbow about one fist's distance from the body (can advance to attack or retreat to defend);
- ③ Torso posture: left shoulder and left abdomen side facing the opponent, chest slightly tucked, abdomen slightly drawn in, upper body leaning slightly forward, head slightly lowered, chin tucked, teeth clenched, lips closed, eyes looking forward. (Protects the vulnerable chest and abdomen from direct attack while maintaining high alertness.)

Of course, untrained people in combat will not necessarily be so precise; they easily make mistakes such as striking wherever they feel like, focusing only on offense, and lacking defensive awareness.

The points described in item 3 above are all combat reactions worth noting in micro-reaction research.

In addition, their striking movements display numerous professional characteristics, including energy allocation and limb coordination. Therefore, the standards described in this book cannot be applied wholesale when observing and testing them.

## 1. Visual Escape

Chapter 3 mentioned the visual comfort reaction: when the subject feels discomfort, the gaze shifts elsewhere to reduce intake of negative stimuli and obtain relief. In terms of gaze change alone, the visual comfort reaction and the visual escape reaction look very similar and are almost impossible to distinguish. Yet the underlying psychological states and motivations are completely different. The purpose of visual comfort is to reduce reception of negative stimuli so that nervous-system pressure stops increasing; it is relatively passive and can be expressed colloquially as "I don't want to look anymore." Visual escape, by contrast, is the worry that excessive visual contact will trigger new negative stimuli; it can be understood as "afraid of being seen through," a relatively active measure. See Figure 5-8.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-8 视觉逃离]*

The greatest difference between the two is that the visual comfort reaction always moves away from the negative stimulus source to seek positive visual information, such as a trusted person; the visual escape reaction does not necessarily move the gaze away from the negative stimulus source—often it is simply the subject's autonomous reaction of not wanting to be noticed or seen through. In appearance, visual escape more often manifests as "gaze drifting," which can generally be read as a sign of guilt.

One example:

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-9 视觉逃离]*

When a person who has completed a task by luck receives praise from a leader, they will usually look away from the leader's kind, caring gaze. It looks like modesty and composure, yet the heart is pounding and the person is inwardly thinking "I'm ashamed," as in Figure 5-9.

Imagine, however, that the task was completed only after immense hardship, even at the cost of health or life (a brother's). In that case, receiving praise from the leader is unlikely to produce gaze drift; instead, the person is more likely to stand tall with head raised, full of tragic, heroic resolve.

Therefore, the psychological state of visual escape is shame or guilt—an attempt to reduce attention to oneself by averting the gaze and thereby prevent any deeper probing that might follow.

## 2. Care and Concern

Dr. Hall has pointed out, "The only possible intimate distance between strangers occurs in the context of professional health care and diagnosis." If an observer notes a very close distance between doctor and patient, or between teacher and student, it should not be interpreted as the result of emotional intimacy but rather as an expression of care arising from role or duty.

This principle can also be applied in reverse: by using caring behaviors and proximity-controlled responses, one can create a sense of being cared for and protected in the other party, thereby accelerating the building of trust.

Usually, most people try to convey their intentions through verbal expression and to signal "please trust me." Yet everyone understands that language can conceal multiple motives, so verbal "declarations" are easiest for the speaker but hardest for the listener to accept.

At such moments, actions and distance control can serve as the primary means, supplemented by verbal expression, to speed the establishment of trust. For example, on a reasonable relational basis, one might take

a small step forward when handing over documents or coffee; when walking alongside someone, move slightly closer so that shoulders occasionally touch or arms lightly brush, rather than trailing at an angle that creates a “being watched” feeling; when speaking, if conditions allow, bring mouth and head close to the other person’s ear for a low-volume statement, and so on. These seemingly casual approaches allow the other person to sense an increase in intimacy without realizing it; when the content of the exchange also aligns on benefits and risks, the building of intimacy is greatly enhanced.

Care must be taken, however, not to overuse the technique. Casually closing distance with a superior or with an unfamiliar person of the opposite sex can be perceived as presumptuous and may damage the relationship instead. Two prerequisites must be kept firmly in mind: first, all such attempts must occur “on a reasonable relational basis”; second, the situation or occasion must permit active trust-building. The methods may be used in contexts such as criminal interrogation, customer service, or negotiation and cooperation, but they must not be employed when strict protocol is required—hierarchical, solemn, or coldly formal settings—otherwise they may cause serious trouble.

## Test Case

### Psychology Professional Challenges Micro-reaction Test (微反应测试)

During our early testing, one participant—a master’s graduate in psychology—agreed to take the test while holding a skeptical attitude toward our research and intending to use his professional knowledge to “crack” it. Consequently, when we met, although he voiced polite words, his chin remained slightly raised throughout, his handshake was perfunctory, and the moment he sat down he adopted a provocative posture with legs spread wide, torso relaxed against the chair in a classic posture of control.

Testing began with a baseline assessment consisting of questions we had designed around psychology research topics. Because the questions were highly specialized and referenced the views of earlier scholars with richness and accuracy, the participant involuntarily drew his legs back into a normal sitting posture and straightened his upper body to engage seriously with the examiners. The remainder of the test proceeded smoothly.

After reviewing the full test analysis report, he expressed approval of the research and a willingness to participate further.

The most relaxed appearance is one of complete unconcern, devoid of any social behavior.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 7-9 Buddha statue in serene form conveying superiority]*

Readers may examine various Buddha statues and observe that most display expressionless faces with eyes half-open (or half-closed), as in Figure 7-9. This is precisely the appearance appropriate to absolute superiority.

When a superior possesses absolute authority, issuing instructions or commands to subordinates rarely produces the arrogant reactions described earlier; instead, the superior more often exhibits calm and silent majesty. This is not mere self-importance but the genuine possession of life-and-death power. Such a person need not expend personal energy to push or urge subordinates; smooth operation relies entirely on institutional mechanisms or personal cult, so the face remains calm, largely expressionless, and the eyes are usually not fully open—the upper eyelids often cover part of the eyeballs.

## (2) Postural Adjustment for Escape

The escape-preparation reactions discussed earlier remain at the preparatory stage and are still far from actual escape movements, making them easy to overlook. By comparison, postural adjustment is a more noticeable form of escape preparation.

### ① **Sitting Posture Adjustment**

Crossing the legs is a relatively comfortable sitting posture (here we refer only to its comfort aspect; crossed legs may also indicate a defensive state, which must be judged in context—see Chapter 9, “Attack and Combat”). The posture of leaning far back in a chair with legs crossed is especially indicative of relaxation and a sense of control. Such a posture makes rising to flee difficult.

Using this posture as a starting point, if the subject encounters an effective negative stimulus, the crossed legs may immediately be uncrossed and the feet placed one in front of the other (not together) while the torso straightens, as though something has been noticed.

If the subject’s emotion at that moment is tension, fear, or embarrassment (note the absence of surprise or anger), the eyes will not fix on the stimulus source (surprise and anger would produce fixation); instead, the subject will quietly scan the entire testing environment in search of a possible escape route. If the subject lacks sufficient composure or if the stimulus is intense, the hands may also press down on the chair arms—or on the seat itself if there are no arms—as though fearing that leg power alone will not allow a fast enough escape, since pushing with the hands enables quicker rising.

### ② **Standing Posture Adjustment**

In a standing position, when a negative stimulus prompts preparation to flee, the legs assume a clear configuration: one foot placed forward and the other back, both oriented toward the stimulus source, rather than both feet facing it simultaneously. Geometrically, the plane defined by the two legs runs parallel to (or at a very small acute angle with) the plane formed by the subject and the stimulus source; the two planes never intersect at a right angle. This posture permits either advance or retreat and signals readiness to escape.

## 2. Obvious Escape

Once preparations are complete, actual flight follows.

Note that in real polygraph examinations and interrogations, escape-preparation reactions and escape reactions seldom appear in strict sequence; in the great majority of cases they occur separately (for example, only a deep inhalation without bodily movement).

In the course of survival, fleeing from danger is a common strategy. Over long periods of evolution, numerous instinctive leg and foot movements arising from anxiety (worry or fear) have accumulated. For instance, when my son was about two years old he would already stamp his feet and shout when he urgently wanted something; no one taught him this stamping behavior—it is purely innate—whereas the shout “Give it to me!” was something I consciously taught him so that he could express his needs in kindergarten. Adults, too, when worried, often pace back and forth unconsciously.

Legs and feet are farthest from the brain; apart from walking and running, ordinary people cannot finely control the use of leg power without specialized practice such as taekwondo kicking techniques. Consequently, actions performed by this less controllable part of the body are the most honest and credible reflections of psychological state.

After being startled, leaping backward is what we commonly call a “jump scare.” A jump scare never involves a vertical leap or a forward jump; retreat invariably increases distance from the stimulus.

All animals understand that only by increasing distance from the stimulus source can life be preserved. Animals that leapt forward when startled were long ago eliminated by predators and no longer exist on Earth. Humans retain this most primitive yet most rational mechanism, so the response occurs without any need for thought.

A relatively calm and subtle movement is controlled retreat. The subject appears composed while taking a few steps backward—usually half a step or one step—often still smiling; moving more than two steps generally constitutes a loss of composure.

## Speaker and Audience

Speaking before a large audience can indeed be daunting; if the audience shows no interest in what is being said, the situation can become awkward. It is no wonder some people experience stage fright or feel as though they are sitting on pins and needles. To capture the audience’s interest, a speaker must invest considerable time in preparation. Yet no matter how thorough the preparation, during the speech itself the speaker must pay close attention to audience reactions and adjust style as needed to maintain the topic’s appeal.

From the moment one steps onto the platform and begins speaking, one must closely monitor the audience’s “silent” feedback. If any negative behaviors appear, the speaker should insert a story or joke that is easy to follow and likely to draw participation. Audiences generally respond more favorably to a speaker who displays a sense of humor.

As a speaker, pay particular attention to critical gestures from the audience. Individuals making such gestures are usually waiting for something of value. If audience members tilt their heads, they are listening attentively and with interest; if their body language indicates that the explanation is unclear or the speech is dull, the speaker should promptly change approach—for example, by posing a question to the audience. Once those individuals are re-engaged, the speaker can return to the previously unfinished content.

Note that even when the topic is highly interesting, presenting too much information at once can produce a sense of “overload.” Audience members may therefore appear temporarily distracted because their brains cannot absorb additional information.

At such times one may observe their slightly forward-leaning torsos suddenly straighten, bodies shift restlessly, glances alternate between watches and the ceiling or between one another, and eyes finally fix on the exit. When the audience reaches this state, it is worth reflecting on the wisdom of the remark: “Why are you still speaking eloquently after all the audience has left?”

### 8.3.2 The Most Complete Defensive Posture

We conducted an experiment to verify human reaction patterns when facing extreme danger.

Before the experiment, all participants were instructed simply to remain still. Our experimenters then demonstrated the procedure by gently tossing a soccer ball at each participant so that it struck the body. The demonstration was performed in a mild, controlled manner.

Some participants requested a trial of the force; after the trial they stated they could remain motionless. The experiment included rewards and penalties: remaining still and absorbing the impact counted as success and earned the corresponding bonus; any movement counted as failure, and all recorded video and photographic materials were provided to us free of charge for use.

When the participants actually stood in position, however, the balls were thrown with full force and intimidating sound. Not a single participant remained motionless under these conditions.

The experiment was originally intended to demonstrate that even when one intends to stay still, movement occurs upon attack because physiological behavior takes precedence over social behavior. After easily confirming this conclusion, we reviewed the recordings and found that every participant's dodging movement was nearly identical—bending and twisting the torso to create a barrier with the limbs, as shown in Figure 8-18.

More detailed elements included shrugging the shoulders while tucking the head downward, rotating and bending the torso to shield its anterior surface, and raising both hands and one leg to form a protective barrier in front of the torso.

This most complete defensive posture reflects a mindset that can be rendered as: "There is no way to dodge; I must take the hit. Taking a hit and dying (or being injured) is normal; I have no capacity to counterattack."

Thus the most complete defensive posture maps onto the most powerless, non-resistant mentality. When this reaction pattern is observed in an opponent, it indicates that at that moment the person regards himself as the losing side and feels incapable of resistance.

### Anecdotal Case: How to Use Small Talk to Quickly Please the Other Person

Meeting a student one has not seen for a long time offers an opportunity to build a good social relationship through conversation.

Friend: "Long time no see!"

Me: "Indeed! You've put on quite a bit of weight since before."

Friend: "Really?"

As he spoke, his eyes looked downward, he quickly pressed his lips together, lowered his head slightly, and spoke in a softer voice, though he soon regained composure.

Me: "Weight gain is actually a mark of successful people."

Friend: "I really have gained weight."

While saying this, his volume rose, his speech slowed, and his tone became gentle—a typical social reaction.

Me: "Still, I think you've matured a great deal since your school days. I hear you're now handling things independently."

Friend: "Of course. When you saw me back then, I was still a student."

As he said this, his head-lift was pronounced enough to cause a slight backward lean of the torso; his face showed a full smile, his pitch rose suddenly, his speech quickened, and his tone became cheerful.

Although the exchange was simple small talk, the deliberate dip followed by elevation often produces a strong approach effect.

The lip-biting upon hearing the first remark is a classic self-soothing response; the gaze aversion and head-lowering reflect communication interruption triggered by negative emotion; the softer voice indicates a nervous system in a negative state with no resistive energy—signs of a guilty emotion.

In fact, I had no clear memory of whether he had gained weight; I merely noted that most people who maintain good living habits do not wish to become heavier, because weight gain usually signals problems with lifestyle or bodily function.

After I commented on his maturity, the head-lift, slight chin raise, and genuine smile showed that he was pleased with the assessment; his tone also conveyed happiness.

Although such conversational pleasantries do not involve real gains or losses and the stimulus is common and mild, the sequence of negative evaluation followed by praise still elicited clear reactions from the subject.

### 4.3 Fear: Kneeling and Kowtowing for Survival

Chinese ancient etiquette was intricate and complex; special institutions even provided training before an audience with the emperor, because errors in protocol could have grave consequences.

Among the many ancient rituals, the one most familiar to Chinese people is kneeling and kowtowing. Kowtowing, put simply, means kneeling and touching the forehead to the ground. This ritual was once condemned as a feudal remnant and, except for descendants paying respects to elders, has been removed from social etiquette.

In reality, kneeling and kowtowing were not invented as ritual actions; they are evolutionarily produced survival skills—instinctive self-protection movements.

Kneeling, with knees on the ground, lowers the center of gravity and prevents serious injury to the head and torso in the event of an accident, while also rendering escape or attack impossible, leaving only passive waiting. Kowtowing is even more effective: the head is placed directly on the ground (already at its lowest), and the hands are positioned behind the head (an action later possibly refined by ritual) to guard against unexpected danger. This single kneel and kowtow also perfectly conceals the chest, abdomen, and genitals—the most vulnerable areas—avoiding injury to the weakest parts. Such a perfect protective movement could never have been devised by conscious thought; the entire body assumes its maximum contracted posture.

Later, rulers adopted this survival movement and elevated it into ritual for good reason. After all, when a superior stands while a subordinate assumes this posture on the ground, both parties perceive an enormous disparity and accept it as natural. The greater the disparity, the more firmly the social hierarchy is anchored and the easier it is to rule.

One can imagine that when an emperor became angry, the minister being reprimanded would immediately and effortlessly perform the full set of kneeling and kowtowing movements without the emperor needing to utter a single coarse word. Although the action appears to be strict etiquette and utmost respect, it also carries an innate impetus.

## Chapter Summary



Offensive reactions within combat responses map onto the actor's anger and desire to win—expressions of a dominant mentality; defensive reactions map onto avoidance and endurance—expressions of a subordinate mentality.

Combat responses proceed through three stages: combat preparation, combat execution, and defensive protection.

### **Combat Preparation**

The characteristic of combat-preparation reactions is that the actor exerts force in an inconspicuous manner, the target of the force being not an external object but "oneself against oneself." Examples include clenching fists, gripping one's own arms, pressing fingertips forcefully against each other, gritting teeth, tugging at one's own clothing, stomping or grinding the foot, or forcefully squeezing a walnut in one's hand.

### **Combat Execution**

The characteristic of combat-execution reactions is that the subject applies force—either overtly or covertly—to an external object, though the force is seldom aimed directly at the stimulus source. Examples include finger-pointing pokes, knocking on a table, slapping a table, flinging a book, slamming a cup, throwing a phone, or slamming a door. After transformation, these actions lose their obvious offensive meaning and become subtle, yet they still reveal the actor's combative mentality and desire to prevail—an expression of a dominant mentality.

### **Defensive Protection**

The characteristic of defensive-protection reactions is curvature of the torso accompanied by the limbs forming a barrier; the torso also naturally rotates to prevent the stimulus source from directly striking the chest, abdomen, or genital surfaces.

Because a threat to interests is the root cause of anger and fighting spirit, the appearance of anger in a subject indicates that the stimulus source is perceived as threatening. In the specific context of testing, this stimulus source carries great significance and is very likely the very clue that everyone is concerned about and that the subject is desperately trying to conceal.

## **III. Body Posture and Expressions**

Human body posture and expressions are rich and varied. In general, when conveying complete information to the outside world, verbal expression accounts for only 7%, tone accounts for 38%, and the remaining 55% of the information must be conveyed through nonverbal body posture. This shows that body posture language plays a vital role in our daily conversations. It allows emotions to be expressed more directly and intuitively, and changes in posture language reflect fluctuations in a person's inner emotions. It is no exaggeration to say that a single posture or movement can easily reveal the emotional state within.

Psychologists have cited a research finding: during conversation, if you are telling the truth, your body will involuntarily lean toward the other person, hoping they will better understand what you are saying; if you are lying, your body will maintain a certain distance from the other person, and the placement of your feet will also appear unnatural.

It is not difficult to notice that some people like to sit upright and proper. From this posture alone, you can roughly tell that the other person is in a state of deference or tension. If the other person's hands involuntarily make many small movements during conversation, such as repeatedly rubbing their hands, pinching their

fingers, or clutching their arms, it indicates they are in a state of unease and tension. This situation is fairly common during job interviews or meetings between superiors and subordinates.

In addition, you will find that when people express happiness, they skip and jump with light steps. If you notice the other person's steps are heavy and uneven, you should consider whether they have something on their mind, because even if they do not voice their true feelings, body posture language has already "betrayed" them.

### 4.5.3 Facial Rigidity

Freezing of breathing, hands, and feet is a natural and instinctive self-protection response and is relatively reliable for judging whether a person is internally distressed. By comparison, facial reactions are generally much more restrained and incorporate many social behaviors, such as a forced smile or an ashamed smile, making them less valid as judgment criteria.

However, when negative stimuli create excessive pressure, the freezing response can also appear on the face, causing the person to lose the composure of etiquette and cultivation. This manifests as facial muscle rigidity, stiff expression, and lack of variation. During this process, even the most mobile eyes will appear sluggish; although they still move slightly to continue observing and receiving information, they are generally fixed on the source of the negative stimulus while searching for subsequent solutions.

We once tested a young man on his loyalty in love. To increase the pressure of the test situation, his girlfriend was also present. When the man admitted that he had "told others the details of his relationship with XX (girlfriend's name)," the young woman froze on the spot, then displayed immense embarrassment and restrained anger. The most obvious sign was her face: the entire countenance was as still as water, the expression rigid, unsure how to face the situation.

Therefore, if during testing you observe that a stimulus has caused the subject's face to become rigid, it indicates the stimulus is sufficiently effective and that the information contained in the stimulus source is of great concern to the subject. In subsequent testing protocols, this point can be targeted for breakthrough to obtain more useful information.

## 10.1 The Physiological Role of Breathing

Oxygen is an essential substance for maintaining human life activities. Cells release chemical energy by oxidizing and breaking down carbohydrates, proteins, or fats to support all life activities, including neural activity and muscle movement. The process of breathing involves inhaling oxygen and exhaling metabolic byproducts such as carbon dioxide, thereby ensuring a continuous supply of energy within the body.

Whether it is the nervous system, the motor system, or other physiological activities, the more active and excited these activities are, the greater the objective demand for oxygen. Because the body's oxygen consumption rises sharply, blood oxygen concentration falls and carbon dioxide concentration in the blood rises; both conditions stimulate the respiratory center, which issues commands to the respiratory muscles, causing breathing to deepen and accelerate—that is, increasing respiratory rate and amplitude. This achieves greater oxygen intake to ensure energy supply for physiological activities. Increased oxygen intake can occur through a single deep inhalation, an increased frequency of inhalation, or both simultaneously.

For example, during intense exercise or loss of emotional control, a person will breathe rapidly in large gulps. In more restrained behavior, however, deep, prolonged breathing is more common. Outwardly, the person

may show no obvious movement or expression changes, and even the volume and frequency of speech may remain unchanged, yet the careful, deep breathing can reveal a controlled confrontational mindset.

Thus, whenever we observe any form of increased breathing, we can conclude that the person's body is becoming excited; if control is present, we can further infer their intent to conceal or resist.

## Chapter Summary

Observing territorial responses indicates that the other person has adopted a dominant and controlling mindset, appearing very confident and in command, with strong pressure tolerance.

### Expansion

Daring to expand and stretch the limbs, especially widening the angle between the arms or between the legs, means the person is willing to expose the most vulnerable parts of the torso—chest, abdomen, and genitals—to incoming pressure and stimuli, even believing that no negative stimuli will enter the expanded area. This is a very dominant mindset, a sign of confidence and control.

When the person facing you spreads their arms or, while seated, widens the angle of their legs, it signals a dominant mindset.

### Relaxation

Within their own territory, the territory holder possesses a strong sense of command, believing no resistance or hostility exists inside the territory. Consequently, limb posture and behavior appear relaxed: no meaningless small movements of self-soothing responses occur, nor is behavior as constrained as in a freezing response. A typical relaxed state features eyes that are neither sharp nor focused, the torso leaning or resting against support, legs crossed or extended, and movement at ease.

### Flair

The third characteristic of territorial responses is large movement amplitude combined with low frequency, presenting a relaxed, commanding flair. Whether it is chin pointing, nodding or shaking the head, waving the arms and hands, or shifting between standing and sitting postures, the above features appear.

### Self-Defense

If the territory is invaded—for instance, dignity is challenged—an immediate, intense anger response occurs, accompanied by clear fight reactions.

## Test Case: Reactions Under Rising Pressure

We once designed an experiment in which students answered questions continuously. Beyond the baseline test section, later questions grew progressively harder and offered greater rewards. Abandoning the test yielded only a fixed reward regardless of how many questions had already been answered. Answering falsely resulted in forfeiture of all rewards. The setup resembled Truth or Dare but was more complex.

In the designed protocol, the sharpness of the questions increased gradually, and the difficulty of deciding whether to answer truthfully also rose. A common situation was that the experiment organizers would judge when the subject was about to give up.

After the subject finished answering, one of our team members said, "She's about done, isn't she? She's going to quit soon. The pressure is huge."

I replied, "No, she'll keep going."

I had noticed her fists were loosely clenched and repeatedly tightened, though without much force. Apart from that, her expression and the rest of her body showed no obvious reaction. Because fist clenching is a classic preparatory fight response, it indicated that energy was still accumulating inside her body and was being mobilized—a sign of preparation to attack. This meant she would continue answering and meet the challenge rather than quit midway.

Sure enough, before the next question, the tester explained and asked, “The remaining questions will be much harder. If you quit now, you can receive the reward you’ve earned. If you continue, you must answer truthfully; otherwise you will receive no reward at all.”

The subject answered, “I choose to continue.”

## Parties in the Courtroom

Every word spoken in court is recorded. If a judge or lawyer finds a loophole in any sentence, it can be used to make a major issue. Yet lawyers and judges know that people often reveal their true feelings through nonverbal communication, which is not recorded but can still influence the outcome of a trial.

Many successful lawyers use their fine observation of nonverbal communication to form rough assessments of colleagues, witnesses, and each member of the jury. Former Florida Supreme Court Justice James C. Adkins once stated that when selecting jurors, they consciously consider a candidate’s body movements that convey character traits and attitudes.

Louis Katz wrote: “A prospective juror who clenches both fists while answering a lawyer’s questions is best not chosen.” Katz believed that hand movements can silently convey whether a person has an open mind, harbors hostility, or is litigious by nature.

Clearly, it is very important for judges and lawyers to be proficient in body language. Only by mastering body language can they interpret others’ various physical behaviors and fully leverage their own advantages.

Below we list some negative and positive postures that lawyers and jurors may display in court.

### 7.2.1 Showing Off

Showing off here does not refer to the usual superficial display in which a person desperately wants others to recognize their abilities. Rather, it denotes the natural emanation of a positive, dominant style—perhaps the refined elegance of strategic planning or the unstoppable aura of dominance—that gives subordinates a strong sense of security and authority. Some people describe this state as “having presence.”

Swaying the body while walking is an excellent example of a showing-off response. This sway is not the deliberate swagger of street toughs, whose style is meant to advertise their toughness. The amplitude of this swaying movement is not large; it is a personal habit. Russian President Putin is an excellent model in this regard.

Putin represents Russia, whose economic strength does not rank as high as its military strength, yet because of that military power Russia remains one of the world’s most influential nations. Military strength is akin to an animal’s fangs and claws; therefore the leader of Russia also possesses certain bestial qualities. His love of judo and piloting aircraft are good illustrations. The slight sway from the waist upward to the shoulders while walking also embodies this style full of primal power, making him distinctive among world leaders. In contrast, U.S. presidents, shaped by their nation’s economic might and the electoral system’s emphasis on compromise

and balance, rarely display this “beast style,” more often projecting the image of an ordinary person who operates behind the scenes.

### 10.3.3 Simultaneous Enhancement of Inhalation and Exhalation

An angry attack excites the entire body and therefore objectively requires faster and more abundant energy supply, resulting in simultaneous enhancement of inhalation and exhalation. If one observes intense, uninhibited breathing with pronounced chest movement, even without accompanying angry facial expressions, expanded limb movements, or forward-leaning posture, it still indicates the presence of anger. When intense angry breathing occurs without accompanying body movement, its main feature is large amplitude but low frequency.

Fear-driven evasion likewise excites the whole body, primarily for concealment and escape, and therefore also intensifies breathing. Unlike the synchronized intensification in anger, fearful breathing intensification is characterized mainly by high frequency, while each inhalation and exhalation may remain incomplete. Observing this type of rapid, small-amplitude breathing allows one to conclude that the person harbors fear.

Sorrowful crying and joyful laughter both intensify inhalation and exhalation simultaneously, yet the resulting intense breathing consists of spasmodic breaths that accompany the emotion. Laughter involves a large inhalation followed by spasmodic, successive exhalations accompanied by vocalization; crying employs spasmodic movements on both inhalation and exhalation, with different vocalization patterns. Because these two forms of intense breathing have clear directional indicators, they fall outside the scope of micro-reaction (微反应) research.

The book *Microexpressions* contains research discussions on genuine versus fake laughter and genuine versus fake crying, including respiratory indicators.

## Interpreting Meaning

Observing victory responses reveals that the person is excited by a sense of gain or superiority and believes they have won the psychological confrontation. Observing defeat responses reveals that the person is dejected by an irreversible loss.

The ancient saying “victory and defeat are common in military affairs” carries the subtext: do not become arrogant when you win, and do not become discouraged when you lose. The phrase is meant to exhort people. Yet battles produce winners and losers, and different outcomes elicit different reactions from each side. Through these reactions one can discern important psychological states. Therefore, for anyone studying micro-reactions, victory and defeat are by no means ordinary matters.

The winning side often raises both arms, cheers loudly or even howls, proudly puffs out the chest, looks around, and shows off the hard-won victory. Afterward comes dividing the spoils, a hearty meal, a comfortable bath, and relaxation—enjoying life. In summary, there are roughly three manifestations: joy, showing off, and relaxation.

The defeated side (here referring to those who inwardly accept the outcome of defeat; those who remain spirited or unwilling to concede are excluded) usually appears “crestfallen.” They cannot straighten their chest or lift their head; even their facial features look listless, their gaze dim, and they try to make themselves disappear from view. If life or safety is at stake, various fear and sadness responses may also appear.

We therefore divide victory-and-defeat responses into two categories—victory responses and defeat responses—for discussion.

## Positive Actions That Yield Significant Results for Lawyers

- Maintain frequent eye contact with jurors
- Keep arms apart, hands outside pockets
- Use appropriate hand gestures to emphasize spoken words
- Move toward jurors to reduce distance
- Actively respond to jurors' facial expressions and postures

For lawyers, controlling their own body movements and carefully observing jurors' body movements are extremely important. One point must be noted, however: when selecting jurors, decisions must never be based solely on a candidate's body movements while ignoring their answers. A candidate's body movements can be deceptive.

For example, some candidates find the selection process tedious and wish to finish quickly yet must wait for the outcome. Expressions of annoyance or anger may therefore reflect dislike of courtroom procedures rather than the lawyer's statements. Similarly, some candidates will do everything possible to appear attentive and impartial in order to win the lawyer's favor and be selected.

Most lawyers consider microexpressions of candidates particularly noteworthy. As discussed earlier, microexpressions occur unconsciously and flash across the face only briefly. Experience has taught lawyers that these fleeting microexpressions reveal a candidate's true qualities more accurately than body movements or deliberate facial expressions.

## 5.1 Escape Responses

In the wild era of survival of the fittest, the survival rule of human ancestors was "fight if you can win, flee if you cannot." When facing powerful predators, the best way to stay alive was neither to wait nor to fight, but to escape.

Later, upon entering civilized society, cultured people established a new principle: "stay close to gentlemen, keep away from villains." Keeping a distance from potentially threatening individuals allows one to live more safely.

Clearly, fleeing negative stimuli is an excellent ability accumulated through generational evolution and is of great help to both survival and daily life. Precisely for this reason, the human nervous system—both central and peripheral—possesses sensitive escape capabilities. These range from a finger instinctively withdrawing from boiling water, to the whole body suddenly jumping in fright, to more advanced responses such as silently leaning back upon hearing a contradictory opinion or even storming out in anger. All are classic expressions of escape responses.

Therefore, during lie detection or evidence-gathering conversations, if the subject exhibits an escape response after receiving a stimulus, one can infer that the stimulus source is negative for the subject. The reason for fleeing constitutes an important clue that must be seized and analyzed.

We first divide escape responses into two major categories: fear-based escape and aversion-based escape.

## Chapter 4 What Happened to Attitudes?

- Openness
- Resistance
- Speculation
- Doubt, uncertainty, concealment, and confusion
- Readiness
- Offense
- Shyness
- Self-affirmation
- Cooperation
- Frustration
- Disgust
- Confidence
- Superiority
- Satisfaction and celebration
- Anxiety
- Surprise
- Self-control
- Boredom or lack of interest
- Approval
- Anticipation
- Courtship
- Conclusion

### Quote

Oh, what men dare do! What men daily do, not knowing what they do! —William Shakespeare

Observing a person's words and actions can reveal their attitude, which is extremely important. In addition, we must pay attention to subsequent changes in that person's mental state—whether the coming shift is negative or positive. If you notice someone suddenly change from an open attitude to resistance and anger, you should consider altering your approach to communication.

In this chapter we will examine various attitudes that both echo and oppose one another. Because some identical gestures appear across different attitudes, you will find that similar or opposing attitudes sometimes reference the same points. We begin the chapter's discussion with the most easily recognized attitude of all: openness.

### 10.3.4 The Calming and Excitation-Suppressing Effect of Deep Breathing

Although the brain accounts for only 2% of human body weight, it consumes 20%-25% of the body's total oxygen. When the brain receives insufficient oxygen, focus, cognitive ability, and rational thinking decline, while emotional instability, irritability, and anger increase. Such a state can cause serious losses for the actor in social interactions, including social evaluation and benefit acquisition.

When blood oxygen levels are sufficient, the brain can think more clearly and efficiently and better control the body's actions. Therefore, when a person feels tension and mild loss of control due to excitement, they typically take deep breaths to increase oxygen intake and carbon dioxide expulsion. This supplies the brain with adequate oxygen, strengthens control over one's own behavior, and slows uncontrolled excitement.

Deep breathing objectively alters internal pressure through large-scale expansion and contraction of the chest cavity while increasing blood oxygen levels, ultimately adjusting blood pressure and heart rate. In simple terms, when heartbeat accelerates and blood pressure rises, people use deep breathing to relieve the discomfort. Thus, the motivation for deep breathing may not stem directly from fear but from discomfort caused by changes in blood circulation, prompting an attempt to adjust internal pressure through respiration.

### Test Case: Under What Circumstances Is Ta's Every Word and Action Under Precise Control?

We conducted an experiment with more than 2,000 participants. The procedure was simple: participants performed two actions of aligning the pads of all ten fingers. The first time, they prepared fully and performed the action without interference or distraction; completion time was recorded. The second time, participants answered a question while performing the same action; completion time was again recorded. The questions used were simple division problems, such as  $27/6$ .

The two sets of data differed significantly. The average completion time for aligning the ten fingers while listening to the question was 4.7 seconds longer than in the first group. In other words, performing the finger-alignment task simultaneously while mentally calculating the division problem was considerably more effortful.

Therefore, when you observe someone speaking fluently while also executing such a precisely controlled action, it indicates that the behavior does not burden their brain and that all statements being made remain under precise control. We know that when seeking clarification on a matter, encountering a possible fraudster, verifying someone's authenticity, conducting inquiries or interrogations in criminal cases, or performing lie detection, if the person opposite is exercising precise control, we must at minimum raise our vigilance to a high level to avoid being deceived.

### Interpretation Significance

By observing the amplitude and frequency of breathing, determine whether the actor's nervous system and physical state show increased or decreased excitement. Increased breathing amplitude or frequency indicates rising excitement; the opposite indicates decreasing excitement. If the actor controls breathing speed and reduces the volume of exhalation and inhalation per unit of time, it indicates entry into a cautious, confrontational state.

Facial expressions, vocal semantics, respiration, and limb postures and movements constitute the four major indicators in the psychological stress micro-reaction (微反应) analysis system. Changes in breathing can be observed clearly through the actor's nostril or mouth movements and chest undulations. Because respiration's physiological significance is directly linked to energy reserves and behavioral drive changes in the body, breathing variations and control serve as a highly important judgment indicator in micro-reaction research. They are classified separately as the eighth category of micro-reaction, alongside the seven previously mentioned types of limb postures. When observing and analyzing an actor, the seven preceding reaction patterns must be integrated with respiratory changes for comprehensive judgment.

It is emphasized that all inhalation and exhalation discussed in this chapter, unless otherwise specified, refer to stress micro-reaction breathing changes—that is, the actor's inadvertent respiratory variations—and do not include deliberately controlled breathing behavior. The significance of breathing control is also addressed separately in this chapter.

### Chapter Summary



## Interpretation Significance

Observing a freezing reaction indicates that the other party's mindset has weakened substantially, presenting a state of fear.

The freezing reaction has two characteristics: reduced movement frequency and reduced amplitude—that is, fewer and smaller movements. Complete freezing means all movement stops while the body assumes a contracted posture. Typical actions of a contracted posture include:

- Shoulders hunched
- Spine curved
- Hands restrained
- Knees pressed together
- Ankles pressed together

## Physiological Significance of the Freezing Reaction

The principle behind reduced or halted movement frequency is that, after the actor assesses the stimulus source as potentially harmful, minimal or no limb movement becomes the optimal survival strategy.

The principle behind reduced or contracted movement amplitude is that, when attack force and quantity remain constant, contracting the body area to a smaller size and tucking vital organs inside for protection reduces the likelihood of injury. One hundred arrows shot at a one-square-meter area will hit one hundred times; shot at a one-square-centimeter area, they can hit only once. This is a basic physical law.

## Defrosting

If the tested person's limb postures and movements lose these two characteristics—that is, they no longer maintain contraction, movements gradually increase, and amplitude gradually enlarges—it indicates that they have "defrosted," fear is dissipating, and their mindset is strengthening.

## Figure 5-11 Multi-Person Conversation Escape

Torso rotation appears more readily in multi-person conversation scenarios and may also occur during chance encounters. When disliking the content discussed or the person speaking, the individual may turn their body toward another person, as in Figure 5-11, or toward another direction of movement. Although the face may maintain a polite smile, the mind is thinking of ending the conversation quickly.

At this point in writing, I cannot help but worry that readers may over-identify or nitpick in daily life. I must emphasize this issue.

The subtle escape reactions discussed in this section are summarized from numerous actual test cases. Each test case occurred within a specific context, including background information, the tested topic, and the testing environment. Therefore, one cannot conclude that if someone nearby exhibits such a reaction in daily life, they must dislike you and do not wish to engage in normal communication. The reactions we study are extremely subtle and must be judged in conjunction with the specific stimulus source and testing context, as well as changes in the tested person's preceding and following behavior. Readers must not finish this section and then seek out conversations with others, immediately assuming dislike upon seeing someone turn away. Such self-assumed cleverness ultimately harms only oneself.

## Basic Theory: Gravity Principle

Overcoming gravity is the most fundamental condition for all organisms to survive on Earth and the first resistance every organism must find ways to counteract. Resistance to gravity is reflected not only in large movements such as standing, jumping, and throwing but also in minute muscle movements such as surprise, smiling, and anger.

In the micro-reaction research system, because the primary subjects are physiological and emotional reactions not dependent on deliberate will, these two conditions can be combined. The higher the level of neural excitement, the greater the energy allocated and the more obvious the resistance to gravity. The lower the neural excitement, the less energy allocated and the weaker the resistance to gravity. If the nervous system enters an inhibitory state, energy replenishment stops and energy is rapidly lost, preventing continued resistance to gravity's pull; the relevant body parts then exhibit a powerless downward droop. We name this law the gravity principle.

When a person is successful, they become excited, filled with energy, and often appear radiant and jubilant. When unsuccessful, they appear dejected, crestfallen, and may squat in a corner crying—these are all manifestations of insufficient energy to resist. Attentive readers may observe smiling and sad expressions to see whether the facial muscles conform to this law (see the book *Microexpressions* for details).

## Chapter Summary

Under controlled conditions, different emotional states present different respiratory changes.

- Controlled surprise produces a small, rapid inhalation followed by breath-holding.
- Mild disgust—that is, disdain or contempt—manifests as a small, rapid exhalation that is barely noticeable when controlled.
- Deep disgust produces breath-holding, rapid distancing, and then resumption of breathing.
- Controlled anger produces a deep, prolonged exhalation through the nostrils.
- In fear, despite high bodily excitement, violent breathing would produce audible sound and airflow. Therefore, during controlled mild fear—for example, when being cautious—the actor employs quiet, deep, prolonged breaths with very small intake and output volumes per unit of time to avoid notice. This is commonly described as "not daring to breathe loudly."
- If the actor is in a state of intense fear yet attempting to control their behavior, they typically adopt high-frequency, small-amplitude breathing—continuous rapid shallow breaths with small volume each time.

Conversely, when the nervous and motor systems enter a low-energy state, physiological activity decreases and large amounts of oxygen are objectively unnecessary, so breathing becomes gentle, low, and shallow.

## 4. Information Overlap Approach

Can people without close emotional ties lean in and whisper together?

It is possible. If the information they possess and exchange overlaps substantially, they will tend to draw closer to maintain a private informational distance. By comparison, someone with no knowledge of the matter will not immediately enter such close proximity. The more difficult the information is to disseminate, the closer people sharing overlapping information will stand to ensure confidentiality.

Therefore, in special situations, if several people are observed clustered closely together, it may indicate they know most of the details of the same event. This inference can be used for information cross-verification.

[1] "Edward Hall, the hidden dimension online abstract". Retrieved 2006-12-14; Hall, Edward (1966). The Hidden Dimension. New York, NY: Peter Smith Publisher Inc. ISBN 0-385-08476-5

## Victory Reaction

Victory reaction manifestations: A person in a victorious mindset becomes excited both neurologically and physically, supported by abundant energy. Under conditions of some inhibition, they display many active behaviors. For example:

1. Frequent eyebrow movements and irrepressible smiling—that is, the common expression "beaming with delight."
2. Eyes become lively and shifting, continually observing noteworthy individuals in an attempt to display achievements and even seek recognition—this is commonly called gloating display and demonstration.
3. Head swaying—not nodding or shaking, but movement in all directions. In opera, to express a young female character's smugness, the eyes may shift dramatically left and right with a smile while the head sways toward each ear in turn.
4. Rapid shoulder shaking.
5. Torso rocking, following the same principle as head swaying—like a relaxed person entering a dance hall and swaying to music, only with much smaller amplitude.
6. Frequent purposeless finger movements, such as repeatedly tapping the tabletop lightly with fingers.
7. If the chair has elasticity, gentle forward-and-back rocking of the torso against the chair back may occur.
8. Feet crossed with one foot swinging.

## 2. Angle Twisting

The rules and social etiquette of modern society both ensure that everyone behaves as civilized individuals—with physical harm rarely occurring in civilized settings—and teach from childhood what constitutes "impolite" behavior.

From around age two, when children can converse normally with adults, my family and I always remind them to look at the aunt when saying hello and to face the child when apologizing. I believe most people are raised this way, absorbing social interaction rules daily through constant exposure.

Consequently, as adults facing a superior's lecture or communicating with business clients, most people, due to their own etiquette cultivation, rarely exhibit obvious reactions such as gaze aversion or torso leaning back.

Therefore, many escape reactions have gradually evolved from obvious positional shifts into subtle angular changes. This satisfies one's own needs (primarily the brain's negative emotions) while also accommodating the other party's feelings and social norms.

Typical reactions include:

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-10 双人对话逃离]*

### 7.2.2 Absence of Tension

Distinct from the primitive, imposing display of showing off, another reaction within one's own territory is "freedom and ease, without concern for trifles," stemming from a completely relaxed mindset.

Yet each person's relaxed state differs; slovenly lounging counts, as does excited wildness. We cannot summarize a universally applicable form, so only one common example is provided for reference—Chinese imperial cultivation.

In ancient China, the royal family maintained a strict training system for heirs apparent. One important requirement was that the ruler walk with the posture and bearing of "dragon-like stride and tiger-like step." This requirement simultaneously achieved two effects: first, it made the emperor appear highly confident and superior, conveying a sense of total control that inspired awe in observers; second, it instilled a deeply rooted habit so that, regardless of circumstances, the emperor would always maintain this calm and assured reaction in public, thereby soothing the ministers' minds. Imagine if, upon encountering something good or bad, the emperor hopped about or paced anxiously; the subordinates' heart rates would surely spike.

## Interesting Case

### **"Best Reconciliation Time" After a Marital Argument**

Arguments between spouses are common. Ordinary arguments do not harm mutual affection and pass quickly. The more proactive party often wishes to express friendliness at an appropriate moment to restore normal relations. The greatest difficulty lies in accurately judging this "appropriate moment" as early as possible. If the timing is misjudged, acting too soon may result in a "hot face pressed against a cold backside," while acting too late may deepen the conflict by missing the optimal window.

Distance provides a useful analytical clue. For example, during a meal, if the other party allows you to pick food from the same dish with chopsticks and even tolerates an apparently unintentional touch (with the chopsticks), the clue is sufficiently clear. If the other party remains angry (dissatisfied, disgusted), they would mind this intimate distance because the chopsticks touch the mouth.

Of course, once this small technique is shared, it may produce a butterfly effect whose specific consequences are unknown; readers may contemplate them at leisure.

## 2. Enhanced Exhalation in Anger

Once anger arises, the body triggers numerous physiological responses: increased inhalation volume, elevated blood pressure, and a sudden rise in internal pressure. In situations requiring restraint, these energy releases cannot be allowed to occur too obviously. Often the tested person relieves the pressure increase caused by anger by intensifying exhalation, most commonly by exhaling forcefully through the nostrils.

Whether a wild ox or an entertainment star being questioned about sensitive matters, both exhibit the same reaction without exception. Moreover, test cases accumulated by our institute show that even when the actor is in a state of restrained anger, their expression may remain smiling, yet few can perfectly control the strong breath expelled through the nostrils.

A variation of this action involves deliberately exhaling rapidly through the nostrils while flaring the nostrils and raising the upper lip, forming a mild anger expression used to convey threat. If the breath is excessively heavy, it can be inferred that anger intensity has increased.

## 6.1.2 Satisfaction and Enjoyment

In the absence of an obvious adversarial relationship, when the actor receives positive stimuli that generate satisfaction and superiority—or purely physiological benefits such as pleasant sounds, fresh air, or good

flavors—a head-raising reaction may also occur.

Everyone maintains an internal self-evaluation and tends to evaluate themselves positively. Even the most heinous villain or utterly worthless rogue will find ways to identify satisfactory aspects to maintain psychological health. Self-identification is a fundamental condition for survival; if someone genuinely negates themselves from within, their only emotion is despair, and terrible consequences will follow.

Using self-evaluation as the baseline, when external evaluation equals or exceeds this baseline, it directly triggers satisfaction or pride. The manifestation of this emotion is an attempt to appear taller, including raising the head, puffing out the chest, and lifting the eyebrows (eyebrow raising belongs to expression composition).

## Conclusion

In this chapter we learned the important role of nonverbal communication in various interpersonal relationships. In fact, whether with family, friends, or business partners, even without speaking we communicate extensively through body movements. From now on, you should pay close attention to the nonverbal signals others send. Of course, fully mastering the impact your own body movements may have on others is equally important.

You might spend a few minutes observing yourself in a mirror. Do you display a smile or a frown? Do you appear stern and unfriendly, or approachable and kind? Recall the postures you frequently adopt. Do you often sit in a chair in a manner that conveys resistance or anger? Does your most common posture communicate friendliness and openness?

By effectively utilizing your own body movements, you will be able to improve various interpersonal relationships and present your best self among family members, business partners, and even strangers.

## Test Case: Are You Two-Timing?

During actual testing we encountered many classic deep-breath reactions.

In one instance we asked the subject, “Have you ever two-timed someone?” The subject’s girlfriend was present at the test site, so the environmental pressure can easily be imagined.

To heighten psychological pressure, the examiner deliberately prolonged the waiting period. After the question was posed, the subject’s face displayed obvious complex expressions of guilt and embarrassment while waiting to answer; the eyes avoided the girlfriend yet occasionally stole glances. Once the decision to answer was made, the first reaction was a deep inhalation, followed by admission of the fact.

That breath was presumably meant to replenish the brain, which had been consuming oxygen at an excessive rate under overload.

When the video was replayed for analysis, although the subject’s entire body showed no obvious limb-movement changes, the breath added an important indicator for verifying the reliability of the answer.

### 7.2.3 Unrestrained Shaking

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图7-10 体现自在的勾脚尖]*

When relaxed, one often sees people (especially women) hook the tips of their shoes with their toes and sway them gently—a typical sign of ease, as shown in Figure 7-10.

Imagine the boss about to fire her; she would hardly be in the mood for such a movement.

However, toe-hooking is not always a sign of relaxation. If the subject encounters pressure and needs to relax, the toes may also hook, yet the movement is tense and may be followed by straightening the toes in the opposite direction before relaxing again. This appears to be a self-soothing method that regulates bodily tension through muscle movement, as shown in Figures 7-11 and 7-12.

Figures 7-11 and 7-12 Toe-hooking that signals pressure

## 2. Inhalation When Preparing to Flee

Before sensing danger and preparing to flee, a person takes a rapid, deep breath to obtain as much oxygen as possible for energy reserves. We can regard this reaction as one of the preparatory movements for escape.

Now close the book and try to summon two emotions on your own: surprise and fear.

You will notice that both emotional displays are accompanied by a rapid yet forceful deep inhalation.

This occurs because surprise is the most direct response to an unexpected stimulus; when friend or foe cannot yet be distinguished, reserving a breath of oxygen is essential. If the stimulus is an enemy, the oxygen can fuel flight or fight; if a friend, it can fuel joyful leaping. Fear, by contrast, is the response to a stimulus perceived as harmful. Once the source is recognized as intent on harming oneself, why wait? Inhale deeply and run.

## Chapter 3 Using the Hands and Other Body Parts to Communicate

- Hands
- Arms and shoulders
- Walking
- Conclusion

What raises man above the brute... is that he knows himself to be an inconceivable part of a whole.  
—Samuel Taylor Coleridge

Other parts of the body, like the face, convey abundant information. In this chapter we examine the various meanings of hand postures and arm postures individually, as well as how our manner of walking conveys important emotional information.

Limb movements are generally easier to detect than facial expressions because we can observe them from a distance. When necessary we can also read people through a window or while watching pedestrians on the street.

Because the hands are the most frequently moving body parts after the face, we begin the discussion with the hands.

## 3. Interested Approach

Even when no emotional closeness exists and no intention to build trust is present, approach reactions may still occur, usually because of interest and a desire for more information.

When a crowd gathers noisily to discuss, perform, or watch something, and the individual assesses no danger yet feels interested, the most common first reaction is to walk closer; if the feet remain still, the body may tilt

forward to obtain information. Idioms such as “listen attentively” and “crane one’s neck in expectation” describe this interested mental state.

Therefore, when we observe an approach reaction, we may also conclude that the individual is interested in the stimulus source and hopes to obtain more information or generate further interaction.

## 8.1 Fight Preparation

During the preparation phase, the individual expresses anger through many subtle actions that share a common feature—covert exertion of force.

Once the desire to fight is ignited by anger, the following reactions appear: the body leans forward, the chin lowers, the gaze focuses, the irises roll upward toward the opponent, and the lower whites of the eyes may even become visible. Accompanying the angry expression, one may observe tightening of the masseter muscles, downward curvature of the lips, and possible baring of the canines. For a detailed discussion of angry expressions, see the book *Microexpressions*.

Because energy reserves are ample, the nervous system gradually shifts the body’s muscles from a loose, relaxed state to a tense state. On a person filled with fighting intent you will therefore observe the following characteristics:

### Positive Movements That Make a Speaker Effective

- Maintain eye contact with the audience
- Walk back and forth on the stage to respond to viewers seated in different areas (note that this movement also helps you relax)
- Display facial expressions appropriate to the audience at suitable moments
- Use natural hand gestures to emphasize your remarks

While reading the above tips, you may already realize how important it is to speak from memory rather than from notes. When you suddenly feel your mind go blank, the script can help retrieve your memory. Only by grasping the main points of the script in advance, however, can you maintain eye contact with the audience comfortably. You should also walk back and forth on the stage, make appropriate gestures at the right moments, and close the distance between yourself and the audience.

### Avoidance Reaction

The most noticeable feature of an avoidance reaction is that the face moves away from the stimulus source. The stronger the negative stimulus, the greater the distance moved; the two are directly proportional. Because the reaction addresses a negative stimulus, tension appears simultaneously with the distancing movement, including an unrelaxed face, gaze, and breathing, as well as a body that does not relax; the limbs are likely to remain tense or blocking.

After avoidance, the gaze stabilizes, yet its direction varies: upward indicates a passive avoidance strategy; downward indicates a patient avoidance strategy that still carries offensive potential; direct eye contact indicates defiant confrontation.

**Summary:** Seeing an avoidance reaction allows us to judge the subject’s subjective cognition and assessment as contempt, disgust, rejection, panic, fear, and so on.

## 1. Heightened Exhalation in Disgust

The essence of disgust is rejection and repulsion—a top-down negation. Toward people or matters one looks down upon, the individual does not expend large amounts of energy to entangle or fight but instead adopts the lowest-cost method of rejection or distancing.

The strongest disgust causes breath-holding to refuse further olfactory negative stimuli. Yet the milder degrees of disdain and contempt manifest in breathing as a rapid increase in exhalation volume.

- Enhanced exhalation through the mouth produces the sound “tch,” often accompanied by a contemptuous smile.
- Enhanced exhalation through the nose produces the sound “hmp” or a silent rapid exhale.

Therefore, observing the above stress reactions allows us to conclude that disgust-type emotions have arisen.

## 1. Inhalation During Surprise

When a person receives an unexpected stimulus and feels surprise, one major reaction is a rapid inhalation. This breath increases oxygen reserves for two possible subsequent developments.

- If the stimulus source is beneficial, the individual can leap forward energetically (approach reaction) to obtain the benefit—for example, meeting an old friend or seeing a long-desired car.
- If the stimulus source is harmful, a rapid assessment follows; once the risk of damage equals or exceeds one’s defensive capacity, the corresponding role—fight or flight—is adopted.
- For an indifferent stimulus, the inhaled breath is simply exhaled at random and the previous state resumes.

## Psychological-Distance Axis

Emotional feelings between men and women follow the law of love-hate reactions. Interactions between men and between women also follow this law. The rule is not limited to relationships involving liking or disliking; even between two people with no emotional bond, distance regulation obeys the same pattern (see Figure 5-16).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5-16 爱恨距离坐标轴]

Using this axis we can judge the degree of mutual psychological acceptance by the physical distance between two or more people; the two are directly proportional. Closer distance indicates greater closeness; greater distance indicates greater estrangement.

## Chapter 4 Attention—Do Not Move: The Freeze Reaction

When a person receives an unexpected stimulus, the very first instant brings a reduction or cessation of movement and maximal contraction of the body in order to gather information, reduce traces, and decide on a response. Observing these tiny reactions tells us the other party’s mindset has weakened sharply and fear is present. This stimulus point may well become a powerful weapon for breaching the other party’s psychological defenses!

**Interpretation:** Seeing a freeze reaction tells us the other party’s mindset has weakened sharply and fear is present.



Long-term evolution has equipped humans, like animals, to stop all movement and contract the body as much as possible in the very first—extremely brief—instant of encountering danger. We call this reaction the freeze reaction.

## Approach Reaction

The approach reaction is the primary way of expressing positive intent. It conveys a desire for more information, more effective expression, or better physical interaction. Corresponding intentions can be scripted as: “What did you say?” “I like him too!” “Don’t let anyone else know about this,” as well as wordless affectionate gestures.

Approach reactions divide into tentative small-amplitude, low-frequency movements and acquisitive large-amplitude, high-frequency movements. When the outcome is unknown, tentative actions are used to intervene—for example, listening attentively; once a definite judgment of the outcome has been reached, vigorous movement expresses and obtains the result—for example, an enthusiastic welcoming embrace.

### 7.1 Expansion

Wild animals often mark territory with scent. Humans use two methods: institutions and the body. Institutional forms mostly involve political systems, management regulations, or other agreements on rights and responsibilities; these belong to the domain of management studies. Body-based territorial confirmation reactions are the focus of our discussion.

Establishing one’s territorial range with the body is actually very simple, requiring only three elements: hands, feet, and torso. In Chapter 4 we discussed the characteristics of the freeze reaction, which demonstrated that inner restraint leads to contraction of the hands; the opposite occurs in territorial-establishment movements—the body assumes an expansive posture.

## Chapter 5 Love Draws Near, Hate Sends Away—Love-Hate Reactions

The distance between people’s bodies reflects the psychological distance between them: liking brings closeness, disliking brings distance. These reactions, appearing in passionate romance, business service, cooperative negotiation, and so on, are vital information. The rule can also be applied in reverse: accelerating the building of trust through caring behavior and distance control in approach reactions.

### Interpretation

The distance between people is extremely subtle: liking brings closeness, disliking brings distance; interest brings closeness, fear brings distance. In this chapter we divide this remarkable pattern into avoidance reactions and approach reactions for separate discussion.

### 7.2 Relaxation

Using hand and foot movements to establish territorial range stems from a psychological defensive or offensive awareness that arises when threat is felt or authority must be displayed. People whose territorial range is established by institutions, however, have no need to use expansive movements to show others the extent of their territory. Although we do not study how to establish authoritative status through institutions, we are interested in how a person with absolute control behaves and reacts inside his or her own territory.

Within a territory where one holds absolute control, the territory holder’s primary displays fall into two categories of reaction: display and relaxation.

## Failure Reaction

The failure reaction is mainly characterized by a dual sense of powerlessness in mental attention and bodily support. Mentally the individual appears listless and uninterested in new matters or information, because the most important interests have already been lost and there is neither will nor capacity to care about anything else. Physically, because of dejection and lack of spirit, the body assumes a naturally scattered posture: the head, torso, and limbs sink downward under gravity; the spine does not straighten, the head does not lift, the hands do not rise or wave broadly, the legs do not spread widely, rise onto tiptoe, shake, or sway, and the person does not stand bolt upright, and so on.

### 1. Visual Blocking

Chapter 7 noted that when ashamed, a person wishes to reduce the degree of attention received. Therefore, when the subject receives a negative stimulus, a reaction of covering the forehead and eye area with the hand may appear; it looks as though the person is rubbing the skin of the forehead or cheekbones to relieve fatigue, yet the actual purpose is to block external attention and reduce the possibility of deeper probing. This reaction belongs to visual blocking; while preventing others from focusing on oneself, it also allows one to avoid looking at the other party (see Figures 8-20 and 8-21).

Figures 8-20 and 8-21 Eye-blocking reactions

## Chapter 6 Arrogance and Humility—Upward-Gaze Reactions

Generations of transmitted memories of survival and death cause people subconsciously to look up to and revere things larger than themselves and, during competition, to make themselves appear taller—even if only by tilting the head or lifting the chin—while lowering the body expresses politeness, modesty, and submission. Therefore, observing a person's bodily height can reveal the true inner self-positioning.

**Interpretation:** Seeing an upward-gaze reaction tells us the other party's mindset has strengthened, the stimulus source is not accepted, not submitted to, and not conceded to, and confrontational tendencies have increased; a downward-gaze reaction indicates acceptance, 认同, and compromise.

### 8.3 Defensive Protection

Offensive signs represent an active fighting state; the individual is generally confident or has adopted an all-or-nothing desperate mentality, indicating a dominant mindset and a desire to win<|eos|>

## Signs Indicating Audience Boredom or Skepticism

- Lack of eye contact with the speaker
- Arms or legs crossed
- Body turned away from the speaker, eyes glancing elsewhere, such as toward the exit
- Expressionless or unhappy face
- Checking watch, looking at the ceiling, or glancing at each other
- Scratching behind the ear or rubbing eyes with hesitation
- Impatiently kicking feet
- Supporting head with hand, eyelids drooping
- Critical pondering posture

### 10.3 Enhanced Breathing

As described earlier, after intense exercise the nervous system self-regulates, increasing the amplitude and frequency of breathing to accelerate metabolism and energy supply in the body. Therefore, reactions in which inhalation and exhalation are simultaneously enhanced most often appear after heightened physiological activity.

In social interactions such as attending lectures, conversations, or negotiations, unidirectional enhancements—either increased inhalation or increased exhalation—are more common.

## 9.2 Defeat Reaction

The defeated party loses not only benefits but also energy. Defeat causes a sharp drop in neural excitability; the nervous system may even enter a suppressed state out of fear of subsequent negative stimuli. The circulatory system then stops supplying energy to the organs previously used for combat. The person appears, as the common saying goes, “wilted.” See Figure 9-11.

### 8.3.4 Blocking Reaction

The blocking reaction is another external manifestation of a defensive mindset; its essence is the creation of a barrier. The difference is that the protective zone established by a blocking reaction is relatively small and usually lacks the obvious morphological change seen with barrier formation. For classification purposes, we refer to certain small movements as blocking reactions.

Common blocking reactions center on the face, mainly the eyes, ears, and mouth.

### 10.3.1 Enhanced Inhalation

When an increased inhalation response is observed, it indicates that the individual requires more energy, meaning physiological or emotional behavior is about to intensify—for example, the nervous system beginning high-speed operation or the muscular system entering an excited state. The greater the increment of the movement, the greater the volume of breathing (frequency or amplitude); the two are directly proportional.

## Chapter 3 Body Movements That Do Not Lie

Language can be deliberately manipulated, but body movements are difficult to fake; they fully reflect a person’s true inner thoughts. Therefore, if we can understand the meanings represented by body movements, we can read others’ micro-emotions (微反应). Mastering the skill of discerning others’ true thoughts through body movements helps eliminate various interpersonal frustrations.

## Conclusion

Through the study of this chapter you have understood that, with careful observation, the human body can be seen to “speak.” You have now acquired some techniques for “reading people” and can begin integrating them. In the next chapter we will examine a range of attitudes and the body movements that express them.

## Chapter 10 At Critical Moments, Do Not Let Breathing Betray You—Respiratory Reactions

Under different emotional states people exhibit different changes in breathing, such as inhalation when surprised, exhalation when disgusted, deep prolonged exhalation when angry, or “not daring to breathe at all”

when afraid. Observing the amplitude and frequency of breathing can also indicate whether the other person's nervous system and physical state are increasing or decreasing in excitability.

## Signs Indicating Audience Interest and Attraction

- Frequent eye contact with the speaker
- Body oriented directly toward the speaker while seated
- Arms or legs apart
- Head tilted to one side, face showing a focused expression such as a pondering posture or chin-stroking posture
- Facial expressions changing continuously in response to the speaker according to the discussion topic

## Negative Actions That Work Against the Speaker

- Lack of eye contact with the audience
- Over-reliance on the script, frequently looking down at the text
- Maintaining a "stiff" body posture or remaining motionless
- Facial expression lacking variation or remaining unchanged
- Arms crossed, hands inserted in pockets
- Rigidly holding the script or gripping its edge stiffly

## Chapter 9 Victory and Defeat Are Not Everyday Matters—Victory and Defeat Reactions

Combat has winners and losers. The victor's body and nerves become highly excited, displaying various signs of activation; the loser's nervous system enters a suppressed state, body center of gravity lowers and contracts, presenting a naturally scattered appearance. Observing these reactions in others allows judgment of their true inner psychological state.

### 5.1.3 Subtle Escape

Although slight backward leaning of the torso is no longer obvious, the head's movement away from the stimulus source during negative stimulation remains noticeable. The subtle reactions listed next lack such uniform and clear criteria and are very covert.

## Chapter 4 Unmasking Emotions Through Language

Communication relies on language, and language carries emotion; it reveals the speaker's inner voice. Sometimes the speaker's tone, volume, speed, or manner of speaking alone can identify inner emotions, expose insincere words, and maintain the upper hand in interactions.

## Negative Actions That Work Against the Lawyer

- Lack of eye contact with the jurors
- Over-reliance on the transcript, frequently looking down
- Arms crossed, creating separation from the jurors
- Hands inserted in pockets, as if hiding something
- Maintaining a "stiff" body posture or remaining motionless in court

### (1) Turning Escape During Two-Person Dialogue

While listening to the other person speak, turn the head to one side and pretend to observe something interesting, as in Figure 5-10. Turn back briefly, listen for a short while—actually to check the time—signal that you are still listening, then turn away again.

## Part Two Body Micro-reactions ()—What Lies Behind Small Movements

Nose rubbing means lying, hand rubbing means anticipation, legs crossed means doubt... this is the astonishing art of reading minds through body micro-reactions. FBI agents tell us the secrets are all in the small movements; once you understand them, you can see through people and control the situation.

### 5.1.1 Fear-Based Escape

As the name implies, fear-based escape occurs when the stimulus source produces a feeling of fear, prompting escape movements. The psychological state of this escape is to distance oneself from danger, placing oneself entirely in the purely vulnerable position of a potential victim.

### 10.3.2 Enhanced Exhalation

When comparing simultaneous inhalation and exhalation, if exhalation is markedly enhanced during a stress response while inhalation shows no change, we refer to it simply as enhanced exhalation. This respiratory reaction appears in states of disgust or anger.

## Summary

The principles of human physiological behavior possess cross-societal, cross-racial, cross-age, cross-gender, and cross-educational applicability. They constitute a method of analyzing and interpreting behavior by treating the person as an animal and therefore carry higher validity and reliability.

## 8.2 Combat Power Generation

The second type of combat reaction is more intuitive; its typical feature is energy expansion, with the force expressed through offensive movements or modified offensive movements. These mainly appear as follows.

## Signs Indicating Jurors Doubt the Lawyer's Statement

- Arms or legs crossed
- Expressionless or unhappy face
- Hands tightly clasped
- Suspiciously scratching behind the ear or rubbing eyes
- Critical pondering posture
- Brows furrowed

## 1. Preparatory Actions Before Escape

Before formally discussing the various manifestations of escape reactions, attention must first be given to the warm-up movements and preparatory actions that precede the formal movements.

## Signs Indicating Jurors Accept the Lawyer's Statement

- Arms or legs apart

- Lincoln-style seated posture
- Chin-supported pondering posture or chin-stroking pondering posture

## 7.5 Self-Defense: External Defense

### Chapter Summary

#### Hands

#### Micro-expression Keywords (B07CM5DW9F)

To control others, one must master their character and personality and be able to anticipate their future actions. We cannot literally read minds, yet applying behavioral psychology makes the goal far easier to reach.

On a financial street in Washington, a patrol detective noticed a woman wearing a scarf at the entrance of a bank. She looked like any ordinary person at first, but after standing at the door and glancing around, she began walking toward an armored car parked nearby.

The detective initially assumed she was waiting for someone, yet the moment she headed for the vehicle his alertness sharpened. The bank handled enormous daily cash volumes on that street, and armed robberies were not uncommon. He slipped into a nearby shop, pretending to examine merchandise while observing her closely.

Up close he saw none of the usual gentleness associated with ordinary women. Her tightly drawn lips and furrowed brows projected a cold, hard demeanor. Unlike other pedestrians hurrying past, she moved slowly, her eyes flashing with tension and excitement.

The detective was almost certain her target was the armored car only a short distance away. He left the shop and approached her quietly. At that moment she pulled on gloves and drew a pistol from her coat. The waiting detective lunged, stopping the robbery before it could begin.

This was no movie scene; it was a real case that occurred in the United States. The woman belonged to a terrorist group that specialized in robbing armored cars. Had the detective not detected her unusual behavior and read her psychological state in advance, the robbery might well have succeeded or caused heavy casualties.

In daily life we usually apply psychology to discern others' mental states so we can steer events or conversations. Behavioral psychology serves the same purpose while also revealing character and habits through observable actions, allowing us to predict future behavior and achieve a measure of foresight.

Xiao Nie was the top salesperson at a real-estate firm. Even the most difficult clients became docile in his hands, a fact that made colleagues envious. Pressed for his secret, he finally explained: "It is actually quite simple. The moment a client walks in, their movements and expression reveal what kind of person they are and what kind of property they want. I simply cater to that."

Colleagues doubted it could be so easy. Just then a middle-aged woman entered. Xiao Nie signaled the others and stepped forward.

"Hello. How may I help you?" he asked politely.

"I have a property I want to sell." The woman's brows were tightly knit; she clearly distrusted him. When he offered her a seat she wiped the chair with a tissue from her bag before sitting down sideways.

"May I ask the location of your property and the price you hope to obtain?" Xiao Nie maintained his warmest smile and most professional manner, yet the woman's guard remained up.

After some negotiation her brow finally relaxed, but as she prepared to leave she clutched her handbag and said sideways, "I've registered, but I'll still check other agencies. Don't try to cheat me!"

"You can rest assured," Xiao Nie replied courteously. "Registration is the same at any agency; we charge no fees. Our firm has the largest client base and our process is completely transparent. Whatever questions you have, I can help."

"Hmph. We'll see." She snorted and walked out.

Once she left, colleagues crowded around, chattering:

- "That auntie is impossible to please..."
- "Exactly. You can tell she isn't serious about selling."
- "This client is obviously a lost cause!"

"Wrong," Xiao Nie said, waving them off. "On the contrary, she genuinely wants to sell and will call again in a few days."

"Impossible," the others murmured, incredulous.

"From the moment she entered with furrowed brows and wiped the chair, it was clear she is withdrawn, highly suspicious, sensitive, and something of a neat freak. People like that avoid strangers unless they have an urgent need for money or some other pressing reason. That is why she came today—she wants the property sold quickly."

"Her habit of clutching her handbag also shows strong defensiveness toward everyone, yet she simultaneously longs for help. Any hint of insincerity from the person serving her makes her feel deceived. Such clients are difficult, but if you handle the transaction cleanly and efficiently they are actually easier to close than many supposedly tougher prospects."

The colleagues nodded. Sure enough, less than two hours later the client phoned, urging Xiao Nie to bring buyers to view her property.

From the simple actions of furrowed brows, wiping the chair, and clutching the handbag, Xiao Nie had deduced the woman's psychology and character. The insight came from his daily study of behavioral psychology. An ordinary salesperson analyzing only her words and tone would have concluded she was not serious and treated her coldly; the sensitive client would have left at once.

Analyzing personality through behavior is therefore the most reliable method. Once you understand someone's character you can anticipate their likely future actions, giving yourself an extra edge and making your own conduct smoother and more effective.

Mastering behavioral psychology turns you into a mind-reader of sorts; every gesture and movement reveals its meaning. From then on everyone appears transparent, and you navigate social circles with effortless ease.

Xiao Juan was the office “ray of sunshine” and confidante. She seemed to possess an innate ability to read minds—who had been hurt, which boss was in a bad mood, even what someone nearby intended to do next. She always offered the right help at the right moment, earning universal affection.

Newcomer Xiao Gao frequently made mistakes and envied her skill. Seizing an opportunity, he asked for her secret.

“There really is no secret,” Xiao Juan replied modestly. “I simply judge everyone’s thoughts from their behavior.”

“For example,” she said, pointing at the director who had just entered, sweating and frowning, mouth turned down. “Look at Director Wang. That expression means he is in a terrible mood—probably upset by a client or delayed by traffic. Whatever you do, do not approach him with problems right now or you will be rebuffed.”

“I see,” Xiao Gao said, impressed. “You notice everything, Juan.”

Nearby, Xiao Chen, eyes bloodshot, stared at his screen, then irritably raked his fingers through his hair, yawned, and walked over.

“Juan...”

Before he could finish, Xiao Juan handed him a packet of instant coffee from her desk. “Here. Next time don’t push yourself so hard. Staying up late isn’t good for you.”

“You really get me,” Xiao Chen chuckled and went to make the coffee.

“Juan, you’re amazing,” Xiao Gao said, giving her a thumbs-up.

Xiao Juan’s insight came not only from careful observation but also from her command of behavioral psychology. Modern society is full of hidden traps and deceptions; people keep their true thoughts guarded. Genuine communication has grown rarer, and many lament the difficulty of finding true understanding.

In such an environment, anyone who can accurately read another’s psychology and dissolve unconscious resistance quickly gains favor and even trust.

Imagine possessing that ability: difficult clients, stern bosses, or suspicious, talkative partners would no longer pose problems. Their behavior would reveal their real intentions, allowing you to manage every interaction smoothly and successfully.

Mastering behavioral psychology also lets you read emotional shifts in real time, respond optimally, and earn a reputation as the resident “psychology expert” within your network. Who would not welcome a trusted advisor who can solve problems on demand?

Former FBI agent Joe Navarro is exactly such a person.

After retiring from the FBI, Navarro became a psychological consultant for major corporations. Once, as an advisor to the British side, he attended negotiations between British and French shipbuilding companies.

The British representatives clearly did not take the famous ex-agent seriously. Upon meeting him they instructed, “When we enter the negotiation room we will first hear the other side’s presentation, then give ours. You can simply observe...”

“You did not hire me merely to observe,” Navarro replied. “I need to discuss contract details with you.”



"That would take too long," the skeptical representative immediately refused.

"If you want an agreement, you had better listen to my objections," Navarro insisted. "During the meeting I will watch which clauses the other side can accept and which they cannot. I will do my best to resolve potential problems."

The talks proceeded as Navarro wished. While both sides reviewed the contract he kept passing notes to the British lead negotiator, flagging problematic clauses. The French representatives were puzzled: how did the British always zero in on the points that mattered most to them?

Afterward the British lead was impressed. "I have studied these clauses too, yet how did you know which ones they cared about?"

"I simply watched their movements," Navarro smiled. "Whenever they reached a clause they truly cared about, their lips tightened involuntarily—an unconscious micro-expression they themselves probably never noticed."

Navarro helped the British side reject several costly revision proposals, saving millions of dollars. The lead negotiator became a lifelong admirer.

People say a gentleman's friendship is as light as water, yet they also say one must diligently cultivate personal connections. In other words, easygoing friends are pleasant, but the modern world most values and needs friends who can be relied upon at any moment. If we can, like Navarro, read hearts through behavior and discern character, we not only sail through life more smoothly but also become increasingly trusted and indispensable within our circles, the natural focal point of any group.

### **Micro-expression Keywords (B07CM5DW9F)**

Each of us possesses a mental model. This specific mental model manifests through our behavior and attitudes, forming a distinctive, predictable habit. Therefore, through in-depth analysis and research in behavioral psychology, we can acquire the "prophetic eye" that foresees others' actions.

The Liezi contains a fable titled "The Man of Qi Loses His Axe." It tells of a man from Qi who lost his axe and suspected his neighbor of stealing it. Once this thought took hold, he saw every movement of his neighbor as that of a thief—whether working, eating, or chatting, the neighbor always appeared shifty-eyed.

Not long afterward, the man found the axe in his own backyard. From then on, whenever he looked at his neighbor, he could see nothing but uprightness and not the slightest trace of thievery.

The psychological principle embedded in this fable is the mental model. The term was coined in the 1940s by Scottish psychologist Kenneth Craik and is also known as a mental model. In simple terms, a mental model refers to the deeply embedded assumptions, images, and stories we hold about ourselves, others, organizations, and every corner of the world—essentially the internet slang "YY." Yet this "YY" is not wild imagination; it is constrained by our fixed thinking, habitual thinking, and existing knowledge, forming a specific mode of thought.

This mode of thought is deeply rooted within us and exerts a profound influence on how we treat others, how we act, and even on our worldview and values. It is the method and habit by which we understand everything. When our mental model aligns with the actual development of events, our actions proceed smoothly and achieve twice the result with half the effort. Conversely, when our mental model does not match reality, our original plans cannot be realized and may even lead to serious consequences.

Dr. Peter Senge of the Massachusetts Institute of Technology illustrated this point in his writings. He studied a group of experienced electrical workers. Because electrical work is a high-risk industry, habitual violations of safety rules pose the greatest hidden danger. Every electrical worker must undergo rigorous training and periodic assessments to obtain certification.

Even so, operational accidents continue to occur frequently in the industry.

Dr. Senge immersed himself among these workers and discovered that they could recite theory and answer exam questions with great professionalism, yet during actual operations they treated procedures such as calling out and repeating each checklist item as “child’s play” and skipped them to avoid trouble.

These workers understood the dangers of the job better than anyone. During safety-regulation exams or on-site inspections they followed every rule to the letter, but in practice they were often careless, took chances, or became complacent. Some did not even realize they had made an operational error.

This habitual violation of rules ultimately stems from long-standing negative mental models. Habitual behavior is rarely conscious; it is subconscious or unconscious. Under the influence of these persistent negative mental models, the gap between espoused theory and actual practice widens until it becomes automatic behavior that seriously threatens workers’ safety.

Dr. Senge maintains that mental models are “simplified assumptions” in people’s minds. When facing a situation or deciding on action, what surfaces is not a complete, comprehensive image of reality but conceptualized assumptions, prejudices, and impressions. In other words, people frequently rely on experience to determine how they observe and act.

This does not mean mental models are merely prejudices or negative; they are the sum of experience and habit. Everyone has mental models. We may not notice them, yet they genuinely shape our behavior and decisions.

Recognizing our own mental models and discerning others’ mental models through behavior therefore carries important and far-reaching significance for understanding others’ psychology and habits.

After summarizing his research, Dr. Senge outlined five typical characteristics of mental models:

### 1. **Universality**

People have long been aware of mental models, yet most regard them as individual quirks. In fact, mental models are a universal phenomenon of cognition and behavior. Everyone possesses them and always thinks and acts through their own distinctive mental model.

### 2. **Concealment**

Mental models are hidden and difficult to detect. We often take what we are accustomed to as self-evident, which is precisely the work of mental models. Everyone is directed by their own mental model in observing, thinking, and acting, yet usually remains unaware of it.

### 3. **Duality**

As with the electrical workers who violated rules, their mental models manifested as a complete separation between espoused theory and actual practice. This separation is not a conscious case of saying one thing and doing another; rather, people endorse a theory yet act according to their own habits when performing the task.

#### 4. **Parochialism**

People always view the world through their own eyes—in other words, they judge the world through their own mental models. Through observation and accumulation, what remains in the mind is usually whatever fits the existing mental model; it is remembered and internalized, while whatever does not fit is automatically excluded. Consequently, mental models possess a degree of parochialism that leads us to treat unverified inferences as facts, causing biased decisions and making it difficult to view matters objectively and fairly.

#### 5. **Continuous Maturation**

The advantage of mental models is that they allow people to dispense with unnecessary actions through mental planning. Because individuals differ in social position, background, culture, and values, mental models can never be perfect. It is precisely this imperfection that enables mental models to be continually refined and elevated to higher levels.

### **Doubt, Uncertainty, Concealment, and Suspicion**

All gestures expressing doubt, uncertainty, concealment, or suspicion carry negative information. The difference among these signals lies in the importance of the information and its impact on your objective. For example, a schoolgirl concealing something from her teacher differs greatly from an elected official concealing information that could trigger war.

Gestures indicating that someone is concealing something or acting secretly are sometimes called “left-handed” gestures, because “left hand” carries a negative connotation in American slang—for instance, “left-handed compliment” or “left-handed marriage.”

During a recent business meeting, one colleague expressed opposition very cautiously. He never volunteered his thoughts or suggestions; we could only infer them from his body language.

Whenever we touched on a sensitive topic, he would place his left hand on his face. To avoid making him more uncomfortable, we rephrased our statements as questions. He only had to answer, and his replies would reveal his feelings.

His answers were always absent-minded, and his attitude clearly signaled strong opposition to the discussion. Had we failed to notice the information conveyed by his silent gesture, we might have forced a resolution that benefited no one.

In business meetings, people often feel dissatisfied with proposals or decisions yet are reluctant to share their views. Worse, they may say only what others want to hear rather than what would produce the best outcome.

Such behavior typically produces two negative effects:

- Others in the room pay no attention to their ideas.
- Because they never voiced their true thoughts during the meeting, they leave frustrated and angry.

Another gesture that reveals concealment or insincerity is avoiding eye contact. When you try to make eye contact with someone unwilling to communicate honestly, that person tends to look away. Many police officers notice this during interrogations.

For instance, an officer was questioning a well-known actor involved in a traffic accident. The officer observed that whenever the actor answered honestly, he maintained eye contact. When he lied or withheld information,

he would shift his gaze midway through his reply. Once the officer recognized the pattern, he repeatedly questioned the actor on the exact phrasing that triggered the gaze shift in order to uncover the truth.

Note, however, that many people consciously maintain eye contact while lying because they know that avoiding it can betray them. In fact, some people give themselves away precisely because their eye contact is too frequent. If you suspect someone is lying, watch for anomalies in their eye contact: either too much or too little indicates deception.

When others feel doubt, uncertainty, or opposition to what we say, the most obvious rejection posture is crossing the arms and quietly moving away, or turning sideways to present a shoulder rather than the front of the body while casting a sidelong glance (see Figure 4.12). If the person is wearing glasses, they are likely to tilt the head slightly forward and peer over the top of the lenses.

As the phrase “giving someone the cold shoulder” suggests, the combination of turning the body and casting a sidelong glance usually signals strong opposition. We have also found that people making these gestures often voice their objections angrily, as if saying, “What exactly do you mean?”

Touching or lightly rubbing the nose (usually with the index finger) is a classic gesture of doubt (see Figure 4.13). When someone is unsure whether to speak or doubts another’s statement, they often touch the nose. The gesture can also indicate suspicion, uncertainty, or resistance.

Many years ago, the late Professor Ray L. Birdwhistell, a renowned expert in human body-language communication, discussed a book with a young man. When the professor asked the young man’s opinion of the book, the young man said he liked it very much while lightly rubbing his nose with his hand.

Professor Birdwhistell smiled and said, “You’re lying. You don’t like the book at all.” The young man was stunned. He did not realize how he had given himself away and finally admitted he had read only a few pages before finding the writing “really tedious.” He should not have touched his nose in front of a body-language expert.

Another example occurred during a television interview. A well-known news commentator was asked, “What do you think historians would say about today’s young people and their ideals?” Although the trained commentator knew he should keep his hands away from his face while answering, he forgot the rule. While placing his right index finger on his nose, he said, “I believe historians will regard today’s young people as the greatest patriots in our nation’s history!”

From this inadvertent nose-touch, we can infer that before answering he entertained one of four doubts:

1. Whether to answer the question at all;
2. Whether he believed what he was about to say;
3. How to convey his belief;
4. Whether the audience would accept what he said.

By examining the commentator’s other postures and the shifts in his attitude before and after, we concluded that his doubt concerned (4)—concern over how the audience would receive his remarks.

Why? Because he had previously displayed an open, relaxed posture—sitting upright and leaning slightly forward—which ruled out (1) and (2). Only this question triggered the nose-touch; the gesture did not appear when he answered other questions, ruling out (3).

Besides touching the nose, two other gestures also indicate doubt: rubbing the ear with the index finger and rubbing the eye with the fingers (see Figures 4.14 and 4.15). Both are common in everyday conversation.

A participant in one of our workshops mentioned that he often “places” his offer or counteroffer right under the other party’s nose. He explained that during negotiations he watches closely for touches to the nose, ears, or eyes. These gestures reveal how far the parties remain from agreement.

He observed that in the early stages, when both sides jockey for advantage, nose-touching occurs frequently. As the negotiation tilts clearly toward one side, such gestures diminish. When agreement is imminent, touches to the nose, ears, or eyes nearly disappear. Moreover, when negotiators uncross their arms and lean toward the center of the table, it signals that “the distance between the two sides has narrowed.”

Is your nose itchy, or are you truly doubting me?

Remember not to interpret every gesture too literally. Sometimes a person rubs the nose simply because it itches. Yet clear differences exist between an itch-driven rub and a touch that signals negation or opposition.

An itch produces a vigorous rub, whereas a gesture of doubt or lying is gentle and often graceful, frequently accompanied by other signals such as crossed arms, fidgeting, or rapid blinking.

## Discovering the Hidden Meaning Behind a Person's Behavior

**Micro-expression Keywords** Observing the people around you, you will notice that every gesture and movement follows its own unique patterns and meanings. Mastering the methods to interpret these patterns is the essence of behavioral psychology, which allows you to uncover the true thoughts hidden in others' minds.

Behavioral philosophy holds that human actions originate from the guidance of human consciousness, meaning behavior and psychology are closely intertwined. Building on this idea, American psychologist John Watson founded behavioral psychology in the early twentieth century. It is grounded in psychology yet avoids the common psychological focus on studying consciousness directly, instead concentrating on understanding human mental activity through observable behavior. This distinctive approach has made behavioral psychology one of the most authoritative and popular fields in psychology today.

At its core, behavioral psychology examines people's physical actions to infer their mental states, providing the most fundamental and practical method for uncovering the hidden meanings behind behavior.

Why is behavioral psychology considered the most basic and practical method? The following incident makes this clear.

U.S. Federal Bureau of Investigation agents captured a high-level spy who had been operating undercover for years. To extract the names of higher-ranking spies from him, the agents subjected him to intense interrogation.

At first, the spy appeared cooperative and revealed several insignificant pieces of information, but whenever the questioning turned to his superiors, he fell silent and refused to speak.

The agents tried many approaches without success. Eventually, an experienced senior agent took over the case. He entered the interrogation room carrying a list of suspected spy leaders.

"I know why you are not talking," the senior agent said with a smile as he sat down in front of the spy. "Given your current situation, you are likely to be extradited back to your country. You must be waiting for that day, aren't you?"

The spy looked up at him briefly, then lowered his head again. No matter what the senior agent said, he showed no reaction.

Undeterred, the senior agent smiled slightly. "Your tight lips are admirable, but that approach is unwise here. We already have solid intelligence. The individuals on this list will soon be brought here to meet you. I believe you have met some of them. Let me read their names: Quinn Green, Nicole Carlins, Scock Hanks..."

After each name, the senior agent paused for a second to observe the spy's reaction. Although the spy's facial expression remained unchanged, when he heard the name "Rooney Smith," his index finger resting on the table twitched reflexively.

The senior agent caught this tiny movement and quickly concluded that Rooney Smith was the spy's superior. Sure enough, after a period of intensified surveillance on Smith, the FBI obtained evidence of his crimes and arrested him.

When communicating with others, we can often infer their thoughts from their words and attitudes. But what if the other person refuses to cooperate? They may not answer questions or even show the slightest expression. In such cases, are we powerless to judge their psychology?

In situations like this, we need the tools of behavioral psychology.

When people encounter external stimuli, their bodies produce various unique responses to adapt to the environment, such as muscle contractions, glandular secretions, or limb movements. These distinctive responses are what we call behavior, the primary subject of behavioral psychology. Drawing on Pavlovian conditioning, external stimuli can be paired with the body's unconditioned stimuli. An external stimulus can trigger bodily reactions that were originally elicited only by unconditioned stimuli, forming primary conditioned responses. When similar stimulating events recur or are presented verbally by others, the body produces corresponding unconscious reactions.

In other words, unconscious behaviors can be traced back to conditioned reflexes, and these reflexes reveal a person's true thoughts. Once you master behavioral psychology, even the most closely guarded secrets become visible.

Old Niu and Old Xu had been business partners for many years. Recently, a major deal came Old Niu's way, and his first instinct was to discuss it with Old Xu.

However, rumors had reached Old Niu suggesting that Old Xu had found new partners and was shifting investments overseas.

Should he tell Old Xu about the project? Old Niu was torn. Using the pretext of having tea, he invited Old Xu out to sound him out.

During their casual conversation, Old Niu repeatedly hinted at the matter indirectly, but Old Xu, a seasoned businessman, would not easily reveal his thoughts. After a long exchange, Old Niu gained nothing.

Growing frustrated, Old Niu casually placed his teacup right next to Old Xu's. Under normal circumstances this would not matter, and Old Xu would not have minded. This time, however, Old Xu frowned slightly and quietly

lifted his own cup to take a sip.

Old Niu noticed the subtle movement and felt a sudden unease. He swallowed the words he had been about to say.

Sure enough, after watching for some time, Old Niu discovered that Old Xu had indeed shifted his investment direction and was gradually moving away from their partnership.

As a veteran in business, Old Xu could keep his words airtight, yet his small action betrayed his inner sense of distance from Old Niu. Had Old Niu not possessed some knowledge of behavioral psychology and recognized the hidden meaning behind that gesture, he might have continued treating Old Xu as before, only to face betrayal by his long-time partner and possibly even risk the major deal itself.

This shows how important it is in daily life to uncover the hidden meanings behind others' small actions. We usually study psychology books to judge others' mental states so that, knowing both ourselves and others, we can succeed in every endeavor. Learning psychology is like building a house: the height of the structure depends on the strength of the foundation. Techniques such as cold reading or psychological manipulation focus on skills and methods, whereas behavioral psychology addresses the root of judgment. Without accurately reading another's psychology, even extensive technique will yield half the results with twice the effort. With correct psychological insight, all techniques become twice as effective with half the effort.

## **Inferring the Other Person's True Psychological State from Behavior**

### **Micro-expression Keywords**

Psychologist Sigmund Freud once said: "Anyone with intact senses will eventually believe that no one can keep a secret. If his lips are sealed, his fingertips will speak, and every pore on his body will betray him." Our words may deceive, but behavior cannot lie.

As a child, I read the Sherlock Holmes detective stories and admired Holmes's seemingly supernatural deductive powers. After studying behavioral psychology, I realized that Holmes often judged whether someone was lying or hiding something by observing their behavior. These judgments, it turns out, were usually correct, and this intuitive approach aligns with the theoretical findings of behavioral psychology.

*The Silence of the Lambs, The Rock, The Rock (alternate title), True Lies, Die Hard...* These familiar film titles draw us into battles between justice and evil, filled with passion and intensity. At the same time, the weighty name FBI has entered the minds of most citizens.

FBI stands for Federal Bureau of Investigation, America's premier intelligence agency. Every FBI agent is among the elite of U.S. law enforcement. Only after multiple rounds of selection and three months of rigorous, fully enclosed training do candidates earn the right to serve as FBI agents. During this training, the most critical and important course is behavioral psychology.

Why must even FBI agents study behavioral psychology?

Dealing daily with terrorists and highly intelligent criminals, FBI agents need to determine immediately whether someone is lying to them or even what the person is thinking. Many criminals are skilled liars, so relying solely on verbal cues can easily miss the truth. Therefore, FBI agents primarily rely on behavioral analysis to understand a suspect's mental state.

Veteran agent Navarro, with more than twenty years at the FBI, once visited the mother of an armed fugitive during a pursuit. He and a colleague entered the elderly woman's home, showed their credentials, and began routine questioning. When Navarro asked, "Is your son at home?" he noticed the woman place her hand on her neck before answering, "No, he is not."

After several more questions, Navarro asked again, "Could your son sneak into your house while you are out?" Once more, the woman put her hand to her neck and replied, "No, I don't think so."

Navarro remained impassive and continued questioning until, just before leaving, he asked pointedly, "So, to summarize my notes, your son is definitely not in this house, correct?"

This time the woman again placed her hand on her neck and nodded.

Navarro was almost certain she was lying and that her son was hidden inside. After obtaining a search warrant, the agents found the fugitive in a concealed space beneath a stack of boxes.

In this real case, Navarro applied the principles of behavioral psychology. When people experience a negative reaction to something they have said or done—for example, lying—they unconsciously perform self-soothing gestures such as touching the neck or nose to mask or relieve inner discomfort. The elderly woman's repeated gestures allowed the experienced Navarro to see through her immediately.

In today's colorful society, lying has become commonplace for most people. Judging truthfulness from words alone is extremely difficult, especially with ruthless and cunning criminals who can lie without changing expression and argue calmly. Therefore, reading behavior to discern inner thoughts is the only reliable way to secure a confession.

Seated across the table, the suspect answered the FBI agent's questions with careful caution. His words were sincere, and he had solid evidence placing him elsewhere at the time of the crime. Still, the agent pressed on.

"If you were to kill someone, would you use a gun?"

The suspect shrugged, shook his head, and put on a helpless expression.

"Then, if you were to kill someone, would you use a knife?"

The suspect repeated the same gesture and shook his head.

"If you were to kill someone, would you use a hammer?"

"No." The suspect shook his head again.

"If you were to kill someone, would you use an ice pick?"

At this question, the suspect showed a slight change in expression. His eyelids visibly drooped, as if trying to hide something, but the movement vanished instantly.

The sharp-eyed FBI agent noticed it. The suspect became the prime suspect in the case. Further investigation confirmed he was the murderer.

A single blink lasting only 0.2 to 0.4 seconds revealed the suspect's flaw. The abnormal bodily reaction triggered by hearing the murder weapon he had actually used—an ice pick—gave the FBI the breakthrough they needed. It is precisely this sensitivity to physical actions that allows FBI agents to perceive psychological shifts at a glance, much like the superhuman figures in ordinary people's eyes.



It is no exaggeration to call behavioral psychology the FBI's ultimate secret for reading people. Senior FBI agents have stated: "In actual investigations, reading a person's inner world from their external body language is extremely helpful for solving difficult cases. That is why we make instruction on decoding internal information through body language a core part of FBI training."

After systematic training in behavioral psychology, FBI agents mentally "scan" every subtle movement of a suspect and analyze its precise meaning. Mastery of this skill enables them to seize critical details, solve extraordinary cases, and become the living legends among us.

## Using the Subconscious to Help You Understand Others' Deepest Secrets

### Micro-expression Keywords

In his work *Death in the Afternoon*, the renowned author Ernest Hemingway compared literary creation to an iceberg. In reality, human consciousness resembles an iceberg as well. Therefore, mastering 95 percent of another person's subconscious through behavioral psychology proves far more useful than struggling to control the mere 5 percent of conscious awareness.

Anyone who has seen *Titanic* remembers the scene in which the liner strikes the iceberg. When the ship veered sharply to avoid an iceberg smaller than one-tenth its own size, many viewers held their breath. Yet how many have asked why the sight of such a modest iceberg caused panic among everyone aboard, why Captain Edward ordered an emergency turn, and why an iceberg of that volume could slice the supposedly unsinkable *Titanic* in two?

A detail in the film supplies the answer. As the hull advanced through the water, a massive dark shape scraped violently against the submerged portion of the ship, breaching the section hidden beneath the surface and allowing seawater to flood the engine room.

That dark shape was the part of the iceberg concealed below the waterline. It also illustrates the psychological principle we will discuss—the iceberg effect.

The iceberg effect, also known as iceberg theory, was proposed by the psychologist Sigmund Freud. He argued that personality resembles an iceberg floating in the sea: only the tip is visible above the surface, corresponding to the conscious level, while the far larger portion that remains hidden belongs to the subconscious, which to a great extent governs development and behavior.

The subconscious refers to a mysterious force buried beneath conscious awareness, sometimes called right-brain consciousness or cosmic consciousness. In daily life it is often described as "potential"—an undeveloped capacity that exists within the body.

In a report, Dr. Konstantin of the University of Vienna estimated that the human brain contains roughly 150 billion neurons. Each neuron connects with others to form neural circuits that process information. At least 95 percent of these neurons remain undeveloped; even a scientific giant such as Albert Einstein utilized only about 2 percent of his subconscious capacity.

This demonstrates the enormous influence the subconscious exerts. Although we cannot directly control it, our behavior, movements, expressions, and attitudes are shaped by it at every turn. Consequently, understanding another person's subconscious offers invaluable assistance in approaching others and earning their trust without conscious effort.

Language and outward appearance reflect the conscious mind, which people can regulate, whereas the subconscious can be inferred only through observation of unconscious actions. The most rapid and reliable method for discerning another's subconscious is therefore the behavioral psychology presented in this book.

Meihong, a graduate of a prestigious foreign university, secured an interview at a large company through a friend's introduction.

The interviewer, a sharp and capable-looking female executive, displayed the polished demeanor expected of a mid-level leader in a major corporation. She invited Meihong to sit, reviewed her résumé, asked several professional questions, and inquired about Meihong's impressions of the company.

Their exchange proceeded in a formal, measured manner, yet the observant Meihong noticed that the interviewer repeatedly glanced at her watch and kept her feet angled toward the door.

Once the standard questions ended, it was time for Meihong to speak freely. By then the company's closing hour had already passed. Checking her own watch, Meihong made a decision that surprised the interviewer: "Manager Zhang, it is already quite late. Why don't we continue while we walk? The time it takes to reach the parking lot should be enough for my self-introduction."

"Er... all right." Although surprised, Manager Zhang's slightly furrowed brow relaxed.

On the way, Meihong delivered a concise self-introduction. Although incomplete because of time constraints, the interviewer's attitude shifted from strictly businesslike to noticeably warmer and even slightly cordial.

The next morning Meihong received word that she had passed the interview and could begin work at the new company.

Most candidates would have tried to use every available minute to showcase their strengths. Why did Meihong's seemingly "lazy" approach instead win the interviewer's favor?

Attentive readers will recognize that Meihong succeeded by observing the interviewer's behavior. As a mid-level manager, the interviewer felt obliged to maintain a professional image at all times. Even though she was eager to leave, she could not show it outwardly. Her actions, however, betrayed her: the unconscious glances at her watch and the feet pointing toward the door revealed an urgent desire to finish and go home.

These movements may have gone unnoticed by the interviewer herself, yet Meihong registered them. By responding to the unspoken cue, Meihong left a favorable impression on the interviewer's subconscious. Combined with her own qualifications, the job offer followed naturally.

Judging another person's subconscious thoughts through behavior is therefore far more practical than guessing conscious intentions from words or expressions alone. If human consciousness is likened to an iceberg, 95 percent of its volume lies hidden beneath the surface in the subconscious. Behavior, being directly linked to the subconscious, supplies the most important information available to us.

### **Hands Formed into a Steeple Shape, Indicating Confidence**

FBI agents have observed that confident speakers rarely touch their mouths, noses, or hair. When watching a confident presenter, one notices that the speaker relies almost exclusively on hand gestures to emphasize words and avoids contact with the face or head.

Agents have also noted that confident individuals maintain an upright, proud posture, never slouching or shifting restlessly. They sustain eye contact longer than less confident people, who tend to do the opposite.

Confident people frequently form a steeple with their hands by pressing the fingertips of both hands together, creating the shape of a church steeple (see Figure 2.11). The gesture is sometimes interpreted as affected, arrogant, or proud.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.11 将手摆成尖塔状]

In *The Art of Reading Minds in the White House*, author Henry H. Calero recounts an anecdote involving the steeped-hands gesture.

Steve McQueen, the American actor nicknamed “The King of Cool,” appeared in many popular films, including the classic *The Great Escape*.

During a flight, Calero found himself seated next to McQueen in first class. They began talking, and when the conversation turned to McQueen’s performance as a poker player in *The Cincinnati Kid*, Calero remarked that the portrayal was unconvincing.

McQueen folded his arms, fixed Calero with his piercing blue eyes, and asked sharply, “What do you mean?”

Calero explained that in a key scene McQueen’s character inadvertently revealed a winning hand by forming a steeple after placing a bet. McQueen nodded, and Calero continued: steady professional players never make that gesture unless they are bluffing, yet McQueen’s character clearly was not. The scene therefore contained a nonverbal error.

After hearing the explanation, McQueen dropped his arms, snapped his fingers, and told Calero that others had offered the same criticism but could not explain why—they simply “felt” something was wrong.

McQueen shook Calero’s hand warmly and thanked him. The remainder of the flight passed pleasantly.

People sometimes adopt the steeped-hands position while speaking or listening, though the hands may rest slightly higher or lower than shown in Figure 2.11.

Those who rarely use the gesture may raise their hands so high that they peer through the gaps between their fingers, an action that can make others uncomfortable. If you must continue a conversation with such a person, practice self-control. A lower steeple is most common among women (see Figure 2.12).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.12 双手位置较低的尖塔状手势]

An elegant variation occurs when the hands are clasped with one hand gently enclosing the other, which is formed into a fist (see Figure 2.13).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.13 优雅的尖塔状手势]

This refined steeple most often appears in business settings. Company employees, lawyers, doctors, and especially professors lecturing on favorite topics frequently adopt it, apparently signaling satisfaction with their current roles.

Most of the time the steeped-hands gesture is unconscious, yet some people deliberately employ it to project strong security and absolute confidence.

One piece of advice suggests that, after delivering a final offer in negotiations, a businessperson should lean back, smile, and form the steeple. The client, after studying the gesture for some time, may then declare, "Deal!" The movement seems to exert a quiet power that can sway the other party.

FBI agents have also observed that when the weaker party in a negotiation forms a steeple, the stronger party may conclude that the person is holding something back and knows more than has been said, prompting an immediate change of subject.

If your next argument lacks the persuasive force you hoped for, try forming a steeple, remain silent, and wait for the other person's reaction.

### **Resting Chin on Hand: Contemplating or Bored**

Success in business or social life depends on communication skills, so anyone who wants to know how well their message has been received must understand and evaluate feedback.

Several specific gestures indicate that a person is contemplating received verbal information. Without careful observation, however, these gestures can be difficult to detect. Consider a young teacher explaining a principle who notices a student staring fixedly, unblinking, sitting rigidly with almost no movement. The teacher may assume the student is fully attentive, yet that assumption would be mistaken. Some people can feign rapt attention when they are not truly engaged.

A genuinely attentive student sits on the edge of the chair, leans forward, tilts the head slightly to one side, and may rest the chin on a hand (see Figure 2.24). A tilted head usually signals that the listener is not only hearing the words but also reflecting on them.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.24 揣摩的姿势]

As C. H. Woolbert wrote in *The Audience*: "When a student in class gradually becomes absorbed by the problem before him, he generally slumps his shoulders, spreads his feet, scratches his head, and performs many unconscious movements. Once the problem is solved, he sits up straight, straightens his clothes, and returns to his normal state."

Auguste Rodin's sculpture *The Thinker* exemplifies the language of posture. No one doubts that the figure is deeply pondering a difficult question and seeking its solution. In everyday life we often see "The Thinker" pose or similar postures, indicating that the person is reflecting on something puzzling or troublesome.

It is worth noting that contemplative gestures can easily be mistaken for signs of boredom. When someone loses interest, they may also rest their chin on a hand (see Figure 2.25), though in the latter case the eyelids droop and the gaze becomes vacant.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.25 表示厌烦的典型动作]

Sometimes a person adopts a series of critical contemplative postures: placing one hand on the cheek, cupping the jaw, extending the index finger along the face while curling the remaining fingers beneath the mouth (see Figure 2.26). This posture shows that the individual is both weighing the speaker's words and evaluating the ideas being presented.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.26 批判性的揣摩姿势]

Another contemplative gesture involves stroking the chin or beard (for men with facial hair) (see Figure 2.27). This “let me think” posture typically appears when someone is about to make a decision. The accompanying facial expression often features slightly narrowed eyes, as if considering the matter from a long-term perspective to determine the best answer.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.27 抚摸下巴的揣摩姿势]

Sliding glasses down the nose and peering over the rims at the speaker is another common contemplative gesture (see Figure 2.28). The person being observed may feel criticized or looked down upon. Anyone who habitually uses this posture should recognize its potentially negative effect; if you wish to avoid an unfavorable response, refrain from it.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.28 通过眼镜缝隙窥探]

People who wear glasses sometimes remove them slowly and carefully clean the lenses—even when the lenses are already clean—to manage conflict or buy time for a decision. While performing this action they usually speak more slowly.

A similar time-buying gesture is to remove the glasses and place one temple arm between the teeth (see Figure 2.29). This posture indicates that the person is listening attentively and carefully considering what is being said.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.29 拖延时间, 仔细思考]

## Section 2: Having a Pair of Confident Hands

Since ancient times, open palms have always been associated with truthfulness, honesty, and compliance. If you want to know whether someone is being candid, the most direct method is to observe their palm movements. Through long-term practice, gestures have acquired specific meanings and become a powerful means of expressing thoughts and feelings, holding a primary position in body language. Gestures assist speakers in conveying ideas and emotions through changes in the fingers, palms, and arms. Graceful and engaging gestures create a sense of pleasure, while gentle gestures evoke gratitude; negative and listless gestures produce feelings of depression and displeasure.

In interpersonal interactions, gestures form an important component. They reinforce the power of language and enrich its color through supplementation and clarification—thus enhancing emotional expressiveness while also describing objects more concretely. At times, gestures can even function as an independent and effective form of language, such as in situations where speaking is inconvenient. Moreover, gestures play a greater role for deaf and mute individuals than any other communication method.

Although gestures can assist speakers in expressing their intended content, improper use produces the opposite effect, as unnatural gestures become obstacles to interaction. When employing gesture language, observe the following points:

1. Apply gestures appropriately so they fulfill their function.
2. Gestures do not suit every occasion and every audience.
3. Using gestures to express meaning should occur unconsciously rather than through deliberate movements.
4. Gestures must coordinate with speech; avoid actions that directly contradict spoken words.

So, which gestures qualify as positive and convey constructive messages?

The most renowned is the “steeple” gesture. Psychologists Nivenber and Cabro conducted specialized research on the steeple gesture and found that professionals such as lawyers, accountants, and managers use it most frequently during interactions; when superiors address subordinates, the steeple gesture appears most often.

The steeple gesture has two forms: the “upright steeple” and the “inverted steeple.” Generally, the upright steeple indicates the person’s sense of confidence and superiority. When someone forms this gesture while also tilting their head upward, it shows they feel highly confident, even somewhat self-important, at that moment.

Note that, like spoken language, gestures require surrounding context for accurate interpretation. For example, a salesperson observes a customer leaning forward, palms open, smiling, and finally forming the upright steeple; this indicates the customer is satisfied with the products and signals the conversation is ending in preparation to place an order or make a purchase. However, if the upright steeple appears after a series of negative body-language signals—such as arms crossed over the chest, legs crossed, and gaze wandering—it shows the customer is dissatisfied and has no intention of buying. Many might view the second scenario as conveying negative information and conclude the upright steeple does not apply in all confident situations. In reality, for the customer the gesture expresses personal confidence in both cases: the first reflects firm intent to buy, the second firm intent not to buy. The difference lies only in the salesperson’s perspective—positive in the former, negative in the latter. Therefore, when encountering the upright steeple, always combine it with preceding body-language cues for a comprehensive judgment.

The inverted steeple commonly appears when listening to others’ opinions and occurs more frequently among women, suggesting a low-profile, slightly reserved stance. Like the upright steeple, an inverted steeple following positive body language indicates acceptance; conversely, following negative body language it signals rejection or negation.

Research shows that the higher a person’s confidence level, the higher the position of the steeple gesture—sometimes even level with the eyebrows, as if viewing others through the gaps between the fingers. Interestingly, negotiators sometimes unconsciously adopt this posture when at a disadvantage. The counterpart’s reaction is almost invariably the same: they assume the person displaying the gesture is concealing information and knows more than they reveal, prompting an immediate change of topic. In poker, if an opponent forms the steeple gesture, stop playing unless you hold a strong hand.

If you rarely use the steeple gesture yet wish to increase your own confidence, the following points may help:

#### **Section 4: When Excited, Do Your Hands Sweat or Tremble?**

Some people’s hands sweat or tremble when they feel nervous. Once the tension subsides, the sweating and trembling disappear automatically. What causes these reactions?

First, consider the causes of sweaty hands.

Under pressure, the body’s hormones trigger the release of stored energy to supply the brain and limbs for handling sudden events, rapidly raising body temperature. Yet organs function normally only at a constant temperature and cannot tolerate excessive heat. The body therefore secretes sweat to lower temperature and thereby relieve tension.

Sweating falls into three categories according to stimulus type: thermal sweating, emotional sweating, gustatory sweating, and exertional sweating. Thermal sweating results from elevated external temperature and generally affects all skin except the palms and soles. Emotional sweating arises from mental excitement or stimulation and occurs mainly on the palms, soles, and armpits. Gustatory sweating is a physiological response triggered by eating certain stimulating foods. Exertional sweating, as the name implies, occurs after physical activity.

Sweaty palms during tension, fear, or excitement constitute emotional sweating. Emotional sweating typically appears on the palms and sometimes on the backs of the hands, face, neck, forearms, and lower legs. Palmar sweating relates to physical constitution and endocrine factors. A healthy person's palms remain dry even during profuse perspiration elsewhere. People who frequently experience sweaty palms often have dry skin elsewhere yet cold, clammy palms. In extreme cases of intense mental stress, some individuals sweat profusely over the entire body. Others progress to more severe symptoms: cold sweats accompanied by pallor, visual disturbances, limb weakness, collapse, or fainting. In such emergencies, first identify the cause. Under major shock, the body rapidly converts blood sugar and other nutrients into energy; this sudden surge can lower blood sugar and trigger the symptoms described. Pinching the philtrum (the point between the nose and upper lip) and the tiger's mouth (the point at the base of the thumb) can alleviate symptoms. If sweating is accompanied by chills, cold extremities, irregular pulse, or shortness of breath, the issue may extend beyond emotional sweating and indicate a cardiac problem; seek an electrocardiogram at a proper hospital.

Next, examine the causes of hand trembling.

Hand tremors fall into two major categories: physiological and pathological. Physiological tremors are small in amplitude and rapid in speed, usually appearing at rest as fine, quick, irregular movements. They commonly occur under mental tension, fear, emotional agitation, severe pain, or extreme fatigue. Once the triggering factors are removed, the tremor disappears, so its impact on daily life remains limited. Pathological tremors involve involuntary shaking that is often permanent and subdivide into resting and action tremors. Resting tremor occurs when muscles are fully relaxed, i.e., in a quiet state; it disappears during sleep and follows a regular pattern, as seen in Parkinson's syndrome. Action tremor appears only during movement and intensifies as the limb approaches a target. It is irregular, large in amplitude, and intensifies with emotion; it commonly results from lesions of the cranial or upper-limb nerves.

Trembling during emotional excitement belongs to physiological tremor. Although its daily-life impact is minor, it can still interfere in special situations such as interviews or speeches. The most effective way to address trembling is positive mental suggestion: first, reduce self-focus. Shift attention to the task at hand rather than monitoring personal sensations. Focusing on whether the hands are trembling activates the brain and reinforces the behavior, potentially worsening the condition. Therefore, decrease self-attention and concentrate on the actual situation—such as the interviewer, the examiner, or the environment. Second, abandon the intention to control. When people notice trembling, they often try to suppress it, yet the harder they try, the more ineffective the control becomes, increasing tension. Instead, relinquish the control impulse, ignore the tremor, and allow it to subside naturally once calm returns. Cultivating acceptance of the tremor and learning to coexist with it can also lead to eventual resolution.

### **Different Gestures Convey Different Emotions**

In social interactions, many people possess several distinctive signature gestures. Through these gestures we can gain some understanding of a person's psychological state and emotional changes.

Even before language emerged, humans had learned to express different meanings through various gestures. After language appeared, people continued to use gestures frequently in communication because many found that relying solely on the mouth often proved insufficient. Consequently, gestures have become an indispensable part of interpersonal communication. These gestures carry not only surface meanings but also numerous implied meanings.

During conversation, people habitually place their hands in front of the body, speaking while forming various gestures that serve as supplementary "language" rather than relying only on speech. It can be said that people unconsciously employ gestures to exchange ideas, express emotions, and convey feelings.

Various emotions manifest through different gestures. What emotions do specific gestures reflect?

### 1. Palms facing upward

In conversation, palms facing upward constitute a positive signal suggesting an open communicative attitude, indicating sufficient candor with nothing concealed and no malice. This gesture reflects the speaker's desire for interaction and acceptance by the other party.

### 2. Palms facing downward

In conversation, palms facing downward represent a commanding signal denoting status, authority, or orders. For instance, when a couple holds hands, if the man's palm faces down and the woman's faces up, it indicates the man's dominance. This gesture reflects the speaker's wish to diminish the other person while elevating the self. Additionally, palms often face downward when refusing someone.

### 3. Palms facing each other

When the other person places palms facing each other with fingertips touching to form a steeple shape, it usually indicates a confident attitude. This common gesture has two variants: the lowered steeple, used when listening to others' views; and the raised steeple, typically employed when expressing one's own opinions or speaking.

### 4. Extending the index and middle fingers

With the palm outward, the gesture signifies "victory"; with the palm inward, it becomes an insulting expression.

### 5. Fingers interlocked

Many people enjoy forming the interlocked-fingers gesture, which relates closely to psychology. When someone interlocks their fingers, it signals confidence. Such individuals often smile, appear composed, and speak frankly. If they interlock their fingers on their thighs with thumbs touching, it means they feel uncertain and caught in a dilemma. If they interlock their fingers while staring at you, it indicates dissatisfaction and ongoing restraint.

### 6. Clenching the fingers

Clenching the fingers is commonly called making a fist. In combat, the fist embodies strength for both offense and defense. When used in daily life, the gesture communicates "I am full of power" and "You had better not provoke me." It constitutes a provocative or demonstrative action.

### 7. Hands clasped together

Clasping the hands together expresses a sense of helplessness. Even when the person smiles, the inner feeling of loss and frustration remains visible. Typically, someone who feels their words lack persuasiveness or who perceives themselves in a passive position during conversation will clasp their hands. The clasped-hands posture has three variations: raising both hands to the face and clasping



them tightly; resting elbows on the knees or table and clasping the hands; or standing with hands clasped in front of the lower abdomen. The height of the hands also reflects the intensity of the frustration. Hands held high in the middle of the body indicate a highly negative mindset and rejection of further interaction. Hands placed lower on the body signal milder frustration, making conversation relatively easier.

## 2. Hands Restrained Behind the Body

Hands restrained behind the body also indicate endurance, yet without self-protective intent—an unyielding, head-on form of endurance.

Thus, when the spine is not fully erect, the torso leans slightly forward, the legs stand straight and together, the body remains still, and the hands are placed behind the back in restraint, this constitutes a freeze response. Because the person dares to face the stimulus source directly without defense, the posture carries a sense of “taking it head-on,” reflecting a stronger drive than hands restrained in front of the body.

When the hands are clasped behind the back with the torso erect and the head held high, the posture is often interpreted as a sign of maturity or control. See Figure 4-4.

Several subtler variations appear to have reasonable explanations for restraining the hands and may even seem stylish—for example, inserting both hands into trouser pockets. Similar adaptations include a novice host holding a microphone in one hand (thus occupying it and providing a plausible excuse) while placing the other hand in a pocket. See Figures 4-5 and 4-6. Such postures generally occur only in inexperienced young men (age extendable to 40), who also believe the stance looks dashing.

Less stylish examples include pulling the sleeves down to cover the hands, ostensibly because of cold weather, thereby concealing the restrained hands. See Figure 4-7. Unless the temperature is genuinely low, this posture represents a freeze response.

In essence, these postures use external means to restrain hand movement. In context, they can all be interpreted as freeze responses stemming from uncertainty, reflecting inner tension and anxiety. If this interpretation seems forced, consider a simple question: when have you seen national leaders place their hands in their pockets during formal occasions?

These hand-freeze responses follow an underlying psychological pattern. Expansive limb movements signify expansion and a positive mental state; varied limb movements indicate diversity and richness of mind; conversely, contractive limb movements represent concealment, self-diminishment, and a negative mental state. Whether the hands rest in front or behind the body, or inside pockets, the underlying psychology is to reduce the body’s visible surface area (military parade-rest posture excepted) or to decrease the variety of limb movements and the degree of attention received (less movement is wiser when unskilled), thereby minimizing exposure to harm such as criticism or rejection.

Conversely, individuals who feel strong control over a situation do not adopt these postures. In a popular television program, for instance, the host rarely places hands in pockets because reputation and experience grant command of the scene and a dominant mindset.

We can readily imagine that a boss feels similarly in control within their own domain. When reprimanding subordinates, the boss does not confine the hands to one location or posture. Trained professional actors, possessing command of the performance space, do not insert hands into pockets or adopt other restrained

postures when taking the stage or speaking; instead, they naturally position the hands at the sides of the body, moving them appropriately with the action.

Even without a sense of control, mere situational security precludes hand-freeze responses. At a gathering of friends, genuinely happy people converse animatedly, raise glasses, and adopt relaxed, casual postures and movements rather than remaining restrained. Strangers, by contrast, often stay frozen in a corner, avoiding interaction. In such settings, anyone displaying a hand-freeze response stands out conspicuously—either from unfamiliarity or from low self-esteem—making the reaction easy to identify.

### **People Who Twirl Their Hands by Their Ears Are Giving Hints**

FBI agent Laura received orders from the Federal Bureau of Investigation to enter a certain insurance company to investigate whether the company had established spy operations in other countries. However, there was an unwritten rule for entering this company: every employee on probation must sell a set amount of insurance within the one-month probationary period to become a permanent employee.

One day a middle-aged couple came to the insurance company, and Laura greeted them. Laura first welcomed them warmly, then introduced various insurance products suitable for their age group. The couple did not appear very interested, which made Laura wonder whether they had come to buy insurance or merely to gather information. Yet during the conversation, when Laura mentioned a family insurance policy, one of the couple casually touched an ear with a hand. Laura therefore concluded that they wanted to purchase a family combination policy.

To test her conclusion, Laura asked, "Are you interested in learning about family combination insurance?" The couple looked surprised but answered seriously: "Yes, because we have considered our children."

Laura then focused on family insurance and explained in detail the various family-unit policies. Clearly she had found an effective entry point, and one of the products won the couple's approval. In the end Laura met her sales target and became a permanent employee of the insurance company.

American marketing consultant Mike Stark once said, "If the other person touches an ear, they are signaling interest." When we speak, if the listener pulls an earlobe, touches an ear, or rubs the temple or the back of the head near the ear, it means the listener is interested in the topic and wants to hear more. This matches the Japanese saying "Pull the ears open to hear good words."

The subconscious act of touching the ear to signal a desire to keep listening is easy to notice. For example, when someone says "I'm very interested in this topic" or "Really? Why haven't I heard of that before?" the words are often accompanied by an ear touch. The gesture shows that the listener has become engaged and wants the conversation to continue. We should therefore identify the other person's "sensitive words" of interest and keep the discussion going; doing so helps both sides communicate effectively.

We should also note that if, during a conversation, the listener folds the entire auricle forward to cover the ear canal, the gesture is a signal to stop talking at once. The movement already conveys the message "I don't want to hear any more; I've heard enough." It is the same action children sometimes make when they cover their ears with both hands to shut out their parents' arguing voices from another room.

Adults who do not wish to hear someone speak usually perform a similar gesture. While you are speaking enthusiastically, if the listener inserts a finger into the ear canal as though cleaning the ear, the action signals disdain for your topic. It is best to ask politely whether the listener has any comments or objections. If the person is not someone you can question directly, you should consider changing the subject.

Therefore, while conversing we must observe whether the other person is touching an ear or trying to shift the topic. In short, if the listener's hands are twirling beside the ears, the gesture is telling us it is time to be on guard.

## **Interpreting Different Emotions from Ear Scratching**

Ear scratching is a common action, and the precise spot being scratched reveals different emotions. When someone scratches an ear in front of you, the ear itself is "speaking."

We often see children cover both ears with their hands when their parents scold them, signaling that they do not want to listen. Adults who do not want to hear someone speak will not cover their ears but will scratch them instead. Moreover, the part of the ear that is scratched carries a distinct meaning. What, then, do the different scratching locations signify? Let us examine them one by one.

### **1. Using the fingertip to dig inside the ear**

If you are speaking enthusiastically and the listener, looking uninterested, inserts a fingertip into the ear canal and digs, the gesture expresses disdain. Many people find the action particularly offensive. When you see someone digging inside an ear with a fingertip, you can politely ask, "Do you have a different opinion? I'd like to hear it." Giving the listener a chance to speak keeps the exchange going; otherwise the listener remains resistant and disengaged, rendering the conversation unproductive.

### **2. Rubbing behind the auricle**

Suppose you are trying to persuade a customer. After speaking until your mouth is dry, you notice the customer unconsciously rub behind the auricle, then turn the head aside and say coolly, "I'll think about it." The gesture shows that the customer holds the opposite view and is preparing to state it. If you continue with the same sales pitch, the effort will most likely fail. Rubbing behind the auricle means the listener is trying to keep your words from entering the ear completely.

### **3. Folding the entire auricle forward to cover the ear canal**

If, while talking, you see the listener fold the entire auricle forward to cover the ear canal, stop speaking immediately. The movement signals "I'm tired of listening and don't want you to continue." By covering the ear canal with the auricle, the listener physically blocks unwanted words and expresses impatience. In films we often see the female lead on a blind date with a man she finds unappealing; while she smiles politely, she folds the auricle forward to cover the ear canal. The gesture lets her see only the man's moving mouth without hearing any sound. Although the scene adds an artistic touch, it vividly conveys the character's inner feeling. When someone folds the auricle forward to cover the ear canal, remember to change the subject or end the conversation at once; otherwise you will only appear long-winded and make the listener dislike you even more.

### **4. Repeatedly scratching the earlobe or the back of the ear**

If a person keeps scratching the earlobe or the back of the ear, the action indicates anxiety. Seeing someone scratch the back of the ear usually means the person is facing a problem. If you notice a colleague repeatedly scratching the back of the ear, you can approach and ask whether help is needed. The colleague may be experiencing work difficulties, and offering assistance will leave a favorable impression.

## **Confidence**

Confident speakers rarely make small gestures such as covering the mouth, hiding the nose, or scratching the head. Watch any confident speaker and you will notice that the person uses the hands only to emphasize words and almost never touches the face or head.

You will also observe that confident people stand tall and proud, never slouching or shifting their weight from side to side. In addition, they maintain frequent eye contact and hold the other person's gaze longer, whereas people lacking confidence do the opposite.

Confident people often form a steeple gesture with the hands—the same gesture discussed in Chapter 3—by bringing the fingertips of both hands together so they touch and form a “church steeple” shape (see Figure 4.22).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.22 尖塔状手势]*

People sometimes adopt this gesture while speaking or listening, though the hands may be positioned slightly higher or lower than shown. The lower steeple is most common among women (see Figure 4.23).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.23 双手位置较低的尖塔状手势]*

Another elegant version of the steeple occurs when the hands are clasped together and one hand wraps around the other, which is formed into a fist (see Figure 4.24).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.24 优雅的尖塔状手势]*

This elegant steeple, a sign of confidence, appears most often in business settings. Company employees, lawyers, doctors, and especially professors lecturing on a favorite subject frequently display it, as though expressing satisfaction with their current position.

People who seldom use the steeple sometimes raise it very high when they do use it, almost looking at others through the gaps between their fingers. The posture can make others feel uneasy. If you must continue a conversation with such a person, you will need to exercise self-control.

We have also found that most behavior is unconscious. In negotiations, a weaker party who makes this gesture may give the stronger party the impression that the gesturer is hiding something and knows more than is being said, prompting an immediate change of topic.

The suggestion, therefore, is that if your next negotiating position is not as persuasive as you would like, form the steeple gesture, remain silent, and wait for the other side's reaction.

Another common sign of confidence is standing with the hands clasped behind the back and the body erect (see Figure 4.25). The posture conveys both confidence and authority. Law-enforcement officers around the world often adopt it. Anyone who has served in the military will immediately recognize it as the stance of a strict drill instructor. In short, the posture is an unmistakable display of power and dignity.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.25 权威的站姿]*

## Readiness

Some people describe the “readiness” posture as aggressive. Here we retain the term “readiness” because a person with a clear goal and strong determination to achieve it is usually too busy gathering information and solving problems to behave in a hostile manner.

Such individuals resemble the people psychologist Abraham Harold Maslow described as operating at the self-actualization (自我实现 is the highest level need in Maslow's hierarchy of needs. People with self-actualization needs seem to be doing their utmost to perfect themselves) level; they exhibit this trait to a greater or lesser degree. The following gestures, or any combination of them, are typical of such people.

One classic readiness posture that is easy to recognize is standing with the hands on the hips. A fully confident person who is ready to accept a task usually stands in this way (both men and women of all ages adopt it, though women tend to place one hand lower on the hip).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.16 表示准备就绪的站姿]

In sports we often see athletes about to enter a game place their hands on their hips. In a business meeting, someone standing with feet apart and hands on hips is usually about to express a serious opinion. If the person is waiting patiently for objections from the group, the arms may also be folded.

Children challenging parental authority likewise place their hands on their hips. Some men, while standing with hands on hips, occasionally pull up their trouser legs.

When determined people stand with hands on hips, they usually place their feet farther apart than usual. The stance emphasizes their resolve and their commitment to their words or plans.

A similar but slightly different readiness posture is the seated version. Notice the consistent elements: (1) the body leans forward; (2) the bent arms and hands rest on the thighs; (3) the legs are apart, as though ready to stand and join the activity.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.17 表示准备就绪的坐姿]

A person displaying a readiness posture—whether standing or sitting—is interested in what is about to be said or done. The interest does not necessarily mean a desire to participate; it may simply mean fascination with the speaker's words. This is probably why the phrase "sitting on the edge of the chair" is used to describe someone who is keenly interested in a matter.

In business meetings, people sitting on the edge of their chairs are usually ready to compromise, cooperate, buy, accept, or make an offer. In other words, the posture signals that the person is about to take action.

Salespeople like to see this posture because it marks the moment they "close the deal." However, if the posture appears together with other negative gestures, it may instead mean "stop," indicating that the person is about to stand up, cancel the negotiation, or end the meeting.

## Frustration

Postures that convey frustration are usually easy to detect. Watch a football game on television and you will see plenty of frustrated faces. For example, when a defensive back evades an opponent and passes the ball to a teammate who then fumbles it into the hands of an opposing player, the player who dropped the ball most often reacts by kicking the ground in anger and slapping the helmet.

If you are watching a baseball game and the batter strikes out, you will see the player angrily throw the bat, scratch the back of the neck, and kick up dirt (or anything else within reach) while walking dejectedly back to the dugout.

Non-baseball players may not throw bats to express frustration, but they perform similar actions: scratching the back of the neck and lowering the head (see Figure 4.20). Slamming a table, snapping a pencil, stamping a foot, and other behaviors carry the same meaning as kicking the ground or throwing a bat.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.20 沮丧地用手抓挠颈背]

Another common frustration gesture is the “hot collar” (see Figure 4.12), in which a person tugs at the shirt collar. The next time you cut in front of another driver and then quickly change lanes, the driver you passed will often make this gesture.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.21 受挫后, 用手扯衣领]

Sometimes frustration is expressed not through body movement but through sound—deep sighs or rapid breathing. One colleague with a quick temper often struggles to control his emotions. When he feels he is approaching his “boiling point,” he begins to inhale forcefully. The sharp intake of breath shows he is trying to stay calm; otherwise he might lose control.

A rancher from Texas once told us that an angry bull snorts loudly through its nostrils before charging. It is a serious warning that must be taken seriously. Psychologists generally agree that when people are frustrated or angry, their breathing becomes rapid and deep, much like a bull panting. The sound is a warning.

Another sound worth noting is the “tsk-tsk.” It is commonly used to express disapproval or disgust and sometimes surprise or regret. We must therefore use all available cues to determine the precise meaning of the sound in any given situation (note: in Syrian, the “tsk-tsk” sound means “no” and is frequently heard in daily life).

If a person kicks the ground, the action indicates frustration. Be careful, however, not to confuse it with the slow, thoughtful walking of someone absorbed in a problem. A person may pause while thinking or deciding and kick the ground absentmindedly.

People sometimes misread frustration gestures, just as they misread other postures. The wise course is therefore to pay attention to what the other person says in order to judge their state of mind.

## Hands on Hips Convey Hostility

Micro-expression keywords: When people argue or fight, they always place both hands on their hips so they can strike at any moment; such a posture is full of hostility. In daily life, some people unconsciously adopt this pose as well, which makes others feel uncomfortable. If you want to make friends, it is best to lower your hands first.

Friends who enjoy sports know that before certain major boxing matches, organizers often have the fighters strike provocative poses for promotional photos to build hype. We frequently see boxers standing with hands on hips, chins slightly raised, looking arrogant and fearless. In fact, if we observe carefully, the hands-on-hips posture appears not only in competitive settings but also often in ordinary life. In the classic work *Hometown*, Lu Xun depicts Yang Ersao with “thin lips...both hands resting on her hips,” portraying a woman of “sharp-tongued and mean” character. Clearly, hands on hips do not convey a friendly or approachable image.

The hands-on-hips gesture can be displayed by different people in different situations—for example, when children argue with parents, when athletes wait for a competition to begin, and so on. When a man’s territory is invaded by another male, he may also use this posture to issue a silent challenge to the intruder.

At a weekend work-summary meeting, colleagues Xiao Zhang and Xiao Wang disagreed over work responsibilities and progress, but thanks to other colleagues and leaders being present, their argument did not escalate. After work, Xiao Zhang went to the smoking area to relax his nerves and suddenly saw Xiao Wang there, hands on hips and a cigarette in his mouth, which instantly filled him with anger. In this scene, Xiao Zhang perceived Xiao Wang's dissatisfaction with the earlier dispute and his unwillingness to let it go, so a new argument began.

Perhaps Xiao Wang had no aggressive intent, yet the posture conveyed an unfriendly attitude and caused misunderstanding.

According to foreign scientists' research, the hands-on-hips posture produces subtle visual and emotional stimulation. With both hands on the hips, a person occupies more space; the elbows that jut outward resemble weapons and create an intimidating effect. This visual stimulus becomes even more pronounced when both parties already sense conflict, triggering psychological defensiveness.

This dominant posture is recognized worldwide; its signal is that the person is ready to attack at any moment. In countless American Western films, it became a classic cowboy pose: before a duel, cowboys always held a revolver in one hand and kept the other on the hip.

The posture makes others feel that the newcomer is ill-intentioned and determined to achieve the targeted goal. Even when conversation is casual and friendly, the hands-on-hips posture prevents a completely relaxed atmosphere unless the arms are lowered from the waist.

Therefore, when talking with others, avoid placing both hands on your hips, as it makes people feel threatened. Even during an argument, refrain from this gesture and instead seek a calm resolution; otherwise, the situation will only worsen.

### 8.2.3 Pointing at the Target of Attack

A person's offensive actions in combat include linear movements such as poking, slapping, or smashing with the hands—fast and forceful—as well as kicking or stomping with the feet, and even biting when enraged.

Similarly, in situations where direct attack is not permitted, although the individual restrains words and actions, once anger arises it is still vented toward the stimulus through various modified offensive gestures. Most of these movements point directly at the stimulus, mimicking real attacks to release inner rage—for instance, offensive hand movements.

The fingers most commonly used to convey meaning are the thumb and index finger.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-10 强势自我认同的手指指向]*

The thumb is naturally used to express praise or approval. Pointing the thumb at oneself while speaking—whether at the nose or the chest—is a very assertive form of self-affirmation whose subtext is "I'm impressive." Raising the thumb toward someone else signals affirmation or encouragement of that person, as shown in Figure 8-10.

In some television dramas or films, pointing the thumb downward to express contempt is used to create a humorous or unexpected dramatic effect: first raising it to suggest approval, then lowering it to indicate disapproval doubles the gap between the two evaluations, making the negation far stronger than a single denial—hence the term "killing with praise," as shown in Figure 8-11.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-11 蔑视的手指指向, 有双倍的蔑视效果]

The index finger is often used for pointing. In Asian cultural etiquette, pointing with the index finger alone is considered disrespectful, as shown in Figure 8-12. Subordinates, for example, normally do not point at superiors with the index finger because both parties recognize the contempt it conveys. Pointing or guiding with the entire palm is a sign of respect, as shown in Figure 8-13.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-12 不尊重的手指指向]

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-13 体现尊重的手掌姿势]

Besides fingers, fists and palms are also common weapons in attacks; offensive movements include chopping (horizontal swing), cleaving (vertical swing), slapping, and smashing. When these movements appear during speech, they reinforce the verbal message. A common positive context is expressing determination: clenching a fist or waving a hand can make others believe in one's sincerity. Using similar gestures in an argument intensifies the anger being expressed. Issuing commands with such movements heightens the command's appeal and impact while conveying the decision-maker's firm resolve.

### **Interlaced Fingers, Clenched Fists, Clasped Hands**

Imagine someone sitting in a conference room with both hands tightly clasped together while saying, "I have always maintained an open-minded attitude and sincerely hope we can solve the problem." Everyone present would consciously or unconsciously notice the inconsistency between words and actions.

An open palm signals candor and sincerity, whereas a clenched fist signals the opposite. By attempting to deceive others in this way to obtain the desired result, the person is likely to achieve the opposite effect and provoke hostility or attack.

When facing pressure and feeling the need to defend, a person may interlace the fingers of both hands tightly (see Figure 3.8). Interlaced fingers usually indicate that the individual is trying to suppress strong emotions (often anger).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.8 十指交叉紧握]

A clenched fist is sometimes used to emphasize an upcoming statement; this is common in passionate speeches. Some people raise a clenched fist and wave it in the air to indicate or express strong emotion, such as vehement opposition. Others hide a clenched fist under an armpit or in a pocket to conceal their feelings (see Figure 3.9).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.9 紧握成拳头且双臂交叉]

In *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals*, Charles Darwin notes that a clenched fist signifies determination or anger and is, in most cases, a hostile gesture. Darwin also observed that when one person clenches a fist, others tend to do the same, especially during a heated argument, which can easily escalate into actual physical combat.

When a person clasps both hands together (see Figure 3.10)—that is, tightly wrings the hands—it indicates anxiety. This gesture often accompanies clenched fists. When asked to answer serious questions or explain behavior, the person typically adopts this posture, revealing concern and tension.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.10 双手交握]



If your conversation partner's hands are tightly clasped or wrung together, you should try to put the person at ease. You will then notice the attitude soften, allowing you to maintain control of the situation.

## Superiority

In every profession, countless nonverbal postures clearly define superior and subordinate status; this is especially common and obvious in the military. In most cases, the more aggressive the superior appears, the more frightened and insecure the subordinate feels and the quicker the response.

Anthropologists hold that men are naturally more "territorial" than women. Both men and women, however, can assert control through nonverbal body movements. One such posture is placing one foot on a table and silently displaying "superiority" (see Figure 4.26).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.26 脚置于桌上的姿势]

In certain environments we also extend our control by placing personal items—books, papers, notebooks, wallets, etc.—on empty seats to prevent others from occupying that space.

For example, university students studying in a library often spread their books and notebooks across a table to discourage others from sitting nearby. This action clearly communicates "I want personal space." British psychiatrist Humphrey Osmond termed this "sociofugal space."

In fact, most of us unconsciously create sociofugal space every day. When watching a movie, we place a coat or scarf on the adjacent empty seat to stop others from sitting there. Upon entering an elevator, we immediately claim an unoccupied corner, just as professional boxers do upon entering the ring. All these behaviors stem from the same psychology.

Sometimes people create sociofugal space to keep out unnecessary individuals while awaiting more suitable ones. For instance, a passenger seated in the aisle may place a briefcase on the window seat until an attractive woman approaches, at which point the briefcase is removed to offer the seat.

When people stand face-to-face, an accepted sociofugal space is the appropriate interpersonal distance. This distance varies by regional culture and by the relationship between the two individuals. One stands closer to a spouse than to a stranger, for example.

If someone invades our space, we feel uncomfortable. Therefore, we must constantly monitor and maintain this distance to avoid making others uneasy.

## Cooperation

Roman Emperor Marcus Aurelius once said: "People are born to help one another, like hands, feet, and eyelids that depend on each other, or lips and teeth that cannot be separated!"

This is indeed the case. If the parts of our body cannot coordinate, trouble arises. Likewise, to achieve certain goals we must cooperate with others. If you wish to obtain help or form a cooperative group, it is essential to notice the following cooperative postures.

We have all experienced situations in which someone who was initially cooperative suddenly reverses attitude 180 degrees and the matter falls through, or someone who once affectionately used a nickname suddenly addresses you by full name in a formal manner while a relaxed smile turns into a frown. These changes indicate that the other party no longer wishes to cooperate.

Therefore, it is very important to observe team members' behavior and find ways to secure their support and participation.

We (Henry Calero and Gerard Nierenberg) once attended a seminar discussing a new product of significant scientific value. Topics included patent rights, equity, royalties, research and development costs, and how to persuade the client company to manufacture and sell the product.

At the start of the discussion, one member of the opposing team adopted an eager posture: sitting forward on the edge of the chair, body leaning ahead, toes touching the floor like a sprinter awaiting the starting signal (see Figure 4.19).

Because this individual was a technical expert on the opposing team, his reaction directly affected our sales outcome. His "ready-to-spring" posture told us he was interested in what we were presenting. We therefore encouraged him to raise technical questions, which our researchers answered one by one.

In fact, we had deliberately chosen seats beside this key person at the outset so we could closely observe his every movement. Once we fully addressed his technical concerns and removed his doubts, his attitude became highly cooperative.

The key to the smooth negotiation was that we immediately recognized the cooperative posture displayed by this technical expert, made good use of it, and quickly concluded a win-win agreement.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.19 跃跃欲试的姿势]*

### **Is a Person Who Covers the Mouth While Speaking Necessarily Lying?**

Observing and understanding others' postures is quite simple, yet accurately interpreting their meaning is extremely difficult. For example, when someone suddenly covers the mouth while speaking, it usually indicates uncertainty about the truth of the statement. If you encounter this situation—someone covers the mouth while talking to you—do you assume the person is lying? Human nature being what it is, we rarely instinctively consider other possibilities. Most people automatically interpret the gesture as lying, uncertainty, or an attempt to hide something.

That may indeed be the case, but before drawing a conclusion, recall whether the person has made this gesture before and, if so, under what circumstances. If not, consider whether the person may have just had dental work, was told of bad breath, or suddenly became aware of it during the conversation. In short, always consider other possibilities.

Although objectively interpreting others' postures is difficult at first, daily practice makes it easier. It is like learning a foreign language: once familiar, it can be used freely.

Most foreign-language teachers strongly recommend that students spend more time listening and watching fluent speakers' pronunciation—that is, "immersion learning." Similarly, once you grasp the meaning of the body movements you see, repeated practice will suffice.

Any gathering place is an excellent observation venue—airports, parks, shopping centers, and especially social gatherings and business meetings that permit free expression of emotion and attitude are ideal for thorough study. Participants at such events are highly engaged and express their views openly.

Another good way to hone people-reading skills is to watch documentary reports, panel discussions, debates, or even fictional crime dramas on television. In simulated performances, actors display a wide range of

emotions and intentions. Interview programs are also worth watching because, during the interview, you unconsciously observe how the interviewee responds to questions through body movements.

When watching these programs, first try to follow the narrative from the visuals alone and note the person's facial expressions, gestures, and postures. Then, every five minutes, turn on the sound and compare the verbal expression with the conclusions you drew from the expressions and postures, paying attention to consistency and coherence.

### **George's Case**

George was a shareholder and manager at a listed company. He considered himself the most generous among all shareholders and never shortchanged his subordinates when it came to dividends or bonuses.

What annoyed George, however, was that in a recent leadership influence survey he had topped the list as the "stingiest leader."

Fuming, George returned to his office, complained to his secretary, and then sent her out for a cup of coffee. After she left, he casually picked up a chocolate from her desk, unwrapped it, and took a bite.

The moment he did so, George regretted it. Beneath the chocolate box lay a note: "Dear, this is my Valentine's gift for you..."

Having eaten someone else's Valentine's gift, what was he to do? George felt flustered but quickly calmed down. When the secretary returned, he would apologize and buy her two boxes of chocolate to make up for it.

Yet it was not merely a matter of a few boxes of chocolate; it was a token of affection from her boyfriend. A voice named conscience protested inside him.

After thinking it over, an idea suddenly struck George. He looked at the half-eaten chocolate still in his hand and reflected on his past behavior. He began to understand why he had been voted "stingiest leader."

He often sent his secretary to buy coffee, black tea, chewing gum, and similar items but never reimbursed her for these "small expenses." Moreover, whenever he felt hungry or thirsty and saw food or drink on someone's desk, he would simply take it. George had previously believed that the extra tens of thousands of dollars in annual bonuses he gave his staff meant no one would mind such trivial matters, but reality suggested otherwise...

Perhaps it was time to correct this habit, George thought.

Born into a wealthy family, George had always been accustomed to having everything handed to him. As a child, people constantly offered him all sorts of fine things to choose from. Although he later became a successful manager, the "little emperor" mindset formed in childhood remained deeply embedded in his behavior. Without recognizing this trait, George could never earn genuine respect from his subordinates no matter how hard he tried.

Through behavior we can uncover the hidden secrets in others' hearts. Likewise, through behavior we can discover another "self" within us that even we ourselves may not notice.

### **Whether the Other Person Is Sincere: Look at the Hands, Not the Face**

How can one judge whether someone is sincere? FBI agents suggest looking at the hands rather than the face. If the other person places open palms in front of the chest with hands facing upward, it indicates an open and candid individual. Sometimes people accompany this gesture by saying, "I have nothing to hide." Actors frequently use this posture not only to convey emotion but also to project an open personality for the character.

When children feel proud of something they have accomplished, they openly show their hands. When they feel guilty or uncertain, they hide their hands in pockets or behind their backs.

Like other attitudes, an open demeanor encourages similar feelings in others. British biologist Charles Darwin observed that when animals express submission (a form of candor), they roll onto their backs with all four feet in the air, exposing their soft underbellies and throats. He noted that even highly hostile animals would not attack a submissive individual in such a posture.

Comparative psychologist Dr. Leon Smith, an expert in animal behavior and communication, once conducted an experiment with a wild wolf. As the fierce wolf snarled and bared its teeth, Smith lay on the ground and exposed his throat. The wolf gently nuzzled him, touching his throat lightly with its teeth but causing no harm.

In formal business meetings, participants seated at a large conference table usually keep their suit jackets on. Observing whether they button or unbutton their jackets reveals whether they feel open or defensive.

When a person feels friendly, relaxed, and comfortable, they unbutton their jacket. If someone says something they dislike, they are likely to button it again and cross their arms.

Those who keep their jackets unbuttoned tend to be active participants in the discussion. They usually lean forward and rest their arms and elbows on the table. Those who sit with jackets tightly buttoned, posture erect, and sometimes arms crossed are generally less engaged.

When participants begin discussing a topic of common interest and reach a basic agreement in principle, they remove their jackets. This signals that the negotiation is moving in a positive direction. Conversely, it indicates the meeting may face difficult issues.

### **Scratching the Back of the Neck Indicates Frustration**

FBI experts note that gestures conveying frustration are usually easy to spot. If you doubt this, watch a football game on television; you will certainly see plenty of frustrated faces. For example, during a play the quarterback evades defenders and passes to a teammate, only for the teammate to fumble. The ball slips through the teammate's hands and lands at an opponent's feet. The player who missed the catch most often reacts by kicking the ground in anger and slapping his helmet to express regret.

If you are watching a baseball game and the batter strikes out, you will see him angrily throw his bat, scratch the back of his neck, then kick the dirt, pebbles, or anything else near his feet while hanging his head as he walks back to the dugout.

Non-baseball players may not throw bats to show annoyance or regret, but they perform similar actions such as scratching the back of the neck and lowering the head. Slamming a table, snapping a pencil, stamping a foot, and other behaviors carry the same meaning as kicking dirt or throwing a bat.

Another common gesture of frustration is the "collar feels hot" posture. Next time you drive, watch your rearview mirror; you may see someone tugging at their shirt collar. If you cut in front of another driver and

quickly merge into their lane, the driver you passed may angrily perform this collar-tugging gesture.

Sometimes frustration is expressed not through body movements but through sounds, such as heavy sighs or rapid breathing. Another sound worth noting is the "tsk-tsk" noise. It is often used to express disapproval or disgust and sometimes surprise or regret. We must therefore use all contextual cues to determine its specific meaning. (Note: In Syrian language the "tsk-tsk" sound means "no" and is common in daily life.)

If a person kicks the ground with their foot, it indicates they are in a frustrated state. Be careful not to confuse this with someone walking slowly while deeply absorbed in thought. A person may pause and kick the ground while pondering a problem or making a decision.

People sometimes misread these frustration gestures just as they misinterpret other postures. Therefore, paying attention to what the other person says is the wise way to assess their mental state.

### **Asu's Case**

Asu was a white-collar worker at a foreign company. His annual salary reached several hundred thousand yuan, placing him among the top performers in his field. Yet Asu had an embarrassing problem: he repeatedly could not control the urge to steal other people's wallets. Even when a wallet contained only a few dozen yuan, he derived pleasure from the act of theft.

The situation grew increasingly serious. Asu had to seek help from a psychologist to resolve the issue.

With the psychologist's assistance, Asu worked hard to recall childhood events and eventually remembered an incident from when he was eight.

It was New Year, and children loved buying firecrackers to set off. Because Asu's father had just gone bankrupt, Asu could only watch others play. One neighbor's child flaunted his firecrackers in front of Asu and called him a "poor ghost." Unwilling to accept the insult, Asu secretly ran home, took his mother's wallet, bought many firecrackers, and enjoyed setting them off.

When he returned home, his mother learned what had happened but did not scold him. After his father came back, however, the parents had a big argument.

Not long afterward the parents divorced. Although Asu's mistake played only a minor role in the divorce, in his childhood subconscious he believed the divorce resulted from his taking the wallet. Because of this belief, Asu developed a compulsion: by repeatedly stealing others' wallets he tried to compensate for the regret in his heart.

Once he understood this, Asu worked to overcome his psychological barrier and broke the habit of stealing.

Without the occurrence of the theft behavior, Asu might never have known that another self—weak, helpless, and guilty—existed inside him. By recognizing this "self," he was able to become more mature and stronger.

Therefore, the first purpose of mastering behavioral psychology is not to study others' minds but to recognize and understand oneself. A Latin American sage put it well: when you truly know yourself and are honest with yourself, no one in the world can deceive you.

Behavioral psychology is undoubtedly the best path to understanding oneself, because behavior largely originates from the subconscious, and the subconscious represents the unknown "self" deep within us.

## 4. The Pressing Handshake

A person can also use this brief ritual to compete. Someone who wishes to signal that they are the dominant party will usually shake hands firmly (displaying strength) while simultaneously pressing downward during the motion (displaying status). If you encounter such a handshake, it indicates that the other person inwardly wants to place you in a lower position. The gesture is not necessarily deliberate; when the other person harbors hostility, they may perform it involuntarily.

## Chapter Summary

### Upward Gaze Reaction

Larger animals win fights more easily; their strength hierarchy is that simple. Humans have inherited this awareness preserved through millions of years of evolution. When feeling confrontational and unwilling to yield, they try to increase their apparent height by straightening the torso and lifting the head. The actual increase in height is negligible, yet the movement alters the viewing angle, creating a top-down visual perspective. In refined confrontations the chin lift may be only slight, but it still highlights the actor's noncompliance and refusal to accept.

Under normal conditions the action of raising the head and chin can be described as an increase in the angle between the jawline and the cervical spine. This indicator serves as a baseline for judgment. If the angle increases, a head-raising movement is present, indicating heightened mentality. When combined with lateral angle changes, confrontational and noncompliant qualities become more pronounced.

### Downward Gaze Reaction

In our social etiquette, apologies after wrongdoing employ bowing or even kneeling. Anyone hoping an apology will be accepted uses the same posture: bending the spine and lowering the head. The curvature of the torso and the downward orientation of the head and face express a weak mentality and fully demonstrate sincerity, guilt, sorrow, and a request for forgiveness. Leg and hand movements usually follow the pattern of the freeze response, reflecting caution and concern that one's actions may anger the other party.

## Chapter 7 This Is My Territory—Territorial Reactions

In the human world, territory signifies authority and a sense of control. People appear relaxed and confident. Once challenged or invaded, strong alertness, anger, and counterattack are triggered. Do not cross a leader's "red line," as it determines your future or even your life. Deliberately offending a controller's territory can

### 8.2.2 Attacking the Desktop

Most work, life, testing, and case investigations occur in environments containing tables. Regardless of how gentle the actor's words, how humble the posture, or how refined the cultivation, if an effective stimulus elicits an attack or a modified attack on the desktop, one can conclude that inner confrontation and anger are present. An example is slapping the table. See Figure 8-7.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 8-7 Destructive actions when angry]*

Slapping the table is the most obvious behavioral sign; any sensible adult can see that the person is angry. Many attacks on the desktop, however, are more subtle. Readers may not have noticed them.

Forcefully tapping the desktop with the index finger or knuckles is also a modified attack gesture. This action usually appears together with strong verbal statements. When one party is speaking alone, the gesture

indicates that the speaker is highly confident, holds a dominant mindset, and believes what they say is inevitable; the gesture emphasizes the words. During an argument, if one side uses this gesture while stressing their viewpoint, it shows they have begun to express dissatisfaction with the other party's noncompliance or lack of understanding. See Figures 8-8 and 8-9.

### **Figures 8-8 and 8-9 Finger tapping indicating mild anger**

Finally, there are other modified attacks on the desktop that involve tools, such as slamming a stack of documents onto the table or, more lightly, releasing the documents so they fall onto the surface. Although no force is applied, gravity still accelerates the documents, expressing the actor's anger. Consider whether you would dare let materials land on the table with a loud "thud" in front of a leader you greatly respect.

Stricter social norms give rise to even more subtle forceful attacks on the desktop. At a standing committee meeting, if a member of the Party committee has no dissenting opinion, they will set their water cup down gently after drinking to avoid any slight sound or forceful motion. Otherwise, others may interpret the action and sound as expressing anger.

### **Reading People Through Hand Gestures**

Every newborn infant grips its tiny thumb inside the palm. This shows that every infant possesses willpower and reasoning ability from the moment of birth. Once the thumb leaves the palm and begins to grow outward, it never returns unless through human intervention or disease. A medical authority once said: "Serious illnesses affecting willpower, such as stroke, epilepsy, and paralysis, weaken the thumb." Experienced physicians determining whether a critically ill or severely injured person will survive examine not only breathing, heartbeat, and pulse but also the thumb. If the thumb has not yet retracted into the palm, there remains a chance of survival; otherwise, the prognosis is poor.

During the American Civil War, a Virginia congressman suggested that the federal government abandon Fort Sumter, Fort Pickens, and other federal properties in the Southern states. Lincoln told the congressman a story:

A lion fell in love with a woodcutter's daughter. The beautiful girl asked the lion to propose to her father. The woodcutter said, "Your teeth are too long." So the lion pulled out its teeth. The woodcutter then said, "Your claws are too long." So the lion pulled out its claws as well. Seeing that the lion had disarmed itself, the woodcutter shot it in the head and killed it.

After finishing the story, Lincoln clenched his fist and declared firmly, "I will not allow myself to end up like that lion! I will never let anyone dictate to me!"

Here, "clenching the fist" conveys decisiveness, determination, confidence, and strength. It is easy to observe that charismatic orators often clench their fists at the climax of their speeches. When facing an enemy, clenching the fist means, "Come on, I am not afraid of you!"

By now you surely know the keyword of this section—hand gestures. In a sense, hand gestures are a person's second face. Hand movements reach different centers of the brain and produce effects of varying scope and depth in different functional areas. Brain activity is also transmitted through nerves to the hands, including various latent thoughts. Therefore, when speaking, people consciously or unconsciously use hand gestures to accompany their voices in order to convey their intentions more accurately. In addition to the clenched fist mentioned above, basic hand postures include the following:

## Offense

Sometimes, certain behaviors of others can be offensive to you. For example, he keeps leaning forward, shortening the distance between the two of you, as if wanting to speak privately. Usually, when people make this offensive move, they pull the normal distance between you (23–25 inches) closer to about 13 inches of intimate distance, while also lowering their voice and whispering to you, to avoid being heard by others. In fact, his approaching you and getting close is very likely a disguise. Before you fully trust this person, ask the other party more questions to determine his true purpose.

A typical gesture with offensive meaning is the "palms down" action. When a person has this thought, she quickly stands up, spreads her hands flat on the table, and states her thoughts one word at a time.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.18 摊牌的姿势]

In most cases, this emotion is hostile, resistant, and destructive in nature. This gesture means: "Damn it! Listen to me!" Therefore, it may trigger a series of serious consequences.

If you notice someone making this move, it is strongly recommended that you recognize it as early as possible and mediate quickly; do not add fuel to her anger. Unfortunately, in real life, many people do exactly that.

When we are offended, the wisest choice is to remain silent rather than impulsively retaliate.

We (Henry Calero and Gerard Nierenberg) once had such an experience. During negotiations with a publisher, the publisher showed opposition because they were dissatisfied with the conditions we proposed. At that moment, we took a deep breath, looked at each other, said nothing, and began packing all the materials into our briefcases, as if preparing to leave. Even when the angry publisher sat back heavily in his seat, we did not look at him.

Just as we were about to stand up, the publisher suddenly said: "Where are you going? I was just joking... Let's talk more!" We used silence to effectively defuse the conflict; perhaps this was the publisher's usual tactic. In the end, the negotiations proceeded smoothly.

## Determining Whether a Person Is Nervous Based on Whether Their Palms Are Sweating

In the human body, emotional changes such as fear and surprise activate the autonomic nervous system beyond voluntary control, causing irregular breathing, changes in blood pressure and pulse, or sweat-gland excitation (psychogenic sweating). If you shake hands with the other person and feel moisture on their palm, you can determine that they are tense and have lost inner balance.

Experienced scientific investigators once active in police stations advised officers to try the "handshake inquiry method": gently shake hands with a suspect during questioning. Begin by shaking hands, then each time a core question arises, say something like "Let's talk slowly, all right?" while shaking the suspect's hand.

If the suspect's palm starts dry and gradually becomes moist during the conversation, it can basically be inferred that this person is the culprit. The well-known polygraph relies on recording the excitation of the subject's sweat glands to make a scientific judgment of their psychological state; its principle is no different from the "handshake inquiry method."

In addition, if someone grips the other person's hand tightly during a handshake and shakes it up and down repeatedly, it indicates that the person is enthusiastic, optimistic, and full of hope for life. Their positive zeal



also makes them frequent focal points in crowds, widely liked and admired. If someone shakes hands vigorously with strangers at a party, it shows that this person likes to display themselves.

Handshake customs vary by country. For example, the French like to shake hands when entering or leaving a room, while Germans shake hands only once... Before shaking hands with someone, it is best to learn local customs; mastering appropriate greeting methods can help avoid unnecessary mistakes.

### **People with Strong Defensiveness Like to Cross Their Arms in Front of Their Chest**

Our arms are highly expressive and can effectively convey a great deal of information. In any scene, simply knowing the range of a person's arm movements allows you to judge whether that person is in a natural state. The smaller the range of the speaker's arm movements, the more it indicates unnaturalness; the larger and more complex the range, the more it indicates immersion in their own narration.

#### **8.1.5 The Most Subtle Combat Preparation — Fingertip Control**

All the combat-preparation reactions described above share one characteristic: the person exerts force against themselves. In Chinese, we can also express this state with phrases such as "exerting force in secret" or "antagonism." Clearly, the person has generated energy for attack, yet because self-restraint is required, this energy is not directed at others but is instead dissipated through the opposition of their own limbs. Actions such as clenching fists, gritting teeth, or trying to snap a pen all secretly consume energy within the body.

One gesture whose meaning is extremely subtle yet reveals the person's inner force control is the mutual resistance of the hands. Many people are impressed by the gesture of rapidly aligning the fingertips, because prominent figures such as Obama frequently use it while speaking.

Foreign scholars have attempted to link this gesture to the shape of church architecture and thereby deduce a religious significance, suggesting that the person making the gesture is outwardly displaying reverence, openness, piety, and confidence in and control over their own words.

A single question, however, can falsify such an explanation: people who have never received religious education, or whose education was not in Christian, Catholic, Orthodox, or Muslim doctrines and who therefore have no knowledge of churches or their architectural features, also perform the same gesture. What, then, is their inner state?

Explaining behavioral meaning through cultural reasoning is itself an error-laden method full of uncertainty. Culture possesses typical social attributes; different histories, geographies, educations, and ethnicities produce vastly different cultural norms. Even within the same neighborhood, some aunties believe in Buddhism while some uncles practice Taoism. How can a monolithic cultural theoretical paradigm be used to interpret behavior?

In reality, this fingertip-alignment gesture has a very clear physiological meaning—precise control. Regardless of nationality or the knowledge and wisdom stored in the brain, anyone who wishes to perform this gesture must first use the brain to precisely control the movement and positioning of all ten fingers, especially when other stimuli are present.

#### **9.1.2 Victory Actions**

Following a head-to-toe order, we list the inadvertent actions commonly made by people who feel superiority or victory.

### 1. Eyebrows Dancing with Joy

When people speak, their eyebrows rarely move. The most common eyebrow movement is raising them in surprise—an action that is relatively easy to control—yet no one frequently raises their eyebrows while speaking. Provided there is no facial disease, a quiet eyebrow position is the baseline feature for most people.

When a person develops a sense of superiority or gain, the pleasurable emotion stimulates activity in the eyebrow region, greatly increasing both the amplitude and frequency of eyebrow movement, and the manner of movement also becomes more varied.

If you observe that the speaker's eyebrows violate their calm baseline by becoming highly variable while coordinating with speech and body movements, you can judge that their mindset is one of satisfaction and relaxation.

### 2. Head Shaking

When girls feel pleased with themselves, they often tilt their heads slightly from side to side with a smile on their face—not a rotational shake but a small-amplitude, high-frequency pendulum-like sway completed entirely within one second. Although the action appears minute and rapid, it actually requires considerable energy to perform deliberately; it arises spontaneously only when emotion dictates, and the person themselves may not even notice it.

Drama amplifies and slows this classic gesture of satisfaction and showing off, using the artistically processed version on stage to represent a flower-role character's secret delight (note the word "secret"). Therefore, if the subject exhibits a similar reaction, one can judge that their inner sense of victorious joy is genuine.

Summarizing the patterns of the above post-victory reactions leads to the conclusion that the larger or more complex the action, the more energy it consumes and the higher the required level of nervous-system excitation. Hence, if a subject displays such reactions during a polygraph test, one can judge the authenticity of their positive inner emotion, because it is difficult to fabricate or perform such a large reaction instantaneously.

## Expressing Approval of the Other Person Through Gestures

Placing both hands on the chest is a common, emblematic gesture of approval, indicating agreement with what the other person has said or done. This is the practical experience of FBI agents.

For centuries, people have placed a hand on the chest to express their own loyalty, integrity, and honesty. Americans adopt a similar posture when pledging allegiance to the flag. In fact, the gesture can be traced back to ancient Rome, where Roman soldiers expressed loyalty and approval through a salute in which one hand was placed on the chest and the other pointed toward the recipient.

FBI agents specifically remind us that, outside formal occasions, women rarely use this posture to express loyalty or allegiance. When they place one or both hands on the chest, it is usually a protective or excited posture indicating sudden fright or great surprise.

Gestures of approval involving touch are more common among acquaintances, friends, and relatives; they almost never occur between strangers or people who are not well acquainted. People who engage in non-

verbal communication through touch are generally able to express their emotions easily. The most common body parts touched are the shoulders and arms.

Touching behavior can also serve as a calming gesture; the person making the gesture usually says reassuring words at the same time, such as "Don't worry" or "Calm down."

If someone slowly approaches you and keeps reducing the distance between you, it indicates that they are very likely to agree with your viewpoint, wish to share something with you privately, or both. Of course, such intimate behavior from others can sometimes make you feel uncomfortable.

Interestingly, the distance between two deaf people who are communicating is generally greater than that between hearing people. This is because deaf people need sufficient space to clearly observe each other's facial expressions and body movements. Usually, the part they focus on most is the face (mainly the mouth), while hands and body movements are not primary observation targets. Only when one person is signing does the other fully direct attention to the other's hands.

### **Rubbing Both Hands Together Often Indicates Expectation**

Perhaps each of us has wordlessly expressed anticipation for something. For example, before participating in an activity, people rub their hands together (see Figure 2.10) as if washing them. Unless the weather is cold and the hands are icy and need friction for warmth, this is a non-verbal way of conveying strong interest in the activity. Gamblers always like to rub the dice between their palms before throwing them; perhaps this is the reason!

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.10 揉搓双手, 表示期待]*

When a child sees the tour bus carrying their mother stop, they happily rub their hands together in eager anticipation of seeing what "delicious" treats are in the travel bag. A company executive over sixty will also make this gesture upon learning that the company has just landed a major deal.

Another gesture of expectation is rubbing the thumb and index finger together (often used when people anticipate receiving money or gifts). It is undeniable that we sometimes convey this feeling of expectation without realizing it.

In many large cities, doormen, waiters, and other service-industry employees generally adopt various expectant postures to signal their hope for a tip. Examples include jingling coins in their pockets or assuming the "ancient Egyptian statue" pose with palms held behind the back and facing upward.

Verbal pauses are often an extremely important part of expectant postures. For instance, a waiter may say, "Have a pleasant day, and we hope you are satisfied with our service," then pause and wait for the customer to respond. If the customer fails to understand the tip request, the waiter may continue: "Sir, let me check whether a better table has been reserved for you." If the customer repeatedly ignores the hint, the service will be noticeably downgraded.

### **Speculation**

The speculation posture may be the most easily misunderstood of all; it indicates contemplation or careful thought. Because success in business or interpersonal dealings depends on personal communication skills, understanding and evaluating feedback is extremely important for those who want to know how much of their message has been received<|eos|>

## Carleiro Encounters the Cool Guy

Steve McQueen was a famous American film actor whom people nicknamed “the Cool Guy.” He appeared in many hit films, including the classic *The Great Escape*.

Many years ago, I (Henry Carleiro) experienced a very interesting incident. I was sitting in first class on a plane when I discovered that my seatmate was none other than McQueen. We began to chat, and when the conversation turned to McQueen’s performance as the poker player in *The Cincinnati Kid*, I remarked that his acting was not particularly strong.

Hearing this, the Cool Guy folded his arms, fixed me with his piercing blue eyes, and asked with a trace of irritation, “What do you mean?”

I explained that in one key scene, the poker player McQueen portrayed had unintentionally shown his opponent a winning gesture—he formed his hands into a steeple after placing his bet.

McQueen nodded, and I went on to explain that steady professional players never make this gesture unless they are bluffing, yet the character McQueen played clearly did not intend to bluff. Thus, it was a nonverbal gesture error on McQueen’s part.

After listening to my explanation, McQueen quickly unfolded his arms, snapped his fingers, and told me that others had given him the same feedback about the role but could offer no reason—they could only “feel” it.

McQueen shook my hand firmly and expressed deep gratitude for the suggestion. We spent the rest of the flight pleasantly. I often recall the experience.

## Judging Nervousness by Whether the Palms Sweat

In the human body, emotions such as fear and surprise trigger activity in the autonomic nervous system, which is not under voluntary control. This activity produces irregular breathing, changes in blood pressure and pulse, or excitation of the sweat glands (emotional sweating). If you shake someone’s hand and feel moisture on the palm, you can conclude that the person is tense and has lost inner equilibrium.

A veteran scientific investigator who once worked for the FBI advised agents to try the “interrogation handshake”: during questioning, the agent would lightly shake the suspect’s hand at the outset and then, each time a core question arose, say something like “Let’s talk this through slowly, all right?” while shaking hands again.

If the suspect’s palm began dry but gradually grew moist during the conversation, it could reasonably be inferred that the person was the culprit. The well-known polygraph operates on the same principle, scientifically assessing psychological state by recording excitation of the sweat glands.

In addition, when someone grips the other person’s hand tightly and pumps it up and down repeatedly, the gesture indicates enthusiasm, optimism, and hopefulness about life. Such positive energy often makes these individuals the center of attention and earns them affection and admiration. Someone who shakes hands vigorously with strangers at a party is displaying a desire to be noticed.

Handshake customs vary by country. The French, for example, shake hands upon entering or leaving a room, whereas Germans shake hands only once. Before shaking hands with someone, it is best to learn local customs; mastering appropriate greetings helps avoid unnecessary mistakes.

## Hand Gestures

At the beginning of this chapter we saw how a simple handshake can unintentionally reveal a person's emotions and intentions. Likewise, the direction of the fingers and other hand gestures can convey a great deal of information. Of course, we also use specific gestures to communicate emotions and ideas.

In our culture, for instance, extending the index and middle fingers of either hand to form a "V" usually means "good luck" or "success."

Another widely recognized gesture is the "okay" sign—thumb and index finger touching to form a circle, the other three fingers extended. As the name suggests, this confident gesture indicates that everything is going well.

A classic gesture is the upright thumb, commonly used to convey that things are going well, victory is at hand, or one hopes for a good outcome.

In the United States, any discussion of hand gestures must mention William Ellsworth Hoy. In the late nineteenth century, Hoy was an outfielder for a major-league baseball team. As the first deaf player in the major leagues, Hoy not only made history but also invented the hand signals still used in baseball today.

Because Hoy could not hear the umpire's calls when it was the opposing team's turn to bat, he asked his third-base coach to raise the left hand for a ball and the right hand for a strike. Gradually other signals came into general use to meet the player's special needs.

Eventually it became clear that these signals helped the rest of the team as well. Today, umpires, coaches, and players rely on them for important communication during games.

## Clenched Fists Indicate Determination or Anger

In a report titled "The Fist," Dr. Louis R. R. Royer noted that the clenched-fist posture often transmits information without either party being consciously aware of it. Simply clenching both fists to emphasize one's words can influence the other person's reaction; the gesture is common in impassioned speeches.

Some people openly raise a clenched fist and wave it in the air, signaling or expressing a strong emotion such as vehement opposition. Others unconsciously tuck their clenched fists into their pockets or under their arms to conceal their feelings.

In his book *The Two-Way Influence of Posture*, Albert Bacon states that clenched fists signify special emphasis, a grave declaration, firm resolve, or steadfastness.

In *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals*, Charles Darwin also observed that clenched fists represent determination or anger and are, in most cases, a hostile action. He further noted that when one person clenches a fist, others tend to do the same, especially during a heated argument, which can easily escalate into actual fisticuffs.

Primitive peoples often used the clenched fist to signal a challenge, and Native Americans frequently clenched their fists during war dances. Today the gesture is widely employed in politics to indicate a firm statement.

A person's inner thought processes, conscious activity, and unconscious activity are all revealed through hand movements. Therefore, when trying to read another's inner needs, it is useful to pay attention to hand actions as a window into that person's inner world.

## (1) Clasped Hands

Jack and I were chatting in a café when two middle-aged men in suits sat down at the next table—one wearing glasses, the other not. They appeared to be negotiating. I said to Jack, “Wait and see—the man with glasses is about to lose.” Sure enough, five minutes later the man without glasses stood up with a triumphant smile, shook hands with his counterpart, and left with the documents. The man with glasses heaved a heavy sigh, sat alone for a while, then walked out dejectedly.

“Well, congratulations—you guessed right,” Jack said.

I smiled. “It wasn’t a guess; it was analysis. Did you notice the man with glasses’ hands? He was clasping them tightly together. Although I couldn’t see his facial expression clearly, there was no doubt he was losing the negotiation.”

My judgment was not mere talk. Negotiation experts have conducted special studies on this movement, and the results show that when someone clasps their hands during a negotiation, it indicates that anxiety and negativity are spreading within them and that the initiative has passed to the other side. Many people mistake the gesture for a sign of confidence because the person often smiles while doing it. In reality, people who are genuinely relaxed and confident rarely perform the action.

Sometimes you may wish to exploit the other person’s tension and anxiety to gain more favorable terms; at other times you may need to help the other person relax so that communication can proceed smoothly. Whenever I notice a client clasping their hands, I offer them a cup of coffee or something else, which usually causes them to release the grip and reduces their tension.

## Clenched Fists Indicate Determination or Anger

In a report titled “The Fist,” Dr. Louis R. R. Royer noted that the clenched-fist posture often transmits information without either party being consciously aware of it. Simply clenching both fists to emphasize one’s words can influence the other person’s reaction; the gesture is common in impassioned speeches.

Some people openly raise a clenched fist and wave it in the air, signaling or expressing a strong emotion such as vehement opposition. Others unconsciously tuck their clenched fists into their pockets or under their arms (see Figure 2.8) to conceal their feelings.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.8 Clenched fists with arms crossed]*

In his book *The Two-Way Influence of Posture*, Albert Bacon states that clenched fists signify special emphasis, a grave declaration, firm resolve, or steadfastness.

In *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals*, Charles Darwin also observed that clenched fists represent determination or anger and are, in most cases, a hostile action. He further noted that when one person clenches a fist, others tend to do the same, especially during a heated argument, which can easily escalate into actual fisticuffs.

Primitive peoples often used the clenched fist to signal a challenge, and Native Americans frequently clenched their fists during war dances. Today the gesture is widely employed in politics to indicate a firm statement.

## The Art of the Handshake

Whenever I meet a new friend, I immediately shake hands. This is not merely habitual courtesy; I also have an eager desire to do so—because, as I mentioned earlier, the texture of a person's tissues can reflect inner character. A handshake allows one to sense directly the firmness of the other's muscles and the hardness of the bones.

Combining the theory I described earlier with my own experience of people, I have reached the following general conclusions:

People whose muscles and bones are both very soft tend to be versatile and easily moved. They have compliant personalities but lack creativity and endurance; to satisfy their idealism they can sometimes be extravagant. In men this may give an impression of weakness or incompetence. Such individuals are not suited to high-pressure work.

People whose muscles are soft but whose bones are hard find it difficult to handle complex tasks. They are naturally melancholic and, in extreme cases, may develop depression.

People whose muscles and bones both possess resilience are optimistic, enthusiastic yet strong, lively and enterprising. Fortunately, most people in society belong to this category. They are undoubtedly likable, though not perfect. Their greatest character flaw is fickleness; at times they even make decisions or take actions that puzzle themselves.

People whose muscles and bones are both very hard are generally decisive, persevering, diligent, and practical, but they tend toward stubbornness and conservatism.

Here I would like to touch briefly on some practical workplace psychology knowledge and techniques.

## **1. Men with Hands on Hips**

Many animals have ways of making themselves appear stronger. During a fight, for example, small birds fluff their feathers to look larger, while cats or dogs try to make their fur stand on end. Because humans lack abundant body hair, we cannot use raised fur to appear stronger, but we can achieve a more imposing stance by placing our hands on our hips and occupying more space. When a man feels his interests are threatened or his authority challenged, he adopts the hands-on-hips posture as a silent challenge. In other words, a man's hands-on-hips stance is often a warning meant to intimidate the other person.

When a man stands with hands on hips in front of a woman, he may be displaying his masculinity to show he is an ambitious male. Still, the gesture must be interpreted in context with other body language. If he stands with hands on hips while his jacket is buttoned, he is likely frustrated rather than confident. If he leaves his jacket open to reveal a muscular chest, the posture is clearly provocative. If he spreads his feet, clenches his fists, and places his hands on his hips, the signal is even more aggressive.

When a man walks with hands on hips, it indicates he is decisive and self-assured; once he makes up his mind to do something, he is confident he can accomplish it and acts at once. Generally, such men dislike slow, deliberate work and prefer to tackle matters with full energy.

## **Discovering the Unknown Self Hidden Deep Within**

Micro-expression keywords We can deceive our own minds, yet our behavior arises from the heart and cannot be entirely governed by external consciousness. Therefore, using behavioral psychology to understand ourselves and gain deeper self-knowledge is more effective and direct than other methods.

As the saying goes, to understand others one must first understand oneself. If a person does not understand himself, any talk of understanding others is merely empty theory.

A Greek proverb states that the most difficult thing in the world is to know oneself. Knowing oneself is not merely knowing one's preferences, personality, or temperament. Within each of us lies a hidden, unknown self that influences everything we say and do. Sometimes an otherwise outgoing person suddenly withdraws from society and shuts himself in his room for days without speaking to anyone; sometimes a strong person suddenly bursts into tears or even sobs in public; sometimes a timid person, faced with sudden danger, acts heroically without fear.

We usually attribute such behavior to excessive stress or "losing composure," yet every action a person takes is closely connected to the depths of his inner self. Doubt it? Consider the following case:

### **Forming the Hands into a Steeple**

The steeple gesture is made by bringing the fingertips of both hands together so they touch, forming a shape resembling a church steeple (see Figure 3.11). The movement indicates confidence and is sometimes viewed as affectation, arrogance, or pride. It is often interpreted as a sign that the person "holds power" or has the upper hand.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 3.11 Hands formed into a steeple]*

If someone makes this gesture while the corners of the mouth turn slightly upward (a knowing smile), you should understand that the person has reached the goal only by luck (see "Carleiro Encounters the Cool Guy" for an anecdote about the steeple gesture).

Most of the time people form a steeple unconsciously. Some, however, deliberately use the gesture to emphasize strong feelings of security and absolute self-confidence.

One suggestion, for example, is that a businessperson, after making a final offer in a negotiation, should adopt this posture: lean back in the chair, smile, and form the hands into a steeple. The client, after watching for a long time, will finally say firmly, "Deal." Thus, in negotiations the gesture seems to possess a kind of magic that can easily win others over.

### **Clasped Hands Indicate Tension and Unease**

When a person clasps both hands together (see Figure 2.9)—in other words, interlaces the fingers tightly—it usually signals anxiety.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.9 Clasped hands]*

The center of attention at a meeting often adopts this posture, especially when asked to answer a series of difficult questions. During an election in California, when the vote-counting machine suddenly malfunctioned, the official explaining the breakdown to voters was photographed; later it was noticed that the official had been clasping his hands.

If your conversation partner keeps both hands tightly clasped, it means he is too tense to be approachable; you should try to help him relax. One effective way is to lean slightly toward him.

For example, during a conversation between a superior and a subordinate, the subordinate may feel uncertain about the superior's attitude. If the superior remains seated behind a large desk and looks at the subordinate



over the top of his glasses, the subordinate—sitting on a sofa some distance away—will almost certainly clasp his hands. Yet if the superior stands, moves closer, sits down, and leans forward to show trust, the subordinate's hands will immediately separate and display a confident attitude.

## 2. Woman with Hands on Hips

With a little attention, one notices that women often adopt the hands-on-hips posture in many situations. The gesture may be deliberate or unconscious. So what are women "saying" when they place both hands on their hips?

In general, women's inner world is comparatively fragile. When they wish to dominate peers or subordinates, they often unconsciously rely on the hands-on-hips posture to appear more powerful.

When a hen encounters a strong enemy, it immediately stretches its neck, spreads its feathers, and assumes a fierce, imposing stance to drive the threat away. In the same way, when a woman faces a formidable opponent, she may also bluff by striking the hands-on-hips pose, glaring fiercely to project overwhelming strength.

Another situation arises when the posture expresses confidence and pride rather than a show of force. On the runway, tall, elegant models frequently walk with hands on hips, as if declaring, "Look how beautiful my outfit is!"

Women may also place their hands on their hips when they are extremely angry and on the verge of an outburst. In many films and television dramas, the posture is the classic image of a shrew. In the movie *Kung Fu Hustle*, for example, the landlady stands with hands on hips, concealing her Lion's Roar technique, and frequently intimidates tenants into silence.

## Scratching the Back of the Neck with the Hand Indicates Frustration

Postures that convey frustration are usually easy to spot. Turn on a football game and you will see plenty of dejected faces. In one play, the quarterback evades a defender and throws to a receiver; the receiver drops the ball, which is recovered by the opposing team. The receiver's most common reaction is to kick the ground in anger and slap his helmet.

During a baseball game, when a batter strikes out, you will see him angrily fling his bat, scratch the back of his neck, kick up dirt (or anything else near his feet), and walk back to the dugout with his head down.

Non-baseball players may not throw bats to express annoyance or regret, yet they perform similar actions: scratching the back of the neck and lowering the head. Slamming a table, snapping a pencil, or stamping a foot carry the same meaning as kicking dirt or throwing a bat.

In business negotiations, once you have clearly stated your position and the other party remains noncommittal, watch for small hand movements, as experience suggests these often reveal the true response.

## Psychology Mini-Lesson

One website reported that observing whether a U.S. presidential candidate uses left- or right-hand gestures can indicate his mood.

Research shows that right-handed candidates tend to use their right hand for positive ideas and their left hand for negative ones. Examples include John Kerry and George W. Bush.

Exceptions exist. Left-handed candidates Barack Obama and John McCain display the opposite pattern: they use the left hand for positive ideas and the right hand for negative ones.

The study analyzed debate footage of multiple candidates. Daniel Casasanto, lead researcher at the Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics in the Netherlands, noted: "In the real world, abundant data confirm that people recruit the side of the body they use most when thinking of positive things. Simply observing gestures can therefore reveal a person's emotional state."

## **Section 1: Hands Also Betray You**

It has been said that to determine whether a woman leads a privileged life, one need only look at her hands. Indeed, hands reveal not only gender and age but also character and intention.

Each hand has five fingers, a palm, and a back; superficially they appear similar. Yet different people possess different hand shapes, which disclose distinct personalities and life prospects. While gestures can be learned or altered, hand shape is innate and unchangeable; unlike the face, hands cannot be easily disguised.

In Chinese physiognomy, hand shapes are classified by the five elements into metal-shaped, wood-shaped, water-shaped, fire-shaped, earth-shaped, and mixed hands—six categories. Western physiognomy divides them into square, spatulate, conical, psychic, philosophical, elementary, and mixed hands—seven categories. Although the names differ, the systems largely correspond: metal-shaped aligns with square, wood-shaped with philosophical, water-shaped with conical, fire-shaped with psychic, earth-shaped with spatulate, and mixed with mixed. The elementary hand has no direct counterpart and is discussed separately in this section.

## **We Are Breaking Up—Humans Are Emotion-Driven Animals**

Humans are indeed advanced animals.

Beyond the creation and use of tools, humans possess memory, cognition, logical reasoning, and judgment—higher brain functions unmatched by other species on Earth. Even the instincts and emotions shaped by evolution are far more complex than those of other animals.

While awake, humans continuously receive and process information. In this book, information received by the nervous system is collectively termed "stimuli," yet not every stimulus warrants an external bodily response. Two people sit facing each other; during conversation the boy blinks. The blink registers as a visual stimulus through the girl's eyes, but carries no special meaning for her and is dismissed without further processing or motor command.

Stimuli that trigger stress responses are called "effective stimuli." After an effective stimulus occurs, in addition to instinctive reactions (such as instantly withdrawing a hand from a glass of boiling water), responses at various emotional levels may also arise.

### **1. Hands Restrained in Front of the Body**

A common female gesture is to clasp both hands and hold them in front of the body. Observers often interpret this as shy or endearing. Under a submissive mindset, the person feels that without this mutual restraint the hands would have nowhere to rest. See Figure 4-3.

Many standard service protocols instruct staff to keep hands restrained in front of the body during greetings, explanations, bows, or responses as a sign of respect. This submissive posture conveys deference from a lower to a higher position, giving customers a satisfying sense of being respected.

Men also display this reaction, especially in unfamiliar settings. When an invited guest meets others—even a mature, high-status male who is not in a leadership role—most will place their hands restrained in front of the body. They regard the posture as proper and modest. In reality, the subtle movement signals inner restraint and mild tension.

Hands restrained in front of the body indicate endurance—self-protective endurance—and reflect a weaker underlying mindset than hands restrained behind the back.

## 5. Raising Both Hands

The upward hand gesture is large in amplitude and produces a distinct visual impression. It expresses praise, satisfaction, encouragement, or a call to action, and is also used for greeting. Employed during speeches or conversation, it most clearly reveals personal style. People who favor upward gestures are generally outgoing, generous, informal, and confident; the gesture often imparts an uplifting force. Overall, it is a well-received movement that can be used effectively when confidence needs boosting.

When conversing, a person cannot remain completely expressionless or motionless. Especially when feeling insecure, attempting to conceal something, or lying, the hands frequently produce small, involuntary revealing movements. Modern research confirms that the hands are the body's most touch-sensitive region and the site of the greatest number of limb movements. Observing changes in hand gestures while someone speaks often reveals hidden inner information. To project an impression of confidence and optimism, pay attention to your habitual gestures and correct them when necessary.

## 4. Fire-shaped Hand / Psychic Hand

The fire-shaped hand, also called the psychic or ideal hand, has the following main features:

- Overall shape resembles the water-shaped hand but is more slender and thin
- The palm is long, soft, and slim, slightly curved, pale in color, with visible veins
- The palm tapers at the top and widens at the base; knuckles are not prominent; nails are long, oval, and reddish; the thumb is proportionally placed

People with fire-shaped hands are emotional, quick-thinking, aesthetically sensitive, and decisive in likes and dislikes, yet impatient and fond of comfort. Naturally clever and dexterous, they show strong interest in many subjects and possess good eloquence, but lack perseverance. They readily trust those who treat them kindly and are easily deceived. They suit careers that allow full expression of talent, such as poet, actor, singer, or religious leader.

Individuals with fire-shaped hands possess attractive external conditions; love at first sight occurs easily for them. Although the initial feeling is sweet, relationships often end prematurely. For genuine love to arrive, they may do well to moderate emphasis on outward beauty; only those who approach them sincerely will not judge the relationship by appearance alone.

## Grip Strength and Personality

A firm handshake usually indicates confidence and a tendency to take charge. Excessive force, however, can appear rash rather than steady. It also suggests an enthusiastic, sincere, or expectant inner state. Such individuals are typically energetic, self-assured, frank, and resilient; they lean toward decisiveness and authoritarianism, yet demonstrate strong organizational and leadership abilities and are natural leaders.

A handshake of moderate pressure, steady execution, and direct eye contact signals a resolute, responsible, and reliable personality. The person thinks methodically, excels at reasoning, and offers constructive suggestions and practical solutions when difficulties arise.

A limp, lifeless “dead-fish” handshake—offered with no pressure or substance—belongs to someone who is usually introverted, weak-willed, lacking drive, cold, arrogant, and indecisive.

### **3. Handshakes Involving Status Differences**

When a status disparity exists between the two parties—whether in rank, position, or financial power—clear behavioral asymmetry often appears. In a superior-subordinate meeting or a business negotiation involving supplication and granting, the stronger party’s handshake tends to feel neutral: moderate pressure, brief duration, and limited movement. The weaker party, conversely, tends to apply more pressure (within appropriate limits), allows the stronger party to release first (signaling deference), and yields control of the movement to the other side. When the disparity is large, the weaker party may involuntarily add the second hand, clasping with both hands or supporting the other person’s arm.

More importantly, the weaker party tends to lower the head and bend the torso, while the stronger party maintains an upright posture and looks down.

These cues can be used to gauge how the other person positions themselves relative to you and to inform subsequent decisions.

### **1. Metal-shaped Hand / Square Hand**

The metal-shaped hand, also called the capable or practical hand, has the following main features:

- The palm is square with rounded edges, fleshy and elastic, pale in color
- Nails are roughly square; the Mount of Venus beneath the thumb is well developed
- Palm and fingers are square; the four sides of the hand are nearly equal in length, forming a square

People with metal-shaped hands possess leadership ability and practical talent, a strong sense of justice, and a protective attitude toward the weak. They repay kindness and dislike bullying or taking advantage of others. When dissatisfied with the status quo, they act boldly to change their environment and take control of their destiny, though this can place considerable pressure on those around them. They suit careers that reward execution, such as accountant, engineer, architect, lawyer, soldier, or physician.

In romance, metal-shaped-hand individuals are not sentimental. They reject deception and dislike casual or glib partners. They prefer ambitious, capable companions; therefore, anyone seeking such a person should demonstrate commitment through determined action.

### **Frequent Chin-Resting Fantasizing Indicates Detachment from Reality**

Habitual chin-resting suggests a rich imagination and an active inner life, or possibly frequent absent-mindedness, a sense of emptiness in daily life, and a longing for novelty or happiness elsewhere. Happiness

cannot be seized merely by resting the chin and fantasizing; waiting passively is the typical pattern for such individuals.

From another perspective, because everyday life feels dull, these people inhabit a self-constructed world, drifting from reality and filled with romantic notions. Conversation with them often yields unexpected and interesting topics. They resemble a spoiled child who constantly requires care, yet excessive indulgence is also inadvisable. The best approach is to gauge the right measure and satisfy their needs appropriately. Those who frequently rest their chin should also monitor whether the gesture stems from inner emptiness and should enrich their lives, reduce internal unease, and adjust their mindset to improve outward body language.

### **Why People Who Love to Fantasize Rest Their Chin on Both Hands**

Many people enjoy fantasizing. Adolescent girls typically imagine unknown futures and beautiful romances, picturing themselves as the heroine of a drama united with a loved one. Young adults entering society fantasize about successful careers and harmonious families. The chin-resting gesture, though seemingly casual, substitutes one's own hands for those of family, friends, or a lover, providing self-embrace and comfort that compensates for currently missing sensations and offers physical and emotional reassurance during fantasy.

Busy, fulfilled individuals rarely rest their chins while fantasizing; only when time allows and thoughts arise does the gesture appear. If someone rests their chin while listening to you, it indicates the topic feels uninteresting and their attention has drifted elsewhere. If your romantic partner displays the gesture, they may be weary of the conversation and hoping for a different kind of surprise.

### **Thumb Raised, Thumb Outside the Pocket**

A raised thumb is commonly recognized as a nonverbal signal of high confidence. Many view the thumb as a symbol of authority and strength. When the thumb is held upright, it indicates a high self-assessment or strong confidence in one's ideas or circumstances. It is also an anti-gravity posture that conveys positive emotion.

The gesture of placing the thumb outside a pocket is equally common. People who feel superior or hold an advantageous position—regardless of gender—often perform it unconsciously. Thumb movements are highly reliable for assessing whether someone feels good about themselves or is struggling.

Understanding the code of thumb gestures allows one to train oneself to use these signals effectively.

Low-confidence displays are the opposite of high-confidence ones. They reflect discomfort, insecurity, and self-doubt. Low-confidence hand movements include the following:

#### **Self-Affirmation**

We often feel insecure and therefore need occasional self-affirmation. Seeking reassurance "from a blanket or other object" is not unique to Linus in the *Peanuts* comic strip; adults also unconsciously perform self-affirming gestures.

Children's confidence-restoring gestures differ from those of adolescents. Young children may suck a thumb, a piece of cloth, or clothing, while teenagers may bite nails or develop smoking habits.

Observation shows that the most common adult self-affirming gesture is crossing the hands and rubbing the two thumbs together. Other similar actions include scratching the scalp, kneading the palms, or holding a pen in the mouth (biting or sucking). Sometimes a meeting participant, to justify attendance, will touch the back of a chair before sitting. Another self-affirming gesture is placing a hand at the throat or touching a necklace. People frequently perform these movements when they hear something unsettling.

## VII. Primitive Hand

The primitive hand, also known as the inferior hand or lower-class hand, has the following main characteristics:

- The hand is plump, short, thick, and hard; the palm is short and curved, with very few and simple palm lines; veins stand out on the back of the hand, and the palm color is relatively dark.
- The fingers are short and thick; the nails are short and difficult to bend backward; the fingerprints are deep and messy.

People with primitive hands tend to lack rationality, have a violent and irritable temperament, and are timid and cunning, yet they are practical and very hardworking. They are better suited to physical labor.

Love is not a particularly elegant or refined emotion for people with primitive hands. They do not deliberately pursue a partner; when the time comes, they naturally find someone to accompany them, much like drinking water when thirsty. Therefore, the foundation of their relationship with a partner is often not love but desire, finances, family pressure, or similar factors.

Hand shape not only reflects a person's personality traits but also their health condition. For example, people with long fingers generally suffer from poor appetite; those whose upper thumb can bend often have congenital or acquired issues with the eyes, waist, or digestive system.

## Pointing a Finger at Others

Pointing a finger at others is a common gesture, usually used to clearly state a point or seriously emphasize something. Observation shows that even when deliberately avoiding this gesture, one can still communicate ideas and views smoothly.

Why avoid it? The answer is simple: it is a gesture that can provoke resistance. Combined with a raised voice, this gesture is highly likely to spark a heated argument.

In practice, pointing a finger at others occurs frequently during intense discussions. However, if people control or restrain their tone and pitch, the gesture often does not generate much resistance in others.

Politicians or clergy who point a "condemning" finger at an audience usually do not provoke resistance, because the audience does not perceive the gesture as directed at themselves. In one-on-one situations, however, the gesture is unquestionably aimed at a specific person and therefore can cause problems.

## III. Water-shaped Hand / Conical Hand

The water-shaped hand, also known as the artistic hand, beauty-loving hand, or emotional hand, has the following main characteristics:

- The palm is plump, soft, and elastic; veins on the back of the hand are hidden and not prominent.
- The hand is slightly short and broad, with a relatively pale color.

- The base of the fingers is broad while the tips are pointed; the nails are long and not square; the thumb is relatively slender.

People with water-shaped hands are intelligent, observant, quick learners, and possess unique judgment and analytical ability as well as rich imagination, yet they often lack drive. They adapt well to environmental changes; when dissatisfied with the status quo, they prefer to devise coping strategies rather than take action. They are suited to thinking-oriented work such as artist, musician, or writer.

People with water-shaped hands easily find complementary partners because the great differences between them feel novel; however, they must confront communication gaps arising from differences in mindset, life background, and knowledge. Once the novelty fades, most enter a difficult adjustment period.

### **Ten Fingers Interlocked and Clenched: Hard to Convince Others**

Imagine someone sitting upright at a conference table, arms resting on the table, fingers interlocked and clenched, saying in a mild tone, "I have always been open-minded and sincerely hope we can solve the problem." Those present will inevitably notice, consciously or not, the inconsistency between words and actions.

An open palm signals honesty and sincerity, while a clenched fist signals the opposite. By attempting to deceive others in this way to achieve a desired result, the person is likely to provoke hostility and attack instead.

When under pressure and feeling the need to defend themselves, people may also interlock and clench their fingers (see Figure 2.7), indicating they are trying to suppress strong emotions—often dissatisfaction or anger.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.7 十指交叉紧握]*

### **Hands on Hips: Indicates Readiness**

One typical posture that clearly signals readiness is "hands on hips." We often see overly confident individuals—regardless of age or gender—stand in this posture when prepared to take on a task (women tend to place only one hand on the hip).

In sports competitions, athletes about to enter the field frequently adopt the hands-on-hips posture. In business meetings, someone standing with legs apart and hands on hips usually means they are about to express their views seriously.

Children challenging parental authority may also place both hands on their hips. Some men, while placing hands on hips, occasionally accompany the gesture with pulling up their trouser legs.

Determined individuals who adopt the hands-on-hips posture generally stand with legs farther apart than usual. These postures emphasize their resolve and commitment to their words, actions, or plans.

### **(IV) People Who Carry Large Handbags**

Spending time with those who prefer large bags creates an atmosphere of freedom and ease. They are easygoing and quick to form connections with others. However, these connections are not strong, because their casualness and lack of responsibility can become hard to tolerate.

In addition, if the interior of a person's handbag is neatly organized with distinct compartments, the owner is reliable, enterprising, and confident. At times, insistence on principles may make them overly serious or rigid.

Conversely, if a person's handbag is messy and finding items requires rummaging through the entire bag, their life is likely equally disorganized. At work they struggle to maintain order, leading to oversights that can sometimes cause major losses. They are warm and friendly toward colleagues and friends, yet their overly casual manner often places them in awkward situations.

## **Psychology Mini-Class**

The hands-on-hips posture is sometimes interpreted as the "winner's posture." Ambitious individuals who refuse to give up until they reach their goal often favor this stance. Consequently, many men use it to signal their ambition.

The hands-on-hips posture makes a person's body appear more imposing. Those adopting it seem to say, "I am someone with great aspirations, capable of controlling my own destiny." In American Western films, one frequently sees the righteous cowboy stand tall and proud before an enemy, hands on hips, fearless and especially imposing.

Nevertheless, not every person with hands on hips is a winner. Some adopt the posture without the aura of success and merely come across as offensive. Therefore, one should not treat every hands-on-hips individual as a representative of success; each case must be analyzed individually.

## **II. Wood-shaped Hand / Philosophical Hand**

The wood-shaped hand, also known as the knotty hand or intellectual hand, has the following main characteristics:

- The palm is flat and long, of moderate thickness, firm yet elastic; the palm color has a bluish tint and the skin is relatively dark.
- Veins and muscles stand out on the back of the hand; the knuckles are prominent.
- Both fingers and nails are long, slender, and knotted; the thumb is strong and upright, not easily bent.

People with wood-shaped hands are independent, possess a strong sense of autonomy, dare to express themselves, and can be exclusive and stubborn. They prefer fixed routines and adapt poorly to change. They are soft-hearted and easily moved; they display exceptional talent in religion, art, philosophy, and spirituality. They are suited to static, thinking-oriented positions such as writer, religious scholar, educator, philosopher, or horticulturist.

People with wood-shaped hands are romantic and tend toward Platonic spiritual love. Their criteria for a partner are high, requiring both inner and outer beauty.

## **VI. Hands on Hips**

Hands on hips is a dominant action signal indicating anger, provocation, or questioning. People who habitually adopt this posture are often dominant in daily life and use it to protest when others fail to meet their standards. When angry, women frequently place both hands on their hips, giving a fierce impression. If someone leans forward with hands on hips, it indicates they wish to debate and determine right from wrong. When encountering such individuals, it is best not to argue excessively, as they are not in a reasonable frame



of mind at that moment. However, hands on hips combined with a smile on the face is a sign of self-confidence.

Hand gestures and their changes correspond to psychological shifts; when we are unhappy, our hands are also unhappy and convey this message externally. For this reason, hand gestures are considered a person's second tongue.

### **People Who Love to Daydream Often Rest Their Chin on Both Hands**

Micro-expression keywords: Stress is everywhere in life; one way to relieve it is to fantasize about pleasant things. When daydreaming, people like to rest their chin on both hands, giving themselves mental and physical comfort. At such moments, one should not disturb them, or they may become displeased.

Everyone has surely seen the classic fairy-tale play *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs*, in which Snow White often rests her chin on both hands while gazing out the window, imagining her prince charming and a romantic Christmas ball. In Japan's developed animation industry, almost every anime features this endearing chin-resting gesture whenever a sentimental, daydreaming girl appears. The frequency of this action has made it a standard design motif, and resting the chin on both hands has become the signature pose of dreamy young women.

### **V. Earth-shaped Hand / Comb-shaped Hand**

The earth-shaped hand, also known as the oval hand, entrepreneurial hand, or agile hand, has the following main characteristics:

- The palm is broad and thick, irregular in shape, with especially thick and firm muscles; the palm color is yellowish.
- The wrist connection is wide.
- The fingers are slightly flat and thick.

People with earth-shaped hands are energetic, agile, and hardworking; they are practical, not vain, confident, and bold, yet stubborn and prone to emotional excitement. They are easygoing, willing to sacrifice themselves to protect others, but somewhat slow-witted and guarded. They are suited to work that allows deep cultivation, such as inventor, explorer, scientist, navigator, or technician.

People with earth-shaped hands fall in love easily, yet romance rarely succeeds and often ends without resolution. Generally, members of the opposite sex discover their virtues only after deeper contact.

### **Psychology Mini-Class**

If a person scratches their ear, it indicates they are in an anxious state.

In kindergarten, teachers taught us to raise our hands when speaking. As adults, even though we know raising a hand signals a desire to speak, we often hesitate to continue the habit, feeling it too formal. Consequently, we frequently start to raise a hand only to pull it back.

In its place appears the subtle action of scratching the ear. Ear scratching both signals an intention to interrupt and serves as a self-touching action to relieve inner restlessness.

Of course, not every ear-scratching action carries emotional meaning; sometimes it is merely an unconscious response to an itch, without any intent to refuse listening or show impatience.

## **Handbags That Attest to Identity**

A handbag is both a daily necessity and a status symbol; wherever the owner goes, it appears. Therefore, through these handbags that “follow like a shadow,” one can discern a person’s preferences, taste, and cultivation.

Generally, owners of ordinary, mass-market handbags are themselves ordinary, lacking any particularly distinctive personality.

Among those who consult me, some carry no bag at all. When asked why, most shrug and say, “Oh, it’s too much trouble; this way is more relaxed, isn’t it?” From this I can generally conclude that people who carry no bag are either rather lazy or prefer a simple lifestyle.

Next, I will discuss the “inner connection” between handbag and owner, which I believe will help you understand a person.

## **Shyness**

In group discussions, the person who speaks the least often contributes the most valuable insights. If you are attending a business meeting, watch for “shyness syndrome.” When someone has listened attentively for a long time without speaking much, this pattern appears. Through their gestures and facial expressions, you will discover they actually have many thoughts on the topic under discussion.

A wise management principle is to draw the person into the discussion by asking a question. For example, you might say, “You’ve been listening very attentively but haven’t shared your views. What do you think?” Such an invitation usually elicits interesting ideas. If the encouragement is mishandled or the relevant knowledge is lacking, however, the opposite occurs and those ideas may remain unspoken forever.

## **IV. A Firm Handshake**

Handshakes are very common in social settings and are the greeting and farewell custom most frequently used by Chinese people. A handshake is not only a universal greeting; the moment two people shake hands also reveals important information. When shaking hands with a stranger, if the other person grips firmly, it indicates a proactive and confident personality. Conversely, a weak handshake or reluctance to extend the hand suggests a passive personality and lack of confidence. A handshake is not an arm-wrestling match; excessive force should be avoided to prevent hurting the other person’s hand, and the duration should not be overly long. The firmness should also be adjusted according to the level of acquaintance: a light handshake is appropriate with new clients, but it should not be limp; with long-standing clients, a firmer grip conveys politeness and warmth.

### **8.1.2 Clenching a Fist**

Whether standing or sitting, one of the most representative actions of someone harboring confrontational feelings is clenching a fist. It is unnecessary to observe a very forceful clench, as that level of tension is required only for actual combat. Even a light, non-forceful clench is sufficient to reveal the presence of a confrontational mindset. This seemingly casual gripping action, which appears to be merely loosening the

forearm and fingers, is followed in criminal interrogation by suspect behavior aimed at resistance rather than cooperation.

The reason is simple: clenching a fist is a preparatory action for combat. This neural reflex has formed deep muscle memory; when a suspect is mentally exerting effort, the hands involuntarily perform the preparatory action.

## **Hands Are the Best Tool for Conveying Information**

Micro-expression keywords: Hands, as an important part of the human body, play a vital role. Every movement of the hands often transmits a wealth of information about a person's character, emotions, and psychology. To understand someone, one must observe their hands closely and capture psychological signals through details.

In daily life, we rely on our hands for countless tasks. Beyond performing actions, when we experience emotions we instinctively use our hands to express them. For example, raising a thumb signals praise or appreciation; waving indicates liking or farewell. In addition, unconscious hand habits naturally reveal inner feelings; observant people can capture others' psychological signals from these hand details.

### **Candor**

British biologist Charles Darwin noted that when animals express submission (a form of candor), they roll onto their backs before an enemy, exposing their soft abdomen and throat. Similarly, people often signal candor by placing open hands in front of the chest, palms upward (see Figure 4.1). Sometimes they accompany the gesture with the words, "I have nothing to hide."

#### **Figure 4.1** Hands open to show sincerity

Darwin also observed that even the most hostile animals will spare an opponent who is open and honest. Likewise, human candor can elicit sincerity and honesty from those around them.

### **Hands Behind the Back**

Sometimes we see people unconsciously place both hands behind their back while walking or talking with others. This is often thought to be a contemplative or thinking gesture, but it actually conveys two messages: "My status is high" and "Please do not approach me." The action is sometimes called the "imperial stance," as members of royalty have long used it to maintain distance from others.

When someone suddenly places their hands behind their back during a conversation, we should consider whether the distance between us has become too intimate. People naturally move closer to things they like and avoid touching things they dislike.

### **You're Out!**

Baseball fans are surely familiar with the following scene: on the field, an umpire makes a call with which a team's coach disagrees. The coach runs onto the field, gesticulates wildly in protest before the umpire, and may even raise a clenched fist.

The umpire stares sternly at the furious coach, arms crossed over the chest (except in American football, where the umpire already wears a chest protector and cannot cross the arms, but instead places hands on hips

and juts the chin toward the disputing coach). If the umpire feels they have heard enough, they turn their back on the coach to signal "You're out," or simply walk away.

## II. Clenching a Fist

Clenching a fist carries three meanings:

1. A display of confidence and strength. During solemn oath-taking ceremonies, most participants are required to clench the right fist and raise it to eyebrow level as an affirmation of self.
2. Indicates latent aggressiveness; the person repeatedly clenches their fists while conversing, as if preparing to attack or counterattack.
3. Signals unwillingness to engage with new things or new people and a preference for remaining closed off.

When dealing with the second type, one should choose words carefully during conversation, lest the other person become upset and launch into a tirade or even physical assault. For the third type, sustained friendliness can gradually lower their guard.

## 2. Equal, Approaching Handshakes

If both parties already know each other fairly well (even if they have never met in person) and mutually recognize or even admire each other, the handshake will involve full palm contact with moderate pressure and up-and-down movement, though it will not last long. When you sense that the other person's feedback (pressure, amplitude, duration, etc.) matches your own, it indicates that they also look forward to further interaction and hope to advance the relationship.

Most importantly, equals maintain equal head and spinal posture. If both are being polite, they will nod moderately and curve the spine; if both carry themselves with presence, they will stand tall with chests out, signaling formality and respect.

## Hands Together, Revealing True Thoughts

A person's inner world is expressed not only through the face. When people consciously suppress facial changes, other body parts inadvertently leak the truth.

The hands are the most frequently used body parts besides the face and the most practical tools humans possess. What a person does with their hands reveals considerable information about their thoughts and feelings. In sign language, the hands can convey endless information just like spoken words.

Clasping the hands together is a common hand movement. The specific postures and corresponding mental states are described below:

## Everything in the Palm: Reading the Other Person's Confidence Level Through Their Hands

Micro-expression keyword: Is this person confident? In fact, you do not need to ask anyone else; simply observing their hands and hand movements reveals their level of confidence. Learning to read the code of the hands allows you to understand another person's self-assurance.

Hands are among the most useful parts of the body in daily life, and we rely on them for countless tasks. Consequently, hand movements and behaviors readily express our emotions, and we can gauge a person's

confidence through their hands.

Highly confident movements reflect a high degree of mental comfort and absolute self-assurance. The following hand movements indicate high confidence:

### **Hand Gestures and Psychology (Continued)**

Some people tap their fingers while talking with others. There are two common reasons: first, the person is waiting for someone and growing impatient; the tapping reflects restlessness. Second, the person is angry or inwardly frustrated, possibly because events are not unfolding as expected; the tapping then serves as a warning signal, advising others to keep a safe distance for the time being. If you notice a friend making this gesture, it is wise not to press for details immediately; wait until their mood has settled before inquiring.

## **6. Mixed-Shape Hands / Hybrid Hands**

As the name suggests, mixed-shape hands combine features of the five preceding hand shapes, making their outward characteristics difficult to classify precisely.

People with mixed-shape hands possess both the strengths and weaknesses of the various shapes. When the combination involves mutually conflicting elements (for example, metal-wood, wood-earth, water-fire, or fire-metal pairings), instability or contradictory personality tendencies may appear. When three or more shapes are mixed, the person often lacks independent judgment and is prone to changing their mind. Nevertheless, individuals with mixed-shape hands are generally intelligent, highly adaptable, quick learners, and alert; they are versatile yet also changeable and liable to place themselves in self-contradictory situations.

### **4.5.1 Freezing Response of the Hands**

Have you ever stood on a stage facing hundreds of spectators and felt uncomfortable? Have you noticed that most people in such situations do not know where to place their hands?

In reality, "discomfort" is a state of worry; the subconscious concern is that the audience will dislike or even reject the speaker.

Anyone on stage wants their inner and outer self to be accepted. The fear of not being recognized or accepted becomes a powerful stimulus.

At that moment, the hands involuntarily assume a constrained posture and produce a freezing response.

### **(6) Palms Up, Open**

When people speak from the heart or tell the truth, they open their palms toward the other person. Like most body language, this gesture can be unconscious or deliberate. Either way, it makes the other person appear to be telling the truth. Children who lie usually hide their palms behind their backs; a husband who does not want to reveal where he is going may put his hands in his pockets or fold his arms, and a wife can sense the concealment from that single movement. In other words, extending both hands with palms open from time to time during conversation makes you appear more honest and reliable.

## **People Who Walk with Hands Clapsed Behind Their Back Have Something on Their Mind**

When someone is preoccupied, they usually walk slowly and adopt a contemplative posture, head slightly lowered and hands tightly clasped behind the back. They may occasionally stop to think, kick a stone, or pick up a piece of paper from the ground, as if saying to themselves, "Perhaps I should look at this from another angle." Such a person has typically encountered a difficult problem.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.41 全神贯注的行人]

## Handshakes and First Impressions

Psychological research shows that in the workplace it is important to convey an impression of "competence" at first meeting, especially during interviews and negotiations; competent individuals tend to receive more opportunities. One detail that cannot be overlooked if you want to appear competent is the handshake.

A handshake is a conscious act. Even if your bones and muscles are soft and your personality is gentle, increasing the pressure during the handshake can still convey determination and sincerity. Conversely, a limp handshake may lead to rejection.

## The Meaning of Hands on Hips

When you see someone with hands on hips, avoid overgeneralizing; analyze the specific situation so you can discern each possible emotion behind the gesture and reach an accurate judgment.

Hands on hips means the thumbs and remaining fingers are spread and pressed firmly against the sides of the waist. In daily life or at work, many people place their hands on their hips—perhaps while stretching after sitting for a long time, while speaking with acquaintances, or while walking. Men and women, however, convey different meanings with this posture. What, then, are men and women respectively "saying" when they place their hands on their hips?

## Hand Movements That Indicate a Negative Attitude

Although the other person may feign interest on the surface, their hand movements can betray an inner negative attitude. The following hand movements often signal that the person is "unhappy," "does not want to listen," or "will not agree":

- Clenching the fists
- Placing both hands on the thighs with thumbs pointing toward each other
- Crossing both hands behind the head
- Pressing a finger to the center of the forehead while toying with objects on the table during conversation
- Opening and closing a drawer as if searching for something
- Repeatedly tapping the table with a finger

## (1) People Who Like Pocket Watches

Such individuals display three clear characteristics:

1. They manage time well; although busy all day, they are never slaves to the clock and know how to relax within limited time.
2. They are nostalgic, fond of old objects, and refined in speech and manner.

3. They are patient and steady in dealing with others, earning respect.

Of course, a small number of people carry a pocket watch merely to display status. These individuals are easy to recognize: those who hold a pocket watch with an air of importance and an arrogant gait belong to this group.

### **People Who Walk with Hands on Hips Are Impatient**

Some people walk with hands on hips, resembling sprinters. They may be quick-tempered individuals who want to reach their destination by the shortest route and at the greatest speed. Such people possess strong explosive power and often adopt this posture when executing the next plan. The stance has become a signature of this type, much like using "V" to signify victory.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.40 奔向目的地的行人]

### **(3) Steeple Gesture**

In body language, understanding a posture generally requires combining it with other postures and the specific context; otherwise, misinterpretation is likely. One posture, however, is an exception—the steeple gesture.

The steeple gesture is formed when the fingertips of both hands touch each other while the palms remain apart, creating a shape resembling a church steeple. Its meaning is confidence.

Research indicates that confident high achievers in the workplace frequently use this gesture, especially among accountants, lawyers, and managers.

#### **1. Avoid Putting Hands in Pockets**

When we feel nervous, we instinctively hide our hands, so a lack of confidence often leads us to slip our hands into our pockets without realizing it. Hands in pockets usually signal withdrawal and convey insufficient confidence along with a casual air. Keeping the hands outside the pockets, by contrast, projects confidence and transmits an open message. Experts also suggest that placing the hands at the sides of the hips or thighs can further boost confidence. The next time you feel insecure, try keeping your hands out of your pockets; the effect may surprise you.

#### **Resting the Chin in a Dreamy Pose**

At eight o'clock in the morning during English reading time, homeroom teacher Ms. Wang entered the classroom as usual. Looking around, she heard a chorus of reading voices and smiled with satisfaction. Suddenly she noticed that student A's textbook in the farthest seat of the front row was standing upright on the desk, yet student A's face was not visible. Ms. Wang walked over quietly, removed the textbook, and gently called, "Student A, Student A..." but received no reply. Student A was resting both hands on their chin, smiling, lost in pleasant reverie.

#### **Frozen Hands**

Research shows that compared with honest people, those who lie or lack confidence tend to minimize gestures and physical contact. Therefore, hand behavior is often more trustworthy than words and can reveal

the speaker's true thoughts. If a person lacks confidence, their hand movements appear stiff because they are unsure whether their lie will succeed. Consequently, when you observe someone's hands freezing, it indicates that the person is experiencing extreme lack of confidence at that moment.

### **People Who Walk with Hands in Pockets Are Critical**

People who habitually walk with hands in pockets, even in warm weather, tend to be highly critical and enjoy criticizing or belittling others. They often project an air of mystery, are skilled at concealing real emotions, and appear cynical. When interacting with such individuals, first overpower them with presence.

People who repeatedly pull their hands out of their pockets and then put them back in while walking are more cautious and deliberate, yet they easily become discouraged in adversity. Sometimes the behavior also signals nervousness.

### **Touching**

Touching an object or another person expresses pride or ownership. It can also convey interest, concern, affection, understanding, sympathy, confidence, or comfort. In essence, romantic relationships are largely built on physical touch.

To determine the true meaning behind a person's touch signals, remember that most information is conveyed through body language; observe the entire posture cluster the other person displays to interpret the touch more accurately.

### **The Nature Behind a Wristwatch**

A truly successful person is someone who knows how to use time. In other words, your attitude toward time determines your probability of success. I am not about to repeat how precious time is; that is obvious. Since the first self-winding wristwatch appeared in 1926, both style and function have evolved. What I want to say is that a person's treatment of time can be judged from the watch they wear.

#### **1. Purely Ritual Handshakes**

A ritual handshake is formal and correct, typically occurring at a first meeting when the parties know little about each other. Its chief characteristics are brevity and light pressure; contact is minimal and quickly released. Between opposite sexes, the palms may not fully meet; only the fingers may touch briefly, especially when the woman initiates or holds the advantage. Such a handshake signals that both sides intend to remain completely independent for the time being and that further contact is required to deepen the relationship.

#### **2. Do Not Cross Your Arms**

When we feel cold, dissatisfied, or tense, we generally cross our arms over the chest. This defensive posture transmits negative messages: emotional closure, low mood, unwillingness to communicate, or an attempt to mask discontent or anxiety. Who would want to befriend a pessimist? Therefore, in social settings we should relax appropriately and avoid crossing our arms, thereby appearing more open and confident.

#### **3. Avoid Biting Fingers**



Finger biting is common among children and adolescents and usually appears after intense tension, reflecting depression, frustration, feelings of inferiority, or hostility. The root cause may be insufficient attention or lack of security. Many young people and adults substitute biting a pen or pencil for biting fingers. Finger biting signals not only insufficient confidence but also poses a health risk because fingernails harbor large numbers of harmful bacteria.

### **Section 3 Hands Can Also Be Unhappy**

Hand gestures are external expressions of inner states and are determined entirely by mood, feeling, and interest. A gesture made in accordance with inner feeling can sometimes convey more information than a thousand words. The more genuine the emotion, the more natural the movement and posture appear. When we feel unhappy, our hands also appear unhappy, producing gestures of sadness, anger, or impatience; this is what is meant by the saying that the ten fingers are connected to the heart.

#### **(2) People Who Wear Classical Gold Watches**

They possess strong foresight and will not sacrifice long-term interests for short-term gains. Combined with strong willpower and meticulous thinking, they usually achieve success in their careers. Because of their maturity and tolerance, family and friends trust them deeply. If your opponent wears a classical gold watch, you will face a formidable challenge; if you also wear one, the contest will undoubtedly be intense and fascinating.

#### **Fingers Interlaced and Clasped Tightly**

When confronted with a major event or sudden change, many people habitually interlace and clasp their fingers tightly. This is an unconscious action performed under extreme lack of confidence or great pressure. As the gripping force increases, the color of the fingers may change; if you notice whitening in parts of the hands of someone whose fingers are interlaced, it suggests that the current situation may have become quite serious.

#### **Hands**

Hands are the most practical body parts humans possess. What a person does with their hands reveals considerable information about their thoughts and feelings. In sign language, the hands can convey endless information just like spoken words.

In this section we first describe the most common gesture used to express welcome—the handshake. We then continue with the meanings of other hand gestures.

#### **Summary**

When a person feels no sense of control, no security, worry (fear) of being rejected, or lack of confidence, a freezing response of the hands occurs. Once the subject exhibits this reaction, it indicates a shift toward psychological weakness; not only is there no offensive tendency, even defensive psychology is weak, placing the person in a state between caution and fear. At this point it is easy to increase the intensity of stimulation, and the effect of the stimulus will be relatively obvious.

#### **Standing with Hands Behind the Back**

Such individuals have conservative personalities; their most notable traits are respect for authority, adherence to conventional rules, and a strong sense of responsibility. Given sufficient time, however, they can also accept new ideas and viewpoints. In addition, their emotions are not very stable, so they often appear somewhat inscrutable. Their strengths include patience and perseverance; they do not fear trouble and can persist until the end no matter what difficulties arise.

## **5. Resting the Chin**

Resting the chin is an extremely common action; the gesture of propping up the chin in public is a negative social signal. When a person feels psychologically bored, they become listless and dejected; the head naturally drops, and the hand naturally props it up, producing the chin-resting gesture. Many students make this movement unconsciously when they find class content boring or the teacher's lecture dull.

### **(1) People Who Carry Briefcases**

In relatively formal settings, many people carry briefcases, mainly for work. If someone habitually uses a briefcase, they are likely a manager or higher-ranking executive in a company. They emphasize efficiency, are strict with subordinates, and set even higher standards for themselves. Women who like to carry briefcases are, nine times out of ten, assertive and strong-willed.

## **Hands on Hips**

When a person places both hands on their hips, they project a surging presence. We often see this posture on police officers, soldiers, and leaders. It is actually a territorial-defense gesture frequently used to assert dominance or maintain authority. We can infer the other person's identity from this posture, because apart from authority figures, ordinary people rarely place their hands on their hips.

## **Chapter 10 Seeing Through Behavioral Psychology to Master the Overall Picture of Life**

Humans are like trees in nature: each tree has its own characteristics, yet commonalities exist. Analyzing the self through authoritative behavioral psychology not only helps you understand yourself better but also enables you to grasp universal human traits, making it easier to understand others and, from their perspective, to see directly into the secrets of their hearts.

## **How Much Information Your Hands Can Reveal**

Millions of years ago, our ancestors began using their hands to make weapons and employ tools. Scientific research shows that the hands contain a rich network of nerves and are among the body parts with the highest concentration of nerve endings. The color, structure, skin texture, flexibility, finger shape, and even the nails of the hands conceal a person's temperament.

Overall, hands fall into six basic forms.

### **(II) The Hands of the Easygoing Type**

Compared with the ideal type, these hands are slightly shorter and broader, with fingers that taper a little. Their owners are artistic, sensitive, impulsive, and delicate. Yet they prefer a life of ease and may even suppress their artistic talent for it. You can observe their thumbs further: whether they achieve anything depends on whether those thumbs are firm or weak.

## **Covering the Mouth with a Hand**

This indicates that the person realizes a remark was inappropriate and quickly covers the mouth to conceal it. At such a moment, offering a few reassuring words will make the person deeply grateful to you.

We often say “the ten fingers are connected to the heart.” It is an undeniable fact that the hands can express a person’s inner voice. If we wish to understand someone’s inner thoughts, simply observing their hand gestures will suffice.

## **Tapping the Fingertips on the Table**

When you are speaking to someone and they perform this action, they may be caught in a mental dilemma, considering how to solve a problem, or still hesitating over a decision. At this point you should tactfully stop; continuing may irritate the other person and make the situation worse.

## **(V) Hands on the Hips**

This is a common posture that signals protest or aggression. Some observers call the gesture “ready for action,” yet its fundamental meaning is “challenge.” It is especially typical during arguments. Men adopt it to display bravery and strength, but when women do so it conveys a fierce impression.

## **III. Scratching the Neck**

Scratching the neck is a bodily signal of inner melancholy and expresses anxiety and helplessness. When someone seeks a definite answer to a matter or question, they often scratch their neck while thinking. If you notice a friend making this gesture, you might ask what is troubling them and offer to share the worry or provide advice.

## **IV. Slapping the Table and Rising**

When struck by an unexpected blow or gripped by extreme anger, a person is very likely to slap the table and stand up. The slapping action serves to defend one’s dignity and strongly condemns the other party’s words or deeds. When someone slaps the table and rises, it is best not to argue; otherwise the other person’s anger will intensify and irrational behavior may follow.

## **(II) People Who Prefer Square Handbags**

The “square handbag” I refer to does not include the briefcases already mentioned; it means ordinary, mass-market bags. These bags are finely made, not very large in volume, yet roomy enough for daily essentials and money. People who like such bags generally fall into two groups: one consists of fashion leaders, the other of rather meticulous ordinary office workers.

## **Rubbing the Hands**

When people are doubtful or under great pressure, they usually rub their hands involuntarily, especially when the situation is tense. The rubbing motion becomes more pronounced, revealing a lack of confidence, distress, irritability, and anxiety, along with uncertainty. Rubbing the hands serves to relieve tension and unease.

## **Chapter 3 Hands and Heart Are Linked—Body Movements Best Express Inner Feelings**

American psychologist Albert Mehrabian once proposed the famous formula: "Total expression of information = 7 % tone + 38 % voice + 55 % body language." The 55 % is enough to let someone skilled in "body-language mind reading" see through what another person truly wishes to express even when that person stops short or remains silent.

### **(I) The Ideal Type of Hand**

The hand is overall small, the palm long and slender, the fingers oval, and the fingertips fine. The skin is fair and soft, the nails almond-shaped. This is the hand of rich ideals—the hand of dreamers, poets, artists, and literati. Whether male or female, people with this hand shape are sensitive and beauty-loving, yet often impractical.

### **Hands and Heart Are Linked—Hand Movements Portray Inner Emotions**

The hands are the most touch-sensitive and most active part of the body. Observing the changes in a person's hand postures while speaking often allows one to capture various messages promptly. American psychologist Dr. San Feldman also said: "Small hand movements have little capacity for deception; they are like a mirror that reflects one's intentions completely."

### **Inserting the Thumb into a Pocket**

During conversation, only the thumb is placed in the pocket while the other four fingers remain outside the clothing. This shows the person is in a state of unease, usually stemming from lack of confidence or a sense of insecurity. It creates the impression that the person is untrustworthy, so the gesture should be avoided as much as possible.

### **Standing with Arms Crossed over the Chest**

Most such people have a strong personality and refuse to yield in the face of difficulty. At the same time they pursue personal interests excessively and maintain a high level of vigilance. When interacting with others they often adopt a self-protective defensive posture that keeps people at a distance, giving a cold impression that makes them hard to approach.

### **Hands Clasped Behind the Head**

This is a very comfortable posture. The person may be in a position of authority and uses the relaxed pose to display composure, calmness, and status. For example, at a gathering the head of a department might make this gesture, yet as soon as the manager enters the hands are immediately lowered and the posture becomes respectful.

### **Pointing a Finger at Someone**

People who do this are usually in a dominant state. They are arrogant and short-tempered. If they are performing the gesture, it indicates dissatisfaction with something or someone. At such times do not contradict them, or their temper may flare and an argument may ensue.

### **Feet Together, Hands Crossed**

Such people are cautious in their dealings and pursue perfection in everything. Outwardly they may appear somewhat timid and lacking in initiative, yet they possess a tenacious side: once they decide on a course, they pursue it silently and persistently and never give up easily.

### **(III) People Who Carry Small, Exquisite Handbags**

Among women who frequently appear in social settings you will often notice elegant little bags containing little more than everyday cosmetics and some money. Generally speaking, women of status, beauty, and refinement choose such small bags to display their identity and taste.

### **(III) People Who Wear Specially Designed Watches**

Clearly they like being unique and have the ability to make themselves unique. They care so much about the image they project that they may change themselves to please others. Yet their intelligence allows everything to appear natural and unforced.

### **Continuously Rubbing the Hands**

When a person makes this movement it shows they are in a state of tension, anxiety, and unease. Especially when the fingers are interlaced and rubbed up and down, it indicates anxiety has reached an extreme; if no good solution is found, an emotional outburst may follow.

### **Standing with Hands Usually Placed on the Hips**

Such people tend to have their own opinions and confidence. They are absolutely conscientious in their work, steady and never rash, and possess a commanding charm along with considerable leadership ability. Their greatest shortcoming is excessive subjectivity; they do not listen to advice and can therefore appear stubborn at times.

### **Touching the Mouth, Nose, or Ears with a Hand**

These are subconscious actions people make when lying. They may be deliberately deceiving or may simply not wish to reveal something. In either case, if you see someone performing this small gesture, do not readily believe what they say.

### **(IV) The Tray Pose**

When facing someone they admire, women often adopt this gesture—elbows resting on the table, hands clasped together, chin resting on the hands. The tray pose signals interest in the other person, yet it occurs mostly among women.

### **Clasped Hands Reveal Dissatisfaction and Unease**

Clasping the hands is a hand movement we often make. What are the common postures of this action, and what corresponding mental activities do they reflect? With these questions in mind, let us look at the explanations given by FBI agents.

### **Standing with Hands on the Hips**

Most such people are leaders with strong self-confidence and authority. If their feet are spread wider than shoulder width and the torso leans slightly forward, it often indicates latent aggression; you should prepare yourself for the possibility that the person is about to lose their temper<|eos|>

See Microexpression foundations (c-micro-foundations).

See Part VI — Deception (p-deception).

See Arms and shoulders (c-arms).

## Handshake

### Handshake

The handshake gesture evolved from an ancient hand signal in which people raised both hands upon meeting to show they carried no weapons. In the Roman Empire era, people did not shake hands but grasped the other person's forearm as a greeting. In modern times, the handshake has become one of the world's most representative greeting customs, signifying openness and unity.

A dry palm and firm grip usually indicate confidence and a tendency to take control. A weak handshake may be interpreted as a sign of weak character. Sweaty palms during a handshake can stem from nervousness, anxiety, or simply hot weather. All such interpretations, however, remain broad generalizations.

Some strong individuals avoid gripping tightly because they fear causing pain. Artists or surgeons who rely on their hands for work may also refrain from firm handshakes to protect themselves. Likewise, people with arthritis may prefer not to shake hands.

A standard or equal handshake occurs when both palms are vertical, the pressure is mutual, and the hands clasp rather than squeeze (see Figure 3.1). Eye contact during the handshake is limited to three glances, conveying confidence without arrogance. To further express friendliness and sincerity, maintain a smile while shaking hands.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.1 标准或平等的握手]*

In the politician-style handshake, the initiator typically uses both hands rather than one (see Figure 3.2). The right hand clasps the other person's hand while the left hand rests lightly on top.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.2 政客式握手]*

Another common handshake involves the right hand shaking while the left hand grasps the other person's forearm or shoulder. This style is acceptable between close old friends. After the handshake, the pair often immediately shares a warm "bear hug." When used with someone who is not a close friend, however, most people feel uncomfortable, viewing the gesture as insincere or overly flattering. Whenever anyone greets us this way, we should treat it as a sincere expression.

In times of distress, people generally do not convey deep emotion through a handshake. Instead, they gently take both of the other person's hands and communicate sympathy through facial expressions (see Figure 3.3), often adding an embrace. This gesture tells the person in need that you will remain by their side until the crisis passes.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.3 同情地紧握双手]*

Sometimes people unconsciously display superiority during an initial handshake by extending their hand palm-down, forcing the other person to respond with an upturned palm (see Figure 3.4).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.4 握手时伸出一只“带有优越感”的手]

Conversely, some individuals instinctively extend an upturned palm, signaling inferiority and failing to align vertically with the other person's hand (see Figure 3.5).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.5 握手时伸出一只“自卑”的手]

In another variation, one person uses the transition of the handshake to flip the other's hand underneath so that their own hand ends up on top. They extend their hand, grasp the other's, then rotate it so the other person's palm faces down. This conveys the simple nonverbal message: "I have the upper hand!" (see Figure 3.6).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.6 “自信VS自卑”的握手]

Cultural differences also require attention. The French often shake hands when entering or leaving a room, while Germans shake hands only once. Learning appropriate greetings while traveling helps avoid unnecessary mistakes.

### **Hands Formed into a Steeple, Indicating Confidence**

When the fingertips of both hands are brought together and touch correspondingly, they form a "church steeple" gesture. This is commonly used to express confidence, though it can also be viewed as affected, arrogant, or proud.

Most of the time, people form the steeple unconsciously. Some deliberately use the gesture to emphasize strong security and absolute self-confidence. One suggestion, for example, advises businesspeople to make this gesture after delivering a final offer during negotiations. The person leans back in the chair, smiles, and forms the steeple with their fingers. The client watches for a long time before firmly saying, "Deal!" During negotiations, the gesture seems to possess a certain magic that easily wins others over.

In *The Art of Reading Minds in the White House*, author Henry H. Calero recounts an anecdote about the steeple gesture.

Steve McQueen, the famous American film actor nicknamed "The King of Cool," starred in many hit movies, including the classic *The Great Escape*.

Once, while seated in first class, Calero discovered that his neighbor was McQueen. They began talking. When the conversation turned to McQueen's performance as a poker player in *The Cincinnati Kid*, Calero remarked that the acting was not outstanding.

"The King of Cool" crossed his arms, fixed Calero with his sharp blue eyes, and asked with slight irritation, "What do you mean?"

Calero explained that in one key scene, the poker player McQueen portrayed unconsciously revealed a winning gesture: after placing a bet, he formed a steeple with his hands.

McQueen nodded. Calero continued, noting that steady professional players never make this gesture unless bluffing, yet McQueen's character clearly was not bluffing. Thus, it was a nonverbal error on McQueen's part.

After hearing the explanation, McQueen quickly uncrossed his arms, snapped his fingers, and told Calero that others had given similar feedback about the role but could not explain why—they could only “feel” it.

McQueen shook Calero’s hand warmly and expressed deep gratitude. They spent the rest of the flight pleasantly.

People occasionally form this gesture while speaking or listening, sometimes with the hands positioned slightly higher or lower.

Those who rarely use the steeple gesture tend to raise their hands very high when they do, almost looking at others through the gaps between their fingers. This behavior often makes others feel uneasy. If you must continue a conversation with such a person, you need to exercise self-control. The lower steeple is most common among women.

There is also an elegant version of the steeple in which the hands are clasped together, one hand wrapping around the other, which is already formed into a fist.

This confident, elegant steeple is most frequently seen in business settings. Company employees, lawyers, doctors, and especially professors lecturing on favorite topics often adopt the posture, appearing highly satisfied with their current positions.

We also observe that most people’s behavior is unconscious. In some cases, the weaker party in a negotiation occasionally forms the steeple, giving the stronger party the impression that the person making the gesture is hiding something and knows more than they are saying, prompting an immediate change of topic.

The advice is: if your point in the next negotiation does not feel as persuasive as you imagined, try forming the steeple, remain silent, and wait for the other person’s reaction.

### **Handshake Reveals Inner Secrets**

#### Micro-expression Keywords

Whether greeting an old friend not seen for a long time or a stranger just met, a handshake is essential. It is not only basic courtesy but also a way to sense the other person’s inner state and infer their character and behavioral tendencies through the handshake.

The handshake is one of the most common courtesies in interpersonal communication. It is also a form of communication that conveys respect, enthusiasm, encouragement, or indifference, flattery, and arrogance. Subconscious movements during a handshake reveal one party’s hidden inner secrets.

- **Habit of grasping the other person’s hand with both hands**

Such individuals are warm, gentle in character, kind-hearted, able to confide in friends, open with their emotions, and clear in their likes and dislikes.

- **Firm, strong grip during handshake**

This type of handshake feels like an arm-wrestling match and can cause pain. The person intends to convey sincerity but often leaves an impression of insincerity because the action is excessive. Many people, especially on first meeting, are unaccustomed to this style. In personality, these individuals are energetic and highly confident yet tend to be domineering and arrogant. They also exhibit strong organizational and leadership abilities.



- **Moderate pressure during handshake**

They shake hands with moderate pressure and steady movements while naturally looking at the other person. Such people are resolute, frank, responsible, and reliable. They think carefully, excel at reasoning, and frequently offer constructive suggestions. When others face difficulties, they quickly propose practical solutions, displaying the demeanor of a capable leader and earning trust. They possess leadership potential, so it is worthwhile to build connections; they may later become valuable allies.

- **Light touch during handshake**

This is a major taboo in social etiquette. A mere light touch without a firm grip creates an impression of perfunctoriness and disrespect. Generally, such people tend to be pessimistic, indifferent to most matters, and possess a carefree, worldly attitude. On the other hand, they are open-minded, modest, and easygoing.

- **Up-and-down shaking during handshake**

They grasp the other person's hand tightly and shake it continuously. These individuals are extreme optimists, full of hope for the future, always energetic, and seemingly never seen worried. Their positive enthusiasm often makes them beloved and admired.

- **Holding on without releasing**

They often hold the other person's hand until they finish speaking. Overall, such people are emotionally rich and enjoy making friends. When two men shake hands this way, the one who does not release may have a request and hopes the other will listen carefully and respond. When two women do so, the one holding on may be someone who enjoys gossip and discussing others behind their backs. When a man holds a woman's hand this way, it indicates he has a favorable impression of her and hopes to convey it through this gesture.

- **Grasping only with fingers during handshake**

Such individuals are sensitive, emotionally unstable, and easily agitated. When interacting with them, one must be careful not to touch their sensitive spots, or one may end up embarrassed. In addition, they are kind-hearted and compassionate.

- **Unwilling to shake hands**

They do not initiate handshakes and appear reluctant when others extend a hand first. Most such people are introverted, shy, and conservative in character, yet sincere toward others.

Psychologists consider the best handshake method to be moderate pressure while looking directly into the other person's eyes. Only then can one display confidence while conveying sincerity and goodwill. Through the handshake, a bridge of heartfelt communication is built between both parties.

### **Handshake Strength Correlates with Personality**

A very firm handshake usually indicates that the person is confident and tends to control others. Excessive force, however, can appear rash rather than steady. It also suggests the shaker's inner warmth, sincerity, or expectation. Such individuals are generally energetic, self-confident, frank, and strong-willed, yet inclined toward authoritarianism. They possess outstanding organizational and leadership abilities and are natural leaders.

A handshake with moderate pressure, steady movements, and direct eye contact indicates a resolute, responsible, and reliable personality. These people think carefully, excel at reasoning, and possess strong responsibility. When difficulties arise, they quickly offer constructive opinions and practical solutions, making them trustworthy.

A handshake that extends a lifeless, textureless, information-free “dead fish” palm that merely brushes the other person’s hand lightly—neither firm nor forceful—usually belongs to someone who is introverted, weak-willed, lacking drive, cold, indifferent, negative, arrogant, and without decisive or crisp energy.

### **Palm-Scratching Handshake**

The specific form is: the hands clasp but do not release quickly; instead, they slide apart slowly, with the fingers lingering appropriately in the other person’s palm. Such individuals are emotionally rich and enjoy making friends. Once friendship is established, they remain loyal.

In addition, another common handshake involves the right hand shaking while the left hand grasps the other person’s forearm or shoulder. This style is acceptable between close old friends, and the pair often immediately shares a warm “bear hug” afterward. When used with someone who is not a close friend, however, most people feel uncomfortable, viewing the gesture as insincere or mistaken flattery.

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### **The Art of the Handshake**

The handshake gesture evolved from an ancient hand signal in which people raised both hands upon meeting to show they carried no weapons. In the Roman Empire era, people did not shake hands but grasped the other person’s forearm as a greeting. In modern times, the handshake has become one of the most common greeting and farewell rituals in social interactions.

FBI agents note that handshake style and pressure can express different levels of courtesy and attitude toward the other person, reveal the shaker’s personality, allow one to understand the other’s personality, and gain the initiative in conversation.

### **Shaking Hands in an Appropriate Manner**

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In fact, handshake style and pressure can express different levels of courtesy and attitude toward the other person, reveal the shaker's personality, allow one to understand the other's personality, and gain the initiative in conversation.

### **Hand-Holding Handshake**

The specific form is: one person gently takes both of the other person's hands, usually with their own right hand taking the other's left hand and their own left hand taking the other's right hand. In times of distress, people generally do not convey deep emotion through a handshake. Instead, they gently take both of the other person's hands and communicate sympathy through facial expressions, sometimes adding an embrace. This gesture tells the person in need that you will remain by their side until the crisis passes.

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### **Flipping Handshake**

The specific form is: one person uses the transition of the handshake to press the other's hand underneath so that their own hand ends up on top. They extend their hand, grasp the other's, then flip it over so the other person's palm faces down. This handshake conveys the simple nonverbal message: "I have the upper hand!" It means the person has seized the initiative in the interaction.

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### **Humble Handshake**

Also known as the begging handshake or submissive handshake, its specific form is: extend the hand with the palm facing upward or upward to the left, without aligning with the other person's vertically extended palm. Some people, when shaking hands, to show respect or admiration for the other person, or to express their own humility and approachability, often subconsciously adopt this handshake method, implying that they are willing to be dominated by the other party.

### **Finger-grasp Handshake**

Also known as the finger-pinching handshake, its specific form is: when shaking hands, intentionally or unintentionally grasp only a few of the other person's fingers or fingertips with the fingers, without the palm making contact with the other person. Most people who adopt this handshake style have a gentle and sensitive personality and are easily emotionally aroused. However, they are kind-hearted and extremely

compassionate. Between opposite sexes it indicates reserve and composure; between same-sex individuals it indicates coldness, unfamiliarity, or high status.

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### **Dominant Handshake**

Also known as the controlling handshake, its specific form is: extend the hand with the palm facing downward or downward to the left, so that the other person, to accommodate it, must turn their own palm upward. People often adopt this handshake method during an initial handshake to display their sense of superiority, initiative, or arrogance, implying that they hold a position of dominance over the other person.

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### **Two-handed Handshake**

Also known as the American politician-style handshake, its specific form is: first grasp the other person's right hand with your right hand, then gently place your left hand on top of the clasped hands. Most people who habitually hold the other person's hand with both hands during a handshake are warm and sincere, kind-hearted, honest and reliable, most willing to confide in friends, and express joy and anger openly with clear likes and dislikes.

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### **Standard Handshake**

Also known as the equal handshake, its specific form is: both parties extend their palms facing left to grasp each other. During the handshake, eye contact between both parties is limited to three instances or fewer. This is a simple, ceremonial way of expressing friendliness through a handshake. To further convey a friendly and sincere attitude, please remember to maintain a smile while shaking hands.

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### **Handshake Styles Best Reflect a Person's Personality**

Although the action of shaking hands is simple, each person's way of shaking hands differs. American psychologist Elaine Garlan concluded through survey research that the manner in which a person shakes hands with others best reflects their personality and attitude.

### **Handshake Styles Best Reflect a Person's Personality**

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See Hands (c-hands).

### **Open Hands and Clenched Hands**

#### **Rubbing Both Hands Together Often Signals Expectation**

Perhaps each of us has silently expressed expectation for something. For example, before participating in an activity, people rub their hands together as if washing them. Unless their hands are cold from the weather and they need friction to warm them, this is a nonverbal way of conveying strong interest in the activity. This may explain why gamblers always like to rub the dice between their hands before throwing them!

When a child sees the tour bus carrying their mother stop, they rub their hands together with delight, showing eager anticipation to see what "delicious" treats the travel bag holds. A company executive over sixty will make the same gesture upon learning the firm has just landed a major deal.

In many large cities, doormen, waiters, and other service-industry employees adopt expectant postures to signal their hope for a tip. They may jingle coins in their pockets or strike the pose of an "ancient Egyptian statue," with palms held behind the back and facing upward.

Verbal pauses often form a crucial part of expectant postures. A waiter might say, "I hope you have a pleasant day and are satisfied with our service," then pause to wait for a response. If the customer misses the hint, the waiter may add, "Sir, let me check whether a better table has been reserved for you." Repeatedly ignoring such hints results in noticeably reduced service.

### **Open Palms Signal Openness and Sincerity**

People often place open palms in front of the chest, facing upward, to indicate candor. Sometimes they accompany the gesture with the words "I have nothing to hide." Actors frequently use this posture not only to convey emotion but also to reveal a character's open nature.

When children feel proud of something they have done, they readily show their hands; when they feel guilty or uncertain, they hide their hands in pockets or behind their backs.

Like other attitudes, an open stance encourages similar feelings in others. British biologist Charles Darwin observed that when animals signal submission—an expression of openness—they roll onto their backs with all four feet in the air, exposing their soft underbelly and throat. He noted that even highly hostile animals will refrain from attacking a submissive individual in this position.

Comparative psychologist Dr. Leon Smith, an expert on animal behavior and communication, once tested this with a wild wolf. As the wolf snarled and bared its teeth, Smith lay on the ground and exposed his throat. The wolf gently nuzzled him, touching his throat with its teeth but causing no harm.

### **Clasped Hands Indicate Tension and Unease**

When a person clasps their hands together—tightly wringing them—this usually signals anxiety.

The center of attention at a meeting often adopts this posture, especially when asked a series of difficult questions. During a California election, when the voting machine malfunctioned, the official explaining the failure to voters was photographed in exactly this clasped-hands posture.

If your conversation partner keeps their hands tightly clasped, they are tense and hard to approach; try to help them relax. One effective method is to lean slightly toward them.

For instance, during a conversation between a superior and a subordinate, the subordinate may feel uncertain about the superior's attitude. If the superior remains seated behind a large desk and looks down over their glasses, the subordinate on the nearby sofa will likely keep their hands tightly clasped. Once the superior stands, moves closer, and sits near the subordinate while leaning forward to show trust, the subordinate's hands will immediately separate and display a more confident posture.

### **Fingers Interlaced and Clasped Make a Person Hard to Believe**

Imagine someone sitting upright at a conference table, arms resting on the surface, fingers interlaced and tightly clasped, while saying in a mild tone, "I have always been open-minded and sincerely hope we can solve the problem." Everyone present will consciously or unconsciously notice the inconsistency between words and posture.

Open palms signal honesty and sincerity; clenched fists signal the opposite. Attempting to achieve a desired result through such deception is likely to backfire and provoke hostility or attack.

A person under pressure who feels the need to defend themselves may also interlace and clasp their fingers, indicating an attempt to suppress strong emotions—often dissatisfaction or anger.

### **Hands Placed on the Chest Signal Agreement**

This is a common, emblematic gesture of approval, indicating agreement with what has been said or done.

For centuries, people have placed a hand on the chest to express loyalty, integrity, and honesty. Americans adopt a similar posture when pledging allegiance to the flag. The gesture actually dates back to ancient Rome, where soldiers saluted by placing one hand on the chest and extending the other toward the recipient.

Note that, except in formal settings, women rarely use this posture to express loyalty. When a woman places one or both hands on her chest, the gesture is usually protective or excited, signaling sudden fright or great surprise.

### **Open Palms**

Open palms generally indicate openness and sincerity (see Figure 3.7). When children feel proud of something they have done, they open their palms. When people feel guilty or uncertain, the same gesture can help them find a way forward. An extended palm signals expectation—perhaps for money, an object, or even an idea.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图3.7 摊开双手，以示真诚]*

### **Hands Held Apart Can Also Reveal Inner Thoughts**

The postures discussed above all involve the hands held together. When the hands are apart, however, different movements carry different meanings.

## **Arms and Shoulders**

### **Can You Take Off Your Jacket?**

In formal business meetings, if someone is preparing to sit at a large conference table, they usually do not remove their suit jacket. However, observing whether they fasten or unfasten the jacket reveals whether they are open or defensive.

When a person feels friendly, relaxed, and comfortable, they unbutton their suit jacket. But if someone says something they dislike, they are very likely to button it again and cross their arms.

Those who keep their suit jackets unbuttoned tend to be active participants in the discussion. They usually lean forward and place their arms and elbows on the table. Those who sit with their jackets tightly buttoned, in a straight and upright posture, and sometimes with arms crossed, are usually less engaged.

When participants begin discussing a topic that everyone cares about and have essentially reached agreement in principle, they remove their jackets. This indicates that the negotiation is moving in a positive direction. Conversely, it suggests that the meeting may face some thorny issues.

The sculpture *The Thinker* by the famous French sculptor Auguste Rodin is a classic example of deep understanding of postural language. Who would doubt that the figure is pondering a problem and striving to

find a solution? In real life, we often see “the thinker” posture or similar poses. This shows that the person is grappling with something difficult or puzzling.

Sometimes a person adopts a series of critical evaluation postures. For example, placing one hand on the cheek, gripping the jaw with the palm, extending the index finger along the face, and curling the other fingers beneath the mouth (see Figure 4.6). This posture indicates that she is not only evaluating what the other person is saying at that moment but also critiquing the ideas being presented.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.6 批判性的揣摩姿势]

Another evaluation posture is stroking one’s chin or beard (in the case of some bearded men) (see Figure 4.7). This “let me think about it” gesture typically appears when a person is about to make a decision. The accompanying facial expression is often eyes slightly narrowed, as if considering the best long-term answer to the question.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.7 抚摸下巴的揣摩姿势]

When a person stands up and paces back and forth in the room, it usually indicates they are pondering what someone has just said. Most people exhibit this behavior when solving difficult problems or making tough decisions, because standing helps them think more clearly. This is a positive posture.

Therefore, when you see someone pacing while deep in thought, remember to stay quiet, wait patiently for them to speak, and do not interrupt. Doing so would break their train of thought and prevent them from reaching a decision or offering a final offer. This explains why some negotiators fail to achieve their goals: they cannot remain calm.

Experienced salespeople are generally adept at reading this “pacing person” (see Figure 4.8). They know that when facing a pacing prospect, it is best to wait patiently, because the posture signals that the client is ready to decide.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.8 来回踱步的思考者]

If a person pinches the bridge of their nose, it often indicates they are focusing on and reflecting upon a decision they must make. Similar gestures include lowering the head and pinching the bridge of the nose while experiencing intense inner conflict (see Figure 4.9), as if checking whether one is truly in a difficult situation or merely in a nightmare.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.9 捏鼻梁的姿势]

In most cases, people close their eyes while pinching the bridge of their nose; this posture represents strong inner doubt. For example, a lawyer attending one of our seminars mentioned in a report that he knew a judge who frequently used this posture to express thoughts and feelings about a case. If the judge believed the defendant was guilty, the gesture would not appear; if the judge believed the defendant was innocent, the gesture would appear, sometimes with eyes closed for several minutes while internally struggling over how to determine the defendant’s guilt.

Sliding glasses down the nose and peering over the top at the speaker is another common evaluation posture (see Figure 4.10). Anyone seeing this posture feels they are being criticized and looked down upon.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.10 通过眼镜缝隙窥探]



We emphasize that if this posture is one of your habits, you must recognize the negative effect it may have on others. If you do not want to elicit a negative response, it is best to avoid it.

Another posture glasses-wearers adopt when facing conflict or confrontation, or when buying time to decide, is to slowly remove the glasses and carefully wipe the lenses—even when the lenses are clean and do not need wiping. People usually speak more slowly while performing this action.

A similar time-buying posture is removing the glasses and placing one temple tip in the mouth (see Figure 4.11). This posture shows that the person is not only listening attentively but also carefully considering what the other person is saying.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.11 拖延时间, 仔细思考]

### 9.1.1 Victory Posture

We often see winners of wars or competitions habitually perform actions such as raising both hands high or shouting loudly. These energy-intensive movements originally serve to attract more attention.

Victory brings joy. The person who achieves a competitive victory experiences positive emotions that mobilize energy reserves. Winning implies many subsequent benefits; these positive stimuli heighten the winner's neural excitement. During combat, the body stores large amounts of energy for mental or physical confrontation. After the fight ends, excess energy must be released and tense nerves soothed so the body returns to its normal state; otherwise, prolonged excitement overloads the nervous and circulatory systems.

Many celebratory postures are anti-gravity movements.

Raising both hands high is a common victory gesture and one of the classic anti-gravity movements (see Figures 9-1 and 9-2).

- Figure 9-1 Hands raised high in victory response
- Figure 9-2 Phelps waving to the audience at the award ceremony

On the playing field, when an athlete scores a crucial goal, spectators frequently see various post-goal celebrations, one of which is raising both hands and leaping to chest-bump (see Figure 9-3).

- Figure 9-3 Chest-bump victory response, common in male sports settings

When two people celebrate together, they may also raise one hand each and perform a high-five (see Figure 9-4).

Jumping and cheering is essentially a fixed combination of actions after victory, captured in the idiom "jumping for joy" (see Figure 9-5).

- Figure 9-4 High-five victory response
- Figure 9-5 Jumping victory response

Some athletes perform a complex jump—a backflip—after victory to express inner joy and excitement (see Figure 9-6). Jumping is a classic anti-gravity movement, while cheering is a way to attract more attention through display; it also helps regulate breathing and expend energy.

- Figure 9-6 Backflip victory response

Another reaction equivalent to jumping is climbing to a high place after victory. It is common for winning athletes, in their excitement, to climb to an elevated spot or run around the field while raising one hand to salute the audience; the essence is display (see Figure 9-7). The increase in altitude and the greater area of visibility created by running attract more people to see and praise them.

- Figure 9-7 Arms raised in victory response
- Figure 9-8 Hands raised high in victory response

A more subtle “climbing high” reaction is stretching the body. Almost everyone has done this: after completing a worthwhile task (which, in a sense, counts as victory), they face the morning sun (or sunset, or city lights at night) and stretch fully. On one hand, this moves the cervical and lumbar spine and relaxes the nerves; on the other, it generates a sense of accomplishment and hopeful anticipation of a bright future (perhaps a greater challenge).

In fact, while raising both hands to express the joy of victory, the torso and legs naturally straighten, allowing the person to reach their natural maximum height. It is difficult to imagine someone hunching with bent knees raising both hands (except in cases of congenital disability) to display themselves (see Figure 9-8).

- Figure 9-9 Leg raised and fist clenched in victory response

Additional ways to express victory through sound include cheering, singing loudly, whistling, and roaring. These convert internal energy into sound waves while also attracting more attention through display; they involve substantial exhalation and reduced inhalation to lower energy reserves. In many high-stakes win-or-lose games, the winner often exhales deeply to relax.

Other ways to expend energy after victory include the common “Oh, yeah!” action (see Figure 9-9). Raising one leg, clenching both fists, and contracting the body’s muscles so the torso curves inward—sometimes to an exaggerated degree—mobilizes many muscles, consuming significant energy and neural excitement.

Of course, in the cautious setting of psychological testing, test subjects rarely perform such large-scale complex movements; they more often use refined, subtle, and complex actions to express joy and excitement, actions that also carry a performative quality.

## 1. The Advance-or-Retreat Arm Barrier

The anterior chest and abdomen are protected only by the thoracic vertebrae, the thinner ends of the ribs, and the costal cartilages on the sides, while the entire abdomen lacks bony protection; the back, by contrast, is more thoroughly protected by the spinal column and the thicker proximal ends of the ribs. Consequently, the anterior chest and abdomen are areas to which the nervous system pays special attention—sensitive and relatively vulnerable. Over long-term evolution, humans have learned to use various movements and techniques to protect these vulnerable regions.

The front of the human body (including the anterior neck and the chest-abdomen area) contains most of the body’s sensitive and vulnerable organs, such as the throat, breasts, solar plexus (located below the thoracic vertebrae), and genitals; the nervous system therefore protects them with particular vigilance. When faced with negative stimuli (danger, discomfort, tension, provocation), humans instinctively create a barrier—sometimes merely conceptual—between the torso and the stimulus to protect themselves. This barrier may be as simple as crossing the arms or may involve objects such as books, cushions, or pillows.

Crossing the arms is an obvious defensive behavior, yet further analysis of accompanying body states can reveal different psychological conditions.

### **(1) Maximum defensive state—ready to strike**

An active defensive state is a fight-ready defensive response, usually accompanied by an upright torso, head held high, chest thrust forward, and legs apart. This combination of movements generally arises under the dominance of anger, implying relative dominance and the possibility of counterattack (see Figure 8-15).

This combination can be interpreted as several psychological states:

- Arms crossed to increase torso protection; relatively slender individuals are more likely to adopt it for this purpose than those with stronger builds.
- If the legs are also spread, it reflects territorial awareness on one hand and, on the other, stabilizes the body to convey a non-retreating fighting mindset and strong territorial defense and counterattack readiness. (See Chapter 8 for details.)
- The posture makes the person appear more imposing and substantial, increasing pressure and deterrence.

### **(2) Passive defensive arm crossing**

The passive defensive state is the opposite: the spine curves, the head lowers, the legs do not stand straight; if seated, the upper body may lean against the chair back and turn sideways toward the stimulus, resembling a reaction to cold (see Figure 8-16).

Such arm crossing stems purely from negative emotions such as fear or anxiety. Without body-temperature detection equipment, it is impossible to determine whether the person is cold or subconsciously afraid of attack. However, lowered body temperature and defensive reactions are not contradictory. The fight-or-flight preparation (emotion) redirects blood circulation, sending large amounts of blood to the limbs to store energy, which can indeed lower torso temperature and make the subject feel cold. Thus, passive arm-crossing can genuinely reflect the subject's negative emotional state.

Interestingly, the arm-crossing posture can also be used without any psychological pressure, simply to appear weak through this self-protective gesture. Users are often female students who carry books, folders, or bags in front of their chests throughout campus. The action essentially makes them appear vulnerable in order to receive more care. Why do few boys use this posture? Because men are naturally combative and will not display weakness without reason; doing so not only fails to elicit care but may invite bullying or at least the perception that they are "acting cute."

### **Explicit Resistance: Arms Crossed over the Chest**

Our arms are highly expressive and can convey a great deal of information effectively. When interrogating a suspect, FBI agents can judge whether the person is in a natural state—and therefore whether their statements are true—simply by observing the amplitude of arm movements. The less natural the person appears, the smaller the amplitude of arm movements; the larger and more complex the amplitude, the more it indicates that the speaker is immersed in their account and is usually expressing something genuinely felt.

Among all human postural behaviors (including gestures, postures, and facial expressions), crossing the arms over the chest conveys the most easily recognized resistance and is the posture most likely to influence

others' behavior (see Figure 2.14). According to Darwin's observations, this posture appears to represent resistance in cultures around the world.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.14 双臂交叉的男人]

Because women's upper-torso anatomy differs from men's, women typically cross their arms lower than men do (see Figure 2.15). When a person crosses their arms while clenching their fists, the resistance is further intensified (see Figure 2.8).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.15 双臂交叉的女人]

In negotiations, crossed arms are very common and indicate dissatisfaction with some aspect of the proceedings. It is important to identify this resistance immediately, locate its cause, and attempt to spread positive emotions. Unfortunately, most people fail to notice it, let alone act on it.

In failed negotiations, we often see that one party's offers, questions, or demands go unmet precisely because the other party developed resistance that went unnoticed and was allowed to spread. Once a negotiator's attitude shifts in this way, reaching agreement on contracts, treaties, or settlements becomes far more difficult.

Conducting a smooth negotiation is like steering a boat on a swift river: everyone must recognize the presence of turbulence and respond positively, or the boat will capsize. Therefore, when we notice the other party crossing their arms, it is time for self-examination—because they have clearly signaled their intention to end the conversation.

Baseball fans are familiar with the following scene: an umpire makes a call, and a coach disagrees. The coach runs onto the field, confronts the umpire, gestures angrily, and may even shake a fist.

The umpire stares hard at the furious coach and crosses both arms over the chest (except for football referees, who already wear chest protectors and cannot cross their arms; instead they place their hands on their hips and jut their chins toward the disputant). If the umpire feels they have heard enough, they turn their back on the coach to signal "you've said too much," or simply walk away.

## Social Centrifugal Space Invaders

Social centrifugal space is the private space a person imagines around themselves. As long as you remain outside another person's mental comfort zone, the other party feels at ease. But if you intrude on the private space in their mind, they immediately feel anxious and unsettled.

Most people respect others' social centrifugal space, yet some individuals, such as the so-called "intimate conversationalist" (see Figure 4.27), always try to invade that space. They tend to ignore the other person's reactions and keep moving closer, shortening the distance, which forces the other person to step back repeatedly.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.27 亲密的谈话人]

If the other person's repeated concessions fail to stop the invasion of their mental private space, the best response is to end the conversation or frankly state that you need some breathing room.

Therefore, when you try to close the distance with others, pay close attention to their reactions and respond when necessary to maintain or restore mutual comfort.

Sitting with legs spread across a chair and using the chair back as a barrier is another posture that signals authority and dominance (see Figure 4.28). Salespeople never adopt this sitting position when visiting potential clients unless they have no intention of closing the deal.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.28 双腿分开跨在椅子上]

Standing and looking down at a seated person also conveys arrogance through nonverbal body language. In general, raising one's body above others demonstrates dominance. This is why thrones for kings and queens are placed on elevated platforms. Many common descriptive terms reflect this higher position, such as "Your Highness," "high hall," "reverence," and "gaze up at."

If you wish to convey dominance or control over someone, simply stand up while they remain seated or sit in a position higher than theirs. Exercise caution when making this move, as it can provoke resentment. If your goal is cooperation, eliminate this pretense of superiority and meet the other person on equal footing.

To convey equality through nonverbal body language, adopt the Lincoln-style sitting posture: legs apart on the chair, arms resting on the armrests, and jacket open (see Figure 4.29). This is an open, relaxed sitting position. When two people sit facing each other in the Lincoln posture, neither is signaling superiority.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.29 林肯式的姿势]

## Resistance

The opposite of gestures that express openness are those that signal readiness to defend against physical or emotional threat. Note that when openness is misunderstood or fails to resolve an issue, it can turn into offense.

Among all human postures (including gestures, body positions, and facial expressions), crossing the arms over the chest conveys resistance that is the easiest to recognize and the most likely to influence others' behavior.

During negotiations, the crossed-arms posture (see Figure 4.2) is very common and indicates dissatisfaction with some aspect of the discussion. It is important to identify this resistance at the first moment, determine its cause, and then attempt to spread positive emotions.

### Figure 4.2 Arms crossed, indicating resistance

In failed negotiations, we often see that a party's offer, question, or request goes unmet because the other side developed resistance that went unnoticed and spread. When one party's attitude shifts in this way, reaching agreement on contracts, treaties, or settlements becomes far more difficult. Conducting a smooth negotiation is like steering a boat on a swift river: everyone must recognize the presence of turbulence and respond actively, or the boat will capsize.

Another gesture that conveys resistance or lack of interest is draping one leg over the arm of the chair while crossing the other leg (see Figure 4.3). At first glance it may appear open and relaxed, yet we soon notice that the person adopting this posture is usually expressing hostility or disregard.

### Figure 4.3 Casually draping one leg over the chair arm

Airline cabin crew generally regard passengers who rest a leg on the seat armrest as demanding and difficult to satisfy. Salespeople likewise find buyers seated in this posture hard to close. The behavior signals that the person is silently declaring dominance and strength in the transaction.

A very common posture expressing resistance is crossing the legs (see Figure 4.4). When negotiation participants are ready to raise and discuss issues, they generally do not cross their legs. If two or more people cross their legs together, it signals that a confrontation is about to begin.

#### **Figure 4.4** Legs crossed, indicating resistance

When a negotiation is nearing agreement, participants almost never cross their legs. They lean forward, which both shortens the distance to the other party and reduces divergence in judgment.

### **Recognition**

A common, emblematic gesture of recognition is placing both hands on the chest to signal agreement with what the other person has said or done (see Figure 4.40).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.40 双手放在胸前, 表示认可]*

For centuries people have used this gesture to communicate loyalty, integrity, and devotion. Americans use a similar posture when pledging allegiance to the flag. In fact, the gesture dates back to ancient Rome, where Roman soldiers saluted to express loyalty and recognition by placing one hand on the chest and extending the other toward the recipient.

Recognition through touch is most often seen between acquaintances, friends, and family members (see Figure 4.41) and rarely occurs between strangers or casual acquaintances. People who communicate nonverbally through touch can readily express their emotions. The most common areas touched are the shoulders and arms.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.41 父子交流彼此的认可和爱意]*

Touch can also serve as a calming gesture. The person performing the action usually accompanies it with reassuring words such as "Don't worry" or "Calm down."

If someone slowly moves closer to you, steadily reducing the distance, it usually means they agree with your viewpoint, wish to share something privately, or both. Such displays of closeness can sometimes make you uncomfortable (see "Social Centrifugal Space Invaders").

Interestingly, the distance between two communicating deaf individuals is generally greater than that between hearing people. This is because deaf people need sufficient space to clearly observe each other's facial expressions and body movements. They focus most on the face (primarily the mouth), while hands and body movements are not the primary focus. Only when one person is signing does the other fully direct attention to the hands.

## **2. The Innocent Shrug That Can Advance or Retreat — Shrugging Shoulders**

A composite movement frequently observed, especially among Westerners, is raising both shoulders while turning the palms upward, usually accompanied by the lines "Nothing," "Not my problem," "I don't know," or "There's nothing I can do."

This shrug is also a classic defensive reaction, as shown in Figure 8-17.

Through long evolution, the same response can occur even without physical threat, simply when the nervous system receives negative stimulation and perceives a need for self-protection. The psychological state mapped

by this reaction is a sense of needing protection—a posture of weakness. Thus the shrug with palms up can be interpreted as: “I am weak, I am afraid, I am powerless, and look, my hands are empty—I have no intention of attacking.” Paired with the lines listed earlier, the meaning is precise.

Building on this standard movement, foreign researchers have concluded that a quick, one-sided shoulder shrug while speaking indicates a lack of confidence and, by extension, that the speaker is not confident in what they are saying and may be lying. The reasoning is sound: an incomplete shrug is a weakened version of the full shrug, sharing the same root and belonging to the category of micro-reactions (微反应). However, in our actual testing, instances where this movement genuinely correlates with lying remain very few and require further verification.

Whether a shrug, like arm-crossing, expresses a dominant or submissive mindset depends entirely on the degree of torso curvature. With the arm posture of the shrug held constant, an upright torso conveys dominance and can be voiced as “Not my damn problem,” “I don’t care,” or “I’m indifferent,” depicting a cold, aloof interior. A curved torso, by contrast, conveys the submissive appeals “There’s nothing I can do,” “I don’t want it this way either,” “I don’t know,” or “Please let me off the hook.”

### **People Who Cross Their Arms Over Their Chest Have Strong Defenses**

Micro-expression keyword: In daily life many people cross their arms over their chest. This is a gesture of defense, refusal, and negation. Especially during conversation, if the other person adopts this posture, they are likely in a defensive frame of mind. We must first find a way to reduce their defensiveness before the conversation can proceed smoothly.

When faced with danger, what is your first instinctive movement? Most people probably choose to wrap their arms around their body. This is a natural self-protection response.

In daily life we also frequently see people crossing their arms over their chest. The movement is an external manifestation of psychological defense. When we find ourselves in an unfamiliar environment, among strangers, or holding a rejecting attitude toward a certain viewpoint, we often unconsciously cross our arms over our chest.

It is a physical barrier we erect for ourselves; subconsciously it tells others not to cross that line, conveying a sense of defense, refusal, and negation. People who frequently adopt this posture have strong defenses.

An experiment was once conducted in which strangers who did not know one another were randomly divided into two groups and seated in circles. Members of the first group sat naturally relaxed. Members of the second group all tightly crossed their arms over their chests.

The first group quickly began chatting animatedly; by the end of the experiment they had become as familiar as friends. The second group remained subdued; no one initiated conversation, and at the end they were still strangers to one another.

The results demonstrate that crossing the arms over the chest projects an aloof, unapproachable impression, causing others to hesitate to approach. At the same time, it causes the person to miss many valuable social opportunities.

People who cross their arms over their chest essentially belong to the type with strong defenses. They trust no one, refuse to open their hearts, and keep others at a distance; naturally they do not have many friends.

### 7.1.1 Establishing Territory: Hands and Arms

There are three common postures:

#### Establishing territory with the hands

The most obvious, and the one frequently used by celebrities or their security personnel, is a blocking movement. This includes human chains formed by linked hands or simply extending and waving an arm straight out—without offensive intent, merely to secure necessary space. This purely protective action uses the hands to create a barrier around the individual, ensuring they remain undisturbed.

#### Establishing territory with the arms

The second posture is to spread both arms slightly downward, usually accompanied by clenched fists, colloquially called “rolling up the sleeves.” Variations exist, but they require well-developed muscles: the arms do not spread widely, yet the shoulders widen through the extension of the back muscles. The person performing the action can feel the expansion and often adds a slight sway to enhance the effect.

The meaning of this reaction is complex. For the individual it serves both as a psychological cue for establishing territory and as a way to appear more imposing (the occupied area increases), thereby increasing deterrence to some degree. Even without developed muscles, the posture can still heighten deterrence.

#### Establishing territory with the arms

The third posture is crossing the arms over the chest. When performed by a powerfully built person with thick upper limbs, it usually stems not from a protective mindset but from a desire to intimidate. Because of skeletal structure, crossing the arms allows them to occupy more lateral space than arms hanging straight down; the contraction and overlap of muscles also make the upper body appear more imposing and substantial (more effective than rolling up the sleeves), increasing the sense of intimidation.

If any of the three reactions above appears, it indicates that the person being observed has a strong confrontational mindset. The situation you face is comparable to attempting to enter the territory of a wild animal.

### Arms and Shoulders

Our arms are highly expressive and can convey a great deal of information effectively. In any setting, simply knowing the amplitude of a person’s arm movements allows us to judge whether they are in a natural state. The less natural speakers appear, the smaller their arm movements; the larger and more complex the arm movements, the more clearly they indicate that the speaker is immersed in their narrative.

Crossing the arms over the chest as a sign of resistance is very common worldwide (see Figure 3.12). Because of differences in upper-body structure, women generally cross their arms lower than men (see Figure 3.13). When a person crosses their arms while clenching both hands into fists, the gesture further intensifies their resistance (see Figure 3.9).

- Figure 3.12 Man with arms crossed
- Figure 3.13 Woman with arms crossed

Compared with the arms, shoulder movement has a more limited range. Yet careful observation can still yield information from shoulder movements.



For example, when the shoulders are held low, straight, and relaxed, the person is relaxed and confident (see Figure 3.14). If the shoulders slump forward and the head hangs, the person feels defeated, unhappy, or fatigued (see Figure 3.15). The typical shrug (raising then lowering) conveys “I don’t know” (see Figure 3.16). Sometimes a person also raises their eyebrows while shrugging.

- Figure 3.14 Shoulders held straight
- Figure 3.15 Shoulders slumped
- Figure 3.16 Shrugging movement

## What Should We Do?

If the other person keeps their arms crossed over their chest throughout the conversation, it shows they are not listening to anything you say.

At a company seminar featuring a well-known expert, some attendees agreed with the speaker’s views while others opposed them. The boss observed that those who raised objections almost invariably crossed their arms over their chests while listening. Those who supported the speaker kept their arms resting naturally on the chair or their laps, displaying an accepting, open posture.

Therefore, if we can find a way to get the person to uncross their arms, we may lower their defensiveness and make them receptive to our ideas.

Several simple methods are worth trying:

1. Hand them a small object—a pen, a promotional flyer, or a notebook—so they must release their crossed arms.
2. Offer a chair with armrests so they can rest their hands on the armrests.
3. While speaking, use matching body language. Body language can be contagious and may prompt them to uncross their arms and imitate your posture.
4. Occasionally glance at their crossed arms during the conversation. Your gaze tells them “I don’t like that posture” and exerts pressure, encouraging them to lower their arms.

Crossing the arms over the chest indicates strong defenses; the person will not easily let you into their inner world. Try a few small techniques to get them to lower their arms. Only after they adopt an open physical posture will they begin to accept you.

## Arms That Symbolize Territory: Arm Movements as Declarations of Power

Micro-expression keyword: People maintain a certain wariness toward those they do not know well. This is expressed in body language by instinctively crossing the arms over the chest in a posture of refusal or vigilance. Arms help people express feelings of defense, comfort, and acceptance. Therefore, by reading arm movements accurately we can understand others’ inner thoughts, respond correctly, and gain their goodwill.

Often, when people sense danger or encounter something they do not wish to face, they unconsciously cross their arms over their chest, erecting a physical barrier for themselves. This instinctive movement protects their territory. Clearly, arms are no less effective than other body parts at expressing comfort, confidence, and similar emotions.

When we encounter a threat, we find that the arms are always the first to react. If someone throws an object at us, our arms instinctively rise to block or catch it. Sometimes they even rise to protect us even when the

action is illogical or based on a mistaken judgment—for instance, when a bullet is fired, we still raise our arms even though we know they cannot stop it.

Consequently, in many situations a person's arm movements can reveal genuine feelings. Unlike expressions that are easy to fake, arm movements provide clear, authentic clues that allow us to understand others' thoughts, feelings, or intentions accurately.

Below are several arm postures commonly seen in daily life:

### **Shoulder Contraction: Weakness, Insecurity, Low Mood**

Some people slowly raise both shoulders to ear height during conversation, making it look as if their neck has disappeared. The focus of this movement is the gradual upward lift of the shoulders. Essentially, the purpose of this action is to pull the head back in, like a turtle. People who make this movement lack confidence and feel very uncomfortable. I have seen many people do this in meetings, especially when the boss walks in and says, "All right, I want to hear what everyone has been up to." While others enthusiastically discuss their impressive achievements, those with mediocre results shrink lower and lower, their shoulders rising as if trying to hide their heads.

Because the torso houses all the body's vital organs, which are fragile, the torso has developed strong vigilance over long-term evolution. It sensitively detects approaching danger and promptly produces various protective movements. In short, torso movements draw closer to what is beneficial—accepting or even liking people who benefit oneself—and move away from what is harmful—rejecting or even disliking people who harm oneself.

For example, when lovers share a close relationship and extremely high mutual trust, they instinctively want to approach, lean on, hug, or kiss each other. If two people are distant and lack sufficient trust, feelings of anger or disgust arise, along with strong defensiveness; physically, there is no desire for closeness, only an urge to stay as far away as possible. From torso movements, we can therefore easily discern the level of intimacy and trust between two people.

### **Hugging**

The "hug" can be described as a behavior prevalent worldwide, conveying care and affection. Sometimes a well-intentioned hug may be taken as a gesture of goodwill. A person's attitude toward hugging reveals whether that individual is polite or cold and difficult to deal with.

Although people can use words to conceal themselves, their arms cannot; arm movements expose all inner thoughts. If we understand these body-language signals, we can anticipate decisions that may work against us and gain time to reverse unfavorable situations. For instance, suppose you are a salesperson pitching a product. Near the end of the pitch, the client suddenly crosses both arms over the chest while keeping the thumbs raised and visible, accompanied by other affirmative gestures and expressions. You can confidently ask the client to sign a contract, because even though the client has not spoken, the purchase intention has already been clearly conveyed through body language.

Note that under the same circumstances, if the client adopts a clenched-fist arm-cross posture with a blank expression, any further request from you will meet resistance and yield no positive result. Thus, by reading arm body language we can perceive others' thoughts and take better precautions.

### 8.1.4 Hands on Hips

Both parties preparing for confrontation try to appear taller than the other; chest out and head up are essential. An erect spine and raised chin constitute one of the territorial-response features introduced in Chapter 7.

One interesting posture combines chest out and head up with both hands placed on the hips. Frequently seen in quarrel scenes, this pose is actually a contradictory combination. On one hand, the person tries to make their image appear extremely imposing; on the other hand, the hands are firmly restricted to the body, subconsciously reserved for display rather than attack. Experiments and real cases confirm this: when this posture appears, conflict usually remains at the stage of standoff or verbal sparring. A party truly intending physical attack will not adopt it.

However, although this posture indicates no physical attack will occur, the desire to attack has already formed and is very strong.

Please note that arm posture alone does not convey meaning. With the same hands-on-hips posture, if the person bends the torso while keeping the arms unchanged, an entirely different effect may result. In behavior driven by genuine emotion, anger never permits torso bending; bending can only stem from a sense of weakness, such as guilt or sadness.

### Arms Spread, Hands Open on the Table, Indicating Anger

Whether seated or standing, a person making this gesture strongly communicates: "Listen! I have something to say!" Failure to recognize this posture and the hostile, resistant, or destructive emotions about to erupt can make the situation extremely awkward and may even trigger serious consequences.

Therefore, no matter who adopts this posture—your child, employee, boss, or customer—recognize it early, intervene promptly, or remain silent. Never add fuel to the fire or impulsively counterattack, pushing the other person into an emotional explosion. Unfortunately, many people do exactly that in real life.

Compared with the arms, shoulder movements are relatively limited. Yet careful observation can still yield useful information.

For example, when the shoulders are held low, straight, and relaxed, the person is relaxed and confident. Shoulders slumped forward with the head hanging indicate defeat, unhappiness, or fatigue.

The shrug (shoulders rising then falling) is usually accompanied by open hands with palms up, conveying a "What do you want me to do?" attitude. Sometimes a person also raises the eyebrows while shrugging.

### Ventral Denial and Ventral Presentation

The former signals dislike of a person; the latter signals liking. Our ventral side gathers the eyes, mouth, chest, and genitals; it is sensitive to people or things we like or dislike. When encountering something good, the ventral side leans toward it; the same occurs with people we like. When we sense something is wrong—such as a change in relationship or an unwelcome topic—ventral-denial behavior appears: we shift posture or turn away. That is why, at a banquet, we instinctively rotate our bodies slightly when someone we dislike approaches.

The opposite of ventral denial is ventral display: we present our ventral side to people or things we like. When our child runs over to hug us, we move aside anything that might block the child, including our arms. We present the ventral side because it feels most warm and comfortable. Conversely, we express negative attitudes toward someone or something by turning away or ignoring them, because we always face what we like with our ventral side and turn our back on what we dislike.

## Shoulder Movements

Compared with the arms, shoulder movements are relatively limited. Yet careful observation can still yield useful information.

For example, when the shoulders are held low, straight, and relaxed, the person is relaxed and confident (see Figure 2.16). Shoulders slumped forward with the head hanging indicate defeat, unhappiness, or fatigue (see Figure 2.17). The typical shrug (rising then falling) conveys “I don’t know” (see Figure 2.18). Sometimes a person also raises the eyebrows while shrugging.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.16 Shoulders held straight]*

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.17 Shoulders slumped]*

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: Figure 2.18 Shrugging motion]*

## Touching the Neck

When a person touches the neck, they are telling us they lack confidence. For instance, when we ask someone for a favor, the other person may unconsciously touch their own neck, indicating they are not confident they can fulfill the request. At such moments it is best to prepare a backup plan.

When doing something or witnessing an event, we often hear people say they “broke into a sweat.” This means that although they appear outwardly calm, “hand expressions” are usually more truthful than facial expressions. Hand movements reveal inner emotions and thoughts; through these movements we can fully gauge a person’s level of confidence.

Therefore, learning to read hand body language not only boosts our own sense of achievement and helps us win more victories, but also allows us to understand others’ inner states. This way, we can interact with anyone with ease.

## (7) Arm Folding

Folding the arms across the chest creates a protective barrier against threat. Thus, when a person feels nervous, negative, or hostile, they naturally fold their arms over the chest. This posture often appears among strangers, especially in unsafe settings such as elevators. During conversation, if the other person folds their arms, pay attention: they may disagree with your views even while verbally expressing agreement.

Of course, many other gestures exist—stroking the chin for thought, raising the thumb for approval, slapping the head for sudden realization, scratching the head for difficulty or confusion. These gestures seem simple yet play extremely important roles in daily life. Looking back, some of the knowledge you have learned may already feel fuzzy. That is all right; this “people-reading” knowledge is the summary of my twenty-five years of experience. Do not expect to master and apply it in just a few hours—that is unrealistic. I simply want to tell you: never rush for quick results. Reading people is a delicate skill that requires patience and care.

## **Defensive Torso: Torso Movements Reveal the Level of Trust Between Two Parties**

Micro-reaction keywords: Human instinct—when sensing danger or discomfort, a person involuntarily uses the torso to protect themselves or adopts a challenging posture. Therefore, certain torso movements alone can indicate whether trust has already been established with the other person<|eos|>

### **8.3.1 Establishing Barriers**

The barrier-establishing response refers to the test subject attempting to use limbs or objects to create obstacles around the head or torso in order to hinder the advance of negative stimuli. A relatively classic defensive response is shown in Figure 8-14.

#### **Arms Wrapped Around the Head**

The action of wrapping both arms around the head indicates a sense of comfort and dominance. This is frequently observed in some business meetings, as if declaring to others: "This is my territory."

See Hands (c-hands).

#### **Arm Crossing Suggests Rejection**

##### **Arm Crossing Suggests Rejection**

A person crossing their arms often indicates defense or rejection. However, arm crossing takes many forms, and the meaning of each must be analyzed according to the specific situation.

When we were children, whenever danger approached or a threatening person drew near, we instinctively hid behind our parents or under a table or behind a cabinet to signal rejection. As adults, we instinctively cross our arms in front of our chest when facing similar threats, creating a physical barrier that prevents others from crossing it.

Many people share the consensus that crossing the arms signals defense or rejection. We frequently observe strangers adopting this posture when they feel uncertain or unsafe. When two standing people converse and one makes this gesture, it generally suggests rejection; the likelihood is even higher when the individuals are meeting for the first time.

A reporter once attended a forum on energy conservation and emission reduction for small and medium-sized enterprises. The theme was "How SMEs Can Strengthen Energy Conservation and Emission Reduction During Development."

The host speaker delivered an enthusiastic presentation, yet the reporter noticed that several rows of seated audience members had crossed their arms. For these SMEs, survival and growth issues had already exhausted them; energy conservation and emission reduction would only add pressure and make survival harder. Consequently, they viewed the speaker's content with negation and doubt.

The organizers' advocacy of energy conservation and emission reduction was not wrong, but they failed to consider the SMEs' standpoint and therefore could not convey their message effectively. They did not promptly notice the crossed arms and could not sense the audience's rejection, so they could not use the speech to overcome the opposition.

In public settings, many strangers habitually cross their arms, as if erecting a barrier between themselves and the outside world that separates them from disliked people and objects.

Arm crossing has three main manifestations:

1. Partial Arm Crossing

Because the full arm-crossing posture is too obvious, some people consciously adopt a subtler version—partial arm crossing. A common example is one arm reaching across the body to touch or grasp the other arm, forming a concealed barrier that provides a sense of security.

2. Disguised Arm Crossing

An even more sophisticated and concealed form is disguised arm crossing. One arm reaches across the body to touch a watch, bracelet, cuff, or jacket pocket, creating a barrier while appearing casual. If someone uses this method, stay alert; the disguise is effective and often goes unnoticed.

3. Reinforced Arm Crossing

A more overt form is reinforced arm crossing. When a person clearly senses imminent danger, they cross their arms while clenching their fists and occasionally gritting their teeth, signaling a defensive stance. If the emotion escalates out of control, an attack may follow. In such cases, maintain eye contact with a smile and open your palms to ease the tension in a friendly manner.

In summary, when conversing with someone, if you observe them crossing their arms, recognize their negative attitude and the possibility that you have voiced a disagreeable point. Even if they verbally agree, understand that they will not readily accept your view.

### **Arms Crossed in Front of the Chest Represents Defense**

Baseball fans are familiar with the following scene: a referee issues a ruling, a coach disagrees, runs onto the field, gestures emphatically in protest, and may even raise a clenched fist.

The referee stares sternly at the furious coach and crosses his arms in front of his chest (football referees, already wearing chest protectors, cannot cross their arms and instead place their hands on their hips while jutting their chin toward the disputant), adopting a defensive posture. If the referee has heard enough, he turns his back to signal “you have said too much” or simply walks away.

Among all postural behaviors, arms crossed in front of the chest conveys the most easily recognizable resistance and is most likely to influence others’ actions. Darwin’s research indicates this posture represents resistance across cultures.

Women typically cross their arms slightly lower than men because of differences in upper-body structure. Middle-aged women adopt the posture more often than older women.

In negotiations, crossed arms are common and signal dissatisfaction with some aspect of the discussion. Identifying this defensive mindset promptly, locating its trigger, and attempting to introduce positive emotions is important. Unfortunately, most people neither notice nor act on it.

In failed negotiations, one side’s offers or requests often fail because the other side developed defensive psychology that went unnoticed and spread. Once a party’s attitude shifts this way, agreements, contracts, or settlements become harder to reach.

A smooth negotiation resembles steering a boat on turbulent water: everyone must recognize the currents and respond positively, or the vessel will capsize. Therefore, whenever the other party crosses their arms, it is time for self-reflection, because they have clearly signaled an intention to end the conversation.

### **Arm Crossing Affects Listening Effectiveness**

Researchers divided volunteers into two groups to listen to a lecture and instructed each group to adopt a different posture. The first group was told to keep their arms in a natural, uncrossed position and listen in a relaxed, natural state. The second group listened at the same time and place but was required to cross their arms in front of their chest.

The researchers found that the first group raised fewer objections, while the second group was highly critical and frequently refuted the speaker's points. After the lecture, retention testing showed that the first group remembered 38 percent more content than the second group, demonstrating that arm crossing seriously impairs listening effectiveness.

Therefore, when communicating with others, crossed arms indicate reduced listening effectiveness. You should find a way to get the person to uncross their arms. Rather than reacting after the posture appears, prevent it from occurring in the first place. For example, hand the person an object to hold so they must release their arms. Or, during the conversation, show materials that require a posture change to view, such as books or images placed on a table, to prompt a shift in position.

### **Psychology Mini-Class**

American researchers examined the arm-crossing gesture and uncovered some concerning findings. The study indicates that arm crossing severely impairs listening effectiveness.

## **Legs and Feet**

### **Assessing His Willingness to Cooperate from Sitting Posture**

Roman Emperor Marcus Aurelius once said: "People are born to help and cooperate with one another, like hands, feet, or eyelids that depend on each other, or lips and teeth that cannot be separated!"

This is indeed the case. If the various parts of our body cannot coordinate and function together, trouble arises. By the same token, to achieve certain goals we also need to cooperate with others. If you are trying to obtain someone's help or form a cooperative group, it is crucial to notice the following postures that signal cooperation.

Once, Gerard Nierenberg, the "father of negotiation training" whose ability to read people was no less than that of an FBI agent, attended a seminar discussing a new product of great scientific value. The topics included patent rights, equity stakes, royalties, research and development costs, and how to persuade the client company to manufacture and sell the product.

At the very start of the discussion, a key technical member of the other team adopted an eager posture: sitting forward on the edge of his chair, body leaning in, toes pointed as though a sprinter awaiting the starting gun (see Figure 2.37). Nierenberg immediately recognized that this "poised to launch" posture meant the man was interested in the subject under discussion. Nierenberg therefore guided him to raise several technical questions. Once those questions were answered, the man's attitude became openly cooperative.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.37 跃跃欲试的姿势]

In fact, Nierenberg had deliberately chosen to sit beside this important person from the outset so he could observe every movement. The negotiation proceeded smoothly precisely because Nierenberg spotted the cooperative signal at once and used it to secure a mutually beneficial agreement.

Thus, during a negotiation, if you notice the other party sitting on the front edge of the chair with toes lifted in an expectant posture, it indicates readiness to concede, cooperate, purchase, accept, or even outdo others. This is a positive emotion and a signal of willingness to cooperate; if leveraged well, it greatly increases the chance of reaching a mutually beneficial agreement.

We have all experienced situations in which someone who was initially cooperative suddenly reverses course 180 degrees and the matter collapses; or someone who once affectionately used your nickname abruptly switches to your full name in a formal tone, the relaxed smile replaced by a furrowed brow. These changes show the other party no longer wishes to cooperate.

During an interrogation, after FBI agent Jeff finished presenting the known facts, he waited for the suspect to provide further details. Although the suspect said sincerely, "I am cooperating with you in good faith; I have told you everything I know," Jeff did not believe him.

Why? The suspect's legs betrayed his true feelings. While speaking, he sat upright with his legs crossed (see Figure 2.38). This posture signals doubt and resistance, contradicting his claim of "good faith."

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.38 双腿交叉, 表示抵触]

In negotiations, participants generally do not cross their legs when preparing to raise a question. Once a question is introduced or heated debate begins, one or both sides usually cross their legs. If both parties uncross their legs and lean forward, it signals that an agreement is about to be reached.

Some people cross their legs the moment they sit down. This indicates a guarded, competitive mindset, ambition, self-confidence, and a tendency to act decisively once a decision is made. This applies to men; women differ slightly.

A woman who boldly crosses her legs is usually confident in her appearance or attire and has a strong desire to be noticed. Such women tend to have high self-esteem, deliberately display charm, interact casually with the opposite sex, and aspire to be in charge; winning their affection or commitment is not easy.

Therefore, in negotiations, sales, or personal interactions, pay attention to anyone who crosses their legs. Once the other party crosses their legs, they are signaling competition or challenge. You must stay alert and focused to avoid costly oversights. Be even more cautious with someone who drapes one leg over the arm of the chair while lifting a foot (see Figure 2.39); such a posture often indicates a lack of cooperative intent, indifference to others' needs, and even a degree of hostility.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.39 满不在乎地将一条腿搭在椅子扶手上]

Flight attendants know that passengers who rest a leg on the armrest are usually demanding and hard to please. Salespeople likewise find buyers who sit this way difficult to close. The posture silently asserts dominance and control in the interaction or transaction.

## Reading Superiority: Feet on the Desk



In every profession, countless nonverbal cues clearly define superior and subordinate status. This is especially evident in the military. In most cases, the more domineering the superior acts, the more fearful and insecure the subordinate feels, prompting an immediate response.

Anthropologists note that men are naturally more territorial than women. Both men and women, however, can assert control through nonverbal gestures. When an FBI agent interviews a suspect, if the suspect places one foot on the desk, he is silently displaying "superiority" (see Figure 2.33). Such individuals usually lack cooperative intent.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.33 脚置于桌上的姿势]

In certain settings we also extend our control by placing personal items (books, papers, notebooks, wallets, etc.) on empty seats to prevent others from occupying the space.

For example, students in a library often spread their books and belongings across a table to discourage others from sitting nearby. This action clearly communicates "I want personal space." British psychiatrist Humphrey Osmond called this "sociopetal space"—the imagined private zone surrounding an individual.

In fact, most of us unconsciously create sociopetal space every day. When watching a movie, we place a coat or scarf on the adjacent seat to stop others from sitting there. Upon entering an elevator, we immediately claim an unoccupied corner, much like a boxer entering the ring. All these behaviors stem from the same impulse.

Sometimes people create sociopetal space to keep unsuitable individuals away while awaiting more desirable company. A passenger seated in the aisle seat on a train may place a briefcase on the window seat until an attractive woman approaches, at which point the briefcase is removed to offer the seat.

When two people stand face to face, an accepted sociopetal distance also exists. This distance varies by culture and depends on the relationship between the individuals. You naturally stand closer to your spouse than to a stranger.

As long as we remain outside another person's comfort zone, that person feels at ease. Once we intrude into their personal space, discomfort arises. We must therefore remain mindful of this distance to avoid making others uneasy.

FBI agents also note that straddling a chair with legs apart, using the chair back as a barrier, is another posture of authority and dominance (see Figure 2.34). A suspect adopting this posture may appear pleasant and friendly on the surface, yet the stance reveals a controlling and aggressive nature. A salesperson visiting a prospective client would never sit this way unless the deal is already off the table.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.34 双腿分开跨在椅子上]

When a person feels satisfied, comfortable, and confident, they typically lean back, clasp their hands behind their head, and cross their legs in a "4" shape (see Figure 2.35). This posture conveys the impression that they are in control.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.35 "4"字形的坐姿]

Standing while looking down at a seated person is another nonverbal way of expressing superiority. Elevating one's body above others in their presence signals dominance. This is why thrones for kings and queens are

placed on raised platforms. Many common honorifics—"Your Highness," "highness," "look up to," "gaze upon"—reflect this association with height.

If you wish to project dominance over someone, simply stand while they remain seated or sit in a noticeably higher position. Exercise caution, however, as this action can provoke resentment. When seeking cooperation, it is better to eliminate any artificial elevation and meet the other person on equal terms.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.36 林肯式的姿势]*

To convey equality through nonverbal cues, adopt the Lincoln-style posture: legs apart, arms resting on the chair arms, jacket open (see Figure 2.36). This is an open, relaxed sitting position. When two people sit facing each other in this manner, neither is signaling superiority.

## **Different Walking Styles Reflect Different Moods**

Walking appears ordinary, yet it most clearly reveals a person's emotional state. Learning to read others' walking postures therefore allows us to discern their changing moods.

Psychologists have found that the farther a body part is from the brain, the more trustworthy its signals. Areas closer to the brain's central control are easier to disguise and therefore less reliable. In social interactions we habitually watch faces, yet the face produces the most deceptive information. The lower body, by contrast, concentrates the most authentic signals. Walking posture is difficult to fake or alter, so observing it quickly reveals personality and emotional state.

Walking speed and stride length are closely tied to mood. What moods do different walking styles express? The following detailed explanations address this question.

### **1. Walking briskly**

Walking briskly with arms swinging naturally usually indicates inner excitement. People who walk this way are typically anticipating something pleasant or hopeful. They tend to be outgoing, lively, and sociable, approaching tasks with boldness and a spirit of adventure. Because they are impatient, however, they can become impulsive or even aggressive. They hurry even when there is no urgency, sometimes breaking into a trot. This gait signals impatience; such individuals are energetic yet often lack patience.

### **2. Walking with the body leaning forward**

People who walk leaning forward, almost hunched, are generally modest, well-mannered, and emotionally sensitive. By keeping their heads down and shoulders rounded, they try to remain unobtrusive, as if saying, "Shh—don't disturb others." They are usually reserved, rarely confide in others, and tend to brood alone, making them prone to emotional hurt.

### **3. Walking slowly and deliberately**

A slow, unhurried gait, regardless of others' opinions, often reflects indecision. Such walkers avoid risk, prefer to think things through, and refuse to act impulsively. They wait until others have tested an idea and proven it safe before proceeding, frequently missing opportunities as a result.

### **4. Walking with head held high and chest out**

Walking with head high and chest out expresses confidence and strong self-esteem, sometimes bordering on arrogance. People who walk this way are usually in good spirits. They trust only

themselves, rely on subjective judgment, dismiss others' advice, and center interactions on themselves, often appearing indifferent. Consequently they frequently operate alone.

### 5. Walking with a steady, measured gait

A steady, measured walk usually accompanies a pleasant, relaxed mood, because only emotional calm produces such even steps. These individuals are composed, seek stability in their actions, remain unflustered, and think before acting. Their deliberate approach allows them to advance steadily and succeed through calmness and courage in both career and life. They keep their word and treat others with integrity.

### 6. Walking with a bounce or skip

A bouncy or skipping walk typically signals that something joyful has occurred. Such people are usually open and sincere with friends, making interactions with them light and enjoyable. They tend to be optimistic, positive, and content with simple lives. Although occasionally careless, most are generous and kind.

In summary, walking postures vary widely and are closely linked to a person's emotions and character. Walking style is not fixed, however. Someone who normally walks slowly may suddenly hurry because of an urgent matter; conversely, a normally brisk walker may slow down after a disheartening event. To interpret mood and personality from gait, always consider the immediate context.

## People with Ankles Crossed Are Restraining Their Emotions

From childhood, parents and teachers taught us to learn self-control. "Just endure it for a while" was the phrase we heard most often. We also frequently use similar words to overcome emotions such as frustration and anxiety, the most important of which is suppressing anger. As we grow older, we gradually learn to use various postures to conceal our feelings and regulate our behavior.

When you see someone with both ankles crossed over each other, you should notice whether that person is restraining themselves. Because when people suppress strong sensations or emotions, they involuntarily press their ankles tightly together. Some people joke that this posture expresses a kind of "repression," like "needing to use the restroom urgently but being unable to go."

When negotiating with suspects, FBI agents often choose to have the other person sit while they stand. This is because people tend to produce more leg movements when seated, making it easier for their inner state to be revealed. For example, when a person is tense or fearful, they often adopt a posture with ankles crossed and both hands gripping the chair arms tightly (see Figures 2.30 and 2.31, noting the difference between how men and women cross their ankles).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.30 自我克制的男人]

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.31 自我克制的女人]

Flight attendants are highly skilled at reading passengers' body language. They have a unique ability to identify passengers who truly need service but are too shy to ask. If a passenger repeatedly crosses and uncrosses their ankles after boarding—especially before takeoff—the attendants can determine that the person is very tense and uneasy. When the attendants bring coffee, tea, or milk, if the passenger's ankles remain tightly crossed instead of separating and moving toward the edge of the seat, it indicates they may need something.

We have also observed that patients seated in a dentist's chair and customers reclining in a barber's chair for a shave both involuntarily press their ankles tightly together while gripping the chair arms with both hands. From this we can conclude that people in both situations are working hard to restrain unpleasant emotions.

Some may say that adopting this posture makes them feel comfortable. In reality, this is merely using comfort as an excuse to mask inner tension. When you lie down to rest, if you notice your ankles are crossed, uncross them and see whether doing so makes you feel more relaxed.

People also unconsciously cross their ankles when facing difficult problems at work or in daily life. Once the matter is resolved smoothly and everything proceeds well, they unconsciously separate their legs.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.32 自我克制的站姿]*

The self-restraining postures discussed above are those commonly seen while seated. When people are standing or walking, the most common self-control posture is clasping the hands behind the back, with one hand tightly gripping the wrist or arm of the other hand, which is already formed into a fist (see Figure 2.32). This posture clearly signals to everyone that the person is striving to control their emotions.

The act of gripping the wrist indicates that the individual is filled with frustration and is attempting to steady their emotions by holding their own wrist, keeping themselves calm and preventing an outburst. In addition, when a person feels frustrated, they involuntarily draw their chest inward in an effort to gain a sense of inner security.

This posture also reveals a sense of fear toward the situation at hand and a profound lack of self-confidence. Therefore, never adopt this posture during an interview; an experienced interviewer will immediately detect your inner tension and unease, and your lack of confidence will be unlikely to leave a favorable impression.

## **Walking Posture Is a Sketch of Personality**

Micro-expression keywords

No two leaves in the world are identical, and no two people have exactly the same walking posture. This is due not only to physical differences but, more importantly, to differences in personality. Different ways of walking reflect each person's unique character.

On the street, apart from soldiers marching in formation, everyone walks differently; no two gaits are exactly alike. Over time, you will notice that a person's walking posture is closely related to their personality and psychology. In general, walking styles can be summarized into the following types:

- **Standard gait**

Back straight, abdomen and chest drawn in, springy steps, arms swinging naturally, eyes looking straight ahead. Such people are generally optimistic, confident, friendly, and forward-looking.

- **Hands in pockets while walking**

A person who keeps one hand in a pocket walks with a carefree air, places great importance on their image, values emotions highly, and understands feelings well. Someone who keeps both hands in their pockets is usually rather lazy and somewhat sentimental.

- **Arms swinging behind the back while walking**

Such people tend to be arrogant, dismissive of everything, and fearless. Their temperament is relatively overbearing, making verbal communication difficult. They enjoy championing justice, like to direct

others, and dislike being directed. Nevertheless, they are mentally agile, methodical in their work, possess strong organizational skills, and have leadership potential.

- **Arms swinging in front of the body while walking**

Such people are often timid and cautious, overly compliant, listless, and frail. They cannot withstand even minor emotional shocks and their mood collapses easily. If the gait is deliberately adopted, however, it indicates the person is slippery and that others will find it hard to discern their true character or intentions.

- **Upper body leaning slightly forward while walking**

Most such people are introverted, modest, and reserved. When interacting with others they appear taciturn on the surface yet place great value on friendship. They seem calm outwardly but are actually quite proactive or impatient inside.

- **Very slow walking speed**

Walking at a calm, unhurried pace—half a beat slower than others—indicates a person who is strictly self-disciplined, cautious, methodical, and extremely tolerant toward everyone. They are shrewd yet steady, do not readily trust others' words, value integrity, and keep their promises. Although they may appear somewhat weak, they are in fact thoughtful and independent-minded.

- **Very fast walking speed**

Most such people are intelligent and capable, energetic, courageous in facing life's challenges, and highly adaptable. They work efficiently, never dawdle, and once they decide to accomplish something they pursue the goal with seriousness and determination—"a promise is a promise, and action follows through."

- **Quick small steps**

Like ancient officials hurrying to an audience with their ruler, taking rapid little steps. Such people may have long been in subordinate or managed positions and have developed this habit, or they may be naturally impatient or currently in a hurry.

- **Large strides while walking**

Such people generally have a strong physique, high self-confidence, a stubborn and competitive personality, and work efficiently; they dislike others dragging their feet. They are kind-hearted and will do their utmost to help when asked.

- **Dragging feet while walking**

Such people do not lift their feet, causing their heels to rub heavily against the ground. They often feel fatigued, unhappy, and depressed. They lack initiative, prefer to stick to conventions, show no pioneering spirit, and possess no outstanding talents; they frequently encounter obstacles or setbacks in life.

In summary, the best way to walk is with head held high, chest out, eyes looking forward, and a steady, unhurried pace. Only then will you convey an impression of confidence and positivity and easily win others' trust and goodwill.

### **Unconscious Leg Jiggling Is a Sign of Inner Tension**

Micro-expression keywords: When encountering pressure or danger, people feel tense—a normal psychological response. When tense, individuals often unconsciously jiggle their legs or perform other small

movements, which can hinder the expression of their true thoughts.

Everyone experiences tension at times. Especially in unfamiliar environments, when handling uncertain matters, or when feeling unpredictable worry and lack of control over external circumstances, a sense of tension arises psychologically.

To steady tense emotions, people usually make small, subtle movements—clenching fists, biting lips, or unconsciously jiggling their legs. With careful observation these are easy to catch.

Xiao Fei's first blind date began with both parties sitting in awkward silence, each appearing slightly nervous. Under the table, both their legs were jiggling unconsciously.

"Would you like some water?" Xiao Fei stood to pour water for the young woman and accidentally knocked over the cup.

"Sorry, sorry..."

"It's fine..." The young woman helped clear the table, and the atmosphere suddenly became lively.

As the conversation continued, both shifted to more comfortable postures and their legs stopped jiggling forcefully.

In daily life, careful observation reveals that people experience varying degrees of tension. Speakers at meetings, students in exam halls, and new graduates entering the workplace all share one common action—leg jiggling.

From a neuroanatomical perspective, when we feel tense, the cerebral cortex sends commands via the central nervous system to the limbs, which then unconsciously jiggle the legs to relieve neural tension. Similar actions include clenching fists, biting lips, and smoking.

Therefore, if someone's face appears completely calm during a conversation yet their legs keep jiggling, their level of nervous tension must be high. We should then pay attention to what is causing such tension.

If the other person's legs keep jiggling and tension is evident, we must take note. They may have been asked a sensitive question they do not wish to answer, they may lack confidence in what they are saying, or they may simply be lying.

In the first case, reflect on whether the question touched on personal privacy. Adjust the topic promptly, avoid pressing further, and casually change the subject.

If your statements are guiding the conversation and are factual, yet the other person begins jiggling their legs, this may indicate guilt. Boldly consider where their tension originates. They may be about to lie; in that case, ask several follow-up questions to truly understand their inner world.

For example, Xiao Zhang and Xiao Li are chatting. Xiao Zhang: "This month's bonus is really generous. I got a full 2,000 yuan. How about you?" Xiao Li: "Ah? Really? I... I got the same as you." At the same time, his legs begin to jiggle unnaturally. In fact, Xiao Li received 3,000 yuan, and he knows that most colleagues received 3,000 yuan as well.

He was afraid of discouraging Xiao Zhang and dared not tell the truth. The white lie also made him tense, causing the leg jiggle. Xiao Zhang noticed the movement but, to avoid embarrassment, skillfully changed the topic. Xiao Li relaxed considerably and his legs stopped jiggling.

In short, when interacting with others, gaining a better understanding requires more careful and detailed observation. Through a person's small movements we can glimpse their vast inner world; through their inner thoughts we can truly understand their character, thereby securing greater advantages for our own lives.

### **Crossed Legs Symbolize Confidence and Comfort**

Micro-expression keywords: When strangers converse, they often feel constrained and guarded, so most conversational postures involve sitting upright and proper. Among friends, people relax much more and adopt comfortable postures during conversation, such as crossing their legs. Therefore, when you see the other person adopt this posture, it indicates they already regard you as a friend.

In the high-end conference room of multinational company H, Xiao Li, Commercial Director Wang, and President Liu of H Company were discussing domestic agency rights for H Company's products. The meeting proceeded smoothly and both sides were relatively relaxed. President Liu even stood up, brewed a cup of tea, leaned against the conference table, placed his left leg in front of his right, and sipped his tea. After further detailed negotiations, both parties happily signed the cooperation contract.

Afterward, Director Wang said confidently, "Actually, halfway through the meeting I could already predict that the contract was in the bag."

Xiao Li was surprised: "Why? Could Director Wang really calculate everything in advance?"

Director Wang laughed and replied, "Small cues happen around you at every moment. You must have noticed how candid and natural President Liu of H Company appeared, without excessive formality or restraint, indicating he was quite satisfied with our communication."

Xiao Li: "You mean he still had the mood to brew tea midway through the meeting?"

Director Wang: "That's not the main point. Notice how he crossed his legs with an air of complete ease, as if victory were already assured—that already tells the story."

Xiao Li: "Crossed legs can also indicate something?"

Millions of years ago, before humans developed language, legs and feet became the most effective tools for rapid and efficient communication because mutual understanding was impossible. In dangerous situations they enabled escape from wild beasts, disasters, and so on. During that period, crossing the legs could only be done when relaxed and at ease, because the posture made the body unstable and hindered quick reactions. Therefore, the appearance of this posture proves that both parties feel comfortable with each other and consider each other trustworthy.

Generally, in situations that feel constraining, people initially adopt a formal sitting posture—sitting upright and proper—because an invisible psychological constraint governs their behavior, making their performance appear more official. At the start of business exchanges, both parties exchange slight nods out of politeness; this is a defensive posture. Psychologically, the person's mind is not calm and lacks confidence.

After a series of verbal and physical exchanges that foster greater understanding of the conversation partner, people gradually integrate into the group and their bodies shift from formal postures to the casual crossed-leg posture. They can now raise topics that were previously awkward to discuss openly. This intimate attitude shows they have gradually become good friends. Interestingly, people standing with crossed legs often appear relaxed, and the conversation seems quite casual.

Thus, the entire process of postural change during conversation actually reflects the psychological changes driving bodily expression. As a person's mood moves from tension to relaxation, the body shifts from formal to casual posture.

Research shows that people lacking confidence frequently use formal sitting postures, while those who feel confident, comfortable, and in control often adopt crossed-leg postures. Therefore, to obtain more useful information during communication, you must make your counterpart feel comfortable and at ease, without psychological burden.

#### 7.2.4 Leg Jiggling

Many people believe that leg jiggling indicates the person is relaxed.

Indeed, many individuals unconsciously jiggle their legs when relaxed in order to enjoy inner ease and comfort.

However, when using micro-reaction (微反应) analysis, one must be cautious and identify the stimulus source, baseline, and response pattern before beginning analysis. Therefore, the meaning of leg jiggling is not so simple; one cannot conclude relaxation merely upon seeing the movement.

People newly interested in behavioral analysis often ask: "What does leg jiggling represent? Tension or relaxation?"

Before answering, set aside the pursuit of "what it represents." Quiet down, adopt a neutral stance, and experience the jiggling action itself and its physiological effect.

Jiggling while standing is usually due to a physiological condition and will not be discussed here. While seated, whether the movement involves raising the toes and jiggling up and down or gently swinging the knees inward and outward, both count as leg jiggling. Quietly and calmly experience the action; you will find it produces a very obvious physiological pleasure—do not misinterpret this; it refers to relaxing the muscles of the buttocks and thighs, improving blood circulation, and sending a positive comfort signal to the brain via the nervous system.

In short, the leg-jiggling action is comfortable.

At this point, do not rush to conclude "leg jiggling means relaxation."

When people jiggle their legs while singing in a KTV or drinking in a restaurant, they are simply enjoying themselves.

But what about high-pressure situations such as job interviews, business negotiations, or important meetings? Is there time to enjoy one's own relaxation movement?

Remember this point:

People do everything to seek benefit and avoid harm. The leg jiggling you see in restaurants and KTVs represents "very relaxed, very comfortable"; the leg jiggling you see during negotiations and meetings precisely indicates that the other person is under pressure.

At this point, do not rush to conclude that "leg jiggling in formal, serious, or pressured situations always means the person is tense!"



Consider carefully whether the following two scenarios both indicate tension.

Scenario 1: A young troublemaker with a poor record is taken to the police station after a fight. During questioning he initially shakes his head, sways, and jiggles his legs with a distracted air. Later, realizing he is about to be detained, he freezes and stops jiggling. Does the transition from jiggling to stillness represent a shift from tension to lack of tension?

Scenario 2: A senior official, normally very reserved and proper, wastes no movement or glance. Under investigation for corruption, he initially maintains a dignified demeanor. When asked a key question, one leg begins to jiggle slightly—almost imperceptibly—while he continues to offer fluent explanations. Does the shift from complete control to the appearance of slight jiggling indicate an increase in tension?

To determine what leg jiggling means, first ask yourself several questions.

1. Who is jiggling? Do they usually jiggle? This is called the baseline.
2. When did the jiggling occur? If the person jiggles all the time, it may be a habit or performance and has no diagnostic value. If they do not usually jiggle but suddenly begin at a critical question, that jiggling has value.

## Toes Reveal Your True Thoughts

Compared with hand movements, leg and foot movements are clearly fewer, so their expressions are much simpler than those of the hands. Moreover, when a person is emotionally agitated, foot movements become even more limited, which is why the emotional information conveyed by the feet is often overlooked.

Yet precisely because people always forget to pay attention to their own feet, the information they provide is instead more valuable and better reflects a person's true inner state. As former FBI counterintelligence expert Joe Navarro, with twenty-five years of experience, put it: "Facial expressions can be faked, but few people know how to disguise the movements of their feet."

For example, three men stand chatting with a beautiful woman nearby. On the surface, the three men appear absorbed in conversation and pay no attention to the woman beside them, but that is not actually the case, because each of them has one foot pointed toward her. In other words, all three men are noticing the beautiful woman; their apparent concentration is merely a mask concealing their true feelings.

You may have encountered a situation like this. While speaking with someone, the other person suddenly turns their body and points their feet toward the door instead of directly at you. This posture means they want to end the conversation, gathering, or other ongoing activity as soon as possible. Upon receiving this signal, you should sincerely say to the other person: "It's getting late, and it's been a pleasure talking with you—the time has flown by!"

In addition, the direction of the toes serves as a reliable gauge for estimating the closeness of relationships between people. For instance, if two people standing and talking have their toes pointed directly at each other with very little distance between them, it indicates an extremely close relationship. If their feet form a 90-degree or 60-degree angle, they are not particularly familiar and would allow a third party to join the conversation.

The physical distance between seats can indicate the degree to which one party subjectively intends to intrude upon the other's personal space. For example, a couple deeply in love will sit as close as possible to each other even when plenty of space is available, reflecting their inseparable affection. Similarly, in a university

classroom, students who wish to participate actively in discussion choose seats near the front, while those uninterested in the subject sit toward the back.

Seating arrangements are also quite revealing. People favored by or seeking to please a leader usually sit beside or near the leader to demonstrate loyalty and attentiveness. Those disliked by the leader or harboring resentment typically sit far away or in a corner. This shows that the psychological distance between them matches the physical distance between their seats.

Thus, by observing the direction of the toes and the physical distance between seats, we can infer people's psychological states and related information, giving us a basis for any action we may take.

#### **4.5.2 The Freezing Response of the Feet**

The most common freezing response of the feet in a standing posture is standing with legs together and straight, muscles tense. When escape is known to be impossible (if escape were possible, the ready-to-flee starting posture discussed in Chapter 5 would appear), such as during training or reprimand, the nervous system, after receiving negative stimulation, does not dare issue an order for the legs to stand in a wide, casual stance or a completely relaxed posture. Instead, it commands the legs to stand straight and tense, motionless, enduring the subsequent stimulation.

The most common freezing response of the legs and feet in a seated posture is constraining both legs into a state where they cannot move freely. The most frequent versions are keeping both feet together with knees and ankles simultaneously closed, or tucking the feet behind the chair legs, as shown in Figures 4-8 and 4-9.

If you deliberately perform these two actions while relaxed, you will find them rather strenuous. After some time they also cause fatigue and soreness in the legs. Yet when a person is afraid, they involuntarily adopt similar movements to restrain the feet, displaying a localized freezing response. As with the hands, contracted limbs mirror a contracted mindset; by controlling the feet through external force or one's own effort, unnecessary movements are reduced, thereby lowering the likelihood of attack (criticism). This completely passive, receptive mindset expresses the actor's inner sense of weakness.

We conducted a simple survey of more than 6,000 samples. When suddenly asked about their seated posture, none of the thousands of classroom participants kept both knees and ankles simultaneously closed. The "surprise attack" success rate was 100 percent. The reason for the "surprise" was to avoid triggering the listeners' attention and defensive awareness. The underlying cause is simple: the audience's mindset is relaxed and unthreatened.

A job interview is the best moment to observe the freezing response. Candidates generally fall into two categories: the majority who lack confidence, and the minority who feel confident. To feel confident, meeting the stated requirements is only the minimum; one must also have a grasp of the overall situation—such as the nature of the organization, the positioning of the role, and HR habits—and, of course, having connections counts as well.

Candidates who feel admiration and a sense of supplication invariably sit with hands and feet restrained and speak haltingly. Some have memorized their lines yet cannot converse normally. Confident individuals, by contrast, appear relaxed and natural, with no overall or localized tendency toward contraction.

Asking a nervous job seeker to stand with legs apart is tantamount to violating their fragile psyche; they will be extremely reluctant and unwilling to comply, believing it makes them seem overbearing and disrespectful and will harm their own interests.

Beyond sitting and standing postures, walking can also reveal a person's state through leg and foot responses. A cautious, weak mindset causes the person to take small, infrequent steps and to move hesitantly.

### **Confidence or Not, Look at His Stance**

We often describe a woman's beauty as "gracefully upright" and praise a man's heroic bearing as "tall and straight." Standing like a pine tree reflects an upright spirit; standing crooked shows a lack of strength. A person of integrity can stand with sleeves carrying a pure breeze; a person with ill intentions will set traps even while standing.

Although elders constantly remind us to "sit properly and stand properly," most people's standing postures vary widely. Next, FBI agents will reveal the psychological secrets behind standing postures.

Standing with hands clasped behind the back, one hand gripping the back of the other, body erect, creates an aura of authority whether viewed from the front or the back. Such individuals are usually highly confident, like to control situations, or regard themselves as superior.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.45 权威的站姿]*

An official inspecting grassroots work walks through a production workshop where workers are focused on their tasks. Head held high, chest out, hands behind the back, spine straight, accompanied by local leaders, the official slowly paces from one end of the workshop to the other.

Besides this official, we encounter many others adopting this posture in daily life—senior officers reviewing troops, principals inspecting teaching, and so on. Generally, people in high positions habitually assume this posture when facing subordinates. The posture is unequivocally a symbol of power and dignity.

Can people stand confidently or stand uneasily? Of course they can.

Standing confidently is usually shown by both feet stably supporting the entire body, legs straight yet with relaxed leg muscles, knees not unnaturally locked as during roll call. The feet are not completely parallel; the toes point slightly outward.

In this state, people usually do not move about frequently or shift their body restlessly from side to side. Those with a confident stance tend to act decisively and with resolve. Moreover, they engage in frequent eye contact and maintain longer mutual gazes.

People lacking confidence stand in a bent, stooped posture, head lowered, shoulders hunched, gaze directed downward. Such individuals act timidly and avoid taking risks or responsibility.

An uneasy standing posture typically involves shifting body weight onto one supporting foot while extending the other foot, toes possibly pointing slightly inward. In this case, people usually do not stand still but keep walking around, trying to find a better spot.

### **Legs That Can Never Hide Tension**

Which part of the body should we observe first for nonverbal signals? Which part best reveals a person's true intentions? FBI veteran Joe Navarro tells us: "The legs and feet."

FBI agent Jason was interrogating an informant connected to a terrorist incident. After several hours with no progress, the suspect had maintained an impeccable facade, offering Jason no meaningful signals. The only

anomaly was the constant shaking of his legs. Yet this could have been a habitual movement and did not prove the suspect knew anything.

When Jason asked the key question—"Were you at the scene of this terrorist attack?"—the suspect's legs underwent a striking change. Although he had not yet answered, his legs shifted from side-to-side rocking to up-and-down kicking. This single clue told Jason that the question had affected the suspect's emotions. Jason used it as an opening, continuing with more intense verbal probing until the suspect finally spoke, confirming he had knowledge of the attack.

Drawing on years of intelligence experience, Joe Navarro tells us: "When a person's foot movements change from gentle side-to-side rocking to up-and-down kicking, it indicates that the individual has seen or heard something negative or unpleasant. This change in body language is entirely unconscious on the part of the individual, yet many remain unaware of it."

Why, then, can the legs or feet reflect our emotional and psychological changes so precisely?

Over millions of years of human evolution, our legs and feet have continuously responded to external threats through instinctive reactions that require no thought. When we sense danger, our legs and feet naturally enter a state of readiness and respond accordingly—stopping, fleeing, or kicking at an opponent.

We have long practiced "reading faces and expressions" to understand others, yet the cunning face has gradually learned to bluff or conceal true emotions. On reflection, such deception is understandable. From childhood we are taught that "such an expression is unattractive" or "why frown at such a young age?" Consequently we learn to hide, deceive, and lie.

Thus, in an era when "reading faces and expressions" has become difficult, we can readily master the rhythm of any conversation by observing the most honest part of body language—the legs and feet.

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**The Touch Effect**

Do not underestimate the power of the “touch effect.” People have a tendency to relax their vigilance toward others because of physical contact, a phenomenon psychologists call the “touch effect.” Various studies have examined the psychological impact of physical contact with others.

Dr. Damien Els of the University of Brittany in France surveyed 40 male customers at a used-car dealership about the touch effect.

The salespeople greeting these male customers were also male. The doctor instructed the salespeople to accompany the phrase “Please be sure to look inside the car” with a one-second grasp of the wrist for half the customers, while making no physical contact with the other half.

Afterward, another staff member asked the customers to rate their satisfaction with the salesperson’s service.

The result was that customers who had been touched gave significantly higher ratings than those who had not. The specific scores were as follows:

| Item         | No Touch | With Touch |
|--------------|----------|------------|
| Friendly     | 5.20     | 6.65       |
| Honest       | 4.68     | 6.45       |
| Integrity    | 4.50     | 6.05       |
| Nice person  | 4.95     | 6.65       |
| Enthusiastic | 5.25     | 6.65       |

(Out of 10)

When the touch is without motive and casual, no one questions it. Yet when touched, people often develop a favorable impression of the other person—an effect they themselves may not consciously notice. In other words, the touch reaches the heart. Many businesses’ “free trial” marketing strategies actually leverage the touch effect to gain customer approval.

The touch effect possesses the magic of opening people’s hearts. For example, when you want someone to buy something for you, offer advice, or work overtime, an appropriate physical contact combined with a sincere tone can make your request hard to refuse.

Psychologists have also found that intentional touch effectively reduces barriers and eases relationships. When couples or partners are in a “cold war” after an argument, a light pat on the shoulder, head, or forehead—or a big hug—works better than purely verbal reconciliation.

## Walking

By observing a person’s leg and foot movements, we can obtain a great deal of information. In fact, the information conveyed by the legs is more reliable than that from any other part of the body, because when people try to conceal their emotions they usually do not consider their legs and feet.

In the next chapter we will learn how sitting and standing postures clearly convey a person’s thoughts and emotions. The remainder of this chapter focuses on the most important leg activity—walking.

Each person’s walking style is as unique as a fingerprint. Because everyone has a distinct gait, our friends can recognize us from a distance. However, a person’s walking style can change with mood and age.

Generally, people who walk quickly with arms swinging freely usually have firm goals and are prepared to pursue them actively. People who habitually walk with hands in their pockets—even in warm weather—are usually very picky, somewhat mysterious, and skilled at hiding their true emotions.

When depressed, a person often walks with head lowered, dragging their feet, hands in pockets, rarely looking up to see where they are going (see Figure 3.17). A person walking quickly with hands placed on the hips usually wants to reach their destination in the shortest possible time (see Figure 3.18).

- Figure 3.17 Depressed pedestrian
- Figure 3.18 Pedestrian heading for destination

Some people walk very slowly because they are making an important decision. They clasp their hands tightly behind their back and occasionally stop to think (see Figure 3.19). A self-satisfied or even arrogant person is likely to hold their head high, swing their arms exaggeratedly, and stride forward as if deliberately trying to make an impression (see Figure 3.20).

- Figure 3.19 Deeply focused pedestrian
- Figure 3.20 Striding pedestrian

“Setting the pace” means subordinates match the leader’s stride and follow behind. Following is a nonverbal signal representing the subordinate’s unwavering loyalty to the goals and principles set by the leader.

## 2. Distance Between Feet in Standing Posture

In a standing posture, the feet are also used to establish one’s territory. The clues revealed by the state and changes of the feet are closer to human primal instincts and thus more accurate. The more limited the area in a confined space, the more obvious this pattern becomes.

In an elevator, observing the different standing postures of passengers can roughly determine the status differences and mindset differences among these people.

Generally, junior employees, due to long-term direction and even criticism, basically stand with their feet together, not daring to occupy too much space in the limited area. Higher-status managers or bosses naturally adopt a comfortable posture to stand, but in crowded situations they may spread their feet apart, instinctively occupying more territory, highlighting their dominance, and ensuring they are not overly

disturbed (disturbance can be others' smells, breathing, or the sticky touch in summer). Of course, it is also possible to appear indifferent, standing on one foot too casually while lifting the other, purely for comfort.

### **Spreading Feet to Establish Territory**

Spreading the feet occurs in many situations and almost always reflects a dominant mindset (at least a desire to appear dominant), such as in soldiers or police officers. During confrontations, the dominant and aggressive party often makes this move, frequently combined with arm movements to occupy more territory with the upper body, appearing more imposing.

The spreading of the feet is an expression of power consciousness; it does not inherently carry a defensive meaning but subconsciously indicates that this is my territory. If there is an intrusion, other reactions will be taken to respond to the challenge. Usually, the purpose of spreading the feet is to express a dominant mindset.

In the process of establishing and expanding territory, a person will simultaneously exhibit the head-up and chest-out reaction of looking up, which is an inevitable manifestation of high self-perception. Therefore, an upright torso is also one of the typical characteristics.

### **Either End the Conversation and Leave, or Continue Talking for a While**

Whether in a formal business meeting or in informal exchanges with friends, family, or strangers, if someone wants to end the meeting or conversation, you will see a clear action: turning the body toward the door or another exit.

This posture clearly tells you that the person wants to end the discussion and is ready to leave. If the person is seated, you will notice constant fidgeting, as if on pins and needles, indicating a strong desire to depart.

When you observe these postures in others, you can take one of the following two measures according to your own needs:

- If you do not want to end the conversation, it is best to change the topic and ask the other person some personal questions.
- If you also want to end the conversation, you can say, "I think that covers everything; I should get back to work." You will then see the other person nod quickly and stand up to leave.

Among all body movements people display, the above postures are the easiest to overlook. Noticing these behaviors can prevent you from speaking to an "empty wall."

Generally, during the final half-hour of a social visit, people's bodies exhibit "ready to leave" postures. An observant and thoughtful host will notice these postures and end the visit with remarks such as "I'm glad you came over tonight."

When someone wants to discuss a very important matter with you but hesitates because you are speaking on another topic, they will not turn the body toward an exit but will lean closer to you, as if preparing to whisper in your ear.

If you notice this behavior, you can say something to allow the other person to express their view comfortably. For example, "Is there something you want to say?" If your guess is correct, you will immediately see a relieved expression on the other person's face, followed by an open sharing of their thoughts.

## Tension That Is Hard to Conceal

After years of research, behaviorists have found that the human brain has two innate functions: first, directing the body to obtain what is needed for survival; second, commanding the body to quickly leave what is unwanted. The legs (and of course the feet) help the brain carry out these two functions.

Parts of the body closer to the brain are easier for the brain to control and therefore easier to disguise. The face is closest to the brain, so it has the lowest credibility; the legs and feet are farthest from the brain, making immediate disguise difficult. When danger approaches, the legs naturally enter a state of alert and produce involuntary movements. Therefore, observing a person's legs and feet can sometimes help us understand their inner state.

Experienced operative Jack was interrogating a suspect in a terrorism incident. Other operatives told Jack that the suspect was extremely cunning; after several hours of questioning he had given no meaningful signals, and everyone was at a loss.

Jack sat down and glanced at the suspect. The man appeared neither nervous nor afraid, only constantly shaking his legs. Of course, this alone proved nothing; it could simply be a habitual movement.

"Were you at the scene of this terrorist attack?"

As soon as the question was asked, the suspect showed no reaction on his face, and his hands and body remained completely normal, yet the leg that had been swaying side to side suddenly jerked up and down for an instant before resuming its side-to-side motion. Jack calmly noted this fleeting change and used it as a breakthrough for skillful questioning and probing.

What I will share with you next are methods for judging a person's inner thoughts from leg and foot postures. Of course, you may already be using some of these methods without having formalized them.

## Psychology Mini-Lesson

A person's walking style can reveal their emotions, personality, and character. So how can we read people through different walking styles?

### 1. Swaying Type

This style is usually seen in women. Their waists are supple and they walk with a graceful sway, but this should never be mistaken for wantonness. Many of them are honest, warm-hearted, and kind; they are easy to get along with, often the center of attention in social settings, and very popular.

### 2. Gentle Type

The so-called "gentle type" walks with feet placed flat, hands swinging naturally, without any affected manner. Such people are generally timid and conservative, yet calm and composed when facing situations and not easily angered.

### 3. Pigeon-Toed or Splay-Footed Type

The so-called "eight-character type" refers to feet turned inward or outward in an eight shape. The walk is forceful and impatient, yet the upper body does not sway left or right. These people are not good at socializing and prefer to do things quietly.



#### 4. Casual Type

The so-called "casual type" walks with no fixed pattern. Sometimes both hands are in the trouser pockets with shoulders hunched; sometimes the hands are extended and the chest is thrust out. Such people are generally generous, loyal, and unconcerned with trifles; they have ambitions to build a career, though at times they can also be unyielding.

#### 5. Charging Type

The so-called "charging type" walks rapidly without looking back, barging through whether in a crowded place or a quiet one. These people generally enjoy conversation, are open and upright, and will not do anything to betray friends. However, they can be somewhat impatient.

### Shallow Sitting and Deep Sitting

For humans, the standing posture is the normal state most suited to activity, so when sitting people adopt a posture from which they can stand up immediately. Shallow sitting on a chair is one example.

Many people, out of nervousness, only dare to sit on the edge of the chair; they are often in an urgent state of readiness to act. In psychology this is called high "alertness." Once they relax, their "alertness" drops; they settle fully into the chair, extend both feet, and appear at ease, indicating they will not stand up right away.

We can see this in lions and horses: lions are fierce and powerful, so they can sleep all day, seemingly representing confidence; because lions like to prey on horses, horses remain nervous all day, even sleeping standing up, yet they still cannot escape being hunted.

Looking at humans, people who sit deeply hold a psychological advantage or deliberately assume a superior position; at the very least they wish to look down on others. People who sit shallowly often feel uneasy inside, displaying a subordinate state and subconsciously wishing to show respect and obedience.

In front of someone who sits shallowly, never be arrogant or appear too powerful, because they harbor strong inner resistance. If you show friendliness or concern, they will genuinely like you and be willing to approach you, laying the foundation for expanding your network later.

Remember that anyone can be useful. If most people are willing to draw close to you, you gain an invisible advantage; at least in interpersonal relations you have already won. Your work and studies will therefore move more easily toward success.

#### 8.3.3 Crossing the Legs

Another common barrier is crossing the legs, usually seen in seated postures. See Figure 8-19.

In Chapter 5 on escape reactions we discussed the comfortable crossed-leg sitting posture. If the observed person, while seated, leans back with the torso relaxed, this does not belong to the barrier reaction we are discussing now. Note that even when the torso rests against the chair back, it cannot be taken as proof of a relaxed state. Relaxation usually has two clear features: one is that the head also rests against the chair or sofa back and is tilted backward in the same direction as the torso; the other is that the lower leg of the crossed leg may swing comfortably at a natural, unhurried rhythm.

Conversely, a crossed-leg posture that can be judged as establishing a barrier may possess the following features:

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图8-19 作为屏障的二郎腿姿态]

- ① The torso is upright and tense; the person may even clasp the knee with the hands, forcing themselves into an uncomfortable seated posture. This action reflects inner fear and worry.
- ② If the head remains alert and upright and eye attention has not diminished, then the backward lean of the torso belongs to an escape reaction and suggests dissatisfaction or displeasure.
- ③ The crossed leg shows no voluntary movement.

When the above features appear, crossing the legs is an intentional attempt to increase distance from the stimulus source, trying to build a barrier to protect oneself from negative stimuli.

### Scenario Two: Senior Official

Usually deeply reserved and well-mannered, no movement or glance is wasted. Suspected of corruption and under investigation. At the start of the conversation the official maintains an upright and dignified demeanor. When asked a key question, one leg begins to tremble slightly, the movement barely visible, yet the mouth continues a fluent defense. Does this shift from total bodily control to a faint tremor indicate increased tension?

#### Analysis:

A senior official never allows any meaningless movement; this is an efficiency habit cultivated over years in officialdom—too many resources and affairs to waste time on idle matters, too many watching eyes to move casually. This silent state is the baseline. Such a baseline shows that at the beginning of the conversation the psychological state was controlled.

However, when hearing a question that is disadvantageous or even dangerous, one leg breaks through both habitual and willful control and begins to tremble, proving that biological emotional will is stronger than social logical will. On the surface calm is maintained, yet inside there is great torment; therefore the biological emotional will demands active pursuit of physical comfort for self-soothing. This reaction is called a comfort response, using physical comfort to compensate for psychological discomfort. The person himself is unaware of it.

### Seat Distance Can Reflect Psychological Distance

The physical distance between seats can indicate the degree to which one party subjectively wishes to encroach on the other party's personal space. In other words, unrelated people who are seated too close will feel unpleasant or uneasy. Therefore, physical seat distance can be used to infer psychological distance.

For example, an affectionate couple will sit as close as possible even when plenty of space is available, reflecting their inseparable state. In a university classroom, students who want to participate actively in discussion choose seats near the front, while those uninterested in the subject choose seats at the back. By the same logic, among staff in a government office, those who actively communicate with leaders and those who hold negative feelings toward superiors will choose different seat distances from the leader.

Seating arrangements are also quite interesting. People favored by the leader or eager to please the leader

### Relationship Between Seat and Leader

usually sit beside or near the leader to show loyalty and attentiveness; those the leader dislikes or who hold grievances usually sit far from the leader or in a corner. This shows that the psychological distance between the two is as great as the physical distance between their seats.

### **Reading People Through Their Shoes**

More than ten years ago I took a friend to buy shoes. The owner of the shoe store happened to know me slightly, so we chatted for a while. Looking at my friend who was choosing shoes, the owner said, "He looks casual, but I know he should be a rather meticulous person, right?"

I was surprised and replied with a smile, "Oh, exactly right. I didn't expect to meet a colleague here, haha!"

The owner shook his head and said, "No, no, I'm just a shoe seller; I don't understand those complicated analytical methods."

"Then how did you judge?"

"Shoes."

"Shoes?"

"That's right. From a person's choice of shoes one can roughly judge their personality. Have you noticed that the several pairs your friend picked are all the same style as the pair he is wearing? People who consistently wear one particular style they like tend to be conscientious; that's my experience selling shoes over the years."

That conversation gave me great inspiration, and afterward I began to include shoes in my "people-reading techniques." So specifically, what connection exists between shoes and a person's inner state?

### **People Pacing Back and Forth Are Thinking**

When a person stands up and paces back and forth in a room, it usually indicates they are pondering what someone has just said. When solving difficult problems or making tough decisions, most people exhibit this behavior because standing allows better thinking.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.43 来回踱步的思考者]*

Therefore, when you see someone pacing and deep in thought, remember to stay quiet, wait patiently for them to speak, and do not interrupt. Doing so would break their train of thought and prevent them from reaching a decision or offering a final quote. This also explains why some negotiators fail to reach their goals: they cannot remain calm.

Experienced salespeople are very good at reading this "person pacing back and forth." When encountering a potential customer who is pacing, they usually wait patiently, knowing the posture means the customer is ready to make a decision.

### **Psychology Mini-Lesson**

During interrogations, police often read a suspect's psychological state from leg movements. For example, when a suspect frequently shakes both legs, it usually indicates inner anxiety and unease.

In a major criminal case the police could not find a breakthrough and only located one eyewitness at the scene. During questioning the police obtained no valuable information, only noticing that the witness's legs were shaking frequently. From this movement the police concluded that the witness must be lying. After further interrogation the witness told the truth, identified the perpetrator, and helped the police solve the case smoothly.

The reason the witness kept shaking both legs was inner fear and a desire to end the interrogation quickly. When a person pretends to be calm, facial expressions are hard to read, yet leg movements are easy to detect. Even if the other party tries hard to conceal their emotions, they may inadvertently reveal them through leg movements.

### **Scenario One: Young Thug**

Usually unruly, brought to the police station after a fight. At the start of questioning he shook his head, nodded, and shook his legs, looking distracted. Later, upon learning he would be detained, he froze in place and stopped shaking his legs. Does this change from shaking to stillness represent a shift from tension to calm?

#### **Analysis:**

The initial combination of head-shaking and leg-shaking stemmed from a lack of proper upbringing and the bad habits acquired in his social circle. Only this way could he appear cool and "in the scene" and maintain good relations with his peers. Therefore the leg-shaking belonged to the baseline, showing that the young thug, without realizing the depth of the situation, believed he had control—a relaxed expression of territorial reaction. Given this baseline, the leg-shaking itself carried no special meaning.

However, the instant he learned he would be detained, all bodily movement ceased and the legs stopped shaking. This reaction is highly meaningful; it is called a freeze response.

### **(10) "4"-Shaped Sitting Posture**

One leg is bent and crossed over the other, forming a "4" shape with the body and the chair.

Two politicians sit facing each other discussing current affairs: one leans back, hands clasped behind his head, legs crossed in a "4" shape, looking smug; the other hangs his head, shoulders hunched forward, hands resting limply on his legs, looking listless.

The above describes a cartoon. Clearly, the politician sitting in the "4" posture holds the upper hand. When a person casually places one leg over the other, it indicates inner defensiveness or negation.

This posture reflects a competitive attitude and can sometimes convey arrogance. In negotiations, if the other party maintains this posture for a long time, it signals that you have reached an impasse unless you are willing to concede. He has already made it clear: "I will not change my decision; it is up to you!"

### **Self-Restraining Standing Posture**

Hands placed behind the back, one hand tightly gripping the wrist of the other hand, which is clenched into a fist, similar to crossed ankles. This posture typically appears when a person is under extreme tension or great pressure.

The wrist-gripping action indicates inner frustration; the person hopes to steady their emotions by holding their own wrist, remaining calm without losing temper. Additionally, when facing frustration, a person instinctively contracts the chest to seek inner security.

This posture also reveals fear toward the situation at hand and extreme lack of confidence. Therefore, never adopt this posture during an interview, as an experienced interviewer will immediately detect your nervousness and insecurity, leaving a poor impression.

### **Seating Direction Reveals Two People's Mindset**

Sitting face-to-face or side-by-side reveals distinctly different personalities.

Sitting face-to-face creates a sense of distance; a table or other barrier between them makes it feel more comfortable. Sitting side-by-side, facing the same direction and observing the same object, easily fosters a sense of connection.

When two people sit face-to-face, both occupy optimal positions for observing the other, readily generating a confrontational feeling. Thus, choosing to sit directly opposite signals a desire for the other person to understand oneself better. This seating style is common during first meetings or business interactions. Choosing to sit side-by-side indicates an intent to gauge the other's psychology. In hotel lounges, waitresses often sit beside guests for this reason.

### **How Walking Reveals Your Inner State**

When someone is far away, although their physical features may be unclear, their walking posture can still convey information. In other words, gait reflects not only health but also character.

For example, people who walk with a steady, grounded step tend to be composed and methodical, remaining calm even in emergencies; those who walk with chin raised, arms swinging, and stiff legs often appear arrogant or self-important; people who walk briskly are usually straightforward, efficiency-oriented, and plan their work and life meticulously, making success more likely.

If you wish to systematically understand the psychological insights hidden in walking posture, continue reading patiently; the following content will surely offer enlightenment.

### **Authoritative Standing Posture**

Hands clasped behind the back, one hand gripping the back of the other, body erect. Viewed from front or back, this posture projects authority and confidence.

An official inspecting grassroots work walks through a production workshop, head held high, chest out, hands behind his back, back perfectly straight, strolling slowly from one end to the other accompanied by local leaders.

Besides this official, many others adopt this posture in daily life, such as senior officers reviewing troops or principals inspecting teaching. Generally, those in high positions habitually assume this stance when facing subordinates. It is undeniably a symbol of power and dignity.

### **Confident and Unconfident Standing Postures**

A confident stance features both feet stably supporting the body, legs straight yet relaxed, knees not unnaturally locked as in a roll call. Feet are not perfectly parallel; toes point slightly outward.

In this posture, people rarely pace or shift side to side. Those with confident posture tend to act decisively and boldly. They also maintain frequent eye contact, holding gazes longer, whereas those lacking confidence do the opposite.

People lacking confidence or feeling inferior stand hunched, head lowered, shoulders rounded, gaze directed downward. They hesitate to take risks or responsibility.

## **1. Thigh Angle in Sitting Posture**

While seated, pressing the thighs together requires effort; if the mindset weakens into fear, it becomes the freeze response discussed earlier. The most natural state is legs slightly apart at roughly a 30-degree acute angle, thigh muscles completely relaxed. This angle represents the natural resting position of the thigh muscles when seated without support, neither deliberately constrained inward nor exaggeratedly open, indicating a relaxed, natural mindset. An exaggeratedly wide angle between the thighs signals a dominant mindset, first establishing territory through bodily expansion (the span of the angle) and showing willingness to face all stimuli from that territory with chest, abdomen, and genitals.

### **Feet Frozen, Interlocked**

Foot freezing is another manifestation of edge-control response, a tendency when facing danger. If someone who has been constantly swinging or bouncing their feet suddenly stops, they warrant attention; they may have heard something uncomfortable. This usually indicates the person is under pressure or emotional fluctuation, or feeling some degree of stress. When a person suddenly turns their toes inward or interlocks both feet, the signal is that they feel insecure, anxious, or threatened. This is the brain's reaction upon encountering threat.

Through a person's foot behavior, one can fully perceive their inner emotional shifts and determine appropriate ways to respond.

## **(2) T-Stance**

Legs slightly apart, crossed front to back, one foot bearing body weight while the other maintains balance.

This posture is among the most common, as it avoids stiffness, facilitates movement, and aids breathing and speaking. Straight legs convey an impression of uprightness and height; slightly relaxed legs convey friendliness. At gatherings, careful observation reveals that the direction of the front foot's toes often points to the person's interest. For instance, when conversing with a group, a person unconsciously directs their front foot's toes toward the most compatible individual; if the toes point left or right of the body, it signals the brain's message: "Sorry, I need to leave."

## **5. Leg Crossing**

If you offer a suggestion to a superior and they cross their legs after listening briefly, become alert; it indicates disinterest. End the conversation and leave promptly. If you persist, the superior will repeatedly shift their crossed legs, growing increasingly impatient and eventually interrupting, placing you in an awkward position.

The same applies to chess and negotiation. When heated debate arises, a negotiator crossing their legs sends a challenge signal; stay alert and focused to avoid costly mistakes. When both parties uncross their legs and lean forward, it often means negotiations are proceeding smoothly.

## **2. Legs Apart**

Spread legs display an open posture, a dominant signal, and an expression of absolute power, always conveying strength and authority. In reality, spread legs constitute a territory-defending behavior. For example, chimpanzees typically spread their legs wide; whoever occupies the largest area becomes the most dominant leader. In this respect, humans and animals are remarkably similar: spread legs signify defense or resistance.

When two men meet and one perceives the other as weaker, he may spread his legs in a provocative gesture, asserting dominance. Spread legs can also signal preparation for attack.

### **Feet on the Table, Displaying “Superiority”**

Anthropologists note that men are naturally more territorial than women. Yet both can express control through nonverbal body language. One such posture involves sitting deep in a chair with one foot placed on the table, silently displaying “superiority.”

According to Morris’s territory theory, placing a foot on an object signifies dominance or ownership over it. Old photographs often show owners leaning against their cars. Even today, many people touch or lean on their cars while being photographed or discussing their property.

### **Pacing Indicates Thinking**

When a person stands and paces the room, it usually shows they are pondering what was just said. Most people do this when solving difficult problems or making tough decisions, because standing facilitates clearer thinking. Therefore, when you see someone pacing in thought, remain quiet, wait patiently for them to speak, and do not interrupt.

Experienced salespeople excel at reading this “pacing person.” Upon encountering a pacing potential client, they typically wait patiently, knowing the posture signals the client is ready to decide.

### **Arrogance or Humility, Revealed by Gait**

Although footsteps vary by terrain and circumstance, each person’s walking style is as unique as a fingerprint. This explains why, for familiar individuals, one can judge their state from footsteps alone—fast or light, heavy or steady—without seeing them.

Behaviorists clearly state: “Generally, to assess someone’s mental flexibility, simply have them walk; this provides a basic understanding.” FBI agents share this view, believing a person’s gait reveals inner traits or at least current mood.

### **People Who Prefer Central Seating Are Self-Centered**

Such individuals have a strong desire for self-expression. When speaking with others, they center everything on themselves, repeatedly emphasizing their own words, ignoring others’ matters, showing indifference, and

dismissing others' opinions.

When a store becomes crowded and customers are asked to move tables together, these people immediately display annoyance and dissatisfaction, even seizing on the store's mistake to lodge strong protests. They are not easygoing or communicative types; if they order milk tea and the server mistakenly brings lemon black tea, they become highly displeased.

### **Standing Posture Best Reflects Character**

Micro-expression keywords

The saying "stand with proper posture" is not easily followed. A person's standing posture is closely tied to personality; character determines stance. Thus, as personalities differ widely, so do standing postures.

During upbringing, elders always teach "sit properly, stand properly." Nevertheless, standing postures vary greatly. Everyone has habitual ways of standing. Psychologists at the University of Hawaii note that "standing posture" is determined by personality traits.

### **People Who Walk in Corners Feel Inferior**

People who prefer walking in corners belong to the inferiority type. Their personalities often have eccentric aspects: call them incompetent and they will perform a brilliant feat; call them capable and they become overly modest; when everyone says something cannot be done, they will attempt it. Such people are not strong verbally, though many are intelligent. Their writing ability is quite good; they excel at love letters. Unfortunately, no matter how many they write, most remain hidden under pillows. The only way to motivate them is through praise, making them feel they possess many strengths and advantages.

### **Leg Movements Reveal Emotional Changes**

Understanding leg movements is a powerful tool for deciphering inner secrets, because legs reveal intentions. To interpret emotional shifts, leg movements are indispensable clues.

You may have noticed that when people prefer not to display inner anxiety on their faces, they often express it through the body part farthest from the brain. Precisely for this reason, the legs, located at the lowest point, are often the first to reveal subconscious thoughts and emotions. What emotions do different leg movements express? The following examples illustrate.

#### **(5) Resolute Sitting Posture**

Thighs apart, heels together, hands habitually placed at the navel.

Such people are courageous and decisive, immediately acting once they decide. Combateness is their nature; challenge is their pleasure. They possess a leader's authority and presence; many may not genuinely respect them but are simply awed by that intangible force. They never fear pressure and dare to take responsibility, yet sometimes struggle with interpersonal relations. In relationships, they are possessive and often interfere in their partner's life, easily incurring dislike.

#### **(4) Shy Sitting Posture**



Knees pressed together, calves forming an “eight” shape with heels apart, palms facing each other and placed between the knees.

People accustomed to this posture are often shy; a few words cause blushing and unease. They represent the “conservative” archetype—traditional, unsociable, sometimes seeming inexplicable.

At work, they prefer relying on past successes and resist innovation, suiting roles with fixed patterns. They treat friends sincerely and emotions delicately, yet their introverted, quiet nature often leads to being overlooked.

### **Arrogance or Humility, Revealed by Gait**

Although footsteps vary by terrain and circumstance, each person’s walking style is as unique as a fingerprint. This explains why, for familiar individuals, one can judge their state from footsteps alone—fast or light, heavy or steady—without seeing them.

Behaviorists clearly state: “Generally, to assess someone’s mental flexibility, simply have them walk; this provides a basic understanding.” Different moods produce different walking postures; different temperaments produce different gaits.

### **Feet Extended Forward, Ankles Crossed**

When men adopt this sitting posture, they often clench fists on their knees or grip chair arms tightly; women rest hands naturally on knees or fold them. Such people typically enjoy issuing orders and harbor strong jealousy, always striving to be first in every aspect and dominate or control others. They may therefore be difficult to get along with. They also tend to hesitate, especially in personal matters, often fearing failure and experiencing tension or fear. At the same time, they remain defensive, avoiding domination or attack by others.

## **6. Leg Draped Over Chair Arm**

If someone sits in a chair, lifts one leg, and drapes it over the armrest, appearing very relaxed, do not assume they are open or eager to cooperate. In reality, people adopting this posture are often indifferent or even hostile. Some superiors display this posture before subordinates to project authority. In negotiations, some representatives also use it to signal strong superiority and dominance.

### **Leg-Rubbing Motion**

This is a self-soothing behavior, usually performed under the table and thus easily overlooked. When a person places one or both hands on one or both legs and rubs downward along the thigh to the knee, the purpose is not merely to dry sweaty palms but primarily to relieve tension.

In daily life, although legs and feet are covered by clothing and shoes, they remain the earliest body parts to react and are key to obtaining more information; therefore, observe them carefully.

### **People Who Walk in Corners Feel Inferior**

People who prefer walking in corners generally have an inferiority complex. Their personalities often have eccentric aspects: call them incompetent and they will perform a brilliant feat; call them capable and they

become overly modest; when everyone says something cannot be done, they will attempt it.

Such people are not strong verbally, yet their writing ability is quite good; they excel at love letters. Unfortunately, no matter how many they write, most remain hidden under pillows. The only way to motivate them is through praise, making them feel they possess many strengths and advantages.

### **Leg-Rubbing Motion**

This is a comforting behavior, mostly performed under the table, so it is easily overlooked. If a person places one hand (or both hands) on one leg (or both legs) and rubs down the thigh to the knee, the purpose is not merely to dry the sweat on the palms; the main goal is to relieve tension.

In real life, although the legs and feet are covered by clothing and shoes, they remain the body parts that react first and are key to obtaining more information, so careful observation is essential.

### **Curled-Up Sleeping**

People who sleep this way generally lack a sense of security; loneliness in life, work, or relationships leaves them feeling extremely exhausted and isolated. Sleeping like a cat also signals a relatively weak personality and an inability to withstand setbacks. They have poor independent awareness, prefer to rely on familiar people or environments, and feel fear when encountering unfamiliar people or settings; when facing difficulties, they mostly choose to escape. Their logical reasoning ability is weak, they lack a sense of hierarchy in their actions, and they often find that an event has already occurred before any preparation is complete.

### **People Who Walk with Chin Held High Are Arrogant**

Some people walk with chin raised, head held high, arms swinging exaggeratedly back and forth, striding forward with heavy, slow steps, as if deliberately trying to make an impression. Such individuals are usually self-satisfied and even arrogant. If you do not wish to confront them, it is best to appear modest in their presence.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.42 昂首阔步的行人]

#### **(1) Walking with Chest Out and Head Held High**

People accustomed to walking this way often pay attention to appearance and neat clothing to display their presence. They tend to be self-centered, indifferent to interpersonal interactions, and unlikely to seek help easily; they are also mentally agile and consider issues comprehensively.

Unfortunately, they have two fatal weaknesses—shyness and lack of perseverance. Despite their exceptional abilities, their shy nature prevents them from actively communicating with others, so they often struggle to fully utilize their talents; they also find it difficult to persist in carrying plans through to action.

### **Sitting Posture Reveals a Person's Inner State**

#### **Micro-expression Keywords**

What is the person sitting across from you thinking? This is a question many people want answered. It is actually simple: to know their inner state, just look at their relaxed sitting posture. Sitting posture does not lie; it reveals the person's true psychological condition.

Which sitting position feels most comfortable to you? That seemingly casual posture may “betray” you by disclosing information about your personality traits and inner secrets. Let us examine this together.

### **People Who Walk with Hands in Pockets Are Critical**

People who habitually walk with both hands in their pockets—even in warm weather—are often highly critical and enjoy criticizing or belittling others. They frequently project an air of mystery, are skilled at concealing real emotions, and appear cynical. When interacting with such a person, first overpower them with presence.

Those who repeatedly pull their hands out of their pockets and then put them back in while walking tend to be cautious, think things through before acting, yet easily become discouraged in adversity. This habit can also indicate that the person is tense.

### **Prone Sleeping**

Such individuals are confident in themselves and possess outstanding abilities. They accurately recognize who they are at any moment and know exactly what they are doing. They pursue life goals persistently and have both the confidence and capability to achieve them. In emergencies they make timely decisions, demonstrate strong adaptability, and know how to adjust themselves. In addition, they are adept at concealing their true feelings so thoroughly that others cannot detect any flaw.

## **4. Leg Resting**

People with strong dominance and possessiveness generally rest their feet on a desk or an open desk drawer. This action can be viewed as using the legs to connect with the desk, thereby expanding one’s sphere of influence and asserting oneself. However, if a subordinate adopts this posture in front of them, they will feel their territory has been invaded and become displeased. If someone places a leg on the desk or drawer during a first meeting or in front of unfamiliar people, it proves they are extremely arrogant.

### **(6) Rigid Sitting Posture**

Legs and heels together, hands crossed on either side of the thighs.

Such people are rigid and stubborn; they refuse to accept others’ opinions even when they privately know those opinions are correct. They project an aristocratic arrogance and possess a romantic temperament. They strive for perfection in everything and hold deep interest in literature and art, yet they lack a practical spirit, so many ideas never reach implementation. They are poor at adapting and often run into obstacles in real life.

### **(3) Attention Posture**

Legs together and straight, toes forward, both legs supporting the body.

This standing posture is relatively formal and commonly seen between bosses and employees, elders and juniors, teachers and students, and unfamiliar men and women. Standing at attention is actually a strenuous posture that signals respect for the other person or seriousness about the occasion. If someone habitually stands this way, it indicates they are reserved, meticulous, and not talkative—difficult to approach—yet often capable of achieving great things.

## **Five Standing Postures for Quick Character Reading**

I have a habit of standing by the window and watching strangers on the street. Analyzing a person's posture while standing or walking to infer their inner state brings me pleasure. I have found that whether in malls, parks, or ordinary social settings, people in a standing position generally adopt one of five basic postures: natural standing, T-stance, legs apart, legs crossed, and attention posture. Below I describe the psychological state each posture represents.

### **Habitually Leaning Against Objects While Standing**

They lean against walls or tables; when no object is available, they lean against other people. On the positive side, they are candid and straightforward and readily accept others. On the negative side, they lack independence and always prefer shortcuts.

Body language is often more honest than words; the mouth frequently lies consciously, while body language unconsciously reveals the true state. By carefully observing a person's standing posture, we can discern what kind of person they are.

### **Leg and Foot Shaking While Seated**

Such people are selfish, always act from self-interest, rarely consider others, are harsh toward others yet indulgent toward themselves, and have few friends. However, they are good thinkers and often raise questions others have not considered.

We may find it difficult to guess what another person is thinking, yet if we observe a stranger's sitting posture attentively, we can grasp their interests within three to five minutes even without speaking. This is an excellent public-relations strategy.

### **(5) Legs Apart**

Legs extended straight, feet more than hip-width apart, forming a triangle with the ground.

This posture is common among men and often carries connotations of challenge, resistance, or confrontation. Male athletes frequently adopt it at the start or end of a competition to display masculine vigor and fighting strength. If someone habitually uses this standing posture in daily life, it can be concluded with 90 percent certainty that the person has a strong sense of superiority and is full of fighting spirit.

### **People Who Like to Shake Their Legs**

Some people shake their legs whether in meetings or while chatting with others. Although this behavior is obviously impolite, many still do it habitually. The most prominent trait of such individuals is selfishness; they disregard others' feelings and become "neurotic" the moment their own interests are threatened.

In negotiations, if a person unconsciously begins tapping the floor with their toes, it can basically be determined that they believe victory is assured—at least in their own mind.

### **Confidence or Inferiority—Look at the Standing Posture**

We often describe a woman's beauty as "gracefully erect" and praise a man's heroic bearing as "tall and straight." Standing like a pine tree reflects a righteous mind; standing crookedly reflects a weak body. A

person of integrity stands with sleeves that can carry a pure breeze; a person with ill intentions sets traps even while standing.

In real life, everyone's standing posture varies constantly. Careful observation of the people around us is very helpful for understanding their character and psychology.

### **Women Who Walk Hurriedly Are Outgoing**

If a dignified and beautiful woman walks in a hurried manner that feels scattered, she can basically be judged as an outgoing, straightforward person who speaks her mind without hidden motives.

Conversely, if a woman who appears large and sturdy walks with extreme caution, she is certainly a shrewd person who is "rough outside, meticulous inside," yet people are often deceived by her bold exterior.

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### **The Most Honest Body Parts—Legs and Feet**

In the human body, the farther a part is from the brain, the higher its credibility. The face is closest to the brain yet least honest, so people often use smiles or frowns to mask their true thoughts. The hands, located in the middle-lower part of the body, have medium honesty; people occasionally use them to lie. The feet, however, are at the lowest part of the body, farthest from brain control, and are far more honest than the face or hands. They constitute a unique psychological leak—foot language.

### **(3) Leisurely Sitting Posture**

Half-reclining, hands clasped behind the head.

This posture looks very relaxed and comfortable; people who habitually adopt it usually have an easygoing yet not casual personality. They possess rigorous logical thinking and strong perseverance, emphasize efficiency in their work, and manage both work and life well. They have little desire for money and buy things by intuition rather than comparison shopping, so they sometimes encounter financial troubles.

### **(2) Confident Sitting Posture**

Left foot crossed over the right leg, hands crossed at the base of the legs.

Such people are naturally intelligent, can hold firmly to their views on any matter, and will use every means to achieve their goals. They possess strong coordination skills, often act as leaders within their circles, and inspire willing followership. At times, however, they become carried away by success and happiness, overlooking others' feelings.

### **(6) Splay-Footed Walking Posture**

This walking style is divided into “pigeon-toed” and “duck-footed.”

- People who habitually walk pigeon-toed give an impression of honesty and simplicity. They pay attention to details, like to proceed step by step, and often lose composure when facing sudden situations.
- People who habitually walk duck-footed give an impression of boldness. They are carefree, sway left and right, live without fussing over trifles, and value loyalty, yet they often disregard others’ feelings.

## **Sitting Posture Betrays Your Character**

When people sit down, they adopt different postures—crossing one leg over the other, keeping both legs together, crossing the ankles, and so on. If your negotiation counterpart sits with both feet naturally extended outward, conveying a calm, steady, unhurried impression, you need not be too nervous, because such people are generally straightforward. Next I will explain how to read a person’s character and psychological state from their sitting posture.

### **Submission or Resistance—Look at the Sitting Posture**

When people sit down, they adopt different postures—crossing one leg over the other, keeping both legs together, crossing the ankles—and choose different positions, such as facing each other or sitting side by side. In fact, in interpersonal relationships, how one sits and where one sits both reflect deep psychological states. Therefore, we can mark and analyze a person’s sitting posture and chosen position to draw a “topographic map” of the heart.

#### **(8) Dissolute Sitting Posture**

Legs spread wide, hands with no fixed resting place, presenting an open posture.

Such people pursue novelty and can even set trends. Those accustomed to this posture usually smile readily and do not care about others’ criticism, so they enjoy good popularity. However, their living habits and thought patterns differ greatly from most people, easily leaving an impression of frivolity and sometimes causing family troubles.

### **People Who Cross Their Legs**

This sitting posture appears natural and indicates that the person is relatively confident, knows how to handle complex interpersonal relationships, and knows how to enjoy life. However, if one leg hooks the other, it shows the person is cautious and reserved, lacks sufficient confidence, often hesitates when acting, and has a rather complex personality. Nevertheless, because they grasp the proper measure in dealing with others, they also win others’ liking and approval.

#### **1. Legs Together**

The legs-together posture is serious, proper, and restrained; although it looks cautious, it can convey a sense of oppression and tension. Both the attention stance and sitting upright with knees together belong to this category.

Legs together is usually a submissive posture. For example, during military training every soldier is required to keep legs together. Therefore, when someone adopts this posture, it often represents submission.

## **Turned Feet**

When a suspect feels relaxed about the conversation content, their feet usually point toward the agent. If the feet point elsewhere, something may be making them uneasy. For instance, when a suspect dislikes the agent they are speaking with, they will turn their feet toward the nearest exit. Although their upper body continues to listen attentively to the agent's questions, their feet have already chosen to flee.

## **People Who Walk with Hands Clapsed Behind Their Back Are Preoccupied**

When a person is preoccupied, they usually walk slowly and often assume a contemplative posture—head slightly lowered, hands tightly clasped behind the back. They may occasionally stop to think, kick a stone, or pick up a piece of paper from the ground, as if saying to themselves, "Perhaps look at this matter from another angle." Such people have usually encountered a difficult problem.

### **(1) Natural Standing**

Legs naturally extended, neither tense nor slack, or slightly together.

People accustomed to standing naturally often lack pioneering spirit yet are down-to-earth, unwilling to compete with others, and relatively easy to satisfy. Emotionally they can be impatient and may pursue one person intensely for a period, yet they cannot withstand long-term tests. They do not know how to say "no," so they get along well with others.

### **Legs Spread Apart**

Legs spread wide is clearly a "territory defense" behavior. When a person feels pressure, agitation, or threat, they unconsciously spread their legs wider than others to emphasize their territory. For example, when two people in conversation enter a standoff, they typically spread their legs and feet. This is not to stand more steadily but to claim more territory.

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### **(4) Hurried Walking Posture**

In non-emergency situations, if a person still walks hurriedly with long strides, it indicates abundant energy, emphasis on efficiency, no procrastination, and great integrity—they never shift blame—although they can sometimes be rash. In addition, if their footsteps are audible, fast yet orderly, it shows the person is rational, has a perfect plan for the future and life, and values relationships highly.

## **People Who Sit Upright and Still**

Legs together, entire soles of the feet on the ground. Such people are sincere, open-hearted, and naturally warm. Although straightforward in character, they do not anger others. Their traits include orderly conduct, a

tendency to be overly particular, and a pursuit of thorough perfection. They also avoid risky actions and lack sufficient flexibility, which can leave an impression of rigidity and formality.

### **Feet Together, Toes Lifted, Heels on the Ground**

Such people are cautious, solitary, and withdrawn; they dare not blend into crowds and usually maintain a distant, defensive attitude toward others. This relates to their unusually sensitive nature—they cannot bear even slight criticism or discussion. Others sense this trait and therefore avoid discussing certain topics with them, which creates a sense of isolated loneliness and heightens their psychological defenses.

### **Legs Crossed**

Usually we cross our legs when we feel comfortable and relaxed, but when someone we dislike suddenly appears we may immediately return to a normal posture. We also cross our legs when we feel confident in front of others. If one party crosses their legs during a conversation, it indicates that person is relaxed, and we can then discuss more important topics.

### **(5) People Who Like to Wear High Heels**

High heels symbolize nobility and are favored by women who love beauty. It can be said that the thinner and higher the heel, the stronger the person's desire to perform and attract attention. For the sake of beauty they are willing to endure some foot pain, so they actually possess considerable endurance. These women are either idle rich girls or accomplished career women.

## **3. Crossed Legs**

Crossed legs is a defensive posture, generally indicating shyness, timidity, casualness, and lack of enthusiasm. For example, the leg-crossing posture when standing, or the crossed-legs posture when sitting. When speaking, if the body is upright with legs crossed and one leg raised, it indicates a skeptical mood. Additionally, when feeling uneasy or wanting to reject someone, people often make this rejecting gesture.

### **(1) Gentle Sitting Posture**

The legs and heels are held tightly together, the hands rest on the knees, and the body is upright.

Such people are generally introverted, humble, with a closed emotional world; their speech and actions are relatively mild. For those with outgoing emotions, this can be hard to endure. They consider others, are meticulous and serious at work, and greatly value the fruits of their labor, avoiding extravagant spending.

### **Toes Together, Heels Apart**

Such people are overly serious and meticulous in their work, often appearing indecisive. Although they know this delays matters, they frequently cannot correct it. They do not particularly enjoy socializing and prefer to be alone or with only their closest few people. They possess strong insight and can accurately judge a stranger's character at the fastest speed. However, they sometimes overestimate their own abilities.

## **Analysis of Sitting Posture Types**



Such people appear amiable and approachable, yet are actually indifferent. They will not proactively help others unless sincerely asked. They are rational, smooth, and selfish, but possess strong work ability because their indifference allows them to exclude external distractions. On the surface they have good interpersonal relations, yet in reality it is difficult for them to have even one or two close friends.

### **(1) Always Wearing One's Preferred Style**

As the shoe-store owner said, people who always wear a certain fixed style of shoes are mostly quite rigorous. They know what they like and dislike and do not overly concern themselves with others' opinions. In their careers, such people tend to succeed because they can always focus single-mindedly on their goals. In life, they are also reliable individuals.

### **(4) People Who Like Wearing Slippers**

I can guarantee that if someone attends an interview wearing slippers, they will hardly avoid being turned away. In a relatively formal setting, appearing in slippers is undoubtedly rude. They lack basic etiquette awareness and are always careless about work, yet in daily life they are actually easy to get along with. They are quite free-spirited and know how to enjoy life.

### **People Who Walk with Hands on Hips Are Impatient**

Some people walk with hands on their hips, like sprinters. They may be quick-tempered individuals who want to reach their destination by the shortest route and fastest speed. Such people have strong explosive power and often make this gesture when preparing to implement the next plan. This posture has become a characteristic of these individuals, much like using "V" to represent victory.

### **Feet Shifting from Side-to-Side Rocking to Kicking**

When a person's foot movements shift from gentle side-to-side rocking to up-and-down kicking, it indicates that the person has seen or heard something negative or unpleasant. This is entirely an unconscious behavior; most people are unaware of it. Although these actions do not necessarily indicate deceptive intent, they do show that the current topic has affected the person.

### **People Who Walk with Chin Raised Are Arrogant**

Some people walk with chin lifted, head held high, arms swinging exaggeratedly, striding forward with heavy, slow steps, as if deliberately trying to make an impression. Such people are usually self-satisfied or even arrogant. If you do not wish to confront them, it is best to appear modest in their presence.

### **(5) Slightly Leaning Walking Posture**

Some people habitually lean slightly forward while walking, even appearing somewhat hunched. Most such individuals are introverted, humble, and without flowery speech. They never deceive others and cherish relationships, yet because they are unsmiling, they find it difficult to get along with people. Consequently, a large portion of them develop a sense of weariness toward life.

### **Sleeping on One's Back**

Such people are very outgoing and generous, warm and kind, full of sympathy, willing to give, able to read others' psychology well, and aware of others' needs. Their thinking is quite mature; they can usually distinguish priorities in people and matters. They also have a strong sense of responsibility, dare to take on duties, and maintain relatively good interpersonal relationships.

### **One Leg Straight, the Other Bent or Crossed to the Side**

This is a standing posture that conveys reservation or a slight tendency toward rejection. People accustomed to standing this way often lack confidence and are relatively shy; in an unfamiliar environment or among unfamiliar people they feel constrained. However, they are sincere toward others, inwardly warm, and enjoy helping people.

### **People Who Walk with Head Lowered Are Depressed**

When a person is depressed, they often walk with head down, dragging their feet, hands in pockets, rarely looking up to notice where they are going.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图2.44 沮丧的行人]*

### **(4) Crossed Legs**

One leg relatively straight, the other crossed in front or behind, heel slightly raised.

At gatherings, some people habitually keep both arms and legs in a crossed posture; if you observe further, you will find that the distance between these people is often greater. When women maintain this posture, it indicates they want to stay or do not want others to approach.

## **3. Is the Shaking Obvious?**

Leg-shaking in KTVs and restaurants is not done stealthily; it is done openly for pleasure and must be vigorous! But when the shaking is slight during conversation and was not present before, then this leg-shaking is the micro-reaction (微反应) flaw we are looking for.

We will now analyze the two cases mentioned earlier in detail.

### **(3) Neat and Orderly Walking Posture**

This walking style gives a sense of seriousness and tension. People who walk with neat, orderly steps possess super-strong willpower and a high degree of organizational ability. Once they set a goal, they advance toward it unwaveringly and allow themselves no errors or slackness. Consequently, they often make those around them feel intimidated.

### **Shy, Restless Standing Posture**

At such times, people tend to shift their body weight onto one supporting foot while extending the other foot, the toes possibly turned slightly inward. In this situation, people usually do not stand still but keep moving about, trying to find a better spot.

### **Sitting with Legs Apart**

Such people are open-hearted and may have a preference for taking charge of everything, possessing a leader's temperament or a dominating personality. They are generally extroverted, fearless, and sometimes overconfident. If female, it indicates a lack of life experience and a degree of self-importance.

## **6. Temporarily Walk Away**

When you feel especially angry and have reached the point of being unable to control yourself, it is best to walk away temporarily, change the setting, and first distance yourself from the person who angered you. You can shut yourself in a room alone for a while or find a place to calm your mood.

## **People Who Like Sitting in the Center Are Self-Centered**

In a restaurant, which seat do you prefer? In a café, which seat do you prefer? In a meeting room, which seat do you prefer?...

Through different positions we can roughly judge a person's psychology and personality.

## **(2) Methodical Walking Posture**

This posture gives others a calm and unhurried feeling. Such people remain composed in situations and appear cultured. If people accustomed to this walking style have steady steps, it indicates confidence and decisiveness; if their steps are weak, it indicates a lack of grand ambitions and a lack of drive.

## **People Who Like Sitting in Corners Prefer Quiet**

Such people like a stable, secure life, do not want to be noticed, and do not wish to be disturbed. Because they prefer to be observers, they lack decision-making ability regarding most matters and lack the proactive attitude a leader should have.

## **Face Down, Head Between Arms, Knees Drawn Up**

Such people have a strong defensive mentality and a strong sense of autonomy; they will not obey others' orders or be manipulated, nor will they bow to power. They like doing what they enjoy; if someone forcibly requires them to do something else, they will resist.

## **(9) Lincoln-Style Sitting Posture**

Sitting upright on a chair with legs apart, hands on the armrests, and jacket open.

The Lincoln-style sitting posture indicates frankness and comfort. When two people adopt Lincoln's open sitting posture, it means there is no mutual resistance and communication flows smoothly.

## **(2) People Who Like Wearing Fashionable Styles**

Some people are covered from head to toe in fashionable elements. Such people have two characteristics:

1. Strong receptiveness to new things, strong vanity and desire for self-expression.
2. Not very thorough in considering matters, sometimes unrealistic.

## **People Who Walk Steadily Are Pragmatic**

Some people always walk unhurriedly, even in emergencies. Such people have always sought stability in handling affairs, "think three times before acting," and are relatively pragmatic. Generally speaking, these people have high work efficiency and do what they say.

### **Lying Diagonally Across the Bed**

Such people are quite arbitrary; although they handle matters shrewdly and competently, they will never compromise with others. Their attitude toward matters is: "I say how it is, and you may not object." They enjoy leading others and have a strong desire for power.

### **Upright Standing Posture**

People who stand without leaning to either side are often called "roly-polys." That is to say, such people flatter and curry favor, are skilled at disguise. Therefore, they generally have deep scheming and can remain inscrutable.

### **People Who Walk Steadily Are Pragmatic**

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### **8.2.4 Offensive Leg and Foot Movements**

The attacking actions of the legs are stamping, kicking, and striking. Given that in psychological testing scenarios involving two parties, foot-kicking of walls or other objects is rare, the general expression of anger is stamping and grinding.

### **People Who Walk Leaning Forward Are Humble**

Some people habitually lean their upper body forward while walking rather than holding their head high and chest out, appearing somewhat hunched. Most such individuals have gentle, introverted personalities, are relatively humble, generally do not show off, and are quite cultured.

### **People Who Walk Leaning Forward Are Humble**

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### **People Who Like Sitting Near the Entrance Are Impatient**

Such people can observe their surroundings in minute detail, hold a very serious attitude toward life, like to move around, and are never idle. Serving and helping others are what they most enjoy doing.

### **Feet Placed Outside the Bed**

Such people have a rather fast pace of life, are busy with work, and have little rest time. They hold a quite positive and optimistic attitude toward life, are energetic, and treat others with great warmth and kindness.

### **People Who Like Sleeping at the Edge of the Bed**

Such people lack a sense of security but possess strong self-control and tolerance, enabling them to keep uneasy emotions from showing. If matters do not exceed their tolerance limit, they will not easily retaliate or become angry.

### **Hands at Sides, Legs Extended, Sitting While Sleeping**

Such people are constantly in a state of high tension; their pace of life is very fast and regular, with fixed times for what should and should not be done.

### **People Who Like Sitting by the Window Are Ordinary**

People who like sitting by a bright window usually have no particularly distinctive personality. They avoid areas near entrances, exits, and restrooms and stay away from noisy guests whenever possible.

### **People Who Sleep with Both Arms and Legs Crossed**

Such people have a relatively strong sense of self-defense and do not allow others to infringe upon them. However, their personalities are fragile and they find it difficult to withstand certain kinds of harm.

### **(3) People Who Like Wearing Casual Shoes**

They are kind to others and full of vitality, yet their lives lack regularity. They love nature, enjoy making friends, and pursue a simple, comfortable life.

### **Sleeping Postures Reveal Your Personality: Curled-Up Sleeping Indicates Insecurity**

A person's sleeping posture is a form of body language expressed directly from the subconscious and is very helpful for understanding personality and psychology.

### **People Who Walk with Head Lowered Are Depressed**

When a person is depressed, they often walk with head down, dragging their feet, hands in pockets, rarely looking up to notice where they are going.

### **People Who Like Sitting Against a Wall with Their Back to Others Are Aloof**

Such people are naturally aloof, keen on immersing themselves in their own world, and disregard external existence.

### **Standing While Leaning Against an Object**

Such people are usually cold, responsible, and resilient, belonging to the type who struggle alone.

### **(7) Indifferent Sitting Posture**

Right leg crossed over the left leg, lower legs close together, hands crossed on the lap.

See Hands (c-hands).

See Hands (c-hands).

See Hands (c-hands).

See Hands (c-hands).

## **Crossed Legs and the Figure-Four Position**

### **Ankles Crossed, Indicating Someone Is Suppressing Strong Emotions**

When you see someone with both ankles crossed over each other, you should note that the person may be restraining themselves. People instinctively press their ankles tightly together when suppressing intense sensations or emotions. Some jokingly describe the posture as looking like “someone who urgently needs the restroom but cannot go.”

In business negotiations or various social settings, a person under tension or fear often sits with ankles tightly crossed and hands gripping the chair arms.

Flight attendants are highly skilled at reading passengers’ body language. They have a unique ability to identify passengers who genuinely need service but are too shy to ask. If a passenger repeatedly crosses and uncrosses their ankles after boarding—especially before takeoff—the attendant can tell the person is very tense or uneasy. When the attendant offers coffee, tea, or milk, if the passenger’s ankles remain crossed and do not move toward the edge of the seat, it indicates they may want something.

Similarly, patients in a dentist’s chair and customers in a barber’s chair preparing for a shave often cross their ankles tightly while gripping the armrests. This tells us both are trying to control unpleasant feelings.

Renowned negotiation experts Gerard Nierenberg and Henry Calero observed that during negotiations, crossed ankles usually mean the person is hesitating to reveal an important concession.

People also unconsciously cross their ankles when facing difficult problems at work or in daily life. Once the issue is resolved and everything proceeds smoothly, they tend to uncross their legs without thinking.

Therefore, when you cannot read someone’s true intentions, it can be useful to observe their feet and interpret their “foot language.”

### **Sitting Upright with Legs Crossed, Indicating Doubt and Resistance**

A businessman once noticed his counterpart looking displeased and reluctant to continue the discussion. Still hoping to close the deal, he said tactfully, “I sincerely want to make this transaction. I have laid all my cards on the table.” He expected his apparent sincerity to win agreement, yet the other party grew even more rigid. The counterpart had detected the inconsistency between words and body language and ultimately refused to sign.

The cause lay in the businessman’s legs. While speaking, he sat upright with his legs crossed—a posture that signals doubt and resistance, directly contradicting his claim of sincerity. The other party naturally declined the agreement.

During negotiations, participants rarely cross their legs when preparing to raise a question. Once discussion or heated debate begins, one or both sides typically cross their legs. When an agreement is near, if both parties uncross their legs and lean forward, the chance of reaching consensus rises sharply. Therefore, pay special attention to anyone sitting with legs crossed during talks.

Some people cross their legs the moment they sit down. This shows they are on guard, competitive, ambitious, confident, and ready to act once decided. This applies mainly to men; women differ slightly.

A woman who boldly crosses her legs in this manner demonstrates confidence in her appearance or clothing and a strong desire to be noticed. Such women tend to have high self-esteem, enjoy displaying charm, and are relatively casual with the opposite sex. They often aspire to leadership roles, yet winning their affection or commitment is not easy.

### **Satisfaction and Celebration**

When someone feels highly satisfied, they typically lean back, clasp their hands behind their head, and cross their legs in the figure-four position (see Figure 4.30). The posture conveys the impression that they are in control.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.30 “4”字形的坐姿]*

Conversely, a person who feels deeply discouraged tends to hunch forward, letting their arms hang limply over their knees in a listless manner (see Figure 4.31).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.31 沮丧的坐姿]*

When feeling satisfied, comfortable, and confident, a person may emit a “cluck” sound. The tongue presses against the roof of the mouth and then relaxes quickly, allowing the tongue to drop. You may have heard the expression “She clucked like a proud hen,” indicating strong self-satisfaction.

People who make this sound often accompany it by snapping their fingers or clapping their hands as if striking a bottle cap with a bottle.

A common celebratory gesture for satisfaction and celebration (such as concluding an agreement) is raising a fist in the air and then pulling it back sharply a few inches, as if yanking the whistle cord on an old steam locomotive. This is sometimes viewed as a fist-pump.

Another familiar celebratory gesture is the thumbs-up: both hands formed into fists with only the thumbs extended upward.

### **The Figure-Four Sitting Posture and the Discouraged Sitting Posture**

A cartoon shows two well-known politicians seated face-to-face discussing current affairs. One leans back with hands clasped behind his head and legs crossed in the figure-four position—one foot resting flat on the opposite thigh, ankle on the knee—looking thoroughly pleased with himself. The other slumps forward, shoulders hunched, arms dangling over his legs, appearing thoroughly dejected.

At a seminar organized by Gerard Nierenberg and Henry Calero, the instructors showed participants this cartoon and asked who was speaking and what was being said. Most participants said the man leaning back was speaking and appeared confident in his words; some even described him as arrogant and fond of showing off. The other politician was characterized as sullen, discouraged, and suspicious.

The figure-four posture is a typical American sitting style; many American women adopt it when wearing trousers. Female lawyers attending Nierenberg seminars have acknowledged that they unconsciously assume

this posture while listening to a client's complaints, noting that it helps them focus more intently on analyzing the client's words.

### **One Leg Draped over the Arm of the Chair, Expressing Hostility or Disregard**

Sitting with one leg casually thrown over the arm of the chair while the other foot remains on the floor may at first appear open and relaxed. Closer observation reveals that the person is usually signaling hostility or disregard.

Flight attendants note that passengers who rest a leg on the armrest tend to be demanding and difficult to please. Salespeople likewise find buyers seated in this posture hard to satisfy. The behavior silently asserts dominance and superior status in the interaction or transaction.

### **Legs Straddling the Chair, a Posture Indicating Authority and Dominant Advantage**

Sitting astride a chair with legs spread and the chair back used as a barrier is a posture of authority and dominance. It conveys a meaning similar to placing one's feet on a desk. Salespeople visiting prospective clients never adopt this posture unless they have no intention of closing the deal.

Therefore, in negotiations, sales, or social interactions, remain especially alert to anyone sitting backward on a chair. Such individuals often lack cooperative intent, show little regard for others' needs, and may even harbor hostility.

### **The Lincoln Sitting Posture, an Open and Relaxed Position Conveying Candor**

Placing feet on a desk or straddling a chair are nonverbal ways of displaying arrogance and authority. In contrast, the Lincoln sitting posture—sitting squarely with legs apart, arms resting on the chair arms, and jacket open—conveys equality through nonverbal means.

The Lincoln posture is candid and comfortable. When two people adopt this open stance, communication flows more easily, neither resists the other, and neither projects a sense of superiority.

### **Legs Crossed with One Foot Swinging Lightly, Indicating Boredom or Impatience**

At times we become restless or lose interest in our surroundings. How can we tell when someone else is also bored?

A signature movement is crossing the legs and swinging one raised foot back and forth. People often perform this action while waiting—for example, before a plane departs or a meeting ends.

## **Direction and Orientation of the Feet**

### **Where the Toes Point, the Heart Follows**

In the human body, the farther a part is from the brain, the more trustworthy it tends to be. The face is closest to the brain yet least honest, which is why people often use smiles or frowns to conceal their true thoughts. The hands sit in the middle-lower region of the body and are only moderately reliable; people occasionally use them to lie as well. The feet, however, occupy the lowest position, farthest from brain control, and are



therefore far more honest than the face or hands. They produce a distinctive form of psychological leakage known as foot language.

Compared with hand movements, leg and foot movements are noticeably fewer, so their expressions are simpler. When a person becomes emotionally agitated, foot movements actually become even more limited. As a result, the emotional information conveyed by the feet is often overlooked. Yet because people routinely forget to monitor their own feet, the signals they provide are especially valuable and more likely to reveal a person's genuine inner state. As body-language expert Joe Navarro observed, "Facial expressions can be faked, but few people know how to disguise the movements of their feet."

### **The Direction the Feet Face Usually Indicates What a Person Truly Cares About**

For example, three men stand together chatting while a beautiful woman stands nearby. On the surface, the three men appear absorbed in conversation and pay no attention to her. In reality, each of them has one foot angled toward her. In other words, all three men are noticing the woman; their apparent focus on the conversation is merely a mask hiding their true interest.

Numerous studies of courtroom behavior have reached the same conclusion: when a judge dislikes a witness, the judge's feet will point toward the courtroom door through which the judge entered earlier. Likewise, when you are speaking with someone whose feet are angled away from you rather than directly toward you, that person is signaling a desire to end the conversation as soon as possible.

### **Feet That Turn Away**

When a suspect feels relaxed about the topic under discussion, both feet usually point toward the agent. If the feet point elsewhere, something in the exchange is likely making the suspect uneasy. For instance, when a suspect dislikes the agent conducting the interview, the suspect will turn one or both feet toward the nearest exit. Although the upper body may still appear to be listening attentively, the feet have already chosen to leave.

## **Voice and Speaking**

### **"May I Interrupt?"**

A person who wants to become a good listener faces the greatest difficulty in overcoming the urge to interrupt others. Normally, during conversation, we can hear 650–700 words per minute, while even the fastest speaker can utter only 150–160 words per minute. This leaves us with 75 percent of our listening time to evaluate, accept, or reject the other person's viewpoint.

We all remember from elementary school that raising a hand above the head was required before speaking. This habit is so ingrained that as adults, even without needing to raise our hands, we sometimes lift them partway (though not above the head) to signal that we have something to say or a question to ask.

Although raising a hand clearly signals an intention to speak, most adults prefer not to use it. They often start the motion and then withdraw it, substituting subtler gestures such as touching an earlobe or the lips before returning the hand to its original position.

When the hand rises only to ear-lobe height, it gently tugs the ear and returns (see Figure 4.34). When it reaches the mouth, the index finger lightly covers the lips as if trying to hold back words. If the finger remains

on the lips for an extended period, the listener taps them lightly while continuing to attend.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.34 用手扯耳朵]

Some people occasionally manage to suppress interruption gestures altogether. They raise a hand without touching the head, lift it a few inches, and return it to the lap or table. This motion may be repeated silently several times. Unfortunately, such subtle interruption signals are often overlooked.

When a speaker becomes animated, listeners may also wish to speak, requiring a role switch. On some occasions, however, the speaker does not want to yield and ignores the listener's cues.

Skilled communicators do the opposite: they watch listeners' body movements and facial expressions and pause when they detect a desire to speak.

A hand placed on the speaker's arm or shoulder indicates a firmer intention to interrupt. To soften the gesture, the listener may add, "I'm sorry to interrupt, but..." or "I largely agree, but...."

Noticing these interruption signals and treating them as a listener's wish to participate does not harm the speaker. The listener may simply want to express appreciation or to flag potential objections ahead.

Responding positively to such cues leads others to regard you as an excellent conversationalist, because you allow them to join the exchange. The Greek philosopher Zeno observed, "We have two ears but only one mouth, which shows we should listen more and speak less."

When standing or walking, the most common self-control posture is hands clasped behind the back, one hand gripping the wrist or forearm of the other hand, which is clenched (see Figure 4.35). The posture clearly signals that the person is working to control emotion.

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.35 站立时自我控制的姿势]

When seated, the common self-control posture is ankles tightly crossed and hands gripping the chair arms (see Figures 4.36 and 4.37, noting the difference between men and women).

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.36 坐着时自我控制的男人]

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.37 坐着时自我控制的女人]

Flight attendants are adept at reading passengers' body language. They can identify travelers who need service yet hesitate to ask. If a passenger repeatedly crosses and uncrosses the ankles (especially before takeoff), attendants recognize acute nervousness. When coffee, tea, or milk is offered and the ankles remain tightly crossed rather than moving toward the seat edge, the passenger likely wants something.

Similarly, dental patients and customers in barber chairs awaiting a shave often cross their ankles tightly and grip the armrests, indicating they are suppressing discomfort.

People also cross their ankles unconsciously when facing difficult problems at work or in daily life. Once the issue is resolved, they tend to uncross their legs.

### Section 3: Being Right Does Not Require Raising One's Voice

A common saying advises, "Forgive others when possible." Yielding even when in the right is a social virtue, because being right does not require raising one's voice. Chinese tradition values harmony and tolerance, yet

two regrettable patterns appear in daily life: the unreasonable party twists facts and wrongs the reasonable party, or the reasonable party presses so aggressively that the other is driven into a corner.

Why do these patterns occur?

Consider the first case. The unreasonable party has no valid argument yet overwhelms the reasonable party through glib speech for three reasons: first, to mask inner weakness—knowing they lack justification, they rely on forceful rhetoric to save face; second, to exploit the tendency to “avoid the strong and yield to the weak,” hoping an aggressive stance will prevail; third, because they genuinely fail to recognize their error and therefore keep arguing rather than concede.

When facing any of these three types, remain calm. Allowing oneself to be provoked only escalates the conflict and strengthens the other side. If patience is exhausted, respond without trading verbal blows. Silence, cool observation, and an occasional smile can suffice. A reasonable person will stop rather than continue a monologue; persistent ranting will only earn disapproval from bystanders. This “silent victory” may prove more effective than argument. Yet when someone is truly overbearing, endless tolerance invites further mistreatment. In such cases, stand firm, present evidence, and assert one’s position without descending to the same level of shouting. A wise person uses logic and irrefutable facts to deflate the opponent’s momentum.

Now consider the second case. The reasonable party refuses to yield and corners the other simply because they believe, “I am right, so why should I not claim my rights?” They are willing to fight to the end to protect those rights.

It is best not to become this kind of person. If one is right, why not explain calmly instead of raising one’s voice? News stories frequently show customers who discover a fly in a restaurant meal, confront the owner, and, knowing they hold the advantage, intimidate the owner into kneeling and begging forgiveness. While the owner’s lapse in hygiene is at fault, such escalation is unnecessary. Observers often view the customer as lacking basic decency for driving another person into a corner. The saying “Uphold principles in major matters and style in minor ones” suggests that small frictions can be handled peacefully. Most people respond to reason. When emotion overrides judgment and one scolds or resorts to extremes simply because one is right, the original advantage is lost. Therefore, avoid confrontational argumentation and seek calm resolution.

Both the overbearing unreasonable party and the unyielding reasonable party are, at root, weak. Spending precious time on verbal victory leaves little room for meaningful pursuits. Even if they “win,” the victory is hollow. Combative individuals accumulate enemies, damage relationships, and rarely succeed in their careers.

In short, being right does not require raising one’s voice; when right, one should still yield. If genuinely wronged, choose the appropriate person, occasion, and method to raise the issue. Resolve matters calmly to avoid hurtful words that may produce unintended consequences.

### **Boredom or Lack of Interest**

At times we become restless or lose interest in our surroundings. Can we detect the same state in others? A signature movement is crossing the legs and swinging the raised foot back and forth (see Figure 4.38). People often display this gesture while waiting—for a plane to depart or a meeting to end, for example.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.38 厌倦或不耐烦]*

Another sign of boredom or disinterest is rhythmic tapping of fingers or a pencil on a table. The action may be unconscious or deliberate; either way, the repetitive sound eventually irritates.

Some mental-health professionals suggest that when bored, impatient, or anxious, people recreate a reassuring rhythm they experienced as fetuses—the steady beat of the mother’s heart. By producing repetitive sounds, they nonverbally express a need for comfort.

A colleague nicknamed a labor negotiator “the hammer” because he constantly tapped his fingers on any hard surface within reach. Observing the speed of the tapping revealed the negotiator’s state of mind: rapid tapping with all four fingers signaled boredom with the proceedings; slower, middle-finger tapping indicated he was weighing a final offer; complete cessation, accompanied by a glance at the ceiling and a deep breath, meant he was about to state his conclusion.

Years after the negotiator retired, an opponent revealed that he had “read him like a book” by interpreting these gestures.

When listening to a speaker or watching a presentation, a person who props their head on one hand with drooping eyelids is bored (see Figure 4.39). The posture makes no attempt to conceal disinterest; the open hand supports one side of the face in a visibly unhappy expression.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图4.39 表示厌烦的典型动作]*

A vacant stare is another indicator of boredom. The eyes appear fixed on the speaker yet register nothing. Initially one may assume the person is attentive, but soon it becomes clear the mind has wandered, as if asleep with eyes open. The most definitive sign of total disinterest is a blank, unblinking gaze.

Fidgeting or pained shifting also suggests extreme boredom, though other possibilities must be considered:

1. The person is tired and wants to rest.
2. Lunchtime is approaching or a restroom is needed.
3. The person feels physically unwell.
4. The person is preoccupied with other important matters.

Because multiple explanations exist, additional contextual cues should always be examined.

## Verbal Tics Reveal Personality

Micro-expression keyword: A verbal tic (口头禅) is a habitual phrase that gradually forms and expresses inner feelings and expectations. It carries a distinct imprint of character and offers the most direct window into personality. Understanding someone’s verbal tics allows one to read the person.

Most people in social settings have one or more recurring verbal tics. These habits reflect clear personality traits. Examples include:

- Jay Chou’s tic “diao” conveys “cool,” “great,” “handsome,” or “good,” revealing a desire to appear more masculine and powerful while also expressing insecurity about being a “good boy” and a need for a stronger, more distinctive persona.
- Jolin Tsai’s tic “是哦” (“yes, oh”) shows caution and a slight tendency toward compromise and accommodation.

In everyday life, common verbal tics fall into several categories:

### “To be honest,” “frankly,” “indeed,” “I’m not lying”

These phrases are inserted to preempt doubt. The speaker tends to be impatient, harbors a sense of injustice,

cares about others' opinions, and wants to be trusted.

### **"Maybe," "perhaps," "probably"**

Such speakers are usually diplomatic, strongly self-protective, and reluctant to reveal their full thoughts. They remain composed in social situations and generally maintain good relationships. Many politicians favor these expressions.

### **"I heard," "it is said"**

These phrases create room for retreat. The speaker is typically well-informed and smooth but often lacks decisiveness.

### **"You should," "you must," "it is necessary"**

These speakers possess strong self-confidence and a controlling streak; they expect unconditional compliance. People in leadership positions frequently use them.

### **"Ah," "ya," "um," "well"**

Two types employ these fillers: those who are slow to respond or have limited vocabulary and use them to gather thoughts, and those who are cautious or calculating—often leaders—who pause to project authority and avoid mistakes.

### **"Okay," "right," "that makes sense," "exactly"**

This signals compliance. The speaker is usually polished, even Machiavellian, appearing to agree in order to gain favor or encourage further disclosure, yet ready to turn hostile if interests are threatened and to weaponize the other person's words.

### **"But," "however"**

The speaker seems agreeable yet introduces a counterpoint to defend their own position. They are generally mild-mannered, avoid outright refusal, and speak gently. Public-relations professionals often use this tic.

### **"In addition," "also"**

These speakers think quickly, display curiosity about many things, and enjoy involvement, yet they tend to lose interest after a short time and rarely see projects through. They are forward-thinking and innovative, frequently producing fresh ideas.

### **"Actually," "the thing is"**

These individuals are usually stubborn and somewhat arrogant, holding firmly to their views and resisting persuasion. They also possess a strong need for attention.

Recognizing the information contained in verbal tics shows that even small habits can greatly aid in understanding another person's character.

## **II. Tone**

Tone is also an important link in revealing information. Tone refers to the attitude with which one speaks. Tone carries an individual's emotional coloring; by observing tone, one can discern a person's joy or anger. Different speaking tones produce different effects. For example, the sentence "You are really capable," when said in a cheerful tone, expresses great appreciation for the other person, while said in a flat tone, it indicates limited approval of the other person.

Tone can be divided into the following types, each representing people of different personalities:

### 1. **Tone mild and steady**

People with this speaking tone often possess the demeanor of elders, consider problems deeply, and have strong endurance. Once they set a goal, they advance toward it step by step and never give up until it is achieved; however, they proceed slowly and methodically. Interacting with such individuals may feel somewhat difficult at the outset, but the longer one knows them, the more one senses their loyalty and reliability.

### 2. **Tone solemn and profound**

People whose tone is solemn and profound generally have mature thinking and a strong sense of responsibility; they are trustworthy. Such individuals possess high learning and are skilled at grasping the ways of the world and human nature, yet their straightforward temperament often leaves their talents without outlet. In addition, they have strong self-respect, a touch of aloofness, and a love of competition; they never yield easily.

### 3. **Tone sharp and incisive**

People whose tone is sharp and incisive tend to be aggressive in conversation. Their thinking is distinctive, and they possess keen observational ability, allowing them to penetrate to the essence of matters. Such individuals are often candid and frequently point out others' shortcomings or mistakes without mercy; sometimes they embarrass others by failing to consider the occasion. In their careers, they tend to seek quick success, neglect fundamentals, overlook important matters, and thus fall into difficulties.

### 4. **Tone resolute and strong**

People whose tone is resolute and strong act openly and uprightly, distinguish clearly between right and wrong, and adhere to principles. Such individuals display strong organization and discipline, earn the support of the majority, and are suited to leadership roles. Yet they are inflexible, rather stubborn, and never leave room for discussion, so they may offend some people.

### 5. **Tone blunt**

People whose tone is blunt have strong personalities and relatively unstable emotions. Such individuals possess a strong sense of self and may tend toward authoritarianism; they always hope others will act according to their will.

### 6. **Tone tactful and gentle**

Such people are magnanimous and gentle at heart; their speech is mild as water, unhurried, and measured. They are kind-hearted, cheerful, open-minded, warm and sincere toward others, and possess sympathy and tolerance. Their ability to accept new things is not strong, yet they generally adopt an understanding attitude. In social interactions, they handle people and matters smoothly and rarely offend others.

### 7. **Tone restless**

People whose tone is restless are often irritable and quick to anger. They generally act rashly, lack thorough thinking and patience, pursue results without plans, and are easily swayed by emotion; thus they frequently create imbalances that bring unnecessary trouble upon themselves.

## **Those Who Speak Overly Deferentially Must Harbor Caution**

### Micro-expression Keywords

Our country is one that values etiquette; moderate politeness is an important tool for maintaining good

interpersonal relationships. Excessive deference, however, can also cause dislike.

Xiao Xin was hired by a chain enterprise and assigned to a store as a cashier. On her first day she reported to the store. The manager greeted her warmly. To show respect, Xiao Xin kept bowing to the manager and responded to everything the manager said with "Yes," "All right," or "No problem." The next day at work, her new colleagues pointed and laughed: "That's the one who kept bowing, right? She thinks she's Japanese." The manager, who had been warm the day before, now barely acknowledged her. Feeling insulted, Xiao Xin quit on her second day.

In fact, many people resemble Xiao Xin. When interacting with others, they habitually speak in a humble, deferential manner, always using respectful language and a flattering tone. At first contact the other party may feel embarrassed, yet may not develop dislike. As familiarity grows, however, the other party gradually senses that "this person is actually duplicitous and only outwardly respectful," concludes that the deference is in fact an insult, and becomes deeply annoyed. This explains why the manager's attitude changed.

People who overuse deferential language may have received overly strict upbringing, especially regarding etiquette. Consequently, desires that seem normal to most people are forbidden by their conscience, producing fear and unease; they become guarded toward others. As these desires and guard accumulate, they may one day erupt in powerful aggression. To conceal this, such individuals activate a reactive defense mechanism—growing ever more deferential toward others—creating a vicious cycle.

In other words, people who speak overly deferentially are not necessarily showing respect. On the contrary, they may harbor caution toward you, and their deferential words serve only as a cover. For example, when a woman uses excessive honorifics with a man, she is signaling: "I have no interest in you. You'd best stay away." She simply does not wish to continue the relationship.

Therefore, if an acquaintance suddenly addresses you with honorifics, you should reflect on whether some misunderstanding or barrier has arisen between you.

People who speak overly deferentially generally have poor interpersonal relations. Such deference easily makes others sense your caution and feel displeased. For instance, when a colleague brings you a meal, some people feel they owe a great favor, repeatedly say "Thank you," and promise to return the favor next time. A small matter is turned into a debt of gratitude; even if unintentional, the other person will think, "Does he not want to associate with me?" and feel unhappy, unwilling to continue the relationship.

In reality, with unimportant or very familiar people we have no need to use honorifics. Honorifics signal the closeness or distance of a relationship, status, and power; when used inappropriately or incorrectly, they disrupt the proper relationship. Being more relaxed makes it easier to connect with others.

### **Those Who Are Overly Deferential in Speech May Harbor Caution**

Accurately determine a person's emotional fluctuations. For example, someone normally eloquent may suddenly stammer and be unable to complete a sentence; someone normally taciturn and introverted may suddenly speak fluently and eloquently, leaving others astonished. Upon encountering such a situation, one should heighten vigilance to guard against the unexpected, for a problem has certainly arisen.

Moderate politeness is one method of maintaining good interpersonal relationships. Excessive eagerness, however, and overly deferential speech, is actually a form of rudeness. When the other party is excessively deferential toward you, it often indicates that he harbors caution toward you.

A prerequisite for successful interpersonal interaction is the existence of an appropriate psychological distance between the parties. Language can narrow or widen that distance. To ensure smooth and satisfactory interactions, it is necessary to use appropriately deferential language. Such language must be employed at the right time and in the right setting, and applied in balanced measure; otherwise the result will be counterproductive.

Moderate politeness is one method of maintaining good interpersonal relationships. Excessive eagerness, however, and overly deferential speech, is actually a form of rudeness and easily causes dislike. As the French writer Rabelais said: "The outward forms of courtesy can be fully mastered with only a little knowledge; to display inner moral character, however, requires far more temperament." Thus, those who are always deferential in word and deed may be lacking in temperament.

When interacting with others, such people habitually humble themselves, use deferential language throughout, and lavish praise. At the beginning of contact their deferential attitude merely causes embarrassment rather than dislike. As the relationship deepens, however, this extreme deference provokes anger; such people are judged "duplicitous villains" or "hypocrites who only pretend respect."

When the other party uses excessively deferential language in interaction, the speech appears artificial and creates a sense of hypocrisy. In daily life, when we first meet someone we may use deferential expressions such as "you," "please take care of me," "please," "thank you very much," "excuse me," or "you've worked hard." Such deferential speech precisely indicates that the two parties do not yet know each other well, so they remain distant and speak with extreme caution, fearing to offend. Once further interaction makes the parties familiar, they no longer use such deference and instead communicate directly with everyday language. Thus, through dialogue one can accurately gauge the stage the relationship has reached. For example, a man and woman meeting for the first time often use honorifics; the man appears refined, the woman reserved. Once they have spent time together and confirmed a romantic relationship, they dispense with those honorifics and say whatever comes to mind.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

If the other party is excessively deferential toward you, it often indicates that he harbors caution toward you. What causes this situation?

### 1. A new barrier has arisen between you

Japanese semanticist Kashima Tadao states: "Honorifics signal the closeness or distance of interpersonal relations, status, and power; when used inappropriately or incorrectly, they disrupt the proper relationship." Therefore, when speaking with very familiar people we have no need to use honorifics. If a friend suddenly uses honorifics with you, you should heighten vigilance. Perhaps you should consider whether a new barrier has arisen between you, or whether you have unwittingly offended him without realizing it, causing him to feel distant and to use honorifics to keep you at arm's length.

### 2. Hostility toward you

During conversation, if the other party frequently uses honorifics unconsciously, it indicates a large psychological distance and a relatively distant relationship. If the other party uses honorifics excessively, it signals strong hostility, jealousy, and caution toward you. For example, when a woman uses many honorifics with a man, it does not express respect but hostility; what she actually means is "I have no feelings for you" or "I have no interest in talking with a man like you."

If you have known someone for a long time and understand each other deeply, yet he remains



excessively polite, speaks with great caution, and even overuses honorifics, it is generally because he harbors hostility toward you. People who have grown accustomed to speaking deferentially and treating others with excessive deference often harbor strong aggressive impulses toward others.

### 3. Attempt to control you

When the other party deliberately uses humble and polite language in interaction, he may be attempting to breach your psychological defenses and enter your mind through this manner and attitude. In reality, the psychological motive behind such behavior is to control you and achieve the goal of communicating from a position of superiority.

### 4. Psychological defense

Many people are extremely deferential in both speech and behavior; this may stem from a certain lack of temperament. Perhaps they received strict parental upbringing in childhood, especially regarding etiquette. Consequently, behaviors that seem entirely normal to others appear to them as violations of conscience, producing unease, guilt, and fear. They therefore suppress all impulses, desires, and emotions that their conscience does not permit. Yet they are especially afraid that these impulses, desires, and emotions will accumulate until one day they erupt in powerful aggression. Hence they decide to mask them with deferential language and use this method for psychological defense.

## **Changes in Speaking Speed Can Reveal a Person's Psychological Secrets**

Generally speaking, people who speak quickly tend to be extroverted, eloquent, and full of youthful vitality, giving others a sunny impression. Because of their speed, however, they can also create a sense of tension and pressure, as though something major or urgent has occurred, and may also seem anxious, disorganized, or somewhat rude.

People who speak slowly appear more taciturn than those who speak quickly, giving an impression of honesty, sincerity, thoughtfulness, or unfathomable depth; yet they may also seem indecisive, careless, deliberately mystifying, or even negative and pessimistic.

For the same individual, the situation must be judged differently. When speaking speed is slower than usual, it indicates dissatisfaction or hostility toward someone; conversely, when a person feels guilty or is lying, speaking speed naturally increases. Encountering such a situation, one must be especially careful; a problem has certainly arisen, and close observation is required.

If a man usually returns home on time after work, but one day colleagues keep him late to play poker in the office, upon arriving home he immediately explains to his wife that he worked overtime and, while speaking, curses the excessive workload. Careful listening will reveal that his speaking speed is faster than usual, because this helps relieve his underlying unease.

When harboring affection, unease, or fear, speaking speed also increases, because people generally use rapid speech to express inner affection or to dispel inner unease and fear.

When a person's speaking speed suddenly slows and he falls into thought, it indicates that he has already revealed a secret.

During the Second World War, Japan secretly decided to appoint Tōjō Hideki as prime minister. Reporters from various newspapers tried hard to discover the secret by interviewing ministers who had attended the meeting, but obtained nothing.

One reporter was particularly clever. He studied the ministers' psychological pattern: none would reveal who would become prime minister, yet if the question were posed cleverly, the other party would unconsciously reveal some clue, making it possible to uncover the secret. The reporter therefore asked a minister who had attended the meeting: "Is the person appointed prime minister bald?"

At the time, three candidates existed: one bald, one with a full head of white hair, and one half-bald. The half-bald candidate was Tōjō Hideki. The question appeared to be casual conversation; the minister did not realize it contained a trap. Upon hearing the question, his expression grew hesitant and he did not answer directly. In that instant the clever reporter deduced the final answer and obtained an exclusive story. Because the other party paused, he was certainly thinking: Does "half-bald" count as "bald"?

## **Distinguishing Emotions Through Voice**

A speaker's voice is closely related to his state of mind and emotions; different emotions produce different vocal characteristics. Therefore, with only slight attention to his voice, one can determine his emotions and state of mind.

If you ask someone, "How have you been lately?" the reply may be "Quite well." You usually do not judge his emotions by the words alone but by the pitch and rhythm of his voice when he speaks. For example, if his pitch is low and rhythm slow, it indicates he has not been well lately; conversely, if his pitch is high and rhythm fast, it indicates he has indeed been well.

In daily life, without using our eyes, we can often recognize a person or even guess who he is simply by listening to his voice. The reason is simple: each person's voice is distinctive. Some voices are resonant, some hoarse, some shrill, some heavy, some thin like the sound of metal striking metal, some thick like the sound of a drum.

When facial expressions or body movements fail to reveal the other party's emotions, one can generally begin with the voice and carefully discern emotional changes. It is no exaggeration to say that voice is an important clue for understanding the human heart and seeing through emotional shifts.

The *Yizhoushu* · "Vision and Hearing" chapter also contains discussions on judging a person's inner world through voice: a sincere person is relatively calm, and his voice is clear and rhythmically distinct; a dishonest person, being uneasy, speaks haltingly; a magnanimous and gentle person speaks in a mild, gentle voice, flowing steadily like a gentle stream; a mean and perverse person, harboring ulterior motives, speaks in a strange, grating tone.

When a person encounters joyful events or becomes emotionally excited, volume increases unconsciously. When attempting to persuade others or overpower them with presence, volume also increases unconsciously. The speaker believes that sufficient volume conveys confidence and thereby persuades others. For example, in the workplace, when a leader assigns a task and a subordinate refuses, the leader often says, "No more discussion—do as I say!" At that moment the leader's volume is noticeably louder than usual.

Generally, when a person's mind is clear and open, the voice is bright; when calm, the voice is even; when lacking confidence, the voice is soft; when full of confidence, the voice is resonant; when nervous, the voice trembles. In short, changes in voice precisely reflect changes in emotion.

## **Learning to Hear the "Words Within Words"**

Chinese speech tends to be indirect, avoiding blunt statements, so people often rely on implied meanings to convey their intent. If we fail to catch these “words within words,” it becomes difficult to grasp what the other person truly means.

An old Chinese saying reminds us: “Listen to the tone in speech, and the rhythm in drums.” It urges attention to what lies beneath the surface. In daily life many things cannot be stated outright and must be expressed through implication. For example, when you ask someone “How have you been lately?” and they reply “Fine” in a sarcastic tone, taking the word at face value would be a serious mistake.

“I’m really upset and need to talk about it,” “This job is driving me crazy,” “I need to vent to you”—such direct statements are probably heard most often in therapy rooms. In everyday interactions people play emotional hide-and-seek and speak in implications. Therefore, listening cannot stop at the literal words; one must learn to detect the deeper meaning hidden between the lines.

A small newspaper once visited a prestigious university to recruit editors. A journalism student sailed through the early rounds only to fail at the final interview.

The interviewer asked, “Your school is top-ranked and your major matches the job, yet we’re just a small paper. Don’t you think this would be a waste of your talent?” The student missed the implied question: “Are you planning to use us as a stepping-stone to a bigger publication?” He had no such intention, but because he failed to hear the “words within words,” he lost the opportunity.

“Words within words” appear everywhere. When someone says “It was only a joke,” the implication is often “How could you take that seriously?” When someone says “I’m just telling the truth,” the subtext may be “I’m honest; your inability to accept it shows your narrow-mindedness.” When someone says “What more do you want?” the hidden message is frequently “You’re too demanding and I’m getting tired of you.”

People’s spoken words and their real intentions often diverge. To catch the “words within words,” ask yourself: Why did they phrase it that way? Is there something they hesitated to say outright?

## II. Vocal Tone and Expression

Facial expressions directly reflect inner emotions, and vocal tone and expression serve the same function. Language itself conveys complex feelings; in conversation we also modulate volume, speed, pitch, and melody to make emotions richer, more vivid, and more precise. Vocal tone and expression reveal a person’s cultural level, values, and personality.

By observing differences in vocal tone we can judge emotional state and character. When sad, people usually speak more slowly, in a lower pitch, with limited range—matching the heavy, stiff look on their face. When excited or agitated, the voice rises, becomes sharper, speeds up, and shows wide pitch variation, often with a tremor. Rapid speech with frequent slips is commonly associated with lower status or timidity. A loud but unhurried voice suggests higher status and composure. Stammering or disorganized speech often signals lack of confidence or insincerity. From a gender perspective, a breathy male voice is frequently read as youthful and artistic, while a breathy female voice is perceived as more feminine.

In daily interaction, understanding another person’s mood and intent requires attention not only to content but also to delivery—pitch, variation, rhythm, volume, range, inflection, and speed all betray concealed emotions. This is how one hears the “words within words.”

Verbal exchange reveals inner thoughts and fosters mutual understanding, while vocal tone adds emotional color. From vocal expression we can infer thoughts, feelings, and intentions. Language allows fluent expression of emotion beyond the limits of body language alone; combining vocal and physical cues lets us read people more accurately.

## I. Volume

Volume refers to loudness and is closely tied to personality. People who speak loudly tend to be extroverted, dominant, and inclined to impose their will; they speak clearly so others will understand. People who speak softly are often introverted, suppress their feelings, and rarely reveal their full thoughts unless pressed. Thus volume offers a rough guide to character.

Volume is not fixed; adjusting it improves listener comfort and depends on setting, audience, and the privacy of the content.

At a noisy street-side food stall, a whisper will be drowned out by traffic, chatter, and cooking sounds. In an upscale Western restaurant, loud conversation draws disapproving glances for poor manners.

Volume should also suit the listener: speak softly to children to create closeness; speak louder to older adults who may have hearing loss. Privacy matters too—jokes or harmless topics can be loud, but personal or sensitive matters should be kept quiet and considered carefully before being shared.

Adjusting volume is a matter of upbringing. As Taiwanese writer Liu Yong observed: “The right volume depends on the environment. If you want charm and elegance, first check whether your volume is appropriate. Observe neighbors and friends, then compare yourself. If you realize you have been too loud in every setting, or that stress and fatigue make you speak faster and louder, correct it at once. Change speed first, then practice speaking softly to those nearby and more loudly to those farther away so your volume varies.”

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

“Words within words” take several common forms.

### 1. Compliment form

A remark that sounds like praise may actually conceal criticism. “You really put a lot of thought into this” can become sarcastic when delivered with a particular rhythm and tone.

### 2. Reproach form

Phrases that include qualifiers of quantity often carry reproach: “You’re a bit careless,” “Your conduct falls a little short of normal standards.” The implication is dissatisfaction.

### 3. Warning form

Some implications issue warnings. Stressing “meaning” in “My meaning is...” signals that disagreement is acceptable; stressing “my” signals “Listen, but you have no choice but to agree.”

### 4. Self-mockery form

A friend you once teased about her weight may, upon meeting again, say first, “Have I gotten even fatter?” This preemptive self-mockery blocks further teasing and conveys, “We haven’t seen each other in a while; you’d probably tease me again, so I’ll do it myself.”

## 5. Negation form

This form subtly expresses disapproval. A visitor to a new apartment may say, "For someone so young, having a place like this is already quite good," with emphasis on "like this" and "already." The hidden message is that the apartment is mediocre but the owner is still young enough to buy something better.

## Detecting Insincere Irony

Both saying the opposite of what one means and meaning the opposite of what one says fall under irony. The *Guiguzi* advises: "Those skilled at reverse listening change like spirits and gods to learn the truth... To hear the sound, first be silent; to expand, first contract; to rise, first descend; to take, first give." In practice this means observing reactions by speaking in opposites.

People long to be understood yet often hide their true wishes and say the reverse: claiming to be satisfied when they are not, or claiming indifference when they actually desire something. During the Spring Festival parents may telephone and say, "If work is busy, don't come home," while hoping their children will return. If the children stay away, the parents feel deeply disappointed.

Irony is common among close relations, especially couples. A wife may say "You're so annoying" when she means affection, or "Get lost!" when she means "Come here." On an anniversary, a wife may scold her husband for buying flowers—"You're so impractical!"—yet feel pleased. Failing to recognize the reversed meaning makes one seem insensitive; misreading it leads to unnecessary arguments.

## Following the Voice into the Heart

A beautiful voice is an important aspect of human aesthetics. Sweet, rounded, or deep and resonant voices leave pleasant impressions. Many public figures have worked to improve their voices to gain favor.

Generally, loud speakers fall into two types: those whose roughness conceals refinement and who are trustworthy, and those who are impulsive and hot-tempered. Both tend to be frank and outgoing. Soft speakers are often introverted, sensitive, suspicious, and lacking courage; they vent through gossip.

Slow speakers are steady, good at concealing emotion, thorough, and persistent once committed. Fast speakers are quick-thinking, responsive, and expressive, though their haste can cause interruptions and trouble.

People who speak sparingly may seem impolite, yet their few words are usually sincere and reliable; they finish tasks quietly and can be trusted.

A normally loud person who suddenly lowers their voice is probably not gossiping—such people criticize openly—but may be reacting to a superior's arrival. A normally soft speaker who suddenly raises volume may be trying to escape feeling ignored. Someone whose voice remains clear though not loud is usually deliberate and mentally stable, suited for important work.

A normally slow speaker who suddenly accelerates is likely agitated, making agreement difficult. The reverse—sudden slowing—suggests distraction or discomfort.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

The voice carries strong emotional coloring; its strength, speed, pitch, and clarity reveal complex feelings. As the *Lingshan Miyè* states: "Observe the breath and tone to gauge bearing; note the timbre to distinguish quality; listen to the force to assess power; examine the emotion to infer intent." Volume (breath and tone) reveals bearing; duration and force reveal strength.

Joy, anger, sorrow, and pleasure surface in the voice even when suppressed. Listening therefore reveals inner states and emotional shifts.

### 1. **Sharp and severe speakers**

They enjoy debate, seize verbal openings, and counterattack relentlessly. Their insight is keen, yet their focus on weaknesses can cause them to miss the bigger picture and descend into pointless argument.

### 2. **Grave and profound speakers**

Their words are measured and insightful; they understand human affairs accurately and act conscientiously. They dislike discord and manipulation. In complex environments they are often overlooked and find it hard to advance.

### 3. **Resolute and steadfast speakers**

They uphold principles, distinguish right from wrong, and earn respect for fairness. They judge others without personal bias, yet their rigidity can appear unfeeling.

## III. **Extremely Slow Speakers**

Extremely slow speakers frustrate listeners with their tortoise-like pace. Their temperament is likewise unhurried, sometimes timid or introverted. Their strengths are attentive listening and honesty; their weaknesses are lack of confidence and an impression of dullness or poor social skills.

No universal standard defines ideal speed; norms vary by occasion and profession. CCTV news anchors average about 300 characters per minute, debaters 450–520, poetry reciters 70–90, and ordinary Mandarin speakers roughly 240.

Abnormal speed can hinder communication and employment, yet speed can be trained. Appropriate pacing, pauses, and intonation improve clarity and appeal. Practice by reading articles aloud, following television news subtitles, or recording and reviewing one's own speech.

Most people speak at medium speed, so excessive worry is unnecessary. Speed offers clues to personality but does not fully reflect inner cultivation. Fast speakers may lack focus; slow speakers may be coherent and substantive. Regardless of natural speed, one must first enrich one's knowledge; only then will speech be orderly and earn respect.

Speed is not fixed; it shifts with psychological state. Emotionally healthy, expressive people vary their pace according to circumstances, and such shifts are interpretable.

## **Anxiety**

You might guess that the most obvious and accurate way to express anxiety is not through body movements. Indeed, the truly reliable and easily recognizable carrier of an anxious state is the voice.

A person clearing their throat before speaking or midway through a sentence indicates unease or anxiety. In fact, when someone must speak in front of a group, a tense feeling arises in the throat, followed by mucus

that prevents sound from emerging. Therefore, the throat must be cleared before speaking to restore normal voice.

Sometimes, people unaccustomed to public speaking repeatedly clear their throats during a speech, with accompanying changes in pitch and tone, all signaling anxiety or tension. When children feel anxious, they typically do not clear their throats but instead stammer “uh” or habitually say “you know.”

We suggest that the next time you feel the urge to clear your throat before speaking, consider whether it stems from actual throat discomfort or from an unconscious anxious reaction.

Restlessness is often a sign of tension. During witness questioning, skilled defense attorneys pay close attention to questions that make the witness restless. They will repeatedly probe such questions to elicit clear answers.

A person slowly rubbing their hands on clothing or a handkerchief nonverbally signals anxiety, frustration, anger, tension, or doubt. In such cases, the palms are usually sweaty.

Generally, the above phenomenon occurs when people engage in stressful activities. We see these “sweaty palms” in witnesses testifying in court, first-time public speakers, or athletes at the starting line of a competition.

### **How Topics Reveal Inner Thoughts**

I once surveyed 200 managers, more than 80 percent of whom attributed their success primarily to superior communication skills. Choosing the right topic is a prerequisite for smooth communication; in other words, in interpersonal interactions, finding the correct topic means you have already won half the battle.

Yet everyone’s interests differ, making it seem complicated to lock onto a topic. With someone you have just met, begin with neutral subjects such as the weather or work. As the conversation deepens, the other person will gradually disclose more information. Effectively integrating these fragments helps guide the topic in a direction favorable to you.

If the other person voluntarily raises personal topics, it indicates they are in a happy state. On this point, I once conducted a survey with 80 women. I divided them into two groups: one watched a comedy film, the other a tragedy. I then observed what they first discussed with friends or family afterward. The results showed that women whose mood improved after watching the comedy mostly talked about private matters such as money, health, or sex. Thus, when a person is happy, they tend not to put up defenses. If you seize the moment, success is near.

In addition, avoid two types of topics that can lead to failure:

- Subjects you yourself find uninteresting—how can you engage the other person if you lack interest?
- Subjects you only partially understand—if you speak vaguely or incorrectly, you will leave an impression of superficiality.

### **How to Read Others’ Inner Worlds from Their Speech Patterns**

When conversational partners hold differing views, each may rebut the other to assert their own position, and people rebut in different ways. How, then, can we understand someone’s psychology from their style of rebuttal?

If the other person does not bother with tact and directly retorts “You’re wrong,” it shows they are self-centered, attach great importance to their own opinions, and will offend others rather than yield.

If the other person speaks tactfully, first expresses agreement, then states their own view with a rebuttal such as “That’s right, but...,” it indicates they are kindhearted and considerate. This approach is steady and sincere, far gentler and more indirect than a blunt “You’re wrong.”

If the other person rebuts with “So...” or “In that case, why...,” the implication is “We’ve already reached this point—why are you still not getting it?” Such rebuttals carry an undertone of blame. Rather than confident, this person is arrogant and headstrong, always believing their own mind works best.

In short, a person’s thoughts often surface unconsciously through their manner of speaking, and their emotions are likewise reflected in it. Therefore, careful observation will allow us to see through others’ inner worlds via their speech patterns.

### **People Who Like to Say “Right”**

People who frequently say “right” lack strong self-awareness and generally maintain good interpersonal relationships, yet the phrase is not their genuine sentiment; it is merely a way of accommodating others while privately calculating their own interests.

In addition, those who repeatedly use “indeed” tend to be self-righteous and strongly self-centered; those who often say “actually” have a strong desire for self-expression and are somewhat conceited; those who habitually use “this...” “that...” “um...” are cautious, avoid trouble, and are generally agreeable; those who frequently say “in the end...” usually harbor unfulfilled desires; those who often say “exactly” are mostly shallow and ignorant yet self-important; those who repeatedly say “really” tend to lack confidence; those who frequently use “you should...” “you can’t...” “you must...” are authoritarian, stubborn, and domineering, with a strong desire to lead; those who often say “my personal thought is...” “isn’t it...” “couldn’t we...” are amiable, non-dictatorial, respectful of others, and in turn respected and liked; those who frequently use “I want...” “I think...” “I don’t know...” are mostly simple-minded, act on impulse, and have unstable emotions.

## **Chapter 5 The Mystery of Speaking Styles**

Observing others’ speaking style, wording, speed, and accompanying gestures reveals their true inner thoughts. A pleasing speaking style easily earns favorable impressions, whereas poor speaking habits readily create negative ones.

From a physics perspective, the human voice is produced when airflow vibrates the vocal cords, which in turn vibrate the air. Pitch and volume are determined by the tension of the vocal cords and the amount of exhaled air. Voice is also closely linked to psychological activity. Hence different people have different voices and different speaking styles—this is the foundation for identifying character through voice.

Observing others’ speaking style, wording, speed, and accompanying gestures reveals their true inner thoughts. A pleasing speaking style easily earns favorable impressions, whereas poor speaking habits readily create negative ones. As the renowned Taiwanese success expert Lin Daoan said, “A person fails to speak well because they do not know what the other party wants to hear. If you can read the other person’s psychological activity like a scout, you will understand how powerful speech can be.”



As the saying goes, "One remark reveals the whole truth." Which aspects, then, indicate whether your speech is good or bad? This chapter will uncover the answers one by one.

## 2. Ways of Answering Questions

Often we are still enthusiastically talking while the other person has already disengaged. If we fail to notice and keep chattering, communication becomes ineffective. How, during a conversation, can we tell whether the other person is still willing to engage?

In a conversation, if you are doing most of the talking, pay attention to whether the other person is absorbed or merely hoping you will finish soon and fearing that any response will encourage further monologue. People usually respond actively only when they find the conversation interesting. The more responses your words elicit, the more it shows the other person enjoys talking with you. If you notice the other person suddenly become silent and stare blankly, it indicates they no longer wish to continue.

Sometimes, even when uninterested, people will ask simple, polite questions out of courtesy—"What time did you go?" "It was fun there, right?"—yet if genuinely interested they tend to ask more complex questions such as "What did you mean by ×× earlier?" "Could you explain exactly what happened?" or "How did you feel at the time?" This shows they are following your train of thought and are engaged with the topic.

## 5. A Sweet and Sticky Tone

This is a feminine tone that makes the speaker seem like a hothouse flower.

Women with a slightly nasal, sticky tone usually crave public affection. Yet such people are often restless; their excessive desire to please can instead annoy others. Men with this tone are usually only children raised under excessive protection. They feel especially lonely when alone and become bewildered when forced to make independent judgments. They are very reserved toward women; in one-on-one conversations they often appear tense and will never take the initiative.

Humans have two kinds of expressions: one on the face, the other in the manner of speaking. Speed, volume, and tone of speech contain rich secondary information. Removing the surface veil reveals a person's true inner thoughts. Speech can be said to be the outward manifestation of character and intellect. Therefore, before words leave the mouth, if you wish to avoid leaving a bad impression, carefully consider how to phrase each sentence appropriately and comfortably.

## Psychology Mini-Class

Everyone has a different temperament, and different speaking styles reflect different temperaments. Below are several speaking styles and the temperaments they reveal.

### 1. Gentle-speaking people

Gentle speakers have soft personalities, dislike competition, and rarely offend others, yet they are weak-willed, lack confidence, and are timid. They often adopt an avoidant attitude toward people and situations.

### 2. Even-paced speakers

Even-paced speakers have elegant temperaments and treat others generously and kindly, but they react slowly, lack decisiveness, and tend to be conservative in thought.

### 3. Righteous and stern speakers

Righteous and stern speakers possess an indomitable spirit, act fairly and impartially, distinguish right from wrong, hold firm positions, and exhibit strong principles. However, they are inflexible and can seem stubborn.

### 4. People who pepper speech with trendy words

Such people readily accept new things and feel compelled to use newly learned buzzwords. Yet they lack independent judgment and tend to be weak.

Sarcasm takes two forms: saying the opposite of what is meant, or saying what is meant in an opposite tone.

For example, during a quarrel a husband asks, "How have I treated you all these years?" The wife angrily replies, "Great, really great—how could it be so great?" Here the wife is using sarcasm.

One point to note: judge whether a remark is sarcastic by the speaker's tone. The same sentence can mean the exact opposite depending on tone. For instance, "How could you be so sensible?" might mean "You're really not sensible" or "You're truly so sensible."

## Reading the Other Person's Mind from Intonation

Within speaking style, intonation itself is an important factor. Friendliness or hostility, calmness or agitation, sincerity or falseness, modesty or arrogance, sympathy or mockery—all can be conveyed through intonation.

Generally, a gentle tone indicates frankness and friendliness; a trembling tone indicates agitation; a low tone indicates sympathy; any statement delivered in a sarcastic tone appears mocking and insincere.

When facial expressions, gestures, and words fail to reveal another person's state of mind, we can still infer their character from the rhythm of their speech.

Confident people speak in an affirmative rhythm; those lacking confidence or with weak personalities speak in an uncertain rhythm; dishonest people hem and haw—an outward sign of a guilty conscience; calm people speak calmly; kind and gentle people speak like a gentle stream—smooth, soft, and highly approachable; restless people talk endlessly; people whose minds are clear and orderly speak clearly and evenly.

### 3. A Husky Tone

People with this tone expand their influence through personal strength, take the lead in guiding others within organizations, and possess the fighting spirit to bounce back from setbacks; many become politicians, writers, or commentators.

Women with a husky tone usually have strong personalities; even if they appear delicate outwardly, they possess inner resilience. They have refined tastes in clothing and art and often possess musical or painting talent. They are courteous yet do not easily reveal their true feelings, giving an elusive impression. Generally, they have poorer relationships with other women and are prone to disagreements or exclusion, yet they are popular with men. When dealing with such women, avoid forcing your own views, or they will become resistant. Men with a husky tone are usually highly enduring and action-oriented; they charge forward even when others hesitate. Their shortcoming is a tendency toward self-importance, which can appear arrogant, and they may be careless about seemingly minor matters.

## 9.2.2 Helpless Sigh

[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图9-12 捂脸]

Failure reactions also appear in uncontrolled exhalation—commonly known as sighing. When expressing helplessness, a person uses a long exhalation to lower internal body pressure; it is also the nervous system's attempt to reduce blood carbon dioxide levels and shift from a suppressed state to an excited one, although people themselves are unaware of this process. It may be accompanied by a restorative gesture of covering the entire face while wiping, as shown in Figure 9-12. Such sighs generally express helpless assessment and feeling; if expressed verbally, they appear as refusal to abandon or accept, such as "I can't believe it," "Oh my God!," "How could this happen?!", or "No way," "Impossible." Beyond surface disbelief and non-acceptance, the essence is helplessness together with regret and self-blame.

## 1. Topic Preferences

A person's inner world often reveals itself unconsciously through the topics they discuss. Therefore, to understand someone's character, thoughts, or emotions, start with the topics they habitually raise.

If their topics center on themselves or family, it indicates strong self-awareness and a tendency to be self-centered. For example, some middle-aged women frequently talk about their children and dislike sudden topic shifts while doing so. In such cases, simply listen and hand the conversational floor to them.

Some young men like to discuss cars, often mentioning brands, specifications, appearance, and prices in front of others; this likely signals their future purchasing ability or shows off their extensive car knowledge. In such situations, listen attentively, occasionally ask questions about cars to satisfy their vanity, and avoid showing annoyance or impatience.

## Why Do Women Love to Speak Ironically?

Why not just say what you mean? There is a common psychological motive: concealing inner shyness. For instance, when a man asks, "Do you miss me?" a woman replies, "No!" Some women worry, "If I say I miss you, you'll look down on me," while others simply feel too embarrassed to say it.

People speak ironically for four reasons:

1. To protect themselves, not wanting others to see through their thoughts and expose their inner world completely.
2. To spare others worry, out of kindness, yet this often becomes the chief culprit that hinders communication and creates unnecessary misunderstandings.
3. To project an image of magnanimity—harboring resentment yet appearing friendly and tolerant on the surface.
4. To satirize others, highlighting absurdity through contrast to achieve a strong ironic effect.

## 7.2.5 Voice

Voice frequency is moderate and consistent with the individual's normal baseline—neither excessively high (because high volume requires extra excitatory energy to intensify vocal-cord vibration) nor weak and listless. Speaking rate also matches the person's habit; it may be slow but is unlikely to be fast, since rapid speech corresponds to rapid thinking and high-speed vocal-system movement, demanding high excitement and consuming considerable energy. Specific frequency varies by individual, so the tested person's baseline must first be established for accurate comparison.

The states described above reflect a relaxed condition on one's own territory with no concerns, indicating normality—neither negative emotion nor anything particularly joyful or exciting. For each different tested person, record their behavioral and nervous-system relaxation baselines according to the above framework; this is extremely important for later observing changes and analyzing micro-reactions.

### **Distinguishing the Other Party's True Intentions from Polite Remarks**

Micro-expression keywords

Chinese people are adept at using polite remarks; this is a form of etiquette and one of our common ways of dealing with the world. Although polite remarks should not be taken literally, one must listen carefully to discern the other party's true intentions in order to act appropriately.

In the skit *The Honest Man*, Guo Donglin plays an "honest man" who, unable to distinguish polite remarks, fails to grasp the host's real intentions and puts the host in an awkward position. In real life, such people are also common. Chinese people value face and are skilled at using polite remarks in conversation. For example, the greeting "Have you eaten?" is not a genuine invitation to a meal but a conventional polite remark. Many foreigners fail to understand this and create numerous awkward situations.

Therefore, we must learn to discern the other party's true intentions from polite remarks in order to behave appropriately and graciously.

Generally speaking, people use polite remarks in roughly the following categories:

### **5. Sudden Slowing of Speech Rate**

If a person who normally speaks quickly suddenly slows down, one of the following four situations may be the cause:

- A shortcoming or weakness has been touched upon by the other party; lack of confidence or timidity has caused the speech rate to slow.
- Something is being concealed from the other party, so the speaker can only stall, reflecting a guilty state of mind.
- The speaker may also hope that the slower pace will draw attention and make listeners more convinced; this is a debate tactic of "blunting the opponent's edge and boosting one's own confidence."
- The fourth situation occurs when reading beautiful, lyrical prose or poetry, or when recalling a pleasant memory; the relaxed pace simply expresses the speaker's appreciation of beauty.

Speech rate and its changes can reflect a person's psychological state. Much information can be gleaned from a person's speech rate, so do not underestimate the role of speech rate in conversation!

### **Section 1 Information Revealed in Speech Rate**

Human language is a complex system combining sound and meaning. Speaking, unlike an animal's instinctive roar, serves to exchange ideas and simultaneously reveals psychological and emotional states. Among these, speech rate subtly reflects the speaker's psychological condition.

Everyone has a fixed personal speech rate: some speak slowly, some quickly, and some at a moderate pace. Generally, fast speakers tend to be extroverted and youthful, yet they can also convey tension or urgency. Slow, deliberate speakers are often seen as sluggish, reacting half a beat behind others. At the same time,

changes in speech rate reflect the speaker's current psychological state. Speech rate is related to gender, personality, experience, age, and occupation. Based on long-formed personality traits, we can analyze different speech rates and the "secrets" behind changes in pace.

### 8.2.1 Sparse and Monotonous Language

Because most blood is directed to the limbs for fighting, the energy available to the cerebral cortex (responsible for higher functions) decreases. Consequently, an angry person is more likely to lose rationality, with only one thought in mind—defeating the opponent—while judgment of the surroundings and situation declines. The same cause also weakens another higher function besides thinking: language.

Angry people often say little or nothing at all; their mouths are usually tightly closed. If fighting begins, any words spoken will be as simple and meaningless as possible—"Charge!" "Kill!"—or profanity (which explains why swearing is common in fights), because these utterances require no thought.

In a verbal confrontation such as a debate, language itself tends to be rapid and forceful.

### Polite Remarks Spoken Excessively May Indicate a Request

In social interactions, if someone has a request, their speech will certainly contain many polite remarks.

A "guest" arrived at Director Qian's home—Xiao Jin from the same company, carrying several expensive gifts. Director Qian asked what the matter was. Xiao Jin replied, "Nothing special. It's the holidays, so coming to see the leader is only proper. The leader is usually very busy and works so hard. There are so many big and small matters in the company that require attention." Director Qian was not so naïve and said, "I'm not a big leader; I'm not as busy as you say. Are you about to be made permanent?" Caught out, Xiao Jin nodded sheepishly and admitted he wanted Director Qian's help.

When someone's polite remarks seem excessive and insincere, it indicates they have a request. Do not rush to respond; wait patiently until they state their purpose.

### Language Style Reflects Personal Cultivation

Language is the key that opens the door to communication and the most important tool in social interaction. Besides appearance, speaking style is an important indicator of a person's cultivation. As the saying goes, "Words are the voice of the heart"; a person's language style is the best certificate of their cultivation.

Language is an art. In social dealings we often judge whether another's speech suits our taste. The main impetus for deciding whether to continue associating with someone is the most direct feeling their language produces in us.

In interacting with others, we tend to focus on whether their speech brings us pleasure and overlook observing their inner activity and character through their words. Only by deeply understanding a person's character and inner needs can we cater to their preferences and gain the initiative in interpersonal relations.

### 1. High, Sharp Tone

People with a high, sharp tone are generally neurotic, react strongly to their environment, possess creativity and imagination, have an aesthetic sense, refuse to admit defeat, dislike yielding to others, speak fluently, and

enjoy imposing their views. When encountering such a person, it is best not to contradict them; showing a modest attitude will satisfy them.

Women with a high tone usually have fluctuating emotions, are easily hurt or enraged by trifles, and display clear likes and dislikes. Once fixated on something, they often neglect everything else and may make statements that completely contradict the past without learning from the experience. Men with this tone are usually passionate, easily excited yet easily fatigued, and prone to falling in love at first sight or blurting out their feelings, often startling the other person.

### **Recognizing the Other Party's Humorous Motives**

Shakespeare said, "Humor and wit are flashes of wisdom." A person with a strong sense of humor can not only bring joy through wit, self-mockery, teasing, and playfulness but also help eliminate hostility, ease friction, prevent escalation of conflict, and allow you to achieve twice the result with half the effort on the road to success.

In fact, everyone possesses a stronger or weaker sense of humor, yet the ways of expressing it differ. Canadian psychology professor Rod Martin notes, "In social life, men and women also differ in their use of humor. Men prefer to use 'malicious' jokes to criticize one another and establish 'superior' status, while women use humor to maintain relationships and put each other at ease."

When a person displays their sense of humor, their character is revealed.

### **The Psychology of Greetings**

Greetings are a means of connecting emotionally, enhancing spiritual communication, and reducing distance. Whether between acquaintances or strangers, greetings are extremely common.

During my acting career I met far more people each day than I do now. Sometimes I would shake hands, sometimes simply wave and say "Hi," and sometimes merely nod. Receiving a friendly response always made me happy. Of course, I also encountered rebuffs. When leaving, I never forgot to say goodbye. After more than twenty years of experience, I can responsibly tell you that a person's character and mood can be read from the simple act of greeting. When you greet others, you generally encounter the following types of people:

#### **Those Who Pad Their Answers**

Such people possess life experience and know how to protect themselves wisely and safeguard their interests. They never speak first; they wait until the end, then repackage others' already-stated views into something that sounds more incisive. In personality, they are mostly timid, even-tempered, and averse to argument. They prefer the status quo and lack the courage to change. They are harmless yet also lack significant ability.

In short, the more one tries to hide or cover what lies in the heart, the more it is exposed. Personality, for example, is revealed the moment one begins to answer, whether after careful deliberation or without thinking.

### **Chapter 9 Countless Threads Hidden in the Heart, Every Movement Reveals the Truth**

Micro-expression keywords

A person's normal speech rate falls between 300 and 500 characters per minute. Different people have slightly

different rates. What affects speech rate? Psychologists have found through research that the speed of speech is closely related to a person's inner state. Changes in speech rate also reveal inner changes.

Body language is a subconscious action and the least deceptive, so it often betrays a person's true thoughts. By reading body language, you can easily decode information that lies beyond the words, understand others, grasp their subtle emotions, and more clearly perceive their real meaning, thereby making communication smoother and allowing you to control the situation at will.

#### **4. Rough, Deep Tone**

People who produce a rough, deep tone—whether male or female—tend to be generous, philanthropic, and fond of leadership. They like to be active and dislike staying at home; with age they may become stout, as the saying goes, "a broad mind makes a plump body." Both men and women of this type have wide circles of friends and can associate with all kinds of people.

Women with this tone enjoy good relations among their own sex, easily gain others' trust, become the person everyone consults, and act as a "big sister." Men with this tone often pursue careers in politics or business, possess a strong sense of justice and mission, yet are emotionally fragile and prone to regret after quarrels or excessive actions; they also tend to purchase high-priced goods without hesitation.

#### **4. Sudden Acceleration of Speech Rate**

If a person's speech rate suddenly quickens, one of the following three situations may be the cause:

- They have probably done something wrong and are trying to mask inner unease or fear; the content of their speech is therefore often inaccurate and should not be taken too seriously. Such people are not very seasoned and are easily caught out; those deeply experienced in the world do not exhibit this behavior.
- The other party may have said something unfavorable to them, prompting them to accelerate their speech to express dissatisfaction and urgency.
- Another possibility is that they are reading a passionate battle manifesto or delivering an impassioned speech; the faster rate expresses strong inner emotion.

#### **People Who Speak Rudely**

Such people usually lack education and cultivation, speak without tact, and easily offend others. They have a poor understanding of themselves and others and do not know how to speak appropriately. They are forthright and direct. Regardless of outward maturity, they actually lack good verbal cultivation. They are also careless and forgetful in their actions. They usually have no great ambitions and seek only modest comfort.

In social interactions, do not focus solely on the psychological effect of others' words; pay more attention to understanding their character and inner world through their language style so that you can gain the initiative and advantage.

#### **Husky Voice**

Women with a husky voice are usually very individualistic. Although they may appear delicate, their character is strong. They are courteous to everyone yet find it hard to reveal their true feelings, making them difficult to read. They may disagree with members of their own sex or even be ostracized by them, yet they are popular

with the opposite sex. They have excellent taste in clothing. When encountering this type of woman, never try to force your own views on her.

Men with a husky voice usually possess great endurance and initiative; even when others hesitate, they push forward. They tend to be self-opinionated and careless about matters they consider unimportant.

### **Situation-Forced Type**

One day, A went to B's home as a guest and arrived just as B's family was eating. B politely invited him: "Have you eaten? If not, have some with us." A had not eaten dinner, so he accepted without ceremony. The hostess, however, looked awkward because the noodles she had prepared were insufficient for another person.

A clearly failed to understand B's true meaning. B had merely asked out of politeness and had no real intention of inviting him to eat. If B had truly wanted to invite him, he would have stood up to fetch bowls and chopsticks instead of merely moving his mouth. As the saying goes, "Listen to what is said and observe what is done." When someone invites you, first watch what they do, or embarrassment may result.

### **Polite Remarks Still Need to Be Said**

"Not everyone possesses the magnanimity to rejoice when told of their faults." In real life, some people repeatedly claim they dislike polite remarks and prefer the truth. Yet if you truly act on that claim, they will certainly be displeased. Everyone likes to hear pleasant words and dislikes criticism. Polite remarks sound agreeable; even if exaggerated, the listener pays no mind and feels happy. If you omit them, others will find you difficult to get along with and gradually distance themselves.

Therefore, to maintain good social relations, one must say a moderate number of polite remarks. At the same time, one must discern the true intentions behind others' polite remarks, cater to their preferences, and thereby win their favor.

### **1. Fast Speakers**

Fast speakers articulate as if firing a machine gun, finishing an entire thought in one breath with no room for interruption. Such people are generally extroverted, quick-thinking, eloquent, and adaptable. They are natural and generous toward others and see no need to hide anything, sometimes even recounting their own embarrassing moments without regard for image. They excel at socializing, handle interpersonal relations with ease, and achieve their goals effortlessly. Their strengths are lack of guile, inability to conceal anything, straightforwardness, and naturalness; their weaknesses are emotional volatility, impatience, decisiveness that borders on arbitrariness, and a tendency to act alone.

### **3. Degree of Politeness**

You may have noticed that the degree of politeness reveals changes in a person's mood. Someone who speaks very politely feels favorably toward you and hopes to become your friend quickly; they are also straightforward and candid. If the two of you have already met many times yet the speaker remains equally polite, it indicates they wish only to maintain a working relationship or ordinary friendship. There are exceptions: some people, because of excessive vigilance, habitually keep themselves closed off or lack the ability to communicate deeply, and therefore remain polite. Such people are not truly being polite; they use politeness to keep distance.



## 2. Gentle, Steady Tone

People with a gentle, steady tone are compassionate and helpful; they will not ignore those in difficulty, yet they act in a deliberate, unhurried manner. As conversation partners they may seem difficult at first, but they prove loyal and reliable.

Women with this tone are usually introverted; they control their emotions according to circumstances yet also long to express their views, so one should give them ample opportunity to do so. Men with a gentle, steady tone may sound honest at first, but they are actually rather stubborn; they hold firm to their opinions, rarely compromise, neither flatter others nor are easily influenced by others' views.

### Soft, Clinging Voice

Women whose speech carries a nasal, clinging quality are often vain and eager to be liked. Sometimes their excessive efforts to please backfire and cause annoyance. For children from single-parent families, this vocal quality indicates an inner desire for gentle treatment from elders.

Men who produce this sound are mostly only children or were pampered while growing up. They often feel lonely when alone and become confused or at a loss when required to make decisions. Toward women they are very reserved; when speaking with a woman alone, they appear especially nervous.

### The Most Insincere Greeting—"How Are You?"

When they ask "How are you?" they are not genuinely concerned; they merely want to draw attention to themselves. Such people like to stand out, are full of self-confidence, yet frequently fall into deep thought. Before acting they like to deliberate repeatedly, then commit fully once they begin, with a determination not to stop until the goal is reached.

Everyone we meet has their own habitual greeting. The moment they open their mouth, their personality is exposed. In other words, we can judge a person's character traits from their everyday greetings and thereby interact with them effectively.

## 2. Moderate-Paced Speakers

People who speak at a moderate pace generally speak slowly but not so slowly as to cause impatience; they use a relaxed, gentle manner. A moderate pace is a relatively balanced speech rate. Such people are mostly gentle and kind, generous and benevolent, compassionate, and considerate. Their strengths are meticulous thinking, good planning ability, respect for others' opinions while retaining their own distinctive views, and avoidance of blind conformity. Their weaknesses are conservative thinking, lack of mental agility, hesitation in action, insufficient self-confidence, lower acceptance of new things, and in extreme cases outright rejection, making success difficult.

## III. Tone

Tone refers to the pitch of the voice. Tone also leaves an impression on others, because when facial expressions, movements, and words fail to reveal a person's state of mind, one can often infer the other party's character and shifts in emotions such as joy, anger, sorrow, or pleasure from their tone. Generally speaking, if the other party begins speaking slowly and in a high pitch but suddenly speeds up and lowers the

tone when the core issue arises, there is a high probability of deception in their words. This is because a liar feels somewhat guilty, hoping to deceive the other party yet lacking full confidence.

Tones fall into various types, each reflecting different personality traits:

### **Seeing Through the Other Person's Psychology from Their Way of Speaking**

Everyone has a unique conversational style, and each style is in fact an expression of emotion. Preferences for topics, the manner of answering questions, the degree of politeness, and the way of refuting questions all reveal one's psychology.

When we communicate with others, we hope the conversation flows pleasantly and creates a sense of instant rapport. Yet the conversation does not always proceed as smoothly as we wish; various unexpected changes often arise. Therefore, we must learn to see through the other person's psychology from their conversational style, promptly detect emotions in their words that hinder the exchange, and then resolve them.

### **Section 2: Careful, Your Voice Reveals Your Secrets**

The *Lüshi Chunqiu* states: "Hear the voice and know the demeanor; observe the demeanor and know the aspirations; examine the aspirations and know the virtue." This means that listening to someone speak reveals their bearing, observing their bearing clarifies their interests, and understanding their interests discloses their moral character. Through the voice one can "hear the sound, know the person, and recognize the heart," gaining a general sense of an individual's character or moral quality. Clearly, the voice readily exposes a person's secrets.

What aspects of the voice convey information? Primarily volume, tone, and pitch.

### **People Who Like to Discuss Matters in the Office**

The office is a single-purpose venue where no one else will interrupt or affect the content and atmosphere of the conversation. Choosing this location indicates that such people generally approach others and situations with sincerity and are trustworthy. Moreover, they are confident in their work and regard it as the center of life; if they suddenly stop working one day, they become irritable and insecure. Generally, these individuals are highly responsible and conscientious, especially when handling matters entrusted by friends—they will spare no effort to complete them well. Consequently, they enjoy good popularity and earn the respect and trust of friends.

### **Acquaintances Exchanging Polite Remarks**

Generally, when we are very familiar with someone, we do not exchange many polite remarks, as doing so would seem distant. If a very familiar person suddenly becomes overly courteous, it may indicate dissatisfaction and a deliberate attempt to distance themselves. At such times, one should reflect on one's own words and actions or any impropriety that offended the other party and repair the relationship promptly. In the case of romantic partners, it is quite possible that the other person has done something wrong and feels guilty, hence offering many polite remarks to please you; we should then pay attention or find ways to uncover the truth.

### **The Habit of Answering Questions Reveals Character Secrets**

**Micro-expression keywords** The process of conversing with others is interactive and always involves questions and answers. The way one answers questions can inadvertently reveal character secrets. Therefore, discerning personality from the other person's answers and adjusting one's speaking style in time can enhance communication effectiveness.

When conversing, we inevitably ask others questions or answer their questions. From the habit of answering, one can discern a person's character secrets. Generally, answers fall into the following personality types:

### **People Who Like to Discuss Matters in Open Spaces**

For example, squares or rooftops—places where one need not worry about eavesdroppers causing trouble. Such people are broad-minded, optimistic, and straightforward, yet they also have a timid side. Most are men. They harbor grand ambitions, pursue long-term goals, and act steadily. At the same time, they are skilled at concealing their true feelings; once someone enters their inner world, they cherish that person greatly.

With this understanding, if someone invites you to discuss matters at a particular location, you can first learn about their character and approach to life and prepare accordingly.

### **The Most Common Greeting — Hello!**

This is the word used most frequently and in the widest range of situations when meeting others. Whether addressing a stranger or an old friend, whether in public or in the office, greeting with "Hello!" is always the safest choice.

People accustomed to this greeting tend to have calm minds, control their emotions well, and dislike making a fuss. Whatever they do, they are diligent and meticulous, earning the trust of colleagues and friends. They treat others honestly, say what they mean, rarely engage in direct conflict, and enjoy good popularity.

### **People Who Speak in a Pedantic Manner**

This type of person usually has a strong educational background and likes to use ornate language, introducing large amounts of irrelevant information during conversation. In life they affect an elegant style; outwardly confident, they are inwardly insecure. They also enjoy showing off their knowledge. As the saying goes, what a person flaunts is precisely what they lack. Outwardly well-mannered, such individuals actually lack self-assurance and therefore assume an air of superiority in conversation. They are empty inside—an ornamental facade.

### **People Who Like to Expose Others' Privacy**

When four or five people gather, the conversation often revolves around someone's private matters. Some expose others' privacy; naturally, others listen. This is an interesting subject. I have studied the psychology of such people and found that they enjoy revealing others' secrets either out of hostility, envy, inferiority, or jealousy. When with them, one must be very cautious, because if they disclose someone else's privacy to you, they will just as readily disclose yours to others.

### **The Choice of Venue for Discussions Reflects One's Approach to Life**

Daily social interactions require a venue—restaurants, bars, offices, homes, and so on. The choice of location when discussing matters reveals a person's approach to life. Whether they are smooth or rigid, honest or

cunning, can be discerned to some degree.

When people need to discuss something, some invite others to a restaurant for a meal, others choose the office, and still others prefer a bar. Different venues highlight different approaches to life.

### **One's Personality Can Be Seen from Greeting Words**

Micro-expression keywords Greeting others upon meeting is common courtesy, and everyone has their own greeting style and habitual phrases. These are closely tied to personality. In other words, we can read a person's character from the way they greet and thereby pave the way for future interactions.

Personality traits manifest in the small details of daily life. Greeting is the most ordinary daily occurrence. What character does each greeting style reveal? Let us examine them together.

#### **People Who Like to Say "Absolutely"**

Psychological research shows that people who frequently use the word "absolutely" tend to be subjective, self-centered, and inclined toward self-love. They also employ "absolutely" as a defensive excuse or shield when proven wrong—for example, "I will absolutely never do it again" or "I will absolutely never act that way again." Such assurances initially inspire trust, but over time they make the speaker appear inconsistent in word and deed.

#### **(III) People Who Deliberately Step Back and Maintain a Certain Distance from You**

Greeting is meant to foster closeness, so encountering such people can feel uncomfortable. At first I assumed they were inwardly closed off and socially inept, but after several encounters I discovered they actually maintain fixed social circles; once that familiar circle is breached, they experience panic and rejection. Understanding this, you know what to do: when interacting with them, keep a certain distance so they feel safe.

#### **People Who Show an Expression of Disbelief**

Some people react to praise with great surprise as a way of reciprocating the compliment. These individuals are undoubtedly endearing; they are honest and simple, often suffering losses while helping others. They enjoy group activities and treat others generously, thus maintaining good interpersonal networks and remaining popular in both life and work. Because they are overly generous toward others, they sometimes endure grievances and may even implicate family or friends.

#### **Glib-Tongued People**

This type is calculating and shrewd. They have usually seen a bit of the world and are driven by self-interest. They are generous toward themselves yet extremely stingy toward others. Their character is unstable; they are smooth and worldly-wise, thoroughly versed in the rules of social interaction. Such people are hypocritical and adept at concealing their true thoughts. One may associate with them but should not become close.

#### **People Who Seem to Know Everything**

Some individuals possess broad knowledge, understand a little about many subjects, cite widely, and appear profound. Yet their minds are cluttered with unsystematic information; when facing a difficult problem they

often miss the point. They may offer several suggestions, none of which hits the mark. If they consciously strengthen their analytical ability and grasp the essence of matters, they may well become well-rounded talents.

### **High-Pitched and Sharp Voices**

Women with high-pitched, sharp voices tend to have fluctuating emotions, clear likes and dislikes, and may easily contradict their past statements without realizing it. Such people are also prone to sentimentality or sudden anger over minor matters.

Men with high-pitched, sharp voices are fervent by nature, easily excited yet also easily fatigued. A characteristic of these individuals is that they master the art of success by leveraging their personality at a young age.

### **Those Who Pretend to Understand When Answering Questions**

These people are face-conscious and highly vain. They dread being mocked for ignorance, so they pretend to understand. They are also stubborn, unwilling to accept others' opinions, and will argue heatedly with anyone who disagrees, refusing to yield until the other party concedes. If they are in the right, they press their advantage relentlessly. Consequently, within groups they are generally kept at a respectful distance.

### **Fullness**

Whether the other person's voice is rich or thin, firm and powerful or light and gentle, serves as an important reference for judging their personality. Generally, a full, varied voice is perceived as strong and trustworthy.

In short, the voice contains many subtle elements. Grasping their micro-changes allows us to understand others while consciously imitating and adjusting to establish consistency.

### **Those Who Avoid the Real Issue When Answering Questions**

These people are smooth operators who seek advantage and avoid harm. Generally, when faced with unfavorable situations they try to muddle through. They also employ unorthodox methods, letting others do the work while they reap the benefits. In addition, they are timid, unwilling to take responsibility, and quick to shift blame for fear of becoming involved in any trouble. They are poor at seizing opportunities; even good ones slip away while they hesitate.

### **(I) People Who Look Directly at the Other Person**

Such individuals possess strong self-awareness. In conversation their words are often probing and aggressive. Becoming close friends with them requires time and effort, because they are inwardly guarded. My approach with them is to respond with a gentle gaze and relaxed tone. You must neither be intimidated by their stare nor confront it directly, or the conversation will stall.

### **People Who Like to Discuss Matters in a Tea Art Gallery**

Tea art galleries offer a degree of privacy and allow one to conceal one's true identity—underground agents in television dramas, for example, often meet there. Such people are extremely cautious in their dealings, handle

everything carefully, and rarely reveal their intentions. They usually present a relaxed façade to extract information or gain trust from others. They belong to the highly calculating type.

### **Those Who Are Flashy but Substance-Lacking When Answering Questions**

These individuals are eloquent and articulate. When answering questions they speak volubly and at length. At first hearing they give the impression of being knowledgeable and expressive. Upon closer scrutiny, however, their answers sound impressive yet miss the point entirely. Such people tend to be seasoned, hypocritical, and cunning. When dealing with them, be careful not to be deceived by their fine words.

### **People Who Like to Discuss Matters at Home**

Choosing home indicates familiarity with the environment and no concern that unexpected people or sounds will disturb the conversation. This suggests that such individuals are relatively weak-willed, timid, and poorly adapted to the outside world. In work and life they often suppress themselves, conceal their emotions, and keep joy or anger from showing. Consequently they frequently feel pressure without knowing how to release it, becoming increasingly exhausted.

### **People Who Like to Discuss Matters in Restaurants**

Restaurants are public places filled with people and chatter. Choosing such a venue first indicates that these individuals are bold and unafraid of their privacy being overheard; second, they are ambitious and confident that they can avoid or solve any problem. Moreover, they are exceptionally intelligent and can devise various methods to handle sudden difficulties.

## **(II) People Who Often Go Off-Topic**

These individuals have an intense desire for control and self-expression.

Conversing with them often leaves one confused, because they constantly digress, shift topics, and speak at length. If you cannot endure their pace, here are two simple, effective tactics:

1. Deliberately drop an object to interrupt them
2. Immediately leave the scene—that is, disappear from their sight

### **People with Intense Speech**

These individuals possess rich knowledge, speak sharply and rapidly, and offer profound, original insights into human affairs, often hitting the mark directly. They adapt quickly to new things and react swiftly, yet they feel at a loss when confronted with matters beyond their ability. Once they seize an opponent's weakness they launch a fierce counterattack, sometimes becoming so obsessive that they trap themselves in a dead end.

### **The Shyest Greeting Method — Hi!**

Such people are shy and sentimental. They act with extreme caution, fearing criticism for mistakes, and therefore dare not undertake innovative or pioneering endeavors. In social interactions they are usually taciturn and unwilling to go out with friends, preferring to stay home with their partner. However, with familiar people they display warmth and enthusiasm, deliberately trying to please.

## **Calm and Composed People**

These individuals are courteous and steady. They express gratitude appropriately to those who praise them. They maintain independent principles, advance steadily toward their goals, excel at keeping a low profile, avoid ostentation and arrogance, and work pragmatically and single-mindedly. If you have such a subordinate, pay close attention—they may well bring you substantial returns and become your right-hand person.

## **Those Who Pretend to Be Erudite When Answering Questions**

These people possess some talent and are not entirely ignorant of various subjects, yet they know only the surface and speak in generalities. In personality they are somewhat clever yet rely on that cleverness and refuse to study diligently. Their interests are broad, but lacking perseverance they cannot master any subject deeply. At work they lack a sense of responsibility, cannot handle specific tasks competently, and certainly cannot lead.

## **Those Who Parrot When Answering Questions**

These individuals lack independent views or original thought. When required to answer a question they merely repeat others' words without offering their own opinions. They are vain, appropriate others' theories for display without citing sources, and possess strong imitative ability—anything they hear or see they can basically reproduce. Employers can certainly make use of this trait for their own purposes.

## **Chapter 8: Hearing the Voice, Distinguishing the Person, Knowing the Heart**

A person's words are the simplest and most direct way to convey inner thoughts. Different psychological reactions often manifest through different words and expressions. Language and micro-expressions are closely linked, and micro-language is a true reflection of one's inner world. Therefore, through a person's voice we can discern their character and then infer their thoughts.

## **People Who Praise Each Other**

Those who immediately return a compliment with a corresponding remark generally possess independent personalities. They dislike relying on others and are full of self-confidence. In interactions they place great value on equality, so you need not worry about suffering losses nor expect to gain advantages from them. Such people carry presence in the workplace and enjoy challenges.

### **1. Slow Down Your Speech Rate and Adjust Your Mood**

When angry, try regulating your breathing until it becomes even and silently remind yourself: "Stay relaxed; you must remain calm." If your emotions are still agitated, close your eyes, think of things that make you happy, and attempt to view yourself from the other person's perspective. This will naturally calm you down.

## **People Who Like to Discuss Matters in Bars or Clubs**

Choosing such venues satisfies many of the other party's desires while providing a legitimate pretext. It also elevates their status, expands their influence, and aids goal achievement. In reality, these individuals are often fame-seekers who act ostentatiously and love to show off. They pursue success yet frequently fail because of some personal desire.

## **People Who Like to Use Humor to Mock Others**

Most of them have a narrow mind and strong jealousy. They sometimes even do things that go against their conscience or kick someone when they are down. In addition, they have a strong sense of inferiority, a negative attitude toward life, and often negate what they themselves have done. Being picky and sarcastic toward others is their specialty. They spend all day plotting how to scheme against others, yet they themselves have never truly been happy.

## **Identifying People by Their Voices, Delving into Their Hearts Through Sound**

The strength, speed, pitch, and clarity of a voice can also reveal a person's complex inner emotions. Not only can voices help us observe and understand people, but even the instruments they play can reflect the player's psychological state.

The following sections explain how to discern a person's character and psychology from their voice.

### **People Who Speak Quickly and Directly**

This type of person usually has a forthright character, acts with integrity, and possesses a very open heart. Their inner thoughts align closely with their words and actions. They tend to trust their own feelings, say whatever is on their mind, and keep nothing hidden. Because of their direct and candid nature, they cannot keep secrets about their own affairs or those of others. As a result, their moods shift rapidly and they show little persistence in what they do.

### **People Who Nod or Shake Their Head Repeatedly**

People who nod repeatedly during conversation appear to understand and agree with the other person's views, yet they tend to act rashly. Often they make promises they cannot keep, leaving others with a poor impression. What about those who shake their head repeatedly? Clearly they are arrogant and self-willed; winning their approval is extremely difficult.

### **People Who Stare at the Other Person**

This type of person has a strong desire for control and will seize any opportunity to display themselves. They do as they please, dislike being constrained, yet possess enough intelligence and presence to accomplish tasks others cannot. Once they set a goal, they pursue it relentlessly. Their unrestrained personality, however, sometimes leads to misunderstandings.

### **How a Person Accepts Praise**

Praise affirms achievement and is something most people desire as an external response. Receiving praise often brings inner satisfaction and pleasure.

Dangerous situations test courage, the ability to handle trivial matters reveals patience, and the manner in which a person accepts praise likewise reflects their true character and emotions.

### **Self-Control**



From childhood, parents and teachers teach us to restrain ourselves. “Be patient” is one of the phrases we hear most often. We also use similar words to overcome depression, anxiety, and other emotions, the most important of which is suppressing anger. As we grow older, we gradually learn to mask our feelings and regulate our behavior through various postures.

### **The Most Enthusiastic Greeting Style—“I’m so glad to see you!”**

This type of person is outgoing, warm, and modest. They enjoy participating in all kinds of activities and easily blend into new groups. They are helpful; when friends need assistance, they never stand idly by, regardless of whether they can actually help, and thus win good relationships. Their drawbacks are a tendency to fantasize, a lack of rationality, and being easily swayed by their own emotions.

### **People Who Like to Say “Whatever”**

When ordering in a restaurant and asking what the other person wants to eat, one often hears the word “whatever.” If the two people meet only occasionally, this may be politeness. For someone already familiar who still frequently says “whatever,” the person is usually easygoing but also indicates a lack of personal opinion in daily life.

### **People Who Like to Be Different**

This type can be divided into two kinds. One kind is highly curious, dares to say “no” to authority, and possesses a spirit of challenge and exploration; however, they can be extreme and lack calm thinking. The other kind habitually uses language to cover up inferiority, showing off literary flair and spouting new theories that sound impressive but are merely rehashing old ideas.

### **Catchphrases Reveal a Person’s True Nature**

In daily life, many people unconsciously use certain words or phrases repeatedly while speaking; these are called “catchphrases.” As the saying goes, “habit becomes second nature,” and to some extent these linguistic habits best reflect the speaker’s real psychology and personality. The following sections introduce some of the most common catchphrases.

### **Taciturn People**

Most people of this type are either overly self-conscious or excessively calculating. They usually do not want to reveal their inner thoughts, so others cannot know the real them. They have a strong sense of self-protection and can often focus on their own careers. They show good persistence, can persevere, and maintain a stable character without major fluctuations.

### **People Who Like to Create Prank-like Humor**

Most are lively, outgoing, warm, and generous. They live relatively lightly; even under pressure they find ways to relieve it. They dislike restraint, are rather mischievous, and enjoy joking with others. In the process they entertain themselves and also hope to share that joy with others.

### **The Most Gossipy Greeting Style—“Any fresh news?”**

This type of person usually has an extremely strong curiosity and wants to get to the bottom of everything. Some even pry into others' private affairs and gossip behind their backs, which makes them unpopular. At the same time, they are keen on material comforts and pursue them relentlessly. Their advantage is that they plan thoroughly before acting and proceed in an orderly manner.

### **A Rough, Deep Voice**

People whose voices are rough and deep—whether male or female—enjoy doing good deeds and hope to be leaders. They are active types who dislike staying quietly at home. Both men and women with this voice have wide circles of friends and can associate with all kinds of people. Women with such a voice tend to have good relationships and are trusted by others.

### **Subtle Changes in Voice**

Voice is a powerful tool for building rapport. Skilled salespeople, negotiators, and speakers know how to adjust their voices to align with others and gain favor. Therefore, you must first identify the other person's vocal characteristics before you can move closer to matching them.

### **Reading Minds Through Speaking Gestures**

A person with full use of their limbs can hardly speak without accompanying gestures. Some gestures are habitual; others are made to emphasize tone or content. Whether intentional or not, these movements allow us to glimpse certain "psychological codes."

### **Volume**

Voice carries power, and the strength of that power reflects a person's inner traits. For example, if the other person speaks softly while you prefer to speak loudly, reaching agreement will be difficult. Likewise, to gain the approval of loud-voiced people, you should raise your own volume.

### **People Who Use Humor to Break an Impasse**

They possess strong adaptability. Most have a strong desire to perform and hope their actions receive attention and recognition. Their outstanding performance may make them the center of attention, which satisfies their need for self-expression.

### **The Most Straightforward Greeting Style—"Hey!"**

People who open with this greeting are relatively frank and direct. They are energetic, lively, and cheerful. They tend to be optimistic and open-minded when facing difficulties. They also think quickly, possess a sense of humor, are flexible in dealing with others, and can accept opposing opinions.

### **People Who Become Shy When Praised**

Some people blush the moment they receive praise and appear bashful. They are generally fragile and sensitive; criticism hurts them, let alone sudden setbacks. Yet they are compassionate and do not use words to hurt or attack others.

### **(7) People Who Strongly Deny**

They are modest and dislike being disturbed, so they spend much time maintaining their independent space. Humor and boldness are only their outward appearance; in reality they deliberately close themselves off, making it difficult to form deep friendships with others.

### **Abnormal Voice and Tone**

A liar's voice may unconsciously rise because they are trying to conceal inner unease. Therefore, if the other person's voice suddenly rises during a conversation, it is time to be on guard.

### **People Who Like to Say "I'm only telling you"**

"I'm only telling you," yet in fact they tell everyone. Most people have this habit. Those who frequently say "I'm only telling you" are rather ridiculous and display immaturity; such people are not suited to keeping secrets.

### **People Skilled at Self-deprecating Humor**

They have a broad mind, readily accept others' opinions and suggestions, and often engage in self-reflection and self-criticism, seeking out and correcting their own mistakes. They enjoy good interpersonal relationships.

### **People Who Like to Spread Rumors**

This type is a typical prankster. They talk nonsense and delight in stirring up trouble, yet their intentions are not truly malicious. Their purpose is simply to attract attention and satisfy their vanity.

## **Chapter 4: The Profound Meaning in Words—Deciphering the Mysteries Behind What Is Said**

"A fool who keeps silent leaves even a sage at a loss." Once the other person opens their mouth, it becomes easy to grasp their character traits, perceive their inner activities, understand their knowledge and cultivation, and judge their living conditions.

### **(3) People Who Speak with Flattery and Artful Words**

Some people frequently use sweet talk and flattery to achieve their goals or gain business advantages. Soft-hearted individuals often fall into their traps, so one must remain vigilant.

### **(6) Absent-minded People**

They are mentally agile, exceptionally intelligent, and talented. They are both realistic and decisive, do not pursue fame and fortune excessively, and do not care overly about others' praise. Self-confidence and boldness are their most obvious character traits.

### **Seeing Through an Opponent via Conversation Style**

A person's conversation style largely reflects their true nature. Therefore, mastering the connection between conversation style and personality makes it easy to see through someone's inner thoughts.

### **People Who Constantly Touch or Scratch Their Hair**

Most of this type are thoughtful, highly motivated, and detest evil. They belong to the active group. When they touch or scratch their hair, they are usually thinking and observing.

### **(5) Unmoved People**

They are conscientious and low-key at work, disliking attention because they feel it would distract them. They are not competitive and let things take their natural course.

### **People Who Like to Say “I”**

People who frequently say “I” possess a childlike or feminine character and a strong desire for self-display. Those who often use the plural form are usually lacking in individuality, submerged in the collective, and inclined to echo others.

### **Both Speed and Tone Reveal the Heart**

A person’s emotions and opinions are clearly expressed in their words. With careful attention, even the meanings between the lines gradually become apparent beneath the curtain of speech.

### **People Who Like to Say “I know”**

When the other person repeatedly says “I know” during conversation, it means they no longer wish to listen. At that point it is best to end the conversation or change the topic.

### **The Most Direct Greeting Style—“Come here!”**

This type of person tends to act decisively, enjoys taking risks, and can learn from failures. They are also willing to share their feelings and experiences with others and like to express themselves.

### **(1) People Who Stick Strictly to the Matter at Hand**

This type usually has clear goals, acts decisively, and behaves with integrity, though they sometimes give an impression of rigidity. A large portion of them experience interpersonal difficulties.

### **(2) People Who Do Not Look at the Other Person**

This type often lacks self-confidence. Even before meeting, they have already anticipated every possible difficulty, so deep down they are unwilling to interact with strangers.

### **People Who Prepare Humorous Remarks in Advance to Show Their Sense of Humor**

Most prefer formal things and place great importance on how others view them. Their attitude toward life is serious and restrained.

### **A Gentle, Steady Voice**

This type of person is generous and kind-hearted, yet not quick or decisive in response. They belong to the careful, long-considering type and prefer to uphold tradition and hold conservative views.

## **People Who Like to Say "So"**

The most striking trait of people who frequently say "so" is their tendency to regard themselves as clever and self-righteous.

## **(4) People Who Do Not Respond**

Such people are undoubtedly arrogant; they believe your greeting is an attempt to curry favor and therefore refuse to acknowledge you.

## **People Who Like to Say "I can't..."**

On the surface this type appears modest, but in reality they are quite incompetent.

See Legs and feet (c-legs).

See Types of smiles (c-smile-types).

See Types of smiles (c-smile-types).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Tone and pitch (s-tone-pitch).

See Speech rate (s-speech-rate).

See Speech rate (s-speech-rate).

See Speech rate (s-speech-rate).

See Speech rate (s-speech-rate).

## **Speaking Speed**

### **Speaking Speed Reveals Inner Changes**

Speaking speed can reflect a person's emotions while speaking. Therefore, by listening to someone's speaking speed, we can determine their emotional state.

When people speak, they are engaging in an exchange of ideas as well as a natural expression of their psychology and emotions. Many people know only that the content of speech directly conveys the speaker's

thoughts, yet they overlook how other factors can also reveal the speaker's psychology and emotions. For example, the pace of a speaker's delivery directly indicates their personality and psychological state.

### 1. **Extremely Fast Speaking Speed**

If someone speaks at an extremely fast pace, like a machine gun firing without pause, the listener can easily miss important information if they are not careful. This indicates that the speaker has an extroverted personality, strong self-awareness, and likes to control the conversation, dominating the exchange. The speaker's rapid pace stems from keen interest in the topic and eagerness to express themselves, along with concern about omitting thoughts that have just occurred to them. In addition, when the speaker has something to hide, intends to lie, or feels inner tension, their speaking speed will involuntarily quicken in an attempt to conceal their true thoughts.

### 2. **Extremely Slow Speaking Speed**

If someone speaks at an extremely slow pace and stammers, it suggests a weak, introverted personality marked by low self-esteem and reluctance to interact with others. People who speak very slowly are often mild-mannered, though they may sometimes be sensitive and prone to depressive moods. However, slow speech does not always indicate weakness, introversion, or low self-esteem; it can also reflect a calm, steady personality. Such individuals think while speaking, maintain stable emotions, avoid impulsiveness, and remain composed in any situation.

### 3. **A Normally Fast Speaker Suddenly Slows Down**

If someone who usually speaks quickly suddenly slows their pace, it shows they consider what they are about to say very important and want others to hear and remember it clearly. For instance, when a leader reaches a key point during a meeting, they will instinctively slow down so subordinates can follow without missing the main points. Yet a sudden slowdown by a fast speaker is not always meant to draw attention; it can also serve to convey emotion and resonate with listeners. During a speech, for example, the speaker may deliberately slow down to express certain feelings. In addition, when a speaker feels sad or distressed, their mood grows heavy and their normally rapid pace slows. If someone who is usually eloquent suddenly becomes slow and hesitant, the reason is obvious: they are hiding something or have done something wrong, leaving them lacking in confidence, nervous, and uneasy.

### 4. **A Normally Slow Speaker Suddenly Speeds Up**

If someone who usually speaks slowly suddenly accelerates, they may be trying to mask inner unease. For example, when a lie is exposed, the person often rushes to explain, becoming incoherent and using an extremely fast pace to conceal their discomfort. A sudden acceleration by a slow speaker can also result from emotional agitation; excitement, anger, fear, impatience, anxiety, or tension can all cause an abrupt increase in speed.

## **Psychology Mini-Class**

Security Bureau psychological experts note that a person's speaking speed and tone can reveal their inner world. This is why we can sense whether the other party is in a good mood during a phone call even without seeing them.

When Security Bureau agents interview a subject, two or three officers typically participate: one converses with the subject, another observes body language, and a third focuses on the subject's speaking speed and tone. This arrangement underscores how closely changes in tone, speed, and pitch relate to the inner world. Indeed,

solving cases through speaking speed has become a secret technique that helps Security Bureau agents accelerate investigations.

Security Bureau psychological experts have found through research that speaking speed is the primary feature for analyzing how a person speaks. Fast speakers are often eloquent, while slow speakers tend to be more taciturn. In psychology, however, the key is to understand the other person's psychology by noting deviations from their usual manner of speaking.

Security Bureau agents solve cases through speaking speed not because they possess supernatural powers or mind-reading abilities, but because speaking speed directly reflects psychological state and emotional fluctuations, allowing insight into a person's thoughts.

In daily life, we can also accurately grasp a person's rich psychological changes by observing shifts in their speaking speed and pitch, and even, based on these external changes, acc

### **Speaking Speed Suddenly Slows**

When a person feels weighed down—for instance, when sad or confused—their speaking speed also becomes very slow. During news broadcasts, whenever a disaster or the death of an important figure is reported, the announcer deliberately slows down; the principle is the same.

In addition, when people harbor dissatisfaction or hostility toward someone, their speaking speed slows and may even take on a somewhat wooden quality. Although they try not to display their discontent or hostility, the more they attempt to conceal it, the more obvious it becomes.

In short, speaking speed can subtly reflect a person's psychological state while speaking. Paying close attention to others' speaking speed and its variations ensures that their subtle inner activities will not escape your notice.

### **People Who Speak Slowly**

Such individuals are generally unhurried by nature. They not only speak at a measured pace but also remain calm even when facing urgent matters. They are kind-hearted, generous, compassionate, and considerate of others. Women of this type tend to be gentle. Generally, these people maintain inner calm, think carefully and methodically, enjoy planning, listen to others' opinions, and yet retain their own distinctive views. Because they are approachable and speak tactfully, they enjoy good interpersonal relationships. Their drawbacks include conservative thinking, resistance to new ideas, rigid adherence to principles, slightly slow thinking, hesitation in action, and lack of decisiveness.

### **People Who Speak Quickly**

These individuals speak like a string of firecrackers—rapidly and without allowing others to interrupt. They are generally intelligent, think quickly, and possess strong adaptability, which contributes to their fast speech. Most are extroverted, articulate, and skilled at tailoring their words to the listener. They excel in social settings, win others' favor, and readily achieve their goals. Their shortcomings include an inability to keep matters to themselves, occasionally revealing things better left unsaid. They also tend to be short-tempered, easily angered by minor issues, and prone to arbitrary decisions that may lead them to act willfully.

### **Different Speaking Speeds Reflect Different Inner States**

When people speak, they exchange ideas and simultaneously reveal their emotions. Variations in speaking speed indicate different inner conditions. For example, if someone who is normally eloquent suddenly stammers, or if someone who is usually taciturn suddenly becomes talkative, there must be a reason: their psychology has undergone a fundamental shift. Therefore, carefully observing a person's speaking speed and its changes allows one to grasp their psychological state.

### **Speaking Speed Suddenly Accelerates**

Research indicates that people suddenly speed up when they are nervous, angry, excited, impatient, or fearful. They hope rapid speech will relieve their inner agitation. Because they have not thought calmly, however, the content of their speech often becomes empty. Anyone who is cautious and perceptive can immediately detect their wavering inner state.

### **Speaking Speed**

If your speaking speed is too fast, the other person's thinking may not keep up, impeding communication. If it is too slow, the listener may grow bored and wish to end the conversation early. Therefore, maintaining a pace the other person can accept is very important; the simplest method is to mirror their speaking speed.

### **People Who Speak Extremely Slowly**

These individuals speak very slowly, often hesitating and rambling. They have overly weak, introverted personalities, lack confidence, appear dull, and act sluggishly.

### **Pitch and Intonation**

#### **Changes in Speaking Voice Can Reflect Inner Changes**

Micro-expression keywords: Generally speaking, a person's voice remains steady while speaking. However, when special circumstances arise and subtle inner changes occur, the voice will shift accordingly. Therefore, variations in a person's voice not only reveal emotional shifts but also expose inner activity.

During the Spring and Autumn period, Zichan, prime minister of the state of Zheng, once went out on an inspection tour. He saw a woman weeping at a grave and ordered her arrest. His attendants were puzzled. Zichan explained, "Although her crying is loud, there is no grief in it—only fear. There must be something false here." Later interrogation confirmed that the woman had been having an affair and had plotted to murder her husband.

From a person's voice one can discern not only emotion but also inner changes.

### **Speaking in a very loud voice**

Such people are straightforward and open, treat others sincerely, and speak directly without beating around the bush. They often offend others unintentionally. Although they recognize this trait, they will never change their manner of speaking. In addition, they are upright in character, act openly and honorably, and command respect. They also possess good organizational skills and a strong sense of responsibility, earning others' trust. They are therefore well suited to leadership roles.

### **Speaking in a very soft voice**

Such people lack confidence and breadth of mind. They often quarrel with others over trivial matters. They are



usually deep and calculating, skilled at scheming, and determined to succeed at any cost—even by unscrupulous means. In dealing with others they are snobbish and never reveal genuine feelings. Consequently, although they may achieve career success, they have few close friends.

### **Voice suddenly rising from low to high**

Three psychological reasons generally account for this:

1. Strong emotional agitation. When stimulated, a person loses emotional control and the voice rises involuntarily. For example, someone who suddenly wins a prize will excitedly shout “I won!” to share the joy; likewise, during an argument with a loved one, anger is hard to suppress and the voice grows louder.
2. Attempting to persuade the other party. In a debate, when a speaker becomes excited, the words are almost shouted in order to make the listener accept the opinion. In moments of urgency, people subconsciously hope the volume will intimidate the other side; raising the voice also boosts the speaker’s own confidence.
3. Wishing to dominate or command the other party. This is common when parents address children, teachers address students, or superiors address subordinates. Raising the voice reinforces authority and elicits obedience.

### **Voice suddenly falling from high to low**

Two reasons explain this:

- One is running out of arguments and losing confidence. When confident, a person speaks with full volume; when sensing a weak position, the voice gradually drops. For instance, a child who has erred may still argue while being scolded by a parent, yet the voice grows softer as the questioning continues.
- The other is inner fear and unease. When confidence gives way to anxiety, the voice also descends. For example, an employee reporting to a silent boss may worry that something was done poorly and will speak more and more softly.

Voice changes are thus inseparable from the speaker’s current psychological state. Differences in volume, weight, pace, and length correspond to differences in inner activity. The saying “hear the voice, know the person” captures this principle.

### **Speaking Tone Can Also Reveal Personality**

Micro-expression keywords: Voice does express character. When facial expressions, gestures, or words fail to reveal a person’s mindset, try reading tone to gauge personality and emotion.

In daily life some people speak softly and gently, others heavily and authoritatively, and still others in a high, clear tone. As the saying goes, “Listen to the tone when hearing words; water the roots when watering a tree.” Different tones reflect different personalities. No one forgets the character Little Swallow played by Zhao Wei in the television drama *My Fair Princess*; wherever she goes, her loud voice is audible, perfectly matching her carefree and impulsive nature.

### **People Whose Voices Are High and Sharp**

Such individuals tend to be neurotic, sensitive to their surroundings, creative and imaginative, and possessed of excellent aesthetic sense. They are also assertive: in social interactions they point out others’ faults without mercy, regardless of embarrassment caused. As a result they are often disliked. At the same time they possess

strong insight and original thinking, quickly identifying the essence of any issue. When this trait is fully utilized, success comes more readily.

### **People Whose Voices Are Soft and Gentle**

Such people are usually mild-tempered, indifferent to fame and fortune, and rarely become entangled in conflicts of interest. They get along easily with others and maintain good relations. From another angle, they are timid and avoid involvement in disputes, adopting an evasive stance. With guidance and encouragement, however, they can enter competition, display their talents fully, and become balanced individuals capable of both firmness and flexibility—people destined for significant achievement.

### **People Whose Tone Is Mild and Steady**

Such individuals often display an elder's composure. They consider matters thoroughly, act methodically and unhurriedly, and possess strong endurance; once a goal is set, they persevere steadily. Men of this type can be somewhat stubborn, holding to their own views and neither swayed by others nor inclined to flatter. They may be difficult at first but prove loyal and reliable. Women of this type are compassionate, understanding, and willing to make sacrifices for others.

### **People Whose Voices Are Affectingly Sweet**

Such people speak in a coquettish manner in hopes of winning affection and protection. Yet they are restless and prone to fabricating lies, which ultimately repels others. When male, they are often only children raised with excessive indulgence. Such men tend to be indecisive, uncertain when judging situations. Toward women they are very reserved: one-on-one conversations make them extremely nervous, and they never take the initiative.

### **Intonation**

Does the other person maintain a single intonation throughout? When finished speaking, do they use a falling or rising tone? These are points to observe. Some people show little intonation change, making their true intent hard to discern; others vary intonation richly, rendering their words easier to understand. Judge character from intonation, then adjust your own tone to accommodate the other person.

### **Pitch**

Cultural influences on behavior lead us to use pitch to emphasize gender. Generally, when seeking attention, men tend to produce a muffled, low sound from the throat while women produce a sharp, light sound. At such moments, pause or lower your voice to show respect.

### **People Whose Tone Is Strong and Resolute**

Such individuals are open-minded, distinguish right from wrong clearly, act honorably, uphold principles, and maintain strong organizational discipline. However, they lack flexibility, can be rigid, and rarely allow room for discussion, which may offend some. Because they remain impartial and realistic, they gain the support of most people.

### **People Whose Tone Is Tactful and Mild**

Such people are broad-minded, cheerful, generous, benevolent, sincere, and possessed of sympathy and tolerance. In social dealings they navigate situations skillfully and rarely incur blame. They are not quick to accept new things yet do not oppose them, generally maintaining an understanding attitude.

See Voice and speech (c-voice).

See Voice and speech (c-voice).

See Voice and speech (c-voice).

See Voice and speech (c-voice).

See Voice and speech (c-voice).

## Part Eight: Applications

### People Who Put Others First Can Be Trusted in Interactions

**Micro-expression Keywords** Living in society, everyone needs to interact with others. In this process, people who put others first are welcomed everywhere. Because, when with such a person, there is no need to worry about being betrayed or suffering losses in interests. When in difficulty, they will extend a helping hand. Such people are few, but if you meet one, be sure to make friends with them.

If a person can always put others first and consider others in every situation, then we can interact with such a person with confidence. When with them, we need not worry about being deceived or harmed, because in the face of interests or danger, they think of others first rather than themselves.

"Never benefit oneself at the expense of others, but always benefit others at the expense of oneself" is a noble sentiment, yet many find it hard to practice. It cannot be denied that some people in life follow the philosophy of "sweep the snow from one's own doorstep and ignore the frost on others' roofs." Some even pursue personal gain at all costs, disregarding morality and law, and commit acts that harm others for their own benefit. In their view, their own interests come first. With such people, you may never know when you will become their scapegoat. Only those who put others first will think of others rather than themselves.

I once watched a television variety show in which the host asked the guests on stage: "When we ride an elevator, there is often a large mirror inside. What is that mirror for?"

The guests below began offering answers one after another:

- "It is used to check one's appearance."
- "It is used to expand visual space and create a sense of airiness."
- "It makes the elevator look clean and bright."

The guests gave many answers, none of them correct. After repeated prompts still failed to elicit the right answer, the host finally revealed a very simple reason: "It is so that people with limb disabilities in wheelchairs do not have to turn around to see the floor indicator lights."

Once the answer was given, the guests looked embarrassed. One complained, "How could we have thought of that?"

Only a selfish person considers only their own interests, because in their eyes there is only themselves and no one else. Interacting with such a person means that when danger arrives they will abandon you, and when

interests are at stake they will isolate you or even frame you.

In life, when facing a problem, if someone considers only their own gains and losses while ignoring others, that person is not worth getting to know. How many people live only for themselves? Their selfish nature prevents them from offering even the slightest convenience to others, let alone sacrificing any of their own interests. Others will certainly be unwilling to offer them any convenience in return.

A father once asked his son to hand him a pen. The son passed the pen over, but accidentally placed the tip in his father's hand.

The father said to his son: "When you hand something to someone, you must first consider whether it will be convenient for them to receive it. By handing over the tip, they would have to turn it around; if there is no cap, they might get ink on their hand. This is especially true for knives and scissors—never point the blade or tip toward someone."

This is an ordinary example Mr. Ye Shengtao used to teach his children to think of others.

A kind person can always put themselves in others' shoes, feel compassion when seeing others in distress, sympathize with them, help them, and put others first. This is a noble quality, and such a person will surely be accepted by others. The Northern Song philosopher Cheng Yi once said, in essence: the willingness to consider others in all matters is the highest form of learning. This is a simple statement that not only expresses a profound truth in plain language but also identifies the foremost element of being human.

As the saying goes, "Those who plant trees enjoy the shade later," reminding us to think of others. One cannot think only of oneself; one must also think of others. Those who consider others first will surely earn others' appreciation.

The French banker Lafeist, before he made his fortune, was once unemployed and at home.

One day he summoned the courage to visit the chairman of a major bank to seek a job, only to be rejected upon meeting him. This was not his first such experience; it was already his fifty-second rejection. Lafeist left the bank dejected and accidentally stepped on a thumbtack on the ground.

"Everyone is against me!" he muttered angrily, about to walk away. But then he thought better of it: he could not let it prick anyone else, so he picked up the thumbtack.

The next day, to his surprise, Lafeist received a hiring notice from the bank. Excited yet puzzled—he had already been rejected—he learned that the thumbtack had "saved" him. The moment he bent down to pick it up, the bank chairman saw it. From this small act the chairman concluded that Lafeist was a careful, considerate person and changed his mind, hiring him.

From then on, Lafeist's career began at that bank, and he later became a leading French banker.

Although Lafeist's opportunity appeared to stem merely from picking up a small thumbtack—seemingly accidental—his ability to maintain good conduct even in disappointment and to think of others demonstrated his noble character. The chairman, who could discern spirit in small details, was an expert judge of people; he had spotted Lafeist as a "thoroughbred." It can also be said that Lafeist's success owed much to that chairman's unique insight.

Thinking of others and putting them first is a virtue. Being kept in others' hearts and receiving their help is a happiness. Everyone carries a scale in their heart: those who are cold and selfish toward others will eventually

be shunned; conversely, those who always put others first and think of them will surely be welcomed. With such people we can interact with confidence.

## People Who Offer a "Choose One of Two" Option Are Setting a Trap for You

Micro-expression Keywords: When asked whether you want tea or plain boiled water, no one asks for a bowl of rice. This is a form of habitual thinking. People with ulterior motives exploit this psychology by setting traps for others to fall into. Therefore, when someone forces you to "choose one of two," the best response is to choose neither.

In sales there is a "choose one of two" rule: salespeople can present price packages and appropriately pressure customers to decide between option 1 or 2. For example, a salesperson might ask a prospective customer, "Would you like the two-door or the one-door refrigerator?" or "Would you like delivery on Tuesday or Wednesday?" With such "choose one of two" questions, once the prospect selects one, the salesperson has essentially made the decision for them and prompted the purchase.

A boss once opened two identical congee shops on opposite sides of the same street. The number of customers each day was roughly the same, yet the left shop consistently earned nearly a hundred yuan more than the right one, almost every day. Puzzled, the boss sent someone to investigate the operations and service of both shops to solve the mystery of the differing revenue.

The investigator posed as an ordinary customer and first entered the right-hand shop. Seeing a guest arrive, the waitress greeted him with a beaming smile, served a bowl of steaming congee, and then asked warmly, "Sir, would you like to add an egg?" The investigator noticed that every customer received the same question: "Add an egg or not?" Roughly half the customers said yes and half said no.

He then entered the left-hand shop. The waitress likewise greeted him with a smile, served a bowl of hot congee, and asked amiably, "Sir, would you like one egg or two eggs?" Other customers received the same question. Usually those who liked eggs asked for two, those who did not asked for one, and only a few declined. By the end of the day the left shop had sold far more eggs than the right one. The different phrasing produced different revenues.

The question "Would you like one egg or two eggs?" traps customers inside the asker's preset premise, prompting an involuntary choice.

This is a psychological tactic. The other party sets the answers in advance and gives you the power to choose. On the surface you have great autonomy; in reality it is a trap, because whichever answer you pick is the one they want—just as Sun Wukong could never escape the Buddha's palm.

If you encounter a salesperson skilled at reading consumer psychology, maintain sufficient reason and clarity to avoid being misled. For instance, if you are sitting on a sofa, an ordinary salesperson might ask, "Do you need a sofa?" If your desire to buy is not strong, you will say, "I'm just looking" or "No." Naturally you will not purchase a sofa that does not meet your wishes.

If you meet a more sophisticated salesperson, they will ask, "Would you like a leather sofa or a fabric one?" If you genuinely intend to buy a sofa, you will make a choice from their options.

Sometimes salespeople guide you toward the answer they want through their questions. For example: "Would it be convenient for delivery on December 1 or December 8?" "Would you like red sheets or white ones?" "Would you like to pay a 1,000-yuan or 1,500-yuan deposit?"

Many people find it hard to resist this “choose one of two” sales approach. In psychology this is called “false-premise suggestion.” From the salesperson’s standpoint, success comes as soon as the customer buys. They therefore assume a purchase premise, turning “buy or not buy” into “buy red or purple.” Although the customer chooses under a false premise, they believe the choice of color stems from their own will and end up buying as the salesperson intended.

If you are a consumer and truly have no intention of completing the transaction, the best method is to reject both answers. By refusing to choose, you largely dismantle the trap the other party has carefully laid.

If you genuinely need the product but are undecided about price, color, or style, you may consider the salesperson’s suggestions and choose what suits you. If you have no need at all and are merely browsing, or if nothing appeals, do not let the “choose one of two” sales pattern influence you. The best approach is to choose neither.

## People Who Constantly Complain About a Third Party May Be Indirectly Complaining About You

Micro-expression Keywords: There is an idiom “point at the mulberry while cursing the locust tree,” meaning to scold one thing while appearing to address another. Such people are common in life. They do not wish to confront others directly yet want to vent their dissatisfaction, so they pretend to grumble about someone else in front of you while actually complaining about you. At such moments you should carefully check whether you have offended them and correct the matter promptly.

Many people prefer not to voice complaints or criticisms directly because such remarks easily offend. Instead they choose a roundabout method, expressing dissatisfaction with you by complaining about a third party.

Mr. Ma lived in an apartment. Recently a new neighbor, a music lover, moved in upstairs. The neighbor played the piano every day, even late into the night. Mr. Ma endured it silently, but the constant disturbance eventually exhausted his patience.

Finally Mr. Ma met the neighbor on the staircase and said, “I can still hear your piano through the floorboards, which shows the floor has a problem—the soundproofing is too poor. The builders of this building are responsible; we should ask the original construction company to fix it.”

The music lover understood that his daily playing disturbed his neighbor. After returning home he placed soft padding under the piano for soundproofing and stopped playing late at night.

Mr. Ma had cleverly shifted the blame onto the building’s constructors while implicitly telling the music lover that the piano disturbed his life. The music lover fully grasped the intent and ceased playing at night.

We often use this speaking style ourselves. This indirect method of complaining can sometimes avoid direct confrontation. For example, when the neighbor’s child repeatedly invites her son—who is preparing for the college entrance exam—out to play, a mother might say to the neighbor’s wife, “Your son often comes looking for mine; I’m afraid it disturbs his studies. I feel very sorry.” The other party quickly realizes her own son’s behavior is inappropriate and that the mother is complaining about lax discipline.

If the mother had gone directly to the neighbor’s home and demanded, “You should discipline your son properly—he keeps coming to play with mine, and mine is preparing for the exam...” and the other side had retorted, a fierce argument would have been inevitable.

Because people dislike direct, face-to-face complaints, some express them indirectly to prompt reflection. Such people are clever and prefer to avoid open conflict. When a superior uses this method with subordinates, it indicates a relatively gentle personality that can earn more trust and affection than a blunt superior.

The general manager of a department store often inspected the sales floor to check employees' work. One day, while touring the floor, he noticed a customer waiting at a counter while the sales assistant Xiaoqiao chatted and laughed with another assistant nearby.

The manager wanted to reprimand Xiaoqiao but realized that scolding an employee publicly in the store would look bad. Instead he walked to the counter and served the customer himself.

Xiaoqiao saw the manager, walked over awkwardly, expecting a scolding. The manager merely said calmly, "Oh, you were busy just now, so I happened to pass by. The previous assistant, Xiao Zhao, once left for something and received a customer complaint, resulting in a month's bonus being deducted. That really wasn't good—it wasted the customer's time and harmed her own reputation. In the future, if you need to leave, just let me know so I can arrange for someone else to cover."

Xiaoqiao replied, "It won't happen again, Manager." Indeed, for a long time afterward, whenever the manager inspected the floor he saw Xiaoqiao standing attentively behind her counter, never leaving her post even when no customers were present.

In interpersonal interactions, some people are straightforward and speak their minds openly. Although candid, they can easily offend others. Smarter individuals choose another approach: when they have a grievance they do not state it directly but pretend to complain about someone else in front of you, implicitly signaling that they hope you will improve.

Human relationships are subtle. Sometimes the other party does not express their meaning directly but takes a detour. If you do not react quickly enough to grasp the underlying message, you may be seen as slow-witted. Therefore, when someone complains in front of you, be alert: quietly examine whether you have done something wrong and correct it in time.

## People Who Ask for a Third Party's Opinion Actually Want to Know Yours

### Micro-expression keywords

As the saying goes, "Listen to what is said and what lies between the lines." Skilled listeners discern the unspoken implications in others' words. For instance, when someone asks you for a third party's opinion, they are really seeking yours. In such cases, simply stating your own view will satisfy them.

Sometimes people are reluctant to voice their true thoughts directly, fearing they might say the wrong thing or face negative consequences. They therefore adopt a clever indirect approach: "How do his neighbors view him?" "What does his teacher say about him?" "How do his classmates describe him?" This removes the speaker's inner reservations, because they can tell themselves, "After all, I am only reporting what the neighbors, teacher, or classmates think, not my own opinion, so I bear no responsibility." As a result, they reveal their real views.

Many journalists skillfully use this third-party technique to draw out a subject's genuine opinions, especially when covering life-and-death cases. Instead of asking "What is your impression of the deceased?" or "Did you notice anything unusual about the deceased recently?"—questions that often make people wary and evasive—reporters ask, "How did the deceased's neighbors view him?" The interviewee then lowers their guard and

expresses their own thoughts under the guise of reporting the neighbors' views. *Dream of the Red Chamber* contains numerous examples of this technique.

In Chapter 6, "Granny Liu's First Visit to the Rongguo Mansion," Granny Liu and her grandson Ban'er kowtow to Xifeng. Xifeng says she is "too young to recognize the visitor and does not know the exact relationship, so she dares not address her properly." Zhou Rui's wife replies, "This is the granny I just mentioned." Granny Liu then tries to bring Ban'er forward to bow, but the boy refuses out of shyness.

Xifeng smiles and says, "Relatives who seldom visit grow distant. Those who know us will say you disdain us and refuse to come often; those who do not know us will assume we look down on everyone."

Xifeng's final remarks are spoken through the mouths of imagined third parties, yet they express her own feelings. It is not really "those who know" who think "you disdain us," nor "those who do not know" who think "we look down on everyone"; it is Xifeng herself who holds these views. A similar scene appears in Chapter 45:

When Ping'er brings tea, Granny Lai rises to accept it and says with a smile, "Miss, you need only have sent any child with it; there is no need to trouble yourself on my account." While drinking, she continues, "The old lady does not realize that these young ones must be kept under strict control. Even so, they still find moments to stir up trouble and worry their elders. Those who understand will say the children are merely mischievous; those who do not will claim we rely on wealth and power to bully others, damaging even the masters' reputation. It angers me so much that I often summon their fathers and scold them before things improve."

Granny Lai is not reporting what "those who understand" or "those who do not" think; she is voicing her own opinion while shifting potential responsibility onto unnamed others.

When we wish to learn someone's true thoughts but the person is unwilling to speak openly because of interests or other concerns—and especially when they hold opposing views—we can use the third-party technique. Ask what other people would most likely think about the matter. Because the speaker is ostensibly reporting others' opinions, they feel no personal responsibility and will relax their guard, revealing their own views.

You may wonder whether they are truly describing someone else's ideas. In the vast majority of cases, they are expressing their own real thoughts. Even if they claim to be citing others, those others rarely share a single opinion, so the speaker must choose the view they consider most plausible—thereby indicating their own preference. Moreover, they rarely repeat the supposed source verbatim; their own wording and framing make the statement essentially their personal opinion. Some people add a final disclaimer—"They think this way, but I do not"—to mask the fact that the view is their own. If you then ask, "Could you share your own thoughts?" they usually smile and remain silent, because they have already told you.

## Social Gatherings

In Chapter 1 we noted that airports offer the best panoramic view of human behavior. Social gatherings likewise provide an excellent setting both for observing others and for practicing the interpretation of body language. Let us now examine some of the gestures and postures commonly seen at such events.

We find that married women tend to cluster together at gatherings, as do married men, while single people gravitate toward other singles.

Couples on a date walk very close to each other and touch affectionately. Intimate married couples display similar gestures of affection. By observing these movements we can often identify which couple has been



married the shortest time.

Newlyweds, for example, frequently walk with an arm around the partner's waist or hand in hand. The gesture silently announces to everyone, "Hands off—she (he) is mine!" Touch thus signals both possession and a posture of protection and trust.

The two couples in Figure 5.1 are clearly enjoying each other's affection. Notice that the woman on the left has her arm around her husband's neck, while the man on the right has his arm around his wife's neck—both gestures conveying deep warmth.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5.1 表达爱意的两对夫妻]*

Some individuals are more openly expressive of emotion than others. At gatherings, one partner in a couple is often more inclined to display affection through physical contact.

If a couple argued before arriving and the tension has not eased, they are likely to appear stiff, their smiles forced and rectangular.

Regardless of marital status, couples who are not getting along well show almost no physical contact. If one touches the other, the touched person quickly withdraws the hand or shoulder. Even when seated on the same sofa, they deliberately maintain distance rather than sitting close (see Figure 5.2).

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5.2 各怀心事的一对夫妻]*

At a large gathering, if you notice two people repeatedly closing the distance between them while talking, you may assume they are sharing a private matter. If you are nearby, you may also observe them shift from standing side by side to facing each other. The nonverbal message they send is: "This is private space—please do not disturb."

Observing and correctly interpreting attendees' body language can be as enjoyable as participating in the gathering itself. The key is to become an active "player," accurately reading others' nonverbal cues and responding appropriately so that the social event fulfills its purpose.

For example, if you attend a gathering alone and meet someone who attracts you, how can you tell whether they are open to meeting you? Here are some common gestures you may encounter:

## Schwab's Path to Success

Charles Schwab, founder of the Bethlehem Steel Corporation in the United States, was born in a rural village and received only a brief formal education. At fifteen, with his family impoverished, he took a job as a stable hand in a mountain village.

Three years later he found work at a construction site owned by steel magnate Andrew Carnegie. From the moment he arrived, Schwab resolved to become the best worker on the site. While others complained about the hard labor and low pay and slacked off, Schwab quietly accumulated experience and taught himself construction knowledge.

In the evenings, while others chatted, Schwab sat in a corner reading. The manager glanced at the book in Schwab's hands, flipped through his notebook, and left without a word. The next day the manager summoned Schwab to his office and asked, "What are you studying for?" Schwab replied, "Our company does not lack

laborers; it lacks technicians and managers who possess both practical experience and professional knowledge, doesn't it?" The manager nodded. Soon afterward Schwab was promoted to technician.

Many of his fellow workers mocked and ridiculed him, but Schwab remained unmoved. "I am working for myself," he said, "and for my own company." With this conviction he rose step by step to chief engineer. At twenty-five he became general manager of the construction company.

Even as general manager, Schwab did not relax his standards. While overseeing construction of the company's largest plant, the Braddock Steel Works, he arrived at the site earlier than anyone else each day. When engineer Jones asked why he came so early, Schwab answered, "Only this way can I avoid delays if an emergency arises." After the plant was completed, Jones recommended Schwab as his deputy to oversee all plant operations.

Two years later Jones died in an accident, and Schwab succeeded him as plant manager. Thanks to his exceptional managerial skill and work ethic, Carnegie appointed him chairman of the steel company a few years later. Schwab eventually founded the Bethlehem Steel Corporation and achieved remarkable success. Through persistent dreams and practice he rose from laborer to entrepreneur, while many of his former coworkers remained manual laborers all their lives, struggling daily for a living.

What employer would not value an employee like Schwab? The same service rendered with different attitudes produces different results. All new employees start on equal footing; their initial pay and performance differ little. The vast differences that later emerge stem from the attitudes they bring to their work.

Employees who see themselves merely as hired hands and regard "the company as the boss's" never integrate fully and never become outstanding. Only those who treat the company as their own—caring for it as they would their home—stand out, earn the boss's recognition, and become true stakeholders.

Only those who approach others' affairs with the same care they give their own are worth partnering with. Therefore, when choosing collaborators, observe how they handle tasks assigned to them; their attitude toward such work reveals their attitude toward work in general.

## Saying "Welcome to Offer Opinions" While Not Wanting to Hear Your Criticism

Micro-expression keywords: Think about it—have you often met people who say "Welcome to offer opinions" yet become visibly displeased the moment you actually voice one? This is human nature; no one truly enjoys criticism, and verbal modesty does not equal genuine humility. So when someone utters such words, do not take them literally, or you may wound their self-esteem and cause offense.

No one likes feeling negated, yet some people adopt a magnanimous pose and declare, "Everyone is welcome to offer opinions." Do not assume such individuals are different or genuinely open to dissent. The more someone claims to be indifferent to criticism, the more sensitive they actually are and the less they wish to hear it.

After graduating from a top university, Zhu Feng joined a private refrigeration-equipment company. The owner valued Zhu highly, promoting him to sales supervisor in his first year and then directly to assistant general manager because of outstanding performance. Their personal relationship was close; they often socialized, and the boss relied heavily on Zhu in business matters. Gradually Zhu came to feel he held a status equal to the owner's within the company<|eos|>

## Zhang Fan's Story

Zhang Fan joined the office of a state-owned enterprise after graduating from university. Although young and inexperienced, she felt she had every advantage over the sluggish office director, Lao Guo, who was always nodding and bowing to leaders and responding with deferential murmurs. Despite being a newcomer, she showed no respect for her elder.

The most demanding part of office work was drafting various reports and speeches. Seeing Lao Guo struggle with them day after day, Zhang Fan volunteered to take on those tedious writing tasks. Lao Guo felt immense relief and thanked her repeatedly. Yet her offer was not motivated by a desire to serve others; she had her own agenda. She believed Lao Guo was too old to match her professionally trained abilities in speech or manner, so she intended to display her own competence and talent in order to replace him.

One day the general manager asked her to help complete an academic paper, and Zhang Fan finally saw her chance. Relying on the leader's favor, she began to take charge, assigning tasks to Lao Guo and managing the office's daily affairs. In the office she frequently flaunted her professional knowledge, boasting about how highly the general manager valued her, which drew murmurs of discontent from her colleagues. Lao Guo, however, remained unchanged, always wearing his trademark smile; even when Zhang Fan issued orders, he kept grinning. She completed the academic paper brilliantly, and the general manager was pleased.

The leader's appreciation and attitude made Zhang Fan secretly smug and extremely arrogant. She began to run the office with a commanding air. Lao Guo's authority at work was almost entirely supplanted by hers. Zhang Fan confidently assumed the directorship was hers and was merely waiting for the leader to announce it at the right moment.

Matters did not unfold as she expected. In the biennial leadership election, Lao Guo retained the directorship by a wide margin, while Zhang Fan received only verbal praise and encouragement. Unconvinced, she demanded an explanation. The general manager looked at her and said: "Ability alone is not enough to lead; experience and a character that commands respect are also required. You are still young—learn well. There is always someone better; keep striving." His words reminded her of the respect and support other employees showed the "mediocre" Lao Guo, and she seemed to understand.

Zhang Fan's work ability was indeed strong, yet she constantly showed off, considered herself exceptional, looked down on the director, and compared colleagues unfavorably with the leader's regard for her. The result was colleagues' dislike, a poor reputation, and the loss of a great opportunity. Had she modestly assisted Lao Guo, treated colleagues kindly, and sought advice humbly, the departmental directorship might well have been hers within a few years.

## The Art of Reading People: Observing Words and Expressions

A successful candidate for the imperial examinations finally obtained a county magistrate post in Shandong after arduous exams and further selection. On his second day in office he went to pay respects to his superior but could think of nothing to say. After a long silence he suddenly asked, "What is your honorable surname, sir?" The superior was astonished and reluctantly gave his surname.

The magistrate fell silent again, thought for a long while, and said, "Your surname does not appear in the Book of Hundred Surnames." The superior grew more puzzled and replied, "Do you not know I am a bannerman?" The magistrate stood up again and asked, "Which banner do you belong to, sir?" The superior answered, "The Plain Red Banner." The magistrate said, "The Plain Yellow Banner is the best; why are you not in that one?" The superior flew into a rage and roared, "Which province are you from?" The magistrate replied, "Guangxi." The superior retorted, "Guangdong is best; why are you not from Guangdong?" Only then did the magistrate

notice the superior's face was flushed with anger and hastily withdrew. The next day the superior ordered him back to Guangxi to serve as a school instructor. The reason was simple: he lacked the skill of reading people and situations.

In social interactions, the ability to observe words and expressions and adapt accordingly is itself a valuable skill.

During a visit, if the host speaks with you while glancing elsewhere and someone nearby is whispering, it indicates your arrival has interrupted an important matter he must attend to. Although he is physically receiving you, his mind remains elsewhere. The wisest course is to stop and take your leave: "You must be busy. I will not disturb you further; I will return in a day or two to hear your reply."

When you depart, the host will feel both gratitude and guilt—guilt for having been preoccupied with his own affairs. Consequently he will exert greater effort to fulfill your request as compensation.

If the host's doorbell or telephone rings during conversation, you should pause and allow the host to attend to the visitor or call. Continuing to speak at length places the host in an awkward position.

When you later inquire whether the matter you entrusted has been completed, you may find that despite the host's considerable effort the outcome is imperfect or progress is slow. You may feel impatient, yet you must restrain yourself. Turn the urge to urge into thanks, fully acknowledge the host's efforts, then explain your current situation to seek understanding and sympathy. The host will then realize that although much time and energy have been spent, the issue remains unresolved, and will be determined to see it through to the end.

## The Art of Winning Hearts and Providing Incentives

We often say there is an art to winning hearts; in essence it means grasping the other party's inner needs. Give meat to those who love meat and grass to those who love grass, and both will be sent away delighted.

Some people spend half the day anxious, unable to guess why the boss has summoned them; others pursue a deal for months yet dare not assume sincerity until the contract is signed; still others exhaust themselves pleading for help yet cannot discern whether the other party intends to assist. What these people lack is the ability to perceive and meet others' needs. Those skilled at identifying needs are usually attentive and capable. When they become leaders, they can appropriately apply incentives to arouse subordinates' enthusiasm.

A small mold-making company had cramped, cluttered workspaces, yet every employee worked with total concentration and no supervision. The owner explained: "The key is that detailed quotas and corresponding pay for each process are clearly defined. Workers know exactly how much more they earn for doing more or better work." By aligning labor efficiency with income, the owner raised employee initiative.

Effective incentives meet actual needs. In modern enterprise management, the most important step in mobilizing staff is to analyze differing needs, set visible goals, and give employees a sense of purpose and drive. This demonstrates managerial skill.

No matter the position or industry, those who can promptly grasp others' needs inspire confidence and achieve results. Such people inevitably accomplish great things. Therefore we should recognize individuals who understand others' inner needs; such employees or partners bring lasting benefits. Under such managers we can fully exercise our abilities, because they provide the necessary stage.

In daily life we are constantly busy and often expend great effort on tasks that remain unfinished. Yet if we encounter someone who can instantly grasp another's needs, every problem ceases to be a problem.

## Ms. Zhuo's Experience

Ms. Zhuo was a highly regarded sales professional. She recently resigned to rest before deciding her next move. Many headhunters and companies pursued her; one offered an annual salary exceeding two million yuan, yet she remained unmoved—she was not short of money.

At a friend's gathering she met a Mr. Chen. They conversed congenially, but he did not invite her to join his company that evening. Afterward he invited her to dinner and proposed she join him, but she declined. He did not press the matter and continued to stay in touch.

During one phone call he learned she would soon travel to Beijing and offered, "What a coincidence—I am also going to Beijing. Let me book your ticket." Ms. Zhuo gave no clear reply, assuming he merely wished to ingratiate himself. On the flight they chatted about various topics, yet to her surprise he did not mention employment again.

Later Mr. Chen happened to return on the same flight, still without raising the subject. Some days afterward he invited her to visit a newly opened branch. Upon returning to the Shanghai headquarters he led her to an elegantly appointed office that matched her taste exactly.

He said sincerely, "This is the office we have prepared for you. Are you satisfied?" Shortly thereafter Ms. Zhuo became a partner in Mr. Chen's company—an outcome that astonished the industry. Everyone had assumed her new employer would be either a leading firm or one offering lavish compensation; instead she chose a relatively modest company.

A major factor in her decision was Mr. Chen's skill at creating seemingly coincidental encounters that demonstrated sincerity and regard. Although Ms. Zhuo had remained noncommittal about the deliberate same-flight arrangement, she felt inwardly warmed by it.

## Sales Case Analysis

In an automobile dealership a star salesperson consistently met or exceeded targets under any circumstances. He regarded selling as straightforward.

When colleagues lost confidence in an ordinary salaried couple and refused to pursue the sale, he took over and successfully sold them a car. Colleagues viewed the couple's purchasing power as too low; buying a car would exhaust most of their savings, so the likelihood of a purchase seemed negligible.

The salesperson thought differently. He believed the couple genuinely needed a car; precisely because their means were limited, they would choose carefully to maximize value. They did not require a luxury vehicle to display status; they simply needed reliable transportation to and from work. He recommended a small-displacement model with low fuel consumption that met their needs at minimal cost. They purchased it without hesitation.

When colleagues dismissed a wealthy man who already owned several luxury cars, believing he would not buy another, the salesperson sold him one. Colleagues assumed the man had no need for an additional identical vehicle. The salesperson understood that the man bought cars to display status rather than for comfort.

Accordingly he spent little time describing performance and instead emphasized the vehicle's prestige. The wealthy man became deeply interested in the "high-status" car and bought it.

The salesperson succeeded by identifying each client's true needs.

## Mei Ling's Love Story

If someone were willing to contrive various coincidences to meet you, you would surely be moved. The same tactic is frequently used in romance. People tend to believe in fate; when a coincidence is added, they conclude heaven has destined the match and will strive to overcome every obstacle to love.

Mei Ling was exceptionally beautiful, yet her husband was of ordinary appearance and shorter than she. Whenever she recounted their meeting, courtship, marriage, and the birth of their child, her face glowed with happiness.

Mei Ling walked the single stop from the subway station to her office. One rainy day without an umbrella she took shelter under an eave, watching the downpour and worrying she would be late. An umbrella appeared above her head. The young man holding it asked, "Heading to work? Where is your company?"

She pointed to a nearby building. He said, "Let's walk together; I work there too." Mei Ling looked at him doubtfully; he gave her a reassuring nod. They walked side by side, exchanged a few words, and became acquainted. They did indeed work in the same building—she on the eighth floor, he on the tenth.

The next day they "happened" to meet again on the route from the subway to the building. Mei Ling learned he, like her, preferred walking from the station. From then on they "coincidentally" met every weekday, chatting as they walked; she alighted at the eighth floor, he at the tenth. As they grew closer they began dating.

Only later did Mei Ling discover he did not actually work in the same building; his office was two stops farther away. All their encounters had been deliberately staged so he could pursue her. Each day he accompanied her one stop, rode the elevator with her to the eighth floor, then descended from the tenth and hurried to his own workplace. Mei Ling was deeply moved; she knew marrying such a man would be the right choice.

## Carnegie's Story

While teaching, the American Dale Carnegie received a visit from a company manager perpetually overwhelmed by endless work. The manager was astonished to find Carnegie's desk neat and empty; he had expected it to be buried under papers like his own. He asked, "Mr. Carnegie, where do you keep the letters you have not yet handled?"

Carnegie replied, "I have finished all my correspondence."

The manager, puzzled, continued, "Then to whom have you delegated today's unfinished tasks?"

"I have completed everything," Carnegie answered with a smile.

Seeing the manager's confusion, Carnegie explained: "It is simple. I know there is much to do, yet my energy is limited. I can handle only one matter at a time. I therefore list tasks in order of importance and address them one by one. The result is that everything gets done."

The manager suddenly understood. "Ah, I see. Thank you, Mr. Carnegie." Several weeks later the manager invited Carnegie to his now spacious office and said gratefully, "Mr. Carnegie, thank you for teaching me how to manage work. Previously my large office was piled with documents and letters like small mountains; one desk was insufficient, so I used three. After adopting your method the situation improved dramatically—nothing remains unfinished."

The manager not only escaped the backlog but years later became one of America's most successful figures.

Those who work methodically, with clear priorities and goals, possess superior understanding and guidance. They analyze situations quickly and effectively, then proceed step by step. Such people are worthy of admiration both in life and at work.

## The Story of Three Workers

A psychologist once visited a church under construction and noticed three workers performing identical tasks yet displaying markedly different expressions. He approached each and asked the same question: "Who are you working for?"

- The first worker replied resentfully that he was smashing unbearably heavy stones with an impossibly heavy hammer—working merely for the sake of working.
- The second answered helplessly that he was smashing stones to feed his family—working for his wages.
- The third replied calmly that he was helping build a magnificent church and a modern city—working for the value of his life.

The same work, yet three different perspectives that produced three different feelings about the work and three different outcomes. The first two workers were merely enduring their jobs; only the third truly regarded his labor as serving others and himself.

Employers naturally prefer the third type of employee. The first two will only complain; the third works with genuine purpose. While an employer pays wages, the employee receives experience, training, the exercise of ability, and the tempering of character. An employee whose sole aim is to extract money from the employer will inevitably adopt a negative attitude; such a person will never be entrusted with important responsibilities.

Therefore the employees employers most need are those who abandon the notion of "working for the boss," treat the company as their own, and regard themselves as partners. Such employees are worthy of being entrusted with significant duties.

## Couples

Due to certain reasons, most people find it difficult to correctly interpret their closest loved ones, even if they appear to be in harmony overall. People always take their intimate relationships for granted, thus neglecting those silent communications.

Here, we strongly recommend that no matter how well you think you know your spouse or partner, you must patiently listen to the other person finish speaking and carefully observe the body movements they display. Because body movements usually reveal true feelings more than words. Many marriage counselors have said that most marital problems stem from poor communication between the two parties. Therefore, patient listening and careful observation are very important for maintaining a long and happy marriage.

In the 1980s, Japanese women could not express their dissatisfaction with their husbands verbally, but they could show their emotions in other ways. After the husband returned home from work, he could infer his wife's mood by observing the placement of the flower bouquet at home and further consider how to respond.

Below we list some movements that lovers may use when expressing affection and anger. While interpreting these movements, please remember that some people may prefer to show their emotions, especially when others are present. When a person places an arm around his wife to express affection, the other party may adopt more subtle movements, such as leaning against him while he speaks.

In addition, people vary in the movements they use to express dissatisfaction and anger. You can draw on your knowledge of your loved one to help you correctly interpret their behavior.

## People Who Can Grasp the Other Party's Needs in Real Time Are Capable at Handling Affairs

Micro-expression keywords: How to speak so as not to be rejected? How to speak so as to move the other person? It depends on what the other party needs most and on grasping the other party's true needs. Of course, people generally do not state these needs outright, but as long as you carefully analyze their psychology, you can understand what they want. Focusing on this point can achieve twice the result with half the effort.

Being capable at handling affairs refers to a person who proceeds without dragging things out, can rapidly grasp others' needs in real time, identify the key points, and thereby bring matters to a satisfactory conclusion. For example, when fishing, it is not a matter of simply setting the rod in place and waiting for a fish to bite; rather, you must judge from the circumstances what the fish like to eat and where they linger. Only then can you catch fish quickly and effectively.

Therefore, whether one can grasp the other party's needs in real time is the key to success in handling affairs and also a manifestation of one's capability. Needs are not always shown on the surface; they also have deeper layers. Just as we sometimes think a person needs only one car, yet some people insist on buying several. In these people's eyes, a car is not merely a means of transportation but also a form of showing off; what it brings them is not only material satisfaction but, more importantly, spiritual satisfaction. Hence they are willing to purchase things they seemingly do not need. The same principle applies when handling affairs: only by identifying the other party's true needs can one bring matters to a successful conclusion.

## Humble People Naturally Attract Many Helpers

Micro-expression keywords: A popular person is necessarily a humble person. Humble people consider others in every respect and know how to respect others' feelings, so they win everyone's affection and assistance. Therefore, to see whether a person is humble, one need only look at how many friends they have when facing difficulties.

Socrates once said: "Humility is the sweet root hidden in the soil from which all noble virtues sprout and grow." Humility is a virtue and a noble human quality. In life there are always people who, once they accomplish something or achieve some credit, go around boasting, even treating the achievements of their ancestors as their own glory. Seniority naturally deserves respect, but constantly singing about it on one's lips causes it to lose value. What is more lamentable is that boasting also incurs the envy and resentment of those around one, ultimately leaving one isolated.

Truly capable people do not need to proclaim their abilities themselves; only humility and courtesy can display one's cultivation and virtue. Humble people are also more welcome. If a person only knows how to elevate



themselves in front of others, they are invisibly belittling others; this is disrespectful and harms others' self-esteem, inevitably leading to denial and contempt. Conversely, when a person shows deference in front of others, it is a sign of respect; once the other person's heart is satisfied, they will repay with a higher evaluation. Therefore, humble people naturally have many helpers around them, because they can place themselves in a lower position and are not stingy about seeking advice from others.

## Parents and Children

During the first two years after birth, infants communicate with their parents mainly through sound. When hungry, wet, or uncomfortable, they cry or scream until the parents respond. As infants grow older, they begin to integrate into their surroundings and develop various body movements that express emotion.

Parents should understand their children's gestures, expressions, and postures, because these movements are sometimes the only clue that a child is facing a problem. Below we introduce some body movements young children may use when communicating normal emotions such as anger, fear, or happiness.

It should be noted that some of the following postures can be seen in children of any age, while others appear only in adolescents or younger children. Generally, the younger the child, the more obvious the body movements used to express emotion. As they grow older and their minds mature, they tend to adopt more subtle postures.

It is also important to interpret a child's behavior by combining your knowledge of the child with your understanding of their various actions. For example, slamming a door may indicate excitement about going out to play with friends, but it may also indicate anger and frustration.

## People Who Regard Serving Others as Their Own Duty Can Coexist and Prosper Together

**Micro-expression keywords:** Human nature is selfish, so people generally do not regard doing things for others as their own duty. In fact, they overlook the principle that hard work creates wealth for others while simultaneously enhancing one's own value. Therefore, if someone regards serving others as their own duty, it shows that this person has strong ambition and is worth coexisting and prospering with.

Sometimes, to see a person clearly, we can assign them a task and observe their attitude toward it to discern their character. Only those who regard serving others as their own duty are worth coexisting and prospering with. In other words, only those who treat work assigned by others as their own work and devote themselves wholeheartedly to completing it are worth coexisting with.

For example, in the workplace many people view work as a simple employment relationship; whether they do more or less, well or poorly, makes little difference to them, because they always feel they are working for the boss. If a person holds this mentality, then no matter what work they do, they will merely go through the motions. With this attitude they will never grow or develop, will never have a chance to "get ahead," and certainly cannot accomplish anything great.

## Bill Gates's Humility

Bill Gates and his team led Microsoft to create one myth after another in the IT industry. Li Kaifu, Microsoft's first Chinese vice president, admired not only Bill Gates's business achievements but, above all, his humble character. A widely circulated story illustrates Bill Gates's humility.

A staff member at Microsoft who was specially assigned to prepare Bill's speeches said that before every speech Bill would carefully annotate the draft himself and prepare and practice earnestly. After every speech, Bill would come down and talk with him, asking, "Where did I speak well today, and where did I speak poorly?" He did not merely ask; he would also take a notebook and carefully record what he had done wrong so he could correct and improve it next time.

It is rare for someone who has achieved such success in his career to remain so dedicated, so humble, and so willing to learn, because many people become arrogant once they succeed. Yet, as the saying goes, "the tall tree catches the wind." A person who is overly conspicuous will inevitably incur others' envy and resentment and will be isolated; after all, no one wants to be with an arrogant person.

## People Who Handle Affairs in an Orderly Manner Possess Understanding and Guidance Ability

**Micro-expression keywords** There are two kinds of people in the workplace: one kind handles affairs with great efficiency and clear order; the other kind appears busy but never finishes work on time. Where does the difference lie? In fact, it comes down to personal understanding. A person with understanding will arrange work according to importance, set priorities, and then complete tasks one by one. Consequently, their work is not only orderly but also highly efficient.

We often say efficiency comes first, and rightly so; no matter what one does, efficiency is most important. For example, in the workplace, whoever can complete a task first is an outstanding worker; in studies, whoever can master the most knowledge in the shortest time will rank at the top. Therefore, improving efficiency has become everyone's goal.

Efficiency in work reflects a person's understanding and guidance ability. Someone who works methodically and in an orderly fashion necessarily possesses strong understanding and guidance abilities; conversely, those who work without order, without sequence, in a chaotic manner, and without distinguishing priorities may appear to be working hard on the surface, yet in reality they achieve little efficiency.

## Chapter 5: Interpersonal Relationships and Body Language

- Parents and children
- Couples
- Social gatherings
- Bosses and employees
- Clients and professionals
- Buyers and sellers
- Parties in court
- Speakers and audiences
- Conclusion

We cannot control our surroundings, but we can master our own behavior.

—Benjamin Disraeli

Whether you are facing your own children, loved ones, business partners, or strangers, clearly understanding the meanings of body language can help you better grasp the situation and effectively communicate your own emotions and thoughts. In this chapter we discuss non-verbal movements related to specific interpersonal relationships.

While reading the following content and suggestions, try to recall some non-verbal exchanges you have had with your own children, loved ones, business partners, and others. Consider what role your body language plays in these social relationships. Then think about what techniques you can use to improve your ability to handle interpersonal relationships.

## Deliberately Emphasizing “Coincidence” May Be Intentional

Micro-expression keywords: In television dramas, many plot points are too “coincidental”; this is indeed the screenwriters’ deliberate arrangement to advance the story. But in real life there are also many “coincidences,” especially when the other party deliberately emphasizes them; these may well be intentional acts designed to achieve a certain purpose.

“Wow, what a coincidence that you’re here too.” An accidental encounter always brings extra surprise. Because coincidence appears completely devoid of self-interest on the surface, it easily brings people closer. For example, if you happen to meet someone who moves you at a friend’s gathering, and the other person happens to feel the same, you may think it was arranged by heaven and you may quickly fall in love...

Accidental coincidences can rapidly dismantle the other party’s psychological defenses and generate trust in you. Therefore, many people carefully stage coincidences, exploiting people’s unconditional trust in them, in order to achieve their own ends.

## Signs That Others Are Willing to Talk

- More eye contact
- Clearing the throat, as if preparing to speak
- Maintaining a closer distance from you
- Facing you or leaning the body toward you
- Relaxed standing posture
- Arms or legs apart
- Open expression or a smiling face

Earlier we mentioned that when interpreting a person’s body language one must consider the person’s character traits as a whole, not merely individual postures. When observing a stranger’s posture and body movements, one should realize that one is not familiar with this person, so there is a high possibility of making an erroneous judgment.

For example, her posture may appear uninterested in you, yet in fact she may simply be shy; therefore do not retreat—step forward bravely and try to talk with her. If you appear relaxed and candid and can offer some good suggestions at any time, you will soon find that you have already entered a meaningful conversation.

## The Meaning of Coincidence and a Reminder

Coincidence, in interpersonal interaction, reflects the other party’s respect and regard for you. In romantic relationships, it reflects the other party’s deep affection for you. Both can make you accept and approve of the other party in a relatively short time. Of course, these deliberately arranged coincidences are well-intentioned; while feeling moved, we must also guard against “coincidences” created by people with ill intentions.

For example, some swindlers pop open a can of soda and exclaim, “Hey, I won a prize!” Then they offer various reasons to sell the prize at a low price, luring you to take out your wallet. This is now a well-known scam. Nowadays, prize-winning messages sent via mobile phones or QQ, as well as claims that your bank card

was used for a certain amount of spending in a certain place and instructions to transfer money to a certain account, all exploit coincidence to defraud money; one must not fall for them easily.

## Conclusion

People react differently to arrogant and humble individuals because life has formed the view that proud, boastful people are ignorant and uncultured, while humble people are usually those with real talent and cultivation.

Therefore, only humble people win others' goodwill and receive their help. Even if a person's ability is truly lacking, they still do not want to see others placed above them; those who understand humility can place themselves lower everywhere, so they are bound to win everyone's affection. Hence, to see whether a person is humble, one need only observe their attitude toward those around them and the attitude of those around them toward them; humble people will be surrounded by helpers.

## All True Greatness Is Humble

All truly great things are simple and humble. In this world, all those with real talent and learning, all true heroes and outstanding figures, are without exception open-minded and humble. Those who are overbearing, arrogant, and self-satisfied may be superior in one aspect or another, but more often than not they have no outstanding qualities and merely use bluster and mystification to conceal their limited ability.

## Chapter 5: Observing Ways of Conducting Oneself and Revealing Rules of Interaction

In daily life, interpersonal interaction is unavoidable, yet the world is complex and human hearts are hard to fathom. Especially for young people just entering society, lack of experience in discerning others' intentions often leads to failure. In fact, reading minds and understanding people is not difficult! As long as you can carefully explore the other party's way of conducting themselves, you can adjust your own interaction style and easily handle complex human hearts!

## Chapter 4: Through the Other Party's Words, Probing Inner Needs

A person's speech, including tone and rhythm, is an expression of their inner voice. Learning to analyze the basic characteristics of voice and to interpret deeper meanings from simple words allows you, even with vague or obscure speech, to hear the speaker's true thoughts and emotions, thereby gaining a deeper understanding of the other party and seeing through human hearts.

## Signs of Expressing Affection

- Standing or sitting beside you
- Moving closer when speaking with you
- Holding your hand
- Wrapping an arm around your shoulder
- Frequently touching your hand, arm, or shoulder
- Frequently making eye contact with you

## Signs That Others Are Unwilling to Talk

- Less eye contact
- Maintaining a certain distance from you

- Turning the head away from you
- Tense standing posture
- Arms or legs crossed
- Cold expression or an unhappy face

## Workplace and Professional Applications

### **Listen, Listen, and Listen Again**

Listeners are irresistible because they are compassionate, willing to share people's weaknesses, and ready to hear people express unpleasant emotions. If you want others to like the real you, become a listener and never shy away.

One day, American host Linkletter interviewed a young child. Linkletter asked, "What do you want to be when you grow up?" The child answered innocently, "I want to be a pilot!" Linkletter followed up: "If one day your plane flies over the Pacific and all engines fail, what would you do?" The child thought for a moment and said, "I would first tell everyone on the plane to fasten their seat belts, then I would put on my parachute and jump out."

The audience laughed uproariously, yet Linkletter kept watching the child to see if he was being clever. Unexpectedly, tears streamed down the child's face. Linkletter felt deeply moved by the child's compassion. He asked, "Why would you do that?" The child's answer revealed a child's sincere empathy: "I'm going to get fuel, and I'll come back! I'll come back!"

When the child jumped out with the parachute without regard for others, who "heard" the child's compassion? Writer Powell once said: We must listen to the meaning behind the words, not the words themselves. In sincere listening, we can penetrate the words and discover the other person's inner world.

People like listeners, especially compassionate ones. They are as important as close friends, exerting a positive influence on individuals and groups alike, and they make people feel reliable, trustworthy, and loyal. Listeners consider others' needs before their own, and they support and help others. Listeners enjoy entering other people's hearts and minds and gladly share others' deeper feelings. People tend to open up to listeners because they long to be cared for, and sincere listeners truly deliver that care.

Freud was arguably the greatest listening master of modern times. Someone who once met Freud described his attitude while listening to others.

"It was simply astonishing. I had never seen anyone so focused, with such a keen soul capable of insight and scrutiny."

"His gaze was modest and gentle, his voice soft, his posture almost unchanging. Yet his attention to me, the way he showed he enjoyed my speaking—even when I did not speak well—you truly cannot imagine what it means for someone to listen to you like that."

What is the most effective way to listen in order to understand the other person, communicate, and build rapport? Psychologists recommend "empathic listening."

Empathic listening means listening with the heart to another person's thoughts and feelings. It is a way of listening that puts oneself in the other's place and tries to see the world through their eyes. Among all

listening styles, it is the only one that truly reaches another person's psyche and is a hallmark of high emotional intelligence.

While listening, listeners often put themselves in the speaker's position and offer opinions or suggestions. Many listeners, driven by the other person's emotions, believe they can solve the other person's problems.

Suppose your friend has quarreled with his wife and tells you about it. You naturally react. You might comfort him like this:

- If I were in your place, I couldn't stand it either.
- It's unbelievable. I never thought your wife would act that way.
- This is just like last time; you two always argue about these things.
- You have to draw your own conclusions.
- Don't take it too hard; everything will soon return to normal.

In reality, none of these reactions is what your friend expects, and none offers him substantial help. Some remarks may even make him angrier, while others are mostly empty words.

As a listener, you may not realize that you are not truly putting yourself in his place; your reactions may make him feel you are showing off rather than caring about him.

A listener should understand that the views you express cannot fully solve someone else's problems. The only thing you can do for another person is to show understanding and consideration while listening attentively.

During listening, you can use appropriate exchanges and guidance to help the other person gain more insight into the issue they face and encourage them to find solutions through their own strength.

You can guide others toward solutions in two ways during conversation.

1. Restate in your own words what you heard, for example, "You think..." On one hand, this shows you listened carefully; on the other, it gives the speaker a chance to revise or add to what they said.
2. During the conversation, appropriately analyze the other person's psychological state and evaluate their emotional state from your perspective. For example, "You are so angry about..." What you say may be something the other person has not yet recognized, allowing you to hit the core of the problem and help them see it clearly.

Listening to others' disclosures is the best way to identify their inner emotions and the prerequisite for communication. Only by listening attentively can people engage appropriately in conversation.

The following principles deserve attention while listening:

- Maintain eye contact with the speaker throughout.
- Focus entirely on the other person.
- Show your interest.
- Do not let others distract you.
- Avoid distracting actions such as browsing a newspaper.
- Devote your full time.
- When someone cannot immediately reach the point, you share responsibility.
- Do not interrupt.
- Put yourself in the other person's situation and imagine being in their place.
- Use body language to convey your signals, such as nodding to show agreement and interest.

- Do not remain completely silent, staring only at the other person's eyes and nodding constantly.
- You may drink a cup of coffee while listening.

These so-called principles are merely reference points, not mandatory rules. Each conversation style requires different listening behaviors.

## Choosing a Career That Suits You

In the opening section of this book, I already discussed the importance of knowing oneself. To make what follows more valuable, I feel it necessary to briefly explore the issue of career choice.

Recently I received a letter from Mr. Davord. He wrote: "Mr. Balken, you once said I am suited for independent work and suggested mechanical manufacturing. In fact, I worked as an accountant for six years. Later I quarreled with my boss, lost my job, and could not find satisfactory work. One day I remembered your advice and decided to sell things I made myself. Guess what happened? Ha-ha, my income more than doubled compared with my accounting days. Now I even employ two assistants. Of course, what pleases me most is no longer having to serve those unscrupulous bosses."

I retrieved Mr. Davord's personality analysis from old files. The data showed he had fair skin (willing to take on challenges), a large build (energetic and quick-tempered), and a sturdy frame (rough and straightforward). With even a little knowledge of personality analysis, one can easily see that the dull, meticulous work of an accountant did not suit him. Fortunately, he eventually found his place and stepped onto his own path to success.

To date I have provided career analysis for at least sixteen thousand people. From my experience, many people fail not because they lack ability, but because they apply their ability in the wrong place. To succeed and be happy, a person must have a clear understanding of themselves and their career.

Many young people tell me:

- "I want to change jobs."
- "I plan to resign and open a restaurant with friends."
- "I'm not going to be a salesperson anymore; I want to become a photographer."

...

Changing jobs carries risk; switching fields is even riskier. For these young people I ask three questions: First, what aspects of your current job dissatisfy you? Second, have you assessed the risks of the new job? Third, if you fail, have you prepared a contingency plan?

I know a young woman who wanted to work in photography. Based on my analysis and understanding of her, photography was a good choice, yet I still asked her to consider the three questions. Ten minutes later she gave me her answers—

First, although her current job paid well, it was not what she liked, so she could never muster enthusiasm.

Second, although the new field was competitive, she had three advantages. First, she had done extensive research on children's photography; second, she had rich personal networks and many friends; third, she enjoyed being with children and children liked her.

Third, she had decided that if the business failed, she would accept a friend's invitation to join a magazine as a photographer.

Soon she opened a photo studio and announced it on cards sent to her married friends. She carefully recorded the birthdays of her friends' children and, before each child's birthday, sent the parents a sincere letter suggesting they take a commemorative photograph. Through her careful management, the studio's business grew steadily.

Returning to the topic of young people changing jobs or fields: Further inquiry revealed that a large portion of these young people were overconfident and held excessively high expectations for the new work. Confidence itself is not wrong, but creating miracles requires two conditions: first, a deep understanding of one's own potential abilities; second, the techniques to bring those potential abilities into play. The former comes from self-analysis; the latter comes from study, training, and experience. Without these two conditions, greater confidence only increases the likelihood of failure. Therefore, before changing jobs, carefully consider the three questions I raised—this is my advice.

Now that you have chosen a career, step together into the turbulent workplace. The following content will influence your career for better or worse.

### **Fill the Other Person's Stomach First, Then Loosen Their Mouth**

"Dining-table culture" (饭桌文化) not only enriches daily meals but also relates to people's livelihood and safety. Looking around, many business deals are concluded at the table, many contracts are signed at the table, and many heartfelt words are spoken at the table... Clearly, the dining table is an important arena that cannot be ignored when extracting information.

During training, FBI headquarters arranged a special experiment for trainees to help them complete future tasks. The experiment was conducted by Dr. Bert of the New York Comprehensive Institute. The process was as follows:

Some trainees were sent onto the street to find two presumed target informants and invite each to a pre-designated room. The first informant was taken to a room filled with food; the second was invited to an empty room. The final interview results surprised the trainees: in the food-filled room, 56 percent agreed to help; in the empty room, only 20 percent agreed. The reasons for requesting help and the conversation content were identical; only the environment differed, yet the number of agreements and refusals differed by roughly twofold. This shows the power of food should not be underestimated.

Why does food exert such a strong influence on interview outcomes?

- First, after people eat and drink their fill, they become more talkative. If you doubt this, observe crowded restaurants at mealtimes and you will see people at the tables shedding their usual reserve; laughter rises and falls, and complaints and dissatisfaction increase noticeably. Therefore, extracting someone's true thoughts at such moments is easy even without special techniques.
- Second, sharing a meal effectively demonstrates mutual closeness and helps promote and deepen friendly relations. FBI agents have a conversational technique called "Luncheon," meaning lunch-table exchange. Its purpose is to strengthen closeness through shared meals. In Japan the technique is renamed "Dinner," or evening meal, because Japanese hosts usually entertain guests in the evening. Japanese contains a term translated as "people who eat from the same pot," used to describe friends who live together and implying psychological closeness that makes it easier to speak the truth.



- The final reason is that after eating, people become very tolerant. With a full stomach, they rarely feel hostility toward the other person. Discussing matters at this time can objectively restrain the other person from raising objections, no matter how difficult the request. Even if the other person wants to object, speaking with a mouth full of food is impolite. Therefore, one can try to state one's request just as the other person puts food in their mouth; this is an extremely effective tactic for preventing objections.

Some say, "Meeting often is not as good as eating together occasionally, and eating occasionally is not as good as drinking heartily once." This statement highlights the importance of meals and also mentions drinking. If the relationship has reached the point where drinking together is possible, the other person may reveal the truth even without deliberate prompting. However, if the drinking session has a purpose, one must never get drunk, or the result may be counterproductive.

### **How to Make the Chair Most Practical**

When entering McDonald's or KFC, one notices that most chairs are fixed. Consequently, when the restaurant is crowded, people often complain about having to sit with strangers. Yet few realize this is a merchant strategy to increase customer flow by preventing patrons from lingering.

Clearly, seat choice affects daily life. So what kind of seat should one choose to facilitate successful information extraction? The answer depends on the specific purpose of the conversation, the other party, and similar factors.

FBI agents can actively assign the interviewee's seat, so they usually place the interviewee in a chair lower than their own. If two identical chairs are available, they add extra cushions to their own chair or place something underneath to ensure their seat is at least five centimeters higher.

Why do agents perform these small actions? The sole purpose is to raise their own line of sight. Looking down from above conveys more authority than looking straight ahead or upward and elicits more truthful information.

A psychologist at Washington University once showed photographs of two people conversing to more than one hundred students and asked them to judge which speaker appeared more dominant. The results showed that the person whose chair was slightly higher conveyed a stronger sense of power. Clearly, seat height exerts a direct influence on a person's presence.

In daily life one can observe that leaders speaking, teachers lecturing, and even ancient emperors all chose elevated positions to display status and authority. When the two parties are equal in strength or one is slightly weaker, choosing a higher chair creates a psychological advantage whose effect often exceeds expectations.

If one does not wish to raise the seat yet still wants to strengthen one's presence, what can be done? Visitors to FBI headquarters notice that interrogation rooms mostly contain chairs with wheels. One might assume this is for easy movement, but that is not the case. During interviews the roles between agent and interviewee constantly shift; when the interaction moves from confrontation to cooperation, wheeled chairs allow the agent to slide quickly beside the interviewee to offer encouragement.

Thus the main reason FBI places wheeled chairs in interrogation rooms is to let agents adjust distance according to the conversation's dynamics, thereby controlling the interviewee's psychological state to extract more information. This method achieves an effect similar to raising the seat.

One can also choose chairs with armrests, because such chairs make it inconvenient for the other person to use hand gestures or other body movements, naturally diminishing their presence. To further reduce the other person's presence, one can even deliberately shorten one leg of the chair. Dr. Madairu once had students unknowingly sit on chairs whose legs had been shortened and made wobbly while performing attention-demanding proofreading work. Students working on the wobbly chairs made significantly more errors because the unstable chair seriously disrupted their concentration.

Of course, these techniques must be applied with moderation; overuse easily alerts the other person, and once suspicion arises the objective becomes difficult to achieve.

### **Nod Your Head, and the Other Person Will Say More**

Many times we see people handing out flyers along cars after the red light comes on. Some of them bow to each driver in the hope that the driver will roll down the window and accept the flyer they push into the car. People sitting inside the car are moved by the bow and roll down the window. Lowering one's posture is therefore the first step toward acceptance.

Jesse, an outstanding FBI negotiator, is called in whenever agents face a difficult suspect. For Jesse, the most common technique for getting a suspect to tell the truth is "nodding." Every time he meets an interviewee, Jesse opens with three sentences: "You are Mr. XX, right?" "You are the subject of this interview, correct?" "You are very punctual today!" Each interviewee nods three times in response. These three nods should not be underestimated; they make the exchange smoother because they signal agreement and act like subconscious hypnosis.

During the conversation Jesse nods to show agreement with what the interviewee says. When someone is speaking freely and receives no sign of agreement, they gradually lose the desire to continue. Most people only nod slightly while saying "mm-hmm" or "uh-huh," but the motion is too small to register. For interviewees who find it hard to open up, the low frequency of nodding is another reason they remain distrustful. Therefore Jesse listens with his whole body and nods noticeably. He often says, "If you want to pry open a suspect's mouth, nodding is essential."

American psychologist Dr. Matarazzo once conducted an experiment with police officers and firefighters. Twenty participants each spoke for about forty-five minutes on family background and educational experience, fifteen minutes per topic. In the first fifteen minutes the doctor listened normally; in the second he nodded vigorously; in the third he stopped nodding entirely. A recorder tracked how long each participant spoke.

The results showed that when the doctor nodded vigorously, seventeen of the twenty participants increased their speaking time. Nodding was perceived as a friendly act that satisfied the human need for social recognition.

The experiment also showed that slightly faster or more exaggerated nods worked better than ordinary ones. Checking one's own nod in a mirror reveals that a normal nod is usually too small to be effective.

When we want the other person to continue a topic at a certain rhythm, we can nod at the right moment to signal agreement. The motion makes them feel our enthusiasm and speak without reservation. When they fall silent, we can nod exaggeratedly and say, "Yes, what you said makes sense; I think so too." They will immediately feel favorably disposed and often resume the topic.

Communication between people is not complicated. As long as we keep nodding while listening attentively, the other person feels satisfied and keeps talking. If our nodding rate is twice the usual frequency, they sense twice the agreement and return it twofold.

### **Interrupt the Other Person's Speech, but Don't Let Your Own Be Interrupted**

Zorro was one of the most difficult interviewees FBI agent James ever faced. A former high-ranking government official, Zorro dominated every session with lengthy monologues and gave James no chance to object. Because Zorro was widely read, James rarely found an opening, and the first two interviews ended in failure, derailing the entire interrogation plan. James had no choice but to bring in his experienced supervisor, Peter.

Once they were seated, Peter asked a question and Zorro launched into his usual performance, expanding one question into many anecdotes and citing similar cases from home and abroad. While impressed by Zorro's knowledge, Peter refused to let the monologue derail his plan. He interrupted whenever Zorro was in full flow: "May I interrupt for a moment?" or "I'm not familiar with that incident—could you explain it?" At first Zorro stopped to explain once or twice, but as the interruptions increased he grew impatient. Unwilling to have his train of thought constantly broken, he said, "I haven't finished yet. Explain after I'm done." Peter did not yield. He replied firmly, "I really cannot follow what you are saying. If you do not clarify this part, I will understand even less of what follows." Zorro was forced to stop repeatedly and explain the points Peter claimed not to understand, completely disrupting his own line of thought.

In the end, unable to deliver a long speech, Zorro had to cooperate and complete the interview.

Interrupting someone is normally considered rude. Anyone whose speech is cut off without reason feels displeased, and frequent interruptions can be especially humiliating for people with strong self-esteem. Yet as a conversational technique, interrupting can exert pressure during an exchange, signaling "I know at least as much as you" or "What you are saying is not important enough for me to let you finish." The two most effective forms are asking the speaker to explain difficult terms or to illustrate abstract points with examples.

Interruption is used mainly in purposeful conversations such as business negotiations or interrogations. Dutch social psychologist Dr. Arco Kalma has said, "Keep interrupting the other person; that way you control the conversation and increase your own power." In his view, commercial negotiation is less a refined activity than a fight to the death. Although many businesspeople objected, experimental data ultimately supported the technique's effectiveness.

Dr. Kalma also noted that an interruption must succeed; failure carries serious consequences. If the attempt fails, the other person's momentum grows while yours weakens. Therefore one must weigh this risk before interrupting—or, like Peter in the example, force the interruption.

### **No Matter Who You Meet, Consciously Open Your Eyes Wide**

Helen of Greek myth summoned ships with her captivating gaze; national hero Davy Crockett drove off a bear with his eyes; lovers convey affection through their eyes... In many situations the eyes play a vital social role, and a well-judged glance can carry great impact.

A psychologist once showed participants two photographs of eyes—one wide open, the other slightly narrowed—and asked which they preferred. Most chose the wide-open pair.

People like wide eyes because the pupils dilate at the same time, making the eyes appear brighter and the person more energetic and lively. Wide eyes also send the message “I am very interested in you” or “I enjoy talking with you.” Recipients feel pleased and become more willing to engage.

Former FBI agent Charlie once gave a lecture at a university. Several hundred students filled the auditorium; Charlie was quickly drawn to one female student. Her appearance was unremarkable, yet he could not stop noticing her, as though the entire talk were addressed only to her.

The reason became clear when Charlie realized the student’s eyes were wide open and fixed on his face, as if eagerly absorbing every word. Her admiration energized him; he spoke fluently, adding many examples not in his notes, and the lecture ran long.

Afterward Charlie approached the student, hoping to discuss the talk. When he asked which part had impressed her most, she apologized and shook her head: “I’m sorry, I couldn’t hear you clearly. The student in front of me was wearing headphones, but the music was still loud. I had to read your lips and expressions instead.” Although her answer disappointed him, the impression of her wide-eyed attention remained vivid.

When people encounter something or someone they find interesting, their pupils dilate involuntarily. Observe men viewing photographs of women bathing: pupil dilation averages 11.3 percent; even with swimsuit photos the rate can reach 20 percent unconsciously. Therefore, whenever we meet anyone, consciously widening our eyes makes at least two to three times the impression we would make with normal eyes.

In daily interactions—with friends, clients, or superiors—avoid narrowing the eyes if you want to be liked. Narrowed eyes signal “Please stop,” “I dislike this topic,” or “I am not interested.” Instead, open your eyes wide; beautiful wide eyes open the other person’s heart and earn their trust.

### **Standing Conveys More Presence Than Sitting**

Recently a young university lecturer was criticized by the academic affairs office for sitting while teaching. The teacher felt the school’s rule requiring lecturers to stand was unfair.

Throughout history, “teachers stand while teaching” has been standard professional practice. Many schools regard standing as a basic requirement. Standing, they argue, brings energy to the lesson; sitting drains that energy and reduces student interest. Young teachers likewise believe sitting makes them appear listless and fails to engage students. Education experts note that while the two postures are not fundamentally different, standing facilitates interaction and improves classroom results.

A professor at the University of Washington surveyed the different effects of standing versus sitting. Participants viewed one photograph of a seated person and one of a standing person and were asked which posture seemed more imposing. Fifty-nine percent found the standing figure more imposing; forty-one percent chose the seated figure.

FBI supervisor Matt, the youngest in his unit, always stands when addressing agents. Even meetings on complex cases that last three or four hours are conducted standing. When asked why, Matt replies, “I am the youngest supervisor here—an outsider, essentially. Although I graduated from a top university, my practical experience is less than that of the veteran agents. I know this clearly. If I sat down during meetings, my professionalism, enthusiasm, and authority would all diminish. My weaknesses would become psychological disadvantages and my presence would shrink.”

A seated posture suits people who want to relax, but once the lower back relaxes, the voice loses projection. Therefore sitting is not recommended during conversation. Standing, by contrast, silently conveys the message: "I am now in attack mode and ready to engage you at any moment."

The higher the social status or power of the person you are addressing, the more important it is to stand, because the posture itself exerts a deterrent effect. Consider which feels more comfortable: looking down from above or looking up from below. The former, of course. When making a request—promotion, raise, leave—do so while the other person is seated and you are standing; success rates rise significantly.

The choice of posture must still suit the situation. If you wish to create a relaxed atmosphere, invite the other person to sit first, then sit yourself. Standing can heighten tension and turn light topics serious.

### **When Late for an Important Appointment, Don't "Apologize"—Say "Thank You"**

Although the words "I'm sorry" are easy to say, they must be used with care; apologizing is not always the right move. In certain situations an apology can give others leverage and exact an unforeseen cost.

"Thank you for waiting so long. Are you ready? Let's begin..." FBI agent Charlie's remark left Millie, who had waited fifteen minutes, with no further grounds to dwell on his lateness and no reason to refuse the interview.

You may wonder why Charlie did not apologize. Was he being rude? For Charlie the important interview had to reach its substance quickly; the case had already been delayed by Millie's repeated postponements. A simple "thank you" expressed gratitude while minimizing the awkwardness caused by his lateness.

Among FBI conversational techniques, refusing to apologize and saying "thank you" instead is one of the most assertive ways to seize control and is used frequently during interviews.

Whether in interrogations or ordinary exchanges, every word FBI agents use is carefully chosen; even a slight misstep can alter the atmosphere and outcome. Below are simple examples illustrating the importance of precise wording.

- **The difference between "but" and "and":** When agreeing with a friend's view you might say, "That's a good topic, but there are still many..." Your agreement is thereby discounted in the friend's mind. An FBI agent would say, "That's a good idea, and if we refine it a little it will be even better..."
- **The difference between "first" and "already":** When reporting a newly assigned task to a boss, one might say, "Boss, first I need to familiarize myself with the situation..." The boss may infer that much work remains undone. An FBI agent would typically reply, "Boss, I have already familiarized myself with the situation here..." The tone conveys optimism rather than pessimism about future progress.
- **The difference between "around X o'clock" and "exactly X o'clock":** When setting an interview time, FBI agents give a precise hour. They rarely say, "Are you free around nine on Wednesday? We'd like to talk." Such phrasing suggests uncertainty and implies the matter is not important. Instead they say, "We would like to speak with you at nine o'clock Wednesday morning. Do you have time?"

## **II. The Eyes Reveal Your Soul**

A smile is a weapon that displays friendliness outward, while the eyes are the window that reveals the mind. Gaze and eye contact are the most infectious forms of facial language. In interpersonal interactions, the eyes coordinate with spoken language to express countless variations of thought and emotion. The duration of eye

contact, the degree to which the eyelids are open, the extent of pupil dilation, and other changes in the eyes all convey the subtlest information.

During an interview, an experienced interviewer obtains various information about you by observing your gaze. Of course, if you are familiar with reading the micro-expressions in the interviewer's eyes, you can also gather useful intelligence from them.

When conversing with the interviewer, pay attention to the other person's expressions:

- Gaze directed upward from below generally indicates inquiry and means "I am willing to listen to you."
- Gaze directed downward from above generally means "I am paying attention to what you are saying."
- Head slightly tilted with gaze fixed on you generally means "Oh, so that's how it is."
- Eyes showing brightness generally indicate interest.
- Glancing at the watch every few seconds signals urgency or impatience and means the speaker hopes the other person will end the conversation.

If a candidate understands the meaning of eye language, they can skillfully use it to support their speech during the interview. The requirements for using eye language in an interview are:

1. Look at the other person with a natural, gentle, friendly, and sincere gaze. Each type of eye contact carries a specific meaning: direct gaze conveys seriousness; sideways glance conveys contempt; upward glance conveys contemplation; downward glance conveys shyness, and so on.
2. In the interview, gazing attentively at the other person shows strong interest in what they are saying. To avoid making the interviewer uncomfortable with prolonged staring, use "soft scattered gaze" appropriately by placing your eyes on the upper triangular area from the eyes to the middle of the forehead.
3. Avoid staring fixedly at the other person's eyes, as this will make them extremely uncomfortable. Also avoid letting your gaze dart up and down within a localized area, which will leave the other person baffled.
4. Do not look around or glance left and right, which appears distracted; do not hunch your chest and lower your head, which appears timid or uninterested; do not tilt your head high with eyes looking at the ceiling, which appears arrogant. All of these are signs of rudeness and lack of cultivation.
5. Note how often the other person blinks. Blinking 6–8 times per minute is normal. Excessive blinking indicates doubt about the truthfulness of what is being said, while a blink lasting more than one second becomes an eye closure, indicating disgust or disinterest.
6. When your eyes meet, maintain natural eye contact for 1–3 seconds before slowly looking away. This conveys openness and makes it easier to gain the other person's trust. Someone who immediately averts their gaze upon meeting another's eyes easily arouses suspicion or is seen as timid.

## II. Through the Boss's Eyes

The eyes are the window to the soul. A person's words can lie, but the subtle differences reflected in the eyes are hard to hide. No matter what scheme a person has in mind, their eyes will immediately and faithfully reveal what they are thinking. When dealing with a boss, if you can carefully observe their eye movements and gaze, you can discern their inner world.

1. The boss does not look at you at all while speaking, or even raises their head. This often means they look down on you, consider your abilities insufficient, and think your suggestions unworthy of consideration.

2. The boss looks down at you from above, indicating a person who likes to dominate others. This gaze expresses a sense of superiority as well as arrogance and self-importance.
3. The boss stares at you for a long time while you report work or present a plan, showing they expect more detailed and comprehensive information; their impression of you may still be incomplete.
4. The boss always appears sharp-eyed, as if wielding two swords, and maintains the same expression. This is a display of cold indifference and superiority, while also implying: "I can see through your thoughts one hundred percent! Do not try to deceive me!"
5. The boss occasionally glances upward, meets your eyes, then looks down again, repeating this several times, indicating they have not fully trusted you and are still uncertain about you.
6. When the conversation reaches the main point, the boss sometimes shifts their gaze into the distance, showing they have no interest in what you are saying; however, if their eyes suddenly brighten, it means what you said has caught their attention and sparked interest.
7. A dull look in the boss's eyes most likely means something unpleasant or unexpected has occurred.
8. A flickering gaze in the boss's eyes most likely means they are worried about something but cannot truly speak openly about it, or do not want to reveal the actual situation.
9. Continuous blinking by the boss indicates they are trying hard to suppress their emotions; if the blink is slower and larger in amplitude, it means they cannot believe their own eyes, so they blink hard to clear them and confirm whether what they see is real.
10. The boss's gaze shifts to the side with eyebrows slightly raised or a smile on the face, indicating interest; if the sideways glance is accompanied by lowered eyebrows, a furrowed brow, or downturned corners of the mouth, it signals suspicion, hostility, or a critical attitude.
11. The boss looks at subordinates in a friendly and candid manner, or sometimes winks at them: the subordinate is capable and likable, and even mistakes can be forgiven.
12. The boss gazes into the room while nodding slightly from time to time: this is a very bad signal, indicating the boss wants the subordinate to obey completely, regardless of what the subordinate says or thinks.

#### IV. Recognizing the "Expressions" of Closure—Leave in Time

You have paid attention to the interviewer's micro-expressions and to your own speech and demeanor. A good beginning and process are important, yet many people overlook the ending.

University graduate Xiao Li once chatted confidently with an interviewer for more than two hours during an interview. Toward the end, the interviewer began checking the time frequently, though still remaining polite in speech. Xiao Li failed to notice the interviewer's change and continued talking at length. Finally, when the interviewer's colleague rushed in to announce a meeting, the interviewer had to stand up politely, apologize, suggest rescheduling, and then leave hurriedly. Xiao Li did not shake hands or say goodbye when the interviewer departed.

Xiao Li had believed the job was certain, yet never received any response from the interviewer.

Successful interviews have a set time limit. Too short a time prevents a full presentation of oneself; too long wastes both parties' time. Within that period, the basic exchange of information is usually complete, so one can check whether the other party shows signs of wanting to end the interview.

If the interviewer keeps looking at the watch or changing posture, it means they want to conclude the interview. If you fail to notice and keep talking, the interviewer's impression of you will drop sharply. At the

end of the interview, no matter how pressed for time, always shake hands and say goodbye. If a candidate lacks even this perceptiveness and courtesy, job hunting will be difficult.

Usually, when an interviewer believes the interview should end, they send body-language signals indicating closure. You should recognize these cues.

There are three main signals:

1. The interviewer frequently checks the watch, meaning they are pressed for time or have grown impatient. The action often implies "You have already taken up a lot of my time," "Can't you see I dislike you?" or "We have said enough; it is time to go."
2. If the interviewer frequently changes sitting posture, it means they feel they have been sitting too long and need to shift position, indicating they have other matters to attend to and want the interview to finish quickly.
3. If the interviewer obviously looks around, rarely maintains eye contact, shifts their gaze elsewhere, or appears restless and fidgety, these all indicate they want to end the conversation. You should stop your long speech and conclude the talk.

At this point, you must still close the interview with proper courtesy. If you made a strong impression at the beginning and became the interviewer's preferred candidate, pay special attention to your final manners. Failing to observe small courtesies can still cost you the job you almost secured.

### **Interpreting the Boss's Hand Gestures**

1. The boss particularly likes to place both hands behind the back and clasp them while speaking, especially when inspecting work or facing subordinates. From any angle, this posture conveys authority, confidence, and strength.

However, if one hand behind the back grasps the wrist of the other, it indicates the boss is filled with frustration or anger; the higher the grip, the stronger the frustration or anger. The gesture is an attempt to regain a sense of control.

2. The boss likes to rub the palms together while speaking, conveying a positive expectation and heartfelt joy. Another situation: if the boss is undecided about something, they will also rub their hands together.
3. The boss likes to rest one hand on the cheek while listening. This gesture often means the topic feels uninteresting, your remarks fail to engage them, or they are thinking about their own matters and wish you would listen to them.
4. The boss always gestures animatedly while speaking, even on the phone, indicating strong work ability and the capacity to convey intended words and actions smoothly and effortlessly. Such a person can mobilize others and themselves, excelling at enlivening the atmosphere and uniting everyone.
5. An open palm always represents truthfulness, honesty, loyalty, and compliance. When wanting to show frankness and sincerity, the boss will extend one or both palms toward the other person—an often subconscious action indicating complete openness. If both hands are pressed together and downward with the body maintaining balance, it signifies moderation and calmness.
6. Hands on hips with elbows pointing outward: this is a traditional body-language posture of someone accustomed to giving orders, usually adopted when facing a concrete power issue.



7. The boss leans back in the chair, places both hands behind the head, and spreads the elbows outward: this certainly shows relaxation at the moment, but it may also indicate arrogance.
8. The boss pats a subordinate on the shoulder—signaling recognition and appreciation—yet only a pat from the side truly conveys acknowledgment and appreciation. A pat from the front or above indicates looking down on the subordinate or displaying power.
9. Fingers together forming a pyramid shape with fingertips pointing forward: a signal that the other person's suggestion will be rejected.
10. Clenching the hands into fists: not only to intimidate others but also to defend one's own viewpoint; striking the table with a fist is simply an attempt to prevent others from speaking.

## **I. Through the Boss's Head Movements**

Liu, the company sales manager, once submitted a payment request to the company owner. He felt quite uneasy at first because he had no idea whether the owner would approve it. While reading the document, the owner asked questions, and Liu answered truthfully and logically. After finishing, the owner lowered his head, thought for a moment, finally said "good," and offered some words of praise and support on the spot. Liu assumed the owner had agreed and felt relieved. He waited for the signed and stamped application to be issued, but one week passed, then two weeks, and the payment form remained untouched. When he finally asked a colleague in the owner's office, he learned the owner had been dissatisfied with the request all along and had simply left it on his desk.

Liu could not understand why the owner had said "good" to his face yet immediately went back on his word and rejected the request. In fact, he had not noticed that while the owner was saying "good," his head kept shaking slightly.

Head movements, also called cephalic language, are among the most common in interpersonal communication: nodding and shaking the head. The types are simple, yet because these movements are easier to overlook than body language or facial expressions and often occur unconsciously alongside speech, they are frequently missed.

Nodding generally expresses affirmation or approval. When the boss holds a positive or affirmative attitude, they will nod sincerely while speaking as a hint.

When the boss agrees with your viewpoint, observe their head movement. If accompanied by a slight nod, you can trust the answer. If the boss gives an affirmative reply without nodding, "lowers the head to think," or even shows signs of shaking the head, you can basically conclude the words do not match the true intention; do not place high expectations on the answer.

Shaking the head usually expresses "no." If the boss claims to agree with your opinion, check whether they make a slight head-shaking motion. If they offer various affirmations and promises while gently shaking the head, it reveals an underlying negative attitude.

If your boss tilts the head, leans forward, rests the chin on a hand, and appears thoughtful, it means your words carry considerable persuasive power and they are seriously considering your proposal. If your boss likes to tilt the head upward, you must not take it lightly. This signals an unequal dialogue and rejection of your proposal. You should proceed with caution.

## Explanation

Did you notice Mr. Miyashita's eyebrows drawing toward the center? Is this the micro-expression of "anger," or the conversational signal of "deep thought"? To distinguish "anger" from "deep thought," the key lies in the speed of the expression.

An instantaneous change with only slight alteration in complexion indicates the micro-expression of "anger"; if the change in complexion is obvious, it represents the conversational signal of "deep thought."

If it is the micro-expression of "anger," it can be understood as irritation caused by not understanding the clerk's explanation: "How do I log into the official website?", "What does this card mean?", "Does 'free' mean the battery is free, or is the monthly three-hundred-yuan membership fee free?" It is not difficult to imagine several reasons why Mr. Miyashita might feel puzzled.

For the micro-expression of "anger" in this case, a careful and easily understood explanation is advisable. Avoid unclear wording or omitted subjects; it is absolutely necessary to demonstrate how to use the membership card for the customer.

If it is the conversational signal of "deep thought," it means the clerk's explanation was difficult to understand. The cause of the difficulty can be viewed as the same as in the "anger" situation. The response method can also follow the same approach used for "anger."

However, if one wishes to advance a step further in customer service, the level of care and attentiveness toward Mr. Miyashita must be arranged differently according to whether the expression is "anger" or "deep thought."

Compared with "deep thought," "anger" is a more negative emotional state. Handling the micro-expression of "anger" requires finer attention. For example, adding words of apology, greeting the customer with a smile, and eliminating or confirming the causes of irritation and points of confusion one by one are all good ways to respond.

This case has a follow-up. Because Mr. Miyashita did not know how to log into the official website and three hundred yuan in membership fees were automatically deducted from his account each month, he angrily declared, "I will never buy anything from that store again! I had no idea what was going on, and three hundred yuan is still deducted every month. The explanation was far too sloppy!"

The possibility of losing a repeat customer because micro-expressions could not be read is the consequence this case illustrates.

## Missing the Micro-expression of "Contempt" Dooms the Presentation

The micro-expressions that require special attention during a presentation are those already discussed earlier, including "anger," "surprise," "disgust," "conversational signals," and "contempt." Among them, the micro-expression of "contempt" appears as "one corner of the mouth raised." At first glance this micro-expression resembles a smile. If the micro-expression of "contempt" is masked by a smile, detecting it correctly is quite difficult; missing the micro-expression of "contempt" leads to disastrous consequences.

If the presenter sees the audience listening with a "smile" and feels reassured, they will assume the presentation was successful. Yet the expression taken for a smile may actually be "contempt."

The listener may feel superior to you or look down on you. Mistaking the micro-expression of "contempt" for a smile becomes a major cause of presentation failure.

- A team member displays a "smile" while listening to the presentation but lacks motivation during execution.
- The general manager praises my proposal with a "smile," yet the proposal is ultimately not adopted.
- The interview examiner speaks to me with a smiling face; why was I not hired?
- The client signs the contract with a "smile." Could it be that I lowered the price too much?

Have you experienced anything of this sort? The reasons for these failures can of course be considered in various ways, but the possibility of mistaking the micro-expression of "contempt" for a smile is very high. Failing to perceive the true meaning of "contempt" is usually a major cause of presentation failure.

How can one notice the micro-expression of "contempt"? How should one respond once it is detected?

The key to noticing the micro-expression of "contempt" is to observe the other person's expression carefully while presenting the content in which you feel most confident.

The moment you think "Great! I am speaking really well right now" is especially important. Your confidence may make the other person feel "This person is not saying anything important at all!" This emotion can flash across the face as the micro-expression of "contempt," yet it is often masked by a "smile."

### **"Changes in the Buyer's Facial Expressions" Are Important Clues for Observation in Sales Negotiations**

In business negotiations or direct sales to consumers (clients) at retail locations, accurately assessing the other party's payment limit or sensing the depth of the client's pockets and appropriately suggesting an amount can facilitate a successful transaction.

On the other hand, when a contract is concluded, one may later regret that "it could have been sold at a higher price" or "there was still plenty of room in the other party's budget," or one may be overwhelmed by the client's momentum, resulting in poor sales performance and a selling price lower than the originally planned discount level. What causes these differences between successful and failed negotiations?

Success and failure in negotiation arise from a complex interplay of various factors, not from any single cause. However, performance achieved through negotiation is closely tied to the ability to read facial expressions, as confirmed by experiments conducted by Hillary Anger Elfenbein, professor of organizational behavior at Washington University.

These experiments established that sellers who achieve good results in negotiations possess a highly developed ability to accurately interpret facial expressions. In contrast, buyers' negotiation ability showed no correlation with their facial recognition skills.

Although the experiments did not clearly reveal how sellers effectively use buyers' facial information to close deals, inferences from other negotiation experiments and real-world negotiation experience suggest that the combination of "changes in the buyer's facial expressions" and "differences in how buyers and sellers perceive product information" plays an effective role. Generally, sellers possess more information about a product than buyers.

In other words, high-performing sellers can detect changes in the buyer's interest, preferences, or budget range and adjust the strength of their product pitch points, recommend suitable items, and skillfully leverage

their product knowledge to make sales. Of course, the ability to interpret a buyer's psychological state from facial expressions and apply that information varies depending on the seller's choice of words and depth of product knowledge.

A seller's facial recognition ability can be considered a necessary condition for successful negotiation.

## Find Your Own Position

The famous French fabulist La Fontaine<sup>[^1]</sup> once told a story about the stomach and the limbs—

The limbs no longer wanted to work for the stomach; they wished to live a leisurely, gentlemanly life. They said: "Without our hard labor, the stomach would have nothing but the northwest wind to drink. We toil like beasts every day, all for its sake. Yet while we sweat and suffer here, it sits there well fed and watered. Let's strike and make the stomach understand that we have been sustaining it all along."

So the hands stopped grasping, the legs rested, and everyone unanimously told the stomach to find its own food and drink.

Yet the poor limbs, deprived of nourishment and fresh blood, soon grew weak. They finally realized that although the stomach appeared idle every day, its contribution to the collective was no less than that of the limbs.

This story teaches us:

- In any collective, each person has their own division of labor and responsibilities. The "limbs" cannot demand that the "stomach" perform tasks outside its scope, and vice versa. Whether you are an ordinary employee or a manager, you must maintain a clear understanding of your role, neither neglecting your duties nor overstepping boundaries, and remain vigilant against role misalignment.
- Only when everyone fulfills their respective roles and responsibilities can the whole operate organically and protect the interests of each individual. Otherwise, not only does one suffer, but the collective is also harmed.

Upon entering the workplace, the first task is to clarify your identity, define your responsibilities, and establish a clear sense of your position. The Temple of Apollo at Delphi bears the ancient Greek maxim that has influenced humanity for millennia: Know thyself. If you aspire to become an excellent manager, you must first develop a clear and accurate understanding of yourself before becoming the boss. Only by recognizing your role in the workplace will you know how to manage and be managed, and what to say or not say. Conversely, if one's self-positioning deviates, not only will one fail to utilize one's talents and contributions effectively, but one will also hinder others' work and damage both personal reputation and company interests.

## Techniques for Leading Negotiations

Next, let us examine how sellers, in negotiation scenarios, apply facial recognition skills in concrete situations. The procurement process is divided into several stages; here we focus on the final stage—"whether to confirm the purchase of the product." We consider the situation from the seller's perspective in business negotiations or retail sales.

You have already provided a detailed product explanation to the potential buyer and fully answered all questions. You have said nearly everything you can; your remaining cards are almost played out. The buyer's questions gradually decrease, and both you and the buyer fall into silence. The final moment of decision is

approaching. Will they buy, or not? Before you and the other party are Product A and Product B displayed side by side. At this moment, the negotiating counterpart may be considering comparisons between the old and new products, between Product A and Product B, or between price and budget. Imagine the various possibilities.

Under these circumstances, various expressions or micro-expressions (微表情) appear on the buyer's face. Which expression or micro-expression indicates a willingness to purchase or sign a contract, so that one more push will result in a "deal"?

In conclusion, when a certain degree of emotion appears on the other party's face, that expression must be taken seriously; the display of emotion indicates that the buyer is using it to help confirm their decision, meaning they are considering whether to buy.

Whether the emotion appears as a regular expression or a micro-expression depends on the importance of the situation. Compared with purchasing a small item in a store, concluding a large contract in a business negotiation places heavy responsibility on the buyer, who must therefore conceal their true intentions, making micro-expressions more likely. Even in small purchases, if the client's budget is limited yet the item must be bought, the decision's importance increases and micro-expressions may appear.

## II. The Pupils That See Straight into the Client's Heart

During a business meeting, junior salesperson Xiao Zeng accompanied Manager Liu to meet a client. The client nitpicked the samples relentlessly. Xiao Zeng grew restless while watching Manager Liu, who remained calm, held the price line, and eventually the meeting ended unhappily.

Curious, Xiao Zeng asked Manager Liu, who smiled confidently and replied, "They will call soon and accept all our terms." Xiao Zeng wondered whether Manager Liu had become overconfident.

A few days later, the client did call and accepted almost all of Manager Liu's conditions for the batch. Xiao Zeng was astonished. Manager Liu then revealed the key: although the client had expressed extreme dissatisfaction with the product, Manager Liu noticed that when the client's boss picked up the sample, his pupils immediately dilated, indicating that only this company's product met their requirements; the criticisms were merely bargaining tactics.

The human pupil is one of the most honest organs; it enlarges or shrinks according to psychological changes. When a person sees something they like, their pupils dilate even if their face remains expressionless. This dilation and constriction can accurately reveal a person's mental activity and its shifts.

If a client's pupils dilate while examining materials you hand them, it indicates liking or excitement, and your work can proceed smoothly. Conversely, if the pupils constrict, the client is in a negative, guarded, or even angry state, and you must devise another approach.

Clients often criticize your product with various excuses. When facing such clients, always check their pupils first. If the pupils dilate, they are lying. Hold your ground. If necessary, add bargaining chips to the transaction and do not be misled by their words.

## Section 5: Precautions for Recognizing Micro-Expressions

The preceding text introduced many workplace applications of micro-expressions. In practice, the most important factor is the accumulation of daily experience. Some widely circulated techniques for reading micro-

expressions may reflect momentary subconscious reactions or habitual movements rather than fixed rules; one should not rigidly apply micro-expression doctrines such as "eyes looking left indicate recall, looking right indicate fabrication of lies," since habits differ between individuals and between Eastern and Western cultures. Colleagues should therefore maintain good daily interactions and familiarity so that micro-expression techniques can be applied while minimizing misreadings.

In many work situations—discussing progress, reporting status, or addressing responsibility issues—observing the other party's movements, demeanor, and micro-expressions to identify their bottom line protects oneself and provides the advantage of knowing both sides. In reality, both parties at the negotiating table usually possess some intuitive "people-reading" experience, even if it has not been systematized into academic "micro-expression" knowledge. Tension is typically higher in meetings and negotiations, so micro-expressions may appear more briefly and require sharper observation.

In the workplace, is there a way to correct one's own micro-expressions? Micro-expressions are often mistaken for habitual actions without awareness of the underlying emotions. One can adopt daily stress-release methods such as running or listening to music. Asking friends to observe your micro-expressions can also help identify and correct undesirable ones that appear under pressure.

Focusing excessive energy on "reading faces" is insufficient and may even invert priorities. Strengthening professional knowledge and continuously improving one's capabilities so that one's abilities truly match job requirements remains the fundamental way to prevail in competition.

### **Dangerous Signals That Destroy Relationships**

Although views on maintaining marriage differ, the key to marital harmony lies in a balanced relationship of mutual respect together with care and tolerance—principles that should be universal. Love, in the end, is about learning to "accept."

Consider the act of kissing. If a stranger placed their tongue in one's mouth, the mere thought would evoke disgust; yet with one's lover it is acceptable. Love initially transforms rejection into acceptance. Once "disgust" (expressing a sense of rejection) arises, separation naturally follows.

Dr. Gottman has also studied couples' interactions. The logic of relationship breakdown is that the emotion of "contempt" destroys the balance of mutual respect, while the emotion of "disgust" converts tolerance (acceptance) into rejection, causing intimate relationships to collapse. This applies not only to spouses but also to romantic partners and other interpersonal relationships.

Observational evidence confirms that displays of "contempt" and "disgust" are dangerous signals of impending relationship destruction.

A group leader, speaking critically of a rival organization before a crowd, displayed a combination of "anger," "contempt," and "disgust" on their face, igniting riots or terrorist attacks. The precise mechanism by which such an expression combination incites violence remains unclear.

It is conceivable, however, that the messages conveyed by "anger," "contempt," and "disgust"—images of "aggression," "moral superiority," and "rejection"—become embedded in the crowd's subconscious, stirring thoughts that translate into direct action.

### **The Micro-Expression of "Anger" as a Moment to Apologize**

Suppose you are a salesperson or receptionist. While explaining product features, a client suddenly displays a micro-expression of "anger." Why might the client feel angry? Various possibilities exist. Your explanation may be too slow, too complex, or too fragmented for the client to grasp the main points. Conversely, it may be too fast, too jumbled, or too abstract. Repeatedly explaining what the client already understands can also cause annoyance.

"Anger" is an emotion triggered by "obstacles to achieving a goal." The client's goal in listening to the product explanation is to decide whether to purchase. The obstacle can therefore be defined as whether they can efficiently obtain the information needed to decide.

How to remove this obstacle, and whether the client can obtain the necessary conditions, are important considerations. When a crisis arises and you detect the client's micro-expression of "anger," apologize immediately.

"I'm sorry my explanation was unclear! Please tell me what you most want to know." Responding appropriately in this manner can ease the client's "anger" and steer the conversation toward the client's needs.

How, then, should one handle a client whose face conveys a message of "deep thought" or puzzlement?

The "deep thought" situation is easier to understand than "anger." When a client shows "deep thought," they are usually puzzled by your explanation. The response is similar to handling "anger," but in most cases, providing a careful explanation, allowing time for reactions during the explanation, and appropriately asking for the client's thoughts prove more effective.

### **Do You Want to Know How Much Your Boss Trusts You?**

The relationship between superior and subordinate is based purely on business. A superior selects you as a subordinate because of the company's operational needs, not for personal social or recreational reasons.

If a superior does not trust a subordinate, they generally will not assign important tasks. A calculating superior may put on a show of trust and utter inspiring words. If you believe those words literally, the blow will be exceptionally heavy when you later realize they were false. If you notice your superior unconsciously rubbing their eyes while talking with you, looking at the floor while raising their eyebrows, tilting their head slightly downward to one side, or pressing their lips together with a forced smile at the corners, these actions clearly indicate a negative attitude and show that their words are insincere.

If your superior's previously smiling face suddenly turns gloomy, their hands resting on the table are drawn back to their chest, their eyebrows knit together, and from then on they stop saying things like "Everything depends on you" or "I feel at ease with you handling it," while ignoring your suggestions or taking measures such as sidelining you or narrowing your scope of work, it means they have never truly trusted you.

Even if this is the case, do not develop feelings of inferiority, lose motivation, or discard what little confidence you have, nor should you reproach or despise your superior with thoughts of "So that's the kind of person they are." Recognize that this is simply a superior's standard method of motivating subordinates. What you should actually do is work harder to enrich and demonstrate yourself, gradually increasing your superior's trust in you.

## **II. Micro-Expressions During Colleague Collaboration**

For colleagues to work in harmony, they must learn to read faces and understand each other's true thoughts. The following 11 common micro-expressions are provided for reference.

1. Speaking rapidly, holding an object in front of the chest as a barrier, and deliberately maintaining distance from the interlocutor indicate anxiety.
2. The corners of the mouth turning downward is a classic expression of having made a mistake.
3. When asking a question one already knows the answer to, the eyebrows rise slightly.
4. Facial features drawing toward the center of the face indicate hidden dislike.
5. Hands placed flat at the sides with a rigid posture is a "stop" gesture, indicating the person is in a state of irritation or anger.
6. Genuine versus feigned anger: suddenly speaking loudly accompanied by strong body language; if there is a time gap between the two, the anger is feigned.
7. When inquiring about something, if the other party's shoulder on one side twitches, it indicates lack of confidence in what they are saying.
8. Nostrils flaring outward with lips tightly closed indicates anger.
9. Hands clasped and rubbing together: a typical self-soothing posture, usually indicating that the person does not believe what they are saying and is trying to reassure themselves.
10. Touching the forehead or brow ridge as if wiping sweat indicates shame.

People who "get along well" in the workplace are simply those who say the right things and do the right things to the right people at the right times. In workplace interactions, one must always pay attention to the other party's state, emotions, and psychological needs.

In workplace interpersonal interactions, knowing how to "read faces" is extremely important. Whether requesting a raise from a superior or collaborating with colleagues, you need sharp observational skills to interpret others' thoughts. Correctly applying micro-expression techniques minimizes misunderstandings and helps build rapport with colleagues more quickly.

### **Before Divorce, There Are Precursors in Facial Expressions During Communication**

#### **Case:**

You are discussing your child's education with your wife. She wants the child to attend a private elementary school, but you believe a public school is sufficient. Opinions clash and an argument nearly breaks out.

Wife: "Honey, I want the child to go to a private elementary school. If accepted, it is basically a direct path to university, which will be very helpful for finding a job in the future."

You: "Public school is fine. Simply studying hard will not make the child a mature adult. Besides, how can we know they will easily find a good job in the future?"

Wife: "Is it not good to study well? And I am not saying it will be easy, I am saying it will be 'helpful.'"

#### **Question:**

What action should you take in response to your wife's reaction?

#### **Explanation:**

Your expression shows the left corner of your mouth raised. This is the micro-expression of "contempt." From your wife's expression when she speaks her second line, wrinkles appear around the nose and the nasolabial folds form a bell shape, with the upper lip pulled upward, indicating the micro-expression of "disgust." Both "contempt" and "disgust" carry rejection and can interrupt the ongoing communication.



Of course, a single instance of the "contempt" or "disgust" micro-expression will not seriously damage the relationship, but if such emotional states continue to appear, the couple may enter the countdown to divorce.

To maintain marital harmony, it is important to apologize to your wife, show that you are willing to lower your posture, and once again express respect for her. For example: "Sorry, sorry! Could you bring me the school information so we can discuss it together?" Keeping the conversation going is most important.

## 1. Pay Attention to Your Gaze

You observe others through your gaze, and others observe you through your gaze. Using your gaze well leaves the best impression on colleagues, superiors, and clients. Below are three different methods of using gaze and their occasions.

1. **Staring:** When communicating and listening, staring is the most commonly used gaze. Focus your eyes on the other person. For business matters, limit the gaze to the forehead down to the eyes to convey sincerity and seriousness. For social situations, look at the triangular area from the eyes to the mouth.
2. **Scanning:** When you are seated with a group in a meeting room and they are listening to your speech, pay attention to scanning... During scanning, look forward and then sweep purposefully. The benefit is that everyone listening feels you are paying attention to them rather than communicating with any single individual, allowing you to gain a more comprehensive understanding of the audience's psychological reactions. You can also adjust the rhythm, content, and tone of your speech at any time based on the scan, maintaining control of the conversation. Make each person feel you are looking at them. The specific method is to focus primarily on the main target (the highest-ranking person present) and move your gaze from left to right, then right to left (or front to back, then back to front) to achieve simultaneous communication with everyone present, avoiding neglecting anyone and thereby gaining unanimous goodwill.
3. **Soft focus:** This is looking without truly focusing. Speeches require alternating between soft and focused gaze—"focused" on a portion of the audience, "soft" on everyone. A speech should achieve "no one in the eyes, yet everyone in the heart."

## 4. Watch the Client's Micro-Expressions During Negotiations

During meetings and negotiations, micro-expressions can be used to determine whether the other party is deliberately provoking, shifting responsibility, or lying, achieving the goal of knowing both yourself and the opponent to win every battle.

1. Repeating the question stiffly when answering is a typical sign of lying.
2. Rubbing the nose is an attempt to hide the truth. (This has been explained earlier.)
3. Raising the chin and pursing the lips indicates embarrassment.
4. Chin raised and corners of the mouth turned down indicates self-blame.
5. If you make a mistake, the other party will show a slight upward curl of the mouth corners that quickly returns to normal.
6. Shrugging one shoulder or pressing the lower lip while speaking indicates extreme lack of confidence in what is being said.
7. Inconsistency between body and words indicates lying; facial expressions that are asymmetrical left to right are the same, and such emotions are likely fabricated. For example, before shaking the head to deny something while lying, there may be a momentary nod.
8. Left corner of the mouth raised with lips tightly closed indicates contempt.

Every change in the client's expression or demeanor may signal the end of further business discussion. Therefore, astute professionals must capture every subtle tremor and change in the client's expression and demeanor, promptly inferring the client's psychology from these changes and identifying the other party's bottom line. This protects oneself and provides a path to knowing both sides for victory in every battle. In fact, both parties at the negotiation table are usually more nervous than usual, so micro-expressions may appear for shorter durations than normal, requiring sharper observational skills.

### **Frequent Eye Contact Can Also Convey Affection**

If one wishes to prevent relationship breakdowns such as divorce, breakup, or violence before they occur, what should be done? Relationship breakdown results from the interweaving of various complex factors and has no simple solution. However, from the perspective of expression studies, the following two methods are recommended.

The first method is to observe the other person's expressions regularly. This allows clear mastery of the other person's emotional changes and expression characteristics, enabling more sensitive detection when emotions shift. Once emotional changes are noticed, appropriate words or actions can be used to respond at any time. Furthermore, being frequently noticed by a loved one creates a sense of being acknowledged, which pleases the other person. Simply paying attention to the other person's expressions in daily life can maintain the relationship and reduce the likelihood of disputes.

The second method is to watch for "contempt" and "disgust" expressions on the other person's face during arguments. When these expressions appear, the person will not accept what is being said. Therefore, in such situations, regardless of how unreasonable the other person seems, one must temporarily accept their statements and apologize.

No matter how justified one's position, insisting on it at this moment will only sever communication between both parties. This damages the relationship and begins a downward spiral in the relationship.

Properly interpreting expressions and micro-expressions allows prediction of future interpersonal relationships and construction of a mutually desired future.

### **Are "Interest and Concern" Conversational Signals Faked?**

How should one respond when a client displays conversational signals of "interest and concern"? The client may genuinely be interested, or may simply be matching your tone.

Some clients deliberately display "interest and concern" out of consideration for the salesperson. However, there are also cases where the expression is not deliberately faked but naturally emerges during the conversation. Upon seeing signals of interest, no immediate response is required.

When explaining a product, if the client raises both eyebrows for two to three seconds, displaying an "interest and concern" appearance, it may indicate continuous interest or a deliberate display of "surprise." When "interest and concern" reactions appear consecutively, even if not in deep thought, the client may have questions about your words, desire more information, or simply be interested.

The key to distinguishing genuine "interest and concern" from acting "surprise" is the presence of a smile. "Interest and concern" signals are usually accompanied by a slight smile. A faked "surprise" expression raises both eyebrows noticeably, opens the mouth wide, and gives an artificial impression. "Surprise" micro-

expressions are harder to fake. However, interpreting a client's "surprise" micro-expression reveals what the client is truly interested in.

### **The Micro-expression of "Surprise" Is the Best Time for Explanation**

If, under the same circumstances, the client's face shows a "surprise" micro-expression, what does that mean? Compared with "anger," surprise is a very brief emotion whose meaning is also quite limited. Therefore, the micro-expression of "surprise" is a critical focal point, indicating a high likelihood that the client is particularly interested in a specific part of the explanation. So when a client displays a "surprise" micro-expression, that point should be explained in greater detail.

Sometimes the selling points a salesperson or receptionist wants to emphasize differ from the points the client wants to hear. When the desire to close the deal is too strong, the salesperson may enthusiastically rattle off product features that have nothing to do with what the client actually wants to know. Like a double-edged sword, this approach has both advantages and disadvantages. There are certainly cases closed through enthusiasm and sincerity, yet there are also countless examples of deals that fall through.

Moreover, this nonstop "hawking" style suits extroverted, lively people with a natural sales personality. Adjusting the sales approach according to the client's micro-expressions and conversational cues is less constrained by personal character or temperament; it is a method anyone can use to improve sales skills and raise the probability of a successful close.

### **Being Able to Speak Does Not Equal Successful Communication If You Cannot Read People**

Many professional courses and books focus on "successful presentation techniques" or "precise speaking skills." A presentation is the act of conveying key points and core messages to others. Therefore it is important to craft strong openings and closings and to learn appropriate vocabulary, tone of voice, body language, and conversational style.

"Conveying" is not merely a one-way transmission of information; it is a two-way process that requires observing the other person's reactions. Learning how to convey a message means mastering not only speaking techniques but also the ability to interpret the listener's responses.

Studying only the sending side is like learning only the speaking portion of English conversation.

No matter how fluently you speak English, if you cannot understand what the other person says, a conversation cannot take place. Likewise, no matter how skilled you are at speaking, if you cannot read the other person's reactions during the exchange, you cannot know whether your message has been received correctly.

To optimize presentation skills, the following sections therefore focus on the micro-expressions that must be watched most carefully.

### **② Precursors of "Disgust," "Fear," and "Sadness"**

When a buyer shows a "disgust" expression, it indicates that although the person wants to buy, they cannot yet make the decision; some condition is causing hesitation. At this point, a compromise must be found.

When a buyer shows a "fear" expression or micro-expression, it means the buyer will be troubled if they do not purchase the item. A firm stance while waiting for a decision is one approach, but offering some

concession will usually lead to a smoother transaction.

A “sadness” expression or micro-expression carries the same possibility as fear: it signals regret that the purchase may not happen and is a sign that a decision is imminent. If the seller wants the item purchased, it is necessary to explore how to reach agreement.

“Contemplation” conversational cues also frequently appear on a buyer’s face. The moment a buyer shows “contemplation,” the seller should seize the opportunity to emphasize selling points or restate key sales information to deepen the impression and give the wavering buyer a helpful nudge.

### **What to Do When You Detect a “Contempt” Micro-expression**

When the emotion of “contempt” expresses a claim of superiority, the person displaying contempt feels superior to you and will seize any chance to demonstrate that superiority. Therefore, when a “contempt” micro-expression appears, the appropriate response is to “allow the other person to assert superiority.”

Using the earlier example, if the other party shows a “contempt” micro-expression toward your opinion, you can stimulate their sense of superiority with statements such as:

“What does Mr. ○○ think?” “My idea seems inadequate.” “If my suggestion needs improvement, how would you do it better?”

In contract negotiations, during the final price discussion, if the other party shows a “contempt” micro-expression, they are likely thinking, “I won this price negotiation!” In such cases, consider offering non-price concessions or added-value options.

### **“Anger” and “Surprise” Expressions That Salespeople Must Remember**

The micro-expressions sales and reception staff most need to remember are “anger” and “surprise,” along with the corresponding conversational cues.

Ideally, one would master every type of micro-expression and respond appropriately. Yet if priorities must be set, the most important are the micro-expressions of “anger” and “surprise” and the conversational signals of the “concentration” face and the “information-gathering” face.

The reason is that the core task of sales or reception work is explaining products and services. When clients cannot understand the explanation, they display the “concentration” face in order to follow the content. When they are interested and want to learn more, they show the “information-gathering” face.

Accurately reading the customer’s state of mind, knowing when to add selling points and when to skip explanations, is a vital skill for sales and reception staff. Let us now examine concrete situations.

## **Section 1 Using Micro-expressions Appropriately in Interviews**

The first threshold when moving from campus to society is the job interview. Even the calmest person feels nervous facing a stern interviewer; no matter how hard you try to stay composed, your micro-expressions may still betray you.

Many graduates are eliminated because their micro-expressions reveal them, with interviewers citing “poor psychological resilience.” How a candidate reacts under pressure is often something interviewers deliberately test. Sometimes they even pose pressure-inducing questions to observe the response.

The best way to eliminate unfavorable impressions and present your best self is to reduce your own stress. Chewing gum, listening to music, or focusing on deep breathing before the interview can all help. In addition, pay attention to the following points:

## **Section 6 Watching Your Partner's Micro-expressions**

When you begin a relationship, use micro-expressions to read the other person. After marriage, monitoring your spouse's micro-expressions is also an important topic.

During dating, micro-expressions in the matchmaking phase often conceal personal shortcomings; in the cohabitation phase they more often hide mistakes. Once married, the relationship gradually settles into a stable state that involves mutual exposure and systematic desensitization. At this stage micro-expressions also help coordinate the couple's relationship—for example, by pinpointing problems more accurately when repairing the bond. Given the average statistic that people lie three times in every ten minutes of conversation, it is necessary to stay alert to small cracks in the relationship, whether to prevent problems or to "stockpile grain."

### **① Pay Attention to the "Social Smile"**

First, consider the situations in which a social smile appears. When a buyer displays a social smile, it can be viewed as a sign that further negotiation is desired or that the negotiation is about to collapse. A genuine smile indicates satisfaction with everything. If a buyer maintains a genuine smile throughout the purchasing process right up to the final moment, the buyer is likely to proceed directly to purchase. However, when a social smile appears, it suggests the buyer is trying to curry favor with the seller—perhaps a prelude to "Can you lower the price a bit more?"—or a sign that the buyer hopes the relationship will not deteriorate and wants to reset the negotiation to its original blank-slate state. Experience shows that a social smile surfacing at the final stage of negotiation often signals an impending breakdown, a tendency frequently observed among Japanese and other Asian negotiators.

### **(3) Recognizing Different Types of Colleagues**

It can be said that the types of people you meet on the street are the same types you will meet as colleagues in the workplace.

Some people stay busy all day yet produce no results. Some work hard only when the boss is watching and become lazy the moment the boss leaves. Some remain silent but deliver impressive results. Some are passionate about work and warm toward others yet constantly make mistakes... Only by identifying each colleague's type can you adopt the right approach and reduce friction and conflict. For example, with colleagues who habitually watch the boss's face or those who stay silent, you must remain alert, because they often say one thing to your face and another behind your back. With outgoing, straightforward colleagues, careful attention can yield a great deal of useful information.

## **Reading the Other Party's "Hidden Emotions" in Business Meetings and Negotiations**

This chapter introduces micro-expressions that require special attention in common work and daily-life scenarios. What micro-expressions may be hidden during ordinary conversations without any particular purpose?

Business negotiations involve the exchange of various ideas and objectives. Some emotions are expressed directly; others remain hidden. When ideas or objectives must be concealed, there is usually a reason for doing so.

What causes these hidden emotions, and how should one respond? This section explains how to detect the other party's true intentions in meetings and negotiations and how to adjust the direction and focus of the conversation accordingly.

### **Detecting “Danger Signals” Hidden in Emotions in Daily Life**

Even with close people, etiquette must be observed. In other words, one should remain courteous toward those nearest to oneself—family members, romantic partners, good friends. No matter how well you know each other or how attuned your minds are, directly expressing inner feelings can still feel awkward.

Sometimes familiarity makes one even more reluctant to let the other person know one's deepest thoughts. Yet in such cases the relationship may develop shadows precisely because genuine emotions are being hidden. How can one avoid invading the other person's privacy while preserving important relationships?

This chapter introduces, from the world of micro-expressions, potential crisis situations between spouses, lovers, and parents and children, as well as techniques for maintaining interpersonal bonds.

### **Chapter 8 Micro-expressions, Great Success**

Once you master the recognition of micro-expressions, you hold a window into the other person's inner world. Applying this skill successfully in the workplace and in life gives you a powerful advantage, allowing you to interact with greater confidence and precision.

Usually, when people hear or see something they like or dislike, or feel uncomfortable with the person they are talking to, their body language changes. These changes require you to develop a keen “sense of smell” to read their “micro-expressions” and infer their psychology. In this way you can navigate smoothly both at work and in daily life.

### **③ Use Gaze as a Clue When a “Neutral” Expression Appears**

If the buyer maintains a “neutral” expression until the end of the negotiation, their thoughts and intentions are difficult to read. However, one usable clue is the buyer's gaze. Does the buyer's gaze rest on the product? If it remains fixed on a particular point, it indicates interest in the item and that the buyer has reached the final consideration stage. People's eyes naturally drift toward things that interest them. Likewise, when thinking, people's eyes tend to fix on a single point. The appropriate response is the same as for “contemplation”: seize the moment to emphasize key selling points.

### **Case Study**

After purchasing a personal computer, Mr. Miyashita was persuaded by the salesperson to sign up for a membership card. The card costs three hundred yen per month; if the computer breaks, the card provides warranty coverage and priority service.

The salesperson explained:

Salesperson: "Please register on the official website. Whether it's a battery replacement or any other part, with this card everything is free."

Mr. Miyashita: "I see. Understood."

After completing the purchase, Mr. Miyashita left the store.

## **(5) Knowing When to Yield**

Colleagues are peers, and the relationship among them is the most delicate and difficult to harmonize within a company. Competing for limited opportunities, mutual wariness, exclusion, and suspicion are common. As a newcomer, to win colleagues' goodwill you must know when to yield. Opportunities that will not significantly advance your career are better given generously to colleagues; there is no need to fight tooth and nail for them. Doing so not only earns goodwill but also allows you to observe the company environment more calmly and prepare for better opportunities.

## **(2) Do More, Talk Less**

Once you start working, you must settle down and persuade colleagues through actual performance. In the workplace, ability is your most important "weapon." No matter how eloquently you speak, without ability you will eventually be eliminated. In addition to your assigned duties, here is a small technique for gaining goodwill: perform "small favors." For example, when fetching the newspaper, bring a colleague's copy as well; when buying coffee, bring one for a colleague too.

## **Reading the Other Party's Reactions During a Presentation**

This section explains how to pay attention to the listener's expressions while conveying information. When "conveying" a message, speaking style, tone of voice, facial expressions, movements, and gestures must all be considered, and the receiver's responses must be correctly interpreted so that the message is accurately conveyed and understood.

Words alone cannot determine the listener's true intent. The following therefore introduces the how and why of reading the listener's expressions in order to achieve two-way dialogue.

## **(3) Observing Personal Taste**

A person's clothing, shoes, tie, bag, watch, and other personal items can reveal cultural taste and lifestyle aspirations.

Ordinary managers spend enormous time and energy formulating strategic plans, budgets, and project collaborations, working diligently for the company, yet they may fail because of poor personnel decisions. Enlightened managers know how to assign the right people to the right tasks, thereby achieving goals with ease and shaping the future.

## **(1) Playing the Sincere and Humble Self**

Before you fully understand a colleague's personality, temperament, and work habits, you must be cautious—extremely cautious—to avoid stepping on landmines without realizing it. To win the goodwill of senior employees, show your sincere side so they know you genuinely respect them, want to learn from them, and

welcome their guidance. If there are female colleagues, preparing small gifts can help; believe me, they will be happy to accept your “bribe.”

### **(1) Observing Personal Image**

This is the basic reference for correctly positioning a person. By observing how someone is perceived and spoken of by those around them, you can roughly judge their way of dealing with others. If you want a more detailed understanding, pay attention during interaction to facial expressions, posture, speaking style, and other characteristics to form a basic internal assessment.

## **Section 2 Reading Your Boss’s Micro-expressions**

Once you successfully enter the workplace, in this fiercely competitive environment, knowing more about micro-expressions will greatly benefit your development. For a newcomer, the most important skill is naturally learning to read your boss’s or superior’s micro-expressions and thereby discern their inner motives by watching their demeanor.

Below we examine in detail how to read a superior through “micro-expressions.”

### **3. Your Boss’s Hand-gesture Signals**

Compared with speech, hand gestures carry more information and convey richer, more precise emotional experiences. Moreover, gestures are harder to “fake”; even when someone tries hard to conceal their feelings, their hand movements will quietly reveal their inner emotions and psychological state. When communicating with your boss, a little observation of hand movements can clarify their views and attitudes.

## **Who Is Listening to You?—How the FBI Wins Hearts and Minds**

FBI agents have summarized from years of field experience that psychological activity governs all human behavior. Whether defeating an opponent, gaining the upper hand, turning an enemy into a friend, or resolving conflict, “winning hearts and minds” is an effective shortcut. As the saying goes, “To catch the thief, first catch the leader; to win people over, first win their hearts.” Skillful use of “heart-winning tactics” often lets you achieve twice the result with half the effort and open the way to victory.

### **(4) Making Full Use of Free Time**

After work, participating in gatherings, watching movies, or playing golf with colleagues will help you integrate into the group more quickly. If you dislike lively events or are not good at sports, sending a greeting card on holidays or colleagues’ birthdays is another option. In short, avoid giving the impression that you keep yourself separate from the group.

## **Not Understanding Colleagues Means You Deserve to Be Excluded**

To succeed in a company, winning your boss’s favor is not enough. If you cannot build good relationships with colleagues, you will face greater doubt and pressure. As a newcomer you must earn colleagues’ goodwill so you can reduce resistance and gain more resources and opportunities.

### **(2) Observing Their Network**



Birds of a feather flock together. To understand a person's aspirations, look at the people around them. From their relatives, friends, and even rivals you can discern their true character and dispel certain misconceptions.

## **How to Read People?**

There are many methods—this book is built around that core. If all the methods I have mentioned are strung together, they can be summarized into three basic principles.

## **Section 3 Micro-expressions When Communicating with Clients**

When you face a client, you must also pay special attention to their micro-expressions, because the client relationship is the key measure of your career success.

## **Interpreting and Responding to Micro-expressions**

We will now explain how to interpret and respond to representative expressions and micro-expressions.

### **Question**

If you are a store clerk, how would you respond?

See Interviews and deception (s-interview).

See Interviews and deception (s-interview).

See Observing body language when dealing with superiors (s-superiors).

See Observing body language when dealing with superiors (s-superiors).

See Observing body language when dealing with superiors (s-superiors).

See Observing body language when dealing with superiors (s-superiors).

See Observing body language when dealing with superiors (s-superiors).

See Negotiation and sales (s-negotiation).

See Negotiation and sales (s-negotiation).

See Negotiation and sales (s-negotiation).

See Negotiation and sales (s-negotiation).

See Negotiation and sales (s-negotiation).

## **Body Language Observation When Dealing with Superiors**

### **Unable to Read the Boss, Busy to Death Without Favor**

In the workplace, employees cannot help but guess their boss's thoughts, and bosses also try to figure out what their employees are thinking. This creates a dual relationship of "seeing through" and "being seen through" between bosses and employees. As an ordinary employee, you do not need to like your boss or hate

your boss, but you must understand him so that you can turn your boss into a “resource” for your success. It can be said that whether you can read your boss is the best test of a person’s level of “insight.”

Jesse passed the assessment last month and joined a large company as a manager’s assistant. On his first day, his direct supervisor told him: “You’re new and don’t understand the work yet. You can go around to the various departments first and familiarize yourself with the specific business and processes.” But two weeks later, the supervisor harshly criticized Jesse for being idle and lacking enthusiasm for work.

Now Jesse sits across from me, his two thick eyebrows almost knitted together: “Mr. Balkan, I can’t stand it! How can there be such a person? He told me to do that, and now he says if I keep this up I should quit.”

I reassured Jesse: “Don’t worry yet, Jesse. I want to know, what exactly have you been doing these past two weeks?”

“Following the manager’s instructions, learning about the work of several key departments such as the planning department, marketing department, and publicity department. Every day is the same. Actually I find it very boring, but since the boss instructed it, I had no choice but to comply.”

That is how I knew why Jesse had been criticized. He had not understood the “implied meaning” of his supervisor’s words—that a new employee should quickly familiarize himself with the environment and get involved in the work. Of course, Jesse’s oversight was not surprising. When I shook hands with him, I clearly sensed that his body structure was of the sturdy type, and his eyebrows, way of speaking, and movements all told me he was a straightforward young man, careless and not inclined to think deeply about things.

In the workplace, however, you need an extra eye and must think from another angle. Often a boss’s intentions are not expressed directly and require careful interpretation. Sometimes a boss says one thing but expects you not to do it; sometimes, because of his position, a boss cannot easily state his position but has already given a hint, so you must be “discerning” and never force the boss. If a boss praises you in private, it may not be genuine appreciation but a reminder that if you do not reflect on yourself, you may be in trouble. In short: if you cannot read your boss, being busy to death will not win favor.

[^1]: La Fontaine (1621–1695), one of the representative writers of French classical literature and a fabulist. His works were later compiled into *The Fables of La Fontaine* and, together with the ancient Greek fabulist Aesop’s *Aesop’s Fables* and the Russian writer Krylov’s *Krylov’s Fables*, are known as the “World’s Three Great Fables.”

Through my analysis, Jesse finally recognized his own naivety and oversight. He began to calmly ask me how to read his boss’s mind. To understand a boss is to know his character, work style, and thinking habits. This returns us to the core of this book—“reading people”—which I have already covered in sufficient detail and need not repeat.

Every month I meet young people like Jesse. Through conversations with them, I have summarized several “workplace iron laws” that I believe will be helpful to you.

### **Body Language Observation When Dealing with Superiors**

When interacting with a superior, observing the eyes and hands reveals the inner mind more clearly.

- The superior speaks without looking up or at anyone. This shows contempt for the subordinate, regarding the person as incompetent.

- The superior looks down at people. This conveys a sense of superiority—domineering, arrogant, and conceited.
- The superior stares at the subordinate for a long time. This indicates the impression of the subordinate is still incomplete—waiting for more information.
- The superior looks at the subordinate in a friendly and open manner, or occasionally winks. This is a good sign—the subordinate is capable, liked, and even mistakes may be forgiven.
- The superior's gaze is sharp, expression unchanged, as if a sword were piercing through the subordinate. This expression displays power, cold indifference, and superiority, while also implying to the subordinate: do not try to deceive me; I can see through your thoughts.
- The superior occasionally glances upward, meets the subordinate's eyes, then looks down again; if the superior does this repeatedly, it confirms uncertainty about the subordinate.
- The superior gazes into the room, nodding slightly from time to time. This is a very bad sign and may indicate that the subordinate must obey completely; no matter what the subordinates say or think, the superior pays no attention.
- During conversation the superior presses palms together from above, using the body for balance—this indicates relaxation and calm.
- During conversation the superior places hands on hips, elbows pointing outward; this is often the posture adopted when facing a concrete power issue.
- The superior sits in a chair, leans back, places both hands behind the head, elbows pointing outward; this posture shows relaxation at the moment but may also indicate conceit.
- During conversation the superior points an index finger at the other person—a naked display of superiority and combativeness.
- During conversation the superior clasps hands behind the back; this is also a sign of superiority.
- During conversation the superior pats the subordinate's shoulder—this indicates recognition and appreciation; only a pat from the side truly signifies recognition and appreciation. A pat from the front or above signals looking down on the subordinate or displaying power.
- During conversation the superior brings fingertips together, forming a pyramid shape with both hands pointing forward—this is a signal that the other party's suggestion must be rejected.
- During conversation the superior clenches fists; this posture indicates not only an attempt to intimidate but also a determination to defend one's own views. If the fist strikes the table, it is simply an attempt to stop others from speaking.

### **Stress Signs Leaking from Subordinates' Expressions**

- A subordinate suddenly hands in a resignation letter!
- An outstanding subordinate suddenly says they want to change jobs!
- A subordinate who has always been serious, diligent, and proactive about every task suddenly develops emotional problems...

Whether for yourself or those around you, you have probably had such experiences: "suddenly" quitting a job, "suddenly" wanting to change jobs, "suddenly" being unable to continue working... In fact, none of these are truly "sudden." They are the accumulation of depression or a state of ongoing dissatisfaction. Before the "sudden" event, the person has very likely already sent out several distress signals.

The precursor to these distress signals is discussion of anxieties and expectations regarding promotion and compensation, workplace interpersonal troubles, and so on. If good communication occurs in advance, the relationship between subordinate and superior deepens and management crises are more easily avoided. In

reality, however, it is unlikely that either superior or subordinate will have sufficient time and energy to discuss and communicate everything.

From the subordinate's standpoint, "Can I really consult the boss about this?" leads to hesitation, accumulating until something "sudden" happens. From the superior's standpoint, the thought arises: "If only we had discussed it earlier, we would not have reached today's situation."

Both sides usually differ in their view of the "timing" of discussion. In other words, the balance point between "wanting to consult the superior" and "wanting to discuss with the subordinate" is misaligned.

How can the balance point of discussion be found? At this moment, the reading of micro-expressions (微表情) comes into play. Because micro-expressions are suppressed emotions that leak out, in certain situations the appearance of a micro-expression on a subordinate's face indicates that the emotion can no longer be fully suppressed and psychological fluctuation has occurred.

This emotional fluctuation usually disappears automatically as the subordinate gradually becomes accustomed to the work and builds confidence, but some people are never able to resolve it and accumulate depressive emotions. In either case, if the subordinate's micro-expressions can be detected and read, showing a little extra care at that moment can reduce the possibility of future escalation into a major problem.

#### **Have "Sadness," "Contempt," and "Disgust" Been Overlooked?**

People with suicidal intent who hide it may say with a smiling face, "I'm doing fine right now!" Although the smile conceals the distress, the distress that cannot be hidden reveals a micro-expression of "sadness." When someone carrying a heavy burden who has hinted at wanting to commit suicide more than once suddenly appears full of energy, special attention is required! Although the words say "It's already fine!" if a micro-expression of "sadness" is still visible, it means the distress has not actually been resolved.

In a hospital consultation room, psychiatric patients listening to a doctor's suggestions sometimes display micro-expressions of "contempt" or "disgust." It should be noted that the appearance of "contempt" or "disgust" micro-expressions does not necessarily mean mental illness; however, patients showing these emotions are less willing to follow the doctor's instructions and suggestions compared with other patients, making recovery more difficult.

When a doctor offers various treatment suggestions or future treatment directions, patients unwilling to seriously accept the instructions tend to show "contempt," while patients who do not want to accept them tend to show "disgust." Patients displaying these expressions will not follow the doctor's professional advice and will instead act in their own way. The result, of course, is that the mental condition will not be cured. When a suggestion is made to a subordinate regarding a certain issue and a micro-expression of "contempt" or "disgust" appears on the subordinate's face, it indicates that the suggestion has not been taken to heart.

One final reminder: the "asymmetrical" expressions, "motionless above the nose" expressions, and micro-expressions of "sadness," "contempt," and "disgust" introduced so far should not be taken as immediate proof that a subordinate has a mental health problem. When these expressions are captured, please consider that they result from accumulated stress in the subordinate. The most appropriate action is to pay closer attention and observe the subordinate's movements than usual.

#### **Common Facial Features of Mental Health Problems**

Here the key micro-expressions and facial points to watch for regarding “mental health problems” are explained. Detecting “mental health problems” from expressions has been identified through various studies. Research to date indicates that “asymmetrical” expressions, “motionless above the nose” expressions, and micro-expressions of “sadness,” “contempt,” and “disgust” are all associated with “mental health problems.”

However, observing these expressions does not allow an immediate conclusion of “mental health problems.” First, it is important to consider the expression together with the context. Next, we will examine the reasons for each expression one by one.

An “asymmetrical” expression appears when a person deliberately tries not to reveal their true intention on the face. In simple terms, it is the expression shown when trying to control emotions at that moment. The brain’s actual emotion interferes with the emotion-control mechanism, causing the facial muscles to move asymmetrically and forming an asymmetrical expression. The person may say “It’s fine!” or “Full of hope!” yet contradict their true intention.

A “motionless above the nose” expression means the will to send or receive messages is weak—in other words, an expression in which emotion has died. During conversation, our eyebrows usually move. Eyebrows raised emphasize words or phrases; eyebrows lowered indicate disagreement with the other person’s opinion. When sending or receiving messages, eyebrows always move unconsciously. If these movements are absent, it indicates a weak will to send or receive messages. In the worst case, emotion has already been wiped out. When a subordinate’s face shows no expression, especially when the mouth moves but the eyebrows do not, it is very possible that the subordinate’s mind is overshadowed by a great shadow.

### **Bosses and Employees**

In common work relationships, a large amount of verbal or written language communication is usually involved, but people occasionally “converse” through body movements. The relationship between bosses and employees is no exception. Therefore, we must recognize and correctly interpret those different postures and make full use of them.

Of course, as an employee, learning to interpret the negative facial expressions shown by the boss is very important. For example, raised eyebrows, slight head turns, doubtful looks when rejecting a suggestion, or not looking the employee in the eye. If the employee does not realize the boss does not want to talk at the moment, the boss may enter the second stage—moving the body and looking at the watch on the wrist while sighing deeply (see Figure 5.3). The ability to interpret and accurately predict the boss’s attitude in a timely manner is a very valuable asset for your career.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图5.3 不高兴的老板]*

Similarly, for the boss, it is also very important to read the employee’s non-verbal behavior and respond appropriately. Because the goals of boss and employee are the same. To create benefits for the company, they must maintain a good cooperative relationship. If an employee feels dissatisfied, resentful, or doubtful about a company policy, that emotion will not only affect the employee’s own work but will also negatively affect the morale of other staff.

Below we briefly list some common gestures that may be seen in the workplace:

#### **(2) Do Not Get Too Close to Your Superior**

A young man told me that he often drank and chatted with his superior, just like friends. Then one day he was suddenly informed that he was being transferred from the New York headquarters to the Texas branch. The young man ran to ask his superior in disbelief, but the superior shrugged and said, "There's no way around it; this is the company's decision."

As a workplace professional, it is understandable to build a good relationship with your superior, but getting too close is very dangerous. Why? Because the more a leader is understood by a subordinate, the greater the sense of crisis; they will never keep danger by their side. Moreover, being close to the superior easily arouses resentment from colleagues and is not beneficial for handling interpersonal relationships. Therefore, between you and your superior, you must approach at the right time yet still maintain distance.

### **Observation Techniques for Solving "Interpersonal Relationship" Problems**

In student days, we can avoid people whose personalities do not match our own in daily life. But after entering society, we can no longer do as we please; whether we get along or not, we must learn to interact with them. Especially for supervisors who lead subordinates and teams, regardless of personality compatibility, they must be able to manage people and organizations within interpersonal relationships.

Once you have subordinates, the superior bears additional responsibility and must also understand how to respond. In this scenario, let us glimpse the management method of "leading hearts" from the world of emotions.

### **Signs Indicating Boss or Employee Satisfaction**

- Frequent eye contact with others
- Open expression or smiling face
- Casual standing posture, arms or legs apart
- Body continuously moving closer to others during conversation
- Hands placed in front of the chest
- Lincoln-style sitting posture

When you notice that your boss or colleague is dissatisfied and feels irritable or angry, never let the situation worsen. Based on your judgment of the other person's body movements, you should find a way to solve the problem before it seriously damages your relationship or affects productivity.

### **(3) Make Yourself Indispensable to Your Superior**

Every excellent leader has both a "think tank" and an "execution team" around them; the former helps with planning and advice, the latter helps implement and execute, and the two complement each other under the leader's direction. If you are a rational person, use your intelligence and strive to become a core member of the "think tank"; if you are a practical person, use your execution ability and make the "execution team" your platform. In short, becoming someone the superior cannot do without will be the capital for your greater success.

### **Signs Indicating Boss Anger or Doubt**

- No eye contact with others
- Hands tightly clasped

- Eyebrows raised
- Peering through the gap above the glasses
- Scratching the back of the neck
- Pulling at the collar with the hand
- Stern or suspicious expression
- Looking down at the watch
- Sighing deeply

#### **(4) Maintain Proper Boundaries When Receiving Recognition**

When facing praise from your superior, you must keep your composure. If you become arrogant because of recognition, you will not only lose the superior's trust but also offend colleagues. Moreover, sometimes a superior's recognition is not purely genuine, so you need to watch for hidden intentions.

#### **Signs Indicating Boss Frustration or Resistance**

- Reduced eye contact with others
- Hands tightly clasped
- Arms defensively crossed with fists clenched
- Legs defensively crossed
- Suspiciously rubbing the eyes
- Scratching the back of the neck
- Pulling at the collar with the hand

#### **(1) Always Remember You Are a Subordinate**

Between superior and subordinate there is always a "leading" and "being led" relationship, so no matter how outstanding you are or how terrible you think your superior is, you must never openly "challenge" them.

#### **Signs Indicating Employee Annoyance**

- Impatiently kicking feet
- Repeatedly fiddling with a pen or other object on the desk
- Hand supporting the head, eyelids drooping
- Blank gaze, absent-minded

### **Business and Negotiation**

#### **Clients and Professionals**

The relationship between clients and professionals is one of the most sensitive interpersonal relationships. Successful lawyers, accountants, consultants, and others understand the importance of body language communication, while less successful professionals seem unable to send signals of wanting to build good relationships. In fact, the communication skills between professionals and clients can be improved. Below, we will discuss their relationship from the client's perspective.

If a client seeks help from a newly practicing professional, they are likely to doubt the other's ability but also hope for some advice. If the advice given is too simple or too general, the client may become full of doubts,

because most of them firmly believe their situation is special, and the professional must come up with some fresh ideas. Even worse, some clients only listen to the advice they want to hear and are not prepared to accept other opinions from the other party. All these factors can make it difficult for the professional to convey conclusions to their client.

So, how can professionals avoid causing client concerns and build a constructive relationship with them?

One way for professionals to build trust with clients is to record what the client says, regardless of whether the client thinks it's important. This approach makes the client feel that the other party understands and notices their specific situation.

Another way to make the client feel attended to is for the professional to adopt the postures we discussed earlier for interpreting others' behavior. For example, tilting the head slightly to one side, supporting the head with one hand, etc. These postures not only indicate that the professional is interested in what the client is saying but also show that they are thinking of ways to help the client.

In the process of negotiating with clients, it is equally crucial for professionals to avoid negative body movements as it is to adopt positive ones. If the professional leans back in the chair with hands in a casual steeple shape, the client will see it as indifference to their problem.

If there is a large desk between you, the client will think: "He is not on my side; he doesn't care about my problem, only about making money." To solve this, more and more professionals are rearranging their offices, such as removing large desks, to reduce unnecessary hostility and promote communication with clients.

Additionally, professionals should not display a commanding or lecturing posture toward clients but should convey an approachable feeling. Avoid the hand-grabbing-collar gesture that indicates arrogance, as it will damage the relationship with the client.

Below, we briefly summarize some common negative and positive actions between clients and professionals.

### **Buyers and Sellers**

Successful salespeople know that the ability to correctly identify and interpret buyers' body language and the skill to control their own body movements are key to whether a deal is reached. Buyers are also very aware that salespeople will make gestures or movements to make them feel relaxed or to draw them into the promoted product or service.

In many buying and selling transactions, both buyers and sellers evaluate various negative emotions shown by the other party with an "I must win, you must lose" attitude. For example, the buyer leans back in the chair, stares at the seller, crosses arms and legs, and asks in a skeptical tone: "What do you want to talk about?" Meanwhile, the seller may lean forward in a sprinter's eager posture while using fingers to indicate their intent.

If the buyer dislikes this hard-sell approach, they may lean back and adopt a defensive posture. If the seller becomes uneasy because the pitch failed, they too will adopt a defensive posture, such as fidgeting, crossing arms and legs, or even turning their head away from the buyer. The situation then deteriorates rapidly.

Experienced salespeople quickly infer the buyer's personality traits by observing their body movements—for instance, whether the buyer's sitting posture is casual and relaxed or formal and serious. Once the salesperson identifies the buyer's personality, they adjust their sales approach accordingly. If the buyer appears casual and



has a sense of humor, opening with a joke will instantly liven up the atmosphere; if the buyer looks serious and formal, the salesperson should stick to conventional, structured opening lines.

Salespeople can also convey friendliness and sincerity through their own body movements to shorten the distance with the buyer. For example, some salespeople consciously mirror the buyer's posture, such as spreading their legs or tilting their head. This helps most people feel relaxed and sets the stage for the sales discussion.

Once the buyer shows interest, the salesperson can present the product according to the buyer's needs or move directly to the buyer's desk to introduce it. In this situation, the buyer will notice the salesperson's nonverbal actions and may signal that they do not welcome the close proximity. If the buyer leans back, moves away, or even shifts their chair aside, the salesperson should immediately return to the original position.

Below, we briefly summarize some negative and positive actions that may occur between buyers and sellers.

### Answering Techniques

In negotiations, answering questions is unavoidable, and how you answer often determines your position. If you are inadvertently led into a trap, it means negotiation failure. Therefore, I believe it is necessary to teach novice negotiators several practical answering techniques.

- **Answer selectively:** Experienced negotiators know that not every question must be answered. For provocative questions that harm your side's image or boring questions about personal privacy, you can choose to say "no comment."
- **Avoid absolute answers:** Always leave yourself room when answering. Revealing your strength too early gives the other side an opening; stating things definitively almost guarantees the end of cooperation.
- **Do not rush to answer:** Before replying, analyze the substance of the question, clarify the other party's true intent, and then respond in a targeted way. If you sense a trap, use ambiguous phrasing to avoid being put on the defensive.
- **Go along with a misunderstanding:** Sometimes the other party may have misunderstood your meaning, but if the situation favors your side, going along with the misunderstanding can be a good choice.

### Watch for Small Movements

Once negotiations enter the substantive phase, both sides usually discuss terms. When an immediate agreement cannot be reached, how should the conversation continue? Pay attention to the following small movements; they indicate the other party is likely about to take the next step.

- **Clearing the throat:** If the other party clears their throat during negotiations, it means they cannot accept the proposed terms and you need to prepare; if they clear their throat when talks are stalled, it shows they are about to speak and feel somewhat nervous.
- **Fingers spreading open:** Spreading the fingers releases tension and increases confidence. If the other party gradually opens their fingers, it indicates they are relaxed and ready to state their views.
- **Leaning forward with mouth slightly open:** When talks fall silent, if the other party leans toward the table with mouth slightly parted, it shows they have formulated terms and intend to continue the discussion.

- **Lightly clenching both hands:** If the opponent places lightly clenched hands in front of them, it means they are still thinking. You need to consider internally how to break the deadlock, because the other party usually will not speak first. They are cautious, planned, and will not decide easily.

## Facial Expressions

During negotiations, the face is the part of a person that receives the most eye contact. Most people prefer a friendly, approachable face over a stern, rigid one. In other words, "cold faces," "bitter faces," and "angry faces" all detract from your position and are best avoided.

In daily life, we can easily read a person's inner thoughts through static features and dynamic changes in the forehead, eyebrows, eyes, and mouth corners. In professional negotiations, however, "disguise" is a common tactic. Therefore, you must be more cautious when interpreting facial expressions.

For example, a "smile" can indicate either agreement or disagreement. If one corner of the other party's mouth rises while their gaze shifts elsewhere, they likely have reservations about your proposal. At such times, you need to readjust your thinking.

Another example: throughout the negotiation the other party appears attentive and focused, yet at the end shows a hesitant expression. They are probably testing you to see if you will make further concessions.

## Using Props

True negotiation experts rarely negotiate empty-handed because they understand the principle that seeing is believing. They often bring models, pictures, charts, reports, samples, and other visual items as props to strengthen their negotiating position. However, several points must be observed when using props: first, you must be very familiar with the props you bring; second, you must ensure their quality; third, you must time their use correctly during the negotiation—knowing when to deploy and when to put them away. I can tell you without exaggeration that the correct use of props can increase your negotiation success rate by more than 50 percent.

### (1) Eye Contact

There is an invisible "weapon" in negotiations: presence. Whether a person's presence is strong or weak can easily be seen in their eyes. As I mentioned earlier, the eyes readily betray a person's inner state. You can tell at a glance whether the other party is sincere and confident or timid and hesitant. The other party can likewise read your thoughts from your gaze. Therefore, to close the deal, you must let the other party perceive your sincerity, and the most effective way is through eye contact. Remember the gazing technique I taught you? Used well, it doubles the results.

## Positive Actions That Yield Significant Results for Professionals

- Lincoln-style sitting posture
- Taking notes
- Frequent eye contact
- Chin-supporting or chin-stroking interpretive postures

When professionals first meet a client, they must pay attention to the client's various body movements. If you sense the client harbors doubts or unease, you can pair your words with positive body movements to build

trust. When you do so, you will soon see the client display a relaxed expression and quickly accept your professional advice.

## Eyes

If the other party's eyes suddenly widen—even for just a second—they have likely heard or thought of key information; if their eyeballs move slightly, they are thinking about what you just said and you should press the advantage; if they avoid looking at you or glance away immediately, congratulations—you are in the dominant position; if they stare at you with a cold, hard gaze, they are clearly threatening you to accept their terms.

## Positive Actions That Yield Significant Results for Sellers

- Casual body posture
- Sincere facial expression
- Mirroring the buyer's body movements
- Once the buyer shows interest, move closer and tailor the product introduction to their needs

Like other interactive relationships, buyers and sellers are engaged in a dance. The seller takes the lead but must keenly observe the buyer's reactions and then carefully choose their own movements. Only then will the buyer be successfully "drawn in" by the seller.

## Signs That the Buyer Is Resistant or Uninterested

- Arms or legs crossed
- Angry, dissatisfied, or exclusive facial expression
- Critical interpretive posture, with index finger placed on one side of the face and other fingers curled below the mouth
- Head turned away from the seller while looking sideways
- Suspicious nose touch
- Suspicious ear-root rub
- Suspicious eye rub

## Signs That the Client Is Doubtful or Worried

- Arms or legs crossed
- Hands tightly clasped
- Critical interpretive posture, with index finger placed on one side of the face and other fingers curled below the mouth
- Head turned away from the professional while looking sideways
- Suspicious nose touch
- Suspicious ear-root rub
- Suspicious eye rub

## If You Cannot Handle the Opponent, What Proves Your Worth

To succeed and persuade the opponent, relying on words alone is not enough. Effectively using body language together with appropriate speaking strategies greatly increases the likelihood of negotiation

SUCCESS.

### **Signs That the Buyer Is Willing to Accept or Interested**

- Arms or legs apart
- Sincere expression or smiling face
- Less frequent face-touching
- More frequent eye contact
- Chin-supporting interpretive posture

### **Negative Actions That Backfire for Sellers**

- Arms or legs crossed
- Adopting a sprinter's eager posture before the buyer shows interest
- Quickly closing the distance with the buyer

### **Negative Actions That Backfire for Professionals**

- Leaning back in the chair with an arrogant air
- Forming a steeple with the hands
- Placing feet on the desk
- Grabbing the collar with the hand

### **Signs That the Client Trusts and Is Satisfied**

- Arms or legs apart
- Less frequent face-touching
- Interpretive postures

See Workplace and professional contexts (c-workplace).

See Workplace and professional contexts (c-workplace).

See Eyes (c-eyes).

## **Interview and Lie Detection**

### **Spotting Small Lies from Micro-expressions**

#### **Case:**

When you, as the interviewer, ask the question "What do you think is the most important thing in work?" during a company recruitment of new graduates.

Applicant: "I think the most important thing in work is action. For example, I have a very smart friend, Mr. K. He has opinions on every matter regarding the goods displayed at our school festival booth, procurement, or how to make profits. Having opinions is a good thing, but the problem is that he doesn't participate in any actions at all and only talks. Without actually taking action, you completely don't know how difficult it is to concretize ideas."

Interviewer: "Indeed, the action to concretize ideas is important. So, what do you think of Mr. K's ideas? And have you taken any measures regarding Mr. K's reactions?"

Applicant: "Mr. K, who takes no action at all, makes me very angry, so I demanded that he participate."

**Question:** To know more deeply about this student's action characteristics or personality, what kind of question should be asked?

**Explanation:** It can be seen that the applicant's eyebrows are raised upward and drawn toward the center, with eyes wide open. The expression of wide eyes and wrinkles between the eyebrows easily shows that this is the micro-expression of "fear".

This is inconsistent with the "anger" expression indicated by the applicant's words "I feel very angry". The moment the micro-expression is revealed is the timing for questioning, especially the moment when the micro-expression is inconsistent with the words, which is the key point that needs attention for questioning.

The ways of questioning include direct inquiry or indirect questioning that supports the emotion.

- The direct method is for the interviewer to use the interpreted emotion and directly ask: "Was there any feeling of unease at that time?"
- The indirect method to support the emotion is: "It takes courage to voice opinions to others or to prompt them to act! How did you encourage Mr. K to actively participate?"

The emotional function of "fear" is "ensuring physical and mental safety and avoiding crises". The interviewer first expresses the emotion on behalf of the applicant with "It takes courage!". This way, the applicant can feel supported and be more willing to express their true feelings.

Whether using the direct or indirect method, the fundamental principle is the same. In reality, one should feel angry rather than afraid and uneasy about Mr. K's behavior, so it can perhaps be interpreted that the feeling of fear or unease was stronger than anger at the time, and from this, infer the applicant's emotional tendency.

If continuing the conversation based on the literal meaning of the applicant's words "makes me very angry", it is very likely that the applicant's emotional tendency cannot be correctly judged. If the "indirect questioning method" can be practiced, perhaps the applicant can also discover their true emotional tendency. Finally, infer personality from emotional tendency.

People who generate "anger" emotions toward similar events will proactively understand the "obstacles" of the problem, which can be inferred as having an inner strength to independently and proactively solve problems; while people who feel "fear" emotions will dread the threat of the problem, which can be inferred as trying to solve and handle it, but with less proactive action.

By listening to the applicant's inner voice using different micro-expression detection techniques, the interviewer can more accurately infer personality, and even emotional tendencies or action tendencies that the applicant themselves have not noticed can emerge.

### Scene Setting: Interview

You must prove to the interviewer: I am a capable person! Regardless of whether your personality is gentle and delicate or rough and unrestrained, slow and methodical or impatient and aggressive, once you decide to enter a certain industry or department, you must display the abilities most suitable for that industry or department.

1. Appear neatly and appropriately in front of the interviewer. You cannot change your body type, skin color, appearance, and other features, but you can choose clothing suitable for yourself. Based on industry characteristics, wearing appropriate clothing can reflect your qualities and abilities. If you are not good at grasping colors, then wear black; it can give you a sense of power and authority.
2. The handshake should have strength. If you have the opportunity to shake hands with the interviewer, remember to put in some force. As I analyzed earlier, through the handshake, you can very intuitively feel the other's muscle tension and bone hardness or softness, and this is not only a means for you to understand the other but also a means to showcase yourself.
3. Timely make your gaze meet the other's gaze. When the interviewer asks you a question, never lower your head and remain silent, nor look around. In the limited time, what best reflects your honesty and confidence is the eyes. Research shows that appropriate eye contact can increase favorability.
4. Maintain a smile, making people feel you are an outgoing person. No matter who it is, no one wants to be with a gloomy person, while outgoing people have an aura that makes people unconsciously generate trust. You can be introverted, but you must not be timid. When you smile while looking at the other person, it can make people feel you are relatively outgoing and effectively reduce inner tension, killing two birds with one stone.
5. Speak less and listen more. Time is limited; do not expect one interview to fully showcase yourself. The more you speak, the more emotions will inadvertently be revealed, and the greater the possibility of loopholes, which directly relates to whether you can pass the interview. So even if you are eloquent, temporarily put away your desire to perform and be a sincere listener.

### **Mastering Four Minutes to Win Over the Interviewer**

I can confidently tell you: It only takes four minutes to read a person.

From the moment a person walks into my office to sitting down, just one minute, then opening pleasantries and self-introduction, at most three minutes. In these brief four minutes, I can basically figure out the other's intentions. Perhaps you will question that I am talking nonsense, but language communication experts, through tracking analysis of thousands of business negotiations, finally concluded: Between two people who do not know each other, 60%~80% of the initial impression is formed within four minutes after the first meeting. — Completely consistent with the conclusion I reached through practice!

Never underestimate these four minutes, because your success or failure is very likely to depend on the impression left on the other within these four minutes, which is what we often call the "first impression". From a psychological perspective, the first impression refers to the brain forming certain views and making certain judgments based on the other's gender, age, clothing, posture, facial expressions, and other features. Generally speaking, the first impression is very stubborn. If a bad first impression is left, it often means the cooperation will end in failure; even if you luckily get the opportunity, you will have to spend more time and energy to reverse this impression. So if you can leave a good first impression, it means you are one step closer to success!

Next, I will use the knowledge in this book to tell you some basic techniques and simple methods to correctly and effectively master these critical four minutes, thereby winning the first "pass" in the workplace and business world.

### **Techniques for Accurately Distinguishing Lies**

When using micro-expression detection techniques in recruitment interviews, how exactly should it be done? To see through others' lies, in addition to micro-expressions, one must deploy all lie-judging techniques from non-verbal information such as body language and tone, verbal information such as wording or logic integration, and even questioning methods that can distinguish liars from honest people; otherwise, it is difficult to accurately distinguish lies.

Instead, make use of micro-expression information, explained as follows:

- Do not make people feel suspected
- Consider the questioning focus of micro-expressions

If the interviewer does not make the applicant feel suspected, and the aforementioned micro-expression occurs, then one must consider that besides the pressure given by the interviewer, there are other reasons causing the micro-expression.

But this cannot directly conclude that the applicant is lying, because the applicant may be unaccustomed to the interview atmosphere, causing emotional fluctuations. Therefore, at the beginning of the interview, it is necessary to ease the applicant's tension. If the applicant shows micro-expressions on the face without being under additional pressure, it indicates that behind the applicant's words, there may be other meanings.

That is to say, the interviewer should note that when a micro-expression appears, it is the time to question why the applicant's face shows a micro-expression, and ask questions based on the micro-expression to guide them to explain, thereby understanding the true meaning.

### **Micro-expressions Also Shown by Honest People**

From this, it can be known that if one can detect and interpret micro-expressions, of course one can see through the applicant's lies. However, emotions generated when lying may also occur even without lying.

When the applicant is telling the truth, if the interviewer suspects it is a lie, the applicant will feel "guilt" toward themselves for being suspected of lying, and feel "distress" about such a scene, and perhaps also feel "disgust" or "contempt" toward the interviewer who suspects them.

In addition, the applicant may also feel "fear" about being wronged and unable to prove innocence! Being suspected of lying does not produce "secret delight", but the seemingly "happy" smiling face on the surface is actually to encourage oneself in a difficult situation, or to leave a good impression on the interviewer.

Even without lying, when suspected of lying, one uses feigned calmness to suppress emotions. Emotions that cannot be completely suppressed will become micro-expressions and appear on the face.

How does that feel? Whether lying or not lying, the same emotions and same micro-expressions will be produced. Compared to truth-tellers, liars have a more obvious tendency to display micro-expressions. And what is produced from being suspected of lying is the micro-expression of honest people.

### **Lying Emotions in Recruitment Interviews**

Next, let us imagine the emotional state of an applicant lying in a recruitment interview. People who want to enter the company through lying will, when facing themselves, feel "guilt", "distress", "(self-)disgust" due to conscience's reproach, and additionally, will have a "fear" feeling worrying that the lie will be exposed.

Conversely, there may also be applicants who feel excited “happiness” about lying, and this emotion is called “secret delight”. “Contempt” is a sense of superiority relative to others; when one feels that one’s clever lie has been smoothly accepted and affirmed by the interviewer, one will feel “contempt”; of course, such applicants will not reveal the emotion on their expression, and if they accidentally show a flaw in front of the interviewer, the lie will be exposed. Therefore, they will deliberately suppress such emotions, and if they cannot suppress them, they will appear on the applicant’s face in the form of micro-expressions.

See Eyes and mouth in deception (c-deception-eyes-mouth).

## Part Nine Psychological Testing

### 1.1 Recognition of Ordinary Expressions

This level of the test contains 6 images. After viewing each one, give an intuitive judgment. The reference answer is on the back of the image; you do not need to match the wording exactly. If your judgment is close in meaning to the reference answer, it counts as correct. Each correctly judged expression image earns 5 points.

#### **Beginner Test 1**

Reference answer: A happy smile.

A hearty laugh represents the emotion that is the lifelong pursuit of every person—joy. A genuine smile is highly recognizable and contagious. Even from 100 meters away, a bright smiling face can be easily identified. If you judged correctly (which, presumably, you did not get wrong), flip back and observe at random: in a smiling face, what state are the various organs—from eyebrows to mouth—in?

#### **Beginner Test 2**

Reference answer: Surprise.

When encountering or hearing something unexpected, a person instinctively produces this expression. The eyes widen to see clearly what is happening, and you may notice that opening the mouth is always accompanied by a quick intake of breath.

#### **Beginner Test 3**

Reference answer: Disgust.

Whether in ancient times or today, encountering foul odors, spoiled food, or disliked people or things during the process of survival elicits this expression. The facial movements convey the attitude: do not look, do not smell, do not taste. If the ears could move, there might also be a refusal to listen. If you see this expression on someone else’s face, you can probably gauge your standing in that person’s mind.

#### **Beginner Test 4**

Reference answer: Anger.

When provoked or even offended, anger is triggered. The direct manifestations of anger, beyond the angry face itself, include other aggressive actions such as roaring, shoving, kicking, or at least heavy breathing. The teeth bared in the image are essentially no different from those of an animal preparing to attack.

#### **Beginner Test 5**

Reference answer: Fear.



When facing something terrifying, what is feared? It is the possibility of harm, coupled with the inability to eliminate, drive away, or remove the threat. Fear of that harmful outcome is fear itself. When confronted with an overwhelming threat and feeling powerless to resist or eliminate it, anger subsides and is replaced by fear. The most immediate response to fear is flight; under extreme pressure, it may lead to despairing surrender.

### Beginner Test 6

Reference answer: Sadness.

The death of a loved one, or expending great effort and cost only to fail, may trigger uncontrollable weeping.

## 1.4 Test Result Evaluation and Recommendations

- If your score falls between 0–50 points, you can identify relatively obvious expression meanings, but your recognition of complex micro-expressions (微表情) is not high. You need to meet more people and experience more events, building perceptual understanding through accumulation to improve your recognition ability.
- If your score falls between 50–60 points, you possess good intuitive sense and are quite sensitive to people's expressions, yet you tend to doubt your own judgments when questioned or when self-doubting. You need to read this book carefully to master in detail the morphological features and judgment criteria of each type of micro-expression.
- If your score falls between 60–80 points, you have relatively high expression-interpretation ability, whether from extensive experience with people or from specialized study of human expressions. Building on this solid foundation by reading the entire book will give you a more systematic and comprehensive grasp of micro-expression morphological features, leading to greater accuracy.
- If your score exceeds 80 points, there is only one piece of advice—read this book thoroughly, for it belongs to you. Then, in actual events or cases, apply consistent standards for judgment, forging stable criteria and convictions so that this skill becomes a personal strength. Early on you may make more mistakes, but each error is worth ten correct judgments, and proficiency will grow rapidly. Afterward, we can enjoy practicing together.

After completing the above test, firmly remember your current feeling: are the faces before you clearly legible to your eyes? Do genuine and false expressions cause confusion or misunderstanding? Chapters 4 through 10 of this book dissect the necessary and typical features of various micro-expressions. Using these standards, you can retake the advanced test after finishing your study. At that point, recognition and analysis of these complex faces should become as clear and definite as consulting a dictionary.

Before that, however, we must first confirm a core question: is analyzing a person's inner state through micro-expressions reliable after all? Myth or science? This requires you to exercise patience and read the next two chapters.

## 1.2 Recognition of Common Expressions

This level of the test also contains 6 images. After viewing each one, give an intuitive judgment. The reference answer is on the back of the image. If your judgment is close in meaning to the reference answer, it counts as correct. Each correctly judged expression image earns 5 points.

### Intermediate Test 1

Reference answer: Smile.

The key question is whether this smile is sincere. Such smiles are very common in daily life. Can the structural morphology of this face alone determine that the other person truly likes and is happy?

To judge whether a smile is fully sincere, two criteria must be observed: first, examine the morphology of the eyebrows, eyes, degree of cheek elevation, and mouth shape; second, examine the force-matching relationship among the four organs. Combining the above features shows that the smile is sincere, yet the mouth displays a deliberate suppression—the lips are pressed together, indicating the person intends to restrain the full expression of the smile.

### Intermediate Test 2

Reference answer: Surprise.

The degree of surprise in the image can be inferred to mean the unexpected stimulus was not very intense. However, can you determine whether fear is also present in this expression? The answer is no.

### Intermediate Test 3

Reference answer: Disdain.

Disdain belongs to the mild tier of disgust-related emotions. Its difference from intense avoidant disgust lies in the fact that disdain involves viewing the disliked matter with great contempt and deeming it unworthy of entanglement or attention. Disdain is a derivative of disgust; therefore its micro-expression morphology retains the muscular features of extreme disgust expressions.

### Intermediate Test 4

Reference answer: Mild anger.

Usually, when facing someone harboring dissatisfaction, one can often see this expression on the other person's face. Beyond revealing the other party's discontent, this expression also conveys an important piece of information—the other person is still holding back a surge of determination and, given the opportunity, may act according to their own wishes.

## Chapter 1 Expression Recognition Ability Test

- 1.1 Recognition of Ordinary Expressions
- 1.2 Recognition of Common Expressions
- 1.3 Recognition of Complex Expressions
- 1.4 Test Result Evaluation and Recommendations

### Intermediate Test 6

**Reference answer:** Melancholy.

Opposite this expression, something the person does not wish to see has occurred. The inability to reverse the outcome produces inner sadness.

Does this expression seem very similar to the worried expression in Intermediate Test 5? Upon comparison, it indeed is quite similar, yet there is a key distinction—please carefully compare the subtle differences in eyebrow morphology.

I know that by now you have become somewhat skeptical and sensitive, and you may feel a bit dizzy between Intermediate Test 5 and Intermediate Test 6. In fact, this indicates you have reached the edge of the “window

paper” of whether micro-expressions are professional; only a little more effort is needed to break through.

Moreover, there is indeed a very subtle relationship between these two emotions, because matters worth worrying about can lead to sorrowful outcomes, so the expressions also share common ground.

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Moreover, there is indeed a very subtle relationship between these two emotions, because matters worth worrying about can lead to sorrowful outcomes, so the expressions also share common ground.

## Advanced Test 8

Is this expression recalling something, or expressing disagreement?

**Answer 7:** This is suppressed disgust. Although the face appears calm, the inner disgust is already quite strong. The key micro-expression features are the degree of eyebrow furrowing and the mouth being deliberately controlled into a natural shape; moreover, the upper eyelid drooping to the upper edge of the pupil is the micro-expression line “I do not want to see you,” a state that is difficult to achieve through deliberate effort.

**Answer 8:** This is not recollection but disagreement, without any rebellious behavior; it can be briefly called “unconvinced.” Observe the eyelid morphology: if the eyeball does not turn downward, does it again present the state of the upper eyelid drooping to the upper edge of the pupil? Exactly! Combined with the downward gaze and the wrinkling of the chin, these fully indicate inner negation.

## Intermediate Test 1

**Reference answer:** Smile.

The key question is whether this smile is sincere. Such smiles are very common in daily life. Can the structural morphology of this face alone determine that the other person truly likes and is happy?

To judge whether a smile is fully sincere, two criteria must be observed: first, examine the morphology of the eyebrows, eyes, degree of cheek elevation, and mouth shape; second, examine the force-matching relationship among the four organs. Combining the above features shows that the smile is sincere, yet the mouth displays a deliberate suppression—the lips are pressed together, indicating the person intends to restrain the full expression of the smile.

## Advanced Test 2

Is this person smiling? What other meaning is contained in the smile?

**Answer 1:** No.

The judgment basis is: the eyelids are essentially in a relaxed state, without active closing tension; the slight closure does not match the degree to which the mouth is open. In a genuine smile, if the mouth opens this wide, the eyes would be fully squinted.

**Answer 2:** It is a genuine smile supported by emotion, yet it carries a trace of fear, generally appearing in situations of pleading or flattery.

The judgment basis comes from the morphology of the eyebrows and upper eyelids, which carry fear-type micro-expression features.

## Psychological Testing

Psychological testing is a broad concept that includes various tests conducted in psychology using scientific methods and techniques, and to a large extent even physiological indicator tests caused by psychological activity; it also encompasses numerous small games that analyze personality and emotional intelligence through means such as astrology or blood type.

In this book, the scope of psychological testing is limited to analyzing real emotional states, information cognition, and information expression through stress micro-expressions, with particular emphasis on filtering disguises and discerning lies. Therefore, if strict rigor is not required, it can be briefly called lie detection.

## Advanced Test 4

What emotional factors are contained in this expression?

**Answer 3:** This is an obviously startled expression, and within the startle there is also an admixture of sadness micro-expression morphology; therefore it can be judged that, in the situation the person witnessed, an undesirable outcome has already occurred.

**Answer 4:** This is a startled-and-fearful expression. The eyes are opened so wide that the irises are almost fully exposed, yet the degree of eyebrow distortion is very small, confirming the presence of startle and fear. The key distinction between fear and sadness lies in the morphology of the eyebrows and eyes.

## Beginner Test 5

**Reference answer:** Fear.

When facing something terrifying, what is feared? It is the possibility of harm, coupled with the inability to eliminate, drive away, or remove the threat. Fear of that harmful outcome is fear itself. When confronted with an overwhelming threat and feeling powerless to resist or eliminate it, anger subsides and is replaced by fear. The most immediate response to fear is flight; under extreme pressure, it may lead to despairing surrender.

## Advanced Test 6

Is this crying, laughing, or a mixture of sorrow and joy?

**Answer 5:** This is a smug smile, and a secret one. The slightly furrowed eyebrows indicate an effort to think; the eye, cheek, and mouth morphology prove the genuineness of the smile; the gaze deflection reflects the subjective tendency of "don't be too conspicuous."

**Answer 6:** This is a mixture of sorrow and joy, with joy predominating, generally appearing in moments of extreme happiness turning to tears; you may often see such expressions on a soccer field.

## Advanced Test 8

Is this expression recalling something, or expressing disagreement?

**Reference answer:**

This is not recollection but disagreement, without any rebellious behavior; it can be briefly called "unconvinced." Observe the eyelid morphology: if the eyeball does not turn downward, does it again present the state of the upper eyelid drooping to the upper edge of the pupil? Exactly! Combined with the downward gaze and the wrinkling of the chin, these fully indicate inner negation.

## Beginner Test 3

**Reference answer:** Disgust.

Whether in ancient times or today, encountering foul odors, spoiled food, or disliked people or things during the process of survival elicits this expression. The facial movements convey the attitude: do not look, do not smell, do not taste. If the ears could move, there might also be a refusal to listen. If you see this expression on someone else's face, you can probably gauge your standing in that person's mind.

## Beginner Test 4

**Reference answer:** Anger.

When provoked or even offended, anger is triggered. The direct manifestations of anger, beyond the angry face itself, include other aggressive actions such as roaring, shoving, kicking, or at least heavy breathing. The teeth bared in the image are essentially no different from those of an animal preparing to attack.

## Intermediate Test 3

**Reference answer:** Disdain.

Disdain belongs to the mild tier of disgust-related emotions. Its difference from intense avoidant disgust lies in the fact that disdain involves viewing the disliked matter with great contempt and deeming it unworthy of entanglement or attention. Disdain is a derivative of disgust; therefore its micro-expression morphology retains the muscular features of extreme disgust expressions.

## Intermediate Test 4

**Reference answer:** Mild anger.

Usually, when facing someone harboring dissatisfaction, one can often see this expression on the other person's face. Beyond revealing the other party's discontent, this expression also conveys an important piece of information—the other person is still holding back a surge of determination and, given the opportunity, may act according to their own wishes.

## Advanced Test 4

This expression contains what emotional factors?

**Reference answer:**

This is a startled-and-fearful expression. The eyes are opened so wide that the irises are almost fully exposed, yet the degree of eyebrow distortion is very small, confirming the presence of startle and fear. The key distinction between fear and sadness lies in the morphology of the eyebrows and eyes.

## Intermediate Test 5

**Reference answer:** Worry.

The lightly furrowed brows reveal worry; even with the face below the nose covered, worry remains clearly visible. From the morphology of the eyebrows and eyes, the presence of worry can be confirmed. Worry is a mild derivative of fear; the inner state of both is the same—fear that something will happen.

## Intermediate Test 5

**Reference answer:** Worry.

The lightly furrowed brows reveal worry; even with the face below the nose covered, worry remains clearly visible. From the morphology of the eyebrows and eyes, the presence of worry can be confirmed. Worry is a mild derivative of fear; the inner state of both is the same—fear that something will happen.

## Advanced Test 1

Is this a genuine smile?

**Reference answer:**

No. The judgment basis is: the eyelids are essentially in a relaxed state, without active closing tension; the slight closure does not match the degree to which the mouth is open. In a genuine smile, if the mouth opens this wide, the eyes would be fully squinted.

## Advanced Test 2

Is this person smiling? What other meaning is contained in the smile?

**Reference answer:**

It is a genuine smile supported by emotion, yet it carries a trace of fear, generally appearing in situations of pleading or flattery. The judgment basis comes from the morphology of the eyebrows and upper eyelids, which carry fear-type micro-expression features.

## Advanced Test 5

What kind of smile is this?

**Reference answer:**

This is a smug smile, and a secret one. The slightly furrowed eyebrows indicate an effort to think; the eye, cheek, and mouth morphology prove the genuineness of the smile; the gaze deflection reflects the subjective tendency of "don't be too conspicuous."

## Advanced Test 3

Has something undesirable already occurred?

**Reference answer:**

This is an obviously startled expression, and within the startle there is also an admixture of sadness micro-expression morphology; therefore it can be judged that, in the situation the person witnessed, an undesirable outcome has already occurred.

## 1.3 Recognition of Complex Expressions

This level of the test contains 8 images. After viewing each one, give an intuitive judgment and then compare it with the reference answer. If your judgment is close in meaning to the reference answer, it counts as correct. Each correctly judged expression image earns 5 points.

## Advanced Test 6

Is this crying, laughing, or a mix of joy and sorrow?

**Answer:**

This is a mix of joy and sorrow, with a greater share of joy. It generally appears when someone cries tears of joy. You may often see such an expression on the football pitch.

## Intermediate Test 2

**Answer:** Surprise.

The degree of surprise shown in the image can be inferred in reverse: the unexpected stimulus is not very intense. Still, can you tell whether fear is present in this expression? The answer is no.

## Beginner Test 6

**Reference Answer:** Sadness.

The death of a close relative, or expending tremendous effort and paying a huge price only to fail, can trigger uncontrollable sobbing.

## Advanced Test 7

Is she unhappy? What is she thinking?

## Advanced Test 3

Has something bad already happened?

## Advanced Test 1

Is this a genuine smile?

## Advanced Test 5

What kind of smile is this?

## Are Your Emotions Stable?

### Chapter 1: Expression Recognition Ability Test

The first step is to understand; the second step is to control! Expressions are an important code in interpersonal communication and a key step in understanding others. Take the expression recognition ability test in this chapter to see how well you read faces.

This chapter contains three levels of expression tests, ranging from the simplest to the most complex, designed to test and differentiate readers' ability to recognize expressions.

Real-life micro-expressions fall into two categories: one consists of subtle facial changes that leak out inadvertently under extreme suppression, when emotions cannot be freely expressed; the muscle movements are incomplete and brief, representing relatively pure micro-expressions. The other consists of compound expressions in which various complex emotions are blended onto a single face, often described as "conflicted" or "meaningful." The latter type appears far more frequently. Unless people are under intense pressure, such as during a judicial investigation, they usually do not make every effort to suppress their emotional expressions.

With that in mind, let us proceed with an "easy-in, deep-out" expression recognition test.

### Psychological Testing

Psychological testing is a broad concept that includes various assessments conducted with scientific tools and methods in psychology, as well as a large number of tests that measure physiological indicators caused by psychological activity. It also encompasses numerous small games that analyze personality and emotional intelligence through means such as astrology or blood type.

In this book, the scope of psychological testing is limited to analyzing real emotional states, information cognition, and information expression through stress micro-expressions, with special emphasis on filtering disguises and detecting lies. Therefore, if strict rigor is not required, it can be abbreviated as lie detection.

### Beginner Test 1

**Reference Answer:** A happy smile.

A hearty laugh represents the emotion that is the lifelong pursuit of every person—joy. A genuine smile possesses extremely high recognizability and contagiousness. Even from 100 meters away, a bright smiling face can be easily identified. If you judged correctly (which, presumably, you did not get wrong), flip back and observe the smiling faces at random: what states are the various organs—from eyebrows to mouth—in?

#### 1.1 Recognition of Ordinary Expressions

This level of testing contains six images in total. After viewing each one, give an intuitive judgment. The reference answers are on the reverse side of the images. There is no need to match the wording exactly; if your judgment is close in meaning to the reference answer, it counts as correct. Each correctly judged expression image earns 5 points.

### Beginner Test 2



**Reference Answer:** Surprise.

When encountering or hearing something unexpected, a person instinctively produces this expression. The eyes widen to see clearly what is happening, and you may notice that opening the mouth is always accompanied by a quick intake of breath.

See Part IX — Quizzes (p-quizzes).

## Part Ten: Peripheral Topics

### A Small Scenario

Woman: Let's break up.

Man: What did you say? (Surprise. He did not expect her to bring it up so directly.)

Woman: Yesterday I got a call from XX (note: ex-boyfriend's name). He said he can't forget me.

Man: Why is he still calling you now? (Disgust. He feels repelled by her ex-boyfriend.)

Woman: I think he's right. He understands me better than you do.

Man: What!! (Anger. He feels an urge to attack; if the other man were present, he would probably charge at him.)

Woman: Being with you is fun, but it's equally painful. We've argued so many times, yet you still can't fully understand who I am. He may not be romantic, but I feel more secure with him. I can't let him go. I've thought about it for a long time. For both our sakes, let's just be friends.

Man: I can change. I'll change anything for you. I can't live without you. (Fear. He knows the chance of reconciliation is slim.)

Woman: You deserve a better girl, and there are plenty of good ones around you. This reluctance is just habit. I know it's cruel, but I really don't want us to repeat the same arguments. Here's your phone back, and the house key. Goodbye. I'll always wish you well.

Man: ... (Sadness. He knows it's irreversible.)

This is only one of many common scenes in life. Indifference simply means the heart no longer cares; as long as care remains, emotional reactions will occur.

Are humans rational, superior beings or slaves to emotion? Both claims are extreme. Adding a condition makes it more accurate: when not pressed, humans are masters of reason; when pressed, they become slaves to emotion. The "pressed" here refers to encountering an effective stimulus.

When we encounter an effective stimulus, the first reaction is surprise. Unexpected or uncertain sudden stimuli draw attention. If the event was already confirmed and anticipated, the worrying is already done and one simply waits calmly.

Simultaneously with surprise, a rapid judgment follows: is the stimulus source beneficial or harmful? If beneficial, the response is simple—great joy for major good news, quiet delight for smaller good news. If harmful, further intensity assessment is required.

Stimuli that are disliked, disapproved of, or unacceptable—such as an unpleasant smell or offensive words—but that carry no aggression or threat, elicit disgust. The immediate thought with disgust is to confirm that the source will not harm oneself; rejection suffices, so the impulse is merely to move away or ignore it. Contempt is the most common form of disgust: disapproval combined with a very low evaluation.

If the negative stimulus escalates to a threat—whether to physical safety, opinions, reputation, or even minor contradictions and obstacles—anger arises. Anger is characterized by an urge to attack, a desire to eliminate the threatening source through specific action.

However, if the negative pressure exceeds the person's capacity to bear—for instance, being unable to fight back, argue effectively, or reverse a decline—the individual loses confidence to attack (or resist) and to remove the threat. The only options left are flight or resignation. At this point the harmful outcome has not yet occurred, so the emotion is fear.

Once the outcome materializes and becomes an irreversible fact, fear ceases and is replaced by sadness. Any negative stimulus that produces a result entails loss of benefit, and sadness stems from that loss. All prior concern and effort were aimed at preventing the adverse outcome; once it occurs, the body goes limp and loses energy—the most typical outward sign of sadness.

*[Figure omitted from source conversion: 图1]*

In summary, the first reaction to an effective stimulus is surprise, after which two emotional directions emerge: the positive direction produces varying degrees of pleasure; the negative direction, depending on stimulus intensity, produces disgust, anger, fear, and sadness in ascending order. These six basic emotions encompass all possible emotional reactions when humans process external information. Common emotions such as contempt, irritation, apprehension, embarrassment, displeasure, and guilt can be classified as derivatives of these six at different intensities. See Figure 1.

Likewise, American micro-expression pioneer Paul Ekman holds that humans possess six universal emotions and expressions that transcend race, culture, and geography: surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and pleasure. To substantiate this crucial conclusion, the professor traveled to primitive tribes in New Guinea to study facial expressions among populations that had never had deep contact with the outside world. This single pioneering study alone commands the respect of later generations.

Emotions process different stimuli, while expressions constitute another human communication channel—more authentic and accurate than language. More importantly, these six emotions and the expressions they drive are naturally linked. By dissecting expressions and analyzing the emotions behind the face, one can, to some extent, discern others' true inner thoughts (see Chapters 2–3 for details).

Therefore, this book organizes its research and discussion of micro-expressions along the trajectory of these six emotions. In addition to the six basic emotions—surprise, disgust, anger, fear, sadness, and pleasure—it incorporates as many derivative emotions as possible, seeking the core essence of their subtle expressions to help readers improve their ability and efficiency in capturing micro-expressions. Surprise is a relatively pure emotion; only afterward do various judgments arise. If the judgment is negative, the following sequence appears according to stimulus intensity: disgust-type emotions (including disgust, contempt, disdain, and other derivatives), anger-type emotions (including anger, threat, irritation, and displeasure at varying intensities), fear-type emotions (including fear, apprehension, unease, worry, and other derivatives), and sadness-type emotions (including sadness, guilt, helplessness, and other derivatives). If the judgment is positive, pleasure arises and triggers a smile.

Each emotion possesses its own distinctive expression. No matter how complex, every expression has necessary and typical morphological features. These minute and subtle features are the so-called micro-expressions (微表情).

Whether dealing with pure “micro-expressions” or complex compound expressions, only one method exists for grasping their true meaning: capture every subtle change on the face, distinguish genuine from feigned elements, and finally confirm the inner thoughts they represent.

Next, test your current level of expression-recognition ability.

## What You Know and Don't Know About the Psychology of the Sexes

Men and women differ visibly in outward appearance. Overall, men have darker skin, coarser hair, and sturdier bones and muscles. Women, by contrast, have lighter skin, finer hair, and softer bones and muscles. These differences determine distinct social roles for men and women and shape perceptions of gender relations—namely, that men are dominant and women are merely appendages.

For a long historical period this traditional view of the sexes was widely accepted and is still staunchly defended by some today. Whether in ancient times or in the modern era, men have been natural warriors who contend with nature and enemies; they symbolize strength and pursue honor and admiration. Women's primary tasks have been household management and child-rearing, creating a sphere of tranquility. Although this clear-cut division of labor has undergone some changes today—women have become increasingly independent and work outside the home rather than relying on men—the psychological needs and characteristics of men and women have not changed substantially.

Men resemble fierce lions; aggression and dominance are instinctive. They are combative, highly possessive, and regard conquest as the highest glory. Once they identify “prey,” they usually strike directly and forcefully. Women resemble docile sheep, seeking stability and warmth—even outwardly capable career women remain inwardly delicate and yearn to be protected.

In relationships, men tend to be careless while women are sensitive and attentive; men are accustomed to taking the initiative, women to being passive—if reversed, the situation can become dangerous.

Men like to conquer; women like to be conquered. Men enjoy women's admiration; women long for a man they can admire.

For men, career is the highest goal; for women, family matters most. In other words, men strive for wealth, power, and women, while women seek beauty, tranquility, and happiness. An interesting phenomenon therefore arises: a strong man is taken for granted and wins women's favor, whereas a woman who is too strong often intimidates men.

I once conducted two surveys. One targeted successful career women; more than 75 percent reported unsatisfactory emotional lives. The other surveyed ordinary unmarried men; 90 percent said they preferred to be depended upon and did not want a future wife who was too formidable.

Under normal circumstances, the physical differences between men and women are absolute, yet psychological differences are relative.

No purely masculine man or purely feminine woman exists in the world. Many men display feminine traits such as sensitivity, delicacy, gentleness, and strong empathy; many women display masculine traits such as

combativeness, toughness, carelessness, and strong ambition. When feminine traits predominate, the person tends to be gentle and compliant; when masculine traits predominate, the person tends to be brave and assertive.

Civilizational progress has made relations between the sexes increasingly harmonious. Compared with the savage primitive era, contemporary men clearly possess more feminine traits; they also value emotion, art, and family and understand gentleness, compassion, and compromise. Women, likewise, have gradually acquired certain masculine traits. They are no longer merely "cave-dwelling animals" responsible for childbearing; they have become confident, courageous, and proactive, and a minority have achieved remarkable success in politics, economics, and other fields alongside men.

For women, the ideal partner possesses both distinct masculine traits and a measure of feminine traits—ambitious and conquering yet considerate. For men, the purely submissive, unmotivated, and indecisive woman is not the most desirable partner either.

## Makeup "Reveals" a Woman's Inner World

Women are born lovers of beauty. Through their own methods they display attractiveness, intelligence, and taste to win the favor of the opposite sex. To understand the woman you meet, in addition to inherent physical features such as skin tone, figure, and face, makeup is another reference that cannot be ignored.

Many women enjoy following fashion trends and adopt currently popular makeup styles. These women are enthusiastic about new things and full of passion for life, yet they lack independent personality. Being with them feels exciting, but if marriage is the goal, further consideration is advisable; nine out of ten lack financial-planning habits and have no long-term plans.

Heavily made-up women possess a strong desire for attention and wield unique charm and control in attracting male gazes. Outwardly glamorous and warm, they are inwardly lonely because they frequently face attacks from conservatives. They are undoubtedly strong, independent, and contradictory. Yet if one day they willingly abandon vivid makeup for a plain style, they can become excellent companions and assistants.

Women who prefer light makeup are generally simple and traditional, not fond of drawing attention. When facing difficulties they may sometimes appear weak. They favor tangible things over avant-garde or dazzling ones. Consequently, most make good domestic partners; only a small portion, being overly sensitive, are prone to hysteria, depression, or autism.

Women who never initiate makeup can be roughly divided into three types. The first are coarse and practical women who are too busy surviving to care about appearance and care only about having enough to eat. The second are plain women who also love beauty and often envy attractive peers, yet due to upbringing they have never tried makeup and dare not, fearing they will make matters worse. The third are women who pursue natural beauty; they understand and appreciate beauty, possess refined artistic taste, and hold deep insights into many matters.

Women who spend a long time applying makeup are perfectionists and somewhat lacking in confidence. Women who pay special attention to one particular feature during makeup demonstrate clear self-awareness and know how to accentuate strengths and conceal weaknesses.

Lipstick color also reflects a woman's inner state. I can guarantee that at least half the women in the world use lipstick. Some feel as awkward without it as if they had not dressed properly.

Generally, bright red lipstick accentuates the lips and projects a sexy, passionate, outgoing personality; such women are socially adept and often work in public relations or sales. Women who use pink lipstick tend to be gentle, innocent, and caring, with lower psychological resilience; they are somewhat reserved in social interactions yet warm inside. Women who favor purple lipstick usually have a strong desire for attention and a sense of superiority; they pursue extraordinary lives and often captivate men.

Corresponding to their innate love of beauty, women also love compliments, yet complimenting women requires care. Using the same phrase for every woman will, I guarantee, make 80 percent of them dislike you.

When interacting with women, you must capture their individual characteristics at any moment, identify their strengths, and highlight them. For example, praise a young woman for her radiance and vitality; praise an attractive woman for her beauty and charm; praise a middle-aged woman for her maturity and grace; praise a woman who enjoys dressing up for her striking appearance; praise a woman who dislikes makeup for her natural beauty...

In short, a woman's beauty is brought out by praise. Even if you are not eloquent, do not stint on the well-chosen compliment.

## The Barnum Effect: Others Can Always Influence Your Emotions

In daily life and work it is unrealistic to engage in constant self-reflection, so many people rely on external information to understand themselves. Consequently, during the process of self-understanding people are easily swayed by outside information, lose direction under surrounding cues, and adopt others' words and actions as their standard.

The Barnum effect refers to the tendency for people to regard a vague, general personality description as accurately revealing their own traits. Even when the description is hollow, they still believe it reflects their personality, even if they are not that kind of person at all.

Einstein's father once told him this story:

"Your Uncle Jack and I went to clean a large chimney at the south factory. We had to climb the steel rungs inside to reach the top. Uncle Jack went first, I followed. We held the handrail and finally reached the top rung by rung. When we came down, Uncle Jack still went first and I followed behind. When we emerged from the chimney I noticed something strange: Uncle Jack's back and face were blackened by soot, yet I had not a speck on me."

Einstein's father continued with a smile: "Seeing Uncle Jack's appearance, I assumed I must look just as clownish, so I washed again and again in a nearby stream. Uncle Jack, seeing me come out clean, naturally assumed he was clean too and merely rinsed his hands before striding off down the street. The people on the street laughed until their stomachs hurt, thinking Uncle Jack was mad."

Einstein could not help laughing.

At that point his father said solemnly: "In reality, no one else can serve as your mirror; only you yourself are your own mirror. Using others as a mirror, even an idiot may see himself as a genius."

In life people are constantly influenced by others. Seeing what others do, they subconsciously feel they should do the same, so they act without independent judgment and develop cognitive biases in everything, always unable to find the correct approach.

We are social beings and cannot survive apart from society. Therefore our emotions are inevitably affected by others' words and actions. We should view matters objectively, maintain our own values and judgment standards, so that we can control our emotions and prevent them from being easily swayed by others.

To avoid the Barnum effect, recognize oneself objectively and truthfully, and manage one's emotions, the following paths can be taken:

### 1. Learn to face yourself

Consider this scenario: a woman falls into the water, is rescued, and upon waking finds herself naked. What is her first reaction? The answer is a scream followed by covering her eyes with both hands. Why does she act this way? Psychologically, this is a classic case of unwillingness to face oneself. Because she perceives a flaw, she covers it in a manner she believes is correct. Therefore, to control one's emotions one must first have an accurate self-understanding and learn to face oneself.

### 2. Cultivate the ability to gather information and exercise keen judgment

No one is born with prudent judgment. Judgment is the capacity to make decisions on the basis of collected information; the supportive role of information must never be overlooked. Without sufficient information, wise decisions cannot be reached.

### 3. Stay calm

## Love Personality: Dangerous Traps in the Emotional World

When with someone of the opposite sex, we instinctively hide our character flaws and bad habits. While in Britain, the family I rented from had a daughter who was young and rather cold, even indifferent to her own parents. Yet the moment her boyfriend appeared at the door, the girl instantly became warm and lively, shedding her usual languor. He was a fine young man with a healthy complexion and a resolute face. From the way he greeted people and shook hands, he seemed well-mannered and, with a little polishing, destined for success.

No matter how cautious and shrewd a person usually is, once romance enters the picture, intelligence plummets—sometimes to zero. When two people enter the hall of marriage, they shift from lovers to family. In the grind of daily life, flaws and conflicts unnoticed during courtship surface. We often hear complaints such as “How did you become so slovenly?” or “Can’t you be as diligent as before?”

For example, the lady told me: “Reginald made me feel the thrill of romance. He was humorous and always made me laugh. At meals his manners were elegant, unlike my husband, who waves his hands about while eating.”

I understood her distress and hesitation. She believed she had found a better man than her husband and hoped to fly away with him, yet the decision felt like a gamble requiring courage and resolve; she needed someone to support her emotionally. As a counselor, I never give a direct answer in such cases. I simply asked: “On a scale of 100, what score would you give your husband before marriage, shortly after marriage, and in the past six months?”

She thought for a moment and replied seriously: “Before marriage, despite some bad habits, we got along pleasantly enough—90 points. After marriage I noticed he grew lazier; we argued occasionally, but I thought

that normal—70 or 80 points. Now... oh, I really can't stand it. He boasts, shows no gentlemanly manners, and dislikes brushing his teeth... even 60 points feels generous."

"Indeed, madam. The longer one lives with someone, the more visible their shortcomings become. Have you considered that during your time with Mr. Reginald you have shown only your best side? You did not want him to see your shortcomings, correct? Mr. Reginald's mindset is the same. If you had lived with him for seven or eight years, would your assessment of him really be higher than your current view of your husband? What do you think?"

She fell silent for a while, then said: "Perhaps I should think it over more carefully."

In the emotional world, "love personality" is an extremely dangerous trap. Men and women in the throes of passion consciously conceal their flaws, creating an illusion of perfection. Once two people truly share daily life, shortcomings in character and habit gradually appear. Many couples end up unhappy in marriage precisely because they were blinded by "love personality."

## Conclusion: Letting the Right Person Do the Right Thing

A couple I know forced their eleven-year-old son out of the house to play football with other children. They told me: "Mr. Balken, we only want him to become stronger and more energetic. But Bill does not understand our good intentions at all; he buries himself in books all day..."

I met the boy. He enjoys quiet and is interested only in books; he refuses all vigorous exercise, even though both parents are sports enthusiasts.

This reminds me of another case. Years ago, a young European man came to me for advice. He said that to survive he had become a tailor, yet he disliked the work. Unable to escape the "terrible" job, he felt miserable.

Compared with most Europeans, the young man was slight in build with small hands and feet, but he had a large head, a high broad forehead, and a prominent chin—if one applied the earlier analytical framework, this described an energetic, enterprising young man who liked to ask "why," with strong logical thinking and observational skills.

Such an intellectual type is clearly unsuited to the monotonous, mechanical work of tailoring. I recommended he join an advertising agency; I later heard he was doing well.

The point of this example is that habits can be formed or changed, but innate nature cannot be altered. Like the boy mentioned earlier, he was born an intellectual type—diligent, studious, and thoughtful. Forcing him into an athletic mold would only distort both body and mind, ultimately producing neither a practical doer nor preserving a thinker. Therefore parents and teachers must first grasp a child's physical and psychological characteristics, then provide purposeful, planned cultivation and training so the child can develop most fully.

Besides the intellectual type already mentioned, there are also the energetic type and the active type. The energetic type harbors great inner reserves of energy; the plump person described earlier is a typical example. The active type is outwardly lively, enjoys movement, and tends to be extroverted. In reality, most people are mixed types; purely intellectual, purely energetic, or purely active individuals are rare.

The intellectual-active mixed type combines thinker and doer; automobile magnate Henry Ford, Madame Curie, and General Pershing all belong to this group. The intellectual-energetic mixed type is generally plump and often plays key roles in education, finance, law, advertising, and the arts—for instance, Columbia

University president Nicholas Murray Butler, scholar Hendrik Willem van Loon, and young director Orson Welles. The active-energetic mixed type is the active plump person whose domains include railways, construction, sports, manufacturing, and the military; they usually serve as managers—Italian dictator Mussolini, steel magnate Andrew Carnegie and his assistant Charles Schwab are famous representatives.

Once the characteristics and expressions of each type are understood, one can match the right person to the right task and the right task to the right person.

## Watches: Glimpsing Innate Nature Behind Time

Time is precious. A person's attitude toward time is closely tied to character, and the influence time exerts is often conveyed through the watch one wears. The relationship between the two is intimate; a brief explanation follows.

One new type of electronic watch appears completely black at first glance, showing nothing, yet pressing a button reveals the time in red. People who like to wear such watches tend to be somewhat unusual. They possess strong independent awareness, dislike constraints, prefer a free and easy life, and do whatever they please. Others see them as mysterious, and they themselves wish to remain so, enjoying the speculation others direct at them.

People who favor liquid-crystal-display watches are usually frugal, straightforward in thinking, and fond of simple, convenient things.

Those who wear alarm-style watches can strictly discipline themselves and keep their nerves taut at all times. Although not especially traditional or conservative, they habitually follow rules when handling affairs. They are responsible and sometimes deliberately cultivate and train that sense of responsibility.

Wearers of multi-time-zone watches tend to be somewhat unrealistic. They possess a bit of cleverness, yet it remains confined to imagination and is never put into practice. Such people are often indecisive and, when responsibility is required, tend to evade it.

Wearers of classic gold watches have a long-term perspective and plan everything with the future in mind. They will not sacrifice the overall picture for minor gains and make good businesspeople. They are meticulous, flexible, and can often foresee developments.

Wearers of pocket watches manage time well, arrange every matter appropriately, and know how to balance work and rest.

Wearers of wind-up watches generally have strong independent awareness. They dislike receiving favors and prefer self-sufficiency; they insist on doing things themselves and value the sense of accomplishment that follows. They enjoy tackling tasks that involve a certain degree of difficulty; if something is accomplished too easily, they feel it lacks meaning or value.

People who wear watches without numerals hold strong abstract concepts; they like ambiguity and prefer that matters not be explained too thoroughly.

Those who wear watches specially designed for them by a designer care greatly about the image and status they project to others and may even change themselves for a particular matter or person. Some things become exaggerated in their telling so they can draw attention to themselves.



People who wear no watch at all are relatively independent and autonomous; others cannot easily control them. They like to do what they want and display strong adaptability wherever they are, quickly devising responses to thorny problems. They also enjoy making friends.

## Handbags: Revealing Character and Preferences

In daily life the handbag has become an inseparable assistant. Precisely for this reason, observing the handbag a person uses can help one understand its owner.

Handbag styles vary endlessly, and different personalities choose different styles.

- People who choose ordinary, mass-market styles usually lack a particularly distinctive character; they mostly follow the crowd and echo others.
- People whose handbags have striking features fall into two categories: first, those with strong individuality who hold unique thoughts and views on many matters—most of them possess artistic sensibility and enjoy novelty and risk; second, those who deliberately act for attention, whose desire for self-expression and vanity are especially strong.
- People who like casual-style handbags know how to enjoy life and are not overly strict with themselves.
- People who like briefcases are often company executives or employees of formal firms; they handle matters with care and caution.
- People who like small, decorative handbags have usually never faced hardship; they are emotionally fragile and easily abandon their ideals when setbacks occur.
- People who like medium-sized shoulder bags value independence yet remain conservative in character.
- People who like small, delicate but impractical handbags have limited worldly experience, little guile, and hold optimistic expectations for the future.
- People who like small handbags with strong ethnic or regional flavor often dress and think differently from most; at times they appear out of place, so their interpersonal relationships are not especially good.
- People who like oversized handbags enjoy freedom and lack of restraint; they easily form relationships but also easily break them, approach life with a casual attitude, and lack strong responsibility.
- People who like handbags with many pockets and keep everything neatly arranged lead orderly lives, keep a clear head, and rarely act foolishly.
- People who keep their handbags in disorder tend to be vague in their actions and unclear about goals, yet they are warm and approachable; getting to know and befriending them is relatively easy.
- People who like metal handbags are sensitive, keep pace with trends, and readily absorb new things.
- Women who like masculine leather bags are relatively strong, capable, and tend to be extroverted.
- People who like neutral-color handbags do not wish to create pressure for themselves; they avoid performing in public, dislike being noticed, do not want to offend others, and prefer to remain neutral.
- People who dislike carrying handbags fall into several groups: first, the lazy who find a bag too troublesome; second, the strongly autonomous who desire independence. Neither type possesses particularly strong responsibility.

## Money Follows the Heart: Payment Methods Hold Hidden Clues

Material life is determined by earning money, while spending money reflects spiritual life. The same expenditure can produce entirely different outcomes depending on whether the spender acts consciously or unconsciously.

People who often feel pain when spending money will never find their work easy; their methods and results are unlikely to satisfy bosses or colleagues.

People who know how to spend are different. They treat spending as one of life's pleasures, which in turn makes earning meaningful and joyful. Such individuals usually maintain a calm mindset at work, can pick things up and put them down, and remain unentangled by momentary gains, losses, honors, or humiliations; their colleagues are likewise affected and do not regard work as a burden. Anyone who enjoys shopping knows that purchasing is a process of interpersonal exchange. Only those skilled at communication and reading people can obtain what they truly desire. In other words, people who know how to spend complete transactions at the most satisfactory price and fill the process with pleasure. Besides whether spending brings joy, the manner of payment also reveals a person's psychology and character.

#### © **People who prefer to pay in person**

Such people are relatively traditional and conservative, slow to accept new things, follow rules, lack adventurous spirit and a sense of security, and strongly desire others' approval and recognition. Only when they handle matters themselves do they feel secure.

#### © **People who delay payment as long as possible**

Such people have a strong desire to take advantage, are rather selfish, lack fairness, and always seek maximum return for minimal (or zero) effort. Generally they do not care for or help others; although not especially cold, they are far from warm.

#### © **People who shift the payment task to others**

Such people often cannot maintain their own principles or positions and are accustomed to being led by others. They lack responsibility; when setbacks arise they become timid and retreat, frequently offering various excuses to exonerate themselves.

#### © **People who pay the bill immediately upon receipt**

Such people do what they say, can pick things up and put them down, act decisively without procrastination, and are sincere and straightforward. They never like owing others, though they can tolerate others owing them.

#### © **People who pay by telephone**

Such people readily accept new things and know how to use them to serve themselves, yet excessive dependence on certain items causes them to lose initiative and become controlled by others. In addition, they place great trust in others.

### Small Accessories and a Woman's Heart

Just as with clothing choices, the accessories a person likes also express inner feelings outwardly. American psychologist Dr. Irene believes that observing the small accessories on a person can reveal their inner character.

- **Women who like gold earrings:** usually quite confident. They are outgoing, friendly, and exercise good self-control.
- **Women who like silver earrings:** act in an orderly, rule-bound manner and dislike sudden changes.
- **Women who like old-style earrings:** generally love family and are loyal to relatives; they make good home companions.
- **Women who like large earrings:** enjoy attracting attention and are generally carefree.

- **Women who like gem-set earrings:** pay great attention to appearance.

Women who like to wear bracelets or bangles are usually energetic, spirited, and full of vitality. They are exceptionally intelligent, possess special talents in certain areas, and are idealistic. They know what they want, pursue it actively, and do not give up easily.

Some women pay attention to overall coordination in dress and often wear brooches; they attach considerable importance to their external image, act prudently, and sometimes harbor suspicion. While they wish to attract notice, they can also conceal that desire well.

Women who like jewelry are, nine times out of ten, perfectionists. Those who wear small, unobtrusive pieces are generally steady; their desire for self-expression is not strong, yet they care deeply about fitting into a given atmosphere and therefore pay special attention to overall styling when choosing clothes. If the jewelry is large, abundant, and dazzling, it indicates strong vanity and a love of showing off.

Among women's many accessories, rings are especially important:

- The more ornate a wedding ring, the stronger its owner's desire to be noticed.
- If a ring bears a family crest, the owner values family highly.
- Women who like diamond rings often feel smug, remain intoxicated with past glories, and possess considerable vanity.
- Women whose rings feature highly complex and unique craftsmanship generally hold strict standards for people and matters, are confident, and can be stubborn.

If a person wears no accessories at all beyond necessary clothing, it indicates simplicity, a pursuit of natural beauty, and self-confidence; they believe they do not need external adornment. Nevertheless, most women still choose one or two accessories to enhance their beauty.

## Home Decor Hints at Personal Taste

The bedroom is a highly personal space. If you wish, you can make the bedroom an extremely private place. Everything used to decorate the bedroom, from bed linens to paintings on the wall, hints at what kind of person you are.

### © **Treating the bedroom as the center of life, using it for eating, entertainment, and sleeping**

Such people tend to be outgoing. They want others to know them and hope others will share their interests and joys with them. In other words, they "rejoice in others' joy and grieve in others' grief."

### © **The room is used only for sleeping**

This person's personality bears some resemblance to the bedroom: orderly in every respect, knowing how to control their emotions and rarely losing their temper. In most situations they behave with great propriety and naturalness.

### © **Walls covered with celebrity posters**

Almost everyone has idols they admire. If the bedroom walls are covered with posters of admired figures, each face larger than life, the person tends to be somewhat withdrawn and finds it difficult to interact well with others. They often give up what is easily within reach and chase after the unattainable. They lack self-confidence and always feel inferior in every way.

### © **The bedroom is lavishly decorated yet lacks personal style**

Although the owner possesses a certain level of taste, they do not trust their own judgment. Bound by convention and rules, they cannot act freely.

### © **The bedroom contains various toys and fitness equipment**

This person is a big child—outgoing, cheerful, and lively, warm and affectionate toward others, and possessed of a certain empathy. Their life is always filled with passion; they detest dull, unchanging, or slow-paced routines.

### © **Some people keep their living room very neat and clean, suitable for visitors, yet their bedroom is a complete mess, resembling a junkyard**

On the surface such people may appear efficient, but in reality they are quite sluggish. They cannot take tasks seriously and often muddle through or do the bare minimum.

### © **The room still contains many childhood items such as furniture, souvenirs, toys, and team flags**

This person harbors a strong sense of nostalgia. They are not yet ready to leave childhood or decide what to do after becoming independent. They enjoy parental protection and constraints and remain emotionally immature.

## Choosing the Right Person to Marry

"I'm getting married!"

The sentence takes only seconds to say, yet maintaining a marriage requires a lifetime. Men's and women's differing understandings and experiences of love and marriage mean that sustaining a marriage is necessarily a process of striving for balance.

During a card game, several players discussed the topic of "partner compatibility."

A divorced woman told us that her marriage failed mainly because she and her husband were too alike; she felt as though she were "marrying herself," and life became "utterly boring." Another divorced woman said, "I like quiet—reading and listening to music—yet he loves going out and can't stand staying home for five minutes. At first I would reluctantly go out with him, but over time..."

When two people are too similar—both hot-tempered, both taciturn, both extravagant, or both miserly—married life is either filled with tension or as stagnant as a pool of still water. Of course, if the differences are too great and they can never find common ground, the marriage is also unlikely to last.

Therefore people often ask me what kind of partner they should choose to enjoy a harmonious and happy marriage. In reply I would like to quote a single man who was playing cards with us at the time:

"Although I am not yet married, I know exactly what kind of woman I need. First, our interests and hobbies should be roughly the same so we have more topics and resonance. Second, we should each have our own areas of strength so we can respect and admire each other while maintaining our own space. Third, if she can tolerate certain shortcomings of mine or help curb my spending habits, I would feel truly honored."

Many people would agree with this player's view. Historical and contemporary experience tells us that the true meaning of a "lifelong partner" is not momentary excitement or satisfaction, but someone who can accept our shortcomings for a lifetime and help us develop our strengths.

Most unhappy marriages result from an initial error in judgment—either a failure to understand oneself correctly or a failure to understand one's partner correctly. The worst case is having no accurate understanding of either party and remaining lost in a world of fantasy.

Choosing a partner must be approached with care, and personality analysis is a step that cannot be omitted.

## Perfume: The Scent of Love and Personality

Everyone has a different scent, just as every romance carries different memories. In this sense, perfume is more than perfume; it also contains love. That colored or transparent liquid can bring peace or passion, intoxication or clarity to your love life. Therefore, a person's taste in perfume reveals their romantic personality.

Let us begin with a test.

If perfume represented a place, which of the following would your intuition lead you to choose?

- **A: Rose garden**
- **B: A harbor in the Far East**
- **C: Desert with flowers swaying in the wind**
- **D: Internet café**
- **E: Fresh hot spring**

People who choose "rose garden" are filled with romantic feminine sentiment and like to pursue a passionate, romantic emotional life. They do not calculate the emotions they invest in the person they love; their entire heart is devoted to selfless love for the other.

People who choose "Far East harbor" are filled with mysterious exotic charm and a melancholic temperament. They love the love they imagine and will pursue an ideal emotional life relentlessly. Such people enjoy guessing subtle changes in the other person from their movements and expressions. They also possess strong observational skills and can sense what the other is thinking, making them a mysterious and unpredictable type.

People who choose "desert with flowers swaying in the wind" possess a melancholic, independent, unconventional temperament. From the inside out they exude a faint melancholic aura, like an orchid blooming alone in a secluded valley. They do not care whether anyone applauds their beauty. They enjoy the feeling of independence, sometimes feel lonely, yet cannot tolerate being tainted by worldly conventions.

People who choose "internet café" have unpredictable, sensitive qualities and always crave novelty. They cannot endure monotony or mediocrity. In the realm of self-exile they are absolute masters. They are fascinated by sudden shifts between elegant and unrestrained roles.

People who choose "fresh hot spring" are filled with the soft, pure, and beautiful qualities of a clear spring, like a pure white lily. They deeply appreciate every delicate and beautiful thing in life. They know how to enjoy a good life and make those around them cling to them as one clings to the water of nature.

## Marriage Advice

The scholar Fosdick once said: "Marriages do not fail; people fail."

So how can one avoid an unhappy marriage?

If you are a woman with delicate skin, soft hair, refined features, and a slender figure, would you be willing to marry a man with rugged looks and a strong, bold physique? I imagine seventy to eighty percent of women would shake their heads. Of course, nature might be very pleased to see the two united, since such a union often produces robust children. In real life, however, the cost of such a union is too high, because a woman's softness and delicacy gradually fade with time. Nor do I recommend marrying a similarly frail, pale scholar. Two equally sensitive and fragile people together tend to hurt each other or themselves.

By the same token, if you are a blunt and straightforward man, marrying a mischievous and rough girl is clearly unsuitable; you would never understand what ideals, culture, or art are. You had better not choose a woman whose skin is too delicate or whose appearance is too soft and beautiful, because your carelessness will make her feel neglected, and she will gradually drift away.

If you want your partner to love the family and remain loyal, look for someone whose back of the head is fuller. If you want a partner who can earn money and manage finances well, pay attention to the temples—the wider this area, the greater their ability to make large sums.

If you like someone with perseverance, they should have a high head (the portion above the ears) or a long, protruding chin.

In addition, I want to give you a tip—beware of people with very thick lips, a large back of the head, a fleshy nape, and thick, fleshy eyelids. Try not to get involved with such people; they represent selfishness and greed.

There is no absolute perfection in the world, but I am certain we can move toward greater harmony if we apply a little common sense.

## The "Confession" of the Beard

The beard is a man's signature facial feature. Like the eyebrows, eyes, and mouth, it can also reveal a person's inner world—more precisely, a man's inner world.

- **Men with thick beards and thick hair:** Generally possess an enthusiastic and proactive personality. They are active, have wide social circles, speak their minds, and give an impression of being easygoing, yet they are absolutely trustworthy.
- **Men with sparse beards:** Give a refined and bright impression. If their hair and eyebrows are also not very thick, they appear energetic overall, indicating a healthy body and positive mindset.
- **Men with sparse beards but thick hair:** Tend to be passive, treating people and situations with indifference and giving an introverted or aloof impression.
- **Men with very little or almost no beard:** Generally appear somewhat feminine, and their personality leans feminine as well.

If a man's beard curls like screws, with each strand clearly visible and distinct in density, he is certainly intelligent, full of unusual ideas, and especially suited to creative work. He has far-sighted vision, excellent planning and leadership abilities, and, combined with a broad mind and cheerful disposition, becomes one of the male types most favored by women.

Some men like to keep their beards long; they generally possess artistic sensibility and are romantic and affectionate. They are gentle and considerate, making the women with them often feel they are in heaven. Yet this passion does not last long, because they remain flirtatious at heart.

A beard that is strong and powerful, like an open halberd, belongs to a man of great ambition and planning—a leadership type. If they are willing to work hard at self-cultivation, they have every chance of becoming prominent figures in business or politics.

A man with a loose, messy beard appears careless but is actually meticulous beneath the surface. He too is a leadership type, only with a more impatient temper. If the beard grows all the way behind the ears, it indicates that, given the right opportunity, this man could become a high-ranking political official.

## Neckties: “Tying” a Man’s Personality

For men, tying a necktie is like women tying a silk scarf. To a certain extent, the way a necktie is knotted and how it matches the suit color can reflect a man’s principles of conduct and moral character.

- A man who ties his necktie small and tight, if he is thin and slight, is trying to make himself appear “taller” with the small, tight knot. If he is not thin and slight, he is displaying his authority, as if saying, “You had better not show the slightest contempt or neglect toward me.”
- A man who ties his necktie large and loose is usually refined, unrestrained, and proactive in social interactions. His elegant demeanor is the natural expression of rich emotion, never affected. Because his social skills are highly developed, he wins women’s favor and admiration.
- A person wearing a green necktie with a yellow shirt is usually sunny, energetic, and full of vitality. They turn every idea into action, dislike procrastination, and are confident in their career, though sometimes rash and impulsive with weak self-control.
- A person wearing a dark-blue necktie with a white shirt can balance both sides, acts mature beyond their years, stays focused on work, and is strongly career-oriented.
- A person wearing a multicolored necktie with a light-blue shirt tends to have a petty-bourgeois temperament, is keen on fame and fortune, lacks fidelity in love, and constantly changes their goals.
- A person wearing a black necktie with a white shirt is steady and mature, knows what they pursue in life, is good at reading people, and can distinguish right from wrong.
- A person wearing a black necktie with a gray shirt carries a deep sense of melancholy and is narrow-minded.
- A person wearing a red necktie with a white shirt is passionate and unrestrained, hopes to be the center of attention, and possesses fiery enthusiasm.
- A person wearing a yellow necktie with a green shirt usually has strong ideals and the courage to implement them. They believe that effort will be rewarded, so they do not worry unnecessarily.

## Cultivating Your Powers of Observation

Surely everyone knows the stories of the great detective Sherlock Holmes. Those bizarre and complicated cases, once analyzed by Holmes, quickly come to light. In Conan Doyle’s pen, Holmes is a man of profound knowledge and extraordinary powers of observation. For example, his judgment of Watson’s profession is simply astonishing. The original text is quoted below:

The gentleman possesses the bearing of a medical man and the demeanor of a soldier; therefore he is an army surgeon. His face is dark, yet this is not his natural complexion, for the skin at the wrist is distinctly lighter; hence he has recently returned from the tropics. He looks haggard, evidently having just recovered from a long illness after enduring hardship. His left arm has been injured, and his movements appear somewhat stiff. An English army surgeon who has suffered greatly in the tropics and been wounded—where could that have been? Only Afghanistan, of course.

What an incisive and accurate analysis! In the course of an investigation, Holmes never stops at the surface of events. Instead he seizes the details connected to the essence of the case and observes and probes deeply.

In daily life we often hear such complaints:

"My wife wants a divorce, yet I never noticed the slightest dissatisfaction with our marriage."

"The counselor says my son has been using cocaine for three years, but I had no idea."

"I was fired, yet the day before the boss was still praising me. Good heavens!"

Because we habitually ignore body language and remain indifferent to a person's facial expressions and behavioral movements, these "unexpected" outcomes occur. In other words, we lack powers of observation. Fortunately, observation can be learned. Some people are naturally perceptive; others may be slower. Yet through training and practice anyone can improve their powers of observation.

## Shoes: A Medium for Seeing into the Heart

Shoes not only protect the feet; they are also a medium for reading people. Different personalities choose different shoes, so observing the shoes a person prefers can reveal something about their character and psychology.

- People who love only one style of shoe and, when one pair wears out, buy another of the same style are quite independent in thought. Their goals are clear; they know what they like and dislike. They act with great caution and deliberate carefully before accepting anything. Once they commit, they devote themselves fully. They will not easily betray the affection of family, friends, or loved ones.
- People who prefer shoes without laces seek convenience in everything they do.
- Women who wear thin high heels have a strong desire to perform and wish to attract the attention of the opposite sex.
- People who like fashionable shoes have a strong ability to accept new things, a strong desire to perform, and a high degree of vanity.
- People who wear sneakers outside the court or sports field always place comfort first in life.
- People who like wearing slippers give the impression of being relaxed and casual, yet they have strong personalities and will not change themselves for others. In addition, they know how to enjoy life and do not treat themselves harshly.
- People who like hiking boots devote more time and energy to work than others. They have a strong sense of crisis and are always prepared for sudden events. They also possess strong initiative and innovation, and they feel confident even in unfamiliar fields, believing they will succeed.
- People who like open-toed shoes are extroverted and radiate vitality and freedom. They enjoy making friends, can let go when necessary, and are relatively carefree.

## Makeup: "Painting" a Woman's Personality

The kind of makeup a woman wears is often determined by her personality.

- Women who like fashionable makeup can quickly accept new things.
- Women who favor heavy, glamorous makeup have a strong desire for self-expression. They hope their appearance will attract others, especially the attention of the opposite sex. Avant-garde and open-minded are their intellectual characteristics; they often adopt a tolerant attitude toward bold or extreme behavior. A woman whose dressing table is filled with cosmetics, ribbons, gold and silver threads,



pearls, and so on uses every means to make herself look younger and more beautiful in order to draw attention from those around her and gain the notice of men.

- Women who spend most of their time on makeup are perfectionists who always pursue the utmost excellence in everything.
- Women who began wearing makeup in childhood and have maintained the same style for many years are actually driven by nostalgia; the beautiful past lingers in their memory.
- Women who like exotic-style makeup have rich imaginations and well-developed artistic sensibilities. They yearn for freedom and dislike constraints.
- Women who feel they must wear makeup at all times lack self-confidence; the purpose of makeup is to conceal some perceived flaw.
- Women who prefer light makeup have no strong desire to perform and sometimes even dislike being noticed by others.
- Women who never wear makeup care most about "a lotus emerging from clear water, naturally unadorned"—the most fitting and vivid metaphor for them. They pursue a natural kind of beauty.

## Five Methods to Improve Insight

1. **Clarify the purpose of observation.** Whether observing people or events, one must understand one's own purpose for observation. This avoids blindness and spontaneity, and enhances initiative and focus.
2. **Accumulate a certain amount of knowledge and experience.** A knowledgeable archaeologist can infer an era from a fragment of brick or tile; but for a farmer who only knows how to till the land, it's just a brick or tile, yielding no interesting information.
3. **Establish an order for observation.** Observation should proceed in an orderly and systematic manner. This allows for a more comprehensive understanding of details without appearing abrupt. Especially when interacting with new friends, new colleagues, or a new boss, without a rough "observation roadmap" in mind, important information may be missed.
4. **Engage more senses.** Observation involves not only seeing with the eyes but also listening with the ears, smelling with the nose, and touching with the hands.
5. **Make appropriate records.** It is necessary to organize and summarize the information collected. In this process, one's understanding of the observed subject advances further.

A person in society cannot avoid interacting with others. Only by mastering the correct methods of "reading people" can one better navigate the subtle relationships in interpersonal interactions, making one's life smoother and happier. That is all I have to say. If it brings you some inspiration, I would be greatly honored.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

To verify the Barnum effect, psychologist Forer in 1948 conducted a personality test on students, asking them to rate how well the test results matched their own traits (0 being lowest, 5 highest). In fact, every student received exactly the same "personal analysis":

"You wish to be liked by others, yet you are critical of yourself. You have some personality flaws, but generally you can find ways to compensate. You have many untapped potentials. You appear tough and self-disciplined, but inwardly you feel restless and anxious. Often, you seriously doubt whether your actions or decisions are correct. You like a certain degree of change; once restricted, you become dissatisfied. You pride yourself on being an independent thinker and unwilling to accept statements without sufficient evidence. You consider it unwise to be overly frank with others. Sometimes you are

extroverted, affable, and sociable; at other times, you are introverted, cautious, and quiet. Some of your dreams do not align with reality."

The results showed an average score of 4.26. Finally, Forer revealed that these descriptions were collected from astrological personality relationship descriptions. In reality, these general descriptions fit anyone. As the famous showman P.T. Barnum said when evaluating his performances, his popularity stemmed from including elements everyone likes, thus deceiving someone every minute.

## The Psychology of Men in Ties

A tie is to a man what clothing is to a woman: a symbol of style. A man's principles of conduct and personal character can be read clearly from his tie.

- **Men who tie their knots small and tight:** Most are cautious in speech and action, narrow-minded, and many have solitary personalities. They always consider themselves first in everything, are keen on material pleasures, and are often stingy toward others.
- **Men who pair their ties with appropriately sized knots:** They give off an energetic impression. Such men pay close attention to their image and always appear courteous in public.
- **Men whose knots are loose and large yet whose clothing is neat:** They are generally the most favored by women in social settings. Refined and elegant, with natural charm, they possess extraordinary affinity.

Many men have no habit of wearing ties. Even in relatively formal occasions, they dress casually. Most dislike being constrained, often deviate from conventions in their actions, and lead free, unstructured lives, yet they are undoubtedly talented.

Additionally, some men wear ties but cannot tie them themselves and need help. Most are open-minded, unconcerned with trifles, easygoing, and well-regarded.

## Psychology Mini-Classroom

Professor Rex Hersey of the University of California conducted scientific research and found that the average human emotional cycle lasts five weeks. That is, the time from elation to depression and back to elation generally spans five weeks. Of course, your own cycle may be longer or shorter. Here we introduce a charting method to help you understand your emotional cycle.

Take any month of the year as an example. Fill the vertical axis with dates 1 through 31 and the horizontal axis with different emotional indices such as elated, cheerful, feeling good, average, not feeling well, sad, or depressed. Each night before bed, reflect on the day's emotions and mark the corresponding cell. At the end of the month, observe your emotional changes and identify patterns. After several consecutive months, you will be surprised to discover when your emotional peaks and troughs arrive. With this knowledge, you gain the ability to predict your emotional shifts and adjust your daily behavior accordingly. For instance, during low periods, encourage yourself that the state will soon pass; during high periods, remind yourself to stay rational.

## Let's Break Up—Humans Are Emotion-Driven Animals

Humans are indeed advanced animals. Beyond the advanced behaviors of creating and using tools, the higher brain functions of memory, cognition, logical deduction, and judgment far surpass those of any other earthly species. Even the instincts and emotions acquired through human evolution are far more complex than those of other animals.

As long as a person is awake, they continuously receive and process information. In this book, information received by the human nervous system is collectively termed "stimuli," yet not all stimuli warrant an external bodily action response. For example, two people sit facing each other; during conversation the boy inadvertently blinks. Although this action does transmit a visual stimulus to the girl's nervous system via her eyes, it carries no special meaning to her, so it is discarded without processing and certainly without issuing any command for action.

Stimuli capable of triggering a stress response are called "effective stimuli." After an effective stimulus occurs, in addition to instinctive reactions (such as immediately withdrawing a hand that touches a glass of boiling water), it may also elicit emotional responses at varying levels.

## 2. Women's Emotional Cycles

Women's emotional cycles have a certain connection to their physiological cycles. To illustrate this, researchers analyzed 96 female suicide patients aged 17–45. Of the 96 subjects, detailed menstrual information was available for 85; 55 were in the menstrual phase and 30 were not. Among the 55 in the menstrual phase, 34 had menstrual irregularities. This largely indicates that the menstrual period is a low point in women's emotional cycles; encountering setbacks or psychological stress during this time may lead to extreme behavior. Therefore, family members should show greater understanding toward women in their menstrual phase and help them navigate emotional lows smoothly.

For women, when the physiological cycle arrives, remind yourself not to become melancholic or anxious, and certainly not to lash out at others arbitrarily. This helps ease emotions and maintain a calm state. Female friends are advised to mark their emotional cycles on a calendar; the moment feelings of melancholy, anxiety, or irritability arise, check whether an emotional low has arrived. This method can help women ease emotions and manage their emotional cycles.

### The Trap of "Romantic Personality"

A very beautiful lady once consulted me:

"My husband and I have been married for eight years. I have always felt quite satisfied and believed we were very well matched. But six months ago something unexpected happened. I met a man. Through my interactions with him, I saw another world. I began to understand what true love is. Before this, I thought happiness meant a stable life; now I know that is not the case. Rigard—the man—fills my life with passion and anticipation, and I increasingly feel my husband has many shortcomings, sometimes to the point of being unbearable. I want to be with Rigard and start a new happy life. Yet I am unsure whether this is feasible, and I feel conflicted. Mr. Balkan, can you give me some advice?"

I often encounter similar questions, but I rarely offer them advice.

### Men Who Suddenly Change Their Clothing Preferences Want to Alter Their Lifestyle, Yet Also Carry an Element of Escaping Reality

A company employee, Xiao Zhang, had until now always worn suits of fixed style and tone. One day, however, he arrived at work in a dashing jacket, bright trousers, and a tie of an entirely different color. From both surface and psychological perspectives, Xiao Zhang's inner self must have received some stimulus that prompted several changes in his thinking; thus, in his deeper psyche, he usually harbors some new intention.

Colleagues curiously speculate: "Does he have something going on today?" "What problem has he encountered?"

When dealing with someone who suddenly alters their clothing preferences, if you wish to maintain a good relationship, act as though it is nothing out of the ordinary or compliment that he looks good in anything. His heart's door will surely open to you; an accepting attitude is stronger than a questioning one, and you will earn his reciprocation—praise.

#### (IV) Men with Extremely Strong Possessiveness

Their greatest flaw is treating women as private property. If a wife goes out alone or comes into contact with other men, they become jealous, suspicious, obstructive, and interrogative, completely disregarding the wife's dignity and feelings; in severe cases they may even resort to physical violence. They tend toward extremes and, for women, are simply demonic.

As I stated earlier, the union of man and woman is a process of striving for balance. Yet with the four types of men described above, balance is difficult to achieve.

No relationship is without expectation of return, both material and emotional; for most women, the emotional return matters more than the material. Overall, a failed marriage inflicts greater and deeper harm on women. Therefore, when choosing a partner, women must proceed with utmost caution, clearly discern a man's "true nature," and never be driven by momentary impulse.

#### Clothing: Reflection of Temperament and Taste

In ancient times, the style and material of clothing served as markers of a person's age, identity, status, and even clan. Today these markers are no longer necessarily reliable, yet clothing remains a person's "second skin" and can still reflect personality, character, and psychological state.

Humans arrive in this world naked; only to conceal their true appearance do they don clothing. Yet humans never anticipated that wearing their favorite clothes (including color and material) would instead reveal their inner psychology without disguise.

Although wearers may not wish others to discern their occupation, economic capacity, or psychological state from their attire and instead seek to express individuality fully, in practice a person's inner self is more directly manifested through clothing. Apparel can very clearly reveal character and psychological state.

#### Sunglasses: A Means to Hide "Telltale Signs"

Wearing sunglasses is a highly effective method for concealing one's psychology. Why do so many people like to wear them?

There are actually many reasons: first, others cannot see what they are looking at; second, sunglasses make a person appear less friendly, so they need not deal with many who wish to approach. Another possibility is to project an aura of intimidation, greater control, and authority.

Of course, there are other reasons. Sunglasses can block many "telltale signs" revealed by the eyes, such as pupil dilation and constriction (especially noticeable in green- and blue-eyed people), changes in the eye sockets, and raised eyebrows. Once these "telltale signs" are hidden, others find it difficult to read his psychology, while he can easily read theirs.

## (I) Men with a Mother Complex

Some men, even after reaching adulthood, remain severely dependent on their mothers. They lack independent opinions, lack initiative, fear losing their mother's love, constantly watch her expressions, and live solely to please her. Excessive attachment to the mother easily feminizes their thinking, speech, and behavior. Entering society with this attitude, they become timid individuals lacking autonomy. Moreover, they are accustomed to receiving unilaterally.

They find it intolerable when their wives speak ill of their mothers and may even feel an inexplicable sense of guilt themselves. Consequently, they frequently quarrel with their wives, widening the rift in the marital relationship until it becomes irreparable.

## (III) Red

**Keywords:** Passion, impulsiveness, sensuality

Red is the color of flame. People who like red are like flames—full of passion, daring to take risks and strive. They are energetic and emotionally rich, able to make friends wherever they go and achieve success in their careers. Their greatest character flaw is excessive impulsiveness, which sometimes brings them trouble. At the same time, people who like red are also very romantic.

However, I feel it necessary to remind everyone: red can also evoke a sense of bloodiness and violence, so it is best to avoid wearing bright red clothing in serious meetings, negotiations, or similar settings.

## (III) Men Who Love Only Themselves

Such men devote themselves entirely to caring for and looking after themselves, always proceeding from their own conditions and interests, without understanding how to respect others. Their most prominent trait is selfishness; when conflicts arise, they see only the other party's shortcomings and faults, never their own, and do nothing but complain. To protect themselves they do not hesitate to trample on others' dignity, even when that "other" is a close relative. Therefore they are extremely dangerous.

Some of them lack a sense of security, let alone provide it to women who are naturally insecure; women with them often end up mentally and physically exhausted.

## (V) Yellow

**Keywords:** Friendliness, confidence, hope

This bright color stimulates the brain regions associated with anxiety and has a warning effect. That is why the three-color lights atop New York's Fifth Avenue towers include yellow. To be more precise, bright yellow represents confidence and hope, while pale yellow represents romance and delicacy. People who like to wear yellow are undoubtedly friendly and cheerful. Yet yellow also carries connotations of instability and provocation, so no matter how much you like this color, please avoid wearing yellow clothing during negotiations.

## Hats That Cover the Brain but Not the Mind

Hats not only ward off cold but also enhance aesthetic appeal. Hats are produced worldwide; entering any entertainment venue or restaurant, you will see signs reading "cloakroom," indicating their importance. So let

me discuss the relationship between hats and personality.

A noble and upright person would hardly wear a hat tilted toward the back of the head. Although these are personal quirks, everyone has occasional habits and postures; precisely these actions and habits are extremely important to those who study them objectively.

## Those Who Dress Simply Lack Confidence and Enjoy Arguing

People who dress simply and dislike ornate clothing generally lack a dominant personality and self-confidence. They hope to project authority over others to compensate for their sense of inferiority. When encountering such individuals, do not argue endlessly with them, because the more inferior a person feels, the more they try to conceal it and the more they will chatter and quarrel in an attempt to preserve what little face remains—an approach that actually harms relationships. At such moments, generously accept their viewpoint; this makes them feel your magnanimity, and you will achieve unexpected results.

## Color Psychology in Clothing

Psychology experts believe color is "the world's cheapest psychotherapist." Everyone has favorite colors and applies these preferences across life and work. The most direct way to learn a person's color preferences is to look at their clothing. Of course, the world's colors are countless; to better explain color psychology, I have chosen the seven colors of the rainbow—red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, and violet—plus the most common black and white as examples.

### (VII) Blue

**Keywords:** Agility, intellect

I once administered a simple questionnaire to 200 consultees and found that almost no one—man or woman, manager or ordinary employee—disliked blue. I believe this is largely due to blue's own charm. Bright sky blue conveys hope, simplicity, and relaxation, while deeper sea blue represents trust and authority, and sapphire blue symbolizes steadfastness and wisdom. In short, people who like to wear blue clothing often combine agility and intellect.

## Those Who Dress Lavishly Have Strong Desires for Self-Display and Love to Show Off

In public we can observe certain people always wearing eye-catching, ornate attire; such individuals generally possess a strong desire for self-display. They also harbor particularly intense desires for money. Therefore, when you see someone dressed in fine clothing, you can discern this psychology; complimenting their attire to satisfy their inflated display desire is a good approach, as it prevents them from easily becoming your enemy.

## Those Who Are Neither Enthusiastic About Nor Indifferent to Fashion Are Moderate in Conduct and Emotionally Stable

Such people are usually rational, neither overly indulgent in desires nor blindly following mass fashion, and always maintain a middle position. They moderately and sequentially select what suits them. They can respect their own opinions appropriately, are relatively reliable and worth befriending, and tend to yield under social pressure; thus, when seeking their counsel, it is best to appeal through personal rapport, which proves far more effective than formal business connections.

## (II) Black

**Keywords:** Mysterious, Dignified, Elegant, Low-key

They are steady and low-key, disliking ostentation. Wherever they go, they project an imposing presence, especially in formal settings.

If a man dressed entirely in black stands before you, you will surely sense he is mysterious and unfathomable. Yet if a woman's black skirt is edged with light-colored lace, you may find yourself drawn to her elegance.

## (VI) Green

**Keywords:** Safety, Steadiness, Vitality

After a long winter, when you see leaves budding and lawns turning green, do you not feel a surge of vitality? Green is indeed the color of life, evoking freshness and comfort. Darker shades such as ink green or olive green convey steadiness and a sense of security. People who favor green clothing also value freedom and tend to be broad-minded.

## (V) People Who Wear Their Hats Tilted

Such individuals often give an impression of frivolity and recklessness, since many hooligans and ruffians also favor this style. This does not mean, however, that everyone who tilts a hat is a troublemaker. Many are quite capable; they simply have a casual disposition. Spending time with them feels relaxed, as they possess a strong sense of humor and do not engage in mind games.

## (II) Self-Important Men

These men aim high without substance. Lacking real ability, they refuse to work steadily and instead boast and exaggerate at every turn. They lack steadiness and drive. Though they appear popular on the surface, they are destined to achieve little. Their flamboyance often forces the women around them to clean up their messes.

## (IV) Orange

**Keywords:** Approachability, Cheerfulness, Warmth

Orange radiates maternal warmth and conveys health and friendliness. Many people in social work prefer orange because their hearts, like the color itself, are filled with sunny warmth. A large portion of them are also ambitious and proactive in exploring new paths.

## Women Who Smoke

Psychologists have found that a person's smoking posture can reveal character and habits. Women who smoke are often extroverted, or smoking itself may make their personalities more outgoing. Generally, extroverted women smoke for stimulation, while introverted women smoke to relieve melancholy.

## (I) People Who Like Wearing Bowler Hats

These individuals see themselves as steady and gentlemanly, enjoying the appearance of maturity in front of others. Close observation often reveals that their leather shoes are always polished to a shine and their socks

are thick. They are self-important, regard themselves as destined for great things, and look down on many matters.

## Chapter 5: Observing People in Detail — Uncovering the Little Thoughts Hidden by Clothing

The master of psychological description, Balzac, wrote: "For a woman, clothing is the external expression of her privacy and desires." Careful attention to a person's attire can reveal their true inner world, because when people wear clothes they love, they lay their psychological state bare.

## Chapter 6: Seeing the Details, Knowing the Heart — Deciphering the Psychological Codes Behind Daily Habits

British psychologist Lane once said: "The habitual actions people perform every day actually reflect a special correspondence between objective circumstances and their personalities." Observing habits is therefore a shortcut to understanding inner activity and the key to grasping a person's full psychological profile.

### (IV) People Who Always Wear Their Hats Straight

Two types of people prefer to keep their hats perfectly straight at all times: one type consists of rule-abiding, honest, and sincere individuals who are practical workers but can seem pedantic or even annoying because they lack flexibility; the other type comprises people with strong principles who are serious and unsmiling, often the sort who achieve success more readily.

### Women Who Raise Their Pinky Finger While Holding a Cigarette

These women tend to be sensitive and somewhat neurotic. Most are delicate and feminine, which can captivate the men around them. They pay close attention to graceful manners and appearance, yet they lack inner confidence. When faced with difficulty or misfortune, they easily lose emotional control and become irritable.

### (III) People Who Frequently Change Hats

These individuals know exactly which outfit, hat, and shoes suit each occasion and are highly attuned to trends. Open their closets and you will be dazzled by the variety of hats and shoes. They dread loneliness yet refuse to accept it, so they frequently appear at dance halls, cocktail parties, and similar venues.

### Women Who Hold a Cigarette Between Their Lips So the Tip Tilts Upward

These women are generally confident, unafraid of difficulties, and highly capable in specialized work, sometimes surpassing men to become leaders. They distinguish clearly between right and wrong, possess a strong desire for self-expression, and tend to be self-centered, aloof, and independent. They enjoy freedom but can easily offend others.

### (VIII) Indigo

**Keywords:** Conservative, Professional, Practical

People who like wearing indigo clothing are usually rule-following, down-to-earth, professional, and serious. If your interviewer wears indigo, it is best to set aside any clever tricks.

### (I) White



**Keywords:** Purity, Simplicity, Sacredness

They stand out, pursue progress actively, live simply, and value practicality. Women in white skirts always project freshness and nobility, while men in white shirts convey a clean, efficient impression.

### Those Who Ignore Fashion Are Often Self-Centered and Seek Novelty

People who show no interest in current trends have very strong personalities. Some, however, simply dare not face the outside world and shut themselves in small, dark rooms. They believe that following others would mean losing their sense of self.

### What Television Programs People Watch Reveals What Kind of Life They Aspire To

Watching television is something most of us do every day; many even use it to pass time. Different people prefer different programs. What hidden personality traits lie behind these choices? Let's find out.

### (IX) Purple

**Keywords:** Elegance, Romance, Mystery

Light purple is noble and mysterious, while deep purple is gorgeous and romantic. People who wear purple clothing therefore carry an artistic air, possess intense emotions, yet remain restrained and rarely reveal their thoughts.

### People Who Enjoy Large Variety Shows

These individuals are confident and fulfilled, warm-hearted and generous, with broad minds. They hold no permanent grudges. In social interactions they avoid defensiveness, readily forgive others' faults, and offer timely help.

### Those Who Favor Trendy Clothing Often Feel Lonely and Experience Frequent Mood Swings

People who completely disregard their own preferences, or even claim not to know what they truly like, treat fashion itself as their preference and simply follow trends. Deep down they often harbor a sense of loneliness, and their moods fluctuate easily.

### (IV) Women Who Hold a Cigarette Close to the Filter

These women have strong self-awareness, enjoy attracting attention, love socializing, and are lively and straightforward—true optimists. They are caring and enjoy looking after others, yet they lack financial discipline and spend freely.

### Four Types of Men to Avoid

Women treat marriage as a lifelong endeavor, yet not every woman attains a happy marriage. Psychologists have identified certain male personality traits that can push women into "the grave of marriage."

### Women Who Hold a Cigarette Close to the Lit End

**These women pay close attention to detail and care greatly about others' opinions of them, so they can be somewhat introverted. They are cautious, rarely display joy or anger on their faces, and belong to**

## **the careful, prudent type.**

### (V) Women Who Habitually Hold a Cigarette in the Middle

These women possess strong adaptability, give others a sense of security, and act prudently. Even when they feel reluctant to help someone, they will not show it.

### (II) People Who Like Wearing Newsboy Caps

Young people who wear newsboy caps tend to be energetic, while older people who wear them are usually law-abiding. Both types, however, love life.

### People Who Enjoy Watching Sports Programs

These individuals are competitive and relish challenges. They approach difficulties as if playing a game and derive great pleasure from striving.

## Identifying Personality Types and Understanding Behavioral Patterns

### **Dependent Personality: The "Mindless" Clinger**

Micro-expression keywords: Put kindly, people with dependent personality are like "mindless" clingers; put harshly, they are bottomless pits of endless demands. Unless you enjoy being relied upon, it is best not to provoke such individuals.

A couple had a son late in life and doted on their precious only child, cradling him for fear he would fall and holding him in their mouths for fear he would melt; they never let him lift a finger.

Years passed and the son grew older. One day the couple had to travel far and could not take him, yet they feared he would starve. The mother came up with an idea: she baked a large ring of flatbread and placed it around the son's neck so that whenever he was hungry he could simply stretch his head forward and eat.

The couple left with peace of mind, but when they returned the son had already died. The bread in front of his chest was nearly gone, yet the bread behind his neck remained untouched. The foolish son had not even known how to turn around to reach the bread behind him and had starved to death.

This fable is well known throughout China. Of course, no one in real life is quite so foolish or lazy, yet the dependent personality displayed by the "son" in the story can be seen everywhere in daily life.

Dependent personality, as the term suggests, means complete reliance on others and a total lack of independent judgment. In practice this is indeed its core feature. Individuals with dependent personality lean without limit on those close to them for every aspect of life, emotion, and decision-making. They may even discard basic self-respect, confidence, and feelings in order to maintain that dependence; without someone to rely on, they feel as though the world has ended.

People with dependent personality are often model children, good students, and devoted wives or mothers. Because of their excessive dependence, however, everything they have is controlled by others, and even their moods rise and fall according to others' decisions. The person depended upon usually feels stuck, like a piece of dog-skin plaster that cannot be shaken off.

When Ah Lie first met Xiao Miao, his eyes lit up. Xiao Miao was gentle and lovely, with a timid air that stirred a strong protective instinct in him.

The matchmaking went smoothly; Ah Lie's tall stature and solid career greatly pleased Xiao Miao's parents.

During their courtship, however, Ah Lie noticed a problem: Xiao Miao was excessively "filial." Even when he asked her out to dinner and wanted to hold or kiss her, she had to report it to her parents and obtain permission first. Lost in romance, Ah Lie interpreted this as strict family discipline and a sign that she valued herself, so he treated her with even greater care.

Before long they married.

Yet the seemingly harmonious couple began quarreling within months.

"I've worked all day and I'm exhausted. You decide things like where to put the rag or what color tablecloth to buy," Ah Lie said patiently.

"But I can't decide," Xiao Miao replied timidly, eyes wide like a frightened fawn.

...

"Darling, what shall we have for dinner tonight?" Xiao Miao asked as Ah Lie returned from work.

"Darling, don't you think we could cook something at home? We bought all the pots and pans," Ah Lie answered, frowning at the brand-new stove and cookware.

"But I don't know how. My mother never taught me."

"Then go buy the ingredients and I'll cook when I get back," Ah Lie replied, suppressing his irritation.

"But I don't know what we're going to eat," Xiao Miao answered, leaving him speechless.

...

Every evening Xiao Miao had a list of questions for Ah Lie to handle. Finally he suggested, "Darling, why don't you find a job? No matter what you do or how much you earn, it would be better than staying home."

Xiao Miao, who had never worked, reddened around the eyes but nodded. "Then what kind of job should I look for?"

...

After considerable effort Xiao Miao went to work, yet Ah Lie's problems only multiplied. At home she asked even more questions—how to get along with colleagues, how to handle office matters—dumping everything on him whether he knew the answer or not.

When Xiao Miao's parents learned that Ah Lie had sent their precious daughter out to work, they rushed to the couple's apartment and berated him: "We raised our girl to this age without ever making her wash a single plate. You're not short of money, so why make her go out to work...?"

Overwhelmed, Ah Lie chose divorce. Afterward Xiao Miao immediately found another man who reportedly doted on her.

A wife like Xiao Miao may appear gentle and refined at first glance, yet few can withstand her “dependence offensive.” People with dependent personality remain like immature children, letting others decide everything and constantly seeking others’ opinions. When dependence exceeds reasonable bounds, it eventually breeds annoyance and fear.

Dependent personality also forms in early childhood. As young children we view our parents as omnipotent and rely on them for care and protection. Likewise, if parents continue to overindulge a child instead of fostering independence, the child may develop a dependent personality marked by lack of confidence, reliance on others, and avoidance of responsibility.

Identifying dependent personality is not difficult. Such individuals typically display the following behavioral traits:

**1. Inability to function independently**

People with dependent personality constantly feel weak and helpless, frequently thinking “I’m so pitiful” or believing they lack ability and energy. They attach their needs to others and, fearing abandonment, become excessively compliant, even allowing others to arrange their lives, goals, and futures.

**2. Lack of autonomy**

Once they find what they consider a reliable “backing,” everything seems fine. To preserve stable affection they abandon their own outlook, values, and interests, becoming increasingly lazy, fragile, and devoid of independent creativity.

**3. Inability to be alone**

Spending even a short time alone triggers panic and helplessness, so they do everything possible to avoid solitude. Before making any decision they require abundant advice and reassurance from others; consequently they are often taken in by glib swindlers.

**4. Avoidance of reality**

They harbor an irrational, compulsive craving for belonging. When they sense this belonging is threatened, they shift blame onto others and shut their eyes to future consequences. Driven by inner fear, they also frequently anticipate abandonment.

**5. Enduring humiliation to preserve relationships**

They evaluate themselves through others’ eyes, always feeling others are more capable. They repeatedly tolerate excessive behavior and sometimes perform demeaning acts they dislike simply to please others. This accumulates suppressed feelings and causes them to abandon their own pursuits and values.

**Borderline Personality: The “Source of Turmoil” with Unstable Emotions**

Micro-expression keywords: For people with borderline personality, life is filled with turbulence; even trivial matters can produce drastic shifts in their view of a person or situation. Their behavioral reactions are therefore extremely unstable.

When we think of Princess Diana, words such as noble, elegant, and charming come to mind. Yet in 1995, during a BBC interview at Kensington Palace, she herself revealed symptoms consistent with borderline personality disorder.

Friends and acquaintances described her as unpredictable: prone to tantrums, sobbing fits, manipulation, outright lying, and self-harm with sharp objects until others fully submitted and obeyed her.

Most individuals with borderline personality are attractive men or women who possess a melancholic or pitiable charm that easily arouses protective instincts in those around them. Their volatile nature, however, often wreaks severe damage on interpersonal relationships.

A new transfer student named Meng Meng joined the class. Rumors of her wealthy family and good looks drew many classmates, including Xiao Dan, who hoped to befriend her.

Meng Meng proved colder than expected, but after months of persistent effort Xiao Dan finally won a smile: "Xiao Dan, you're the kindest and most helpful person in class. I like you very much."

Xiao Dan was delighted, yet her happiness soon turned to headaches.

"Xiao Dan, are you free this weekend? Let's go see Titanic," Meng Meng said cheerfully over the phone.

"But... I already promised to go to the aquarium with Ah Lan and the others..." Xiao Dan replied awkwardly.

"What?" Meng Meng's tone turned icy. "Am I your good friend, or are they?"

"Of course you are," Xiao Dan hastened to reassure her.

"If I'm more important, why would you leave me to go with them?"

"But that's a biology assignment we arranged last week..." Xiao Dan tried to explain, only for Meng Meng to hang up.

After much thought Xiao Dan canceled her plans with Ah Lan and rushed, sweating, to Meng Meng's home.

The moment she arrived, Meng Meng burst into tears: "I knew I was your best friend..."

Such incidents repeated until even Xiao Dan's good temper wore thin. When she tried to end the friendship, Meng Meng cut her own wrist while crying.

She really values me more than her own life! With that thought, Xiao Dan chose to endure in silence.

Did Meng Meng truly value Xiao Dan more than her own life? No. Her actions stemmed entirely from borderline personality.

Borderline personality disorder does not mean a person is on the verge of personality collapse; it means their emotions are chronically unstable and they lack security and consistency in relationships, as though walking along a cliff edge.

The most striking feature is the extreme, rapid reversal in their attitude toward others. At times they seem like fragile children or helpless puppies needing care; at other times they behave like hysterical maniacs or cold, vengeful punishers. One moment they may be warmly friendly; the next, over a trivial matter, they erupt in fury, leaving others bewildered.

Psychologists attribute borderline personality primarily to genetic, neurological, or environmental factors, with the last receiving the broadest acceptance. Many such individuals experienced childhood abuse. Under unstable parental influence their emotions fragmented, preventing them from forming a unified view of the

world and causing them to split experiences into absolute good or absolute bad—both unrealistic. Consequently they oscillate between these poles, producing an extremely unstable personality.

A person may be considered to have borderline personality if most of the following behaviors are present:

1. Extreme lack of security and intense fear of abandonment, sometimes triggering panic over imagined rejection and leading to drastic acts such as self-harm or violence to protect themselves.
2. Identity disturbance: uncertainty about who they are or what they believe, coupled with wildly fluctuating self-assessment—from grandiose confidence to crushing self-contempt.
3. Highly unstable interpersonal relationships. A person may be idealized as the kindest and most wonderful one moment, then completely devalued over a minor slight. Evaluations swing between extreme idealization and total negation.
4. Chronic feelings of emptiness.
5. Rapid, intense mood shifts—from joy to sorrow or anger, from calm to irritability or anxiety—within very short periods.
6. Frequent, intense, and inappropriate anger, often mistaken for mania.
7. Difficulty controlling impulsive self-harm or self-destructive behaviors.
8. Repeated suicidal acts.
9. Under severe stress, transient paranoid ideation or dissociative symptoms involving two opposing personality states. For example, when fearing abandonment they may first exhaust themselves to please the other person, then suddenly turn cold and commit hurtful or self-injurious acts.

Relationships with borderline individuals often feel exploitative or controlling, because their insecurity drives them to use threats, silent treatment, or self-harm to bind others. Their constant oscillation between extremes makes interactions unpredictable and exhausting for most people.

Yet once it is understood that their behavior arises not from malice but from innate loneliness and fear, they become somewhat less repellent. Even so, dealing with them requires great resolve, endurance, and firm adherence to one's own principles. Unless self-harm or suicidal behavior is severe, most people with borderline personality can maintain relationships with others.

### **Avoidant Personality: The Overly Shy "Honest Person"**

**Micro-expression Keywords** People with avoidant personality differ from ordinary aloofness or withdrawal from the world; they even avoid their own hearts. Therefore, people with avoidant personality always exhibit characteristics of blindness, compulsiveness, and irrationality.

Lao Zhou's five-year-old daughter had reached kindergarten age, yet no amount of persuasion from the family could convince the pretty little girl to leave home and attend school.

The helpless family sought help from a psychologist. When Dr. Zhang first met Xiaomei, it took considerable effort before the introverted little girl would speak with her.

"Would you like to go buy a lollipop with Auntie?" Dr. Zhang offered an irresistible temptation for a child.

"No." Xiaomei shook her head timidly. "I want to stay at home."

"Why?" Dr. Zhang asked. "Xiaomei, don't you think the sunshine outside is lovely? Don't you want to go to kindergarten and play with other children?"

"No." Xiaomei kept shaking her head. "I just want to stay home. The children outside don't like me."

"How could that be?" Dr. Zhang looked surprised. "Don't you have even one friend?"

"I used to have Xiao Le. She's cute and can sing, but I'm no good at jumping rope and I'm ugly, so even she doesn't like me anymore." Xiaomei's eyes filled with tears.

"How could that be? You're very pretty. And who would dislike someone just because they're not good at jumping rope?"

"But none of them like me." Xiaomei stubbornly shook her head. "I don't want to go to school. I just want to stay home. I can learn to write and draw by myself..."

Even professional psychologists find children like Xiaomei difficult. Though their external conditions are good, they are extremely introverted, always feel inferior, and carry a victim mentality of being rejected by others. When interacting with people, they constantly watch others' expressions. At the slightest hint of dissatisfaction or contempt, they immediately withdraw into their shells like turtles.

This pattern appears not only in children but also among many adults.

Xiao Huang, a new hire, stood out among his cohort. He graduated from a prestigious domestic university, so his leader placed high expectations on him from the start and provided special training.

This drew envy from colleagues, yet before long the leader shifted attention to another standout employee and set Xiao Huang aside.

The reason becomes clear upon examining how Xiao Huang handled assigned tasks:

When the leader first gave Xiao Huang a project, he intended to groom him as group leader. Upon learning this, Xiao Huang hesitated and told the leader, "I'm just new here. There are many more experienced seniors in the group. I'm afraid I won't do well..."

Although disappointed, the leader accepted Xiao Huang's assessment and dropped the idea.

Later, Xiao Huang's performance satisfied the leader, who again considered grooming him. This time the leader chose a simpler project and asked Xiao Huang to lead three new hires.

Xiao Huang tried to decline, but seeing the leader's darkening expression, he reluctantly agreed.

In the following days Xiao Huang worked diligently, yet even veterans make mistakes, let alone a fresh graduate. Before long a common novice error prompted the leader to summon him for a scolding, delivered more harshly than usual because the leader was in a bad mood.

At the end of the day the leader expected to see Xiao Huang "return victorious," but instead received a disastrous project and three disgruntled employees.

After the reprimand, Xiao Huang's enthusiasm turned into hesitation and over-caution. Simple matters required prolonged indecision. After several arguments with his subordinates, he stopped communicating with them altogether. The project's collapse was inevitable.

Having assessed the situation, the leader labeled Xiao Huang "psychologically unfit for major responsibility" and placed him on the layoff watch list.

In behavioral psychology, personalities like Xiaomei's and Xiao Huang's are termed "avoidant personality," also called "evasive personality." Individuals with this personality lack confidence, severely devalue themselves, and often feel sensitive and insecure. The American *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* systematically summarizes the behavioral traits of avoidant personality into four points:

1. Almost no friends outside family, at most one close friend.
2. Sensitive, shy, and inwardly inferior; afraid of embarrassing themselves in front of others; reluctant to speak in public; even when questioned, fear giving wrong answers that invite ridicule, sometimes crying without reason.
3. Almost never involve themselves in others' affairs unless certain the matter requires them and they will be welcomed. Easily hurt by criticism or opposition, even trivial matters or casual refusals can leave them depressed and unable to recover.
4. Behaviorally withdrawn, harboring unfounded fear of crowds; either unconditionally accept others' opinions or completely avoid interpersonal relationships. They avoid work or activities requiring social interaction and struggle to communicate with others. When unavoidable tasks arise, they exaggerate obstacles or potential dangers.

People with avoidant personality dislike standing out or even speaking with others. This largely stems from childhood. The root cause is a sense of inferiority; children who believe their parents dislike them or who are highly sensitive to negative emotions are more prone to developing this personality.

Psychologists note that inferiority originates in childhood from feelings of pain and incompetence in certain situations, leaving a deep imprint. Additionally, physical or psychological defects, the impact of setbacks on the mind, severe underestimation of oneself, and negative self-suggestion form an inescapable cycle that draws people into avoidant personality.

In daily life, although avoidant individuals fear failure, lack confidence, and hesitate to make new friends, appearing shy, genuine interaction reveals they are not as frightening as other personality types. When engaging with them, proceed slowly and carefully, expressing genuine liking. Rushing forward is most likely to scare them away. Equally important, offer criticism or reproach with extreme caution; one careless remark may result in a letter severing ties.

### **A-type Angry Personality: The Always Tense "High-Voltage Electricity"**

**Micro-expression Keywords** People with A-type angry personality resemble a barrel of gunpowder ready to explode at any moment, keeping those around them cautious and walking on eggshells. When interacting with them, cultivating an inner sea of calm is the most effective approach.

Finance manager Lao Jiang was widely regarded as the most difficult person in the company. The moment he stepped through the office door, everyone erupted into chaos.

"What? It's already this late and your work report isn't finished? Do you not want your salary?" He scolded a veteran employee into meek submission.

"Even if you're new, you've been here long enough. Do I still have to teach you this?" He reduced a new hire to tears.

"Where are the documents I told you to put on my desk last night? I can't find them anywhere. Don't you know this wastes my time?" He sent his secretary scurrying in confusion.



"I told you to prepare long ago. Where have you gotten to? If the accounts aren't done properly by the end of the day, you can explain it to the president yourself!" He pushed the finance staff to desperation.

"It's already noon and you're still mopping the floor? That should have been finished this morning. Don't you know the dust will choke people?" He even berated the cleaning lady.

Do you have someone like Lao Jiang around you?

Such people resemble high-voltage boxes in the wilderness, marked "Keep away." Anyone who approaches too closely receives an immediate shock that leaves them stunned.

In behavioral psychology, these individuals are called A-type angry personality types.

This personality is rarely discussed in ordinary books. Its name does not derive from blood type A but represents a high-stress behavioral pattern.

It is labeled high-stress because A-type angry individuals possess strong ambition, confidence, achievement orientation, and aggression. They habitually engage in high-pressure, high-intensity competitive activities, always hoping to accomplish the most in the shortest time. This demand applies not only to themselves but also to those around them, whom they unconsciously attempt to control. Toward anyone obstructing their efforts, they display powerful aggression.

At bus stops, bank counters, or ticket windows, A-type angry individuals are common. Whether or not they have urgent matters, they appear hurried and impatient, repeatedly checking their watches, glancing at the window, and muttering complaints about the weather, traffic, or the social system. Their behavior affects those nearby. Wherever such a person is present, the temperature seems several degrees higher and everyone grows restless.

This is the "charm" of A-type angry personality: they are perpetually tense and transmit that tension maximally to others, making everyone around them tense, on edge, and agitated.

"Today is the deadline. The task must be finished or no one goes home to sleep." In the design firm the director issued a stern order to the team.

"Is the task really that urgent?" After four or five consecutive overtime days, someone voiced discontent.

"How could it not be?" The sharp-eared director overheard and flew into a rage. "Three or four other companies are competing for this project. Although we hold an advantage, only delivering the most perfect plan in the shortest time matters. If we lose this project, everyone's promotions will be affected."

"Probably only your promotion," someone muttered, too quietly for the director to hear.

After an all-night push, the exhausted employees finally completed the proposal and collapsed at their desks. Only the highly responsible director continued revising the plan.

A week after submission, the client's reply arrived. After evaluating proposals from several firms, they chose a more comprehensive and polished plan from another company.

Having such a leader is both a blessing and a misfortune. The blessing is their fervent drive and confidence that can break through any barrier, inspiring ambition and teaching valuable lessons. The misfortune is that, willing or not, you must keep charging forward with them; any pause from fatigue earns a whip.

A-type angry individuals are so tense and irritable that both their psychological and physiological burdens are enormous. They never relax, pack their schedules with ceaseless activity, and drive themselves beyond their limits through sheer willpower. They permit only success and never failure. This distinctive pattern continuously generates tension and pressure within them. Consequently, they constitute the group most prone to cardiovascular disease and myocardial infarction.

Once we recognize the nature of A-type angry personality, their actions become understandable. Unlike antisocial personalities, they possess a strong sense of responsibility; unlike borderline personalities, they do not lack perseverance. For them, an excess of responsibility and perseverance itself produces greater pressure.

Most A-type angry individuals focus solely on career success. For them, prestigious titles, high earnings, and elevated positions constitute validation; everything else receives indifference.

Although we can understand and sympathize with A-type angry individuals, encountering them in daily life remains extremely trying. When possible, avoid simply complying when they erupt, as this only reinforces their sense of control. Maintaining a steady mindset, clarifying one's own goals, and refusing to be infected by their "high voltage" is the fundamental solution.

## **Schizoid Personality: The "Autistic" Who Struggles with Interpersonal Relationships**

### **Micro-expression Keywords**

People with schizoid personality are often seen as eccentric, solitary, and cold. The reason is that they inherently feel tension and fear toward intimate relationships, causing their interpersonal connections to plummet.

A friend named Ah Hui recently hired a private detective to investigate her husband Ah Ming's whereabouts.

Ah Hui and Ah Ming had been married for over two years. Their married life was not particularly passionate, yet it remained harmonious. However, Ah Ming had a peculiar habit: every month he would disappear from home for a period ranging from one or two days to as long as a week. At first Ah Hui assumed he was on business trips, but once she learned that his supervisor never sent him on such trips, she grew suspicious.

The detective viewed Ah Ming as a silent, even somewhat wooden person; the idea that he would seek a mistress or keep a lover outside seemed entirely implausible. Still, he intended to fulfill Ah Hui's request.

After some investigation, the detective uncovered a secret: in addition to the three-bedroom apartment he shared with Ah Hui, Ah Ming, a programmer at a research institute, had purchased another residence in the same city. Even the detective began to suspect that Ah Ming was supporting a woman elsewhere.

Yet after a week of surveillance, the detective found no trace of any woman entering or leaving the small apartment. Ah Ming continued his normal work routine, simply returning after hours not to the family home but to the solitary small room, where he quietly ate, read, and slept. After seven or eight days he returned home. When Ah Hui asked the detective what he had discovered and received this account, she was utterly perplexed.

In our social circles, people like Ah Ming are regarded as odd. They may maintain normal interpersonal relations, yet those who know them well sense their flat, indifferent expressions and lack of interest—even toward family or friends.

Many assume such individuals are merely introverted, but in behavioral psychology they are recognized as having a distinct personality type: schizoid personality.

Schizoid personality does not reach the level of schizophrenia; it is a personality disorder triggered by severe or prolonged psychological trauma. Most people with schizoid personality are loners who dislike close relationships, have few friends, and show little interest in sex or love. Outwardly they appear solitary and cold, rarely revealing their emotions unless discussing a topic that genuinely interests them, at which point they may show slight animation—yet they still cannot achieve emotional rapport with others.

Individuals with schizoid personality often gravitate toward non-competitive fields such as chemistry, astronomy, or mathematics. As long as the work is not socially oriented, they can excel through knowledge and perseverance. Ah Ming is a clear example. He leaves home because proximity to family triggers fear. For someone with schizoid personality, expressing inner feelings or engaging in intimate gestures feels extremely dangerous. When tension accumulates, he must withdraw for a period; only inside his own world can he regain a sense of calm.

Typical schizoid personality is not limited to the pattern described above. Another, markedly different presentation also falls within the schizoid range.

Li Wei is likewise viewed as an eccentric by those around him. He likes to wear robes resembling ancient Chinese garments, lets his hair grow past his waist, sometimes ties it with a ribbon, and sometimes lets it hang loose in a wild, unrestrained style.

His parents believe Li Wei has read too many novels and become “possessed,” yet to his peers he is interesting despite the exaggerated “look.” He frequently discusses his research in metaphysics, offering original views on the origin of the universe, the existence of the soul, or the cultivation of vital energy. Some listeners who lack worldly experience or broad knowledge feel genuine admiration for his erudition.

Cases like Li Wei also belong to the schizoid personality spectrum. However, not everyone who enjoys discussing supernatural topics qualifies; in addition to magical thinking, people with this form of schizoid personality display other eccentric behaviors. Generally, when speaking, their facial expressions are stiff, their tone distinctive, and their vocabulary unusual. They often leap from one topic to another that seems almost unrelated. This kind of idiosyncratic associative thinking is one diagnostic criterion for schizoid personality.

Beyond an exaggerated emphasis on their own unusual perceptual experiences, the chief difference between this subtype and the first is that these individuals are willing to interact with others, even if the interaction is often unsatisfying. Their emotional state is atypical; suspicion, paranoia, and anxiety dominate. Maintaining close relationships does not reduce their inner tension; instead, the difficulty of sustaining good relations increases their distress.

Psychologist Freud attributed both forms of schizoid personality to childhood trauma. Incorrect upbringing in early years or prolonged exposure to contradictory environments can, under environmental or other stressors, produce schizoid personality.

When interacting with the first subtype, one should show understanding, avoid discrimination or ridicule, and discuss topics in their areas of expertise. When interacting with the second subtype, one must not be dazzled by their mysterious behavior and speech into admiration, nor should one belittle them or make jokes at their expense. Although people with schizoid personality may not care much about mockery, thoughtless ridicule can still hurt them and may provoke anger, leading to unnecessary consequences.

## Eight Physical Features for Judging People

We live in a complex society and interact daily with many different people, many of whom we have never met before. This requires us to remain cautious, employing every mental resource and method to discern, in the shortest possible time, another person's character traits and psychological calculations. Only then can we gain the upper hand in subsequent encounters, seize the initiative, steer the psychological contest, and remain undefeated.

A geologist can read a rock and recount a vivid story of the earth; a botanist can examine a plant and produce an engaging botanical record; an astronomer, using a 100-foot telescope and spectroscope, observes a star millions of light-years away and, by calculating its size, speed, structure, and chemical composition, completes a scientific treatise. Reading people is like observing a rock, a plant, or a star: it requires theoretical guidance and practical verification.

The object of "reading people" is "people"; the key lies in "reading." As parents and teachers, how do we discover a child's potential and guide its proper development? As leaders, how do we identify subordinates' strengths and channel them into productive work? As subordinates, how do we understand a superior's intentions and complete tasks successfully? As negotiators, how do we probe an opponent's psychology and enter the adversary's mind? As business operators, how do we see through consumers' inner desires and convert those desires into revenue?

You must first become a personality analyst—note the term: "personality analyst," not "character analyst." Although many call me a "character analyst," you know my work involves more than analyzing "character."

To many, "analyst" sounds professional, yet it simply means making judgments based on observation and then applying scientific knowledge and experimental data to analyze or predict. Believe me: once you know a few standards and master a little "technique," anyone can become a personality analyst.

The first step in reading people is to form an intuitive judgment from external appearance. In general, human physique exhibits eight features. These obvious external traits encode a person's inner character, lifestyle, thinking habits, strengths, and weaknesses. The eight physical features are as follows:

1. **Body color**, including the color of skin, hair, eyes, and beard. Some people have blond hair, blue eyes, and fair skin; others have black hair, black eyes, and yellow skin. Differences in color correspond to differences in personality, physique, and intelligence.
2. **Body type**. Some people are tall and robust; others are small and compact. Overall, Eastern and Western populations also show clear differences in stature.
3. **Hair, skin, and facial features**. Some people have soft hair and delicate skin; others have dry hair and rough skin. Both innate genetic factors and acquired environmental influences are at work, reflecting lifestyle habits, interests, and values.
4. **Body structure**. A person's physical build is closely related to their way of life. Generally, the thinker type is intelligent, plans ahead, highly creative, and skilled at analysis and reasoning; the doer type tends to carry out the plans formulated by the thinker type; the manager type possesses drive and often assists and supervises the other two.
5. **Facial features**, including the forehead, eyes, nose, mouth, and chin. The shape and movement of these parts all hint at a person's inner state.
6. **Muscle tone and bone flexibility**. This is easy to understand: whether a handshake is firm or limp, whether the body is supple or stiff, indicates what a person is suited for and enjoys doing.
7. **Proportions of body parts**. Studying these ratios yields many interesting discoveries.

8. **Movements and voice.** The most dynamic and textured elements of body language are a person's movements and voice. Gait, posture, handshake style, and tone of voice all convey thoughts and desires. You must learn to distinguish what is deliberate from what is spontaneous, avoid the traps others set, and capture fleeting micro-changes; success will follow.

Everyone has a door that belongs to them alone. If you wish to enter another person's inner world and see the truth of their thinking, the key is to find the right key. These eight "body languages" are the golden keys that open others' hearts and also the golden keys that lead you to success and happiness.

### **The Inner Connection Between Skin Color and Personality**

According to existing scientific data and theories, our ancestors originally lived in the tropical and subtropical regions near the equator. To resist intense ultraviolet radiation, nature endowed them with melanin, giving them brown skin and eyes. Later they discovered fire, achieving a great leap forward. Some began a journey of world conquest. They traveled from the warm south to the cold north, continually adapting to changing environments along the way. In the north, whether frozen or rainy and overcast, sunlight was markedly reduced compared with equatorial regions; consequently their melanin decreased and their skin and eye color gradually lightened.

To survive, the ancestors living in the cold northern regions had to struggle against a harsh environment, fighting other tribes for hunting and fishing grounds. Over time they developed strong competitive awareness, materialism, courage to challenge, and sharp vision. In contrast, the ancestors living in the south were more enduring and down-to-earth, and less combative.

Thus the inner connection between skin color and personality is the result of ancestors adapting to natural environments. In today's modern world, people of different skin colors can appear in the same place, and the exchange of information and culture has long transcended geographical limits; yet this link, transmitted over hundreds of thousands or even millions of years, does not completely disappear.

According to Haeckel's<sup>[^1]</sup> theory, human skin can be divided into two major categories: dark skin and light skin. In the West, both yellow and black races are considered dark-skinned. Further distinctions exist within both dark-skinned and light-skinned groups, and the theory mentioned above still applies.

[^1]: Haeckel (1834–1919), German biologist and naturalist, defender and popularizer of Darwin's theory of evolution.

One winter five years ago, the owner of an automobile company brought a pair of young twin technicians to see me.

The owner said, "They are both people I deeply care about. I hope they will be positive and motivated. Frankly, I am not worried about the older brother, but the younger one truly gives me headaches. They grew up together, studied together, and are both intelligent. Why can't the younger one stay in the workshop like his brother? Mr. Balkan, do you have any good suggestions?"

I called the brothers from the reception room into my office. They looked as though they had been cast from the same mold—golden hair, light-gray eyes, even similar eyebrows. Yet I could tell at a glance which was the older and which the younger, because their skin tones differed. I said to the young man with the slightly darker skin, "Young man, I can see you prefer outdoor activities and dislike machines, correct?"

The young man looked surprised, then shrugged. "Yes, sir. I hate staying in the assembly room all day doing the same thing. It's driving me crazy!"

I turned to the young man with the slightly lighter skin. "And you? I don't think you dislike the machines."

"I find it quite interesting to try tightening screws faster and tighter, and I can share experiences with my colleagues."

Afterward I told the owner, "My friend, both of your technicians are talented. With the right placement, guidance, and training, they will both achieve success. Since you are so concerned about the younger brother, why not give him a different position? Let him introduce new cars or serve as a field instructor. With his knowledge of cars he will certainly do well. For him, monotonous work is simply poison."

Today one brother is director of the assembly department and the other is director of the sales department. This is a simple real-life application of "skin-color psychology."

### **Judging a Child's Personality from Reactions to Mistakes**

A study examined the relationship between children's personality and their facial expressions. In the study, children of different personalities faced an interviewer in a face-to-face oral test, and their expressions were analyzed. The subjects were seventy children aged twelve to thirteen. After each child answered a question, the interviewer immediately told the child whether the answer was correct or incorrect.

The focus was on the emotions the child felt when the answer was wrong and on the facial reactions that appeared. The results showed that a child's reaction when corrected for an incorrect answer corresponded to the child's individual personality.

Most ordinary children without personality deviations displayed an expression of "shame," whereas children with tendencies toward inattention, hyperactivity, aggression, or antisocial behavior tended to show "anger." In addition, children with excessive anxiety, fear, psychosomatic symptoms, or depressive traits tended to show "fear."

What problems arise from reacting to mistakes with "anger" or "fear"? First, such reactions may create negative impressions in others and damage interpersonal relationships; second, the child loses the proper direction for solving the problem.

Imagine the impression given by a child who reacts to mistakes with "anger" or "fear."

A person who shows "shame" when making a mistake elicits goodwill and sympathy from others and is more socially acceptable. Research indicates that people who do not display "shame" produce the opposite result.

The child mentioned earlier who reacted to mistakes with "anger" not only frequently forgot things and was inattentive in class but also displayed irritability. Such a child is likely to have tendencies toward inattention, hyperactivity, aggression, or antisocial behavior. Moreover, if a child continues to react to mistakes with "anger" and the personality does not improve, these traits persist and may eventually cause serious social problems.

A child's loss of proper direction for solving problems is closely related to the function of emotions. Emotions serve as adaptive mechanisms that allow various feelings and situations to proceed smoothly.

For example, the function of the emotion “shame” is to apologize and repair one’s self-image. A person who feels “shame” signals an apologetic attitude, gets back on their feet after failure, and seeks goodwill. In the present case, a child who feels “shame” after giving a wrong answer will be more careful to avoid repeating the mistake. By contrast, the function of “anger” is to remove obstacles to a goal, and the function of “fear” is to avoid threats.

A child who feels “anger” at a wrong answer treats the mistake or the person correcting it as an “obstacle” to be eliminated. The child’s goal is to avoid being disturbed by anyone; when things seem to be going smoothly and an error is pointed out, that correction itself becomes an obstacle to be removed.

Most people grow from mistakes through correction and do not regard mistakes as obstacles; conversely, treating mistakes as obstacles causes one to miss opportunities for self-growth.

“Fear” is more complex than “anger.” It treats the mistake as a threat and seeks to avoid it. Facing mistakes with a positive attitude leads to solutions and preventive measures. Acting with a negative attitude leads only to simple avoidance without confronting the mistake itself. Experience suggests that children who feel “fear” about mistakes rarely act proactively without adult prompting. Therefore, when a child reacts to mistakes with expressions or emotions of “anger” or “fear,” the child easily loses opportunities for self-growth.

### **Characteristics of Antisocial Personality**

The reason antisocial personality receives this name is inseparable from the behavioral code in their hearts that runs counter to society’s prevailing norms. When first encountering people of this type, they often appear enthusiastic and can create a very harmonious atmosphere. However, once contact deepens—especially when it comes to shouldering responsibility or paying the bill—they always smile and brush it off or simply flee. In their minds, the etiquette and morals we take for granted are nothing more than jokes written on paper.

Identifying someone with antisocial personality is not difficult at all. Psychologist Cleckley, in his book *The Mask of Sanity*, describes in detail the various behavioral characteristics of antisocial personality:

1. Appearance and intelligence show no problems; the first impression is usually favorable, with no signs of schizophrenia or anxiety found in other personality disorders.
2. They lack necessary responsibility and sense of duty, disregard social norms, morality, and law. In childhood they may already lie or steal; after adulthood they become even more unrestrained, possibly engaging in illegal transactions or even dangerous criminal activities.
3. They are extremely self-centered, using charisma and charm to manipulate and deceive others, remaining completely at ease about it and never believing they have harmed anyone. After satisfying their own desires, they refuse to give anything back to others.
4. They feel no remorse even when they know they are wrong and are very skilled at making excuses for themselves. They believe victims were fooled because of their own stupidity and fully deserved it; even if the antisocial person had not acted, the victims would have been deceived by someone else. They never reflect on their own actions.
5. Their emotions are cold and lack variation; they rarely display the joy, anger, sorrow, or happiness that normal people show when moved. They never pay attention to others yet strongly need others’ attention and trust. In interactions they focus only on self-gratification and never offer genuine feelings to the other person.
6. They act impulsively, without plans, often cramming at the last minute. Even acts that infringe on others’ interests usually stem from hidden impulses rather than clear motives or plans.

7. They are irritable and reckless, with poor tolerance, easily provoked into aggressive behavior, and completely unconcerned about their own or others' safety. Many engage in binge eating, tattooing or piercing, speeding, or even drug use and self-harm. After drinking they also display crude and ugly behavior.
8. Their lives lack regularity; most people of this type have no steady job, and even if they do, they cannot hold it for long. They do everything possible to avoid work yet want more money. They often run up heavy debts but are always pressing others to repay what they owe.

These eight characteristics basically cover the behavioral manifestations of people with antisocial personality. Such individuals are not rare around us. People who slip away the moment the bill arrives, falsify accounts to satisfy private desires without any remorse, or slack off at work while brazenly offering improper excuses all carry traces of antisocial personality.

Most psychologists believe that only a small portion of antisocial personality arises from heredity or poor brain development; the majority stems from family and social environment. Faulty educational methods, childhood psychological trauma, and negative social environmental factors can all contribute to the formation of antisocial personality.

Given the lack of shame and responsibility that characterizes antisocial personality, the best approach when encountering such people is to keep a respectful distance. Once entangled with them, it is like being bitten by a leech: after sucking your blood they will still frown in disgust, complaining that your blood is not sweet enough.

### Sheldon's Theory: Research on the Relationship Between Body Type and Personality

| Body Type | Physical Characteristics                     | Personality Type                                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Endomorph | Soft, plump, well-developed digestive organs | Viscerotonic: leisurely, fond of food, slow-moving, sociable, generous; psychological traits include being calm and empathetic                                            |
| Mesomorph | Muscular, strong and powerful                | Somatotonic: confident, bold, robust, energetic, adventurous and impulsive; psychological traits include being willful and stubborn                                       |
| Ectomorph | Slender, frail, sensitive nervous system     | Cerebrotonic: introverted, reserved, not good at socializing, enthusiastic and responsible at work, loves art; psychological traits include being timid yet overly steady |

You may find the above theory overly specialized, yet it is not hard to understand when placed in daily life.

It is very difficult for a tall, large person to fully rouse body and mind and become truly angry, because it requires consuming a great deal of time and energy to change their heavy frame, let alone generate a highly tense state of anger in a short time. Therefore, people with large builds are mostly gentle, better able to control their emotions, and more stable. Dr. Paul of the University of California once tracked eighty people weighing over 200 pounds and found that sixty-eight preferred a comfortable, easy life while only four were willing to try a stimulating lifestyle. In contrast, people of small stature are easily impulsive and excitable, yet they also possess greater endurance and explosive power. Many world-renowned achievers are not large in



build—for example, Napoleon. Who could imagine that a body of five feet two inches could unleash the astonishing energy that swept across Europe?

Therefore, if you are a leader, remember this: do not assign tasks requiring quick reactions and high dexterity to your large-built subordinates, because most of them will disappoint you; nor should you force your short, agile subordinates to perform slow work that demands patience, because they will likewise disappoint you.

In short, the body is a mirror of emotion, and a mirror with memory-storage function. Every instance of joy, anger, sorrow, or pleasure leaves subtle traces on various parts of the body. When you repeatedly experience a certain emotion, the traces belonging to that emotion deepen until they become your label. You will notice that people who often frown have narrower space between their eyebrows, people who frequently glare have protruding eyeballs, and people who laugh heartily have more developed muscles in their cheeks... Although everyone experiences multiple emotions, it is still possible to roughly classify personality according to the dominant emotion a person displays.

The research and development of “body-type theory” added a striking chapter to psychology. Despite certain drawbacks—for instance, body type can change with environment and age—it is undeniable that using body type as a “ruler” to measure the formless aspects of personality and psychology is indeed a way to simplify complexity. Moreover, a large body of evidence shows that people of certain body types do tend to develop certain personality qualities and characteristics. As long as the theory is not applied mechanically, using “body-type theory” for rough observation and preliminary judgment of psychology remains very effective.

### **Xiao Nan’s Encounter**

“Good afternoon.”

Community volunteer Xiao Nan was sitting in the office sorting documents when a coquettish voice suddenly sounded outside the door. He looked up and saw a woman in her fifties, dressed in gaudy attire, walk in.

“Hel... hello.” To be honest, Xiao Nan was startled.

“Young man, you must be new here?” The woman blinked eyes painted with royal-blue eyeshadow. “I’ve never seen you before.”

“Yes.” Cold sweat broke out on Xiao Nan’s forehead. “Is there something I can help you with?”

“Ah, this time I really do have a bit of a headache, but can I talk to you about it?” The woman put on a mournful expression.

“Su... sure.” Xiao Nan nodded.

“See, a handsome young man like you should be trustworthy.”

Please... what does being handsome have to do with being trustworthy? Besides, this is just the community office. What kind of matter requires someone to be trustworthy before it can be discussed? Xiao Nan grumbled inwardly.

“Actually, it’s like this. My head has been hurting lately and I can’t sleep...”

“Then you should go to the community hospital. Turn left when you go out the door; it’s two hundred meters away.” Xiao Nan could hardly wait to send this plague god away.

"I'm not here because of physical discomfort." The woman, speaking with a Taiwanese accent, stamped her foot and refused to leave.

"Please go ahead, please go ahead." Xiao Nan raised both hands in surrender.

"Actually... it's an emotional problem." The woman's next words left Xiao Nan stunned. "My husband and I have been in a cold war for several months, but I know he still loves me. Recently, however, another man has been pursuing me. I don't know whether I love him or still love my husband... But when my husband heard about this, he became extremely jealous and we had a huge fight. I really don't know what to do, so I came here for help. A handsome young man like you should be able to mediate for me, right?"

Watching the woman's gaze gradually grow misty, Xiao Nan felt both amused and exasperated. "But... this is a community office, not a marriage agency or a counseling center..."

"If that man were as handsome as you, I would agree to him without hesitation." The woman seemed not to have heard Xiao Nan and suddenly grasped his hand with deep emotion. "Handsome boy, even though I'm a bit older, women of any age still need the nourishment of love. You can understand that, right?"

"Yes, yes..." A wave of nausea swept over Xiao Nan as he desperately tried to pull his hand back.

"What, do you dislike me?" Sensing his resistance, the woman stared at him resentfully.

"No..." Even if he disliked her, he could not say so to her face. Xiao Nan was on the verge of tears.

"Then why are you rejecting me like this?"

The woman's question left Xiao Nan speechless. Watching his "little hand" about to fall once more into the "devil's claw," Xiao Nan could no longer care that he was still on volunteer duty. He made up an excuse and fled the office at top speed.

If Xiao Nan's experience were posted online, it would surely earn that woman the title of "Most Terrifying Auntie of the Year." When we encounter such people in life, we are either left speechless or, like Xiao Nan, flee in panic.

These individuals always give an exaggerated, affected impression, yet they themselves do not feel anything strange about it. On the contrary, if they lose others' attention they feel extremely uncomfortable. Therefore they constantly crave to be the center of everyone's attention.

### **A Du and the "Old Ghost's" Story**

A Du was a newcomer at a multinational company. On his very first day he noticed many colleagues casting sympathetic glances his way.

"This newcomer is really unlucky, assigned to Old Ghost. He's in for it."

"Yeah, no one has lasted more than three months under Old Ghost. This guy's probation is going to be a problem..."

"Old Ghost" was the nickname of A Du's immediate superior. Although the boss was a bit strict and rigid, it could not be that bad. At worst he would just be more careful. That was what A Du thought.

At first, because A Du was cautious and followed every rule, nothing major went wrong. After a few days he relaxed, and one careless moment produced a small error in the plan he submitted.

"What is this?" When Old Ghost called A Du into his office, A Du knew he was in trouble.

"I... I didn't do it on purpose..."

"Who knows whether you did it on purpose!" Old Ghost cut off A Du's explanation. "This plan was going straight to the president. If I hadn't glanced at it first, this mistake would have reached the president. You're new, so the president won't say anything to you. The responsibility this time will fall entirely on me!"

"I'm sorry, truly sorry." A Du had not expected such serious consequences and stopped explaining, apologizing repeatedly.

Yet Old Ghost's next words left him completely baffled: "Are you dissatisfied that I'm too strict with you? So you deliberately tried to make me look bad?"

"How could that be? You're my superior..."

"Exactly because you're my superior, right? When have you ever shown me respect as your superior? You've only been here a few days, kid, and you already want to step on my head to climb above me?" Old Ghost's questioning left A Du wanting to defend himself but not knowing where to begin.

After a storm of scolding, A Du was finally released from the office.

This time he learned his lesson. The next morning A Du arrived early, grabbed a broom, and cleaned both the office area and Old Ghost's office.

A Du's action delighted the cleaning auntie. She had also witnessed the miserable scene of A Du being scolded, so she put in a few good words for him in front of Old Ghost: "Manager Huai, this new young man is really good. Look how clean he made your office—cleaner than when I sweep it."

"Hmph." Old Ghost snorted coldly and shot A Du a sidelong glance. "Cleaning? Is that necessary? Does he think I would hold a grudge over that little matter? Am I that kind of person? The way he's acting, he's probably just putting on a show for others to see, isn't he?"

A Du was completely dumbfounded.

A Du's superior, Old Ghost, was narrow-minded, sinister, and suspicious. No matter what A Du said or did, Old Ghost could always find fault. In Old Ghost's eyes, although A Du had just joined the company, he had already set his sights on Old Ghost's position. The mistake A Du made was also intended to make Old Ghost lose credibility in front of the president. Even the cleaning auntie in the company was someone A Du wanted to impress with a false image of respect toward his superior. It was truly detestable.

Of course, all of this was Old Ghost's own imagination. Having such a paranoid superior, A Du was truly unlucky.

## **Dr. Yang's Encounter**

Recently Dr. Yang had been thoroughly annoyed by a newly arrived patient. Dr. Yang was known for his good temper, and the new patient did not look like a vicious person either. When he first came for treatment he had acute gastritis, but because Dr. Yang was busy operating on a patient with acute appendicitis, it took nearly half an hour before he could see him.

The patient appeared very polite and readily accepted Dr. Yang's apology. While chatting with Dr. Yang he first complained about society, then about his parents and wife, as if everything were at odds with him. Next he

lavishly praised Dr. Yang, saying his medical skills were superb, his prescriptions accurate, and that he had promptly controlled the acute gastritis.

It should have been a win-win situation, yet in the following days Dr. Yang noticed that the number of patients in his clinic had dropped sharply. One day, when he stepped out to buy coffee, he happened to see the patient, wearing a hospital gown, sitting on a bench in the waiting area chatting with other patients.

"I heard the doctor named Yang in this department is quite good—experienced and skilled," one patient said.

"His medical skills are all right, but the attitude of the medical staff here is really too negligent. I came for acute gastritis and was delayed for more than half an hour," the patient replied.

"Really? Even for an acute condition?" The other patient's eyes widened in surprise. "The medical ethics of the doctors here are really poor..."

"Who knows." The patient waved his hand with a laugh.

When Dr. Yang discovered this he became very angry. He asked himself: he had been sweating on the operating table and had not even had time for a sip of water before immediately inquiring about the patient's condition, yet the man was bad-mouthing him behind his back.

Unable to contain his anger, Dr. Yang went to confront the patient, but the man looked at him innocently and defended himself: "Doctor, you misunderstood. I wasn't talking about you; I was talking about the nurses here. I was already feeling unwell, but their attitude toward me was cold and indifferent. It really made me angry."

So that was it. Dr. Yang suddenly felt he had wrongly blamed a good person. But when he turned around and scolded the nurses in his department, they protested: "That patient was respectful enough to you, but he orders us around and yells at us over the slightest oversight. With so many patients every day, how can we revolve around him alone?"

What the patient said seemed reasonable, yet the nurses also had plenty of grievances. At this point Dr. Yang truly did not know what to do. He could only hope that the troublesome patient would be discharged soon so he would no longer sit idle in the clinic swatting at flies.

Dr. Yang's experience is pitiable. That patient was like a soft pillow: when Dr. Yang directed anger at him, he found there was nowhere to apply force and even felt as though he were bullying a "pillow."

Have you ever had this feeling?

### **Reading Preferences Reveal a Person's Work Attitude**

Books are the items in the home that best reflect personality. If there are bookshelves or desks holding books and magazines in the room, observe them carefully. Identifying the types of books can yield surprisingly rich information.

For example, although the other person collects many books introducing health topics, they may not care much about health. Yet even a single book on a specific disease can indicate that the person or a relative or friend suffers from that condition. If a bookshelf is filled with unopened "deluxe editions of world classics," the person probably likes to put on airs.

Books and periodicals kept at the workplace reflect not only personal taste in reading but also one's attitude toward work. Romance novels or parenting magazines on the desk indicate that the person's mind is elsewhere.

The following book types reveal corresponding psychological traits and personalities.

- **People who like to read financial magazines:** These individuals are not content with the status quo, unwilling to remain subordinate, competitive, and eager to surpass others. They revere authority and crave honor; given a good opportunity, they can spot it in advance.
- **People who like to read fashion magazines:** These individuals pursue trends, spend generously, and devote time and energy to appearance while neglecting inner cultivation, making it difficult for them to achieve great things.
- **People who like to read martial-arts novels:** These individuals are imaginative and romantic, hoping one day to rise above others. They are emotionally rich, yet sometimes overly delicate, which can make them less appealing to the opposite sex.
- **People who like to read romance novels:** These individuals (mostly women) value emotions and share the joys and sorrows of the story's highlights. They possess strong insight, handle affairs with confidence, and remain open-minded.
- **People who like to read biographies:** These individuals are highly curious, cautious in their actions, skilled at overseeing the big picture, and adept at weighing pros and cons. They never fight a battle without certainty and will not overstep boundaries if conditions are not ripe.
- **People who like to read comic books:** These individuals enjoy games, retain a childlike heart, possess an outgoing personality, are easy to get along with, and dislike constraints. They do not guard against others and only realize their own naivety after being taken advantage of.
- **People who like to read detective novels:** These individuals enjoy challenging mental difficulties and possess rich imagination and creativity. They excel at solving problems and can analyze difficulties from multiple angles when they arise.
- **People who like to read horror novels:** These individuals enjoy complex lives and crave stimulation and adventure to activate their brain cells.
- **People who like to read science-fiction novels:** These individuals are imaginative and creative, deeply fascinated and attracted by science and technology. They like to plan for the future but lack persistence.

### The Story of Old Wei and the Hong Kong Merchant

Old Wei had been hosting a Hong Kong merchant on behalf of his work unit for several days. The merchant looked distinguished, wore designer clothes, and projected an air of great wealth.

On the first day of the visit, Old Wei arranged for several subordinates to accompany the merchant to a three-star hotel in the city for dinner. The guests and hosts enjoyed themselves thoroughly. The merchant was quite forthright, repeatedly toasting Old Wei and his subordinates, and conveyed eagerness to cooperate. Seeing that the task showed promise, Old Wei grew cheerful and drank a little more. Halfway through the banquet, however, a phone call from his superior summoned him back to the unit for an urgent matter.

Still slightly tipsy, Old Wei hurried back, forgetting in his haste to leave money for his subordinates to settle the bill. After working at the unit for some time, Old Wei checked his phone and found more than a dozen missed calls, all from one of the subordinates who had accompanied the merchant.

Old Wei called back immediately. The subordinate said tearfully, "Section Chief Wei, please come settle the bill quickly. We don't have enough money, and the hotel staff are holding us here."

"What?" Old Wei was startled. "What about Mr. Tong?"

Mr. Tong was the Hong Kong merchant. Upon hearing the name, the subordinate gritted his teeth. "After he finished eating, he told the waiter that we would pay and left for the hotel you arranged, without waiting for us to speak."

Although he was a guest, covering a modest bill was hardly a big deal and the amount was small; how could he behave this way? Old Wei muttered inwardly and rushed to the hotel to "rescue" his subordinates.

"Section Chief Wei, that Mr. Tong was really dishonorable," subordinate Xiao Huang complained angrily. "After you left, he kept pouring drinks for us. At first we thought he was generous, but when it came time to pay, he saw you were gone and noticed our awkward expressions. Without giving us a chance to speak, he pretended to be drunk and slipped away!"

Xiao Huang vented at length, but Old Wei took note. Why would a Hong Kong merchant worth tens of millions quibble over such a small sum? Back at the unit, Old Wei immediately contacted relatives in Hong Kong to investigate Mr. Tong's background.

The results were startling. According to the relatives' investigation, Mr. Tong was indeed from Hong Kong, but he possessed no tens of millions in assets; instead, he was deeply in debt. His trip to the mainland posing as a wealthy man was purely an attempt to "scrape some benefits" before fleeing. With evidence in hand, Old Wei reported the matter to the police and prevented major losses for the unit.

The fake "Hong Kong merchant" Old Wei encountered was a typical antisocial personality. His habitual refusal to pay bills had given him away.

## **Definition and Characteristics of Dual Personality**

Personality refers to an individual's unique and stable patterns of thinking and acting that distinguish them from others. Dual personality, taken literally, means that a person's mind contains two entirely different modes of thinking and acting. The coexistence of these two personalities makes dual-personality individuals more changeable and complex than ordinary people. Interacting with someone who has a dual personality feels like riding a roller coaster—constantly stimulating and thrilling.

The protagonist Travis in the American film *Taxi Driver* is a typical dual-personality individual. A Vietnam War veteran, he returns to New York and drives a night-shift taxi. Travis usually drifts along and enjoys watching erotic films, yet he also harbors a deep loathing for crime and depravity. On one hand, he pursues Betsy, an aide to a presidential candidate; on the other, he befriends the underage prostitute Iris in New York and tries to help her escape the grip of her criminal environment so she can return to school.

Reality, however, proves heartbreaking. Ultimately, after being rejected by Betsy and failing to help Iris, Travis launches a series of frenzied actions. He buys four handguns, attempts to assassinate another presidential candidate, then single-handedly storms the gang controlling Iris, fighting his way out with her in a bloodbath...

Clearly, Travis harbors two opposing personalities: the degenerate and the hero.

Dual personality is not an occasional flash of conscience or an outburst of anger; rather, it is a fundamental, subconscious psychological habit and imprint that does not change with status and does not recede simply because one personality dominates. These two personalities permeate the dual-personality individual's life at every moment and continue to manifest even when they affect daily living. In severe cases, external factors can cause the person to become someone else at any time, much like Travis, who, under environmental pressure, transforms from an ineffectual everyman into a tragic "hero."

Dual-personality individuals commonly experience poor social adaptation. Their dual nature can cause them internal confusion, yet many fail to recognize this confusion and instead extend it into a more subjective, self-centered mindset—what is commonly called self-righteousness.

Because of this mindset, dual-personality individuals are harder to persuade and more inclined to defend themselves than ordinary people. When faced with embarrassing situations, they do not admit fault frankly but instead offer various excuses and rationalizations.

### Hobbies Reveal One's True Nature

Interests and preferences, over time, become a person's hobbies. Nothing reveals a person's essence more clearly than hobbies. Hobbies require no consideration of others' opinions and are free from external constraints; they are the direct expression of one's nature and therefore expose the deepest layers of the psyche.

- **People who like performing:** These individuals have delicate, sensitive emotions and rich imagination, though they can sometimes be unrealistic.
- **People who like fishing:** These individuals yearn for inner purity and seek a clear conscience. They value the process more than the result, hoping to experience joy and self-realization along the way.
- **People who like gardening:** These individuals willingly spend time, energy, and money on flowers and potted plants. They generally know how to enjoy life, possess strong sensitivity to things, and are warm and hospitable.
- **People who like cooking gourmet food:** These individuals have good creativity and imagination and often create pleasant surprises for family and friends. They set high goals and ideals and pursue them persistently.
- **People who like playing chess or cards:** These individuals often surpass others in intellect, possess strong logical thinking, and enjoy a higher likelihood of success.
- **People who like writing:** These individuals have strong analytical ability, seek unique insights on every matter, and enjoy putting their thoughts in writing.
- **People who like stamp collecting:** These individuals are skilled at self-regulation when emotionally unsettled and care greatly about face. Often, not knowing how to refuse others, they create unnecessary troubles for themselves.
- **People who like hunting:** These individuals are relatively rugged and forthright, value loyalty, avoid excessive quibbling, and possess courage and insight, daring to take responsibility for their actions.
- **People who like traveling:** These individuals are outgoing, curious, and restless; only varied and stimulating experiences satisfy them.
- **People who like high-risk activities:** These individuals are drawn to thrilling pursuits such as hang gliding, skydiving, and mountaineering. They are physically robust, meticulous, and always cautious, considering every possible problem before acting. They are resilient and stubborn; once they decide on something, they rarely change course even in the face of great difficulty. They possess boldness and drive, willing to challenge unknown fields.

## Personality Traces on the Desk

The office is a workplace filled with work-related furnishings. Careful observation can reveal many secrets, because every item incorporates the employee's preferences. The appearance of the desk can display the person's character traits.

- **Desk surface and drawers both neat and orderly:** Such people have high work efficiency and are excellent employees. They are self-disciplined, lead regular lives, and plan tasks in advance. They treasure time and allocate it carefully for meaningful activities. Accustomed to following plans, they often feel at a loss when sudden changes occur.
- **Desk surface clean and tidy, but drawers in chaos:** Such people lack great wisdom, cannot work steadily, like to play petty tricks, and focus on appearances. They tend to be lazy and unreliable in dealings. Like their desks, their interpersonal relationships appear good on the surface but lack any truly intimate friends.
- **Both desk surface and drawers completely empty:** These individuals are usually impatient. To facilitate work and avoid searching for materials, they keep needed items within easy reach. They are highly ambitious and can generally become bosses.
- **Drawers and desk surface both messy:** Such people often lack planning, fail to consider matters thoroughly in advance, and frequently respond hastily with poor results. They pursue simplicity in life, disregard minor details, and lack long-term vision.
- **Desk contains mementos:** These individuals are relatively introverted, not good at socializing, and unwilling to have excessive contact with strangers. They often come and go alone. Although they have few friends, the few they have are very close. They value these relationships deeply. Emotionally rich yet psychologically fragile, they are easily hurt and often lack sufficient perseverance, retreating at the first sign of setbacks or difficulties.
- **Cash kept in the desk:** These individuals are highly suspicious. They do not fully trust banks and therefore do not deposit all their cash there; they also constantly worry about theft at home and choose to keep cash in the desk.

## Personality Analysis of Fat and Thin People

The most typical hotel owner in British novelist Dickens's works is fat; Shakespeare once described a loud-voiced, heavy-drinking man popular with women who was also fat. Some cartoonists, when satirizing stock-market tycoons, often choose fat protagonists. If you observe carefully, you will find that fat people are not rare in finance and politics.

Generally speaking, we classify fat people as vitality types. The "vitality" referred to here means the latent capacity and recuperative power stored in the body; it is static and differs from the vitality displayed by athletic types. When with fat people, you rarely feel tense, because their large frames and calm dispositions give a sense of security.

Fat people are often labeled "pleasure-seeking," "lazy," or "gluttonous," yet their advantages are obvious: affability, kindness, humor, and so on. Most fat people are warm and lively, enjoy socializing, and are easily understood and accepted by those around them, making them popular. Fat people exercise good self-control in many areas but lose all resistance when faced with delicious food. Another annoying shortcoming is their aversion to exercise—or, more precisely, to moving at all. In addition, because they overestimate themselves and like to meddle, some people dislike them, yet this does not harm their good interpersonal relationships.



Many fat people are born with leadership ability. As noted earlier, large-framed people react more slowly, and precisely because of this they prefer not to handle everything themselves but to delegate. They are neither perpetually high-strung like intellectual types nor physically overtaxed like restless types, so they can become leaders. Many fat people are intellectually superior and morally upright, making them ideal notaries, commentators, or judges.

In contrast to fat people, thin people are sensitive, delicate, and alert. The thinner the person, the more tense and oppressive you feel in their company. Some thin people are introverted, quiet, sincere, and somewhat neurotic, making them harder to get along with. They are emotionally unstable and prone to anxiety, yet they possess the courage to shoulder everything. If your friend is thin, be sure to keep your promises; if your superior is thin, strive to complete tasks well. They have the personality of "if you do it, do it perfectly," pursuing excellence.

## (II) The Slender Type

- **Facial features:** Soft contours, delicate skin, fine soft hair, gentle and pleasant voice.
- **Psychological features:** Delicate and refined.
- **Behavioral features:** Gentle.

Slender-type people love beauty greatly; exquisite, clever, and idealized things are what they pursue. Their income may only afford beer, yet they have the palate for champagne. They find it hard to discover joy in harsh environments, so you rarely see them in brick factories, iron mines, slaughterhouses, or steel mills.

They emphasize quality of life. Faced with a pair of eighty-dollar leather shoes and a pair of twenty-dollar shoes, most will choose the former even if their wallet is not full. Therefore, a clever salesperson need only say the following to win such customers: "Although the price is a bit high, this is absolutely genuine leather, and the sole design is extremely comfortable. Oh, these shoes look perfect on you. Trust me, you need them."

Observe and you will notice an interesting phenomenon: slender-type people often gather in refined settings such as symphony concerts, social dances, and opera performances. They enjoy associating with courteous and elegant people. Getting along with a slender-type person is like handling a delicate work of art: you must mobilize all your knowledge, humor, taste, and artistic sensibility; otherwise, it is difficult to please them. So if the girl you admire has delicate features, small hands and feet, and silky smooth hair, please note the following:

1. Do not shout at her;
2. Do not appear before her unkempt;
3. Compared with vulgar but amusing street art, she may prefer an elegant concert;
4. Take her to a restaurant with a good atmosphere, because she does not care whether the portions are large; she cares about soft lighting, graceful music, gleaming silverware, a white tablecloth, and your gentle words.

Note: The above points also apply to business negotiations, seeking cooperation, interpersonal interactions, enterprise management, and any occasion requiring contact with the outside world.

In summary, judging a person's character and divining their psychology from skin, hair, voice, and other bodily features is by no means nonsense. The key lies in whether you possess the devil's eye!

## Case Two: Dr. Bai and the Patient's Conversation

Dr. Bai recently encountered a patient who gave him a great deal of trouble.

That was a woman in her thirties. After entering Dr. Bai's consultation room, she politely greeted him: "Hello, Doctor."

"Hello." Dr. Bai smiled and gestured to her. "Please have a seat. What's bothering you?"

"I've had some stomach pain recently," the patient replied.

"Stomach pain? You should see an internist for that, but this is the neurosurgery department." Dr. Bai was somewhat surprised.

"Well, I've had some stomach pain recently, maybe from eating something bad." With Dr. Bai's nod, the patient continued, "So I took some stomach medicine, like this bottle, roughly."

She picked up the medicine bottle on Dr. Bai's desk and gestured with it: "I probably took about a bottle's worth, but my stomach still feels uncomfortable."

"This is an antidepressant." Dr. Bai still didn't know what she was getting at.

"Ah, are you saying I need to take antidepressants? Do I have depression?"

"No, no, I didn't say you have depression. I was just saying that what's in this bottle is an antidepressant." Dr. Bai quickly clarified.

"Could it be that I took the wrong medicine?" The patient began pulling at her hair. "That can't be. I have a friend who ended up in the hospital after taking the wrong medicine and almost died."

"It shouldn't be that serious." Dr. Bai wiped the cold sweat from his forehead. "Didn't you say you took stomach medicine?"

"Okay, it should be stomach medicine. But the internist said this is neuralgia caused by too much stress, so I came to see you." The patient picked up the paperweight on Dr. Bai's desk again. "Sometimes when it hurts, it's like this thing is smashing my stomach."

"Then you should go see a psychiatrist," Dr. Bai suggested. "For neuralgia, they're more specialized."

"What? Shouldn't neuralgia be treated in neurosurgery? How are these two not the most relevant? Aren't you just trying to push me out?"

At this point, Dr. Bai had no idea how to respond.

Talking with this patient was more exhausting than dealing with three or four people at once. She kept veering off topic, creating trouble, and didn't listen to Dr. Bai's explanations at all. In the end, before any problem was resolved, the doctor was already exhausted.

## Identifying Personality from How People Handle Documents

Americans have long been dedicated to studying the work environments in which people can achieve the highest productivity. During this research, an efficiency expert unexpectedly discovered that certain personality traits can be revealed by the way employees handle documents.

- **Documents scattered everywhere, piles here and there:** Such people handle tasks with a degree of aimlessness. They struggle to see things through from start to finish, have poor self-control, and cannot promptly adjust their emotions and habits, making it difficult for them to adapt quickly to new external environments.
- **Documents and materials in complete disarray, requiring a thorough search for each file:** These individuals have weaker work abilities and often achieve half the results with twice the effort. They lack organization and cannot proceed step by step. Their sense of responsibility is weak, and they lack persistent perseverance.
- **Habit of stuffing documents here and there:** Such people are often flashy but insubstantial. They like to play clever tricks, excel at maneuvering for advantage, and place great importance on appearances.
- **Documents on the desk and in drawers all neatly arranged, clearly layered and categorized:** These people handle tasks in an orderly manner, possess strong organizational and hands-on skills, work efficiently, and have a sense of responsibility. They approach everything with caution and diligence. However, they lack a pioneering spirit and have weaker innovative abilities.
- **Opening and reading mail immediately upon receipt and replying in the shortest possible time:** Such people have a strong sense of time. They want to complete everything as quickly as possible before moving on to other tasks.
- **Tossing letters aside without even looking at them:** If this person is not deliberately ignoring the letter, it indicates they are very busy at the moment, with their time tightly scheduled. Letters that are not particularly important to them will naturally be set aside for later processing. Of course, they may never find the time to handle them.
- **Having someone else read letters on their behalf:** Such people place great trust in others. They are not skilled at hiding themselves and can share many of their secrets with others.
- **Enjoying reading junk mail:** They have strong curiosity and can quickly absorb new things.
- **Deleting junk mail on sight:** They are quite cautious, with strong self-defense awareness, and do not easily trust another person.

## Identifying People by Color Preferences

In daily life, we see the presence and application of various colors. For example, Coca-Cola's logo is red, and McDonald's brand identity is yellow... Some merchants have openly stated that the color of a logo, to some extent, represents the spirit of the enterprise. Everyone has their own favorite colors, so what meanings do these colors symbolize when applied to people?

FBI agent Henry Gies tells us that a person's preferred colors can reveal a great deal about their inner self. When negotiating with terrorists, FBI agents also use the colors of the other party's clothing to determine their personality. It can be said that there is a very close relationship between psychology and color.

When feeling restless, a visit to a park filled with green or a seaside full of blue can quickly restore calm. Yet in a bar where the sofas are all red, people often remain agitated and can only drown their sorrows in drink. Different colors evoke different feelings in us. In other words, people who like different colors also differ in their attitudes toward life and interactions with others.

Gies points out that human brainwaves respond to red with alertness and to blue and green with relaxation. In other words, blue and green have a spontaneous regulatory effect on tense and agitated states of mind; they are nature's best psychological sedatives for humans. Many experiments conducted by psychologists have confirmed this conclusion. They found that in a blue environment, people's emotions are relatively stable and

their pulse rates are steadier. However, when people are in a red environment, their emotions tend to become excited, blood pressure rises, and pulse rates quicken.

A person's preferred color often represents their personality. Through monitoring terrorists' brainwaves, FBI agents have determined that brainwaves change with alterations in the colors within the visual field. This scientifically confirms the influence of color on the mind. Accordingly, they often provide terrorists with items of various colors and allow them to choose their favorite hues, with the goal of unlocking their "multicolored" psychological packaging through their color selections.

What personality traits do different colors reveal? Let us look at the conclusions drawn by FBI agents.

### **Story: The Conflict Between the Father and Tom**

He could not understand why his son refused the ready-made department store and insisted on pursuing the unpromising field of fashion design.

Young Tom had inherited his father's stubbornness. He insisted on working at the department store while attending night school.

"Mr. Balkan, you must understand my intentions. I had high hopes for him. For three years he worked at the store during the day and attended that night school in the evening. Now he tells me he has found another job as a designer at some silk factory... Oh, heavens! I really don't know what he's thinking!"

I poured him a glass of water and asked, "So you've come today hoping I can tell you what he's thinking?"

"Yes. You know the economy is poor right now, and I need his help. The boy is capable, but I can't persuade him. So, Mr. Balkan, I can only ask for your assistance to see what this child is actually suited for. I'm worried he's just trapped in his own imagination and wasting his prime years." As he spoke, he handed me several photos of Tom. "I know you're always accurate at reading people."

From the photos, Tom appeared to be a very handsome young man. His skin was good, and his well-developed muscles wrapped around his bones, giving an impression of creativity. His forehead was flat, his brow high and broad, his nose straight and slightly pointed, conveying an artistic quality.

"He's a lively young fellow. Do you want him to take over the store?"

"Yes. This child has many ideas. He knows how to arrange items to better attract customers and has good judgment about wrapping paper. So if he were willing, he could certainly make my store thrive. But he says working in the store doesn't make him happy..."

That was the crux of the conflict: an idealistic child full of artistic creativity, and a father who, though aware of the child's talents, did not know in which area those talents lay.

If this conflict is not resolved well, two outcomes often result: first, the child's rebellion exceeds the parents' expectations, leading them to pursue their own path in lonely isolation; second, the child chooses to obey the parents and toils in another field that is entirely incompatible with their nature. Whichever outcome occurs, I believe, is not one you would wish to see.

### **Typical Case Analysis**

In a psychological clinic in South Korea, a middle-aged woman dressed appropriately and with refined makeup was invited into the counselor's consultation room.

"Hello, Ms. Wen," the counselor said after greeting her, referring to the results of the psychological assessment. "Based on your assessment results, we believe you possess basic emotional intelligence and can maintain ordinary interpersonal relationships..."

"Mm." Ms. Wen nodded repeatedly, displaying a good attitude and composure.

"However, your depression is quite severe. You cannot regulate your temper well and often experience intermittent outbursts due to excessive stress..."

"Is that so?" Ms. Wen continued nodding but countered, "I'm not like that. I don't lose my temper much."

"All right. You may be resistant to this result, but please listen patiently until I finish..."

"From the very beginning it's wrong. I don't have depression at all!"

"Please let me finish." Sweat had already begun to appear on the counselor's forehead. "The assessment results indicate that you cannot properly recognize your own emotions, and as a result, certain problems have arisen in your relationships with others..."

"Is this result reliable?" Ms. Wen was still nodding, yet her words were filled with doubt. "I think I'm quite normal. There's nothing that strange about me, is there? But why does this assessment keep saying bad things about me?"

"When one's shortcomings are pointed out, people always deny them at the first moment."

"Is that so? But I'm not like that." Ms. Wen rebutted at the first moment.

A brief silence fell over the consultation room. Soon the counselor could not help laughing. Ms. Wen seemed somewhat embarrassed, lowered her head silently, and blushed.

This Ms. Wen was a typical case of someone with a dual personality. On one hand, she was a privileged middle-aged lady of refinement who possessed good manners and virtue; even when others pointed out her faults, she could refrain from anger or irritation and simply nod to show she was listening attentively. On the other hand, she also possessed an overbearing mindset that assumed she was always right and would not allow others to say anything negative about her. The combination of these two personalities produced the strange behavior described above.

### **Xiao Jiang's Blind Date Experience**

Through a friend's introduction, Xiao Jiang went on a blind date with a man said to be very handsome.

The moment she saw him in the café, Xiao Jiang was indeed drawn to his appearance. The man had a rugged build and melancholic eyes; even the way he held his coffee cup appeared elegant and graceful.

Xiao Jiang's own appearance was only average. The man clearly did not take her seriously, yet he still chatted with her in a friendly manner.

Through conversation, Xiao Jiang learned that his family had once been prominent, though it had declined in recent generations. Even so, he knew many celebrities in the film and television circles and political circles. He

had also studied in the United States and now worked as a white-collar professional at a multinational company...

His conditions were so favorable that Xiao Jiang felt somewhat ashamed of herself. She had assumed he would not want to see her a second time, but a few days later he actually called and asked her out again.

The conversation covered the same topics as before, yet Xiao Jiang now harbored a trace of doubt. After the date, she contacted the friend who had introduced them and inquired about the man's situation.

"Him? There's nothing special. His family background is ordinary. Right now he's working as a gas station attendant."

The friend's words left Xiao Jiang deeply puzzled. During their third date, she voiced her doubts to him.

"So you never believed me at all." The man's attitude shifted so abruptly that Xiao Jiang was startled. He shouted at her: "Yes, I was recently laid off and I'm working as a gas station attendant now, but so what? Don't successful people ever hit a low point?"

With red-rimmed eyes he stormed out, leaving Xiao Jiang uneasy yet somewhat guilty. Only after questioning her friend did she learn that everything the man had boasted about was a lie. He had never been abroad, had never worked at a multinational company, and the story about a prominent family was pure nonsense...

Just like the man Xiao Jiang met on her blind date, individuals with histrionic personality disorder are typically vain, superficial, and hypocritical, with extremely rapid emotional shifts. When others suit their tastes, they appear cordial and polite, but once exposed, they immediately become hysterical and storm off.

### **Ah Sang's Story**

Ah Sang was regarded by everyone as a "strong woman." She was decisive and bold in her actions, with a strong drive to advance. In less than two years at the company, she rose from an ordinary employee to vice general manager.

On the day Ah Sang assumed the vice general manager position, every colleague who was on good terms with her was delighted and praised her for "achieving success in her career." Yet Ah Sang herself still wore a dejected expression.

"Don't tell me there's anything you're dissatisfied with after taking the vice general manager position?" the general manager, who greatly valued Ah Sang, asked her.

"It's not that, Mr. Yang." Ah Sang shook her head. "Of course I'm very happy to have been promoted to this position, but sometimes I wonder: I keep pursuing success nonstop, but what exactly is success to me?"

The reason Ah Sang felt this confusion was inseparable from her family environment during childhood. She was the eldest daughter and had a younger sister two years her junior.

The younger sister was small and exceptionally intelligent, so she was favored by their parents more than Ah Sang was. After every exam, their parents would lavish praise on the sister's test papers and offer verbal or material rewards. Because Ah Sang's academic performance was weaker, she was not favored by her parents and was always left aside and neglected.

Unwilling to accept this, Ah Sang worked exceptionally hard and her grades improved steadily. Yet no matter how diligently she studied, her parents remained indifferent to her achievements. Gradually, Ah Sang came to feel that her successes were not yet big enough or obvious enough, so she needed to achieve even greater successes to prove herself to her parents. After striving for so many years, however, Ah Sang grew increasingly confused, unsure what exactly she had been pursuing all these years.

Ah Sang's feeling stemmed from the "inner child" she had developed in childhood. Her inner child had such a strong need for success and attention. Yet after growing up, she clearly could no longer obtain the affirmation her parents had once given, and this produced confusion within her. At such times, if someone could provide her with a similar feeling, she would inevitably become devoted to that person.

## **Seeing Through Others' Past Through the Inner Child**

### **Micro-expression Keywords**

Do not underestimate the influence of the word "past" on a person. All our current behaviors reflect consciousness that remained unsatisfied in the past. By understanding our own inner child, we can understand ourselves and correct our shortcomings. Understanding others' inner children is even more helpful for reaching people's hearts and controlling them.

A young pony was tied to a wooden stake. It was still small and very mischievous, always wanting either to chase fluttering butterflies or to nibble on roadside grass. Yet with its strength, it could not budge the stake to which it was tied. Over time, whenever the young pony was tied to the stake, it would stay obediently and stop struggling.

Gradually the pony grew into a horse. Its strength multiplied, enabling it to pull carts weighing hundreds of pounds and to uproot that small wooden stake. Yet whenever the horse was tied to the stake, it would behave as obediently as it had in childhood, with no thought of moving the stake.

Habit is a terrifying force, especially when it is a deeply rooted habit formed in childhood. This terrifying force of habit is closely connected to the "inner child" we are about to discuss.

The neo-psychoanalytic school and modern object relations psychology hold that most modern people possess an internal relational pattern. This pattern determines how we interact with others, society, the world, and even ourselves. The pattern is usually established before the age of six and is referred to in behavioral psychology as the "inner child."

In simple terms, the inner child is a fixed pattern formed in a child's mind due to the ways, methods, and behaviors with which parents treated them during early childhood. In adulthood, individuals unconsciously apply this pattern to themselves and even to others. Based on this, we can work in the opposite direction: through the external manifestations of a person's "inner child," we can easily infer their past and personality, and through this, achieve the goal of controlling them.

### **Organizational Structure Psychology**

Once there was a prince who wanted to marry a real princess. He traveled the world in search of one, but always encountered obstacles. There were plenty of princesses, yet the prince could never be sure whether they were truly real, for something about each of them seemed off. In the end he had to return home, deeply unhappy, for he longed so much for a genuine princess.

One night a terrible storm suddenly broke, with thunder and rain that struck fear into everyone. At that moment someone knocked on the door, and the old king went to open it.

The girl standing outside said she was a princess. But heavens! After the wind and rain she looked dreadful. Water streamed down her hair and clothes, into her shoes, and out again at the heels.

The old queen thought, "No matter, we shall know soon enough." She went to the bedroom, removed all the bedding, and placed a single pea on the bed. She then laid twenty mattresses on top of the pea and twenty eiderdown quilts on top of the mattresses.

The princess slept on this arrangement that night.

In the morning everyone asked, "Dear princess, how did you sleep?"

"Ah, not at all comfortably!" the princess replied. "I hardly closed my eyes all night. Heaven knows what was pressing into me beneath the bed—something so hard, it was dreadful!"

Everyone then knew she was indeed a real princess. Only a true princess could feel a single pea through twenty layers of mattresses and twenty eiderdown quilts. No one else would have skin so delicate.

You are surely familiar with this fairy tale. I am no master of fairy tales; I recount it only to introduce the topic that follows—human body-structure psychology, or, in plain terms, reading a person by the thickness of hair, muscle, and skin. It may sound improbable. In brief, human body structure can be divided into two types: robust and slender.

### **Life Portraits and the Path to Success**

Many years ago I hosted a small family gathering. Someone suggested a game: each person would sum up their life in a few sentences, as if for a gravestone. After everyone finished, we passed the papers around. One young man's entry has stayed with me ever since. He wrote only three punctuation marks: a dash "—", an exclamation point "!", and a period "." When I asked what it meant, he answered sadly, "A headlong rush, ending in sorrow and self-pity, then a quiet close."

I would say this describes the life of most people.

Success and happiness require exploration, yet the real question is how much time and energy you devote to that exploration. We allow setbacks and failures, and we allow a certain amount of starting over. But if you still wish to reach the shores of success and happiness within your lifetime, you must shorten the period of exploration.

Winners win because they find the right path in the shortest time and then follow it unwaveringly to the end. This brings us to questions of personality analysis and career guidance, and back to the example of Tom I mentioned earlier.

I did not want to see a designer of exceptional talent buried under a noisy pile of money, so I told the father, "From your description and these photographs I see a spark of art. If you trust me, give Tom the confidence to walk his own path."

Although the father had a rather hot temper, he listened and agreed to a deal with his son: if Tom achieved nothing in fashion design within two years, he would return to help in the store.



Tom was undoubtedly fortunate, though he had already walked many thorny roads before that fortune arrived. A month ago I met Tom again. He was now head of the design department at the silk factory, with five or six designers under him, and he also handled cooperation and negotiations with other companies. He had come specifically to ask me for advice on the skill of “reading people.”

## **Emotional Support Can Rescue a Child’s Future**

Next we must address a deeper issue. This section has already discussed the expression of “shame” and “anger.” Some may ask, what about micro-expressions (微表情)?

In conclusion, the problem of micro-expressions is more profound than that of ordinary expressions. Children generally have less ability than adults to suppress emotion. When they feel negative emotions, whether they cannot suppress them or cannot suppress them completely, the expressions appear readily. A child’s facial changes are therefore easy to notice.

However, when a child expresses emotion through micro-expressions, it is possible that even the child has not registered the emotion. This means a child’s micro-expressions must be treated as danger signals and handled with care.

Finally, for children whose mistakes produce different emotional changes, we offer a solution: emotional support.

“Shame” is an important opportunity to revise one’s self-image. For example, explain an incorrect answer, help the child discover the cause of the mistake, and then present a similar problem for another attempt. Once the child answers correctly, offer appropriate praise—“Well done!”—to facilitate correction and reflection.

When a child feels “anger,” the impulse is to remove the obstacle. At that moment tell the child that the mistake itself is not an obstacle but an opportunity to grow. For the child to accept this idea, patient repetition is required.

If a “fear” response appears, the child will instinctively try to avoid the threat. Begin with simpler questions, guide the child step by step toward correct answers, and gradually bring the child to the point where the same level of problem can be handled without avoidance—learning instead to overcome it. This approach shows the child that, besides avoidance, more proactive methods exist for solving problems.

## **(7) Round Heads and Square Heads**

In general terms, the former refers to a head shape close to spherical, while the latter refers to a head shape close to square.

Not long ago an engineering-company owner came to see me. He had a large manufacturing plant and wanted to know how to select an efficient crane operator from a large group of workers. It seemed a small matter, yet it had troubled him for a long time; every operator he had chosen had caused an accident through negligence. Following his usual standards of caution and steadiness, the owner hired two new workers, but accidents increased rather than decreased. In desperation he came to me for advice.

I visited the factory and met the two new workers—dark-skinned, with clearly angular occiputs when viewed from behind, both square-headed types.

I pointed to a fair-skinned, rough-featured, broad-built young man with a short, round head and said, "That fellow looks promising. Why not try him?"

"Mr. Balkan, you mean Michael? Oh, he won't do. He's too unsteady; I can't take the risk."

"Trust me. At least give him a trial."

Events proved my judgment correct.

The owner later reported that in all his years of monitoring manufacturing operations he had "never seen anyone manage a crane as skillfully and safely as Michael."

I had met the two new workers and Michael only once, with no physical contact or verbal exchange. I had simply analyzed their psychology from the shape of their heads. The new workers kept making mistakes because square-headed people tend to be excessively cautious in everything; by contrast, round-headed people, though prone to impulsiveness, are also adaptable, adventurous, and capable of being meticulous within their boldness.

### **Characteristics of Passive-Aggressive Personality**

There are people who, when dissatisfied with you, never express it to your face. Sometimes they themselves do not realize how strong their dissatisfaction is. Instead they make inexplicable mistakes or behave in a negative, dilatory way that leaves you embarrassed and furious. Yet when you try to vent your anger, they always have a ready excuse or look at you with innocent eyes. In extreme cases the people around you may even turn hostile toward you because of this person, who stands aside smiling like the schemer in a film who sows discord among others.

Such individuals are truly troublesome, and in behavioral psychology they have a specific name: passive-aggressive personality.

The reason it is called passive-aggressive rather than active-aggressive is that their aggression is not active or spontaneous; it takes the form of negativity or error.

When dealing with others, such people are usually in a weaker position. Yet no matter how weak that position, when anger arises their first impulse is still to strike back. Because the power imbalance is severe, they cannot express anger or even refuse the stronger party's demands, for fear of losing what they currently possess.

At the same time, the anger stored in their unconscious prevents them from maintaining an objective attitude. They frequently procrastinate, break promises, or bungle simple tasks. Although this behavior does not directly express anger, it has the same effect as active aggression: it leaves the stronger party anxious and enraged.

### **Typical Features of Paranoid Personality**

People with paranoid personality are constantly suspicious of others and brood over injuries and insults they believe others have inflicted. They are like porcupines at every moment—either quarreling openly, publicly accusing others, or making sarcastic remarks behind their backs. Once they decide someone is making things difficult for them, they can see no virtues in that person; even sincere attempts at reconciliation are met with absolute distrust.

The Chinese Classification of Mental Disorders and Diagnostic Criteria once listed the common behavioral features of paranoid personality:

1. They interpret others' unintentional or even friendly actions as malicious and, without sufficient evidence, believe others are exploiting, deceiving, or trying to harm them.
2. They are extremely conceited and self-important, always considering themselves correct and capable; if anything goes wrong they blame others. Even when the fault is clearly their own and evidence is presented, they refuse to admit it.
3. They easily develop pathological jealousy and never forgive others' offenses, remembering them long afterward and interpreting every action through a suspicious lens, convinced that others are targeting them.
4. They connect unrelated events in their environment to themselves, feeling that everything is aimed at them; they may even identify with content in broadcasts or television and maintain intense vigilance and hostility toward supposed "conspiracies" from the outside world.
5. If married, they repeatedly suspect their spouse of infidelity and cannot tolerate even the slightest hint of disloyalty.

### **Case 1: Driver Old Zhang's Conversation with the Girl**

Driver Old Zhang picked up a young woman. After she got in, he asked politely, "Where to, miss?"

"Um, just drive ahead for now. I haven't decided—probably somewhere south of the bridge," she replied.

Old Zhang started the car. They had not gone far when the girl suddenly asked, "Master, the houses south of the bridge are expensive, right?"

"Huh?" The question caught Old Zhang off guard. After a moment he answered, "They really aren't cheap. I live over there myself. Prices have risen sharply these past few years..."

"Is the scenery north of the bridge better?" the girl interrupted.

"North of the bridge?" Old Zhang thought again. "There are more universities over there..."

"Universities? Going to university must be really interesting."

Old Zhang was baffled by the girl's remark. He ventured, "Miss, are we heading south or north of the bridge? Are you going to look at houses?"

"Oh, no. I'm thinking of opening a milk-tea shop recently," she said, shaking her head.

"A milk-tea shop?" Old Zhang was almost in tears. What did opening a milk-tea shop have to do with where they were driving right now? "Yes, it should be quite profitable." "Never mind profit for the moment—where exactly are we going?" Old Zhang exploded.

Many people cannot help smiling at the exchange between poor Old Zhang and the girl. Yet the girl had no intention of toying with him. The effect was produced entirely by her ADHD-type personality.

### **Main Behavioral Characteristics of ADHD-Type Personality**

This is the most striking behavioral feature of ADHD-type personality. Generally, people with this personality do not pay attention when others speak. In other words, when listening they let words go in one ear and out

the other; they may believe they are listening attentively, yet in reality they have no idea what was said.

Second, they tend to interrupt in order to voice their own thoughts. Their ideas flit about so rapidly that they fear forgetting them if they do not speak at once. Because of this they are often considered rude, although they themselves are unaware of it.

Finally, people with ADHD-type personality frequently suffer from restlessness and low self-confidence. Their character is rather scattered—in colloquial terms, a bit “off-kilter.” Their reactions are always half a beat slow, and they often fail to give others feedback. While performing an action or speaking a sentence, their thoughts may already have circled the universe, making it difficult for ordinary people to understand them; they are frequently judged as absent-minded and erratic.

Getting along with someone who has ADHD-type personality simply requires a little extra tolerance. They are not inherently difficult; their thoughts merely move too quickly. The important point is never to let their leaping thoughts lead the conversation, or you may spend a long time discussing something only to forget what you originally wanted to achieve. At that moment you will be like Dr. Bai or Old Zhang in the cases above—either flying into a rage or surrendering completely.

### **Xiao Bin's Story**

A-Sang may not have shown the pattern very clearly, but Xiao Bin, whom I know, is a very typical example.

Xiao Bin and Xiao Xu were colleagues in the same group. Although Xiao Bin was considerably more capable than Xiao Xu, he often did Xiao Xu's work, and Xiao Xu took it for granted that he could order Xiao Bin around.

Many colleagues could not understand the relationship. In their view Xiao Bin had no need to depend on Xiao Xu; with his ability he could handle matters independently.

For Xiao Bin, however, the situation was different. Before he met Xiao Xu, he would hesitate over every task, worrying that he would not do it well enough, that others would outperform him, or that the boss would scold him. He always tried to make his work perfect, yet this very perfectionism caused delays that provoked the boss's fury.

After “teaming up” with Xiao Xu, Xiao Xu's daily task became to encourage and flatter Xiao Bin so that he could work without anxiety about the future.

There is no doubt that Xiao Xu had accurately identified Xiao Bin's “inner child” and, by accommodating his temperament, created value for himself.

The influence of the inner child is profound. It does not grow naturally with age; on the contrary, it erupts powerfully when we fall into pain or difficulty. It is a force that binds us, yet if we recognize and break through it, it can greatly propel our growth.

### **Jenny's Example**

Jenny was always bustling about the office, yet no one liked her. The newcomer A-Dan felt some sympathy and grew closer to her.

“Please take care of the report,” A-Dan instructed during a joint project. “I'll finish the contract.”

"No problem, leave it to me," Jenny promised earnestly.

The next morning, just before the report to the manager, Jenny slapped her forehead and said, "Oh no, I forgot the report. I'm really sorry—I'll do it right away."

Although A-Dan had handled the contract successfully, Jenny's lapse caused both of them to receive a scolding from the manager.

The same thing happened repeatedly. Gradually A-Dan saw Jenny's true nature: her "forgetfulness" was not occasional, and it was precisely this trait that made colleagues avoid her at every turn<|eos|>

### **The Glib and Flattering Person**

In real life, some people, in order to achieve a certain expected goal, or to broaden their career prospects, or to gain some business benefits, use sweet words to flatter and fawn, or do things that make you feel overly intimate, tricking you into being deceived. Others try to pull strings, get close by claiming relations, or drag you into kinship and friendship, and so on.

During the Three Kingdoms period, Xun You was one of Cao Cao's strategists. When Xun You was thirteen, his grandfather passed away. While the family was still in mourning, Zhang Quan, a former subordinate of Xun You's grandfather, came to pay his respects.

As soon as Zhang Quan reached the coffin, he began to wail loudly, as if he had lost his own parents. While weeping, he declared that he wished to guard the tomb of the late prefect in order to repay the deep kindness and great virtue of Xun You's grandfather.

Zhang Quan's display moved the Xun family deeply, and they prepared to grant his request with gratitude. At that moment, the ever-calm Xun You, after careful observation, sensed that the man's behavior was highly unusual. Xun You recalled that his grandfather had never mentioned this person to the family, indicating that Zhang Quan had not been a close associate. Nor had anyone heard of any great favor the grandfather had shown him. Xun You reasoned that when someone offers excessive kindness, there must be an ulterior motive. Moreover, Zhang Quan's request was overly insistent, his words evasive, and his face showed alarm and worry. Xun You concluded that the man was hiding something and was afraid.

After spotting these flaws, Xun You quickly shared his suspicions with his uncle. Sure enough, after the uncle questioned him, Zhang Quan confessed that he had killed someone and had hoped to use the pretext of guarding the tomb to escape legal punishment.

### **Like Signatures from Student Days**

The handwriting of their signatures remains the same as it was in their student days. Although such people may appear quite mature on the surface, they are in fact immature. They cannot adapt to the adult world and may still be living with their parents even at age forty-five. They often harbor ideas that sound childish and unrealistic, yet they themselves fail to notice this.

Besides handwriting revealing character, spontaneous doodles can also expose psychological secrets.

When taking phone calls or attending meetings, if paper and pen are nearby, do you have the habit of doodling absentmindedly? When facing troubles at work or in life, or when feeling bored or distressed, do you scribble on paper without thinking, then toss the paper aside as if nothing happened?

Experts at Germany's Bonn Institute of Psychology spent a year observing people's superfluous movements during phone calls and meetings. They found that this unconscious doodling is closely linked to certain personality traits.

Renata Belkova, a researcher at Russia's Human Development Center and a doctor of psychology, commented that abstract drawings can indeed reflect a person's inner thoughts. Someone preoccupied with worries may show nothing on the surface, yet the "pictures" drawn subconsciously reveal their attitude toward those around them and the thoughts they are trying to conceal.

### **The Boastful Talker**

Such people often speak with great fluency, covering broad and lofty topics yet remaining careless about details. They never concern themselves with trivial matters.

The Nagoya Chamber of Commerce and Industry urgently needed to hire a director. Nagao Yoshiro, president of Meitetsu Department Store, recommended one of his friends to Chairman Tsuchikawa Motoo.

After the interview, Nagao asked Tsuchikawa how his friend had performed. Tsuchikawa immediately replied, "Your friend is not the right talent; he will be hard to retain."

Nagao was astonished and somewhat annoyed. "You only spoke with him for twenty minutes. How can you be sure he is not the right talent? Your judgment seems hasty and arbitrary."

Tsuchikawa explained: "From the moment he met me, he talked nonstop and gave me no chance to speak. When I spoke, he looked around distractedly, half-listening and indifferent. That is the first reason I say he is not the right talent. Second, he loves to advertise his personal connections, mentioning high officials as close friends and celebrities as drinking buddies, all to show he is no ordinary person. Third, when I asked about his management methods, he could not provide any answers. Is this the kind of person who qualifies as talent?"

After hearing Tsuchikawa's words, Nagao nodded repeatedly, acknowledging that they made perfect sense.

### **Body Type and Personality Psychology**

A giant ocean liner crossing the Atlantic begins to move so slowly that the motion is barely perceptible. Gradually it accelerates. Once at full speed, no matter how skilled the helmsman, it cannot execute a sudden turn or stop, unlike the small tugboats alongside it. Similarly, once a train has gathered speed, stopping requires considerable braking time. Automobile advertisements often praise cars for being "nimble and responsive," yet no one uses those words for a twelve-ton truck.

This is the simplest distinction between "large" and "small."

You may wonder what this has to do with the subject of this book. Indeed, what follows is the psychology of personality as expressed through body type. The same "large" and "small" principle applies to people. In short, a large-bodied person tends to react more slowly, while a small-framed person tends to react more quickly.

The first to link body type with personality psychology was German psychiatrist Ernst Kretschmer. He identified four basic body types: pyknic, asthenic, athletic, and dysplastic.

Through extensive clinical research, Kretschmer showed that people of different body types also differ in personality and susceptibility to certain disorders, and he summarized these findings.

## Dual Personality: "Two People" in One Body

Micro-expression keywords: Every one of us has multiple facets, yet not everyone possesses a dual personality. Only when personality has split to such an extent that one personality cannot be influenced or controlled by the other can it be called a true dual personality.

Many people born in the 1970s and 1980s are familiar with Akira Toriyama's Dragon Ball, and many born in the 1990s know it as well. In Dragon Ball there is a girl named Launch who "transforms" whenever she sneezes.

Normally, Launch is a gentle girl with blue hair and a simple mind, skilled at housework and cooking. But once she sneezes, she becomes a blonde, hot-tempered, violent criminal who robs banks with machine guns and rocket launchers.

The character in the manga is fictional and exaggerated. In real life we do not encounter people who change into someone else after a sneeze. Yet around us there are indeed many individuals with dual personalities. When we first meet them, we may think they are affable gentlemen or refined ladies. After getting to know them better, however, we discover they are not as they first appeared; they possess another set of habits completely different from, and sometimes directly opposed to, their outward image, yet these two sets of habits coexist within the same person.

### (I) The Robust Type

- **Facial and physical features:** Large build, coarse and stiff hair, deep and resonant voice.
- **Psychological traits:** Rough, bold, straightforward.
- **Behavioral traits:** Impulsive, physically strong and powerful.

Of course, they can also be intelligent, compassionate, and full of imagination. The great sculptor Rodin was a robust type; his masterpiece The Thinker expresses his powerful and vigorous nature.

Robust types pay little attention to details. Clothing, hairstyle, and fingernails are not their concern. They often ignore social settings, laughing heartily, speaking bluntly, or even telling crude jokes. They enjoy the company of other robust types and display leadership qualities. Former New York mayor Fiorello La Guardia was a representative figure; his image of clenched fists and fearless combativeness remains vivid. Lenin exemplified the people's leader: sturdy in build and unconcerned with trifles. Peasants arriving from all over Russia would exclaim in surprise at first sight, "Why, he looks just like us!"

Do not ask a train driver to do embroidery, nor ask a poet to shovel coal. This is the art of recognizing talent that every leader must master. A leader's true value and ability are proven by guiding subordinates to success.

### Personality Projected in Head Shape

The shape of the skull bears certain natural connections to personality traits.

Consider animals: lions and tigers have broader skulls, while elk and giraffes have narrower ones; correspondingly, the former are fierce and the latter gentle. Broad-skulled eagles, hawks, and vultures are predators, while narrow-skulled doves and chickens are usually prey.

By the same logic, the shape of a person's skull reflects, to some extent, their psychological characteristics. By studying skulls, anthropologists can determine a person's race, sex, personality, and talents. They have also found that Greeks, Italians, and Germans tend to have longer skulls, Asians generally have broader skulls,

Sicilians have smaller and narrower skulls, and Swedes and Scots often have square skulls. Of course, as ordinary people without special abilities, we cannot see another person's skull directly, so we must rely on external indicators—namely, the shape of the head above the ears and eyebrows—to make judgments.

In daily life and work, the ability to discern someone's psychology at first glance is key to success. At the end of this chapter, we will analyze in detail the relationship between head shape and psychological characteristics.

### **Wang Yaru in the TV Drama Yearning**

In the television drama *Yearning*, the person considered the most lacking in human warmth and the most stubborn and headstrong is Huifang's sister-in-law, the skilled physician Wang Yaru.

Wang Yaru is arrogant, aloof, eccentric, suspicious, and cold. Although she is an excellent doctor, she is poor at social interaction, rarely smiles, and does not get along with Xiaofang, Yuejuan, Aunt Liu, or Huifang. Even her only brother seldom sees her smile. Toward her former lover Luo Gang, who once wronged her, she behaves in an utterly unreasonable manner. Even her only close classmate, Tuan Li, cannot tolerate her rigid and peculiar temperament and nearly breaks with her several times.

Wang Yaru's behavioral pattern exemplifies a very typical personality feature in behavioral psychology: the paranoid personality. The most prominent characteristic of such people is that they live in a state of constant suspicion and complaint. They act entirely according to their own will, disregarding others' feelings and social consequences. They speak and act solely according to their own preferences. Even when they are wrong, they refuse to admit it, and thus they almost always hurt others, reaching the point where "everyone hates them."

### **People Who Like to Expose Others' Privacy**

When four or five colleagues gather, conversation often revolves around someone's private matters. Some play the role of revealing the secrets, while others play the role of listeners. What are the psychological motives of those who enjoy exposing others' privacy to create topics, and of those who listen?

People who disclose others' private information usually harbor hostility, envy, or inferiority toward that person. Listeners often share similar mindsets, which is why they pay attention.

- Desire to relieve psychological frustration from unmet needs: Such people usually have conflicts with the subject of the conversation and feel resentful, so they supply these privacy-revealing topics.
- Envy-based psychology: The targets of discussion are neither superiors nor subordinates but colleagues. By revealing such information, these people hope to gain favor with superiors and popularity with the opposite sex. The content usually concerns the target's private life, with the aim of damaging their image. If listeners also dislike the target, the speaker's goal is even easier to achieve.

### **Manifestations of Dual Personality in Daily Life**

Dual-personality individuals are common in everyday life. Examples include:

- A normally quiet and shy girl who at home chatters incessantly and loses her temper without reason
- An easygoing optimist who sometimes "gazes at the sky at a 45-degree angle and sheds lonely tears"
- A worker who always shouts and curses loudly yet treats women with more courtesy and consideration than a gentleman

All of these are expressions of dual personality.



When dealing with dual-personality individuals, there is no need to become overly nervous. Generally, they will interact with you using the personality that met and knows you. You may ignore the other personality they occasionally display, provided it does not affect you. If it does interfere with communication, you must stay alert, try to adapt to the other personality, and turn a two-person conversation into a three-person one. As long as the dual personality has not reached a pathological level, interacting with such people is generally safe.

### **The Definition of Histrionic Personality**

In behavioral psychology, such people are defined as “histrionic personalities.”

As the term suggests, individuals with this personality always behave in an extremely dramatic manner, as if performing in a poorly written, exaggerated television drama. They typically wear outlandish clothing or, in milder cases, dress in an overly ornate style in hopes of attracting attention. Their behavior is also flirtatious and seductive—not because they wish to flirt with or seduce the person in front of them, but because they seek permission, praise, and protection. To achieve this, they consider even age-inappropriate actions normal and interpret others’ strange looks as signs of attention.

Histrionic personalities crave attention so intensely that they frequently become overly emotional. Once they sense insufficient attention, they express their feelings in exaggerated ways, even reversing their attitude 180 degrees, bursting into tears at the slightest provocation and becoming quite annoying.

### **ADHD-Type Personality: The “Alien” with Leaping Thoughts**

Micro-expression keywords: People with ADHD-type personality have difficulty maintaining attention; therefore, during interactions one must constantly bring them back to the topic. For most people this requires patience and strong self-control.

ADHD, known in psychology as attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder, was originally recognized as a common childhood mental disorder—commonly called childhood hyperactivity. With increased understanding of the condition, psychologists have recently discovered that the symptoms can also appear in adults and form a specific personality type known as ADHD-type personality<|eos|>

### **Other Characteristics of Histrionic Personality and Ways to Get Along**

In addition to the above traits, people with histrionic personality are usually highly susceptible to suggestion. Both external environments and other people can easily influence them. In interpersonal relationships, they always overestimate the closeness of their bonds with others and place excessive trust in people. At first glance they may seem easygoing, yet actual interactions quickly reveal their various shortcomings.

Moreover, to achieve their own ends, people with histrionic personality can employ a variety of tactics—lying, deception, or obsequious flattery. For them these are merely performances that cause no psychological burden. When dealing with someone who has histrionic personality, playing along with their “act” is not the best approach. The optimal way to get along is to identify their personality type and show tolerance without indulgence.

### **Causes and Suggestions for Getting Along**

The causes of paranoid personality are generally considered to be a lack of love in early years or setbacks experienced later in life. Being distrusted in childhood, or being unable to bear frustration, injustice, or failure in adulthood, can all lead to the development of paranoid personality. In addition, excessive self-demand may also contribute. For example, someone without formal education may feel inferior and therefore resent any mention of academic qualifications by others; a person with unattractive features may feel that others are constantly targeting their appearance.

When interacting with someone who has paranoid personality, remain tolerant and do not let their suspicions provoke your own anger. It is also essential to uphold principles and maintain a certain distance. When faced with their endless doubts, express resistance at the appropriate moment.

### **(5) Long-Shaped Head**

Measured from the midpoint between the forehead and eyebrows over the top of the head to the back of the skull, the length is 7.6 inches or more.

If your child has a long-shaped head, I can guarantee they will always come up with peculiar questions that leave you dizzy. For instance, they like to ask, "Where will we go on vacation next summer?" or "What should I do when I grow up?"

Indeed, compared with the present, they prefer to focus on the distant future. In work, when negotiating with such a person, you must prepare a long-term plan and a precise budget; otherwise you cannot expect their support. In daily life they excel at socializing and enjoy group living, so they are very family-oriented.

A wise leader knows to place employees with long-shaped heads in social positions to fully utilize their sociable nature.

### **People Who Like to Keep Dogs Are Gentle**

Such individuals are easygoing and docile, appearing very approachable. They are extroverted, dislike loneliness, laugh and joke all day, and quickly blend in with others. They are warm-hearted, sensitive, and candid; any genuine thought immediately shows on their face or in their words and actions, yet they also tend to follow the crowd.

Generally, people who keep dogs with unattractive appearances mostly lack in their own looks; those who keep poodles are lively and childlike; those who keep large dogs have strong vanity; those who keep pedigree dogs come from affluent families and enjoy smooth careers; those who keep only Oriental dogs tend to be dictatorial and suspicious; those who adopt stray dogs are compassionate.

### **(3) High-Shaped Head**

Measured from the top of the ears to the crown, the height is 5.8 inches or more.

People with high heads also have high aspirations. They possess strong willpower, are upright and positive, yet they are also ambitious; their powerful self-esteem is their Achilles' heel. Many educators, missionaries, social workers, politicians, and judges have high head shapes. To defeat such an opponent you must maintain an even higher state of mind and pursuit; if you cannot, simply smile and remain silent.

If you are a manager and encounter a subordinate with a high-shaped head, pay close attention to their development. The seeds of success are already within them; all they may need is your timely nurturing.

## **(6) Short-Shaped Head**

Measured from the midpoint between the forehead and eyebrows over the top of the head to the back of the skull, the length is less than 7.6 inches.

People with short-shaped heads lack focus and dislike socializing; they are interested only in themselves. They often possess remarkable talents yet have no grand goals. If your competitor belongs to this type, you must stay calm and plan for the long term; otherwise you may well be defeated.

Viewed from behind, if a person's head is short and round without angles, they are likely to enjoy cutting corners and are keen on gambling or risk-taking. If the back of the head is square, they are cautious—sometimes overly so, appearing weak.

## **(1) Wide-Shaped Head**

Measured with a curved ruler at the top of the ears, the width is 6.5 inches or more.

If your opponent has a wide head shape, you must be fully alert, for they are a true warrior. They are energetic, aggressive, and every glance radiates powerful intensity. When facing such a person, never meet force with force; doing so will only leave you humiliated. The most effective way to defeat a wide-headed opponent is to yield in order to advance. Another fatal weakness is insatiable greed, so appropriate inducements can serve as another powerful weapon.

## **People Who Like White**

White is a color that represents passivity. Those who choose white have strong self-protective instincts and a pronounced sense of shyness. They may sometimes appear aloof, yet at heart they are kind and soft-hearted. They rarely fight for greater benefits within their social circles and are somewhat sensitive to interpersonal communication.

Different colors represent different personalities; therefore we should learn to read the psychological code behind colors. Only then can we catch others off guard in communication. The other party will surely be surprised that you already understand their character and style before they have even spoken.

## **People Who Prefer to Sit in the Center Are Self-Centered**

Such individuals have a strong desire for self-expression. Whenever they speak with others they center the conversation on themselves, repeatedly emphasizing their own words while ignoring others' matters and opinions.

When a shop becomes crowded and customers are asked to push tables together, these people immediately display annoyance and dissatisfaction, even seizing on the shop's mistake to lodge strong protests. They are by no means easygoing or communicative. If they order milk tea and the server mistakenly brings lemon black tea, they will be extremely displeased.

## **How to See a Child's Future from Micro-Expressions?**

During the ten years from my student days to completing graduate studies, I taught English at cram schools to middle-school students, adults, and people of various ages. One middle-school student left a particularly strong impression.

While correcting this child's exam mistakes, his face flashed an expression of "anger" for an instant before it vanished—this is the micro-expression of anger (微反应 (micro-reaction)). Normally, making a mistake evokes shame, yet he reacted with anger.

What exactly is this child's inner world like? We can consider the question through the following research.

## **Chapter 11 Identifying Personality Types and Understanding Behavioral Patterns**

Personality refers to the unique and stable patterns of thinking and acting that distinguish one person from another. If a person is likened to a computer's main unit, personality is the operating program running on that unit. Different personalities produce different styles of conduct. Understanding someone's personality type helps greatly in determining what "model" they are and which "program" to use when communicating with them. Identifying others' behavioral traits and seeing through their psychological activities offers significant and far-reaching assistance in recognizing, observing, and employing people.

### **People Who Steer Conversations Far Off Topic**

When talking with others, some people frequently steer the topic far away, making it impossible to grasp what they actually want to say, or they keep changing the subject, leaving listeners bewildered. Constantly shifting content can be positive, yet when the discussion becomes incoherent and pointless, listeners quickly lose interest. This behavior indicates a strong desire for control and self-expression. Such people rarely consider others; they prefer to act as they please and expect others to follow their lead.

### **People Who Steer Conversations Back to Themselves**

In real life there are people who, regardless of the occasion, always redirect conversations to themselves, boasting about how they struggled in the past. They fear others may not know their glorious history, yet such talk rarely achieves the desired effect. Close observation reveals that these individuals are largely dissatisfied with reality. They fail to realize that self-aggrandizing remarks struggle to adapt to changing times. Perhaps they are genuine failures who rely entirely on nostalgia to get by.

### **Signature Slants Right While Other Characters Slant Left**

People whose signature slants right while other characters slant left are social experts. They quickly become the center of attention through interpersonal skills as well as their cheerful, enthusiastic, witty, and humorous nature. Although their open personality makes them appear fully integrated with others and the setting, they often step outside the circle to observe everything as bystanders.

### **People Who Sleep in the Prone Position**

Such individuals are confident and highly capable. They accurately recognize themselves, always know who they are and what they are doing. They pursue life goals persistently and possess both the confidence and ability to achieve them. In emergencies they make timely decisions, demonstrate strong adaptability, and know how to adjust themselves. They are also adept at concealing their true feelings so completely that others cannot detect any flaw.

### **People Who Seem to Know Everything**

These individuals possess broad knowledge. They can cite examples from many fields during conversation and offer opinions on any topic, appearing erudite. Yet because they have accumulated too much information without sufficient system or depth of thought, they often miss the main point. They can produce dozens of ideas at once, none of which hit the mark. They are also not very modest; their knowledge, experience, and insight are wide but shallow—learned yet not refined.

#### **(4) Low-Shaped Head**

Measured from the top of the ears to the crown, the height is less than 5.8 inches.

People with low-shaped heads are pragmatists. They have ideals, yet these lean toward material concerns and tangible things. Spending time with them involves little pressure; defeating them requires no great wisdom or strategy—only realistic benefits. If you wish to befriend them, remember to give and take in moderation, for they tend to be selfish and your efforts may not be reciprocated.

#### **People Who Like Red**

Red symbolizes action. Those who choose red act immediately on any idea. They want to finish everything quickly, so they speak and act rapidly without much thought. They are usually energetic, vibrant, and driven by strong curiosity and desire, which they satisfy through action. They handle interpersonal relationships skillfully yet lack patience, easily becoming angry over trifles—though the anger passes quickly.

#### **People Who Like Yellow**

Yellow is associated with joy. Those who choose yellow love power and enjoy dominating others. They are intelligent, calm, and possess strong analytical and judgmental abilities, yet they tend to be self-centered. They have good business sense and often seek success through intellect. They are not very candid, especially under pressure, when they close themselves off and hide their true emotions while presenting a cheerful, positive image to outsiders.

#### **People Who Collect Old Receipts**

Such individuals possess strong organizational and leadership skills; they are meticulous, methodical, and systematic. However, most of their energy is wasted on useless details and meaningless processes. Sometimes their precautions are merely needless worry, as the dangers they fear have very low probability of occurring. They may also crave stimulation, yet overthinking prevents them from acting, so their lives remain largely unchanged.

#### **People Who Enjoy Scenery**

These individuals dislike being controlled. They pursue an unrestrained, relaxed, and colorful life and grow weary of rigid, dull, or monotonous routines. They are energetic and imaginative, always eager to explore new and unknown fields. Their wish is to seek new ideas or experiences in life, often bringing unexpected surprises—sometimes shocks—to family and friends.

#### **Analyzing the Owner's Life Attitude Through Collections**

Everyone collects for different reasons: some hope for future appreciation; some seek self-cultivation and refinement; some wish to display elegance and distinction; others collect to reminisce about the past. Different

collections also reveal distinct personality traits. A person's collected items can help us understand their psychology and character.

### **People Who Collect Toys**

Such individuals are easily satisfied. Their happiest place is home, and their greatest enjoyment is a quiet, comfortable life. They are nostalgic about the past, proud of past achievements, and try every means to preserve them in memory. They always use a childlike heart to stir excitement and happiness. They like youth and do everything possible to maintain a cheerful mood, enjoying play with children.

### **People Who Keep Cats Are Independent**

These individuals rarely conform to others or compromise against their will. If they dislike someone, they state it clearly. They value independence, prefer solitude, and are not good at expressing emotions or opening up. They are strict with themselves, dislike acting on impulse, and give the impression of being unenthusiastic, unsociable, eccentric, cold, or pretentious.

### **People Who Like Pink**

Pink is a soft color. Those who choose pink are usually sensitive and gentle. They strive to stay youthful and energetic and want to project an endearing aura. Yet they have a strong tendency to escape reality, preferring to hide in their own small world rather than readily accept others' opinions. In truth, they cannot bear the awkwardness of reality.

### **Your Music, Your Personality**

Music is an important form of entertainment in human life and is purely emotional. Many people form an inseparable bond with music. Some pursue it as a lifelong ideal; some treat it as a confidant to whom they pour out their hearts; some regard it as a mentor from whom they seek guidance.

By understanding a person's favorite music, we can glimpse certain aspects of their character.

### **People Who Sleep in an Infant-Like Position**

Most such individuals lack a sense of security and have weak characters that cannot withstand setbacks. They have poor independent awareness and like to depend on familiar people or environments; unfamiliar people or settings trigger fear. When facing difficulties they usually choose to escape. Their logical thinking is weak, and they lack a sense of order; often an event has already occurred before they have prepared.

### **Illegible Signature**

To the world this person is a mystery; perhaps even to themselves they remain a mystery. Others cannot understand them because the clues they receive contradict their true personality, yet they do not mind. They have long since learned to become a contradictory individual and have grown accustomed to it. Still, being an enigmatic figure has its advantages—they receive considerable attention.

### **People Who Keep Birds or Fish Are Reclusive**

These individuals have delicate temperaments and generally wish to care for their pets according to their own preferences while meticulously arranging their personal space. They dislike complicated interpersonal relationships and find daily social interactions quite tiresome.

Additionally, a woman who always carries a gift from her father is said to have an Electra complex; a man who always carries a gift from his mother is said to have an Oedipus complex.

### **Writing and Drawing Reveal Your Aspirations**

Writing is a reflection of the mind. Posture while writing reveals character; the beauty or ugliness of characters does not indicate whether the mind is sound, yet the extension or contraction of strokes shows whether a person is reserved or unrestrained.

You can find an appropriate moment to ask the other person to write some information on a sheet of paper—for example, their name and contact details.

### **(2) Narrow-Shaped Head**

Measured with a curved ruler at the top of the ears, the width is less than 6.5 inches.

These people are born diplomats and negotiators. They are modest, patient, and resourceful. When dealing with them you need not be overly guarded, nor should you rush. The most effective approach is to listen—judging their thoughts from their fluent speech.

### **People Who Collect Books, Magazines, and Newspapers**

Such individuals are knowledgeable and ambitious. Reading at home is one of their great pleasures; they enjoy solitude and find contentment in it. Although their collections are large and their materials abundant, most are outdated and of little practical value, yet they continue to keep them. Consequently, in real life they are always half a step behind others.

### **People Who Like Handicrafts and Embroidery**

Such people are warm and caring toward others, with a strong sense of responsibility and the ability to take ownership of everything they do. They maintain a positive and optimistic attitude toward life, knowing clearly what they should and should not do. They possess strong self-confidence and do not indulge themselves; even after achieving success, they merely savor the moment privately, deriving a sense of fulfillment and accomplishment from it.

### **People Who Like Black**

Black is a color that conveys self-control. People who choose black are typically highly intimidating; they appear complex and dramatic, often leaving others with the impression of a serious personality. They long for power and usually wish to project an authoritative image. Even under heavy pressure, they remain relatively composed.

### **People Who Like Green**

Green is the most vibrant color in natural life. People who choose green are willing to help everyone. Although they rarely concern themselves with others' affairs, they often make excellent listeners and can serve as advisors. They have easygoing personalities and readily become others' best friends. They enjoy group living, treat everyone equally, and always give a gentle, approachable impression.

### **People Who Like Orange**

Orange is a bright, energetic color. People who choose orange enjoy outdoor activities, feel close to nature, and love sports. Although they frequently display a sentimental side, they remain clear about what they want. They make ideal partners and are willing to change for the other person. They readily sympathize with the weak, are polite, and enjoy helping others.

### **People Who Like Brown**

Brown is a stable, reliable color that symbolizes masculinity. People who choose brown deeply appreciate the finer things in life. Although passionate and eager for external recognition and companionship, they may fear the outside world because they overly suppress their emotions. They tend to be ordinary, honest individuals who prefer an orderly life.

### **People Who Like Symphonic Music**

Such people are confident and ambitious, always focusing on the positive aspects of any situation. They quickly connect with others, yet their excessive trust in people often leads to losses or harm. They enjoy showcasing themselves and boasting about their extraordinary qualities in front of others, hoping to enter high society, though they have a tendency toward impracticality.

### **People Who Value Collecting Items That Symbolize Honor**

Such people are usually dissatisfied with their current circumstances and believe their past glory should not fade so quickly; they feel they should continue enjoying life surrounded by honors and accolades. They do not understand the concept that "each new wave on the Yangtze pushes the previous one forward," so they comfort their disappointed hearts only by recalling past achievements.

### **Sleeping on One's Back**

Such people are very outgoing and generous, warm and approachable, full of sympathy, and willing to give. They can read others' minds well and understand others' needs. Their thinking is quite mature; they can distinguish priorities in people and matters. They also have a strong sense of responsibility, dare to take on duties, and maintain good interpersonal relationships.

### **People Who Like the Waltz**

Such people are calm and steady in their actions, relatively approachable and easygoing, and rich in social experience and life exposure. They are well-versed in various etiquette and understand the subtle dynamics between people, so they handle social interactions and dealings with others appropriately, naturally exuding an air of maturity and elegance.

### **How to Respond**



When dealing with someone who has a passive-aggressive personality, it is best not to hold too many expectations, as most of them are undisciplined and lack credibility. When negotiating with them, excessive accommodation only puts you at a greater disadvantage, while sudden anger is also inadvisable. Therefore, directly confronting them and setting a clear deadline is a relatively safe approach.

### **People Who Like Spreading Rumors**

There are people who delight in stirring up trouble and enjoy spreading and circulating rumors that make others feel uneasy. In reality, they are not inherently malicious; they do this simply to attract attention and satisfy their vanity of refusing to remain obscure. Once their vanity is satisfied, they quiet down.

### **Drawing a Line Under a Signature**

People who habitually draw a wavy line under their signature are usually smooth and worldly. At any time, they can rely on their careful consideration and years of accumulated life experience to place themselves in an advantageous position, staying proactive rather than passive, because they deeply understand how to follow the flow of trends.

### **People Who Like Tap Dancing**

Most such people are energetic and have a strong desire to perform, seeking to attract others' attention through their displays in front of crowds. When setbacks and hardships arise, they can persevere and find every possible way to overcome difficulties. They have a strong sense of time; every minute and second is precious to them.

### **People Who Like Strolling on the Beach**

Such people are somewhat reclusive, conservative, and traditional. They carry heavy thoughts, are unwilling to reveal their true inner feelings, and harbor a desire or tendency to live in seclusion. They do not have many friends, but their relationships with those friends are strong. They possess a certain sense of responsibility, especially investing considerable time and energy in raising their children.

### **People Who Like Drawing Triangles**

Such people have agile minds, quick reactions, and a strong ability to accept new things and ideas. They prefer to act independently and dislike ready-made solutions. They only proceed with any matter after thorough consideration, demonstrating a spirit of striving for excellence and seeking truth from facts, though they may sometimes become overly fixated on minor details.

## **Chapter 7 "Micro" View of Hobbies — The Mind Map Hidden in Hobbies**

Western psychology experts point out that interest psychology is a psychological driving force with subconscious characteristics. As long as you carefully observe a person's interests and hobbies, you will discover the psychological driving forces hidden behind them; as long as you identify and analyze these psychological driving forces, you will gain insight into their innate character.

### **People Who Like Gray**

Gray is generally perceived as a rather ambiguous color. People who choose gray tend to suppress their enthusiasm in social interactions but display traits of attentiveness, stability, pursuit of peace, and caution. They dislike displaying their emotions, often consider others, yet avoid deep contact with people.

### **Small Characters Written Close Together**

Writing characters close together indicates a desire to maximize the use of minimal space and shows that the person is thrifty and meticulous with calculations, knowing how to spend every penny. They do not care too much about how others view them; as long as they consider something meaningful, they will pursue it without hesitation.

### **Signature Font Smaller Than Regular Font**

People whose signature font is smaller than their regular font are the opposite of those whose signature font is larger. They generally lack a sense of self-inflation and may even feel they are insignificant and without influence. They often avoid honors and praise that rightfully belong to them and engage in self-deprecation.

### **Signature Slanting Left While Other Characters Slant Right**

People whose signature slants left while other characters slant right tend to have strong rebellious tendencies, though this rebelliousness may not reflect their true nature; they merely wish to leave others with a cold and silent impression. Beneath this feigned exterior, their true selves are actually quite friendly and sociable.

### **People Who Like Doodling Randomly**

Such people actively pursue the things they idealize and do not become discouraged or despondent even after failure, so they always give others an optimistic and upbeat impression. They possess strong adaptability and the ability to regulate their mindset, enabling them to integrate into new environments at the fastest speed.

### **Signature Font Larger Than Regular Font**

People whose signature font is much larger than their regular font have a strong desire for self-expression and a tendency toward self-inflation. They emphasize superficial aspects and hope to leave a refreshing visual impression. This goal is often achieved.

### **People Who Like Jazz Music**

Such people tend to have more emotional than rational components in their personality; they often get involved in matters due to momentary impulses and overlook objective realities. They dislike being constrained, act independently, pursue a rich and colorful life, detest monotony, and linger in the dazzling nightlife.

### **People Who Like Watching Drama Programs**

Such people have exceptionally strong self-confidence; no matter the difficulties or obstacles, they believe they can break through them. They dare to challenge limits and possess a stubborn character that brooks no

contradiction. They are romantic and possess a sense of justice, yet they are also very self-centered and give the impression of wanting to dominate others.

### **Passive-Aggressive Personality: The “Old Hand” Who Stabs from Behind**

#### **Micro-expression Keywords**

People with a passive-aggressive personality are usually the weaker party, yet they can often make the stronger party fly into a rage. Their attacks are not like a straightforward knife but more like a needle hidden in cotton; thus they are often described as using “invisible attacks.”

#### **People Who Like Blue**

Blue is an emotional color. People who choose blue often harbor guarded feelings toward others and focus more on their personal world. In order to experience a rich variety of life, they are very willing to communicate with others, yet they are also easily influenced by their environment and other people.

#### **People Who Like Jazz Dance**

Such people have strong adaptability. They are informal and humorous; this humor is not deliberately displayed but flows naturally. They enjoy the liveliness of being with many people, yet they can also find or create their own enjoyment when alone.

#### **People Who Like Rock Music**

Such people enjoy socializing, fear loneliness, and cannot tolerate solitude; they prefer activity over stillness. They are somewhat cynical and need rock music as an outlet for their emotions. They can use their hobbies as powerful guidance, enjoy showing off everywhere, and attract attention.

#### **People Who Like Quiz Programs**

Such people can solve the various problems before them one by one. While watching television, they follow the program with thinking and reasoning; whether right or wrong, they display an active, enterprising, and competitive personality. They are intelligent and remain calm in the face of events.

### **The Art of Reading People Through the Enneagram**

As the saying goes, “One mother gives birth to nine sons, and each son is different.” There are great differences among people, and each possesses a distinct temperament. Failing to understand these temperaments may hinder our comprehension of others. The following focuses on explaining nine narrow-minded temperaments.

#### **People Who Like Drawing Circles**

Such people are far-sighted, skilled at strategic planning and keeping a low profile; they are the deeply hidden masters who remain outside the fray. On the surface they appear indifferent and carefree about life, yet they actually possess extremely meticulous and practical life plans.

#### **People Who Like Drawing Vehicles**

Such people love traveling and hope to see the world; they have many lofty ideals and therefore also face many disappointments and setbacks. They lack confidence in themselves and hold little hope for their own future, but they place great hope in others, especially their children.

### **People Who Like Collecting Art and Antiques**

Such people place great importance on their social status and identity and are highly competitive. Because art and antiques represent elegance, erudition, and wealth, the comparison of the grade and value of collections becomes a contest of taste and vision among collectors.

### **The Personality Code Hidden in Seating Choices**

In a restaurant, which seat do you prefer? In a café, which seat do you prefer? In a conference room, which seat do you prefer?...

Through different positions, we can roughly judge a person's psychology and personality.

### **Interpreting the Mind Through Dance**

One of humanity's oldest forms of communication is dance; like language, dance is constantly evolving. The way a person likes to dance and the type of dance they favor can also reveal their psychological characteristics.

### **People Who Like the Tango**

Most such people are unwilling to settle for mediocrity; they yearn for a rich and colorful life, preferably with a touch of mystery. They place great value on a person's talent and cultivation, considering these more important than anything else.

### **Fat People and Thin People**

If you were a cartoonist asked to draw a person living comfortably and particular about food and clothing, the first image that would come to mind would probably not be a bony figure, right? Below we explore the "life philosophy" of fat people.

### **People Who Like Opera**

Such people have many traditional and conservative elements in their personality; they are relatively emotional and prone to extreme behavior. They are conscientious and responsible in their work, possess a strong sense of duty, always demand the best of themselves, and strive for perfection in everything.

### **Paranoid Personality: The "Stubborn Temperament" That Is Always Suspicious**

#### **Micro-expression Keywords**

People with a paranoid personality find it difficult to recognize their own shortcomings. Their self-righteousness, jealousy, suspicion, mistrust, and stubbornness fracture their relationships with those around them, yet they remain unrepentant.

### **Lying Diagonally Across the Bed While Sleeping**

Such people are quite arbitrary. Although they are shrewd and capable in their actions, they will never compromise with others. Their attitude toward matters is "It will be done my way; you have no right to object." They enjoy leading others and possess a strong desire for power.

### **People Who Like Collecting Coins**

Such people are relatively conservative and traditional, unwilling to take risks and slow to accept new things, yet they have a strong sense of responsibility, can see tasks through to completion, and pursue perfection. They place more importance on results than on the process.

### **People Who Like Woodwork**

Such people have strong hands-on abilities and dislike relying on others because they possess a strong sense of self-respect. They also have strong self-confidence and firmly believe they can succeed. They quickly accept new things and dare to take risks, explore, and experiment.

### **People Who Like Purple**

Purple is a noble and mysterious color. People who choose purple are often extremely strict with themselves in their pursuit of perfection. In order to become their ideal selves, they crave reading, love knowledge, and hope to advance further in their careers.

### **People Who Like Drawing Natural Scenery**

Such people have gentle and kind dispositions, are sensitive and enthusiastic, and possess strong abilities to appreciate and distinguish shapes and colors. They do not place much value on material life, are not bound by fame or fortune, and yearn for a relaxed, quiet, and peaceful existence.

### **Face Down, Head Between Arms, Knees Drawn Up**

Such people have a strong defensive mentality and a pronounced sense of autonomy; they will not obey others' orders or be manipulated, nor will they bow to authority. They like to do what they enjoy; if someone forces them, they will resist.

### **People Who Like Sleeping on the Edge of the Bed**

Such people lack a sense of security. They possess strong rational thinking, yet their self-control and tolerance are high, allowing them to keep anxious emotions from showing. As long as matters do not exceed their tolerance limit, they will not easily retaliate or become angry.

### **People Who Like Percussion Music**

Such people are straightforward and candid, full of hope for life, and have carefully planned their future. They value harmony in social interactions, are not picky, and are also humorous with strong social skills; most are well-liked individuals.

### **People Who Like Drawing Waves**

Such people are intelligent and talented, never superstitious about authority, and insist on basing everything on facts. They take responsibility for their actions and never waver once they have decided on something; they can generally achieve any ideal they set.

### **People Who Like Drawing Irregular Zigzag Shapes**

Such people are never satisfied with the status quo and are constantly striving toward new and higher goals. They are competitive and absolutely will not allow others to get ahead of them; even if they end up battered and bruised, they will still challenge.

### **Adding a Dash or Period After a Signature**

Some people habitually add a small dot to the lower right of their name after signing. This signature style carries meanings of thoughtfulness, caution, confidence, responsibility, and distrust. They tend to be quite careful and prudent in their dealings with others.

### **People Who Like Talk Shows**

Such people are meticulous and considerate in their actions and dealings, refuse to yield even when in the right, and sometimes appear impulsive. They have their own methods for handling social situations but do not make subjective assumptions. They think before acting and rarely act on impulse.

### **People Who Like Sitting in the Corner Prefer Quiet**

Such people prefer a stable and secure life. Because they like to be observers, they can be said to lack decision-making ability in most matters and lack the proactive attitude required of a leader.

### **People Who Like Marches**

Such people strive for perfection in everything they do and set extremely high standards for themselves, refusing to allow the slightest error in their work. The imperfections of real life often leave them helpless, disappointed, and even bruised all over.

### **People Who Like Visiting Relatives and Friends in Various Places**

Such people are sincere and warm, value honesty and trustworthiness, and dislike hypocrisy or affectation; this has earned them widespread friendship and assistance. They bring great fulfillment and satisfaction to their relatives and friends.

### **People Who Like Collecting Photos and Postcards**

Such people use these photos to bridge the distance between themselves and the people or scenes in their memories, frequently recalling past happy times. They treat life as a play, writing, directing, and acting in it themselves, striving to create a perfect life.

### **People Who Like Thrilling and Exciting Programs**

Such people are competitive, unwilling to remain subordinate, and approach every task with seriousness and dedication. They dislike a plain and ordinary life and always find every means to make their days rich and

colorful.

### **People Who Prefer Group Tours When Traveling**

This type of person possesses a certain capacity for logical reasoning; they plan every matter that comes into their hands in an orderly fashion. They are quite realistic, dislike fantasies, and never anticipate any unexpected surprises.

### **Talking Dolls and Pets**

Keeping pets is a form of leisure. Preferences vary from person to person, so the pets they keep naturally differ widely. From a psychological perspective, one's favorite dolls and preferred pets can reveal their true character.

### **People Who Choose Seats Near the Entrance Tend to Be Impatient**

Such individuals observe their surroundings with meticulous attention, maintain a serious attitude toward life, enjoy moving about, and can never stay idle. Caring for others and serving them are the activities they like most.

### **The Psychological Code Hidden in Skin Color**

Based on differences in physique and skin color, the world's human races can be broadly divided into three categories: the yellow race (Mongoloid), the white race (Caucasoid), and the black race (Negroid).

### **Sleeping with Both Feet Outside the Bed**

These people maintain a fast pace of life and stay busy at work, leaving them little time for rest. They hold a positive and optimistic outlook, possess abundant energy, and treat others with warmth and friendliness.

### **People Who Like Country Music**

Such individuals are mature and prudent; they rarely do anything that would cause regret or harm their interests. Their temperament is mild and approachable. They dislike the complexity and noise of big cities and prefer a pastoral lifestyle.

### **People Who Like to Be Different**

These individuals are highly curious, willing to challenge authority, and enjoy confronting tradition; they show strong pioneering spirit. However, they cannot think calmly and easily fall into extremism. They can undertake groundbreaking work.

### **People Who Like to Draw Straight Lines or Crosses**

These people overflow with vitality and seem to have endless energy. They cannot tolerate solitude, enjoy joining the crowd, and have no fixed likes or dislikes. They often talk boastfully and stir up trouble when there is none.

### **Histrionic Personality: Life Is as Wonderful as a Drama**

Micro-expression keywords: People with histrionic personality often fantasize, treat imagination as reality, and exaggerate their own feelings, thereby giving others the impression of affectation and making a fuss over nothing.

### **Sitting and Sleeping with Hands at the Sides and Legs Straight**

These individuals remain in a state of high tension at all times. Their life rhythm is very fast and regular; what should be done at any given moment appears fixed in advance.

### **People Who Like Dark Green**

Dark green is a deep and restrained color. Choosing it indicates that the person usually harbors many ideals and knows how to be inclusive. Although they yearn for breadth and depth, they easily become worldly-wise.

### **People Who Prefer Window Seats Are Ordinary**

These individuals have quite ordinary personalities. They avoid entrances, exits, and areas near restrooms, and stay away from noisy guests whenever possible. They possess no particularly distinctive traits.

### **People Who Love Ballet**

Such people usually have strong patience; once they set a goal, they pursue it through their own efforts. They can also observe discipline and follow organizational arrangements.

### **People Who Like to Travel Abroad**

These individuals are relatively fashionable, enjoy following trends, and stand at the forefront of the times. They like change, feel deep affection for new things, and remain confident about life.

### **People Who Like to Watch Comedies**

These people are humorous and witty. On the surface they appear casual and absent-minded, yet they harbor strong emotions; once they become genuinely attached to someone, their feelings become unstoppable.

### **People Who Sleep with Arms and Legs Crossed**

Such individuals possess a strong sense of self-defense and do not allow others to infringe upon them. However, their character is fragile, and they find it difficult to withstand certain kinds of harm.

### **Large, Flourished, or Decorative Characters**

People accustomed to writing in large, flourished, or decorative scripts often lack self-confidence and use this style to conceal their insecurity.

### **People Who Like to Draw Continuous Circular Shapes**

These individuals are empathetic, frequently put themselves in others' positions, and are trustworthy. They enjoy making friends, are not greedy, and are easily satisfied.



## **People Who Like to Camp Outdoors While Traveling**

Such people have relatively independent personalities and possess a degree of imagination and creativity, yet they do not live in fantasy; they still pay close attention to objective reality.

## **Obtaining Sleeping Postures to Understand True Character**

A person's sleeping posture is a form of body language expressed directly by the subconscious and is very helpful for understanding their character and psychology.

## **High-and-Narrow Forehead Head Shape**

These individuals excel at analyzing and commenting on matters and enjoy specialized, in-depth research; however, they approach everything with a critical mindset and are narrow-minded.

## **People Who Like Pop Music**

Such individuals pursue a relatively simple and free lifestyle, seeking to become more relaxed and happy through listening to music.

## **People Who Like to Draw Small Sawtooth Patterns**

These people are mentally agile, react quickly, and possess analytical abilities beyond the ordinary; they can penetrate to the essence of things when viewing problems.

## **Understanding a Person's Inner World Through Travel Preferences**

Travel relaxes a tense and weary mind. Travel preferences can reveal what a person is truly thinking.

## **Low-in-Front, High-in-Back Head Shape**

These individuals are arrogant, possess strong willpower, and are ambitious; however, they can sometimes be overbearing and stubborn, lacking skill in judging people.

## **People Who Like Rock Dancing**

They are generally young people whose thinking is relatively advanced and avant-garde, filled with rebellious ideas.

## **People Who Like Classical Music**

Such individuals are strongly rational, frequently engage in self-reflection, and draw considerable life insights from music.

## **People Who Sit Against a Wall with Their Back to Others Are Aloof**

These people are naturally aloof, devoted to immersing themselves in their own world, and oblivious to external existence.

### **High-in-Front, Low-in-Back Head Shape**

These individuals are highly compassionate and emotional, easily moved; their shortcoming is that their sympathy can easily become excessive.

### **Wide-and-Low Forehead Head Shape**

These individuals are versatile, broad-minded, and constructive; however, their mental energy is scattered and cannot be concentrated.

### **People Who Like Latin Dance**

Such people are energetic and full of charm; they possess a strong desire to perform.

### **People Who Like Social Dancing**

These individuals enjoy interacting with others and possess strong organizational and creative abilities.

### **People Who Like to Collect Travel Souvenirs**

Such people enjoy constantly pursuing novel, unusual, and bizarre things.

### **People Who Like to Watch Talk Shows**

These individuals have active minds and rich imaginations.

### **Narcissistic Personality: The Arrogant and Conceited “Selfish Egoist”**

Micro-expression keywords: People with narcissistic personality are mostly arrogant. Lowering your own status will only make them look down on you even more and exploit you more casually. Understanding their psychology and displaying a stronger inner self than theirs can make them hesitate to underestimate you.

Anyone who has watched *Slam Dunk* is familiar with the protagonist Sakuragi Hanamichi. He is a straightforward high-school student and a key player on the basketball team. Unlike the other members, Sakuragi is extremely narcissistic; every time he appears, he bursts into exaggerated laughter and boasts, “I’m a genius.”

Convinced he is a genius, Sakuragi refuses to take orders from anyone on the court except the coach and the captain. When his “rival” Rukawa Kaede shows disdain, Sakuragi interprets it as jealousy and sometimes ends up in a fight.

As a manga character, Sakuragi’s narcissism differs somewhat from the clinical narcissistic personality. Beyond narcissism, Sakuragi mainly displays a simple, straightforward nature. In real life, however, narcissistic individuals are rarely so endearing.

Xiao Chen, newly employed at a foreign-trade company, visited the notoriously difficult client Manager Li. After respectfully knocking and entering the office, Xiao Chen received only a sidelong glance: “Who are you? What do you want?”

“I’m a sales representative from xx Company...”

Before Xiao Chen could finish, Manager Li rudely interrupted: "Just a sales rep? Who sent you?"

"Our General Manager Yang asked me to discuss this deal..."

Xiao Chen had barely spoken when Manager Li cut in again: "Hmph, only a sales rep to talk business with me? Does your company have no one more suitable?"

Suppressing his anger, Xiao Chen explained, "Because I've been following this project, General Manager Yang thought I was the right person..."

"Suitable?" Manager Li gave him another sidelong look. "Sending a junior salesman to negotiate with a company manager—does that seem appropriate? If General Manager Yang looks down on me like this, I'll have to revise the project. Your company's quote must be 20 percent lower than the listed price!"

The demand was unreasonable, yet a 20 percent reduction still left the company with acceptable margins. Believing a deal remained possible, Xiao Chen nodded and said, "All right. I'll go back and calculate whether we can offer you a satisfactory price."

"Is the price something you can decide?" Manager Li snorted. "I'm not asking you; I'm asking General Manager Yang. Go run the errand and report back."

Furious, Xiao Chen pulled out his phone and began dialing while saying, "Since you feel you can't discuss details with me, you might as well speak directly with General Manager Yang."

"What are you doing..." Manager Li tried to stop him, but the call connected and General Manager Yang's voice came through: "Hello..."

"Ah, General Manager Yang, it's me, Little Li." Instantly dropping his earlier arrogance—even though General Manager Yang could not see him—Manager Li forced a smile. "Here's the situation: one of your junior salesmen came to quote a price. I thought it was a bit high, so I wanted to ask if you could lower it."

"We've worked together for years; that's negotiable. Talk to Xiao Chen about it and have him report back to me," General Manager Yang replied briskly. "I'm busy—got to go. Let's have tea sometime."

"Yes, yes, no problem."

After hanging up, Manager Li's face changed again. He tossed the phone back to Xiao Chen and said coldly, "What are you still standing there for? Your task is done—go report back."

Business circles contain no shortage of people like Manager Li. Once they gain a little status, they become arrogant, refuse to deal with anyone they consider beneath them or useless, and treat even potentially useful people as inferior. Only those who flatter and obey them may win approval; any resistance or questioning triggers immediate contempt and dismissal.

Everyone harbors some narcissistic tendencies, but only when these tendencies are deeply rooted in one's core thinking and exert a strong influence on personality can the condition be called narcissistic personality. Typical narcissistic individuals frequently exhibit the following behaviors:

1. They spend long periods lost in fantasies of unlimited power, success, brilliance, beauty, or perfect love, often becoming self-absorbed in these daydreams.
2. They place extreme value on themselves, possess intense self-confidence, expect to be treated as extraordinary successes, exaggerate their talents and achievements, and demand special favors and

privileges.

3. They flatter and ingratiate themselves with those they perceive as stronger, yet secretly envy others' accomplishments and possessions; toward those they view as weaker, they are arrogant and dismissive. When criticized, they immediately assume others are jealous or envious rather than reflect on their own faults.
4. They crave more admiration than most people and want everyone to worship and respect them. They frequently award themselves titles, emphasize their special privileges, and believe they are exempt from ordinary rules—even when they make mistakes.
5. In relationships they tend to take petty advantages and exploit others, stopping at nothing to achieve their goals.
6. They feel no empathy for anyone except themselves and have no interest in others' feelings or needs, focusing only on how others' shortcomings might cause them loss.

People with narcissistic personality usually developed greedy, selfish, and cold-blooded traits in childhood due to various negative influences. Most are intensely drawn to power and skilled at using others; they remember someone only while that person remains "useful," and quickly discard "useless" friends as burdens.

One narcissistic individual asked a friend to help him find a job. On the day of the interview the friend fell ill and could not accompany him. Instead of considering how unwell his friend must have felt, the man blamed him for breaking the appointment and leaving him "feeling insecure"—a classic display of selfish behavior typical of narcissistic personality.

Dealing with someone who has narcissistic personality is exhausting. They may be capable leaders or successful professionals, yet they can never be caring, understanding friends. Therefore, when interacting with them, never endure humiliation or yield completely; doing so only encourages further exploitation. The correct approach is to remain neither obsequious nor arrogant, maintain an even demeanor, and let them sense that you are a cultivated and substantial person. They will then naturally refrain from treating you as beneath them.

## **Obsessive-Compulsive Personality: The "Workaholic" with Obsessive Tendencies**

### **Obsessive-Compulsive Personality: The "Workaholic" with Obsessive Tendencies**

Micro-expression keywords: People with obsessive-compulsive personality always force themselves to do this and that. Little do they know that this obsessive and anxious mindset may actually be the reason things go wrong.

During the Joseon Dynasty, there was a famous general named Yi Sun-sin. He came from a declining scholar-official family and grew up in poverty, yet he was ambitious and excelled in poetry, literature, riding, and archery. In his thirties he passed the military examination and devoted his entire career to the army.

Throughout his life Yi Sun-sin was deeply concerned for his country and people. His character was upright and uncompromising. While leading the Joseon navy against Japanese invaders, he achieved indelible accomplishments.

Yet this great figure recorded in Joseon history also possessed a personality trait that could be viewed as either a flaw or a virtue. Beyond striving for thorough preparation and meticulous planning during wartime, Yi Sun-sin remained constantly on guard even in peacetime, drilling his troops and preparing defenses. He made detailed plans for every matter and could not help but strongly oppose or condemn any behavior or opinion he found unacceptable. Even in battle he would never engage unless victory was certain.

Yi Sun-sin's superiors considered him overly strict, his colleagues found him difficult, and his subordinates were annoyed by his numerous demands. It was precisely this character, however, that enabled his wartime achievements.

Individuals like General Yi Sun-sin, who are principled and demanding, are undoubtedly national treasures in wartime. In today's society, however, they often become "problematic" figures who cause headaches for many. Their obsessive tendencies manifest not only in self-restraint but also extend to others; they frequently "show concern" in ways that feel intrusive.

Xiao Luo's immediate superior, Director Ma, was an out-and-out workaholic. After more than twenty years at the office he remained diligent, handling more tasks and performing better than anyone else, often working unpaid overtime on weekends. Despite this dedication he was still only a minor director and had not been promoted in nearly a decade.

Xiao Luo found this puzzling and felt sympathy for Director Ma. One day, after everyone else had left, he saw Director Ma still busy and approached with concern: "Director Ma, it's already this late—aren't you going to eat?"

"I'll go in a moment. I can't rest easy until I finish these tasks," Director Ma replied.

"Let me help you," Xiao Luo offered kindly and stayed behind.

After more than an hour of work the official business was finally completed. Director Ma patted Xiao Luo on the shoulder and said, "Young man, you have real drive. Let's go eat together."

Pleased to have earned his superior's approval, Xiao Luo soon found his satisfaction replaced by regret. At the table Director Ma talked nonstop, but every topic concerned the just-finished tasks; he worried that one thing had not been done properly and that another needed supplementation. Finally, setting down his chopsticks, Director Ma patted Xiao Luo again: "Come on, let's go back and revise that plan."

By now the lights were on outside. Xiao Luo wanted only to go home but could not refuse, because a large part of the plan Director Ma mentioned had been prepared with Xiao Luo's help.

Thus the energetic Director Ma dragged the reluctant Xiao Luo back to the office for another night of overtime.

Anyone with a superior like Director Ma would surely complain. Such people are passionate about work, obsessed with scrutinizing details, and hold extremely strict standards for themselves and others, pursuing perfection to a pathological degree. People like Director Ma belong to the obsessive-compulsive personality type.

Of course, obsessive-compulsive personality does not manifest only at work. In every aspect of life, individuals with this personality exhibit compulsive behaviors—for example, having a cleanliness obsession, repeatedly checking whether doors are locked, or recalculating figures on a report multiple times without feeling reassured.

### **Behavioral Manifestations of Obsessive-Compulsive Personality**

1. They possess strong moral and ethical values and a keen sense of responsibility. They show extraordinary focus on matters they deem important and always demand perfection from themselves

with no room for error. They invest excessive time and energy in details such as lists, sequences, reports, and schedules, often neglecting the main objectives of the work.

2. They exercise excessive self-restraint, appear rigid and inflexible, and remain emotionally tense—in other words, they lack a sense of security. They are constantly preparing yet feel uncertain about what they have done; any questioning from others leaves them uneasy.
3. They have almost no hobbies or personal life and few friends. They are reluctant to delegate tasks; even when they do, they impose their own strict rules. If others fail to follow their methods, they become even more anxious and distrustful.
4. People with obsessive-compulsive personality are often stingy and stubborn. They handle matters in an orderly fashion but struggle to accept new things. They also tend to keep childhood belongings and refuse to discard them, even if the items are nothing more than useless scraps of paper.

Obsessive-compulsive personality usually forms in childhood. When parents are overly strict, children often develop cautious and restrained characters. Fear of punishment for mistakes leads them to deliberate repeatedly before acting, creating habitual tension and anxiety that eventually solidify into obsessive-compulsive personality. In addition, children who suffer severe setbacks or stimulation, or whose family members already exhibit compulsive habits, may also develop this personality.

In reality, mild obsessive-compulsive personality is not necessarily a bad thing. The renowned director Stanley Kubrick, for example, had obsessive-compulsive personality, and this trait drove him to make his films more perfect. In China, Stephen Chow also shows this tendency; actors who have worked with him commonly note that his requirements are extremely strict and that he insists others follow his exact specifications, becoming angry at the slightest deviation. Yet it is undeniable that Stephen Chow stands as a monumental figure in the history of Chinese comedic cinema.

Interacting with people who have obsessive-compulsive personality can be taxing, but unlike those with narcissistic personality, they still consider others' feelings to some degree—though they may be unable to open up because of pride or other reasons. Therefore, when dealing with such individuals, it helps to guide them toward opening up or to deliver a blunt "wake-up call" when they become fixated, helping them recognize the flaws in their behavior. Generally, once mutual resonance is achieved, the interaction becomes far less troublesome than expected.

## Penetrating Psychological Weaknesses Through Defense Mechanisms

### **Compensation Mechanism: Those Who Vent Their Anger Must Have a Fragile Heart**

#### **Micro-expression keywords**

Compensation has two sides: one is "I cannot target you, so I target someone else"; the other is "I cannot obtain you, so what I have is not bad either." This is a relatively reasonable way to relieve anxiety.

There is a joke about a father who doted excessively on his son. One day the little fellow mischievously provoked his grandfather, who flew into a rage and gave the boy a thorough beating. The father watched, heart aching, yet dared not intervene. Instead he began slapping his own face. The grandfather, distressed, asked why. The son replied, "You hit my son, so I have to hit your son."

Many people know this joke, yet the term compensatory defense mechanism may be less familiar. The father in the story, seeing his child punished, felt unbearable distress and used self-punishment to shift his emotions while also arousing the grandfather's sympathy.

Such incidents are common in daily life. Another online joke makes a similar point:

A company manager quarreled with his wife early in the morning, then hit traffic and was running late. He ran a red light and was stopped by a traffic officer who issued a ticket.

When he finally reached the office, he saw yesterday's documents still sitting on his desk. Furious, he summoned the secretary and berated her.

The secretary, who had received clear instructions the previous evening, felt wronged but did not dare talk back. After the scolding she took the documents to the reception desk and blamed the receptionist for leaving too early the day before and failing to mail the package.

The bewildered receptionist, seething with anger, spotted the cleaner who had not yet removed some trash and seized the opportunity to reprimand her sharply.

The cleaner, unable to find anyone lower in rank, swallowed her anger and continued working. That evening she returned home, saw her son watching television instead of doing homework, and flew into a rage, scolding him severely.

With no one else to vent on, the son noticed the family's big yellow dog lying by the door and kicked it.

In this chain of bullying, the most pitiful victim was a dog that could not even speak.

Humans seem born to "bully the weak and fear the strong," a habit rooted in our innate compensatory defense mechanism. The mechanism allows people to express rationally suppressed anxiety through a new channel similar to the one originally avoided, thereby restoring psychological balance. In the example above, the manager, secretary, receptionist, cleaner, and the cleaner's son all first wanted to argue with the person who scolded them, yet reason told them the consequences would be severe. They therefore suppressed the impulse and waited for a suitable moment and target.

The "reverse-attitude mechanism" mentioned earlier represents reason's total negation when anxiety arises: losing one's temper in front of a superior is unacceptable, so one must grovel. Reason completely negates and controls the impulse to vent at the superior. Compensatory behavior, by contrast, is an incomplete negation: one cannot lose one's temper at the superior, but one can still take it out on the child at home. Because reason's suppression is incomplete, the compensator does not appear so "two-faced." It can be described as a relatively safe way to transfer anxiety.

Compensatory behavior is equally common in emotional life.

Wu Lili, a freshman, and her classmate Sun Gang discovered on the first day of school that they were from the same hometown and were seated at the same desk. They began to interact more. At first Sun Gang often visited her dorm to chat, repeating seemingly profound yet empty remarks from magazines; these soon won Wu Lili's heart. She fell madly in love with him but, out of shyness, could not speak. Sun Gang remained unaware and treated her with deepening friendship.

He grew increasingly candid with her, even boasting about having seduced the department beauty from another major. Wu Lili suffered in silence yet could not bring herself to cut ties. Eventually Sun Gang turned his attention to Wu Lili's roommate and best friend.

Wu Lili wanted to intervene but found no grounds; as their mutual friend she should even help bring them together. The pain finally prompted her to fix her gaze on another classmate, an ordinary young man. She

began to discover in him several traits that reminded her of Sun Gang: a love of rollerblading, tabletop games, medium-short hair, double eyelids, a preference for single-strap backpacks, a low growl when spitting, and an unconscious twirling of the index finger when hands were clasped.

Wu Lili spent day and night convincing herself that she loved this young man. She carved his name on her desk, painted it on walls, and wrote it in every textbook. Everyone around her said "Lili is deeply in love"...

"I refuse to be anyone's substitute" was once a staple line in romantic soap operas, yet in real relationships it is hard to say that anyone is not someone else's substitute. In the end Wu Lili herself came to believe she loved the young man, while only her unconscious—beyond rational awareness—retained the original impulse of love for Sun Gang.

This behavior of treating X as a substitute for XX is a typical compensatory act.

The idiom "point at the mulberry while cursing the locust tree" and the recently popular "venting centers" in big cities operate on the same principle.

Although compensatory defense mechanisms cannot fulfill the original wish, they produce effects sufficiently similar to the initial goal and quickly release anxiety; therefore they remain one of the defense mechanisms people frequently employ without realizing it.

When discussing compensation, one must mention a variant: the "sweet-lemon mechanism."

A fox that cannot reach the grapes settles for lemons and declares the grapes sour and the lemons sweet. "Sour grapes" is itself a typical variant of compensatory behavior.

When an effective compensatory object is found, typical compensation occurs. When no suitable object appears, another, less typical form of compensation is required to dispel anxiety—the sweet-lemon mechanism.

- A young man with an overweight girlfriend says, "Being thin is useless; it feels bony."
- A young woman with a poor boyfriend says, "Rich men are no good; they're unfaithful."
- Someone who cannot afford a large house says, "A big bedroom is empty and the acoustics are poor."

...All such varied "sour-grapes" statements can be classified as compensatory behavior.

### **Lapse Mechanism: When Reason Fails to Restrain You...**

Micro-expression keywords: When reason proves insufficient to suppress or relieve anxiety, the anxiety slips past rational defenses and manifests in a form contrary to reason, producing lapse behavior. Lapse behavior easily harms the individual and should be avoided whenever possible.

Famous CCTV football commentator Han Qiaosheng is known for his "lapses." Consider some of his unintentionally comical remarks:

- "With the goalkeeper's whistle, the match has ended."
- "Dear viewers, the Mid-Autumn Festival has just passed; I wish you all a belated New Year."
- "Players must strengthen physical fitness and confrontation training in daily practice so they can withstand the intensity of competition; otherwise they will topple like a roly-poly toy at the slightest touch."



- "Foreign players are very professional—for example, Matthäus played a match only three months after his child was born."
- "A few days ago Fan Zhiyi was running a high fever—36.8 °C; goalkeeper Ou Chuliang is 1.82 m tall and weighs 28 kg."
- "Last week a wedding ceremony of a different kind was held."
- "Some viewers may have just turned on the elevator; let us repeat the score..."
- "With pursuers behind and blockers ahead, Baggio dribbled into the penalty area."
- "If this goal counts, it is invalid."
- "Several clubs have expressed interest in buying Piero; Lazio offered 30 million USD, Manchester United a higher bid—28 million USD."
- "Every blade of grass is fiercely contested."
- "One defender has two legs, two defenders have four legs, three defenders have eight legs."
- "Player XX shoots from 30 km away!"
- "With the speed of thunder that cannot cover the ears while stealing a bell."
- "The ball was blocked by the goalkeeper's back leg."
- "The Brazilian defense is composed entirely of Brazilian players."
- "Goalkeeper An Qi participated in this year's World Table Tennis Championships held in Mexico."

Mr. Han's "lapses" have become a style and a trademark whose humorous effect keeps audiences entertained.

Beyond appreciating his humor, we may examine the cause of these lapses.

When objective circumstances produce imbalance, anxiety arises. Reason attempts to suppress it. Successful suppression yields the two-faced behavior of reverse attitude. When suppression is incomplete, lapses occur.

In *Xiang Xing Gu Jian* there is a short story titled "Yang the Evaluator Discerns the Boatman's Crime." Zhao San and Zhou Sheng, both from Huzhou, were close friends who planned to do business together in Nanjing.

At dawn Zhao San rose early, reached the river first, and woke boatman Zhang Chao. Because it was still early, Zhao San dozed in the cabin. Zhang Chao, seeing the large amount of silver Zhao San carried, was seized by greed. While Zhao San slept, Zhang Chao killed him and sank the body in the river.

At daybreak Zhou Sheng arrived at the river and, not seeing Zhao San, asked Zhang Chao to fetch him from home. Zhang Chao knocked on the door and called, "Madam Zhao San, open the door."

Madam Zhao San opened the door, exchanged a few words with Zhang Chao, and remarked in surprise that her husband had already left and should be on the boat by now. Zhang Chao returned and told Zhou Sheng. The two, together with Madam Zhao San, searched everywhere but found no trace of Zhao San. They filed a complaint with the county office.

The county magistrate, knowing the couple had quarreled, suspected Madam Zhao San of murdering her husband but lacked evidence. The case reached the Ministry of Justice. Evaluator Yang of the Court of Judicial Review studied the dossier and declared: "Zhang Chao called for Madam Zhao San, not Zhao San himself, which proves he knew Zhao San was no longer in the house."

On this single point Yang concluded that Zhang Chao was highly suspect. During interrogation Zhang Chao, conscience-stricken, confessed and revealed the details of his crime for money.

Evaluator Yang's ability to read subtle clues commands admiration, while Zhang Chao's "unintentional slip" exposed his guilt and brought him to ruin.

Was Zhang Chao's mistake truly unintentional? More precisely, it should be called an "intentional slip." He had killed Zhao San and knew he must conceal the fact, yet his unconscious had already accepted Zhao San's death as settled; thus the truth leaked out in his later behavior without his awareness.

When reason's "oversight" allows anxiety or unease to surface in an unexpected form, the phenomenon is called the lapse defense mechanism.

In the storytelling work *Northeast King Zhang Zuolin* there is the following episode:

One day Zhang Zuolin attended a gathering of social notables that included many prominent Japanese figures. Knowing Zhang had little education, they deliberately and warmly asked him to write a piece of calligraphy for them, hoping to embarrass him.

Zhang realized it was a trap but had no choice. He stepped to the table, dipped his brush, and wrote a large character "虚" (void). After inspecting it with feigned satisfaction he added his signature and seal.

Just as he was about to feel pleased with himself, his secretary noticed a glaring error: the signature should have read "Zhang Zuolin's hand-brushed ink," yet Zhang had mistakenly written "Zhang Zuolin's hand-black." The Japanese guests looked puzzled.

Realizing the blunder and unable to correct it, Zhang found himself in an awkward position. The interpreter quickly whispered, "Marshal, the signature reads 'hand-black' instead of 'hand-brushed ink'; the character for 'earth' is missing."

Zhang had a flash of inspiration. He slammed the table with his fist and pretended to scold the interpreter: "Damn it! Do you think I don't know there's an 'earth' under 'ink'? But this piece was requested by the Japanese, so not an inch of earth will be yielded!"

The coarse remark drew thunderous applause from the Chinese guests present.

In terms of defense mechanisms, lapses and reverse attitudes are classic counter-examples. Reverse attitude arises when accumulated anxiety produces a resistant defense against reason; lapse occurs when anxiety, unease, or reluctance slips past reason's guard and finds expression. People may be aware of their reverse-attitude defenses, yet before a lapse occurs they can take no preventive action.

Lapse defense mechanisms commonly appear as slips of the tongue or other errors. Saying "the meeting is over" when one meant "the meeting begins," or leaving an unfinished report at home, are both manifestations of the lapse defense mechanism.

Individuals who frequently experience lapses generally suffer from poor concentration. The conflict between unconscious and conscious mind makes them more prone than others to escape reality and to rationalize their behavior. Analysis of lapse behavior readily reveals a person's true inner thoughts; most often, the unintentional slip expresses what the person actually wanted to say.

### **Daydreaming: The Mental Sanctuary for Those with Unfulfilled Desires**

Daydreaming is in fact a form of escape, and while this escape can provide significant relief from anxiety, when the relief becomes addictive, a person easily falls into inescapable erotic fantasy.

Xiao Hua was a quiet and somewhat introverted child. Recently, a group of delinquent youths several years older than him had moved into the alley near his home. Every day they blocked him at the alley entrance and

“squeezed a little spending money” out of him.

Timid Xiao Hua, under coercion, dared not tell his parents or his teachers. He could only endure in silence, and when he cried alone he would fantasize that one day he suddenly gained superpowers. Then, when the youths bullied him, he would erupt and beat them until they were groveling on the ground...

In this way, although he continued to be bullied, Xiao Hua could find “self-consolation” in fantasy.

Situations like Xiao Hua’s are not uncommon. When people encounter something they cannot achieve or feel crushed by external pressure, in order to maintain a certain physiological and psychological balance, those intense, repressed instinctual desires are discharged in a manner detached from reality yet still controllable by consciousness. This is what we ordinarily call daydreaming.

Everyone has daydreamed, yet few realize that daydreaming is itself a defense mechanism—a defensive process in which unfulfilled desires from reality are consoled through fantasy, thereby restoring psychological equilibrium.

Daydreaming is based on fantasy and, to a certain extent, aligns closely with the needs of certain professions. The renowned psychologist Freud made an interesting claim: artistic creation is essentially an act of daydreaming. Ordinary people have a daydream and then move on, but artists differ in that they write their daydreams onto manuscript paper or paint them onto canvases, allowing those daydreams to circulate widely and be shared with all readers.

At this point we must mention the currently popular online “YY” novels. Although YY novels do not reach the level of art, they embody daydreaming even more explicitly than art does. “YY” is taken from the pinyin initials of “意淫” (yì yín), and conceptually “意淫” is indistinguishable from daydreaming.

Is this phenomenon unique to China? Of course not.

In the United States, young people are obsessed with superheroes. The two most famous teams are the Justice League—featuring Superman, Spider-Man, Batman, the Flash, and Green Lantern—and the Avengers—featuring Captain America, Iron Man, the Hulk, Hawkeye, Black Widow, and Thor.

These superheroes either possess superpowers or have developed a single outstanding talent to its utmost. Their moves and skills differ, and their personalities vary widely, yet they are all good people who perform morally upright deeds.

The true homeland of anime, however, is Japan. Japanese anime style is more distinctive and better suited to Eastern aesthetics; feminine beauty is exaggerated to the extreme. Most anime beauties, for example, have large eyes that occupy a quarter of the face and deep, attractive pupils even without colored contact lenses.

Combined with stirring, heartfelt plots and vivid character personalities, a large number of Japanese people have become hopelessly immersed in the world of manga. They even regard the real world as fake and believe true love exists only in the “2D realm.” “2D realm” is their term for the anime world, and such people call themselves otaku. The words “otaku male” and “otaku female” originated this way.

Lacking the strength to confront reality and unable to resolve anxiety through reason, people place themselves in an illusory world to alleviate anxiety and become addicted. This is why fantasy-oriented literary and artistic works have become so prevalent.

Occasionally daydreaming is harmless; it helps relax body and mind, relieves real-world pressure, and can expand imaginative capacity. Yet because the psychological satisfaction fantasy can provide is very limited, if a person relies excessively on the daydreaming defense mechanism and cannot convert it into reality, neural pathology or mental distortion and perversion may result.

In the mid-Qing dynasty, after Cao Xueqin wrote *Dream of the Red Chamber*, Gao E completed it and a major bookseller published the work, which quickly became popular throughout the empire. Many lovelorn men and women became obsessed. It is said that in the prosperous regions of Jiangnan, *Red Chamber* fans split into two factions—one favoring Lin Daiyu, the other Xue Baochai—and the two sides frequently clashed in street fights...

An even more curious anecdote occurred in the north. A young lady from an official family obtained a copy of *Dream of the Red Chamber* from a close friend. She opened the first page, began reading, and became enchanted. From then on her only pastime was staring into space. While other young ladies' boudoirs contained needlework and rouge, hers was filled with every edition of the novel. Conservative estimates suggest that even the late Redology master Zhou Ruchang's collection of *Dream of the Red Chamber* editions did not amount to half the number this young lady possessed.

In the blink of an eye, while daydreaming and lost in reverie, the young lady reached the age of twenty. "A twenty-year-old daughter still unmarried" was an unequivocal insult in ancient times, because women of that era typically gave birth for the first time between the ages of fifteen and sixteen. The young lady was now twenty and had never been touched by a man; all sorts of rumors began to circulate.

Yet the entire household understood that she was simply addicted to *Dream of the Red Chamber*, and the whole estate grew anxious. Her father tried every method, even summoning shamans and diviners, but nothing worked. Once he grasped the crux of the problem, he decided to administer a "strong medicine" to rescue his daughter.

One day he brought several servants, lured her to the front hall, had them search her boudoir for every copy of the novel, and piled them in the courtyard to be burned to ashes. The commotion naturally alarmed the young lady. She ran into the courtyard, saw her beloved books about to be incinerated, and tried to throw herself into the flames. Had the servants and maids not restrained her, it would have been a real-life case of the moth flying into the fire.

Watching the copies of *Dream of the Red Chamber* burn away, the young lady cried out in grief, "Why burn my Baoyu?" and fainted.

For the next several days she drifted between sleep and wakefulness, unable to eat or drink, growing thinner by the day. Her parents watched with aching hearts, yet they knew that emotional ailments require emotional remedies. They spared no effort to gather several editions of the novel for her. Only after reading them did her furrowed brows gradually relax and her health return.

### **Counter-Attitude Mechanism: The Two-Faced Person Bound by Rationality**

Micro-expression keywords: Because the object of discharge in the counter-attitude mechanism is not the direct source of anxiety, counter-attitude often fails to vent anxiety completely. If one continues down this path, extreme, pathological, or perverse counter-attitude behavior may develop.

Xiao Wang, who had just obtained his driver's license, took his friends for a drive in his new car, but was stopped by a traffic officer at an intersection.

"You violated traffic regulations. Please hand over your license," the officer said politely, extending his hand.

"I just got my license. Please be lenient—don't deduct any points," Xiao Wang said with a smile, pulling several hundred yuan from his wallet instead of his license.

"Stop the nonsense. Give me the license."

"There aren't many officers as upright as you these days." Seeing that bribery failed, Xiao Wang reluctantly produced his license. As he handed it over he flattered the officer: "It really wasn't intentional. Please go easy on me. I'll be more careful from now on..."

Taking back his license, Xiao Wang watched the officer walk away and spat heavily on the ground. "Pah! What a piece of work..."

Such scenes are commonplace. Drivers stopped by traffic police, subordinates dealing with nitpicking bosses, and criminals facing escorting officers all display outward compliance while harboring intense inner resentment. In the catalog of defense mechanisms, this behavior pattern has a specific name: "counter-attitude."

When awake, people remain rational; reason suppresses anger so that, in threatening situations, one does not suddenly explode into attack or other destructive acts. Yet the repressed anxiety and anger remain "stored" in the brain. Through powerful mental investment they produce a reaction formation, causing one to exhibit behavior diametrically opposed to one's true feelings. This is how the counter-attitude defense mechanism arises.

Old Lady Pang had six children. After she raised them with great effort, each started a family and began to neglect her. At first they visited infrequently; later they sent less and less living expenses. For several years the old lady voiced many complaints, yet she dared not fall out with her children because she would need their support in old age.

A few years later the children had offspring of their own but were too busy with work, so they entrusted the grandchildren to the old lady. Having toiled half her life, she had hoped to enjoy a quiet old age, but she could not refuse her children's requests and reluctantly began caring for the grandchildren.

Thus the following scene emerged: when the children were absent, Old Lady Pang was neither indifferent nor particularly affectionate toward the grandchildren; she often treated them coldly. Yet the moment her children appeared, her attitude toward the grandchildren executed a 180-degree turn. She smiled benevolently, inquired after their well-being, and played the role of the kindly elder to perfection.

Children's hearts are sensitive, however. After growing up, the grandchildren never developed deep affection for Old Lady Pang, even though she had raised them for several years.

As Old Lady Pang aged and became frail, she could no longer live independently and began rotating among her children's homes. Each household had its own life; although they treated her decently, they could not devote excessive attention. The old lady harbored grievances about this attitude but dared not voice them.

She did, however, dare to criticize one child in front of the others, so that every child came to believe he or she was filial while the siblings were not. Over time the estrangement deepened until several violent confrontations occurred. After Old Lady Pang's death the children never visited one another again; the family became complete strangers.

Old Lady Pang was dissatisfied with her children, yet reason told her that an open rupture would make her final years miserable. Therefore reason imposed a constraint: no matter how much she wished to complain, she must not do so in her children's presence. When the children were absent, she was less kind to the grandchildren—sometimes even unkind—thereby compensating for the subservience she displayed before her children.

In the 1940s, China's finest actor, the "King of Spoken Drama" Shi Hui, played the lead role in the celebrated film *This Life of Mine*—a humble patrolman in the old society.

In the film, his most brilliant extreme performances almost all embody "counter-attitude behavior": in front of dignitaries, an exaggerated, false smile, bowing at the waist, ready at the slightest misstep to slap his own face; when the powerful walked, he would fussily sweep the dust from the ground before them. The instant the dignitaries left his sight, the patrolman's expression changed instantly—he spat, cursed, and uttered every form of belittlement.

Shi Hui's method of character portrayal was hailed as a classic.

This pattern of one face in front of people and another behind their backs is typical counter-attitude behavior. In this case, what merits attention is the patrolman's dramatically exaggerated performance before the powerful.

Because the counter-attitude defense mechanism forces reason to suppress anxious emotions, individuals employing it often display obvious exaggeration and compulsiveness. They frequently speak glibly, repeatedly profess their sincerity in an inflated manner, and when smiling their facial muscles stiffen or tremble involuntarily, accompanied by blinking, nose wrinkling, and similar movements.

Thus, outward compliance does not necessarily indicate heartfelt conviction; it may stem from an inner counter-attitude defense mechanism driven by anger and resistance. In general, people who frequently exhibit the counter-attitude defense mechanism are also prone to lying, denial, and shifting responsibility in daily life. What we ordinarily call "one face in front, another behind" largely refers to this type.

### **Projection Mechanism: Criticizing Others Is Criticizing Yourself**

Micro-expression keywords: People who habitually use the projection mechanism to displace anxiety may not be morally corrupt, but they can certainly be called unprincipled. Therefore, to avoid becoming a slave to the projection mechanism, recognizing one's own desires is essential.

In a village beside the Yellow River lived two widows whose husbands had died in a natural disaster several years earlier. Both women were young and reasonably attractive, so their private lives gradually became less restrained.

The two widows did not live close to each other, so although they sometimes shared the same lovers, they managed to coexist without incident.

Then a university graduate arrived in the village. He had graduated from a prestigious teachers' college and came to teach English at the town's only middle school. Because the village was near the town and the English teacher preferred quiet, he moved into the village.

The teacher stood 184 centimeters tall, had fair skin, and a fine physique. Both widows immediately took notice and began courting him with attentiveness and flirtatious glances. In the end, Widow Zhang succeeded

in luring the teacher into her bed.

Widow Li was furious when she learned of this and began spreading rumors about Widow Zhang throughout the village—claiming she was a husband-killer, that she was promiscuous, that she changed men every night...

When the teacher heard these rumors, he began to believe them and left Widow Zhang. Widow Zhang discovered the reason, became equally enraged, and started spreading similar gossip about Widow Li. As the two women slandered each other, their reputations deteriorated...

When people experience unfulfilled desires because of rational control, they adopt this defensive posture: they externalize anxiety in the form of deliberate emphasis, accusation, or slander and direct it at someone whose behavior resembles the action their own reason has forbidden.

The “chief culprit” behind the projection defense mechanism is usually a life impulse repressed in the unconscious. For example, a person may wish to curry favor with a superior but, lacking sufficient social skill or thick skin, bungles the attempt. Upon seeing colleagues who have won the superior’s favor, the person openly expresses disdain, calling them sycophants or flatterers, without realizing they have done the same thing themselves.

In other words, the projection defense mechanism uses criticism of others’ behavior to exonerate oneself and to dispel the anxiety and unease that cling to the unconscious in opposition to reason and moral sense. People who employ projection generally conceal or disguise their own private matters—the root of their anxiety—and present them from another person’s perspective, openly criticizing or expressing contempt in order to satisfy their unconscious sense of morality and justice.

In the Qing-dynasty scholar Yu Yue’s *Miscellaneous Compilations from Yu Garden* there is a short anecdote about a capital official about to be transferred to a provincial post. Before departing, he paid a special farewell visit to his teacher’s residence.

The teacher was delighted to see his prized student and asked, “What preparations have you made for this journey?”

The official replied, “I have prepared one hundred tall hats; whenever I encounter difficulty, I will present one to the person involved.”

The teacher was displeased and scolded him: “We are men of integrity; how can we engage in such crooked practices?”

The official remained calm and answered, “Teacher is correct, yet how many people in today’s world are as upright as you?”

Hearing this, the teacher’s anger turned to pleasure. “You are right; there are indeed few upright people under heaven.”

After leaving his teacher’s residence, the official laughed to his attendants: “Of the one hundred tall hats I originally prepared, only ninety-nine remain.”

Any discerning reader can see that the teacher in the anecdote was himself fond of wearing tall hats and hearing flattery. Yet his high position and role as a mentor prevented him from displaying this trait openly. He therefore employed the projection defense mechanism, declaring that he detested the crooked practices of other officials—only to reveal his true nature and give himself away.

The same holds true in daily life. Men who constantly proclaim they "defend women's rights" are often the most chauvinistic; people who declare "I most hate those who speak ill of others behind their backs" are often the most fond of spreading gossip; those who claim "corrupt officials are the most detestable" may, once in office, prove even more rapacious than the officials they once despised. Such behaviors are frequently the work of the projection defense mechanism.

Although not every act of projection appears so despicable, in most cases projection is unprincipled and, within the framework of public morality, even pernicious.

During World War II, in order to sustain a massive three-front war and realize Hitler's personal delusion of world domination, Germany requisitioned every available resource. Consequently, although Nazi Germany possessed the greatest controllable resources of any nation, its people still went hungry and threadbare because of the war.

To strengthen unity and requisition still more resources, Hitler and Goebbels promoted the notorious slogan "Tanks, not bread." Countless Germans began to starve while producing weapons.

At the same time, the entire Nazi Party leadership set an example, with reports daily describing how high- and mid-level officials responded to the Führer's call by practicing frugality. Many officials personally testified, denouncing those "heartless rich who refuse to economize."

In reality, a considerable number of these ostensibly austere Nazi high officials were merely performing. They spent at least half of every year vacationing in villas along the Seine in France, surrounded by several beautiful women, drinking rare wines, and listening to French musicians—now reduced to slaves of a conquered nation—perform the Eroica Symphony...

### **Defense Mechanisms: The "Converter" of Emotional Stress**

Micro-expression keywords: Defense mechanisms originate from people's self-protection mechanisms, avoiding excessive anxiety and repression in one's mind due to shocks. Understanding defense mechanisms is of extremely important significance for judging others' behaviors and even psychological activities.

In the Old Testament of the Bible, there is this legend:

To test the prophet Abraham's loyalty to him, God asked him to offer his only son Isaac as a sacrifice. When Abraham took Isaac to the altar and raised his knife to kill his son, God, moved by his loyalty, sent an angel to stop him. At that moment, a stray goat passed by on the roadside. Abraham led the goat over and offered it in place of Isaac.

This legend was passed down and inherited by ancient Judaism. During annual sacrifices, the high priest of ancient Judaism would bring a goat, place his hands on its head to signify entrusting the sins of the entire nation to the animal, then drive it into the wilderness to fend for itself, thereby cleansing the nation's sins.

Most people find this allusion familiar; it is what we commonly call a "scapegoat." In life, a scapegoat often refers to a pitiful, unfortunate person who suffers in another's place. In reality, however, our brains also possess this "scapegoat" mechanism.

This mechanism is called a defense mechanism, also known as a displacement mechanism.

When humans face setbacks, conflicts, or other tense situations, they experience negative emotions such as anxiety and distress. These negative emotions may be temporarily suppressed, yet until they are released, they



continue to disturb the subconscious. To avoid this interference, people consciously or unconsciously tend to restore psychological balance and stability.

Defense mechanisms operate on this principle. To prevent excessive accumulation of anxious emotions from creating mental barriers between the subconscious and conscious mind, people transform repressed anxiety into another form and project it back into real life. In short, a defense mechanism is the body's "firewall" that displaces anxiety into other forms of release, preventing psychological problems.

Defense mechanisms appear everywhere in daily life. For example, a child breaks expensive dishes during the New Year. The parents feel distressed but, given the festive occasion, cannot scold the child outright, so they console themselves with "peace every year" (a pun on "broken every year"). This is a typical defense mechanism.

Another example: a wife sees her mother-in-law soil the new bedsheets but cannot confront her directly, so she vents her anger on her husband for forgetting to change his slippers at the door. The husband cannot understand why an occasional occurrence provokes such fury today.

A few years ago, an astonishing scene unfolded in a building in Xidan, Beijing: a middle-aged man in a sweatshirt, dressed like a migrant worker, flung a thick stack of hundred-yuan notes at a sales clerk, then pulled out a large pair of scissors, cut a set of expensive Armani suits into strips, and strode away disdainfully.

Media outlets followed up on the incident. Investigations revealed that the man came from a rural area. Before reaching adulthood, he had joined a village construction crew to "make a living" in the big city, enduring hardships and the snobbery of others. Later, through skill and boldness, he rose to the position of "crew leader." He then connected with a major construction company and began trading building materials. Step by step, over decades, he became a multimillionaire. Yet the cold treatment and humiliation he suffered in his youth remained deeply rooted in his heart.

He often wore shabby clothes while browsing luxury malls. That day, at the Armani counter, the sales clerk sharply rebuked him: "Can you afford this? Don't touch it—you couldn't pay for the damage if you soiled it!"

What followed was the scene described above.

Some called the man a show-off; others said he was psychologically twisted. In truth, this was merely a common manifestation of a defense mechanism. Although wealthy, the man's mind remained filled with the shadows of his youth. These shadows prevented him from integrating into so-called "high society," so he devised this method to elicit others' astonished gazes, release his inner knots, and gain momentary satisfaction.

Defense mechanisms are a natural human response to self-protection; therefore, the vast majority are displayed unconsciously. This is precisely why we emphasize them in this book. The psychological activities we observe through conversation or other means may have been carefully disguised by others and are difficult to verify. Reactions produced by defense mechanisms, however, are unconscious actions. In other words, judging human psychology through defense mechanisms more easily reaches the root of the mind.

Because individuals differ in personality and habits, each person's defense mechanisms manifest differently. The following chapters will detail the ten common types of defense mechanisms to give readers a deeper understanding.

## **Sublimation Mechanism: Memoirs of the Bittersweet Past of Successful People**

Micro-expression keywords: The sublimation mechanism not only benefits oneself but also benefits the entire society and even humanity. To become a better person, sublimate!

There is a fable about a man who, whenever he got angry, would run three laps around his house and land. After sweating profusely, his anger would subside.

Thanks to his good temper and exceptional mind, his land and house grew larger and larger, yet his habit of running three laps around his property when angry never changed, even into his eighties.

His grandson was puzzled and asked, "Grandfather, whenever you are unhappy, you run around the house and land. Is there a secret to this?"

"There is," the old man replied. "When I was young and quarreled or got angry, I would run around my house. As I ran, I would think: my land is still so small, my house so tiny—I have no time to be angry with others. It is better to use that energy for work and study."

"Then why do you still run around the land now that you are so wealthy?" the grandson asked, still confused.

The old man smiled. "Even in old age, one cannot avoid anger. As I run, I think: I already own such vast land and so many houses—why haggle with others? At that thought, my anger disappears."

The anxiety in this man's mind was clearly anger arising from conflict with others. He transformed that anger into a pursuit of success and wealth, using it as motivation to achieve goals others could not reach. This exemplifies the sublimation defense mechanism.

Many renowned writers and composers produced immortal works through the sublimation defense mechanism. Austrian composer Schubert suffered repeated heartbreak; emotional setbacks left him despondent yet also stimulated his creativity and imagination. During his fifteen-year creative career, Schubert wrote more than a thousand pieces. He himself said, "The works I wrote in the deepest pain are the ones most appreciated by the world."

French writer Romain Rolland, likewise tormented by lost love, swore "I shall create or die" to escape the pain and spent ten years writing the epic *Jean-Christophe*.

For these composers and literary giants, trauma was not a quagmire but a driving force. With the sublimation defense mechanism, every wound became a benchmark and footprint of progress and success.

Truly happy people do not generate sublimation defense mechanisms. Only those whose instinctive desires remain unsatisfied develop powerful inner drive from unfulfilled life impulses, achieving remarkable sublimated results.

There is a saying that anger produces poets, but I believe suffering produces poets.

Qu Yuan loved the state of Chu, yet corrupt officials and a foolish ruler held power. From this pain came the timeless *Li Sao*, *Nine Songs*, and China's first ultimate interrogation, *Heavenly Questions*.

Li Bai devoted his life to politics but was treated by Emperor Xuanzong merely as a favored courtier. His apparent glory masked deep frustration. Later he wandered destitute and nearly faced imprisonment. This suffering turned him into the brightest note in Tang poetry.

Ten years younger than Li Bai, Du Fu spent his life without a fixed home, which produced the accusatory "Three Officers" and "Three Partings."

Li Yu, the last ruler of Southern Tang, possessed outstanding talent while ruling Jiangnan and enjoying the company of the two Zhou sisters, yet his early ci poems rarely moved readers. Only after Zhao Guangyi captured him and repeatedly humiliated his wife did intense suffering produce the line: "How much sorrow can one man bear? It is like a river of spring water flowing east."

Foreign poets followed the same pattern.

T. S. Eliot could not escape self-doubt and spent his life casting himself into this abyss, writing "We are the hollow men."

W. B. Yeats's lifelong love regarded him only as a friend; he wrote plaintively that others loved her for her charming demeanor, youthful beauty, or with true or false hearts—only one loved her pilgrim soul.

Dylan Thomas, at his father's deathbed, roared his grief: "Do not go gentle into that good night. Rage, rage against the dying of the light."

The opening line of the programmatic long poem of the American Beat Generation reads: "I saw the best minds of my generation destroyed by madness, starving hysterical naked, dragging themselves through the negro streets at dawn looking for an angry fix." Its author, Allen Ginsberg, admitted there was no Beat Generation—only a group of young people who wanted enough to eat and to publish their work.

Behind the sublimation mechanism lies an act of abandonment: when desires are repressed and cannot be satisfied or released, anxiety arises. Intense pain then prompts people to abandon that anxiety and seek higher pursuits aligned with universal values. This is sublimation.

Sublimation helps those trapped in anxiety escape their predicament and carries great positive significance for society. To put it strongly, human history has been driven by people who abandoned personal anxiety to achieve individual sublimation.

## **Revealing Others' Psychological Motivations Through Cognitive Dissonance**

### **Micro-expression keywords**

Conflicting cognitions are an original driving force in our psychology. The process in which people, in order to reduce conflicts between cognitions and balance the gap in their hearts, force themselves to accept or seek new concepts, is called the self-balancing of cognitive dissonance.

In the 1950s, Marian Keech, leader of a UFO doomsday cult, prophesied that her followers would be taken away by an alien spaceship on the night of December 20, after which the end of the world would arrive.

Many followers believed her and even quit their jobs to wait at home for the end. At midnight, the followers gathered at the designated spot, awaiting the spaceship.

At midnight exactly, there was no sign of the spaceship; the followers grew slightly tense. By two o'clock it still had not come, and unease spread. After four o'clock, as panic set in, Ms. Keech appeared and told them: "Because of your devotion, the world has been redeemed."

In other words, the followers' faith and waiting had postponed doomsday. This was clearly an absurd lie, yet the waiting followers did not question Keech. Instead, they excitedly ran into the streets to proselytize, telling everyone that the aliens had been moved by their positive efforts and enthusiasm and had spared Earth.

When a person is deceived, the first reaction should be anger.

Yet why did these UFO doomsday cultists become even more devout after being deceived?

To understand this, we must examine the concept of cognitive dissonance proposed by American psychologist Leon Festinger in his book *When Prophecy Fails*.

Cognitive dissonance refers to the uncomfortable feeling triggered when one performs an action inconsistent with one's attitude—that is, when an individual recognizes two conflicting attitudes or a contradiction between attitude and behavior. This contradiction usually produces psychological tension. To overcome it, people employ various methods to reduce the discomfort.

Old Wang had been a heavy smoker for nearly ten years. Recently, after a big argument with his wife, he resolved to quit.

Yet only two days into his resolution, at a class reunion, an old classmate casually offered him a cigarette.

To smoke or not to smoke?

Watching his classmates puffing away, Old Wang felt tempted, but he shook his head and refused: "No thanks, I've quit."

"Come on, if you can quit smoking, I can quit eating," the classmate said, stuffing the cigarette into Old Wang's hand without another word.

Holding the burning cigarette, Old Wang hesitated, then finally lit it with determination.

It seemed he still liked smoking. Even if not for stress relief, there were so many occasions in life that called for it. He could only smoke less. From now on, when offered a cigarette, he would refuse if possible; if not, he would smoke.

Old Wang's psychological shift illustrates cognitive dissonance. His original intention to quit clashed with the behavior of accepting and smoking the cigarette offered by his classmate. To balance the discrepancy, he supplied himself with four justifications—"I still like smoking," "to relieve stress," "there are so many occasions in life that call for it," and "refuse when possible, smoke only when unavoidable"—thereby convincing himself to enjoy the cigarette with a clear conscience.

The UFO doomsday cultists behaved similarly. Their own faith and the subsequent outcome created a psychological gap of "failed expectations." To balance this gap, they had to persuade themselves to believe Ms. Keech's words, resulting in even more fanatical devotion.

Festinger argued that every person's cognitive structure, or psychological space, consists of various cognitive elements. These elements are independent and relative. Once two cognitive elements in a person's mind conflict, cognitive dissonance arises. As dissonance increases, the psychological pressure to reduce or eliminate it grows accordingly.

Cognitive dissonance theory also holds that cognition and behavior are necessarily linked: only after behavior changes does cognition change; cognitive dissonance serves merely as an intermediary. The reason people alter their cognition and balance dissonance is ultimately to provide a rationale for their behavior, rendering it reasonable. Neither Old Wang the smoker nor the fervent cultists escape this pattern.

Therefore, when we notice someone whose words and actions contradict each other or whose attitudes and behaviors differ sharply, we can carefully observe their actions and apply behavioral psychology for analysis. It

is then easy to identify the cause of their cognitive dissonance.

Such examples are common in life. Subordinates who privately despise their incompetent superiors—believing they hold their positions only through power—still act obsequious and deferential in front of those superiors. This is a typical case of cognitive dissonance.

## **Eliminating Regretful Emotions, Letting Go of Inner Burdens**

Everyone's life has a gap that follows them like a shadow throughout their life. For regrets in life, it is better to accept them with ease and let go of the inner burdens, so that one can cherish everything one has more.

Singaporean singer Xu Meijing has a song called "Regret," which contains these lines: "Stop saying whose fault it is, let everything turn to ash. Unless you let go of the inner burdens, everything will be irretrievable. You always let the past follow you, afraid that the past was in vain..." Regret is actually the feeling of regret when one hopes to do something or is about to do it but ultimately fails to do it, or the feeling of regret when one strives bravely for an ideal but ultimately fails to achieve it.

In life, one inevitably encounters some regrettable things. If we bury regrets in our hearts, over time they accumulate, and we will sink into a quagmire of vanishing willpower from which we cannot extricate ourselves, falling into an abyss of mental lethargy from which we cannot escape. Therefore, we should eliminate regretful emotions so that we can maintain psychological balance.

So how can we eliminate regretful emotions? Here are several methods:

### **1. Accept the Facts**

William James once said: "To be willing to admit that things are as they are, to be able to accept what has already happened, is the first step in overcoming any misfortune." Missed time is gone forever. Since it has become fact and cannot be changed, what else can one do besides calmly accepting it?

The TV drama *Half a Lifetime's Fate* introduces a pair of truly loving lovers who, under the tricks of fate, go their separate ways. When they meet again years later, the two are in great pain, full of remorse, left only with regret. Perhaps the greatest regret in the world is that two people in love cannot hold hands for a lifetime, but since it has already happened, one can only accept the facts rather than live in regret and fantasy.

### **2. Accept One's Imperfect Self**

We always overemphasize shame and guilt while neglecting the importance of acceptance and forgiveness. Admittedly, shame and guilt are very important to the individual, but they must never become shackles that kidnap one's inner self. This is like going to church to confess, unloading one's burdens through confession and, to some extent, gaining forgiveness for oneself.

No one wants to wallow in self-blame; everyone needs to continue living and pursue happiness. From this perspective, accepting one's imperfect self is necessary, because life has no perfection to speak of. Perfection exists only in ideals. Regrets are everywhere in life; this is real life.

### **3. Learn from One's Mistakes**

"The tree wants to be still, but the wind does not stop; the child wants to care for parents, but they are no longer there." When children wish to fulfill their filial duties, their parents have already passed away. This must be considered one of life's great regrets.

Confucius heard someone crying in extreme grief, so he found the person and asked: "Could it be that there has been a death in your family? Otherwise, why are you crying so sorrowfully?"

The person replied: "I have made three mistakes in my life. When I was young, I traveled the states in pursuit of learning and did not put caring for my family first—that is the first. In pursuit of my ideals, I served the ruler and did not show filial piety to my parents—that is the second. I was close with friends but distant with family—that is the third. The tree wants to be still, but the wind does not stop; the child wants to care for parents, but the parents are no longer in this world. Let me leave this world from now on!" With that, he died.

Confucius said to his disciples: "You should take this as a warning. I hope this matter will help you understand some truths." As a result, three-tenths of his disciples chose to leave and return home to care for their parents.

Regarding life's regrets, Bill Gates has a classic metaphor: "Life is like a big fire. The only thing each of us can do is salvage a little more from this fire." So having regrets is not terrible; what is terrible is failing to learn from them and letting them repeat over and over.

#### **4. Think More About the Positive Meaning of Regret**

Regret can also bring us gains. For example, it can increase life experience, broaden horizons, accumulate knowledge, help us recognize our own shortcomings, and prompt us to become better versions of ourselves. For instance, after experiencing the regret of "the child wants to care for parents, but they are no longer there," one will inevitably understand the importance of family ties and value relationships with relatives and friends more.

#### **5. Do Not Cling to the Past**

People with regrets in their hearts often say "If only..." or "Why didn't I back then..." Saying these things is useless and only adds to the sadness. Lost time cannot be recovered; the life one has lived cannot be relived. If one remains immersed in memories, one will lose the good mood of the present and miss more beauty. So for things that have already happened, do not cling to them. Let what is past pass!

### **Taking All Blame: Blindly Assuming Fault Leads to Overwhelming Burden**

Taking all blame makes a person feel extreme guilt. Because of a strong sense of responsibility, they shoulder the entire world and ultimately become overwhelmed, unable to breathe.

Do you often feel dissatisfied with yourself and like to say to yourself "I should..." or "If only..."? For example: "If I hadn't said in front of him that this major has good prospects, maybe he wouldn't have chosen the wrong one when filling out his application." "It's all my fault. If I hadn't called him then, he wouldn't have answered while driving and wouldn't have gotten into the accident." Many people fall into the thinking trap of taking all blame because they keep using the "if... then..." way of thinking. The harm of this thinking trap is that it exists only in subjective reasoning and severely undermines a person's confidence.

People who like to take all blame always shoulder the responsibility for things themselves, and their hearts are filled with guilt, self-blame, regret, and other emotions. Psychology calls this phenomenon "guilt." It often arises because we feel responsible for something we did or something we said, thinking we should not have done or said it. The reason guilt is so harmful is that what we criticize is often not only our individual actions but our entire person.

Ms. Guo's younger brother suddenly jumped to his death at home. This caused Ms. Guo great pain, but what pained her even more was that she felt his death was related to her. To prove her guess was correct, she found many irrefutable reasons. Deep guilt tormented her every day, making her wish she were dead. She often blamed herself: "I'm so useless, so stupid! How could I not have stopped this? How could I not have seen that he wanted to commit suicide? I even talked to him yesterday; I shouldn't have said that. I indirectly killed him!"

Ms. Guo is a typical case of taking all blame. Because of distorted thinking, she blindly guessed the cause of her brother's death and felt she was the trigger for his suicide. However, no one has the ability to foresee the future; otherwise, they would certainly find ways to prevent the tragedy. In other words, she should not blame herself for her brother's death; that is illogical. She should not think she should be responsible for her brother's emotions and behavior, because these were not within her control.

Self-blame adds a burden to our minds and subjects us to the torment of guilt and shame. Therefore, we need to strengthen self-awareness and say goodbye to thinking patterns like "I should..." and "I really regret..." When facing things that cause self-blame, we should make objective evaluations, point out our own responsibilities factually, and not blindly exaggerate our responsibility or shoulder responsibilities that are not ours.

If one feels overwhelmed from blindly assuming fault, the following methods can be used to relieve the inner burden.

### 1. Do Some Things You Want to Do

Shift attention away from things that cause self-blame and do things you want to do, especially ideas hidden deep in your heart, such as traveling somewhere, meeting someone you have always wanted to meet, watching a movie you have really wanted to see, and so on. Make sure you can devote yourself fully without caring about results or achievements, because doing something you are interested in is itself a very meaningful thing.

Psychologists have found that being able to devote oneself fully to something one likes can eliminate people's dissatisfaction. Psychology calls this state "flow." In this state, people forget all their troubles and even forget themselves.

### 2. Recognize One's Own Limitations

No one is omnipotent; everyone makes various mistakes, so there is no need to blame oneself excessively. A bad outcome may have been caused by you, but more likely it was caused by a combination of various factors, so there is no need to bear full responsibility for one's mistakes.

### 3. Recognize That Many Outcomes Cannot Be Changed

Recognize that many outcomes cannot be changed. Therefore, guilt is only a negative solution. A more effective solution is to recognize the mistake, analyze the mistake, distinguish one's own responsibilities from others', and not shoulder all the blame oneself.

### 4. Do Everything Possible to Help Others

The "helping others" mentioned here does not mean only focusing on others' needs and giving unconditionally, but investing one's enthusiasm and doing everything possible to help others. Doing so can give you a sense of satisfaction. A group in the United States surveyed thousands of members of social rescue

organizations, asking what they gained from serving others. Their answers were strikingly consistent: "spiritual pleasure and a sense of fulfillment."

### **Overgeneralization: A Single Setback Leads to Complete Collapse**

Negative people, even after encountering a single setback, will overgeneralize it as caused by their own lack of ability, thereby completely denying their own abilities and value and falling into despair.

On the road of life, occasional failure is inevitable, but failure is only a moment in our lives; the past and future are not included. If you therefore regard yourself as a worthless person and collapse from then on, you have fallen into the erroneous thinking of overgeneralization. Once your brain is filled with such negative thoughts, more negative emotions will follow, leaving you breathless.

Some people lack confidence because they feel inferior to others in certain areas and never dare to try new things. Some become despondent when a partner leaves and lose faith in love. Some become depressed because of career setbacks and even choose to end their lives to escape this negative emotion.

Severe frustration causes strong psychological reactions and brings enormous pressure. If a person is tormented by this for a long time, physical and mental health will be damaged, and the person will become decadent, depressed, and even collapse completely. At this time, many people become indignant, habitually blame others for mistakes and failures, and even become cold and heartless, treating life and work with a cynical attitude, without knowing how to reflect on themselves. In extreme cases, they may even become mentally deranged and develop psychological disorders.

A young man who had a breakup could not escape the blow of lost love. He gradually became emotionally low, which affected his normal life and made it impossible for him to concentrate on work. He had fallen into an overgeneralization thinking pattern, resenting his ex-girlfriend's heartlessness and regretting having given so much foolishly. Later, he had to seek help from a psychologist.

The psychologist told him that his situation was far less bad than he imagined. To illustrate this, the psychologist asked: "If one day you are sitting on a park bench resting, with a book you like very much on the bench, and suddenly someone walks straight toward you, sits on the book you placed on the chair, and damages your book, how would you feel?"

The young man replied: "I would definitely be very angry and blame him for damaging someone else's things for no reason."

The psychologist continued: "Now let me tell you, if he were blind, how would you feel then?"

The young man scratched his head, thought for a moment, and said: "Then he definitely wouldn't have known there was a book on the chair, so I wouldn't be angry."

The psychologist smiled knowingly and said to him: "The same act of damaging your book produces completely opposite emotions before and after. Do you know why?"

The young man replied: "Maybe because my view of the matter is different!"

Different views of a matter can indeed cause different emotions. Obviously, sometimes what makes us sad and painful is not the matter itself, but incorrect interpretations and evaluations of the matter. If people only evaluate their own behavior and classify it as good or bad, they will hardly experience any emotional distress. Many people are affected by negative emotions because they extend their negative evaluation of their



behavior to a judgment of their personal worth. Even if they occasionally make a mistake, they see it as an unforgivable act and even regard themselves as a complete failure.

Psychologists have found that negative thoughts often include unfounded inferences, excessive exaggeration or minimization of problems, and negative associations with oneself. For example, "I didn't do this well, so my career is hopeless," "My partner broke up with me, so no one else will like me," "I was so nervous during the speech that I couldn't speak; I'll definitely be nervous and unable to speak in future speeches too"...

Everyone generates these thoughts to some extent. When facing such ideas, what we need to do is actively question them, because the emergence of negative emotions is actually a warning, reminding us to pay attention to whether our thoughts are reasonable.

### **Mislabeling: Negative Suggestion Leads to Emotional Fluctuations**

Labeling oneself means using mistakes to create a completely negative self-image. It is an extreme form of overgeneralization that both creates trouble for oneself and appears absurd and foolish.

In life, many people often say to themselves "I am a very lousy person," "I am worthless," or "I am not good at socializing," thereby affixing a wrong label to themselves. Mislabeling causes one to use inaccurate words when describing things and to be overly emotional. For example, a person who is dieting and eats an ice cream often thinks: "I really am a gluttonous pig; I hate myself!" With this thought, she becomes upset and restless.

After mislabeling, we often use various examples to prove our label. For instance, when doing things we become full of worries, always doubting we will do poorly, and involuntarily prove that we are indeed lousy. This kind of thinking takes deep root in the mind. Every time we do something, these negative contents come to mind, suggesting to ourselves that we will do poorly.

Self-suggestion often has unexpected effects and exerts a tremendous influence on a person's psychological state. When we engage in self-suggestion, we are actually continuously giving ourselves commands. If self-suggestion continues for a long time, it forms a habit. This habit will produce the most direct reaction on a person's attitude and thinking, thereby affecting the person's body and behavior.

Once a person accustomed to negative thinking falls into a fixed thinking pattern, they will evaluate the problems they face negatively. What is even more frightening is that even positive events, once trapped in a negative thinking pattern, will be viewed with a negative attitude. If negativity is allowed to accumulate, it deepens the sense of misfortune, makes one feel disasters more deeply, and leads to greatly reduced self-control.

There was a person who frequently suspected he had cancer. He was scared to death, looked worried every day, fell into a state of anxiety and restlessness, could not eat or sleep well, and every movement showed the behavior of a cancer patient. In just half a month, he lost more than ten pounds. Later, after examinations at multiple hospitals, it was found that he did not have cancer at all. Upon hearing this news, he finally slowly recovered his health.

In contrast, there was a person diagnosed with cancer by the hospital, but he did not take it too seriously. He often engaged in positive self-suggestion: "As long as my spirit does not collapse, I can overcome cancer and gradually get better." When taking medicine, he often muttered: "This medicine must be good; taking it will definitely be effective." When walking, he often suggested to himself: "Life lies in movement; more walking will

naturally make the body better." Gradually, this suggestion produced a positive effect on his body and mind. For more than ten years he had no major problems, and he became increasingly confident about his body.

The two people in the cases form a sharp contrast, fully illustrating that negative suggestion and positive suggestion can lead to completely different results. Negative suggestion easily causes emotional fluctuations, produces great errors in judging things, and leads to cognitive deviations from the norm. Such people's thinking is easily led astray; they are often in a state of confusion psychologically, encounter obstacles everywhere in life, and frequently fail at work.

Although the harm of negative suggestion is great, we can use the same principle to cure negative suggestion—that is, to apply positive suggestion more often. French physician Coué, who first proposed autosuggestion therapy in 1920, had a famous saying: "Every day in every way I am getting better and better." He had patients repeat this sentence daily, and many patients recovered as a result. In fact, suggestion therapy gives patients a good mood and the confidence to overcome illness, thereby mobilizing their inner factors and giving play to their subjective initiative. As the ancients said, "When emotions are urgent, a hundred illnesses increase; when emotions are relaxed, a hundred illnesses are removed."

### **Escaping Despair: Resolving Conflict Is Key**

Long-term immersion in a state of low mood leaves the inner self extremely fragile, with no hope visible for the present or the future—this is despair. Failure to emerge from despair easily leads to self-abandonment.

"Grief greater than the death of the heart" describes despair as the extreme expression of negative emotion. For a despairing person the heart has died, leaving only a shell; the harm exceeds that of depression.

A despairing person has already sunk into the negative emotion of self-loathing. Watching others succeed and live happily while repeatedly failing and living in pain, such a person falls into self-loathing. Despairing people often mutter "Why am I so useless?" and consequently cannot accept themselves, lose faith in themselves, and stop believing in themselves.

If self-loathing is left unchecked and thoughts of "I am truly useless" flash repeatedly, or if events are exaggerated, self-evaluation drops and the ability to perform calmly declines. Once self-loathing intensifies, the person ultimately abandons all effort.

Despair usually stems from inability to accept the gap between reality and ideals: expectations are too high and fantasies too rosy on one side, while reality is too harsh and life too miserable on the other. High ambition is originally positive, yet setting expectations too high—"I must achieve this," "I ought to do that"—locks a person inside an ideal cage. Any discrepancy between ideal and reality then triggers self-loathing. Ambition itself is not wrong, but one must also recognize reality, take each step steadily, and gradually approach the goal.

Despair arises from various conflicts in life. Only by handling these conflicts can despair be relieved and released. How, then, is this done?

#### **1. Resolve conflict with awareness**

Research shows that awareness can control the generation of emotion and regulate its intensity.

Positive self-suggestion can therefore be used skillfully to resolve conflict—for example, telling oneself "I can..." or "I will..." to indicate what one can and will do, thereby regulating emotion.

## 2. **Resolve conflict with language**

Awareness alone is insufficient; thoughts must be spoken aloud, because voicing them produces an entirely different emotional experience from thinking them silently. Inspirational slogans can also be posted where they are frequently seen, guiding positive emotion from the outside in.

## 3. **Resolve conflict by shifting attention**

When something triggers despair, stop dwelling on it. Shift attention to view or handle it from a fresh angle or in a new way instead of remaining immersed in despair and dejection. Watching mood-regulating films or reading mood-regulating books, or listening to soothing music, can also redirect attention and fill life with positive emotion.

## 4. **“Out with the old, in with the new”**

This means completely abandoning lifestyles that breed despair and adopting those that generate hope—ending a despair-inducing relationship and beginning one that offers hope, or resigning from a suffocating job to find new work. Small changes also help: a new hairstyle, a new fruit, a new outfit. In short, “out with the old, in with the new” frees one from despair.

## **Excessive Expectations: Overly High Demands Lead to Inner Anxiety**

Excessive expectations are the root cause of inner anxiety. To escape anxiety and pain, one must discard this mindset and return demands on oneself and others to a rational level.

People differ in their expectations of themselves and therefore in the demands they place on themselves. High personal standards are originally beneficial and can drive excellence. Yet when standards become too high they backfire, imposing invisible pressure that ultimately hinders achievement. Unrealistic goals keep a person in constant tension and high stress, followed by anxiety and pain.

Which mindsets readily produce inner anxiety, and how can they be discarded?

### 1. **Fast-paced thinking**

Many people adopt fast-paced thinking: in pursuit of expected goals they become impatient, demanding an unnaturally rapid work or life rhythm without regard for their own stress limits. When feeling overwhelmed, check whether fast-paced thinking is present. If so, remind yourself that life contains no goals that must be reached. Slow the pace, proceed according to natural rhythms, make goals attainable, enjoy the scenery along the way, and move forward calmly while savoring the process rather than fixating solely on the outcome.

### 2. **Single-value thinking**

People with single-value thinking judge success or failure by only one standard—for instance, that a good life requires a car, a house, and savings. This mindset appears unproblematic in favorable circumstances, yet any gap between reality and the chosen value triggers endless self-conflict. The conflict consumes energy, distances the person from goals and expectations, and creates a vicious cycle.

### 3. **Absolutist thinking**

People with absolutist thinking start from personal wishes and insist that something must or must not happen. They convert “want” or “hope” into “must,” “should,” or “have to.” Typical statements include “I must succeed” or “Others must treat me well.”

Such absolutist demands are unreasonable because every phenomenon follows its own developmental

laws independent of human will. When events diverge from these absolutist expectations, the person finds them unacceptable and falls into emotional distress.

#### 4. Idealized thinking

When unrealistic expectations far exceed what reality can satisfy, a person becomes captive to desire and cannot feel relaxed or happy. Desire itself is a neutral primal driving force, yet excessive self-demand equals captivity by desire. As rational beings we should control desire rather than be dominated or consumed by it. Recognizing human smallness in the universe and centering on reality rather than the self removes much pressure.

Every phenomenon has its own laws of occurrence, development, and conclusion. One cannot alter these objective laws and can only align with them. Focus attention on actual matters rather than on personal imaginings.

### Worrying About the Sky Falling: Self-Disturbance Leads to Melancholy

People chronically troubled by sadness tend to view matters pessimistically. They see only the negative side, their mood cannot improve, and sadness easily enters.

Have you ever worried on a rainy day about being struck by lightning, or on a flight about the plane crashing? The ancient Chinese idiom “the man of Qi fears the sky will fall” tells of someone who constantly feared the heavens would collapse. The probability of such events is so low as to be laughable.

Exaggerating a minor matter into a catastrophe or treating it as utterly disastrous generates negative emotions such as anxiety, dejection, despair, and melancholy. These emotions neither improve the situation nor benefit work, life, or health.

Mr. Wu, convinced he had cancer, visited a major hospital hoping for early detection.

The doctor asked, “Do you feel discomfort anywhere?”

Mr. Wu replied, “Nothing in particular.”

The doctor asked, “Any sharp pain?”

Mr. Wu replied, “Everything feels fine.”

The doctor asked, “Have you lost weight recently?”

Mr. Wu replied, “No, my weight is normal.”

The doctor finally asked, “Then why suspect cancer?”

Mr. Wu answered, “I read a book that said early-stage cancer has no symptoms—and that is exactly my situation!”

Such groundless worry is comical. When a person sinks into wild speculation, others perceive the behavior as absurd. A devoted couple may still hear the wife complain, “Why are you warm to everyone else? You seem indifferent to me but attentive to others.” Even while knowing worry is useless, the person continues to assess how bad things might become and grows agitated through self-disturbance.

When feeling melancholy, first determine whether the worry is real or self-generated; only then can it cease to obstruct growth. Most worries are in fact absurd; examining probabilities reveals them as groundless and eliminates the majority of troubles.

Sadness arises from incorrect ways of viewing problems. Overcoming sadness therefore requires cultivating the habit of seeing matters positively and optimistically. Once formed, this habit changes one’s entire state: problems are met with hope, and hope supplies the strength to surmount difficulties.

Changing perspective belongs to the cognitive approach frequently used in psychology. Cognitive theorists hold that psychological difficulties stem from flawed ways of viewing problems. In therapy they therefore guide clients to examine issues from another, more positive angle; once clients do so, the difficulties are resolved.

### **Compensation Mechanism: The Sweat of Effort Originates from Inferiority**

Micro-expression keywords: The compensation mechanism is beneficial and harmless to people. Psychological anxiety is effectively relieved through compensation, and compensatory effort often produces useful outcomes. The behaviors reflecting this mechanism are mostly harmless.

The ancient Greek orator Demosthenes had small lung capacity, difficulty with pronunciation, and a stutter in his youth, yet he resolved to become a successful speaker. He practiced with pebbles in his mouth to improve fluency, rehearsed before a mirror to correct facial distortions, ran uphill each morning to strengthen his lungs, and each evening addressed the roaring sea so his voice would carry. His efforts succeeded; Demosthenes became known as the true “king of orators.”

This inspirational story illustrates a behavioral-psychology principle called the compensation defense mechanism.

The compensation defense mechanism originates in the human sense of inferiority. When a person perceives a personal defect, the resulting feeling of incompetence and distress is called inferiority. Combined with anxiety, inferiority forms an inferiority complex that becomes a powerful inner drive, prompting conscious self-shaping and compensatory effort to overcome the feeling and strive for improvement. This defensive process is the compensation defense mechanism.

Examples surround us. Australian youth of the year Nick Vujicic was born with phocomelia, lacking both arms and legs, yet through extraordinary courage and perseverance he has accomplished what many able-bodied people cannot: riding, playing ball, swimming, earning two university degrees, and serving as a company director.

Vujicic’s achievements rest on effort and courage, yet even this resilient individual attempted suicide three times before age ten. An inferiority complex clearly existed within him; it became the force that drove him beyond the reach of many healthy people.

Everyone possesses an inner “rational ideal,” an uncommon psychological term that may be understood as the self one believes oneself to be and the self one aspires to become.

Physiological or psychological defects often obstruct the path to this ideal self. When the desire for self-realization prompts the rational self to make the more admirable choice of meeting difficulty head-on, compensatory behavior appears.

Ultimately, whether or not the compensation mechanism objectively achieves the desired result, the subjective experience is that one feels considerably lighter after having tried one’s best; anxiety is effectively eased.

### **Jealousy Mechanism: The Malignant Transfer of Those Harboring Resentment**

Micro-expression keywords: Unlike the attack mechanism, the jealousy mechanism releases tension more gently and rationality plays a clearer role, making jealousy easier to control. As an effective channel for

discharging anxiety, jealousy can be acceptable when properly managed. Only uncontrolled jealousy that produces extreme behavior requires caution.

Forty-three-year-old teacher Liu had lost attraction to her husband, four years her senior, and began transferring her “love” to her students.

Seventeen-year-old Xiao Hua, an average student but handsome, was one of them. One day Liu kept him after class under the pretext of tutoring and initiated a sexual relationship in the empty classroom. The affair lasted nearly three months.

A new transfer student, A Bin, then joined the class. A Bin, a year younger than Xiao Hua, was a sports specialist, 184 cm tall, and already muscular. Liu soon became infatuated with him and used the same methods to win him.

Xiao Hua grew extremely jealous, repeatedly begging Liu to abandon A Bin and stay with him alone. When unsuccessful he turned to threats. Liu was unmoved by a child’s threats and continued the relationship with A Bin while occasionally seeing Xiao Hua as well.

Xiao Hua’s resentment finally erupted. One evening, after failing to persuade Liu and witnessing her intimacy with A Bin, he rushed into the classroom, killed A Bin with an iron clamp, and wounded Liu.

From a police perspective this was a typical crime of passion. Psychology, however, classifies Xiao Hua’s act as an expression of a psychological defense mechanism: jealousy.

“The best husband is always the neighbor’s husband” is a common quip among middle-class circles in certain German regions, usually uttered when men gather to mock their own “tigress” wives for jealousy and complaining.

The jealousy mechanism shares features with the attack mechanism—both manifest through destruction, harm, or conquest—yet the distinction is clear. The attack mechanism arises from blocked self-realization desires that produce violence. Jealous anxiety, by contrast, typically stems from psychological disparity.

What one already possesses, others must not obtain; what others obtain, one must also obtain. This is the typical mindset of the jealous person.

### **Case One: Aunt Zhang and the Vegetable Vendor**

Retired Aunt Zhang carried her vegetable basket to the morning market. Passing a stall, she was drawn to the fresh green cucumbers on display and asked the price.

“What! Eight yuan per jin?” Aunt Zhang could hardly believe her ears. “Other stalls sell them for three yuan. Are these golden cucumbers? No wonder you can’t sell them!”

“These are organic cucumbers. Are you buying or not? If not, move along and stop blocking my business.” The vendor was annoyed by her tone.

“Organic? More like a scam!” Aunt Zhang, unfamiliar with the term, grew angry at the vendor’s attitude. “These days people will say anything to make money. They say people full of tricks don’t grow tall—and it’s true.”

The vendor's short stature was already a sore point. Provoked by Aunt Zhang's remark, he retorted, "They also say a broad mind makes a plump body. Some old folks are as thin as kindling, yet their minds are narrower than the eye of a needle..."

Aunt Zhang wanted to buy the cucumbers at a reasonable price; saving money was her desire. The vendor's high price blocked that desire, so she resorted to insults. This is how her aggressive behavior arose.

Such scenes are common in daily life. In a society that moves ever faster, tempers grow shorter. Minor arguments over purchases can escalate to violent outbursts or even fatal revenge after perceived insults. In countless situations, people may harm others out of momentary anger or impulse. In behavioral psychology, such aggressive speech and actions are called the attack defense mechanism.

According to Freud, every person's mental activity has a dominant tendency: the unconscious strives to reduce or eliminate sudden external stimuli in order to maintain psychological balance. Based on this principle, the attack defense mechanism expresses anxiety and anger caused by displeasure through violence or other destructive, confrontational behavior. This allows the impulse to be discharged and restores inner equilibrium. The targets of attack are those who create conflict or obstruct the discharge.

The quarrel between Aunt Zhang and the vendor escalated from a pricing dispute to personal attacks on each other's shortcomings precisely because of this mechanism, triggering an all-out confrontation.

### **Resolving Jealousy by Suppressing the Urge to Compare**

"Why was there a Zhou Yu if there had to be a Zhuge Liang?" People who envy others constantly compare themselves and, upon discovering their shortcomings, cannot let go. Blind comparison is the root of envy; only by curbing the urge to compare can envy be resolved.

In daily life one often overhears women chatting: "I heard Xiaoman's husband earns twenty thousand a month plus a two-hundred-thousand bonus. Impressive! But his company is struggling; he might be laid off any time." "He buys a car and suddenly walks differently." "Xiaoli's husband bought her that skirt we saw last time—over ten thousand yuan! The skirt is nice, but it doesn't look great on her."

Some people feel admiration—an active emotion—when they meet someone more accomplished; others feel envy—a passive emotion. Envy arises because one covets what another possesses yet lacks the ability to obtain it, resulting in feelings of inferiority, shame, and resentment.

American anthropologist George Foster observed: "In every culture, the tall poppy is treated the same." Every success provokes envy in those around it, as if others' gains automatically diminish one's own.

Envy is a distinctly negative emotion. The envious person suffers at every success of others, even when that success does not harm them. This suffering breeds restlessness and irritability, damaging both mind and body. To escape the pain, the envious heart secretly wishes others would fail. Those consumed by envy may even sabotage others' success at any cost, including their own interests. As Bacon wrote, "Envy is the worst of devils and ever secretly and quietly ruins the good things of this world."

How, then, can we resolve envy and curb the urge to compare?

### **Case Three: Mr. Sun and His Wife**

Mr. Sun had been married five years. His wife's family was wealthy; he came from a poor rural background. After arriving in the city he built a career by relying on his wife's family connections.

Once he had a career, Mr. Sun began to stray. His wife sensed part of it but, for the sake of the family, turned a blind eye. Only when he transferred 500,000 yuan from their joint account did she sense real danger. Investigation revealed he had a steady mistress and planned to buy her an apartment.

The wife realized that once the money was spent she would lose her share of the marital property. She located the other woman's address and went to confront her.

Unexpectedly, her husband—who should have been at work—arrived for a tryst at the same moment. The three met. Seeing the disheveled pair, the wife screamed at them in fury.

Mr. Sun feared his wife would destroy his career and also dreaded losing the woman in his arms. In this extreme state of mind he struck his wife.

The wife had become an obstacle to his pleasure; under intense anxiety Mr. Sun resorted to violence. Despite his clear moral fault, he could still attack her. Once the attack mechanism takes over, moral judgment at the superego level disappears and reason vanishes. We must therefore stay alert to those who lash out when cornered and also find ways not to be ruled by this mechanism ourselves.

The attack mechanism is perhaps the most direct way to discharge anxiety: it converts anxiety into direct harm inflicted on the immediate party. We have all met people who react emotionally to any frustration by snapping back at whoever crosses them.

Such individuals habitually use the attack mechanism to vent anxiety. We should extend them a measure of understanding: attacking us is not their true intention; they are simply blocked by anxiety.

### **Subjective Assumptions: Bias Easily Introduces Emotional Coloring**

When judging an event we often see only one side and automatically ignore other possibilities. In most cases people tend to believe the negative side, plunging themselves into negative emotions.

In daily life we habitually project our own feelings and will onto others, distorting facts and producing mistaken evaluations. Psychology calls this the "self-projection effect." Many misunderstandings and negative emotions arise in exactly this way.

American psychologist Edward Thorndike termed it the "halo effect": influenced by mental set, cognition and judgment often start from a single aspect, spread outward, and form an overall impression that overgeneralizes and produces error.

A young man from a poor family discussed his wedding plans with his girlfriend: "Can we keep it simple and skip the gold necklace, ring, and earrings?" She replied, "No, that's the custom." Her father insisted the groom buy the three gold items plus a 100,000-yuan bride price. The young man borrowed from everyone he knew and finally gathered the sum.

At the wedding the bride's father handed the groom a red envelope. Still resentful, the groom threw it on the floor. After much persuasion he picked it up. Someone urged him to open it. Inside was not cash but a passbook showing a 100,000-yuan deposit.



The father-in-law had not intended to extract money; he simply believed local custom required the bride price or the couple would lose face at the wedding.

The young man never inquired into his father-in-law's real intention; he judged it by his own assumptions, triggering a chain of emotional reactions and impulsive behavior. All of it stemmed from bias.

## The Blind Self

Next is the window in the upper-right corner of the mind, called the "blind self," also known as the "back self." It earns this name because it belongs to the blind-spot area of self-knowledge. The saying "the spectator sees clearly while the participant is lost" refers to the blind self.

The blind self represents unconscious behavioral traits—prominent psychological features, inadvertent gestures, or habits. We usually cannot detect these emotional leaks ourselves; only when others point them out do we become aware, and we typically react with surprise, denial, or doubt, because the trait does not match our self-image.

When her close friend seriously told Xiaohong that she could no longer tolerate her unreliability, Xiaohong felt deeply wronged.

"When have I been unreliable?" she protested. "When did I ever promise something and fail to deliver?"

"Last week you said you would go shopping with me but canceled at the last minute. Last month you said you would introduce me to a boyfriend, yet you've probably forgotten completely," her friend challenged.

Xiaohong was speechless. Until her friend mentioned them, she had almost forgotten these incidents. Still, she muttered, did her friend have to get so angry? Everyone forgets things sometimes.

Xiaohong's situation illustrates the inability to see one's own blind self. The trait of making easy promises and then forgetting them was invisible to her until someone else revealed it.

The blind self is the part of the mind that we cannot see but others can. People who habitually reflect on themselves tend to have a smaller blind self; those who never engage in self-reflection have a very large one.

The story of Xi Shi clutching her heart and Dong Shi imitating her carries a similar lesson. Xi Shi did not know how beautiful she looked while clutching her heart, yet others saw it clearly—hence the anecdote of Dong Shi's clumsy imitation.

## The Five Things People Regret Most at Life's End

1. I wish I had had the courage to live the life I truly wanted.
2. I wish I had not spent so much energy on work and had not missed watching my children grow or the warmth of my partner.
3. I wish I had had the courage to express my feelings instead of suppressing anger and negative emotions for so long.
4. I wish I had stayed in touch with good friends instead of letting busy life erode genuine friendships.
5. I wish I had allowed myself to be happier instead of habitually hiding behind a smile in front of others.

A Japanese hospice nurse, Hidekazu Otsu, had a similar experience. After hearing the final regrets of a thousand patients, he wrote the book *25 Things People Regret Before They Die*. The listed regrets include:

1. Not doing what I wanted to do.
2. Not fulfilling my dreams.
3. Doing things against my conscience.
4. Letting emotions rule my life.
5. Not helping others enough.
6. Being overly confident in myself.
7. Not arranging my property properly.
8. Not considering arrangements after death.
9. Not returning to my hometown.
10. Not enjoying fine food.
11. Spending most of my time working.
12. Not traveling to the places I wanted to see.
13. Not meeting the people I wanted to meet.
14. Not experiencing a love worth remembering forever.
15. Never marrying.
16. Not having children.
17. Not seeing my children marry.
18. Not paying attention to my health.
19. Not quitting smoking.
20. Not expressing my true wishes.
21. Not understanding the meaning of life.
22. Not leaving evidence that I existed.
23. Not seeing through life and death.
24. Not having faith.
25. Not saying "thank you" to the people I deeply loved.

### **Manifestations of Regressive Behavior at Different Ages**

A six- or seven-year-old child who feels neglected after the birth of a younger sibling may revert to earlier habits such as bed-wetting or thumb-sucking. Scolding or punishment does not reduce the behavior; it may even increase. The cause is not physical but the operation of the regressive defense mechanism.

Adults also exhibit regressive defense mechanisms. A strong man in pain may cry out "Mama!" A capable businesswoman who feels wronged may weep like a child. A woman entering menopause, fearing aging, may become hypersensitive and dress or behave like a teenager.

The reason lies in childhood, when demands were fewer, inner security was greater, and happiness and satisfaction were more abundant. When problems seem insoluble, people therefore adopt regressive defense behaviors—expressing anxiety or anger through actions that are age-inappropriate, regressive, and immature.

Most of these behaviors fail to resolve the anxiety-provoking situation and may even deepen the predicament. Regressive behavior temporarily relieves anxiety, yet childish actions cannot meaningfully address real, uncontrollable circumstances. The relief is therefore short-lived. Once the "impulse" of regression passes and anxiety returns, the psyche suffers an even greater blow. This pattern is even cited as a cause of some psychological disorders.

It is therefore advisable to avoid relying on regressive behavior to relieve stress and instead address problems rationally; doing so better supports long-term well-being.

## Causes of Regressive Behavior

Regressive behavior usually occurs when anxiety exceeds a certain threshold, causing temporary weakening of rational control and prompting an instinctive, ostrich-like avoidance.

Many martial-arts programs begin by teaching students how to take hits. The goal is not only to build resistance to impact but, more importantly, to counteract the tendency toward regressive behavior during combat.

The threat of violence in sparring arrives with lightning speed and generates intense anxiety. Because the threat is so rapid, reason has no time to suppress the anxiety. When a fist comes toward the face, the instinctive reaction is to close the eyes. We all know closing the eyes solves nothing; the better response is to keep the eyes open and dodge. Yet when anxiety overrides reason, there is no time to think of dodging. The only available action is the most instinctive—and least useful—childhood response: close the eyes, turn the head, hunch the shoulders.

This is why many martial-arts schools have beginners strike each other's heads (with protective gear or controlled contact). Some traditions call it "training courage." In Japanese kendo the first lesson is mutual head strikes, known as "courage training."

As people age they tend to become more rational and mature; childish tantrums or pretending not to see difficulties become rarer. Yet when frustration or stress occurs, the anxiety generated in the unconscious is converted into behavior that abandons maturity and retreats to an earlier stage of life. This defense mechanism—warding off anxiety through anti-mature regression—is the regressive defense mechanism.

## Controlling Anxiety: Using Release to Escape Torment

Faced with intense competition and rapid change, many people become anxious and suffer greatly, harming both mind and body. Finding ways to overcome anxiety is therefore essential.

Busy work acts like a furnace, heating the mind to a boil; tense living acts like a whip, constantly striking us and leaving us restless. We worry: What if I lose my job? What if I cannot pay the mortgage? Will I receive a pension? Will my partner leave me? Can my child get into a good school? Life is short, yet we harbor worries that span a thousand years. The sources of anxiety are endless, and the negative emotions they produce cling to us—how can we be happy? A German philosopher once said that no emotion torments us more than anxiety; it inflicts enormous psychological pain.

The Tang-dynasty monk Shenxiu wrote a verse: "The body is a bodhi tree, the mind a bright mirror stand. Polish it constantly; let no dust alight." When Huineng saw it he replied with another verse: "Bodhi has no tree, the mirror no stand. Originally there is not a single thing—where can dust alight?" His verse perfectly captures the sudden-enlightenment spirit of Chan Buddhism. It expresses a transcendent attitude: the world is fundamentally empty; all phenomena are marked by emptiness. The mind is originally empty; there is no need to resist external temptations. Things pass through the mind without leaving a trace. Anxiety is the same. It is not caused by actual threat, and the degree of tension and fear it produces is out of proportion to reality. Anxiety is usually needless worry. To free ourselves completely from its torment we must maintain inner and outer calm.

We can use the following self-regulation methods to free ourselves from anxiety as soon as possible.

## Common Forms of Bias

### 1. Confirmation Bias

Subjectively, if we support a certain viewpoint, we tend to seek out information that supports our original view while unconsciously ignoring information that might overturn it.

Confirmation bias acts like a filter in the brain, retaining what it deems correct and discarding the rest into the trash. Whether regarding a person, a movie, or a product, we easily fall into confirmation-bias thinking.

Confirmation itself is neither wrong nor unnecessary. The key point is that confirmation represents only part of the picture. If we rely solely on confirmation, comprehensive thinking becomes difficult and erroneous conclusions are likely. Yet when we examine phenomena from the angle of “disconfirmation,” thinking in reverse and raising questions, the final conclusion is often more reliable and closer to reality.

### 2. Hindsight Bias

When evaluating an event that has already occurred, we should analyze it based on factors known before the event. Instead, we are often unconsciously influenced by the outcome and assume the event was triggered by factors that could have been predicted. After making a mistake or a decision that was not optimal for us, we frequently feel regret and believe we could have done better; afterward we tend to attribute the result to factors that seem predictable.

If we wish to draw lessons from past errors, we should minimize the influence of known outcomes on our thinking and, ideally, forget those outcomes entirely.

### 3. Anchoring Bias

Anchoring bias refers to the bias formed when first impressions guide subsequent judgments.

Psychologists have found that even when an initial question has no substantive meaning, it can still influence people’s judgments.

## Psychology Corner

On the surface, perfectionism appears to be an excellent way of life, yet it is in fact a sugar-coated bullet. Many people are deceived by the illusion of meticulousness and responsibility it creates. Perfectionists often insist that if something is worth doing, it must be done perfectly; otherwise they do nothing at all. Once their efforts fail to yield the desired results, they become despondent.

Most feelings of panic, depression, and anger actually stem from people converting hoped-for goals into absolute, unchangeable demands and commands. Everything must unfold exactly as wished; when reality falls short, disappointment and distress arise.

USA Today once conducted a survey showing that being a true perfectionist would require far more than twenty-four hours a day: thirty minutes for fitness training, forty-five minutes for personal hygiene, two to four hours with family, forty-five minutes reading the newspaper, two to four hours watching television, one to two hours commuting, seven to ten hours working, and another one to two hours for meals, plus roughly eight hours of sleep. Additional time would still be needed for reading novels, listening to music, and attending social gatherings. In total, the journalists calculated that forty-two hours a day would be ideal.

A brief calculation therefore reveals that most perfectionist expectations are unrealistic. Their goals and demands are often so idealized that they cannot be realized. Under the perfectionist rule of “do it perfectly or not at all,” most of their time would be spent doing nothing. Hence, somewhat imperfect standards are

actually important for us. When outcomes fall short of expectations, we should view them rationally and avoid setting expectations too high.

## Psychology Corner

When feeling low, the following methods can help lift the mood:

1. Identify your shortcomings

When expectations are unmet, avoid complaining or feeling despondent. Instead, reflect on the reasons the expectation fell through and consider which of your abilities may be lacking—whether execution, expression, or interpersonal skills. Once shortcomings are identified, missed opportunities can be faced calmly and a clear direction for improvement emerges.

2. Adjust your work goals

After identifying shortcomings, determine whether disappointment stems from goals that were set too high. Immediately revise those goals, setting new ones based on actual circumstances. For example, if the original goal was to start a company within two years, consider extending the timeline to three or four years to allow breathing room.

3. Work steadily toward the goal

With more realistic goals in place, pursue them persistently and keep improving your abilities. Daily progress will follow, and emotions will remain stable. Because the goals are reasonable, the pressure they generate stays manageable, and the positive energy accumulated will dispel negative feelings.

4. Experience setbacks

Smooth sailing is never conducive to personal growth. Only after weathering storms can one see the rainbow. Setbacks build courage in the face of difficulty. Maintaining the right attitude toward setbacks allows continued maturation and the development of inner strength.

## Case Two: Zhang Hongli and Professor Gong

Zhang Hongli was an art-major undergraduate studying piano.

Her instructor, Professor Gong, was in his forties, handsome and multitalented. Although married, he frequently engaged in improper sexual relationships with precocious female students.

Zhang Hongli became Professor Gong's new target; in appearance, figure, and temperament she was the standout among that year's freshmen. Professor Gong repeatedly took liberties during private lessons.

At first Zhang Hongli could not believe the outwardly respectable professor would actually harass her, but as his advances grew more overt she became increasingly frightened.

Finally, unable to endure it any longer, she fled the piano studio, found the campus police officer on duty, and reported everything in detail. Because of institutional suppression and a settlement reached with Zhang Hongli, the police did not file a case; the matter could have ended there.

Yet the now-disgraced Professor Gong could not let it go. Rumors and irreparable damage to his reputation fueled growing anger. Eventually, whenever he heard the story mentioned, he spread the counter-rumor: "Zhang Hongli seduced me. Every time she asked for private lessons she dressed provocatively and tried to sit on my lap..."

Professor Gong's attack mechanism did not arise from unsatisfied sexual desire but from the frustration of his wish to "maintain a good reputation." Zhang Hongli, as the obstacle to that wish, became his target.

Targets of attack mechanisms are usually both specific and arbitrary. The means of attack also vary widely; some involve direct physical violence.

## Psychology Corner

In daily life one often encounters people who over-interpret ordinary remarks, take jokes as mockery, assume whispered conversations are about them, perceive friendly greetings as insincere, attribute minor setbacks to deliberate sabotage, and suspect even loved ones of disloyalty. They remain hyper-vigilant, treating everyone around them like suspects and sometimes doubting their partners or friends without cause.

Modern psychology indicates that pathological suspicion is a mental disorder belonging to paranoid personality defects. Such individuals often experienced harsh treatment or misfortune in childhood, leading to gradual emotional withdrawal and eventual distrust of everyone. They tend to be hypersensitive, suspicious of everything, narrow-minded, and self-important; they habitually assume the worst and feel that others are deliberately making things difficult. They may even imagine hidden meanings in a cough. Pathological suspicion leaves them trapped in awkward interpersonal situations—unable to get along with family at home or maintain harmonious relations with colleagues at work—resulting in chronically tense relationships. Prolonged anxiety and psychological tension deprive them of genuine love, family affection, and friendship.

## The Universal Psychological Principle of Jealousy

The ancient saying "A tree that stands out in the forest will be felled by the wind; a bank that protrudes will be eroded by the current; a person of high conduct will be criticized by the many" reflects a widespread psychological principle: people readily feel jealousy toward those who are more successful, more outstanding, or more favored than themselves. This jealousy finds expression through resentment, exclusion, slander, defamation, false accusations, sabotage, conspiracy, or covert harm—indirectly satisfying the emotional impulse of jealousy and temporarily restoring psychological equilibrium.

Although the jealousy defense mechanism can relieve anxiety and restore balance, it often produces serious consequences. Because the satisfaction jealousy itself can generate is limited, those who still cannot regain equilibrium through the defense mechanism may redirect their destructive impulses back onto themselves when external outlets are blocked, potentially leading to mental breakdown or psychological distortion.

One restaurant owner, tormented day and night by jealousy after a new establishment across the street took his business, finally decided to poison the rival's ingredients with rat poison during the night. His intention was merely to make diners ill and thereby damage the rival's reputation, but he misjudged the dosage and killed several people. Police investigated, identified him as the perpetrator, and sentenced him to death.

## Historical Case: Zheng Xiu and the Wei Beauty

During the Spring and Autumn period, King Huai of Chu (Xiong Huai) had a favored consort named Zheng Xiu. She was surpassingly beautiful and enjoyed the king's exclusive favor.

Yet no flower blooms for a hundred days. After Zheng Xiu had monopolized the king's affections for only a short time, the state of Wei presented Chu with a beauty whose looks surpassed even Zheng Xiu's. The king transferred his favor to the Wei beauty and neglected Zheng Xiu.

Although jealousy burned within her, Zheng Xiu was clever. On one hand she repeatedly showed goodwill to the Wei beauty, letting her choose the finest fabrics and jewelry and often accompanying her on walks. On the other hand, she pretended to be helpful and told the Wei beauty, "His Majesty often says he likes you, but your nose is the one flaw. If you cover your nose whenever you see him, he will favor you even longer."

The newly arrived Wei beauty never suspected a trick and followed the advice, covering her nose each time she met the king.

After some time the king noticed and asked Zheng Xiu the reason. At first she feigned ignorance, but when pressed she replied, "The new beauty has privately said that Your Majesty has a foul odor, so she must cover her nose in your presence."

The king flew into a rage and ordered his attendants to cut off the Wei beauty's nose and expel her from the palace.

Zheng Xiu's methods were ruthless, yet their root lay in only two words: jealousy.

### **Overcoming Suspiciousness and Suppressing Subjective Assumptions**

Suspicion and mistrust constitute a psychological disorder and an enemy of happiness; they harm others and trap the suspicious person in endless self-inflicted distress. Therefore it is best to stop suspecting, recognize the causes and harms of suspicion, and thoroughly overcome the habit.

Francis Bacon described suspicion thus: "It is a trap that confuses the mind, leading one to mistake friend for foe and thereby ruin others' affairs." Indeed, history abounds with tragedies born of suspicion. King Fuchai of Wu wrongly executed the loyal Wu Zixu because of suspicion; Othello wrongly killed his chaste wife for the same reason. Even the ancient Chinese stratagem of sowing discord exploits humanity's tendency toward suspicion.

Suspicion and mistrust are psychological disorders that strain relationships, inflict needless emotional harm, and burden the suspicious person's own mind. Severe suspiciousness can develop into paranoia—the condition seen in those who imagine others are plotting against them.

Feeling suspicious is a normal phenomenon; excessive worry is unnecessary. The important task is to overcome it before it spreads and causes greater damage. How, then, can one dispel suspiciousness in interpersonal interactions?

### **Psychology Corner**

A psychologist once conducted an interesting experiment. He asked a group of participants, on the first Sunday of a given month, to write down every worry they anticipated for the coming seven days and drop the lists into a large "worry box." On the third Sunday he checked each item with the participants. They discovered that 90 percent of the listed worries had never occurred.

The psychologist then asked the participants to place the remaining 10 percent back into the box and return in three weeks to review them. On opening day the participants were surprised to find that the remaining worries were no longer problems; they now possessed sufficient capacity to handle them.

Further research showed that, among the things most people worry about, 40 percent concern the past and 50 percent concern the future; 92 percent of the worries never materialize, and the remaining 8 percent are

easily resolved by the worrier.

The experiment illustrates a simple truth: most of our troubles are needless anticipations; the things we worry about usually do not happen. Trouble itself is not frightening; what is truly frightening is remaining trapped in worry without realizing it and wasting precious time on events that will never occur.

## Psychology Corner

Psychologists define anxiety as a state of intense apprehension and unease arising from the anticipation of a threatening event or situation. It manifests as mental hypersensitivity and high tension; in severe cases it may impair physiological and psychological functioning. Anxiety can be divided into four levels of intensity:

- **The first level is bodily tension.** People at this level feel unable to relax, appear tense, wear serious expressions, furrow their brows, and sigh frequently.
- **The second level involves strong autonomic nervous-system responses.** Because the sympathetic and parasympathetic systems are chronically overloaded, individuals sweat, feel dizzy, breathe rapidly, and experience tachycardia, alternating sensations of heat and cold, cold or hot extremities, stomach discomfort, frequent urination or defecation, and a lump-in-the-throat sensation.
- **The third level is unwarranted worry about the future.** People at this level constantly worry about career, promotion prospects, finances, health, and similar matters.
- **The fourth level is excessive vigilance.** People at this level remain as alert as sentries, reacting to every minor sound or movement.

## Regression Phenomena in Hospitals

Hospitals frequently observe the following phenomenon:

Elderly patients who have been declared recovered sometimes refuse to leave, preferring to pay high hospitalization fees rather than depart.

Physicians describe such patients as particularly “difficult.” On one hand, continued hospitalization is medically unnecessary and the hospital is reluctant to keep them because beds are already scarce. On the other hand, these elderly individuals inexplicably refuse to leave, ignoring all persuasion from hospital staff and family.

Physicians are puzzled.

A physiological physician may remain puzzled, but a psychologist or psychiatrist would recognize the mindset: staying in the hospital is a classic regressive behavior.

After losing the strength of their prime years, older adults feel especially helpless. This sense of powerlessness makes them simultaneously wish to confront a dangerous world and feel incapable of doing so. The resulting psychological imbalance leads them to revert instinctively to childhood habits and seek refuge in a place that appears safe.

Confronted with the ultimate threats of aging and death, they feel even more powerless and therefore regard the hospital as a vast sanctuary in which they place enormous trust. This is the operating mechanism of the regressive behavior.

## The Unknown Self



The final window is the “Unknown Self,” also called the “Potential Self.” The Unknown Self is closely linked to what we refer to as the subconscious; one could even say that the Unknown Self is the latent aspect of ourselves we usually discuss.

For any individual the Unknown Self constitutes an undeveloped, virgin territory. Latent abilities or traits, as well as talents that emerge only under specific circumstances, all belong to the Unknown Self.

We must explore and develop the Unknown Self more diligently. Only by better knowing, motivating, and understanding ourselves can we develop and transcend ourselves. Behavioral psychology plays the greatest role in this process, because the Unknown Self is typically expressed through unconscious actions. Mastering behavioral psychology therefore equips one with the skill to discern others’ Unknown Selves.

The four windows of the Johari Window exist within each of us. Recognizing these four windows offers the best method for knowing, analyzing, and improving ourselves. Combined with behavioral psychology, recognizing others’ four windows provides an important and far-reaching means of understanding and relating to them.

## **How to Reduce Cognitive Dissonance**

In general, there are four methods that can be applied:

### **1. Change a cognition**

If two cognitions contradict each other, one of them must be changed to align with the other. For example, if we normally see only white swans, we naturally assume all swans are white. When we encounter a black swan, we must revise our original cognition—that swans can also be black.

### **2. Add a new cognition**

When two inconsistent cognitions produce dissonance, we can add a new cognition to restore balance. The excuses Old Wang invented for smoking clearly belong to this category.

### **3. Alter the importance of a cognition**

By comparing the relative importance of two inconsistent cognitions and weighting one accordingly, dissonance can be reduced.

### **4. Change behavior**

Because cognitive dissonance is closely linked to behavior, changing behavior can also ease the sense of imbalance. For most people, however, changing behavior is more difficult than changing attitude.

## **1. Think Rationally Instead of Suspecting Without Cause**

When you notice yourself suspecting someone or something, pause and ask yourself rationally why the suspicion exists and whether it is justified.

Suspicion is a form of negative self-suggestion: forming baseless conjectures about others in the absence of objective evidence. Under the influence of suspicion, people often trap themselves in closed loops of reasoning, starting from an assumed premise and returning to the same premise. Objectively, conclusions reached this way lack foundation and are frequently absurd.

Suspicion usually stems from a person’s own beliefs and habitual thought patterns. To overcome it, apply reasonable beliefs and thinking styles when interpreting everyday events. For instance, if you meet an

acquaintance who does not greet you, do not immediately assume resentment; instead, remind yourself the person may not have seen you or had time to react. Rational thinking prevents or reduces suspicious feelings. The key is refusing to treat minor, non-principle matters as absolute.

## **Opening the Window to the Mind Through the Johari Window**

Micro-expression keywords

Every mind has a four-pane window. Only by opening all four panes can one truly see another person's inner world; behavioral psychology supplies the key that opens that window.

We often say "know yourself and know your enemy, and you will win every battle." Yet how many people actually achieve genuine mutual understanding?

Everyone believes they know themselves, but when faced with unexpected events or setbacks, we often react in uncharacteristic ways and realize we do not fully understand who we are.

Understanding oneself is not difficult once the right method and techniques are used.

The Johari Window is the ultimate technique for examining oneself and deeply understanding others.

Psychologists Luft and Ingham introduced the Johari Window model, dividing the mind into a four-pane window: the Open Self, the Blind Self, the Hidden Self, and the Unknown Self.

These four panes together form the window of the mind.

## **Psychology Mini-Lesson**

Negative emotions arise from negative self-suggestions. What are some common negative psychological suggestions?

1. "I will definitely mess this up"

Some people avoid taking on tasks because they fear failure. They habitually evade opportunities and, even when prepared, retreat at the last moment. They constantly question themselves internally: "Am I really capable? What if I make a mistake?"

2. "I need help"

These individuals never trust themselves to complete tasks independently. Their weakness stems from self-distrust; they rely excessively on others and allow others to control situations. Because they repeatedly tell themselves "I can't," they end up as dependents of stronger people.

3. "My idea is definitely wrong"

These people constantly doubt their own views and hesitate to express their true thoughts, especially when asked for an opinion.

## **Psychology Mini-Lesson**

To investigate the origins of self-blame, psychologists surveyed American college students. Participants were asked to recall and record an event that had brought great joy to someone else. The results showed that students' differing self-views strongly influenced their narratives. Confident students described situations in which their own abilities created happiness for others, whereas less confident students focused on analyzing

others' needs and attending to others' feelings. Confident individuals emphasized their own capabilities; less confident individuals emphasized altruism.

Thus, people lacking confidence often place others' needs first while ignoring their own abilities and legitimate needs. When something goes wrong, they assume responsibility and blame themselves for failing to meet others' expectations. Compared with people who have strong self-awareness, these individuals lack self-awareness and are seen as "nice guys," yet they pay a high psychological price and are more prone to negative emotions.

### **An Example of Regressive Behavior**

A joke circulating online tells of a young preschool teacher who drew an apple on the blackboard and asked the children, "What is this, children?"

"Butt," the children answered in unison.

The teacher ran to the principal's office in tears, claiming the children were mocking her.

"How outrageous!" the principal exclaimed and hurried to the classroom. "Why did you make your teacher cry? Who drew that butt on the board?"

The joke is merely amusing, yet the teacher's reaction illustrates a specific concept in behavioral psychology: the regressive defense mechanism. A key feature of regressive behavior is that it is, to some degree, irrational—both because the behavior itself rejects rationality and because rational analysis struggles to explain its cause.

### **Hidden Self**

The third pane is called the "Hidden Self," also known as the "Private Self." It consists of information we know about ourselves but others do not—personal secrets, flaws, past events, pain, desires, illnesses, and so on.

No one is entirely without privacy, so everyone possesses a Hidden Self. When the Hidden Self grows too large, the Open Self shrinks, creating a high wall between the mind and the outside world that blocks normal interaction.

People with an excessively large Hidden Self are often withdrawn, repressed, timid, vain, or insecure. They suppress themselves and make those around them feel suppressed as well. Therefore, we should confront the Hidden Self, explore ourselves, and face our true nature.

### **Psychology Mini-Lesson**

American psychologists Richard Rahe and Thomas Holmes created a life-events inventory that converts the intensity of emotional change into numerical points to measure the relationship between daily events and emotional stress. Different events receive different point values.

When several events occur simultaneously, the total stress score is the sum of the individual scores. Their research found that 89 percent of people whose annual total exceeded 300 points fell into despair, and most of those individuals developed hypertension, gastric ulcers, migraines, or intestinal colic. Prolonged despair, pessimism, or sorrow also significantly raises the risk of cancer.

## 4. Stop Comparing Yourself with Others

Frequent comparison with others is another source of anxiety. People often think, “I’m over thirty and still single, while my peers already have children,” or “My neighbor buys designer clothes; I can only afford street-market items—when will this end?” or “My colleagues keep getting promoted while I stay in place—it’s frustrating.” Those who constantly compare themselves become controlled by public opinion and others’ judgments, developing thoughts such as “Everyone else bought one, so I should too” or “They were promoted, so I should be promoted.” Once caught in this mindset, anxiety over perceived gaps is inevitable. Face the differences between yourself and others without constant comparison.

### Psychology Mini-Lesson

#### 1. Jealousy is highly domain-specific

Jealousy arises only when two or more people compete within the same domain. Multiple suitors of the same woman, candidates for the same position, classmates in the same class, or athletes in the same event are likely to feel jealous. People feel jealous only toward those in the same domain who outperform them; they do not feel jealous toward people outside their domain or toward those in the same domain who perform worse.

#### 2. Jealousy is a damaged sense of superiority

### 2. Recognize Your Own Strengths and Build Confidence

From a psychological perspective, insecurity often underlies suspicion, and insecurity frequently stems from lack of self-confidence. Everyone wants appreciation and cares about others’ opinions, especially those whose inner state fluctuates easily.

People prone to suspicion tend to harbor strong wariness and hostility toward others and refuse to trust them. The root cause is usually low self-confidence and a tendency toward inferiority. Inferiority breeds sensitivity, and sensitivity breeds suspicion. Therefore, overcoming suspicion requires believing in your own abilities and maintaining sufficient self-confidence.

### Open Self

The upper-left pane is called the “Open Self,” also known as the “Public Self.” It comprises the parts of ourselves that can be revealed outwardly—appearance, gender, occupation, abilities, hometown, hobbies, achievements, and so on. These publicly shareable facts constitute the mind’s free-action zone and form the basic data for self-understanding and self-evaluation.

The size of each person’s Open Self varies according to the degree of psychological openness, the extent of social interaction, and the strength and breadth of personality expression. A popular actor, for example, has a much larger Open Self than an unknown factory worker.

### 3. Establish Priorities

Having several tasks to handle at once can also trigger anxiety. In such situations, calmly assess the current state and set clear priorities. Tasks generally fall into four categories: important but not urgent, urgent but not important, neither important nor urgent, and both important and urgent. The recommended order is to handle important-and-urgent items first, then urgent-but-not-important items, then important-but-not-

urgent items, and finally neither-important-nor-urgent items. Regardless of the plan, remember to focus on only one task at a time. Once priorities are clear, the mind stops juggling multiple concerns.

### **The Psychological Reaction of Jealousy**

Jealousy is the psychological reaction that follows the loss of a sense of superiority. Only when a person possesses superiority and then sees it surpassed does jealousy arise. Without that sense of superiority, the reaction is merely inferiority or envy. A penniless beggar will never feel jealous of an emperor's status, power, or wealth, because the beggar has never held personal superiority in those areas. Only ministers wielding real power or the emperor's brothers and uncles who covet the throne possess the necessary sense of superiority and therefore experience jealousy.

### **3. Use Communication to Overcome Suspicion**

Some people are full of suspicion because they rarely communicate with others. Without communication, they cannot know what others are thinking and must rely on guesswork, allowing misunderstandings to enter. Opening up and exchanging views regularly reveals that many doubts are merely misunderstandings; once clarified, suspicion naturally disappears. Regular communication also allows the other person to notice your confused thoughts and help you sort them out.

### **Psychology Mini-Lesson**

American psychologist Abraham Luchins tested the primacy effect by writing two descriptions of a boy named Jim. One portrayed him as warm and outgoing; the other portrayed him as cold and introverted.

Luchins combined the passages in different orders and asked four groups of participants to read them and judge what kind of person Jim was. The results demonstrated that the order of information strongly affects social cognition: information presented first exerts greater influence than information presented later.

### **4. Reduce Horizontal Comparison and Increase Vertical Comparison**

Comparison can be either horizontal or vertical. Horizontal comparison means measuring oneself against others. "There are always higher mountains and more talented people." Even if you compare your strengths with someone else's, victory is not guaranteed—let alone when you compare your weaknesses with their strengths. Instead of horizontal comparison, practice vertical comparison: measure your present self against your past self, note any progress, and identify long-term development. This growth-oriented mindset provides encouragement.

### **5. Cultivate a Sense of Achievement**

People prone to anxiety often lack a sense of achievement; they underestimate their abilities and exaggerate difficulties. When setbacks occur, anxiety and inferiority surface. Once these weaknesses are identified, address them directly rather than waiting for help. Achievement does not come only from major events; many small daily tasks can generate it. Set modest goals, complete them, and gradually accumulate confidence and the joy of success. Over time, a genuine sense of achievement will develop.

### **1. Use Self-Suggestion to Strengthen Psychological Resilience**

Self-suggestion, also called self-affirmation, is a powerful technique for regulating the mind. It can quickly shift a person's attitude toward life and increase resilience. Common forms include using encouraging words or actions to motivate oneself. After seeing someone else's remarkable achievement, for example, silently tell yourself, "I'm not doing badly either" or "With more effort, I could be just as outstanding." Over time, the habit of blind comparison fades and psychological resilience grows.

### **Five Methods for Resolving Anxiety**

Research shows that many anxiety-disorder patients follow a similar developmental path: long-suppressed emotional experiences or past psychological trauma linger in the subconscious, and anxiety symptoms have already manifested in other forms, yet the individual has not paid attention. Once anxiety is noticed, the underlying causes must be brought into conscious awareness so that targeted measures can be taken to reduce it.

## **Chapter 12: Defense Mechanisms—Seeing Through Psychological Weaknesses**

Everyone possesses a unique set of defense mechanisms, also called displacement mechanisms. They keep us from losing control when angry, from total despair when depressed, and from becoming carried away when excited—functioning as a remarkable psychological “transformer.” Understanding another person's defense mechanisms through their behavior helps us quickly grasp their character and weaknesses, enabling us to guard against or make use of them.

### **2. Maintain a Calm Mindset**

Anxiety can stem from time pressure. When tasks pile up because of tight deadlines, the resulting inner tension produces anxiety. In such moments, the worst response is impatience. Close your eyes, breathe deeply, and allow your mind to settle so that attention can focus on the task at hand. A calm mindset is essential for easing anxiety; therefore, approach everything with a lighter perspective.

## **Chapter 9: Emotions Cannot Escape the Prison of Thought**

We commonly assume that negative emotions are caused by objective facts and therefore uncontrollable. In reality, negative emotions mainly originate from our thinking patterns. The situations we label as anxiety-provoking, annoying, or worrisome are rarely as severe as we imagine; our perception of their severity arises from flawed thinking. Changing the thinking pattern is often enough to eliminate the negative emotion.

### **5. Discover Your Own Strengths**

Many people feel they have nothing worth comparing with others, yet everyone possesses strengths. Only by identifying those strengths can we leverage advantages, compensate for weaknesses, and achieve greater success. Once strengths are recognized, display them boldly, create conditions to amplify them, and let them become stepping-stones for progress.

## **Chapter 5 Controlling Your Negative Emotions**

Many factors around us affect our emotions, and the ability to control emotions determines our lives. People who are good at controlling negative emotions are confident, optimistic, and excellent, while those who are

not good at controlling negative emotions are inferior, pessimistic, and mediocre. It can be said that only by controlling one's negative emotions well can one firmly grasp one's own life.

### **3. Appropriate Venting**

Jealousy is a very normal negative emotion. There is no need to hide feelings of jealousy or to suppress them in the heart for a long time. One can vent appropriately by telling relatives and friends about one's dissatisfaction, thereby preventing jealousy from growing increasingly severe.

### **Regression Mechanism: The Older the Age, the Smaller You Live**

The biggest drawback of the regression mechanism is that it can only temporarily prevent you from facing anxiety directly. The source of anxiety remains, so your anxiety will return to you shortly afterward. Therefore, do not rely excessively on this mechanism, as it ultimately brings no benefit.

### **6. Perfecting Yourself**

If a person understands that only by perfecting oneself can one gradually improve, they can shift their attention and turn jealousy into motivation for their own efforts. In this way, jealousy acquires positive significance.

### **2. Objectively Evaluating Yourself**

When one realizes that jealous emotions have arisen, one should calmly analyze one's own strengths and weaknesses and actively adjust one's awareness and behavior.

### **Attack Mechanism: Violent Catharsis of Self-Anxiety**

Micro-expression keywords: The attack mechanism is the most direct method for relieving anxiety. When it does not produce consequences we cannot bear, employing this psychological mechanism to relieve anxiety is not infeasible. The mechanism itself is not frightening; what is frightening is the ultimate impact it produces.

For humans, the most essential source of happiness is the realization of self-desires. When such desires cannot be fulfilled, anxiety arises. When anxiety is generated or pending, people inflict direct violence, soft violence, or cold violence on those or those things that obstruct them. This method of resolving self-anxiety through violence constitutes the essence of aggressive behavior.

### **Seeing Through Manipulation Patterns: No One Can Manipulate Me**

### **The Liking Principle: Why People Love the House and the Crow**

Micro-expression keywords: Liking Principle. This is a simple yet effective principle. People are always more willing to comply with requests from those they know and like, which is sometimes called the "one of us effect." The key to its application lies in how to gain others' favor and build friendships. To achieve this, you can enhance your physical attractiveness, identify and strengthen similarities with the other person, and increase contact with them.

Wang Le was a top performer in the sales department of a foreign company and the most popular person in the department. She was exceptionally skilled at dealing with clients. Whether they were old or young, male or

female, she could win their favor in a very short time. As a result, her sales performance improved rapidly. In less than two years, she was promoted to assistant to the chief sales representative. Later, when the chief sales representative immigrated to Canada, he handed over most of his business to her. By her third year, her performance far exceeded everyone else in the department, making her the sales champion.

It was not unusual for such an outstanding person to face jealousy and exclusion from colleagues, yet Wang Le successfully avoided these issues and maintained excellent relationships with her coworkers. Everyone was willing to help her whenever she needed it. Once, a friend complained to her about the complexity of interpersonal relationships and the indifference of human feelings, asking, "How do you manage to win so much liking and help from others?" "Because I like them," Wang Le replied. "I don't believe you like everyone you deal with," the friend persisted. "But I show that I like them—that's enough."

The once-famous magician Howard Thurston had a famous saying: "I sincerely love my audience!" This remark deeply embodies a psychological technique worth learning: "Liking begets liking."

People have a strong tendency to like those who like them, even when their values and outlooks on life differ. American social psychologist Elliot Aronson once surveyed his friends: "Why do we like some companions more than others?" The answers varied, but one of the most typical was "Because those people like us in return."

Think about it: in this world, who do you love most? Most people would probably answer "myself." This shows that human nature is self-centered and somewhat narcissistic. Therefore, someone who likes you becomes someone you like. They may not be particularly attractive, intelligent, or socially prominent; it is simply because they like you that you like them back. This is what psychology calls the "law of mutual attraction."

Why do we like those who like us? From a psychological perspective, there are four main reasons:

1. The other person's liking allows us to experience pleasant emotions. Thinking of them reminds us of the joy we felt in their company, and seeing them puts us in a good mood.
2. The other person's liking satisfies our need for respect. In human interactions, everyone hopes to be respected. When someone likes us, they usually express respect through their words and actions, which brings us comfort.
3. The other person's liking gives us confidence. In real life, strictly speaking, no one is completely confident. Most people judge their own worth and adjust their goals by evaluating their achievements and attractiveness. Therefore, most people especially need affirmation from others. Someone's liking is precisely that affirmation—who would not welcome it?
4. The other person's liking creates a sense of shared values. We tend to think that if they like us, they accept certain aspects of our behavior, meaning they share similarities with us in some way. It is only natural that we like people who are similar to us.

Because of these four reasons, in social settings we can easily win others' favor simply by showing that we like them. In daily life and work, to gain others' goodwill more easily and quickly, we might as well show that we like them.

- If you are a salesperson facing a prospective client you have never met, show that you like them. This will make them like you and, in turn, like the product you are selling.
- If you are a new employee entering a company and meeting colleagues with different personalities, show that you like them. This will help them accept you in the shortest possible time.



Of course, this approach is not universally effective. Sometimes people encounter situations where they like someone who does not like them back, or dislike someone who likes them. In such cases, continue to show goodwill toward the person you like who does not like you, and respond with gratitude to the person you dislike who likes you. Over time, you will find that those who previously liked you like you even more, while those who previously disliked you gradually develop goodwill toward you. By showing that you like others in interpersonal interactions, your circle of friends will grow and your affairs will proceed more smoothly.

People always comply with requests from those they know and like; no one finds this strange. This also reflects the liking principle. However, the principle has at times been exploited by strangers in various ways to get us to comply with their requests. In life, those skilled at using human psychology can always establish common goals with us and work toward them together, creating the feeling that “we are working side by side for a shared objective; we are comrades in the same trench.” This reflects another psychological principle: contact and cooperation.

In May 2001, during a football match held in Accra, the capital of Ghana, after the African champions Hearts of Oak defeated Kotoko 2–1, Kotoko supporters were enraged. They destroyed seats in the stands and clashed with Hearts of Oak fans. When police realized the situation could cause irreversible damage, they fired tear gas at the fans. This triggered panic; people began to flee in all directions, leading to a stampede. The incident ultimately resulted in 150 deaths and nearly 20 injuries.

In intense sports competitions, it is understandable for athletes to become excited, but for sports fans to act so impulsively is somewhat astonishing. Sports activities do possess a magical and irresistible power; the relationship between the sport and its audience is entirely personal. Yet, influenced by the liking principle, fans’ self-image becomes tied to the team or athlete they support. If their favored team loses, they feel they have lost as well, making excitement or dejection understandable. A match is not merely a fixed performance or artistic display for our entertainment; it is something we bet on with our own egos. For this reason, fans feel intense love and gratitude toward their country’s victories and, conversely, develop aversion—even cruel behavior—toward athletes, coaches, or officials they hold responsible for defeat.

From this we can conclude that we always hope the team connected to us wins, thereby proving our own superiority. To whom do we wish to prove this? To ourselves and to others. According to the liking principle, if we succeed, our prestige in the public eye increases significantly. The examples above show that we deliberately manipulate the relationship between ourselves and winners or losers so that this connection becomes obvious, all to appear more prestigious in the eyes of those who can see it. By highlighting positive connections and concealing negative ones, we attempt to make onlookers think more highly of us and feel greater liking toward us.

Abroad, one of the most interesting phenomena is that police interrogators use psychological methods to obtain confessions from suspects. The most commonly employed technique is probably the “good cop, bad cop” approach.

For example, a suspect arrested for robbery is brought to the police station and informed of his right to remain silent before giving a statement. As soon as the suspect sits down, the so-called “bad cop” begins shouting insults. Throughout the interrogation, the “bad cop” continues to berate the suspect, sometimes even kicking the suspect’s chair. His eyes are full of contempt. If the suspect refuses to answer questions, the “bad cop” flies into a rage, angrily declaring that he will make sure the suspect spends the rest of his life in prison. He adds that, if possible, he will urge the prosecutor to seek the harshest charges.

Does the “good cop” simply allow the “bad cop” to do as he pleases? No. At first the “good cop” remains silent. Gradually he intervenes, initially urging the “bad cop” to calm down. The “bad cop” ignores him and continues expressing his displeasure with the suspect. Before long, the “good cop” begins speaking up for the suspect, but the “bad cop” remains unmoved and grows even angrier. At this point, the “good cop” starts addressing the suspect directly.

He calls the suspect by name and points out any details in the case that favor the suspect. If the suspect still refuses to cooperate, the “bad cop” resumes his insults and threats. The “good cop” then intervenes, takes out some money, and sends the “bad cop” out to buy coffee or another beverage.

Once the “bad cop” leaves, the “good cop” begins his real performance. He tells the suspect: “You see, for some reason my colleague simply doesn’t like you. He will do everything he can to find evidence against you—and he has the ability to do so, because we already have sufficient proof. The prosecutor will also punish uncooperative suspects severely. In that case, you could face five years in prison.

“I’m truly sorry. I really don’t want that to happen to you. If you admit to the robbery now, before he returns, I’ll take over the case. I promise to speak well of you to the prosecutor. If you cooperate, your sentence could be reduced from five years to two, or even one. It’s up to you. Tell me what happened. We’ll figure it out together and get through this.”

At this point, the suspect usually confesses all his crimes. The combined “good cop, bad cop” strategy has succeeded completely.

In fact, this is also an effective negotiation tactic. Upon closer examination, we see that the liking principle is at work behind the scenes: once the suspect develops goodwill toward the “good cop,” he becomes willing to follow the “good cop’s” instructions.

The method works for several reasons:

1. The “bad cop’s” threats create fear of imprisonment in the suspect, making the “good cop’s” words and actions seem especially reasonable by comparison.
2. Because the “good cop” speaks up for the suspect and even spends his own money to buy coffee, the principle of reciprocity creates psychological pressure on the suspect to return the favor.
3. The “good cop” always puts himself in the suspect’s position and keeps the suspect’s interests in mind. Even under normal circumstances, such a person would leave a good impression—let alone for a suspect in need of help. This savior figure is undoubtedly trustworthy, so revealing the truth to him feels entirely natural.

Whenever we face two people, we can always create a situation in which we like one and dislike the other. This gives the liked person an opportunity. This involves not only the liking principle but also the contrast principle.

### **The Principle of Reciprocity: You Are Good to Me, I Am Good to You**

The principle of reciprocity means that when others treat us well, we treat them well in return and try to repay their favors in kind; otherwise, we feel a sense of indebtedness. Both giving and receiving favors carry a sense of obligation, and repaying or reciprocating is an even stronger duty that cannot be shirked.

“What’s going on? The inspection team arrives tomorrow, and no one told me in advance?” The bureau chief stormed into the office director’s workspace after taking a call from headquarters.

"I, I, I put the notice..." The office director tried to explain, but the chief's expression cut him off.

"Look at this—how are we supposed to handle it? Nothing's been prepared!"

"I'm sorry, Chief. It was my oversight. I'll get everything ready right away."

In fact, the responsibility did not lie with the office director. As soon as he received the inspection notice from higher authorities, he immediately delivered it to the chief's office. At the time, the chief was on the phone and signaled with his eyes for the director to leave the notice on the desk.

"Maybe the chief forgot about it as soon as I left," the office director thought, but he said nothing.

Instead, he rushed back to the chief's office, retrieved the notice, and worked through the night—making calls and chasing numbers—to prepare all the required materials before the inspection team arrived. The inspection passed smoothly.

The office director breathed a sigh of relief, and so did the chief, who then decided to groom the director for advancement. The chief's decision was not solely because the director showed responsibility and courage; a more important reason was the "reciprocity mindset" the chief had developed toward him.

The subordinate had taken the blame and endured public criticism on the chief's behalf. Although the chief preserved his authority and face, he felt psychologically unbalanced and believed he owed his subordinate a favor that needed to be repaid at the first opportunity.

Psychologically, most people experience this reciprocity mindset: after receiving a benefit from someone, they want to return the favor—by helping in return, giving a gift, or treating the person to a meal.

An automobile salesperson once pulled out a pure white handkerchief while showing a car, spread it in front of the customer's old vehicle that was already slated for replacement, and politely said, "Let me check your car for you." He then crawled underneath. Moments later, he emerged, patting the now-dirty handkerchief, and said, "Everything looks fine." Seeing the soiled handkerchief, the customer felt moved and grateful for the salesperson's attentiveness. Although he had not planned to buy a new car immediately, the salesperson's service and dedication convinced him the purchase would be worthwhile, so he decided on the spot to trade in his vehicle. This salesperson repeatedly used the technique—letting a handkerchief get dirty for the customer's sake—to generate gratitude and close sales, significantly boosting his personal performance.

A psychology professor once conducted an experiment: he randomly selected people from a group of strangers and mailed them Christmas cards. Most recipients sent cards back. Those who replied never bothered to find out who the unfamiliar professor was. Their reason for reciprocating was simple: they could not owe anyone a favor, even if that "anyone" was a stranger.

During World War I, certain German special forces units were tasked with capturing prisoners behind enemy lines for interrogation. One soldier had succeeded at this mission many times. On this occasion he slipped through no-man's-land and entered an enemy trench. A lone soldier was eating, completely unguarded, and was quickly disarmed. Still holding a piece of bread, the soldier instinctively offered some to the German. Startled by the unexpected gesture, the German soldier did not take the man prisoner; instead, he returned alone, knowing his commander would be furious. The reason was that the bread triggered his reciprocity mindset—he felt he had received a favor and must repay it. At that moment, the only repayment he could offer was to leave the enemy soldier free.

Consider this: on a battlefield where life and death hang in the balance, a small piece of bread can save an enemy's life. In the workplace, can we not use small favors to build good relationships with superiors, colleagues, or subordinates? The answer is yes.

The principle of reciprocity holds that we should repay others in kind for what they have done for us. If someone gives us a birthday gift, we feel obliged to buy one for them on their birthday. Because of this principle, we treat returning a received favor as a duty that will arise at some future time; thus "returning the favor" becomes synonymous with expressing gratitude.

At an airport, a traveler was resting when a fundraiser approached and suddenly pressed a rose into his hand. The traveler instinctively accepted it, then immediately realized what had happened and tried to return the flower. The fundraiser refused and asked for a donation. The traveler tried again to hand the rose back, but the fundraiser again declined. A conflicted expression appeared on the traveler's face. He could have kept the rose and walked away without donating, yet some force pulled him back as he began to turn. After a moment's hesitation he turned again, still unable to leave. Finally he donated two yuan. Afterward he felt relieved, but he did not keep the rose; he tossed it into a trash bin.

Many people inwardly reject the rose yet feel compelled to accept it, only to discard it later. As a result, trash bins fill with roses, but the original givers simply collect the "trash" and reuse the flowers until they are no longer usable. This is the essence of the reciprocity principle: even a gift so unwelcome that the recipient discards it at the first opportunity can still exert influence during the reciprocity process.

The power of the principle lies in the fact that even a stranger—whether likable or not—who first offers a small benefit and then makes a request greatly increases the chance that the request will be granted. Some people create a sense of indebtedness simply by doing an unsolicited favor.

Careful consideration shows that the principle only requires us to repay favors we have received; it does not obligate us to repay favors we actively solicited. For example, a disabled-veterans organization found that including a small gift (such as personalized address labels with adhesive backs) in a fundraising letter raised the donation rate from 18 percent to 35 percent. Of course, if we actively request a benefit, the sense of obligation becomes even stronger—even when the benefit was unsolicited.

Why do people develop this mindset? Its social function provides the answer. The principle of reciprocity evolved to facilitate mutual exchange by removing the fear of loss when one party initiates a relationship. Once this function is served, an unsolicited benefit reliably produces indebtedness in the recipient. Most people share the underlying belief that giving is a duty, receiving is a duty, and repaying is an even greater duty.

In daily life, the duty to repay not only weakens our power to choose who gives us favors but transfers that power to others. Because the two parties are rarely equal, the real choice rests with the giver, who decides both the form of the initial favor and the form of repayment. Consequently, even an unsolicited benefit, once accepted, creates a sense of indebtedness.

In fact, even an unwanted gift can produce this feeling. The pressure of reciprocity forces us to repay the giver, regardless of whether we wanted the item. Yet we feel no corresponding pressure to purchase goods we do not actually need.

### **The Principle of Conformity: The Feeling of Being Isolated Is Unpleasant**

## Micro-expression Keywords

Conformity, also called the herd mentality, is the tendency to change one's behavior and beliefs to meet the expectations of a group. Many people do what they see others doing, echo what others say, and always try to follow the crowd—this is conformity.

A man walked into a hospital waiting room and was astonished to see everyone sitting in their underwear. Some drank coffee, some smoked, some read newspapers, and some chatted—all in their underwear.

At first he was surprised, but he soon concluded that these people must know something he did not. Twenty seconds later he removed his outer clothes, sat down in his underwear, and waited for the doctor.

The scene comes from American writer Alan Funt's 1960s television script *Candid Camera*.

Is the story funny? You probably think so. Yet similar laughable situations occur in everyday life.

On a street corner, someone sees a long line and assumes a rare opportunity has appeared, so he hurries to join it. The line grows until it stretches into the street. Only when the line rounds the corner does he realize everyone is waiting for the public toilet.

Most people share this psychological tendency: seeing a line makes them want to join it; seeing a crowd makes them want to approach. In psychology this tendency is called conformity, or the herd mentality—a readiness to alter one's behavior and beliefs to fit the demands of a group.

Conformity can appear as adopting the dominant behavior in a temporary situation or as long-term acceptance of prevailing ideas and practices. Almost everyone exhibits it.

A young man sees everyone on the street wearing bell-bottom trousers and buys a pair for himself, even though he is slight. A professional woman notices that all her office colleagues have permed hair and decides to get a perm, even though her hair is thick and coarse. A primary-school child sees that every other child has a Snoopy toy and wants one, even though his own toys already fill his room.

We are no exception. When shopping in a commercial district where neighboring stores sell nearly identical goods, some shops are packed while others are empty. Which shop do you usually enter? The one with the crowd, of course.

On television we constantly hear canned laughter—during variety shows, reality programs, crosstalk, skits, even dramas and films. The same holds for radio. If you listen to programs that tell jokes or funny stories, you will notice that laughter or applause follows every punch line, and it always sounds the same. These are recorded laughs.

You may wonder whether this is necessary. Yet the practice persists despite criticism. Humans naturally prefer genuine interaction and authentic responses. People enjoy sincere laughter, so many viewers reject canned laughter in skits and sitcoms, calling it stupid, fake, and shallow.

If audiences dislike it, why do producers continue using it? Because the minority who object does not represent the majority. Producers understand audience preferences and have seen research showing that canned laughter makes viewers laugh more often and longer, increases perceived humor, and makes even weak jokes or unfunny programs more popular.

Adding canned laughter therefore boosts both the apparent humor of a program and the audience's reaction. The effect is strongest for low-quality content. Producers follow their own logic and interests; if they followed

the audience's logic, that would be surprising. They are not deceiving us—everyone can distinguish recorded laughter from real laughter—yet we are still influenced and may form mistaken judgments.

This reflects the principle of conformity: when judging right and wrong, we usually look first at what others think, especially when deciding on correct behavior. If we see others doing something, we assume it is right. The actions and opinions of those around us shape our own conduct.

The conclusion is reasonable. We tend to regard the majority view as correct because following collective experience reduces mistakes—this is the advantage of social proof. It offers a shortcut for thinking and acting, yet it also makes us vulnerable to manipulation by opportunists. When we automatically respond to social proof, we can be misled by incomplete or false consensus, and problems arise.

Our mistake is not using others' laughter to judge humor; it is allowing fake laughter to produce an erroneous judgment even though the recording has nothing to do with actual humor.

As ordinary viewers we have grown accustomed to treating others' reactions as indicators of whether a program is funny, so we can be misled by a sound rather than by facts. Genuine audience laughter can make us laugh along; producers exploit our automatic response to even false consensus.

Merchants of all sizes are perhaps the most skilled at turning this psychology to profit.

In the late 1970s, Japan's Sony Corporation produced the Walkman, a portable cassette player. To open the market, Sony adopted a novel marketing approach. At the time, English-study fever was sweeping Japanese schools, and every student was required to have a tape recorder. Sony sent ten young employees to walk back and forth in front of school gates carrying Walkmans, playing music at high volume and acting as though they were enjoying themselves.

Students noticed and asked where the devices could be bought. Within days, Sony Walkmans appeared throughout Japanese primary, middle, and high schools. Sony's advertising campaign was highly efficient: instead of addressing the general public, the company targeted a specific group of students and used their conformity to spark a buying wave.

This psychological tactic is not limited to any one group. Anyone can apply it.

If you plan to open a small shop, invite relatives and friends to mill about inside and outside on opening day, pretending to shop. You need not worry about an empty store; the crowd will attract real customers.

If you are organizing a meeting and fear awkward silence, arrange in advance for several people to ask prepared questions. Once the atmosphere becomes lively, others who would otherwise stay quiet may join in.

If you are chairing a company meeting to discuss a controversial reform and expect most participants to remain silent, speak privately beforehand with a few colleagues and ask them to speak first. Their initiative can prompt others to express opinions as well.

### **Authority Principle: Why People Blindly Follow Others**

The powerful psychological pressure formed by social hierarchies has conditioned people who have long obeyed authority to follow orders, suppressing their natural instincts to the point that they would commit murder without hesitation. In daily life, blindly following authority can lead to mistakes.

In 1961, a newspaper in New Haven, Connecticut, ran this advertisement one day:

"Yale University seeks volunteers for a study on memory and learning methods. Any healthy adult male aged 20–55 who is not a current high school or college student may apply. Participants will receive \$4 per hour."

Yale University! Four dollars per hour! Soon, 15 workers, 16 salespeople, and 9 professionals signed up with their own motives.

These 40 applicants had no idea they would become subjects in a psychology experiment designed by 27-year-old Yale psychology assistant professor Stanley Milgram. The recruitment ad was a ruse, a small scheme that leveraged Yale's prestige and high pay. It was a scheme because Milgram's experiment proved shocking; in 2005, Britain's *Focus* magazine listed it among the ten experiments that shook the world.

The experiment sparked enormous controversy. In response, the United States issued strict guidelines for human psychology experiments in 1975 and, over subsequent decades, blocked all psychologists who attempted to replicate it. Why did this happen? Let us begin with the experiment itself.

The experiment aimed to study whether ordinary people would carry out instructions that violated moral standards. In addition to recruiting the 40 subjects, Milgram hired two qualified "actors." One played the role of a stern, meticulous authority figure who would issue various experimental commands to the subjects. The other played a student required to perform associative memory tasks and also served as the recipient of electric shocks.

During the experiment, the meticulous "authority figure" instructed participants to administer shocks to the student playing the "recipient" and told them that the higher the shock intensity, the greater the recipient's pain. The participants began delivering shocks, and screams from the recipient followed—simulated, of course.

The recipient began protesting and demanding that the experiment stop. The participant administering the shocks then asked the "authority figure" whether to continue. The authority figure replied, "Yes, continue." Through the behavior of these 40 participants, Milgram discovered that two-thirds continued to follow orders without regard for the screams. Most disturbingly, when the recipient fell silent, some participants still carried out the "absurd" commands issued by the authority figure.

You may find this psychological experiment cruel, yet Milgram's obedience-to-authority experiment revealed an even crueler fact—one that is frightening because it deepens our understanding of human nature. Perhaps you never imagined that a mentally normal person would inflict severe punishment on an innocent individual simply by obeying the orders of a so-called authority figure.

This psychological phenomenon arises because the person administering the shocks shifts responsibility onto the authority figure. This mirrors the defense offered by soldiers who committed atrocities against civilians in World War II concentration camps and massacres when they stood before military tribunals: "We bear no responsibility for those civilian deaths because we were merely following orders from superiors."

In addition to diffused responsibility, another factor is the inhibitory effect that forms psychologically and morally in individuals at the bottom of the "authority gradient." In other words, the powerful psychological pressure created by social hierarchies conditions people who have long obeyed authority to follow commands, suppressing their natural instincts to the point that they would commit murder without hesitation.

According to statistics from the aviation industry, in 20 percent of fatal crashes, the co-pilot's reluctance to point out the captain's erroneous judgment was a major contributing factor. These co-pilots would rather

sacrifice their own lives, those of the passengers, and those of their colleagues than challenge the captain's authority. This is a startling finding.

On December 1, 1993, a Northwest Airlines flight to Hibbing, Minnesota, suffered a major accident in which no one on board survived. Post-incident analysis of the cockpit voice recorder showed that the co-pilot noticed the aircraft was too high during landing but did not immediately correct the captain. Instead, he cautiously attempted to alert the captain: "Captain, are you planning to maintain this altitude?" Ultimately, the aircraft's excessive descent angle caused it to miss the runway completely. In the moments before the crash, the co-pilot continued to answer the captain's questions with deference. It was truly a tragedy.

What is authority? Authority refers to the person or thing with the highest status within a given domain. Authority indicates only status and does not prove absolute correctness; authority and correctness are two separate concepts. Blindly trusting and obeying authority can lead to mistakes. Recognizing the dangers of the psychological tendency to obey authority blindly, we must view every so-called authority figure rationally. We must not blindly follow their instructions. We must maintain our own thinking and never obey without question. Whenever we encounter authority, we should first ask ourselves: Why should I obey you unquestioningly?

### **Commitment Principle: Why People Keep Their Promises**

Everyone tends to keep their promises. A person whose words and actions are inconsistent is seen as confused, hypocritical, or even mentally unstable. Conversely, high consistency between words and actions is usually associated with strong character and superior intellect, reflecting a person's logic, stability, and honesty.

A study by two Canadian psychologists revealed a curious psychological pattern among racetrack bettors: once a bettor places a wager, confidence in the chosen horse immediately rises. The actual probability of that horse winning has not changed at all; it is still the same horse, the same track, and the same venue.

Once we make a decision or take a position, we face pressure from both internal and external sources that forces our words and actions to remain consistent with it. This is called the commitment-consistency principle.

Never underestimate the power of commitment. The vast majority of people, once they have made a statement, will continue to act in accordance with that statement. This results from the combined effect of external and internal pressures: external public opinion discourages becoming a traitor, while the internal constraints of the "self" and "superego" make people attach great importance to their commitments.

In our culture, a high degree of consistency between words and actions is widely praised—and rightly so. Most of the time, persisting consistently in what we do leads to good results. Without consistency, life would be difficult and chaotic.

Having learned the effectiveness of the commitment-consistency principle, we might consider whether this psychological dynamic can be applied in daily life.

I remember living in a compound-like neighborhood as a child, where children from several courtyards played together. When I was ten, my father bought me a soccer ball. This novelty naturally made me the new center of attention among the children, and even kids from distant courtyards came to play with me.

In truth, I preferred the distant courtyards because they had more pretty girls, whereas our courtyards had only boys. My act of "betrayal" naturally caused dissatisfaction. One day, when the children from the distant



courtyards were away and I had no one to play with, I went to find playmates in the nearby courtyards, only to be rejected. They declared in unison: "We won't play with you unless you stop betraying us from now on."

Not betraying them naturally meant playing only with them. I was unwilling, but with no one else available to kick the ball with, I vaguely agreed. Afterward, whenever I prepared to seek out children from other courtyards, my own courtyard playmates would bring up the matter to pressure me. Out of concern for face, I had to abandon any thought of "betrayal."

Gradually, I found myself automatically distancing myself from the other children. Even after I started school, I remained closer to these childhood playmates than to my classmates. This, I believe, illustrates an application of the commitment-consistency principle: whether through coercion or inducement, first get the other party to agree to your terms, and then they will gradually and automatically adhere to those terms.

The commitment-consistency principle also offers advantages in retail. The experienced computer assemblers I have met are skilled at managing the rhythm and sequence of their speech. They do not immediately recommend the models that would earn them the highest profit. Instead, they first ask in detail what you intend to use the computer for, appearing genuinely concerned about your purpose.

Next, they describe a configuration that, within their framing, seems tailor-made for you. At the moment you begin to feel this way, they suddenly ask, "How about it? This machine suits you perfectly, doesn't it?"

At that point, you cannot help but nod. The moment you answer "yes," you are caught. You will find yourself thinking, "This really is a machine that fits me well." Thereafter, no matter how many drawbacks the assembler mentions, you may find yourself defending the machine.

Therefore, a wise person must understand that assembling a computer is like betting on a horse race: do not place your bet lightly.

"Foolish consistency is the hobgoblin of little minds." This is a famous remark by Ralph Waldo Emerson. He meant that while consistency is generally good and even essential, we must also avoid foolish rigidity. We must guard against unthinking, automatic consistency because some people seek to exploit it for gain.

Thus, when we find ourselves maintaining consistency without thinking, we should ask ourselves whether that consistency is truly rational and whether other, more suitable choices exist.

Of course, when we want someone to do something, we can apply the consistency principle: if we can elicit a commitment from the other party, we have set the stage for them to automatically follow through on that prior commitment without further thought.

Written commitments are even better; they serve as an important psychological mechanism to prevent the other party from breaching a contract. They can genuinely change a person, partly because they are easily made public. Public commitments often carry lasting force. Simply having people write down their commitments produces remarkable results: they actually follow through on what they have written.

## **Second, the Desire to Possess Contested Things Is Almost Human Instinct**

Shoppers who rush to buy during large-scale clearance sales or major price reductions are almost involuntarily swept along. Infected by the frenzied crowd, they push forward without regard for themselves, joining the scramble and even tossing items they would normally ignore into their shopping bags. This differs little from a herd of animals fighting over food in the wild.

Anglers exploit this psychology. They first cast bait into the water, drawing a school of fish into a frenzied rush. Once the entire area is covered by fish with open mouths competing for food, the anglers throw in hooks without bait. The fish, nearly mad with fear that other fish will snatch their food, bite even the bare metal hooks. In this way, the anglers easily catch large numbers of fish.

Merchants who create an atmosphere of frantic competition to lure customers employ a tactic similar to that of anglers. Merchants holding big sales also publicize heavily, claiming they are conducting tearful clearances, loss-making "jumping off the building" sales, or "crocodile bleeding" discounts. Whatever form the "bait" takes, once it works, it draws a crowd competing for it. Amid the scramble, customers become agitated and anxious under the influence of the scene, completely losing self-control. They forget what they actually need and blindly fight for whatever is being contested, even snatching items from others' hands. In the end, customers who return home laden with packages often wonder inwardly: What came over me?

When something becomes scarce, not only do we want it more, but when we must compete to obtain it, our desire intensifies. A rational person should determine what they truly need before deciding to purchase. An irrational person may be swayed by advertising campaigns or other information into consuming things they could have done without.

Competition can be a psychological trap set by merchants. Conversely, you can create the illusion of competition to pressure or coerce the other party.

For example, in a newly built residential complex with only one barbershop, the owner may exploit a "sole provider" mentality to raise prices for greater profit rather than improving service quality to attract more customers. In such cases, even if residents repeatedly complain about high prices, the barbershop is unlikely to lower them because it has you cornered—there is no alternative.

If one day a second barbershop opens in the complex, the first now faces competition. If the competitor offers lower prices or better service, the first shop will lose customers. To prevent this, the original barbershop will proactively improve service or reduce prices.

Thus, the best way to make an opposing party yield is to make them believe they are not your only option.

This method is widely applied in real life:

- A young man courts a reserved, aloof young woman. After much effort he grows close to her, yet she remains noncommittal. One day he tells her that someone has introduced him to another girl whose conditions are excellent and that his family insists he meet her; he does not know what to do. Upon hearing this, the woman immediately changes her attitude, and the relationship rapidly warms.
- A project manager develops a project that generates substantial profit for the company. Expecting the boss to proactively raise his salary, he receives no response. He then tells the boss that a larger company is recruiting him for a higher position with greater pay and that he plans to start after the New Year. The boss becomes alarmed, immediately grants a raise, and promises a promotion once an opportunity arises.
- During stalled negotiations, an enterprise's negotiator has his secretary knock and enter, announcing an urgent phone call. The negotiator appears flustered and leaves "confidential materials" on the table. The other side secretly examines the materials and discovers they are "quotations" from other competitors. When the negotiator returns, the opposing party's attitude undergoes a 180-degree reversal and makes major concessions. An agreement is soon reached. In reality, the "confidential materials" were carefully fabricated by the negotiator.

## Manipulation Technique: Traumatic One-Time Learning

When controlling the manipulated party, manipulators frequently employ a fifth technique called traumatic one-time learning.

When Ahua first met Zhang Li, she thought he was a nice, polite man. After several months of contact, the two people of similar background discussed marriage.

Everything proceeded as Ahua had expected until the day they went to buy a wedding bed. Until then, Ahua had made all household decisions, large and small. Although the heavy responsibilities left her somewhat weary, the joy of the approaching wedding made them bearable.

Inside the furniture store, Ahua spotted a stylish round bed priced at 18,000 yuan. Although expensive, she liked its appearance and color, so she habitually took out her bank card to pay without consulting Zhang Li.

"Wait," Zhang Li's voice, tinged with anger, came from behind her. "Do you have to buy this bed?"

"What's wrong?" Ahua had grown accustomed to making decisions alone, and Zhang Li had never voiced an opinion. This situation surprised her.

"I don't like round beds," Zhang Li snapped, stiff-necked.

"But don't you think the beds over there look too plain? Round beds are popular lately," Ahua replied, not yet sensing anything unusual and assuming he was simply being petulant. She tried to persuade him.

"I said no, so no!"

What followed left Ahua stunned. She had never seen Zhang Li so angry. Even inside the furniture store, he made no effort to control his rage. Eyes wide, he grabbed her arm roughly: "Buy that one!"

"But that one is so ugly..."

Ahua's protest was drowned out by Zhang Li's stormy roar: "I said buy that one, so buy that one, or the wedding is off! From beginning to end, everything has to be your way, everything has to be what you like. Where is my opinion? I am the head of the household—where do you put my position..."

This hysterical outburst left Ahua frozen. In tears, she purchased the bed Zhang Li had pointed to. Even the store staff were stunned by the couple's unusual way of shopping.

From that day on, the dynamic between Ahua and Zhang Li reversed completely. All household matters became Zhang Li's decisions. Whenever Ahua tried to offer an opinion, Zhang Li needed only to glare, and she would recall the scene in the furniture store. She never dared to speak up again.

The relationship between Ahua and Zhang Li was less that of an engaged couple than that of a manipulated party and a manipulator. The manipulator, Zhang Li, used traumatic one-time learning to intimidate Ahua emotionally, firmly controlling her so that she dared not resist or disobey.

## Pigeon Experiment

Regarding this point, when conducting experiments, psychologists did not choose white mice again but instead selected two pigeons:

**Pigeon A** was placed in a cage and went an entire day without food. Driven by hunger, Pigeon A pecked around the cage. Whenever it pecked the lever specially placed inside, the psychologists would add a bit of food to the feed trough, and Pigeon A quickly ate it up.

The second time it pecked the lever, it may still have been by chance, but soon afterward Pigeon A discovered that every time it pecked the lever, some delicious food would appear in the feed trough. Before long, Pigeon A formed a habit: as soon as it felt hungry, it would peck the lever.

Next, the psychologists turned their attention to **Pigeon B**, which had been placed in the cage.

Pigeon B's initial situation was the same as Pigeon A's. The psychologists trained it through ten lever-pecking sessions. Once Pigeon B had just formed the habit of pecking the lever, the psychologists changed the reward strategy. Not every lever peck by Pigeon B received a reward; rewards became irregular. Sometimes Pigeon B received a reward after two pecks, while at other times it received one only after more than ten pecks.

After both pigeons had formed their habits, the psychologists stopped rewarding them entirely. In other words, no matter how they pecked the lever, they could no longer obtain food.

The psychologists took out a stopwatch and recorded how long each pigeon persisted. Pigeon A continued for only a short time. After a few pecks its rate slowed noticeably, and it soon realized the reward had been completely withdrawn. Within minutes it abandoned the pointless behavior.

Pigeon B, however, kept pecking the lever until it was physically exhausted.

Throughout the process, Pigeon A clearly received more food than Pigeon B, yet it persisted for less time. Why?

In behavioral psychology this phenomenon is called **intermittent reinforcement**, also known as partial reinforcement. Unlike continuous positive or negative reinforcement, this process applies the two types of reinforcement intermittently and irregularly. The intermittency can create an addictive sensation in the subject. Like Pigeon B in the experiment, because its initial rewards were sporadic and unpredictable, it could never determine whether a reward would follow its action. Consequently, even when no reward appeared, it continued to fantasize about one that might come and grew more dependent on the lever. Pigeon A, which had always received consistent positive reinforcement, quickly and decisively abandoned the lever once the reward disappeared.

### **Example of Xiao Jin and Xiao Nan**

Xiao Jin and Xiao Nan worked as salespeople at an appliance store. Their daily job was to mind the shop and pitch products whenever customers arrived.

The two were originally equal colleagues, but because Xiao Jin had more seniority and was very familiar with after-sales service and reports, she would occasionally "bully" the newcomer Xiao Nan.

"I want fried rice from the place on the corner." Every noon Xiao Jin would send Xiao Nan to buy lunch, and most of the time she would claim she had no change and give her no money.

Unable to tolerate it any longer, Xiao Nan finally retorted, "Why is it always me? Can't you go yourself?"

"Myself?" Xiao Nan's resistance stunned Xiao Jin. After a long pause she gave a cold laugh. "Fine. From now on I'll go myself. But without a proper lunch break, I probably won't have the energy to handle difficult customers

in the afternoon. After this, you'll be responsible for closing any deals you make yourself."

"Wait... wait a minute." At the thought of those intimidating customers, Xiao Nan's resolve collapsed. Because she was unfamiliar with the work, every customer scolded her until she was dizzy and unsure how to respond. In recent days Xiao Jin had indeed solved quite a few problems for her.

If she refused to buy lunch for Xiao Jin, the next time such a situation arose Xiao Jin would certainly refuse to help. The thought made Xiao Nan panic. She hurried after Xiao Jin, grabbed her arm, and said with a forced smile, "Sister Jin, I wasn't feeling well earlier, so my tone was a bit sharp. Please don't hold it against me. You want fried rice, right? I'll go buy it and add two eggs for you, okay?"

Watching Xiao Nan's retreating figure, Xiao Jin smiled with satisfaction.

The relationship between Xiao Jin and Xiao Nan was clearly one of manipulation. Xiao Jin acted as the manipulator and Xiao Nan as the manipulated. The manipulator controlled Xiao Nan's obedience by threatening to withhold business assistance if she failed to follow orders.

While punishment may be less effective than positive or negative reinforcement for controlling behavior, its key value lies in its deterrent effect. Under this effect the manipulated party spontaneously performs actions to please the manipulator, making it highly effective for large-scale, widespread manipulation. To achieve better results, punishment is usually combined with other manipulation methods.

### **Story of Xiao Bai and Mike**

When Xiao Bai first joined the company, the endless rules and regulations posted on the office wall made his head spin. He had already heard that the CEO of his department was difficult to please, but he had not expected the department's own rules to far exceed the company's.

"Good morning. You must be the new hire. I'm your supervisor, Mike Chen. You can call me Mike." The sharp-looking supervisor extended his hand with a stern expression. Xiao Bai quickly shook it.

"Even though you're new, you must follow company rules," Mike said, immediately giving Xiao Bai a warning. "In addition, in our department I don't want to see subordinates making childish mistakes, so we have more rules than other departments. I've already marked the points that require attention, so you'd better memorize them."

"Understood, understood," Xiao Bai replied hastily, though inwardly he was unconvinced.

Seeming to read Xiao Bai's thoughts, Mike's gaze sharpened. "I'm giving you three days. During those three days you don't need to do anything else—just memorize the rules on the wall. After three days, come to my office for a test."

What kind of supervisor had he been assigned? Xiao Bai grumbled inwardly but did not dare disobey.

The three days passed quickly, and Xiao Bai had memorized the wall of rules thoroughly. Afterward he settled into his work routine. What he did not notice, however, was that the three days of memorization were not as useless as he had thought. Whenever he felt like slacking off or cutting corners on a plan, the relevant clause would surface in his mind.

Doing so might save time, but if Mike found out, given his character he would certainly enforce the rules strictly. That would mean trouble.

With this thought, Xiao Bai no longer dared to slack off at work.

Mike's wall of "rules," though seemingly cumbersome, proved highly effective for management. Because of their deterrent power, subordinates like Xiao Bai weighed the consequences before slacking off. As a result, Mike's department consistently ranked at the top of the company; everyone in it worked at 200 percent effort.

## Real Case

A friend gave up a well-paid position at a large company with an annual salary of several hundred thousand yuan to become CEO of a private enterprise. I once strongly suspected he had been misled, but he said, "These days it's not easy to find a good job, but it's even harder to find a good boss."

The saying "a scholar dies for one who appreciates him" is entirely accurate. After observing for some time, I realized his boss had not won him over with money or generous benefits but with constant praise and approval, making him willing to work devotedly.

Whenever my friend completed a project or closed a deal, his boss never missed an opportunity to offer praise, affirm his ability, and discuss "expanding the present and envisioning the future." As a result, my friend's motivation rose further and his loyalty to his boss grew. In contrast, at his previous large company, despite earning several times more, he had never felt valued or received recognition amid the abundance of talent and had remained dispirited and unmotivated.

This boss was truly shrewd. With minimal capital and positive reinforcement he secured a capable subordinate who was willing to serve him wholeheartedly. Praise, encouragement, consideration, smiles, attention, and recognition—do not underestimate these small gestures that cost nothing. Truly skilled manipulators know how to use these minutiae to satisfy the manipulated party's subconscious vanity, self-confidence, or need for validation through positive reinforcement, thereby making the person willingly obey and regard the manipulator as a "kindred spirit" or "mentor."

Of course, even more skilled manipulators go beyond verbal praise and set tangible rewards based on the manipulated party's desires. These rewards feel more desirable and pleasurable than ordinary encouragement, so the manipulated party becomes more inclined to repeat the previously affirmed behavior and applies greater effort.

In the manipulation process, positive reinforcement is the least repellent method. Therefore, if one finds oneself under positive-reinforcement manipulation, there is no need for excessive worry. The only thing to watch is whether the manipulator will actually deliver on promises. In any case, a sustained positive-reinforcement relationship tends to leave both parties satisfied.

## White Mouse Experiment

After conducting the black-and-white compartment experiment, the psychologists immediately performed another experiment on a different white mouse.

They placed the mouse in the black compartment, which had been wired with electricity. The wires covered the entire black compartment; any slight contact delivered an electric shock. Within seconds the poor mouse kept dodging and jumping, eventually trembling and urinating under the stress. Soon, while trying to hide, it touched the white door and entered the safe zone—the unwired white compartment.

After spending some time in the white compartment, the mouse was returned to the black compartment. This time it took only a short while to run from the black compartment into the white one.

In subsequent trials the time the mouse took to run from the black compartment to the white compartment grew shorter. Eventually, even after the psychologists removed the wires from the black compartment, the mouse would instinctively dash into the white compartment at the first opportunity. In its mind the black compartment had become permanently linked with the pain of electric shock.

Another striking phenomenon occurred during the experiment: the time this mouse took to run from the black compartment to the white compartment was much shorter than that of mice that had received positive reinforcement.

Why did the mouse act faster without any cheese reward? In behavioral psychology this phenomenon is called negative reinforcement. Because the mouse performed the action the scientists wanted—running from the black compartment into the white compartment—it escaped the painful and frightening electric shocks. Thereafter, whenever it was placed back in the black compartment, the danger of shock was immediately imprinted in its mind. Consequently, even after the wires had been removed, the mouse still raced toward what it considered the safe zone.

Negative reinforcement is therefore also known as the “aversive conditioning method.” When the victim yields to the manipulator, the reward is not pleasant praise or a prize but the cessation or avoidance of unpleasant negative stimuli. The manipulator exploits the victim’s fear and aversion to these negative stimuli to bring the victim under control and ensure obedience.

## Workplace Case

When Xiao Hua first joined the company, her supervisor, Manager Fang, thought highly of her and often praised her intelligence and steady work. With such favor from her superior, Xiao Hua believed her conversion to permanent status would be no problem.

As the end of her probation period approached, however, Manager Fang continued to praise her without giving any indication that she would be retained. Moreover, he kept assigning her various tasks, including work that should have been his, forcing her to work overtime.

Constantly exploited yet receiving no clear answer, Xiao Hua grew uneasy. One day, when Manager Fang seemed in a good mood, she cautiously asked, “Manager Fang, I’ve been working here for almost two months now. Do you think I can be converted to permanent status?”

“Conversion is simple. As long as you work hard, there’s no difficulty,” Manager Fang replied evasively.

“Then... may I take two days off? The overtime has been exhausting, and I’m not familiar with many things. I’m really worn out,” Xiao Hua said hesitantly.

A very important task was due, and Xiao Hua’s request for leave would force Manager Fang to work overtime himself. His expression darkened. “Xiao Hua, I understand your hardship, but isn’t this how all newcomers are? Precisely because you know less, you must put in extra effort to study. If your professional skills aren’t solid, how can I convert you to permanent status?”

“Well...” Compared with conversion, physical and mental exhaustion seemed secondary. Xiao Hua braced herself and nodded reluctantly. “Don’t worry, Manager Fang. I’ll definitely finish the report you gave me today

by tomorrow.”

“Good. That’s more like it.” Manager Fang nodded with satisfaction.

The relationship between Xiao Hua and Manager Fang was a typical case of negative-reinforcement control. The manipulator, Manager Fang, firmly controlled Xiao Hua’s behavior by exploiting her fear of losing her job, making her willingly work for him.

Ai Li, a graduate of a prestigious university, was a new force in the company. Diligent and intelligent, she was well liked by her superiors.

During a recent assignment, however, Ai Li was so exhausted that she forgot to make an important phone call. When the client’s contact person called, the project manager summoned Ai Li to his office and scolded her severely.

Perhaps because he was in a bad mood, the manager’s reprimand was harsh and sarcastic; he even pointed at her nose and slammed the desk to express his anger. The tirade left Ai Li terrified. She ran out of the office in tears.

From that day on, whenever Ai Li saw the manager, the image of him losing his temper would flash through her mind. To avoid another outburst, she behaved cautiously in his presence and immediately carried out whatever he said.

No one is immune to mistakes, however. Not long afterward Ai Li was reprimanded again. Although the manager’s anger was milder this time, Ai Li’s fear had reached its peak. She stared at his moving mouth, her ears filled with buzzing, unable to hear clearly what he was saying <|eos|>

## **The Psychological Mechanism of Punishment**

Mike’s manipulation technique is called “punishment” in behavioral psychology. As the term literally suggests, punishment means that if the person being manipulated engages in behavior the manipulator does not allow, the manipulated person will directly experience some negative consequence as punishment. Generally, the manipulated person recognizes the connection between their own behavior and the negative experience; out of fear of punishment, they stop the behavior they were about to perform and instead try to do things that please the manipulator in order to reduce their own anxiety about being punished.

Punishment and negative reinforcement share many similarities: both exploit the manipulated person’s aversion and fear of negative events to force compliance. The sole difference lies in timing. In negative reinforcement, the negative experience occurs when the manipulated person fails to follow the manipulator’s wishes; the pressure of that experience forces compliance, and the experience ends only when the manipulated person yields.

In punishment, performing the disallowed action is directly linked to the negative experience. The manipulator sets a rule: “If you do something that displeases me, you will receive this punishment.” In other words, the negative experience has not yet occurred, but the threat already creates a sense of crisis that deters the manipulated person from acting in ways that might anger the manipulator.

The sequence in which the negative experience arises is the clearest distinction between punishment and negative reinforcement.



Punishment is widely applied as discipline or as stipulated clauses. Beyond explicitly stated rules, many common “punishment” phenomena also appear in daily life.

### **The Principle of Positive Reinforcement**

The method humans use to manipulate white mice is called positive reinforcement. Positive reinforcement rests on the universal human tendency to seek approval and the persistent desire for others’ praise. When an action receives affirmation or reward and the other party signals a wish for the behavior to continue, that affirmation and reward constitute positive reinforcement. This form of manipulation does not produce aversion or boredom; instead, it generates pleasant experiences, which is why positive reinforcement works.

Positive reinforcement appears frequently in everyday life. When we achieve results at work, a boss may reward us with a promotion. When we earn good grades, parents and teachers offer praise. Even a smile or a word of recognition can motivate further effort. Because this reinforcement brings pleasant experiences and psychological satisfaction, it is the most common and most readily accepted manipulation technique in interpersonal relationships.

In another sense, positive reinforcement is less a one-sided manipulation than a process of mutual influence. We unconsciously attend to the actions of those we love, depend on, or respect, and we “approve” of their behavior in various ways; they, in turn, unconsciously strengthen certain behaviors because of the feedback we provide. This interactive pattern is especially common under positive reinforcement.

### **The Essence of Negative Reinforcement**

The essence of negative reinforcement is that the manipulator uses behaviors such as intimidation, silent treatment, threats, or shouting to generate fear, inferiority, or guilt in the manipulated person. To end this painful and uneasy feeling, the manipulated person must comply with, acquiesce in, or yield to the manipulator’s unreasonable demands in exchange for temporary peace and stability.

Although negative reinforcement can secure obedience, the negative emotions it produces—irritability, anger, resentment—often accumulate. Excessive buildup may lead to depression, self-abandonment, or even a vicious cycle in which the manipulated person later applies the same technique to others.

Not all negative reinforcement relies on overt intimidation. Some manipulators display pained, pitiful, or injured expressions or engage in constant nagging criticism that induces shame and guilt, prompting willing compliance. This, too, is a form of negative reinforcement.

Compared with positive reinforcement, negative reinforcement is clearly unpleasant. People repeatedly think, “If I don’t do this, he will ignore me again,” “If I don’t work overtime, the boss might fire me,” or “If I report this, he might blame me.” These “what ifs” create the psychological habit of yielding to avoid negative outcomes, allowing the manipulator to succeed repeatedly.

### **Experimental Case**

Psychologists once conducted the following experiment. They placed a laboratory white mouse inside a specially constructed cage divided into two compartments—one white, one black—with a white door between them.

The mouse was placed in the black compartment; a large piece of high-quality cheese was placed in the white compartment. Attracted by the scent or the sight of the white door, the mouse pushed the door open, entered the white compartment, and ate the cheese.

In subsequent trials, the psychologists returned the mouse to the black compartment and again placed cheese in the white compartment. Each time, the mouse took less time to move from the black compartment to the white one; it appeared to have grown “smarter.”

The experiment was repeated several times. Each trial showed a further reduction in the time required. Eventually, even when no cheese was placed in the white compartment, the mouse still ran quickly from the black compartment to the white one, as though the behavior had become habitual.

The psychologists intended the experiment to demonstrate positive reinforcement. After completing the task of moving from the black to the white compartment, the mouse promptly received a reward; in its mind, the white compartment became equated with delicious cheese.

### **Post-Traumatic Stress Psychological Disorder**

Everyone has experienced traumatic events. Being bitten by a dog in childhood, beaten by parents while growing up, or bullied by stronger classmates—these deepest wounds do not simply fade with time. Most produce serious aftereffects known in behavioral psychology as post-traumatic stress psychological disorder.

Traumatic one-time learning arises from this disorder. The condition appears after a person has undergone an extremely terrifying event—witnessing another’s death or facing one’s own death or serious injury—and exhibits symptoms of psychological debilitation. The victim feels despair and terror not only at the moment of the event; later, any similar situation can re-trigger the memory and the fear.

In the manipulative use of traumatic one-time learning, the manipulator delivers a powerful verbal or physical blow. Under the intense threat, the manipulated person loses control over their own behavior. Thereafter, whenever the manipulator displays a similar expression or action, the manipulated person’s emotions become immediately tense and they strive to prevent the terrifying event from recurring.

### **First, Everyone Has a Competitive Consciousness**

Advertisers frequently exploit this psychological tendency. They show in commercials how popular their product is and urge viewers to “buy now before it’s gone.” Television images depict crowds lining up outside stores before opening hours, hands reaching for shelves, and goods disappearing rapidly.

The message conveyed is that the product is in high demand, that many people want it, and that they are competing directly with the viewer for it.

The sensation of competing with others for scarce resources is highly stimulating. An indifferent lover may become ardent when a rival appears; people in relationships often use this tactic by deliberately or inadvertently revealing the existence of admirers. Salespeople also employ the technique. When showing a house to a hesitant buyer, a real-estate agent may mention that many others are interested or have already viewed it. The strategy usually succeeds: fearing they will lose out, the buyer quickly becomes more proactive.

### **Influence on Humans**

Intermittent reinforcement affects humans as well as birds. Gamblers seen on television continue to stake their savings despite knowing that “nine out of ten bets lose.” Their behavior resembles that of the hopeful pigeon B: an occasional win functions as a reward and deepens addiction to the game.

Continuous positive reinforcement may lose effectiveness once the connection is broken or the reward no longer satisfies. Continuous negative reinforcement can generate resentment and anger that accumulate and produce unexpected consequences for the manipulator. Intermittent reinforcement, however, deepens addictive behavior because the uncertainty it introduces keeps the manipulated person anxious and unsettled. Throughout the process, the manipulated person remains in suspense, unable to predict whether the next outcome will be a reward or renewed indifference, and therefore complies more cautiously and fearfully.

### **Intermittent Reinforcement: The “Gambling” Style Manipulation That One Cannot Extricate From**

Micro-expression Keywords: The most terrifying thing in the world is not gods, demons, or ghosts, but the unknown. Intermittent reinforcement exploits precisely this fact. By using uncertainty to manipulate the other person’s mind, it ensures they can never determine when the next event will occur, leaving them perpetually concerned, anxious, and unsettled, and therefore led by the manipulator.

Both positive and negative reinforcement are uniformly “good” or “bad,” yet in real life no one is consistently good or bad toward another. Manipulators often combine the two techniques and thereby achieve more pronounced results.

### **Trauma: Once Bitten by a Snake, Afraid of Ropes for Ten Years**

Micro-expression Keywords: Manipulators typically frighten or threaten the manipulated person through displays of loss of control. As the saying goes, once there is a first time, a second time will follow. After the first successful instance of traumatic one-time learning, the manipulated person’s greatest fear—the second or third occurrence—will eventually arrive.

A Chinese proverb states: once bitten by a snake, one fears ropes for ten years. It describes how a person who has been bitten by a snake remains fearful for a long time afterward, becoming nervous even at the sight of objects resembling a snake. This characteristic closely resembles the manipulation technique discussed below.

### **The Essence of Intermittent Reinforcement**

The power of intermittent reinforcement lies in its “gambling”-like quality. The feeling of uncertainty combined with hope dilutes the manipulated person’s attention to their own interests and fosters impulsive behavior contrary to those interests. The reward that may or may not appear prevents the manipulated person from giving up, trapping them in the “game.”

Skilled practitioners of intermittent reinforcement keep the manipulated person in a constant state of anxiety and walking on eggshells while unwilling to abandon hope, thereby shaping both the manipulated person’s perception of the manipulator and their subsequent reactions.

### **Manifestations and Coping in the Family**

Traumatic one-time learning appears not only in romantic and workplace settings but also throughout family life. Husbands who beat their wives or abuse their children provide the clearest examples. Tragically, most

victims do not anticipate that they are being manipulated; they endure silently until they can no longer tolerate the situation and then erupt in uncontrolled emotion.

Avoiding traumatic one-time learning requires a clear assessment of the situation, a correct understanding of one's position relative to others, and the overcoming of fear. The manipulated person's compliance only encourages the manipulator to continue.

### **The Scarcity Principle: The Scarcer the Resources, the More Fierce the Competition**

Everyone possesses competitive consciousness. As the saying goes, "the quick hand gets it; the slow hand gets nothing." People fear losing to rivals, regret missing opportunities, and dislike forgoing something they might obtain by trying. Astute merchants exploit this competitive consciousness to set psychological traps; the unwary easily fall in.

In daily life, merchants frequently hold limited-time flash sales that reliably generate substantial revenue.

What explains this phenomenon?

### **Chapter Thirteen Seeing Through Manipulation Patterns, No One Can Manipulate Me**

Living in contemporary society inevitably involves manipulating others and being manipulated. Even if we do not wish to manipulate anyone, living in a world where others manipulate us is always an uncomfortable experience. Therefore, in interpersonal interactions we must learn to read another person's psychology through their behavior, movements, and expressions, to discern their intentions, and to recognize the manipulation techniques they employ, so that we can break free from being manipulated.

### **Negative Reinforcement: The Psychological Inertia of Compromising with Evil**

Micro-expression Keywords: Compared with positive reinforcement, negative reinforcement produces fear, anger, and discomfort. Yet, out of fear that an imagined negative outcome will occur, the person subjected to negative reinforcement consistently yields to the manipulator. Such compliance only encourages the manipulator to continue using negative reinforcement.

### **Punishment: Rules Are an Unsurpassable Mountain**

Micro-expression Keywords: The essence of punishment as a manipulation technique is to exploit people's fear of negative experiences in order to compel obedience. Threats from others, workplace regulations, and even laws and statutes all operate through the mechanism of punishment.

### **Positive Reinforcement: An Affirmation Model Beneficial to Both**

Wise parents and effective leaders understand how to apply positive reinforcement to obtain the greatest loyalty and motivation from children or subordinates with the least expenditure of resources. Because the resulting pleasant experience does not generate resentment in the manipulated person, positive reinforcement possesses unique appeal.

Expanding Psychological Games, Grasping the Key to Victory

### **Cake Division Effect: Bargaining is Also an Art**

Micro-expression keywords Regarding the actual situations that may arise from cake division psychology, we can summarize many similar small strategies to help us achieve optimal benefits. But it must be warned that zero-sum games can easily turn into conflicts in some cases, which will result in a "negative sum," and both parties will suffer losses. Therefore, before dividing the cake, one must grasp the other party's acceptable bottom line and try not to touch it.

A cake is given to two children to eat at the same time. Both want to be the one who divides it, fearing the other will cut it unfairly. So they keep arguing about it.

At this point, their father walks over and says: One cuts, the other chooses first. That way it is fair.

Why do the two children keep arguing over dividing the cake? Because if one cuts more, the other eats less. There is only one cake; once eaten, it is gone. If A eats a bit more, B must eat a bit less. Assume that when each eats exactly half, the gain is 0. Then if one eats a little more, the gain is 1, and the other eats a little less, so the gain is -1. The sum of both parties' gains equals zero.

This situation, where one party gains and the other loses in a game, is called a zero-sum game. The psychological state people develop in a zero-sum game is cake division psychology: always fearing the other side will encroach on one's own interests. This leads to the ubiquitous phenomenon of bargaining.

Bargaining is the most common behavior driven by cake division psychology. Both sides hold the view that if you gain an advantage, my returns will decrease. So after calculating costs, the seller sets a price with profit ten times the cost, while the buyer immediately demands a one-third cut.

Theoretically, the ideal outcome of cake division psychology is an even split, producing a relatively fair result where "A cuts the cake and B chooses first." In practice, however, unequal professional knowledge and information between buyer and seller make it difficult for one side to truly maximize its interests. A buyer who haggles a 100-yuan item down to 80 yuan feels triumphant, as if victorious, when the actual cost may be only 30 yuan.

This is the excellent pricing strategy: making consumers believe they have gotten a bargain. The big discounts and clearance sales in shopping malls all align with consumer psychology. In simple terms, it is nothing more than using a black cloth to hide part of the cake during division, causing the other party to misjudge the cake's size.

Consumers cannot know the exact figures for raw material collection costs, factory assembly-line costs, labor costs, energy costs, or marketing costs. We cannot guess how much labor value is embodied in a product. This is the merchant's greatest reliance for active pricing. What consumers can do is merely "shop around." Yet when three merchants reach a consensus to compete on the surface while actually colluding to control the market, consumers can only be deceived.

Returning to the cake, add another assumption: what if it is an ice-cream cake? That is, if the bargaining parties fail to reach consensus within a certain time, both interests are harmed. The time spent bargaining is also a cost; this is called waiting cost. Generally, waiting cost is not applied equally to both sides but often targets one party.

There is a segment in Guo Degang's crosstalk about a man walking on the street who suddenly sees two city inspectors cleaning the area. He runs 500 meters to a lamb skewer stall, orders 100 skewers, and the owner works hard to grill them and hand them over just as the inspectors approach. The owner naturally cannot wait and rolls up his stall to flee.

If the owner had continued waiting, he would have been caught by the inspectors; confiscation and fines would make the waiting cost unbearable, so the customer benefited cheaply.

Of course, in many cases, one party in a game can impose waiting costs on the other. There was a large antique dealer in old Beijing who had three jade bi discs. A wealthy merchant from Yangzhou had reserved them with a 300-yuan silver deposit.

A week later, the Yangzhou merchant arrived at the antique shop to negotiate. The owner quoted 800 yuan for the three discs.

The merchant immediately shook his head: That is an outrageous price. I will buy only two for 500 yuan!

Without a word, the antique dealer picked up one disc from the table and dropped it to the floor. Before the Yangzhou merchant could react, it shattered. The crisp sound reminded him that this jade was a rare treasure.

The merchant stood up at once and questioned the dealer in alarm. The dealer sipped his tea calmly: Since you want only two, the third has no purpose. These two are still 800 yuan.

The merchant grew angrier: Three for 800, two still 800? Are you treating me as a fool?

The dealer picked up another disc and smashed it on the floor. The Yangzhou merchant was stunned. The dealer continued: Now only one remains on the table. I ask 1,000 yuan, take it or leave it.

The merchant protested: One disc more expensive than three? You...

Before he finished, the dealer reached for the last disc. The merchant, forgetting decorum, lunged forward, grabbed the dealer's sleeve, and shouted: 1,000, deal!

After the transaction, the apprentice cleaned the hall and said to the dealer with heartache: Master, you were too ruthless...

The dealer stroked his beard and smiled proudly: The two smashed discs were fakes. I had Master Ye from the east side make them three days ago for less than 100 yuan...

The antique dealer fabricated a waiting cost for the Yangzhou merchant, eliminating any reason to bargain, and at the final moment crushed his psychological defenses, raising the price to a high level and profiting handsomely.

Using waiting costs to bargain is not only the seller's privilege. In my second year studying abroad, two close classmates and I rented a three-person apartment near school. The first year's contract was 1,500 dollars monthly rent. When the lease expired in May of the second year, we prepared to negotiate renewal. The landlord proposed raising it to 2,000 dollars per month.

The landlord said: More and more international students are coming to the university town, and the rental market is heating up. 1,500 dollars was last year's market price; raising you to 2,000 dollars now is also market price and does not take advantage of you. If you have difficulties, you can renew for one month and then look elsewhere. See if 2,000 dollars is worth it.

I understood the landlord was right and roughly grasped his thinking: he saw other landlords raising prices and similar apartments reaching 2,000 dollars, so he was tempted. Yet although he had his reasons, we had ours: three international students already found the apartment tight; such an increase might leave us "sleeping on the street."

My roommates were an ingenuous Indian and a reticent Peruvian. I could not rely on them, so I thought it over and presented the landlord with a calculation: Sir, what you say is reasonable, but you overlook one thing.

The landlord was taken aback: What?

I continued: Let us do the math. If we move out now and new tenants move in at the current market price of 2,000 dollars, compared with last year you would earn an extra 6,000 dollars next year, correct?

The landlord nodded. I went on: But you overlook that it is now May; within half a month all colleges here will begin a three-month summer vacation. This is a university town, so you probably will not rent the place out again at 2,000 dollars a month until at least three months later when school resumes. In other words, if we leave, you lose at least three months' rent, 4,500 dollars, right?

The landlord said: Even so, I would still earn 1,500 dollars.

I replied: Yes, but you must consider many issues: whether new students will smoke, throw parties, or use marijuana in your apartment, or burn the place down. You have seen how carefully we three treat this apartment; the basic furnishings are almost undamaged. We were even twice designated star tenants by the building manager. Frankly, it will be hard to find tenants as good as us. Are you sure you want to take that risk for 1,500 dollars a year?

The landlord sighed; I saw he was moved. I pressed further: But rising rents nearby are an undeniable fact, and we are poor students, sir. You must understand. How about this: we raise the rent symbolically by 100 dollars. According to our earlier calculation, you lose only 300 dollars a year. 300 dollars buys peace of mind, avoids potential trouble from new tenants, and purchases our friendship. Choose, sir.

The landlord laughed heartily: If you were not Chinese I would suggest you run for senator! Deal, as you say!

I often use this incident to teach juniors; it is one of my proudest "bargaining battles." The reason I succeeded was that I seized the landlord's waiting cost, so I should thank the American education system's three-month long summer vacation, which forced him to rent the place before the holiday or lose three months' rent.

Finally, many people feel a certain shame about the "cake division effect" and are reluctant to bargain. More than ten years after graduation, I visited a professor who had taken great care of me during university. The elderly man was nearly seventy and retired at home. When I visited, he was furnishing his son's new apartment and about to buy furniture. I said I had dealt with people in this line and offered to go with him so he would not be cheated.

The teacher gladly took me to the furniture mall. After selecting a set, he prepared to pay. I immediately held his hand and began bargaining with the seller. Eventually the store manager was called and gave an 20 percent discount, saving more than 1,000 yuan.

I was about to claim credit when, on the way back, the teacher sternly scolded me for losing his face. He continued giving me the cold shoulder at dinner. After the teacher's wife learned the reason, she only laughed and told me: Your teacher is like that; do not take it to heart.

I could not be angry with the teacher and could only smile bitterly. After the bitter smile, I understood his temperament. As an old-generation intellectual, his pride made him ashamed of "bargaining." Many people, to varying degrees, share this complex. It is unnecessary, because once a person enters a zero-sum game, avoiding personal loss is natural and justified; it is a person's instinctive psychological reaction.

## Information Discrimination Effect: Why Billions of Yuan in Ad Slots Are So Sought After

Without control, people's information discrimination is subjective, superficial, and wishful. The process of overcoming this subjective information discrimination is often the shift from emotion-dominated thinking to reason-dominated thinking. This is necessary for a person's maturity and growth. So let us begin with "not judging a person arbitrarily by clothing and appearance."

A few years ago I bought an apartment. When I first moved in, there was inevitable upheaval. Because I had to do dirty and heavy work, I wore very old clothes. After a day of barely getting things in order, my appearance could be described as dust-covered and smoke-stained, temples gray, fingers black.

Feeling thirsty, I went out to buy water. After purchasing a bottle of mineral water at the convenience store, I realized I had left my keys, phone, and wallet behind. I had already drunk from the bottle, so I could not return it. I could only say awkwardly: Sorry, I did not bring money. I live in this neighborhood; can I pay you this evening?

The convenience store owner looked at me suspiciously: There are not many households in this neighborhood; how have I not seen you?

I said I had just moved in, building 16.

Convenience store owner: Building 16 is right across; I can see the unit door. You can go back and get it now.

I said awkwardly again: I did not bring the key.

The owner said somewhat disdainfully: Fine, fine, take the water and go. If you have not eaten I can give you a steamed bun. You have it pretty hard. The neighborhood next door is run by the subdistrict office; they can help unemployed people with reemployment procedures. Let an old man say this: at your age, what can you not do...

Faced with the owner's well-intentioned chatter, I could only smile bitterly. My dark skin from heavy labor and ragged clothes, unable to produce even one yuan for mineral water, being mistaken for a vagrant or beggar was understandable. Later, because I often dealt with this small owner, we became friendly and laughed about the incident. Afterward, however, I realized the event sketched from the side a certain trajectory of human psychology: the information discrimination effect.

The information discrimination effect means that people's cognitive process toward others or things is often achieved through information categorization. For example, when a girl wears a bubble skirt and princess boots, people think she is a cute and petite girl; when she wears a halter dress and high heels, people think she is mature and charming; when she wears a tank top, cropped pants, and canvas shoes, everyone thinks she is energetic, a sporty girl... Yet in reality, this is only the part the girl intends to show outsiders; as for what the girl herself is really like, perhaps even she has not fully grasped.

This method of information discrimination actually stems from human laziness. A person's true character and inner world are extremely complex; when we get to know someone, it is difficult to conduct such deep, all-around recognition. However, we can judge the person through similar labels, saving considerable effort. Zhang San has a hot temper; Li Si is honest and generous. Through such labeling, we treat others as a bundle of information. In this process of information discrimination, people are labeled.

The same applies to objects.



At the end of 2005, the total bid amount for CCTV's 2006 "golden resource" advertising slots reached 5.87 billion yuan. Many large merchants spent hundreds of millions simply to have their products appear on screen for 30 seconds before the evening news.

Statistics show that the combined coverage and viewership of channels airing popular entertainment programs or TV dramas far exceed CCTV's "golden resources." Yet even the total advertising fees for all prime-time slots on these stations do not reach one-fifth of CCTV's same-time rate.

As a promotional method, the strategy of "buying out popular local stations in clusters" is clearly far superior to "CCTV golden resources." Why do so many large manufacturers still flock to CCTV?

The reason is simple: their advertising is not merely to promote products but, more importantly, to tell consumers that the company has the ability to advertise on CCTV, implying abundant capital and substantial resources, so the goods produced cannot be too poor.

In fact, human discrimination effects are also common in nature. In bird populations, female birds often choose males according to this principle: the more splendid the plumage, the more popular.

According to nature's law of survival of the fittest, splendid plumage is actually detrimental to male birds' survival: splendid feathers are often heavy, making males clumsier; moreover, splendid feathers are too conspicuous, making predators and hunters easier to spot.

Yet female birds still flock to males with splendid plumage. Why? Because only strong, healthy males can survive while retaining splendid plumage. In other words, splendid plumage represents a survival cost, and those willing to bear this cost are often the elite among birds. This is analogous to large manufacturers spending enormous advertising fees: hundreds of millions in cost small merchants dare not bear, but I dare, because I have the strength.

Because of the information discrimination effect, people's understanding of things tends to be superficial and labeled. When this simple laziness is exploited, it harms our own interests. Large manufacturers, for instance, do not actually bear the enormous advertising costs; they factor such costs into product pricing, passing them on to consumers.

Therefore, smart people, when choosing goods, do not rely on "reputation" but establish another set of clever, rational discrimination mechanisms: for two similar products with comparable prices, buy the one without reputation, because the famous one necessarily includes advertising costs, so the use value embodied in that product is lower. If concerned about quality, one might as well review it through non-commercial pure quality certification methods: for example, checking whether it has international quality system certification or how the merchants selling it are regarded for reputation...

The same rational discrimination mechanism can be applied to people. A famous story of King Solomon in the Bible offers enlightenment:

Two women and their several-month-old infants lived in one room. One woman accidentally smothered her own child while sleeping and placed the dead infant in the other woman's arms, taking the living infant instead.

At dawn the woman discovered the dead infant in her arms was not her own and brought the matter before King Solomon. In court both women claimed the child as theirs. King Solomon thought for a moment and decided to cut the child in half, giving each woman half.

The false mother agreed to the judgment.

The true mother, upon hearing this, cried out: The child is not mine; give her the child; I do not want it.

King Solomon awarded the child to the true mother.

King Solomon devised a more rational and wise method of information discrimination. In our everyday information discrimination of others, we should likewise draw on King Solomon's wisdom: move beyond traditional, unthinking, intuitive information discrimination and enter deeper information discrimination. Sherlock Holmes represents the extreme of this rational information discrimination; through details of a person's speech, behavior, clothing, and appearance, he could deduce that a beggar had been a noble in his grandfather's generation.

Of course, Holmes's myth-level deductive power appears only in fiction, but this method of information discrimination can be learned by all of us.

### **Stag Hunt Effect: Breaking the Non-Cooperation Misconception, Achieving Common Benefits**

Micro-expression keywords: The damage the stag-hunt mentality inflicts on a community is severe; even in small groups it becomes an obstacle to cooperation. Creating a transcendent power is an effective way to overcome that obstacle. Such a power may seem abstract, yet it becomes convincing once you identify a strong guarantor.

In *Discourse on the Origin and Basis of Inequality Among Men*, philosopher Rousseau recounts a story that illustrates a common human habit of mind—

Two hunters are in a forest. Hunting separately with crude bows, each can take three rabbits. Hunting together with a large trap, they can take one stag. Each rabbit feeds one person for three days; the stag feeds each for five days.

Cooperation yields far greater returns than acting alone, yet most hunters still choose not to cooperate, even though the separate hauls are modest.

The episode later became known as the stag hunt effect, describing the irrational aversion to mutually beneficial cooperation. Economics once posited the “rational agent,” whose every action is calculated to maximize self-interest. As consumer-psychology research deepened, the concept grew increasingly theoretical and lost practical force. Today even traditional economists concede that a purely rational agent does not exist in reality, any more than the frictionless plane of classical physics.

The stag hunt effect is one major barrier to perfect rationality. Periodic economic crises in Western societies, when they escalate into financial crises, trigger bank runs. Runs drain liquidity, commercial banks collapse, panic spreads, financial and trust systems disintegrate, currency and commodity exchange freeze, and depression follows. A bank run is the stag hunt effect in action: everyone knows that if no one runs, the bank survives, yet each fears others will withdraw first and therefore rushes to withdraw.

The late-Qing merchant prince Hu Xueyan met his downfall in precisely such a run.

The crisis began when Hu started hoarding raw silk in the 1880s. He accumulated 8,000 bales—two-thirds of Shanghai's annual turnover—and drove the price to record levels. Still unsatisfied, he continued converting all available cash into silk, believing that once the market was empty he would become the sole supplier and dictate prices.

Then a rumor spread: foreign creditors were demanding repayment and Hu was about to go bankrupt. The rumor was not entirely false. Hu had guaranteed a loan for another merchant; when the borrower defaulted, the foreign lenders turned to him. Hu's resources and reputation made repayment feasible, yet the public knew none of this. A modest debt of 1,000 silver dollars was magnified into "ten thousand taels of gold." Depositors stormed his banks; reserves were emptied. Combined with the capital tied up in silk, his commercial empire collapsed overnight.

Hu's failure was only the prelude. Within a month, runs destroyed hundreds of native banks in Beijing, Yangzhou, Shanghai, Fuzhou, Ningbo, Zhenjiang, and Hankou. A single rumor shattered the Qing empire's nascent financial-trust system.

Whether in the late Qing or in modern America, people need only pause to realize that if no one runs, a solvent bank remains solvent and everyone continues to enjoy safe, convenient services plus interest. Yet whenever the question is "If everyone refrains, no harm occurs," each person thinks instead, "If they act and I do not, I lose." The non-cooperating hunter reasons the same way: what if I help trap the stag and my partner takes it all?

The stag hunt effect inflicts enormous damage on both society and individuals: each person suspects others will harm him, so even when calm cooperation would produce mutual gain, no one cooperates.

Public indifference to communal resources is another manifestation. Outdoor trash bins are battered and filthy while private homes are spotless. People assume household fixtures must be kept clean but treat public property as expendable. Yet the taxes that fund those facilities come from the same citizens. When public property deteriorates, inconvenience rises and government spending increases, leading to higher taxes that fall back on the same people. Everyone knows this, yet the neglect persists—the stag hunt effect at work.

Its harm is not insurmountable. A transcendent regulatory power can restore rationality.

Before Franklin D. Roosevelt took office, the United States followed laissez-faire policies, trusting that market forces would reconcile selfish strategies into an optimal public good. That blind faith produced the financial crisis of the early twentieth century, a worldwide depression that set major economies back decades and left people starving beneath neon lights.

Roosevelt introduced new economic policies: government intervention, large-scale public works, and credit guarantees for banks. The resulting recovery lifted the United States out of the gloom; government had become the economy's transcendent stabilizer.

In daily life, when you seek win-win cooperation but the other party refuses, you can invoke or create such a transcendent presence to free them from the stag hunt effect. As a hunter preparing to stalk a stag, you might swear on your mother's name—provided you are known to be filial—that the kill will be divided fairly. Or you might ask the village elder to stand as guarantor.

### **Chicken Game Effect: Appeasement and Compromise—The Heart of Martial Arts Aims to Stop War**

Micro-expression keywords: The tendency to avoid harm through compromise lies deep in everyone, rooted in the universal impulse to seek gain and shun loss. In daily life it is useful to recognize both one's own and others' chicken-game impulses, distinguishing avoidable conflicts from unavoidable ones. For the former, grasp their nature; for the latter, devise responses.

When two evenly matched people meet on a narrow path, one must yield for the other to pass. Several outcomes are possible:

- Neither yields; they fight to a bloody draw.
- One yields and the other does not; the yielder loses face while the standee wins—or the roles reverse.

The best outcome for either side is the other's retreat, yet misjudging the situation can produce the worst: mutual injury. The safer course, therefore, is to yield when yielding is appropriate.

In real terms this suggests that a "cowardly" disposition can maximize benefit; Americans therefore call the scenario the "chicken game." After the term entered Chinese, the slang sense of "chicken" as coward was overlooked and the phrase was rendered "斗鸡效应."

The chicken game effect highlights the objective advantage of an appeasement mindset in a game-theoretic setting: when interests clash, fighting to the end usually injures both parties, whereas stopping while ahead is the more viable strategy. As the proverb says, "Step back and the sky opens wide."

George Washington led untrained colonial militias to victory over well-equipped British forces by exploiting Anglo-French rivalry, securing the independence of the thirteen colonies. He understood, however, that Britain had not yet committed its full strength. Once London resolved its conflict with France and redirected its resources to North America, the militias would be overwhelmed. While Britain was still occupied elsewhere, Washington sent his ablest deputy, John Jay, to negotiate the Jay Treaty—an unequal agreement that preserved British trade privileges in North America, restricted American exports, and capped the tonnage of the U.S. Navy.

Thus the newly independent United States remained economically subordinate to Britain and, in effect, acknowledged a residual suzerainty. The terms were unpalatable to a public that had just fought for sovereignty, yet most legislators and informed observers recognized that temporary compromise was the only prudent course. History confirmed that Washington's restraint spared the young nation premature entanglement in war and granted a century of peace that later underpinned its rise in two world wars.

Although leaders often declare they will never compromise, the human instinct to avoid harm leads people to choose the less damaging path—conciliation with an adversary. The chicken game effect simply measures how much compromise people will in fact tolerate beneath a rhetoric of intransigence.

From the day I entered school my parents urged me to yield and avoid trouble; other children received the same counsel. After a harmonious primary and secondary education, fistfights increased at university. The small plaza outside our dormitory windows became a regular arena for arranged brawls among male students. What began as a dispute over five yuan and eighty cents between two individuals quickly drew in friends and roommates until dozens were involved. Just as the melee seemed inevitable, someone on each side would discover a distant kinship or hometown tie, the fight would be called off, and the original antagonists might even become friends. In practice, the instigators deliberately delayed so that the crowd would grow and the fight would never start.

No one truly wants to fight; the saying "Better a dog at peace than a man at war" captures the universal aversion. Because conflict usually leaves both sides worse off, the chicken game effect is refined to an art in everyday life. Most quarrels of pride reduce to the problem of "providing a face-saving exit." Once such an exit appears, both parties step back without loss of dignity or goodwill.

The same aversion to harm can produce miscalculation. Neville Chamberlain underestimated Hitler's ambitions and pursued appeasement, allowing Nazi Germany to overrun half of Europe before turning on France, which fell in weeks.

That is the chicken game effect gone wrong. It is not invincible; objective analysis overcomes its downside. Winston Churchill, who consistently advocated resistance to Nazism, correctly assessed Hitler's intentions.

When dealing with potential adversaries, therefore, one must analyze objectively to determine which conflicts can be resolved and which cannot.

Bill Gates avoided the chicken game's distorting influence. Among countless rivals he distinguished those with whom cooperation was possible from those with whom it was not.

He routinely acquired small firms that possessed valuable technology but lacked capital or market presence. When Microsoft's actions harmed such firms, he preferred settlement to litigation.

Against well-funded competitors he fought for market share yet also sought cooperation. Apple is the classic case. Although Apple computers never adopted Windows, in 2000 Microsoft developed a custom version of Office for the Macintosh platform.

Refusing to be ruled by emotion is essential to neutralizing the chicken game effect; only by objectively identifying the other side's tolerance threshold can one optimize one's own interests.

### **The Wise Pig Effect: More Work Does Not Necessarily Yield More Gains, Inaction Is Not Necessarily Laziness**

Micro-expression keywords: The psychological cause of the Wise Pig Effect is not laziness. Although inaction caused by laziness and inaction caused by the Wise Pig Effect appear identical, their psychological origins differ greatly. In the former, people cannot overcome their own inertia, yet rationally they should realize that such inaction harms or at least does not benefit them. In the latter, after objective consideration, the individual concludes that inaction is more advantageous than action.

Nobel laureate in economics John Nash once described the following scenario:

Two highly intelligent pigs share a sty—one large pig with a big appetite and one small pig with a moderate appetite.

At one end of the sty is the food trough; at the other is the button that controls it. Pressing the button once releases 10 jin of feed into the trough. Because the distance between trough and button is great, the pig that runs from trough to button expends energy equivalent to 1 jin of feed.

- If the small pig presses the button while the large pig waits at the trough, the feeding ratio is 9:1. After subtracting the small pig's running cost, the actual ratio becomes 9:0.
- If the large pig presses the button while the small pig waits at the trough, the feeding ratio is 6:4. After subtracting the large pig's cost, the ratio becomes 5:4.

Because both pigs are intelligent, each selects the strategy that best serves its own interests. The small pig therefore refuses to press the button: if the large pig waits, the small pig's share barely covers its expenditure and it will eventually starve.

If the small pig remains inactive, the large pig must act or starve. The final outcome is that the small pig waits at the trough while the large pig repeatedly presses the button. The small pig receives less feed than the large pig, yet its net gain exceeds the cost of action. Nash termed this the Wise Pig Effect. The effect objectively explains a group-psychology phenomenon: people assume that more capable individuals should shoulder greater responsibility and perform more labor—i.e., greater ability entails greater responsibility.

The evolution of international relations over the past two centuries illustrates the same group psychology. After the Industrial Revolution, Britain and France rose first, set international rules, reaped benefits, and shouldered mediating responsibilities. In the nineteenth century, Bismarck's Germany and Metternich's Austria formed a new powerful alliance, competed more aggressively for overseas colonies, and established a new European order. From the twentieth century onward, Americans have assumed that American values are world values and have promoted their own values more zealously than any previous power.

In China's Ming dynasty, as East Asia's strongest state, the court accepted similar duties: during the Yongle reign, Zheng He's voyages distributed vast treasury wealth as gifts to neighboring states, incorporating them into the Ming sphere. In the mid-to-late Ming, when Japanese daimyo Toyotomi Hideyoshi invaded Korea, the Ming government dispatched troops—an obligation recorded as the "Imjin War."

The small pig's gain from inaction largely depends on the large pig's "large-pig cognition," which leads the large pig to accept higher costs because inaction would also cause it to starve. The Wise Pig Effect is thus a shared cognition that produces a joint psychological outcome.

In daily life, if you are the large pig, consciously reduce the Wise Pig Effect by weakening the small pigs' self-perception as "small pigs." Prevent their self-awakening if possible. Even if they realize they can profit without working, and circumstances force you to expend more labor or cost, perform a remedial favor: make them feel indebted. The simplest method is to act as though the task is difficult or to feign fatigue and hardship.

When the cost burden exceeds the large pig's capacity, it must find a way to escape the Wise Pig pattern.

I once shared a large house with five others. The others rarely cooked, yet I prepared two meals daily and therefore used the gas stove most. Although my neighbors cooked infrequently, they still used the stove occasionally, resulting in a monthly gas bill of about 50 yuan. At first the bill was split equally. Later they felt this was unfair because I cooked more and proposed a new arrangement. I agreed that I would pay the gas bill alone and stop contributing to the electricity bill. On paper this seemed fair.

I underestimated their ingenuity. Once I assumed the entire gas bill, they began using the stove freely. The next month the bill more than doubled to over 100 yuan. After three months I suggested changing the arrangement again, but they refused unanimously. They knew my dependence on gas was severe: they could endure a shutoff; I could not.

Paying an extra 60–70 yuan monthly was unsustainable. In the third month I stopped paying the gas bill. After the supply was cut, I cheerfully produced a second-hand induction cooker I had bought for a few dozen yuan. The cooker consumed electricity, which, under our agreement, I did not pay for. Within days my neighbors approached me to renegotiate the division of gas and electricity costs.

Actively changing one's large-pig position is essential for large pigs. Small pigs follow a different maxim: "It is good to rest in the shade of a great tree." Even without working, a large pig will labor on their behalf. The small pig's task is simply to bind itself to the large pig's chariot and make the large pig understand the current reality: the small pig's inaction causes no immediate harm, yet the large pig's inaction starves everyone, and the large pig cannot easily discard the small pig.

The sty's keeper—the manager or rule-maker—should prevent the emergence of Wise Pig Effect mindsets. A rule that permits free-riding frustrates everyone except the small pigs; therefore, rules should reward effort proportionally so that both large and small pigs are motivated to work hard.

### **The Dirty Face Effect: The Operation of Common Knowledge and Unwritten Rules**

Micro-expression keywords: According to Gustave Le Bon in *The Crowd*, group psychology is blind and incapable of complex rational thought. When a group possesses certain common knowledge and an individual lacking that knowledge attempts to enter, only two outcomes are possible: the individual is assimilated and acquires the common knowledge, or the individual refuses it and is isolated by the group.

Logician Littlewood once recounted the following story:

Three men with dirty faces sit in a room without mirrors. A beautiful woman enters, sees their faces, and says helplessly, "One of you has a dirty face."

Each man looks at the other two, sees that both are dirty, assumes his own face is clean, and feels relieved.

When they look up again and notice that everyone else also looks relieved, they immediately understand the situation and all three blush.

Why do they blush together? Because of common knowledge.

Initially they do not know whether their own faces are dirty, but they see the others' dirty faces and assume their own are clean. The woman has stated that someone's face is dirty—everyone now knows this information and knows that everyone else knows it. When they observe one another's relieved expressions a second time, the only explanation is that all three faces are dirty.

This common knowledge changes the situation; Littlewood called the change the Dirty Face Effect. Its core is common knowledge.

The renowned crosstalk performer Liu Baorui once told the following anecdote:

In the late Qing dynasty, a successful tea merchant in Jiangnan decided to purchase an official post. After two years as county magistrate he learned that further promotion required the favor of his superior, the provincial governor. He therefore sent a large bribe and obtained an audience.

Upon arrival he was offered tea. In Qing officialdom, when a subordinate visited a superior, the subordinate was never to drink the tea; its sole purpose was to signal the end of the meeting when the superior lifted the cup.

Unaware of this custom, the magistrate, who knew a great deal about tea, immediately tasted it. Everyone present—the servant, the guards, the governor—was stunned. Even newly admitted scholars knew not to drink a superior's tea; how could a county magistrate be ignorant of so basic a rule?

The magistrate sensed the awkwardness and said politely, "Your Excellency, in my ten years selling tea I have never tasted anything so fine. Please drink some yourself; don't let it go cold."

The governor could only sigh and think: were it not for the generous bribe, he would have been thrown out.

In this incident, "a subordinate must not drink the superior's tea" and "lifting the cup ends the audience" were two items of common knowledge within the officialdom—shared understandings that everyone in the group

knew others also possessed. Historian Wu Si termed such understandings “unwritten rules.”

Entering a group without its common knowledge inevitably incurs extra costs. The magistrate’s “lack of sense” made the governor dislike him; any future promotion would require still more silver.

In the Qing officialdom, the profession of “private secretary” (shiye) existed precisely to sell common knowledge. Although a general set of official rules existed, local variations abounded. A newly arrived magistrate needed to master these local customs, which were never written in books. Private secretaries knew them intimately and therefore became indispensable. Famous private secretaries, such as those from Shaoxing, could amass enough wealth after several years to become large landowners. Many officials borrowed money to hire a good private secretary.

Private secretaries received such generous treatment precisely because officials recognized the importance of common knowledge. Group-psychology founder Gustave Le Bon defined a group as a collection of people who share the same mode of thought and feeling. Common knowledge operates similarly: everyone in the group knows a certain fact and knows that everyone else knows it.

Consequently, anyone who enters a group possessing common knowledge without possessing it will be excluded—that is the force of the Dirty Face Effect. To join a group, one must first acquire its common knowledge.

### **The Gunman Effect: Staying Outside the Conflict, the Commoner’s Victory**

Micro-expression keywords: Only the most outstanding individuals win in the end? Wrong. As the saying goes, the tallest tree catches the wind, and when two tigers fight, one is injured. Shelter beneath the excellence of the tall tree; be the fox behind the tigers. Let those who love conflict fight; the rest of us should simply master our skills and do our work well.

American economists fond of Westerns once devised the following game:

Three mutually hostile gunmen in a small town agree to a duel. Each wants to kill the other two. Because they are old enemies, each knows the others’ abilities:

- Gunman A hits eight out of ten shots;
- Gunman B hits six out of ten;
- Gunman C hits four out of ten.

They form an equilateral triangle. Combat is imminent.

An economic psychologist interrupts: which one is most likely to survive?

According to martial-arts novels or Hollywood logic, A should survive because of superior marksmanship. C, the weakest, should be the first to fall.

The economists’ answer is the opposite. A must aim at the greater threat, B; B must aim at A. Consequently, the weakest gunman, C, is targeted by no one. While A and B shoot each other, C can take the first shot at whichever survives. With luck, A and B may eliminate each other.

The psychologist then asks: if C shoots first, whom should he shoot?



He could aim at the greatest threat, A. If he misses, A will not retaliate, because C has demonstrated his poor aim; A would rather eliminate the more dangerous B first.

Yet if C luckily kills A, he becomes B's only remaining threat and must fight B, who is stronger; C may then die.

Therefore, if C shoots first, the best strategy is to fire harmlessly into the air. As long as the current balance remains, C is the least threatening person present and has the highest survival probability.

The weakest gunman enjoys an advantage so long as he does not upset the balance. Because the strong overlook the weak in combat, this strategic advantage is called the Gunman Effect.

The Three Kingdoms period supplies a vivid illustration. After the Battle of Red Cliff, Sun Quan and Liu Bei defeated Cao Cao, who fled north. Guan Yu released Cao Cao at Huarong Pass, allowing him to return to Xuchang and restore Wei's power.

The reason is simple: had Cao Cao died on the Yangtze, Sun Wu would have become the dominant power, directly threatening the still-weak Liu Bei. To keep Sun Wu occupied, a unified and formidable Wei had to survive, preserving room for Liu Bei between the two giants.

Several years later the Battle of Yiling destroyed the fragile Sun-Liu accord. Liu Bei led his entire army against Sun Quan but was routed by Lu Xun's fire attack. Lu Xun pursued the remnants to Yufu. When he prepared to cross the river, he saw stones arranged in an ominous pattern; a sudden gale arose and he withdrew, remarking that Zhuge Liang was truly a sleeping dragon.

Although Lu Xun possessed the strength to continue the pursuit and expand Wu's territory, he did not. A reasonably strong Shu could threaten Wei more effectively, granting Wu a breathing space of peace.

Events unfolded as Wu expected. Zhuge Liang returned to Shu, spent his remaining years launching northern expeditions (the Six Campaigns on Qishan), while Wu watched from the sidelines and enjoyed years of peaceful development.

The Gunman Effect operates between states and, more commonly, in everyday group life. Whenever interests intersect and conflict arises, avoid direct confrontation. Even when you achieve substantial results, do not draw excessive attention.

When no major stakes are involved, keep your capabilities hidden from rivals. Let your boss alone know your true competence. In the same office, avoid trying to stand out; appear somewhat dull and slow so that seemingly capable colleagues compete with and undermine one another. Simply do your work well and let your superior recognize who is truly capable.

### **Emotional Sunk Cost: The Couple's Story**

When I was studying abroad, a couple lived two doors down from me. Their only child, a six-year-old daughter, was struck and killed by a car while playing in the street. The entire neighborhood witnessed the couple's grief. The once-helpful pair grew cold and silent; weeds overran their yard—an issue treated in the United States almost as seriously as a credit default. Their relationship also became visibly strained. They used to stroll hand in hand at dusk; at the funeral, observers noted almost no physical contact between them. Everything suggested they had lost their will to live. Left unchecked, the loving couple would likely divorce and spend the rest of their lives in regret.

The neighbors therefore devised a plan.

One night the husband, awakened by a noise he first mistook for a rat, got up to investigate. Suddenly the bedroom door was kicked open. He fell to the floor; his wife woke with a start. Five or six masked men carrying carbines burst into the room. Before the couple could react, gun barrels were pressed to their heads.

The pair did not resist. The husband forced himself to stay calm and said, "Take whatever you want, but please don't hurt us."

The men shook their heads. A burly figure spoke in a low voice: "Shut up. You've seen our faces."

The husband replied, "I swear I haven't. There's an ATM nearby. My account holds more than three hundred thousand dollars. I'll withdraw it all—just don't harm my wife."

Before the robbers could answer, the wife threw her arms around her husband. "No. If you go, I go. I want to stay with him."

The burly man snarled, "Quiet. You think we don't know your game? You want us to take you and leave your wife to call the police so they can catch us at the ATM. Not a chance..."

Suddenly another voice cut in: "Boss, there's a car outside. Could be the cops."

The burly man cursed. "Damn it. We have to run—now!"

The intruders fled but did not go far. They crouched beneath the bedroom window, imitating the sound of footsteps receding, then removed their masks. They were the husband's closest friends in the neighborhood. They listened intently.

Inside, the stunned couple embraced and wept. The husband, still shaken, patted his wife's back and comforted her. Through tears she said, "Darling, I couldn't bear to lose both of you."

The next day, when the husband prepared to report the incident to his best friend—a police officer in the community—the friend stopped him and revealed the truth: he had been the burly robber.

As a witness I was astonished by the Americans' bold ingenuity, yet I also understood the emotional mechanism that produces the Concorde fallacy. The couple's grief over their child had blinded them to each other, leaving them without the will to live. In reality they still loved one another. The friends' extreme intervention forced them, in a moment of terror, to see each other again and to recognize what gave their lives meaning. If you have friends who have withdrawn after losing a loved one, remember that others still love them. Let the past sorrow become sunk cost and live well for those who remain.

## **The Concorde Story**

In the 1960s the British and French governments jointly began developing a supersonic airliner meant to astonish the world—fast, high-capacity, safe, comfortable, and versatile.

Vast sums were poured into the project. A single engine component cost hundreds of millions of pounds; the oversized cabin, stability requirements, and aerodynamic challenges turned the aircraft into a financial black hole. France even issued supplementary national debt to keep the program alive.

As work progressed, analysts realized that the passenger volumes of the two national carriers could never generate enough revenue to recover the investment. Yet neither government could afford to abandon the

project; doing so would write off billions already spent. They therefore continued pouring money into a venture they knew would never turn a profit.

The supersonic airliner finally flew in 1969 and was named Concorde. Commercial service began on 1 January 1976 on routes between Europe and the Americas. Its high operating costs left it uncompetitive, and it never achieved its commercial targets.

Knowing the plan could not succeed, the governments kept investing because they could not bear to lose the earlier outlays; losses therefore mounted. This irrational pattern, exemplified by the two governments' actions, became known as the Concorde fallacy. In economics, costs that cannot be recovered once a project is abandoned are called sunk costs. Attachment to sunk costs is what drives the Concorde fallacy. The fallacy lies in mistakenly treating sunk costs as though they were recoverable.

By contrast, Boeing acted more rationally. After learning of the Anglo-French project, Boeing also began work on a supersonic airliner and built two prototypes, the Boeing 2707, by 1971. Market analysis soon showed the investment could not be recouped in the medium term, so the program was cancelled. Britain and France ultimately built twenty Concorde and brought the aircraft into service, but at far greater loss.

Although the Concorde fallacy originated in a "dogfight" between major powers, it is not confined to governments.

### **Personal Case: Guitar and Sunk Cost**

My father loved the guitar but, busy with work, could not study it himself. He therefore placed his hopes on me and spent more than three thousand yuan on a classical guitar with a Brazilian rosewood body.

I disliked being constrained. Although I enjoyed music, I resented being forced to practice. My father saw my attitude and realized I was unlikely to study seriously, yet he still felt the three thousand yuan could not be wasted. He therefore spent another six thousand yuan on a youth classical-guitar training course.

Anyone who has studied classical guitar knows how tedious it is for a child. Before long I was leading other pupils in mischief. By the end of the semester I still could not read a full staff. My father later called it his worst investment.

He knew that further spending would only compound the loss, yet he invested the additional six thousand yuan because he over-weighted the original three-thousand-yuan sunk cost. The Concorde fallacy operated in his case as well.

Moreover, anything that can be regarded as a cost—money, time, emotion—can trigger the same error.

### **Film and Time Cost**

I once took my girlfriend to a film so poor I will not name it. After fifteen minutes I could not continue and prepared to leave. She insisted we stay, arguing that walking out on a ticket that had cost more than a hundred yuan would be an even greater waste.

Our reasoning differed. She treated the money already spent as a reason to endure the remaining two hours. I viewed the hundred-plus yuan as sunk cost. If the film proved good, the outlay was justified; if merely mediocre, finishing it might still be acceptable. But if it was genuinely bad, the next two hours would be pure waste—two hours added to the original monetary loss.

## The Story of Lu Xiangxian

Lu Xiangxian, a chancellor in the mid-Tang dynasty, served earlier as prefect of Tongzhou. One of his servants encountered the Tongzhou adjutant in the street but failed to dismount and salute. The adjutant, enraged, ordered his attendants to flog the servant—an act intended to intimidate Lu. Afterward the adjutant went to Lu's residence to apologize, yet his tone remained arrogant: "I have offended Your Excellency. Please dismiss me from office."

Lu, holding a book, did not look up. "A servant who fails to dismount before an official may or may not be beaten. An official who beats his superior's servant may or may not be dismissed." He then returned to his reading.

The adjutant sat awkwardly for half an hour before taking his leave. Thereafter he behaved with greater restraint.

## Application in Child-Rearing Strategy

An American friend once compared Chinese and American approaches to raising children. "Punish big mistakes severely, small mistakes lightly, and never let them pass. The harshest punishment is withholding a meal." After one prank his father ordered him to go twenty-four hours without food, though both knew the real lesson was simply that punishment was possible.

The experience taught him two things:

- He never committed a serious offense under supervision.
- He learned that, in dealing with others, it is enough to make them aware of one's capacity to punish.

Effective child-rearing does not require frequent punishment; it requires that the child understand both that punishment is possible and that misbehavior will bring it. Constant beating or unchecked indulgence are equally unsuitable.

## Commitment-Threat Effect in International Relations

During the Cold War the advent of nuclear weapons paradoxically made the world appear safer: each side retained a second-strike capability, so any initiator would also be destroyed. This realization led nations to emphasize "second-strike capability."

- Indian Navy Admiral Prakash stated that India's second-strike capability would be especially devastating.
- Russia's Topol-series missiles gained mobility, and submarine-launched missiles entered service.

Responsible nuclear powers understand that deterrence must be credible: others must believe that using nuclear weapons would produce catastrophic consequences. The commitment-threat effect has allowed the world to survive amid weapons of mass destruction.

## The Core of the Commitment-Threat Effect

How does one lead, supervise, or simply live among others? Machiavelli wrote in *The Prince* that people love a ruler of their own free will, but they fear a ruler by the ruler's will. A prudent ruler therefore grounds authority in his own will.

People respect those who can inflict harm more than those who are unfailingly kind. The proverb “a biting dog does not bark” captures the same idea.

## **Chapter 14 Mastering Psychological Games and Seizing the Winning Edge**

Some people always seem to anticipate others’ thoughts and gain the advantage; others can persuade anyone and keep both allies and rivals under control. You may think these abilities are innate and that success is therefore foreordained. I tell you otherwise: if you are less popular or less successful, it is not because you lack luck or talent; it is because you have not yet mastered the psychological tactics of social interaction.

### **Overcoming the Sunk Cost Fallacy**

Experienced hunters in the rainforest know that once a crocodile seizes a leg, the only option is to sever the leg with a machete; otherwise the entire body will be lost. This “amputate-the-leg” resolve is the surest way to overcome the sunk cost fallacy. The action looks drastic, yet it minimizes total loss.

Subjective emotions, like objective resources, can also function as sunk costs.

### **Commitment-Threat Effect: The Knife That Is Never Drawn Is Always the Sharpest**

Micro-expression keywords: People fear injury and therefore fear threats. A threat that cannot be carried out loses all force. To prevent others from testing your resolve, you must extinguish any hope that you will refrain from acting. The commitment-threat effect therefore has two components: first, make the other party understand that you possess the capacity to harm them; second, make clear that crossing the line will bring that harm.

### **Concorde Fallacy: The Dangerous Trap That Deepens the More One Sinks into It**

Micro-expression keywords: The losses caused by the Concorde fallacy are immense yet avoidable. Avoidance requires only a clearer recognition of sunk costs. At any moment the decision to continue investing should rest on future prospects, not on costs already incurred.

See Prisoner's Dilemma (s-prisoners-dilemma).

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## **The Prisoner's Dilemma: Advance to Force Compliance, Retreat to Bluff and Extract Information**

### **Unfinished Case: Zhang Bing Verifies Company Crisis**

Zhang Bing is a mid-level manager at a logistics company. Recently, the company's logistics network expansion in the southwest region failed, wiping out 70% of its liquid assets. This setback could very well

trigger a total collapse. To maintain morale, only the owner and a few senior executives know the details; the information is tightly guarded from mid- and lower-level employees to prevent leaks. Zhang Bing learned the rough outline through a high-level contact at another logistics firm. Although he understands the leadership's fear of widespread panic, he must consider his own future. He needs to confirm the truth so he can plan his next steps.

He devised a method: verify the matter directly with the owner.

The next day, he entered the owner's office carrying an expense reimbursement form.

Although one management layer separates the owner, Sun, from Zhang Bing, Sun recognizes him. On several occasions Zhang Bing handled business with calm competence, leaving a strong impression despite limited direct interaction. Sun asked, "Zhang Bing, what brings you here?"

Holding the reimbursement form, Zhang Bing replied, "Mr. Sun, this is my expense report from the last business trip. Could you please stamp it for me?"

Sun asked in surprise, "According to our policy, the form only needs Manager Song's signature. Why come to me?"

Manager Song is Zhang Bing's direct supervisor and a veteran of the company. At his level and seniority, Song would certainly know any upper-level secrets. Zhang Bing had counted on exactly that point and answered, "Mr. Sun, I already went to Manager Song, but he said the company is tightening cash flow and implementing a liquidity squeeze. From now on, all reimbursements require

### **Another Use of the Prisoner's Dilemma**

your personal stamp."

Sun felt a flicker of doubt. The liquidity squeeze was indeed his directive, yet he had also instructed senior managers to treat the matter as a trade secret. How could Song be so careless? This would soon make every employee aware of the cash-flow problem.

Instead of addressing the request, Sun countered, "Did your manager announce this to everyone?"

Zhang Bing said, "No, he didn't make a formal announcement. He just mentioned it casually when I went to him for the signature."

Sun quietly exhaled in relief, then said, "All right, I'll stamp your form. You can go back to work—and while you're at it, ask your manager to come see me... never mind, I'll call him myself now."

Zhang Bing nodded and left. The next day he began searching job sites, found new employment within days, and resigned.

Not long after his departure, signs of insufficient liquid assets began to appear. The collapse was swift, and the company soon declared bankruptcy.

This illustrates another application of the prisoner's dilemma: feed one party the information that "your partner has already confessed." Even if the other side does not fully cooperate, they will reveal usable clues.

### **Historical Case: Li Deyu Investigates the Ganlu Temple Case**

Once economists formulated the prisoner's dilemma, law-enforcement practitioners quickly recognized its echoes in countless historical cases.

When the renowned late-Tang chancellor Li Deyu served as military governor of Zhexi, he inherited the famous Ganlu Temple case. Monks accused the previous abbot of diverting temple property for personal gain. Their evidence was the account book: every previous abbot had recorded the exact amount of gold remaining in the temple upon leaving office, yet the accused abbot's final ledger showed no gold, and none remained in the storeroom. Senior monks unanimously testified that the defendant had squandered it.

Although the defendant confessed, the confession gave no details on the gold's whereabouts. Suspecting irregularities, Li Deyu pressed the abbot repeatedly until the old monk admitted the truth: successive abbots had long followed the custom of depleting temple funds; the monks were idle and ignorant of Buddhist doctrine. The ledger had always listed one ingot of gold that had long since been consumed; the recorded figure was fictitious. The defendant, wishing to fulfill his duty, had refused to join the others and therefore prepared a fresh ledger—only to be denounced by the resentful monks.

Li Deyu half-believed the story, but the sheer number of corroborating monks forced him to find a way to test it. He ordered all monks named in the testimony brought together and seated each in a sedan chair facing a wall, isolating them from one another and from the outside. He then had his men prepare lumps of yellow clay roughly the size of the gold ingots the monks had described and instructed each isolated monk to shape his lump into the form of the gold he claimed to have seen.

The perjurers were dumbfounded. Because no gold had ever existed, they had coordinated only on weight and size, not on shape. Unable to match their stories, they confessed to giving false testimony.

Li Deyu's era had no term for the "prisoner's dilemma," yet he instinctively grasped its core: isolate the parties so they cannot exchange information. As the most social of group animals, humans rely heavily on their companions; when they cannot confirm their companions' actions, they grow anxious, and fear and betrayal readily surface.

#### **Modern Case: Duke University Professor's Makeup Exam**

Many people today skillfully exploit the prisoner's-dilemma mindset.

Two close friends in Duke University's chemical-engineering program, both excellent students, consistently earned B+ or higher on papers and performed well on quizzes. The night before the final exam they stayed out all night at a city bar, confident they could still handle a straightforward test.

They overslept. By the time they drove back to campus the exam had ended. The pair decided to ask the professor for a makeup exam, agreeing beforehand to claim their car had suffered a flat tire on the return trip from the city.

The professor considered the request and agreed. The next day the students arrived for the makeup. He gave each two sheets. The first, worth 40 points, covered standard course material; they finished the twenty-point section in half an hour. The second sheet contained a single question worth 60 points: "Which tire went flat yesterday on your drive back from the city?" The two looked at each other, then at the professor monitoring from the podium, and confessed.

The professor's exam and Li Deyu's clay illustrate a practical point: when using the prisoner's dilemma, block communication between the parties. If they have already coordinated their stories, locate the "blind spot" in

that coordination—usually a detail such as the shape of the gold or which tire went flat.

Psychologically, the prisoner's dilemma is a state of mind. One need not create the objective conditions; it suffices to induce the subjective sense of being in a dilemma. This is not difficult: simply present one party with fabricated evidence that the other has "confessed."

### **The Prisoner's Dilemma: Advance to Force Compliance, Retreat to Bluff and Extract Information**

**Micro-expression Keywords** The prisoner's-dilemma mindset has at least two uses: exploit information asymmetry between individuals to compel one or all of them to cooperate; or lead one individual to believe a companion has already "confessed," thereby eliciting useful information. The mindset can be applied regardless of rank—superior to subordinate or subordinate to superior, even achieving "regicide."

Two thieves are arrested, but the police lack sufficient evidence. They separate the suspects and offer each the same deal: if one confesses and the other does not, the confessor receives one year while the silent party receives ten; if both confess, each receives five years.

Under these conditions most thieves confess. Isolated from each other, each fears the other will confess to gain early release, leaving him with a ten-year sentence. Distrust and betrayal therefore prevail, and both confess—giving the police their maximum victory.

When each party can harm the other for personal gain and knows the other possesses the same capacity, each tends to strike first to avoid being harmed. This psychological dynamic is called the prisoner's dilemma. Originally an economic game-theory concept, it also carries implications for international relations, negotiation, criminal investigation, and psychology.

To understand the prisoner's dilemma in its psychological dimension, one must recognize its two necessary preconditions.

### **The Second Premise**

The prisoner's dilemma arises only in the final round of a two-player game.

Vendors at train stations often sell expired mineral water, biscuits, or substandard tea eggs, whereas neighborhood supermarkets and cooked-food stalls rarely do. The reason is that transactions at a station are usually one-off; repeat business is unlikely. Each sale is therefore the last round between vendor and customer, so vendors maximize profit by cutting quality. Neighborhood trade, by contrast, is built on repeat customers; every transaction is not the final round. To secure future business, merchants maintain quality so neighbors become regulars and long-term profit is maximized.

Hence the prisoner's-dilemma mindset appears only in the final round of play.

### **The First Premise**

The "prisoners" cannot communicate or establish effective trust, thereby creating the dilemma.

If the two prisoners were held together or allowed any effective contact, they would coordinate and the police would obtain nothing. Likewise, if the two criminals were lovers, father and son, or mother and son, the bond would generate sufficient trust to defeat the scheme.



Therefore, the first step in creating a prisoner's dilemma is to sever all channels of information and trust between the "prisoners."

## Appendix A — Sources

| stem          | bytes  | sha256                                                           |
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## Appendix B — Quizzes

### Psychological Test: Is Your Emotion Stable?

Everyone has their own emotions, which affect every aspect of our lives. People who can usually control their emotions well are more easily accepted by others, while those who lose their temper at the slightest provocation are often disliked. So, is your emotion stable? Take this test to find out.

#### Test Content

Please select answers honestly based on your actual situation.

- When you wake up each morning, what feeling do you usually have?  
A. Depressed   B. Happy   C. Can't say for sure
- Have your friends, colleagues, or classmates ever given you a nickname or teased you?  
A. Happens often   B. Never   C. Occasionally
- How do you evaluate recent photos of yourself?  
A. Feel dissatisfied   B. Feel very good   C. Feel average
- After lying in bed, do you often get up again to check whether the doors and windows are closed?  
A. Do this often   B. Have never done this   C. Occasionally do this
- Do you think about unsettling things that might happen many years from now?  
A. Think about it often   B. Have never thought about it   C. Occasionally think about it
- Are you satisfied with the people closest to you?  
A. Dissatisfied   B. Very satisfied   C. Basically satisfied

7. Do you feel that some of your abilities are stronger than others?  
A. Yes B. No C. Unclear
8. Have you ever seen, heard, or felt something that others do not notice?  
A. This happens often B. Never C. Occasionally
9. Do you feel that someone is paying attention to your words and actions?  
A. Yes B. No C. Not very clear
10. What is your view when someone around you commits suicide or you learn that a familiar person suddenly committed suicide?  
A. Feel it is understandable B. Feel it is inconceivable C. Unclear
11. If someone is walking behind you, do you feel uneasy?  
A. Yes B. No C. Unclear
12. When walking alone at night, do you feel danger is hidden ahead?  
A. Yes B. No C. Occasionally
13. In the middle of the night, do you often feel something that frightens you?  
A. Often B. Never C. Occasionally
14. Do you often feel that your family treats you badly?  
A. Yes B. No C. Occasionally
15. Have you had the same dream multiple times?  
A. Yes B. No C. Can't remember clearly
16. Do you often wake up from nightmares and then cannot fall back asleep?  
A. Often B. No C. Rarely
17. Besides the visible world, do you feel there is also an invisible world?  
A. Yes B. No C. Unclear
18. Do you often feel that your current parents are not your biological parents?  
A. Often B. No C. Occasionally
19. Do you feel that someone loves or respects you?  
A. Yes B. No C. Can't say
20. Do you usually feel that you lose your temper easily?  
A. Yes B. No C. Unclear
21. Do you feel that no one understands you?  
A. Yes B. No C. Can't say clearly
22. When autumn arrives, what feelings do you usually have?  
A. Feel that all things are declining B. Feel the crisp autumn air C. No special feeling
23. When alone in a room, do you feel lonely?  
A. Yes B. No C. Occasionally

24. When you return home, do you shut yourself in your room?  
A. Yes B. No C. Occasionally
25. Do you often have the urge to resign?  
A. Yes B. No C. Occasionally
26. Do you often find someone intolerable, feeling they have many unbearable flaws?  
A. Yes B. No C. Occasionally
27. When you learn that someone has spoken ill of you behind your back, what do you do?  
A. Become furious and confront the person B. Endure it C. Stop associating with the person
28. How do you feel when you see flowers in the park blown down by the wind?  
A. Feel that beautiful things do not last B. Feel the scene is beautiful C. No special feeling
29. When your leader criticizes you in front of many colleagues, what do you do?  
A. Become exasperated B. Accept the criticism humbly C. Accept the criticism but feel very upset inside
30. After arguing with someone you care about, what do you do?  
A. Never speak to the person again B. Take the initiative to reconcile C. Brood in silence

## Scoring Method

For each question, select A for 2 points, B for 0 points, C for 1 point. Tally the scores and calculate the total.

## Result Analysis

- **Total score 0–20 points:** Indicates that your emotion is stable, your self-confidence is strong, and you can understand others' feelings. You are an open and cheerful person who is well-liked.
- **Total score 21–40 points:** Indicates that your emotion is basically stable and your personality is relatively steady, but your enthusiasm fluctuates.
- **Total score above 40 points:** Indicates that your emotion is very unstable, you have many worries in daily life, and you are often in conflict. It is necessary to adjust your emotions.

## Psychological Test: Test Your Emotion Control Ability

Emotion control ability refers to the ability to manage one's own emotions. The strength of a person's emotion control ability can be seen from various daily behaviors.

## Test Content

Please answer the following questions carefully to measure the strength of your emotion control ability.

1. You are driving on the road when heavy rain suddenly begins. What do you do?
  - A. Become furious and complain about the sudden rain
  - B. Feel nothing special
  - C. Feel happy, thinking the sudden rain improves your mood
2. Under the scorching sun, you accidentally collide with someone while riding a bicycle. What do you do?

- A. Become furious and scold the person
- B. Ignore it and continue on your way
- C. Get off the bike and apologize

3. A friend or family member yells at you loudly. What do you do?

- A. Become angry and yell back
- B. Ignore it and walk away
- C. Calmly explain to the person

4. When you are very annoyed and unhappy, what do you do?

- A. Become furious and vent it
- B. Go out for a walk to relax
- C. Chat with friends or family and share your troubles

5. You accidentally lose a piece of clothing you really like. What do you do?

- A. Feel troubled and vent it
- B. Feel annoyed and unhappy
- C. Learn from the experience and be more careful next time

6. While resting in bed due to illness, you see others playing happily outside. What do you do?

- A. Feel irritable and keep blaming your illness
- B. Feel annoyed and unhappy
- C. Rest peacefully to recover

7. When you are very happy, what do you do?

- A. Feel very proud
- B. Act as if nothing happened
- C. Share it with your friends or family

8. When you cannot find a job despite trying, what do you do?

- A. Feel troubled and restless, becoming very anxious
- B. Calm down and keep looking for work
- C. Reflect on yourself, improve your abilities, and keep looking for work

9. A friend does something that makes you very dissatisfied. What do you do?

- A. Feel very unhappy inside and scold the person
- B. Ignore it and act as if nothing happened
- C. Point it out frankly while remaining calm

10. You do something that makes your friend very unhappy. What do you do?

- A. Fall out with the person
- B. Ignore it and act as if nothing happened
- C. Apologize and try to make the person happy

## Scoring Method

For each question, select A for 1 point, B for 2 points, C for 3 points. Tally the scores and calculate the total.

## Result Analysis

If the total score is 1–10 points, it indicates that your emotion control ability is weak. Your mood is easily affected by external factors, your emotions fluctuate greatly, and you have difficulty withstanding life's tests. You need to learn how to control your emotions.

If the total score is 11–20 points, it indicates that your emotion control ability is average. You can handle ordinary life tests, but you struggle to control your emotions effectively and correctly when facing sudden events or situations requiring strong psychological resilience. You still need to actively practice better emotion control.

If the total score is 21–30 points, it indicates that your emotion control ability is strong and you can withstand life's tests.

## Psychological Test: Test How Fragile Your Inner Self Is

In life and work, everyone inevitably encounters setbacks. Facing various pressures in life and work, how fragile is your inner self? Let's test it.

### Test Content

If you trip over an iron bar at a construction site while walking, what is your first reaction?

- A. Argue with the site manager
- B. Claim compensation
- C. Accept it as bad luck

### Result Analysis

- **Choice A:** You are extremely fragile inside. On the surface, your work and life seem fine, but when alone you tend to overthink, and whenever pressure arises you want to escape.
- **Choice B:** You appear strong, as if no difficulty can affect your mood, but in reality you are fragile inside and very prone to low moods.
- **Choice C:** You are very strong, becoming more resilient with each setback. You can face difficulties and challenges bravely, and trivial matters in life and work do not bring you down.

## Psychological Test: Emotion Type Test

Many people experience difficult-to-suppress negative emotions at different times. To find a solution, first take a small test to identify your emotion type.

### Test Content

Please answer the following questions carefully, select the most appropriate answer, and determine which emotion type you belong to.

1. For you, which emotion is the most challenging?

- A. Anger
- B. Fear
- C. Guilt

2. What is your attitude toward change?

- A. Necessary
- B. Optimistic
- C. Energy-consuming

3. Which do you like most?

- A. Efficiency
- B. Vision
- C. Reality

4. Which physical symptom often troubles you?

- A. Cardiovascular problems
- B. Stomach discomfort
- C. Migraines

5. What is your greatest strength in emotion management?

- A. Making decisions unaffected by emotions
- B. Building trust
- C. Win-win communication

6. What characteristics do your emotions show?

- A. Powerful
- B. Unpredictable
- C. Challenging

7. What can you least tolerate?

- A. Wasting time endlessly on emotions
- B. Venting negative emotions rudely
- C. Being bound by emotions yet helpless

8. If you must give up one of the following three options, which would you give up?

- A. Life's mission
- B. Ability to predict others' behavior
- C. Optimistic thinking

## Result Analysis

If you chose A the most, it indicates you are the "time bomb type." You have clear goals, value tangible results, and easily develop the habit of isolating emotions, but you unconsciously neglect others' emotions. The "time bomb" is aggressive, sharp, and angry—the most dominant and confrontational type. The most common emotion is anger.

If you chose B the most, it indicates you are the "people pleaser type." You value long-term goals and others' feelings, are very sensitive, but often neglect your own feelings and current tasks. The most common emotion is fear. "People pleasers" easily satisfy others' immediate emotional needs blindly, but doing so does not always mean win-win outcomes, long-term benefits, or problem resolution. Therefore, you are easily taken advantage of and tend to procrastinate when addressing core issues.

If you chose C the most, it indicates you are the "emotionally depleted type." You insist on perfect results, have a strong sense of responsibility, are good at observation, and value facts and data. However, due to a lack of habit in expressing emotions, you easily develop suppressed emotions. The most common emotion is guilt. Emotionally depleted, you tend to abandon your own needs under pressure. Therefore, you often feel dissatisfied with many of your actions yet powerless to change them.

## Psychological Test: What Is Your Irritability Index?

Did you know that each person's irritability index differs? Through the following test, you can measure your own irritability index.

### Test Content

Please carefully consider the twenty-five situations listed below that might make you angry. Answer honestly, assign the corresponding scores, calculate the total, and determine your irritability index.

1. You open a newly purchased device, plug it in, and find it does not work at all.
2. You are extorted or threatened by a repair person.
3. Only your mistake is ordered to be corrected, while others' mistakes go unnoticed.
4. Your car gets stuck in mud or snow.
5. You are talking to someone who ignores you.
6. Someone deceives you by claiming they have something when they do not.
7. While carrying coffee to your seat in a café with difficulty, someone bumps into you and the coffee spills.
8. You hang up your clothes, but someone knocks them to the ground and does not pick them up.
9. The salesperson follows you from the moment you enter the store.
10. You arranged to go out with someone, but at the last minute the person cancels and leaves you waiting alone.
11. Being joked about or teased.
12. You stop at a red light, but the person behind keeps honking at you.
13. You take a wrong turn in the parking lot, and as soon as you get out of the car someone shouts, "Where did you learn to drive?"
14. Someone makes a mistake but blames you for it.
15. You are trying to concentrate, but people around you tap their feet.
16. You lend an important book or tool to someone who does not return it.
17. You have a busy day, but the person you live with complains that you forgot to do something you promised.
18. You want to discuss an important matter with your partner or colleague, but the person does not give you a chance to express your feelings.
19. During a discussion with someone, the person insists on talking about a topic they do not understand well.
20. While you are discussing with someone, another person suddenly interrupts.

21. You need to get somewhere quickly, but the car in front is driving at 25 km/h in a 40 km/h zone and you cannot overtake.
22. You step on a piece of chewed gum.
23. You are laughed at by a group of people as you pass by.
24. While hurrying somewhere, your good casual pants get torn by a sharp object.
25. You use your last coin to make a call, but the line drops after dialing and the coin is gone.

## Result Analysis

- If your total score is 0–45 points, it indicates you do not get angry easily.
- If your total score is 46–55 points, it indicates you are calmer than average.
- If your total score is 56–75 points, it indicates your irritability index is within the normal range.
- If your total score is 76–85 points, it indicates you get angry more easily than average.
- If your total score is 86–100 points, it indicates your anger often loses control.

## Psychological Test: Test Your Depression Index

Depression causes low mood, slow thinking, and reduced speech and movement. It greatly harms life and work and places a heavy burden on families and society. Let's measure our own depression index!

### Test Content

In the past few days, to what extent have the following emotions troubled you? Please answer honestly and calculate the total score.

1. Sadness: Do you feel sad or discouraged?
2. Hopelessness: Do you feel the future is bleak?
3. Low self-evaluation: Do you feel worthless?
4. Inferiority: Do you feel unconfident or inferior to others?
5. Guilt: Do you often treat yourself too harshly or blame yourself?
6. Indecisiveness: Do you find it difficult to make decisions?
7. Irritability: Do you get angry or resent others easily?
8. Lack of interest: Do you lose interest in work, hobbies, family, or friends?
9. Lack of motivation: Do you feel reluctant when doing things?
10. Poor self-perception: Do you feel you have aged or lost charm?
11. Appetite change: Do you have reduced appetite or overeat?
12. Sleep disturbance: Do you have poor sleep quality or sleep too much and feel tired?
13. Reduced libido: Do you lose interest in sex?
14. Health concern: Do you worry excessively about your health?
15. Suicidal impulse: Do you feel life is meaningless or that you would be better off dead?

## Result Analysis

If your total score is 0–4 points, it indicates that you have no depression or only mild depression.

If your total score is 5–10 points, it indicates that you are normal but unhappy.

If your total score is 11–20 points, it indicates that you are approaching moderate depression.

If your total score is 21–30 points, it indicates moderate depression.



If your total score is 31–45 points, it indicates severe depression.

## Psychological Test: Burns Anxiety Scale

In the face of intense competition and a rapidly changing environment, many people become anxious and fall into distress, which greatly affects our physical and mental health. So, let us use the Burns Anxiety Scale to measure our own level of anxiety!

### Test Content

Based on your actual situation over the past few days, select the most appropriate answer and calculate your total score.

1. Anxiety, nervousness, worry, or fear.
2. Feeling that things around you are strange or unreal.
3. Feeling that parts or all of your body no longer belong to you.
4. Sudden feelings of panic.
5. Fear or a sense of impending death.
6. Feeling tense, distressed, irritable, or on the verge of collapse.
7. Difficulty concentrating.
8. Disordered thinking.
9. Frightening fantasies or unrealistic thoughts.
10. Feeling out of control.
11. Worrying about a mental breakdown or going insane.
12. Worrying about fainting or losing consciousness.
13. Worrying about a heart attack or death.
14. Worrying about appearing foolish or incompetent.
15. Fear of being alone or worrying about isolation or abandonment.
16. Fear of criticism or rejection.
17. Worrying that something terrible will happen.
18. Rapid heartbeat, irregular rhythm, or pounding heart.
19. Chest pain, tightness, or pressure.
20. Tingling or numbness in toes or fingers.
21. Stomach discomfort or tightening sensation.
22. Constipation or diarrhea.
23. Restlessness.
24. Muscle tension.
25. Cold sweats.
26. Sensation of throat obstruction.
27. Trembling hands.
28. Stiff or weak legs.
29. Feeling dizzy, lightheaded, or unsteady on your feet.
30. Difficulty breathing or a choking sensation.
31. Headache, neck pain, or back pain.
32. Feeling alternately hot and cold.
33. Feeling fatigued, weak, or easily tired.

### Result Analysis

- If your total score is 0–4 points, it indicates that you are normal or have no anxiety.
- If your total score is 5–10 points, it indicates that you are on the borderline of anxiety.
- If your total score is 11–20 points, it indicates mild anxiety.
- If your total score is 21–30 points, it indicates moderate anxiety.
- If your total score is 31–50 points, it indicates severe anxiety.
- If your total score is 51–99 points, it indicates extreme anxiety or extreme panic.

## Psychological Test: How Optimistic Are You?

Dutch scientists have shown that an optimistic mindset can extend a person's lifespan. In fact, optimism benefits not only yourself but can also influence others, encouraging them to stay positive. Let us take a small test together to see how optimistic you are!

### Test Content

Would you like to accurately understand your level of optimism? Let us measure it together! Answer the following ten questions, note the corresponding option based on your feelings, and calculate your total score.

1. Most of the time, I expect the best outcome.
2. It is especially easy for me to relax at any moment.

### Questionnaire Items

3. If I think I will mess something up, I really will.
4. I am always fairly optimistic about my future.
5. I really enjoy spending time with friends.
6. Staying busy with work is very important to me.
7. Few things develop in the direction I expect.
8. I do not get upset easily.
9. I hardly ever expect good things to happen to me.
10. In life, I feel that I encounter more good things than bad things.

### Scoring Method

**Questions 1, 4, 10:** A=1 point, B=2 points, C=3 points, D=4 points, E=5 points.

**Questions 3, 7, 9:** A=5 points, B=4 points, C=3 points, D=2 points, E=1 point.

**Questions 2, 5, 6, 8:** Not scored.

### Result Analysis

- If your total score is 6 points, it indicates that you are extremely optimistic.
- If your total score is 7–18 points, it indicates that you are optimistic.
- If your total score is 19–29 points, it indicates that you are pessimistic.
- If your total score is 30 points, it indicates that you are extremely pessimistic.

## Psychological Test: Is Your Emotion "Over the Top"?

People with paranoid personality traits tend to go to extremes, distrust others, are sensitive and suspicious, and often fall into a vortex of hostile thoughts, which seriously affects their physical and mental health. So, do you have paranoid emotions? Take the test and find out!

## Test Content

Based on your recent actual situation, answer the following questions honestly, calculate your total score, and determine whether your emotions are "over the top."

1. Do you demand perfection from others?
2. Do you always blame others for causing you trouble?
3. Do you feel that most people are untrustworthy?
4. Do you have thoughts and ideas that others do not?
5. Are you unable to control your temper?
6. Do you feel that others do not understand or sympathize with you?
7. Do you think others have not given your achievements a fair evaluation?
8. Do you always feel that others are trying to take advantage of you?

## Result Analysis

If your total score is below 10 points, it indicates that you have no paranoid tendencies and are a calm and even-tempered person.

If your total score is 15–24 points, it indicates that you have a certain degree of paranoia. If you often feel that your environment is unsatisfactory, you should be alert and look for reasons within yourself.

If your total score is 25 points or above, it indicates that you have symptoms of paranoia. You need to learn to control your emotions and avoid going "over the top." Once you encounter a major obstacle, seek help from a psychologist.

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- *What Every BODY Is Saying: An Ex-FBI Agent's Guide to Speed-Reading People*
- *The Definitive Book of Body Language*
- *Gray's Anatomy: The Anatomical Basis of Clinical Practice (39th ed.)*

- *Evolutionary Psychology (2nd ed.)*
- *Social Psychology (8th ed.)*
- *Personality Psychology (4th ed.)*
- *How to Read a Person Like a Book*
- *The Art of Negotiation*
- *Forbes*